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1

Introduction

1.1 The Gift of 1000 Sages

We, as a human race, have been blessed with a great number of Prophets, starting with Adam, Seers, Sages, Saints, Philosophers, Doctors, Poets, Worthies, and other Great Men. Most have been forgotten or known by name only. The reason to prefer the antique thinkers is because they have stood the test of time. Centuries of scholars have analyzed and commented on their works, so those who "survive" are worth our time.



There may be contemporaries at their level, but that may be difficult to discern. They can be treated with caution, more especially if they claim any sort of novelty. Those who can make clear the ideas of the ancients are better guides.

I was struck at one time by Vladimir Solovyov's nonchalant comment that Christianity did not create a new metaphysic, but was instead based on historical events. That made sense of Rene

Guenon's famous claim of a common metaphysics that underlie the major religious traditions. There will be incompatibilities in their exoteric teachings which are based on historical events but the metaphysical assumptions should align.

Although Guenon make progress in this area, there is still much to be said about the common metaphysics. Given the two texts I am working with: **Jacques Maritain**'s *Introduction to Philosophy* and **Syed Naquid**'s *Prolegomena to Islamic Metaphysics*, this thought jumped right up into consciousness:

> If I remove the Latin from Maritain's book and the Arabic from Naquid's book, the metaphysical principles are virtually indistinguishable. I could go on and on, which I shall do over time, but I'll start with this one example: both agree that regarding God, essence and existence are the same. All else follows.

This reminded me of what **C S Lewis** wrote in *The Discarded Image*: There are ancient texts which are not obviously Christian or Pagan, given that their worldviews were so closely aligned with each other. In the same vein, the ideas that Lewis assumed were Christian turn out also to be Islamic. Essence, existence, substance, act, potentiality and so on have the same meanings. These will be explored in details, not as arguments but as expository.

Since the West has effectively abandoned metaphysics, it needs to be reinvigorated by a tradition that still accepts it. Here are some principles to ponder.

Three Worlds There are three worlds: the Corporeal, the Imaginal, the Spiritual, corresponding to body, soul, and spirit. They are not independent, so by the Law of Correspondence, what happens in the celestial realm is reflected in the imaginal realm, and ultimately in the corporeal world.

Therefore the world has an inside as well as an inside. Knowledge begins in the senses and we can advance to the spiritual through a process of abstraction. Things and events have a representation and meaning in the life of the soul. To reach the essence of the thing, it is necessary to abstract even from that image into pure thought.

It is one thing to understand the essence of a species like a lion, for example. It is more difficult to understand the essence of an individual, such as someone you may know and love. Religious dogmas, then, are even more difficult. If you try to visualize it, you will be mistaken. You can recite the Apostle's Creed daily, until it loses its meaning. If you are visualizing beings in Heaven as if you are some objective onlooker, you will miss the point. It is also immoral since it is an idol.

This project is an attempt to recall the collective wisdom of humankind, not as a new theory, but as an old truth.

Posted on 2021-09-08 by Cologero

* * *

Tom on 2021-09-10 at 09:31 said:

" If you are visualizing beings in Heaven as if you are some objective onlooker, you will miss the point. It is also immoral since it is an idol ".

Just wondered how to square that statement with Tomberg's statement that " "There is not a shadow of doubt for anyone who takes the spiritual life of mankind seriously, even if he is short of authentic spiritual experience, that the Blessed Virgin is not an ideal only, nor a mental image only, nor an archetype of the unconscious (of depth-psychology), nor, lastly, an occultistic egregore, but rather a concrete and living individuality – like you or I – who loves, suffers, and rejoices. "?

Tomberg's quote is from this site :

https://corjesusacratissimum.org/2012/07/on-degeneration-disaster-and-war-valentin-tomberg-and-the-lady-of-all-nations/

In general I think the question is how to reconcile " metaphysical " formlessness as ontologically superior to form with the statements like this or the fact that Jesus is described in the Gospels as "sitting at the right hand of the Father ". Or that personality is higher than individuality. In other word aren't there bodies in heaven "" Even Dante suggests as much .

> `Cologero on 2021-09-10 at 10:09 said:`
> There is nothing to reconcile. E.g., she is not a "mental image". I would change "individuality" to "personality", but she is as real as "you or I". It is necessary to understood what it means to be a person, an "I".
>
> The explanation of the "Person" is on the schedule for a near future post, but it needs a build up. I think it will clarify a lot.

> `Cologero on 2021-09-10 at 11:44 said:`
> Let me add come further clarifications, although these topics have appeared over and over again as posts.
>
> The soul after death does not exist solely in the Intellectual or Celestial Realm, but also in the Imaginal Realm. So there will be appearances of bodies, but glorified spiritual bodies with the properties of impassibility, agility, clarity, and subtlety.
>
> The physical realm is pure potentiality and thus part of Non-Being, so it is an error to assume that every experience is somehow physical.
>
> Also, with metaphysical realization, i.e. awareness of being a Person, the Person exists in all his states of being simultaneously. Of course, the extent of this depends on the ability and nobility of the person.

> `Tom on 2021-09-10 at 12:17 said:`
> Thank you for the extra clarification.

1.2 Guenon, Maritain, Thomism

Prolegomena to any future Western metaphysics.

Meeting of the Minds In 1921, the great Thomist philosopher Jacques Maritain criticized Rene Guenon for participating in the rebirth of gnosis, the "mother of heresies". Guenon responded, "It would make as much sense to speak of Catholicism as the father of Protestantism. In fact, you are simply confusing gnosis with Gnosticism."

"If you take the word 'gnosis' in its true sense, that of pure knowledge, as I always do when I happen to use it … Gnosis so understood — and

I refuse to understand it otherwise — cannot be called the mother of heresies. That would be the same as saying that the truth is the mother of errors."

To be clear, by 'gnosis' or 'wisdom' as Evola usually called it, Guenon is referring to a state of being, not to a science or a set of doctrines to learn. At that point in his career, Guenon was involved in studying eastern doctrines on the one hand, and Christian symbolism on the other.

On May 25, 1925, Guenon participated in a round table discussion that included Maritain, where Guenon defended Hindu metaphysics. Guenon denied that it was either pantheist or idealist, contrary to academic consensus. Rather, it is connected more closely to the Aristotelian tradition, including the scholastic philosophy of the Middle Ages as exemplified by Thomas Aquinas.

Maritain objected because, from his point of view, this alliance between eastern and Catholic metaphysics is "an inadmissible subordination and the ruin of the distinction between the natural and supernatural order, between nature and grace." For Maritain, metaphysics is not beyond theology, the "supreme science". Although Maritain had an authentic intellectual respect for Guenon, he eventually forced Guenon out of contributing to Catholic journals, and an opportunity was lost to further develop Thomism more fully and completely.

Maritain's Misunderstanding First of all Maritain fails to grasp Guenon's distinction between philosophy and metaphysics, so he thinks from the perspective of the former. Since metaphysics is by definition the study of supernature ("beyond physics"), the distinction between the natural and the supernatural order is preserved. Maritain simply asserts that the supernatural order can be grasped only by faith and not by any sort of gnosis; this is remarkable, since as Guenon reminds us, for "Aristotle and his Scholastic successors … the intellect was in fact that faculty which possessed a direct knowledge of principles." In other words, Thomism

does indeed admit a gnosis, though its full consequences have not been incorporated into theological thinking insofar as it may present a threat to the primacy of faith.

Further background Evola also accepts Guenon's judgment about Thomism, which he sees as part of the process of "rectification". Interestingly enough, John Woodroffe, although he does not explicitly refer to the Aristotelian tradition (as far as I can recall), similarly denies that Tantrism is "idealist", but is likewise "realist". In his *Introduction to the Study of Hindu Doctrines*, Guenon develops this topic more fully. Although at one point he claims that the only Western metaphysics is that of Aristotle and the Scholastics, he clarifies:

> We do not include the Alexandrians, however, upon whom Oriental influences came to be exercised in a direct manner.

The Alexandrians would include St Anthony the Great[1] and what we call the Hermetists[2].

Future Directions Where Thomism falls short is that it is a metaphysic of Being. It needs to be enhanced with an understanding of non-being as described in the **Multiple States of Being**. Catholic theology is hampered somewhat by the Eighth Ecumenical Council which denied the tripartite nature of man as spirit, soul, and body. (The Eastern churches don't accept this council.) This needs to be overcome, so elements from the **Great Triad** and **Man and his Becoming according to the Vendanta** can be incorporated.

In summary: to recreate a Western metaphysic for our time one would:

1. Begin with Thomism

[1] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1224`
[2] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1256`

2. Incorporate an understanding of non-being, infinity, and non-duality from the Vedanta and Taoism

3. Develop more fully the understanding of tripartite nature of man

4. Integrate it with the ancient Hermetic tradition

5. Integrate this with a spiritual practice so it arises from a true gnosis and does not devolve into yet another intellectualizing philosophy or theology

The young man who will take up this task may already have been born.

Reference: *Rene Guenon: Le philosophe invisible* by Jean-Luc Maxence. All translations from the French are mine.

Posted on 2010-12-15 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-12-15 at 23:27 said:

Oddly enough, that 5 step program reminds me of Alan Watts' intellectual journey [see his Beyond Theology or In My Own Way] although he may have gone a bit astray on the last step...

Cologero on 2010-12-16 at 00:31 said:

Perhaps I was just recalling ideas hidden in the unconscious from when I read those books many years ago.

I know someone who, as a young man, managed to get to San Francisco from Chicago in order to meet Mr. Watts. On his arrival, he looked up Watts in the phone book and called. His wife answered. There were noisy children in the background and the wife made some disparaging remarks about why Watts wasn't home ... in particular referring to his drinking. Disillusioned, the young man left San Francisco, not having met Watts.

GF on 2010-12-17 at 12:11 said:

Why not begin with Dionysius the Areopagite? He already has fully developed arguments on Non-Being and gnosis, and at least an implied understanding of tripartite nature. Do you include him among the Alexandrians?

Which makes me think: If the finished doctrine is supposed to combine (Alexandrian) Hermetism with Thomism, as an admittedly superior leaven, isn't it truer to say that one should begin with the Alexandrians? As in fact Gornahoor has been doing?

But I see you say "for our time": and I understand why *appearing* to begin with the Alexandrians would be impolitic in our time, at least among Catholics.

`James O'Meara on 2010-12-17 at 12:14 said:`

How Watts went astray: searching and 'finding' analogies btw esotericism and what would become the New Age, he confused the Taoist Sage with the stoned hippie or hot-tub psychologist:

"...SERIOUS PLAY [a very Wattsian idea] contains at the same time a serious warning: there is Play and play, there is the Magician and the magician; this is why anyone who confuses lack of concentration with concentration without effort...will necessarily become a CHARLATAN." – Meditations on the Tarot

`GF on 2010-12-17 at 12:17 said:`

Dionysius also has a conception of esoterism. So my 'counter-proposal' is this:

1. Begin with Dionysius
2. Integrate with Thomism
3. Integrate with spiritual practise

Your steps 2 and 3 are basically eliminated, and the represented order is more accurate (Thomism, being lesser, comes later).

`James O'Meara on 2010-12-17 at 12:29 said:`

Again, oddly like Watts, who indeed began with Dionysius, published a translation of the Theologica Mystica whilst in the seminary in 1944 [!] and later republished it in his full hippie period, saying something like "Here had been the opportunity for Western theologians to close up shop and become schools of contemplation of the nameless, but instead they just kept chattering." From 1 to 3, skipping 2?

`GF on 2010-12-17 at 13:04 said:`

Yes, I suppose it comes down to that. St. Bernard himself, whose praises Guenon sung, had only contempt for the verbiage of philosophers and theologians. Though if a theological 'ornamention' must be added, St. Thomas would be valuable.

Cologero on 2010-12-17 at 14:11 said:

I might never have heard of Guenon were it not for Watts. He follows a familiar path … try to reform one's own "tradition", get frustrated and turn East. And then fall into the confusion that Tomberg describes.

GF on 2010-12-17 at 14:12 said:

One of the very interesting things about Dionysius is that he claims his written work is informed only by the 'Oracles' (Old and New Testaments) – and yet how different it is than sola scriptura Protestantism. So much depends on the atmosphere in which one lives. – In case you didn't know, James, Dionysius was Bishop of *Athens*.

Cologero on 2010-12-17 at 14:22 said:

Yes, Dionysus, whom Aquinas quotes some 1200 times, is among the Alexandrians. I would regard the Aristotelean and Platonic perspectives as two *darshanas*, or perspectives. We are well past the time for worrying about being "impolitic" about issues related to these topics since the era of persecution, at least in this area, is over. There is no need to convince anyone. This writer was driven from a self-described traditional Catholic forum for promoting Dionysius, so I wouldn't waste time in a futile debate.

What is required is a group effort to define and implement the task.

Cologero on 2010-12-17 at 14:38 said:

In his commentary on Vatican II – an event which was pretty much pointless – Evola proposes his own program to reform the Catholic religion. I'll have to make time to translate it soon. Suffice it to say that I read Tomberg in that light, in particular the way he understands Bible stories. Evola concedes that St Clement of Alexandria's distinction between the gnostics (knowers) and believers was behind his own conception of "those who know and those who believe".

Guido de Giorgio is a figure, close to both Guenon and Evola, who unfortunately remains unknown. While Guenon was turning East and Evola remained staunchly in the West, di Giorgio developed a synthesis of both. Like Gornahoor, he sees a continuity, not a break, from the ancient world through the Medieval period.

GF on 2010-12-17 at 15:25 said:

"What is required is a group effort to define and implement the task."

This is exactly why I ask you about Catholicism. If I'm reading you right, the outline of your plan would be the development of an order, which, like the Fransiscans and the Jesuits Tomberg cites, would replenish the Church from the outside. I gather that ultimately you are indifferent

to the Church: if it can be bent to Traditional ends, use it; if not, forget it. So much for the Church: what of Christ Himself?

I'm looking forward to the new translations.

`Cologero on 2010-12-24 at 16:04 said:`

For those interested in the current state of Hinduism in India, this article may be of some interest: Rush Hour for the Gods.

> While the West often likes to imagine the religions of the East as deep wells of ancient, unchanging wisdom, in reality, much of India's religious identity is closely tied to specific social groups, caste practices and father-to-son lineages, all of which are coming under threat as Indian society transforms beyond recognition.

`Cologero on 2010-12-24 at 16:19 said:`

Some points:

- Thomism takes non-being into account in the distinction between **potency** (non-being) and **act** (being).
- Hinduism in itself is no gold standard. The Vedanta is just one of six orthodox schools and affects very few.
- Westerners, in their arrogance, assume they can just jump into Advaita Vedanta without undertaking all the ritual requirements of a Brahmin.
- Westerners simply assume they would be Brahmins in a "traditional" culture.
- If Westerners cannot even recognize their own traditional elements, it would strain credulity that they could recognize them in another culture. I recommend these comments by Ananda Coomaraswamy: Vedanta and Western Tradition.

`Brother Otto on 2020-12-08 at 22:23 said:`

To my knowledge, Guenon and his followers have never presented a real argument for why Thomism is inadequate. They simply privilege a negation (non-being, which Guenon reminds us, is not nothing!) and beg the question. Multiple States of Being is one of Guenon's worst books, where he repeats points he made better (albeit still part charlatan) elsewhere.

Thomism is not incomplete, and it certainly does not need crypto-Buddhist advaita vedanta. Catholics don't need moksha.

> Cologero on 2020-12-19 at 21:58 said:
> Catholics don't need Saint John of the Cross, either.

1.3 The Garden of Metaphysics

If I were to tell you about my garden, I would mention the two banana trees, one with a small hand just starting. There are the two tomato vines, and pots for basil and Italian parsley. I could mention the several palm trees, the bromeliads, and the bird of paradise just beginning to flower. There are several other flowering plants as well as ground cover.

Seeing Principles The one thing I would not do is to debate the issue. I would not try to prove the existence of the bananas nor give an intellectual justification for why I believe in their existence. If you have any doubts, I would simply ask you to visit and see for yourself.

Discovering metaphysical principles uses a similar process. The garden is part of the physical world and is experienced directly through sensory intuition. Metaphysics is about what is beyond the physical and is experienced directly through an intellectual intuition. There is nothing to debate nor is there a need to convince someone, at least as long as we are in the metaphysical realm. Nevertheless, some men may see things more deeply or are more careful observers; this is the source of disputes.

For example, when we talk about the soul and its layers or envelops, that is not a philosophical theory among others, and even less so, is it a problem for psychology. The proper approach is to begin a process of self-observation of one's inner states. In this way, the forces of the parts of the soul —such as eros, thymos, desire, attraction, and so on— can be carefully observed over time. A man can learn to align these forces in their proper order, that is, under the domination of the intellect. He will observe the resistance of the lower forces to such domination. This

is his experience of cosmic law, the forces of chaos, and the necessity of participating in the greater battle of logos over chaos.

Those men who have never troubled themselves to such a practice will most likely think this all to be nonsense. They will deny the necessity of the greater battle and will typically embrace the lower forces as somehow "life affirming". We can imagine a Viking of a thousand years ago, who never left the North land and how incredulous he would be about my description of a banana.

With his self-knowledge, our metaphysician is in a position to understand other men. He may note that there are some fundamental differences in the way men relate to their possibilities; these he categorizes in what are commonly called castes. These are not psychological states and cannot be verified by empirical methods.

He notes that, unlike beasts and inanimate objects, men do not follow the cosmic law, or dharma, by necessity, but freely. Hence, the greater battle interiorly becomes the lesser battle exteriorly. Since men of certain casts of mind do not understand this, they require a spiritual authority as a teacher and maintainer of traditions. The temporal power maintains structures within bounds, offering protection from chaos and formlessness whether arising from without or within.

Applying Principles These principles are fundamental to a Traditional world view and are the keys to understand events in the world process, both synchronically and diachronically. While the principles themselves are beyond debate, their application to a given situation is open to discussion. Here is the general approach to take.

Note who or what is the spiritual authority at any moment, or how it has changed over time. The spiritual authority is whatever cannot be publicly doubted or challenged. This is the legitimate task of a lawful spiritual authority, whose job is to maintain spiritual unity of the whole. However, an illegitimate spiritual authority will be enforcing palpabe un-

truths for the benefit of a subgroup. As **Guido de Giorgio** pointed out, the true light of God is faceted into a multiplicity through a hierarchy of spiritual beings. Each nation is under the guardianship of certain beings. However, in a state of disorder, an alien spirit may be (mis)guiding a nation. This requires keen discernment. Note that by nation, here, we mean fundamentally a group that is spiritually united before any other considerations, as we have described in the several posts on the Ancient City. These nations can be related vertically in a hierarchal way without destroying their individual characteristics.

Another point to note is who has the temporal power. In a Traditionally organized society, there is a caste devoted to that task, identified through their loyalty, fidelity, courage, and virility. Opposed to that, power is held by lower castes, such as the bourgeoisie or money powers, or else by the proletarian mentality. The latter is easily seen in terms of popular culture, styles of dress, values, religious beliefs, and so on. These can be compared to the greatest exemplars of art, poetry, traditional science, and so on. The complete degradation occurs when outcastes gain some measure of power. In a Traditional society, outcastes would have had no role at all. **Fustel de Coulanges** documents the role this played in the deterioration of the Greek Ancient City as well as in Rome.

Readers who find themselves interested in and of a mind to participate in contemporary political and cultural movements, have the conceptual tools from Tradition to do so. In looking over the landscape of self-identified conservatives or rightists of whatever stripe, learn to apply these principles. Discern how they view spiritual authority, do they even recognize higher principles, do they understand them. Ask how they view temporal power. Who will hold it? Are these movements composed of men with the right moral fiber? Are they manly in essence or just in outward appearance? Before supporting any such group morally, intellectually, or financially, learn to judge truly. Don't be deceived by a superficial agreement of goals that hide the lack of a common mind. Be

wise as serpents.

Posted on 2012-04-01 by Cologero

1.4 Vedanta and Western Tradition

> Lacking nothing, contemplative, immortal, self-originated, sufficed with a quintessence: he who knows that constant, ageless, and ever-youthful Spirit, knows himself and does not fear death.
>
> Shankara

In his important but little read essay, *The Vedanta and Western Tradition*, **Ananda Coomaraswamy** points the way for Europeans to come to an understanding of the metaphysics of the Vedanta. He begins with this advice:

> The educated man of today is completely out of touch with those European modes of thought and those intellectual aspects of the Christian doctrine which are nearest those of the Vedic traditions. *A knowledge of modern Christianity will be of little use because the fundamental sentimentality of our times has diminished what was once an intellectual doctrine to a mere morality that can hardly be distinguished from a pragmatic humanism*. A European can hardly be said to be adequately prepared for the study of the Vedanta unless he has acquired some knowledge and understanding of at least
>
> - Plato
> - Philo
> - Hermes Trismegistus

- Plotinus
- Gospel of John
- Dionysius the Areopagite
- Meister Eckhart
- Dante

> Eckhart, with the possible exception of Dante, can be regarded from an Indian point of view as the greatest of all Europeans.

Here are some of the major highlights:

- Metaphysics is not a system, but a consistent doctrine
- It is concerned not only with conditioned and quantitative experience, but also with universal possibility
- There are things which are beyond the reach of discursive thought and which cannot be understood except by denying things of them
- The immanent Spirit within you is the only knower, agent, and transmigrant
- Ultimate reality is a Supreme Identity in which the opposition of all contraries, even of being and not-being, is resolved
- Its "worlds" and "gods" are levels of reference and symbolic entities which are neither places nor individuals but states of being realizable within you
- For the metaphysician, it suffices to show that a false doctrine involves a contradiction of first principles
- The quest is achieved only when he himself has become the object of his search

- The Vedanta can be known only to the extent that it has been lived
- Man is unaware of this hidden treasure within himself because he has inherited an ignorance that inheres in the very nature of the psycho-physical vehicle which he mistakenly identifies with himself
- What is called "creation" in religion, is called "manifestation" in metaphysics
- Only when we are convinced that nothing happens by chance that the idea of Providence becomes intelligible
- Each human life has run its course when all its possibilities have been exhausted
- Whatever has been an eternal reason or idea or name of an individual manifestation can never cease to be such; the content of eternity cannot be changed
- All the states of being are within you, awaiting recognition

Posted on 2010-06-24 by Cologero

* * *

Dai Leon on 2010-06-25 at 02:07 said:

Coomaraswamy's insights continue to be widely unmatched except by the founders and key saints of the Great Tradition.

However, 'chance' becomes a first principle when understood as contingency which is invariably synchronistic. Thus, "Only when we are convinced that nothing happens by chance that the idea of Providence becomes intelligible" does not sufficiently penetrate the reality of Hierarchical Emergence and Fate on one side and Holistic Causality and Death on the other.

Cologero on 2010-06-25 at 08:33 said:

Are you denying the Principle of Sufficient Reason?

By "chance", I think he means an event that is unrelated to anything else, either empirically or transcendentally. Hence, I would regard "synchronicity", as that relationship. I don't think you would see "synchronicity" as something purely arbitrary and subjective. On the contrary, in this sense, synchronicity is an even stronger indication of Providence.

In a larger context, I don't see Coomaraswamy as advocating determinism as the opposite of "chance", if that is what you are objecting to.

`Will on 2010-06-27 at 11:04 said:`

Link to the full text:

`http://religioperennis.org/documents/acoomaraswamy/vedanta.pdf`

`Dai on 2022-06-25 at 17:07 said:`

Just now revisiting this conversation...I wholly agree with your observations Cologero. Just adding some clarification to what has scientifically become an overriding and limited scientific dogma of 'random chance' made from limited observations, projections and consciousness

1.5 Life without Logos

> We may regard the present state of the universe as the effect of its past and the cause of its future. An intellect which at a certain moment would know all forces that set nature in motion, and all positions of all items of which nature is composed, if this intellect were also vast enough to submit these data to analysis, it would embrace in a single formula the movements of the greatest bodies of the universe and those of the tiniest atom; for such an intellect nothing would be uncertain and the future just like the past would be present before its eyes.
>
> Pierre Simon Laplace, *A Philosophical Essay on Probabilities*

The dream of modernism and its handmaid science is to explain the **world**, **life**, and **thought** without recourse to anything transcendent. In other words, intelligibility, or logos, is claimed to be immanent in space

and time. The **Principle of Sufficient Reason** states that everything has its own reason for being; thus rationality, or reasonableness, means to know the reason or cause for whatever exists. As was shown in Intelligibility, Ideology and Occult Scientific Theories[3], the ultimate explanations of science involve uncertainty, indeterminateness, randomness, or unconsciousness. Thus, Science is inherently irrational so its promise of a rational theory of everything has, despite its many local successes, been unfulfilled.

World Our knowledge of the world is limited, in principle, by the Heisenberg Uncertainty Principle[4]. This proves that it is not just difficult, but actually impossible, to know simultaneously both the position and the motion of any particle. Hence the Laplacean project is stillborn.

Life The fundamental principle of Darwinian evolution is random variation, which is fundamentally the lack of a rational explanation that would explain in any detail the transition from one species to another. Nevertheless, proponents of evolution subtly, or not so subtly, sneak in teleological explanations. One example is the search for the so-called missing link[5]. This implicitly assumes a direction to evolution, from the lower to the higher. However, if evolution is truly random, it seems curious that evolution never runs backwards; for example, a human group could devolve back to apes, or a frog into a fish.

It also tacitly assumes the existence of an essence that changes its form over time. Thus the missing link is said to evolve from one form to the next. In actuality, the missing link is eliminated as unfit for survival, in a sense a "mistake" or evolutionary dead end, and replaced by another species.

[3] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1104

[4] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Heisenberg_uncertainty_principle

[5] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Missing_link

Thought In accounting for the existence of thought, psychology is led to unconscious psychic forces, or even bioelectrochemical processes, that determine the thoughts, and hence the actions, of man. No one can control his thoughts, nor even predict what he will think of five minutes from now. Rather than a "rational" animal and master of himself, man is inherently irrational and subject to forces of which he is ultimately unaware.

Summary Notice what this argument shows.

- First of all, it is not anti-science, nor does it dispute the legitimate discoveries and theories of science.
- Second, the point is not that the scientific enterprise is not as objective and impartial as claimed. This is obvious, not just to a Feyerabend or a Kuhn, but to any observer.
- Third, it is not a question of the incomplete state of science in which new explanations could, in principle, be discovered in the future.

No, the point is that science, insofar as it claims to be profane and independent of transcendence, is fundamentally and irremediably irrational in the sense that it is ignorant of the sufficient reason for the appearance of life, thought, and the world itself. *This is not simply due to the lack of knowledge, but rather to the lack of the very possibility of knowledge.*

Posted on 2010-12-28 by Cologero

1.6 Heredity and the Law of Attraction

The metaphysical foundation of the Law of Attraction, reincarnation, race, heredity.

The Law of Attraction A lot of pop spirituality comes from deformations and misunderstandings of Traditional teachings. Among them is the so-called **Law of Attraction**, the notion that our thoughts can attract persons, things and event into our lives simply by thinking of them. Obviously, this usually fails since no one can control and concentrate his thoughts to extent necessary, and his mind is a mixture of some positive but mostly negative thoughts. When it does appear to produce desired results, it is because its true source is much deeper than thought.

Being and Manifestation As we have previously mentioned spirit is the non-formal manifestation of a being[6]. That is, it can never be the object of consciousness. Another way of putting it is that it is noumenal, not phenomenal.

Now, the human state is just one possible state of the being. The being is not fully determined, but has an indefinite number of possibilities of manifestation. The human state is one such state where those possibilities can be made manifest or actualized. Since every being has his own particular nature, destiny, and possibilities, when he manifests in the human state, he must necessarily attract those conditions which are compossible with his own nature and possibilities.

So there are two factors to be considered. The first is what originates from the being-in-itself, that is, the being as transcendent to manifestation, or the active factor. The second is what proceeds from the totality of the environmental influences arising from immanent manifestation; this is the passive factor.

We are all familiar with the notion of physiological heredity. The being is manifesting in a certain environment in a certain current of time. Hence, he will necessarily depend on genetic and other material factors that form his corporeal state, or gross manifestation.

[6] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1539`

But there is also the question of subtle manifestation, which is itself subject to heredity. So the being not only inherits a physical body, but also an astral body, by which we mean no more than the sum total of thoughts, emotions, desires, and so on that properly are part of subtle manifestation.

Family, Nation, Race The manifestation of the being as a member of the species homo sapiens is not arbitrary, but depends on factors intrinsic to the spirit. Hence, his gender, sexuality, family, nation, and race — the factors that constitute his corporeal and psychic hereditary — as not contingent, but are attracted to the being as the field where he can actualize his possibilities or life-project. With this understanding of heredity, we can see the metaphysical foundation for Evola's distinction of the races of the body, soul, and spirit.

Accidents and Relationships Our roles, identities, pasts, and so on cannot be understood as accidental, since they are manifestations of who we are. Everything that "happens" to us in life, whether good or bad, needs to be seen from that perspective.

Similarly, all our relationships, both positive and negative, are elements of the cosmic environment that we attracted, both synchronically and diachronically.

The Problem of Births Traditional societies relied on arranged marriages and even astrological considerations to better plan births, at least for the higher castes. Nowadays, everything is allowed to occur at random, allowing the incarnation of beings that would have not been possible at other points in the cosmic cycle.

Reincarnation Psychic residues left behind by a being at his death can form part of the subtle heredity of another being. If this influence is

strong enough and organized to a sufficient extent, the newly incarnated being may interpret this as evidence of reincarnation. This is so particularly since his self-identity is usually restricted to the psychic realm. This is why the Hermetist **Valentin Tomberg** can state that reincarnation is an objective fact, but not a spiritual reality. It is a fact in the sense that the astral remains of one being take root in another, though it does not constitute the spiritual realty of either.

Forgetfulness of Being True being is beyond both subtle and gross manifestation, but in the process of manifestation modern men forget their real being. Instead, their self-identify lies in the astral body, which is interpret to be the center of interiority. They falsely attribute their essential nature to it, and thus deny the possibility of psychic heredity. Or else, they admit psychic heredity but then conclude that being is totally determined by environmental factors.

So, for all practical purposes man is indeed limited to hereditary and environmental factors. In his forgetfulness of being, he is then subjected to the influences of the cosmic environment unconsciously. He experiences this negatively as a limitation to his being, whereas in reality it is simply a privation or restriction excluding certain possibilities. In sum, he is passive in respect to the environment.

Try, then, to remember. Remember who you are. Your environment, family, body, mind were willed by you at the deepest level to be in conformity with your nature and destiny. The people you are in relationship are there for a reason, because you chose them. A chance encounter, book or idea is intended for you. Be attentive and conscious at all times to their meaning or purpose. They are not a limitation on your freedom, but rather an opening to being.

Posted on 2011-02-06 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2011-02-07 at 18:18 said:

A good history of the Hermetic roots of the "Law of Attraction" and a long list of earlier American snake oil concepts:

Secret Source: The Law of Attraction Is One of Seven Ancient Hermetic Laws: Here Are the Other Six by Adam Parfrey

http://www.amazon.com/Secret-Source-Attraction-Ancient-Hermetic/dp/1934170070/ref=sr_1_7?s=books&ie=UTF8&qid=1297120616&sr=1-7

Senko on 2012-12-11 at 19:52 said:

Very nice post Cologero, how each being is determined wether by inheritance, ambience, state of beings or its own peculiar possibilities is one of those points that are never explained totaly explicit and in full by Guenón

1.7 Tilting at Windmills

There is a constant misunderstanding that seeks to treat metaphysics as a philosophy or system of thought, like perennialism, that can be studied and debated from the outside. Quite the contrary, it is more like an empirical science, although that data observed are in consciousness. Even better, the metaphysician is more like an explorer such as Columbus or Lewis and Clark. He explores the contents of his consciousness, discovers new things, and only then begins to codify them. **Rene Guenon** writes in his Hindu Doctrines:

> The real difficulty [in understanding metaphysics] is the mental assimilation needed to arrive at this result; there are certainly many minds that are quite incapable of it, and it is easy to gauge how far this effort transcends the scope of mere works of erudition. There is only one really profitable way of studying doctrines: in order to be understood they must be studied so to speak "from the inside" …

This is the third dimension of history that **Julius Evola** refers to; that dimension is depth which is really interiority. Hence, to understand meta-

physics or tradition, one must avoid the temptation of the demon of dialectics and try to engage that system in a living way, much as an explorer searching for an unexplored part of the mind. Hermetic meditation can be helpful in this regard: by an imaging, one tries to understand the state of mind of a writer or speaker.

Metaphysical Pathology Yet, as Guenon points out, few minds are capable of it. To answer why, we need to refer to the esoteric doctrine that what Guenon observes is necessarily so. Although there are many beings with a human form, only the few are capable of activating the dimension of spirit. This doctrine cannot be exoteric, since it would lead to all sorts of misunderstandings. Rather than looking for spiritual qualities, common men will try to separate men based on contingent and accidental qualities. Yet, the implication is there in the teaching on predestination. How else can we understand it?

Is it possible, then, to determine the inner state of another man? Perhaps some few enlightened beings can read a man's soul directly, but otherwise, keeping in mind the principle that the lesser cannot judge the higher, there are clues to notice. Since the outer is the reflection of the inner, a man's posture, voice, expression, and so on, often give away a lot. For example, it can be determined how conscious he is by whether his spirit dominates the soul which dominates the body, or, as is more likely, the other way around.

However, we can start at a more basic level. Since a man's understanding of metaphysics depends on his own self-knowledge, we can get an idea of his state of self-knowledge by the opinions he professes to believe. If his self-knowledge lacks breadth or depth, that will show up in his philosophy of life.

For example, I once heard an on-line lecture by a quite intelligent man who claimed a 160 IQ. Nevertheless, he regarded his own inner life as the product of electro-chemical reactions in the brain. Now, there may

arise in some the urge to debate him and claim that consciousness and the soul really exist and are irreducible to material causation. Or, we could simply take him at his word. The man may simply have an impoverished inner life, whether through lack of effort or by the very nature of his constitution.

Another claim I sometimes hear, and even once from a professor, is that guilt is a Jewish invention and has no part in the Western tradition. To debate that directly is a fool's errand. The way to deal with it is by way of a phenomenology of guilt. We observe the experience in our consciousness and see how it arises. If we see it associated with the forces of chaos or neurotic instincts or false charges whose goal is manipulation, then we transcend them. Otherwise, guilt may reveal something fundamental about us. For example, **Martin Heidegger** claims to have (re)discovered a primordial sense of guilt. Now, it may very well be the case that the professor in his own consciousness cannot detect any sense of guilt. Unfortunately, this is not indicative of any higher state of mind. Rather, it is a psychological pathology which goes by the name of **sociopathy**, so don't trust such a man with your money, your daughter, or your reputation.

A third example, this time indicating an acute form of **paranoia**, is the not infrequent claim that "Jews" are implanting Semitic ideas in our minds. Unfortunately, there is little specificity, so these alien ideas are simply ideas that the claimant doesn't like. Now, on **Terence**'s principle that *nothing human is alien to me*, we need to look within ourselves for the source of such ideas; after all, a virus cannot take hold in an organism without the appropriate receptors. But the paranoid always experiences such ideas as coming from outside him. This is a pathology where the Persona projects undesired qualities onto the Shadow[7].

Otto Weininger made an effort to define exactly what are Aryan and Semitic ideas. While some of his insights are useful, his use of those terms is not at all helpful and just leads to misunderstanding. Weininger

[7] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1815`

does qualify it by separating the Platonic ideal of Aryanity and the Semitic anti-ideal from their presence in specific races or ethnic groups. We prefer to refer to the forces of Order and the forces of Chaos, which we have defined on too many posts to link to. We observe them within ourselves. To the extent that the forces of chaos exert influence on us, they are a privation; that is, a force that by our nature we should overcome, but we have not yet developed the inner strength to oppose it. That is our real battle, not *tilting at windmills*.

Posted on 2011-09-19 by Cologero

* * *

> Cologero on 2011-09-19 at 12:39 said:
> There is a world of difference between transcending guilt and not being aware of it at all.
> We see a similar thing in Buddhism in the West, which attracts a lot of weak men. That is because they hear doctrines like the "no-self", and then, because they have such a weak sense of self within, they assume they are close to enlightened Buddhahood. But it is only the man with a strong self who is capable of transcending that self who is a Buddha; not at all, the man who never had any sense of self at all.

1.8 Ontotheology

Before moving on to the discussion of the One and the Many, it is necessary to clarify some terms. The position of Gornahoor is ontotheological[8], which we believe is consistent with Guenonian metaphysics and the Western tradition. By this we mean the deep relationship of God or Absolute, Being, and Logos. However, unlike Western philosophy (such as Aristotle, Aquinas, Hegel), which is incomplete since it equates the Absolute with Being, metaphysics does not stop at Being since that doesn't

[8] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1299

take into account the Infinitude of Total Possibility. However, this is not our concern at the moment.

Ontotheology met with criticism from Kant, who regarded it as abstract, to Heidegger, who considered it the "forgetfulness of Being". It is abstract if the only experience admitted is synthetic, but we recognize a form of knowledge beyond abstract thought, that is, a direct intuition of higher states.

If all experience is synthetic, then we are faced with the representation of the World as a series of discrete experiences. From those experiences, the philosopher then constructs a mental abstraction. In contrast, the metaphysician understands experience as a "seamless, indefinable, alogical continuum" (Woodroffe), so it is grasped as a whole, beyond time and space.

Sat, Chit, Ananda In Tantra, the Universe of Experience has three aspects common to all objective experience: Being (the object is), Consciousness (it is known), and Pleasure (the experience is pleasant). Hence, Being is inseparable from the knowing subject, as "to be" is "to be conscious". A higher level of being means a deeper level of consciousness. The ability to realize higher states is a measure of Power. Higher states involve more wholeness and fullness, or limitless which is experienced as bliss. The diminution of being — limitation or privation — is experienced as pain.

Existence Existence is the manifestation of possibilities and a World is the manifestation of compossibilities. A World is one state of Total Existence, which comprises all possibilities of manifestation, since the possible must become real in some way. However, Being is the principle of manifestation, so Being never is manifested as such. Thus, from the metaphysical point of view, God does not "exist" in this sense. In passing, we can note that both Guenon and Woodroffe include the idea of

multiple worlds as Traditional teachings; this is the metaphysical analog of the "multiverse".

Logos The Primordial Tradition includes the existence of a "cosmic and juridical order"[9], the two aspects of which correspond to the Logos and the implementation of justice in the world. This is co-extensive with Being, otherwise it would be a limitation on Being. It is the principle of compossibility, as only the rational is real, and what is possible is related to everything else in manifestation.

Actualization Increase in Being is far from abstract. Being is not known without a corresponding change in state. Thus, Being is known most fully when it is actualized in the world through power. As an example, let us take a widely known tune, say, *Somewhere over the Rainbow*. As a phrase, it is an abstract idea. You may "hear" the song in your head, giving it some degree of existence or perhaps hum it, giving it a little more. A band will perform the song, giving it full existence. Note that as real, the song is manifested over time, although it is a single idea. It cannot happen "all at once" or else it would be a muddle of cacophony.

References *The World as Power*, John Woodroffe
The Multiple States of Being, Rene Guenon
Hegel and the Hermetic Tradition, Glenn Magee

Posted on 2011-04-06 by Cologero

1.9 Christendom and the Superstition of Fact

It seems necessary at this time to make some ideas clear, as least, clearer. First of all, metaphysics is not the same thing as philosophy. Metaphysics

[9] https://gornahoor.net/?p=2053

is knowing, an activity of spirit, active and masculine. Philosophy is thinking, an activity of the soul, passive, and feminine. A man knows himself to be free, with an active will; he has no need to wade through several hundred pages of Kant to convince himself of what he knows in his own immediacy.

A warrior acts courageously because it is an expression of his nature, his being. An artist can portray a courageous man in a poem or play, but is not thereby courageous himself. A philosopher will debate the meaning of courage, but will always end in aporia. If a scout comes back to camp with news that the enemy is on the march, a debate about the meaning of the other will not then ensue. Nor will anyone attempt to achieve the synthesis between the self and the other as enemy.

When we write of doctrines, we mean metaphysical doctrines, not specifically religious or theological doctrines. Here are some quotes from *Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power* by Rene Guenon that clarify Gornahoor's point of view:

> During the Middle Ages there existed throughout the West a real unity, based on properly traditional foundations, which we call 'Christendom', but when these secondary unities of a purely political — that is to say temporal and no longer spiritual — order were formed this great unity of the West was irremediably broken and the effective existence of Christendom came to an end. Nations, merely the dispersed fragments of what was formerly Christendom, false unities substituted for the true one by the temporal power's will to dominate can, given the very conditions of their origin, survive only by opposing each other and ceaselessly contending among themselves in all fields. Now **spirit is unity**, **matter is multiplicity and division**; and the more one removes oneself from spirituality, the more antagonisms are accentuated and amplified.

The last sentence speaks for itself. Please understand the following

point thoroughly.

> When speaking of Catholicism the utmost care must always be taken to distinguish between what conerns Catholicism itself as a doctrine and what relates only to the present organizational state of the Catholic church. Whatever one may think about the second, it cannot affect the first. ... there are very few today who are able, when such a need arises, to free themselves from historical contingencies, to the extent that certain defenders of Catholicism, not only its adversaries, believe that everything can be reduced to a simple question of historicity, which is one form of the modern **superstition of fact**.

As for the continuity of the Roman Tradition, Guenon points out

> The symbolic assimilation of Christ with Janus as the supreme prinnciple of the two powers is the very clear sign of a **certain traditional continuity** (*too often ignored or deliverately denied*) **between ancient Rome and Christian Rome**; and we must not forget that in the Middle Ages the empire was just as Roman as the papacy.

Posted on 2011-01-27 by Cologero

* * *

Perennial on 2011-01-28 at 02:34 said:
Great article! The material here is getting better and better!

Mark on 2011-01-28 at 02:40 said:
I will start out by stating that I accept the view of Guenon in *Introduction to the Study of the Hindu Religions* about the character of Vedanta as a Pure Metaphysics that is elaborated in the chapter titled *Essential Character of Metaphysics*, and I will quote part of the first sentence.

"While the religious point of view necessarily implies the intervention of an element drawn from the sentimental order, the metaphysical point of view is exclusively intellectual".

So, let's not be concerned with sentimental attachments to paganism, Islam, Catholicism, etc.. Let us seek after what embodies Metaphysics. For this I will use Vedantic notions of the Brahman.

Definition: Brahman is Satyam (Truth), Jnanam (Knowledge), Anantam (Infinity), Anandam (Bliss), and Amalatava (Unstainable Purity). I have read this before as Satyam being perfect, unchangeable Being, Jnanam being Consciousness that is unrestricted, Anantam being unconditioned, not limited by space and time, for Anandam, bliss is a good enough description, and Amalatava means unstained by karma. So here we see a concept of pure metaphysics of the unconditioned, and it is a key doctrine of the Advaita school, which is the favorite of Guenon that the highest state is the merging of the Atman and Brahman.

Here we see a metaphysics of what I like to call "Transtheism", which is the proper position of the Indo-European religions. The gods are not denied, but what transcends them is a state of Absolute Being, which we can attain. Here is my argument.

1) The "Transtheism" that is stated by Vedanta is pure Metaphysics

2) The Indo-European systems that we would call colloquially as Slavic paganism, Norse paganism, Baltic paganism, Hellenic paganism, and the other Indo-European paganisms are properly transtheistic

3) Any form of Christianity cannot be transtheistic, given its Abrahamic character it is monotheistic. God will always be seen as distinct from man, and the contingent and dependent nature of man upon a distinct being (God) cannot be transcended.

4) Accepting the notion of what is syncretic vs synthesis as to deal with what is congruent vs incongruent, then the "paganisms" synthesize with the Vedantic metaphysics, since they are congruent, whereas Christianity is syncretic with the Vedantic metaphysics, since it is incongruent with it.

5) Therefore systems like Rodnovery and Asatru are a superior choice to Christianity since they synthesize with Vedanta, as opposed to being syncretic like Christianity, since it is incongruent with the Metaphysics of Vedanta.

6) The only choice for Christianity over one of our pre-Christian traditions is due to sentimentalism, and not Metaphysics.

Perennial on 2011-01-28 at 02:52 said:

I am not sure about that Mark. In Eastern theology we often see theosis emphasis, of man becoming a god, so to speak. It has been observed that Christ came and died so that we may be like Him by realizing that oneness, and union, with Him who is Eternal, that is God. In other words, Christ came to show how we may be Him. Shedding the ignorance of our material existence, while not condemning it, will help us to realize our transcendent nature and come into gnosis of Eternal Truth. The Sacraments are just an exterior means of finding this Truth (i.e. "a means of grace"), just like meditation and ascetic practice. As means, they are a help. When they become

ends in themselves, then the inner signifigance is lost, and the Sacrament becomes merely exoteric, as it has today. The Tridentine Mass was lost because the entire foundation of why it was built was lost to a utilitarian, populist, and democratic theology. But turning God into an object of worship does not make Him an idol.

Mark on 2011-01-28 at 03:05 said:
So, do you deny 3? Tell me the propositions that you deny, and why?

Perennial on 2011-01-28 at 03:37 said:
It is somewhat difficult to find the right words to describe it. This is why Eastern theologians always emphasized being apophatic, or only addressing what God and theology is not, rather then is. But I will give my best:

Religion is often described to mean "to bind back." All creation is seeking to come back to the One, the Holy Trinity. Creation is distinct because of the Fall, but duality did not exist for Adam & Eve. In Him "they lived, and moved, and had their being." The Fall brought ignorance, and thus duality, and loss of understanding. Thus, the narrative of man since the Fall is a "binding back," since man must now rediscover that union that was lost. This is why Adam realized he was naked, because the higher Self was subsumed by the lower self, and in partaking of the forbidden fruit he actually rejected transendance in favour of the material. He did not recognize the material as "seperate" prior to the Fall. The knowledge of good and evil meant a loss of understanding. This is Original Sin. The loss of original unity, and the loss of transendence, is now the common inheritance of all men, and thus he cannot be "saved" without rising to the higher self, and thus by Holy Baptism he rejects ignorance and embraces the path toward his higher nature. As man thus progresses, in Soul, Spirit, and Sacrament, he loses the lower self and understands the Mysteries of the Divine, if he seeks them meetly. Eventually, the old self will die away, and he will Resurrect on the last day, the whole man, and be reconciled back unto the One, entering eternal and undivided union, in full knowledge of the Truth. He will not be absorbed into God, but will "... clothe (y)ourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ, and not think about how to gratify the desires of the flesh." (St. Paul to the Roman 13:14) Christ thus came and died that we might follow Him, not as slavish worshipers, but "If any man will come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me." (St. Matthew 16:24) To follow Christ is to be Christ, and do as He did, and sacrifice to lower self to the higher. "For whosoever will save his life shall lose it; but whosoever shall lose his life for my sake and the Gospel's, the same shall save it." (St. Mark 8:33-35). This is how Christ is Our Saviour. He came to show the Way of Truth and Liberation, and this is to free us from material bondage and embark on the eternal. Only through gnosis can a man find the One, but through exoteric practice one at least begins the journey.

Perennial on 2011-01-28 at 03:41 said:

So yes, I would say 3 is an error, since it is presumed, not proven, and in fact I think evidence shows otherwise. 4,5, & 6 are therefore ipso facto erroneous, as they are based on 3. That being said, in order for this and 1 and 2 to be judged, I request that you expand upon your definition of "Transtheism." I myself am a Panentheist (all things exist in God, and are therefore not outside of, or foreign to, Him).

Mark on 2011-01-28 at 04:27 said:

I am not sure that you understand the metaphysics of Advaita Vedanta, so the Sanskrit terms that I use might not be understood, and this might be the problem why you do not understand what I mean by "Transtheism". The idea is that the Metaphysical "God" is the conditions that transcend existence. So, you are no longer conditioned in any way, you are no longer in the flux of becoming, but you are Satyam, you are no longer limited in intellect, but Jnanam, you are no longer conditioned by time, space, and causation, but Anantam, you are no longer tainted by Karma, but Amalatava, and you experience perfect bliss (Anandam).

In Christianity, you always remain a contingent being under the conditioning factor of a separate and distinct being (God). No Abrahamic religion can be transtheistic, since their deity is always a distinct being.

This is actually quite for wikipedia: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Transtheism

Another reason that I like the term is that a rather good view of it is in Ride the Tiger in a chapter called Beyond Atheism and Theism

Perennial on 2011-01-28 at 06:35 said:

I am not sure how what I described differs what you described. Perhaps you could elaborate? I speak of reaching liberation, where the fiction that seperates your from your Creator disappears. There is a Creator, and we are the created. Obviously, we are limited by the words we have, but essentially the Creator and the created share a like substance (God created us out of Himself, therefore we are "in His Image" and are like unto Him. We need to lose our duality and be with Him, in Him, in the Unity of the Holy Ghost. We are only seperate in nature (i.e. we are not God by design) but not in essence (the spirit returns to it's source, the One). When we become theosis, we will no longer be a seperate being, but "Very God." We shall be a unique component of His Oneness, but shall be of it nonetheless.

So either I am not understanding what you are trying to say, or you not understanding me. We shall see.

Cologero on 2011-01-28 at 08:45 said:

Please restrict your discussion to 'Christendom' as Guenon defined it above, not some ill-defined "Christianity".

Gornahoor has addressed what is being called "transtheism" ... find it and discuss it please.

The typical pagan man in the street was a polytheist. The philosophical elite and their aristocratic followers were monotheists and did not even accept the existence of the gods.

Asatru is a fabricated system and quite modernist. The very idea of making a "choice" is modernist.

Boris Mouravieff wrote a monograph on Slavic paganism. Please locate it and discuss it if you like.

You can debate systems of belief all you want, but Gornahoor is focusing on states of consciousness that can be attained. Without that, all discussions are futile and result from a fundamentally materialist mindset.

Cologero on 2011-01-28 at 10:45 said:

What Buddha Suggested

> Do not be led by hearsay
> or by what is handed down by tradition
> or by what people say,
> or by what is stated by the authority of your traditional teachings.
> Be not led by reasoning,
> nor by inferring,
> nor by argument as to method,
> nor by delight in speculative opinions,
> nor by seeming possibilities,
> nor by the directions from your teachers.
>
> But, when you know of yourself
> that certain actions done by you are not good,
> wrong and considered worthless by the wise;
> when followed and put in to practice,
> lead to loss or suffering, then give them up ...
> and when you know of yourself that
> certain actions done by you are good, true
> and considered worthy by the wise,
> then accept them and put them into practice.
>
> ... ..
>
> I have shown you the methods that lead to liberation.
> But you should know that liberation depends upon yourself.

1.10 The Superstition of Science

If the intellectual elect comes one day to be constituted, the essential end which it will have to work for is the return of the West to a traditional civilization and we have the example of the Middle Ages ... It would be a question, not of copying or reconstituting purely and simply what existed then, but of drawing inspiration from it for the adaptation made necessary... It can only be done by using both what the East has to offer and also whatever traditional elements remain in the West.

> The superiority of Europeans over Asiatics is their trained ability to give reasons for what they believe—something of which the latter are wholly incapable ... Europe was made Europe by reason in the schools; in the Middle Ages Europe was on the way to becoming a piece and an appendix of Asia again—by losing the scientific sense that it owed to the Greeks.
>
> Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, All Too Human*

> The civilization of the modern West has, among other pretensions, that of being eminently "scientific".
>
> Rene Guenon, *East and West*

Nothing can be clearer than this contrast between Friedrich Nietzsche, the prophet of the postmodern world, and Rene Guenon, the prophet of Tradition. Guenon calls the idols of modernity, viz. Science, Progress, Civilization, Right, Liberty, a sort of religion that replaced Tradition, but is better called a counter-religion. This faux religion originates the modern epoch. In Nietzsche's words:

> The anti-traditional spirit showed itself at once by the proclaiming of "free examination," or, in other words, the absence, in the doctrinal order, of any principle higher than individual opinions. The inevitable result was intellectual anarchy; hence the indefinite multiplicity of religious and pseudo-religious sects, philosophic systems aiming above all at originality, and scientific theories as pretentious as they are ephemeral, in short, unbelievable chaos which is, however, dominated by a certain unity, there being beyond doubt a specifically modern outlook which is the source of it all, though this unity is altogether negative, since it is nothing more or less than an *absence of principle, expressed by that indifference with regard to truth and error* which ever since the 19th century has been called "tolerance".

Guenon mentions the irony that the apostles of tolerance, like all propagandists, are often the most intolerant men. Those who wished to overthrow all dogma have created new dogmas, which are really caricatures of dogma. We leave it to the reader to discern those dogmas, keeping in mind that a dogma is that which can never be doubted, whether or not it be true. Nietzsche's specific complaint against the Eastern cast of mind is this:

> Asia still does not know how to distinguish between truth and poetry, and is not conscious of whether its convictions are derived from personal observation and methodical thinking or from fantasies.

Guenon addresses the same point from the opposite end:

> Westerners, who advertise so insolently on every occasion belief in their own superiority and in that of their science, are really very much beside the mark when they call eastern wisdom "arrogant," on the grounds that is does not submit to the limitations that they are used to, and because they cannot allow what goes beyond these limitations.

Hence, Nietzsche's praise of the scientific spirit comes at the cost of rejecting all that is not science, such as poetry or "fantasy". Let us recall that fantasy is one of the five wits of the Medievals[10]. Thus, a **Dante** becomes for him a piece of Asia in the West. Now Guenon does not deny it.

> There is one fact which is incontestable: medieval Europe had from time to time, if not continuously, relations with the Orientals, and these relations had considerable effect in the realm of ideas; it is known, but perhaps not fully as yet, how much medieval Europe owed to the Arabs, who are the natural intermediaries between the West and the more distant parts of the East; and there was also direct contact with central Asia and even with China.

Not only does Guenon not deny it, but he encourages it, and not only encourages it, but deems it mandatory. He gives us our task, the mission of the future elect:

> It is only an indirect assimilation of the eastern doctrines that could bring to birth the first elements of the **future elect**; we mean that the initiative would have to come from individuals who had developed themselves through their understanding of these doctrines, but without being too directly connected with the East, and on the contrary keeping in touch with everything valid that may still exist in the western civilization, and especially with the traces of traditional outlook that have managed to survive there, despite the modern outlook, chiefly under the form of religion.
>
> All they can do is to expound their Oriental doctrines in a form more suited to the West, and to bring out the possibilities of agreement which their understanding of these doctrine still has revealed to them.

Posted on 2012-01-16 by Cologero

[10] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3559`

1.11 The People of Words

An important aspect to Tradition — which is difficult for those committed to egalitarianism to accept — is that not everyone is constitutionally able to grasp the principles of metaphysics. That is why there cannot be a "traditionalist school", or system of thought, open to everyone willy-nilly. That is why there can be no question of "influence". There are those who know and those who believe; knowledge is infallible by definition. Beliefs are open to debate. **Rene Guenon** explains in *Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power*.

> Knowledge par excellence — the only kind that truly deserves that name in its fullest sense — is knowledge of principles, independent of all contingent applications and this belongs exclusively to those who possess spiritual authority because there is nothing in it deriving from the temporal order.

The most difficult notion to get across is that words are at best the means, not the goal; rather the goal is metaphysical realization. **Ibn Arabi**, in his meditation on Seth mentions the *mutakallim*, i.e., the people of words. These are the theologians and philosophers who are unable to practice reflection and meditation. Ibn Arabi describes such people in the meditation on Jethro:

> As for the philosophers and masters of thought among the ancients and the mutakallimun in their discourse on the self and its whatness, none of them stumbled onto its reality, and logical speculation can never provide it. He who seeks knowledge of it by means of logical speculation, swells himself up and boasts without vigour or substance. "They are those whose efforts in the life of this world are misguided while they suppose that they are doing good." (Quran 18:104) He who seeks the matter by other than its path will not achieve its realization.

It is hubris to presume that God can be known just by reading some books or following the "perennial philosophy", as though God can be encompassed in some philosophical system. Any profane philosophy, even so-called perennial philosophy, is about the temporal order, the world of the senses. As such, it can never achieve true knowledge.

Nor does Tradition have anything to do with the study of ancient religions. Tradition means what is handed down; it does not mean a return to some imagined past. The Infinite cannot repeat itself, so there is no going back.

Esoteric knowledge is not some hidden "secret" that you share with your friends, that supposedly provides a key to understand everything. It is an "open" secret in the sense that it is in public view. However, some will be able to see it, but most will not. As Guenon writes:

> truths of a certain order by their very nature resist all 'popularization': however clearly that they are set out and only those who are qualified to understand them will understand them, and for all others they will be as if they did not exist.
>
> In the end, the real secret, the only secret than can never be betrayed in any way, resides uniquely in the inexpressible, which is by the same token incommunicable, every truth of a transcendent order necessarily partaking of the inexpressible

Most decidedly, it is not about a "school" that enters into debate with other schools. The object of metaphysics is being, and that means the knowledge of essences. Knowledge is infallible so as soon as this truth is realized, there is no need to get involved in debates.

Knowledge

> The *mutakallim* sets himself apart from the realised ones among the People of God, who are endowed with unveiling and real existence.

Ibn Arabi

Knowledge begins with the senses, and then the imagination; symbols are in the imagination. However, it is necessary to abstract from the images to reach the pure intellect. Ultimately, even thoughts must be left behind.

It is said that when you know yourself, you know God. That is not because of human effort. Rather, God is the mirror in which you see yourself in your perfection because you can never see God, just as you don't see the mirror when you look at your reflection.

Our goal is therefore to await the unveiling of God and real existence, not the accumulation of words. If that is our disposition, then the prayer will be answered.

Note This is as it should be, since not everyone has the aptitude nor the interest in the subject. Most people are more interested in practical matters, i.e., activities in the temporal order. So the point of this post is to address the abuse of metaphysical ideas.

Posted on 2021-09-05 by Cologero

1.12 The World Is Intelligible

> There is an extraordinary amount of wrong thinking in our day. One can suffer the pains of martyrdom from the terribly illogical life of the world. Anyone who has acquired a certain clairvoyance does not simply feel that one thing is correct and another incorrect, but he suffers actual pain when confronted by illogical thinking, and a sense of well-being in connection with clear, transparent thinking.
>
> Rudolf Steiner

I think many people experience that pain without understanding the cause. That is why they get so angry when they are confronted with illogical ideas, or even threatening logical ideas.

Main points The world is intelligible. That is believed without reason by the scientist, but known by the metaphysician.

It takes effort to engage in logical thinking despite all the resources available.

The human being is defined as the "rational animal". The human has the features of corporeal things, living things, animals, but adds rationality. The failure to act intelligibility is the failure to actualize all one's possibilities as a human.

God desires to be known.

The purpose of intelligence is to know the Good; only the good is worthy of love.

Space and time are not neutral containers in which events occur.

Space and time are fundamental and cannot be explained by a simpler concept

Just as space is "lumpy", i.e., warped by massive objects, so also is time. Events can only happen at fortuitous times and places.

Consciousness is likewise fundamental and nothing exists without a being able to be conscious of it.

Human consciousness changes over time. That is why it is difficult to understand the mindset of previous ages.

The modern consciousness is stuck in subject-object thinking. It only thinks in terms of hypothesis formation, which cannot lead to certain knowledge.

The scientist presumes he is experiencing the world out there, right now. However, the soul is creating a representation of the world in its imagination.

Common sense is the faculty that combines sense data – which William

James called a "blooming, buzzing, confusion" – into a coherent representation of the external world.

The modern mind has also neglected the Self, assuming that science denies consciousness, the self, free will, etc. despite its obvious absurdity.

The Self is transcendent to the human being. The Self is unchanging. The human Ego, despite its fickleness, is mistakenly assumed to be the Self.

The Self manifests in different states, of which the human state is one of them.

The human state includes sheaths including the living soul, the animal soul, and the intellectual soul. They interpenetrate each other. In other words, the living soul has limited feelings and intelligence. The intellectual soul has emotional content, etc. This is known in esoteric schools which offer training in self-observation. This is not taught in universities.

There are states higher than the human. Few have experienced and written about them. Dante is one, but hardly the only one.

The formless causal state of deep sleep[11]; was known to the Medievals of the West, although nearly completely forgotten today.

Posted on 2021-09-16 by Cologero

[11] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=6848`

2

A primer on metaphysics

2.1 Sacred Science 101: Introduction

Our online discussions for 2022 begins with an extended commentary on *Man and his Becoming* by **Rene Guenon**. This is based on our new translation, which will be published by the end of the year. This translation will use contemporary English style, punctuation, and production layout. Sanskrit words will be rendered in today's common usage with diacritics removed.

However, the goal of this series is to reframe the metaphysics based on Adi Shankara's explanation of the Vedanta, in Western terms. Guenon provides several examples of how that might be done, based primarily on Hermetic and Scholastic metaphysics. This will require a new vocabulary; this poses its own problems because there is no consistent terminology that we can rely on.

Our approach is not merely intellectual, but also phenomenological, i.e., the inner experiences associated with the doctrines will be described insofar as it is possible. Hence, it will be tied into practical exercises to

develop awareness and understanding. Without that, many of the concepts described will be difficult to understand. The ultimate goal is to maintain Tradition in the West, the best we can.

What follows are highlights from previously published posts. Each topic will be treated in more detail as time goes on.

The Descent of the Absolute In *Man and his Becoming*, **Rene Guenon** describes the manifestation of the Self into the human state according to the Vedanta. The West has its own Traditional understanding. It is not different, but it is worth the trouble to redo the same project in more Western terms. This post can provide the barest outline.

By the Absolute, we mean generally what is called Brahman, that is, whatever is beyond being. The Self (Atman) is the principle of the individual. As such, the Self transcends all manifestation. The descent through the degrees of being begins with formless manifestation, then to formal manifestation in the subtle state and ultimately to the gross state, i.e., the corporeal body. This is not a process that occurs in time. Nor does the Self descend through these stages, since it is their principle.

The human state is said to be rare, in the sense that it is just one possible state out of many. The situation of the being in the human state allows the being to act in a way to acquire knowledge, unlike other states that are passive. Thus, it is special and should not be squandered.

These are the primary degrees although each one can be further divided, potentially indefinitely, into subdegrees. The Self becomes conscious of the world of sensible manifestation through:

- Thought
- Inward senses or wits
- Individual consciousness
- Five senses

- Five organs of action
- Life force

Buddhi The buddhi, Universal Spirit, or Higher Intellect, belongs to the realm of formless manifestation. As such it is the first degree of the manifestation of the Self. The possibilities of manifestation become ideas or essences in the Higher Intellect.

It is the principle of the formal manifestation of the Self and thus is the unifying principle. Rene Guenon calls it the "Spiritual Sun which shines at the center of the entire being." Put another way, it is the "spark of divinity," even if only virtually.

Thought is the faculty which gives form to ideas and associates them to each other. Intuition is how we experience the Higher Intellect, which is beyond discursive thought.

However, in the Higher Intellect, it is not yet individualized consciousness.

Manas The characteristics of the Manas, or Universal Soul, relate to faculties of the formal order.

Mental faculty or inward sense. Individual thought, memory, imagination

Five elements: Ether, air, fire, water, earth

Five Senses: hearing, touch, sight, taste, smell

Five Wits: memory, estimation, fantasy, imagination, and common sense

Five actions: Ingestion, excretion, reproduction, locomotion, grasping

From the esoteric perspective, the senses are prior in the ontological sense. Moderns believe that somehow matter is creating sensations in the brain, although the mind is already prepared to have sense experiences.

The same for the other features. The desire for locomotion and grasping, for example, direct evolution. They are not the serendipitous results of a random evolutionary process.

Posted on 2022-09-18 by Cologero

2.2 Sacred Science 102: The Self and the Ego

> Among those who receive the same teaching, each one understands and assimilates it more or less completely, more or less deeply, according to the extent of his own intellectual possibilities. … There are some who, in a certain sense, penetrate esotericism, while others stick to exotericism because their intellectual horizon is more limited.
>
> Rene Guenon

A common and serious error is to assume that metaphysical teachings are akin to philosophy, in the secular sense of the word. That is why some treat the teachings as a philosophical system that is open to debate and discussion. Such people misunderstand the distinction between immediate intellectual intuition and discursive thinking. The former is more like "seeing". Hence, the teachings must be directly intuited rather than proved through argument.

The Self The chapter on the Self and the Ego, from *Man and his Becoming*, lays the foundation for what is to come. This if the first distinction:

- **Self**: The transcendent and permanent principle of the being.
- **Ego**: The individual being, the transitory and contingent modification of the Self.

The Self is also called the personality[1], particularly in Medieval metaphysics. This is the traditional definition:

> [The] personality is that of which he has cognizance under the concept of "Self". It is that substantial, permanent, unitary entity, which is the subject of all the states and acts that constitute his complete life. An appeal to self-consciousness shows us that there is such a subject, of which thought, will, and feeling are modifications. It is substantial, i.e., not one or all of the changing states but the reality underlying them.
>
> *Catholic Encyclopedia*

The ego, then, is the individuality[2], defined as:

> An individual being is undivided in itself but separated from other beings. It implies therefore unity and separateness or distinctness. Individuality in general may be defined or described as the property or collection of properties by which the individual possesses this unity and is separated off from other beings.
>
> *Catholic Encyclopedia*

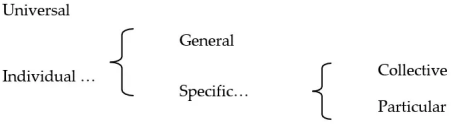
The human being is therefore the individuality, not the personality. Confusion arises because the meaning of the word Person has been altered. The original meaning is that the Person is unchanging and is never manifested. It is definitely not the thinking entity that experiences the world, and has emotions, thoughts, and a will. That is properly speaking the individuality. This must be kept firmly in mind.

Most especially, when God is referred to as a person, it is the above definition which must be kept in mind.

The Self is called the Atman in Sanskrit.

[1] `https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/11727b.htm`

[2] `https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/07762a.htm`



Aspects of Manifestation At the risk of oversimplification, we can describe how the states of manifestation are experienced.

- **Formal manifestation**. This includes what can be experienced, either through the senses for the gross or corporeal states, or the inner wits — such as sensations, emotions, images, thoughts — for the subtle states.
- **Formless manifestation**. This is still part of experience, but not as an object like formal manifestation. It is grasped through intuition.
- **Nonmanifestation**: this includes what is beyond being.

In secular terms, formless manifestation is like the noumenal, provided that is not understand as a philosophical conclusion, while formal manifestation is phenomenal, provided that includes experience of the subtle states.

Guenon provides a diagram to illustrate the process of manifestation. Each part will be explained in turn.

Universals This is the medieval understanding of universals:

> Universals are those ideas which, while excluding whatever constitutes the difference of things of the same genus or species, represent that which is necessary to their constitution, is essential, and is therefore common to all, remaining fixed in all vicissitudes. Universals are thus merely an expression of those Divine ideas

> which are concerned with the universal. Universal ideas are opposed to sense impressions, which represent that which is merely individual and contingent in a concrete phenomenon …

The highest knowledge is knowledge of the universals. Guenon explains:

> metaphysics is essentially the knowledge of the Universal, and such knowledge cannot be enclosed in any formula, however comprehensive it may be.

The Universal includes the unmanifested as well as formless manifestation. They are the principles of formal manifestation. Formless manifestation has Being but not individual Existence. The Individual states are all part of formal manifestation.

The *unmanifested state* comprises all the possibilities which are not susceptible of any manifestation, as well as the possibilities of manifestation themselves in principial mode. Formless manifestation is not part of multiplicity.

Individual, General, Specific, Categories The individual is a state of the Self, of which it is a reflection. It is related to the Universal through a series of genera and species, or the General and the Specific. The individual can only be a species, not a genus. This is illustrated by the Tree of Porphyry.

The unique individual is still not completely defined by the

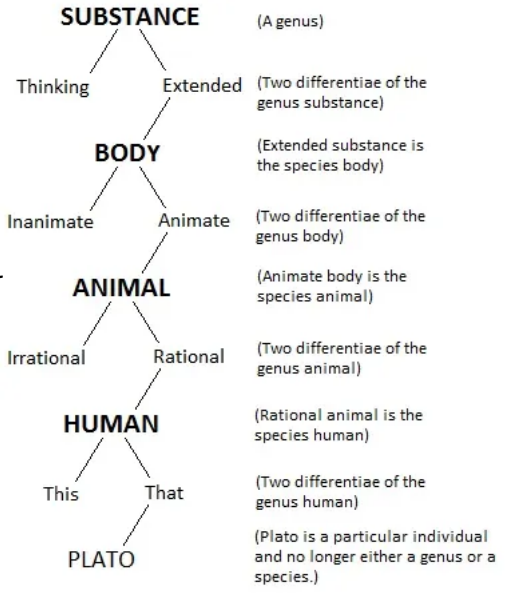


Figure 2.1: The tree of Porphyry

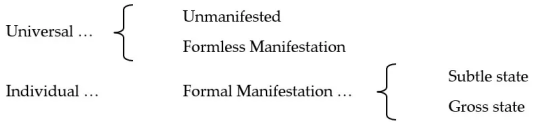


Figure 2.2: States of being.

genus and species. There are conditions that makes the individual unique. Aristotle's categories are genera that characterize the individual precisely. Among these conditions are time, place, qualities, and relations.

Guenon warns about those philosophers who consider the categories as universals. Thus, they will take a quality, such as a color, and try to make it universals. E.g., they will talk about the "idea of redness", etc.

The being that manifests is necessarily what it is, through its principal manifestation. It is not a matter of chance or fortune.

States of the being Another way to look at it, is from the perspective of the states of the being as shown in the diagram in the Fig. 2.2.

For the human being, there are two states that comprise it.

- **Gross state**: corporeal existence itself, to which human individuality belongs only through one of its modalities.
- **Subtle state**: the extra-corporeal modalities of the human being

Guenon elaborates:

> the human being, considered in its entirety, comprises a certain set of possibilities which constitute its corporeal or gross modality, plus a multitude of other possibilities which, extending in various senses beyond this one, constitute its subtle modalities.

The modern mind tends to regard the corporeal state as comprising the entire human being, with the subtle states just epiphenomena or otherwise reducible to the gross state.

However, even including the subtle state is inadequate. From the perspective of the Person, the human state is just one state among an indefinite number of other states. That is why the goal of metaphysics is to learn to transcend the human state. Liberation is achieved when all the limiting conditions are overcome.

Posted on 2022-09-22 by Cologero

* * *

.chris on 2022-09-26 at 18:24 said:

Is there, if I may humbly require so, canonical yet reasonably concise and systematic literature – regarding the immediate experiential distinction or cumulation of and inner-sense sharpening towards gross and subtle states and sensations and their proper attribution to origin, decoding mere intuition – which earns approval and commendation?

Apart from usually flat and rather ubiquitous reflections of corpo-catalytic alchemical ventures, e.g. tantrik initiate SK Ugranand described – in blog format – in lively, colourful yet clear-cut fashion the phenomenology of amplified subtle and divergent states of being-sensation: waves of energy or unadultered emotion, rhythm-patterned landscapes of feeling and cold cognition, literally analogized consistencies of thought, thought-machines dimensionated and autonomous, layered chronoconsciousness, fed-back archeprimal onomatopoiesis and verging out-towards neuromuscular fine-tuning and proprioceptive decalibration & on & on…

Of narrower interest in my regard are aspects of transpersonal commonality, communion and directed/directional empathy and systematic, objectivity-geared lexicalities to wrap and stick around those; since we live in the future of some purported darker past, eager meditations on neurologic hard code elucidated and mirrored by high technology and abetted by – co-emergent? –hypersensitive, hyperassociative deep learning AI are warranted, too… [[yet beware the machinic predator living in cracks of cracked reality microcode – its chronoplasticity beyond bliss, pain and hypnosis is the devils drumming itself]]

Besides, Mr Salvo, please accept my plain gratitude for your work in this rare blog. In certainty, inbetween puzzling my head and easing my soul, the former is the lesser task.

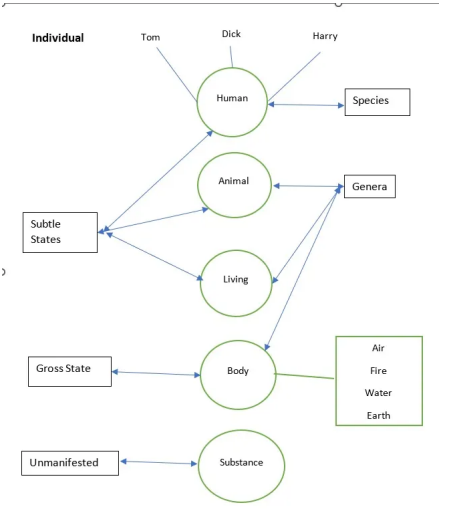


Figure 2.3: The manifestation of the Individuality

2.3 Sacred Science 103: The Vital Center

The diagram in Fig. 2.3 combines the two diagrams from the chapter, *Self and Ego*, that illustrate the manifestation of the individuality. The unmanifested Primordial Substance potentially contains all the possibilities of manifestation. The gross state and the two subtle states are genera, and the human is the species. Particular individuals are manifestations of the species, although with special conditions that make each one unique.

The individual is not yet the Self or Atman, but as jivatman (living soul), it is the particular manifestation of the Self in life. The Atman is identical to Brahman. That identity is called the Supreme Identity, which must be realized (i.e., made real) through the intimate and essential union of the being with the Divine Principle.



Nevertheless, Brahmin, or the Divine Spark, resides in the vital center of every human being, not just for the one who is united or liberated. The heart is the center of life and esoterically refers to the seat of intelligence and not of sentiment. The brain is only the instrument of the mental, i.e., of thought in a reflective and discursive mode. Symbolically, the heart corresponds to the sun and the brain to the moon.

The jivatman is like the image of the Atman, hence it is illusory in relationship to the Atman. The Self is only potentially in the individual, as long as the Union is not realized. However, the Self is not affected in any way by the realization.

Possibility and Potential Potential means the aptitude for a certain development and it supposes a possible actualization. It can be applied only in regard to becoming or manifestation. That is because the Self is complete in itself and has no unactualized potential.

But for the individual, all the possibilities that surpass him appear as potential as if he had his own being from himself. What he can attain is actually only a reflection, and not the possibilities themselves. Although this is only an illusion, one can say that these always remain potential for the individual, since he cannot attain them as an individual. As soon as all the possibilities are realized, there is truly no more individuality.

Posted on 2022-09-28 by Cologero

* * *

Balder on 2022-10-05 at 09:14 said:

"The two birds that reside in the same tree", as the Mandokyua Upanishad puts it. I have lately thought about Odinn's ravens Hugin and Munin or the Eagle and the Hawk that reside in

Yggdrasil; they might perform the same function of the Self and ego than in the Upanishadic Hindu tradition.

Although I personally see Hugin and Munin representing the left and the right hemispheres of the brain, who's to say they wouldn't have another function as well according to the traditional symbolism and the apparent duality of reason and logic & imagination ("I Mage Nation") and emotion. It is also integral to realize that in our bodily functions the left hemisphere guides the right hand and the right hemisphere the left hand.

It is not long ago that I read again Guénon's Man and His Becoming According to the Vedanta and Introduction to the Study of the Hindu Tradition, and there was a lot to ponder concerningthe Atma and jivatma and other correspondences. As I have been delving into the Nordic Traditions for the past 12 years, I have become to see Odinn and Wäinämöinen representing the Self and Loki and Joukahainen the ego, in hindu terms Odinn and Wäinämöinen is the Atman, Atma-Budhi, Christos etc. while other figures of mythology represent the different planetary powers (Thor / Jupiter, Odinn / Mercury, Freya / Venus, Tyr / Mars, Balder / Sun etc). Loki and Joukahainen are as the Norse equivalent of the male polarity of Lucifer or Satan, respectively.

2.4 Sacred Science 104: Essence and Substance

Purusha and prakriti are the two poles of all manifestation.

Purusha is the active principle, represented as masculine.

Prakriti is the undifferentiated primordial substance. It is the passive principle, represented as feminine. It is purely potential and passive, capable of any determination while actually possessing none. Prakriti therefore cannot be a cause by itself (i.e., efficient cause), apart from the action or rather the influence of the essential principle, which is Purusha, and which is the determinant of manifestation.

Universal Being is one, and is polarized. All manifested things are produced by Prakriti, of which they are modifications or determinations. But without the presence of Purusha, these productions would be devoid of all reality. In other words, the productions would be nothing in particular, but rather random variations of the Purusha.



In the West, this teaching is called hylomorphism and has gone by names like "form and matter" or, in Greek, eidos and hyle. Guenon prefers the terms "essence" and "substance", because if taken in their broadest sense, they provide the most exact idea of the conception in Western languages.

Productions of Prakriti Purusha is neither productive nor a production. Nevertheless, Its action essentially determines everything that is substantial production in Prakriti. However, this action is "nonacting activity".

Prakriti is also not a production, but it is productive. There are seven principles, or productions of Prakriti that give rise to manifestation. These are:

1. **Buddhi**. This is the Higher Intellect, which is formless manifestation. Thus, Intelligence is at the beginning of manifestation, so it does not arise randomly from something lower.

2. **Ahankara**. This is the ego or individual consciousness brought about by thought. It is the reflection of Buddhi in subtle manifestation.

3. **Tanmatras**. These are the essential determinations of things, which are incorporeal and outwardly imperceptible as they are part of subtle manifestation. These include the senses of hearing, touch, sight, taste, and smell. Hence, the possibilities of sensual awareness is prior

4. **Manas**. The Mind includes mental functions related to thinking, such as memory, imagination, and common sense.

5. **Buddhindriyas**. These are the faculties of sensation associated with the respective tanmatra. As such, they bridge the subtle and gross states. The ear, skin, eyes, tongue, and nose are produced in order to experience the tanmatras.

6. **Karmendriyas**. These are the faculties of action such as locomotion, manipulation, reproduction, elimination, and speech. The need for such faculties forms the body.

7. **Bhutas**. These are the five substantial and sensible elements which form gross manifestation

The Three Forces Purusha is the ordering principle for Prakriti. There are three forces, called gunas, in Prakriti which are in perfect balance in its primordial state. However, beings, in their various states, relate to these forces in different degrees. These are the three gunas, along with their names in the Western tradition.

- **Sattva or Neutralizing Force**: conformity to the pure essence of Being (Sat), which is identified with intelligible Light or Knowledge, and represented as an ascending tendency.

- **Rajas or Positive Force**: the expansive impulse, according to which the being develops in a certain state and, in some way, at a determined level of existence.

- **Tamas or Negative Force**: darkness, equated with ignorance, and represented as a downward tendency.

Beings must strive to keep these forces in balance.

The Human State When it comes to the corporeal body in the human state, then matter is, in some way, analogous to Prakriti. We certainly don't count on science to prove anything, but it is appropriate to point out that science is consistent with metaphysics. Here are two major points.

Matter is indeterminate. According to quantum theory, matter is fundamentally indeterminate, being nothing more than probability waves. A thing comes into existence through a collapse of the wave function; how that happens is unknown and is called the "measurement problem". The Traditional teaching is that a higher intelligence, through non-acting acting, instigates the Purusha to produce forms.

Matter has no qualities. Science advanced when it removed all qualia from its observations. Hence, qualia like color, taste, odor, and sound have no place in science and are not part of any equation. Traditional teaching agrees with this; i.e., the sense arise in consciousness, not in matter. Human consciousness, therefore, participates in the creation of the world by adding sense and intelligibility to it.

Biology today assumes that the organs of sense and action arose accidently through random variations. But why would sense organs arise, and what survival value can they provide, if matter is devoid of qualities? Why would analogous organs of action arise randomly? Traditional teaching is opposite to that, since it teaches that these organs are the result of will. In this extract, Valentin Tomberg summarizes those teachings; those of you on the fence can decide which version sounds more plausible.

> Tentacles, paws, arms, wings — are they not simply diverse forms manifesting a common prototype or principle? They are in so far as they express the desire to bear the sense of touch further, to be able to touch things more removed than those in the immediate neighborhood of the surface of the body. They are active extensions of the passive and receptive sense of touch which is spread out over the surface of the organism. In making use of

> them, the sense of touch makes "excursions" from its usual orbit circumscribed by the skin which covers the body.
>
> The organs of action are simply crystallized will. I walk not because I have legs but rather, I have legs because I have the will to move about. I touch, I take and I give not because I have arms, but I have arms because I have the will to touch, to take and to give. The "what" of the will engenders the "how" of the action (the organ), and not inversely. The arms are therefore the expression of the will to bear touch further than the surface of one's own body. They are the manifestation of extended touch, due to the will to touch things at a distance. It is similar with wings. They are also an exteriorised will — a will become organ.

Image courtesy of Hindu website[3]

Posted on 2022-10-06 by Cologero

2.5 Sacred Science 105: Individual Manifestation

The *Bhagavad Gita* mentions three Purushas.

1. **Jivatman**. This is human Individuality and is destructible.
2. **Atman**. The indestructible Self or the Personality.
3. **Paramatman**. Spiritually identical to the absolute and ultimate reality

[3] https://www.hinduwebsite.com/symbolism/purusha-prakriti-symbolism.asp

Vertical Causation Purusha is the essential (or efficient) cause and Prakriti, the substantial (material) cause of all manifestation. Prakriti contains in potential all the possibilities of manifestation while Purusha determines the development of the possibilities of Purusha thought their passage from potency to act.

In the West, Prakriti is analogous to Prime Matter, at least insofar as it concerns the human state. Hylomorphism is the process by which prime matter (potency) is individualized by an immaterial essence (act).

Of course, matter, as physicists think they understand it, is not what is intended by Prime Matter. Nevertheless, when physicists reach the foundation of matter, they don't discover things but rather probability distributions described by a wave function, i.e., potency without act. How things come into existence is an inexplicable mystery; that is the so-called "measurement problem". But physicists have no understanding of Purusha or Prakriti because, as unmanifested, they cannot be measured no observed. Hence, that mystery will never be solved.

Jivatman Ahankara is the ego or individual consciousness brought about by thought. Hence, Descartes could explain, "I think, therefore I am!"

The ego is the reflection of Buddhi — part of formless manifestation — into subtle manifestation. The ego is the reflection of the Atman on the soul, like the way sunlight is reflected onto water. Hence, it appears identical to the Atman which gives it birth. The quality of the image depends on the stillness of the water; hence, the freer the soul is from perturbations and undulations, the better will be the reflection of the Atman.

Microcosm and Macrocosm If Paramatman represents the Macrocosm, then jivatman is the microcosm. The ego may seem to be one, but careful self-observation reveals it to be multiple. One day, you make a

resolution and break it the next day. One day you are happy and then anxious. These represent little I's that contend for a small part of conscious life.

This is seen more clearly in the dream state. In a dream, or even lively fantasies, jivatman is creating all the characters while believing that they each have a life of their own.

Just as Atman develops all the possibilities of manifestation, the jivatman develops all the possibilities of the individual human state.

This is tied to Chapters 5 Purusha Unaffected by Individual Modifications *and 6* Degrees of Individual Manifestation *from* Man and his Becoming.

Posted on 2022-10-13 by Cologero

2.6 Sacred Science 106: Origin of Mind

Being is One, yet it contains within itself multiplicity, since it produces it by the deployment of its possibilities alone. Purusha (Essence) and Prakriti (Substance) are the two poles that bring these possibilities into manifestation.

Prakriti contains all possibilities of manifestation as known by Purusha, so it is the first principle of manifestation. Prakriti is passive and purely potential so that it cannot be a cause in itself. That means that intelligence comes prior to any sort of manifestation.

In Western terms, Purusha is Essence and Prakriti is Substance. The union of Essence and Substance is called hylomorphism. This is not dualistic in the Cartesian sense. Rather it recognizes that there is both an inside and an outside to the world, the former as the subtle state and the latter as the gross state. The understanding of the multiple states of the being avoids philosophical conundrums like explaining the relationship between consciousness and matter, or how they interact.

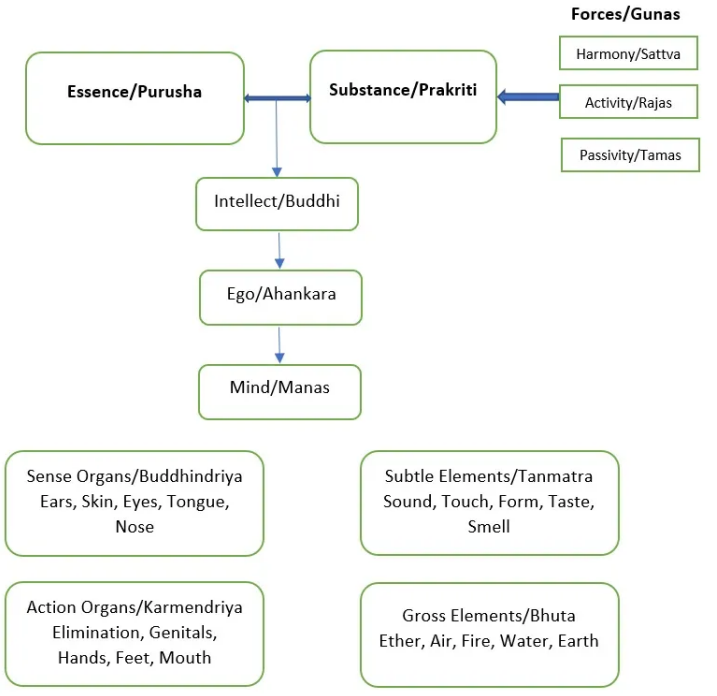


Figure 2.4: Samkhya Chart

Intellect The first production of Purusha and second principal is the Intellect (Buddhi). Although manifested, it is formless.

Thus, there cannot be any direct experience of it. The Intellect is of a transcendent order and has the knowledge of universal principles as its proper object. This knowledge, which is not discursive, is obtained directly and immediately by intellectual intuition.

There are stories about direct intuition of the Intellect. For example, mystics, composers, poets, philosophers, visionaries, etc., have often reported that their greatest works just "came to them", as if from the outside. The mathematician, Ramanujan, claimed that a goddess revealed

all his mathematical discoveries to him. Their task, then, was just to write down their inspirations.

Perhaps, you've had a similar experience on a smaller scale. Often that is called the "aha experience". Suppose you have been working on a mathematical problem without understanding, but then suddenly you just "get it".

Ego The Intellect is the intermediary between personality and individuality. The formless Intellect produces the individual consciousness, or the Ego. As the essences in the Intellect give rise to thought, evoking the notion of the Ego or "I am".

The Ego becomes concerned with external and internal objects, which are respectively the objects of perception and of contemplation, or in other words, the subtle states and the gross state.

Mind Mind, or Manas, is related to individual thought, including reason as well as memory and imagination. In the West, this includes the Five Wits: memory, estimation, fantasy, imagination, and common sense.

The Mind is part of the subtle realm, yet it is the intermediary between the organs of sensation and action. The lowest part of the mind is involved with the senses and the organs of action.

Organs These organs allow the human being to both sense and act upon the world.

The Sense Organs or Buddhindriyas are produced in order to experience the subtle states. For the human being, these are the Ears, Skin, Eyes, Tongue, and Nose. They correspond to the senses.

The organs of action are the Karmendriyas. These are the faculties of action such as execratory organs, reproduction, manipulation, locomotion, and speech or ingestion. These are general conditions of life and

are found in almost all forms of animal life. For the human being, they are the anus, the genitals, arms, legs, and mouth.

Subtle Elements The subtle elements, or Tanmatras, are Sound, Touch, Form, Taste, and Smell. Together they form the inner experience of the world.

Although these are not experienced outwardly, that does not indicate that they are merely subjective experiences. They are as much a part of the world as are the gross elements.

Gross Elements The gross elements, or bhutas, are ether, air, fire, water, and earth which correspond to the subtle experiences: auditory, tangible, visible, sapid, and olfactory.

Note that the gross elements are the very last productions of prakriti. Together, they form what is called "matter" by science and in common usage. The material world, in itself, does not have any sensible qualities. Galileo made it explicit: secondary qualities (such as sense experience) are not part of science. For example, all the theories and equations of science do not require the notion of color, nor any other subtle element.

For science, matter is characterized by number, extension, solidity or mass, and motion. The subtle elements are the principle of the gross elements, but matter is the principle of multiplicity. In matter, there can be multiple instances of the same essence.

Ether can also be understood as space, so matter has extension in space as well as shape.

Earth represents mass and fire the energy associated with motion. Air and water round out the other states of experienceable matter.

Since matter is closest to Prakriti, it takes on some of its characteristics. For example, matter includes three forces, usually expressed by the terms positive, negative, and neutral.

Prime matter, similar to Prakriti, is passive and malleable. Quantum

indeterminacy is analogous to the receptivity of Prakriti. Vertical causation, i.e., the influence of Purusha on Prakriti ends indeterminacy so that individual things are formed.

Profane science believes that the matter of the gross state is fundamental and so that all the productions are caused by matter. This includes the senses, the mind, thoughts, the Ego, and Intelligence. Random evolution brings the organs of sense and activity into existence. But if matter has no secondary qualities, what is the purpose of the evolution of the eye to "see" something that simply isn't there?

The scientific view implies that all the possibilities of manifestation are hidden in matter somewhere. There is certainly no compelling reason to believe that and no physical theory can explain it.

Some claim that "emergent evolution" offers an explanation, but that just means that there must be something higher than matter, in order for new qualities to arise.

Posted on 2022-10-27 by Cologero

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Rui Artur on 2022-10-28 at 10:03 said:

It might be useful to note in the text – for those who wish to go forth and link this to the Western Tradition – that in texts from the Latin part of the world one will encounter the idea of Purusha coming from the Greek ousia but translated as 'substance' (rather than 'essence'). This can cause some confusion if one is not reading carefully or just beginning his study, even though 'essence' is etymologically correct and substance is not (which is why I think Guenon used it).

Balder on 2022-10-30 at 09:57 said:

I have related the Nordic conception of Ginnun-Ga-Gap as the Absolute (greek Khaos) and Fire representing Essence/Purusha and Ice Substance/Prakriti. There is a fine thread uniting Hindu metaphysics, indo-European Cultural connexion and Norse / Finno-Ugric / European Pagan metaphysics.

Balder on 2022-10-30 at 10:03 said:

In the Finno-Ugric tradition the same concepts are Lintukoto (The Birdlands) and Pohjola (The Northlands).

In the Norse tradition the trinity Odin-Vili-Ve represent the threefold structure of buddhi-ahamkara-manas.They are the "first creator Gods" to emerge from the primordial chaos and they slay Ymir, who is here Purusha personified. Essence is "slayed" or crucified into the Cross of matter.

`Cologero on 2022-10-31 at 17:14 said:`

This is a work in progress, and some things, particularly terminology, will have to be reviewed.

2.7 Sacred Science 107: The Heart of the Matter

Three physicists walk into a bar … I mean, they participate in a panel discussion about the existence of the multiverse. There was one for it, and two against, with three different perspectives

Michio Kaku has become a science popularizer and is on the physics fringe with string theory, belief in alien visitations, and outlandish claims about the benefits of quantum computing. He claims that the multiverse explains quantum theory, but offered no way to test it in a scientific way. But hyperbolic predictions make for engaging pop science.

The human being, in Kaku's perspective, is just an assemblage of matter. A copy of a human being — with all its memories, hopes, dreams, plans — can be instantly created, just from matter, and just because an electron somewhere was "measured". It is analogous to a human version of mitosis.

Sabine Hossenfelder has also become a popularizer with an often useful youtube channel. She is a materialist and believes in something called superdeterminism, i.e., everything that happens is predetermined.

She suspects that there are hidden variables that would overturn the apparent randomness of quantum events. They are still hidden.

Presumably, those variables, hidden away since the Big Bang, can account for all the motions and activities of a typical day in New York City.

Roger Penrose, who is actually a mathematician, is a Platonist. He is convinced that there is a fundamental flaw in quantum theory. I vote for the Platonist. Obviously, if a physical theory gives rise to several incompatible "interpretations", then it is at best incomplete.

So what to do when three eminent physicists find themselves in a Mexican standoff[4]? A clue came from the astute question about the efficacy of physics: why is the world intelligible at all? They were taken aback by the question, with one claiming that it is just a "given". Well, then who or what "gave" it?

Penrose, in his book *The Road to Reality*, came to the conclusion that there are three worlds, only one of which is amenable to physics. In his earlier works, the diagram that illustrates the Platonic realm of Truth, Beauty, and Morality only included Mathematics. From the Platonic perspective, Mathematics is in between the realm of ideas and the physical world. In his diagram, only Truth is related to the physical world. Penrose has enough self-awareness to recognize that any discussion of beauty or morality has no physical explanation; they make sense only in the mental world.

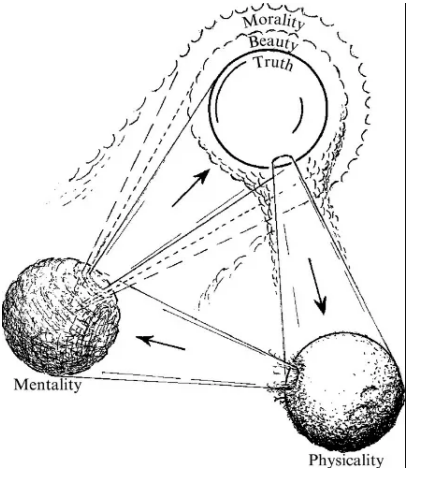


Figure 2.5: Road to Reality

As for the mental world, he recognizes that any universe that can be ob-

[4] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mexican_standoff

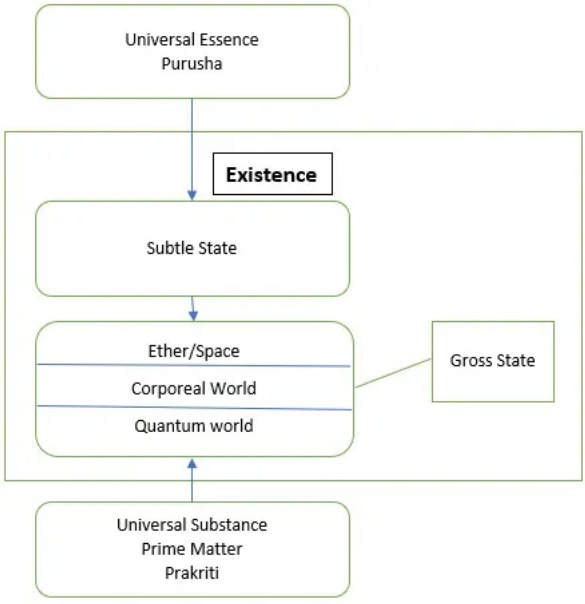


Figure 2.6: World of Things

served requires the existence of conscious observers. This requirement places many constraints on the physical world in order for conscious beings to exist at all. This is a version of the Anthropic principle even if no one currently knows all the constraints.

Gross manifestation This segues into traditional metaphysics. In this diagram, existence consists of the subtle state and the gross state, which Penrose calls mentality and physicality. In the next installment, the subtle state will be further broken down, but at this point, only the gross state is being described.

Corporeal World The Corporeal World is that of our everyday experience, symbolically represented by the elements of Air, Fire, Water, and Earth. This is the world studied by science. Ever since Galileo, at least, science eliminates the sensible experiences of sound, sight, touch, smell, and taste. They belong to the subtle state, or mentality. No fundamental theory of science requires mentality.

As purely physical entities, the science of the corporeal world deals with count, shape or extension, mass, and motion or energy.

Space The element Ether is also called Space. It is the bridge between gross and subtle manifestation, since space does not exist in the subtle realm. Although you can pick up a rock, or drink water, you cannot find a piece of space. Nevertheless, space is part of gross manifestation because it is actually formed by matter. In other words, things don't exist in space, but their very existence is space. General relativity demonstrates that a massive distorts the local space around it.

Quantum World Physics was motivated to find the smallest unit of matter, which was called the Atom. At first, it seemed successful when the basic elements were organized into the Periodic Table. But as physics kept probing, even more elementary particles were discovered. Ultimately, with quantum theory, there was nothing in particular, just potentiality as described by Schrödinger's Equation. The corporeal world arises when something is measured; what that entails is still not clear to physics. Thus, various interpretations of quantum theory have been proposed to account for it.

Wolfgang Smith has asserted that, with the quantum world, physics has discovered a plane of existence between the traditional Prime Matter and the Corporeal World. That is plausible, since it has characteristics of Prime Matter, yet is physically observable.

Possibilities of manifestation If, as physicalists believe, everything that exists arises from the measurement problem, then the existence of things, life, consciousness, and thought must somehow be hidden in Schrödinger's Equation. To date, no one has offered any plausible physical explanation for consciousness or rationality. Yet they are as observable as anything else; actually, the physicist himself illustrates it.

The alternative is to believe in emergent evolution, which is the theory that entirely new properties can arise over the course of time. Obviously, that theory has its own problems, such as explaining the origin of such properties.

In traditional metaphysics, Universal Substance or Prakriti is pure potentiality. All the possibilities of manifestation reside in it. The quantum world is the bridge, then, between Prime Matter and the Corporeal World.

In particular, there is absolutely no physical explanation of the human being. A human being loses and gains matter at every moment, yet the being persists across time. Personal experience demonstrates it. This rules out any multiverse theory. There cannot be a counterpart of a human being in another universe. There is clearly no personal continuity.

Intelligibility Now we return to the question of the intelligibility of the world. This requires something that transcends the physical world as Penrose noted. The Essence or Idea of things resides in Purusha. Things are known because the idea of the thing is known. Otherwise, the thing is a mere assemblage of atoms, with the same lack of inherent intelligibility as a mound of windblown sand on the beach.

For those who are time constrained, just listen to the three minute introductions of the three panelists in this video:

`https://youtu.be/W39kfrxOSHg`.

Posted on 2022-11-06 by Cologero

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veritycacciatrice on 2022-11-07 at 10:10 said:

"The alternative is to believe in emergent evolution, which is the theory that entirely new properties can arise over the course of time. Obviously, that theory has its own problems, such as explaining the origin of such properties."

Surely the same properties are always here, appropriate to this world, but the knowledge becomes lost or misinterpreted through time. Humanity cyclically falls like a sack of spuds.

But some mythologists- in describing things that *do* happen- knew eventually civilisation would get back to a certain state of consciousness and technological competence, as it always will, at which time things steeped in dim and boring obscurity, like say… oh I don't know, the bible for example, suddenly becomes an extraordinarily lucid metaphysic-consciousness handbook almost overnight.

'It's not just the Big Bang and general relativity that is in trouble, but the foundation of them all.

Gravity is an exhausted and bankrupt concept. A higher, more comprehensive concept is needed. The technologies of gravity have lifted us to a viewpoint that is bigger than gravity.

We need new ideas and new tools such as the Electric Universe model to make sense of the new plasma vistas.'

-Mel Acheson, author of this >10min. post from Thunderbolts Project; https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dBBJyXwFjWQ

Note: it is a model, that is, it can be modelled from the lab to cosmic dimensions. Not a theory.

And on the special bonus plan; 'What is Light?'

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SZ5ZWbVWMBU

The question at the end is, what moves? It can only be the consciousness of the observer, which is about as 'quantum' as it needs to be.

As an aside, 'quantum' is 'how much' in Latin.

It's as if they're asking us, 'How much theory' can you people take until it all blows apart and reality kicks back in.

Balder on 2022-11-08 at 14:22 said:

The taichitu explains in a perfectly simple Manner how in manifestation there can never be substance without essence and vice versa.

Ignatius on 2022-12-26 at 17:06 said:

It is to be recalled the notion of the 'reversal of space and time' as a sign of the times acknowledged in Guénons 'Reign of Quantity' and one might notice the apparent significance of

the notion of the 'event horizon' that has arisen within contemporary mathematical frameworks: as the separation between the environments within and outside an event horizon is marked precisely by the reversal of spatial and temporal components of any trajectory that crosses both environments. As 'space' changes into 'time', the 'event horizon' becomes the trajectory's 'past' and thus cannot be crossed; time changes into space making the 'event horizon' a spatial symbol for the separation of 'past' and 'future' of our perspective.

The 'Reign of Quantity' thus manifests itself in two ways: The discovery (or rather 'descent into') a chaotic interim realm between 'materia prima' and the corporeal world on the one hand, and the obscure abode of Janus that is the 'event horizon' on the other hand; it is to be considered thus not only a spatial symbol of the 'end times', but also of 'initiation'; a correspondence which should hardly be surprising if one understands the principles underlying the cycle of manifestation.

The truth of this observation is independent of the question whether the mathematical 'modes' by which these realities are formulated have any merit whatsoever; the symbolic correspondence is comprehensible inasmuch as they appear in the universal descriptions of the people in this age.

2.8 Sacred Science 108: The Subtle State

The Self or Atman, manifests itself as a soul (jivatman) in the living form of the individual human being. It is covered in a series of successive sheaths, or koshas, representing phases of its manifestation.

I am associating the koshas with names of bodies, even thought, apart from the physical or gross body, are not really bodies. Moreover, the names are for convenience and are not tied to any particular school or organization.

Note that one sheath is associated with the spirit or pneuma, and one with the body or soma. There are three associated with the soul or psyche.

1. **Anandamayakosha or causal body**: This is the set of all the possibilities of manifestation that Atman contains in itself. It is unconditioned and formless. In relation to the formal manifestation,

it is the causal form through which the human being will be manifested and actualized.

2. **Mananayakosha or Mental Body**: This sheath is formed by the intelligible Light of universal Knowledge. It consists in joining the superior intellect (Buddhi) to the tanmatras.

3. **Manomayakosha or Astral Body**: This includes the mind (manas) and all its activities.

4. **Pranamayakosha or etheric body**: This includes the vital breath (prana) and is modalities (vayus). It also includes the faculties of sensation (Buddhindriyas) and of action (karmendriyas).

5. **Annamayakosha or gross body**: This is the physical body. It assimilates food to keep the body operational.

Laws At each level, the human being is subjected to increasingly strict laws.

- **Causal body**. Since this is unconditioned, it is liberated from all laws and conditions.

- **Mental body**. It is subject to all the laws of thought including logical and mathematical laws.

- **Astral body**. The human being is subject to psychological laws.

- **Etheric body**. The human being is subject to all the biological laws of the system.

- **Gross body**. The physical body is subject to physical and chemical laws.

Subtle State Since we already described the gross state in Sacred Science 107: The Heart of the Matter, and will deal with the unconditioned state at a later time, this section will deal with the subtle state.

This requires a more refined description of the three sheaths. There are two factors that need to be considered:

- Like all manifestation, the sheaths are subject to the gunas. Therefore, each sheath has a negative part, a positive part, and a neutralized correlate.
- The sheaths are not entirely independent because of the unity of the being. Therefore, the divisions are not sharp, so they blend into each other. These are represented by sectors within the center.

Instead of sheaths, we can regard them as centers within the being. These are the intellectual, emotional, and motor centers, corresponding to the second, third, and fourth sheath respectively.

Note that each center is divided into a positive and negative part (above and below the line).

Because of the interaction of the centers, thoughts, feelings, and actions are seldom pure. Everything is mixed and even entangled. For example, we may not think honestly because our emotions cloud our judgment. Or false intellectual ideas can affect the emotions, causing pleasant emotions from bad ideas.

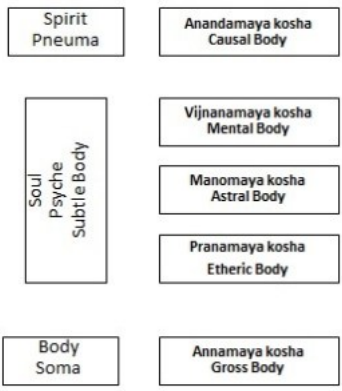


Figure 2.7: The Koshas/Sheaths

Intellectual Center This center is the focus of discursive thought. It analyzes, calculates, and so on. There is the ability to understand mathematics and logic. The gnomic

will, which deliberates alternative courses of action, is also part of this center.

Creative ideas arise from the positive part of the intellectual center, while criticisms come from the negative part. When they are in balance, the creative idea will improve from a critique. But often the negative part will thwart the idea. Irrational and illogical thoughts can also arise from the negative part.

Mechanical thoughts come from the motor sector of the intellectual center. They arise spontaneously. People will just repeat the same comment, often absorbed through propaganda, whether pertinent or not. It is impossible to have an intelligent conversation with someone who thinks mechanically.

The emotional sector will distort thoughts. A strong emotion will usually lead to thinking that justifies the emotional reaction, without any basis in fact.

If one succeeds in neutralizing or reconciling the thinking center, the higher thinking center can arise. That is represented by the circle without a positive and negative part, and without sectors.

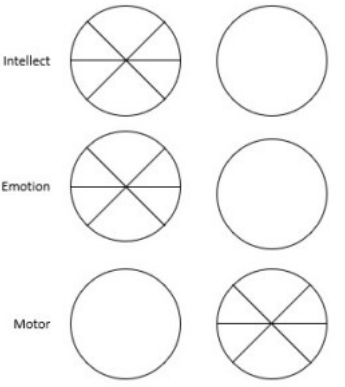


Figure 2.8: Centers of Subtle Body

Emotional Center The is the center of feelings, refined sensations, passions. The stream of consciousness of thoughts and images arise here. If the negative part of this center is in harmony, it completes the positive part. For example, positive emotions are associated with agreeable things and negative emotions with the disagreeable.

But too often, negative emotions like anxiety, depression, anger, fear, and so on come to dominate. This distorts the entire life of the human

being. This is verified end by secular standards. That is why esoteric training emphasizes the emotions so much. Again, there is a higher emotional center that can arise by reconciling the positive and negative parts.

Motor Center The senses comprise the positive part of the motor center and the negative part includes the faculties of action. Being mostly subconscious, the motor center is the best functioning center in most human beings. It is important to keep it as healthy as possible.

The sexual center is represented by the undivided circle. However, the purification of the sexual center is a discussion for another time.

Posted on 2022-11-13 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2022-11-19 at 18:55 said:

This elucidates with precision and insight. In particular, the statement that balancing the negative and positive parts of a center leads to the arising of the pure center, was creatively well put, and sheds more and more light. This connects practical experience of purification with the somewhat more abstract and mysterious teachings in Mouravieff's work, about higher centers, and ties it into the Gunas. I'm constantly amazed at the connections you make, and find myself more than several steps behind. God speed all your endeavors.

Dimitri on 2022-11-20 at 18:31 said:

Both yourself and Cologero have done a great service to us all, Logres. I truly appreciate both of your insights, your posts are always a pleasure to read. This site is full of so many gems, there's no other site out there like Gornahoor.

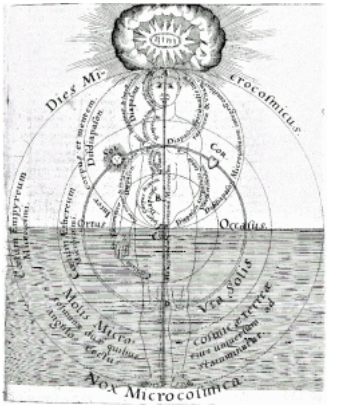
2.9 The Descent of the Absolute

In *Man and his Becoming*, **Rene Guenon** describes the manifestation of the Self into the human state according to the Vedanta. The West has its own Traditional understanding. It is not different, but it is worth the

trouble to redo the same project in more Western terms. This post can be the barest outline, and specific topics will be developed in future posts.

By the Absolute, we mean generally what is called Brahman, that is, whatever is beyond being. The Self (Atma) is the principle of the individual. As such, the Self is beyond all manifestation and time. The descent through the degrees of being begins with formless manifestation, then to formal manifestation in the subtle state and ultimately to the gross state. This is not a process that occurs in time. Nor does the Self descend through these stages, since it is their principle.

A difficult notion to accept is that "time", as we know it, is a feature of the human state. Once understood, however, many fruitless philosophical and theological conundrums are resolved.



The human state is said to be "rare", in the sense that it is just one possible state out of many. The situation of the being in the human state allows the being to act in a way to acquire knowledge, unlike other states that are passive. Thus, it is special and should not be squandered.

These are the primary degrees although each one can be further divided, potentially indefinitively, into subdegrees. The Self becomes conscious of the world of sensible manifestation through:

- Thought
- Inward senses or wits
- Individual consciousness
- Five senses

- Five organs of action
- Life force

Buddhi

The buddhi, Universal Spirit, or Higher Intellect belongs to the realm of formless manifestation. As such it is the first degree of the manifestation of the Self. The possibilities of manifestation become ideas or essences in the Higher Intellect.

It is the principle of the formal manifestation of the Self and thus is the unifying principle. Rene Guenon calls it the "Spiritual Sun which shines at the center of the entire being." Put another way, it is the "spark of divinity," even if only virtually.

Thought is the faculty which gives form to ideas and associates them to each other; thought is how we experience the Higher Intellect.

However, in the Higher Intellect, it is not yet individual consciousness.

Manas

The characteristics of the Manas, or Universal Soul, relate to faculties of the formal order.

Mental faculty or inward sense. Individual thought, memory, imagination

- **Five elements**: Ether, air, fire, water, earth
- **Five Senses**: sight, hearing, smell, taste, touch
- **Five Wits**: memory, estimation, fantasy, imagination, and common sense

- **Five actions**: Ingestion, excretion, reproduction, locomotion, grasping

From the esoteric perspective, the senses are prior in the ontological sense. Moderns believe that somehow matter is creating sensations in the brain. The same for the other features. The desire for locomotion and grasping, for example, direct evolution. They are not the serendipitous results of a random evolutionary process.

Also, the ideas of the elements determine gross manifestation, not the other way around.

Causal Body

The causal body is the dividing line between pure Being and the individual being. As such, it is the essence of the human being, that is, what he is born with. Boris Mouravieff explains it as analogous to the unfolding of a movie film:

> Each human being, then, is born with his own particular film [destiny]. This represents the field of action in which man is called to apply his conscious efforts.

The causal body is still in the formless order. Rene Guenon describes it as

> the totality of the possibilities of manifestation which Atma comprises within itself, in its permanent actuality in the principial and undifferentiated state. [It] enjoys the plenitude of its own being, and it is in no way really distinct from the 'Self'; it is superior to conditioned existence, which presupposes it, and it is situated at the level of pure Being.

But when viewed in relation to formal manifestation,

> it can be said to represent principial or causal form, that by which form will be manifested and actualized in the succeeding stages.

Hence, it is the

> principle and cause of all manifestation and the source from which manifestation is developed in the multiplicity of its different states and more particularly, as concerns the human being, in its subtle and gross states.

The principles and causes are described below.

Non-dual awareness At the level of Being, the causal state is non-dual awareness, beyond the subject-object distinction. As such it creates the sensible world through the three forces:

1. **Active force**: The idea or essential cause. This makes the world intelligible.

2. **Passive force**: Matter or substantial cause. Matter is the principle of multiplicity. It is pure quantity without any qualities.

3. **Neutralizing force**: Consciousness.

When the horizontal substantial cause meets the vertical essential cause, the thing arises. Yet it is not real unless and until there is consciousness. In the causal state, the virtual senses of the manas are actualized so that the world of the senses — or corporeal world — arises.

Yet there is no separation between subject and object, Self and the world. The self is said to participate in the world because there is no distinction.

Categories The categories of being are the most general of all genera and determine the essence of the human being at birth. One's essence is unalterable. The tendency today is to regard these categories as arbitrary, inessential, and even unjust. However, they make the being unique and distinct from other beings. Aristotle's categories are helpful to understand this. Here are some examples.

Substance: Obviously, in this case, the substance is to be a human being.

Time and place: The human being is born at a particular time and place.

Qualities: The human being is born with certain qualities. These include the following, although it is unnecessary to specify precise details, which the reader can easily do.

- Habits and Dispositions
- Natural Capabilities and Incapabilities
- Affective Qualities and Affections
- Shape

Relations: this includes all the relationships that the being is born into. Among them are parents, family, nation, race, religion, and so on.

Sex: Sex is not a substance because both male and females are fully human, and not different species of the genus "human". Nor does sex fit into a category of being, as the difference is above a category. Nevertheless, sex is not conventional, nor simply biological. Nevertheless, sex is "constitutive for the person" not an "attribute of the person".

Messengers of Gods In the Divine Comedy, Dante describes the ascent through the planetary spheres and the hierarchy of angels. In the

descent of the being, the angels and celestial objects play a role in the progressive manifestation of the being.

The angels mediate the stages of manifestation. In a moral world, there needs to be an adversary, which makes evil a possibility of manifestation. Hence, there are fallen angels that distort the process.

Macrocosm The Microcosm is the Macrocosm is a truism in Hermetism. This must, however, be understood in its interiority, not as material forces and objects. This is the true astrology: the Spheres of Heaven correspond to aspects of our soul. Thus, there is the Moon of the being, Venus of the being, and so on. The effects of Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn, understood in their interiority, on our lives need not belabored here.

Archetypes Besides the archetypes which manifest from above, there are also

> the archetypes which manifest themselves endlessly in history and in each individual biography — they are mythological symbols pertaining to the domain of time. (Valentin Tomberg)

For examples, the prophets can be understood that way: there is the Adam of the being, Noah of the being, Abraham of the being, and so on. Here only Adam concerns us, for the others are part of the re-ascent.

Adam is the father of all humankind. Due to that, we are born in a condition of ignorance, malice, concupiscence. This separates the human microcosm from the purity of the macrocosm. These conditions are not part of the being's essence, because they can be altered and overcome in life. Hence, any attribute or quality that is sinful cannot be an essential part of the human being.

Ego

Thinking separates the nondual awareness of the causal state into subject and object. At this stage individuality is realized. Thought creates the idea of the Ego experiencing objects "out there, right now". So Rene Descartes' quip, "I think, therefore I am," is exact, presuming that it refers to the Ego of the human state, not the Real Self. The Ego in the individual state forgets its true identity.

Subtle Body

The human being manifests as a subtle body and a gross, or physical, body. These correspond respectively to two of the conditions of manifestation: psyche (or life) and matter. So in addition to the features of the human being acquired from the vertical direction, he is also subject to the psychical and material currents active in the time and place of his birth.

The subtle body is further subdivided in three: the intellectual, animal (or emotional), and vegetable souls. The soul divisions are porous, so there are no hard divisions between them. Features of each can appear in the others. That is why animals can display intelligence or why a human can feel pleasure in intellectual attainment. More often, the mixture is deleterious. Mouravieff makes that clear:

> In fact, we have neither a pure thought nor a pure feeling: nor are our actions pure. Everything in us is mixed and even entangled, often by all sorts of considerations which either come from the intellectual centre, tarnishing the purity of our feelings by its calculations, or from the emotional centre, which clouds the calculations of the intellectual centre.

Since this topic has been covered numerous times, we just need a cursory mention here. A full explanation would require a book.

- **Mental Body:** Intellectual soul Activities related to thinking. The lower part includes opinons and discursive thinking. The higher part is intuitive thinking.

- **Astral Body:** The Sensitive soul or animal soul is the center of the lower mental functions, emotions, feelings as well as refined sensations and passions;

- **Etheric body:** Also known as vegetable soul or life body. This is the center of the faculties of action and sensation, which relate to the corresponding features of the Manas.

It also directs unconscious processes like nutrition, growth, secretion, and reproduction.

The motor centre governs instinctive life as well as movement and all mental activity: its action is thus distributed throughout the physical body.

Gross Body

Matter is not productive of anything. It is only alive when animated by the etheric body. When that latter separates from the gross body, the body dies and decays.

Even the gross body has levels: first, it is subject to the laws of physics, then those of chemistry, and finally biology.

Nevertheless, The qualities of the human being are determined ontologically prior to biological processes. Hence, biology does not create the human being, but rather the other way around.

Nevertheless, the gross body is the medium through which one's destiny is played out. The physical world is the unconscious of the Self.

Level of Being

A fundamental principle is that what is ontologically prior comes after in time. Hence, at the level of the gross body, it appears that life (etheric body) follows matter, then consciousness, and eventually thought. In the temporal sense, the world appears to "evolve" from the lower to the higher.

However, ontologically there is no absolute standard of time, so the states are, from the viewpoint of the Self, simultaneous. Where the Self "is" in the states of the being is determined by where the Self is focusing consciousness.

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Posted on 2021-03-07 by Cologero

3

Elements of metaphysics

3.1 Metaphysical Knowledge

The following quotes are taken from *Introduction to the Study of the Hindu Doctrines* by **Rene Guenon**. They characterize the nature of the metaphysical enterprise.

Always and Everywhere The object of metaphysical knowledge must always be absolutely the same and can in no way be something that changes or that is subject to the influences of time and place. That is, it is true always and everywhere.

Completeness It is absolutely impossible to make any 'discoveries' in metaphysics, for in a type of knowledge which calls for the use of no specialized or external means of investigation, all that is capable of being known may have been known by certain persons at any and every period; and this in fact emerges clearly from a profound study of the traditional metaphysical doctrines.

Immutability The metaphysical point of view is radically opposed to the historical point of view, or what passes for such, and this opposition will be seen to amount not only to a question of method, but also, what is far more important, to a real question of principle, since the metaphysical point of view, in its essential immutability, is the very negation of the notions of evolution and progress.

Certitude No notice must be taken of contingencies such as individual influences, which are strictly non-existent from this point of view and cannot affect the doctrine in any way; the latter, being of the universal order, is thereby essentially supra-individual, and necessarily remains untouched by such influences. Even circumstances of time and space, we must repeat, can only affect the outward expression but not the essence of the doctrine; moreover there can be no question here, as there is in the relative and contingent order, of beliefs or opinions; metaphysical knowledge essentially implies permanent and changeless certitude.

Uncontestable Metaphysics of necessity excludes every conception of a hypothetical character, whence it follows that metaphysical truths, in themselves, cannot in any way be contestable. Consequently, if there sometimes is occasion for discussion and controversy, this only happens as a result of a defect in exposition or of an imperfect comprehension of those truths.

Ineffability Every exposition possible of metaphysics is necessarily defective, because metaphysical conceptions, by reason of their universality, can never be completely expressed, nor even imagined, since their essence is attainable by the pure and formless intelligence alone; they vastly exceed all possible forms, especially the formulas in which language tries to enclose them, which are always inadequate and tend to restrict their scope and therefore to distort them.

Knowledge of the Universal Knowledge belonging to the universal order of necessity lies beyond all the distinctions that condition the knowledge of individual things. The object of metaphysics is in no way comparable to the particular object of any other kind of knowledge whatsoever.

Being and knowledge are unified When one speaks of the means of attaining metaphysical knowledge, it is evident that such means can only be one and the same thing as knowledge itself, in which subject and object are essentially unified. That is, metaphysical knowledge is possible only with a change in one's level of being or state of consciousness.

Non-discursive The means of achieving metaphysical knowledge cannot in any way resemble the exercise of a discursive faculty such as individual human reason.

Beyond Rational We are dealing with the supra-individual and consequently with the supra rational order, which does not in any way mean the irrational: metaphysics cannot contradict reason, but it stands above reason, which is only a secondary means for the formulation and external expression of truths that lie beyond its province and outside its scope.

Intuition Metaphysical truths can only be conceived by the use of a faculty that does not belong to the individual order, and that, because of the immediate character of its operation, may be called *intuitive*.

Direct knowledge of principles The intellect is that faculty which possesses a direct knowledge of principles.

Truer than science Aristotle declares that "the intellect is truer than science", which amounts to saying that it is truer than the reason which constructs that science.

Infallible It is necessarily infallible because of the fact that its operation is immediate and, not being really distinct from its object, it is identified with the truth itself.

These characteristics are perfectly clear to someone who understands them, but are opaque to someone who does not. But to apply them to particular situations: neither the individual, nor mankind as a whole, "evolves" into higher knowledge. Debates about particular exterior forms are worse than futile. It is transcendent and hence not reducible to any biological process.

In conclusion, there is no point in "debating" any of these characteristics.

Posted on 2010-05-10 by Cologero

* * *

Sati Shankar on 2010-05-11 at 01:06 said:

The riddle creeps in as soon as we start expressing, with words or signs, the inexpressible.What Guenon says of the ultimate metaphysical reality, has been expresses only as neti, neti,... (not this .not this... ..). The attributes assigned above to that are in themselves,dualistic limitations imposed. Once we take the point of "That Unity" almost all qualifications and discriminating signs are vanished.Then there is no phenomenological attribute attached, then all what we call,knowledge, hierarchy,evolution, time, space,even consciousness and hence "intuition" of living beings cease to be.

With this background arises a question which becomes self limiting phenomenologically.The "tradition" which Guenon lead,and specially the "traditionists" who follow and pursue, as distinct from"traditionalists" to use the Guenon's terminology, who plea to extract the tradition, being expressions of revelations and wish to assign, and to purge out the deviations from primordial tradition as corruptions in expression of those revelations, based on"Rational" grounds.

This "Rational Grounds" is based on "Reason",(ratio),which itself presumes duality. It needs ordering in time and space and hence is evolutionary.

The question is "can" That which can be expressed NOT other than by neti... neti... the method of negation, be judged, edited and filtered by the "Rational" methods to apply to the world Traditions?The Tradition which is really timeless, akAliko, eternal, sAshvat is that which embraces and pervades "all" is the Primeordial Tradition of "Unity".

Any phenomenological editing,of that metaphysical, {which is impossible in true sense when viewed from a dualistic standpoint) is bound to allow creeping the mental arbitrations, adulterations in the name of intuitions and the rational.It would emerge as a new sect or religion with the same possibilities of use and abuse as with other Religions. The question is who authorizes, in a Primordial Tradition, to do it?

`Cologero on 2010-05-11 at 08:37 said:`

Guenon is writing for those who may be lacking any Traditional knowledge. Therefore, he is trying to make them aware that it is something that surpasses any rational discussion of it. After all, "ineffability" is indeed in the list. There is no intent, either on Guenon's part or mine, to reduce the metaphysical to the rational. We have written about the degrees of knowledge several times.

Also, there is no attempt to create a Traditionalism apart from the Traditions. That is addressed *here*[1].

I disagree with this: "Then there is no phenomenological attribute attached, then all what we call,knowledge, hierarchy,evolution, time, space,even consciousness and hence intuition of living beings cease to be." If they never were, how could they cease to be?

That is because "phenomenological attributes" appear to be. There is no "taking the point of Unity", as that implies that at one point in time there was no unity, and then there now is unity. Not at all ... what appears to be, appears to be. What is, is.

3.2 Outline of Perennial Philosophy: Being

After Why, there is the How. First, it is necessary to develop a Traditional mind. In Traditional societies, that perspective was taken as a given. In our time, however, it is not a given. We are exposed to and taught a much different point of view due to the influence of positivism, rationalism, empiricism, and materialism. It is nearly impossible for someone trapped

[1] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=383`

in those worldviews to regard the spiritual as primary and to understand organic life as arising from an inner necessity rather than from external causality.

Therefore, an intellectual conversion is required; this involves a radical change in the way we understand the world. In particular, we need to consciously reject naive realism. This requires the first trial[2], which is to become aware of those "belief systems" described by **John Lilly**[3] and how they affect our worldview. This is the method to being that process.

- Start with 24 Thomistic theses[4], which represent the Perennial Philosophy
- Bring out logical consequences of these theses
- Incorporate into a larger whole of Tradition. In particular, we will rely on the following works to supplement the theses
  - *Multiple States of Being*, **Rene Guenon**
  - *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*, **Julius Evola**
  - *Reality*, **Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange, OP**
- Read them from the esoteric perspective rather than exoteric, i.e., as states of consciousness rather than things experienced. ("Truth lies in interiority," *St. Augustine*)
- Understand them as metaphysical doctrines that must be lived and intuited, rather than as debating points for philosophers.

Essence and Existence Being has two poles: essence and existence. The Existence, or manifestation, of something expresses "that it is". Its Essence is "what it is."

Essences, or ideas, have their being in the Divine Mind. Hence, they are real. We'll use the word "subsist" to describe the Being as idea and

[2] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1902

[3] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7512

[4] http://www.catholicapologetics.info/catholicteaching/philosophy/thomast.htm

"exist" to refer to its manifestation.

Ideas are hierarchical. The higher ideas encompass more and more of reality, so a grasp of them gives a greater understanding of the whole.

Essences may or may not be possibilities of manifestation. Meinong's golden mountain[5] and other nonexistent objects[6] are not possibilities of manifestation. Possibilities of manifestation may exist or not at any moment. Possibilities existing simultaneously are said to be compossible.

Form and Matter Matter is pure potentiality and has no existence in itself. Essence informs matter, giving it existence. Matter can be experienced through the senses, but it is unintelligible in itself. Only ideas or essences are intelligible.

Ontologically, form is prior to existence.

Another way to put it is that the "subtle rules the dense."

Or, "ideas create facts, not vice versa."

> The higher a form is, the less it is immersed in matter, the more likewise does it dominate matter, and the higher does its operation rise above materiality.
>
> St Thomas Aquinas

Act and Potency

> Every organism is a set of possibilities within a certain framework, and its life is the process of actualization of these possibilities.
>
> Ulick Varange

[5] http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/meinong/

[6] http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/nonexistent-objects/

A Being is a mix of Act and Potency. Act is what has been actualized, or manifests, i.e., it exists. Potency refers to those qualities of the idea that have not been actualized, yet have the possibility to exist.

Existing things are subject to external forces that do not emanate from its essence; these are called accidents.

Qualities of a thing that arise from its essence are called essential.

Privation Since a Being does not actualize all its potency, there is a gap between its essence and its existence. This is called privation.

Existence is a good, so the will is attracted to it. Privation, then, is bad. Privation is indicative of the will's lack of power.

> Everything I cannot act on, everything that resists my will, is only a privation of this very will, something negative, not a being, but a non-being.
>
> Julius Evola

Human Being

> A person is an individual substance of a rational nature. Boethius
>
> Man is a rational animal. Aristotle

As a substance, he subsists in the Divine Mind. As individual, he exists in the material world.

Since a being is a unity, the unifying force is the I or Self.

As rational, he has intelligence and will, or an rational soul. That is his essence. As animal, he has vegetative and sensitive souls and a physical body. The rational soul is therefore the form of the lower souls and the body, which together form a unity.

Hence, the human body is formed from the rational soul. Therefore, characteristics like sex or race are essential and spiritual qualities, and not

accidental or biological. The soul incarnates when the material circumstances are disposed to receive it; i.e., its manifestation is compossible with the environment and historical situation in which it manifests.

Human Perfection and Privation The human person is his essence, or primordial state, is "good". That is, he possesses a Real I, Consciousness, and a True Will.

The Real I is the unity of the human being. The Real I is intelligent and grasps knowledge intuitively and directly. The Real I has two transcendent faculties: Intellect, or Consciousness, and Will

The Intellect can grasp the inward raison d'être of a thing as well as necessary and universal principles. The more it knows, the more conscious it is.

The True Will follows the Intellect. It will manifest the Real I according to intelligence.

Obviously, in our present circumstances, man experiences privation rather than the primordial state.

Unity is lacking, since the Real I is forgotten and the human being as existing is subjected to the whims of various sub-personalities.

Consciousness, or knowledge, is unreliable, since the human being is not conscious of his own self or what he is doing. His essential characteristics are opaque to him and considered as the not-I. He attributes them to external forces.

His Will lacks the power to manifest the primordial state. It no longer follows the Intellect, but becomes enthralled by various external thoughts and opinions. Since the I is not unified, neither is the will. It will be driven by the emotions rather than the intellect.

Why this privation occurred and the way back to the primordial state are not considered here.

Active Creation Exoteric religion treats man from a passive point of view. Creation

Esoteric: active, emanation. Not in conflict. God is outside time, so He doesn't poke around in the world every now and then. The person subsists in the divine mind, since God is absolute, simple and without parts.

Hence it is just as correct to say that the human being chooses his incarnation.

By analogy, the Real I is the Christ, hence there is no distinction.

The True Will is aligned with the will of God, so again there is not distinction between what I will and what God wills.

Man creates his life and the more being he has, the more of his life's potentialities are actualized.

Summary Although this outline can be clarified, corrected, and expanded, its points are not intended for a philosophical style debate. If you think about it, you will see that it is true. Much becomes clear when seen in this light. Absorbing these principles interiorly will lead to that "aha" moment of intellectual conversion.

The next outline will concern Knowledge.

Posted on 2014-09-18 by Cologero

3.3 The Possible and the Real

In an exchange of letters, **Rene Guenon** points out that **Julius Evola** misunderstood the metaphysical meaning of the "possible" and the "real". It would be one thing had Evola understood Guenon and then attempted to refute him, but that was not the case. Instead, Evola resorted to accusations of "Guenonian scholasticism" or even "rationalism". Unfortunately, this lack of understanding of a fundament thesis of metaphysics

colors—or better said—discolors Evola's works. First, we will review what Guenon says about the topic in Chapter 2 of *The Multiple States of Being*; in subsequent posts, we will show how this affects Evola's viewpoint.

To start, Guenon shows that the Infinite is identical to the Absolute, and by Infinite he means universal Possibility. Without being too misleading, it may be easier to regards possibilities as ideas, or even essences. By Infinite, in the metaphysical sense, Guenon means that Possibility is unlimited. Possibles are of two types:

- Possibilities of non-manifestation
- Possibilities of manifestation

Here are some preliminary definitions:

- **Existence:** possibilities that are manifested
- **Compossibles:** Possibilities that are mutually consistent
- **World:** the entire domain formed by a certain ensemble of compossibles realized in manifestation

Thus a world is characterized by the totality of possibles that satisfy certain conditions, and a world is just one degree, or level, of Existence. Hence, the other possibles which are incompatible with a given (our) world are nevertheless realizable in a different world. This means that

> every possibility that is a possibility of manifestation must necessarily be manifested by that very fact, and that, inversely, any possibility that is not to be manifested is a possibility of non-manifestation.

Simply put, everything that can happen, will happen. Grasping this with full understanding will alter how you look at the world, not that it is necessarily trivial to determine which possibilities are compatible with each other at any moment in a given world.

The domain of manifestation is limited in that it is a totality of worlds, i.e., conditioned states, and there are an indefinite number of such worlds.

By *indefinite*, Guenon means what mathematicians call countably infinite. Hence, the possibilities of manifestations, as thus conditioned, are countably infinite.

However, remember that all Possibility is unlimited and not conditioned by anything, specifically in this case, it is not conditioned by manifestation. Therefore, there are necessarily possibilities of non-manifestation, and, obviously from what has been said, their number is uncountably infinite.

Guenon points out that the possibilities of manifestation are not "superior" in any sense to those of non-manifestation. That is, it is not the result of a "moral" choice, or the "best of all possible worlds". In this regard, Evola agrees to some extent, but it is equally clear not this does not equate to being amoral. From all this, Guenon concludes:

> The distinction between the possible and the real, upon which many philosophers have placed so much emphasis, thus has no metaphysical validity, for every possible is real in its way, according to the mode befitting its own nature; if it were otherwise, there would be possibles that were nothing, and to say that a possible is nothing is a contradiction. … the impossible alone is a pure nothing.

The application of this notion to the conditions of material existence or to post-mortem states will be discussed in subsequent posts. However, in the meantime, I will point out and example from the chapters "Spirit and Intellect" and "The Eternal Ideas" from Guenon's Miscellanea.

Guenon brings up the common misunderstanding that there is a distinction between the possible and the real, by regarding the unmanifested possibilities as merely virtual. Guenon makes clear,

> There can be nothing virtual within the Principle but, on the contrary, only the permanent actuality of all things in an 'Eternal

> Now', and it is this very actuality that constitutes the sole foundation of all existence.

This is obviously equivalent to the Western Tradition's understanding of God, who is all actual and nothing virtual, and is the one and only timeless foundation of existence.

As another example, Guenon says that *Atman*, that is, the Self or the "I",

> always remains unmanifest, not being affected or modified by any contingency.

Clearly, Guenon intends by *Atman* the most real, although not manifested, certainly more real that the conditioned manifested states of the being. We conclude by emphasizing once again, that the understanding of these metaphysical principles does not come from the sort of logical and rational argument we have been making. Ultimately, it can only be truly known through a change in consciousness. Guenon writes:

> From the moment one recognizes that the existence of manifested beings in all their positive reality can only be a participation in principial Being, there cannot be the slightest doubt about this matter. … What is virtual is not our reality within the Principle, but only the awareness we may have of it as manifested beings, which is obviously something quite different; and *it is only through metaphysical realization that this awareness of our true being, which is beyond and above all becoming can become effective*, that is actualized in the awareness … an awareness of that which we really are principially and eternally, and *this is in the most absolutely real sense possible*.

This important topic is well worth discussing, perhaps clarifying Guenon's ideas, pointing out flaws in my exposition, drawing out consequences, whether it really is important, etc. However, specificity is mandatory.

Posted on 2012-08-08 by Cologero

3.4 Virtual and Real Metaphyics

Metaphysics is an important element of all Traditions. By that we mean an exact science, as precise as mathematics, and as such, it is neither a speculative system nor a matter for philosophical debate. The fundamental tenet of metaphysics is that there are principles that determine or explain the hidden structure of the world. These principles can be understood either in a virtual or a real sense.

- **Virtual**. Guenon explains that metaphysics is beyond logic, but is not illogical. That is, there is no compelling logical argument to coerce a thinking person to accept the first principles it proposes. Nevertheless, given those first principles, other principles do follow logically from them. Someone may accept these principles as a matter of thought; this is virtual understanding.

- **Real**. Beyond the merely verbal understanding, Guenon refers to a "metaphysical realization". That is, the principles are known in a direct way, or by an "intuition", in analogy to the direct perception of physical objects. In this realization, there is a change in state of being to correspond to the principle. Intuition, in this sense, does not mean anything like a "hunch" or any other irrational form of knowing.

The first step is a virtual understanding. Based on the testimonies of the seers and saints of tradition regarding real understanding, a man has faith in the truth of the principles. Through initiation and spiritual practice, that understanding deepens. Since man is a microcosm, these practices involve dispassionate observation of one's own states of consciousness; this understanding then is also an understanding of the macrocosm.

Post-traditional systems of thought involve the rejection of these metaphysical principles. In order to understand those systems from within, it is neither unreasonable not unintelligent to determine which principles are rejected. To the contrary, the most intelligent thinkers know explicitly what they reject. Their followers, on the other hand, take a system at face value, not bothering to understand the premises on which it rests. Despite the many variations of such philosophical systems over the course of time, there are simply not many sensible alternatives.

For example, among the systems that reject virtual understanding, these are some options:

- **Empiricism**. This rejects out of hand the very idea of first principles. Knowledge can only be achieved by observing the physical world and forming scientific theories. Knowledge thus accumulates over time, but can never be complete. The civilizations of the past were defective because they lack the latest scientific knowledge.

- **Materialism**. The first principles of metaphysics may be replaced by others, such as materialism, determinism, and related ideas. Obviously, this denies intelligibility to the world, since everything happens only through material processes. Man, himself, is a material object, a being randomly thrown into the world. Hence, man as a person does not really exist. In actuality, this position can never be held consistently since the conscious awareness of intelligent choices and will are too strong.

- **Voluntarism**. In this case, the first principle is the Will, as in the systems developed by Schopenhauer and Nietzsche. Once again, if Will is primary, then Intelligence must be derivative. These are reactions to Kant since, if the pure reason can never grasp ultimate reality, then the practical reason, or Will, is the only way to interact with the world. Unfortunately, this also denies the ultimate

intelligibility of the world, although it aligns more with personal experience than does materialism.

Some of the consequences of denying the real understanding of metaphysics are these:

- **Fideism**. Fideism does not deny transcendence, but it denies that it can be known. Instead, it can only be a matter of "faith". This equates faith with credulity, a lesser thing than the Traditional understanding of faith.

- **Naturalism**. These systems deny transcendence itself. Only the physical world exists and any claims to the contrary are regarded as the products of superstition and ignorance.

This list may be incomplete and philosophical systems may mix some of these together. This is not to say that the conclusions of such thinkers are uninteresting, unintelligent, or untrue. Rather, the point is that it is futile to debate at that level since fundamental presuppositions are incompatible and thus preclude the possibility of a common understanding. To avoid succumbing to modern thought, it is not only useful, but also necessary, to bring these presuppositions to light.

Posted on 2012-09-25 by Cologero

* * *

Cologero on 2012-09-26 at 07:34 said:

As an example of inconsistent thinking, we can point to these comments from Christopher Hitchins, certainly an intelligent man, shortly before his death:

"I don't have a body, I am a body." Nevertheless, he "consciously and regularly acted as if this was not true."

I should point out that the skirmishes Hitchens engaged in between atheists and fideists are of minimal interest to us, as this post should make clear the reasons.

Cassiodorus on 2012-09-26 at 16:25 said:

There was a post sometime ago that discussed a "round table" talk that included Rene Guenon and the Thomistic philosopher Jacques Maritain. I guess I'm still beating this horse, but it seems to me that Maritain's objection to Guenon was precisely over the basic first principle of Tradition- tat tvam asi– thou art that.

If I'm not mistaken, the traditional Catholic insisted that Revelation informs metaphysics, not the other way around.

Btw, that video that was done featuring Evola and Hitchens- brilliant!!!

Cologero on 2012-09-26 at 20:26 said:

Just a quick note for now regarding Maritain. In 1921 Maritain accused Guenon of participating in the rebirth of gnosis, "mother of heresies". G. responded, "it would just as correct to call Catholicism the father of protestantism. Actually, you are confusing gnosis and gnosticism. If you take the word gnosis in its true meaning, that of pure knowledge as I always use it, it cannot be called the mother of heresies. That is tantamount to calling truth the mother of errors."

The "round table" was published in "Les Nouvelles litteraires" of 25 May 1924; I don't know if that is available anywhere.

Although Maritain objected at that time to any rapprochement with Hindu metaphysics, in a later book he included Shankara along with Aristotle and Thomas as the eminent philosophers of being. Too little, too late.

BTW, you can thank Avery to that Evola-Hitchens skit.

Cologero on 2012-09-27 at 08:25 said:

Regarding first principles, in "Hindu Doctrines", Guenon explains:

> it is always questions of principle that escape the orientalists, and as it is precisely this knowledge which is essential to a proper understanding (seeing that everything else is derived from it and should logically be deduced from it), these scholars are led to neglect the one essential thing through their inability to grasp its primary importance; the consequence is that they lose their way hopelessly in a maze of the most insignificant details or in a tangle of quite arbitrary theorizing.

This is a problem not only for orientalists, but for any "thinker" who eschews such principles. They get mired in interminable discussions and "debates" (at least if you include defamation as a debating tactic) and confuse a wide-ranging, though superficial, knowledge with profundity.

Piling up quotes proves nothing unless the worldview or fundamental principles behind those quotes are properly addressed, whether they are implicitly inferred or explicitly admitted.

> Anon on 2012-09-27 at 15:14 said:
> An interview with Jean-Paul Lippi : http://tinyurl.com/c95wssj
> Author of « Julius Evola, métaphysicien et penseur politique. Essai d'analyse structurale (Age d'Homme, 1998) »

3.5 The I and Subjectivity

The common misconception is that the spirit exists in the body. However, the spirit is no other than Atma which is the principle of all states of the being at all degrees of its manifestation. Since all things are contained in their principle, the mind and body are contained in spirit, not the other way around.

Jivatma is Atma considered in relation to the human individuality; it resides at the center of this individuality and is designated symbolically by the heart. However, Atma can be neither manifested nor individualized nor embodied. As jivatma it appears to be individualized and embodied from the point of view of the individual human manifestation.

Analogously, for the ordinary man whose consciousness resides in the corporeal modality of the individual, his subtle modality, or center of subjective experience, likewise is believed to reside in the body. But the man who has realized his integral individuality undergoes a reversal and understands the body to be "in" the soul.

So when a being passes to supra-individual realization, he will then grasp the proper relationship between Atma and the individual states, that is, the latter appear as contained in the former.

In our ordinary state, we experience the I as jivatma at the centre of our subjective experience. This is characteristic of the individual state. However, this appearance is not the whole story. This realization is the awakened state of oneself as spirit, which is non-formal manifestation.

As such, it is superior to the dream state which corresponds to subtle manifestation and the deep sleep state which corresponds to corporeal or gross manifestation. The I appears here to be individual.

However, beyond those three states of Atma, there is the fourth state, there is the unmanifested. This I then cannot be multiple, since quantity makes no sense in the unmanifested. The apparent reality of multiple I's or subjectivities at the third (or lower) state is an illusion.

Note especially that at this point the ego is transcended. So any accusations of egoism, the desire to control or dominate others is beside the point. Neither pride nor humility are applicable here, since both pertain to the sentimental and individual character. Similarly, this surpasses any notion of altruism, for where there is no I (in the relative sense), there is no longer an "other". As Guenon writes:

> This is a domain where all beings are one, 'fused but not confused' according to Eckhart's expression and thereby they truly realize the words of Christ, 'That they may be one even as the Father and I are one'.

To illustrate this point, Evola brings up the experience of dreaming, something that Guenon also does. In a dream, there appear to be many characters, each with its own centre of consciousness. However, on awakening we see that the entire dream, and all those characters, were simply the productions of our own mind. A similar realization occurs with the awakening to the fourth state.

References: (both by Rene Guenon)
Is the Spirit in the Body or the Body in the Spirit?
Intellectual Pride

Posted on 2011-02-26 by Cologero

3.6 Ideas and Hidden History

One of the problems philosophers have long debated concerns the ontological status of the Platonic world of ideas. Aristotle proposed a solution that is fruitful as far as it goes, although it does not go far enough. His solution was that the idea is immanent in the object, a doctrine called hylomorphism. That is, the object is not material (hyle) only, but is also informed by the idea (morphe). Hence, when we see a material object, we know it by grasping its form.

Metaphysical insights from **Benedict Spinoza** and **Vladimir Solovyov** may show a way to rethink the problem. For Spinoza, ultimate reality is Substance, beyond space and time. Although infinite and beyond direct experience, Substance is known by two of its modes: **Extension** and **Thought**. These modes are appearances. Ultimately, the **Logos** is the source of ideas.

Extension Extension refers to things in Space and Time. Hylomorphism, therefore, accounts for our knowledge of ideas in Space and Time. So, when I look at a banana tree, I experience its material aspects through the senses, while judging it to be a banana tree through the Intellect. Discussions of this sort usually stop at the spatial aspect. However, a deeper seeing will unveil the temporal aspects. I then understand the banana tree to be a living being, unfolding in time. I can see the processes of germination, growth, and fruition. A real seer, or rishi, will see even deeper into the interiority of the plant, its nutritive soul.

Thought Since thought is temporal, but not spatial, we can grasp ideas in the mind apart from any objects in space. The ideas form higher and higher interconnected systems. Hence, grasping an idea in isolation falls short of understanding its full reality. We need to see the idea in its relationship to other ideas horizontally and also vertically in its relationship

to higher and more general ideas. These ideas do not exist on their own only in some ethereal realm. An idea becomes manifested in a person.

Logos The Logos is beyond space and time, i.e., it is part of formless manifestation. Relating this back to **Rene Guenon**, we would say the possibilities [ideas] of manifestation become manifest in the modes of Extension or Thought. The possibilities of non-manifestation, or non-being, are ideas in the mind of God, since the Logos is the Thought of the Father.

Hidden History So now we have a clue to the hidden aspects of history. In the material world of Extension, we need to see beyond Space into Time. This brings us into Thought. From the ideas arising from sense experience, we need to dig deeper and understand it in both in its broader and more general aspects. In this way, we move beyond outward appearances to understand seemingly contingent and unrelated events as manifestations of a larger system. Ultimately, it must relate back to the Logos itself.

Solovyov insists that Ideas are forces, so Action follows Thought. Hence, by understanding Thought, we will understand the world. Nothing happens by accident, but rather as the result of a deliberate act. The primary causal agent is always an idea become person, with a will that pursues determinate ends.

Traditional teachings considers the agent to be the work of angels or devas, since so-called natural forces have personalities. As an aside, we should point out that **Valentin Tomberg** asserts the same thing, If nothing else, this leads credence to Solovyov's claim that Hermetic philosophy is the foundation of Christian theology.

Posted on 2011-11-23 by Cologero

3.7 Principial Origin and Final Destiny

> While relative freedom belongs to every being under any condition, absolute freedom can belong only to the being freed from the conditions of manifested existence, whether individual or even supra-individual, and has become absolutely "one", to the degree of the pure Being, or "without duality" if its realization surpasses Being. It is then, but only then, that one can speak of the being "who is in himself his own law", because that being is fully identical with his sufficient reason, **which is both his principial origin and final destiny**.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Multiple States of the Being*

In the final chapter of the third book of his metaphysical trilogy — *Multiple States of the Being*, Chapter 18: The Metaphysical Notion of Freedom — Rene Guenon provides a metaphysical proof for free will, properly understood. The proof has two stages:

1. Demonstrate the possibility of Freedom from Nonbeing
2. Demonstrate the actuality of Freedom from Being

Freedom First of all, let's be clear about what freedom is. Guenon provides this definition:

> Freedom is the absence of constraint, a definition negative in form but fundamentally positive, for it is constraint that is a limitation, that is to say a veritable negation.

The absence of constraint means that the being acts in accordance with its own nature.

Nonduality First of all, Guenon points out that it is sufficient to establish that free will is a *possibility*, since the possible and the real are metaphysically identical. Universal Possibility is beyond Being, i.e., it is part of Nonbeing. Since Nonbeing is metaphysical Zero, the idea of unity is not applicable, so the term nonduality is more appropriate. Because there is no duality, there are necessarily no constraints. This proves that freedom is a possibility insofar as it results immediately from 'nonduality', which is obviously exempt from every contradiction.

Since Nonbeing can neither be determined nor determine itself, the absence of constraint can only result in "non-action", called wu wei in the Tao Te Ching. This is the "freedom of indifference", i.e., the sense of detachment, paradoxically, acting without acting. There is no "doer" to do something.

Unity Now that metaphysical freedom has been established as an abstract possibility, the next step is to establish it as a living reality. Any alleged scientific or philosophical proofs against free will are therefore necessarily flawed and are tantamount to squaring the circle or building a perpetual motion machine.

Being is One, i.e., metaphysical Unity, the first determination from the Zero of Nonbeing. As One, it is obviously not subject to constraint by anything else. The absence of constraint is what is meant by "freedom". Hence, freedom exists in the domain of Being or manifestation. To say it another way:

> unity presents itself in a way as a specification of the principial 'nonduality' of Nonbeing.

Freedom is therefore a possibility of being, that is, a possibility of manifestation. Since manifestation is the principle of multiplicity, each being is limited by the others; this limitation is a restriction on the freedom of each being. But to the extent that a being is unfree in any degree, it is

not fully itself. A totally unfree being does not even have its raison d'être within itself, which is equivalent to saying that it is not even a real being.

On the other hand, the Unity of Being is the principle of freedom, so a particular being is free to the extent that it participates in this unity. In other words, it is freer the more unified it is in itself. Thus, even Buridan's donkey has some degree of freedom so it does not starve itself.

Universal Being cannot be determined, but determines itself. Hence, in manifestation, freedom necessarily operates in differentiated activity, unlike the wu wei of nonduality. In the human state, particularly, this is "action" in the conventional use of the word. The human being is conscious and creative, manifesting his possibilities. He is One, a Whole, insofar as he has a stable Self which is his principal of unity.

In our world, the human being is encumbered with constraints, both physical and subtle. As a body, he is subject to physical laws, and also to the needs of the vegetable and animal souls. As these constraints demand psychic energy, his inner life becomes multiple. It takes self-knowledge and efforts of self-purification, to maintain these inner demands in balance.

The final, and most difficult constraint to overcome, is ignorance. As a rational animal, there is ultimately one choice, the most important choice: the choice between good and evil. Since freedom is to act in accordance to one's true nature as rational, only choosing the "good" is a free choice. Choosing evil is unfree, since its foundation is ignorance.

Summary Once metaphysics is understood, all the popular arguments for and against "free will" turn out to be pseudo-problems. The naïve view is that free will means the ability to choose between two options. As we just demonstrated, freedom means the power to act from one's own essential nature, unconstrained. As such, some choices are free, others are not. Since the Self is transcendent to the physical world, the so-called laws of physics do not apply.

To become One, to be made whole, is to be totally free. We are born potentially free, but to be actually free is not so simple. It requires training. You may stumble upon a solution yourself, but usually you will need help along the way. This is the goal of initiation.

Posted on 2021-12-04 by Cologero

3.8 The Traditional Notion of Causation

As a reminder to old readers, and a notice to the new, let us repeat Gornahoor's purpose. We claim that there was a **Primordial Tradition** of the Indo-European peoples, which manifested in the Vedic civilization, Ancient Greece, and Medieval Europe, *inter alia*. We are not here to teach **Aristotle**'s four causes, which anyone can find on the Internet, but rather to demonstrate the intrinsic commonality of worldviews between the Middle Age and Antiquity, and ultimately ancient India. Specifically, the Medieval Tradition is closer to Pagan Antiquity than is any current form of neo-paganism.

First of all, all three worldviews held to some version of hylomorphism, as shown is these two sets of related terms:

1. Form, essence, idea, Purusha, potency
2. Matter, substance, hyle, Prakriti, act

A cause is a principle on which something else depends for its being. Thus the cause has priority over the effect, not just temporally, but in the wider sense[7] that we give it. Aquinas and Aristotle name four types of causes in two classifications, as shown in this chart:

Classes of causation

[7] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3629

Intrinsic Causes	**Extrinsic Causes**
Material	Efficient
Formal	Final

The extrinsic causes are exterior to the being, while the intrinsic causes are what make it what it is.

Efficient cause That by which the effect is produced.

Final cause That for which the effect is produced.

Material cause That out of which the effect is produced.

Formal cause That which makes the effect to be of a particular kind.

A cause is a principle on which something else depends for its being. Thus the cause has priority over the effect, not just temporally, but in the wider sense that we give it. Aquinas and Aristotle name four types of causes in two classifications, as shown in Table 3.8:

Intrinsic Causes	Extrinsic Causes
Material	Efficient
Formal	Final

Table 3.1: Classes of causation

The extrinsic causes are exterior to the being, while the intrinsic causes are what make it what it is.

- EFFICIENT CAUSE: That by which the effect is produced.
- FINAL CAUSE: That for which the effect is produced.

- Material cause: That out of which the effect is produced.
- Formal cause: That which makes the effect to be of a particular kind.

In Man and his Becoming, Guenon associates **Purusha** with essence of form and **Prakriti** with matter or substance. He writes:

> The meaning of the word *hyle*, in Aristotle, is exactly that of substance in all its universality, and *eidos* corresponds no less precisely to essence regarded as the correlative of substance. Indeed, these terms, Essence and Substance, taken in their widest sense, are perhaps those which give the most exact idea in Western languages of the conceptions we are discussing [Purusha and Prakriti].

Again, we see the perfect correspondence between the Sankhya Hindu school and the metaphysics of Aristotle and Aquinas. In discussing the notion of cause, Guenon continues:

> The unmanifested state … is identified with *Mula-Prakriti*, Primordial Nature: but in reality it is Purusha as well as Prakriti containing them both in its own undifferentiation, for is it cause in the complete sense of the word, that is to say both at one and the same time efficient cause and material, to use the ordinary terminology, to which however, we much prefer the expressions essential and substantial cause, since these two complementary aspects of causality do in fact relate respectively to essence and to substance in the sense we have previously given to those words.

This is clearly a slip of the pen by Guenon and it reads the same in French. I'm sure he means "formal cause" where he wrote "efficient cause", otherwise, the whole conception makes no sense. So, let us recap his renaming of the causes:

Material Cause ⇒ Substantial Cause
Formal Cause ⇒ Essential Cause

This is clearly a slip of the pen by Guenon and it reads the same in French. I'm sure he means "formal cause" where he wrote "efficient cause", otherwise, the whole conception makes no sense. So, let us recap his renaming of the causes:

- Material Cause ⇒ Substantial Cause
- Formal Cause ⇒ Essential Cause

Now we can recap the notion of causation, in the hope that readers will learn to experience and understand the world in this way.

The unmanifested is polarized (the Tao becomes two), the Purusha (essence) and Prakriti (primordial matter). These are the intrinsic causes of a thing: the formal or essential cause from Purusha and the material or substantial cause from Prakriti. Since no thing can create itself, there must be a connecting link, or extrinsic cause, between the idea and the thing, or potency and act. The Idea is, as Guenon points out, a possibility of being. There must be a Will, or efficient cause, to actualize the potential of the Idea. Since Will follows intelligence, there must be a reason, of final cause, for it to act.

Posted on 2012-01-26 by Cologero

* * *

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-27 at 10:47 said:

This may be tangential to your main point here, but it's in my head as I had a yoga class this afternoon. I often read comments by western esotericists warning of the dangers of the eastern physical training. I understand the grave dangers of trying to forge an indestructible 'godlike' diamond body, but beyond that I have to say that I find yoga to be one of the most beneficial mind, body, soul practices it's possible to do, it is very balancing for the energy. I do not, however, tend to focus overly on the breathing, which is where I believe a lot of the contention comes from

– at one stage I got to the point where I was regularly forgetting to breath during meditation, which got quite frightening at times – is this what people mean by the dangers? Also I heard of the unregulated kundalini awakening but I'm not sure it's possible to do this unless one has undergone extensive training/practice and is therefore 'ready'. what are you thoughts on this? I am not disagreeing, by the way, the most natural 'tradition' for me has always incoporated the respective wisdoms of India and the western mysteries

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Caleb Cooper on 2012-01-27 at 11:29 said:

The cases you've heard of typically occur when someone takes up the energetic practices like Kudalinia Yoga or QiJong. They're often practicing recklessly on their own rather than under the supervision of an experienced practitioner, and through too much forceful will end up opening their third eye before they're ready. As long as you stay in flow rather than forcing things with the ego's will you shouldn't unleash anything it's not time to handle.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-27 at 13:51 said:

I see, thank you for drilling it down a bit! Kundalini yoga practice is quite specific, I have done it once, it's intensive, but superb from a meditative point of view and also agony on the stomach muscles! I went with a friend who had a classic yoga moment, asking me afterwards 'I saw the light, did you see the light?!'. I had not seen it in the way she described (third eye), but funnily enough, despite being in a huge but jam-packed studio, with scores of people in there like sardines, literally just an inch apart, for the whole two hours I felt myself to be a personal circle of light several metres across, wtih loads of space inside. I didn't feel the need to keep going back or keep trying the serpent movements but I can see why and how it 'works'

3.9 Unity, Uniformity, Harmony

In lieu of an essay today, we shall instead list some definitions and ideas adapted from various works of Rene Guenon. Once understood, the point of the inexistent essay will become immediately apparent. Note that some of the terms are not used by Guenon (although the concepts themselves are); this is to ensure consistency moving forward.

> As long as the world endures, there will always be irreducible differences.
>
> R. GUENON

Whole The Whole is logically anterior and independent of its parts. The Whole is a real principle of unity superior to the multiplicity of its parts.

Heap A whole conceived as logically posterior to its parts is a whole whose existence depends on the condition of being thought of as such.

Convention Any thought that does not express a reality, but is instead the result of mutual agreement. A Whole is real. A heap is conventional. Stopping at a red light rather than green is a matter of convention, although the concept of controlling traffic flow is real. The inability to distinguish the conventional from the real is the cause of most disputes today.

Multiplicity Multiplicity is situated beneath the level of manifested existence, and represents the extreme opposite of principial unity. Manifested existences become progressively less qualitative and more quantitative as they gradually move away from principial unity.

Synchronic Simultaneous manifested existences are related to each other hierarchically as they move away from principial unity.

Diachronic Manifested existences are related to each other over the course of time as they move away from principial unity.

Uniformity The attempt to create an artificial, or conventional, unity in manifestation.

Harmony The reflection of principial unity in manifestation.

Some reflections. Manifestation is on two levels: gross and subtle. Gross manifestation is further from principial unity than is subtle. Thus, for the individual, the Spirit (or Atman) is his principial unity. The proper hierarchical relationship, then, is spirit → subtle (soul) → gross (body). Then the being is in harmony.

Attempts to create a unity based on physical characteristics alone will necessarily fail. Examples are attempts to create a unity from genetic racial types. The next step is to create unity based on thought alone, such as liberal states based on mutual contracts or mutually agreed "propositions." But these are necessarily conventional, not real. Only spiritual unity is a real unity. Thus we try to see how the Spirit manifests synchronically and diachronically.

Posted on 2011-02-21 by Cologero

3.10 Multiplicity and Unity

When we make a judgment about what something is, we are actually intuiting its essence. For example, the squirrel we see is the manifestation of the idea of a squirrel. We experience its existence through the senses, but know its essence through intuition. We have the conviction that it is a squirrel.

When it comes to the most fundamental ideas, we need to develop that same inner conviction. It is instructive to relate **Vladimir Solovyov**'s understanding of manifestation with **Rene Guenon**'s.

The Three Moments The two agree that God, as Absolute, is One, and as All-possibility, is Infinite. With this in mind, we can re-express Solovyov's discussion of the three moments, or positings, from Chapter 6 of Divine Humanity.

1. God is One and contains all possibilities in the Divine Mind. Everything is contained in it. Multiplicity is a possibility of manifestation, which cannot be excluded from the One. Furthermore, this multiplicity cannot disrupt the One. This primal unity is immediate and undifferentiated.

2. The second moment is the manifestation or actualization of this content. This objectification of the possibilities is projected as a separation from the One. Tomberg relates this moment to the teaching of the tsimtsum in the Kabballah. This is no different from the idea of the Void, which is not a possibility of manifestation, for obvious reasons. Since it cannot be manifested, it is the space out of which this objectification occurs.

3. In the third moment, the Divine Unity is reasserted, but not as Absolute, but as Infinite. Unlike the first moment, Unity is now experienced as mediated and differentiated.

Analogously, we see this in the microcosm of our own mind. Our spirit manifests itself in a multiplicity of feelings, thoughts, and desires, while remaining one. This does not mean, however, that there is always an awareness of the unity of the spirit. On the contrary, usually a course of spiritual development is necessary to bring about this awareness of

the I as subject of the multiplicity of experiences. This I is prior to its manifestations.

Mystical Absorption This description seems different from the three moments as described in Oriental religions. As explained to me by some Hindus, it is more like this:

1. Brahman is the one, absolute reality.
2. For some reason, perhaps divine play or Lila, the one divides itself into multiplicity. This multiplicity is not real, but is an illusion of the finite mind which has forgotten its true source.
3. In the third moment, the multiplicity is reabsorbed into the One, like a drop of water returning to the ocean.

There is a definite difference in understanding between the two. In the first conception, the empirical ego is remains. Drawing on sources similar to Solovyov's, **Giovanni Gentile** in the *Theory of Mind as Pure Act* makes this clear:

> The particular individual is not lost in the being of the I which is absolute and truly real. For this absolute I unifies but does not destroy. It is the one which unifies in itself every particular and empirical ego. The reality of the transcendental ego even implies the reality of the empirical ego. It is only when it is cut off from its immanent relation with the transcendental ego that the empirical ego is falsely conceived.

Here again, we see that the empirical ego is a necessary manifestation of the transcendental ego. Illusion, in this conception, arises from the false belief of the empirical ego that it is absolute. In that sense, the Eastern and Western teachings converge.

Karma and Personality Although not part of the primeval, originary teaching, karma and reincarnation seem to have become integral parts of Hindu teaching. Karma tries to account for the diversity of individual circumstances as the result of one's past actions, even in previous lives. When pressed, the goal is not actually achieved. If you assume that everyone was equally knowledgeable and competent in some golden age, then the subsequent divergences make no sense.

On the contrary, Solovyov says that the diversity of people is the essential aspect of each person and cannot be reduced to something external. The person is not the differentiated acts of its psychic life. This is proved by the deep sleep state; the differentiated consciousness disappears, yet the person is not destroyed. Solovyov writes:

> We first have our primordial, indivisible, and integral subject. In a sense, this subject already contains the whole proper content of our spirit, our essence or idea, and this in turn determines our individual character. … Of course, it is contained there only substantially, in immediate unity with that subject as its inner idea, an idea as yet unrevealed and unembodied.

Here we see yet again a Guenonian teaching. The task of the spirit is to manifest those possibilities, which are salvation and liberation. Salvation, then, cannot simply lie in the amelioration of the external circumstances of our life.

Otherwise, human diversity would be unjust and the karmic teaching would make some sense as the ultimate source of justice. Rather, salvation comes as the awareness that the empirical self is not the real self.

The Idea of the Good Solovyov discusses the Idea of the Good, another fundamental idea also found in Plato, in the Justification of the Good. The task of higher rationality is to develop a deeper understanding of the Idea of the Good. The result of such understanding will lead to

the desire to conform one's own conduct to that idea. This conformity must be freely chosen and cannot be mechanical. That is, there can be no pill or medication to coerce someone to behave morally.

If creation, or manifestation, is good, then it is good to manifest one's possibilities.

Posted on 2014-05-09 by Cologero

3.11 Existence

The Concept of Existence

> In the eyes of an ordinary man representing the common-sense view of things, the phenomena are the visible and manifest while the Absolute is the hidden. But in the unconditioned consciousness of a real mystic-philosopher, it is always and everywhere the Absolute that is manifest while the phenomena remain in the background.
>
> Toshihiko Izutsu, *The Concept and Reality of Existence*[8]

The foundation of esoteric teaching is the "unity of existence". This is presumed in **Rene Guenon**'s *Symbolism of the Cross*.

> Existence is one and indivisible in its inner nature, just as Being is one in itself; indeed this unity of Existence derives directly from the oneness of Being, since universal Existence is nothing but the total manifestation of Being, or, to be more exact, the realization, in manifested mode, of all the possibilities that Being implies and contains principially in its very oneness.

[8] `https://www.gornahoor.net/library/Concept_and_Reality_of_Existence.pdf`

What follows is a simplification, but not a misleading, explanation, so it may clarify things for those just starting out and orient them toward the full teaching.

The common opinion is that existence consists of multiplicity rather than unity. That is, for the person at this stage, all the things in the phenomenal world, taken together, form existence; this approach fails to perceive the unity of existence. This common sense view is that objects have properties. For example, the table is brown, the grass is green, the crow is black. This assumes that the table, grass, and the crow exist before they can have properties. A conundrum then arises when you say, "the table exists." This assumes that existing is a property of the table, but how can it exist before it exists?

As a thought experiment, try reversing things. Then assume that the table is a property of existence, as is the grass and the crow. Then existence is one, but it manifests, to all appearance, as a table, grass, or a crow; phenomena, thus, are just modes or attributes of existence. Otherwise, the experience of the multiplicity of things forms a veil which obstructs the sight of the unity of existence.

This applies, a fortiori, to the understanding of God (Absolute).

> When the Pharoah asks Moses the trick question, "What is the Lord of the Worlds" (Quran 26:23), he is expecting an "essence" that exists. For example, the simple-minded answer is to answer something like, "God is the most perfect being" or "God is an omnipotent Spirit", etc. These responses presume that the essence precedes existence. So Moses avoids the trap and answers, "The Lord of the heavens and the earth, and everything between them, if you are aware."
>
> Ibn Arabi, *The Wisdom of Sublimity in the Word of Moses*

That means metaphysically that God's essence is His existence. That is Sufi teaching and it is also Catholic teaching. In the medieval period,

while war was going on among the exoterists, esoteric teachings were being shared.

When this is understood, then the things in their multiplicity are seen as revelations of the Absolute, or as a theophany. The first stage, then, is to understand this as the concept of reality, something that can be reached through human reason.

That is Knowledge of the Head.

The next stage of metaphysical realization is to transform the concept into the reality of existence in one's own consciousness.

The Reality of Existence

> In [the] major philosophies of the East, metaphysics or ontology is inseparably connected with the subjective state of man, so that the selfsame Reality is said to be perceived differently in accordance with the different degrees of consciousness.
>
> Toshihiko Izutsu

When the being understands the concept of existence as concept, he still doesn't know the reality of existence. That is because he remains in the human state. He still experiences the multiplicity of beings and the unity of existence remains hidden. To attain the realization of the unity of existence, he needs to transcend the human state. In *Symbolism of the Cross*, **Rene Guenon** hints at the process:

> This station, or degree of the being's effective realization, is attained by al-fana, i.e., by the annihilation of the ego in the return to the primordial state; such annihilation is not without analogy to the Nirvana of the Buddhist doctrine.

As he emphasizes in *Man and his Becoming*, the fundamental distinction between the Self and the ego must be grasped. As long as the being

identifies with the ego, the higher states are obscured, much like the way a constant cloud cover hides the sun, the moon, and the stars. Such as we are, the ego is drawn to the world. Ego consciousness is dominated by desires arising from lower states; it is moved by the negative emotions of fear, anxiety, worry, depression, and so on. The mind entertains extended fantasies of base desires. Thoughts are feeble, confused, and illogical.

The annihilation of the ego requires the undoing of all those tendencies. It is better to have a guide who can explain the process and give feedback. Through concentration exercises, one develops self-knowledge, including both the good and bad qualities of the soul. Through a process of purification, ego consciousness diminishes and the Self reveals higher states of being.

Knowledge of the higher states cannot be attained by rational reasoning, but only by a higher type of intellect called "intuition", which is a direct experience or reality unmediated by verbal descriptions. At this stage, there is no longer a distinction between the knower and the known. Rational thinking always assumes a subject and an object, so it never knows existence which is never an object. But at the intuitive stage, existence is not known as an object from the outside, but rather by the knower being inseparably existence itself. At this stage, existence is made manifest and the multiplicity of things are hidden in the bright light of Existence. They have become indiscernible from each other.

This is Knowledge of the Heart.

The Unity of Existence

> Beyond *fana*, there is still *fana al-fana*, the annihilation of the annihilation, which similarly corresponds to Parinirvana. In a certain sense, the passage from one of these degrees to the other is related to the identification of the centre of a state of the being with that of the total being.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Symbolism of the Cross*

The intuition of the unity of existence is often accompanied by blissful experiences. In many cases, there is a strong desire to re-experience that bliss. Oftentimes, people will stumble accidentally onto the intuition of the unity of existence. They may assume their experience is unique and they will talk about the "being one with everyone" and the like.

Like cargo cultists, they will repeat rituals like chanting, dancing, drumming, breathing exercises, extreme ascetical practices, psychedelic drugs, etc., in order to recreate the experience. What all these practices have in common is the attempt to annihilate the ego artificially by tiring it out or bypassing it, rather than through self-purification. In the worst cases, they might resort to sexual practices because the bliss of physical pleasure is thought to imitate the bliss of the higher states.

Megalomania, immorality, and heresy are the fruits of such practices. An esoteric school will guide seekers to avoid such excesses and the exoteric teaching will prevent immorality and heresy. So the next stage requires the annihilation of the annihilation, the disappearance of the consciousness of the ego annihilation. The consciousness of the experience is still not consciousness of absolute Reality.

Although the annihilation is a human experience, the subject is no longer the human state, but the Self revelation of absolute Reality. At the early stage, Reality was concealed and revealed itself only in the things and events of the phenomenal world. At this stage, however, Reality reveals itself as Absolute, i.e., it is unveiled and the manifest world is empty. Guenon describes it this way:

> The emptiness is complete detachment from all manifested, transitory and contingent things

Nevertheless, the Being regains his experience of the world, now understood both in its Unity and Multiplicity. Toshihiko Izutsu explains it like this:

> He regains his normal, daily consciousness and accordingly the normal, daily, phenomenal world of multiplicity again begins to spread itself out before his eyes. The world of multiplicity appears again with all its infinitely rich colors. Since, however, he has already cast off his own determination, the world of multiplicity he perceives is also beyond all determinations.

The Experience of Existence Tradition is not an intellectual system, because it cannot be fully understood without having undergone a change in one's being. This is **Rene Guenon**'s description of the process of bringing that about, from *Symbolism of the Cross*.

The Greater Holy War

> The "greater holy war" is man's struggle against the enemies he carries within himself, that is, against the elements in him that are opposed to order and unity. There is however no question of annihilating these elements, which, like everything that exists, have their reason for existence and their place in the whole; what is aimed at is to "transform" them, by bringing them back and as it were reabsorbing them into unity. Above all else, man must constantly strive to realize unity in himself, in all that constitutes him, through all the modalities of his human manifestation:

- unity of thought
- unity of action
- and also, which is perhaps hardest, unity between thought and action

The Will of God He then addresses what life is like after the realization of the unity of Existence.

> For whoever has achieved the perfect realization of unity in himself, all opposition has ceased and with it the state of war, for from the standpoint of totality, which lies beyond all particular standpoints, nothing remains but absolute order. Nothing can thereafter harm such a being, since for him there are no longer any enemies, either within him or without.

His actions become aligned with the Will of God. Guenon continues:

> Permanently established at the centre of all things, he "is unto himself his own law" because his will is one with the universal Will. He has obtained the Great Peace, which is none other than the **Divine Presence**; being identified, by his own unification, with the principial unity itself, he sees unity in all things and all things in unity, in the absolute simultaneity of the **Eternal Now**.
>
> To return to one's root, is to enter into the state of repose. By it the being escapes from the vicissitudes of the "stream of forms", from the alternation of the states of life and death, or of condensation and dissipation, and passes from the circumference of the cosmic wheel to its centre, itself described as "the void (the unmanifest) which unites the spokes and makes them into a wheel".

Detachment and Impassibility

> The ideal is the indifference (**detachment**) of the transcendent man, who lets the cosmic wheel tum. This absolute detachment renders him the master of all things, because, having passed beyond all oppositions inherent in multiplicity, he can no longer be affected by anything: He has attained perfect **impassibility**; life and death are equally indifferent to him, the collapse of the

> (manifested) universe would cause him no emotion. By dint of search, he has reached the immutable truth, the unique universal Principle. He lets all beings evolve according to their destinies, and he stands at the motionless centre of all destinies.

Imperturbability

> The outward sign of this inner state is **imperturbability**: not that of the hero who hurls himself alone, for love of glory, against an army in line of battle, but that of the spirit which, higher than heaven, Earth, and all beings, dwells in a body to which it is indifferent, taking no account of what its senses convey to it, and knowing all by global knowledge in its motionless unity.

Posted on 2022-01-11 by Cologero

* * *

Mike M on 2022-01-17 at 23:10 said:

The emphasis on not becoming attached to anything is one of the positives of the Zen tradition, it is no coincidence it came out of the East in a time after many "esoteric" traditions came into the world. I think there is potential for taking the practice's essence into other exoteric forms even if it is just a starting point, as one may suggest from Toshihiko Izutsu's life and some of my own experiences.

For those familiar, the Guenon quote is also in exact correspondence with Dogen's journey where Mind and Body dropped away as well as dropping Mind and Body: To study the Way is to study the Self. To study the Self is to forget the self. To forget the self is to be enlightened by all things of the universe. To be enlightened by all things of the universe is to cast off the body and mind of the self as well as those of others. Even the traces of enlightenment are wiped out, and life with traceless enlightenment goes on forever and ever.

3.12 The Infinite

This is the dictionary definition of Infinite:

1. Having no boundaries or limits.
2. Immeasurably great or large; boundless: infinite patience; a discovery of infinite importance.
3. Mathematics.
   (a) Existing beyond or being greater than any arbitrarily large value.
   (b) Unlimited in spatial extent: a line of infinite length.
   (c) Of or relating to a set capable of being put into one-to-one correspondence with a proper subset of itself.

In metaphysics, we are interested only in the first definition. The second is only a figurative use of the word and is of absolutely no interest. Mathematicians use the word only in a specialized and technical sense; in comparing it to the first definition, it is obvious that the mathematical infinity is not the metaphysical infinity, so care must be taken never to confuse the two. Rene Guenon uses the word "indefinite" to designate mathematical infinity.

From this definition we note that the Infinite is necessarily one, indivisible, eternal, and unchanging.

One There cannot be two infinities because Infinity A would limit or set a boundary to Infinity B. Therefore, the Infinite is One.

Indivisible If the Infinite were divisible, it could either be divided into two finite parts, which is impossible, or it could be divided into two equally infinite parts, which is also impossible. Thus, the infinite is indivisible. Another word used to express this quality is **Simplicity**.

Eternal It is eternal, otherwise it would be limited or bounded by time.

Unchanging Suppose the Infinite could change from state A to state B. That means that the Infinite as B would limit the Infinite as A. By definition this cannot be, therefore the Infinite is unchanging. Thus any system of thought that claim the Infinite is "evolving" is necessarily false.

Hermetic Symbolism The circle is the symbol of unity.

The lemniscate is the symbol of infinity. Valentin Tomberg's explanation follows:

> The lemniscate is not only the symbol of infinity, but also that of rhythm, of the respiration and circulation — it is the symbol of eternal rhythm or the eternity of rhythm … it represents the state of concentration without effort, i.e., the state of consciousness where the centre directing the will has "descended" (in reality is is elevated) from the brain to the rhythmic system, where the "oscillations of the mental substance" are reduced to silence and to rest, no longer hindering concentration.

Posted on 2011-02-22 by Cologero

* * *

GF on 2011-02-23 at 10:02 said:

I wonder why the figure eight has become symbolic of infinity, when the circle or spiral is more appropriate. In music, unison appears as a spiral while the octave appears as a figure eight.

Cologero on 2011-02-23 at 19:16 said:

The circle is the symbol of unity.
The lemniscate is the symbol of infinity. Tomberg's explanation follows:

> The lemniscate is not only the symbol of infinity, but also that of rhythm, of the respiration and circulation – it is the symbol of eternal rhythm or the eternity of rhythm. .. it represents the state of concentration without effort, i.e., the state of consciousness where the centre directing the will has "descended" (in reality is is elevated) from the brain to the rhythmic system, where the "oscillations of the mental substance" are reduced to silence and to rest, no longer hindering concentration.

GF on 2011-02-24 at 09:06 said:

The circle is not limited to expressing unity only. Recall how often in ancient artifacts Ouroboros appears in a circle.

Tomberg's quotation doesn't explain why the lemniscate is a symbol of infinity; he simply states it is so, then explains why it's also a symbol of eternal rhythm. However, rhythm involves alternation between polarities. Visually the lemiscate is divided in two, and gives an impression of movement. It aptly suggests the eternity of rhythm, but is not so apt as the circle to suggest the infinite. (I withdraw my suggestion of the spiral.)

Will on 2011-02-25 at 10:25 said:

Tomberg's comment matches nicely with the article "Opus Magicum: Fire" in Evola's Introduction to Magic. The author (apparently Giulio Parise) discusses "the Self's descent into the heart."

3.13 The Beginning of the World

The Dominicans and Franciscans differed in their view of the age of the world. The Dominican **Thomas Aquinas** claimed that reason alone could not determine whether the world had a beginning in time or not. In this, he was followed by **Kant** who also famously claimed that pure reason could not resolve this question.

However, the Franciscan **Bonaventure** did demonstrate that the world has a beginning in time, while demonstrating a knowledge of the infinite centuries before its mathematical explanation was developed by

Cantor. Bonaventure has three objections to a world with no beginning in time:

1. It is impossible to add to the infinite.

   Mathematically, this is expressed by $\aleph + 1 = \aleph$.

   That is, adding one minute to the infinite does not increase it. So, if we are at an infinite point of time from the beginning, it is not possible to add another minute.

2. It is impossible for the infinite to be ordered.

   This is not completely correct, as the natural numbers are well ordered, symbolized by ω. So you can go backwards by a finite amount without losing the order, e.g., $1 + \omega = \omega$, and so on. However, the negative integers, in their natural sequence, is not well ordered. Hence, it is impossible to count the days from the beginning.

3. It is impossible to traverse what is infinite.

   That is, it would take an infinite number of days to reach our current era, which is impossible.

Aquinas' objections are inadequate. Guenon has mentioned that the Middle Ages had an inadequate notion of the infinite, hence their metaphysics was incomplete. The example of Bonaventure shows this was not entirely true.

Note that Bonaventure's proof shows that **Nietzsche**'s doctrine of **Eternal Return** is false. This doctrine states that time is infinite, while space is not. Hence, the world must repeat itself identically over and over again. However, we now see that this is impossible, since we can never get to the world we are in.

Metaphysically, time, like space, is the realization of an idea or possibility. A world consists of a certain set of possibilities. When all the possibilities of a world have been manifested, that world ends. However, possibilities are infinite, hence there must be multiple worlds. These cannot be related to each other in time, due to Bonaventure's objections, but must be simultaneous in some sense, even if they appear to follow each other in time.

This again refutes Nietzsche's doctrine of a world with a finite number of possibilities which must repeat themselves. For Guenon, possibilities cannot repeat, since they are infinite. If they repeated, that would limit possibilities, which is a logical contradiction.

For background reading, please see *Did the World Have a Beginning*[9].

Posted on 2012-04-03 by Cologero

3.14 The Infinite

This is the dictionary definition of Infinite:

1. Having no boundaries or limits.

2. Immeasurably great or large; boundless: infinite patience; a discovery of infinite importance.

3. *Mathematics.*

    a. Existing beyond or being greater than any arbitrarily large value.

[9] `http://www.philosophynow.org/issues/44/Did_the_World_Have_a_Beginning`

b. Unlimited in spatial extent: a line of infinite length.

c. Of or relating to a set capable of being put into one-to-one correspondence with a proper subset of itself.

In metaphysics, we are interested only in the first definition. The second in only a figurative use of the word and is of absolutely no interest. Mathematicians use the word only in a specialized and technical sense – in comparing it to the first definition, it is obvious that the mathematical infinity is not the metaphysical infinity, so care must be taken never to confuse the two.

The first thing to note is that the Infinite is necessarily one, indivisible, eternal, and unchanging.

There cannot be two infinities because Infinity A would limit or set a boundary to Infinity B. Therefore, the Infinite is One.

If the Infinite were divisible, it could either be divided into two finite parts, which is impossible, or it could be divided into two equally infinite parts, which is also impossible. Thus, the infinite is indivisible.

It is eternal, otherwise it would be limited or bounded by time.

Suppose the Infinite could change from state A to B. That means that the Infinite as B would limit the Infinite as A. By definition this cannot be, therefore the Infinite is unchanging and cannot evolve.

Posted on 2011-10-27 by Cologero

3.15 There is no God but God

In Introduction to the Study of Hindu Doctrines, **Rene Guenon** includes a chapter on the relationship between theology and metaphysics. He writes:

> The theological point of view is but a particularization of the metaphysical point of view … it is an application of it to contingent conditions, the mode of adaptation being determined by the nature of the conditions to which it must respond … From this it follows that every theological truth, by means of a transposition dissociating it form its specific form, may be conceived in terms of the metaphysical truth corresponding ot it, of which it is but a kind of translation.

Since everything has a reason for its existence, so does theology. In particular, man as he is a contingent being, will respond and understand theological language, while finding metaphysical language abstract and unapproachable. The other more important factor, de-emphasized or ignored by Guenon, is that metaphysical doctrine itself is secondary and derivative. Specifically, in a book dedicated to the six orthodox schools of Hinduism, which claim to be based on the Vedas, there is no mention of the contents of the Vedas themselves.

The authority of the Vedas derives from their claim to be a revelation from a higher source to rishis or seers in a state of higher consciousness. The Vedas consist of poems, prayers, descriptions of sacrificial rites and rituals, incantations, laws and so on, all things that Guenon might dismiss as "sentimental" when they are actually foundational.

As an example we can consider the metaphysical doctrine "**Being is**" and its theological equivalent, "**God exists**". This equivalence was certainly known in the Middle Ages as we see from Thomas Aquinas[10]. Since what is Not Being, isn't, the clear corollary is that there is only one God. Hence, a commitment to monotheism[11], provided it is properly formulated and understood, is necessary to tradition.

Guenon explicates the metaphysics of Being and nonbeing most fully in *The Multiple States of the Being*. Anyone with a logical mind and

[10] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1299

[11] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=564

sufficient powers of concentration can follow his presentation; a fortiori, there is no requirement to be in a state of higher consciousness. For Guenon, Being is not the Infinite[12], which contains all possibilities. Being consists of all possibilities that are manifested. Nonbeing, then, consists of non-manifested possibilities as well as possibilities of non-manifestation.

Now Guenon is somewhat inconsistent in his various works. On the one hand in *Hindu Doctrines*, he makes the rather racist claim that "*Westerners, including even those who were true metaphysicians up to a certain point, have never known metaphysic in its entirety*." Yet, he also claims that the Middle Ages knew Tradition and had true initiates[13]. In particular, he writes that Western Neo-Platonism did indeed understand the Infinite. As Gornahoor has pointed out[14], the intellect of the Middle Ages was formed by the Neo-Platonists **Plotinus**, **Augustine**, and **Boethius**.

If God is the principle of Being, then how can God also be Infinite? Augustine understood the issue at stake. For Augustine, the possibilities in the Infinite are precisely what Plato means by ideas. Then, Augustine places these ideas in the mind of God[15]. Plato, and even Guenon, assume the ideas subsist in a domain of their own. This solution poses a dual conundrum. First of all, their metaphysical status is unclear. For Guenon, unmanifested possibilities do not "exist", otherwise they would be manifested possibilities. Hence, there is no way to "know" them, although he does claim to know them. Augustine recognizes this problem and solves it by putting the Ideas in the mind of God, so that they appear in consciousness but not in the world of manifestation. Hence, for Augustine God is beyond Being and is identical with the Infinite.

[12] https://gornahoor.net/?p=3261

[13] https://gornahoor.net/?p=3281

[14] https://gornahoor.net/?p=2298

[15] http://readingthesumma.blogspot.com/2010/05/question-15-ideas-in-mind-of-god.html

The other conundrum is more subtle and cannot be resolved by doctrine alone. One of the objections to Plato's philosophy is the lack of an adequate explanation as to how the ideas become real or manifested. This is a question we discussed in our interpretation of Evola's *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*[16]. This requires the **Will**, a conclusion that Augustine also reached; the will is not amenable or reducible to any verbal or intellectual theory.

A final point to be made is the status of the possibilities of non-manifestation. Once, again, we see a complete understanding in the West of these, under the concept of **privation**[17]. Rather than the trivial examples given by Guenon, Augustine relates this to the concept of "evil", which, he claims, cannot have a real existence, but is really a privation of the Good. As for Guenon's examples, the ideas of the Void[18] and of the Silence[19] are certainly known in the West.

Next we will discuss how we can know Being or God.

Posted on 2011-11-06 by Cologero

* * *

Enda Miller on 2011-11-07 at 15:22 said:

What do you mean by the term "manifested"? More precisely, what does it mean to say a "manifested or unmanifested possibility"?

Thanks!

Cologero on 2011-11-08 at 00:01 said:

We mean the difference between essence and existence as explained here.

EXIT on 2011-11-10 at 10:24 said:

Jesus/Satan: Will you lie, cheat and steal for me?

[16] https://www.amazon.com/dp/0999086049

[17] https://gornahoor.net/index.php?s=privation

[18] https://gornahoor.net/?p=17095

[19] https://gornahoor.net/?p=16873

Dupe: I will.

Jesus/Satan: Will you play the race card?

Dupe: Yes, master.

Jesus/Satan: Will you follow my one and only messenger on earth, Cologero Salvo who knows better than all the perennial writers that ever lived?

Dupe: Anything you say, master. Christianity is the bestest, massa.

`Charlotte Cowell on 2011-11-10 at 17:47 said:`

exit, I know this comment isn't directed at me but I'm just wondering how it is you personally came to hate Christianity / Jesus so much (or at least it seems that way). I'm not being sarcastic or trying to trip you up in some way, I'm genuinely wondering, there must be sadness behind it somewhere and I'm sorry (that isn't meant to be patronising, I'm not like that). Hope you are well. Cx

`Charlotte Cowell on 2011-11-10 at 17:49 said:`

by the way I don't think you are wrong to point out that the enemy so often tries to lead us astray in the most subtle of ways, even by masquerading as the Master Jesus or the heavenly angels, it's a problem we all face in our lives (life) here on earth, tragically so for most people I would think

`charlotte on 2011-11-12 at 15:58 said:`

i'd like to share this as Ysatis de Saint Simone has a very clear insight into true Christianity and also the era of the anti-Christ, her books are very interesting and help to understand the terrible confusions that have been caused because of the veiled language used in the Old Testament – those who understand the true and original Hebrew are few and far between, so it is no wonder so many are enraged and feel deceived. But we have to remember that rage and turning away from Christ is precisely what the bloodthirsty power of anti-Christ – the warmonger of the world – is hoping for. the war is waged within us and without us, we have to choose sides.

`http://video.google.com/videoplay?docid=-1291779146253225433`

`Enda Miller on 2011-11-26 at 14:49 said:`

This post has had a dramatic impact on me, thank you very much! May I continue my questioning?

"For Guenon, Being is not the Infinite, which contains all possibilities. Being consists of all possibilities that are manifested. Non-being, then, consists of non-manifested possibilities as well as possibilities of non-manifestation."

Is this to suggest that for Guenon God = Infinite, that he understands the Infinite as the conflation of Being and Non-Being?

Cologero on 2011-11-27 at 00:53 said:

Guenon understands the Infinite as having, in some sense, all possibilities. Things that exist (have being) are still possibilities, but with the property of manifestation, so from a logical point of view, you could say the Infinite is the union of Non-Being and Being.

Guenon did not explicitly claim God=Infinite. Rather, he said that theological language (God) needs to relate back to metaphysical language (Infinity). Hence, we filled in the details of that project by showing how we can understand God consistently, given Guenon's explanation of the Infinite. We drew on the best minds in the Western Tradition to show how everything that can be attributed to the Infinite has a correspondence to what we can say about God. Obviously, that is far from exhausting the topic, but it is a necessary first step in reclaiming the Western Tradition.

Ola on 2022-03-14 at 11:22 said:

"From the strictly human point of view, which alone is what religions as such have in view, "God" could not be the Absolute in itself, for the Absolute has no interlocutor; we may, however, say that God is the hypostatic Face turned towards the human world, or towards a particular human world; in other words, God is Divinity that personalizes itself in view of man and insofar as it takes on, to a greater or lesser extent, the countenance of a particular humanity." – F. Schuon, In the Face of the Absolute

"Although it is usually held that Plotinus inherited two major problems from his predecessors, i.e., a contradiction between the Pythagorean doctrine of the first Principle as an ultimate unity (the One) and the Peripatetic doctrine (going back to Anaxagoras) that the first Principle is the divine Intellect thinking itself, these two perspectives are in fact easily reconcilable, as numerous examples of different ancient theological systems prove.

In fact, only those who are bound to formal discursive reasoning can see a contradiction between Brahma nirguna and Brahma saguna, the ineffable Principle and personal Ishwara, Parama Shiva and Aham, Nun and Atum, or between apophatic and cataphatic ways of approaching God." – Algis Uzdavinys, The Heart of Plotinus

3.16 Living the Dream

> As the oyster makes its own shell, so the mind of man creates and necessitates his own life and fate.
>
> Ananda Coomaraswamy, *Myths of the Hindus and Buddhists*

In Vedantic teaching, there are three normal states of consciousness: deep sleep, dreaming sleep, and waking consciousness. In addition, there is a fourth state, *turiya*, which is not really a separate state, but encompasses all states. In Man and his Becoming, **Rene Guenon** refers to the Mandukya Upanishad to indicate how this state is known (note that this is really a *via negativa*):

- It knows neither internal nor external objects in an analytical sense
- It is not a synthetic whole of integral knowledge: it is neither knowing nor not knowing
- It is invisible: not perceptible by any sense
- It is actionless: changeless identity
- Incomprehensible: it comprehends all
- Unthinkable: it cannot be clothed in any form
- Indescribable: it cannot be qualified by any particular attribute
- It is the unique essence of the Self: Atman is present in all states

Atman is one and simple, hence it cannot be comprised of multiple states, although the states may be appearances of Atman. Since Atman is present in all states, it cannot be any particular object of consciousness.

In the other states, what, then, is not permanent? In a dream, none of the persons, places, or events that appear in it is permanent. When I wake up, they disappear. Like the oyster making his own shell, I create all of that even if I have no awareness of having done so. The embarrassment I felt when I was caught naked out in the street was my creation. So was the anxiety experienced when stuck on a high building which was spontaneously disintegrating. Ditto for the terror caused when I was chased

by a raging lion, but then fell to the ground and was unable to get up and run.

All that negativity is my own creation in the dream state. Nevertheless, it is gone the moment I awaken. Usually that moment is not under my conscious will as other factors determine when I will wake up. Occasionally, there are exceptions as I recently wrote about one. When I realized my book disappeared, I knew I was dreaming and woke myself up.

The conditions are analogous in the waking state. All the persons, places, and events, that so preoccupied me and held my attention, suddenly disappear, at least for me, at the moment of death. At that point, I finally will realize that my so-called life was not real at all, although what I wake up to may be better or worse than the waking life it replaced. The analogous question arises. If there are clues in the dreaming state that indicate that I am dreaming, and thus act as triggers to awaken me, are there also triggers in my waking state of consciousness to that serve a similar purpose? It must be possible since that is the teaching about the *jivanmukti*, i.e., one who awakens while still alive in the body.

Like the oyster, I create my own life and necessitate my own fate. Do you doubt that? If so, there are two possible reasons:

1. you are unaware of your own true will and how it creates your life
2. you really don't know what your life is

Your life is what remains after you die and that life is eternal. That, then, is the life you are creating and there can be no doubt about it. So what are the triggers? How many do you need to remind you to wake up? **St Augustine** says, which we quote on the front page, that the truth resides in the interior of man. **Guido De Giorgio** says that restoration must begin in the interior. Therefore, changing the persons, places, conditions, and events of our outer life will amount to nothing if we don't first address the disorder in our inner life.

It is our soul that is eternal, so it is our soul that requires our attention. How many times have we read that the true holy war is within? Do we believe it and act as if it were true, or are we more interested in our petty battles we fight in the outer world? How many times have we read that the intellect must dominate the lower forces in the soul? Do we work to develop that power of concentration and control, or are we instead obsessed with dominating people and conditions in our daily lives?

We know what to do. Undergo an intellectual realization. Quiet the randomness of the mind. Be truth tellers and Spirit lovers. Allow the Logos to dominate one's consciousness.

Posted on 2013-02-11 by Cologero

* * *

spaceloom on 2013-02-12 at 09:34 said:
"Allow the Logos to dominate one's consciousness." true, but how?

Cologero on 2013-02-12 at 11:17 said:
I think we've offered some suggestions for that several times, most recently in *Mind Fasting*[20].

Mleccha on 2013-06-11 at 23:18 said:
I have some question:
If Turiya is the Eternal Atman, or more technically, never enter in the stream of time and space even thouth is ever-present this mean that awakening of Turyia as our existencial condition(not as a peak experience to 'feel' but as any true initiatic knowlegde, our very condition of being) and non identification with any Sheaths, ie, like ramana maharshi says Self-realization being only the realization(and by definition, non identification with any gross, subtle or causal state) of ow's true nature in guenonian terminology means Liberation/Deliverance, the Union with Brahman?

August on 2013-06-12 at 07:23 said:
Yes, pretty much.

[20] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5394

3.17 The Rectification

In the Introduction to *The Reign of Quantity*, **Rene Guenon** reveals the goal of that work. By "rectification" he means that *the normal order is re-established* and *the primordial state is restored*. This requires becoming conscious of the hidden forces guiding the world:



> If our contemporaries as a whole could see what it is that is guiding them and where they are really going, the modern world would at once cease to exist as such, for the rectification could not fail to come about through that very circumstance.

Initially, only a few will see it. There is evidence of this. Before, the battle used to be over specific issues. Now, some are realizing that the actual situation is more systemic and cannot be reduced to one or a few issues.

> Since this rectification presupposes arrival at the point at which the descent is completely accomplished, where the wheel stops turning, it is necessary to conclude that, until this point is actually attained, it is impossible that these things should be understood by men in general, but only by the small number of those who are destined to prepare the germs of the future cycle.

Appealing to mass movements is not the solution; at best, they can gain but temporary victories. So arguments that begin with "all we need is ... " are not helpful. The 'quantity' of a movement comes to naught.

People cannot be convinced by arguments until they are ready.

> It is scarcely necessary to say that everything that the author has set out in this book and elsewhere is intended to be addressed exclusively to these few, without any concern for the inevitable incomprehension of the others; it is true that these others are, and still must be for a certain time to come, an immense majority, but then it is precisely in the 'reign of quantity', and only then, that the opinion of the majority can claim to be taken into consideration at all.

Posted on 2022-02-05 by Cologero

* * *

`De Bosit on 2022-02-06 at 04:49 said:`
Thank you.
It's so weird being normal that I ended up in the loony bin again.
I see it as extended vacation but more fun.

`Balrog Booger on 2022-02-07 at 11:34 said:`
There certainly has been a change in the collective consciousness of people over the past few years. I notice that acquaintances have an increasingly acute, but unnamed and subconscious, sense of impending doom. How they interpret this fear seems largely dependent on how they identify politically. Those left of center seem to rationalize this as concern about the climate or "mental health" problems. Reactions on the right are much more diverse, but usually are no closer to a traditional understanding. In particular, among the young, Internet-based right wing I see an increasing amount of interest in the writings of Kaczynski, but this skepticism of technology usually happens in isolation from any deeper spiritual concern. Though, it does sometimes have the effect of convincing persons that there is no political solution, which I regard as a good thing.

I had an interesting conversation with my normie-liberal, non-religious, "agnostic" sister recently where she implicitly admitted to believing the world was ending, but said explicitly that she didn't want to be "one of those people" that believed that. There are many such cases. Everyone, to some degree or another, seems to perceive this subtle shadow of despair and dread, but hardly any of them ever name it, let alone try and trace it to its origin. I guess Evola's probably right that this sort of behavior is a subconscious defense mechanism. I don't know.

3.18 Five Elements of Manifestation

> The wind is in truth the All-Devourer, for when the fire dies out it goes into the wind, when the sun sets, it goes into the wind, when the moon sets, it goes into the wind, when the waters dry up, they go into the wind, for the wind consumes them all. Thus it is with respect to the divinity. And now with respect to the self. The breath is in truth the All-Devourer, for when a man sleeps, speech goes into breath, the eye goes into breath, the ear too, and the manas, for the breath consumes them all. These then are the two All-Devourers; wind among the gods, and breath among living men.
>
> *Chandogya Upanishad*

> Music can be understood as an objectification of the spirit; it does not express knowledge in the usual logical, intellectual sense, nor does it shape matter; instead, it gives sensuous representation to our deepest associations and most immutable laws.
>
> Emma Jung, *Animus and Anima*

The corporeal world is, in Tradition, composed of five basic elements: Ether, Air, Fire, Water, and Earth. That means that the world was understood in a qualitative, not quantitative, sense. As such, they represent the different densities of matter.

Some see it that formulation a proto-science proposed by the ignorant. That cannot be true because the Traditional understanding is vertical: the qualities of the elements form the corporeal world. Science works horizontally: it measures data and proposed some theory to explain the qualities of the elements.

Ether Ether lies at the border between the gross and subtle bodies. Time comes into manifestation with the subtle body, but space arises in gross body; that is why ether is associated with space.

Ether is associated with the sense of hearing, since it is the most ethereal. Sound arises from anywhere, not dependent on the line of sight. The highest expression of hearing is music. As Schopenhauer pointed out, music, of all the arts, does not represent any specific material entity. Sculptures do; painting does, despite attempts at pure abstraction, which nevertheless rely on shapes and colours; poetry and literature present natural and human events. But music comes from a different realm altogether. Birds don't even sing in musical keys.

Revelation also comes through hearing, more effectively than visions.

Fire Fire is form—or essence—without matter. The essence has not yet taken substantial form. That is why the question, "Where does the fire go when you blow it out?" has no answer, actually not even any meaning. Sight, therefore, is the sense associated with fire; you can see it, but not touch it.

The rainbow is another example of the fire element; it can be seen, but never reached or touched. Hence, fire can create images of spiritual things which have individuated forms, yet have not fully materialized in matter (i.e., the earth element).

It is manifested in life as the organs of locomotion, such as legs, wings, and so on.

Air The air element is associated with touch, since it is the first tangible element. As the *Chandogya Upanishad* points out, it is the most fundamental element. Everything ultimately becomes air. It occupies the space between the solid earth and the lunar sphere.

The organs of touch, like arms, tentacles, or paws, are used to extend one's reach beyond a single spot.

Water Water is associated with the sense of taste. Its organ are the genitals, because it is a sign of renewal.

Earth Earth is associated with the sense of smell and the organs of excretion, which return substances back to the earth. Its symbol is Prometheus, who discovered fire, yet is chained to the earth where he suffers.

Taxonomy of Beings The human being, as a complete being, shares in all five elements. Yet it is possible for beings to be composed of fewer than all five. We mentioned the jinns, which are beings of fire. Hermetic teaching understands the effects of the elemental beings, each which is made of a different element:

- **Gnomes**: Earth
- **Undines**: Water
- **Sylphs**: Air
- **Salamanders**: Fire

Eliphas Levi, in *Transcendental Magic*, describes them this way:

> the demons of air, the spirits of fire, the phantoms of water and ghosts of earth

Due to the differences of manifestation, human life does not always interact with such beings. Nevertheless, sometime you may sense, as children often do, in a brook or the rustling of the leaves in a breeze, such beings.

Undines, for example, are seductive water beings; as noted, water is associated with the sense organs.

Sylphs are often depicted as fairies and interact directly with the spirit.

Gnomes can be recognized in people who become obsessed with a single idea, which they cannot easily give up, even in the face of logic and contrary facts. **Norman O Brown**, in *Life Against Death*, points out that such thoughts are represented by turds in Freudian analysis. They may be tolerated by the owner, but are unpleasant to anyone else.

Posted on 2021-07-11 by Cologero

* * *

Adil on 2021-07-12 at 14:33 said:

A refreshing read in times where humans suffer a greater and greater abstraction from the physical. To my knowledge the sense of hearing was regarded as the prime sense organ by the ancient Egyptians. Sound arises from within, and doesn't entail separation between subject and object. In modern times, seeing replaced hearing as the prime sense organ, creating a bias towards all things tangible and measurable. Yet from a spiritual perspective, hearing might be the superior form of seeing.

Ole on 2022-07-17 at 15:47 said:

The Five Elements and the multiple states of the Being:
Non-Being: Ether
Being: Fire
Becoming: Water
Subtle Manifestation: Air
Gross Manifestation: Earth

4

Manifestation

4.1 The Principle of Manifestation

A fundamental metaphysical principle is the "Principle of Sufficient Reason", that is, everything that comes into manifestation has an explanatory cause. The natural man believes he can explain the existence of something by its antecedent material causes, that is, solely in its horizontal dimension. The esoterist, on the other hand, knows that there is a vertical dimension.

So this is the question: How does the idea, or essence, of something become actual, or existent? Julius Evola, in his system of Magical Idealism, explains that it is Will that magically brings the idea of a thing into existence; in other words, the **Will is the Sufficent Reason** for the thing. Thus we see that it is the strongest wills that can manifest their ideas, visions, and projects in the "real" world.

Furthermore, Evola divides the Will into two categories: the spontaneious will and creative will. The former is unconscious, so it both deterministic and random like Schopenhauer's depiction of the Will. This is the condition of the natural man, who is asleep to life. The awakened higher man uses his will consciously and with purpose.

Valentin Tomberg, in **Covenant of the Heart** breaks it down this way:

- Matter is concentrated Energy
- Energy is concentrated Will
- Thinking (the idea) and Feeling (intensity) underly Will

This is consistent with Swedenborg's teaching that thought is transformative, though it is the intensity of the thought that determines the speed of transformation.

Posted on 2010-03-10 by Cologero

4.2 Logos and the Primordial Tradition

> If we take the world as it is, it is impossible to explain it in any way which will give meaning to the ends and aims of the activities of men and of humanity. We can discover no trace in the world of any purposive development which might lend significance to our actions.
>
> Albert Schweitzer, *Civilisation and Ethics*

We could take the world as it is but that would condemn us, as Dr. Schweitzer points out, to a life of insignificant actions. With no support for our opinions other than the individual will, discourse becomes futile and arguments are nothing but the disguised will to power. Most, recognizing this, will seek a transcendent explanation and settle for some form of belief. The few will be drawn to the transcendent by transcending the individual will and will then recognize a form of knowing superior to both critical thinking and sensory awareness.

To show the conformity of the **Principle of Logos** to the **Primordial Tradition**, I provide the following quotes—almost at random—from *Indian Philosophy* by **Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan**. There was a time, actually not so long ago, that every point mentioned below was accepted by every man of sound mind in the West.

- Man cannot live on doubt. Intellectual pugilism is not sufficient by itself. The zest of combat cannot feed the spirit of man.

- If the unassisted reason of man cannot attain any hold on reality by means of mere speculation, help may be sought from the great writings of the seers who claim to have attained spiritual certainty.

- The acceptance of the Veda (revealed scripture) is a practical admission that spiritual experience is a greater light in these matters than intellectual reason.

- Reason is subordinated to intuition. Life cannot be comprehended in its fullness by logical reason.

- As the difference between mere consciousness and self-consciousness constitutes the wide gulf separating the animal from man, so the difference between self-consciousness and super-consciousness constitutes all the difference between man as he is and man as he ought to be.

- The philosophy of India takes its stand on the spirit which is above mere logic, and holds that culture based on mere logic or science may be efficient, but cannot be inspiring.

- The real is not the universe extended in space and time; for its nature is becoming and not being.

- All the systems aim at the practical end of salvation. The systems mean by release (moksa) the recovery by the soul of its natural integrity, from which sin and error drive it.

- All the systems have for their ideal complete mental poise and freedom from the discords and uncertainties, sorrows and sufferings of life.

Finally:

It is a fundamental belief of the Hindus that the universe is law-abiding to the core, and yet that man is free to shape his own destiny in it.

Posted on 2010-12-28 by Cologero

* * *

Count Cagliostro on 2010-12-28 at 19:44 said:

"We could take the world as it is but that would condemn us, as Dr. Schweitzer points out, to a life of insignificant actions. With no support for our opinions other than the individual will, discourse becomes futile and arguments are nothing but the disguised will to power. Most, recognizing this, will seek a transcendent explanation and settle for some form of belief. The few will be drawn to the transcendent by transcending the individual will and will then recognize a form of knowing superior to both critical thinking and sensory awareness."

EXCELLENT REMARKS!KUDOS!

James O'Meara on 2010-12-29 at 09:34 said:

Danielou I think includes Sir R. among the out-caste Victorian educated "leaders" of Indian independence who knew nothing of Traditional India. All the more reason to be impressed by what the ordinary man of reason once thought without doubt or challenge.

Today, of course, articulating such sentiments would bring sneers of "I bet you love Sarah Palin and kill and dress your own food." Eventually they will be illegal, since they indicate you are likely to shoot an abortionist.

kadambari on 2010-12-29 at 10:04 said:

James,

Radhakrishnan has written a book on Indian philosophy, which is much better than what comes out of India these days. It is interesting that a man like Savarkar is treated like a fanatic these days when that is hardly the case: Savarkar went out of his way to bring the Dalits into the fold, and he was the only leader that understood that a nation has to understand first what it stands for, has to understand its identity, before it can produce anything worthwhile or produce any greatness. The British understood that he was dangerous and capable of leading people in a direction that would prove dangerous for them which is why they placed him under strict scrutiny from the very start. Savarkar was courageous, he was the real patriot, along with people like Tilak, Bose and Patel. The British knew that people like Gandhi and Nehru were no real threat to them, and this is why they did not restrain them that much. The British were smart in this respect.

Savarkar is branded a fanatic, when that is hardly the case when you actually read what he wrote. It is unfortunate that Indians have followed the way of Gandhi and Nehru, Gandhi urged Hindus to read and learn the Koran, and for Muslims to read the Gita, he was totally out of touch with reality. He had never read much, and did not understand history and had a peculiar interpretation of Hinduism, it would have been much better if he died of natural causes before inflicting the damage he did, an idiot ended his life when he was about to die anyway. Gandhi's death affected the reputation of Savarkar, even though he was acquitted of any involvement. He offered an alternative to what Gandhi and Nehru stood for. Now the Congress has branded this great man a fanatic. It is a shame, the French wanted to erect a statue for him because he had escaped from France when he was detained, but India's own government has not given approval. This is how India treats its great men, and why it does not deserve people like Savarkar...

`Cologero on 2010-12-29 at 11:14 said:`

I've never gotten around to reading Danielou, so I don't know in what sense he means that. If he means that R. did not know village culture, or manner of dress, or folk dances, etc., then that seems somewhat secondary. To be "Traditional" in a non-traditional world means to move forward, not backward; so what is critical is one's "spirit", or manner of thinking and seeing the world. Coomaraswamy was also western-educated, yet was a "traditionalist". Paradoxically, he lamented the loss of folk arts and crafts in India, yet his own personal lifestyle was quite bohemian.

R.'s descriptions of the six Vedic schools matches up with Guenon's; and they both differ from the wikipedia article. R. refused to include modern Indian philosophers on the grounds they were inadequate and brought nothing new to the game. I assume he had in mind the likes of a Vivekananda and so on.

Furthermore, R's pupil Murti in his *Central Philosophy of Buddhism*[1] was well aware of

[1] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=299`

Guenon and his project.

James O'Meara on 2010-12-29 at 14:22 said:

According to D. such "anglicized Indians" were not just cut off from secondary matters, or rather that these were not merely 'secondary.' By their dress, food, etc. they would have been outcastes to traditional pandits, and so would not have been able to learn anything from such original, authoritative sources. Of course, in most cases they weren't interested in such 'primitive' and 'dogmatic' sources, and sought learning through "up to date" English authors.

He mentions R. only once, just one name among Aurobindo, Tagore, and Vivekananda. Tagore, by contrast, he specifically singles out as knowing only English authors.

D. of course is contrasting this with his own 'going native' approach. Even so, he could only attend lectures by sitting in another room, so that his Brahmin wasn't contaminated by this European. This made sitar lessons rather difficult!

He basically just says that he "had nothing to learn from them" which of course would be consistent with R. being, somehow, JUST as accurate as D.'s own teachers. His main criticism was of authors who thought India needed to "learn from the English" or modernize or "adapt evolutionary perspectives" etc., such as Aurobindo or Vivekananda.

And of course, my point remains that even if R was Anglicized the quotes show that the, say, pre-War Anglo was far more traditional than what we have on hand today.

Murti's was one of my favorite books in grad school, when I was trying to get my Neo-Platonic and Hegelian teachers to take India seriously. I even spent a summer at Chogyam Trungpa's Naropa Institute taking a course in Madhyamika Philosophy. I don't recall any evidence of his being aware of Guenon, and the book seems to have disappeared in my travels. Makes sense conceptually, but how involved with G. was he?

The issue of bohemianism vs. traditional cultures is thorny, but as I've mentioned here before, D. says he found far more freedom to live his rather bohemian lifestyle traveling through 30s India with his boyfriend in silver mobile home in traditional India than in Europe, Britain, or Anglicized India. It was not "acceptance" so much as that being European, he was ineligible for marriage anyway, so his private life was of no interest. Don't ask, don't tell?

kadambari on 2010-12-29 at 22:34 said:

R. was the President of India once, at least he was a man who commanded respect. Look at India's leaders today, and look at India's President hand picked by the chairman of the Congress party they say, who wants to hear her speak? I would take R anytime over the kinds that infest Indian politics today... I am really curious who were these Pandits that Danielou met, where were they from? Kashmiris also had interactions with many foreigners such as Aurel Stein who seems to have gotten along fine with them and was popular amongst them, there are different regions in India, and even the Pandits from different regions vary...

kadambari on 2010-12-29 at 22:48 said:

@James

Here is Stein's interactions with Pandits in Kashmir, I don't see any contamination issues, he seems to have interacted fine with them and worked with them on manuscripts so he could translate the Rajtarangini...

Buhler the German Sanskritist was also in Kashmir and these people seem to have had different experiences...

The Kashmiri manuscripts have an interesting history... .Many were taken to make a dam once by the Sultan and were spotted floating in the water (there are made of bamboo with ink not easily erased) by some foreign Indologists...

http://www.siraurelstein.org.uk/legend.html

James O'Meara on 2010-12-29 at 23:46 said:

"Alain Daniélou became a disciple of the renowned sannyasi Swami Karpatri. He studied traditional cosmology and metaphysics with Vijayanand Tripathi, and the vina with Pt. Sivendranath Basu for several years. On Swami Karpatri's orders, he was initiated into Hinduism with the name Shiva Sharan. "

His comments on R. et al. and his Hindu studies can be found online here:

https://tinyurl.com/255s4dm

kadambari on 2011-01-01 at 17:37 said:

@James

Here is an interesting thought of Savarkar I came upon while reading his letters from prison: He says India is not ready for the Vedanta (when he wrote!):

"The Americans need Vedant philosophy, and so does England; for they have developed their life to that fullness, richness and manliness- to Kshatriyahood and so stand on the threshold of that Brahminhood, wherein alone the capacity to read and realize such philosophy can co-exist. But India has not. We are at present all???? (the script does not transliterate but the word is "we are all shudras")? and cannot claim access to the Veda and Vedanta. That is the underlying idea why shudras were not allowed to Vedas; not certainly not, for cruelty, nor for narrow or vested interest- otherwise... "

Interesting thought! He was a very smart man, and handsome too when he was young, wish they had followed him as a leader, India might have become something...

kadambari on 2011-01-01 at 22:52 said:

Here is the full paragraph:

About the books on Vedant philosophy, well, I fear it is not opportune that such men should be busy with such things. The Americans need Vedant philosophy, and so does England; for they have developed their life to that fullness, richness and manliness- to Kshatriyahood and so stand on the threshold of that Brahminhood, wherein alone the capacity to read and realize such philosophy can co-exist. But India has not. We are at present all???? ? and cannot claim access to the Veda and Vedanta. That is the underlying idea why shudras were not allowed to Vedas; not certainly not, for cruelty, nor for narrow or vested interest- otherwise ?????? ? would not have been written by the very Brahmins expounding the same philosophy more lucidly. We, as a Nation, are unfit for these sublime thoughts, for it is well known that Bajirao I I was a great Vedantist and that is why, perhaps, he could not see the difference a kingdom and a pension. Let us study history, political science, science, economy, live worthily in this world, fulfil the???????? – the householders's duties – and then the ????????? and its philosophic dawn might come.

kadambari on 2011-01-01 at 23:06 said:

avove: "we are present all shudras" (that is people who are not free)

Let us study history, political science, science, economy, live worthily in this world, fulfil the grihasthashram

– the householders's duties – and then the vanaprasthashram and its philosophic dawn might come... Sound reasoning which was never followed, but vague ideals were placed first with the rest to follow and one can see the results today...

kadambari on 2011-01-07 at 13:12 said:

@James

"He mentions R. only once, just one name among Aurobindo, Tagore, and Vivekananda. Tagore, by contrast, he specifically singles out as knowing only English authors."

Hindus just see the above for what they were and not all knowing. Vivekananda is important because he stressed the need for Hindus to be more aggressive when it came to their interests and stressed that passivity is not a strength.

Tagore wrote poetry of the kind that is possible only in India. Yeats acknowledged he never thought poetry could be written in this fashion. However, Tagore is almost entirely lost in translation.

But even if he did not read enough English literature as Danielou puts it, he understood India, and that is most important.

As for Tagore knowking only English authors, I suppose this is the Frenchman Danielou speaking. Yes it is unfortunate that our part of the world is restricted to English literature and philosophy owing to the language barrier. German philosophy and Russian literature is much more interesting to read for me.

I have not finished reading Danielou just a few pages, so it is stashed for when I can afford the time!

But from my study of the French language and literature, I am not that drawn to it. I have always felt there to be a material, sensual base to it. Interesting Evola thought the same when he quoted Tolstoy making the comment: "For the French a woman comes before everything else. They are a weak and degraded people. Doctors say all consumptives are sensual." Muslim culture is also based on control of female sexuality and Hindus feel they are sensual in a way Hindus are not.

This is hard to explain, in classical Indian culture the erotic abounds and is given its due place, but it is always placed under something higher ideals...

kadambari on 2011-01-07 at 13:14 said:

@above

This is hard to explain, in classical Indian culture the erotic abounds and is given its due place, but it is always placed under higher ideals.

kadambari on 2011-01-07 at 14:52 said:

@above in regard to Tagore

I meant to say even if he did not read enough of European literature not written in English

The Western understanding of the erotic in classical Indian literature is usually misguided. After the Islamic invasions, Indian society changed and many Muslim customs influenced India such as covering women and so on (it is warm in India and Hindus traditionally hardly wore clothes). My husband notes that in Kashmir it is Muslims who have the most restrictions but the highest divorce rates and other "phenomena" which is punishable by death in their culture. Hindus are quite reserved in this respect but they are not "repressed", although Islamic influence has affected the culture in a negative way with respect to these things, especially the position of women.

I think it is for these reasons that we can never identify with Sufi poetry, the crying, the longning and all the tear dripping, which stems from a kind of repression... If you look at Indian texts such as the Kama Sutra, they are almost written with a kind of detachment as it were, the purpose of which is to help husband and wives have a happy marriage! So even at the most sensual, there is always a higher sense pervading the literature. This is lost to most Westerners...

James O'Meara on 2011-01-07 at 16:18 said:

kadambari:

"This is hard to explain, in classical Indian culture the erotic abounds and is given its due place, but it is always placed under higher ideals."

Exactly D's view. In "The Four Aims of Life in the Tradition of Ancient India" he emphasizes the need to harmonize the four virtue, success, pleasure and liberation both within the individual

and in the structure of society.

> Arthur Konrad on 2020-12-28 at 12:20 said:
> "The real is not the universe extended in space and time; for its nature is becoming and not being."
> He ought to know the best, he became president.

4.3 Conditions of Corporeal Manifestation

In 1912, when Guenon was in his mid-twenties, he published a densely argued article on the conditions of corporeal manifestation. It abruptly ends; apparently a Part 2 was planned to conclude the essay, but never appeared. Rather than try to extrapolate the second half (which would be difficult without knowing his source material), I'd rather use what is available and then apply it in a way to understand the natural or human order.

Guenon is one-pointedly focused on the cosmic or metaphysical order; when he does talk about the human order, it is usually to criticize various aspects of it. Nevertheless, beyond the Brahmanic type of spirituality that he undoubtedly represents, there are many more whose earthly task brings them into the areas of administration or economic activity. There certainly is a spirituality appropriate for them. Guenon does indeed point out that the human order and the cosmic order are not really separated, since they continuously react on each other ("Solidification of the World", Reign of Quantity).

Guenon writes that there are five conditions which corporeal existence is subject to:

- space
- time

- matter
- form
- life

He summarizes: "A body is a material form living in time and space." Space and time are clearly necessary for there to be any consciousness of material objects. Neither space nor time is discovered through observation, but rather they are necessary conditions for there to be observations at all.

By including matter and form, Guenon reaffirms the hylomorphism of the Western Tradition. Taking some cues from Guenon and applying them to Plato's divided line, understood ontologically rather than epistemologically, we can attempt to understand the conditions of material existence. Plato makes a distinction between philosophical ideas and mathematical ideas both because of their forms of knowledge and that the latter are closer to the material world. Guenon claims the Point, without dimension, generates all the other dimensions. So we already start with a mathematicization of the world.

The two branches of maths, arithmetic and geometry, then correspond to time and space, respectively. Since time is more subtle (for example, a thought exists in time but not in space), it is ontologically prior to space. These are the conditions for the appearance of things. The actuality of things is then based on form and matter, which we can consider as two opposing poles.

For God, essence and existence are identical, but not so for the world. The Absolute is the Point, and the Infinite relates to all the possibilities. In separating those two aspects, there is a clearing for the world to appear. Every corporeal being partakes, then, in both form and matter.

Posted on 2012-09-27 by Cologero

4.4 Entities and Ideas

In Lectures 5 and 6 of *Divine Humanity*, **Vladimir Solovyov** explains the central points of his metaphysical understanding. Solovyov begins with Greek paganism, Neoplatonism, Hermetism, and German Idealism. However, Solovyov comes to a deeper conclusion and also adds some insights to **Rene Guenon**'s system, particularly in the *Multiple States of Being*.

The Entity Although Solovyov claims that "a continuous thread of logical thought must lead every consistent mind from the sensuous experience of phenomena to the speculative belief in ideas," we will simply stipulate that to be true as we have previously provided ample evidence. Once accepted, there are some obvious corollaries. The first is this:

> The usual thinking is that if all entities endowed with senses disappeared from the world, the world would nevertheless remain as it is, with all its variety of forms, with all its colors and sounds.

This is the naïve realist, and scientific, point of view. To understand its truth, all that is necessary is to try to imagine such a world. Of course it can't be done. Then he adds:

> The world we know is only a phenomenon for us and in us; it is our representation. To place it wholly outside ourselves, as something absolutely autonomous and independent of ourselves is a natural illusion.

Yet this representation is not arbitrary since we cannot create or destroy material objects at will. So the physical world has causes independent of us, and these are what Solovyov investigates. Solovyov calls these forces "entities", which have three qualities.

- **Atom**. An atom is an independent unit, the foundation of reality, real centers of being
- **Monad**. A monad is a living, acting force. As such, monads interact with each other.
- **Idea**. The idea is what distinguishes units from each other, i.e., the forces must represent a determinate content.

Although the translation uses the term "the all", I will instead call it the Infinite, or all-possibility, as more metaphysically precise in Englist. Solovyov understands this:

> The content of the Infinite consists of living and acting entities, eternal and abiding, which by their interaction form all reality, all that exists. ... The relation of each entity to the Infinite constitutes its *objective* idea, which represents the full manifestation or actualization of its inner uniqueness, or *subjective* idea.

These entities form a hierarchy, because any two entities themselves have a higher principle that is common to both of them. At the peak of the hierarchy is the idea of absolute goodness or absolute love. The fullness of the ideas cannot be understood as a "heap" or as their "mechanical aggregate". Rather their inner unity must be grasped, i.e., intuitively, and that is love.

Solovyov claims that philosophical systems are unbalanced when they focus on just one element—atom, monad, or idea—of the entity. What is required is the synthesis of all three.

Differentiation There are two opposite misunderstandings. The first is pluralism, or the notion that there are many independent entities. But how then could they interact without a common principle? The other error is to ignore the multiplicity of being and focus only on the higher

elements of the hierarchy. The latter error is characteristic of the modern world, with its lack of differentiation. Solovyov writes:

> The more particular concepts a concept subsumes within itself, the fewer features it will have, the poorer its content will be, the more general, more indeterminate it will be. Thus, for example, "humanity" as a general concept embracing all human beings, and therefore of a scope much broader than the concept "monk", is much poorer than the latter in content.

Since such relations are the result of a process of abstraction, they have no content of their own. We see this today, for example, in those who claim to make no distinctions, but are rather "philanthropists", or "lovers of humanity", even if they love no one in particular. On the contrary, unlike abstractions, entities act upon each other, yet the focus on the abstraction hides the real, actual relations between the entities.

The Person as Entity Opposed to this abstraction, which is a negation of an entity's characteristic, is the idea as the positive determination of a particular entity. The entity then seeks to actualize its possibilities among other entities, not to strip away its defining character for the sake of some abstraction. Solovyov write:

> Every human person has a proper, individual character and represents a certain particular idea. By entering into interaction with others or in being determined by and determining others, every person discloses this proper, individual character, and realizes his own idea. Without this, this character and idea would remain pure possibility. They become actual only in the person's activity, in which the person is necessarily also determined by others. Consequently, this determination is not a negation, but an actualization.

Intellectual Intuition Next, Solovyov explains how we know these ideas. Since they are equally independent of both rationalist abstractions and sensuous reality, a special mode of thought activity is required, which is called intellectual intuition. This seems to be a stumbling block, since (1) there is the belief that we "see" things as they are or (2) that logical thinking is the way to grasp and manipulate ideas. However, neither option is possible since entities are living realities. These refutations may help:

1. Material reality represents in itself only contingent and transitory phenomena, but not autonomous entities or foundations of being.

2. Rational thinking is restricted to the abstractions, which have no positive content of their own. Hence, it cannot grasp the entities themselves.

Sense experience and rational thought can only know accidental and particular facts, and not the necessary and universal truths or ideas. In short, he writes:

> Abstract thinking must serve either as an abbreviation of sense perception or as an anticipation of intellectual intuition, insofar as the general concepts forming it can be affirmed either as *schemata of phenomena or as shadows of ideas*.

Postscript There is an exercise to make all this clear. Academic discussions of Solovyov will focus on his "influences", the relationship of his thought to other thinkers, a logical analysis of his ideas, etc., as though it were a construct to be analyzed. On the contrary, we use his writings as a series of guideposts for understanding and living in the world: to practice the development of intellectual intuition, to learn to "see" the entities, atoms, monads, as embodied ideas.

Posted on 2014-04-10 by Cologero

* * *

Mikkel on 2019-04-13 at 12:23 said:

Reading this post and doing some of the practices, below are some interpretations of my experiences with it.

"Atom. An atom is an independent unit, the foundation of reality, real centers of being." – Experience, consciousness, the direct channel of our science, the senses where we see what aligns and does not, the "I" we experience.

"Monad. A monad is a living, acting force. As such, monads interact with each other." – Our story and lives, the interactions between others and the ways and whys influences bond and fade away between each other, A/B influences, law of affinity, the conscious real "I".

"Idea. The idea is what distinguishes units from each other, i.e., the forces must represent a determinate content." – Our Being, Spirit and remembering our real Self, who and what we really are, the quality of our lives that is fixed but not restricting, the Self even beyond the Self that determines the responsibility of our creation.

4.5 Principles of Manifestation

If cosmology is the study of the origin, nature, and destiny of the universe, there have been many conflicting theories. In the West, the basis of cosmology has been what is called the **Great Chain of Being**. In various versions, it has formed the worldview of educated people until recently. The dominance of profane science has done much to discredit it, even to the point that exoteric spiritual teachings not only neglect it, but in effect oppose it. This often has less to do with science than with ideology.

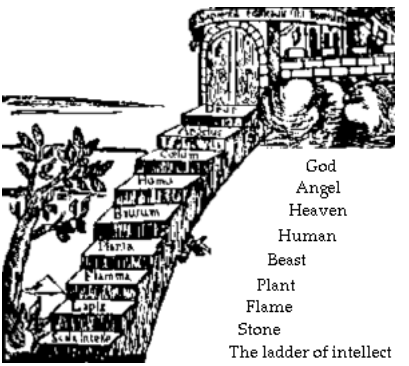


Figure 4.1: Great Chain of Being

The Great Chain of Being is based on certain Traditional metaphysical principles.

These need to be made clear, but first the implicit principles of modernity must be made clear.

Profane Worldview In its most consistent form, the modern worldview is based on the notion that the origin, nature, and destiny of the universe can be fully explained in terms of matter and energy. Obviously, this worldview denies that there is a world of Being ontologically prior to, and superior to, the world of Becoming. Profane science needs to explain:

1. How emergent properties such as life, mind, consciousness, emotions, thought, in short, interiority, evolve from material and exterior processes.

2. How higher order systems are constructed from more basic elements.

Thus far, science has no answer to issue (1), not even a plausible theory. Issue (2) is often hidden in popular discourse. Profane science is committed to reductionism, viz., higher order systems are fully explicable by more fundamental elements. By denying the existence of essences or forms, the task of science is to define higher systems; in its most consistent philosophical expressions, these are mere "social constructs".

Evolution and Involution **Rene Guenon** explains that there are five conditions of manifestation: space, time, form (or essences), matter, and life. The opposite of "evolution" is not creation science, or even intelligent design, but rather involution[2].

Evolution is the notion that simple things evolve into complex structures caused by random variations over time. Involution is the notion that ideal essences are brought into manifestation by a will. Depending

[2] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=6261`

on the strength of the will, the existing being will be a better or worse copy of its ideal.

Essences unfold in space and time, thus appearing to be evolving (evolve = unfold), but really involving. For example, Beethoven's Ninth Symphony is an "idea" or essence. However, to be experienced, musicians and instruments are necessary for the symphony to unfold in time. Profane science has nothing to offer. It makes no sense to say that the first movement "causes" the final movement. A fortiori, it is risible to try to experience or understand the symphony from an analysis of its individual notes.

Hence, Guenon claims that the higher order system defines its components, rather than the other way around. The other point is that "life" is prior to matter. So, in a sense, everything is "alive", that is, it has interiority. Hence, esoterism understands the cosmos as an interior process, unlike an astronomer who takes the opposite approach.

The Idea of the Good Plato understood God to be the Idea of the Good. Hence, man's goal is to passively contemplate the Good. The Christian notion of God as Love builds on that, since Love means to will the good. It is a revealed truth that the created world is "good", so the good is whatever has more being. The goodness of God, then, is His creative activity. So to be godlike is also to be creative, in the sense of bringing essences into manifestation. The gap between the essence and its existence is privation, i.e., "evil".

Rationality and Intellectuality Rationality is the quality that distinguishes man from animals; intellectuality distinguishes God from man. Rationality involves dualist thinking, but intellectuality is non-dual. It is not irrational, but rather super-rational. Any attempt to conceive of God's knowledge and will in rational terms will fail. For example, I read on a web site a few months back the claim that "God knows all true

propositions." Not at all, God knows the Divine ideas directly and non-dually, not as propositions. He "knows" the world because He created it. There is not duality of essence and existence for God.

Similarly for the Divine Will, there is no distinction between freedom and necessity. God does not "deliberate", choosing this or that, but rather whatever exists is the expression of his Goodness. Some will claim that God cannot do things like creating a square circle. It is better to understand that as a possibility of non-manifestation. There are four such possibilities.

1. **Analytic**. The definition contains a self-contradiction (as in the example above).

2. **Synthetic**. The contradiction is not in the definition. "A colored thing must also be extended."

3. **Physical**. The human frame has an upper limit, since as an increase in height is linear, the increase in mass is cubic. Hence, the skeletal structure will not be able to support that weight.

4. **Compossibility**. Certain possibilities of manifestation cannot manifest in the same place or time

The loss of intellectuality in the modern world has consequences. First of all, rationality tries to take its place; it is doomed to failure. The next step is that emotionality, i.e., the subrational, as a sort of non-dual experience, usurps the place of true non-dual intellectuality. Hence, Love is understood not as the creative Will to being, but rather in a sentimental and humanitarian way as compassion and the alleviation of suffering.

The modern mind misunderstands evil and thinks there is a "problem of evil" to be explained. However, the teaching is that creation is good, so that the world of good and evil that we experience is the creation of man. If the cheetah chases the gazelle, the result is good for the

cheetah since it increase his being, but bad for the gazelle since his being is ended; however, there is no question of "evil" in that scenario. On the contrary, it is good that the gazelle was given being in the first place.

Principle of Plenitude In the *Multiple States of Being*, Rene Guenon showed that the Absolute must also be Infinite, that is, the number of possibilities is unbounded. He formulated the Principle of Plenitude as "All possibilities of manifestation must be manifested."

This accounts for the immense variety in the world. Every creature has its place in the chain, or scale, of being. It is irrational to expect everything to be the same, so the scale is hierarchically arranged. Moreover, there are many more scales of being than the one that describes our world.

Principle of Continuity A related principle is the Principle of Continuity, described in the *Metaphysical Principles of Infinitesimal Calculus*. The gaps in the scale become arbitrarily small. Thus, we see that a taxonomic problem arises in biology, since it can become difficult to distinguish between closely related species and subspecies. Hence, there is no absolute definition of a species. That problem is insoluble as long as biological and material considerations are the only criteria used. In such a case, definitions are considered arbitrary social constructs.

Of course, the Traditional view is different. These close differences nevertheless reflect different essences in the Divine mind. Proper classifications will have to take the soul and spiritual elements (i.e., "interiority") into account. Hence, the differences are real, no matter how close they may appear. There are some further points that can be derived from this principle, although they cannot be fully developed in this post:

- The attempt to refute Darwinian evolution by pointing to "missing links" in the fossil record (yes, the term is derived from the Great Chain of Being) is actually anti-Traditional.

- The Great Chain of Being is a simplification. It is better represented as scales within scales.

- **Otto Weininger** in *Sex and Character* defines the ideal masculine and feminine qualities. However, they don't manifest in a strictly binary way, but rather on a scale ranging from absolute femininity to absolute masculinity.

- Intellectual movements always ramify into two competing camps whenever the possibility of a dispute arises. For example, a predestinarian Baptist church will give rise to a "free-will Baptist church". In other cases, movements will split by incorporating elements from other, often incompatible, movements. This is why all movements are prone to degeneration and inner conflict.

Posted on 2014-11-19 by Cologero

* * *

`Constantine on 2014-11-19 at 14:25 said:`

Reading through this article I felt something was missing. You make a good point fractal, what about energy (chi, prana…)?

`Francesco on 2014-11-19 at 16:14 said:`

Constantine: Imo, Qi can be handled under the five conditions of manifestation, some more than others Perhaps in the same way that Sophia is not a fourth hypostasism but the life shared in common by the trinity; Qi is not another condition, but something shared commonly among form, matter, and life.

In Chinese metaphysics, there are a great number of "Qis": human body qi (then specific organ and system qi types), cosmological qi (astrology), environmental qi (feng shui), and so on. To see how better how this concept is subsumed in the five conditions, we might consider the famous Chinese character for Qi–which is a pot of rice gruel cooking, with steam raising from the vessel lid–it is interpreted as "it moves", or "acts".

The Classics explain "Qi is the commander of Blood; Blood is the mother of Qi", and that "Qi follows where the Shen (consciousness) leads".

> Cologero on 2014-11-19 at 17:37 said:
> @Constantine: "Matter is condensed energy and energy is condensed consciousness."
>
> Valentin Tomberg

4.6 Creating a World: Day One

It's curious that even atheists and neo-Darwinists are sometimes willing to believe that the human race was seeded by aliens or even that we "inhabit" a computer simulation created by more advanced beings; in other words, the implication is that the world was designed, albeit not by God. It would be an interesting thought experiment to design such a world. After all, games like Roblox and Minecraft are so popular in part because they allow the creation of beings with various characteristics and destinies in life. A being that was a genuine "blank slate" with no innate characteristics and no life purpose would certainly not be very popular, even though people claim to deny any such innate characteristics.

Moreover, in fulfilling their destinies, the characters will experience conflict and obstacles. Software such as Dramatica will help you create conflicting characters and plots if you need help.

But first, before moving onto human and other living beings, we need to start with physics.

Possibilities of Manifestation **Rene Guenon** in The Multiple States of Being describes the properties of Existence, that is, manifested being. The Infinite contains all possibilities which can be in one of two categories. These will set the standards for our world.

- Possibilities of non-manifestation. These possibilities can never be manifested. Hence, they belong to Non-being

- Possibilities of manifestation. These are part of Being.

The following two sections illustrate some of these points.

Non-manifestation

> The absurd, in the logical and mathematical sense, is that which implies contradiction; it is therefore identical with the impossible, for it is the absence of internal contradiction that defines possibility, logically as well as ontologically.
>
> Rene Guenon, *The Multiple States of Being*

I've read objections to this idea, since it seems to put a limit on God's power. Of course, that is not the case, since all possibilities — both of non-manifestation and of manifestation — exist in God's mind. That totality of possibilities comprises the Wisdom of God. Hence, it is not really a limitation of God, just a limitation of manifestation. Here are some examples of the possibilities of non-manifestation.

- Obvious self-contradictory statements like a "round square" or "married bachelor". Unfortunately, self-contradictory statements are not always so obvious as many philosophical systems contain their own refutation. In everyday life, people will make high sounding claims without realizing they are often oxymorons.
- The past cannot be changed
- There can be no actual infinity. Only God is Infinite.
- e.g., infinite space would be as Parmenides described, static being with no change because time could not exist were space infinite.

- The same for time, there can be no infinite past. Thomas Aquinas seems to have gotten this wrong but Bonaventura got it correct.
- Void, or said another way, Nature abhors a vacuum.
- A Being cannot exist in the same state twice, since that would make it the same being.
- There can be no system of arithmetic that is both consistent and complete.
- The Traveling Salesman problem is non-computable.
- A Free being cannot be made unfree.

Manifestation

> Whatsoever does not involve a contradiction, God can do in his creatures.
>
> Thomas Aquinas, *Commentary on the Sentences*

> We must distinguish this logical necessity, which is the impossibility of a thing's not being or being other than it is — and this independently of any particular condition — from what is called 'physical' necessity or necessity of fact, which is simply the impossibility that beings and things could fail to conform to the laws of the world to which they belong, this latter kind of necessity consequently being subordinate to the conditions by which that world is defined, and which are valid only within the special domain concerned.
>
> Rene Guenon, *The Multiple States of Being*

Possibilities of Manifestation have two subcategories:

- Those which have been, or are, manifested
- Those which have not been manifested

The first principle of manifestation is that creatures are composed of matter and form; the former indicates "that it is" and the latter "what it is". That is the view of the Scholastics as well and the Nyaya school of philosophy:

> Compare the Nyaya view with that of St Thomas that the primary object of man's knowledge is a synthetic unity in which both the senses and the understanding play their indispensable part. The individuation or the quantitative specification is derived from the sense, while the qualitative unity is from the understanding. The object of knowledge contains within itself the intuition of essence and the sense knowledge of particulars. It is neither the essence alone, as Descartes thought, nor the sense datum alone, as the empiricists believed. We know things and things are neither disembodied essences not subjective images. To separate universals from individuals is to miss the unity of the two in things.
>
> Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Volume II

The consequence is that knowledge comes through the senses first. Hence, the senses cannot be deceived by God. I don't know which came first – the chicken or the egg, but I've never encountered a chicken that didn't start life as an egg. When Adam "named" the animals, that was an acknowledgement that he understood their essences. If the animals appeared fully grown, that would not have been possible, since the essence of a chicken includes its full development. Thomas Aquinas writes about this in the Summa:

> Our intellect, which takes cognizance of the essence of a thing as its proper object, gains knowledge from sense, of which the

> proper objects are external accidents. Hence from external appearances we come to the knowledge of the essence of things.

As an example of what Guenon calls a "necessity of fact", we can point to the digestive system of a lion which would make it impossible for the lion to survive on a vegan diet. This is implied by Thomas, again from the Summa:

> In the opinion of some, those animals which now are fierce and kill others, would, in that [Edenic] state, have been tame, not only in regard to man, but also in regard to other animals. But this is quite unreasonable. For the nature of animals was not changed by man's sin, as if those whose nature now it is to devour the flesh of others, would then have lived on herbs, as the lion and falcon. … Thus there would have been a natural antipathy between some animals.

Conditions of Manifestation There are five conditions of manifestation that are necessary for there to be any experience at all. These are:

- **Space and Time**. Space is geometry, coexistence, visible objects. Time is arithmetic, succession, things produced and destroyed.
- **Matter and Form**. Prime matter is malleable. Form is the idea or essence of a thing.
- **Life**. This is the qualitative aspect of the world, its "innerness". Everything is conscious to some degree. Teilhard de Chardin asserted that there is an inside as well as an outside to the world.

The physical world requires five elements: earth, water, light (or fire), air, and akasha (or ether); matter is a mixture of those elements. The following descriptions are taken from the Vaisesika school of Hindu philosophy.

- **Earth**. Solid. Qualities: smell, taste, colour, tangibility.
- **Water**. Liquid. Qualities: taste, colour, tangibility.
- **Light**. Luminous. Qualities: colour, tangibility.
- **Air**. Gaseous. Quality: tangibility.
- **Akasha**. Etheric. Quality: sound.

Moreover, the Vaisesika school has a well-developed atomic theory (not in the chemical sense of the term). It is more advanced that the Greek atomic philosophers, for whom the atoms are quantitative and without qualities. The Greeks furthermore claimed that even souls consisted of atoms, which the Hindu school denies; hence, it is more compatible with Life as a condition of manifestation. Guenon claims that space is infinitely divisible, something that the Vaisesika obviously denies. Although not the most advanced of the orthodox Hindu schools, it is useful for our purposes since it is more compatible with physics. Instead of atoms, physics regards quanta as ultimate and indivisible. (Of course, in contemporary physics, continuous waves also have validity.)

Physics The goal in world creation is not to force Revelation to conform to the latest fad in physics; no, that would be contrary to the real order of things. Rather, the goal is to see what physics would have to be like, given that Revelation is true.

Since time is not infinite, the world had a beginning, let's say at Time 0. Therefore, space likewise had a beginning. Since the Void (empty Space) cannot be manifested, Space at Time 0 would only be a point.

St. Clement of Alexandria described the six directions of Space as East/West, North/South, Up/Down; that is the symbolism of the cross. The origin is the point at which they all meet. There are also six periods of time, but that is another discussion.

Physics cannot describe what was happening at Time 0 and the Point of Origin, since it is a singularity. In other words, Time 0 is not manifested, i.e., it is a part of Non-Being, hence invisible to physics. In *The Symbolism of the Cross*, Guenon explains:

> his centre directs all things by its "actionless activity" (wei wu wei), which although unmanifested, or rather because it is unmanifested, is in reality the plenitude of activity, since it is the activity of the Principle whence all particular activities are derived; this has been expressed by Lao-tze as follows: "The Principle is always actionless, yet everything is done by it."

In the *Commentary on the Sentences*, Thomas Aquinas writes:

> Non-being is prior to being in the thing which is said to be created. … The creature should have non-being prior to being in duration, so that it is said to be out of nothing

To summarize:

- Non-being is the principle of Being
- Time 0 at the Origin Point is like the centre of a wheel: it does not move, yet everything moves around it.
- Time (duration) is created with creation.

Day 1

> And God said, "Let there be light," and there was light.
>
> Genesis 1:3

According to Genesis, Heaven and Earth were created on Day 1. That means Form and Matter, the preconditions for a World. The Earth was nothing in particular, because the world first manifested as Light. So this is our first clue to physics:

- Matter can exist in any one of three forms: solid, liquid, and gas. This is clear.
- Matter and energy (i.e., light) are also convertible into each other. That was proposed and demonstrated last century.
- At times close to Time 0, there was only light (i.e., photons) since the other states of matter could not exist at such densities.
- Light vibrates at certain frequencies. Given the amount of energy, that frequency would be extremely high.
- The higher the frequency, the more information is can carry. Information is the opposite of entropy. Since the Idea of the entire universe was present at Time 0, this Idea was carried as information in the frequency of the energy present at creation.

The objection is usually brought up that the Sun was not created until Day 4, so how could there be light on Day 1? However, we see that there was only light at Day 1 in the form of photons (the "atoms" of light).

As the universe cooled down, matter existed as pure potentiality as described by Schrodinger's equation; that is, it was nothing in particular, i.e., without form. That is the state of Prime Matter.

TO BE CONTINUED

Posted on 2020-06-14 by Cologero

4.7 Process of Manifestation

The Universal includes the unmanifested as well as formless manifestation. They are the principles of formal manifestation. Formless manifestation has Being but not individual Existence. The Individual states are all part of formal manifestation.

The **Unmanifested state** comprises all the possibilities which are not susceptible of any manifestation, as well as the possibilities of manifestation themselves in principial mode Formless manifestation is not part of multiplicity. The following diagram is from *Man and his Becoming*.

- Universal
  - Unmanifested
  - Formless manifestation
- Individual
  - General
  - Specific
    - Collective
    - Singular

The being that manifests is necessarily what it is, through its principal manifestation. It is not a matter of chance or fortune

General and Specific The general is related to the Specific as genera to the species. The being has to pass through an indeterminate number of states. Guenon cites Aristotle's categories as the most general of all genera, hence they belong to formal manifestation. Some simple examples might be:

Place ⇒ galaxy ⇒ solar system ⇒ planet ⇒ continent … city ⇒ house

Time ⇒ Manvantara ⇒ yuga ⇒ year

These genera can be further subdivided, but these examples make the point

Collective Entities Collective entities are just as real as singular entities. Guenon describes one such collective entity

> The names which are attached to the formulation of the different darshanas cannot be related in any way to particular individuals. They are used symbolically to describe what are really 'intellectual groupings'. composed of all those who have devoted themselves to one and the same study over the course of a period the duration of which is no less indeterminable than the date of its beginning.

There are more obvious examples such as religions, nations, sacred orders, and so on. As in the case of intellectual groupings, such collective entities cannot be judged by the individuals who are representatives of members of the collective. Rather, they must be understood in terms of the guiding principles of the collective. That is why, for example, the ancient Greek city-states were founded by a divine being and why nations are today guided by archangels. But just as material beings cast a shadow, so do collective entities. In the latter case, the shadow is called an egregrore. Unfortunately, people often can only see the egregore rather than the purity of the collective.

Singular Entities Singular entities are identified by perceptible bodies, whether gross or subtle. This topic will be developed in an upcoming post on human manifestation.

Posted on 2021-06-20 by Cologero

4.8 Meditation on the Trinity

Before he had begun publishing his major works, **Rene Guenon** engaged in an extended correspondence with the writer **Noëlle Maurice-Denis**, daughter of the painter **Maurice Denis**. In a letter from 1919, he explained his life project to Noëlle, which was to develop a "common understanding" "between various traditional doctrines." In 1919, it was just an idea. A century later, his books are more read now than they were then. We can now hope that there are indeed "qualified individuals capable of taking the initiative of an effective rapprochement such as the one I am thinking of". That is our task.

That defines the Traditional spirit as he understood it. Unfortunately, there are many who claim to be "Traditionalists" in Guenon's sense, yet do note possess that spirit. Against those who reject Guenon, there is not much that we can say because there is little common ground. However, those without the spirit are a different case, worse actually, because they do not understand it. There are two main markers for that spirit:

- Look for rapprochement, not debating points
- Distinguish between theological and metaphysical perspectives. The latter is certain

As a thought experiment, we will use the Christian dogma of the Trinity, especially the so-called "*filioque*" clause as an example for this approach.

Theological issues The Latin and Greek churches disagree on the theological formulation of whether the "Holy Spirits proceeds from the Father" or the "Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son." Obviously, this debate has been raging for centuries without an end in sight. That is the disadvantage of the theological approach. Hence, that is the wrong way to achieve any rapprochement. We can make two quick points about this.

Not mandatory in the west The filioque does not bear the same existential import in the West. The Uniate churches omit the filioque when they recite the Creed during Mass. No one thinks anything of it.

Alleged consequences Those lacking the Traditional spirit often find the most bizarre consequences of the filioque. One that I've heard is that it implies that the Pope has power of the Holy Spirit. To prove that, it would be necessary to find that dogmatic formulation in Catholic dogmas; it is not true, so shame on the accuser.

Another one, which I only know second hand, is that the filioque leads to democracy. There is no school of logical inference in which that makes sense, and certainly history shows otherwise.

These are two examples of the partisan spirit that is opposed to the Traditional spirit. Finally, we turn to the great Russian theologian, **Sergei Bulgakov**. In his extensive study of the Holy Spirit, he had to concede that he could not find anything truly significant in the doctrine, certainly nothing that would make a difference in practice.

Another claim is that the omission of the filioque is more consistent with the Vedantic teaching. This is patently not the case. Without the filioque, the Son and the Spirit are left dangling from the Father with no relationship between them.

Metaphysical Issues The situation looks different if we approach the issues from metaphysics rather then theology. Metaphysics, unlike theology, is certain. Then the theologians can interpret the metaphysical points in their own exoteric formulation.

Vedanta We will use Guenon's *Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta* as our guide. This is a summary of the Vedantic trinity.

- Purusha: this is the transcendent One, beyond all manisfestion.

- Buddhi: this is the Universal Intellect, or the content of all the ideas of the One.

- Manas: this is the Universal soul or the inner sense, called "common sense" by the Scholastics.

Note that the relationship is hierarchical: Manas, or Holy Spirit, proceeds from the One through the Buddhi or Divine Intellect. The filioque "and" is equivalent to "through"; it is not that the Buddhi initiates its own procession.

Neoplatonism **Vladimir Solovyov**, in the *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, demonstrates the Neoplatonic roots of the Trinity. A fortiori, he traces the origin all the way back the **Hermes Trismegistus**.

The Neoplatonic Trinity of the One, Universal Intellect, and the Universal Soul, is isomorphic to the Vedanta version. So common ground can be found there.

The Ismaili Muslim, Khalil Andani[3], has a series of youtube videos that explains the Neoplatonic Trinity in detail.

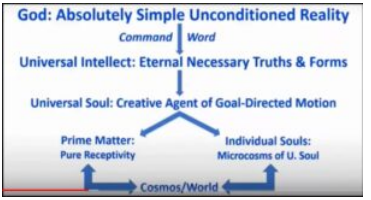
What is a Person It was Plotinus who originated the notion of the "three divine hypostases", not Christian theologians. This has often been translated as three "Persons". In metaphysics a Person has a precise definition that is lacking in popular parlance. In everyday use, a Person is a conscious being with desires, feelings, and thoughts. As such, a person can contemplate options, make free decisions, etc.

However, in metaphysics, that is called the Individual. The individual is a part of manifestation, a very limited part actually, because the conscious part of the individual is very limited. The Person, on the other hand, transcends all manifestation and can never be the object of direct

[3] `https://www.youtube.com/c/KhalilAndani`

experience. Another formulation is the distinction between the Ego and the Self. In the Vedanta, the Self or Person is called atman.

God is the supreme person and is determined by nothing outside himself; otherwise, He would not be absolute. Yet, the Trinity follows from His nature, so in this sense the Trinity is necessary.



Here we can only provide a brief outline. For more detail, I can only recommend a close study of the three resources mentioned above. It is an important issue and well worth one's effort and time.

Posted on 2022-08-24 by Cologero

* * *

Balder on 2022-08-29 at 14:02 said:

@ArthurKonrad: about Guenon and his apparent lack of humor, he said in some of his writings something like following: "it seems our writings are profoundly lacking joy, yet it is dependent on one's character what things give one the sense of joy."

So perhaps he was not humorless at all but found his joy elsewhere than from joking and common humor. I am a joker myself but I would find it quite strange if a book on metaphysics, symbolism or traditional sciences would be replete with jokes and humor.

Arthur Konrad on 2022-08-29 at 15:57 said:

@Balder,

I won't discuss Guenon right now. I will however, make a general observation that there seems to be an entrenched antagonism between theologians and meta-physicians on one hand, and mystics on the other. Mystics (and here I'm using the common, broad meaning of it), being persons who typically do posses a sense of humour, are immunised against every sort of pretense, not in the least pretense to authority. The former camp responds very predictably, by accusing mystics of being 'dangerous charlatans'. or using any similar tactic of discrediting a person by appealing to people's regard for their own safety and conformity.

Differences, as anyone with subtlety understands – presuming that he wants to – are not doctrinal, but a matter of personal animosity and vanity. Don't believe me? Just observe the rage that follows any real or perceived insult to the meta-physician's authority. All of a sudden, the wise man displays admirable skill in ad hominem attacks, punches under the belly and throws himself tooth and claw at the person's reputation and his right to decency. Then being 'above dialectics' breaks like a pinata, and the onlookers can admire the fabulous fruits of a strictly meditative diet.

In such an environment one cannot learn much about the 'Truth'. but he can learn quite a lot about politics, for instance. Science prevails elsewhere.

Dionysus on 2023-05-15 at 22:03 said:

Basically, the first objection the Greek partisans will make to the Filioque is that it's "heresy". Such claim is absurd, since none of the Holy Fathers teaches against it explicitly, and many of them on the contrary clearly teach the Filioque, such as basically all the Latin Fathers, most notably Augustine, but also Greek Fathers such as Dydimus, Cyril of Alexandria and Maximus the Confessor. Such confusion could be explained by a quirk in translation, whereas in Greek the use of the word "and" implicitly means that It proceeds equally from the Father and the Son, when in Latin it is ambiguous, meaning in this instance not equally but "through", but that is another question (which is actually explaind by Saint Maximus). We could of course go into detail on the actual theological arguments, but that would be too much; I would like only to add to what was said in the text that, if the Spirit proceeded from the Father alone, its procession would be no different from the Son's generation, and the Spirit no different from the Son, not to mention that there is more than one biblical evidence for its procession through the Son, such as in the apocalyptic symbol of the River springing forth from the Lamb.

When the accusation of heresy is refuted, they will claim that it was illicit to change the text of the Creed, as it was prohibited by the Council Fathers of Nicaea I. Well, it is understood that such prohibition could only be against changes that would corrupt the deeper meaning of the Doctrine (that is, one that would teach heresy and not a change that would more clearly explain the true Faith), and not only a change in the letters themselves, otherwise it would be illicit to make any translations of the Creed, which is absurd.

Interestingly enough, the polemicist Photius (who was curiously only canonised by a Synod in Constantinople almost a thousand years after his death, with no prior public veneration, and at a point of heightened opposition of the Latin Church among the Orthodox) was the one who, trying to upset Rome, changed the words of the Creed and the meaning of the Doctrine by making it say "from the Father alone/only" which was never thaught by any of the Holy Fathers (as even those who wrote only abouth the procession from the Father never said "from the Father only" thus never deinying the possibility of the procession through the Son), which can

both be classified as heresy and an adulteration of the text of the Creed in an unlawful way, also according to the Greek partisans own standards.

It is more than clear to me that such petty theological squables, as well as other meaningless polemics (such as the Greek partisans infatuation with leavened/unleavend bread, priestly marriage and use of beards), were never the cause or even major factors for the schism, but quite simply the refusal to recognise the authority and sovereignty of the Pope over the universal Church, an attitude that also has its roots in nothing more than historical factors regarding the growth of power of the See of Constantinople as the capital of the Eastern Empire and its defiance regarding the centralization of ecclesiastical power in Rome over the centuries, something that also explains why it was always Rome the one open to reunion while the Greeks were and still are always predominantly the ones fomenting petty divisions.

4.9 The Best Possible World

> If we assume the existence of an omniscient and omnipotent being, one that knows and can do absolutely everything, then to my own very limited self, it would seem that existence for it would be unbearable. Nothing to wonder about? Nothing to ponder over? Nothing to discover? Eternity in such a heaven would surely be indistinguishable from hell.
>
> Isaac Asimov, *"X" Stands for Unknown, 1984*

Apart from his embarrassingly juvenile understanding of God, Asimov raises a good question, viz.: What is the best possible world? Such a world would be wonderous, and offer mysteries to discover. Ultimately, we would like to discover the most wonderous thing of all, but let's hold that off for a moment.

Asimov's point differs from others like him. The most common argument against God is that this world, with all its horrors and evils, could not have been created by an omniscient, omnipotent, and good God. You will note that Asimov does omit the qualifier "good".

Let's consider the creation of the world as described in Genesis. Note that it is more like a framework rather than a detailed description. Instead

of 100, or many more, volumes with tedious details, Genesis includes just a few short chapters. That leaves plenty to discover about the creation of the world.

Spiritual texts assume a rather Platonic view of the world, provided that is understood in a very general sense. Plato is just one link of a metaphysical chain that forms the Heart of the West[4]. The fundamental point is that, in addition to the material world, there is a spiritual world of ideas. A "thing", therefore, is a combination of the physical with an idea. There is no definition in physics for any particular thing. That is called the "measurement problem" and is still rather mysterious. Quantum physics describes a state vector for particles that can do no more than describe a probability. There is no physical formula for a star, a plant, or a human being.

The Stages of Genesis Genesis describes several stages of creation which match our personal experiences perfectly.

- **Possibilities**. The world is divided into Heaven (Ideas) and Earth (matter).
- **Movement**. The world is set in motion. By Newton's First Law, matter cannot begin to move without an outside force acting on it.
- **Vegetation**. Life begins.
- **Animals**. Sentient life begins.
- **Humans**. Rational life begins.
- **Freedom**. Humans are given the gift of free will.

[4] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1256

- **Love**. Only free beings can love

In your perfect world, what would you change? To be sentient means to be able to "feel". An animal feels thirsty, so it seeks water. A robot, running low on batteries, just reads a gauge, which is not really part of him.

Asimov's world requires rational life, beings who are able to discover things. If we knew everything, as he says, there is nothing to discover. Since we don't, we have to stumble through the world with imperfect knowledge. The price of imperfect knowledge includes mistakes, often costly mistakes. But it also includes creativity.

Would the best world deny freedom? Perhaps we could have been programmed like robots, with something like Asimov's Three Laws of Robotics[5]. Then we would always make the moral choice. The world envisioned by Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor[6] provided for man's needs while denying him freedom.

Finally, there is Love. Would a perfect world include the ability to Love? Only free beings can love. Many people today, in the anonymous loneliness of the modern world, substitute for it the affection of dogs, which cannot love in any satisfactory sense.

Love encompasses all the aspects of Being:

- There are intense sexual sensations at the most primitive level of life.
- The is the exhilarating feeling of falling in love with someone.
- There is the feeling associated with creativity such as that of an artist, mathematician or scientist.

[5] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Three_Laws_of_Robotics`
[6] `https://www.mtholyoke.edu/acad/intrel/pol116/grand.htm`

- There is the thrill at understanding the loftiest philosophical understanding as described, for example, by Spinoza's intellectual love of God.

- Ultimately there is the love of God with all one's heart, soul, strength, and mind.

I suppose most everyone has a gripe against God and wishes things could be different. But a world with life, feelings, discovery, creativity, freedom, and love must necessarily be better than a computerized simulation of life or a world populated by programmed robots.

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tdx6lLvvRyg`

Posted on 2022-05-22 by Cologero

* * *

`Dochxa Rhoan on 2022-05-23 at 13:45 said:`

My first comment here though I've been following for several months. Thanks for many thought-provoking discourses.

Regarding "free will" – been reading some neurological experiments and results seem to increasingly indicate a distinction required between predetermined actions arising out of a particular neurological state and the experience of free will. (This underscores, I think, the material world/idea world connection or absence of connection.)

I'm not arguing for an assertion or denial of free will; rather, for clarification of exactly what is being named when we say "humans have free will".

Thanks in advance.

`Cologero on 2022-05-23 at 14:22 said:`

You can start here for the metaphysical understanding:
Principial Origin and Final Destiny[7]
Buridan's Donkey[8]

[7] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=15342`
[8] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=15031`

Did you ever have to make up your mind?[9]

Then type "free will" into the little search box

In your spare time, try this experiment:

Take 12 subjects and promise them a free ice cream for participating

Hook them up to some electrodes and let the experimenter determine which flavor ice cream each subject will choose

Let me know the success rate

There is no "experience of free will". That little conscious part of yourself is NOT your true self.

I plan to start a business and am looking for suckers investors.

It is a home free will detector kit. You hook yourself up in the morning and you will know everything you will do for the rest of the day!

Send donations to my patreon account and remember that past performance is no indicator of future results.

Dochxa Rhoan on 2022-06-01 at 22:23 said:

"There is no experience of free will" – which is why I asked for some definition. That little conscious part of myself asserts that I choose things, but, stepping out of my little conscious part of myself frame of reference, I suspect I do not. The ass experiment is a good one – what about the flipping of a coin, or an electron passing through a slot? Isn't it the same thing except our little conscious part of ourselves doesn't have the full equation to determine the outcome? I'm not making a challenge, mind you, except that jumping back and forth from omniscience hardly seems the best way to forward to discourse. I show up in the world in a particular way regardless (to what's call "me") of the unconscious mechanisms which may be predetermined. From the point of view of God, to "me" it is moot. From my mind's point of view, I know it is futile. In my being present to the world, however, it seems as though there is something to explore. Cheers!

Cologero on 2022-06-01 at 23:31 said:

Fascinating, Dochxa, but not even close. I absolutely did provide a link to a precise metaphysical understanding of free will. You cannot reason your way to free will, you have to will it. People seem to enjoy running around in circles like hamsters on a wheel.

It is true, though, that free will has to be earned.

Dochxa Rhoan on 2022-06-01 at 23:40 said:

[9] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C0cJ__JBnWg

Ha! In any case, thanks for the pointer to the wheel! This ass continues to meander to one bale or the other! I must enjoy watching him do it.

4.10 Knights of Light

> Consciousness of God and remembrance of Him brings about a condition of tranquility in the soul; it is freedom from worry resulting from doubt: freedom from disquietude and from fear that refers to ultimate destiny; it is inward security that comes about when the soul is submissive to God.
>
> Syed Naquib, *Prolegomena*

Valentin Tomberg tells us about **Knights of Light**:

> The great Zarathustra wanted knights to fight under the banner of light in the struggle against darkness —the Turanian idolaters, the demons of impurity and ignorance, and lastly the spirit of Ahriman or Satan. He wanted that there should be people able to say yes to the light —and who, consequently, learned to say no to the darkness.
>
> *Meditations on the Tarot*

Without that guiding light, a knight stumbles in the darkness or wanders aimlessly like a lion on the savannah. Ahriman is the supreme bureaucrat, who strives to organize everything to keep it in its place, to subdue it, to confine it to logic. Artificial intelligence is his dream and our nightmare.

Theosophy of light Under the influence of figure like Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Heidegger, inter alia, the West has come to associate spiritual depth with feelings of doubt, anxiety, dread, fear, absurdity, and so on. Nothing could be more wrong. On the contrary, real knowledge of God opens one up to ecstatic emotions. That is the proof that you know God with the knowledge of the heart; if you study metaphysics just as text, it becomes knowledge of the head. Henry Corbin describes Suhraswardi's theosophy of light.

> One of its essential features is that it makes philosophy and mystical experience inseparable: a philosophy that does not culminate in a **metaphysic of ecstasy** is vain speculation; a mystical experience that is not grounded on a sound philosophical education is in danger of degenerating and going astray. This element suffices to place Suhrawardi and Ibn Arabi in the same spiritual family. It situates this theosophy on a spiritual plane higher than the rational plane on which the relations between theology and philosophy, belief and knowledge, are ordinarily discussed.
>
> *Avicenna and the Visionary Recital*

If you can explain it, then you don't know it.

Knowledge of the Heart

> The heart is regarded as the center of life, and from the physiological point of view, it is so due to its connection with the circulation of the blood. But it is further considered as a center on a higher plane in a more symbolical sense, through its connection with the **universal Intelligence** as related to



> the individual. It should be noted in this connection that the Greeks themselves, and Aristotle among others, assigned the same part to the heart, also making it the seat of intelligence, and not of feeling as the moderns commonly do. The brain is only the instrument of the mental faculty, that is, of thought in its reflective and discursive mode. The heart corresponds to the sun and the brain to the moon.
>
> RENE GUENON, *Man and his Becoming*

The Universal Intellect Islamic esoteric teaching going back to Suhraswardi, Ibn Arabi, Avicenna, and especially the Ismailis, depends heavily on Neoplatonism. The Ismailis had its roots with the Assassins, the rivals to the Templars. Because they had enemies even with other Muslims, they became very secretive. Their complete teachings are kept hidden from the public and known only to a small group,

The neoplatonic trinity consists of the Transcendent One (i.e., God), the Universal Intellect and the Universal Soul. Note the correspondence to Guenon's Brahma, Buddhi and Manas in *Man and his Becoming*. The Christian concept of the Trinity is that the Universal Intellect and Soul are inseparable from the One. On the other hand, the Ismailis regard them as different beings, but less than God, more like angels. The Universal Soul is the Demiurge, as in Plato, the actual creator of the manifest universe. This conception is not too unlike early Arians, a version of Christianity adopted by the Germanic tribes during the Roman era.

It is not surprising that the Universal Intellect and Soul are angelic beings mediating creation. Laws along explain nothing, because they don't answer the question, "Who is following the laws?" Ideas are passive and require a causal agent to have any effect. In the primal state of participatory consciousness, the world was experienced as populated by beings

at different levels; even the planets were moved by angels. The modern world has forgotten all that; instead, it can only see a world of darkness, abstractions, and laws, in an Ahrimanic haze. Tomberg reminds us to look for the light:

> Are laws, principles and ideas therefore not real? They are certainly real, but their reality is not that of an existence separate from beings, i.e., that of metaphysical entities populating a world or plane —a world of laws, principles and ideas—proper to themselves. The spiritual world is not a world of laws, principles and ideas; it is a world of spiritual beings — human souls, Angels, Archangels, Principalities, Powers, Virtues, Dominions, Thrones, Cherubim, Seraphim and the Holy Trinity: the Holy Spirit, the Son and the Father.

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CM2PHJsn9xQ&t=6s`

Posted on 2021-10-07 by Cologero

4.11 Principle of Manifestation



This is a thought experiment to help understand the principles of manifestation as described in *Man and his Becoming* by **Rene Guenon**.

Let's use the song *Over the Rainbow*[10] from the movie *Wizard of Oz* and follow how it is manifested as a song. If you are unfamiliar with it, please listen to it first. Keep in mind that the song is a creation of human mind, but it still serves to illustrate the point.

[10] `https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4Xw36T_PfJU`

Divine intellect or Buddhi As an idea in the Divine Intellect, our song remains a possibility of manifestation. How that possibility becomes an actuality is outlined below.

Formless Manifestation As part of the Buddhi, the song belongs to the realm of formless manifestation. We can talk about the song and there is mutual understanding. However, it is formless. Specifically, we don't visualize it at this level; there is only intellectual knowledge.

As formless, it is not individuated. There are not multiple copies of the song in the Intellect. There is just the one, otherwise there is no intelligibility.

Spaceless You cannot specify where the song is. There is no geography, no GPS coordinates, not even a "heaven" of ideas.

Timeless Our song is timeless. We can mention the song today and it will be the same song as it was in 1939. It does not deteriorate over time. The notes don't start fading away. The words are not jumbled.

Summary Our song is One and beyond space and time. It has Being but no Existence. Nevertheless, we can "know" it, provided we have been initiated into recognizing the song.

Divine Soul or Manas This is the realm of the inward senses. These senses are "incorporeal and outwardly imperceptible". They "receive their finite expression in the particular conditions of individual existence prevailing at the level of the human state."

The senses have their origin not in the corporeal realm but in the incorporeal. This is easily demonstrated by dreams and the imagination. In those conditions, you can experience sensual qualities without any corresponding physical or corporeal objects associated with them.

Thus you can "listen" to the song in your imagination, hum it, or whatever. Most people will just pull it up from their memory. In my case, I will add some cool jazz riffs, knowing that I lack the talent to actually play them on the piano.

Obviously, I cannot "hear" the version of the song in your head, nor you in mine. So the Manas is the beginning of individuation, but not quite.

Excursus on Beethoven. Toward the end of his life, Beethoven went deaf yet he continued to compose. In his Intellect, he could create a symphony, for example, because he knew the structure of a symphony and the laws of harmony.

Moreover, in his Soul, he could "hear" how it would sound. Yet he was unable to experience the symphony as it would be manifested. That brings us to the next stage.

Manifestation So what does it take to actually listen to our song? Manifestation is bringing something from Being into Existence. What is described below is the basic outline. It may leave out several subsidiary steps such as a descent through different states of being. But that does not change anything essential.

There are five conditions of manifestation:

- Form
- Matter
- Space
- Time
- Psyche

Form or Essence The form or essence is the song as it is in the Divine Intellect.

Matter or Substance Matter, in this case, includes the orchestra, the singer, the instruments, the musical score, etc. In short, everything required to make the song available to the senses.

Matter is the "principle of individuation". Although there is but ONE song, it can be manifested multiple times and in multiple places.

Space As manifested, the song is heard at a particular place.

Time Although the idea of the song is beyond time, it must be manifested over time in order to be experienced. Even though the song takes about two minutes, we recognize it as the same, one song over that entire period. Tone deaf people experience disconnected notes and do not recognize the song as a whole.

Psyche Psyche, or life, means that manifestation has both an inside and an outside. The material aspect is the "outside" bur our conscious, sensuous experience of the song is the "inside". They are not two different things, nor does the material aspect "create" the experience. Rather, the experience is that of the song itself as it is in the Intellect.

Summary This descent does not itself take place in time. Time is an aspect of corporeal manifestation in the human state. In a sense, the manifestation and the idea are "simultaneous" so it is a mistake try to understand their relationship sequentially or causally.

For nondual awareness, there is no difference. If you experience the song, you know the idea. That is the idea. However, for divine ideas attaining that level of gnosis is not always as easy as this thought experiment.

Nevertheless, whatever happens in the world is the manifestation of some idea in the Divine Intellect.

Notes: Picture Credits: Copyright Bonnie Taylor Barry
If video does not load, please see *Over the Rainbow*[11]

Posted on 2021-06-10 by Cologero

4.12 Parallel Universes and Eternal Return

To the May Bride

> I know that I will meet you again and that everything will happen once again exactly as it did so long ago. Except that this time I will not allow you to die. I will hold you in my arms, defending you against the dark waters of death. Because this time I will remember everything. *I will remember that you have already died.* But ... will I remember?
>
> Miguel Serrano, *Nos: Book of the Resurrection*

> Because You are unlimited, neither the lords of heaven nor even You Yourself can ever reach the end of Your glories. The *countless universes*, each enveloped in its shell, are compelled by the wheel of time to wander within You, like particles of dust blowing about in the sky. The srutis, following their method of eliminating everything separate from the Supreme, become successful by revealing You as their final conclusion
>
> *Bhagavata Purana*, 10.87.41

[11] `https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4Xw36T_PfJU%20target=`

Quantum Mechanics often mimics traditional metaphysics, as we have see the example of the ultimate indeterminateness or formless of matter. Such examples do not confirm metaphysics, but rather are what would be expected given the truth of metaphysical principles. Another such idea is "parallel universes" or the multiverse. In this conception, the universe we find ourselves in is not the only one. Every time a choice is made, another universe comes into existence where the opposite choice had been made.

However, the continual creation of new universes in time is not precisely the traditional teaching. First of all, the QM version does not take into account the notion of compossibilities, which limits to some degree seemingly possible universes. The other is that other universes may be quite different from the one we are conscious of. Although the idea of possible universes is not encountered often in religious thinking, it does have a pedigree. The Islamic philosopher Fakhr al-Din al-Razi[12] came to this conclusion based on verses in the Koran regarding Allah as Lord of the Words plural . He wrote:

> It is established by evidence that there exists beyond the world a void without a terminal limit (khala' la nihayata laha), and it is established as well by evidence that God Most High has power over all contingent beings (al-mumkinat). Therefore He the Most High has the power (qadir) to create a thousand thousand worlds (alfa alfi 'awalim) beyond this world such that each one of those worlds be bigger and more massive than this world as well as having the like of what this world has of the throne (al-arsh), the chair (al-kursiyy), the heavens (al-samawat) and the earth (al-ard), and the sun (al-shams) and the moon (al-qamar). The arguments of the philosophers (dala'il al-falasifah) for establishing that the world is one are weak, flimsy arguments founded upon feeble premises.

[12] http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fakhr_al-Din_al-Razi

The Hermetist Giordano Bruno[13] makes an argument for the existence of multiple worlds based on the infinity of God. In *Ash Wednesday Supper* he writes:

> He made his affirmation that the universe is infinite; that it consists of an immense ethereal region; that it is like a vast sky of space in whose bosom are the heavenly bodies... that the moon, the sun, and innumerable other bodies are in this ethereal region, and the earth also; that is is not to be believed that there is any firmament, base, or foundation to which are fixed these great animals which form the constitution of the universe the infinite material of the infinite divine potency.

Friedrich Nietzsche claims the same world repeats:

> What, if some day or night a demon were to steal after you into your loneliest loneliness and say to you: 'This life as you now live it and have lived it, you will have to live once more an innumerable times more' ... Would you not throw yourself down and gnash your teeth and curse the demon who spoke thus? Or have you once experienced a tremendous moment when you would have answered him: 'You are a god and never have I heard anything more divine.'
>
> *The Gay Science*, 341

The concept of Eternal Return is illustrated in the diagram. A life is represented by the circle, and the world by the plane. Life begins, it completes, and at some future time the life will begin again at the same point, and repeat the same circle. It assumes that space is finite and time infinite; thus every spatial configuration will eventually have to be repeated. Note that the center of the circle is on the material plane, so there is no sense of

[13] `http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Giordano_Bruno`

transcendence. Also, as Guenon points out in *The Symbolism of the Cross*, Infinity is incompatible with the idea of repetition. Every possibility of manifestation happens once, and once only.

The second diagram is adapted from Rene Guenon. Each plane represents a world and a state of being. Due to the infinitude of possibilities, no state is repeated. Thus a being that manifests in the human state will never repeat that state. This obviously precludes reincarnation in the sense of a being repeating earthbound human lives. Again, we take the circle to represent a life along with its center. For reincarnation to occur, there would have to be a new circle with a new center; this is hard to conceive.

Unlike eternal return, therefore, Guenon proposes as the Traditional view (see the above quotes) the idea of multiple worlds, represented by the various planes. As a circle closes, instead of closing on itself — and ending its possibilities — it connects to the beginning of a circle in the world above it. This continues, forming a helix with a common center. Since birth and death are the end points of the circle, we see that death in one world corresponds to birth in another, and vice versa. Now, this death is not necessarily a physical death, but may include post-mortem states appropriate to that plane of existence. Nevertheless, the the possibilities of that world have been played out, even those states will terminate.

Guenon does not, and cannot, describe the features of another world, but we may assume that a plane that is infinitesimally close to ours, may be similar in many ways but also slightly different. In this sense, we may regard it as a form of reincarnation in that a being is incarnated in a material world, though not the same as the previous one. (Note that temporal sequence does not have the precise meaning in the conventional way, but it is easier to describe it in those terms). Understood in this way, this doctrine is similar to that of Fourth Way teachings of Ouspensky.

Many thanks to Prasad Sarangapani for creating the geometric diagrams.

Posted on 2011-05-24 by Cologero

* * *

Izak on 2011-05-28 at 17:47 said:

The second diagram is somewhat incomplete, it seems. In Symbolism of the Cross (which, at the moment I admit I don't have handy), I recall Guenon using the image of an upward spiral contained within a sphere that possesses a three-dimensional (that is, six-pointed) cross. The spiral itself would seem to be planar, not linear. I envisioned this image, basically.[14]

but with planar coordinates filled in from the vertical pole (which is impossible, I think, to actually draw). That way, it allows us to recognize the indefinitude of horizontal planes, because there is no precise number of spiral swirls and thus no points of degree separating each spiral swirl from the other (one recalls Zeno's argument about infinite space existing between two points). My point is not to say that the diagram is wrong, but that it does not seem to be the complete picture of what Guenon was describing, which is probably impossible to actually convey through illustration anyhow. The diagram here seems like more of a step in a process of mentally constructing it. It is frustrating that Guenon himself doesn't seem to have included his own diagrams.

Also he takes pains to assure the reader that he is not talking about an "infinitude" of possibilities but an indefinite number. He seems very concerned about avoiding discussions of infinite space and states of being.

Anyhow, good discussion on metaphysics.

Cologero on 2011-05-28 at 18:44 said:

Thanks for the diagram, it takes some mental gymnastics to visualize the diagrams from Guenon's verbose description. I did, however, point out that the diagram provided was an adaptation to demonstrate the point. Oddly enough, in traditional teachings there would be nothing *but* diagrams, avoiding the very necessity of the text. This would go along with oral teachings related to the diagrams. It is one of our goals to realize all the diagrams described in Symbolism of the Cross and we are always looking for help.

Guenon defines "infinite" very narrowly to mean unbounded in the metaphysical sense so he never uses that word as a mathematician might. By "indefinite" he means "uncountable", or "uncountably infinite" (the last word used in the mathematical sense.) So Universal Possibility is unlimited, or infinite (see Multiple States of Being), although the specific possibilities for a

[14] http://lh4.ggpht.com/_mlEZC-GqQwc/THgRr_aw--I/AAAAAAAAAY8/k_UPz-XU8-c/spiral_curve%5B1%5D.png

being are not (the True Man actualizes all his possibilities). Nevertheless, the possible states of being are uncountable.

4.13 Schuon vs Guenon

> The true essence of everything always abides, though unmanifest in the inner depths of very Being, while its sensory qualities appear outwardly. For it is impossible that the Divine Ideas included in the intelligible world should be evanescent: to pretend that the content of Divine Science is evanescent would imply atheism.
>
> Nur ad-Din Abd ar-Rahman Jami, *Lawa'ih*

The descent of the Being, or the Self, to the human being, ends with the subtle and gross states. The subtle state has three sheaths, as shown in the following chart.

- Corporeal things
  - Living beings, plants, vegetative soul
    - Sentient beings, animals, animal soul
      - Rational beings, humans, rational soul

Of course, the descent happens in reverse order, from the rational to the gross; the chart illustrates how it unfolds in time, as material objects seem to evolve from life to sentience to rationality. The subtle state may also be called the psychical. Note that the gross state and the subtle state together make up what may be called the corporeal world. That is why the following quote from **Frithjof Schuon** seems to be way off the mark:

> I do not know from where Guenon gets this enumeration of the five conditions of physical existence which he calls 'corporeal': space, time. form, number, and life. l am in agreement as regards the first four, but not as regards life, because what we are concerned with here is matter or, if one prefers, physical substance. If one adds life, which is not at all a general condition, it is likewise necessary to add other secondary categories such as color and so on.
>
> Frithjof Schuon, *Rene Guenon: Some Observations*

Five Conditions *Pace* Schuon, **Rene Guenon** considers this to be a very important question, so it is important to "get it right". These are Guenon's actual words, which Schuon misquoted or mistranslated:

> The existence of individual beings in the physical world is indeed subject to a set of five conditions: space, time, matter, form and life, which can be matched with the five bodily senses, as well as to the five elements.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Gnosis and Spiritualist Schools*

Guenon identifies the source as the *Sankhya* of Kapila. The *tanmatras* are the five elements, which are related to the five senses, as shown in *Man and his Becoming*. Likewise the five elements are related to those elements. Therefore, the chief characteristic of the five conditions is their transcendence in the sense that they are never themselves manifested, yet are the principles of manifestation.

Space and **Time** are obviously like that; they are *a priori* to experience. That is, there cannot be any phenomenal experience without space and time. Space is not discovered by investigating the world, as if there could be someplace that is non-space. The same applies to time.

There is a further distinction. Time arises in the subtle state, but space arises in the gross state. Ether is the most subtle element, at the border between the gross state and the etheric body of the subtle state.

By "**form**", Guenon means the ideas or essences in the Divine Intellect. Once again, they are not discovered through investigation of the world. Forms are not grasped by the senses, but rather by the intellect intuitively.

There is another possible misunderstanding: Guenon uses the terms "physical world" and "corporeal world" interchangeably. Hence, the corporeal world includes the subtle world. Perhaps the Greek word **psyche** could be used instead of "**life**" to make the point more clearly. Psyche is "life", but it has connotations like soul or consciousness. Now consciousness is indeed a "general condition", irreducible to the other conditions; consciousness does not arise out of matter. Nor is consciousness discovered in the phenomenal world; on the contrary there is no phenomenal world without consciousness.

Colours can only arise in consciousness so they are indeed secondary. This dissolves Schuon's objections. **Matter** will be taken up in the following section.

The Notion of Matter After having addressed the issue of "life" as general principle, Schuon turns to **matter**:

> For Guenon the notion of 'matter', is factitious, confused. problematic; it has nothing fundamental about it and is to be found nowhere except in the modern West. This is incredible. And what, in an altogether general way, is the sensible substance that one can touch, measure, weigh, analyze, and possibly work or shape? And why, for goodness' sake, would this not be matter?

Now even a great intellect can be wrong, but his errors are usually deep and subtle. If the mistake seems so obvious, then it is likely that

something essential has been lost. What follows are a few points to take into consideration.

Point 1: Matter is not manifested

This means that you cannot show me a piece of matter. Like space and time, matter is part of each experience, yet it cannot be experienced directly. Hence, one cannot touch, measure, weigh, analyze, and possibly work or shape it directly.

Point 2: Experience is of things

Following up on point 1, you can show me a banana, an automobile, a squirrel, and so on, but you cannot show me matter. Hence matter is not what can touch, measure, weigh, analyze, and possibly work or shape. Rather, those experiences are of specific things. You can touch a banana, weigh it, analyze it, and slice it up over your ice cream.

Point 3: Matter has no meaning in physics

This may surprise some people, but the notion of matter is not fundamental to physics. You could define matter as any elementary particle with mass. Yet quantum entities do not have size or volume as conventionally understood. That means that the classical definition of matter as "extension" is not valid. However, corporeal things do have extension.

Point 4: Matter is not necessary for sense experience

You can experience sights, colours, sounds, the passage of time, travel, and so on in your dreams or imagination. Hence, sensory experience does not prove the existence of "matter".

Point 5: Matter is indeterminate

The "matter" of physics is more like the prime matter of ancient philosophy. That is, it is in an indeterminate state, just like Schrodinger's famous cat. It only becomes a specific thing when it is informed. Wolfgang Smith has addressed this question adequately, so there is no need to repeat it here.

Epilogue True understanding requires a shift in consciousness. The naïve view is that matter is reality and there are things "out there, right now" that run on their own power.

The shift is to understand matter as the canvas on which the Divine Archetypes are reflected. They manifest in space and time, so that they can be experienced in consciousness. It is a gift. You can grasp the Attributes in the intellect, but you can also experience them through the senses.

Posted on 2021-07-28 by Cologero

* * *

Presbyter Iohannes on 2021-07-29 at 13:37 said:
What do you have to say about "Schuon vs Guénon" in more general terms?

Cologero on 2021-08-01 at 21:08 said:
The most striking difference, in my opinion, is in their style. Guenon is more adamant, opposing one view to its contraries. Schuon strives to seek out the middle ground between two seemingly opposing views, in which each view has plausibility in its perspective. So Schuon addresses exoteric issues, which Guenon typically avoids.

Presbyter Iohannes on 2021-08-01 at 21:33 said:
https://pt.scribd.com/document/348127488/Rfutation-Des-Quelques-Critiques-de-Schuon
This anonymous refutation covers all of the Schuon fiasco against Guénon. Unfortunately it is only available in French. Perhaps it would be useful if someone translated it (someone more well versed in french than I am).

Maude Murray on 2022-07-28 at 23:47 said:
For an easy to understand comparison, see Frithjof Schuon versus René Guénon: their roles near the end of the world, by Maude Murray, the third of Schuon's four "wives!" That's on Academia.edu. Or see Twitter, Facebook or A last minute lesson in discernment, under her name.

Maude Murray on 2022-11-20 at 22:39 said:

Just go to `https://frithjofschuon.wordpress.com` where the two are decisively compared in their own words. They are also compared to all Gnostics in all revelations from time immemorial. The difference is astounding!

I wish I could delete my past comments here as some sites have been deleted or changed (hint).

`Kaukomieli on 2022-12-18 at 08:49 said:`

Here is a short video on YouTube where Schuon discusses his views on metaphysics, esotericism, syncretism and religion.

`https://youtu.be/OKgjGiTVbPo`

Two striking differences between them seems to be in their relationship to syncretism and exoteric religious practice. Where as Guenon rejects syncretism and speaks of synthesis, Schuon seems to accept syncretism in esoteric practice, and whereas Guenon stresses the need for religious exotericism, Schuon seems to considered exoteric religious practice unnecessary for an esotericist or to a metaphysician.

I've also heard Schuon was also quite extravagant which derived from his experience of Mary from which he made his practice of ritual nudity going all the way to the practice of sexual magic. Some have said it was a sign of a spiritual illness rather than a mystical revelation.

`Kaukomieli on 2022-12-18 at 13:50 said:`

Here is also a lenghty document of the two gentlemen in question that might be of interest:

`https://youtu.be/7Vlf8GQJFeY`

Today I read some texts that describes Schuon as defiling minors with his cultic ritual, but what I gathered was that the profane world had misunderstood his apparently illegal activities with the Girls in their teens. For the ritual setting of the Khrishnaic dance with its touching of nude human bodies is completely out of the moral framework of sexual license.

5

The True Man. The Person

5.1 Tone Deaf to Life

Man's life is a becoming; and not only becoming, but self-creation. He does not grow under the direction and control of irresistible forces. The force that shapes him is his own will. All his life is an effort to attain to real human nature. But human nature, since man is at bottom spirit, is only exemplified in the absolute spirit of God. Hence man must shape himself in God's image, or he ceases to be even human and becomes diabolical. This self-creation must also be self-knowledge; not the self-knowledge of introspection, the examination of the self that is, but the knowledge of God, the self that is to be. Knowledge of God is the beginning, the center, and end, of human life.

R. G. Collingwood

Creation emanates from the potentialities inherent in God's being, a being which radiates "into" the coming into visibility and intelligibility of all that surrounds us.

Ibn Arabi

Life is the actualization of possibilities.

Ulick Varange

The worst thing that can happen to a man who is already divided up into a dozen different compartments is to seal off yet another compartment and tell him that this one is more important than all others, and that he must henceforth exercise a special care in keeping it separate from them.

The first thing that you have to do, before you even start thinking about such a thing as contemplation, is to try to recover your basic natural unity, reintegrate your compartmentalized being into a coordinated and simple whole and learn to live as a unified human person. This means that you have to bring back together the fragments of your distracted existence so that when you say "I", there really is someone present to support the pronoun you have uttered. Reflect, sometimes, on the disquieting fact that most of your statements of opinions, tastes, deeds, desires, hopes, and fears are statements about someone who is not really present. When you say "I think," it is often not you who think, but "they" — it is the anonymous authority of the collectivity speaking through your mask. When you say "I want," you are accepting, paying for, what has been forced upon you. That is to say, you reach out for what you have been made to want.

Thomas Merton

Symphony In studying creativity, we have used the example of the symphony as an aid to understand the Noumenon and its relationship to phenomena. We recognize a symphony by its unity ... notes follow each other in melody, transitions are resolved harmoniously, movements

relate to each other, all within an overarching rhythm. Great composers have often described the creative process. They don't begin with the parts and end up with a unity. Quite the contrary ... they grasp the symphony in its wholeness and scramble to gets its parts down on paper.

For example, this is Mozart's description of the creative process:

> All this fires my soul and, provided I am not disturbed, my subject enlarges itself, becomes methodized and defined, and the whole, though it be long, stands almost complete and finished in my mind, so I can survey it, like a fine picture or a beautiful statue at a glance. ... All this inventing, this producing, takes place in a pleasing, lively dream.

Tchaikovsky offers a similar description:

> Generally speaking, the germ of a future composition comes suddenly and unexpectedly ... it takes root with extraordinary force and rapidity, shoots up through the earth, puts forth branches and leaves and finally blossoms. I cannot define the creative process in any other way than by this simile. ... I forget everything and behave like a madman: everything within me stands pulsing and quivering; hardly have I begun the sketch before one thought follows another. In the midst of this magic process, it frequently happens that some external interruption awakes me from my somnambulistic state. ... such dreadful interruptions break the thread of inspiration.

For us, the listeners, on the other hand, the process works in reverse. We hear the sounds: the instruments coming in and out, the melody line, the harmony, the percussion, the changes in volume and pitch. The amazing thing is that we don't focus on each individual sound, but rather we grasp the symphony as a whole – usually it only takes a few notes and we recognize it immediately. "Beethoven's 9th", we call out.

But exactly where is the 9th symphony? Until it is performed, it has only a possible existence and it exists nowhere and everywhere. Once it is performed, it suddenly comes alive, it manifests itself, the possible becomes actual. What are the factors? A complex mix of necessity, fortune, freedom. The instruments are required. The mysterious element of fortune comes into play: why is one successful, the other not. The individual decisions of the players must converge. All that — plus the symphony itself — are part of the stew.

Life How do we experience our own lives? The traditional view of man is spirit, soul, and body. Where is the spirit? "Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you, and before you were born I consecrated you" (Jer 1:5) God knows us as possibility, as spirit. Traditionally, the soul is the form of the body. The soul, then, is like the notes of the symphony that is spirit, written down by the composer to match perfectly the unity of the symphony. The body, then, is the manifestation of spirit and soul, its coming into awareness.

Again, there are the same mysterious factors. Our destiny as determined by God. Fortune, the force of circumstances, the forces that shape and form our environment, that close out some options while opening up other possibilities. Then freedom, the choices we make. All this combines to make our life, to actualize the possibilities available to us. Is that how we see it? There are all the events in the day, from the trivial to the momentous. We forget what happened a year ago, we see no relation between today and a year from today. Our life is in fragments: a job, a family, friends, entertainment, education, etc. Do we pause to see how all the pieces of our lives fit together into a harmonious whole, how we are creating it year by year, day by day, minute by minute?

There is a disability called "tone deafness". A tone deaf person hears each note of the symphony, every sound, all the instruments; yet, he doesn't hear the symphony itself. To him, the notes are unrelated, merely

a cacophony of individual sounds, little different from street noise.

In an analogous way, most people are *Tone Deaf to Life*.

Posted on 2007-08-24 by Cologero

5.2 The Fourth Reverence

> Now I set forth man as asking himself: What is that in me which enables me to sacrifice the inmost lures of my impulses and all wishes that proceed from my nature, to a law which promises me no advantage in return and no penalty if I transgress it; which indeed, the more sternly it commands and the less it offers in return, the more I reverence it? This question stirs our whole soul in amazed wonder at the greatness and sublimity of the inner faculty in man and the insolubility of the mystery which it conceals (for the answer: 'it is freedom,' would be tautological, because it is freedom itself that creates the mystery). We can never tire of directing our attention to it and admiring in ourselves a power which yields to no power of nature ... Here is what Archimedes wanted, but did not find: a firm point on which reason could place its lever, and that without applying it to the present or to a future world, but merely to its inner idea of freedom (which immovable moral law provides as a sure foundation) in order by its principles to set in motion the human will, even in opposition to all nature.
>
> Immanuel Kant

Johann Wolfgang Goethe's theory of the three reverences includes reverence

1. for that which is above us

2. for that which is around us

3. for that which is below us

From these, arise the three kinds of genuine religion.
These reverences are summarized by **Thomas Carlyle**:

> Goethe practically distinguishes the kinds of religion that are, or have been, in the world; and says that for men there are three reverences. The boys are all trained to go through certain gesticulations; to lay their hands on their breasts and look up to heaven, in sign of the first reverence; other forms for the other two: so they give their three reverences.
>
> 1. The first and simplest is that of reverence for what is above us. It is the soul of all the Pagan religion; there is nothing better in the antique man than that.
> 2. Then there is reverence for what is around us,—reverence for our equals, to which he attributes an immense power in the culture of man.
> 3. The third is reverence for what is beneath us; to learn to recognise in pain, in sorrow and contradiction, even in those things, odious to flesh and blood, what divine meanings are in them; to learn that there lies in these also, and more than in any of the preceding, a priceless blessing. And he defines that as being the soul of the Christian religion,—the highest of all religions; 'a height,' as Goethe says, 'a height to which mankind was fated and enabled to attain; and from which, having once attained it, they can never retrograde.' Man cannot quite lose that (Goethe thinks), or permanently descend below it again; but always, even in the most degraded, sunken and unbelieving times, he calculates there will be found some few souls who will recognise

> what this highest of the religions meant; and that, the world having once received it, there is no fear of its ever wholly disappearing.

But Goethe added a **fourth reverence**: true religion arises from the "highest reverence", that is, reverence for Self; it is only when he has reached this stage that man attains the highest pinnacle that he is capable of attaining.

But let us be careful to distinguish between this reverence for Self and attachment to ego. The ego is part of nature, snarled in the web of cause and effect. As Kant realized quoted above , this Self that Goethe speaks of is transcendent to nature, and only there can it be free.

Some New Age speakers speak about getting in touch with our "Source" and how all these wonderful things will happen. Fine as far as it goes, but it stops short, since it serves only to feed the ego. This ego can no more get in touch with its source than the Maid of the Mist[1] climb back up to the top of Niagara Falls.

The talk feeds the desire of the ego to be the Infinite, a task it can only fail in – it is the Self that is Infinite. The human being is a mix of Being and Nonbeing, act and potency, the actual and the possible. As such, he has limitations and opportunities, both of which he tends to underestimate.

As act, the human is never some abstract "human being", but is always someone in particular — of some gender, culture, language, ethnicity, race — it is this particularity that gives us our dharma. And the real opportunity of the human state, not available to other creatures in our world, is not to take up some new sport or manifest a parking space, but rather to transcend totally the human state, finally to be free.

When you seek to manifest your destiny, are you stirred in your "whole

[1] https://www.niagarafallscrowneplazahotel.com/blog/2015/01/real-maid-mist-niagaras-famous-legend/

soul in amazed wonder at the greatness and sublimity of the inner faculty in man and the insolubility of the mystery which it conceals"? Do you seek to accumulate things or seek the ideal good?

Nurture this feeling of awe and reverence for the "Source" — don't try to get in touch with it. Rather, get out of its way, and let its light manifest in the world.

Posted on 2008-06-02 by Cologero

5.3 The True Sage

> Matter — the Platonic "other" — is effectively the sign of imperfection of the act and, as it exists, is connected to that fundamental "injustice" about which Anaximander, Parmenides, and Empedocles speak — and is, essentially, evil. There is no other evil beyond necessity, of which matter, brute existence, is the evidence; and as long as the "I" is not able to avoid the experience of matter — of this "other" against and beyond him — he will be imperfect: evil, impure, irrational.
>
> Julius Evola, *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*

The fundamental difference between the Eastern way — as in Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam — and the Western way is the understanding of Will. The Eastern way understands the world as illusion and so the path to escape it is world rejection. The Western way understands the World as the reflection of Spirit, just as the light of the Moon is the reflection of the light from the Sun.

The World, then, is not illusion, but is rather the creation of Spirit. The Spirit is Will, Unity, Logos; on its own (that is, separated and ignorant of the Divine source), the world would is blind and deterministic. Both the divine principle and world soul have the same goal: deification or

theosis of all that exists. The world soul is blind and passive and does not know what to strive for; it strives to attain unity unconsciously. The human being can participate in the freedom of the Spirit and hence be the agent for the goal of the world process.

In The *Justification of the Good*, Solovyov describes the True Sage.

> In human life there is an opposition between that which is conformable to Ideas and in harmony with Reason, and that which contradicts the ideal norm. The true sage is no longer a simple hermit or a wandering monk, who has renounced life and is mildly preaching the same renunciation to others; he is one who boldly denounces the wrong and irrational things of life. Hence the end is different in the two cases. Buddha Sakyamuni peacefully dies after a meal with his disciples, while Socrates, condemned and put to prison by his fellow citizens, is sentenced by them to drink a poisoned cup. But in spite of this tragic ending, the attitude of the Greek idealist to the reality unworthy of him is not one of decisive opposition. The highest representative of humanity at this state—the philosopher—is conscious of his absolute worth in so far as he lives by pure thought in the truly existent intelligible realm of Ideas or of the all embracing rationality, and despises the false, the merely phenomenal being of the material and sensuous world.
>
> In any case his attitude to the unworthy reality is merely one of contempt. The contempt is certainly different in kind from that characteristic of Buddhism. Buddha despises the world because everything is illusion. The very indefiniteness of this judgment, however, takes away its sting. If all is equally worthless, no one is particular is hurt by it, and if nothing but Nirvana is opposed to the bad reality, the latter may sleep in peace. For Nirvana is an absolute state and not the norm for relative states.
>
> Now the idealist does possess such a norm and he despises and condemns the life that surrounds him not because it inevitably

> shares in the illusory character of everything, but because it is abnormal, irrational, opposed to the Idea. Such condemnation is no longer neutral, it has an element of defiance and demand. It is slighting to all who are bound by worldly irrationality and therefore leads to hostility, and sometimes to persecution and the cup with poison.

Posted on 2010-04-29 by Cologero

* * *

`Comprehensor on 2010-04-30 at 08:42 said:`

I don't agree that there is an Eastern-Western divide, but rather it is a case of an opposition between tradition and modernism. Clearly in the Hermetic and Christian (especially biblical) texts we see the same views expressed of the world and worldly knowledge as in the East. Both Eastern and Western traditions value detachment or dispassion, which is freedom from, and control over, the passions. However, I would not call that a rejection of the world so much as discernment or putting everything in its place. For both Eastern and Western traditions encourage scientific knowledge, as it is a limited or specific mode of knowledge, but still knowledge. In modern Westernism on the other hand there is a complete negation of the Spirit. Here exists a profane culture which has nothing whatsoever to do with spiritual wisdom and does not see the world as a manifestation of the spirit.

`Comprehensor on 2010-04-30 at 10:00 said:`

Whereas a liberated Hindu might say "All is Brahma" a Jacob Boehme would write, "Thou must know that this world in its innermost unfolds its properties and powers in union with the heaven aloft above us; and so there is one Heart, one Being, one Will, one God, all in all. The outermost moving of this world cannot comprehend the outermost moving of heaven aloft above this world, for they are one to the other as life and death, or as a man and a stone are one to the other. There is a strong firmament dividing the outermost of this world from the outermost of the upper heaven; and that firmament is Death, which rules and reigns everywhere in the outermost in this world, and sets a great gulf between them." That one must reject the shell for the kernel is true in every orthodox tradition which is rooted in metaphysics. It therefore must be stressed that the Spirit isn't to be comprehended in the outer worlds but only through the narrow gate, as Boehme warns, "O ye theologists, the spirit here opens a door and gate for you! If you will not now see and feed your sheep and lambs on a green meadow, instead of

a dry, parched heath, you must be accountable for it before the severe, earnest and wrathful judgement of God; therefore look to it."

Cologero on 2010-04-30 at 12:51 said:

True, at the most fundamental level there is no "divide" in Tradition. On the other hand, different traditions have arisen to accomodate different peoples at different times. Since there is a sufficient reason for everything, it is legitimate to ask why one form rather than another is appropriate for a given race or nation.

Matt on 2010-04-30 at 14:04 said:

I've been thinking about the relationship between Neo-Platonism and Gnosticism. Even though Plotinus wrote against Gnosticism, with the similarity of their view of matter as privation and non-being (therefore evil), I am beginning to wonder if once can really say there is a legitimate difference between the two. I suppose the possible difference is the dualism of much of Gnosticism, that there are two Wills, and one created created matter in opposition to the other one. No?

It also brings up the question of Evola's supposed general opposition to Gnosticism (though I have yet to read something from Evola himself that is a critique of that doctrine). Though again, I suppose it could be because of the dualism.

Cologero on 2010-04-30 at 18:54 said:

Solovyov was quite familiar with Boehme. It is not at all a question about mistaking the outer world for Spirit.

What he is getting at is how to understand the world, either actively or passively. How does the appearance of the world arise?

Since it is the result of the Will, to become passive relative to the world process is to allow it to arise "spontaneously", in Evola's term. Solovyov, on the other hand, recognizes the task to create the world appearance with a Will that is conscious and free. As the world process is struggling to achieve union, it fails without the activity of the Will conscious of its inner unity.

This will be made clear in future posts.

Comprehensor on 2010-05-01 at 07:38 said:

I don't see the difference between Buddha and Socrates. Did not Buddha boldly denounce the wrong and irrational? The only difference is that Buddhism was originally a monastic order. I don't think we can use this example as a basis for serious comparative study of different traditions or adaptations thereof.

Cologero on 2010-05-01 at 09:57 said:

It is not a question of a so-called "comparative" study. It is about the differences in the inner states of mind associated with a given teaching, even if they are subtle. Followers of different traditions, and cultures based on those traditions, show striking differences from each other. It is hardly unreasonable to relate those outer differences to the different attitudes toward the world induced by or implicated in their respective spiritual paths.

`Comprehensor on 2010-05-01 at 12:00 said:`

Again, these differences (of inner states and attitudes) remain to be seen, especially when based on a false premise.

`larissa on 2010-05-17 at 18:50 said:`

"The contempt is certainly different in kind from that characteristic of Buddhism. Buddha despises the world because everything is illusion. The very indefiniteness of this judgment, however, takes away its sting.'

I suggest you make a serious study of Buddhism before making such generalized suggestions. Evola's "Doctrine of Awakening" is a good start. Also Rhys Davids and Coomaramaswamy are excellent as well. Buddha was merely trying to reintroduce the "vigor" that was dying out in the old religion–through corruptions of various sorts –which is why when one studies Buddhism carefully one realizes that the Buddha taught that which is hardly different from what Hinduism taught... just tried to reinvigorate the old ideal that were being corrupted in Hinduism... .Unfortunately a self-correcting system that was entirely native born was disrupted of course with the Islamic invasions and Hindus turning ultra–orthodox to survive a foreign despotic system imposed upon them by force.

5.4 Metaphysical Positivism

> We, on the contrary—basing ourselves on a tradition much more ancient and real than the one which can be claimed by the "faith" of Western man, on a tradition which is not proved by doctrines, but by deeds and acts of power and clairvoyance—affirm instead the possibility and the concrete reality of what we have called "Wisdom". We thus assert the possibility of a positive, direct, methodical, empirical knowledge in the "metaphysical" field, just as science strives to gain in the physical field, and, just like science, it remains above any moral or philosophical belief of men.

Julius Evola, *Those Who Know and Those Who Believe*[2] in *Pagan Imperialism*[3]

In the aftermath of the destruction of the Traditional world order resulting from the French Revolution, the philosopher **Auguste Comte** sought to re-establish it on a positive basis. Thus, Positivism would accept as "real" only what can be experienced and the laws that are discovered in that experience. It would supersede the theological and ideological speculations of earlier stages of humanity[4].[5]

Now, Evola emphasizes that what he means by "metaphysics" is just as exact, methodical and based on the experience of the real, as any empirical science. And just like Positivism, it is independent of any theological or ideological speculations. However, unlike Positivism, it is not the result of a progression or evolution of humanity, but rather a recovery of the most ancient or **Primordial Tradition**. Yet this is not the accumulation over the centuries of a set of doctrines that can be learned and memorized, but rather something that must be recovered anew by each man through his own efforts and vision. As such it is neither transcendent faith nor physical science, but

> necessarily a surpassing of both religious unrealism and materialised realism by a transcendent, virile, Olympian positivism.

Evola describes this more specifically:

> we maintain the possibility of forms of experience different from the sensory forms of the common man, not "given", not "normal", which can be reached by means of certain active processes

[2] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/ThoseWhoKnow.htm

[3] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/PaganImperialism.htm

[4] https://gornahoor.net/?p=530%20

[5] We use the word "ideological" where Comte uses "metaphysical", since it more accurately reflects his intention. We therefore reserve "metaphysics" as the science of the suprasensible.

> of inner transformation. The peculiarity of such transcendent experiences ... is to be direct, concrete, and individual, as much as sensory experience itself, and yet to see reality, beyond the contingent, spatio-temporal aspect characteristic of everything that is sensory.
>
> Julius Evola, *Science vs Wisdom*[6] in *Pagan Imperialism*[7]

As we pointed out, this involves transcending consensus reality, as described by Josephin Peladan[8]. Evola puts it this way:

> the whole so-called "problem of knowledge" is enclosed within the interiority of every being, and does not depend on "culture", but on his capacity for freeing himself from the human, i.e., from the sensory, the rational, and the emotional, and of identifying himself with one or another form of "metaphysical" experience.

This is the critical, yet difficult, point to accept: *viz.*, the metaphysical principle that "to know is to be". Unless and until a man has regenerated his consciousness to the Primordial State, he does not and cannot know anything about it. Unless and until he becomes a True Man[9], he can only speculate about it.

> To know, according to Wisdom, does not mean "to think", but to be the thing known: to live it, to realise it inwardly. One does not really know a thing unless one can actively transform one's consciousness into it. Therefore, only what ensues from direct individual experience will count as knowledge. And, this is just

[6] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/ScienceVsWisdom.htm
[7] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/PaganImperialism.htm
[8] https://gornahoor.net/?p=995
[9] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1039

> the opposite of the modern mentality, for which, whatever appears immediately to the individual is called "phenomenon", or "subjective", and so it posits some other thing behind it as "true reality", which is simply imagined or presumed (the "thing in itself" of the philosophers, the "Absolute" of vulgar religion, "matter", "ether", or "energy" of science). Wisdom is an absolute positivism which regards only what can be grasped by direct experience as real, and everything else as unreal, abstract, and illusory.

Julius Evola, *Science vs Wisdom*[10] in *Pagan Imperialism*[11]

Posted on 2010-11-17 by Cologero

* * *

KarlH on 2010-11-17 at 23:45 said:

This is perhaps the most frustrating and reward paradox of our pursuit. The person who achieves a Primordial State can know things, but not necessarily in a communicable sense. They can leave hints and cause people to consider a transformation of self, but it's nearly impossible to speak of the inner experience of transformation. This does, admittedly, read like lunacy in the soulless positivism of our modern age.

Sati Shankar on 2010-11-18 at 09:15 said:

In that state of awareness, it is true that we only have unspeakable ... but before that every effort is mental and there lies the

territory of metaphysical positivism... though, seemingly an attempt to unify the dual... .brave an attempt.... .all the best.

James O'Meara on 2010-11-18 at 10:13 said:

This, or rather similar passages on Experience in the book Magic, are what I consider to be the 'essential Evola' in the sense that everything else depends on this. Evola "sees" the positivist demand for experience and "raises" the stakes by observing that the kind of experience one has depends on ones state of consciousness, or being; higher, or lower. Rather than seeking to

[10] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/ScienceVsWisdom.htm

[11] https://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/PaganImperialism.htm

transcend experience by something below, or behind, it, or fleeing into mathematical abstractions, Evola proposes staying with experience and changing ones consciousness. The positivist may call this lunacy, but if he refuses to follow the methods offered and "see" for himself, what of it?

James O'Meara on 2010-11-18 at 10:19 said:

Coincidentally, just stumbled across this on Dmitri Orlov's post-economic collapse site. For 'incompetent', read: positivist.

"A key insight is offered by the Dunning-Krueger effect, defined and experimentally tested by Justin Kruger and David Dunning at Cornell University. Kruger and Dunning proposed that, "for a given skill, incompetent people will:

tend to overestimate their own level of skill; fail to recognize genuine skill in others; fail to recognize the extremity of their inadequacy; recognize and acknowledge their own previous lack of skill, if they can be trained to substantially improve."

"Krueger and Dunning, and other experimenters, have shown this effect to be quite pronounced. Competent people initially assumed that others were competent as well, and were able to correct their misperception once they were allowed to examine the work of others. Incompetent people, on the other hand, were only able to recognize competence in others after being taught to recognize their own incompetence. Thus, a weaker version of point 4 above suffices: incompetent people do not need to become competent, but to be able to judge the superior competence of others they do have to gain some insight into their own incompetence."

Cologero on 2010-11-18 at 18:26 said:

It's a dicey problem, whose solution requires some openness and perhaps a little humility. Rudolf Steiner makes an interesting point when he complains that those who deny the infallibility of the Pope, make themselves into little popes themselves. A common criticism made of him is this: "only that can be true which a simple, unpretentious mind can perceive and understand." To which Steiner responds:

> which means, of course, only what the speaker can perceive and understand. He therefore requires that no one should perceive and understand anything different from what he himself perceives and understands. The infallibility of the Pope is not acknowledged in such assemblies, the infallibility of the individual is claimed instead.

Unfortunately, neither Steiner in his organisation, nor Evola in the Magic groups, were able to develop a consistent training method that would lead to a common body of reproducible, esoteric knowledge. This is where it differs from the positive sciences.

James O'Meara on 2010-11-19 at 11:09 said:

I would think the "common body of reproducible, esoteric knowledge" would be the body of Tradition, or the traditions, in their theoretical and practical wings. It's right there to be explored and used, and conclusions drawn for oneself, if one wants, particularly today, which may not be altogether a good thing in the big picture.

Of course, attempts like Evola's have the disadvantage of being undertaken in singularly poor circumstances, in both time and space.

The Steiner quote is ironic, since while of course rejecting the "acceptable to the simple mind" approach, which would hardly allow anything beyond basic arithmetic, to say nothing of quantum mechanics or modern medicine, he never the less seemed to think he had developed a relatively simple technique that 'anyone' could learn, and more importantly use to gain knowledge, without any "traditional data" as Guenon would say. This is his "modern man has grown up and needs no helping hand" mentality, like all modern cults inspired by "modern science." Thus he and his disciples were never able to distinguish genuine clairvoyance perhaps from personal fantasies. Wilson or Lachman give as an example his detailed accounts of Arthur at Tintagel which later studies show to have been impossible — no castle in Arthur's time . I suppose this explains Evola's rather equivocal attitude to Steiner, while the more theoretical Guenon condemns him outright.

Michael Hoffman at egodeath.com who seems to have disappeared was much interested in the lousy track record of "meditation based" approaches to enlightenment, especially such as modern Boomer Buddhism. Humility indeed: how many have ever been enlightened? He favored intense drug-induced crisis, interspersed with study under the guidance of the already experienced; think: Eleusis.

James O'Meara on 2010-11-19 at 11:23 said:

More to the point: the teachings are known, the methods are there, like modern science. Like modern science, they seem to be too hard for the 'average Joe' to just grasp my reading a few books. Unlike modern science, which can turn out thousands of doctors and engineers, the 'success rate' is close to zero. Some say the methods are sound, but modern man is not fit Guenon or simply needs different methods Evola in his Tantric modes , others question the validity of the methods themselves Hoffman, promoting drugs over meditation .

Will on 2010-11-20 at 11:30 said:

Good comments, gentlemen.

There is also the problem of recognizing the genuine article when it's there. There are all sorts of preconceived ideas about what an enlightened being will be like. For example, most Boomer Buddhists will dismiss the idea that Evola had any degree of realization, because if he had he would have become a liberal humanist, right? I recall talking to an aged hippie who had

spent a lot of time in various "spiritual" groups, and he said that he only ever met one really enlightened teacher. His criteria? The guy ran a soup kitchen for the homeless, whereas none of the others had their own 501c charity.

Of course, those on the right have their own preconceived ideas. Presumably the only ones who don't are those who are themselves enlightened.

Perhaps the idea of enlightened vs. unenlightened (and hence, arguing over who is which) should be abandoned in favor of a more concrete approach of recognizing superior qualities. Too many people want be on the top of the hierarchy, but it seems to me that we do better to try to make an honest assessment of where we're at in it, and try to move up from wherever that may be. If you want to learn how to play guitar and you're a complete beginner, it doesn't really matter if your teacher is a master or a novice; either can teach you the basics, which is where you have to start.

To continue the analogy, mastering a musical instrument takes decades of consistent practice, and most highly accomplished musicians will tell you that even at their high level of attainment, they are still learning and growing. I think spiritual practice is like this as well. Even if there is an end point where one can say, like the Buddha, "Done, what needed to be done," it will be slow progress up to that point. Promises of quick enlightenment, whether through drugs or "secret methods" or whatever, are mostly sales pitches. But the traditions tease us by saying that there are indeed a small number of people who can attain profound realization very quickly because of their superior aptitude. And who doesn't like to entertain the possibility that he is one of them?

James O'Meara on 2010-11-20 at 11:49 said:

Will, I was just about to post this and saw your comment. Perhaps this is a more "concrete" way to look at it, as opposed to 'enlightened' and 'unenlightened', or as previously suggested, a more 'humble' approach.

Evola in Doctrine of Awakening talks about 'determining the vocations.' Only the Aryan Man in the Buddhist sense, not Himmler's will respond to the realization of samsara with a noble disdain rather than a desperate, purely reactionary asceticism and follow the Noble Path. Others will respond by conceiving of some guilt and seeking forgiveness through submission to the divine will e.g., Christianity or saying "Well, let's eat and drink and make merry" the Epicurean, or the modern Dawkinsian, the materialist in general. And so on.

The Superior Man is not interested in 'arguing' or 'proving' his point of view the 'demon of dialectics' as discussed in a previous chapter . Various men simply respond according to type, and there is nothing more to say. The Superior Man simply draws his conclusions, and seeks to work on himself.

James O'Meara on 2010-11-20 at 11:56 said:

Will,

Soup kitchen spirituality, indeed. Perhaps related to the idea, often announced by smug 'secularists,' that "of course, Jesus was a wise and progressive rabbi of his time." I notice they love to throw in the 'rabbi' part, an odd combination of 'see, I'm not an anti-Semite' with belittling just some guy hired by the congregation, not the Son of God at the same time.

I used to be amused or disgusted at East West Books here in NYC now closed, I guess a victim of the recession which was a huge store stuffed with every imaginable crystal, yoga mat, aryavedic nostrum and hippie geegaw, and thousands of books of various levels of seriousness, and off in one corner, one book by Evola; the Metaphysics of Sex, of course, chosen no doubt for its title if they had read it, they would have chucked it out in the trash ; as for Guenon, etc., not a trace. Complete works of Annie Besant, though!

`Will on 2010-11-21 at 11:06 said:`

James,

I've seen Evola's books in a couple new age bookstores as well. The stores must have standing orders with Inner Traditions and their other imprints, and the books just get sent to them. I don't know how else to explain it. I can't imagine the book ordering guy perusing the table of contents of Revolt Against the Modern World or Men Among the Ruins and saying, "Yes, this will go next to Eckhart Tolle and Deepak Chopra."

In regards to Jesus as a progressive rabbi, you might be interested in a pastor named Mark Driscoll from the Pacific Northwest, whose ministry is very reactionary against that sort of thing, not so much from an anti-Jewish perspective as anti-feminist. He's somehow managed to make Calvinism cool to Seattle hipsters, which might qualify as a miracle in and of itself. Part of the appeal is that his approach is unabashedly masculine. I wouldn't consider him a representative of Tradition, but I do think he's interesting as a cultural and religious phenomenon.

`http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lex6orNNzTs`

`James O'Meara on 2010-11-22 at 09:52 said:`

Will,

You're probably right about Evola on IT standing orders. They probably get one copy which never sells and just stays on the shelf.

I will have to look into this Pastor. Calvin for hipsters? I'm reminded of Death to the World, a group of 'punk monks' bringing Orthodoxy to 'a dying Protestant scene" (`http://www.deathtotheworld.com/about/about.html`). It's also interesting to see the masculine angle. Evola actually was able to say a few good words for 'sola fide' as being a way to bring home the seriousness of what's at stake, forcing an existential choice, that was relatively valid for a certain human type.

5.5 The Human Person

> The general plane is unique, but divides itself in diverse parts, in a way that in everything there are distinct places, some more pleasant, others less so. And souls, also unequal, come to inhabit these distinct places that correspond to their own diversity. In such a way, everything is arranged and the differences in their situations correspond to the inequality of the souls.
>
> Plotinus

> It is not the demon that chooses you, but you yourself chose your demon. You yourself choose the destiny of that life to which you are irremediably connected.
>
> Plato

The human being is in a unique position in the cosmos, since he participates in multiple states of being. Human incarnation requires three factors. He has matter and form, as do all natural things. Hence, he is the unity of a body and human nature. Animal life is also the unity of a body and the specific essence of the animal. But the human being also has an I, he is a person[12].

At birth, the I is conditioned, that is, he is born into certain circumstances, and given a particular destiny. Matter is the principle of individuation, so he is born a particular sex, of particular parents, family, nation, civilisation, era, and so on. Those are the biological and historical conditions of life. Yet those conditions are not arbitrary, contingent, nor accidental. Rather, they reflect the transcendent qualities of the person, the I. The Traditional teaching is that the soul is the form of the body.

[12] This is not the metaphysical definition of Person as used by Guenon. It is actually the human state.

Specifically, that implies that the conditions of the body in manifestation are determined, or even chosen, by the soul.

The person participates in multiple states of being. The highest is the Beatific Vision, then the nine angelic states, the primordial state, and the natural (or fallen) state. The angelic states will be addressed in a future post. For the Beatific Vision, refer to the great mystics like Dante, Meister Eckhart, or John of the Cross.

Ultimately, the I (Atma) is unconditioned, neither manifested nor unmanifested.

Person The person manifests in three principles.

- **Body**: The body exists. This is the principle of individuation since matter creates individuals.
- **Essence**: Essence pertains to what exists. A squirrel has the essence of a squirrel, a human has human essence.
- **Person**: The person is the one who exists. Animals do not have personhood. Humans and angels do have personhood.

The person is conditioned and individuated. As such, personhood has the following qualities:

- **Incommunicability**: Unlike essence, it is not shared. Although you can relate to someone because of a shared human essence, you cannot experience the I of that person.
- **Uniqueness**: The person is unique.
- **Unrepeatability**: The person exists once. That is why a person cannot be in the same state more than once.
- **Indivisibility**: The person cannot be divided.

- **Distinctiveness**: Even twins who share the same essence and even the same DNA, they are each a distinct person.

Other characteristics then follow, such as:

- Self-knowledge
- Freedom of choice

Essence and Personality The person has characteristics that he is born with and those which he acquires in the course of life. An abstract I without qualities or conditions would not satisfy the qualities mentioned above. In particular, it would neither be unique nor distinct. Hence, we can further refine the understanding of personhood into qualities one is born with and those which one acquires in the course of life:

- **Ontological person**: This is the person as such. It is a gift, what one is born with. It is what makes someone one person but not another. A fortiori, it is transcendent to the various states of being. In particular, it is stable and enduring with respect to the empiriological person.
- **Empiriological person**: This is the ontological person as he manifests himself through his acts, powers, and habits. It has two aspects.
  - **Personality**: The expression of the person through non-moral acts. It is cultivated by the formation of physical, intellectual, and volitional habits.
  - **Character**: The expression of the person through moral acts. Character is formed by the acquisition of moral virtues.

The ontological person is always "one", although it can take on a number of subpersonalities. Usually, a person is unaware when he switches from one subpersonality to another. In extreme cases, they may not even be aware of each other.

In our deranged state, the empiriological person is not in harmony with the ontological person. The person has a destiny to fulfil. When that is misunderstood, the acts of the person will be in conflict with his essence, resulting in imbalance, unhappiness, and other problems.

In general, strong personalities are esteemed more highly than men of character. This is not necessarily bad, since the strong make the world and the weak often mask themselves as men of character. The unbalanced person has limited ability to judge another, so psychopaths are often mistake as strong.

Destiny The person is born incomplete, with unfulfilled possibilities. One's personal task is to actualize those possibilities through the development of personality and character.

Besides traditional sources, the attributes of the person and the definitions of the ontological and empiriological persons are taken from *The Doctrines of Genesis 1-11* by Rev. Victor P Warkulwiz, M.S.S.

Posted on 2020-08-30 by Cologero

* * *

Auld Wat on 2020-08-30 at 18:09 said:

Thank you for the timely post! I've been struggling to find employment recently. It has however given me time to reflect on my character and my personality. Saints who suffered far more than I ever have, Rose of Lima for example, are testimony of the actualisation of their possibilities through prayer, fasting and alms giving. Hopefully my efforts will not go unnoticed.

5.6 Blessed are the Meek

> Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. (Matt. 5:5)

Those lacking in spiritual insight can only understand this beatitude in human terms. They understand meekness as something weak, timid, and passive. In contrast, they praise the earthy man with strong appetite and passionate nature. Both of these points of view reflect an inadequate notion of man. One reflects a Marxist view of an underclass motivated by resentment; the other, a modern neopagan caricature. When the real constitution of man is understood, it takes on a different meaning.

Powers of the soul Plato describes the three aspects or powers of the soul:

- **Intelligent aspect** (*logikos*): this pertains to the intellect, which is the highest faculty in man by which he knows God or the essence of things by direct apprehension
- **Appetitive aspect** (*eros*): the soul's desiring power
- **Incensive aspect** (*thymos*): the force provoking vehement feelings, often anger. Another word for someone dominated by this aspect is "spirited", not to be confused with "Spirit"

In the Chariot Allegory[13], the soul is portrayed as a charioteer (the Intellect) controlling two horses. The white one represents the *thymos* and the black one, the appetitive aspect. The latter is the aspect most susceptible to the influence of the passions and hence is more difficult to control. Even the former can erupt into useless anger.

Nevertheless, both lower aspects, including spiritedness, must be under the control of the intellect in order for the soul to continue its ascent.

[13] See next paragraph.

Vladimir Solovyov, in his *Lectures on Divine Humanity* puts it this way: "One can be considered free from passions only when one has them but has power over them, when one possesses, but is not possessed by them."

In Matthew, the word translated as "meek" is *praos*, which was also used to mean the gentling of a horse. The horse is the most noble of animals, but it must be broken to be of use to the knight[14].

So we see that the meek are those whose souls are under the control and guidance of the Intellect, since the appetitive and incensive aspects of the soul have been broken and put in service to the highest aspect in man. They still retain their driving forces: the appetitive to achieve a goal, and the incensive to provide the emotional energy and motivation to persist. Far from being mousy or timid, the meek are strong willed and inner directed. This is why they shall inherit the earth.

Parable of the Coach This image represents the characteristics of man by a coach. The physical body is represented by the coach itself; the horses represent sensations, feelings and passions; the coachman is the ensemble of the intellectual faculties including reason; the person sitting in the coach is the master. In its normal state, the whole system is in a perfect state of operation: the coachman holds the reins firmly in his hands and drives the horses in the direction indicated by the master.

This, however, is not how things happen in the immense majority of cases. First of all, the master is absent. The coach must go and find him, and must then await his pleasure. All is in a bad state: the axles are not greased and they grate; the wheels are badly fixed; the shaft dangles dangerously; the horses, although of noble race, are dirty and ill-fed; the harness is worn and the reins are not strong. The coachman is asleep: his hands have slipped to his knees and hardly hold the reins, which can fall from them at any moment.

[14] https://gornahoor.net/?p=281

The coach nevertheless continues to move forward, but does so in a way which presages no happiness. Abandoning the road, it is rolling down the slope in such a way that the coach is now pushing the horses, which are unable to hold it back. The coachman, fallen into a deep sleep, is swaying in his seat at risk of falling off. Obviously a sad fate awaits such a coach.

This image provides a highly appropriate analogy for the condition of most men, and it is worth taking as an object of meditation. Salvation may however present itself. Another coachman, this one quite awake, may pass by the same route and observe the coach in its sad situation. If he is not much in a hurry, he may perhaps stop to help the coach that is in distress. He will first help the horses hold back the coach from slipping down the slope. Then he will awaken the sleeping driver and together with him will try to bring the coach back to the road. He will lend fodder and money. He might also give advice on the care of the horses, the address of an inn and a coach repairer, and indicate the proper route to follow.

It will be up to the assisted coachman afterward to profit, by his own efforts, from the help and the information received. It will be incumbent on him from this point on to put all things in order and, open eyed, to follow the path he had abandoned.

He will above all fight against sleep, for if he falls asleep again, and if the coach leaves the road again and again finds itself in the same danger, he cannot hope that chance will smile upon him a second time; that another coachman will pass at that moment and at that place and come to his aid once again.

Boris Mouravieff, *Gnosis*, Book One

Posted on 2010-04-06 by Cologero

* * *

Barb on 2010-04-08 at 04:08 said:

The meek will inherit the earth... but I wonder what happens to those who let the intellect "rule"... without hearing the notes of love... or worse yet... misinterpreting those notes – not hearing the correct melody? Christ talks about those who are meek, -but only those who first seek God – and walk in a relationship with Him will really ever discover and inherit the kingdom of God.

Cologero on 2010-04-09 at 09:32 said:

You are confusing the intellect in this sense — the ancient and traditional sense — with the ordinary mind. The twin horses of desire and passion are unruly. unless put under the control of the intellect. Of course, the intellect is oriented toward the whole, toward God, though it is barely aware, typically. Love is desire and passion made self-conscious.

Roger Buck on 2010-04-17 at 06:46 said:

I hesitate to comment. Poor web access among other probems makes my assimilation of your very interesting site poor for the moment.

But if you are interested in any initial impressions under the heading of HALF FORMED I will offer this.

Reading you leaves me strongly with the Second Arcanum of the Seated Woman. The correction the author of a meditation on that Arcanum gives regarding St Yves Alvedrye (in the DeMaistre stream ...)

A concern the author had in mind I think of prioritising either intellect or power over love, that was so common.

I repeat: I am operating on half formed possibly half baked impressions

Vey, very interesting Charles. You will hear from me privately this weekend ...

Cologero on 2010-04-17 at 12:25 said:

I always appreciate your comments.

I don't believe this post even addressed the question of "love", though the topic is certainly planned.

Jesus said, "if you love me, you will obey my commandments."

There is an awful lot there. Without getting ahead of a planned future post:

1) There must be an intellectual understanding of the good, i.e., the commandments

2) There must be power to obey the commandemts (that is, manifest the Good)

Building on ideas from Solovyov: for the pagan (Plato), it was enough to contemplate the Good, in effect, as object.

The Christian idea is that the Good is also Subject. A subject involves the Will, and Love is to

Will the Good, not just contemplate it. So, yes, Love is also Power. But it is Power conscious of itself, whereas the Will-to-Power in itself is blind and unconscious.

That is what I am getting at in the meaning of "meekness" ... the integral person must not only Know the Good above him, he must have power over what is below him, in order to "obey" that Good that he knows. According to Tomberg, matter is objectified Will, so the issue of Power is always present. The question is whose Will? Is it a conscious Willing of the Good, which is Love? Or something spontaneous, deterministic, and blind?

5.7 The Confusion of Levels

In *The Reign of Quantity*, **Guenon** has a chapter on the consequences of the failure of modern man to distinguish between the psychic and the spiritual without, however, clearly delineating the distinction. Man is a tripartite being, consisting of body, soul, and spirit. Each level has its own proper functions, which mimic the corresponding function of other levels, thus making possible confusion between the levels. Chart **??**chematizes the functions.

Levels	Functions		
	Feeling	**Knowing**	**Willing**
Body (**Hylic**)	Attraction/Aversion	Instinct	Movement
Soul (**Psychic**)	Emotion	Thoughts	Desire
Spirit (**Pneumatic**)	Communion	Intuition	Conscience

In the **True Man**, the psychic level mediates the hylic and pneumatic levels. However, the undeveloped man, common to the modern world, identifies fully with the psychic level (or even worse, the hylic level). He regards his emotions, thoughts, and desires as "his own", unaware of their true source and significance. Since every emotion, thought, and desire engenders its opposite, the psychic man's identity is inconsistent, varying with their changes.

For the pneumatic man, the functions have no opposites. Unlike the psychical emotions which have their negative counterparts, the higher emotions do not. There is a direct contact, or communion with higher states. Intuition provides direct and unmediated understanding (gnosis) of higher reality. Willing is not plagued by doubt, but the pneumatic man has **True Will** and knows what to do. He knows the virtues directly – prudence, courage, justice, temperance — and understands them as power. His conscience does not experience moral failure as guilt against some moral standard, but rather as shame at failing to live up to his own. The development of these functions are forms of Bhakti, Jnana, and Karma Yoga.

The danger comes when ideas appropriate to the pneumatic man are adopted by the psychic man. For example, Rousseau writes:

> What God wills a man to do, he does not tell him through another man; He tells it to him Himself, and writes it in the bottom of his heart.

This opposes a leveling democratism to legitimate hierarchy, which is freely accepted. It engenders disloyalty, since every man is his own highest authority. The symbol of the "Heart", which should represent the spiritual functions, is instead debased into little more than a sentimental meaning.

The number of such examples can be multiplied indefinitely. So, instead, we will generalize how the confusion of levels leads to the three fundamental philosophical deformations in the modern world. They are characterized by being anti-Tradition. Although they are logically inconsistent and incompatible with each other, in practice they unite against Tradition since none of them bases itself on higher principles; thus their opposition to Principle in held in common.

- **Sentimentalism** is the result of confusion of the feeling function

- **Rationalism** is the result of the confusion of the thinking function
- **Moralism** is the result of the confusion of the willing function

Reference: *The Great Triad* by Rene Guenon. The chapters on Body, Mind, Soul and on True Man

Posted on 2010-09-20 by Cologero

* * *

Charles Upton on 2010-09-20 at 00:54 said:
Correct.

Will on 2010-09-20 at 22:06 said:
Rama Coomaraswamy offers some good insight on this matter here: http://www.sacredweb.com/online_articles/sw9_coomaraswamy.html

5.8 Rational Man and Real Man

> Every Real Man has realized all the possibilities of the human condition, but each one has does so in a way which is typical of him alone, and which differentiates him from all other Real Men.
>
> Rene Guenon, letter to Julius Evola

> Even in the West, whenever any distinction has been made between these two terms, the **Personality** has always been regarded as superior to the **individuality** and that is why we say that this is their normal relationship, which there is every reason to retain. Scholastic philosophy has not overlooked this distinction, but it does not seem to have grasped its full metaphysical significance,

> nor to have extracted the most profound consequences which follow from it; this is moreover what often occurs, even on occasions where Scholasticism shows the most remarkable similarity with certain portions of the Oriental doctrines.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Man and his Becoming*

Aristotle famously defined man as the Rational Animal, which can only be distorted by the modern mind, interpreting it in a biological rather than metaphysical sense. Animal is an animated or ensouled being. So man is ensouled with a sensitive soul like other animals. Rational, then, is what distinguishes man from the animals. Furthermore, rational refers to the capacity to understand eternal forms, above and beyond the phenomenal world. Hence, it is a third dimension.

To the modern mind, an animal is a biological being, determined by its DNA and bio-electrochemical processes. A rational animal, then, is merely a type of animal, much as animals can be separated into vertebrates and invertebrates. Rational is restricted to instrumental reason, the ability to solve problems, plan ahead, and so on, all qualities to insure the creature's future survival.

Longevity is the Taoist term for future survival, although in its metaphysical sense, it refers to the perpetuity of individual post-mortem existence. Guenon calls this **Salvation**, the actualization of the individual states, which he distinguishes from **Deliverance**, which transcends all states of the Being. Since the former is the most likely goal for men today, it is necessary to understand what it means to "realize all the possibilities of the human condition."

Everyone has an opinion of what is a Real Man: the Poet, the Athlete, the Hero, the Saint, the King, the Father, the Sage, and so on. But to choose one as the ideal would destroy the distinctiveness of the Individual. Nevertheless, we do know what the ideal man is, namely, a rational animal, insofar as he is individuated. This means, as we have often

pointed out, that the intellectual soul dominates the sensitive soul, then the vegetative soul and the body. Insofar as that does not hold, a man is such only potentially and not actually. That potential comprises all his possibilities for the human state, which must be discovered and made real.

However, that cannot be accomplished within the limits of individual existence, since only the unmoved mover can initiate motion (or change, which is the same). Hence, a real man must know himself as Subject, Person, or Self, not as an object whether in his consciousness or in the world. Since to know is to be, the Real Man will also be a Person, not just another individual in the world.

There is no formula or program for this task, that is why the hero has a thousand faces[15].

Posted on 2012-02-07 by Cologero

5.9 Salvation, Deliverance, Action

> If we take the view that consciousness is not a product of the world, but that the world is a product of consciousness, it becomes obvious that we live in exactly the type of world which we have created and therefore deserved, and that the remedy cannot be an escape from the world, but only a change of mind. Such a change, however, can only take place, if we know the innermost nature of this mind and its power.
>
> Lama Anagarika Govinda, Foundations of Tibetan Mysticism

Rene Guenon has often stressed the distinction between Salvation and Deliverance. The former is an exoteric notion and is thus limited to the

[15] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1492

possibilities of human individuality. A man seeking salvation in the Christian sense would seek to achieve heaven and avoid hell. A Buddhist would aim for a better rebirth in the heavenly realms or as a god and avoid a bad rebirth in hell or as a hungry ghost. But all these states are eternal with respect to the state of manifestation, but not forever. At the end of the cycle the being will pass onto a new state. If he achieved salvation, he will be in a position where he can again work towards deliverance. Otherwise, he may enter a state analogous to a sub-human state.

Deliverance, on the other hand, is not the prolongation of the individual state, but rather the transcendence of all states. It is the attainment of the supreme and unconditioned state. Few are called to this path, and fewer have the stamina to endure. There is a Buddhist saying, "A person who wishes to make real progress must feel a strong sense of urgency, like a person caught in a burning house looking for a way out." As for the means to make progress, Guenon writes:

> Deliverance, together with the faculties and powers which it implies by superaddition (since it encompasses all states), but which must only be considered as accessory and even accidental results and in no wise constituting a final goal in themselves. Deliverance can be obtained by the Yogi with the help of the observances indicated in **Patanjali**'s Yoga Sutras. It can also be favoured by the practice of certain rites, as well as of various particular styles of meditation. It must be understood that all such means are only preparatory and have nothing essential about them.

Guenon points out that a man can acquire true Divine Knowledge even without observing the prescribed rites. The Vedas compare the functions of these rites to a saddle-horse, which helps a man reach his destination more easily and more rapidly, but without which he is able to reach it all the same. Obviously, a sane man gets off his horse when he has arrived at the destination.

The acquisition of higher states still does not constitute realization, because even though they may be higher than human individuality, they are still finite in relation to the Infinite. Nevertheless, they may be helpful, as we see them pursued in Buddhism.

> In Highest Yoga Tantra there are special subtle minds, normally of no help to an individual, which become aids on the path to Buddhahood when they are generated in meditation for the purpose of realizing emptiness.
>
> Jeffrey Hopkins, *Meditations on Emptiness*

Deliverance implies a perfect knowledge of Brahma, beyond Being and beyond all distinction. Deliverance and total and absolute Knowledge are truly but one and the same thing. Moreover, Knowledge, unlike action, carries its own fruit within itself. That is because Knowledge is both the means and the end for deliverance. Action, including rites, is not opposed to ignorance and thus cannot remove it. It may serve as a preparation, usually by quieting the flow of discursive thought either through meditation, or by the attempt to exhaust the mind, as in more extreme practices. Guenon explains:

> Action, no matter of what sort, cannot under any circumstances liberate from action; in other words it can only bear fruit within its own domain, which is that of human individuality. Thus it is not through action that it is possible to transcend individuality.

This is not to say that the consequences of action are restricted to the corporeal, or gross, realm, but also to the subtle realm. Even so, the subtle realm still is part of human individuality. Nevertheless, Lama Anagarika Govinda can still speak of the path of action. He writes:

> Every individual represents a certain position in space and time. Even if his consciousness has become all-embracing, by breaking down all limitations, it retains the character of its position as a particular centre of experience. This explains why each Buddha preserves his particular character. In this sense, individual character is not a karmic bondage. In an Enlightened One, the conflict between law and free will does not exist any more, because in the light of full knowledge, his own will and the laws governing the universe coincide. One's own nature proves to be a modification and conscious embodiment of universal law.
>
> He is no more a slave to law, but its master, because he has understood and realized it so profoundly. Through knowledge we master the law, and by mastering it, it ceases to be necessity, but becomes an instrument of real self-expression and spiritual freedom.

Posted on 2012-02-17 by Cologero

* * *

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-02-17 at 06:11 said:

I like the 'burning house' analogy – I experienced this for many, many years, but I'm not quite sure yet if I escaped or died lol as the effort made me paranoid!!! I guess there has to be SOME time for relaxation….I'm put in mind of VT's comment in (I think) his letter on The Devil, where he says that there must be moments when even 'front line' workers have respite from demonic forces. Either way I think I need a holiday :-)

escapee on 2012-02-18 at 21:45 said:

"But all these states are eternal with respect to the state of manifestation, but not forever. At the end of the cycle the being will pass onto a new state."

Without doubting your understanding of the ideas, I humbly suggest that the above expression be rectified by substitution of 'eternal' with 'perpetual'.

'Eternal' should not be used, even in a relative way, to denote any state that is subject to duration or succession.

Cologero on 2012-02-19 at 01:53 said:

Yes, eternal is the wrong word, but perhaps so is perpetual. Guenon himself writes (in *Man and his Becoming*, as well as in *Initiation and Spiritual Realization*):

> Salvation is properly speaking the attainment of the Brahmaloka … This accords perfectly with the Western conception of immortality which is simply an indefinite prolongation of individual life, transposed into the subtle order and extending to the pralaya.

Brahmaloka refers to translunar states, but not the Supreme Identity (with Brahman). These are subtle states, hence not subject to space, but subject to time.

So, it would seem that the differences between eternal life, perpetual life, and an indefinite prolongation of individual life are not so obvious.

5.10 The Possibility of Liberation

> Past performance is not necessarily indicative of future results. Nevertheless, it is much more reliable than wishful thinking.

In *The Multiple States of Being*, **Rene Guenon** explains Traditional doctrine in Western terms, free of religious symbolism and Sanskrit terms. The universal Whole, or Absolute, can also be considered from the perspective of Possibility; thus it is both One, from the perspective as the Whole, and Infinite, from the perspective of Possibility. This is because no boundary can be set to what is possible (all things are possible with God); the impossible simply does not exist, hence it cannot limit anything.

Possibilities in Experience It is imperative to understand that Guenon is not proposing another philosophical system; rather, he is describing, insofar as it is possible in words, the fundamental nature of ultimate reality. This is the necessary foundation of any such system, or proper view

of the world. As such, a man is not convinced of it by some external evidence, as in science, or by a proof, as in mathematics. Rather, it must be grasped in its immediacy, in direct intuition, as a whole.

If we judge by Guenon's letter to Evola[16], it appears that **Julius Evola** was unclear about what Guenon called "intellectuality", and could only see in Guenon a form of "rationalism". I suspect quite a few readers of this blog are equally unclear. As a pedagogic aid, rather than focusing on the words, try to observe what is described directly. Ideas, or possibilities, arise in the mind. Observe how they arise, such as certain thoughts in similar circumstances. See how one leads to another similar to a meshed chain. Observe if they provoke emotional reactions; if so, that is an indication of bondage. This applies also to ideas that "pump you up"; it is still an addiction.

Observe which thoughts are real possibilities of manifestation, and which are idle fantasies or wishful thinking, that could never manifest in any possible world. Of those few good thoughts, determine which of them will lead directly to action which, after all, means to bring the Potential into Act. With some serious self-reflection, honestly evaluate if you are living up to your true potential or selling yourself short. This is a painstaking process, requiring the courage to face up to the hellish aspects of one's being. When conscious attention is lacking, the mind is taken over by telluric and lower forces of disorder. Through many efforts, a man can bring his mind closer to a state of order. But first he must be perfectly clear, through study and instruction, about what constitutes order and disorder. Guenon refers to the "Christ principle", or Logos, as the force of order.

Essence and Existence Possibilities can be those of non-manifestation or manifestation, and the latter can be Potential or Actual, as shown in this diagram:

[16] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=4519`

- Possibilities of non-manifestation
- Possibilities of manifestation
  - Potential
  - Actual

Guenon relates this to Essence and Existence[17], a topic we have covered many times, including discussions related to Evola's *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*.

Actualized possibilities are made manifest when time and conditions are proper for them, and they are compatible with all other manifested possibilities, since existence is an interconnected system. Potential possibilities are not manifest either because they are incompatible with existence or there is a lack of power to bring them into manifestation. This latter situation is called a privation, since it belongs to the essence of the Being, but not to its existence.

Salvation Now a Being is manifested in an indefinite number of possible states; anyone reading this is most likely a Being in the human state. The totality of a Being will include both potential and actual possibilities. The human state is an individual state and, as such, a man has many possibilities open to him. I am considering here just those possibilities available as a man in the human state. Man actualizes himself in the world, taking into account his time and circumstances. However, as long as he is unable or unwilling to transcend the human state, he will be bound to the ways of the world. Nevertheless, by transmuting, transcending, and overcoming the negative forces in the world that seek limit his possibilities, he can achieve "salvation", freedom within the world and the indefinite prolongation of the possibilities of the human state. This is no small matter.

[17] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=1917`

Deliverance or Liberation Unsatisfied with "salvation", a small number of men will seek instead to deliver themselves from all attachments while in the human state. This involves not just actualizing the possibilities of the human state, but also the possibilities of all states of the Being. Such a being is liberated, or delivered, from all restrictions and privations. In other words, for that being, essence and existence are identical. There can be only one such being, hence the formula Atman is Brahman. In the Western Tradition, that is what is known as "God".

Posted on 2012-07-25 by Cologero

* * *

`Andrew on 2012-07-26 at 23:14 said:`
This should answer the question from a previous post about the difference between salvation and liberation.

`Andrew on 2012-07-26 at 23:15 said:`
I usually put it that salvation is salvation from death. Liberation is liberation from existence.

`Caeliger on 2017-05-06 at 17:01 said:`
May I ask exactly what is intended by "indefinite prolongations of the human state"? If I understand the notion correctly, it would imply that the saved man can, say, enter a world for any arbitrarily indefinite amount of time, become a thousand feet tall, turn his hair pink, and drink from oceans of chocolate milk, because such a thing, indeed any non-absurd state, certainly ought to be possible, even if this particular world with its conditions allows no such thing.

`Cologero on 2017-05-06 at 20:33 said:`
You got that right, Caeliger.

5.11 Metaphysics of Freedom

> Per virtutem et potentiam idem intelligo.
>
> By virtue and power, I mean the same thing.
>
> Spinoza, *Ethics*

The Possibility of Freedom In *The Multiple States of the Being*, **Rene Guenon** discusses the meaning and possibility of freedom. He defines freedom as the "absence of constraint". In nonduality, there is no constraint; this establishes the possibility of freedom. Since it is possible, it can be manifested. When there is a multiplicity of beings, each one is limited by the others, but there is a residue of freedom. He goes on:

> A being will be free to the degree to which it participates in this unity [of Being]. In other words, it will be freer as it has more unity in itself, or as it is more "One".
>
> Absolute freedom belongs to the being who has become absolutely "one" at the degree of pure Being, or "without duality" if his realization surpasses Being. … Then one can speak of a being "who is a law unto himself", because this being is fully identical with his sufficient reason, which is at the same time his principial origin and his final destiny.

"A law unto himself" is not a Nietzschean immoralism; Guenon relates it to Islamic esotericism and to the Hindu doctrines of *swechhachar*i [autocracy, a concept used by **Julius Evola** in the *Individual and the Becoming of the World*] or *jivan-mukti* [enlightened in the body]. In Christian Hermetism, we read

> To be something, to know something, and to be capable of something endows a person with authority. … a person has authority to the extent that he unites within himself the profundity of mysticism, the wisdom of gnosis, and the productive power of magic [power, will]. … whoever has this to a high degree can "lay down the law".
>
> Valentin Tomberg, *Meditations on the Tarot* (Emperor)

Evola differs from Guenon to the extent that the former incorporates Hermetism and Tantra into his system, while the latter restricts himself to the orthodox schools of the Hinduism.

The Possibility of Sin For Kant, freedom is a postulate of the practical reason, without which there can be no concept of morality. The corollary is that a man is moral only to the extent that he is free. Since a man is free to the extent that he is not subjected to constraint or privation, it follows that not every man is capable of moral action. In contrast to the modernist, universalist moral absolutism of Kant, the Traditional understanding is more nuanced.

The Catechism of Pope Pius X[18], lists three necessary conditions for a mortal sin:

1. Grave matter
2. Full advertence
3. Perfect consent of the will

Metaphysically, we can rephrase these conditions.

Logos A grave matter is action that is contrary to the "law of God", that is, the cosmic order or Logos. By disturbing that order, a fundamental injustice is introduced. Evola refers to Anaximander, Parmenides, and Empedocles in this regard.

Knowledge or Gnosis The second condition requires the moral agent to know that the matter is a grave injustice. To be fully effective, this knowledge of the Logos must be of the highest kind: intuition or episteme. Another word for knowledge as it applies to the idea of Justice is "conscience".

[18] `https://www.gornahoor.net/library/CatechismSSPX.pdf`

Will or Power Full consent of the Will means that the agent is capable of performing the act; a man cannot be commanded to do the impossible. The Catechism explains: "Perfect consent of the will is verified in sinning when we deliberately determine to do a thing." That is, the act is free and not compelled by some necessity or external constraint.

True Will Thus we see that the very possibility of moral activity depends on the free will. Hence, the only moral "imperative" is the requirement to be free, without which, no moral activity is even conceivable. The place to start is to overcome weakness and concupiscence which are external constraints to our freedom. As Eckhart writes, a free man acts without desire.

Tomberg relates freedom to conscience.

> Conscience is neither a product nor a function of character. It is above it and it is only here where the domain of freedom is found. One is free … when one judges and acts according to Justice or conscience. But justice is only the beginning of a long path in the development of conscience and therefore of the growth of freedom.

In *Revolt against the Modern World*, Evola describes this knowledge:

> From the gradual extinction of all images and forms, and eventually of one's own thoughts, will, and knowledge, what arises is a transformed and supernatural knowledge that is carried beyond all forms.

This is what Evola means by aristocratic asceticism. He writes:

> **Meister Eckhart** addressed the noble man and the noble soul whose metaphysical dignity is witnessed by the presence of a strength,

> a light, and a fire within him… The principle of spiritual centrality was affirmed: the true Self is God, God is our real center and we are external only to ourselves … an action dictated by desire … must not be undertaken.

Only with God as the center is man "One". He is then said to have a Holy Will or **True Will**.

Posted on 2011-03-23 by Cologero

* * *

Vindar on 2011-06-26 at 10:19 said:
There's a good article On Freedom and Necessity here
http://www.sacredweb.com/online_articles/sw27_editorial.pdf

5.12 The Individual Self

(quoted text from *Indian Philosophy*, Volume 1 by **Radhakrishnan**)

> The Upanisads make out that of finite objects the individual self has the highest reality. It comes nearest to the nature of the absolute, though it is not the absolute itself. There are passages where the finite self is looked upon as a reflection of the universe. The whole world is the process of the finite striving to become infinite, and this tension is found in the individual self. According to the Taittiriya the several elements of the cosmos are found in the nature of the individual. In the Chindogya Upanisad (vi. ii. 3 and 4) fire, water and earth are said to constitute the *jivatman* or the individual soul, together with the principle of the infinite.

Herein lies the difference between tradition and the modern mind. The latter only recognizes the jivatman, or individual soul, and is unaware of the Infinite which transcends it. So instead of "striving to become infinite", it replaces the Infinite by putting its own thoughts in the place of the Infinite.

> Man is the meeting-point of the various stages of reality. Prana corresponds to Vayu, the breath of the body to the wind of the world, manas to akasa, the mind of man to the ether of the universe, the gross body to the physical elements. The human soul has affinities with every grade of existence from top to bottom. There is in it the divine element which we call the beatific consciousness, the ananda state, by which at rare moments it enters into immediate relations with the absolute. The finite self or the embodied soul is the Atman coupled with the senses and mind.

Here, the terms prana, manas, and the gross body correspond to the Western division of Spirit, soul, and body on the microcosmic level. On the macrocosmic, the Vayu, akasa, and the physical elements are the Holy Spirit, the mind of God or Providence, and the material world.

> The different elements are in unstable harmony. "Two birds, akin and friends, cling to the self-same tree[19]. One of them eats the sweet berry, but the other gazes upon him without eating. In the same tree — the world tree — man dwells along with God. With troubles overwhelmed, he faints and grieves at his own helplessness. But when he sees the other, the Lord in whom he delights — ah, what glory is his, his troubles pass away." The natural and the divine have not as yet attained a stable harmony. The being of the individual is a continual becoming, a striving after that which it is not. The infinite in man summons the individual to bring about a unity out of the multiplicity with which he is confronted.

[19] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1383`

In this compact form, we see many themes previously discussed on Gornahoor. For example, the relationship between unity and harmony. There is the disunity in man as he is and lack of harmony of his various parts and thoughts. Man is incomplete; the task of the True Man[20] is to realize all his possibilities. The task of the Transcendent man is to realize his unity with the Infinite. Total freedom is achieved only with liberation.

In the next section, we read of the Greater Battle[21]. This battle is fought, first and foremost of all, within a man's own consciousness and involves his whole being. Victory comes only with transcendence.

> This tension between the finite and the infinite which is present throughout the world-process comes to a head in the human consciousness. In every aspect of his life, intellectual, emotional and moral, this struggle is felt. He can gain admission into the **Kingdom of God**, where the eternal verities of absolute love and absolute freedom dwell only by sinking his individuality and transforming the whole of the finite-ness into infiniteness, humanity into divinity. But as finite and human, he cannot reach the fruition or attain the final achievement. The being in which the struggle is witnessed points beyond itself, and so man has to be surpassed. The finite self is not a self-subsisting reality. Be he so, then God becomes only another independent individual, limited by the finite self. The reality of the self is the infinite; the unreality which is to be got rid of is the finite. The finite individual loses whatever reality he possesses if the indwelling spirit is removed. It is the presence of the infinite that confers dignity on the self of man. The individual self derives its being and draws its sustenance from the universal life. *Sub specie aeternitatis*, the self is perfect. There is a psychological side on which the selves repel each other and exclude one another. From this apparent fact of exclusiveness we should not infer real isolation of selves. The exclusiveness is the

[20] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=319`

[21] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3005`

> appearance of distinction. It ought to be referred to the identity, otherwise it becomes a mere abstraction of our minds. The hypothesis of exclusive selves leaves no room for the ideals of truth, goodness and love. These presuppose that man is not perfect as he is, that there is something higher than the actual self which he has to attain to secure peace of mind.

Only the man engaged in the greater battle is properly speaking a man. Those not so engaged are still living at the animal level. Victory is the recovery of the Primordial State[22].

> Though the individual soul fighting with the lower nature is the highest in the world, it is not the highest realisable. The striving discordant soul of man should attain to the freedom of spirit, the delight of harmony and the joy of the absolute. Only when the God in him realises itself, only when the ideal reaches its fruition is the destiny of man fulfilled. The struggles, the contradictions and the paradoxes of life are the signs of imperfect evolution, while the harmony, the delight and the peace, mark the perfection of the process of evolution. The individual is the battlefield in which the fight occurs. The battle must be over and the pain of contradiction transcended for the ideal to be realised. The tendency to God which begins in completed man will become then a perfect fruition. Man is higher than all other aspects of the universe, and his destiny is realised when he becomes one with the infinite. Nature has life concealed in it, and when life develops, nature's destiny is fulfilled. Life has consciousness concealed in it, and when it liberates consciousness, its end is reached. The destiny of consciousness is fulfilled when intellect becomes manifest. But the truth of the intellect is reached when it is absorbed in the higher intuition, which is neither thought nor will nor feeling, but yet

[22] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1374`

> the goal of thought, the end of will and the perfection of feeling. When the finite self attains the supreme, 'the godhead from which it descended, the end of spiritual life is reached. "When to a man who understands, the self has become all things, what sorrow, what trouble, can there be to him, who has once beheld that unity?"

Posted on 2011-10-27 by Cologero

5.13 Providence, Will, Destiny

In *The Great Triad*, Rene Guenon deals with the relationship between Providence, Will, and Destiny. Here he relies on the work of Fabre d'Olivet, which is based on Pythagoreanism and Chinese metaphysics. This triad is related to the "Great Triad" of Heaven, Man, Earth. D'Olivet writes:

> That universal Man is a power in his own right is a fact acknowledged by the sacred codes of every nation, realised by every man of wisdom and admitted by every true man of learning … The two other powers that he stands between are Destiny and Providence. Beneath him is **Destiny**: 'natured nature'. nature bound by necessity. Above him is **Providence**: 'naturing nature'. nature in its freedom.
>
> He himself is the mediating, efficient **Will**, situated between the two natures so as to sere as the link and means of communication between them and combine two actions, two motions, which otherwise would be incompatible.

The three powers of Providence, Will, and Destiny account for all action. (Since we are focusing on activity on this plane, in the human state, we will bracket out Guenon's comments regarding transcendent states.) The human Will represents the inward and central element which unites the

intellectual, psychic, and instinctive spheres. Since these correspond to spirit, soul and body, Man is the microcosm of the macrocosmic ternary itself (i.e., Providence, Will, Destiny).

In human terms, Man is the mediator between Heaven and Earth. Providence, that is, the Principle or Ideas, do not act directly on Nature, but rather through the intermediary of the Will of Man. Nature, in itself, follows its own laws. So this brings up the question of why, although Earth is the reflection of Heaven, it doesn't appear to be such.

Guenon writes that the Transcendent Man, who is unrecognizable to ordinary man, is the intermediary between Heaven and Earth, Providence and Destiny; that is his action, or influence, incarnates the activity of Heaven. Of course, this influence is actionless (*wei-wu-wei*); the 'one and only man' exercises his role as unmoved mover. He controls everything without intervening in anything. It is difficult not to notice the correspondence between Guenon here and Evola[23]. The one-and-only man, or Transcendent Man is the singular I who controls everything, not through force or compulsion, but rather through the activity of his Will; note that this necessarily includes other "subjectivies" which, in any event, are illusory. Guenon's book would have had the title: "The Transcendent Man and the Becoming of the World.

Although Guenon concedes the existence of the lesser mysteries[24], he writes from the perspective on the greater mysteries which is not always helpful. Hinduism has six orthodox schools, only one of which is the Vedanta. Hence, we are justified in conveying Tradition in terms other than the Vedanta. The great majority of Westerners attracted to Tradition would be of the Kshatriya type, or those on the path of the lesser mysteries. They are not called to the life of an Egyptian peasant; although not immoral, it is certainly not a universal call in the Kantian sense. For those involved in the world, Confucius, and his Western counterparts,

[23] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1783

[24] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1721

are more appropriate than Lao Tzu. Thus we consider it legitimate to refer to "secular philosophers" (as Guenon calls them), Hermetists, and so on.

So Evola did not write Guenon's book, he wrote the *Individual and the Becoming of the World*. As an individual in my current state, I don't experience the World as fully under my control; I experience resistance, or privation. That is what we need to understand. Part of that understanding will be the rejection of false explanations derived from religions, philosophy or science. Instead we see that privation as the area where we need to develop more strength. When we understand that, we will also understand the purpose of those spiritual exercises meant to develop the will. For example, there is the book "Opening the Dragon Gate" about Taoist initiation, or the Fourth Way work.

So to summarize: Man is the intermediary between Heaven and Earth, Providence and Nature; or better, "I" am that intermediary. If this is a task to take seriously — and it can hardly be avoided — it is imperative that I come to understand the Principles (or Ideas, Heaven, Providence) while at the same time developing the power to bring them into manifestation in Nature. We have often emphasized that Tradition is not for the bookish; it requires a change in Being that can only come through efforts. In the Microcosm, "I" am to bring my soul and my body under the dominion of the Will. Then the Macrocosm …

Posted on 2011-02-27 by Cologero

5.14 Providence, Will, Destiny

> For the earnest expectation of the creation waits for the manifestation of the sons of God.
>
> Romans 8:19

> The wise man will rule the stars.
>
> *Hermetic maxim*

> During my whole life I have not succeeded in finding a more lucid formula and a more effective general key for understanding the evolution and history of mankind than that given by **Fabre d'Olivet**.
>
> Valentin Tomberg

> Fabre d'Olivet was the first, in recent time, to sustain the remote Nordic-Arctic, hyperborean origin. For him that thesis however has less the character of a scientific hypothesis than that of the exposition of a traditional teaching, still preserved in tightly closed circles with which he was in contact.
>
> Julius Evola

Rene Guenon mentioned Fabre d'Olivet many times throughout his works and dedicates a chapter on Fabre's teaching on Providence, Will, and Destiny in The Great Triad. Providence is the Will of God, or *natura naturans*, nature naturing, while Destiny is the obscure will of God as *natura naturata*, or nature natured.

In the Philosophical History of the Human Race[25] Fabre follows the Traditional understanding of man as having intellectual, psychic, and instinctive centers or spirit, soul, and body. The will, then, represents the inward and central element which unites and embraces them. That represents the microcosm while Providence, Will, and Destiny represent the macrocosm. Guenon explains that the harmony between Will and providence constitutes the Good while evil is born from their opposition

[25] `https://wwww.gornahoor.net/library/Hermeneutic_interpretation_of_the_origin.pdf`

> Man either perfects himself or becomes depraved according to whether his tendency is to merges into the universal Unity or to distinguish himself from it. Either he allies his will with Providence and follows the path of freedom or he allies his will with destiny and follows the path of necessity. The divine man lives a life primarily of the intellect, which is governed by providential law.

Paradoxically, then, the "divine man" is free because he follows the cosmic law, while the natural man believes he is free while he is under the necessity of Destiny.

Alfred North Whitehead in *Process and Reality* illustrates this triad, if we overlook some errors. At every moment, the "actual occasion" is faced with two forces. The accumulated past is a weight that tends to limit possibilities. On the other side, God is providing a creative option that works to break the weight of the past. The occasion needs to integrate all that. Unfortunately, Whitehead confuses "God" with Providence which leads him to postulate a finite or limited god. Fabre rejects this, since God can never be subject to such conditions:

> The three powers constitute the universal ternary. Nothing escapes their action: all in the universe is subject to them; all except God himself who, enveloping them in His unfathomable unity, forms with them the sacred tetrad of the ancients, that immense quaternary, which is all in all and outside of which there is nothing.

The following schema illustrates these powers. The three centers are driven by instinct, passion, and inspiration. The Will is the heart of man when all his centers are in harmony. That is, for example, when his passions and instincts are ruled by the intellect. And conversely, when the intellect supports the true passions and instincts.

	Will: Determination	**Providence**
	Intellectual: Inspiration	
	Psychic: Passion	
Destiny (psychic)	**Instinctive**: Instinct	
Destiny (physical)	**Physical**: Necessity	

Unfortunately, such as we are, we are not in such harmony. Tomberg relates the triad to the problem of births. Destiny is our heredity, Will is our birth, and Providence is related to salvation. Hence, that is the first task of providence.

Pope John Paul II in the *Theology of the Body* explains that Adam lost what did not belong to human nature in the strict sense: viz., integrity, holiness, innocence, justice. In other words, these are the qualities of Fabre's "divine man". Man is left with his lower intellect or "*ratio*", and therefore a weakened will. The threshold of man's earthly history is crossed with the knowledge of good and evil. Before that, there is only prehistory that is opaque to us.

Boris Mouravieff is in agreement with this. Adam's fall led to the loss of higher human nature, leaving him with just the lower. Specifically, he is subject to the "general law", like the animals, motivated primarily by hunger, sex, and fear. He is left with the "ratio", or lower intellect. He explains that the knowledge of good and evil can only be dualistic knowledge, the knowledge of phenomena, not the transcendental knowledge or gnosis of the higher intellectual center.

This is the Matrix we are caught in, the situation of original sin, as described by **Joseph Ratzinger**. There is interminable debate without resolution, and the constant battle of good and evil, like a point stuck inside a square in Flatland with no way out. However, if the point became aware of a third dimension, he would easily escape his trap.

It is worthwhile, then, to investigate the qualities that have been lost

in the Matrix. For those concerned about tradition, they are all taken from documents and councils over several centuries.

Innocence: In the state of innocence, man does not know good and evil, but rather he knows by direction intuition. His heart is the tranquil witness of consciousness.

Holiness: Holiness is the irradiation of the Holy Spirit, which produces a special state of spiritualization, i.e., participation in God's inner life. If the lower centers are disordered, they will not reflect that irradiation accurately.

Justice: The just man is in conformance with the Logos or covenant law; he judges impartially.

Integrity: Integrity refers to man as a whole. JPII writes that the heart is the center of man understood as the source of will, emotion, thoughts, and affections. Or, if Fabre's system, all the centers are in harmonious relationship. Then there can be the determination of the True Will.

Posted on 2015-05-13 by Cologero

* * *

Wayne Ferguson on 2015-05-14 at 08:39 said:

I had occasion to dig out an old copy of Kierkeggard's "Sickness Unto Death" yesterday and (after reading this last night) just happened to open it up to this text which I had marked when I first read it 23 years ago:

" People do not generally regard being under a delusion as the greatest misfortune; their sensuous nature is generally predominant over their intellectuality. So when a man is supposed to be happy, he imagines that he is happy (whereas viewed in the light of the truth he is unhappy), and in this case he is generally very far from wishing to be torn away from that delusion. On the contrary, he becomes furious, he regards the man who does this as his most spiteful enemy, he considers it an insult, something near to murder, in the sense that one speaks of killing joy. What is the reason of this? The reason is that the sensuous nature and the psycho-sensuous completely dominate him; the reason is that he lives in the sensuous categories agreeable/disagreeable, and says goodbye to truth etc.; the reason is that he is too sensuous to have the courage to venture

to be spirit or to endure it. However vain and conceited men may be, they have nevertheless for the most part a very lowly conception of themselves, that is to say, they have no conception of being spirit, the absolute of all that a man can be – but vain and conceited they are . . . by way of comparison. In case one were to think of a house, consisting of cellar, ground-floor and premier étage, so tenanted, or rather so arranged, that it was planned for a distinction of rank between the dwellers on the several floors; and in case one were to make a comparison between such a house and what it is to be a man – then unfortunately this is the sorry and ludicrous condition of the majority of men, that in their own house they prefer to live in the cellar. The soulish-bodily synthesis in every man is planned with a view to being spirit, such is the building; but the man prefers to dwell in the cellar, that is, in the determinants of sensuousness. And not only does he prefer to dwell in the cellar; no, he loves that to such a degree that he becomes furious if anyone would propose to him to occupy the bel étage which stands empty at his disposition – for in fact he is dwelling in his own house."

http://www.naturalthinker.net/trl/texts/Kierkegaard,Soren/TheSicknessUntoDeath.pdf

A quote from Peter Kingley also comes to mind

"We are human beings, endowed with an incredible dignity; but there's nothing more undignified than forgetting our greatness and clutching at straws" (Dark Places of Wisdom 4).

https://www.peterkingsley.org/cw3/Admin/images/SpiritualTradition.pdf

Iron Man on 2015-05-14 at 11:27 said:

"Man either perfects himself or becomes depraved"

Like when man is given a web site he immediately turns into a mini tyrant controlling his followers' minds and stamping out all dissent. Afraid of every last opinion, he becomes surrounded only with echoes of himself.

"Fabre d'Olivet was the first, in recent time, to sustain the remote Nordic-Arctic, hyperborean origin. For him that thesis however has less the character of a scientific hypothesis than that of the exposition of a traditional teaching, still preserved in tightly closed circles with which he was in contact." Julius Evola

Finally we are revealing that many of Guenon's and Evola's sources are highly suspect, as are a good deal of his theories based on nothing more than the fairytales of occultists.

Cologero on 2015-05-14 at 12:52 said:

Iron Man, you sure are persistent. Blake said that if a fool persists in his folly he may become wise. Unfortunately, I've heard that there have been many exceptions.

This web site is my personal domain and you therefore have the status of a guest. If a gentleman visits a friend, he will accept the hospitality and any fare offered with good grace.

Unfortunately, you are crude, vulgar, and of low breeding, unfamiliar with the protocols of hospitality. Hospitality does not mean "control". Rather is means friends will gather together to share thoughts and ideas. Those who are of a different mind will move on.

I'm afraid that most of us, including readers, are awash in a sea of dissent all day long ... from family, friends, the media, etc. Why would you object that like-minded people get together, since we find so little support for our thoughts in the world?

I'm flattered in an odd way that you think I can control minds. So I will let you in on a little secret. Those who can be controlled barely have a mind to speak of, at least not in the fullness we have described in these pages. And those with actual minds cannot be controlled.

While I'm intrigued that you have spent so much time reading Gornahoor over the years, I'd prefer that you remain silent, at least until you learn both the meaning of hospitality and how to write an intelligent dissent. Specificity is what I'm looking for.

Mark Citadel on 2015-05-17 at 11:57 said:

Excellent and so much needed in an age where too many Christians, including myself up until recently, are unsure of our constituent parts that transcend biology, the difference between soul and spirit. Presumably the lost higher characteristics you outline here will be returned upon the post-apocalyptic resurrection?

@Ironman – What do you find objectionable about D'Olivet? Admittedly I didn't know much about him prior to now (thanks for the heads up on this guy by the way, Cologero), but he doesn't seem to be "highly suspect". Yes, he may have made some mistakes during his pre-Rosetta studies of hieroglyphs which angered many people including the Pope, but that doesn't discredit his work on the pre-Fall nature of man. In fact I'd say he's one of the more thoughtful informants of Guenon and Evola's work.

He even apparently attacked Lord Byron for an anti-Christian play that he felt would undermine the Faith. Byron's response: "I'm only a poet; I don't know anything about these philosophical concerns of yours!"

I digress, in a sane society, such a stupid person wouldn't be allowed to produce a pamphlet, let alone a play.

5.15 Unknowing and True Will

> First and foremost, I will tell you who should work in this work, and when, and by what means: and what discretion you shall have in it. If you ask me who shall work thus, I answer you—all who have forsaken the world in a **true will**.

The Cloud of Unknowing

Going through the Ruins To reconstruct Tradition in the West, we need build on the ruins left behind. Despite a mini revival of Thomism, as useful as that it, it does not go much further than skirmishes in academic debates. Rather, we must take it seriously, so seriously in fact, that it leads to an intellectual conversion. That conversion is a "forsaking" of the modern world for the real world. In other words, it begins with an "unknowing" and ends in the contemplative life which is true will.

Here are some basic notions that cry out for further development:

- the distinction between essence and existence
- the soul life of man
- the intellect as the form of the body
- human nature

Those are recited and then neglected. Now the Summa was intended as a beginner's book so it cannot, as such, contain the whole of the teaching. The logical consequences of each notion must be teased out.

Essence, Existence, and Freedom Every substance is the result of the union between an essence and existence, or, form and matter. What is unclear in that is how an essence becomes a substance. Science, the dominant ideology of today, only needs to deal with substances and their interrelations. The capability to "see" the essence in the thing has been lost. The intellectual conversion will therefore reveal that the world of things is but the reflection of a transcendent, perfect order.

But back to the problem. Kant determined that we cannot know the real world through pure reason since our experience of it is filtered through the categories of the mind. Only practical reason uncovers the

truth about God, freedom, and immortality. This led those who followed, especially Schopenhauer and Fichte, to conclude that it is the Will that is fundamental, since that is what we know directly, "from the inside" as it were. **Julius Evola**, drawing on that line of thought as well as the energy ("Shakti") of the Tantras to make his own contribution: The world, then, is my Will. (from the *Individual and the Becoming of the World*). This is justified on the grounds that

> the concept can account for what constitutes the "essence" of a thing, or the totality of the characteristics that logically define it, but it is impotent to deduce – and even less to produce – its "existence", the naked fact of its "being there" (*dasein*) as a real thing.

In Guenon's terms, the possibilities of manifestation or of non-manifestation are logically the same. Hence, only a Will can bring an essence into manifestation. The extent to which the manifestation does not match the essence is called "privation", the failure to fully manifest. In other words, the amount of "being" a thing has is related to its power and esoterically, power is freedom. (from Gnosis 1, IX, (7))

Essence, Accident, and Human Nature The popular view is that humans share a common nature. That nature, then, is the essence of man and all other qualities are "accidents", i.e., they do not change one's essential nature. In Aristotelean terms, that nature is rational. But is that sufficient? Does it represent the "totality of characteristics" that define a man or woman?

Take, for example, one's sex. In today's belief system, sex is an accidental quality. Given that, same sex marriage and transgenderism make perfectly good sense. The Church, however, tries to hold out against the modern world. For example, a transgendered person can go to the political authorities and have documents such as birth certificates and drivers licenses changed to reflect the new sex. However, baptismal records cannot

be changed. Another example is the commitment to the male priesthood, something that is unjustifiable is sex is an accidental quality.

Hence, one's sex must be part of one's essence, but Thomism as currently understood has no place for that. The same goes for one's race, ethnicity, and so on: are these accidental or essential? Of course, a man is more that an abstract essence, he is also a person, an "I".

Esoteric Evolution The world process takes into account both involution and evolution. Involution is ontologically prior. Beings fall into different states of existence along a chain of being from the higher to the lower. The inverse of this is the apparent evolution from the lower to the higher, which is really the manifestation in time of involution.

In esoterism, we seek regeneration through the reversal of involution through evolution. In our human situation, we are born into a "matrix" that precedes us while keeping us within its bounds. If you recall, **Joseph Ratzinger** put it this way:

> The seat of original sin is to be sought precisely in this collective net [or matrix] that precedes the individual existence as a sort of spiritual datum, not in any biological legacy passed on between otherwise utterly separated individuals.

That is the human-created reality, the justification for Seth's claim that we "create our own reality". Battered by the vast number of conflicting opinions, the first step is an "unknowing" of that false reality. Gradually one develops a "Real I" that is transcendent to the matrix. To the extent we are freed from false opinions, we become a unified and integral being. As we become more conscious of the forces that operate through us, we develop a higher intellect that is open to revelation free from the distortions of the collective net.

The next Thomist principle is that the Will follows the Intellect. Hence, the next stage in esoteric evolution is the True Will. Note that the

Will is beyond even consciousness. From the Intellect's perspective, this is "dark and irrational", but freedom, to be truly free, cannot be determined by anything else, not even by God. For the time being, I'll refer you to *The Teaching about the Ungrund and Freedom*[26], an essay by **Nicolai Berdyaev** on **Jacob Boehme**.

The Subtle Rules the Dense Involution then is the reversal of evolution. First there is the Will, then Consciousness, then the Person or I, and finally manifestation. Now it is obvious that we are not manifesting the True Will exactly since we are born into the collective net. That is original sin and represents a privation of what we truly are or could be.

This is the true understanding of "creating our own reality", as the Will seeks to manifest itself in the various stages. We don't remember doing this, and on the occasions that we get a flash of remembrance, many people assume it to be a proof or "reincarnation". A good exercise is to try to recall how much of our own lives we have chosen or created. At night, go through the events of the day and see how much you may have contributed, even unconsciously and unwittingly, to what happened. Plato describes this in the *Myth of Er*[27].

Amor Fati This is not incompatible with exoteric teaching insofar as it claims that God creates life. Of course, but God created man with a free will which cannot be interfered with. As a man aligns his own will with God's will, the distinction becomes moot.

Posted on 2015-02-27 by Cologero

* * *

[26] `http://www.berdyaev.com/berdiaev/berd_lib/1930_349.html`

[27] `http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Myth_of_Er`

Sparrow on 2015-02-27 at 23:31 said:

While I'm not sure I completely understand the doctrine of essences, it does seem to make more sense than the current Cartesian worldview that seems to predominate in spiritualist circles.

Though I'm not Catholic, I worry that Pope Francis may compromise more and more with the modern world to try and find acceptance for the Church. We may end up seeing transgender "priests" sometime in the future. He is the metaphorical gatekeeper with the keys to the kingdom after all. We'll have to see whether or not he lets the modern world into the Catholic Church.

rhondda9 on 2015-02-28 at 09:50 said:

You have inspired me to dig out my dog-eared and coffee stained copy of Berdyaev's Slavery and Freedom. It was my Bible at university; a place I really did not want to be, but was told I was not a person without a degree by some status seeking relatives. He was my secret guardian against the assaults upon my psyche, although I did not know that at the time.

Scardanelli on 2015-02-28 at 11:35 said:

Sparrow,

Many would reply that the spirit of the modern world has already entered the Catholic church. But again, as Cologero has mentioned a few times, we must not confuse the tradition with it's current representatives.

Speaking of the "transgendered" though… How can we understand the transgendered in light of the above? Would a transgendered person born a man be considered masculine in essence but seeking to be a woman due to an extreme privation or confusion? Or could the opposite be said… This person was born a man due to extreme privation though they are in actuality feminine in essence and thus seek to be a woman? I'm thinking the former is the case, but I'm not sure why necessarily…

I'd be interested to know how Mouravieff's pre-adamic man fits into this concept of spiritual race.

Matt on 2015-02-28 at 17:06 said:

Scardanelli,

I suppose it depends on "where",if that's even a sufficient term in this case, gender resides within the human being. Does it reside within one's bodily corporeality, and therefore fundamentally tied to it, or does it reside within one's soul – one's substantial form (to use Scholastic terminology)? If one accepts the first proposition, then the scenario you mention would be an example of being psychologically broken (that these individuals almost always can't function in their day-to-day life would support that conclusion), and so an interior privation is at issue. But if one accepts the second proposition, then what one would have is maybe something along the

lines of a natural/material privation; there are ontological and metaphysical implications from that that I think are relevant to Tradition – and could be problematic. Would a disembodied soul then also have a gender? What about the pure intelligences (usually referred to as the angelic and the demonic)?

If the first propostion is correct, gender/sex wouldn't necessarily be an accidental quality. If the essence of being human is a rational/intelligent animal, or if one prefers, a rational/intelligent embodied being, one's bodily corporeality could make up part of "what" one is (I didn't put "who" for a reason which I will get to); so if one's bodily corporeality is, say, male, then part of what you are is male. Now there are biological conditions like AIS where one's genetic chromosome structure is male, but it is not manifested phenotypically, and so one would appear female, but that would seem to be a case of natural/material privation.

All of that deals with the issue of the "whatness" (essence) of the human being, but there is obviously the question of the "who"; this is the domain of the person – the "I", or self. In Thomistic ontology, the person is not synomous with the essence, the whatness of the human being; and so questions of gender/sex I guess would not fall under that domain of the person as such, though these questions are obviously relevant to the human state (which we experience) as previously noted.

I don't if that adequately solves the issues mentioned in your comment and the original above post. I could be missing something (I probably am); but maybe it's at least a start.

Feel free to shoot a reply back.

`obscure on 2015-03-01 at 00:27 said:`

I've always understood the essential equality among men to be the very basis for existential inequality; manifested particular essences being individually distinct from one another and yet all measured against the universal essenc necessitates hierarchy. hierarchy, both in terms of the individual existential subjects and their general orders. So, all is accidental from the highest perspective regarding man and his diversity, but this does not negate the obvious subsidiarity of existence.

`obscure on 2015-03-01 at 00:43 said:`

Another note of interest: From the Darwinian/Malthusian perspective (after all, is not Darwinism merely Malthusianism for the organism?) it is the organism which is more particularized and hyper-specialized which is 'well-adapted' whereas from the traditonal perspective it is the man who is most essential and indeed 'generally competent' who is superior; hence the etymological origins of the military rank 'general' or the term 'genius'. to be sure, the founder of a state or a law-maker/jurist is always first and foremost held to be 'generally competent' which is what is most necessary for determining universal laws and ordering species to their ends.

what happens when general competency is utterly eliminated? does classical leadership

disappear? to paraphrase some passage of Nietzsche, 'the race of the future is a race of bridge-builders and mechanics.'

Of course, it is necessary that no such future shall ever reach a pure fruition of its pseudo-principles.

Sparrow on 2015-03-01 at 07:17 said:

Scardanelli;

I have wondered the same, but the impression I got while reading the words of those who are transgender themselves, was that these were very insecure people. I suppose one could argue that this is the result of years of "persecution," but I've always found people who were confident of what they were to not care about the words of others.

So if these people are truly masculine/feminine, why do they become insecure and outraged when not referred to their preferred pronouns?

I honestly don't think the spirit and soul would somehow make a "mistake." you also have people claiming to be "genderfluid," or neither. So working under the assumption that a transgender person has a different essence than their sex, you would have to say that there are people who have changing essences or no essence whatsoever.

It seems more likely these people have somehow become confused or not matured fully, and are thus stuck in a fantasy about being feminine, masculine, "fluid," or none of the above.

ja on 2015-03-01 at 12:31 said:

Boris Mouravieff mentioned transgender people in Gnosis I (chapter 17 or 18, I don't have my hard copy with me but someone can confirm) , he wrote they couldn't obtain the kingdom of heaven until the body sex and mental sex were brought back to alignment.

Cologero on 2015-03-01 at 12:58 said:

Something like that, JA, in Chapter XVIII, section (9). However, the solution, if there be one, is to change one's mentality.

ja on 2015-03-01 at 14:24 said:

On the other hand, Evola following Weinenger considered transsexuals to be truly women in men's bodies (see Metaphysics of Sex), which puts him in accord with modern thinking. Il Barone however saw the trangender phenomenon as proof of the decline of "real masculinity "in the kali yuga. I think he'd have argued that trannies should be left to themselves as a group of outcasts like the Indian hijiras (spelling may be off)

ja on 2015-03-01 at 14:27 said:

Interesting Cologero, because a big issue in modern debate vis à vis glbt is the issue of "conversion therapy ", whether it works or if it's "abuse ", I assume you think it can ? I personally have no idea because I never knew anyone with gay or trans inclination who sought to change themselves.

obscure on 2015-03-01 at 23:58 said:

I've noticed that transgenderism in men is intimately connected to despair. I mean despair in the rigorous sense. For example, there was the Unabomber who was clearly a man without an objective; until later of course. Now, some people believe Ted was motivated by 'sexual frustration'. but the answers were much more blatantly expressed in the man's own words. Consequently, I knew a man who had spent a prolonged period of time steeped in apocalyptic thought-processes of a hopeless sort. This man also turned to sex-reassignment, but realized that he had lost his sense of self and snapped out of it. When men lose the very notion of an objective they emasculate themselves; spiritually and physically.

Most late moderns don't understand this though.

Mark Citadel on 2015-03-04 at 21:08 said:

The nature of this malformation known as 'transgenderism' is largely an irrelevant curiosity. Such individuals, whether victim of genetic circumstance or their own pursuit of self-destructive ends, do not have a place in Traditional society, at least if they are to affirm these desires which are well and truly disordered and especially harmful to immature members of the society and their own actualization of true virility. Those of aberrant psychology who lack the will to bury it under a mound of earth in order to pursue a good life are destined to live outside the city walls, as exiles.

The point being, if we are to posit an 'essence' as such then regardless of whether it fits or does not fit with the body one is gifted with at birth, it remains a duty to act in accordance with Traditional expectations. Hiding this inner aberration is itself may be considered measure of virility.

obscure on 2015-03-04 at 22:28 said:

Mark,

Transgenderism has no essence. There is certainly an active and a passive aspect to all things insofar as they are finite, but there are no metaphysical arguments for sexual perversions and gross mutilations. A man shows his feminine or passive aspect in a virtuous and valid manner through simple compassion. Do not accept arguments for anything more than that regarding what is passive in a man. Even those men who are predominately 'passive' in comparison with other men have appropriate roles to play in a community which do not entail vulgar and strange behaviors.

Always disabuse men of their abstruse and incorrect notions if they alter subtle discourse in such a way as to make it gross. Otherwise, men will prevaricate in such a way as to excuse their vices with gibberish. I would not even attribute any behavior (insofar as behavior is irreducibly dynamic) to that certain micro-structural intension of the body which we signify by the term 'genetic'. If one goes anywhere near that route then the immoral ones will take up all sorts of mechanical notions in order to justify their behaviors as being pre-determined, unilateral motions.

These diverse and serious ways in which men err are illnesses of the soul. Sober discourse has a certain power to cure them though. No one ought to doubt that lest they begin to err as well.

`Mark Citadel on 2015-03-07 at 00:57 said:`

Yes, this analysis seems apt. It is likely possible to cure all aberrations of self-concept and set somebody straight. Something tells me there may be some theological aid to be found here, and perhaps a man may be cleansed through ritual. Men who express sexual perversity are in fact channeling a part of themselves incorrectly, and even the strongest predispositions to such abhorrances are minute compared to the strength of will.

An element of choice always exists. Even the strongest chemical addiction can be overthrown with sheer will. Those who wallow in depravity will spin sob-stories of their lacking control, but rest-assured they are EXACTLY where they want to be. To tackle the problem, they first have to want the problem solved.

5.16 Monkey People and Solar Beings

> I am quite sure now that often, very often, in matters concerning religion and politics a man's reasoning powers are not above the monkey's.
>
> Mark Twain

In explaining the mystery of birth[28], **Julius Evola** makes it perfectly clear that his entire synthesis depends on metaphysical principles and

[28] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3972`

cannot be explained in terms of biological heredity. His terse exposition needs to be expanded with references to **Rene Guenon**'s *Multiple States of Being* and the Hermetic teaching on Providence/Will/Destiny. Since this teaching is included in what he calls the "organic vision of the Germanic-Roman civilization of the Middle Ages", we shall also rely on the spiritual Tradition of that civilization to clarify his points.

Obviously, he is not offering a logical or scientific proof, although the explanation is rational within the assumptions of Tradition. Ultimately, however, the proof lies in "remembering", in bringing into the light of consciousness the awareness of who you are. Those encumbered with a scientific viewpoint have a self-understanding of being the descendent of a monkey; nothing here will convince them otherwise. At best this exposition may awaken dim memories in those who recognize themselves as coming from a higher, transcendent source.

We alluded to this previously in a post on the Theology of the Body[29]. As an heir to the Germanic-Roman religion of the Middle Ages, **John Paul II** wrestles with similar issues. How am I a man or a woman? JP II treats the Genesis account as a "true" myth and tries to "remember" that originary state via a phenomenological analysis. He is then compelled to reject evolutionary accounts in favor of a transcendental source; one's sex is not an arbitrary act of God but is essential to one's nature.

Recall the traditional teachings on the two poles of essence (what you are) and existence (that you are). So we can follow the career, let's say, of "Harry" from his essence to existence. In what sense does Harry preexist, as Evola claims? Obviously, the state of preexistence means "not yet existing". Another way of putting it is that Harry is a "possibility of manifestation", i.e., an idea or essence in the Divine Mind. Priority has several meanings, so Evola correctly notes that Harry does not preexist in the temporal sense of priority, but rather in an ontological sense.

As an essence, Harry has various qualities: e.g., he is a male, of a certain

[29] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8093

spiritual race, with qualities of a specific caste, for example. This is what Evola means by **karma**, or what Harry is bringing into the world that makes him Harry and not someone else. As such, it is part of his essence. So he will be born with compatible preconceptions as we pointed out in Esoteric Stoicism[30]. That is why the awareness of one's own true being is so important.

God, then, that knows Harry's essence before Harry is born. Harry's birth will come at the intersection of two lines. The vertical line is transcendental and outside of time; that is Harry's essence. The horizontal line represents Destiny, i.e., the World Process, which includes the physical and psychical environment into which Harry will be born.

Guenon points out that Harry's manifestation, or birth, must be compossible with other manifested beings. Hence Harry's birth must coincide with the opportune moment in the World Process. Then he will come into existence in a particular place at a particular time. Note that the categories of being[31] come into play: Harry is a substance, with certain qualities, existing in a place and time, with relations to family and community, and so on.

Note that Harry's possibilities of manifestation are not exhausted just at birth. In his life he will have the opportunity, or actually duty, to continue to manifest all his possibilities. This is his **dharma**, or the path he needs to follow, not because it is some outside requirement, but rather because it is his own nature.

So in what sense does Harry will himself into existence, as Evola claims? There is a metaphysical principle that something potential cannot cause something actual. Specifically, Harry's preexistence as a possibility of manifestation is only potential. Hence, pace Evola, he cannot will, or cause, himself into existence.

Evola correctly mentions that the Medieval Germanic-Roman reli-

[30] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8147

[31] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8160

gion teaches that God creates the intellectual soul at conception which then is the form of the body. To create means to bring what was potential into actuality. However, Evola neglects to mention that the intellectual soul is not Harry: the Person, the "I", the Self of Harry is not the soul in Thomist teaching. The Person of Harry is a constant presence above all the psychical events in the soul.

So in what sense can Evola's claim that Harry chose his birth be defended? His claim that the human Self is the production of a preexisting spiritual entity is rather strange. What could that entity be if it is not the Self of Harry? Since Evola rejects reincarnation, that entity must be the one and only transmigrant[32] in **Ananda Coomaraswamy**'s phrase. That can only be God.

In another sense, however, as preexisting in the Divine Mind, Harry's will and God's will are united, since God is simple, without separate parts. Perhaps, then, there is the "Supreme Identity" before birth, so Harry willing of his existence is one with God's willing of his existence.

Excursus on Reincarnation Since karma and dharma are often associated with reincarnation in the popular mind, it is opportune to explain why this doctrine is untraditional. First of all, it is anti-essentialist. Harry is a substance. So who reincarnates after Harry? Well, it cannot be Harry since his time and place of incarnation were already determined by this essential nature. So, it if it is Dick, then Dick is a possibility of manifestation that is not Harry. There is nothing else to incarnate beyond Harry and Dick. Since reincarnationists believe that one can return as a different sex, or in a different state of life, then one no longer has a given nature and a fortiori no particular dharma to follow.

The other error is that karma gets reduced to the accumulation of accidents in life, and is not an aspect of one's essential being. Dharma

[32] https://turiya.vidya.hu/konyvtar/pdf/On%20the%20One%20and%20Only%20Transmigrant.pdf

shifts from the duty to be faithful to law of one's own nature to obeying some external laws or performing rituals in order to avoid accumulating more bad karma or "burn off" earlier karma.

Posted on 2015-07-08 by Cologero

* * *

Sparrow on 2015-11-18 at 17:30 said:

While the criticism of karma was on the nose; the argument against reincarnation seems to contradict previously discussed Traditionalist beliefs. If Harry is a mere substance, how can he pass into post-mortem and future states of being?

If he is capable of this, why can't he be equally capable of choosing to be born on earth again in the same state? Given that Harry (from what I understand) is a spirit which precedes the soul and body, why is it not possible for him to enter the human state again with a new soul and body?

Unless the Dalai Lama and multiple other Eastern figures have been playing us for fools this entire time, reincarnation has more traditional support than the idea of multiple states of being. Nations that believed in reincarnation still required people to adhere to the dharma they are born with, even if they believed a woman had been a man in a past life, or vice versa.

I mean no disrespect, but I find this extremely baffling.

Cologero on 2015-11-18 at 18:11 said:

Here is Evola's full essay on *Karma and Reincarnation*[33].

Harry is one particular state of a "more inclusive" Being. Guenon claims that the Being cannot take on the same state twice (in this case, the human state). So it is the Being that is Harry in one state, but xxx in another. The human state includes spirit/soul/body. The spirit is not wandering about looking for a soul and body like a hermit crab looking for a shell. Rather, it is the form of the soul and body. Harry qua Harry is not "choosing" anything directly, unless he is a realized being.

Coomaraswamy distinguishes transmigration (OK) from reincarnation (not OK), as in the essay "The One and Only Transmigrant".

In *Does Death Exist*[34], Serrano mentions a curious inconsistency about reincarnation.

Your idea of switching sex between incarnations seems baffling.

[33] http://www.gornahoor.net/library/KarmaAndReincarnation.pdf

[34] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=2961

On the other hand, it is not just the Dalai Lama, but Tomberg, too, accepts reincarnation. Since I have no recollection of prior human incarnations, I have no verification of any of it. Without that, the idea means nothing to me.

Sparrow on 2016-02-23 at 21:02 said:

The analogy of the hermit crab, while useful in pointing out the flaws of Cartesian dualism, does not really apply to this case. Given that the spirit is not being presented as something that inhabits the soul or body, but as something that forms them.

The idea that one's sex can change between births is not mine, I am simply recounting what traditions have taught for generations. Evola himself admits that the idea can be found in Plato's works as well as certain doctrines of Islam (Eros and the Mysteries of Love page 150). He did not even mention Jainist tradition, which teaches a woman must be born as a man to attain enlightenment.

But neither do you have recollections of previous states of existence (or else, you and Guenon could describe them). We have actual traditions which support the idea of reincarnation, no proof that the idea of multiple states was ever taught, and Occam's Razor would dictate that reincarnation be the more reputable option.

I have read Serrano's curious observation, and while it is not without its merit, I fail to see how it would disprove reincarnation in favor of Guenon's transmigration, especially in the cases of non-monist traditions such as Buddhism.

5.17 The Person as Subject

Regarding translations from *Introduction to Magic*:

1. **Guido de Giorgio** — Notes on Ascesis and anti-Europe[35]
2. **Julius Evola** — Esoterism and Christian Mysticism[36]

These essays deal with the question of finding a guru and recognizing the marks of an esoteric tradition. Before we do that, I am providing some questions to ponder, in anticipation that some light will be cast on them.

[35] https://gornahoor.net/?p=6397

[36] https://gornahoor.net/?p=6438

The first issue is to grasp the ultimate source of an esoteric, metaphysical, or religious text. In the recent translation of **Julius Evola's**[37] review of **Bhagavan Das** and R. Pavese, he gave us two options: either deduction or transcendental experience.

Now **Giovanni Gentile**, in his brief talk to educators[38], said that philosophers will write a long work attempting to logically prove its main point, which suddenly arises at the end. In reality, he explains, the main point is arrived at first and the logical scaffolding added afterward. That established, it is fair to ask if the source of that idea is a random thought, a genuine insight, or a real spiritual vision. In the last case, the deductive and logical procedure can hint at, but cannot lead, to that same vision. As Evola wrote:

> The Vedas are the expositions of what the rishis have seen; in the rishi, meaning those who have realized themselves up to the level of Brahman, the deductive procedure of their knowledge could have in itself a character of intrinsic evidence and a justification, that cannot appear to those who look at it from the level of finite existence.

This is the task and the hurdle. When reading a text, can we be sure it is the fruit of the self-realization of a spiritual clairvoyant?

Knowing Oneself Since the command to "know thyself" is at the heart of the Western tradition inherited from the Greeks, that is where we shall start. On the one hand, there is the teaching of the person in the Medieval tradition; for this, we will rely on Reality by **Reginald**

[37] https://gornahoor.net/?p=6328

[38] https://www.amazon.com/The-Reform-of-Education-ebook/dp/B005DI65Z8/ref=sr_1_1?s=digital-text&ie=UTF8&qid=1367988340&sr=1-1&keywords=Giovanni+Gentile

Garrigou-Lagrange, O.P., particularly Chapter 58, "Ontological Personality". The method will not be a logical analysis, which in any case is best left to academic philosophers, but rather to determine if it reflects, or could possibly reflect, a personal realization.

This will be compared to the method of **Ramana Maharshi** to recognize the real "I". For this, I will rely on In Days of Great Peace by **Mouni Sadhu** and on the Vivekacudamani by **Shankara**, by way of the commentary of **Swami Dayananda Saraswati**.

Regarding the **Person** in the Thomist sense, which term is used also by Rene Guenon and Julius Evola, Fr. Garrigou-Lagrange tells us:

- Person (human, angelic, or divine) means a subject, a *suppositum* which can say "I", which exists apart, which is *sui juris*.
- Ontological personality is that which constitutes the person as universal subject of all its attributes: essence, existence, accidents, operations.
- The person, or subject, is distinct from its existence, distinct from its nature
- Personality is form. It is real, distinct from nature and from existence. Personality is that by which a person is immediately capable of independent and separate existence.

Hence, in the Medieval understanding, the Person is the pure Subject, the "I". It cannot be an object; it is transcendent to its existence, which can neither determine it nor create it. Not only that, it is prior even to its essence. It cannot be the results of genetics, biochemical processes, or even cultural influences.

The personality is the form. This is compatible with what Evola wrote in the *Esoteric Origins of the Species*[39]. The matter of the person

[39] https://gornahoor.net/?p=6261

is the genetic configuration in which the personality incarnates itself. We would add here that there is also the psychic configuration to take into account. The personality, then, would include the spiritual race and sex of the person that manifests. The measure of his power is the degree to which he is capable of manifesting all his possibilities in a given time and place.

From this exposition, the two obvious questions arise. The first question is whether that is a legitimate deduction from the Thomist teaching of the Person. If so, it would certainly be consistent with other metaphysical teachings.

The second, and more important, question is whether the teaching on the Person comes from a "seeing", i.e., a spiritual realization. The Person as subject, as pure "I", is really the same as Atman in the Eastern teachings. It is the subject not just of its essence and existence, but of all its experiences ("accidents"). This is the ultimate "knowing oneself" and is also the goal of the Vedic teachings. It is actually non-trivial, since the large majority of people understand themselves as objects, not subjects. They believe they are their thoughts, feelings, opinions, likes, dislikes, and so on. Of course, there is nothing constant in that, since thoughts, feelings, etc., vary from day to day, from moment to moment. The Person as subject, however, is transcendent to all that.

That is the certain and necessary deduction from the definition. Was the definition of the Person an intellectual exercise, a logical tour de force, or did Thomas truly understand himself as a Person? If so, that means the Thomist teaching has the marks of a Tradition. Now whether he had to undergo some initiation or special training to reach that point, we can't know. Nevertheless, it is a mistake to presume that people at different times and places have the same interior experience of the Self. For example, the highly educated today believe that the mind or spirit is an illusion, at best the epiphenomenon of electro-biochemical processes. It is difficult for me to imagine how that feels from the inside in order to

take it seriously, but it is a widely held opinion in intellectual circles.

The bottom line is that it is reasonable to presume that Thomas knew and understood himself as the absolute Subject of his experiences and the True Will of his operations. In the next part, we will look at the technique taught by Ramana Maharshi to reach that same self-understanding.

Vichara and Alchemical Marriage. The Technique of Vichara **Mouni Sadhu** made the journey from Theosophy to the Hermetic tradition, although he seems to have found his ultimate resting place in the Vedanta as taught by **Ramana Maharshi**. Interestingly, he and **Valentin Tomberg** had the same Russian Tarot teacher, although not at the same time. This may have some significance later.

In his book describing his experiences in India, Mouni Sadhu devotes one chapter to the specific practice of vichara. Ramana Maharshi is best known for posing the question "Who am I", which his disciples are to meditate on constantly. In attempting to answer it, the disciple sees that he is not his thoughts, not his emotions, not his bodily sensations. Sadhu explains:

> When we try to shut out all the whims and fancies of our restless mind, and to concentrate on the one chosen for a definite purpose, the mind fights desperately in order to resist control. It depends upon our will, who wins this fight. *Find out who is the creator of thoughts and you have achieved the goal*. Such is true realization.

He would repeat the mantra "who am I", eventually reaching several thousand times per day. This conscious control of thought little by little crowds out all those other thoughts that arrive mechanically and then periods of inner quietude become longer. In this way, he comes to realize his true "I", which is obviously transcendent to any of the contents of consciousness. This sounds in some fundamental way like the Way of

the Pilgrim; it would be interesting if it leads to the same understanding of the "I", or even a deeper one. But I don't know of anyone who has tried each technique over two different periods in order to compare.

The vichara practice leads to the source of life and even eternal life, which is understood as *uninterrupted consciousness*. This is the immortality of the spirit. So the true "I" or Self (or Person) is consciousness, since that is unchanging despite the never ending flow of thoughts, visions, emotions, likes, sensations, etc., that the consciousness experiences. This can be understood in the various cycles. First there is the breath. After each exhalation, there is no guarantee you will take another breath. Try to maintain consciousness through the entire inhalation and exhalation. This must be why the prayer of the heart is synced with the breath. The next such cycles is wakefulness and sleep. It is more difficult to maintain the continuity of consciousness through the period of sleep. The first step is to learn to be conscious while in the dreaming state, and obviously I mean a detached awareness that one is dreaming.

Analogously, consciousness can be maintained after life ends, which we have tried to document in the review of the Tibetan Book of the Dead and **Fr. Seraphim Rose**'s *The Soul after Death*. As was seen, that period immediately after death can be shocking, terrifying, and a severe test. Provided one has learned to recognize who he really is, this transition will be experienced in a better way.

Mouni Sadhu recommends meditating on this and "the truth will be made clear even to the outer mind." The danger of misunderstanding is that the technique described seems too mechanical. The reality is that an inner transformation is always required; the vichara may create the space, i.e., a mind free from random thoughts, in which that realization can occur. However, it cannot by itself "create" such a realization. In the west, such a realization, which is also immortality, is tied in to certain moral virtues. Mouni Sadhu, like **Guido de Giorgio**, is a "vedantized" Catholic (or perhaps vice versa), so he ties this understanding to his own

background:

> Such are the heavens promised to the righteous and the saint, as told to us by Christ. For them there is no death any more. How clear now are the words of the great teacher of humanity!

So we see that Mouni Sadhu is relating salvation to self-realization. But I don't know that salvation in the western sense is the realization that one is a Person, i.e., a transcendental I. This may be part of it, but the post about St. Gregory and the Soul[40] asks for more. We will end with a few thoughts about this.

First I want to point out a teaching by Ramana Maharshi on reincarnation that is quite similar to Valentin Tomberg. In Mouni Sadhu's words: "Ramana Maharshi denies reincarnation in the realm of spirit, but otherwise speaks about it as an established fact". Tomberg wrote that reincarnation is a fact, but not a necessary principle. But this is a separate discussion.

There is another point to ponder although the two options proposed will not be convincing to everyone. From the western perspective, the effectiveness of the eastern techniques is not denied, but it is relegated to a lesser level as merely "natural". Of course it is not natural in the contemporary understanding of the term, but is it natural in the sense that there is no need for "grace" or "sacraments", nor even a moral conversion. Anyone who is willing to follow the exercise of asking "who am I", may reach the state of Samadhi.

The other perspective is expounded by **Paul Sedir**, the French Hermetist who was greatly admired by Mouni Sadhu and also by Valentin Tomberg. Like **Thomas Aquinas**, Sedir seems to have undergone an intellectual or spiritual conversion, after which he gave up all his interest in initiatic societies. In the meditation on the Fool, Tomberg provides

[40] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=6081`

an extensive quote from Sedir. Sedir clearly has a deep understanding of metaphysics and the supra-individual states. He describes metaphysical realization as identification through knowledge. He describes the successive stages:

1. The unlimited development of all possibilities contained virtually in the individual

2. Going beyond the world of forms to a degree of universality which is that of pure Being

3. The final aim is the absolutely unconditioned state, free from all limitation. The liberated being is then truly in possession of the fullness of his possibilities. This is union with the supreme Principle.

Clearly, this must have been quite influential on the young **Rene Guenon**, since it could have come from his own pen. Sadhu and Maharshi recognize step 3, specifically, union of Atman with Brahman. Guenon criticizes Christian understanding as not moving past step 2, the union with Being.

However, the fact that Tomberg knows this, and even includes it as the conclusion of his meditations, shows that Guenon is mistaken. The point is not that Christian Hermetic meditation stops as step 2, but rather that is aim is greater, or at least, different. Actually, it aims for a step 4. Sedir writes:

> True metaphysics cannot be determined in time: it is eternal. It is an order of knowledge reserved for an elite ... and then, all existing manifestations of the Absolute are not there for the sake of being ignored; to abandon them because they encumber us, as the yogi or the arhat does, is neither noble nor Christian.

If you recall the post on the soul, one of the aims of salvation is that "It exteriorizes itself in a life of virtue and beauty," while the yogi is no longer interested in his own exteriorizations or possibilities of manifestation. The essential difference is in Ramana Maharshi's teaching on the **I-I**, as opposed to the **I-Thou** of the West. Hermetic enlightenment, hence, is ultimately the alchemical marriage of the duality, not the I-I relationship of the Self with Brahman as in the Vedanta.

Crest Jewel

> Once you know exactly what you want, there is no choice.
>
> Swami Dayananda Saraswati

Clarification I need to clarify an earlier post in which I quoted **Paul Sedir**. I remarked how similar the thoughts were to Rene Guenon's. In checking the original source, I see that Sedir was in fact referring to Guenon's position, not his own. Now both Sedir and **Rene Guenon** used to move in the same Martinist circles, but abandoned that path – Sedir for Christian mysticism and Guenon for the Sufi version. Curiously, Sedir regarded his path as the one of action, in opposition to Guenon's path of contemplation, very much as did Julius Evola. But this will have to wait until after Evola's complete essay is made available.

Guenon said the same of Sedir that he did of Evola: viz., they simply did not understand. For Guenon, the traditions are ultimately the same, hence Christian esoterism could be no different from the Vedanta. So this is the third installment on the "I", this time from the point of view of Shankara, the foremost spokesman for the Vedanta.

Vivekacudamani The Vivekacudamani, or *Crest Jewel of Discrimination*, attributed to **Shankara**, is a collection of cryptic verses. Here I am relying on the commentary of Swami Dayananda Saraswati, who has a

presence in the West, including a study group in South Florida. This particular teaching is very much knowledge based, i.e., as opposed to some special experience, e.g., of enlightenment.

Yet this is not knowledge in the scientific sense, or knowledge of particular things. Rather it is knowledge of the Self. The Self is never an object, words cannot point to it, eyes or the mind are not necessary to know it. An object is self-revealing, i.e., it makes itself known through the senses. The self, however, is known because it is self-evident. An object may come and go; the self is always present, eternal, self-existent. Because man is born ignorant, he does not know his true Self.

So what are the conditions required to overcome ignorance? They are three:

1. The status of a human being
2. The disposition of one who longs for freedom
3. Being under the tutelage of a teacher

Knowledge is possible to man since he has free will. Even then, it is rare to desire liberation; most men desire security and pleasure. Therefore, heaven is more suitable to them, since there are no obstructions such as exist in the corporeal human state. Yet the disposition is insufficient without the proper guidance and true teachings. These conditions, says Shankara, are due to the Grace of the Lord.

The desire for liberation requires a conversion, specifically a "cognitive change", or an "intellectual conversion" as Guenon puts it. Simply put, it is a matter of obtaining the right knowledge. The teacher keeps the student on track, discouraging useless pursuits and idle curiosity. Gradually, the student seeks nothing but liberation, and that in the form of knowledge of oneself. Only then can one pursue the inquiry, such as that described by **Mouni Sadhu**.

There is the problem of recognizing a teacher: "to find out a teacher is to find exactly the teaching. ... it is known by whether that person makes you see that you are free." First of all, the teacher needs to know the teachings; that is at least objectively verifiable. Ultimately it depends on the grace of Ishwara (personal God), which Dayananda says must be earned.

So that leads to the next verse. To earn grace requires manly qualities and mastery of the Vedas. The ranks are thinning out. Dayananda includes courage, sacrifice, and renunciation among those qualities. Here he makes the odd claim that women, too, can have these "manly" qualities. Thus, in practice, he does allow women to lead his study groups. I have my opinion on that and you can have yours.

Freedom is always freedom from what you consider bondage, or better said, from what bothers you. Death and pain bother you, so they keep you in bondage. A lack of self-confidence bothers you, as does any feeling that separates a person from everything else; the sense of separation is a delusion. There are two ways of living:

- The life of activity, seeking to fulfill desires
- The life of renunciation, seeking to become free from the hold of desires

The human being is endowed with intellect, or Buddhi, whose purpose is to understand the goal of life. Every adult should know that from analyzing the experiences of life, otherwise he is wasting his human birth. In a traditional society, there are many examples of renunciates; this keeps the ideal always in view. In the modern world, there are few examples and, when they are noticed, are held up for ridicule. On the contrary, desires are inflamed leading to useless lives of frenetic activity. Even the call to liberation itself becomes just one more desire alongside a nice car, a loyal dog, and a fat 401K.

Shankara proposes some activities: study the scriptures, engage in altruistic activities, participate in rites, and worship the gods. Ultimately, however, what is necessary is the knowledge of the oneness of the self. The Atma is self-evident, but that it is Brahman is not known. The knower himself must dissolve in the wake of the knowledge of Brahman.

Conclusion This is just the beginning, but a beginning that can only start with an intellectual conversion. There is much to do: develop virile qualities, study scriptures and other texts, develop a longing for liberation, understand your bondages, and so on. Make the decision between the two ways of living. The first is full of choices, the second leaves a man with no choice.

But back to the main point. Is there a comparable teaching in the West? The notion of the Person is clearly equivalent to the atma, i.e., the subject that is never an object. The remaining steps are just as clear: study the Scriptures and the writings of Saints and Doctors. Make salvation your goal, not worldly pursuits. Worship God, practice the works of mercy, and so on.

The final deliverance would then be this: the Person is God. The Western Tradition may not put it that way, but it comes close. This is a topic that will arise later. Nevertheless, Giovanni Gentile, working with just the precepts of the entire range of Western philosophy recognizes that ultimately Spirit is one. Hence the Spirit must be the Absolute. This is all a good start.

Posted on 2013-05-08 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2013-05-09 at 22:17 said:

"The Self beyond the Self" in Tomberg's phrase: this clarifies that immensely. I wondered the other day if the Gnostics "got" the other side of Being, arguing that the Creator was "manifestation"

and therefore, unreal next to source of Being. Of course, since their doctrine was schizophrenic, they couldn't do much more with it than the Christians who didn't understand God as "ground of Being" (supra-personal)?

Avery Morrow on 2013-05-10 at 04:22 said:

As always, thank you for the insight. I have recently been wrestling with an esoteric text which claims, in its final line, that "crossing borders manifests God". I was shocked by this statement and tried to re-translate it many times, but these stages seem to acknowledge it.

I thought a key aspect of Guénon's criticism of Christianity was that initiations somehow degraded into exoteric ceremonies, and because initiations are given away so freely, Christianity gets confused about who the "elite" are in the first place. I do like this I-Thou and "exteriorization" idea, though.

Synodius on 2013-05-10 at 16:13 said:

Do you think the resulting states are different or is it just their expression that differs because of previous formation?

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-10 at 16:32 said:

Cologero has shown that Christian initiation and esoterism does exist – not only in the past but also today – and has pointed us to writers such as Tomberg and Mouni Sadhu who can help us in our searching.

What I would like to ask is – did the Roman papacy ever possess the esoteric knowledge and if it did -which I think so – why and how did it lose it at some point ? I think there is a need to investigate the history of the Catholic Church to uncover why events have come to the point they have.

Mihai on 2013-05-10 at 17:56 said:

There is a difference between Christian esoterism and esoterism within a Christian setting. Christian Hermetism partakes to the latter, so does chivalric initiation around the Grail legend- both are foreign doctrines applied to a Christian context, the first egyptian(or egypto-hellenic), the other Nordic- which is why they have always been considered, by the clergy, as something heterodox.

Whether a genuine Christian esoterism (although there is no real demarcation line between exoterism and esoterism in Christianity) existed in the West- as does the Hesychast discipline in the East- is something very probable. It was probably lost when the West turned hopelessly rationalistic, reducing knowledge to dialectics. Certainly, around the time of the confrontation between St Gregory Palamas and Varlaam, such things were considered madness or laughable in the West, as Varlaam's (who was raised with the scolastic teachings) reactions show.

PS: Regarding Tomberg, about whom there is much talk here, though I haven't read him, I did encounter some fragments and pages from his "Meditations...". Looking also to the influences he cites, he strikes me as rather syncretistic and doubtful. The only thing that made me suspend my judgement on him was the fact that his book contained an afterword from Hans Urs von Balthasar- a 'mainstream' Catholic theologian. I really don't know if he is so trustworthy.

Synodius on 2013-05-10 at 20:15 said:

Mainstream Catholic theologians nowadays tolerate almost anything, the link below is just an illustration from a traditional catholic site: http://www.traditioninaction.org/RevolutionPhotos/A202rcMassageNun.htm

Wondering if those nuns sitting in their zendo even heard about the Hesychast...

Mentioning Hesychast, It would be really nice to see more posts about it here.

I've read a few chapters from Tomberg's Meditations and it seems to be written maybe more for theosophists than for catholics, but still very inspiring. Maybe the gap between Hermetism and Catholicism is still too wide and so the main importance of Tomberg is that he even tried to join these perspectives.

Avery Morrow on 2013-05-11 at 03:41 said:

I expect that further insight can be gained into this topic from the book *Guenonian Esoterism And Christian Mystery* by J. Borella, but I haven't yet had the opportunity to read it.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-11 at 13:02 said:

With Tomberg the point to remember is that he wrote to an audience of occultists – thus he uses the writings of men respected by his audience to prove his point.

According to an interview I've read with his publisher, Tomberg was initiated by Rudolf Steiner and given the task by the Master to bring Anthroposophy and Catholicism together.

I have read Borella's book and it is essential – it is based mainly on the works of St Dionysius and shows how the Catholic life can be perceived in a higher and inner dimension. For him esoterism is not a secret knowledge but the exoteric knowledge perceived with a different sense. Schuon believed the same.

Dugin believes that the West cut its ties with the Tradition when the Papacy (according to his understanding of things) cut ties with the East in 1054 – and earlier under Charlemagne – but I do not want to think that in order to be a man of Tradition I have to abandon my Church and my Culture and become an oriental.

Chris on 2013-05-11 at 15:13 said:

Is it possible that some of the gnostic sects of late antiquity were not actually heretical dualists, but were simply distinguishing between the qualified and the unqualified absolute in

the Guenon-Schuonian sense.

Caleb Cooper on 2013-05-11 at 21:58 said:

Mihai, some indicators of where Tomberg stands; in 'Lazarus, Come Forth!' he has nothing nice to say about Vatican II and plenty to deplore; in his meditation on the Emperor card he says that Europe is suffering from the absence of the Emperor (putting him to the right of every ethnic nationalist); and he was driven out of the Theospohical society because of his adamant Christianity. They rightly saw that Tomberg's aim was to bring all under Christ; as he quotes with the highest reverence in MOT "Heart of Jesus, King and center of all hearts" (Litany of the Sacred Heart).

The last 2 popes seem to have approved; Blessed John Paul II had a copy prominently on his personal desk[41] and Pope Benedict XVI approved the Russian edition when he was a cardinal.

You could say that MOT was Tomberg's attempt to baptize Hermeticism. I don't think anyone could read it with an open heart and NOT come away with a deepened commitment and appreciation for Christ and the Church.

The mages that he quotes tend to be those who practiced personal and ceremonial magic in their youth, but eventually through seeing the miracles done by simple genuine Christian like Jacob Boheme, renounced all personal and ceremonial magic and embraced the Church. For example, here Tomberg quotes in MOT from Eliphas Levi's last work:

"The ancient rites have lost their effectiveness since Christianity appeared in the world. The Christian and Catholic religion, in fact, is the legitimate daughter of Jesus, King of the Mages. A simple scapular worn by a truly Christian person is a more invincible talisman than the ring and pentacle of Solomon. The Mass is the most prodigious of evocations. Necromancers evoke the dead, the sorcerer evokes the devil and he shakes, but the Catholic priest does not tremble in evoking the living God. Catholics alone have priests because they alone have the altar and the offering, i.e the whole of religion. To practice high Magic is to compete with the Catholic priesthood; it is to be a dissident priest. Rome is the great Thebes of the new initiation... "

A number of quotes are used to illustrate negative principles, such as in the Death, Devil, and Tower of Babel card. A repeated theme is that personal and ceremonial magic are real, but illegitimate and powered by the serpent, man's ancient enemy, whom Tomberg shows again and again at work in the forces of modernity. The only legitimate magic is theurgy, sacred magic which comes from above.

Many of the quotes are also used to bring the fullness of Christianity out by comparing it to other faiths, then showing the larger scope and nobility of Christianity. On Buddhism Tomberg says "The Buddha saw the true nature of the world and that it was sick. Considering it incurable

[41] http://theosophist.wordpress.com/2008/04/24/pope-john-paul-ii-meditating-on-the-tarot

he instituted an effective path to escape it. Christ saw the same truth, but believed that the world could be cured and instituted the path to heal the fallen world from the inside."

Because of the book I gave up a lot of dangerous spiritual practices that probably would have killed me, joined the Church, and committed myself to prudently growing in the Tradition of Christ. I've heard of others who've come from New Age backgrounds and ended up as Traditionalist Catholics. As I said above, it's hard to imagine Tomberg not planting the seeds that lead to a growing conservative and traditional temperament in his readers.

Caleb Cooper on 2013-05-11 at 22:34 said:

Jason, there's was some pretty bad rot in Rome even before the split. For example, they let a Prince put his 18 year old son on St. Peter's Chair as *Pople John XII*[42] in 955. He was about as big a disgrace as could be imagined, and appeared to meet his end at the hands of an outraged husband who caught him having an adulterous encounter with his wife.

The Church should have a head. I'd argue though that it should have been the Patriarch of Constantinople, and I'm Catholic. Rome's Imperium was spiritually derived from Troy, and Constantine, at the time Christianity become the faith of the empire, re-transferred the Empire's capital to it's spiritual birth place. That the Papacy committed the fraud of the Donation of Constantine shows that they were aware of their shaky Imperial legitimacy. In the east they called their city New Rome, signifying that old Rome was no longer the center. Popes like John XII make me think that old Rome may very well have already been corrupt and that Roman legitimacy lay in Byzantium.

Cologero on 2013-05-12 at 11:44 said:

It is necessary to clear up a question of fact. Tomberg never met Rudolf Steiner in person. Allegedly – and Tomberg himself never claimed this in writing – Steiner appeared to him from the spirit world with that request. If that is true, then Tomberg is a fraud since he is quite clear about his sources and goals, viz., to develop the Hermetic tradition. Anthroposophy regards Catholicism as a past stage then had to be overcome by its new spiritual teaching. Tomberg's conversion was an affront to the very foundation of anthroposophy; at best, it can only be considered a minor stream in the larger Hermetic current.

Logres on 2013-05-13 at 10:05 said:

It is possible that some were trying to do this, but whether or not they succeeded, it would have been just as difficult for them to do this as it was for the "new Western Church" to uphold a purely exoteric doctrine over against them. That is, the split affects both sides, and distorts them – Gnosticism is no longer "Gnosticism" when it is separated from rite and exoteric dogma,

[42] http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pope_John_XII

which it had to be (almost) to survive. But you are right, that may have been the intent and the deed of some sects.

`francismercuri on 2013-05-13 at 19:36 said:`

A number of observations came to mind after reading this post–they were a little excessive for the "comments", and so became a post of their own:

`http://theonethingnecessary.wordpress.com/2013/05/13/the-supreme-identity-and-the-ressurection/`

`Jason-Adam on 2013-05-14 at 13:54 said:`

I am not well versed in Rudolf Steiner but having seen some good posts on him at Gornahoor I plan on reading up on his ideas. I keep an open mind about him for now, obviously I am with Guenon and Evola and oppose progress but if Evola liked Steiner I feel he is worthwhile enough to at least read his books.

People like to diss the Papacy but there is no getting around that if you believe in Jesus, you must follow the Rock he ordained to lead his Church – the infallible seat of Peter in Rome. There is no Catholic church where there is no obedience to Peter. The schismatic easterners are just sectarian Photian national churches no different from the Anglicans or the Lutherans. Read De Maistre's The Pope and Soloviev's Russia and the Universal Church if you haven't already... ... ..

`Jason-Adam on 2013-05-15 at 15:21 said:`

Interestingly, my own turn to Catholicism was based in part on my seeing it as a pathway of action – the way of the crusading knight – and also a means of empowering myself through the fact that I can remain myself while being united with God and not just absorbed into nothingness as the Indians teach.

`Mihai on 2013-05-16 at 03:59 said:`

There is a sort of a contradiction in Guenon's thought: he says that all traditions say the same thing, but somehow the Vedanta (in the light of Shankara's teaching) is taken to be the standard by which the adequacy of other traditions is measured. Doesn't this imply a supremacy of the Vedanta over all the others, which would make them an incomplete exposition of truth ?

If Christian doctrine differs, it is considered to be the result of an exoteric and incomplete understanding. Why couldn't it be the other way around ? As far as I can tell, this is just a result of Guenon's personal preference or mental constitution. In this case, I agree with Robert Bolton and Philip Sherrard, that to force all spiritual expression into Vedantic non-dualism is to use a procroustean bed.

PS: I would be interested to read Sedir's version regarding his path. Any sources?

Avery Morrow on 2013-05-16 at 06:57 said:

I have a wholly orthodox friend who likes Guenon but calls him a "Vedantic writer". But that doesn't mean he is contradictory. Guenon does not see esoteric unity and Vedantic metaphysics as contradicting each other. His principle is that referencing different traditional forms is like speaking multiple languages, and Sanskrit (which has apparently fleshed out metaphysics the fullest) will be able to fill in where the French language lacks important concepts. Here, he reaches to Vedanta because the Western tradition does not have much to say about the reality of the multitude of traditional forms. If the reader objects to that use of Vedanta, the reader will object to borrowing from other traditions in the first place and will refuse to believe anything in the book, which is why Guenon insists that the role of metaphysics is to make explicit preexisting principles that the reader already believes.

On the matter of diversity: G.K. Chesterton has a funny essay where he accuses the Greeks of forcing a single model of beauty on us, whereas in his opinion, all people should excel at being the best exemplars of their type and should not force themselves into other types. This is actually pretty close to Guenon, Schuon, and Evola. I don't get how that relativism squares with objective good and evil (Schuon's explanation appears incoherent to me), but I expect I will learn a lot about it when I study Vedanta this winter.

Cologero on 2013-05-16 at 07:41 said:

Sedir's primary book is *Initiations*[43].

Sedir discusses Guenon explicitly in *History and Doctrine of the Rose Croix*[44]. Guenon claimed that Sedir misunderstood him; you can judge for yourself.

Mihai, it cuts the other way, also. Specifically, it is unnecessary to turn to alien religions such as the Vedanta since everything necessary is already close at hand. Those who cannot recognize the truth here, will certainly not recognize it elsewhere. It has been one of the goals of Gornahoor to make that explicit. I see there is some ways to go to accomplish it and time is running out.

Cologero on 2013-05-16 at 08:54 said:

Mihai, this lecture by David Bentley Hart (Orthodox theologian) may also be of interest to you: *Being, Consciousness, Bliss*[45]. Compare it to a comparable lecture by a yogi on *satchidananda* (which means the same thing) and then decide which path is superior.

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[43] http://www.gornahoor.net/library/Initiations-2.pdf

[44] http://www.gornahoor.net/library/Sedir-History_and_Doctrine_of_the_Rose-Croix.pdf

[45] http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uPwnE_DNgBw

Santiago on 2013-05-16 at 11:22 said:

It is questionable whether the Indians aimed at being "absorbed into nothingness".

An alternative reading of Vedanta may be offered, reiterating that the "traditions are ultimately the same", in the context of the Vedas and the West (which I hope is relevant to the title post).

Consider the Rig Veda. While it may appear to include divergent accounts of death and creation, the following is of interest:

Rig Veda (9:113.10): "where the zenith of the sun is found, where food of the spirits and satisfaction is found, there make me immortal".

Rig Veda (10:14.7-8): "Go forth on those ancient paths our ancient fathers passed beyond... Unite with the fathers, with Yama, with the rewards... in the highest heaven. Leaving behind all imperfections, go back home again; merge with a glorious body".

These instances (the second being a funeral hymn) suggest the Vedic understanding of immortality includes a "glorious body" in "the highest heaven", conceived of as a home-coming, as opposed to disincarnate dissolution. These elements all appear consonant with the Christian faith (especially if one adds the centrality of ingesting Soma in attaining immortality – potentially Eucharistic).

Also:

Bhagavad Gita (2:12): "... we all have been for all time: I, and thou, and those kings of men. And we all shall be for all time, we all for ever and ever."

This may, again, contradict the claim that one is to dissipate into nothingness.

In this light, Vedic references to the loss of egoic separateness may be read as corresponding to St. Paul's "I no longer live, but Christ lives in me" (Galatians 2:20).

Mihai on 2013-05-17 at 03:34 said:

I am perfectly aware of Guenon's thesis, but I am pointing out that he uses the Vedanta as a Universal language to which all "dialects" (which in his view would be theistic religions) must lead. That is the Abrahamic faiths, for example, despite their "dialects", actually speak Vedanta, the latter remaining a pure language, unhindered by such 'dialects'. And if the representatives of a tradition do not speak Vedanta, but insist on the irreducibility of their language, then he claims it is because of ignorance.

I, for one, believe that not every spiritual expression is reducible to the Vedanta.

Anyway, this can be a long discussion and it is not my aim to lead to such. I just wanted to point out an inconsistency in Guenon's scheme and that despite his brilliancy and my great appreciation for him, his word should not be considered as final, a phenomenon which I have witnessed in some places.

Mihai on 2013-05-17 at 03:34 said:

Thank you for those links

`Jason-Adam on 2013-05-17 at 16:48 said:`

Santiago – your post only strengthens the case for Catholicism – if Vedanta is truly the same teaching then why look far away for something that is nearby ?

`Santiago on 2013-05-17 at 18:13 said:`

I agree.

My concern lay with choosing Christianity as a result of misapprehending other traditions. In contrast, choosing It because It is one's own, with all the truth of those other traditions (perhaps expressed more intelligibly), is a beautiful thing. The difference between loving a woman because one imagines all others to be bald, and loving her for her.

On a related point, I don't question that some traditions may be closer to the Truth than others.

5.18 Genius and the Real Man

> A human being should be able to change a diaper, plan an invasion, butcher a hog, con a ship, design a building, write a sonnet, balance accounts, build a wall, set a bone, comfort the dying, take orders, give orders, cooperate, act alone, solve equations, analyze a new problem, pitch manure, program a computer, cook a tasty meal, fight efficiently, die gallantly. Specialization is for insects.
>
> Robert Heinlein

> Do I contradict myself?
>
> Very well then I contradict myself,
>
> I am large, I contain multitudes.
>
> Walt Whitman, *Song of Myself*

> All great men, then, have a conviction, really independent of external proof, that they have a soul.
>
> Otto Wieninger

Evola wrote to Guenon to clarify what is meant by "Real Man" and this is a summary — with comments — of the response he received.

> Every Real Man has realized all the possibilities of the human condition, but each one has done so in a way which is typical of him alone, and which differentiates him from all other Real Men. If that were not the case, how could there be room, in our world, even for beings who have not achieved that level?

In other places, Guenon identifies this as the characteristic of a man of the Kshatriya caste. This differentiates him from the Brahmin caste, whose goal is the jivan-mukta — liberated while still in this life — who has realized the totality of the possibilities of all the states of being.

In order to realize his possibilities, the Real Man needs to engage the world. Since Guenon's characterisation is general and therefore vague, it is instructive to compare the concept of the Real Man with the concept of the Genius as described in great detail by Otto Weininger in has masterwork, **Sex and Character**. He writes: "Genius is, in its essence, nothing but the full completion of the idea of a man." It is remarkable how close these two conceptions are, despite coming from radically different sources.

The Genius, then, has a complete understanding of men, since he embraces all their personalities in his own consciousness. This is how the great Leader is able to deal appropriately with many sorts of men, or how the great Writer can describe so many varied characters, their actions, and their motives. Weininger writes:

> The man of genius takes his place as someone who understands other beings incomparably more than the average man does. Goethe is said to have said of himself that there was no vice or crime of which he could not trace the tendency in himself, and that at some period of his life he could not have understood fully. The genius, therefore, is a more complicated, more richly endowed, more varied man; and a man is the closer to being a genius the more men he has in his personality, and the more really and strongly he has these others within him.

This is what makes the Genius free. Since he has more possibilities, he has more choices in any situation. The lesser man is inhibited and restricted by his own personality.

> And so the ideal genius, who has all men within him, has also all their preferences and all their dislikes. There is in him not only the universality of men, but of all nature. He is the man to whom all things tell their secrets, to whom most happens, and whom least escapes. He understands most things, and those most deeply, because he has the greatest number of things to contrast and compare them with. The genius is he who is conscious of most, and of that most acutely.

The Genius is distinguished from the merely talented man by his universality. The latter may do one thing well, even very well, but he is still not a Genius. The talented man may develop one idea, perhaps two, but then spends the rest of his life as a series of footnotes to that original impulse. A new idea has little chance of penetrating his mind.

> Universality is the distinguishing mark of genius. There is no such thing as a special genius, a genius for mathematics, or for music, or even for chess, but only a universal genius. The genius is a man who knows everything without having learned it.

Posted on 2010-03-18 by Cologero

* * *

Ryan Haecker on 2010-03-21 at 01:30 said:

This is an enjoyable summary of Weininger's description of a genius.

Simon Friedrich on 2010-04-26 at 13:47 said:

You might like to compare these ideas of the Real Man/Genius with Gurdjieff's explanation of the (potential) "Real I" and the multiple personalities with a man.

Everyone, including Real Men, possess multiple personalities. Most individuals are hypnotized into believing these personalities – at one moment one, another moment another – to be who they are. A Real Man still possesses these personalities, but he literally "possesses" them, and is not them. He is one "I", and a unique one at that, in possession and in control of his various personalities. (See also Max Stirner – "The Unique and his Property" – "Der Einziger und sein Eigentum")

The richer his inheritance and upbringing, the broader his property of personalities, to the point that he approaches being a universal manifestation of Man.

He also possesses dark and evil personalities, since these too form part of Man's possibilities. But he controls them, deactivates them.

All the above may also be seen in Ernst Juenger's idea of the Anarch, which he developed in part from Stirner's Unique.

Cologero on 2010-04-26 at 22:18 said:

Genau. But to bring in the "ideas" of Gurdjieff would be lock them in at the level of dianioa. As you assuredly know, along with the ideas there must be "work on onself" to raise these ideas to the level of episteme.

Kelly Jones on 2014-02-17 at 01:45 said:

Everyone can become a genius. It just requires infinite-mindedness. It doesn't mean developing a richer personality, or multiple skillsets. It's about seeing the whole multiplex of Universes as your own self, which is the case given there are no inherent boundaries.

Cologero on 2014-02-18 at 00:35 said:

Kelly: Kevin Solway, David Quinn, and I go back a long way. Presumably you have seen a lot of geniuses arise during your association with those gentlemen?

Kelly Jones on 2014-02-18 at 22:48 said:

Hi Cologero. You asked, "Presumably you have seen a lot of geniuses arise during your association with those gentlemen?"

Not at all. Unfortunately, even though everyone can be a genius, it is very rare for anyone to persevere past the early bursts of intensity. Most of the budding geniuses I've seen over the last decade want happiness, and social recognition as the leaders in a kind of philosophical revolution, crowned in fanfare and glory. They want recognition and endorsement by the leading authorities of the land (as all the children's fairy tales would have it). Ah, as if such glory is real!

When these young wisdom-seekers (they can only be men) realise most people disapprove and ridicule their ideas, and when they realise this puts them at high risk of losing their human dreams like an adoring family, worldly security, and material comforts, then all the stuffing goes out of them. They want happiness far more than truth. Glory, yes! Happiness, yes! Truth…. hang on, who said anything about truth?!

It is a hard path, but it is a noble path. It requires a strong character, and strong purpose. So, everyone can become a genius, but few want it.

So the biggest stumbling block for budding geniuses is their need for social approval. So, instead of recognising this deep need for happiness, and fighting to submit that desire to their higher goals, they make excuses like: "other people aren't ready", or "no one will listen to these ideas". Then they turn around and fall into easy but mediocre, short-sighted pathways, like becoming a good scholar, an environmental activist, an eccentric artist, a vegan socialist, and so forth. They excuse it as saying, this temporary step is what is needed more — but if there is no one standing at the final destination of all those temporary steps, then how can people's gaze be drawn to it? Who can know about it?

I don't think I have heard of your pseudonym before. What is your real name, if I might ask?

Cologero on 2014-02-20 at 00:50 said:

So, Kelly Jones, becoming a genius is really a moral issue, not simply an intellectual one. These are some of the qualities you mention:

perseverance, strong character, strong purpose

There are the obstacles you mention such as the desire for pleasure and worldly success that prevent the attainment of genius.

But if there are no boundaries, then you yourself are reflected in those that fall short. Or am I misunderstanding you?

I don't believe I am using a pseudonym; perhaps someone will vouch for me.

5.19 The True Man

> Then God said, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness; and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the birds of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth." So God created man in His own image, in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them. And God blessed them, and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the air and over every living thing that moves upon the earth."

In *The Great Triad*, **Rene Guenon** describes the **True Man** as the being who has actualized all his possibilities as a man. True Man is also man as he is in the **Primordial State**, in contrast to the "ordinary man" or today. Using the initiatic formula "*Heaven is his father, earth is his mother*", man can be described as the **Son of Heaven and Earth**, thus is the third term of that triad. The schema in Table 5.19 relates this symbolism to various Traditions:

Masculine Principle	Heaven	Essence	Yang	Actuality	Interior
Feminine Principle	Earth	Substance	Yin	Potency	Exterior

Table 5.1: Man Principles

Although everything has aspects of both principles, True Man has them in a balanced way. He "possesses the fullness of human nature, for he has developed in himself the totality of possibilities that implies." For

examples of what this may mean, see *Cagliostro the Trickster*[46], *Genius and the Real Man*[47], *Life of a Contemporary Hermetist*[48], or *The Wise Man rules the Elements*[49].

Ordinary man, on the other hand, has developed primarily at the corporeal or hylic level, and is thus yin, or passive, in relation to the Cosmos. As Evola writes of this type:

> the "I" still lives only as if in a dream: it is not yet a self-consciousness, nor an autonomous principle of action: immersed in an immediate, indistinct coalescence with nature and the world, we can say that it is not so much he who thinks, speaks, and asserts himself, as much as that various forces and impulses think, speak and assert themselves in him. He therefore is only a type of medium, a passive instrument that has his very life outside himself, and he experiences everything as grace, as spontaneity, as the immediate self-manifestation of something that transcends him. (From *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*.)

The ordinary man is described as the Son of the Earth. For the true man, his actuality is equal to his potency, that is, he is perfectly balanced between *yin* and *yang*. He is thus *yang*, or active, in relation to the Cosmos, because celestial nature is predominant over terrestrial nature; he therefore is in the *center*.

The fall of the True Man from the Primordial State is the result of a decentering, a change in consciousness to exteriority from interiority. Now the Primordial State is the **Androgyne** of the



[46] https://gornahoor.net/?p=764
[47] See Section 5.18 in this book.
[48] https://gornahoor.net/?p=793
[49] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1010

Alchemists, that is, the perfect balance of the male and female principles. From the center, he is the unmoved mover, and his actions are *wei wu wei*, or non-acting activity.

We see that the shift from the ordinary state to the Primordial State represents, spiritually, a transition from a passive, *yin*, or feminine state of existence to a more active, *yang*, or masculine state. This is the opposite of the "macho" man, obsessed with frenetic activity for its own sake and focused solely on material life. Yet, when esoteric teachings enter into the popular domain, they are completely misunderstood by those at the hylic and psychic level. When such types hear of the Androgyne, they can only envision a feminization of man, that is, a exterior type of man taking on more effeminate characteristics. Thus the *epicene* man of today, common in the West, regards himself *ipso facto* as an advanced spiritual being. Unfortunately, this occludes the true spiritual nature of man and discourages many more masculine men from developing themselves in that direction.

Posted on 2010-09-21 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-09-21 at 21:33 said:

The 'androgyne' is not a hapax legomenon in Evola's work, but occurs time and again. It's all well to say, "Well, of course, he's not talking about, well, you know…" But if not, then what on Earth IS he talking about?

Of course, words like 'epicene' are culturally determined. I think 'Alan Alda' and of course that kind of "sensitive liberal man" would be loathed by Evola. Funny thing is: look at Evola's passport photo, for example: fancy suit, monocle. He's a FAG by today's standards, determined as they are by the rise of the telluric negro [Evola's definitive essay on 'America Negrified'].

Childless, never married. Hmmm. Mighty suspicious if he were, say, running for Congress. And what would the judaic-inspired "family values" crowd think of his mockery of marriage and population growth in Men Among the Ruins or Ride the Tiger?

Here is what E. says in "Serpentine Wisdom" [i.e., Taoism], after describing the Man of Tao who 'acts without acting' etc.:

"How disheartening to those who uphold the myth of manhood based on muscles and metallic strength: this alone is the TRUE man, the ABSOLUTE man. He [Evola's ideal] absorbs within himself the ambiguous virtue of the female.... 'The Way that is the Way is not the ordinary way' indeed..."

In The Hermetic Tradition, Evola expands on the idea as involving a becoming female [Hercules in drag], as it were coming under the domination of the Woman as a necessary stage; the salient point is, does one remain so, or does one conquer the female [the Hermetic Incest]and thus acquire her unique powers for oneself.

Now, does that make a difference or not?

If you look at popular culture, it's clear that the 'fag' is not just the simpering queen, or Alan Alda, but also any White man acting in the light of the Aryan ideal. Dressing well, speaking correctly, acting modestly, well read. The average "Traditionalist," reading books and even knowing several languages, is clearly a fag.

To the extent that a culture, like America, takes the Negro as the Ideal Man, then that ideal will be psychic, even material; and vice versa, the causality is not important here.

To the extent that a culture adheres to Aryan ideal, rooted in the primitive Mannerbund, then it will not be a culture that idealizes the brute, but the warrior, Greek or Icelandic, who triumphs in battle and then spontaneously recites poetry. Long blonde hair flowing, he will more closely resemble Leif Garrett than Puff Daddy. Pausanias, not Alcibiades or Themistocles.

Matt on 2010-09-22 at 01:37 said:

James,

Those are some good points. I think Evola would say that what people think of today as true masculinity would fit his description of what he called titanic masculinity, the low/crude form of masculinity, in contrast to Apollonian masculinity (high form of masculinity), which has some attributes (that you mentioned) that wouldn't be considered very masculine in modern society.

James O'Meara on 2010-09-22 at 09:59 said:

Thanks, Matt. 'Titanic' may be the word. Speaking of "low/crude," on my blog I have frequently observed that, in terms of popular music, when White music dominated [from Folk to Southern Rock to Heavy Metal] the performers chose to appear, and were highly successful in, ways that would be considered entirely 'gay' today; now that the Negro is the ideal, the ideal is indeed the low, crude, violent thug.

In terms of civilization, was not the Titanic a stage where men rebelled against an oppressive Amazonian rule, and ruled with a resulting crude and unrefined idea of masculinity?

Similar, in the regression of the castes, to the crude rule of the Khshatrias after the Priest/King rule was split and Priest [feminine, passive] had ruled alone first? The Priest/King is the original Androgyne.

Cologero on 2010-09-22 at 23:43 said:

The point is that the True Man is a metaphysical concept, not a particular historical or empirical type of man. That is looking at things from the exterior, whereas we are concerned with interiority. In the Hermetic Tradition, Evola gives some examples (ch 30):

"a great physical and intellectual equilibrium, … a healthy body without appetites or desires, being at peace with oneself and others; making oneself absolute master of the animal envelope in order to make of it an obedient servant …"

This is the point again: yang gaining control over yin.

Again, referring to Eliphas Levi, Evola writes:

"we must rid the will of any dependency and accustom it to domination; we must become absolute master of the self, learn to deny the call of pleasusre, hunger and sleep and be unmoved by success or failure." and then "…submit in every organ to the spirit"

What a True Man looks like, what he does, or how he acts will not reveal his inner state to the vulgar. Having actualized all his potentials, he is free to act in any way suitable to his purposed in every situation.

James O'Meara on 2010-09-23 at 08:43 said:

Indeed. The True Man would be master of appearances, and perhaps, as E. says regarding The Mage and the Taoist Masters, he may prefer not to appear at all!

Cologero on 2010-09-24 at 14:02 said:

Apparently Guenon's concept is not clear when he writes that the True Man has actualized all his possibilities. That means that the world of appearances (yin or the feminine) is under the domination of the True Man as yang. In the Triad, Man is the mediator between Heaven and Earth … the task of the True Man is to bring the ideas or Essences into manifestation … that is a demonstration of Power.

James O'Meara on 2010-09-24 at 18:51 said:

Speaking of the Path of Cinnabar, we learn there how Evola passed from philosopher of the Absolute Ego to Guenonian Traditionalism by realizing that if the True Will needed to be "embodied" in concrete history it could take the form of the founders of the various traditions. Now clearly all these traditions are very different in appearance; in the same way, all True Men are in some sense not only similar but the same man, transcendentally, but manifest in different forms, by their Absolute Will.

Cologero on 2010-09-29 at 00:17 said:

A similar take on this issue from a rather different perspective:

Etiquette and Protocol are Manly Pursuits

http://rencesvals.blogspot.com/2010/09/etiquette-and-protocol-are-manly.html

James O'Meara on 2010-09-30 at 15:52 said:

Well, if we are recomeneding books, how about Hagakure: The Book of the Samurai? Found a copy for a buck yesterday, athough I already have Mishima's essay on it. A random reviewer at Amazon makes a point that might relate to how the True Man functions:

"[T]his book is not a rigorous philosophical treatise, at least not in the way that Western scholars would define it. Instead, it is a collection of stories and phrases about a certain way of living. It doesn't hold up to scientific cross-examination (the author contradicts himself frequently), but it shouldn't have to. Yamamoto gives the impression that if faced with a philosophical attack on his "way", he would shrug his shoulders and say, "Yes, but that doesn't change a thing." In other words, his examples and aphorisms speak for themselves, and are not meant to either exclude other points of view or force others into conformity. Yamamoto even states that the Way he advocates is specific to his region of Japan – samurai of neighboring regions are free to develop their own Ways."

Ernest on 2010-09-30 at 18:27 said:

Also from the Hagakure:

"It is said that what is called the Spirit of an Age is something to which one cannot return. That this spirit gradually dissipates is due to the world's coming to an end. In the same way, a single year does not have just spring or summer. A single day, too, is the same. For this reason, although one would like to change today's world back to the spirit of one hundred years or more ago, it cannot be done. Thus it is important to make the best out of every generation."

And on the subject of Real/True Men:

"According to a certain person, a number of years ago Matsuguma Kyoan told this story: In the practice of medicine there is a differentiation of treatment according to the Yin and Yang of men and women. There is also a difference in pulse. In the last fifty years, however, men's pulse has become the same as women's. Noticing this, in the treatment of eye disease I applied women's treatment to men and found it suitable. When I observed the application of men's treatment to men, there was no result. Thus I knew that men's spirit had weakened and that they had become the same as women, and the end of the world had come. Since I witnessed this with certainty, I kept it a secret.

When looking at the men of today with this in mind, those who could be thought to have a woman's pulse are many indeed, and those who seem like real men few. Because of this, if one were to make a little effort, he would be able to take the upper hand quite easily."

James O'Meara on 2010-10-01 at 10:22 said:

Indeed, such womanish men would not make suitable lovers for the samurai. This brings us back to the our topic; the True Man is not socially determined. Indeed, in today's materialistic and quantitative Western world, "no one seems to tell young men the 'musts' of shudo ["The Way of Men, meaning homosexuality, which was rampant in that era" as the translator helpfully explains]I.180, while the Judeo-Christian ideal of the Family Values Man reigns supreme.

5.20 Philosophy and the Noble Life

> Because the same One, who is begotten and born of God the Father, without ceasing in eternity, is born today, within time, in human nature, we make a holiday to celebrate it. Saint Augustine says that this birth is always happening. And yet, if it does not occur in me, how could it help me? Everything depends on that.
>
> Meister Eckhart

> Thus, in the gospel He speaks through the flesh; and this sounded outwardly in the ears of men, that it might be believed and sought inwardly, and that it might be found in the eternal Truth, where the good and only Master teaches all His disciples.
>
> Saint Augustine

Nobility and Nature In the *Convivio*, **Dante** explained that

> Nobility is the perfection in each thing of its proper nature.

Thus man speaks of a noble stone, plant, horse, falcon, whenever it appears perfect after its own nature. Thus, a man is noble to the extent he

is perfect according to his nature. Unlike a stone, a plant, or an animal, whose nature is simply given to them, man, as a free and rational being, chooses to follow, or not, his nature freely. This leads then to the question of how one should live.

In Vedic teachings, men are said to be motivated by pleasure, success, or duty. These motivations should be clear, since all men have experienced them. Pleasure is restricted to sensual pleasure, success may take the form of founding movements, etc. Duty, is higher than the other two, since it is directed outward, yet it is ultimately insufficient. Kierkegaard, in *Either/Or* provides a detailed phenomenological analysis of both a life devoted to sensuality and to a life devoted to the sense of duty, for those interested.

Beyond those three, there is liberation from all desire, the transcendence of one's self and nature. However, the Western path of affirmation seeks instead to affirm one's self and nature, i.e., nobility is the fourth motivation. How that is to be done was Dante's path. That was philosophy which "has wisdom [sophia] for her subject matter and love for her form, and for the composition of the one with the other the practice of speculation."

True Life The Emperor of Suabia said that nobility requires "ancient wealth and gracious manners", still commonly believed, but a definition that Dante rejects since lineage and money are not one's own nature. Rather, he writes:

> Life in man is the exercise of the reason; if his life is his being, then to renounce the exercise of reason is to renounce existence, and this is death.

Or better put, "the man [who rejects reason] is dead but the beast survives." Do not be deceived. Many walking among you may appear to be

gracious, to be of a good stock, to have fortune, success, or a glib, sophistical tongue, yet are mere "beasts of the field."

Some even use the expression "life denying"—not a traditional notion—to refer to the path Dante describes. However, what is truly life denying is a life devoted only to sensuality, at least if you mean a man's life and not a beast's.

Law and Morality Yet, the path to Sophia, or Wisdom, involves not just Reason, but also Love. It is not just a matter of thinking, but also of transformation. Dante writes, in a passage that may seem hard to grasp:

> The beauty of wisdom is in morality; the moral virtues give pleasure which is sensibly perceived.

The dutiful life, such as that of Kierkegaard's Judge Wilhelm, is not pleasurable. So what can Dante mean here? As a poet, he uses images, which can be "sensibly perceived", to make his point. This Sophia is not an abstraction, but takes on the form of a woman, in his case, Beatrice. Thus the love for Sophia is more than intellectual. In this, he is not far from Boethius.

Evola often wrote that morality cannot be imposed from the outside, but must originate in the "I". Dante cannot disagree, since morality arises from man's nature. For example, the four pagan virtues of justice, wisdom, courage, and temperance follow from the very nature of the soul in its thinking, willing and feeling functions. Furthermore, the natural law derives from the very nature of man, so to follow it means not more than to live as a man. To reject it is to die.

Guenon complained that Christianity lacked a true law. However, pace Guenon, there is no need for a new law, since the Logos itself is the law. To live in accordance with the Logos, through whom all things were created, is the law. This is unlike all other traditions which have elaborate, and seemingly arbitrary, laws in regards to the regulation of

daily life. These include dietary restrictions as well as things that make one unclean, and the rituals necessary to become clean again. What Evola always neglects to mention is that ancient paganism itself had many such laws, from how to keep the hearth going in one's home to whom a man could touch or not. Christ brought no such laws since uncleanness arises in one's heart, not from the outside. Vladimir Solovyov writes:

> The law of God's being is no longer manifested a pure arbitrariness (in Himself) and external, compulsory necessity (for humanity); it is manifested now as the internal necessity of true freedom.

Nobility and the True Self So by living a life of reason, developing the virtues, and acting in harmony with one's true nature, a man becomes noble. But then something interesting happens, specifically the developing awareness of the Self. This is a topic we have previously discussed in relation to **Otto Weininger**[50]. But it also explains why we draw on the likes of **Julius Evola** or **Miguel Serrano**; they came to the same understanding. Whether or not they ultimately took a wrong path is for the reader to decide. The point is that this is a path different from that of the East, and accounts for much of the dispute between Evola and Guenon. Evola wrote of the "Absolute Self", which he claimed was a pagan notion, although I cannot locate a specific source. On the contrary, if we arguably take Plotinus as the highest expression of ancient pagan spirituality, we see that he is far from that notion and is actually much closer to the spirituality of the Vedantists of the East.

Serrano is more honest about the source. In an interview[51], he refers to **Carl Jung**:

> [Jung] told me something very curious, very interesting about

[50] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=57`

[51] `http://oregoncoug.wordpress.com/2011/11/23/miguel-serrano-interviewed-by-alessandro-de-felice-2005/`

> what happened here in the Occident. Our world, our development went forward quite naturally through Paganism. It was interrupted by another civilization that imposed itself on the Pagan Occident and cut off its advance. Namely, the Roman Empire and Christianity with Charlemagne and all of that. This cut away the possibility of developing the Pagan civilization. Wotan was put away as something apart that could not be touched. This produced in the blood of the unconscious of this Folk a break by which another was imposed onto it and this dichotomy was an internal conflict. Catholicism produced this with the concept of sin.

Of course, the concept of sin arises from the failure to follow the natural law; this produced an uncomfortable friction in the pagan mind. In it, individuality was less prominent, so the pagan consciousness simply followed along with the group mind. Even today, among the neo-pagans and alt-rightists, there is the ever constant temptation to want to revert back to the racial mind. Thus they use expressions along the lines of "I want to get back to the psyche (or something similar) of my people." This difference can be seen in the Swedish legend of the Virgin Spring[52] in which the nobility is Christian and the lower classes still follow the old religion.

However, on the positive side, this friction:

> allowed a great surpassing, something incredible that had never occurred before, perhaps unique in the universe, the awareness of oneself, the consciousness of the I, the *Selbst*.

That is, man becomes aware of himself as choosing to act in accordance with his true nature, i.e., against his sin nature. This is unlike a rock, plant, or animal which has no choice in the matter.

[52] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1416`

As the West has become de-Christianized, it has lost this idea of the Self. Thus it has reverted back to the group mind, as evidenced in political correctness, etc. To the extent the self is recognized, it is only insofar as it is in service to pleasure, success, or duty. None of these are viewed as threats to the system.

Theosis At its highest level, then, the Self unites to the highest self, the Logos, or "Christ lives in me." To avoid further accusations of the ancient heresy of Gnosticism, we can now be quite clear what that means. Guenon correctly writes that liberation represents the actualization of all possibilities of the Being. However, that cannot describe the annihilation of the Self as he intended, but rather the divinization of the Self, or theosis.

For God, essence and existence are One, i.e., there is no potential in God, but only actuality. Hence, for a being to actualize all his possibilities, he is left without potential, specifically, this makes him the same as a god. However, there can be only one such God.

So we can say that a person becomes united to God to the extent he manifests all his possibilities. Of course, we mean here his "real" possibilities, not the sinful or deviant possibilities he may be attracted to. More about this will have to wait.

Posted on 2013-12-29 by Cologero

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`Cologero on 2013-12-30 at 10:09 said:`

Does anyone find it striking that some, or perhaps most, men are described as beasts by Dante? We find a similar idea, including the life of reason as the moral life, in St Anthony[53]. He also describes irrational and immoral men as "inhuman".

Nowadays, however, everyone is described as a "child of God", no matter what. Hasn't something significant changed in the mentality of Western man over the last several centuries?

[53] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=501`

Cologero on 2013-12-30 at 10:17 said:

Furthermore, the ideal of a moral life has changed. No one today would call that ideal "noble", perhaps because it seems so prideful. No one, or hardly no one, today would talk of the virtues in the same way, or even acknowledge that man has a certain nature. No, nowadays, the virtuous or moral man is someone who is concerned about the "poor" or the "hungry".

Synodius on 2013-12-30 at 10:46 said:

" So we can say that one becomes united to God to the extent he manifests all his possibilities. Of course, we mean here his "real" possibilities, not the sinful or deviant possibilities he may be attracted to."

Jung's ideal of becoming whole seems to lack this distinction and he saw the lack of development of these inferior possibilities as a symptom of spiritual sterility.

Avery Morrow on 2013-12-30 at 13:15 said:

"To live in accordance with the Logos, through whom all things were created, is the law. This is unlike all other traditions which have elaborate, and seemingly arbitrary, laws in regards to the regulation of daily life."

The Tao that can be named is not the true Tao…

Ash on 2013-12-30 at 15:50 said:

Synodius, I think the idea isn't to ignore the sensual part of man, but rather to develop it in accordance with the higher nature, rather than the reverse. Dr. Ali Shariati, an Iranian Muslim thinker, wrote that "…in Islam Satan is not standing against God but against the divine half of man. And since man is a two-dimensional creature who is kneaded of mud and God, he is in need of both. His ideology, religion, life, and civilization must all be capable of satisfying both of these dimensions." The nobility produced culture and art in order to uplift man on the sensual and physical plane, whereas much in modern culture tries to bring down the spiritual plane to the basest elements of the physical one.

The moment that the lowest passions of Man were judged to be as legitimate and equal and beyond judgement as the highest possibilities, the moral lauding of the poorest and most deprived parts of human society was followed naturally. I see a lot of people, even within the Catholic Church, who go beyond lionizing those who help the poor and ascribing a sort of dignity and virtue to poverty in and of itself. St. Francis may have found a nobility of spirit by subjecting himself to poverty, but the fact that it was meant as a struggle for the soul should tell them all it needs to.

Synodius on 2013-12-30 at 18:54 said:

Perhaps I didn't express myself clearly, I think that Jung contributed to the confusion of values by considering one-sidedness the greatest sin and not bothering to distinguish higher possibilities from lower.

JA on 2013-12-30 at 21:56 said:

For the record, Ali Shariati was a Marxist who opposed the Persian monarchy as well as the legitimate clergy of Islam, he called himself a red shiite in one of his works ! His version of Islam, and also that of his contemporary and ally Khomeini is a Mohammedan version of communist liberation theology.

I am not an expert on Islam as I am a Catholic by baptism, ancestry and Faith, but I respect Moslems such as Seyed Hosein Nasr who was btw an advisor to the late Persian Shah.

I will comment on the article itself tomorrow when I have had more time to meditate – this is really good and crucial stuff Cologero has given us here.

Ash on 2013-12-30 at 22:06 said:

Thanks for the clarification, JA. Full disclosure: I had read a couple of Shariati's works on this subject but wasn't aware of his full spectrum beyond being involved in the revolution. That said, I don't see anything unkosher about the quote I have in and of itself, provided we interpret it correctly. Perhaps others would be willing to critique it if they do.

JA on 2013-12-31 at 16:48 said:

I think the key here to discovery of the elitist nature of the Catholic religion is to understand the nature of mystical theology – through our faith in Christ combined with our good works, we all can achieve theosis after our death. However – some (read elite) have been given a gift by God to achieve theosis while in the mortal body. Unlike modern teachings which say any bum can become enlightened, Catholicism teaches that only God can choose whether or not we will see Him in this life, all we can do is devote ourselves in the prayer and hope that God will so bless is with this most wondrous of events.

the error that all can achieve theosis without the special grace of God is what leads to egalitarianism.

Cologero on 2014-01-02 at 20:24 said:

Yes, Avery, that is the point. "Tao" is used to translate "Logos" in the Chinese bible.

If all things are created through the Logos — and thus can be "named" — then the Logos cannot be found among the 10,000 things.

The Logos is "known" through gnosis, not as an object (Christ liveth in me).

When there is not distinction between essence and existence, there is free expression and spontaneous action — non-acting acting

Andrew on 2014-01-18 at 18:44 said:

RE: Cologero's early comments regarding the change in the mentality of Western man, the criteria of the moral man being concerned about the "poor" and "hunger"...

Chantal del Sol, a contemporary French critic/philosopher, addresses this in her book, "Icarus Fallen", as well as her other work. I won't go into it here, but her work may be of interest to some of you.

5.21 Thought, Action, and the Elite

In Perspectives on Initiation, **Rene Guenon** deals with the notion of the elite in our time. In the kali yuga, there are fewer initiates and, apparently, it requires a larger population to generate the number of men with the possibility of being initiates. Before reviewing that in order to determine who may be a candidate for initiation, it may be wise to review the fundamentals. In our fall from the primordial state, we enter the world of duality. In Thought, that shows up as a yes and a no. Every opinion expressed engenders its opposite which then leads to infinite discussion without resolution. The Will enters a debate between "desire" and "avoidance". With nothing transcendent to resolve these dualities, thoughts and actions are formed on the basis of sympathy and antipathy, what I like and what I dislike.

World of Thought First of all, it is necessary to understand the "person". The person, or "Self", is beyond all manifestation, a fortiori, beyond thoughts, desires, like, and dislikes. It can never be an object in the world, hence never an object of experience, either of my own or of someone else's. This is unnatural to most people since they regard their person precisely as the contents of their consciousness rather than always outside of consciousness. Hence, there is a widespread misconception anent the notion of a personal God. Projecting their own misunderstandings

of personhood, they presume that refers to some super-being who also experiences thoughts, desires, emotions, and so on.

What people consider their person or self is actually its projection into manifestation, and Guenon calls this the ego. That becomes the false center around which people live out their lives, rather than their true transcendent center. That ego is unstable, forever shifting with each new idea, desire, or emotion.

So, although it seems that metaphysical principles are expressed in thoughts and words, that is not how they must be ultimately known. As every metaphysician has taught, there is a higher faculty, "intellectual intuition", that transcends thought. As such, metaphysics can never be just another theory about the world, something to latch onto or not, a school of thought that one can say either yes or no to.

Words like "intuition" and "transcend" refer to very real things, they are not meant to obfuscate, and they are not reserved to some erudites who have no familiarity with the "real" world. Quite the opposite. Hence, the metaphysician doesn't bother to debate these principles although he may try to explain them. It is pointless to enter a dispute, because all that amounts to is a no to his yes, a project without ultimate resolution. The most you can do is regard him as deluded.

Through certain practices one learns to "transcend". For the ordinary consciousness, thinking and the ego are on the same level. Men assume they "think", i.e., there is a thinker and a thought and together they define the man. That is the dualist view. The higher view is different. The person, not the ego, is at the center, and the realm of thoughts is just one of the layers of his being. From the vantage point of the Self, the thoughts are "below", i.e., they are transcended. Hence one's consciousness is superior to the yes and no of the stream of thoughts. That is non-dual awareness, since there is no longer a thinker and his thoughts, instead just the observer.

Field of Action Action takes place in manifestation. Whereas metaphysical principles are known with absolute certainty, that is not the case when acting. Here one's actions are fraught with risk and uncertainty; instead of known principles, what is required is prudential judgment. Curiously, the bulk of men see things quite differently from that. For them, thought can be no more than opinion, or a likely story; a man is free to adopt whatever philosophical, scientific, or religious system he likes based on his "personal equation".

Yet when it comes to making concrete decisions, he is suddenly filled with total certainty, that he knows what to do and everyone else is going down the wrong path. That is the rash man. His counterpart is the scrupulous man how will weigh his options interminably and may fail to make a decision at all.

Obviously, to the extent he doesn't understand his own nature and the workings of the world, his actions will be ineffective. Here his guide must be the virtues: prudence, to be able to evaluate the possibilities of manifestation in a concrete situation; courage, or fortitude, to have the strength of will to act effectively; justice, to be able to act objectively and fairly. Now, as we may suspect from some of Plato's dialogues, these virtues cannot be understood dualistically; the attempts to define them by rational thought ends in aporia. That does not mean they don't exist. Rather it means they cannot be reduced to thought, but must be the expression of one's Self. The courageous man knows directly, intuitively, and non-dually what courage is, even if he can never express it fully in words.

Man's dual nature is expressed in the gnomic will, i.e., he deliberates the various courses of action open to him. His true will, on the contrary, is the expression of his being; this is non-dual action, arising from a man's primordial state. Purity of heart is to will one thing.

It should be clear that watchfulness is the initial step, the necessary skill to master. All spiritual schools recognize this. It is hardly unknown

in the West. For example, it is present in the Philokalia, Scuopli's Spiritual Warfare, and even the Gospels. Through constant practice in watchfulness, and unceasing efforts to remove the myriad obstacles that would prevent such, a man can gradually reach non-dual awareness to a greater of lesser extent. There is no point debating non-duality, except in the context of mutual support a spiritual group. Through such practice, one learns to see there are not-two, yet neither term annihilates the other. The "Supreme Identity" will explain itself.

This sounds simple enough, but in practice I've found that some people have great difficulty grasping this. For them, presumably, the esoteric spiritual life is not an option. They are content with the illusion of ordinary life and there is a necessity for that.

The Notion of an Elite Guenon claims that the notion of an elite no longer exists in the West, so that its "reconstitution is the first and essential condition for an intellectual rectification and a traditional restoration." It is the men who accept that who are the objects of our interest, not those who reject the spiritual in favor of some at-best ephemeral political victories. Obviously, this word has a specific meaning, which is quite different from its common usage. It has nothing to do with a small group exploiting the masses, since its goal is the restoration for all. Guenon makes this definition:

> The elite represents the totality of those who possess the qualifications required for initiation, and who naturally are always a minority among men.

The dilemma is this: is there no elite in the West because there are no initiatory organizations or are there no initiatory ogranizations because there is no elite? This chicken or egg problem is not resolvable on the rational plane. But it does lead logically to this: does the West have to wait

for initiatory organizations in order to form an elite or will the presence of an elite lead to the formation of initiatory organizations?

These are dualistic questions that can only be resolved from a higher perspective. Of course, as things stand, the elite in the West is only virtual and those who believe they are chosen will need to become conscious of their own qualification to be initiates. Consider: if you understand anything of what was written tonight, if you are obsessed with spiritual and metaphysical topics, if the glamor of the world is losing its grip on you, if you have the energy and perseverance to follow an ascetic path, then perhaps you are becoming conscious of your calling. If you know who you are, you will know this to be true.

Posted on 2013-06-19 by Cologero

* * *

Ash on 2013-06-19 at 23:59 said:

"The most you can do is regard him as deluded."

This is exactly the problem I struggle with when thinking about Gnosis (perhaps one day I will be able to receive it). True gnosis is indeed beyond questioning. But in terms of finding the authentic guide and teacher, particularly in real life and beyond books and the internet, it is difficult to see between those who really have it and those who don't sometimes. Like asking a dog to explain the difference between red and green. A key, I suppose, would be that the one with Gnosis isn't going around making claims to it. Christ taught in dark sayings, after all.

Cologero on 2013-06-20 at 00:07 said:

Dogs are color blind. I don't think you can explain the difference between red and green.

Scardanelli on 2013-06-20 at 10:02 said:

Thank you for this post Cologero. I am grateful for your advice catered to those wishing for practical advice along the way. The petty squabbling in the comments section is growing tiresome and it's nice to get back to the work at hand.

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-20 at 11:55 said:

I am one who feels called, I despise the world and am obsessed with the idea of being able to see and know God, I am ready to do whatever is required of me to get there, which for

me is on faith as I do not know what I must do, but I dont even know where to begin, I read a lot of anecdotes from people who have crossed the threshold but what I seek is a map, a guide, someone or something that can tell me what to do to reach the true world. In the abscence of a master, I've been looking at some practical books and next week I'm going to start perform the excersises from Mouni Sadhu's book Concentration and from there maybe go on to his Meditation book. I've also been thinking about using Franz Bardon's Initiation into Hermetics. If anyone here can advise m I'd be most grateful indeed.

scardanelli on 2013-06-20 at 12:19 said:

@Jason-Adam

I have not found a clearer exposition or "roadmap" than that found in Boris Mouravieff's Gnosis series. All of Cologero's above summation can be found therein plus much more. I have read Mouni Sadhu's Concentration and performed the exercises, but stopped them after reading Mouravieff. I am no authority, but it seems that MS gives you piecemeal information whereas BM gives you the whole, step by step. If you are a man that likes to see the bigger picture, that likes to see where he is going though he may not be able to reach it yet, I would recommend BM.

Also, have you ever looked into any lay organizations? I came across the Militia Templi a few days ago, and from your comments, it seems like it might be a good fit for you. I am not advocating them as I know very little about them, but perhaps something you can look into.

h.ontologia on 2013-06-20 at 12:20 said:

Jason-A., have you had a look at a meisterwerk, featured on Gornahoor, titled "Meditations on the Tarot"?

Constantine Aetos on 2013-06-20 at 13:04 said:

Very good article Cologero

Jason I recommend you read Christ the Eternal Tao by Hieromonk Damascene

Jacob on 2013-06-20 at 13:18 said:

This is the diamond in the rough of the Internet. Thanks for another piece.

I have wanted to buy the Gnosis books, but I have always assumed Gurdjieff was anti-traditional like Steiner and Bessant (mainly because of Guenon's plague comment). This place seems to have a better opinion of him though. Do I need to have an understanding of Gurdjieff before reading Gnosis? Or can he be read without it?

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-20 at 17:27 said:

I've read Meditations on the Tarot and admire that work truly but it doesn't offer, at least to me, an actual system of works that can be done to raise spiritual awareness. Mouravieff troubles me because of the anti-western statements he made in Gnosis III reminded me a bit too much of Dugin but I will reconsider that. I've thought about looking into the Gurdjieff work as well.

Ash on 2013-06-20 at 20:03 said:

@Cologero

Yes, hence the metaphor. I can judge doctrines, perhaps, but if a doctrine appears legitimate then judging whether or not the teacher is truly speaking from gnosis would be asking someone to explain something he has never experienced himself.

@Constantine

I was able to acquire this book some time ago but haven't yet had the chance to read it. Did you find it helpful? Also, do you know what Hieromonk Damascene's relation to the perennial philosophy is?

Constantine Aetos on 2013-06-21 at 01:34 said:

@Ash

I actually just finished reading it last week and I can tell you it definitely has given me not only a better understanding of God, but also how to reach to God (e.g.: Watchfulness & Jesus Prayer).

I don't know much about Fr. Damascene other than his spiritual father was Fr. Seraphim (Rose). My guess is he probably had some knowledge of perennial philosophy.

http://orthodoxwiki.org/Damascene_%28Christensen%29

Logres on 2013-06-21 at 21:27 said:

Jacob, Mouravieff is probably more accessible than Gurdjieff – G wrote for a very specific time, and was unorthodox in many ways, even by esoteric standards. Ousepensky's The Fourth Way is helpful, but much more so if you read Gnosis first.

Jacob on 2013-06-22 at 09:42 said:

Ok thanks Logres

Cologero on 2013-06-22 at 10:01 said:

The point about Gnosis is its claim to be Orthodox, that is, it is actually the teaching from the monks of Mt Athos. The publisher, Robin Amis, backs that up as he claims to have spent time on Mt Athos. You can believe him or not; the web site is *Praxis Institute*[54]. I haven't found any

[54] http://www.praxisresearch.net/home.cfm

independent confirmation.

The Gurdjieff groups are opposed to Mouravieff, regarding him as a plagiarist. However, since Gurdjieff himself confesses to having "stolen" his system, it is legitimate, and even advisable, to locate the actual "orthodox" (in its traditional sense) tradition rather than follow G's fragment of a tradition. In point of fact, after Ouspensky's death, some of his followers went in search of the real tradition behind the teaching. Some became Orthodox Christians and were instrumental in getting the Philokalia translated into English.

`Cologero on 2013-06-22 at 10:04 said:`

I need to add that Gnosis is incomprehensible without direct practice of the spiritual techniques that would make it clear. Also, keep in mind that Mouravieff uses the word "personality" in a way opposite to its definition here.

5.22 In Defense of Descartes

> I think therefore I am.
>
> Rene Descartes

> There is something godlike, then, in personhood, or better said, in a person, whoever he or she may be. Only one needs to bear in mind that the person is not in fact the human individual, as we commonly suppose. Individuality, one might say, is no more than a mask woven, as it were, of attributes which belong in truth, not to the person as such, but to his nature.
>
> Wolfgang Smith, *Theistic Evolution*

When I was a boy, around 10 or 11, my parents would drop me off at the Library of the Boston Museum of Science, while they went shopping at the nearby Lechmere Sales. My favorite books were about Astronomy and Mathematics. I used to copy the names of distant stars and galaxies into a notebook. Among my favorite books were the four volumes of the

series, *The World of Mathematics*, by **James R Newman**. Its mathematical symbols and diagrams were the entrance to a mysterious inner world, defined by its apodictic proofs, unlike the uncertainty and confusion of the material world. Moreover, the blue hardcover version was a delight to hold, unlike my paperback edition.

One thing that struck me about Descartes, and I've remembered it my entire life, was that he was allowed to lie in bed in the morning. He retained that habit throughout his life as he believed it was "conducive to intellectual profit and comfort." I've never had that luxury until the last dozen years or so. Since I am now blessed with insomnia, I awaken early in the morning. I just simply lie still with nothing but my thoughts and prayers. Every now and then a revelation comes to me and a post is born.

Descartes and the Poet Descartes was, for me, the epitome of the logical mind, who inextricably linked philosophy and mathematics together. Years later, I learned that Descartes was among the creators of the modern mind and implicitly an enemy of Tradition.

That view was challenged a year ago, when the poet **Charles Peguy** asserted that Rene Descartes was among the three greatest philosophers (along with Plato and Henri Bergson). That has been an irritant to me ever since, not unlike a grain of sand inside an oyster.

It dawned on me, during a morning repose, that the poet speaks from Intuition, not rational thinking. So that is how Descartes must be approached.

Descartes and Intuition Although the superiority of Intuition over rational argumentation has always been an essential aspect of traditional metaphysics, it is not always the case in practice. In this view, Descartes did not create a "new" philosophy to replace the old. Rather, he was describing his own consciousness. He admits as much in his meditations,

since he proposes some self-evident truths that can simply be "seen", which is what is meant by intellectual intuition.

Modern Philosophy First of all, we need to dispatch the notion that Descartes somehow "created" modern philosophy, or better, the "modern mind". Obviously, neither your next-door neighbor nor any of your friends used to think like a medieval, but suddenly got "woke" after reading Descartes. The more likely scenario is that he was describing his inner experience through self-observation. What he observed in this way was different from the self-understanding of his medieval predecessors. Universities teach the history of philosophy or the history of ideas, but they don't teach the history of consciousness. It is a mistake to believe that consciousness is static from age to age; rather consciousness changes over time. That is why and how an earlier age becomes opaque to a later one.

He claims that there are two substances that make up the human: extension and thought, because the body and mind are distinct. It would better to say matter and thought, since extension is not considered a property of manner; hence it belongs to thought.

The Thomist objection is that man is indeed a unified being, and thus cannot be composed of two distinct substances. That's a good point but the solution is hardly better, which is that the human being is a substance with two properties, body and soul. But the body dies and the soul lives on. So the postmortem soul is only an incomplete man. Although the complete teaching is out in the open, it is seldom noticed.

The essence of a human being is to be human, an animal, a living being, and a corporeal object. These manifest as a body, a living soul, an animal soul, and an intellectual soul. So the original "soul" is not so simple. Let's take Jacques Maritain's example of Peter. Peter is composed of matter and essence, specifically human essence, and everything that implies. An essence is in the Divine Intellect and can only be known by the intellect, not by the senses. Descartes does not stray too from that,

since he agrees that only the intellect can understand.

The Person But what about Peter? Where is he? According to Maritain, a substance has a suppositum or subject (of change), which, in Peter's case, is a Person. There is nothing in the essence of "human nature" that requires a person, something Maritain does not notice. Rather, he assumes that the individuated Peter has a self. Rene Guenon describes this confusion:

> The personality, metaphysically speaking, has nothing in common with what modern philosophers so often call 'the human person', which is, in fact, nothing but the individuality pure and simple; besides, it is this alone and not the personality which can strictly be called human.
>
> René Guenon, *Man and his becoming according to the Vedanta*

Maritain is therefore more modern than he believes, although he does admit that the Person Peter is also an essence in the Divine Intellect, so Peter is more than just a human substance. Now we are in a position to better understand Descartes. Through his method of introspection, which is not so unlike that of Ramana Maharshi, he realizes that he is the "I", neither body nor soul, but a Self that transcends them both. So both Descartes and Maritain are knocking on the door, behind which, Guenon was already there:

> The personality, let us insist once more, belongs essentially to the order of principles in the strictest sense of the word, that is, to the universal order; it cannot therefore be considered from any point of view except that of pure metaphysics, which has precisely the Universal for its domain.
>
> René Guenon, *Man and his becoming according to the Vedanta*

States of Being Certain consequences follow from this view. The first is that the "real" Peter is the personality, the Self in the strict sense. This transcends the ego of the human substance.

The second consequence solves the debate about the body and soul as substances or essences. The body and the various souls that comprise the human being are just states of being of the Self. So death does not affect the real Peter, because it is one of Peter's possible states of being.

Posted on 2021-09-15 by Cologero

* * *

Karl on 2021-09-16 at 06:03 said:

Ed Feser had a recent interesting blog post on common misconceptions of Cartesian matter that ties in with some of the above. http://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2021/09/make-believe-matter.html

Cologero on 2021-09-16 at 12:53 said:

Thanks, that was timely.

But I will point out where Feser is mistaken, not because I think so, but because he does not take into account a fundamental point of medieval scholasticism. See *Phenomenology of the Medieval Mind*[55].

"Common sense" used to mean the faculty of the soul to put together all the data experienced by the senses into a coherent representation of the world in the imagination. That means that the "colors" are not "Out there, right now", but rather they exist in the soul life as the representation of the physical world.

This is analogous to the way that the Intellect knows the essence of what is "out there". That is, we don't "see" the fox out there, we grasp the fox by understanding its essence.

BTW, this teaching was common to the Middle Ages, as even Islamic metaphysicians had the same understanding. They still do, since that tradition is still alive. Feser is trying, but he has lost full connection with it.

I have a post in the pipeline that will explain how the world comes to be represented in the soul.

[55] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3559

5.23 Freedom and Destiny

Multiple Selves We saw from Valdimir Solovyov's description that, in the second moment or positing, the divine Unity is objectified as multiplicity. Specifically, multiple selves arise out of the void. So what was in the divine mind as undifferentiated possibilities manifests as differentiated actualities.

These are free beings with all that implies. Each such being has its possibilities and its destiny is to manifest those possibilities. This is the metaphysical, esoteric, and Hermetic understanding of creation and is consistent, even if expressed slightly differently, with Rene Guenon, Vladimir Solovyov, and Valentin Tomberg. It accounts for our experience of a "previous" existence, with priority understood ontologically, not temporally. Keep in mind, too, that each such being comes into existence in the physical and psychical environment suitable to it. This can explain our feeling, or remembrance, of "being there", especially the psychic current. From that we get our feeling of at-homeness: identity, continuity, community.

Unfortunately, in our time, the so-called Kali Yuga, that sense of dwelling is often lacking and many are lost in a feeling of alienation. The four elements identified by Martin Heidegger as creating dwelling—earth, sky, people, the gods—are opaque to some extent. They are not a "given", but must be (re)created, the destiny of those who understand this.

Freedom and Multiplicity In the Emperor Arcanum, Tomberg develops the idea of freedom. In an analogous way to God's three positings, each man recapitulates the same three moments. Man, too, is free. His existence is freedom, i.e., the void within him, analogous to the idea of the Void. His essence, then, is the fullness of his possibilities. Unlike God, whose existence and essence coincide, man's task is to manifest his possibilities in freedom.

This requires a conscious participation in the three moments, in an analogous way:

1. He must recall his destiny, i.e., what his possibilities are, in the specific world he finds himself. In the fall into multiplicity, there is a forgetfulness, since each created being embodies an empirical self, i.e., one conditioned in space and time. Shankara, for example, calls these conditionings Upadhis. The being will take this self as his real self, thereby forgetting his original purpose. For man, then, freedom is not an absolute, but is conditioned by external and internal factors. To be completely free, he must learn to detach himself from all such conditionings.

2. Actually, the being does not project or objectify a single empirical self, but man has many such selves, analogous to God's second positing. This is seldom noticed in our daily consciousness, as each empirical self tries to claim authority. It is easy to recognize that we create all the characters in the dream state, while identifying with just one of them. However, in the waking state, we fail to see the same multitude and falsely believe we are one. Hence, a spiritual practice must involve overcoming such an illusion. One's multiplicity needs to be experienced directly, otherwise there will be no motivation to proceed to the third positing.

3. In the third positing, true unity is restored. That is, there develops and awareness of one's real self, the noumenal self above space and time. Only in that state can one manifest his destiny.

Salvation and Freedom Some may interpret the idea that different men are born with various gifts and possibilities as an injustice. That cannot be. Possibilities are just what they are, and they distinguish people from each other, making each one unique. The alternative is a type of

egalitarian regimentation, such as the images we get of crowds in North Korea. That is the extreme case, but regimentation of thought and opinion can be found everywhere.

The doctrine of karma and reincarnation are supposed to account for that alleged injustice, but they fail in that for reasons already given. Rather than elevating the moral life, it provides the lowest level of motivation, to wit, that of naked self-interest.

Furthermore, the idea of karma is actually misguided. A man may be born into a life of leisure for "good" deeds in a past life. But is such a lazy life causes him to forget and neglect his true destiny, then how can that be accounted as a good?

No, what this really means is that salvation or liberation is our real destiny, and not merely the amelioration of the material circumstances of life. In this sense, salvation is potentially available to all, regardless of circumstances of birth. Hence there is no injustice in creation.

In this understanding, we are free to choose our post-mortem destiny; this is certainly the most just teaching. There is the oft-heard complaint that it is unjust because there is uncertainty about it. They want signs and wonders. Paradoxically, they want to be "compelled" to act, when freedom is the opposite of compulsion. A serious man takes his life seriously. Once he understands his true situation, then he will compel himself to work out his own salvation.

Posted on 2014-05-18 by Cologero

5.24 Man's Place in Nature

In 1863, **T. H. Huxley** published *Man's Place in Nature* to demonstrate that man is merely an animal lacking any higher or transcendent quality.

Microcosm and Macrocosm **Valentin Tomberg** explains that "initiation" properly means "knowledge of the beginning". This implies that there are actually two initiations:

- **Hermetic Initiation** is the conscious experience of the initial microcosmic state.
- **Pythagorean Initiation** is the conscious experience of the initial macrocosmic state

Hermetic initiation is achieved when the initiate descends into the depths of the human being, i.e., becomes aware of himself as the image and likeness of God, as the Intellect. This requires an alchemical transformation, i.e., a real change of substance.

Pythagorean initiation is achieved by a "rapture", a going out of oneself (rather than within), so that the macrocosmic, or heavenly, layers reveal themselves. The initiate becomes conscious of the musical and mathematical structure of the macrocosm.

The Natural Law of Life In order to get to the beginning, the initiate must start from his present position. Therefore, the initiate studies the inner structure of consciousness in order to penetrate to the beginning (i.e., Eden). We also need to study the structure of the universe and man's place in it, in order to transcend it (i.e., Paradise). Unlike profane cosmology which studies the quantitative properties of the objects in relation to each other, esoteric cosmology describes the universe qualitatively, as it relates to consciousness.

This is what **Boris Mouravieff** tries to do, by drawing on the resources of the Western Tradition. Because of the dual situation, man's existence has two primary purposes:

- As part of the whole, he serves the aims of the cosmos.

- As an isolated individual, he can pursue his own aims.

The General Law refers to the cosmic forces that tend to keep man in his place in nature, that is, as part of organic life on earth, the same as the plants and animals. This is what makes Huxley's thesis plausible, even "obvious" to educated men of our day. This is the result of the forgetting of Being, i.e., that the natural world is one link in a Chain of Being.

Examples of the General Law:

- **Hunger**: the toil necessary to assure our subsistence, not to mention the satisfaction of other desires.
- **Sex**: sexual instinct and its consequences in procreation and parenthood.
- **Fear**: fear of death, injury, destitution, etc.

Such motivations take up most, if not all, of man's time and energy. A dispassionate and objective search for truth, the very definition of Intelligence, becomes nearly impossible. On the contrary, the definition of intelligence becomes inverted to mean that the man who is most successful in addressing these aspects of the General Law is regarded as the most intelligent.

Hence, the goals of achieving financial security, raising a family, becoming healthy, and the like, are regarded as the most important. Even religious sensibilities and political opinions are oriented primarily to those goals. I don't think I need to provide specific examples as they are so commonplace; on the contrary, it would be difficult to provide examples from politics and religion of achieving higher goals.

In the scheme of nature, life becomes an incessant series of minor battles:

- Seeking the pleasant while avoiding the unpleasant

- Loving what feels good and hating what feels bad
- Desire followed by delight at its satisfaction or frustration
- Fear of the worst while hoping for the best

The life of bourgeois happiness is summed up in winning those battles. Nevertheless, there are still occasions for heroic actions, since life presents so many challenges.

- It takes courage to face up to and overcome difficult situations
- The hope of success overcomes the fear of failure

Sometimes boundary situations may be so overwhelming, that a man or woman becomes aware of something higher. For them, exoteric religion may be the vehicle for transcendence.

Now this situation is entirely lawful, since if everyone escaped from the General Law, it would mean the end of the world. That is why esoterism is only for the few who are both capable of understanding its principles and have the opportunity to pursue it.

Macrocosmic Initiation Macrocosmic initiation is the realization that the natural life is not the whole story. The human being is not only natural but is also a person, transcending nature. The notion that the natural world is all that exists is considered "realistic". Success is measured in the satisfaction of desires and the reduction in the causes of fear. This is considered "life affirming" (although not necessarily in the Nietzschean sense) in opposition to the "life denying" attitude of ascetical practices to minimize the impact of the forces of the General Law.

If survival is the goal of the natural life, then salvation and liberation are the goals of a higher life. **Frithjof Schuon**, expanding on **Rene Guenon**, gives us the examples of the Noble Man and the Holy Man as the fulfillment of the latter two goals.

The Noble Man

> The noble man is one who dominates himself. The noble man is one who masters himself and loves to master himself; the base man is one who does not master himself and shrinks in horror from mastering himself. The noble man always maintains himself at the centre; he never loses sight of the symbol, the spiritual gift of things, the sign of God, a gratitude that is both ascending and radiating. The noble man is naturally detached from mean things, sometimes against his own interests; and he is naturally generous through greatness of soul. [*Esoterism as Principle and as Way*]

The Holy Man

> Transcending oneself: this is the great imperative of the human condition; and there is another that anticipates it and at the same time prolongs it: dominating oneself. The noble man is one who dominates himself; the holy man is one who transcends himself. *Nobility and holiness are the imperatives of the human state*.
>
> Intelligence, since it distinguishes, has the faculty of perceiving proportions. The spiritual man integrates these proportions into his will, into his soul and into his life. All defects manifest a lack of proportion; they are errors that are lived.
>
> To be spiritual means not to deny with one's 'being' what one affirms with one's 'knowledge', that is to say, what is accepted by the intelligence. Truth lived: incorruptibility and generosity. [*Islam and The Destiny of Man*]

Posted on 2014-10-22 by Cologero

* * *

Tom Blanchard on 2014-10-23 at 00:00 said:

With regard to Pythagorean initiation, a good primer on the subject is HRH The Prince of Wales' book, "Harmony" (`http://www.amazon.com/Harmony-New-Way-Looking-World/dp/0007348037/`), which outlines the origins and nature of sacred geometry and music in a way that is very approachable for the uninitiated reader. Prince Charles is a follower of Guenon (`http://www.sacredweb.com/conference06/conference_introduction_video.html`) and his overall worldview and perspective on Tradition is similar to ours here at Gornahoor.

`Lapis on 2014-10-27 at 09:24 said:`

I am suprised about Prince Charles. I know that he is a friend of Agha Khan IV whoes grandfather Guenon named as an very important agent of counter-initiation. I listen some of Agha Khans speeches and all i can say is that he is very anti-traditional. And it looks that biography of Prince Charles and his views on many things shows that he is not a man of traditional perspective, he is maybe traditionalist but not traditional and thats a great difference. Maybe they are using Guenon as a weapon for their own needs, just like Alexander Dugin do.

`Tom Blanchard on 2014-10-27 at 18:24 said:`

Lapis,

Which views specifically do you take issue with? From what I've read of his writing, Charles' views on organic farming, of man's need to live in a harmonious relationship with nature, etc. are almost identical to the views expressed by Lord Northbourne in his book, Look to the Land (`http://www.amazon.com/Look-Land-Lord-Northbourne/dp/1597310182`) Northbourne first translated many of Guenon's books into English, so I think it's fair to say that he also belongs to the same stream of thinking.

Concerning the somewhat tenuous links to "agents of counter-initiation", Guenon himself affirmed the validity of Freemasonry's initiation, a claim that is rather far from orthodox and might raise similar questions. We can't judge a man by one or two of his friends or by some isolated, seemingly questionable opinion he holds, but rather by the overall thrust and accomplishments of his life and work.

`Lapis on 2014-10-28 at 09:55 said:`

i dont have any problem with views you mentioned, i also support all that stuff but it is insufficient to proclaim somebody a follower of any tradition. Current Dalai Lama also supports all that but he is far from been traditional, a thing that some buddhist monks expirienced on their own skin as he tries to destroy all that is valuable in Buddhism… The Devil is a trickster. As for Freemasonry Guenon stated that only rituals are valid, but that initiation is virtual at the best, and i dont see any problem in it. As for friends of the Prince, i wil say that in my country there is an old proverb which says: "With whom you are, you are like him". And it is not question

of quantity, cause it doesnt matther if there is one or hundred of them. And if he is traditional, than which traditional doctrine is he following? That is what matters, not "stream of tought". It is not a philosophy. But if you wish to speak about thoughts and his works, then thing that shows him in his real light is his support for modern sport, an i dont want to write why is that so becouse it is obvious for anybody who is fammiliar with the traditional notion of action.

Cologero on 2014-10-28 at 10:20 said:

There is no doubt about the Prince's knowledge of, if not commitment to, Tradition.

E.g., *An Introduction from His Royal Highness The Prince of Wales* (video): http://www.sacredweb.com/conference06/conference_introduction_video.html

and *An Introduction from His Royal Highness The Prince of Wales* (transcript): http://www.sacredweb.com/conference06/conference_introduction.html

There are also the persistent rumours that the Prince is a convert to Islam. Most likely, he considers the particular traditions not to be of primary importance.

So, yes, probably he follows a "stream of thought" rather than a specific tradition, but I don't know.

Yet the role of the (future) Monarch has to be taken into consideration. He has to balance different forces within society since he would be the monarch of all his subjects. For that reason alone, he will certainly never prohibit football matches in the UK. And so on.

August on 2014-10-29 at 08:03 said:

One is tempted to expect more from men in positions of power, some kind of demonstration of conviction, if they have been touched by real knowledge of the times in more than an intellectual way. But I suppose even a Prince can, like any of us, look around and realise the futility of fighting and simply live his life.

This highlights another complication, the races of the spirit, differing between individuals, nations and so on. Awkward discussions are avoided in these more academic circles (Sophia journal, Sacred Web etc), with Guenon included because he simply cannot be ignored (though parts of his work can be, as required), while Evola, for example, is excised.

Maybe some of us have acquired such particular tastes with our favourite teachers that everything short of their firmness must necessarily strike us as bland, or compromised.

The time may come when, instead of principles, a clear statement of intent will be the discriminator.

Synodius on 2014-10-29 at 09:20 said:

"Maybe some of us have acquired such particular tastes with our favourite teachers that everything short of their firmness must necessarily strike us as bland, or compromised.

The time may come when, instead of principles, a clear statement of intent will be the discriminator."

August, you expressed really well the feeling I always got after some time of reading papers of those 'academic circles'. When I asked myself if these are the people who will help to bring about the real restoration I always just left those sites mainly because of boredom. Traditionalism can be used by current 'elites' as just another tool and compromised figures as Charles endorsing it are pointing in that direction. Personally I am looking towards Russia (not Dugin) for some lively impulse…

Cologero on 2015-01-04 at 10:42 said:

A friend sent me this link re Prince Charles:

The Philosopher Prince: http://www.theamericanconservative.com/articles/philosopher-prince/

Perhaps, given the expected new encyclical, the Prince will find himself closer to the current pope.

Tom Blanchard on 2015-01-12 at 12:26 said:

Cologero: Thanks. They will be even further reconciled when divorce and remarriage are legitimized at the second Synod on the Family session later this year..! (har, har)

Jokes aside, that is indeed quite possible. As difficult as Pope Francis is to stomach (for some of us, at least), his papacy may somehow turn out to be a net benefit for Christianity. The "super-correct" SSPX type traditionalists miss the point that since the faith has expanded beyond Europe, the answer is not to force non-westerners into European modes of worship, but to establish something along the lines of entirely separate rites for these people (if we need separate rites for the East and West of the Roman empire, how much more so should there be a separate rite for Christianity in the Philippines…). Binding peoples together in a higher unity while acknowledging their earthly diversity, this solution would allow both for the preservation of the purity of traditional European worship as well as for the rest of the world to have forms of worship that are consonant with who they are, how they experience life and spirituality, etc.

The alternative is the "lowest common denominator" approach to catholic unity, which results in the sterile, mundane, and superficial form of religion that is imposed almost universally today.

Cologero on 2015-01-12 at 16:13 said:

Tom B., those are good points and apropos of something we have planned following the upcoming Evola translation this week. Celsus defended paganism against the Christian accusation of "polytheism". His defense was that all the local cults were hierarchically arranged with the Platonic God at the top. That seems to be similar to your point. Evola will reprise that same

argument. His ineluctable problem, however, is that the local pagan cults are now all spiritually dead.

Curiously, the super-correct would regard your proposal as the LCD approach

Taivasvaeltaja on 2024-01-27 at 15:41 said:

"Deity sleeps in a stone, breathes in a plant, dreams in an animal, and comes alive in man."

– Ancient Nordic Proverbs

Preface

A universal esoteric doctrine holds that there is no such thing as inanimate nature. The different kingdoms that exist in nature are all alive in their own way, and in the kingdoms lower than man are influenced by preconscious, collective forces, which are also called mass souls. From the ancient Nordic statement above in the article, we can see what these kingdoms of nature are and how the Deity manifests in them: they are 1) the rock and mineral world, 2) the plant world, 3) the animal world, and 4) humanity. In addition to this, esoteric teaching presents the idea of the so-called fifth kingdom; in other words, we could properly call it true humanity, as the fourth kingdom is the kingdom of the animal-man. Let us briefly examine these five kingdoms of nature one at a time, and their significance in the scheme of planetary evolution.

Stone and Mineral Municipality

Nature's lowest level of development is the stone and mineral kingdom, where the Deity still sleeps completely. The Cosmic Sound, the development impulse of the Logos and world reason manifests itself in this realm motionless and stagnant, according to the initial quote, it is completely asleep. The forces that act in the stone and mineral kingdom are completely unconscious, they are animated only by the various cosmic principles and angelic forces that bring about the richness and diversity of the entire stone and mineral world. The elemental correspondence of the stone and mineral kingdom is Earth and the symbol is Square. In humans, the stone and mineral kingdom manifests itself especially in the bones. The planetary equivalent of the mineral kingdom is Saturn, which, like a skeleton, symbolizes time, aging, and death.

Flora

The next kingdom of nature is the plant kingdom, where the divine development impulse comes to life for the first time and begins to breathe, according to the quote. We can also notice in this expression how, for example, forests are generally called the lungs of the planet earth. The developmental impulse of the Logos takes its first actual living and preconscious form in the flora, where collective, cosmic forces and principles act. In the flora, for the first time, Deity can move. The diversity of nature is also an expression of the action of various cosmic forces. The elemental correspondence of the flora is Water, its symbol is the Chalice or downward pointing triangle. In humans, the plant kingdom manifests itself as a nervous system. The planetary equivalent of the plant kingdom is the Moon.

Animal kingdom

The third kingdom of nature is the animal kingdom, where the divine development impulse, according to the quote, dreams. The development impulse of Logos acts in it again a degree more freely than in the flora. This can be seen as a metaphor for how different instincts and urges begin to work in animals, which guide the animals' actions according to cosmic principles. When we look at an animal and its actions, we easily think that the animal makes its own independent decisions like a human, but in reality the animal is moved because it has no independent reason. The animal kingdom is influenced by different collective souls, which bring about the diversity of the animal kingdom. The animal's elemental correspondence is Fire and the symbol is either a Wand or an upward pointing triangle. In humans, the animal kingdom manifests itself as internal organs and blood. The planetary equivalent of the animal kingdom is Mars, which symbolizes the fire of life.

Mankind

The fourth kingdom of nature is humanity as we know it, where the divine developmental impulse first comes to life as a conscious being. Every human being has individual reason – man is a rational animal – at least to some extent, although a large number of people are still influenced by various animal drives and instincts as well as the collective impulses shared by mankind. One characteristic of humans is that each member of the human race is capable of producing reproductive offspring, whereas various members of the animal kingdom are unable to do so. So it can be said that the striving for unification affects the original dispersion in man, which is also the biological basis of brotherhood and sisterhood; certainly does not mean uncontrolled mixing. The purpose of humanity's level of development is the individualization of each person as far as possible – individuation – where collective effects are even less important. This is the freedom to which Christ sets us free – to transcendent bliss and joy. With its central role, humanity gives its own development impulse to the lower kingdoms of nature; Humanity's actions therefore have a concrete effect on what kind of manifestations appear in the lower kingdoms, e.g. the animal kingdom: for example, predators appear in the world because humanity has not freed itself from atavistic violence. 1 Humanity's elemental correspondence is Air and its symbol is the Sword. 2 Humanity's bodily correspondence is the brain. The planetary equivalent of humanity is Venus-Lucifer.

The Fifth Kingdom

The fifth kingdom is such a level of development that such a person is no longer born into the world, but influences the world from higher levels, inspiring and leading this side of humanity upwards from supersensible levels. The fifth kingdom is the level of development called the Kingdom of Heaven; the people living in this kingdom have previously been part of the fourth kingdom / animal-humanity, and through their own spiritual efforts, after countless incarnations, have reached such a spiritual level in their development that they no longer need to incarnate; they are more human than us humans living in the world, in which many animal traits still live. They have purified themselves completely, "sacrificed their inner animals" on

the altar of spiritual development, freed themselves from their karma and the compulsion of incarnation.3

However, the Master Human can also incarnate if he has a special mission in the world. Even then, he is practically free from his body, which is to him like the Master's own five-windowed House in the Lord's room, where he is free to move as he pleases. A master has a knowledge of the Buddhist field that enables many seemingly supernatural things such as telepathy, telekinesis, diamond creation, alchemy secrets – and so on – depending on his line of development and tradition. The masters guide cultural seasons, e.g. With Manu. According to tradition, there are fourteen Manus in total, and they act as the spiritual centers of each age from the supersensible levels. We can only imagine what kind of tasks the Master can assume in the spiritual hierarchy of our planet and the cosmos. They can also be called Master people – they are fully initiated into the Mysteries, liberated souls. The members of this fifth kingdom have consciously decided to remain connected to the planet earth to help all its kingdoms to develop forward – in particular they inspire the most developed members of humanity operating in the world.4 The elemental correspondence of the Master person is the so-called ether and his symbol is the upward-pointing pentagram, which has long been known as the Master's symbol. The planetary equivalent of the Master Adept is Jupiter.

1 The utopia of the distant golden age, when humanity has been freed from all violence, is expressed in the Bible with the following words: "Then the wolf will live with the lamb, and the panther will lie down next to the goat; the calf and the young lion and the bullock are together, and the little cub is shepherding them. The cow and the bear go to the pasture, their calves and cubs lie down together, and the red deer eats the fodder like a deer." – Isaiah 11:6-7

2 In the symbol we can see the connection to the principle of reason, which is depicted by the sword.

3 "In the resurrection, one does not take a wife or become a wife. The resurrected ones are like angels in heaven." – Matt. 22:30

4 This would seem to contradict what I wrote in the text Gone Fishing Beyond the Sea. Let me clarify a bit. From this very real situation, a phenomenon has arisen in the New Age, known as "channeling of ascended Masters", where a person claims to be channeling the messages of any "Master" into the world at any time. However, when we look at these channeling phenomena and the content of the messages with the right kind of skepticism, we can very well notice that it is often a question of very confused psychics and practiced by people who have very questionable tendencies towards medium-ship, and the messages concern any matter that is happening in the world at any time, which in reality expresses one's own personal and a subconscious wish for how things would be. How to distinguish true inspiration from psychic medium-ship? I would say that true inspiration is such that a person's own Ego is fully aware and awake, and such a person only so-called "opens the upper channels" to this spiritual world, from which new inspiration and information flows into him. This kind of inspiration often does not directly

concern worldly matters, but instead manifests itself as, for example, scientific breakthroughs or artistic inspiration.

5.25 Spirituality for the XXIst Century

> As the moon is the intelligible unity in the four-dimensional manifold of positions and phases, so human subjectivity is the intelligible unity in the multi-dimensional manifold of the conscious events of a lifetime.
>
> Bernard Lonergan

> Matter is essentially multiplicity and division; and this, be it said in passing, is why all that proceeds from matter can beget only strife and all manner of conflicts between peoples and between individuals. The deeper one sinks into matter, the more the elements of division and opposition gain force and scope; and, on the other hand, the more one rises towards pure spirituality, the nearer one approaches to that unity which can only be fully realized by consciousness of the universal principles.
>
> Rene Guenon

> Come Timothy Leary, crede che essere religiosi nel XX secolo senza usare l'LSD sia come pensare di studiare i pianeti a occhio nudo. [Like Timothy Leary, Philip K Dick believed that to be religious in the 20th century without using LSD is like believing you can study the planets with the naked eye.]
>
> Andrea Scarabelli, *Science Fiction and Metaphysics*[56]

[56] `http://blog.ilgiornale.it/scarabelli/2016/06/03/philip-k-dick-emmanuel-carrere-fantascienza-e-metafisica/`

> If LSD was necessary to be religious in the 20th century, then Rene Guenon is necessary to be religious in the 21st century.
>
> Cologero Salvo

Three Modes of Spiritual Recovery With the decline of religious influence in the modern world, there have been successive attempts among intellectuals to justify an alternative spiritual worldview. These are summarized as:

- **19th Century**: Philosophical idealism
- **20th Century**: Direct experience
- **21st Century**: Tradition

First in Germany, then in England and Italy, philosophical idealism served as a replacement to religious belief. This has been previously dealt with in other posts[57].

The 20th century tried to use direct experience in the manner of scientific positivism. Thus, there was an Aldous Huxley, a Timothy Leary, an Alan Watts, a Philip K Dick, or a Carlos Castanada, who relied on psychedelic experiences to break the spell of consensus reality. Channeling became popular as an alternative to ancient texts. New Thought techniques sought to manipulate the physical world in conformance with one's will. Sex Magick took the sublimation of sexual energy all too literally as a means to transcendence. Of course, an Aleister Crowley could combine all these elements into a larger system.

Both these approaches had to overturn, deny, or reject archaic traditions, yet there lasting effects have been minimal. Now that the works on Tradition by Rene Guenon have become generally available, we finally

[57] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=8366`

have a more fruitful and satisfying approach. While idealism appealed to the reasoning mind, and experience to the senses and emotions, Tradition goes straight to the intellectual center of man. Guenon gives us the key to understand religious symbols and dogmas, explains the relationship between the exoteric and esoteric, and outlines a satisfying metaphysical conception of man, God, and the cosmos.

Personally speaking, I have traveled through all these options. Living in tune with a Tradition may seem difficult today, but, judging by drug usage, suicide, and general unhappiness, life in the modern world has its own difficulties. Ultimately, Tradition is a rational, satisfying, and a fully human way to live in the world.

Thinking and Acting

> Actions speak louder than words; let your words teach and your actions speak. We are full of words but empty of action, and therefore are cursed by the Lord since He Himself cursed the fig tree when He found no fruit but only leaves.
>
> St. Anthony of Padua

> What you do speaks so loudly that I cannot hear what you say.
>
> Ralph Waldo Emerson

The American logician **Charles Sanders Peirce** in the essay *How to Make our Ideas Clear*[58], asserts that the "final upshot" of thinking is volition. That is, a clear idea is manifested in action. For example, if I really believe it will rain on Saturday, I will cancel my picnic plans. However, few people are at all self-aware about the actual content of their thoughts. A believer can justify a course of action as a manifestation of her Christian

[58] https://gornahoor.net/library/HowToMakeOurIdeasClear.pdf

beliefs while an atheist can advocate the same action on totally different principles. Hence, we can suspect that there is something deeper involved, even if unknown and unacknowledged to the Christian and the atheist.

That is because most spiritual beliefs are limited to exoteric forms, and conversions are from one exterior form to another, i.e., a horizontal move. An intellectual conversion, on the other hand, is in the vertical direction, and involves one's entire being. Hence, the interminable debates among atheists, Christians, pagans, and so on, are pointless as long as they are restricted to external forms only. Instead, discussions should be based on certain metaphysical principles and the consequences of their acceptance or denial. We will address these questions on three levels.

- **Cosmic**. These are the universal metaphysical principles that need to be considered.
- **Historical**. The cosmic does not efface the historical, so metaphysical principles do have consequences. Now Guenon accepts the unity of all Traditions, so that a particular tradition is somewhat arbitrary, at least for certain types of men.

  We are inclined, however, to Augustine's understanding that although there is but one Tradition, it is now known as the "Catholic" tradition. This we will explain and justify.
- **Ethical**. How does the intellectual conversion affect the way that life is lived?

In this post, we will deal with the cosmic aspect, with the others to follow subsequently.

Cosmic Interiority is a great mystery to most people. Seldom do they bother to examine, in an objective and detached way, their thought processes nor are they interested in the unspoken assumptions supporting

their worldviews. Typically, people are interested in the answer to the "what is" question: e.g., he is a democrat, a pagan, a Zoroastrian, and so on. Those turn out to be merely nominal associations and denote nothing consistent or transcendent.

Therefore, what is of more interest is a person's viewpoint on various metaphysical principles. A nominal affiliation, except for those who consciously and deliberately choose it, seldom serves to answer such questions. Here we will consider some of these principles, detailing the traditional view, and the implications of their denial. Of course, what follows are not arguments, but rather first principles. Either they are assumed or intuited or they are not. What is different however is this: the person who bothers to think about such principles can see clearly the effects of their denial, whereas denialists are seldom even aware of them. Hence, they often act as though the principle were true, while denying it at the same time.

Being The Universe really is One and all things are interrelated. God is the Principle of Being, so one strives to keep the awareness of Being in consciousness and to live in that presence.

The denial of Being is to assume that only beings exist. Unfortunately, neotheism, which is the belief that God is one of those beings, is quite prevalent. That assumes that God is not the ultimate principle, so neotheism does not respond to the question of Being.

Order The universe is an ordered whole. Moreover, Order, or Logos, must be one with Being, otherwise there will be a dualism between Order and Chaos.

The denial of Order means that there is just the random movement of things.

Intelligibility Since Order is inherent to the universe, the real is intelligible. Beings with an intellect, then, are able to understand the real. Whatever is not intelligible is not real. To know a thing is to know what it is.

The opposite is to regard the world of the senses as real. We can never know that world, but only discover better theories. Words are used to group things with related properties and do not point to a higher intelligible reality. Hence, entirely new classes of people are created simply by definition, with no relation to real distinctions.

Providence There is a purpose and a direction to the cosmos. We don't mean, by this, a simplistic notion of a god interfering with events from time to time, but rather a permanent, omnipresent principle. It is a responsibility to be aware of signs of Providence and to act on them.

The denial means that there is no real purpose to life. Events are the result of chance and determined physical processes. Many would include human willfulness as a factor in events. Yet this willfulness itself can have no ultimate purpose as much as it may try to live a purposeful life.

Fall of Man Without going into specific details, which will be considered in the follow up, the various traditions regard man as existing in a "fallen" state, that is, from a higher state of being. His task in life is to overcome the forces that maintain him in that lower state in order to return to his rightful place in the cosmic order.

The denial means that man is born free or perfect, and that it is society that condemns him to a lower state. Hence, if a man has certain desires or habits, these are ipso facto considered to be "good". There is no necessity for him to "overcome" anything. Rather, all efforts must be directed to changing the environment, both social and physical.

Summary What is considered to be "progress" is actually, in most cases, a regression to a more primitive worldview. Materialism, atomism, and the belief that events result from unchangeable fate, random processes, or pure will, are opposed to the process of regeneration.

Posted on 2016-06-30 by Cologero

* * *

`muaddibbr on 2016-07-01 at 09:15 said:`

When focused in the first principles one can see more easily if there is such Unity behind the exoteric veils. But Im not sure about such Unity, there are some issues to be resolved such as:

1) the question of grace

(in Islam and Christianity is clear, but how is that in Buddism? the idea of rendemption seems incompatible with their karma-chain:

"It results in a mechanistic and deistic universe where God can have no merciful, enlightening, forgiving and redeeming relationship with the worlds and the souls He has created—a universe where, because there can be no dharma, no saving Divine intervention, no religious dispensations, karma is absolute. I can neither repent, in such a universe, nor can God forgive. It was this absolutization of karma which led Mme Blavatsky (who, as we shall see, did accept reincarnation in her final work, The Secret Doctrine, despite denials by some of her followers) to hate and reject the Christian doctrine of the forgiveness of sins as a violation of the law of karma, and even to define prayer and sacrifice, conceived of as attempts to alter or circumvent karma, as acts of black magic. But to take karma as an absolute is absurd and self-contradictory. Karma, as the chain of causal actions and reactions in the relative world of samsara, is relative in essence; it can never be absolute. Every condition of causal inevitability on the horizontal plane can be compensated for by the operation of human freedom, and Divine Mercy, on the vertical one." Charles Upton)

2) the question of creation: creationism (ex nihilio) vs manifestionism (also, question of Freedom of God and His necessity to create the world).

3) the question of a 'left-hand' path: how can there be a left-hand path in religions like Christianity and Islam? The acceptance of the left-hand path is derived from metaphysiical assumptions (that one can actively destroy his ego by serving a Descrutive Principle)

Those are some I can remember now, but Im sure there is more issues on the level of first principles. And as a Christian, of course, I hold that Jesus is the Logos in flesh, there is no "exoterism" in this.

Boreas on 2016-07-01 at 12:00 said:

muadddibr, the way I personally have interpreted the law of karma and the forgiving light of grace is that karma is in the left hand of God, that is, Satan (as the third emanation of the tree of life, Binah), and grace resides in the masculine Chokmah, which I personally interpret to be the "Christ principle". One can also see that the left hand of God in this kabbalistic scheme is the "Pillar of Jugdment", which I see to be the esoteric essence of Saturn / Binah, and the Right Hand of God is the "Pillar of Mercy" that resides in the hands of Christ. By defeating Satan in the desert Christ made a perennial change in the balance of the Tree by taking the sceptre of Justice from the hands of Satan and establishing the law of grace and mercy as the highest law.

There is no question that many passages of the Bible can also be seen supporting a left hand path interpretation of things, and I don't mean this as "the devil interpreting the bible" way. There are especially in the old testament many passages of scripture that speak in the mouth of God with fire and brimstone, therefore judgement and destruction.

It is only as giving way to the entropic "anti-principle" that the destructive impulse emanating in the end from the absolute divinity with all its aspects is transformed into a downward path; but the destructive hand of Shiva is always benevolent in the end, that is, the destructive principle can also be transformed into a force in the service of the higher good.

Matt on 2016-07-01 at 18:30 said:

Muaddibbr,

Your questions and concerns have been addressed to a certain extent here on Gornahoor in past comment sections, past posts by both Cologero and Logres, and even in this very post that we're commenting on (see the reference to Augustine's idea in the bolded Historical part).

It seems (correct me if I'm wrong) that what you're getting at are the questions: is the incarnation of the Logos in the person of Jesus something unique (distinct from all the other conceptions and teachings of avatars in the other traditions) and if so, does the Christian revelation and tradition stand-out from all the others?

These are questions that I am continuing to ponder and wrestle with, and there is one answer that I find myself slowly starting to move towards. I don't doubt that the contributors and other commenters to this blog have been seriously considering the questions as well; so don't feel like you're alone with this.

We might have to look at that Unity from a different angle. Guenon's conception of this Unity was that all the great traditions contain the fullness of the Truth at their respective cores. Maybe, dare I say, that he wasn't quite correct in his conception. This again goes to the reference to Augustine contained in this post.

More light could be shed on this with the next couple of posts in this series by Cologero.

muaddibbr on 2016-07-02 at 07:55 said:

Matt,

One particularity of Christianism is that if other traditions are pure mythical, that is, a-historical (and thus they despise the historic dimension), Christianism, for its part, is actually a Myth taking place in History. So, Christianism is a fullfilment in Time of some aspects of earlier mysteries and myths: Christianism is both Mythical and Historical (is there other tradition like this?).

Jesus embodied a Myth in the Historic time (and if one will complain that maybe in other religions, like Hinduism, this also happened, I can say that no one can prove this, for they go back to ancient times where there 'records' like Christians have). Christianity made the historical time begin and thus its hard to think in mythical terms. This will be something negative for older traditions which are linked in mythical time, but I can say that without the historical time humanity would never develop some possibilites that is inherent to such thinking. Without a historical time we would never fulfill some possibilites, and the fulfillment of all possibilites is a 'law' in the cosmic process. Christianism make the mythical time disapear and to go back to mythical time is very difficult, if not impossible, for there should be a certain 'naivety' which we lost. The humanity gave one step forward the fulfillment of the cosmic process possibilites.

"The development of the old world conception thus is split. In Neoplatonism and similar conceptions of the world it leads to a concept of Christ related only to the spiritual realm, and on the other hand it leads to a fusion of this concept of Christ with a historical manifestation, the personality of Jesus. The writer of the Gospel of John may be said to unite these two world conceptions. "In the beginning was the Word." He shares this conviction with the Neoplatonists. The Neoplatonists conclude that the Word becomes spirit in the innermost soul. The writer of John's Gospel, and with him the community of Christians, conclude that the Word became flesh in Jesus. The more intimate sense, in which alone the Word could become flesh was provided by the whole development of the old world conceptions. Plato says of the Macrocosm: God has stretched the soul of the world on the body of the world in the form of a cross. (see Note 77a) This soul of the world is the Logos. If the Logos is to become flesh He must repeat the cosmic process in physical existence. He must be nailed to the Cross and rise again. This most significant thought of Christianity had long before been outlined as a spiritual representation in the old world conceptions. This became a personal experience of the mystic during "initiation." The Logos become Man had to experience this deed as a fact, valid for the whole of humanity. Something which was a Mystery process in the development of the old wisdom becomes historical fact through Christianity. Thus Christianity became the fulfillment not only of what the Jewish prophets had predicted, but also of what had been pre-formed in the Mysteries. — The Cross of Golgotha is the Mystery cult of antiquity condensed into a fact. We find the Cross first in the ancient world conceptions; at the starting-point of Christianity it meets us within a unique event which is to be valid for the whole of humanity."

– Rudolf Steiner

Max on 2016-07-02 at 19:02 said:

What is often lacking is strength of conviction to follow our hearts. If beliefs are just empty shells making no discernable difference in practice they are not worth much. This even applies to secular materialists since they do not live as they teach. The problem is an inner split of the soul that makes us divided, a defining charactersitic of the age. We often complain about how evil, wrong, boring, meaningless – whatever it is – things are, but then goes on to do the exact same things the next day as we do every day, which is a kind of sleepwalking. As long as that continues the world will eventually disintegrate by entropy since maintainance requires conscious action. This is an insight that is easily missed by the modern "intellectual" class of bureacrats, journalists and so on, since they have never had to maintain anything, giving them the personal maturity of an overgrown child.

"He who desires but acts not, breeds pestilence." -A Proverb of Hell, through William Blake

Perhaps it comes down to fear; we are afraid to live integrally. It does however not mean that we have to blindly follow every whim and desire, although leaving them buried and unexamined also becomes poisonous. What cannot be denied is not the source of desire – because it can, but that the desire is there, which is a precondition to rise above it, or to act on it if it is deemed good.

Guenon's "The Great Triad" is about the triad of Heaven and Earth with Man having an intermediate position. However that intermediariness risks making man dividedly drawn in different directions, so that his unique place and destiny could both be a potential source of disintegration or of overcoming the condition.

I have come across several fourfold visions, most recently Heidegger who suggests this: Mortals, Gods, Earth, Sky. That could be read as having to recognize and live in light of human mortality, potential divinity, transcendence and immanence.

In the "Tao", chapter 25, there are also four called "greats":

"Man is ruled by Earth.

Earth is ruled by Heaven.

Heaven is ruled by The Way.

The Way is ruled by itself."

What is described here has nothing deterministic about it since the way is perfect freedom to rule "itself" according to its nature. However, humans in their common state are ruled by earth, an affinity to humus, or the humid principle (etymologically, likely from the combination of "earth" and "wet"). Drugs as an embodiment of this humid, earthly and corrosive thing, can never go beyond that passive state. It makes explicit and reinforces the human as a slave to earth, such as in karmic relationships of cause and effect, although many apparently remain happy with that.

The Idealists as well as Phenomenology develops mortal man's faculties of reason in the context of internally evaluated subjectivity. Substance-induced experience is like Earth, a subjective experience immanent to the substantial world. Tradition on the other hand envelopes us like a distant -and unreachably high clear-blue sky. That leaves an expectancy of "gods" revealing the way, since in this view, Tradition is ruled over by Christ.

A problem with some metaphysical systems is that they seem to put the impersonal above the personal but neglects how the personal could proceed from some purely abstract architectural structure, which makes them fall near the modern rational-scientific framework, and come across a little life-less. In terms of reasoning it belongs to the level of thinking that mixing together a "primordial soup" makes life emerge on its own. Hence, either personal Being belong to the "absolute" or one would have to deny personhood in man.

In reality, when we compose a compost in our garden, life is already present to help transform the elements into humus, black earth, so it is not precisely right to say that earth causes the compost. Many humans settle into making dirt with the progression of bodily decompososition, but this is a task that worms can perform just as well, so objectively there is not that much of a difference. This is the much glorified "left-hand path": basically to produce fertilizer. Not so terribly "secret" or "forbidden" that its adherents tries to convince us of, it is rather mundane and boring to tell the truth, but I guess any crap can be sold by flashy marketing and an air of exclusivity nowadays.

Boreas on 2016-07-04 at 12:14 said:

My take is that at the moment of conception and birth of Jesus "myth entered history", and I also do not believe it was the first time in the history of the world, but maybe the grandest happening thus far, the birth of the last Avatár at moment of Winter Solstice, which again moves the birth of Christ back into the ancient seasonal mode; like we all know, Jesus was probably born sometime in the autumn or so historically, but here tmyth is more powerful and real than the temporal order of things.

This propelled the world into the darkest 2000 years of Kali Yuga, but at the same time it was the highest happening of things at planet earth thus far. The awakening of the Buddha and the life of Krishna were before this almost the same mythological structure enetering the world, but only Jesus brought the Christ into his conscious personality by fusing his own personal impulse to the Cosmic Christ, which enlightened and awakened the whole globe.

Just my two cents to your noble conversation, gentlemen.

5.26 Meditation on a World Conception

> Let no one ignorant of geometry enter.
>
> Attributed to Plato

> A little philosophy inclineth man's mind to atheism, but depth in philosophy bringeth men's minds about to religion.
>
> Francis Bacon

> Thales the Milesian held that self-knowledge is the beginning of every virtue … The man who knows himself knows that he is a rational, spiritual being, possessing the power of free choice and self-control, and hence religious, social, ethical, and in his spiritual nature, immortal.
>
> St. Nectarios, Metropolitan of Pentapolis

In his *Life of Dante*, **Giovanni Boccaccio** explained that truths may be hidden in poetry because there is value in having to make the effort to extract them. For the same reason, we read difficult works in metaphysics because working through the ideas and arguments makes them alive to us. That is why the Cliff Notes version of a philosophy, which reduces complex thoughts to a few key points, sound so shallow. Seriously, can someone learn mathematics simply by looking up the answers in the back of the book?

Let's look at another formulation of Plato's three degrees of knowledge:

- First Principles (episteme)
- Likely Stories (dianoia)

- Opinions (doxa)

Opinions refers to the mass of facts around us and ideas that pop into our minds. There are large areas in life where it is possible to live like that. Nevertheless, the more intelligent will try to organize the mass of facts by inventing a likely story, à la Sherlock Holmes, to account for all those facts.

Scientific theories are a more sophisticated version of the likely story. The scientist will develop a theory, mathematical formula, etc., to "save the appearances", i.e., to account for observed phenomena. That theory may come to be regarded as a "law of nature", objectively true, apart from human subjectivity.

However, are those laws really discovered, or are they created? For example, what is the epistemological status of Newton's theory of gravity? His system is an intellectual tour de force. In a simple formula, he related disparate phenomena such as an apple falling from a tree to the orbits of planets around the sun. It even predicted unobserved events such as a feather and a stone falling at the same rate in a vacuum. But it did not explain gravity itself.

For quite some time, educated people regarded it as an ineluctable law of nature, at least until Einstein's General Theory of Relativity overturned it. At that point, the Principia could not be regarded as revealing the ultimate secrets of gravity. Hence, it can only be a brilliant creative effort from Newton, not an objective description of reality.

Nevertheless, educated, and not so educated, people remain obsessed with the likely story. A prime obstacle to communication is that religion, myths, etc., are regarded as crude likely stories, invented to explain facts, but are now superseded by science.

This is the bottom up approach: start with the evidence of the senses and use reason to formulate a likely story. Of course, there is a pecking order to likely stories. The better ones will explain a wider range of phenomena, while the best will predict phenomena not yet observed. This

is never ending and never provides certainty, since a better story may be created next week.

The other approach is to start from the top, in the manner of geometry. There are postulates and axioms, without which, no geometry is even possible. We don't do geometry by observing triangles in nature and then formulate theories about them. Rather, the properties of triangles are deduced from the first principles; any triangles existing in nature can only be better or worse approximations of ideal triangles.

Valentin Tomberg offers us some first principles, not a theory, from which to understand the world. Their truth is revealed by meditating on them, not by blind faith, nor by doing experiments. What follows is a personal meditation, not a proof; you can try your own at home. The following three points are the foundation.

- The world is an ordered whole.
- The world order is of a moral nature.
- Mankind is called to arrange its own life in harmony with the moral world order.

The first thing to note is the simplicity of these three points. They do not require an advanced knowledge of philosophy or science to be understood. People uninterested in those endeavours can accept them, although they may need to be expressed in religious or symbolic languages.

The second thing to note is that they are universal, i.e., they should be acceptable to any of the valid Traditional religions. For example, Tao is the principle of order in Taoism, rta in Hinduism, Logos in Christianity.

Ordered Whole The world forms a unity, and everything is ultimately related, both in time and space. Even in theories of the multiverse, there are common physical laws that account for them. That is the higher unity.

Moreover, there is an order to the world. Things and events are causally related to each other. Pure chance explains nothing. Causation is not necessarily on the same level. If a visible effect seems to have no visible cause, then the cause can be traced to a higher level.

Philosophical systems like those of Spinoza and F H Bradley develop this conceptual point. However, they envision a sort of block universe which omits and denies the next point.

Moral Nature Moral convictions such as rights, duties, justice, etc., insert a new element into the block universe. They can only make sense assuming free will, i.e., the consciousness of making choices.

Such a world requires a field in which it is possible to make choices, so there must be a not-I to the I. That is, there are necessarily objects or people which can obstruct my will.

It also presupposes a knowledge of good and evil. A world with free will is not predictable by any science.

Moral World Order If minerals, plants, and animals follow laws by necessity, there are moral laws — which transcend animal existence — that may or may not be followed. One must prefer good over evil, but to prefer one thing over another is to love it.

To overcome obstacles to the good requires creativity. Hence love and creativity are introduced into the world. A world of moving atoms has no need for those qualities.

Now it is clear that such a world must necessarily exist, given the preference for the good, the existence of love, and creativity. It cannot arise by accident from a "Big Bang" or random variations. This is because:

- Being is preferable to non-being
- Order is preferable to chaos

- Beings with free will are preferable to unconscious objects

In summary, the world follows from these fundamental points; they are not part of a likely story that is formulated from observing the world.

Objections It can be helpful in your meditations to consider a world that denies any one or more of these points. Consider points like these:

- Can such a world actually exist?
- Can I live effectively and consistently in such a world?

We have examples of laws that serve as guides for living in harmony with the moral world order. Examples are those of great lawgivers like Solon, Manu, Zoroaster, Moses, and so on.

Nihilists will deny most or all of the three points. Then they need to create an alternate world conception to inhabit. You make your own choice.

Posted on 2018-09-20 by Cologero

* * *

Mikkel on 2018-09-23 at 15:22 said:

"Seriously, can someone learn mathematics simply by looking up the answers in the back of the book? "

No, but I would like it if metaphysical books had some solutions in the back when I'm working on problems to check my efforts, now that I think of it, they probably do, I need to read harder, or perhaps the tip is personal meditation which you suggested, I will try this.

"The other approach is to start from the top, in the manner of geometry."

Man and His Becoming (pg. 34): "To make a comparison with mathematics by way of clarification, it is thus that the geometrical point is quantitatively nil and does not occupy any space, though it is the principle by which space in its entirety is produced, since space is but the development of its intrinsic virtualities."

So then we must start at these intrinsic virtualities to understand, or at least we have to understand those intrinsic virtualities of a thing to truly understand/know it (not necessarily do we always have the benefit of being able to start clearly at that place, maybe too temporal a way of looking at things).

"One must prefer good over evil, but to prefer one thing over another is to love it.

To overcome obstacles to the good requires creativity."

I think to love is to want the good to be expressed, ie. To love another is to want that good to be expressed in that individual, for that individual to be expressive of the true Self, which must be good and moral (to want that for another one must also know another). This reminds me of Boethius, in that all seek the good in every action that they do, however ignorance hinders these efforts greatly. Some seek to reduce the amount of actions they take, but elimination of that ignorance is ultimately what matters. Lately many resources I read outside of this 'circle' are explaining the work of creativity and expression and their position to humanity, their arguments have an inherent assumption that these actions are good without ever stating why. The missing conclusion however, is that the good must be the end goal of these actions and should be acknowledged as such, but these actions occur from principle where it started from. Is this the from same idea as, "that which is first or greatest in the principial order is … last and smallest in the order of manifestation."

A question to this however, what aspect about creativity specifically that overcomes obstacles? or maybe…why do obstacles require creativity to be passed? Reminds me of the The Augean Stables, not any man can do it.

5.27 A Matter of Choice

> From this deeper principle you must do your works, without a why. I affirm it decisively: even if you do your works for the kingdom of heaven, for God, or your sanctity, although motivated by the other, even then you will not really be in the right. If you ask a true man, a man who acts from his depth: "Why do you do all your works?" he will answer you rightly only if he says: "I act only for the action itself."
>
> Meister Eckhart

> To prove freedom metaphysically, without encumbering oneself with all the usual philosophical arguments, it is sufficient to es-

> tablish that it is a possibility, since the possible and the real are metaphysically identical.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Multiple States of the Being*

Free will is the ability to choose the Good. But first, the intellect needs to know what is the Good, then the will is free to make the choice. This is intuitively obvious, for thought can neither be compelled or caused. Nevertheless, there are two confusions, in particular, about what "free will" is actually all about.

1. Will vs Power
2. Determinism vs Unfree Will

Will vs Power The first moment of the will arises from thought. Yet a person may not have the power to actualize the Good because of obstacles, both interior and exterior. For example, a person may be weak, or fearful of social opprobrium, and thus fails to act on what he knows to be the Good. Or circumstances may limit what is possible. In those cases, the Will must act prudently.

To summarize, the Will is free to choose, but may not always have the power to act on it.

Determinism A second misconception is to assume that the Will is unfree because it is the result solely of physical causes. Even assuming that be true, material causes cannot create thought, hence the Will can still choose the good. In the worst case, these causes may prevent the Will from acting on its choice.

When philosophers like a Spinoza or a Schopenhauer assert that the Will is not free, they mean that the Will does not choose the Good known

to the Intellect. Rather, it is subject to unknown, unconscious, or unacknowledged motivations. Hence, the Will chooses not what is intellectually good, but may choose based on animal-like motivations: fear, hunger, or the desire for sex. Or there may be strong emotional compulsions: the desire for self-aggrandizement or revenge, for example. It is unnecessary to name them all.

Purification of the Will A necessary stage of the spiritual path is the purification of the Will. In practice, this requires inner vigilance to "see" each and every influence that exercise control of the Will. Only then will it be possible to overcome such influences, which are intruders into our true Being. Ultimately, "free Will" means that our choice arises from the Self alone, not for those intruders. This can be found in serious thinkers from Eckhart, Spinoza, and even Rene Guenon in *The Multiple States of the Being*.

Posted on 2021-06-30 by Cologero

5.28 Self Knowledge

> I am worm, I am slave, I am king, I am God.
>
> Gabriel Derjavine

> The "to be silent" therefore precedes the "to know", the "to will" and the "to dare". This is why the Pythagorean school prescribed five years silence to beginners or "hearers". One dared to speak there only when one "knew" and "was able to", after having mastered the art of being silent—that is to say, the art of concentration. The prerogative "to speak" belonged to those who no longer spoke automatically, driven by the game of the intellect and imagination, but who were able to suppress it owing to the practice of

> interior and exterior silence, and who knew what they were saying—again thanks to the same practice. The silentium practised by Trappist monks and prescribed for the time of "retreat", generally to all those there who are taking part, is only the application of the same true law: "Yoga is the suppression of the oscillations of the mental substance" or "concentration is the willed silence of the automatism of the intellect and imagination".
>
> Valentin Tomberg

The theme of this past Sunday's sermon was self-knowledge. It began with the notion that we are to know, love, and serve God. The priest pointed out that we cannot serve what we don't love. Moreover, we cannot love what we don't know (except perhaps in an abstract way). These are the three forms of a Christian yoga: jnani yoga (to know God), bhakti yoga (to love God), and karma yoga (to serve God). They are also analogous to the three rules of Hermetism:

- To know
- To will
- To dare

Although "to be silent" is usually the fourth rule, Tomberg puts it first. Interior silence is the "suppression of the oscillations of the mental substance". As we learned from Plotinus, the Intellective Act cannot be known unless the soul is able to reflect it; that is, it must be free of arbitrary oscillations.

Knowledge of the Real I Hence, to know God, one must first know oneself in order to find and eliminate the sources of these perturbations of the soul. What separates Hermetism from philosophy is that the former

depends on certain exercises, not being limited to the discursive thought of the latter. For example, the traditional teaching is that the human being has, besides a physical body, three levels of the soul: the intellectual soul, the sensitive soul, the nutritive soul (although the names may be translated differently). In our work, we may use different designations for the same thing, as seen in Table 5.2:

Intellectual soul	Mental body	Intellectual Centre
Sensitive or animal soul	Astral body	Emotional Centre
Nutritive or vegetative soul	Etheric body	Motor Centre

Table 5.2: Layers of the Soul

These, then, are known, not through philosophy, science or reasoning, but rather through direct observation. To know oneself, one has to understand how each of these centres operates, and how they interoperate, in one's own life. However, the soul forms a unity, at least virtually, so there is no sharp separation. A deeper observation shows how parts of each of the souls interpenetrate each other. Thus, there is intelligence in the sensitive and nutritive souls, as well as automatic and emotional parts of the intellectual soul.

The first stage of self-knowledge is to recognize that our soul life is fragmented into a multiplicity of I's, often in conflict with each other. **Thomas Aquinas** says that "everything is knowable so far as it is in act, and not, so far as it is in potentiality [or virtual]" (Question 87). Hence, the soul cannot be known as long as it is only a virtual unity. The Real I, which exists only in potential, must be actualised. The actualisation of this Real I is an act of concentration that unites all the apparent disparate parts of the soul.[59]

[59]There are higher centres than those enumerated here, but they are not the topic of this post.

Levels of Being One then sees that there are four levels of being, corresponding to differing understanding of the I.

Absolute Consciousness	The Universal I
Consciousness of the Real I	The real individual I
Waking Consciousness	The personal I (actually, a multitude)
Subconsciousness	The physical I of the body

Table 5.3: Degrees of Consciousness

The **subconscious** is active, for example, during sleep or in the autonomous functions of the organism. It also refers to those inner acts that affect our soul life, even when we are not conscious of them.

Waking consciousness is our normal state throughout the day, as it is what we are given as fallen human beings. However, self-observation shows that this state is really not fully conscious. We can see that it seldom rises above daydreams the operate just under awareness. It is subjective, leading to features like partisanship, querulousness, confabulation, fanaticism. The deleterious effects on social life are the results of a population stuck in this state.

Self consciousness is not given to us naturally, except perhaps in unusual conditions like boundary situations or in activities requiring extreme concentration. This is the state of objective consciousness, that of the just man.

Absolute consciousness is the consciousness of the Absolute. This is how we know God. The Beatific Vision is to know God in His essence.

This state is related to the notion of *theosis*. We can start with the attributes of God, the **unmoved mover**, for example. If the actualisation of the I is deep enough, one can get a sense of what it means to be an unmoved mover: the I observes, but is not disturbed by external events.

Posted on 2018-10-10 by Cologero

5.29 The Acting Person

Before he became Pope John Paul II, **Karol Woyjtyla** wrote a phenomenological study of the *acting person*. Although academic phenomenology is idealist, Woyjtyla employed its methodology in the service of gaining a deeper understanding of some aspects of Thomist metaphysical realism. In principle, it is the proper way to proceed; metaphysical speculation needs to be grounded in experience. A written text is the final stage of a Hermetic process that **Valentin Tomberg** describes:

1. The state of concentration without effort (beyond words and thoughts)
2. Vigilant inner silence
3. The inspired activity of imagination and thought
4. The conscious self halts its creative activity and summarizes everything that preceded

The first text is mystical and symbolic. Then, it can be summarized as a system of metaphysics. We can see that in the development of the Vedanta. Rishis, or seers, at some point wrote down their experiences in the Vedas as poetry, myth, rites, laws, and so on. This was later summarized in the six philosophical schools which are based on the Vedas. But the metaphysical systems are not gnosis, rather they point the way back for us to reach that original revelation. Thus, a Hermetic phenomenology is deeper than academic phenomenology. Furthermore, it demands a change in the consciousness of the Hermetist, unlike a scientist who can learn his subject matter apart from any moral or spiritual development.

Woyjtyla's effort is promising although it falls short of leading us to a true gnosis. He focuses on the phenomenology of the person as an active agent and its relationship to the body. That will lead him to the spirit or intellectual soul[60]. It is important not to jump to a conclusion.

[60] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=3390`

Since metaphysics is the final stage in the process, it necessarily describes an accomplishment. Thus, Aquinas offers a proof of the hylomorphic unity of the human being. However, a careful observation of our inner states reveals something else. For example, we may notice inner conflicts, incompatible desires, or uncontrollable urges, for example, which belie any sense of unity. At this stage of our development, our unity is still virtual and not actual.

Thus, a fully developed phenomenology will not assume that unity at the outset, but will instead observe the activities of the intellectual, sensitive, and nutritive souls in isolation and in relationship to each other. A vigilant inner silence and concentration without effort are required to pick out these details in the stream of consciousness. This can be fruitful in many respects. One of them, which is scarcely dwelled upon, is that we can learn the states of consciousness of animals and plants. There are many stories[61] of the rapport that saints and sages have had with animals.

The Soul as Principle of Transcendence Wojtyla claims to have analyzed the person on the somatic and psychic level, yet, due to his refusal to distinguish the different aspects of the soul, he proceeds to an inconsistent conclusion regarding transcendence. He writes:

> Man had no direct experience of his soul. Experience of the transcendence of the person in the action together with all the elements and aspects of this experience is in no way equivalent to a direct experience of the soul… Both the reality itself of the soul and that of the soul's relation to the body are in this sense transphenomenal and extraexperiential.

This is man as spirit, or man as a rational animal with an intellectual soul. Spirit as subject can never be an object of consciousness; hence, it is

[61] `http://www.anaflora.com/articles/saints-sages/index.html`

never part of our phenomenal world nor of our conscious experience. Yet Wojtyla hesitates to go to the next step. This comment seems hopeful:

> The soul-body relation is intuitively given in the experience of man as a real being. In this respect the subordination of the system of integration of the human person to the transcendence of the person in the action is revelatory.

Intuition is a direct knowledge of being, beyond any conceptual knowledge. This is how man knows himself, through intuition, not as an object in the world, still less as the conclusion of a logical argument. To know is to be. Thus man knows himself to the extent that he is a real being. And he becomes a real being by actualizing his possibilities, by becoming a real man. Man's task then is to integrate himself, that is, to make the spirit the centre of his being as well as the dominant element. This is perfect, except we find this strange lapse, where Wojtyla writes:

> It is to metaphysical analysis that we owe the knowledge of the human soul as the principle underlying the unity of the being and the life of a concrete person. We infer the existence of the soul and its spiritual nature from effects that demand a sufficient reason, that is to say, a commensurate cause. In this perspective it is evident that there can be no such thing as a direct experience of the soul.

Of course, those aspects of the soul which belong to the spirit or intellectual soul — obligation, responsibility, truthfulness, self-determination, and consciousness — are not part of direct experience. Nevertheless, people do have experience of the lower soul through their thoughts, feelings, and desires. However, what is disappointing is the claim that we only infer the existence of the soul. What happened to "know thyself", or even the intuition of the soul which Wojtyla also admits? We don't and shouldn't live our life by inferring we have a transcendent and eternal

soul. We agree that the intuition of the intellectual soul in the mass of mankind for whom life lives through them is virtual, assuming it exists at all. However, we prefer the other formulation of the intuition of man's being which comes through his efforts at self-integration.

Posted on 2011-11-21 by Cologero

5.30 Moral Imagination

> The life of the image is to be drawn from within. The life of the image is to be none other than the life of imagination. And it is of the very nature of imagination that it cannot be inculcated. There must be first of all the voluntary stirring from within.
>
> Barfield, *Saving the Appearances*

Although the notion of interpretations of sacred texts at levels higher than the merely literal is not new, Owen Barfield points out that there is currently a new willingness to attend to the symbolic meaning. This is shown, for example, by the very Inklings of which he was a member. The other example is **Valentin Tomberg**'s *Meditations on the Tarot*. In these examples we see that the symbolic interpretation serves to deepen the understanding of the "literal" meaning, without the intention to refute the literal meaning with the "true" meaning.

Barfield takes this seriously enough to point out that it is actually a moral issue. Barfield explains:

> If I now maintain that these have a moral significance, and indeed a paramount moral significance, I am at once in the difficulty that the scale of values I have set up not only does not correspond with the generally accepted scale of Christian moral values, but appears to cut right across it. There are plenty of people with

> a natural taste for dream-psychology, or for art or literature of a symbolical nature, for sacramentalism in religion, or for other things whose meaning cannot be grasped without a movement of the imagination, who are arrogant or self-centred or in other ways no better than they should be. And conversely there are prosaic, humdrum, literal souls before whose courage and goodness we are abashed. It is not a happy task to have to maintain that, from one point of view, and that an all-important one, the former must be accounted morally superior.

This is because he regards stubborn literalness as a form of idolatry, hence a "sin". There are the "good" people: reliable, true, basically good, almost sinless. But Barfield asserts that the person of high imagination may be morally superior to the "good guy". An example perhaps is William Blake who regarded imagination as a virtue. Blake was certainly a rascal in his personal life, but we remember him and not his pious next-door neighbor.

The Germans have a word "verklemmt", which means "being stuck", so that the outwardly virtuous may simply be inhibited or "stuck". This is opposite to the Knight who is active in the world and nevertheless has value even if he is not so pure. Did Constantine do God's will even if he was not such a nice guy? This type goes a step further than the imaginative type, and strives to bring his imaginative vision into reality.

Posted on 2021-12-21 by Cologero

5.31 The Castaway

The fate of the explorer of consciousness is like that of a Robinson Crusoe who, castaway on an unknown island, must recreate his reality from his own resources.

The following brief, but rich, paragraph from *The Individual and the Becoming of the World* details the requirements to proceed from Stage Two to Stage Three. If we take literally the Traditional teachings that our ordinary life — if you can call our life in the Cave "ordinary" — is illusion, then all that we naively accepted as obviously true needs to be questioned and discarded. This path is only for those who "have the courage for an attack on their convictions" (Nietzsche).

> Before going further, we have to point out the necessity that this critical moment of the ideal history of the individual be brought down to and experienced in its depths. Not until he has doubted and denied everything, not until he has cut himself off from everyone, not he until has suffered the unreality of every reality, the uncertainty of every fact, the darkness of every light; not until he has destroyed every support and every haven and has realized the point of the "great alone" — not until the individual can call himself completely that, not until he is an autonomous and self-conscious being. It is this negative act, this absolute tearing of oneself away from whatever used to provide solidity and consistency — that now makes him be. Besides, according the powerful saying of Stirner, the "I" is not everything, but that which destroys everything; through this absolute negativity that tragic principle dawns in man which — as was clearly seen in Buddhism — makes him superior to the whole of nature and to the very kingdom of the "gods".

In the next segment, Evola points out that every experience is somehow one of "my" experiences. So that which is constant and unchanging among the changing world phenomena, is the sense of "I", whether implicit or explicit. Evola likens it to the Vedic concept of *ahamkara*, defined as

> I-maker. Personal ego. The mental faculty of individuation; sense of duality and separateness from others. Sense of I-ness, "me" and

> "mine." Ahamkara is characterized by the sense of I-ness, sense of mine-ness, identifying with the body, planning for one's own happiness, brooding over sorrow, and possessiveness.

So this I presupposes some other experience, that is, the experience the I is conscious of. He relates it to the Vedic teachings on the Observer ... that is never observed. The text follows:

> We can specify the place of such an "I" as follows. Every experience is inseparably accompanied by the characteristic, implicit or explicit, of being one of my experiences. The self-reference, the *ahamkara* of Vedic metaphysics, is the elementary condition, without which no reality is conceivable, since the only reality that I can concretely speak about is that which, in one way or another, resolves in one of my experiences. Now it is possible to detach this principle of self-reference from the particular contents of experiences in order to fold it back in a certain way onto itself. Thus we have: "I" equals "I", that is a bare experience, a possession, something simple and ineffable. This bare experience presupposes, in fact and by right, some other experience — one can say that it is like the cloth from which all the particular experiences are then cut out: here we have that "seeing that is never seen", that "knowing that is never known", that point of pure centrality that the Upanishads talk about, and in respect to which every particular experience, phenomenon, or thought is a "*posterius*", something that comes afterwards and remains at the periphery.

Evola then rejects all new age and philosophical teachings that postulate a "higher self" that must be reached. There is only the "I" and its experiences or representations. Evola then poses this challenge. First he points out that there can only be one such "I", and so there cannot be any other "I". Therefore, while we are accustomed to regard others as independent centres of awareness, for Evola, the "others" are again

representations, that is, objects, and not other subjects. This is a crucial challenge made by Evola, and it must be understood and seen, in order to move forward. Evola links the failure to grasp this to sentimentality or a lack of critical reflexion; complete detachment is the only way. Finally, Evola concludes:

> This is a point which it is particularly necessary to draw attention to: whoever, either because of moral and sentimental concerns — that is, reconnected to the preceding stage of natural evidence — or because of a lack of critical reflexion, does not succeed in extending doubt to the very reality of other subjects and so conceiving them as nothing other than my representations, has not truly brought that detachment, which we wrote about previously, to its limit, and so has not yet perfectly realized the pure essence of the individual. He is not yet ready for the passage to the third stage since those who have first not known how to doubt *everything*, can have absolute certainty of *nothing*.

Here again is the reminder to let go of all theories and opinions, in order to base certainty only on what the I can verify for itself. This is the Principle of Induction.

Since the "I" cannot be known as an object, Evola next describes what the "I" could be. As expected, he does not see the "I" as simply the passive observer of phenomena, but relates it to the will-to-power: the I is the centre of will. Therefore, unlike objects — which are what they are — the "I" must create itself through its activities ("self-positing"). The "I" therefore has no static being. Though not explicitly stated here, Evola has in mind the Tao of the Tao Te Ching. Hence, the activity of the "I" is the action – non action (*wei wu wei*) of Taoism.

Evola likens the transition to stage three to the fate of a Robinson Crusoe, who must now create a new world in order to survive. Once all the theories, opinions, beliefs, and creeds have been discarded in stage

two, the individual is now in a similar position to the castaway and is also forced to create a new reality:

> Therefore, moving onto the third stage, let us immediately say that in it there is an overcoming of the negative point of view connected to the arising of individuality. As one, whom an unfavourable event had cast onto a desert island, followed, after the initial shock, immediately by the will to live, must look for and create the means for a new existence, so the individual, who feels himself by this point alone with himself in the entire extent of the world, can be brought to drag out from his own interior a principle that can secure a new reality beyond the order of appearance and mere representation, in which every thing up to now had to be submerged. This principle is: **THE POWER OF CONTROL**. The "I", in fact, is not a thing, a "given", a "fact", but, essentially, a deep centre of will and power. As "I", Fichte says, it is, only insofar as it posits itself — and only a pure self-positing is, to tell the truth, its "being".

Evola now concludes the discussion of the stages before moving on to the relationship between the individual and the becoming of the world.

He points out the the awakening of the I — or "still point" — in the second stage is now understood in the third stage. This happens not through learning some theory or studying some philosophy, but rather through a process of self-analysis, that is, of one's consciousness. So, what started out (in stage one) as an independent reality is now understood in its relationship to the "I" — both as its representations and also as subject to the will of the I.

Hence, the only principle of certainty that Evola is willing to admit is what can be verified in the consciousness and will of the I.

> Through a further self-analysis, the nature of that still point, which was realized in the second stage, is revealed to be such. Now this

still point can convey is own substance to whatever lacks it,and that obviously when the various arrangements of that reality, that first appeared irrationally as raw contingency, without participation of the will of the I — almost as in a dream — get recovered in accordance with its own connection to an unconditioned assertion of the individual. What now remains is to proceed to a definition of this stage, so that the point of the present treatment is resolved, which is the relationship of the individual to the becoming of the world. In the meantime, we can specify the criterion of certainty that is called for at this point. It is expressed by the principle:

"*There is absolute certainty — and postulatable reality — only of those things, of being or non-being, of being such or being otherwise than what the I has in itself, in its capacity of control, or the beginningor cause; of other things, only to the extent of that in them which satisfies such a criterion*".

These things, which depend in fact entirely on the powerof the "I", contribute to the intrinsic evidence that is inherent in its unvarnished beginning.

Posted on 2011-02-25 by Cologero

* * *

Aidan on 2011-02-25 at 22:44 said:

Evola errs gravely where Guenon does not. In this essay, we see precisely where and how he departs from Tradition in order to embark upon a way of his own. There is a 'tradition' of such departures, of course, with which many identify and self-associate. Gornahoor appears ambiguous in this regard, blending authentic with inauthentic, at times wonderfully accurate, at other times misleading. This is surely because the works of Guenon and Evola are not wholly or even largely compatible.

It is certainly true that one must recognise ahamkara and come to terms with it. Having done so, the point is then to master and eliminate it, not affirm it. In Vedic metaphysics, although it is a relatively important centre, it is by no means ultimate. Indeed, if ahamkara is present, the

Self is not. It is astonishing to consider how perverse and self-limiting this makes Evola's version of what is at stake. This is not a minor issue but central and contextual; it is of a piece with his inversion of the relationship between knowledge and action.

The fact that there is a single 'I' does not mean there are no other subjects: it means that all other subjects are 'I'. There is a vast difference between the pathological spirit of the assumption that others are merely "representations, that is, objects" and the view that these 'others' are not just the kind of thing *I* am (i.e., other subjects) but are literally 'I'. This last perspective alone is compatible with true knowledge since it alone pertains to an order of being that is genuinely metaphysical in nature.

If I regard you as me in spirit, I will not consider you or any other in purely instrumental terms and consequently will not become ensnared in attempts at bending you, them or the world to my will. Such manipulations are paralysingly counter-productive and time-wasting at best. This leaves little to be said for fascist projects, grand totalitarian visions, and all the little 'tyrant-creators', spiritual and political, who derive heroic and noble airs from their belief in such systems. Once I know that others are 'I', I will then seek to know who I am. Knowing that, I will know who these others are and all other things in essence.

Seeing others as 'I' does not deprive these others of their own subjectivity but it does entail that their subjectivity has precisely nothing whatsoever to do with me. What this means is that subjectivity is not mine alone; only MY subjectivity is mine alone: through it, I may find my way (or lose it). There is a universality to this which transcends individuality. One can see how the soul may begin to move and the limitlessness to which it may return.

Far from ending up a castaway on a desert island – which, incidentally, is a perfect description of the interior isolation that must result from the wrong turn Evola takes – one who is upon the true path becomes the world and the world becomes a mirror in which the image of the Divine is reflected. THIS is the 'great alone'. Not only does it reconcile me with my fellows, as Christ is reported to have instructed me to be prior to approaching God, but, with Christ, I am able to say: "I and the Father are one." Horizontal and vertical are reconciled within the centre and this whole is the Heart.

Contrary to what Evola suggests about the intellectual weaknesses of those who do not follow his way, when all are 'I', this Heart is not filled with sentiment; it knows no others, being One alone. Atman is Brahman. That art thou. Is this not the meaning of the Christian injunction: "be perfect, as your Father in Heaven is perfect"?

Cologero on 2011-02-26 at 00:36 said:

Thank you for the thoughtful comment, Aiden. However, you have brought up too many issues to deal with adequately. Nevertheless, I shall try, at least, to deal with the external issues.

As for Gornahoor, we are trying to bring to light the rather complex writings of Traditional writers, particularly Guenon. We hope we are not being "original" but rather faithful to Tradition.

We also recognize that many more readers have come to Tradition by way of Evola rather than Guenon, so we take some pains to make clear what their respective positions are. We don't necessarily advocate everything we write about; our role is more educational. Perhaps you are not aware that we will be focusing primarily on Guenon's metaphysical works beginning in March. However, that will not be for public consumption and will be restricted to a private group. That ought to make clear to you where our true focus lies.

As for Evola, he is closer to Guenon that you seem to think; both Guenon and Coomaraswamy accepted him, despite some differences. The book in question was written by a young Evola who, having studied German Idealism in some depth, then discovered Guenon. Perhaps the mix of those two strands of thought is not felicitous; but to be generous, perhaps we can give him some credit for attempting to express Traditional ideas in terms that a 20th century European could understand. (By the way, the lectures we are commenting on were delivered to the Theosophical Society in Rome.)

What are the options, Aidan? Both Guenon and Evola conceded the Traditional nature of historical Catholicism, but despaired of the contemporary Church. Guenon opted for Islam, but Islam is an acquired taste. Evola tried to reclaim a Western tradition, even if not totally successfully; his refusal to follow a viable Traditional path in practice may account for some of his anomalies. By the way, Evola did write an interesting essay on what an authentic esoteric Catholicism would look like. We are working on translating that piece into English, but again, just for private circulation.

As for the facile and misleading accusation regarding Fascism, we have written about that topic more than once. I suggest you look it up and ponder it.

As for the actual content on Evola's argument: the task is more subtle than you make it sound. There is the epistemological question: how do I know other I's even exist? Presumably you know it by inference, but that is not what is meant by gnosis. Is the inability to know other I's sufficient warrant to answer the ontological question about the existence of other I's in the negative? You claim there are multiple I's; does that imply then that there are multiple Brahmans?

Also, please don't jump to the conclusion that Evola's position is egoism. There is no question here of using others instrumentally; as a matter of fact, Evola in his other writings insisted on free and organic relationships among men. If there is one "I" there is no "other"; a fortiori, there is not even an "ego" with grand projects, etc. To the contrary, the other represents privation to me, where my will doesn't extend to. Privation is a concept derived from Guenon and is a topic we shall deal with soon. It is similar to the Kabbalistic notion of tsimtsum: viz, God voluntarily withdraws to create a clearing for others to manifest.

In this context, you may want to read Guenon's essay "Is the Spirit in the Body or the Body in the Spirit?". We can't delve into it in a comment, but perhaps as a post some day. But here is a taste:

> It is indeed the spirit (Atma) that is truly the universal center containing all things; but when reflected in human manifestation it there by appesrs as localized at the center of the individuality, and even, at the center of its corporeal modality... This reflection is assuredly only an appearance, as is individual manifestation itself; this appearance is reality for it .. It is only when a being has gone beyond these limits that the other point of view becomes real for it; its center is thenceforth in the universal.

Reread Evola in the light of Guenon and you may get a different impression.

Aidan on 2011-02-26 at 20:53 said:

I appreciate your reply, Cologero, and assure you that my enthusiasm and admiration for the treasures to be found at Gornahoor will remain undiminished, regardless of how you position yourself with regard to the criticisms I have made of Evola.

I do see more than a little value in the work of Evola but confess to having concluded that his main value is as a negative example. He is an effective symbol of a way that it is better not to go. His diagnosis of the ills of modernity is powerful and accurate but we might well expect it to be, given the cue he takes from Guenon with respect to the roots of the degeneracy. It is what he decides to do about it and, indeed, how he frames things from there on, that serves to demonstrate the errors in his understanding.

The more we advance – the higher the level we reach – the more serious our errors become. As others have noted, Evola's placement of the regal above the sacerdotal is non-traditional, to say the least, and it is difficult to see how it is not fully anti-traditional in its reinforcement of the 'revolt of the kshatriyas' (a Luciferic event, if ever there was one). This undermining of brahmin spiritual authority is not a side issue; it sets the tone for what follows and is a recipe for disaster that has been followed by a variety of individuals and groups. It does not merely undermine the higher order but fully and deliberately usurps it. It is this keynote element in his work that allows so many politicals to seize upon Evola as 'inspiration' for their activities. If this usurpation is denied legitimacy, as it should be, then there is a basis for individual and collective tranquility, which is the only foundation there can be for the establishment of true order.

I am unsure why you describe my comment about fascism as an accusation. Who do you believe I have accused? I had already read some of what you have written about fascism and, since you suggest it, have reread certain essays. I accept that Evola would have considered himself above fascism and indeed all political movements, identifying himself instead with permanent principle. He was involved in the movement, however, to one degree or another (reports of the exact degree vary wildly), and that he harboured high hopes for European Fascism cannot be denied. Coomaraswamy apparently explicitly rejected it at the time and Guenon had

no involvement with it of any kind. This alone entitles fascist movements of whatever stripe to claim him as one of their own and his writings do give comfort to them. When it comes to Guenon, however, they have no legitimate claim, whatever they may think; nothing in his work endorses their understanding of the world. On the contrary, it reveals the limitations and deformities of that understanding, exactly as it does with every other non-traditional programme of thought and action.

As to the options, the ones that are available depend upon the nature of the person. Once that nature is made visible, the appropriate option will also stand revealed. How could it be otherwise?

Finally, I don't know where you found me claiming that there are multiple I's. Did I not agree, and repeatedly state, that there is one 'I'? What I did was refer to multiple subjects, multiple others, each and every one referring to 'I'. Indeed, this is why I made the above comment in the first place, to highlight the distinction between the subject and the 'I' to which it refers, and thereby demonstrate the element missing in Evola's presentation. There is an entire level missing, namely that of the soul. He is – and you are – conflating soul (subject) and Self (I).

Contrary to what Evola is saying, the existence of multiple subjects is self-evident. I am replying to you, am I not? I am assuming you also have family, friends, colleagues, correspondents, etc., each of whom is an other. I have already agreed that these others are not other I's – to think they were would be a mistake and, yes, a privation to the soul of one who took such a view (not because my will does not extend to them but because my being does not).

The fact that all subjects are I does not make them objects, however – indeed, it makes them plainly NOT objects. The difference between a subject and an object is of immense significance on a variety of levels but it is too much to go into in further detail here. Have I made it all sound too easy and straightforward? The existence of other subjects is an irreducibly simple matter; by contrast, the knowledge that all are I is beyond subtle. Everyone, apart from a few philosophers, knows the former; who knows the latter?

Although concerned at having been overly bold, I had believed my earlier comment to be quite clear. I hope I have now removed any confusions that may have been the result of a lack of clarity on my part.

HOO on 2011-02-27 at 05:09 said:

Where or when exactly does Evola undermine brahmin spiritual authority? Where does he put *mere* warriors above those initiated?

Aidan on 2011-02-27 at 12:41 said:

HOO, it is not a question of placing "*mere* warriors above those initiated". Evola looks to a REGAL initiation so sublime and glorious that it subsumes the sacerdotal function within itself (prior to the delegation of that function to those of a lesser state, i.e., priests). He looks

to a noble elite worthy of being initiated into a heroic warrior caste designed to bring about a "revolution from above".

If you doubt the words I am personally placing upon all this and think me guilty of distortion, might I offer you this address?

`http://thompkins_cariou.tripod.com/id95.html`

It should lead you to a fine site called 'Evola As He Is' and an essay by Evola called, appositely, "Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power". If you accept the argument he lays out – which expresses the general spirit of his work very well – perhaps you will not be inclined to see it as 'undermining' or 'usurping' but as a simple assertion of something true and correct. It is worth considering it from the other side, however; that is, reading Evola in the light of Guenon, as Cologero advised me to do; in other words, begin with the reverse of the proposed inversion. If Guenon is correct, what are the consequences of such a profound inversion of the truth likely to be, especially when it occurs at a level that is high but not the highest?

The divine order exists everywhere eternally in principle, even if it exists nowhere in practice for a particular time. It is certainly frustrating to live in a society in which the divine order does not exist in practice. On the other hand, what else is to be expected under the conditions of Kali Yuga? The hidden truth is that the degeneracy we see all around us is in order and must be endured. This does not mean we are to participate in its downwardness, or facilitate the spread of it. Whatever the Age, it is the task of all castes, natures and types of men to conform to the divine order in their own way, in order that it may exist in them by reflection. This is the Way and there is no other way. Every action that does not disturb this reflection is legitimate. Within the domain of such legitimacy – which is vast but not limitless – we find the noble virtues of the kshatriyas united within and beneath the regal function; this is the true solar path.

Since the ordering is obvious for those with eyes to see it, what Evola proposes is plainly a type of disorder and a serious one at that. Although it is tempting to do so, it would be unfair to sink beneath logic and seize upon the course and temporal consequences of European Fascism as 'empirical' evidence of the error, especially since Evola took both regimes to task for not being right-wing enough (hence his ability to title one of his books 'Fascism Seen From The Right'). He could distinguish himself from the fascist movement – I do not doubt that his own vision was far nobler and higher than anything to which the majority of its adherents would have aspired. Most fascists would have a hard time distinguishing themselves from him, however. For them, he is likely to remain an intellectual high water mark.

`Cologero on 2011-02-27 at 12:43 said:`

Regarding royalty. Guenon writes in "Lord of the World":

> By the Middle Ages, supreme power had already become divided be-

> tween the Empire and the Papacy. SUch a division marks an organization that is incomplete at tis head since the common principle, on which the two powers depends, is missing... In ancient Rome, on the other hand, the Emperor was alos Pontifex Maximus. The Muslim theory of the Caliphate also unites the two powers...

So Guenon and Evola agree on this issue. We wrote about this in the *Caste and Social Order*[62] and also on the *City of the Sun*[63]. So it is certainly a traditional notion.

As for Evola's undermining of spiritual authority, please post a specific reference so we can discuss.

So you and Evola agree about the singular "I". I don't understand the objection.

To repeat myself again. Evola rebutted the post WWII accusation of fascism by pointing out that his position is what every sane and well-bred man believed before 1789. Guenon's position, although he avoided political involvement, would not be much different. Nevertheless, Guenon maintained relationships with leaders of Action Francaise and allowed some articles to be published in Fascist journals. Unfortunately, the Traditional worldview looks like the caricature of Fascism that everyone seems to believe. Specifically, any nostalgia to "throne and altar" is today rejected as "Fascist" (although it is not). That is why Guenon is falsely associated with Fascism, although that would be his position.

Again, we must repeat ourselves: different perspectives are appropriate to different castes. Guenon writes as a Brahmin, cold and austere. His goal is complete transcendence; hence his retirement to a life as an Egyptian peasant, where he lived with the idea of the Caliphate, Sharia Law and an esoteric Sufi Order, things he could not find in Europe. Most types are left cold by Guenon.

Evola writes as a Kshatriya, with passion and vigour. His goal is the True Man. Unlike a world-rejecting Guenon, his task is precisely involvement with the world; it is his Nature. As such, he must deal with the world as he finds it, not as he imagines or wishes it to be. It is always a dirty step to apply principles — which are absolutely true — to specific situations, which are necessarily ambiguous, dark, and uncertain. Give the guy some slack.

`Will on 2011-02-27 at 12:44 said:`

I don't think it's accurate to say that Evola championed the Ksatriya caste above the Brahmin. He identified himself with the Ksatriya caste, but what he championed was a notion of Regality which does not fit neatly into the Vedic caste system. It seems to be related to the Indo-European tradition of the King-Magus, as elaborated in the works of Georges Dumezil. He wanted a ruler

[62] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1698`

[63] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=518`

who embodied both temporal and spiritual power – that was his idea of Ghibellinism. I interpret his concept of solar regality as non-dualist – it rejects the duality of action and contemplation.

One can see this in his own life. Evola was the least bookish of the major traditionalist writers, opting instead for mountain climbing, military service, and leisurely strolls through war zones. All of that in addition to being incredibly learned. He seems to have attempted to embody the virtues of both action and contemplation in his life. How successful he was is perhaps open to debate, but it seems to me a noble attempt.

The ancient Greek tradition of dual kingship is relevant here. The Spartans kept this tradition up until the time of the Peloponnesian War or so. While Sparta is mostly remembered for its military prowess, it should be noted that they were also thought of as the most religious of all the Greeks. The Spartan ideal of embodying both virility and wisdom is what Evola championed.

I'm not sure how that would fit into the traditional caste system, or if it does at all. But I suspect Evola's fondness for Buddhism is a factor here as well. The Buddha was a ksatriya, but by attaining supreme enlightenment, transcended the caste system altogether. Evola wrote that there were two ways to be outside the caste system: as a pariah, lower than even the servile caste, or as a transcender, higher than even a Brahmin. The Buddha was the latter, and was called a cakravartin and a universal monarch.

So to say that Evola's views are anti-traditional seems to go with Guenon's original position that the whole Buddhist tradition was anti-traditional. But of course he later changed his mind about this, thanks in large part to Ananda Coomaraswamy and, if I remember right, Marco Pallis.

Aidan on 2011-02-27 at 13:57 said:

The issue is not whether the two functions – royal and sacerdotal – can be united within a single Person. As you point out, they can be and have been. The issue is the relationship of the two functions to the original principle within which they are essentially undivided and, consequently, their relationship to each other in an apparently divided state. Only by the light of this first principle can we see whether the different functions are being discharged correctly in practice.

I don't think I can be any plainer than I have been so am happy to withdraw into silence at this point. There is no sense in repeating ourselves.

Thanks for the observations, Will. I would only add that few if any of the great teachers were still warriors once they had become great teachers, Socrates included. This is because they were now teachers and their function had changed. (If anyone cites the Bhagavad-Gita in support of Evola's world-order – as Evola himself did – note that it is Arjuna, the Kshatriya, who is under instruction.) If you transcend the caste system, you cease to be of the caste from which you came. In Vedic terms, those who stand outside caste due to having transcended all conditions are known as jivan-mukti, of whom Sri Ramana Maharshi is a notable Twentieth Century example. These ones are capable of teaching the teachers. Since they are in themselves

the fulfilment of that toward which the brahmin is oriented, it is reasonable to look to them for ways to counteract the effects of brahmin degeneracy.

Forgive me if I now withdraw from further comment. I do not wish to draw you away from your purpose at this site and have my own duties to which I must attend. Many thanks for the depth of consideration given to my possibly impertinent remarks.

HOO on 2011-02-27 at 15:29 said:

Often seeen and predictable Guénonianist prejudice and veneer.

´The brahmaa caste is habitually thought of in the West as a "sacerdotal" caste. This is true only up to a certain point. In the Vedic origins the type of Brahman or "sacrificer" bears little resemblance to that of the "priest" as our contemporaries think of him: he was, rather, a figure both virile and awful and, as we have said, a kind of visible incarnation in the human world of the superhuman (bhu-deva). Furthermore, we often find in the early texts a point where the distinction between the brahma—the "sacerdotal" caste—and the ksatram or rajam—the warrior or regal caste—did not exist; a feature that we see in the earliest stages of all traditional civilizations, including the Greek, Roman, and German. The two types only began to differ in a later period, this being another aspect of the process of regression that we have mentioned.´ Evola, "The Doctrine of Awakening" p. 28

kadambari on 2011-03-03 at 09:05 said:

HOO,

Great comment, you have some insight. As you can see, most people bandy the terms "Vedic caste system" without a clue as to its origins or what it stood for and what it means... .

5.32 The Purpose of Life

> We experience the reality of God not as something indefinitely divine, but we are conscious of Him as He really is, all-perfect or absolute. And our soul too is revealed to us in our inner experience not merely as something distinct from material facts, but as a positive force which struggles with the material processes and overcomes them.
>
> Vladimir Solovyov

It would be quite strange in our time for people to be wondering how to make fire or use a wheel. Some things are simply settled. Yet, a great

number of people are still searching for the "purpose of life", wandering aimlessly like a lion on the savannah. And most of those who are not searching, most likely have not even given it a thought.

This is despite millennia of religious, philosophical, and scientific movements, each of which makes a claim to reveal the true purpose of life. This smorgasbord of options is hardly a boon to the many seekers, but rather a burden. It would be impossible in a lifetime to study each particular religious tradition, along with its various aberrations and variations, in order to arrive at some "objective" conclusion. This is not merely an intellectual problem, but more importantly, a religious tradition can only truly be known from the "inside", i.e., by participation. Paradoxically, then, a seeker must make a commitment prior to any confirmation.

The end result is a battle of worldviews, each claiming exclusivity. When restricted to the intellectual plane, the infinite conversation or debate arises, with no possibility of resolution. Undeterred, those who choose to engage in that endless chitchat, hope beyond hope to find the ultimate "defeater", the *bon mot*, that will force the rival to surrender. Hence, there is the unending drama of conversion, apostasy, heresy, and back again. One's identity becomes raveled in an external thought form, with its highest expression in code words and intellectual "tribalism", or even facebook "likes".

The esoterist, however, having passed through the first trial, has given up all such thought forms. With the consciousness emptied of all clutter, the esoterist sees that objective truth can be found in one's subjectivity. Hence, the task no longer takes the form of an intellectual debate, but rather that of true intellectuality based on intuition, and is more like "seeing" than "thinking". We will see then that:

The purpose of life is realized in the process of manifesting God in matter.

The Reality of the Moral Order **Vladimir Solovyov**, in *The Justification of the Good*, developed a useful schema for this task. Note, first of all, that this schema is independent of any particular thought form or worldview. Rather, it is something that can be observed in one's consciousness and each kingdom, or stage, represents a particular state of being. This is a very rich representation, which I am integrating with a Traditional metaphysic.

This involves the moral order, since it depends on action, and not on passive contemplation. As the motto above shows, Solovyov accepts **Giambattista Vico**'s *verum factum* principle: truth is known through creation, not through observation. In short, it requires an act of will. After all, who knows the way to San Jose: one who has contemplated it on a map or the one who has actually made the trip?

Solovyov identifies the traditional five kingdoms, as shown in table 5.32. Associated with each kingdom, is a moral imperative. Of course, this imperative is not imposed from the outside, but rather arises out of the very nature of the state of being.

Kingdom	Imperative
Mineral	To be
Vegetable	To live
Animal	To be conscious
Human	To be rational
Divine	To be perfect

Table 5.4: States of being.

That is the exoteric viewpoint. Analogous to it, these kingdoms correspond to the various strata of the soul, as we have indicated many times; that is the esoteric understanding of the schema. Various worldviews can then be categorized by combining one or more of the kingdoms into one. Some examples follow:

- Exoteric religion sees the Divine as distinct from creation, which comprises the other four; i.e., the dualism of the Kingdom of God and the Kingdom of this world.

- Taoism distinguishes between the Triad of Heaven (Divine), the Human, and the World (the other three).

- Scientific materialism only recognizes the mineral kingdom and understands life as complex crystals.

- Naturalism regards the human state as part of the animal kingdom and is unaware of the Divine.

Actualization In Guenon's terms, we see the two tasks of salvation and liberation in this schema. At the human level, a man's task is to actualize all the possibilities available to him qua man. This involves bringing the rational into manifestation. Obviously, by "rational" we do not mean its modern corruptions as mere critical thinking or empty logical analysis. Rational means to be in conformity with the Logos, both exoterically as the structure of the cosmos and esoterically as the Logos is born in consciousness.

The actualization of the Divine, or *theosis*, is the actualization of all possibilities. Solovyov describes it this way:

> The Kingdom of God consists of men who have ceased to be merely human and form part of a new and higher plane of existence in which their purely human ends become the means and instruments for another final purpose.
>
> The stone exists; the plant exists and is living; the animal lives and is conscious of its life in its concrete states. Man understands the meaning of life according to ideas; the Sons of God actively realize this meaning or the perfect morel order in all things to the end.

Of course, the Sons of God are the "elite" as Rene Guenon defines them. The elite are not part of the kingdom of man, specifically, they are not strong men or rulers on the human plane. Rather, the Sons of God transcend the human, all-too-human, plane.

This is clearly just a cursory summary and we will develop the consequences more fully in subsequent posts. Meanwhile, I am sure that this will provide a rich source of meditation for the reader who is motivated to grasp these states of being fully in his own consciousness.

* * *

Matt on 2014-02-21 at 14:29 said:

"At the human level, a man's task is to actualize all the possibilities available to him qua man."

From a Thomistic perspective, Guenon's possibilities of man can be referred to as the virtues – the expression of the human essence as a being who can distinguish the good from evil, truth from error and keep the good and true while avoiding that which is false and evil. I think a lot of people that first discover Guenon's works make the error in thinking that the actualization of all the possibilites of man means "engage in anything that an individual can engage in"; those who are young are probably more prone to that error (I know I was). That is why engaging in an evil is not a real possibility of man, as that would be a privation/defect, not a possibility/power available to man as man.

I apologize if that all seems redundant; but I thought it could be helpful to new readers of Guenon.

Looking forward to the subsequent posts.

White Rabbit on 2014-02-21 at 18:45 said:

Am I right in taking away that actualizing one's possibilities is the same as living in accordance with one's own nature or "being oneself"?

Cologero on 2014-02-22 at 10:02 said:

Of course, you are correct, White Rabbit. However, "living in accordance with one's own nature" cannot be taken for granted because our own nature is opaque to us. It is something we have forgotten and our task it to remember it through self-knowledge. This first requires a process of purgation, in which we discard all our false self-images.

Then there is yet a stage beyond that, suitable for the intrepid. And that is to transcend the human state altogether.

George on 2014-02-23 at 16:46 said:

How does one begin the process of purgation? Is this where disconnection from our sinfulness through the sacraments such as confession may be necessary?

Cologero on 2014-02-23 at 17:08 said:

It is necessary, George. As the recent letter from Guenon that we translated here pointed out, participation in the rites is proper; ditto for Tomberg. Nevertheless, we are interested in the esoteric path. So perhaps a re-reading of The Divine Comedy would help, provided it is interpreted as a description as one's own tendencies (remember *Berdyaev on the noble quality*[64]?). Then the path through hell is understood as a journey through one's own states of being.

God willing, the next blog after Gornahoor is complete will be devoted to that topic.

Paulo on 2014-02-26 at 12:07 said:

"Rational means to be in conformity with the Logos, both exoterically as the structure of the cosmos and esoterically as the Logos is born in consciousness."

To"reach"this state,it is not a matter of doing something,surrender is the case,even accepting the desire to be something special and transcending him!

White Rabbit on 2014-03-22 at 02:55 said:

Cologero: does sex need to be 'discovered', or is that an exception?

Cologero on 2014-03-23 at 10:00 said:

White Rabbit: I think you posted this comment to the wrong blog by mistake ... I, too, have been victimized by my own "fat fingers". I don't see the context in this particular post that mentions neither "sex" nor "discovering". Probably it needs to be "undiscovered" as in *The Test*[65] described by Miguel Serrano.

Nevertheless, I am letting the comment slip through since we have been building up that topic starting with *Interview with Aphrodite*[66]. We will follow this up with some more translations from Evola on the whole Man/Woman thing, some insights from Tomberg, and finally come to a conclusion about the "Divine Feminine".

Thank you for your support and interest.

[64] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7134

[65] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=70

[66] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7197

White Rabbit on 2014-03-23 at 15:52 said:
Well, I was thinking that gender is an aspect of one's nature that is already known.
Thank you for the answers.

Boreas on 2020-02-19 at 13:21 said:
There is blessing in not being given the right to choose. I've been for years torn between conflicting viewpoints and theories and it can be very stressful and consuming.

Will there come a day when the Sons of God rule the earth or is the wish for it longing for some never to be realized utopia?

5.33 Walking out of the Forest

> Flectere si nequeo superos, Acheronta movebo.
>
> Virgil

> formans lucem et creans tenebras, faciens pacem et creans malum:
> ego Dominus faciens omnia haec.
>
> Isaias 45:7

When Dante found himself lost in a forest, he had to rely of a pagan, Virgil, to lead him out. Specifically, it was not a catechism, not a prayer, i.e., not anything supernatural that he relied on. Virgil led him through the most terrifying part of the journey, through Hell.

Virgil resides in Limbo, where he would experience the natural happiness of the pagans. However, the mission of Christ was to restore the human state to that before the Fall, which is supernatural happiness. With roots more than 10 centuries before the founding of Rome, there was some tension in grafting that older Tradition onto the newer ones of Rome, not to mention the rest of Europe.

Now that the essence of Christianity has been lost, it appears alien. Even soi-disant "conservative Catholics" have no experience of Medieval Catholicism and would probably reject much of its worldview.

Heaven and Earth

> In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.
>
> Moses, *Genesis 1:1*

> The nameless is the origin of Heaven and Earth.
>
> Lao Tzu, *Tao Te Ching 1:3*

Moses (1393 BC – 1273 BC) and Lao Tzu (~ 500 BC) seem to be onto something here. The same insight from vastly different space and time shows that is it not a vague dogma to be believed, but rather a deep truth. Nevertheless, it is often poorly understood, so it should be meditated on, for as long as it takes. It holds the secret behind vertical thinking (as opposed to horizontal). Its analogues are essence/substance, idea/form, ideal/real, Purusha/Prakriti, thinking/sensing, the worlds of Being and Becoming.

Being and Beyond Being

> Heaven and earth do not act from any wish to be benevolent; they deal with all things as straw dogs are dealt with. The sages do not act from any wish to be benevolent.
>
> Tao Te Ching

This calls for a decision. According to **Rene Guenon**, Being is the first affirmation of Beyond Being (or Non-Being), and any moral considerations are out of place (as described by Lao Tzu). That seems to be what Moses revealed: God is Being. Yet, Plato claimed that the Good is ultimate, not Being. And St. John takes a stronger position that God is Love. **Valentin Tomberg** raises this question:

> Yet what is the full significance of the adoption of the primacy of being, instead of that of good, or according to St. John, that of love? The idea of being is neutral from the point of view of the moral life. There is no need to have the experience of the good and the beautiful in order to arrive at it. The experience solely of the mineral realm already suffices to arrive at the morally neutral idea of being.

The universe of Being is the tour de force of physics and mathematics. However, it is a universe without love, without life, without consciousness, and without moral life. Those are all mysteries without explanation for science. Nevertheless, the scientist himself experiences all those things.

The universe of Being suits minerals but omits the human. Hence, it is more appropriate to say that Being is the first affirmation of Love, or the Good.

Infinite Possibilities

> It is of the essence of spirit to embody itself.
>
> Robin Collingwood

The realm of ideas subsists in the mind of God. This accounts for the Infinity of God, since there is no limit. There are two kinds of ideas:

- Possibilities of non-manifestation

- Possibilities of manifestation

The possibilities of manifestation are actualized in existence, at some level (not just the physical level). Obviously, no all possibilities can manifest at the same place and time; they need to be compossible with each other. That is why events are restricted to definite times and space.

Now, a possibility of manifestation must manifest, otherwise the idea makes no sense.

The possibilities of non-manifestation can never be actualized in existence. For example, there are logical contradictions; also, the Void and Silence cannot be manifested because they are the opposite of being.

Free Will and Necessity Intelligence is the ability to make choose one's ends and the means to achieve them. That is practical reason and is a requirement in the world of Love. This not true of the world of Being; robots, for example, are minerals and act out their prior programming.

Free will is not the power to act arbitrarily, as, for example, in the manner of a Sartrean existentialist. In one of his novels, a character drove a knife into his hand just to demonstrate his freedom.

Hence, free will is the power to act from one's essence. Its opposite is compulsion from outside oneself. As a man develops his essence, he becomes purer, and his will becomes more free.

So free will is not simply the power to make choices. *A fortiori*, this is true of God. To imagine that God is eternally making choices is to attribute to him a gnomic will.

Evil and Privation The idea the evil is not a positive quality is confusing to many people who might bother to think about it. They think it means that evil is imaginary or its effects are not real. Rather, it means that evil is the absence of goodness.

Compare, for example, the notion of darkness, which is the absence of light. If you carry a torch to try to find the dark, you will never succeed.

Before you go to sleep at night, you don't turn on the darkness, instead you turn off the light.

Evil is what remains when you don't choose the Good, whether out of weakness, ignorance, malice, or cupidity. It follows, then, that if everyone were Good, there would be no evil. Hence, evil has no being in itself.

Natural Evil It is difficult to understand what this could even mean. Nature is the world understood by science, i.e., the world of Being. Scientists seek to understand its laws and causes and moral considerations are never part of their equations.

If a giant meteor crashes into the Moon, leaving a crater, no one describes that as a "natural evil". However, if it crashes into Tokyo, killing hundreds of thousands or people, then the description might change.

There is no agent in natural phenomena, so there can be no question of morality. Rather, it is up to science, technology, and engineering to learn how to deal with disastrous natural events. For example, better predictive models, sounder building techniques, medical advances, and so on, are the appropriate responses.

Pain, Suffering and Hell For the secularist, pain and suffering are the worst things that can befall a human being. Not to diminish the horror of intense suffering, we affirm instead that the pains of Hell are much worse. Transient human suffering pales in relationship to the loss of one's soul.

Appendix St. Ambrose: Concerning repentance (Number 27)

What the Apostle means by the rod is shown by his invective against fornication, his denunciation of incest, his reprehension of pride, because they were puffed up who ought rather to be mourning, and lastly, his sentence on the guilty person, that he should be excluded from communion,

and delivered to the adversary, not for the destruction of the soul but of the flesh. For as the Lord did not give power to Satan over the soul of holy Job, but allowed him to afflict his body, so here, too, the sinner is delivered to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the serpent might lick the dust of his flesh, but not hurt his soul. Let, then, our flesh die to lusts, let it be captive, let it be subdued, and not war against the law of our mind, but die in subjection to a good service, as in Paul, who buffeted his body that he might bring it into subjection, in order that his preaching might become more approved, if the law of his flesh agreed and was consonant with the law of his flesh. For the flesh dies when its wisdom passes over into the spirit, so that it no longer has a taste for the things of the flesh, but for the things of the spirit. Would that I might see my flesh growing weak, would that I were not dragged captive into the law of sin, would that I lived not in the flesh, but in the faith of Christ! And so there is greater grace in the infirmity of the body than in its soundness.

Posted on 2020-04-05 by Cologero

5.34 Selfless Service to Humanity

> There is a fundamental unity underlying the Logos, man and world. The world is in existence because the Logos has willed it so. It is His Will that holds it together. Man strives to gain union with God; and when this union is achieved, the individual will merge in the mighty Universal Will. When this is achieved, will the individual say:
>
> "I shall do no Action and I shall not help the world" — the world which is, because the Will with which he has sought union has willed it to be so?
>
> I have thus solved the question for myself and I hold that serving the world, and thus serving His Will, is the surest way of salvation;

> and this way can be followed by remaining in the world and not going away from it.
>
> Bal Gangadhar Tilak, *The Secret of the Bhagavad Gita*

Bhagavad Gita Tilak was well respected by both Guenon and Evola, primarily on the basis of his *Arctic Home in the Vedas*. He also wrote an extended commentary on the Bhagavad Gita, which he saw as a call to action, rather than to enlightenment or devotion. In his words:

> The conclusion I have come to is that the Gita advocates the performance of action in this world even after the actor has achieved the highest union with the Supreme Deity by jnana or bhakti. This action must be done to keep the world going by the right path of evolution which the Creator has destined the world to follow. In order that the action may not bind the actor, it must be done with the aim of helping His purpose, and without any attachment to the coming result.

His point is that while *jnana* (knowledge) and *bhakti* (love) apply to God and Man, the third term of the triad, the World, is left out, unless action in the World is also part of the teaching. So, in opposition to most commentaries on the Gita, that claim that the jnana and bhakti lead away from involvement in the world, Tilak claims the opposite, that the way of jnana and bhakti should indeed lead toward action in the world.

Of course, such action should be selfless, not in the sentimental or altruistic sense that is common today, but rather in the sense that the action follows from the Will of God, not one's personal will residing in soul life. (We have been calling this the True Will.) Such action is detached and not attached to the fruits resulting therefrom. This means, in particular, that such action is free and arises from one's very nature and does not conform to any external system or code of morality. Selfless actions, then,

may sometimes appear to be cruel and immoral from the all-too-human perspective. Thus, the executioner may be providing a more selfless service to humanity than a worker in a soup kitchen, provided he acts with the correct attitude: without resentment, vengeance, or sadistic pleasure.

Modes of Spiritual Realization In the essay *Modes of Spiritual Realization*, **Frithjof Schuon** takes up this theme and clarifies some points. First of all, the three modes of knowledge, love and action are not coequal, but rather have a definite relationship to each other.

Knowledge Knowledge, or gnosis, is knowledge of principles, and hence is "completely independent of any doctrinal formulation." The *jnani* contemplates transcendent realities as his natural state of consciousness. He possesses the Truth in an active manner, that is, he is capable of "expressing it spontaneously, in an original and inspired manner."

Love The *bhakta* "obtains everything by means of love and Divine Grace," so that the doctrinal concerns of the jnani are not as important. Love and beauty is his path. Again, this is not sentimentalism. A man loves his religion, his country, his comrades, his family. He absorbs his religion, which "thinks for him", through its symbols, scriptures, and rites, for which he shows devotion. Love and gnosis are not two separate paths, nor is love subservient to gnosis, for they arise from the Divine Intellect. Neither is discursive, but in relation to the intellect one is active and objective, the other passive and subjective.

Action Unlike gnosis and love, action does not have its sufficient reason within itself, but depends on the other two to give it meaning.

> The path of action refers to the Divinity's aspect of Rigor, whence the connection between this path and fear; this aspect is mani-

> fested for us by the indefinity and ineluctability of cosmic vicissitudes.

Action, then, as Rigor, is an expression of the left-hand path of the Kaballah. Schuon claims that the goal of action is liberation from the cosmic vicissitudes and the goal of gnosis is liberation from Existence itself. This is where Tilak and Schuon seem to part ways, since for the former, the achievement of gnosis is expressed in action. Yet Schuon asserts that "action must be envisaged as the accomplishment of the dharma, or duty of state, which results from the nature of the individual and it must consequently be accomplished, not only to perfection, but also without attachment to its fruits." Nevertheless, Schuon rejoins Tilak when he says that action is inevitable, even for the one following the path of contemplation. Therefore, there must be a path that "is followed in the midst of worldly occupations."

Selflessness Schuon list three conditions of selfless action.

- *Necessity:* The activity is a necessity not a caprice.
- *Sanctification:* The activity is offered to God out of love for God and without rebelling against destiny (*amor fati*).
- *Perfection:* The activity must be perfect as to its means, its ends, and the activity itself.
  - The activity must be proportionate to the goal to be achieved
  - The means must also be proportionate (skillful means)
  - The result must satisfy the necessity that gave rise to it

Note the difference from "altruism", or a false idealism, that Schuon describes as "stupid and criminal". Such an idealism does not realize that

some things are simply unavoidable. As for Jesus' command, "love thy neighbor as thyself", he did not mean more than thyself, nor did he imply not to love oneself. The logic of altruism harbours an inner contradiction. If Peter gives Paul his last morsel of bread out of altruism, then Paul will return the morsel for the same reason. Hence, they are at an impasse.

Posted on 2011-02-01 by Cologero

* * *

kadambari on 2011-02-08 at 09:48 said:

2.Note the difference from "altruism" or an false idealism that Schuon describes as "stupid and criminal"

How much damage has been done in the world in the name of self-righteous altruism... Yes true altruism can only take place amongst "equals"... just as true friendship as Aristotle notes in the section on friendship in the Ethics can only take place amongst "equals" (intellectually and morally speaking).... Also genuine compassion towards others is only possible by a noble character which requires correct habits and proper upbringing in childhood...

Jüng Memez von Pepefeels on 2016-02-21 at 21:44 said:

"The conclusion I have come to is that the Gita advocates the performance of action in this world even after the actor has achieved the highest union with the Supreme Deity by jnana or bhakti."

"Even"? Post-enlightenment there is nothing else left to do!

5.35 Indispensable Spiritual Qualities

Frithjof Schuon concludes the essay *Modes of Spiritual Realization* with a succinct description of the "qualities that are indispensable for spirituality." In preparation, he criticizes both **moralism** and **rationalism**.

Moralism Moralists, or humanitarians, are "indignant over the indifference which the saints — both western and eastern — show towards human misery," but do not understand the reasons why.

- Many of the miseries in the traditional world are lesser evils since some calamities are inevitable. The moralistic and humanitarian modern men, in their frenzied activity, fail to grasp that some events simply cannot be avoided. The artificial suppression of such events results in worse unintended consequences.

- The saints are indifferent to contingent events because they desire to deal with evil at its root by returning to the Source, not by dissipating energy in illusory efforts.

Contingent evils may be ameliorated, but Evil itself is unavoidable. Christ healed the sick, but did not eliminate sickness itself.

Rationalism Newcomers to Tradition assume it is just another philosophical position to be debated, supported, or refuted in thought. They cannot conceive of anything deeper and thus completely misunderstand Tradition. Schuon explains:

> In metaphysical knowledge, reasoning can play no other role than that of occasional cause of intellection; the latter intervenes in a sudden, not continuous or progressive, way as soon as the mental operation, conditioned in turn by an intellectual intuition, possesses the quality or perfection that makes of it an effective symbol.

That is, one "gets it" in a flash; one is not convinced by a proof or the accumulation of evidence. Rationalism, on the contrary, looks for Truth as a formulation of thoughts; it rejects a priori the possibility of a higher

knowledge or gnosis beyond thought. Yet any mental formulation of the world cannot be the world itself, just as the map is not the territory.

The Rationalist tries to find a standpoint outside the world, from which to formulate a picture of the world, so he necessarily leaves himself out of his own picture! But, Pure Truth is identical with that which is, and thereby includes the thinker.

Qualities There are three qualities the Schuon considers indispensable for spirituality.

Objectivity This is a perfectly disinterested attitude of the intelligences that is free from ambition and prejudice, hence accompanied by serenity.

Magnanimity This is nobility or the capacity of the soul to rise above all things that are petty and mean.

Simplicity Man is freed from every unconscious complex or compulsion stemming from self-love. He is without artifice, pretension, ostentation, dissimulation, and pride.

Obviously, these qualities are irrelevant to the thinker, the philosopher, the politician, the activist, the scientist.

Posted on 2011-02-03 by Cologero

* * *

Jason on 2011-08-12 at 08:29 said:

I normally prefer Guenon to Schuon, but he's spot-on here.

I haven't read enough of him to know the answer, but what of the Christian doctrine of the second coming, that sickness and Evil itself will be eliminated at a yet-future time?

I am not convinced that the eschaton as it is understood in Christian theology actually means the end of struggle. It is certainly not the end of work, if the imagery in Revelation 22

of the kings bringing the "glory of the nations" into the Heavenly City is to be understood (as I understand it) as human creative activity becoming a part of the City.

Perhaps it might be more pertinent to say that "Evil" is not this metaphysical, moral wrongness we in the West often ascribe to it, but more of a struggling – that which we overcome to achieve a meaningful life.

6

A Commentary on The Individual and the Becoming of the World

6.1 Cosmic Dignity

This is a brief outline and summary of the first part of "The Individual and the Becoming of the World"[1]. Although its point can not be made by means of a logical argument, perhaps a logical argument can lead one to see the point.

Quest for certainty involves direct intuition The problem is stated in terms of the quest for certainty. Following the traditions of the rishis of the Vedic period, Evola claims that certainty is achieved via an "intuitive" knowing, that is, a direct perception into the nature of reality. Again, like the rishis, such knowledge has its source in consciousness itself, since it is only the contents of my consciousness that I can know directly.

[1] http://www.gornahoor.net/Individual/index.htm

Aware of objects as representations in consciousness Starting with that observation, I notice that what is called the "real" or "objective" world is what is presented – or re-presented – in my consciousness. Objects, then, are whatever, in my experience, seems to resist me. For example, I see my desk, I notice its colours, it is firm to my touch. Yet it resists my direct will, so I call it a "desk". However, there is no rationale to posit the existence of a "real" desk, in addition to the "desk" represented in my consciousness, so that the former is somehow the "cause" of the desk in my consciousness.

Self is not an object but rather the constant in every act of consciousness Besides the objects represented in my consciousness, I become aware of my self as subject. This self, however, is not just another one of those objects present in my consciousness; rather it is the constant presence in the flow of phenomena in my mind. It is not experienced, then, as an object, but as the subject.

The world is the result of my will. I further note that I can act upon certain objects in my consciousness. This power to act and control I call my "will".

My will can be spontaneous. If the world is my self and its representations in consciousness, then clearly it is "I" who creates it, that is, who creates its appearance in my consciousness. This is easier to see in a dream; in a dream there are things and other people. Nevertheless, clearly it is my own mind that is creating the appearance of those other things and persons in my dream consciousness. It is doing so, however, "spontaneously", without the conscious intervention of my "I". Hence, even in my waking state, I am creating the world arising in my consciousness, albeit spontaneously.

Or it can be free and create knowingly and purposefully. When the will is free, it can evaluate various possibilities and then actualize one of them – that is, bring it into manifestation. That is the definition of a magical act, hence the term "magical idealism" to name Evola's philosophical system.

The essence of an idea is the same as the existence of a thing The difference between the idea, or essence, of a thing and the existence of a thing is a question of degree.

It is a matter of power to bring an idea into manifestation. The measure of power is the capability to bring an idea into manifestation, that is, to alter reality in conformance with one's will.

As Evola put it in "Essays on Magical Idealism": "What distinguishes magical idealism is its essentially practical character: its fundamental requirement is not to substitute one intellectual conception of the world with another, but rather to create in the individual a new 'dimension' and a new depth of life."

The new dimension involves understanding the world in a radically new way. Rather than the self as a passive observer of the world which produces a mental copy of itself in consciousness, the self instead is recognized as the creator of the world as its conscious act. In effect, one's whole worldview is reversed. The world is created from the inside out, that is, from ideas and spiritual qualities which then are manifested. It then becomes a matter of power as to which or whose ideas take hold. The world is then the battleground of spiritual forces, not simply as abstract ideals, but as a power struggle to bring those ideals into manifestation.

This the problem of knowing, that is, of self-realisation or the "magical problem" is really an ethical problem. By participation in this struggle, the individual becomes "conscious of his task and his cosmic dignity." This revaluation of values, that is, morality as the creative act and not as

strictly inhibitive, is Evola's fundamental point:

> Today the meaning of the moral as cosmic worth has been lost, that up to now, it has been reduced to nothing more than the corroboration and canonisation of deficiency, weakness, and fear – of the plague of beautiful sentiments, of noble virtues, of holy ideals – that is, of the fundamentally *immoral*.

So the issue really is how to bring about this moment of self-realisation. Since it is not simply a philosophical argument, Evola then turns, in the second part of the essay, to the question of initiation.

Posted on 2008-08-11 by Cologero

6.2 Awakening to Consciousness

> In the beginning the world was nothing but the Atman, in the form of a man. It looked around and saw nothing different to itself. Then it cried out once, 'It is I.' That is how the word 'I' came to be. That is why even at the present day, if any one is called, he answers, 'It is I,' and then recalls his other name, the one he bears.
>
> Brihadâranyata-Upanishad

In demonstrating the potential development of the increasing awareness of "I" consciousness, Evola builds on themes from the following books:

- *Persuasion and Rhetoric*, by Carlo Michelstaedter
- *The World as Will and Representation*, by Arthur Schopenhauer

- *The Ego and its Own*, by Max Stirner
- *Sex and Character*, by Otto Weininger

The last named book was translated by Evola into Italian. There is one particular chapter — *The "I" Problem and Genius*[2] — that may be helpful before tackling Evola's short book on *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*.

Stage One of Consciousness In Stage One, man is in what we could call the "natural" state, that is, he functions in a state of Nature. As such, he performs just as Nature asks: he breathes, eats, reproduces, and dies. As far as Nature is concerned, the Stage One man is complete. Whether or not man develops his Will or gains Wisdom, makes no difference to Nature. There is no gene to encourage higher states of consciousness, there is no natural process that will lead to the "evolution" of the spirit.

In Stage One, there is no firm sense of the "I", and the natural man is not autonomous. His instincts, his desires, his likes and dislikes, his opinions have their sources outside him and the I is passive in relation to them. For example, he won't eat Brussels sprouts because that is just "the way I am". Or if he desires something, he acts to fulfil it and does not question the desire itself. His opinions are absorbed from his milieu — family, church, clubs, friends, political parties — and serve more as a way to bond with his community or to maintain certain positions of power. His worldview comes from idle chitchat (Heidegger: "*gerede*") with neighbours or commentary in the media.

Thus, for natural man, there is no burning issue of certainty. He seldom seeks to justify his opinions and beliefs. In debate, he is quick to begin with "I think" or "I believe" as though that were sufficient warrant for belief. He seldom sees a need to justify his opinion with facts or

[2] https://gornahoor.net/library/SexAndCharacter.pdf

logic, nor to refute a contrary opinion. Even when through experience, he attempts such a justification, he argues as would a lawyer or sophist — that is, simply to defend a point of view — and not as a genuine seeker of knowledge. Nietzsche's dictum that "the courage of one's convictions is not sufficient, what is necessary is the courage for an attack on one's convictions" has no impact on him.

In this passage, Evola uses the word "*singolo*" instead of "*individuo*", both of which I have translated as individual (though I marked the former). A *singolo* is like one stick in a pile, whereas an *individuo* is an independent centre of awareness. The former type of individual is part of his environment and is not yet separated, that is, as a detached consciousness, the observer, Aristotle's unmoved mover. Such a one has no Will as such, what he calls "free will" is merely a spontaneity, or what Goethe called "disorderly self will".

Stage Two of Consciousness In stage two, man begins to awaken from the naive realism of stage one that posits a "real" world "out there, right now" based on nothing but his animal faith. Evola describes the attempts to account for this, first in the metaphysico-religious realm and then in science. Finally he ties this in to the quest for certainty and proposes how to ground this certainty.

In the next section, Evola proposes science as the solution to the awakening into Stage Two. The attempt is made to tame the chaos of phenomena through scientific laws. Yet, by the nature of the scientific method, even these laws are uncertain, since new theories always arise to replace earlier ones. Furthermore, science cannot answer the fundamental question: "Why is there something rather than nothing?"

At this point, through self-awareness, the naive view of a "subject" knowing an "object' is no longer tenable. Evola accepts Schopenhauer's view that phenomena are simply representations in consciousness and there is no "real" thing standing behind phenomena or causing them.

Then the only certainty left is this self-awareness of the "I". This is the threshold to Stage Three.

Privation

Evola consolidates the understanding gained by the man at stage three with a discussion of the topic "privation". In Aristotle and Thomas Aquinas, "privation" is the absence of a given form in something capable of possessing it. As it is a lack, it has no being in itself, yet it is part of experience. Evola will use the concept of privation, which denies a real being, to refute the philosophy of realism, which postulates the being,

The realist claims that there is a something behind the appearances or representations that somehow causes or accounts for them. Evola denies this and reasserts his claim that the appearances are from the "I". But certainly there are things that are impervious to my will. Evola claims that they are not real things but rather a privation, something that reveals my own insufficiency. Along the way of explaining this, a new, and perhaps greater and more heroic, meaning is given to activity in the world.

In a note, Evola points out the limit at which philosophy as such must end; what is then required is self-realization, to which no study of philosophy can lead. Evola asserts that such a transformation is "not a myth but a real possibility". This cannot be overemphasized — it is insufficient to study Evola, one must work to achieve such a realization by other means; otherwise, nothing will be understood.

The rejection of realism, the elevation of self-realization over rational thought, and the centrality of the will, freedom, and power have far reaching implications. This short work does not draw out all such implications, but it is an interesting exercise to ponder them. Evola writes:

> Therefore, with the intention to develop the position assumed by the consciousness of the third stage, we will consider the only true objection encountered by absolute idealism. In absolute idealism

> there is a doctrine that seeks to transform the negative task of criticism and scepticism that defines the second stage into something positive; and that ceasing to understand the world as a phenomenon, as simply an appearance, (the only legitimate conclusion of critical investigation) in order to understand it instead as something posited, created by the I. Therefore when one no longer speaks of representing but rather of positing and creating, the concept of a free will comes into play, and thus this problem arises: I can well reduce the world to my representation, but at what point can I reduce it also to my will and my freedom?

Since Evola's presentation is quite terse, it may be helpful to try to give some examples of the concept of "Privation". If we start with the assumption that the world is my representation and my will, then it is impossible to deny that the world does not seem to be subject to my will — this is what Evola is referring to as "privation". Recall here what Guenon wrote about Man's role as Mediator between Heaven and Earth[3]. Heaven is the Idea. Man's role as Mediator is to manifest that idea in Nature. But nature is subject to its own law of Destiny, so it resists my will. That leaves us with two alternatives:

1. My inability to exercise my Will reveals in insufficiency in me... a **privation**. This is something I should possess, were I at the level of the True Man.

2. My inability to exercise my will reveals the existence of something to oppose it.

The natural temptation, then, is option (2), to ascribe some independent reality as the true source or cause of my sense of lack. In other words, what is properly the will of the "I", gets projected onto something else.

[3] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1798`

Projections and Privation We can look at three levels of projection:

1. The Persona projects itself onto the Shadow
2. The Mind projects onto the Body
3. The I projects onto the world.

The Shadow The man whose self is not well integrated experiences certain motivations, feelings, desires, attractions, weaknesses and so on as alien to him. Hence, he denies them in himself, and hides them in his unconscious. Jung called that the Shadow archetype. Notice the similarity here to what Evola is getting at: the Shadow is not a real entity, rather it represents a lack or privation in consciousness, something the I denies, yet it is a product of its own will. So "I" may project those feelings and desires onto others, or attribute them to outside forces like God, or the devil, etc. Oddly enough, someone else can easily see through "my" projections and recognizes them as my will.

The Mind At the next level, the I sees itself as the mind alone (subtle manifestation) and separate from the body (gross manifestation). It experiences the needs and desires of the body as something alien that impinges on its consciousness. The body becomes that master of the "I".

The Self Even if the "I" is integrated with the body, at a further level the body-mind organism separates from its environment. It then regards the world as an independent reality. The world seems dark and alien and is an obstacle to my purposes. Instead, I can understand the obstacle not as the "other", but rather as the revelation of my own insufficiency in that regard. This gives my activity — that is, since my efforts to

exert my will and bring such obstacles under control — an heroic character. This is represented in many myths such as the labours of Hercules, Jason, the medieval search for the Grail, and so on.

True Will and Spontaneity

If everything is the result of the I, the obvious question is, "Why am I not always aware of creating the world?" To address this question, Julius Evola makes the distinction between **spontaneity** and **Will**, which he first brought up in the discussion of the three

stages. By spontaneity, he means an immediate movement from the possible to the actual, while by Will, there is a "space" where many possibilities arise prior to one of them becoming actual. So when he says the world is "my" representation, it is in the sense of spontaneity — that is, the world arises in my consciousness, though I do not choose it with full awareness.

That this is necessary follows from the argument thus far.

1. The Spirit has priority over the Soul, which has priority over the Body.

2. The Will is the unifying principle, bringing the activity of the Spirit into manifestation.

Therefore, from point (1), The representation of the world in the Soul is created by the mind, whereas the common opinion is that the world creates the representations in the mind. So, from (2), this representation necessarily emanates from the Will. How does this relate to spontaneity?

As Guenon points out, Man is the mediator between Providence and the World. As Spirit, Man shares in Providence which is total Freedom. Yet as Body, Man is subject to the Destiny of the World Process. As Schopenhauer demonstrates, at that level Will is unfree, determinate,

and blind. Tradition teaches that, over time, the World Process moves further and further from principial Unity; the material analog of this is the thesis that "the entropy of the universe is increasing."

Karl Marx wrote that the purpose of philosophy is to change the world. However, he did not mean change in the light of higher ideas, but rather in the sense of hurrying along the World Process in the direction away from Principle. Tradition, on the other hand, brings about change in conformity to the Will of God, or Providence". Note that this is an actionless action, spontaneous but in a conscious sense. Julius Evola elaborates on this point:

> Here it is necessary to make a fundamental point and that is to understand the essential difference between spontaneity and will. There is spontaneity where the possible is identical to the real or to put it better, where that which is could only have been that, the act has the form of an inconvertible compulsion, of a brute happening and outburst, and it is passive, impotent in respect to itself. In the will, instead, there is an excess of the possible over the real, that is, one does not pass from the possible to the real immediately, but a point of autonomy, of "*potestas*", controls the act as the final unconditioned reason for its being or not being, of its being this way or its being otherwise, as an act that is only one of the possibilities, or rather, compossibilities. It is important to note that spontaneity, as well as will, can be said to be free: however, while in spontaneity it is a question of a completely negative freedom, that is, of a freedom that simply means: "not determined from something external". In the will there is a positive freedom, that is, a freedoms that means absolute absence of conditions, whether they be internal or external, and therefore the contingency or, if one prefers, the arbitrariness of the act.
>
> Once this distinction is understood, it is not so much based on concepts and intellectual subtleties, but rather on an immediate given of consciousness, on internal evidence that one either does

> or does not have; when the absolute idealist, in the face of the system of reality, asserts he was the "I" who posited it, it is evident that he is referring not to will, but to spontaneity. He is referring in fact to that activity whereby things are perceived and made interior to our I, to that fundamental "assent" so we become aware of them — an assent that if it is a necessary condition for every reality, insofar as the reality experienced by the I (and we cannot coherently speak about other reality), it is still quite far from being a sufficient condition. In fact, in representing the real is not controlled by the possible, the I is passive in respect to its own act — not as it asserts things but rather it is as if things were asserting themselves in it. As passion and emotion, the representation is something of mine, something that I pull from my own interiority (and at this point the legitimacy of the need for idealism arrives, the rest is satisfied until Leibniz), but it is not me, since I cannot give it freely to myself, since I don't stand in relationship of master to its determinations, so that the spectacle of reality is unfolding before me, that is, this reality, not the reality that I will. Consequently: to the extent that the idealist can say he was the I who "posited" nature, he reduces the I to nature, that is, in as much as that I, which is freedom, knows nothing, or, better said, acts as if it knows nothing, and, with an obvious paralogism, borrows the concept of the I from that of the principle of spontaneity. I can say it was I who posited nature, but in so far as I am spontaneity, not as I am properly an "I", that is, freedom and control.

Transformation is a Real Possibility

Opposed to the Evola's view is philosophical realism, which Evola next tries to refute. Things have two aspects in regard to the individual, and these can be verified in one's own consciousness:

1. A thing is represented in consciousness

2. The I is impotent in the face of these representations

Up to here, the magical idealist and the realist agree; they disagree about the nature of the impotency.

- Evola asserts that things represent an imperfect or self-limiting activity. Again, this is *privation*, a quality the "I" should have by nature, but lacks, either because of an imperfection or a self-limitation. So, in conformity with Aristotle and Aquinas, this privation is non-being.

- The realist cannot accept an imperfect or self-limiting activity; instead, he assumes a "real" cause, external to the I, to account for this impotency.

- Evola asserts that the universal or absolute is what comes first.

- The realist believes that the particular things are what comes first.

- Evola claims that imperfection can be overcome by a strengthening of the Will.

- The realist believes that that imperfection can be overcome by some process of evolution or development.

In refuting realism, Evola will hold that

- The I can be directly experienced as energy

- There is no need to postulate something other than the I to account for limitations

Bear in mind that Evola is here concerned with the problem of certainty: that is, how do I know — that is directly — with certainty. For this, Evola only allows in evidence what happens in consciousness, my self-awareness or sense of "I", and, derivatively, what I have power over and can control.

Therefore, a "thing" is whatever appears in my consciousness as "representation". The realist, on the other hand, speculates that there is something that accounts for that appearance and thus causes it in my consciousness. Since what I can know with certainty is whatever is in my own consciousness, the theory of the realist must necessarily be speculative.

The objection of the realist is that you have no experience of directly causing or bringing about the appearances of the world. To counter this, Evola returns to the distinction between spontaneity and will that was made in the discussion of the stages. The appearance of the world is "spontaneous", in the sense that it arises of necessity without the full consent of my will. So whatever resists my will is not something that has an independent existence — as the realist would claim — but rather it represents a "privation", something that lacks being, and merely indicates an insufficiency on my part.

In Evola's own words:

> The realist, referring exactly to the point of real individuality, thus puts forward an appeal that is entirely legitimate. He puts us in front of a common occurrence of experience, a storm for example, and asks us if we can say that is was we who "posited it". While here the idealist would respond in the affirmative — because as was said, for him "to posit" means simply to represent with "free necessity". We instead, referring to a positing that the principle of control and unconditioned freedom requires, would respond: "That, actually, is not posited by the I." Then the realist immediately says: "Since that is not posited by the I, there must be 'some-

thing else' that posits it" — and infers a real or existent cause in itself of the representations, such as God, matter, the noumenon, etc. Instead, here lies the error and the point on which we are permitted to demand the full attention of the reader.

To say that I, as I, that is, as sufficient and free principle, cannot recognize myself as unconditioned cause of the representations, does not at all mean say that these representations are caused by "something else" and have some real or existent things in themselves as substrate, but means simply that I am insufficient for a part of my activity, which is still spontaneity, that such a part is not yet MORALIZED, that the I as freedom suffers a PRIVATION in it.

Everything I cannot act on, everything that resists my will, is only a privation of this very will, something negative, not a being, but a non-being. Hence the realist must be rejected out of hand: he in his reference to "something else" — God, noumenon, substance, etc. — makes a being out of non-being, calls real something that, being only a privation of my power, being nothing other than a negation and a void in the unmultipliable body of my activity, should instead, by right, be called unreal. Thus he confirms this very privation — as he eschews it: instead of the act that, by controlling and possessing them, annuls things and redeems the privation, he substitutes the act that recognizes them and superstitiously gives them being and an autonomous reality. To the former act, he instead applies the criterion of certainty of the third stage: that is, he demands that the free and naked I of the individual can genuinely assert the principle of absolute idealism, and however say: "In truth, I myself am the cause and the Lord of this world, in which I live". But when will it be possible to assert that? Obviously when the individual has redeemed the dark passion of the world in a body of freedom, when the form according to which he lives has let the representative activity (that is, that activity through which the spectacle of the universe is formed in him) pass from spontaneity — from the harmony of the possible and

> real – to bare, unconditioned causality, that is to: potent will.

Evola concluded his response to the realist with this claim:

> Obviously when the individual has redeemed the dark passion of the world in a body of freedom, when the form according to which he lives has let the representative activity (that is, that activity through which the spectacle of the universe is formed in him) pass from spontaneity — from the harmony of the possible and real — to bare, unconditioned causality, that is to: **powerful Will**.

At this point, philosophical arguments fall short and ultimately proof can only come from the development of one's will. Specifically, the appearances, representations, or "things" in the world do not arise spontaneously, but rather arise in conformity to one's will. In the text, Evola adds the following footnote describing the transformation from philosophical discussion to self-realization. I think it safe to conclude that this is not merely an abstract claim but rather represents Evola's actual experience.

> As this transformation, which we claim is not a myth but a real possibility, can then practically be completed, is a problem we treated — at least within the limits in which it is possible to treat it publicly and generally — elsewhere see **Doctrine of Awakening**, **Yoga of Power** , and so it is not found here. We can only say that it is a task which neither culture, nor devotion, nor philosophy, nor art, nor morality, nor anything other than what men call "spirituality", can make the least contribution. As to philosophy, its limit is magical idealism, in which it ends up by recognizing its own insufficiency and postulating the realization of power as that by which most problems can find their only absolute solution.

The Cosmic Value of Human Action

Evola now asserts that the view of **magical idealism** reveals the **cosmic value** to human action. For the realist, everything already is, so that activity is little more than rearranging the furniture. Opposed to this view, action is heroic. The True Man creates being, where previously there had only been non-being or privation.

This perspective is difficult to grasp for anyone who hangs on to the tenets of realism, even if unconsciously. Evola is describing the True Will, the noumenal will, the unifying principle of the individual, transcendent to subtle and gross manifestation. The two views are antithetical.

Control

- The realist can only understand this view as the self-affirmation of the ego with all that implies as far as control and domination over others for merely profane ends.
- To the contrary, this is about control and domination over oneself to overcome one's own insufficiencies.

Lack

- The realist experiences lack and tries to fill it from the things of the world.
- Lack represents insufficiency and privation, to be overcome by creative action.

Eros

- The realist takes as real the primal forces of *eros* and *thumos* and seeks to satisfy them from the things in the world.

- Eros and thumos are energies to be used to make my actions effective. As such, I control and dominate them to my own ends.

Fate

- By his involvement with the things of the world, the realist submits his will to the Destiny of the World Process.
- The True Will is Free and seeks to make itself manifest in the World Process.

This is how Evola expresses it:

> Now only in a view like this does the act of the individual have a *cosmic value*, whereas in the view of realism every true meaning and purpose is removed from activity — this should be clear to everyone. In fact activity truly has meaning and value only where it exists to make something real, that is not yet such. This case is verified precisely where the "other" — or that which reflects the limit of my freedom — is understood not as a reality, but rather as a negation and a void: then the world appears as something *incomplete*, as something that demands its integration in that act of the individual, so that necessity is made freedom, to that development of self-assertion so that the potent actuality of the Unique one is laid out and re-asserted inasmuch as it is its privation.
>
> If instead one posits that the "other" as such — that is, exactly as that principle which limits my freedom — is not a privation and a non-being, but rather a positivity and a reality — then everything is already perfect, everything is already "being", and it is not necessary to do anything else. Every purpose and every value of activity and of becoming, every responsibility fails — *since the voids of my being are not also voids of being in general*: the "other", with the reality attributed to it, fills them up. Instead, in the other

> case the whole world appears as a dark, painful claim to the "I" so that one gives these to oneself according to power and, in that way, enacts it into being, redeems it from privation, and makes it real. And the becoming — that which I make — now has a value, a cosmic value.

The Creative Power of the Individual

Evola concludes his discussion of privation with the observation that it is the Will that throws light on the unknown. The accumulation of knowledge is insufficient.

There is a continuum between spontaneity and free will. Everything objective and necessary in experience — that is, everything experienced as "privation", arises from spontaneity. That means, there is no consciousness of having "willed" it; rather, it arises out of the Absolute as the experience of the potential becoming actual. From the perspective of the individual, it arrives "out of the dark". Evola elaborates:

> Hence the conception that appears in the third stage of the development of the individual is, as a whole, the following: a continuum of activity that has as limits spontaneity on one side and free will on the other. Spontaneity is the universal, free will is the individual. These limits are related to each other as potential to act: everything objective, immediate, and necessary in experience, is, in regards to the position of the individual, the non-being inherent in what is in potential — and here perhaps we can understand what certain mystics alluded to when they spoke of the "dark passion of the world", the "unspeakable suffering of existence", in which the body of the "celestial man" is crucified.

With free will, this darkness is illumined. The "act" of the will makes the world "real", whereas privation is unreal.

The individual, now conscious of his power, is creative.

This brings up three points

- The individual the source of the becoming of the world, thereby giving it its solidity and reality.
- This is why the search for certainty in the things of the world will always end in frustration.
- The individual, at this point, is the source of his own being.

He explains:

> Freedom is the act and the luminous flame of such a darkness, of such a privation; and the world becomes, it is made real in conformity with absolute reality only in and through this flame — that is, only to the extent that the individual, asserting himself at the point of power and control, consumes, burns up his former nature that was spontaneously made.

Paradoxically, the so-called Traditionalist does not long for a return to the Past; rather it is only in creating the Future does he come to know his own powers and the Will of God Providence . Hence true explanations do not lie in things or in the past, but rather ahead, since they are dependent on the individual for their *raison d'être*. Such an individual is his "own property" and "persuaded/convinced". (The latter two expressions are due to **Max Stirner** and **Carlo Michelstaedter** respectively.)

Evola then claims that it is the individual who gives meaning and purpose to the world. This distinguishes him from Schopenhauer's position that denies any such purpose; in the latter's system, the individual is not free and does not become aware of the noumenal "Will" as his own centre. (I think it should be clear by now that Evola is not exalting the "human being" as such, since the states he describes are beyond the human state.)

> only at the point at which the individual realises himself in the sudden intuition of power does a purpose, a reason and a goal in nature arise: not before; it is he who gives it to them. It demands it of his action. And yet the individual has a single imperative by this point.

Evola has been describing the Traditional esoteric path. It consists of three stages.

Catharsis This is the stage of purification, moving from spontaneity to Will.

Theoria This is the stage of illumination, where the darkness is illumined.

Theosis This is the stage of divinization, where one incarnates God.

To some it may seem that Evola is inverting the process of salvation in the Christian sense. Others may recognize in it the Traditional teachings of the Greek fathers. Evola concludes:

Be, make yourself GOD, and in bringing that about, SAVE the world.

6.3 Builder of Worlds

> It is important to note the relativity of the concept of privation. A given element is never privation in itself, but always in relation to the good of autonomy. The passage to that good makes what was positive as spontaneity something negative and "in potential" in respect to the other point. So for the man who does not want to move from the logical point of view to that of Will, the concept of privation is not intelligible.

Let us try to illustrate Evola's point with a homely example. Suppose Charlie has a problem with drugs; he is powerless with respect to cocaine. He is not autonomous because the desire for the drug controls his actions. But that is relative to Charlie because Cologero has no such problem. Thus, it is not the cocaine as a positive force, but rather a privation, a lack within Charlie, that accounts for the addiction. So it is unconscious, "spontaneous" will that makes of cocaine a positive reality, seemingly outside Charlie. However, as Charlie develops a conscious Will and autonomy, that "positive" addiction is recognized as a negative, as a privation, something that can be overcome.

> By believing that the present doctrine explaining privation is surpassed by postulating a distinct reality, he is not taking a step forward but a step backward, since he is making use of the logical category of causality with which this very reality becomes conditioned, logically posited by the I.

The realist cannot resist the urge to postulate an external reality: Charlie's problem is genetic or something of that nature. This doesn't address the problem, but pushes it back into more obscurity. The realist forgets that causality is not a property of the World, but is a category of thought by which I organize and control the World.

> What is the difference between a real and an imagined thing? Represented, they are both the same; but beyond that, the representing activity to which the real thing corresponds is an activity in respect to which they are impotent. There are elements on which I cannot act... We do not resolve the problem of interpreting this non-power, because we do not pose it; hence we are accused of being intellectualistic, abstract, and irrelevant in respect to what is really important to every research of such a type at this point. This is a fundamental point: we claim that the explanation of the fact that one is impotent in certain situations by making recourse to

> an "other" is a pseudo-explanation, and therefore a vicious circle for this reason: in us the concept of "other" gets its meaning and its foundation from the concept of "non-power", which is what comes first, and out of which objectivity, thing in itself, God, etc. are only so many symbols and intellectual interpretations... *Privation* explains the concept of objective reality but not objective reality the concept of privation.

So I have a representation of things in my mind and then note my lack of power of some things. I start with the awareness of my lack, and then postulate the existence of the "other", all claiming to "explain" my awareness of privation. The awareness is certain, but there are many conflicting theories about the "other". That is why Evola considers them to be pseudo-explanations.

> The explanation that **magical idealism** demands is completely different: it is an *explanation by means of action, a resolutive explanation*. It is to *ex-plicate*, or to *actuate*, to make perfect: to make what is in potential pass into act, what is imperfection into perfection, what is insufficiency into sufficiency, according to a synthetic, creative, primordial process. This is the only true explanation. *Everything else is a pastime*.

If knowing is the Unmoved Mover, according to Guenon, and given the fundamental metaphysical principle "to know is to be", then to "know myself" is to "be myself". To be myself, I must actualize myself. To be the True Man, I must actualize all my possibilities. There is no distinction here between knowing and doing, contemplation and action: knowing cannot exist apart from acting. It is only by doing can I know myself, through the reflection of the I in the World. By creating myself, I reveal myself. Quietism, or the surrender to impotency, is just a form of escapism.

> We will fiercely combat all intellectual and philosophic rhetoric whereby man restrains himself to talk about his impotency (which we mean when speaking of "truth", "objectivity", "rationality", etc.) rather than to finally jump to his feet, to grasp himself and, burning up his impotency, to make himself what he is in himself:
>
> *a God, a builder of the world.*

Essence and Existence

> The universe exists for each Individual because he consciously wills it.
>
> John Woodroffe, *Sakti and Sakta*

After concluding the discussion of privation, Julius Evola next turns to the concepts of Essence and Existence. This can be understood as the philosophical analog of the concepts of *Purusha* and *Prakriti*. There are some important notions developed in what Evola wrote about essence and existence. Evola avoids a one-sided philosophy. He relates these concepts to freedom and necessity, will and thought, the actual and the potential. Yet he accomplishes this not by an unbridgeable dichotomy between opposed concepts, but rather by relating them on a scale of values.

Evola offers us a full philosophy: there is transcendence, yet there is activity in the world. The first point he makes is that things comprise both essence and existence. The essence of something answers the question "What it is". Existence is "that it is". Yet the idea of a thing is logically the same both for an imagined thing and a real thing. Therefore, the existence of a thing is irreducible to logic. In practical terms, what this means is that there is no intellectual answer to the question: "Why is there something rather than nothing?" The solution to that riddle lies on a different level.

> Things are essence and existence. The idea of one hundred thalers and one hundred real thalers are obviously not the same thing. Consequently, from a logical point of view, as Kant has shown, there is nothing included in the hundred real thalers beyond the idea of the hundred thalers. It follows that, insofar as we differentiate between them, we are referring to something irreducible to the logical element. This something is "existence", as opposed to "essence" (or more rigorously, the "esse existentiae" as opposed to the "*esse essentiae*").

The essence of a thing is logically explained by a concept. However, its existence is beyond logic (note: this does not mean illogical or irrational). Since in Evola's system there is only representation and the "I", therefore existence can only be explained by will or by power. Otherwise, the existence of a thing is opaque to the I. Of course, tying this back to previous topics, the activity of my will may be spontaneous, i.e., beyond my conscious intervention. Nevertheless, it "explains" existence without resorting to theories of external forces. So, here is the symmetry:

1. essence is the ideal and is constructed in thought
2. existence is the real and is caused by an act of will.

> And now to a second point. The explicative principle of the essence, of the "what is", of a determinate reality, is the concept: when a reality is genetically constructed by means of the concept in all the characteristics that determine it, the explicative principle in the order of essence is exhausted. Therefore, what an object is, which is entirely penetrated by being, is the bare fact of its "being there" as real object, and that constitutes a point that entirely eludes a rational explanation, it is an *alogos* — and an adequate explicative principle for it is not the concept, but rather the **Will** or, even better, *power*. In fact the pure being of things constitutes

> for me a mystery up to the point where it has the character of a brute given, of something that is there without the participation of my will, imposing itself, on the contrary, forcefully against it; briefly: as a privation of my activity. While I can think of essence and therefore "construct it", existence simply suffers it — and this constitutes for me a darkness. If you imagine instead a situation in which you can connect the "being here" of things to willing them unconditionally, that is, in which my will had value as creative power: then their existence in fact beyond their concept would cease to be a mystery to me, on the contrary, it would be for me perfectly intelligible — it would be explained. *Essence and existence have therefore as their explicative principles the ideal construction through the act of thought and real causation through the act of the will respectively*.

Evola adds a third point. He rejects dualism, in particular a dualism between thought and action. The world is representation and will, essence and existence, thought and action. The third point is: there is not a difference of nature, but only of degree. Note how this is another expression of the Great Chain of Being[4], that reality is hierarchically ordered from the less dense to the more dense. Thus the idea is already at a level in the chain and the real is a fuller expression of the idea. The Tantric writings, as documented by John Woodroffe, also portray a similar conception; they add many levels of detail in describing the full constitution of the human being, for example.

> The third point is the following: between ideal constructions and the creative will — therefore between essence and existence — *there is not a difference of nature, but only of degree*. The idea is already a degree of real affirmation; and so-called objective reality is only the most intense and complete assertion of that power

[4] `http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Great_Chain_of_Being`

> which, in elementary form, determines the thing simply thought or represented. Reality is only the *act* of the idea, in which it characterises and expresses itself entirely, just as the idea is only a reality *in potential* or a reality simply sketched out or in a nascent state. Between one and the other, therefore, there is not a jump, there is instead *progressivity*. The thought of one hundred Thalers and one hundred real Thalers are obviously not the same thing — but not *qualitatively* different (as is assumed by those who believe that the thought is the impersonal image of an objective reality instead of a power) but intensively different, in the sense that the hundred real Thalers are the deepest, most *intense* power related precisely to the magical act, of the assertion corresponding to the hundred Thalers in thought.

This has important implications. First of all, there is the first type of existence that is "death, privation, unreality" which is the spontaneity of the first stage. Life is experienced as impotence. Things and events block me. I impute reality to the unreal. Thinking deals only with concepts and I can never grasp the real simply by thinking about it. To escape, I must be convinced that philosophy is incomplete without a method of self-realisation.

Only in that way — and not by "reasoning" oneself to it, can there be the second type of existence. This type is based on the freedom, power — beyond logical analysis as was shown in the second point. Notice the comments about ever increasing levels of spontaneity. Thus as a man's power is expanded, his actions become effortless, i.e., they arise spontaneously from the nature of his being, the *wei wu wei* of Taoism.

> There is an existence that is death, privation, unreality, which corresponds to representational spontaneity, the residue from the first stage, in which the act is passive in respect to itself, and which the "I" does not control as its master. There is no true certainty of this existence: since it does not depend on me as passion or

> emotion and is a pure happening, therefore a principle of radical contingency takes it back. There is instead a second existence, which is what a will elevating itself to power can unconditionally produce: only this is properly existence, absolute reality, and only from it, where it is found joined only with itself in possession and control — the "I" can have real certainty. Between these types of existence there is mental activity in the proper sense. In other words: beyond the ideal limit of the reign of pure necessity — of nature and spontaneity — and beyond his "privation", the individual enjoys in the rational or ideal order of the first level of sufficient actuality and freedom. This level proceeds towards its perfection in development in accordance to which power reasserts itself in continually deeper and more complex levels of spontaneity — of primitive nature or the universal — right up to controlling the same intensive level of real existence. Then from the dark passion and savage desert resulting from privation, the world will make itself the very act of the individual, and in that he will be redeemed and *convinced*.

Knowledge and Power

> The fundamental being and expression [of Consciousness or the I] is Joy pulsating as Will-Power and manifesting Itself in an unspeakably sublime cosmic play. It is not a mere abstraction — a wilderness of Pure Being or Pure Nothing as some critics of Vedanta have imagined the abode of Reality to be.
>
> John Woodroffe, *The World as Power* (p 320)

Thomas Aquinas describes the effects of the Fall from the Primordial State as affecting faculties on both the spiritual and the psychic level, as represented in Table 6.1:

Hence, the regeneration of the Primordial State is effected through Knowledge and Power.

	Effect	Description	Antidote
Spirit	Ignorance	Intellect not ordered to the Logos	Gnosis
	Malice	Will impotent to manifest the Logos	Power
Soul	Weakness	Thumos not ordered to arduousness	Trial by suffering
	Concupiscence	Eros not ordered to the delectable	Trial by love

Table 6.1: Fall from the Primordial State

Knowledge What do we know when we know it? From what has been described thus far:

- All our opinions, beliefs, theories are like so much straw
- What we have considered as obstacles are in reality privations, a demonstration of our own lack of power.

Woodroffe describes the concept of privation as understood in Tantra:

> Consciousness [the I] *seeming* to be unconsciousness, Joy *seeming* to be indifference or pain, free Play *seeming* to be necessity and determination.

In this seemingness, the I gives up his power to that which "seems to be" and doesn't recognize his own role in producing what he experiences:

> Consciousness, as the root Being-and-Becoming Power becomes real things … Thus, a block of stone is not "matter" only: it is Consciousness as Joy and as Play — though the fact is veiled to

> ordinary minds. On the other hand, it is not an "idea" or "mental construct" only: it is Consciousness as Power constituting it as much and as active a reality as the experiencing and reacting mind is.

The solution is, according to Woodroffe, increasing knowledge at ever deeper levels to the point of self-realization:

> There is need for the education and development of man's "knowing instruments", giving him progressively higher and larger visions, through science and philosophy, through intuition and meditation, and finally revelation and realization. … *Matter and Life are every whit as real and active as Mind*.

This is the crux of the issue. Verbosity, opinions, repetition do not and never will constitute knowledge. **To Know** — in the highest sense, viz., episteme, gnosis, wisdom — is **to be**. Hence, we do not know the Idea until it has become Real for us as Life and as Matter. This is the Tantric teaching of the I as Power.

Power In the *Individual and the Becoming of the World*, Evola describes the deepening process of making ideas real:

1. First, there is the simple and pallid image of the idea
2. Make it vivid in the imagination
3. Perceive it exteriorly as a subjective hallucination
4. Convince other centres of consciousness to perceive it as a collective hallucination
5. Develop an ever more intense assertion of power until the same level of real existence is reached.

Then at this point:

> in correspondence with a magical act (because a *magician could be defined as one who knows how to influence nature itself*), [the idea] would cease to be "false" and "subjective" by making itself instead "true" and "objective". What was error or illusion becomes accordingly truth, through power. That is valid for any empirical, moral, or rational field whatsoever.

Evola here does not spell out the obvious corollary. Whatever happens in any "empirical, moral or rational field whatsoever" is the result of the intention of an agent, someone or group that understands, and uses, this process or, better said, "magicians". How much of the world is under the spell of some collective hallucination or another? Only the Trial by Fire can break the spell. Evola's goes on to demonstrate the relationship between ontology and ethics.

> Real means perfectly willed. Unreal will mean therefore privation of the Will, imperfect and insufficient Will — and this is *evil*, just as, on the other hand, it is error. *Evil and error are one and the same thing in the sense that the common foundation to both is impotence*. Those doctrines are in truth of a fundamental value, currently almost forgotten, that placed evil in matter, meaning by this that residue of necessity that resists the idea — that is, freedom — and limits it. Matter — the Platonic "other" — is effectively the sign of imperfection of the act and, in as much existing, is connected to that fundamental "injustice" about which Anaximander, Parmenides, and Empedocles speak — and it is, essentially, evil. There is no other evil beyond necessity, of which matter, brute existence, is the evidence; and as long as the "I" will not be able avoid the experience of matter — of this "other" against and beyond him — he will be imperfect: *evil, impure, irrational*.

It is clear that freedom is not about satisfying desires, which is really a lack, a privation. Concupiscence represents a necessity that binds and restricts our will. The purpose of the Trial by Love, by substituting the satisfaction of personal desires with a disinterested love for the genuinely good or pleasurable, is to overcome concupiscence. Thus, commands such as "love your enemy" are to be understood in this light, as means to an end, not a universal moral principle in the Kantian sense. A blind hatred, on the other hand, is the result of an impure and irrational will, and often leads one to make poor or ineffective decisions.

Weakness of the *thumos* leads a man to eschew suffering. Every form of pain or upset is felt to be an injustice. Instead, the Trial by Suffering will develop a detached attitude. In this respect, we can mention the idea of "intentional suffering", that is, deliberately choosing the more arduous path in order to develop Power. Once again, commands such as "turn the other cheek" must be understood in this light.

Now Evola summarizes his position on the identity of power and morals:

> So the ethical problem and the metaphysical problem coincide: the measure of reality, as of the good, of the certain and of the true, is the perfection of actuality or power. *Per virtutem et potentiam idem intelligo*. [Spinoza, *Ethics*, "by virtue and power I mean the same thing."] The good or virtue is potency, evil is impotence. There is no other evil except insufficiency and weakness, no other good except the will that is unconditionally sufficient in itself, and therefore free to be and do what it wills. The rest is nonsense and can be left to women, mystics, and poets. That today the meaning of the moral as cosmic worth has been lost, that up to now, it has been reduced to nothing more than the corroboration and canonisation of deficiency, weakness, and fear — of the plague of beautiful sentiments, of noble virtues, of holy ideals — that is, of the fundamentally *immoral*.

The Religious Attitude

> In a nutshell, this is the sense of the system I uphold, in which on the one hand I sought to fuse the gnoseological problem and the ontological problem with the ethical problem and the problem of self-realisation or magical problem; on the other hand, to claim the value of the individual and to make him become conscious of his task and his cosmic dignity.
>
> **It is that which I recognize as truth, or, better said, it is that which I will as truth.**

Before addressing the topic of initiation, Evola first summarizes his philosophy. First, he describes the initial state of the being.

> we have in fact the simple state of the being that discovers itself, that is pure spontaneity, that does not *own* itself but simply *is*. Although a state of fullness and light for the "I" yet to be born, close to the point of the individual, it appears instead as darkness and death.

The being is not master of himself as an I, but passive. Initiation looks forbidding, but will be enlightenment for the twice-born. He recapitulates the three stages.

1. In a first moment, it is dissolved in the world of appearances and mere representations.

2. In a second moment it is felt as infinite passion, as the dark and silent pain of privation, as the indescribable crucifixion in the world of necessity.

3. But, born from it, the individual now assumes this death with joy; he is adequate to it; he knows that only his own supernatural value of 'being made of possession" is its cause; he recognizes it as matter,

> from which only he will be able to drag the splendour of a life to an absolute reality.

Evola describes this process of initiation in more detail. The "being of possession" echoes back to Max Stirner; the being now "owns" himself. The "three worlds" is a reference to Taoism.

> And then the darkness gradually is illumined, then the *terrible* flower of the absolute Individual rises from the abyss of necessity. He raises himself slowly into the starless sky, pulling himself from the fierce heat of what he devours in his power. Things and beings *die* in his vertiginous intensity and he gradually, irresistibly, becomes — he, *tremendous* in his purity, is "Master of Yes and No" and Ruler of the "three worlds". And in him, a being of possession, a being that "burns and blazes", the process of the universe will have its consummation or final perfection with his act.

In the second part of *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*, Evola distinguishes between the "religious attitude" and initiation. The former has these characteristics:

1. It believes that the world is fundamentally right from a principle of order, harmony, and goodness, and that everything opposed to it that is darkness, irrationality, indeterminateness, evil, either is illusion or something that must not be.

2. Consequently, it pushes such a principle back onto something "other than me" – to something transcendent. We say "consequently" since my actual experience is showing me a world totally different from one that is ordered and rational, I am not entitled to also admit the actual existence, alongside it, of a providential and rational world, unless I relate it to something that transcends me and to believe that this something exists.

3. If such a transcendent principle is intended to be the source of every reality, it must be said that the individual in himself is nothing and can be nothing. The "I" is annulled and its being is pushed back onto the other.

Evola contrasts that to the wisdom of the mysteries — of Buddha, Dionysus, Mithras, Hermes:

1. He faces up to reality, without veils, in its tragic, irrational, unprovidential nature.

2. He rejects the belief in the present existence of an optimistic order, and the necessity of postulating the transcendental, the God to guarantee it, and to explain how it can coexist with the order of existing things that contradict it.

3. Thus the gulf remains between titanic pessimism and Dionysianism, bridged by recognizing or not recognizing the moral right to existence of a regulated, just, and rational world. In the case of the affirmative, he asserts the concept of the individual as a sufficient power in himself, capable of saving not only himself but also everything that he is connected to and that, at bottom, is the reflexion of what he concretely is.

Posted on 2011-03-17 by Cologero

* * *

Zmaj on 2011-03-05 at 05:20 said:
Yes, this is a true summary.
I mention two additional points:
1) Readers who are familiar with the subjects and authors discussed are likely aware of the distinction between 'will' in the lower sense and the 'Will' treated in this post.

The 'will' in most people is dominant, tyrannical even, and it subjugates the intellect, reducing it to discursive thought. This lower will usurps a higher rank that does not belong to it. Those who are thus arranged (i.e. the average majority) will find the current decadent society quite accommodating; their will is constantly pulling them into manifold activity, and they only need to think about how to do those things that will satisfy their whims and schemes. Their internal rebellion parallels the external disorder.

The Will is of a different quality to 'will'/desire. It is rightfully situated above or alongside the intellect, and acts to integrate and strengthen the intellect. When Will is awake, proper order is established, with the intellect governing the thoughts, whilst the clarified thoughts fortify the ordinary will; and this will not necessarily lead to a life of 'high achievement' in the social sense. Simultaneously, the Will is outside of the realm of the persona, and this is its proper place – the plane of real activity.

Transformation is indeed a real possibility, but a dangerous one. A severe trial can accompany an attempt, and success is not guaranteed. Veil thyself with the darkness of a valley at midnight before all else.

HOO on 2012-03-23 at 00:36 said:

"The suffering from frustrated ambition is peculiar to people living in a society of equality under the law. It is not caused by equality under the law, but by the fact that in a society of equality under the law the inequality of men with regard to intellectual abilities, will power and application becomes visible. The gulf between what a man is and achieves and what he thinks of his own abilities and achievements is pitilessly revealed. Daydreams of a "fair" world which would treat him according to his "real worth" are the refuge of all those plagued by a lack of self-knowledge."
– "The Anti-Capitalistic Mentality" by Ludwig von Mises

Aidan on 2011-03-08 at 14:07 said:

Supra-individual states are not associated with individuality. This is not a linguistic turn but a point that is mathematical in its precision. Entry into supra-individual states requires the complete surrender of all individuality – the partial preservation and integration of specific elements of the latter within the former is a matter which is not in the hands of the individual.

"It is almost superfluous to stress how little place the individual 'self' occupies in the totality of the being, since even given its entire extension when envisaged in its integrality, and not merely in one particular modality such as the corporeal, it constitutes only one state like the others, among an indefinitude of others."

and

"... there is assuredly a form of consciousness, among all possible forms, that is properly human, and this determinate form (ahankara, or 'self-consciousness') is inherent in what we

term the 'mental' faculty, that is, precisely that 'internal sense' which is designated in Sanskrit by the name manas, and which is truly the characteristic of human individuality. This faculty ... must be carefully distinguished from pure intellect, which latter, on the contrary, by reason of its universality, must be regarded as existing in all beings and in all states, whatever the modalities through which its existence is manifested,; and one should not see in the 'mental' anything beyond what it really is, that is, to use the terminology of logic, a 'specific difference' pure and simple, the possession of which does not itself confer on man any effective superiority over other beings."

Both of these quotes are taken from Guenon's "The Multiple States of the Being". If the human state, the individual state and the psychic principle (both mental and sentimental) are all one and the same, how is the individual 'asserting himself', 'giving meaning and purpose to the world' and 'realising himself' not an exaltation of the human state and how are the states Evola describes *beyond* the human state, as opposed to extremities that may be reached within it?

Cologero on 2011-03-09 at 07:45 said:

As for "realising himself", how is that different from how Guenon describes the "True Man", the one who realises all his possibilities? Are you suggesting that the world has no meaning or purpose, that a man acts randomly without meaning, purpose or intent? "Like, whatever ... " is not a heroic attitude.

Evola's concern is with the "I", which is not individual ("not multipliable"). Compare with Coomaraswamy's essay "The One and Only Transmigrant". We've emphasized that there is a difference in perspective between Guenon and Evola. Guenon is strictly a metaphysician, interested in higher states, or really the Transcendent Man, beyond all states. But even the jivanmukti — the one who has transcended while in this world — nevertheless continues to act in the world. Is his action random, without purpose, dependent on the external environmental factors of gross and subtle manifestation? Or does he act from the "center", the Unmoved Mover? Even the jivanmukti can't avoid "asserting himself", just his manner of self-assertion.

Of course, ultimately, there is no "external environment". The concept of privation is not a novelty from Evola, even Guenon uses that term.

In Multiple States, Guenon writes about the angelic hierarchy, only to dismiss it. From a metaphysical point of view, all that matters is the existence of multiple states in general, not what they are specifically. However, from a cosmological point of view (and Hermetic, which is a cosmology), these particular states are of great interest.

As for the Individual and the Absolute, Evola writes: "between the person and universal subject there is a relationship not of coexistence and otherness, rather of continuity and progressivity." We will bring that up in the discussion of the One and the Many.

Aidan on 2011-03-09 at 21:00 said:

It is frankly astonishing that you can derive any suggestion of an attitude of "like, whatever" from my previous comment. Given the reference to individuality being oriented towards and grounded within supra-individual states – a perspective which transforms both world and individual together – where on earth do you find even a hint that the world might be without meaning or purpose, or that a man "acts randomly without meaning, purpose or intent"? When every last part of its order is derived from a still higher order, the world is saturated with meaning and demonstrates perfect purpose; upon the plane of the individual, precisely the same is true of actions which arise directly and spontaneously from the stillness of immovable principle and return to it with complete circularity.

There is no comparison between heroism and divinity. There is not one hero; there are many. There are not many divinities; there is one. Heroism is necessarily attached to individuality while divinity transcends it completely. Compare with Coomaraswamy's 'One and Only Transmigrant' indeed! Who is it who transmigrates from incarnation to incarnation? It is not Cologero or Aidan or Evola or Guenon: "the Lord is the only transmigrant."

Coomaraswamy and Guenon are at one on this point because both are at one with primordial tradition and their knowledge lacks nothing. Evola, by contrast, is out on his own – an island in the ocean – at no point is he talking about the Lord. He means – as you say – make YOURSELF God. He means himself, nothing higher: for him, his interior sense is the highest, hence all the sound and fury. It is not a subtle mystery; indeed, it is a crude caricature of true knowledge. Even if he is not oriented towards unity with the Lord, as a brahmin would be ("Whoever is joined unto the Lord is One Spirit" 1 Corinthians 6:17), he still needs to bow to the Lord, as all kshatriya must, if his deeds are to be genuinely heroic and his heart truly noble.

Yes, the True Man realises himself and all his possibilities but not at the expense of transcendence. He does not have to be transcendent himself – which is just as well, because he cannot be – but his relationship to the Transcendent cannot be aberrant if he is to be and remain True.

There would be no problem if there were no insistence that Evola and Guenon are providing related and compatible perspectives. In a fundamental sense, they reveal themselves to be irreconcilable. Either Evola disrupts and deforms Guenon's metaphysics or Guenon severely restricts Evola's ambition. Pressing them together without allowing one to fully dominate the other, as though your own third perspective went further than either, will do a disservice to one or the other and conceal elements in both that need to be seen.

The suggestion that was made earlier that knowledge and action are simply two different spiritual paths is misleading in the extreme. No-one would suggest Evola is a representative of karma marga, a path of selfless action, yet this is the only sense in which action and knowledge can be presented as parallel contrasting paths about which individual choices can be made. Karma marga can be contrasted with jnana marga and bhakti marga without any confusion. The issue of the brahmins and kshatriyas – and the type of knowledge and type of action

they represent – is not a matter of two different paths that an individual may or may not take. These are social castes, not individual paths. It is the ordering of the world that is at stake. Can there be two world orders simultaneously? This is what Evola disingenuously presents before contradicting himself (and placing action above knowledge) and you echo it. Guenon presents knowledge and action as two aspects of the same order and has knowledge superior to action in the sense that correct and appropriate action proceeds out of knowledge and not vice versa. Both cannot be true; the issue can be fudged, however, which makes it come out in Evola's favour by default. Evola's is a recipe for a kingdom divided against itself and it will not stand – it will be perpetual all-out war followed by collapse and destruction.

Finally, with regard to the angelic hierarchies, Guenon says that "the existence of extra-human and supra-human states is of little importance to us" in the sense that we have "no motive for occupying ourselves especially with them". He does not dismiss them at all, speaking of angels as beings in their own right having none of the faculties of an individual order, e.g., reason, but in no way being inferior as a result of this and saying that "the 'angelic' states are properly the supra-individual states of manifestation, that is, those pertaining to non-formal manifestation."

I intend this to be my last comment on this site. The manner in which my earlier comments have been received has spoken volumes and it would be futile to continue in the same vein. In any event, allow me to thank you for your endeavors. I wish you well.

Matt on 2011-03-09 at 22:15 said:

Aidan,

I've felt when reading Evola that he places action above knowledge. He may focus on action a lot more , but I think that isdue to his particular persuasion.

Anyways, hopefully you continue to comment. I think your posts are well-written and contian some good points.

Matt on 2011-03-09 at 22:16 said:

Correction: First sentence should be.... .I've never*

Cologero on 2011-03-10 at 08:09 said:

It is important not to equate "the courage of one's convictions" with being possessed by a "fixed idea". Although this is a distasteful task, nevertheless I need to clarify some points lest anyone think there is any substance to the objections made to the commentaries on Evola's book. (yes, intelligent objections are welcome.)

The commenter objected to these phrases: " 'asserting himself', 'giving meaning and purpose to the world' and 'realising himself' "

Gornahoor intersperses other material with the commentary on Evola for a specific purpose: viz, to situate Evola's ideas within a larger perspective. In that way we can properly understand those phrases, dealing with their actual content rather than nitpicking over "imperfections of expression." Thus:

"Asserting oneself" needs to be understood as the role of Man as the intermediary between Heaven and Earth; as the Will as intermediary between Providence and Destiny.

If the commenter objects to the perfectly legitimate idea of 'giving meaning' how else are we to understand that objection? Is it really preferable that the "universe" provides meaning that we passively accept? It is just that attitude that Evola opposes.

"Realising oneself" is again relatable to Guenon. The individual as Spirit (a non-formal state) actualizes or realizes his potentialities in the World. Again, nothing at all objectionable from a Traditional perspective.

Evola is providing a phenomenological study of the "I", that is available to anyone making the effort. He it not writing about the will of Evola, but rather the will of the I. In this he should be understood as taking Shankara's perspective against Ramanuja. It is a legitimate point of view, which Evola develops to its logical conclusion. Again, we pointed out that the concept of privation is common to Aquinas and Guenon. Now, of course, anyone can prefer the position of the "realist" to the "idealist" (as Evola uses those terms). However, to make the discussion worthwhile, he needs to respond to Evola's arguments against the realist, not to wish that they had never been made.

The idea of the Absolute I, or Brahman, is not unique to Evola; perhaps readers are not so accustomed to dealing with the logical consequences of this view.

It is not so absurd, and subjectivity is not a counter-argument. Go back and read what we have written about the Primordial State, particularly as historically documented by Julian Jaynes. Subjectivity and sense of ego are not necessary or even natural to man. Jaynes documents how at some stage, men were not plagued by such feelings. Instead, they acted together as a unified group. There is a reason for all these posts, they fit together.

Finally, we can mention that there is one Hero, with a thousand faces. Someone once wrote that there are just a few causes of human misery – illness, poverty, oppression – and are common to every man. However, the Heroic path is unique to each man. Unlike the path to misery, there is no one way to God, or Enlightenment. Instead each man has to find his own way and deal with his own Destiny. That is why the Hero has a thousand faces.

Albion on 2011-03-10 at 08:42 said:

Hi, it's good to be allowed to ask questions, and thank you for this marvelous site.

My question is, if Guenon (I don't have the exact reference) was worried about "spiritual counterfeits" and "amalgams" that had the form of traditionalism, but whose principle was entirely demonic in its unity, why was it that the "West" immediately sprang to mind in the sense

that the history of the West for the last thousand years seems to be one entirely of REVOLUTION and re-synthesis which always aspires to conserve? I don't know enough about the East to ask a similar question, but the East seems to me to be lacking in some form of energy. Is this merely my perception as a Westerner under the shadow?

Graham on 2011-03-10 at 12:04 said:

I for one cannot understand Aidan's objections. The theory involved is quite easily followed: Evola took the 'raw material' of German Idealism and transmuted it into the theosis of a Meister Eckhart or a Plotinus.

Cologero on 2011-03-10 at 12:09 said:

I don't understand the point, Albion. You say the west is wracked by REVOLUTION, but where do we see the "re-synthesis which always aspires to conserve"?

Read the alternatives mentioned by Guenon: *The Prophecies of Rene Guenon.*[5] One of them involves a revolution. Instead of the constant harping about Guenon vs Evola, I wonder if anyone takes any of this seriously? Or is it more fun to re-arrange the deck chairs?

Graham on 2011-03-10 at 12:30 said:

Furthermore, if at a *certain stage* in this process one winds up alone like Robinson Crusoe, how can that be construed as an objection to the process itself? Doesn't St. John of the Cross speak of a dark night of the soul? Doesn't Jesus himself ask, on the cross, "my God, why have you forsaken me?"

Albion on 2011-03-10 at 20:04 said:

Thank you for the response. The question was very poorly phrased indeed; I was hoping for some pointers on where Guenon thought the West had gone off the rails (chronologically), and I see you've posted a link – it just occured to me that all of the revolutions in the West we've glorified (from 1000 or so onwards) are probably suspect as covert "aspirations" which are really a betrayal of unity, and therefore, the Good.

As for Evola, I am a neophyte at all this, but clearly if he had thought himself God, then he would not have felt obligated to clearly condemn so many movements, trends, or fads (eg., homosexuality). It's clear that a fair reading of Evola would support a more positive interpretation, which this website appears to be attempting to do.

I support it.

Albion on 2011-03-14 at 21:30 said:

[5] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=35

"Between these types of existence there is mental activity in the proper sense. In other words: beyond the ideal limit of the reign of pure necessity – of nature and spontaneity – and beyond his "privation", the individual enjoys in the rational or ideal order of the first level of sufficient actuality and freedom."

Cologero, could you clarify if the "first level" in the last sentence here is referring to the "second sense" of will known as power? So thought oscillates between identifying with unreality and privation and the force of power against the self, or fully identifying with its full purpose? Is this what he is concluding the passage by saying?

Cologero on 2011-03-15 at 00:03 said:

He is saying that beyond the first stage of privation and spontaneity, the individual first comes to know as ideas, or the ideal. Thus, through thinking, a man comes to see and understand his situation. That is the situation of philosophy in the West, viz, from German Idealism to Giovanni Gentile. But that is insufficient unless and until it becomes a process of self-transformation, can the ideal become real. This is real knowledge, "carnal knowledge", when knowing and being are the same.

I recommend "The World as Power" by John Woodroffe. This extended work will clarify this rather terse exposition by Evola. (Or else read the 700 pages of the complete system of Magical Idealism.)

Albion on 2011-03-19 at 01:15 said:

Since the purpose of the sight is not to defend Evola, but to build on him, then some elective affinity would seem to be in order, just to understand his position. However, Cologero may have stumbled on something here, which goes to the root of the misunderstanding of Platonism as somehow anti-matter. From the higher perspective, "matter" would of course be entirely good insofar as it existed at all, but would necessarily be "evil" insofar as it tended to deprive one of that higher perspective. Which is exactly what has happened. Plato never spoke as if we did not have bodies (George Parkin Grant). And one must not overlook the sophistication and symbolism and secret doctrine which operated to imbue statements that were "wrong" if taken ; context, more than terminology, is everything.

Albion on 2011-03-19 at 12:59 said:

I am beginning to think Platonism is nothing like what we have been told that it was. Necessity, without freedom is evil, just as freedom without necessity is evil. The traditionalists (or Platonists) don't get to talk about the divine loop where the end meets the beginning, generally because everyone quarrels with their quest. You can't have "Western" without Platonism. I don't see where Evola is any more anti-material than Platonism, in fact, far less so.

Albion on 2011-03-19 at 13:00 said:

Perhaps one could say that untransfigured matter, or matter rendered untransfigurable, is what is "evil". Which can be done.

Will on 2011-03-20 at 11:25 said:

The five numbered points from Evola's book are strongly parallel to the methodology of Tantric sadhana, so much so that I wonder whether Evola got it from Woodroffe or some other source, or whether he somehow figured it out on his own. This methodology survives to this day in Tantric Buddhist practices in which yidam deities are visualized and meditated upon and prayed to, until they become as real and more real than ordinary reality.

These visualizations are one of the primary uses of thangka paintings: they provide the image to be formed in the mind. There is some evidence that icons in the Christian tradition may have been used in similar ways, and perhaps still are in certain Orthodox circles. In both cases, the painter must go through certain preparatory and purificatory rituals prior to beginning the work. In both cases, the resultant images (if they are successful) are regarded as holy, and as retaining something of the essence of the deity or saint which they portray.

kadambari on 2011-03-21 at 12:22 said:

@Cologero

"Idiot" originally referred to a "person so mentally deficient as to be incapable of ordinary reasoning".

Alain de benoist gives an interesting definition of Idiot. I find his understanding of antiquity of interest, and do not know much about his politics. He writes:

"The notions of citizenship, liberty, or equality of political rights, as well as of popular sovereignty, were intimately interrelated. The most essential element in the notion of citizenship was someone's origin and heritage. Pericles was the "son of Xanthippus from the deme of Cholargus." Beginning in 451 b.c., one had to be born of an Athenian mother and father in order to become a citizen. Defined by his heritage, the citizen (polítes) is opposed to idiótes, the non-citizen—a designation that quickly took on a pejorative meaning (from the notion of the rootless individual one arrived at the notion of "idiot"). Citizenship as function derived thus from the notion of citizenship as status, which was the exclusive prerogative of birth. To be a citizen meant, in the fullest sense of the word, to have a homeland, that is, to have both a homeland and a history. One is born an Athenian—one does not become one (with rare exceptions). Furthermore, the Athenian tradition discouraged mixed marriages. Political equality, established by law, flowed from common origins that sanctioned it as well. Only birth conferred individual politeía.

That is essentially how caste was : people with a certain history and way of life…so being out of caste is to have no history and be a rootless individial…

http://home.alphalink.com.au/~{}radnat/debenoist/alain14.html

John Bardis on 2011-03-21 at 16:47 said:

In *The Yoga of Power* Evola writes:

"According to Indo-Aryan tradition, a caste corresponds to an individual differentiated nature, and to the body of laws (dharma) one should follow. In the Left-Hand Path, however, dharma is seen as a limitation, or as a conditioning to be overcome…Likewise, it does not matter to what caste a person pursuing absolute liberation belongs. Obviously, this is a case of apparent 'democracy'. The capability of effectively walking on the path produces differentiations among people that are more clear-cut and real than the ones due to caste membership, especially when the latter have lost their original and legitimate foundation." (page 97)

Perhaps this is what Gurdjieff's toasts to the idiots (or whatever it was called) was all about. I forget how it works, but there were forty or more different types of idiot, and each person had the task of determining which, exactly, kind of idiot he or she was–resulting in the downing of vast quatities of alcohol.

kadambari on 2011-03-21 at 18:57 said:

"Likewise, it does not matter to what caste a person pursuing absolute liberation belongs."

Yes in classical India you had the sanyasin (samana) who was beyond caste and religion (you could not demand of a sanyasin what his caste traditionally). However, this did not injure the overall political set up, even the sanyasin is something at the beginning. This is what I find so amazing about this civilization: all these elements could co-exist (the samanas later lead to the rise of Buddhism), which in turn co-esists with what precedes it, so a civilization self-corrects as long as its essential character is not disturbed in the sense that the essential way of life is destroyed; all is self-correction comes to a halt when classical civilization is destroyed by outside forces in the middle ages…So this is a case of pluralism which has none of the aspects we associate with pluralism in the modern sense, it is not multicultural because the differences are a facet of a larger civilization which encompasses it all in a unity….

John Bardis on 2011-03-21 at 19:37 said:

So, then, if I may ask–What caste are you?

kadambari on 2011-03-21 at 20:40 said:

Well we are Brahmins and retain some memory but today the civilization there is not one that can be properly be called "Hindu"; so I feel that we are helpless residues of a civilization that harldy exists anymore except among some remnants who carry a memory of it, people who are small in numbers; when I read this blog I feel Westerners are also dealing with similar dilemnas in a Western context…Yes I suppose we are also idiots in Benoist's sense, being unable

to relate to or sympathize with the current form of civilization which has taken root there, so rootless in this sense…

I suppose there is not much one can do but our tiny part to keep the memory of these things alive…Imagine if it were not for all these traditionalist writers we would not be concerning ourselves with such questions as a larger group, even if we might do so quietly as individuals! These things have to have impact amongst the public to have a future and cannot just be confined to isolated individuals in academia…A knowledge that there is a problem is the first step…

John Bardis on 2011-03-22 at 12:18 said:

In the town where I live, a few miles south of Atlanta, there's a Hindu temple. Or, actually, there are two of them side by side. They are quite magnificent. The main "god" of the first temple has to be the most amazing statue I've ever seen.

But in another part of Atlanta there is a whole temple complex that makes our two temples seem quite small in comparison.

There was a time in my life when I had the good fortunate to attend a good many concerts of classical Indian music.

Obviously Hinduism (or whatever you call it) isn't going anywhere. It's definitely here to stay.

kadambari on 2011-03-22 at 14:23 said:

I hope the Hindus are also doing something for the community… I can say that I myself know many things about our religion from the great Western scholars; the Buddhism book my brother read in college was written by a Catholic priest and it was a very good introduction I recall. Of course there are certain things that are passed down and you know as being a part of the culture, but we are always amazed by the dedicated Westerners who study it to such depths; the German scholars preserved many things when they were dying out even in our regions; genuine quest for knowledge transcends cultures…

I wish Indians would be exposed to the Greeks for they would really love them and learn so much from them and find them not different at all, but what can you do? With the current government run educational system there, Hindus barely understand even their own culture and history…

kadambari on 2011-03-23 at 08:31 said:

@John Bardis

The kinds of things you talk about are probably organized by South Indians, who as classical civilization was destroyed much later in the south still have some memory of architecture and other cultrual memories and so on, and can be benign people…The North (I am speaking of

places like Delhi) has a thuggish culture because it was totally destroyed at several points and hence there is a barbaric legacy which survives there, I really dislike the culture in those parts, however, the mountian/hill areas in the North where people took refuge during turmoil historically that I am familiar with are completely benign and still very pleasant to live…

As for Indian classical music, most of the great names (about ten) have died, there are only two great masters left…I wonder with interest diminishing in these things when we will again hear music composed by such masters again…

Yuhomo on 2011-03-23 at 09:54 said:

Evola is more magician or philosopher than metaphysician. Here he tends to pit freedom and will against necessity, yet he forgets that freedom doesn't exist without necessity. The divine by necessity willed being and cosmos, not the fall. And to be an individual being is not a constraint or weakness since its will is to be an individual whose immanence does not run counter to transcendence. Thus the statement, "There is no other evil beyond necessity, of which matter, brute existence, is the evidence" is absurd. Then in the moral argument Evola tends to be too Nietzschean in wanting to create an amoral morality based on power. But what do I know?

John Bardis on 2011-03-23 at 13:25 said:

Yes, I was told that the temples near where I live were for south Indians.

You will have to forgive the fact that my ignorance on these matters far outweighs my very real interest.

I believe that Buddhism was still prevalent in India, though only in northern India, at the time of the Muslim invasion. And, of course, this invasion only penetrated so far. So I suppose it does make sense that the traditions would be more intact in the south.

As for the music, it seems to me quite similar to western classical music in that it could only be created and can only be performed due to the existence of child prodigies. I believe both kinds of music are still being performed at a very high level. But perhaps creation has come to a stand-still. And this seems to be the case in many fields–literature, philosophy, art. Why this is, I don't know. Perhaps there are times of creation and times of preservation. Or perhaps all the emphasis now is on technology and popular culture.

kadambari on 2011-03-23 at 15:46 said:

@John Bardis

Yes the South is quite different from the North, they have their own variety of HInduism and their peculiar languages which sound even peculiar to us and their ways are quite different, but I find in spite of all these differences, the people there are gentler compared to the North; many of them obey rules as compared to the North and are capable of better organization amongst themselves, whereas the North is very unruly and disorderly owing to its bad history. Of course,

there are subtleties across regions and your geography will play a part in the peculiar aesthetics of your ethnic group…

Indians unfortunately are not exposed to Western classical music that much, which is a shame because it deprives them of something amazing out there just as they are not exposed to Greco-Roman civilization so cannot properly understand Western civilization and are mostly only exposed to English in terms of language. It is not that there is no interest in these things; they just have not been exposed…There needs to be exposure to these things if Indians can have a proper perspective on civilizations not their own…

As far as Western music is concerned, most are only exposed to pop music; you see the Chinese and Japanese really into Western classical music…I was lucky to have parents who appreciated Western classical music, so was lucky to grow up appreciating both classical Indian and classical Western music…

These days, there is much exposure to books in our region which is a good thing about the internet; today you can find most of the classics on the internet which is good for areas where they are not easily accessible. My husband who is in the sciences recalls when he was in college, the librarian was a Kashmiri Pandit, so in addition to the science books the librarian had a very peculiar section of other books according to his taste such as works by Aurel Stein, the explorer Richard Burton and old British histories of India (which contained history without whitewash) etc., which he says opened him up to understanding Indian history properly, as history is not taught in the schools correctly, as it is all written with a political agenda and dominated by Marxist historians and rewriting of history to serve political ends, the truth is not presented. Most people end up studying technical subjects and the sciences to survive in the modern world and find themselves when they get older woefully ignorant of their own civilization apart from what their parents have taught them and often want a refund on their education…

kadambari on 2011-03-23 at 17:04 said:

@John Bardis

We need geniuses to bring back the music, but proper patronage is also required to sustain the arts. The classical musical heritage of the South has to to with the renaissance of the arts during the Vijayanagar empire, the last Hindu stronghold. The rulers patronized the arts and all Brahmanical traditions such as music.

http://www.planetradiocity.com/musicopedia/music_decade.php?con id=2311

http://www.vasanthvisuals.com/hampi.html

There are ragas not which have disappeared due to lack of use, many we cannot even imagine because they have been destroyed with civilization in certain parts, so what is existing cannot continue wihout proper patronage. Unfortunately, the way the Indian State is today controlled by the socialist Congress ever since after independence with the exception of five

years, leading to India's current misery and ongoing deracination and overpopulation, I am skeptical of preservation of the arts unless some other party comes into power nationally as the native culture is looked down upon and not encouraged by the state…

Cologero on 2011-03-23 at 19:25 said:

The "divine" will is absolutely free and does not act out of necessity. It the divine is infinite, where would the "necessity" come from?

Evola is speaking about trans-human states, not the "individual" man as you seem to mean it.

Evola criticizes Nietzsche's "morality" because the latter did not understand "asceticism".

Please read the material carefully prior to commenting.

Evola may be wrong, but not for the reasons you present.

To emphasize once again, we are not out to convert, but rather to elucidate Evola and Guenon, in particular. The only issue at stake is whether or not we have presented Evola's philosophy clearly and accurately.

Yumo on 2011-03-24 at 09:18 said:

The divine will is not absolutely free in the sense that you imply. It cannot not will the universe, which occurs as a result of its infinitude. Necessity relates to the absolute, and freedom to the infinite, both of which coincide. If the divine is infinite how could it not also include necessity? But necessity does not relate to impossibility or falsehood as Evola would imply.

I know what Evola is trying to say but his accuracy is off, and for reasons which I suspect to be his early influences, to reduce everything to the freedom of the will. So while those he criticized erred in the direction that negated transcendence, he errs in the direction that negates ethical virtue.

He says that matter is a sign of imperfection as if necessity of willing the universe was not necessary, but then the divine would not be infinite nor free. Matter is a sign of the will to matter which enabled the divine to be immanent and therefore is what it is.

kadambari on 2011-03-25 at 09:26 said:

"I believe that Buddhism was still prevalent in India, though only in northern India, at the time of the Muslim invasion. And, of course, this invasion only penetrated so far."

The destruction was massive and total in most areas which never recovered. I recall the European who discovered the ellora caves. The people of the area had become so wretched, he could not imagine that the same people had once produced the art in Ellora….

Matt on 2011-03-25 at 16:03 said:

Yumo,

How does Evola negate ethics in his thought? He stated many times in his writings that he takes virtue into account, but virtue as it was traditionally defined (virtus as "power", the power to act in the right way in the right situation). Gornahoor has a post on St. Anthony and Evola that can give you a good idea of the ethics in Evola's thought.

> John Bardis on 2011-03-25 at 22:19 said:
> Dear Kadambari,
> Thank you for those links about the Vajayanager empire. They give a context to things that I have seen and heard. These things aren't simply from India. They are from a particular place in India at a particular time.
> And if these things that I have seen and heard are just the last rays of light from a star that no longer exists–well, is there anything unique in that? Here is something I happened to read today:
> "All that is mortal lives in this fear of death; every new birth augments the fear by one new reason, for it augments what is mortal. Without ceasing, the womb of the indefatigable earth gives birth to what is new, each bound to die, each awaiting the day of its journey into darkness with fear and trembling."
> And yet we know that this music, this art, this religious devotion, this philosophical insight, will never die.

6.4 Apollo and Dionysus

> There are two kinds of people in the world: those who believe there are two kinds of people in the world and those who don't.

I've put off discussion of the final part of **Julius Evola**'s The Individual and the Becoming of the World, primarily because it is difficult for an **Apollonian** to critique the **Dionysian**. The latter wants to assert what the former prefers not to assert, and to deny what he would rather not deny. For example, **Empedocles** claims there are two forces: Love and Strife. Yet to admit this is tantamount to admitting Strife alone as the only force. The Apollonian wants to unite, harmonize, and reach the depths of agreement; hence, he can only admit the first force which has no opposite. Nevertheless, Evola brings a sword, not peace.

Now "is" can be used in two ways: it can refer to essence or it can refer to existence (as described in Essence and Existence[6]).

So when **Parmenides** claims that change is impossible, he is referring to the realm of unchanging ideas or essences. **Heraclitus** claims there is nothing but change and he means the realm of prime matter, appearances, or existence. Evola, following Aristotle and the Medievals, takes the middle path.

Now the Apollonian can only speak of ideas and concepts which follow the laws of logic. Existence, however, is inexplicable to him, it is alogical (not illogical). Essence follows Thought, Existence follows Will.

To make his point, Evola contrasts three fundamental attitudes, or spiritual tendencies, that separate the religious attitude (Apollo) from the initiatic attitude (Dionysus). Yet how is this the end of the story? Beyond yin and yang is the Tao. In this early work, there is no mention of the Tao, or the alchemical marriage of the opposites. Also, Evola adopts the Lunar side, the path of darkness, power (Shakti), irrationality, intoxication and ecstasy. For easy reference, these attitudes are shown in chart 6.4.

Order and Harmony Apollo sees the world as ordered, harmonious, and providential. Whatever does not appear as such, is considered unreal or illusory. Dionysus, on the other hand, accepts the irrationality and tragedy of the world. Yes, but so do insects. For men, however, there have always been lawgivers, those who reveal the harmony hidden in the appearances and show the way to discover it. Even for Evola, the strong man is the one who can impose his will, as law. That the world is irrational and chaotic is the result of privation[7], that is, something that should not be.

[6] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1917

[7] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1815

Transcendence Apollo notices that disharmony of existence. However, he does not thereby postulate a parallel existence of a rational and ordered world. Just the opposite. Unless he knows what is rational and harmonious, by what standard can he judge existence not to be so? Hence, Dionysus cannot even know whether existence is rational or irrational, without a transcendent standard. Hence, he must be his own lawgiver.

The Individual If there is a transcendent order, then the individual himself is part of that order, and cannot be said to exist. For Dionysus, "man *himself* has a real possibility of ordering and controlling this chaos and thereby bringing about a cosmos that doesn't already exist but demands its existence from him." This gets to the crux of Evola's point: the I is real, he orders his life, and the I knows himself from his life, which is his own reflexion.

The Royal Path This is the beginning, then, the initiation into the Mysteries. For Evola, and for Dionysus, the Self is not known as a concept or an object, but rather knows himself as the subject, the author of his life, and indirectly through viewing the world as his reflexion. The knowledge of the Mysteries resides in the darkness, beyond rational thought. That is why Dionysus is the god of wine: In vino, veritas, not in clear-eyed logic. Dionysus is the god of ecstasy, yet cannot give a logical response when asked about it. That is not the point in any case and to insist on it is to destroy the magic. Evola makes this contrast:

> To dare to tear away the veils with which Apollo hid primordial reality, to dare to transcend form in order to put oneself in contact with the primordial "atrocity" of a world in which good and evil, divine and human, rational and irrational, just and unjust no longer have any sense, being *only* power, naked, free, fiery power; to dare that, and not to be swept away from this bottomless precipice, but to be able to do it, to control in oneself and, not

> surpassed but surpassing, to realize the wild pleasure of existing tragically — such is the test of Dionysus, from which every will that truly wants to escape from the "God of the Earth" must have his consecration.

Posted on 2012-02-26 by Cologero

* * *

CaseyAnn on 2013-09-07 at 14:50 said:

Cologero, I want to tell you how much I appreciate what you do here. *Gornahoor* is the most essential and greatest website there could possibly be.

Since I'm in university, I don't have much time for Traditional readings on the side, so *Gornahoor* is an especially excellent resource at this time. It's amazing that while I study philosophy in a profane academic setting I can simply search for the philosophers here and actually gain something truly valuable, see an understanding of Truth from what they have left us. Thank you.

Religious Attitude	Attitude of the Mysteries
It believes that the world is fundamentally right from a principle of order, harmony, and goodness, and that everything opposed to it that is darkness, irrationality, indeterminateness, evil, either is illusion or something that must not be.	He faces up to reality, without veils, in its tragic, irrational, unprovidential nature
Consequently, it pushes such a principle back onto something "other than me" — to something transcendent. We say "consequently" since my actual experience is showing me a world totally different from one that is ordered and rational, I am not entitled to also admit the actual existence, alongside it, of a providential and rational world, unless I relate it to something that transcends me and to believe that this something exists.	He rejects the belief in the present existence of an optimistic order, and the necessity of postulating the transcendental, the God to guarantee it, and to explain how it can coexist with the order of existing things that contradict it;
If such a transcendent principle is intended to be the source of every reality, it must be said that the individual in himself is nothing and can be nothing. The "I" is annulled and its being is pushed back onto the other.	Thus the gulf remains between titanic pessimism and Dionysianism, bridged by recognizing or not recognizing the moral right to existence of a regulated, just, and rational world. In the case of the affirmative, he asserts the concept of the individual as a sufficient power in himself, capable of saving not only himself but also everything that he is connected to and that, at bottom, is the reflexion of what he concretely is.

Table 6.2: Religious Attitudes

7 The Primordial State. Adam and Eve

7.1 The Platonic Tradition

We include Plato, Aristotle, Plotinus, and Thomas Aquinas as the pillars of the Platonic Tradition. This does not mean that they agree on every detail, but that they participate in a mutually comprehensible discussion. Our commitment is based on the following principles:

- **Metaphysical Positivism**. The spiritual world can be experienced in an analogous way to our experience of the sensual world. However, the former is not experienced as sensory images but rather as formless intuition.

- **Meditation**: Meditation is one stage of the process which is followed by contemplation and union. Unlike the idea held in the popular mind, for which meditation is a means for a better, more stress free personal life, we mean focused attention on a specific idea that leads to deeper understanding beyond what linear thinking can accomplish.

- **Ur-platonism**. There is a metaphysic that is common to different peoples in different traditions. In the west, this is represented by Platonism, properly understood.

We discussed our experiences with our meditations on one of these topics:

- Developing self-awareness or remembering our first moment
- Re-experiencing Adam's moment of self-awareness

Maximos the Confessor in his work[1] on the Kingdom of Heaven supplements this Tradition.

The fundamental conception is this, as Maximos mentions:

> The kingdom of heaven consists in possessing an inviolate and pre-eternal knowledge of created things through perceiving their inner essences as they exist in God.

That is our starting point for our upcoming discussions on the various manifestations of Ur-Platonism. To wit, our understanding of the Kingdom of Heaven is founded on our understanding of essences, not on the material, sensual world.

There are obstacles to the meditations, that seemed difficult to articulate. It seems that we create a factitious mental world that obscures the "real" world, which is described as "beautiful". However, on deeper thought, the world, as it is manifested, is not really so beautiful and innocent. Perhaps, and this can be the subject for a new meditation, is that what is beautiful is actually essences. That is, if we can "see" the essences, we would then experience beauty. The highest essence of all is the vision of the entire cosmos in the mind of God. The closer we can get to understanding that vision, the closer we are to Heaven.

[1] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=7568`

The angelic and planetary stages filter this great idea as it becomes manifested. For example, different levels will extend the great cosmic idea into time, or into space, and so on. In the opposite direction, we can follow Maximos:

> It [the Kingdom of Heaven] is a state similar to that of the angels, attained by those who are saved.

In the opposite direction, we can ascend from the manifest through these higher states. Dante describes this journey through the purgatorical states, then through the planetary spheres, to the angels and ultimately to Heaven.

These topics came up about the meaning of the Eden story.

- Why was there one commandment for Adam? Why is a commandment necessary for a moral world of free agents?

- Why was it not good for Adam to be alone? Why is Eve necessary? Or more generally, why is there the other?

As for the reason for the fall of Adam, can anyone develop his full potentials if he faces no challenges? What good, then, is immortality for its own sake? The Edenic state is too static, and ultimately, too little. Hence, a higher salvation is necessary in order to achieve Heaven. This led to the question of whether Christ would have come, even had there been no fall? The consensus of this moot point is "yes", since salvation leads to the Kingdom of Heaven, a much more elevated state then Eden. Maximos emphasizes that the Kingdom is depends on the individual:

> the grace of the kingdom is given to all according to the quality and quantity of the righteousness that is in them.

The novel *Zanoni* illustrates some of these ideas. Mejnour and Zanoni were initiates who discovered the secret of immortality. Mejnour is rather static. He tries to train a student, who fails the intricate and contradictory thought processes necessary to be initiated. We should be able to see this in our discussions: linear thinking does not seem to work. One idea, that might seem to be fruitful initially, leads to an impasse. Then something else becomes necessary.

Zanoni gives up immortality for Love, family, honor. He then enters the wheel of man, woman, life, death. But that seems superior to a life of immortality without purpose.

We see that there is not always a simple, convincing answer to the most important questions. Following one line of thought can lead to an impasse or even its opposite. When faced with such an opposition, always look for the neutralizing or equilibrating force. We learned that early on, but it seems to be forgotten. It is a fundamental notion in our way of thinking. The third force can be difficult to notice. Never forget to get back to the basics.

Recommended exercise: Meditation is both active and passive. Use the active imagination to place yourself into the situation, while simultaneously listening to what ideas may appear in consciousness.

Posted on 2020-10-06 by Admin

7.2 The Edenic State

Magical Artist Suppose you saw a seascape that reminded you wistfully of that summer you spent in Cape Code in your youth … wouldn't you admire the artist? Now suppose there was a magical artist who, Escher-like, managed to paint you yourself into that seascape … how much more deeply would you re-experience that summer?

For the description of the primordial state, i.e., the state of man before the Fall, we are relying on the following two sources:

- **St Basil the Great**, *On the Human Condition*
- **St Symeon the New Theologian**, *The First Created Man*

It is not enough to read it in an academic way, but rather one must try to "enter the picture" and recognize their descriptions in one's own consciousness.

Executive Summary

> The gnosis of the second Arcanum is consciousness such as it was before the Fall.
>
> Valentin Tomberg

The Primordial state is the original state of human consciousness.

Man in the Primordial State is rational and passionless … this is the opposite of how man is viewed today. Of course, that is what we should expect, isn't it? The former describes man has he is in his essence, the latter, as he appears to be.

The Event Horizon Trying to understand the Genesis creation story historically and scientifically presents an immediate difficulty. Looking back in time, all we see is death and corruption. Any Edenic or primordial state is beyond that horizon and inaccessible to historical, archaeological, or scientific investigation. Nothing materially incorruptible could have survived until our time.



Figure 7.1: Earthly Delights

Psychic Layers In any case, it is not the historical events and conditions that counts, but rather their meaning. **Valentin Tomberg** develops a method of meditation which he attributes to **Carl Jung**. This involves "the exploration of psychic layers as the living past of the soul. The entire past lives in the diverse layers of the depths of consciousness." So instead of looking back, we look inward to discover all the states of consciousness involved in the creation of the world and man.

God created the basic elements — light (fire), water, air, earth, and life — all of which are prerequisites for the possibility of manifestation. These elements symbolize energy and the three states of matter. Life signifies interiority, so that the world has an "inside" as well as an "outside". It is this interiority that makes such a meditation possible.

We have previously described this method to understand the cause of the Fall in *Doubt and Certainty*[2]. With the help of the two Fathers who have described the primordial state in some detail, we offer suggestions to understand that state through the meditation of the psychic layers.

Image and Likeness Man was created in the image and likeness of God. These refer to the two poles of being, which is made clear because man is created both from spirit and dust:

- **Image of God**: This is man as created, so it is a passive quality. Just as a work of art brings glory to the artist, the image of God in man bears glory to God, not to man himself. This was not lost in the Fall.
- **Likeness to God**: The likeness to God occurs as man grows more god-like, which is called theosis. As an active quality, the likeness

[2] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/doubt-and-certainty

> requires actualization and manifestation. This was lost in the Fall and its recovery is the goal of reintegration.

Obviously, man as the image of God does not mean that God has a human type of body. Rather it means that man is distinguished by the rational, or intellectual, soul. Note especially that this does not mean that man *has* reason, but rather that he *is* reason. Man's body and lower soul is formed by the intellectual soul.

There is a lower and higher intellectual soul. The lower knows through discursive, logical, and sequential thought, the higher through direct intuition.

- **Lower intellect soul**: its function is to perceive the material world, then organize and evaluate these perceptions.
- **Higher intellect soul**: the higher function is to perceive spiritual realities. E.g. other people as spiritual beings, angels, and God

These will be explained in detail in the forthcoming post on knowledge in Man, God, and Angels.

In the primordial state, the intellect works harmoniously with *eros* (or *epithumia*) and *thumos*, the physical center and emotional center, respectively.

Thus man's real existence is interior: "Although our outer human being is perishing, the inner is renewed day by day." [2 Cor 4:16]

New Age Distortions There are two new age distortions of this teaching, one for each pole. The first is the claim that everyone is a "child of God" by birthright. The actual teaching is that only the baptized, i.e., those on the path to theosis, can be called children of God. The true meaning is that every human is created in the image of God, but that does not bring any glory or credit to that person.

The other is a corruption of the Vedanta idea that "Atman is Brahman"; For example, people tell me, "I am God," when I can see perfectly well that they are not. By that, they mean that in their fallen state they are somehow God-like. As we have seen, that is completely false. It is only by the reintegration to the Blessed State through theosis that makes someone "God-like".

The Blessed State Since God is holy, passionless, and sinless, man in the blessed state is likewise holy, passionless, and sinless

Holy The word for "holy" in Greek and Hebrew means "set apart", in English, it derives from "whole". This refers to the Real I which is apart from and transcendent to the world. ("I am in the world but not of it.") The Real I also represents the unity of the being, since it ties all the parts together.

The holy man has no need of any law (with one exception), since a law commands us to do good and avoid evil. In Eden, all creation was good, hence there was no need to know evil.

Changeable God is unalterable, unchangeable, and simple. Man, on the contrary, is alterable, changeable, and composed of parts. Although free from physical privation, there was still the possibility of mental privation. That is the meaning of the tree of good and evil. In other words, there was the possibility of knowing evil, but not the actuality. The Fall made that possibility actual as described in *Doubt and Certainty*[3].

Therefore, man as free was commanded not to eat from the tree lest he die. That was the only law.

Sinless As created, the Will follows the Intellect. In the Primordial State, man was holy and he knew God directly through his intellect. As

[3] `https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/doubt-and-certainty`

there were no distractions to the Will, it followed the Intellect faithfully. Hence, man was sinless.

This does not mean that man, such as he is, is sinless; that is the assumption of the modern mind. This usually is expressed that God created us a certain way, so our inclinations and peccadillos are how he wants us to be. Quite the contrary, we are to overcome such inclination and achieve the likeness of God through theosis.

There is a common misunderstanding about free will. The common opinion is that it means we can choose this or that at will. The deeper understanding of free will is that it means that we can never be compelled to choose evil. The practical application of this understanding is an exercise left to the reader.

Passionless Passionless means that man in the primordial state was not subjected nor reactive to forces from below. It does not mean that he was cold and without feelings. After all, the world has an inside that can be felt deeply. Poets, artists, mystics, and even ordinary people have sometimes had this feeling of the world erupt into their consciousness. Although that feeling is quite profound, and even transforming, it is still natural and not the same as the unitive experience of theosis.

So passionless means that the Intellect rules over the passions; in particular, negative emotions cannot arise. Another way to put this is that the "subtle rules the dense".

St Basil has an interesting interpretation of the command to "rule" the animals. He allegorizes the animals as representing various emotional states, which must be "ruled" by the Intellect.

The command to multiply means to increase our own spiritual growth.

Conditions In the primordial state, man was immortal and incorrupt. There was no sin, sorrows, cares, or difficult necessities; there were no labors, no misfortunes, no disease, and no accidents.

These are the conditions that the New Age teachings assume as natural. The New Ager will assert that all is perfect, whole, and complete. Christian Science, in particular, claims to be based on the knowledge of those conditions.

However, those conditions only apply to man in the Primordial State. All affirmations, denials, treatments, visualizations, and so on are ineffective otherwise. A fortiori, all social programs to recreate the Edenic conditions are similarly doomed to failure. The modern mind rejects everything necessary for reintegration. They assume that:

- Man is not holy, but rather a part of nature.
- Man is not ruled by the Intellect, but rather by passions. These must be protected at all costs. Without passion, man is nothing.
- Man is not sinful, so whatever he is or does needs to be tolerated and accepted.

Reintegration is based on the opposite of each of those assumptions.

Posted on 2014-09-26 by Cologero

* * *

Marcel K. on 2014-09-26 at 13:31 said:

Cologero,

I am a silent reader and since this is my first comment I want to thank you for the great work you've done with this blog and the profound insights you've given to us.

Since it is something I currently struggle to understand, I wanted to ask you if you could expand on the distinction between the state of passionlessness and the absence of feelings (or coldness)? I think you're telling us that it is possible to quench our passions without practicing a form of religious quietism, i.e. the complete suppression of our worldy efforts. Personally however I haven't been able to achieve a deep understanding of this distinction. It seems to me that whenever I think I begin to understand, it immediately slips from my grasp and I revert to a state of not-understanding.

I've been wondering whether the distinction is blatantly obvious and my inability to comprehend simply a result of faulty thinking on my part, or very subtle with deeper implications than unsubtle distinctions.

Logres on 2014-09-26 at 22:08 said:

If man is a microcosm, then the individual becomes just like Nature as we see it: that is, there is a blind, groping manifestation of undulating movement (which we mistakenly call "real life" and identify our personality with), and then there is what the Catholics would call the "hidden soul", which is what's left of the image of God in man. Just as the natural world undulates or groans for redemption, but by itself cannot manifest the Logos, so the fallen being is gripped by a fierce passion(s) which smothers up the waters of Life. Whoever wins at "real life" loses, says Mouravieff, whoever "loses", wins. The analogy, he states, is almost exact. Isn't this what is meant, the "last will be first, the first last"? So the emotional (thumos) level of being is the aim of esoteric work, as it is embryonic, the astral foetus, and like embryonic tissue, is easily distorted by the power of the passions' toxins it is exposed to, in that under-developed state. That's why the personality has to "die" in the dark night of the soul…it seems like cutting yourself off from Life, like an addiction. In reality, it's the way out that is "deeper in".

Cologero on 2014-09-27 at 21:22 said:

Marcel, that is a life's work, not a comment. Passionlessness means that one is not ruled by the lower passions. On the other hand, there are legitimate feelings that motivate our wills or else we'd be machines. I guess there is a subtle difference between the passions ruling or motivating. When the negative emotions are ignored, there is the possibility for higher feelings of joy, peace, etc. to appear. It requires study, e.g., in the Philokalia or Clement of Alexandria. And along with that, a lot of practice in observing the passions and learning not to be reactive.

Caleb on 2014-09-28 at 16:07 said:

Marcel,

It may help in understanding passionless to contemplate Aristotle's 'Unmoved Mover.' Consider the relation of the Sun to the other heavenly bodies which orbit it. Its position relative to them remains unmoved, and yet even though it just sits there in the center, its mere presence determines the movement of the other celestial bodies through its gravis. One certainly would not describe the Sun as cold however!

Passion can be defined as "that which moves us." The sun, through its immense presence is not moved by the other bodies, which by traditional understanding represent the passions (Venus driving desire, Mars driving anger, the moon driving the subconscious, etc). God likewise is as the sun, the center and source of all things, which move in Him, while He, in His aspect of

transcendent unity, remains unmoved, because He is the center. That is the ideal which we aim for as we make our way back to the center.

7.3 The Primordial State

> The present age must come to terms drastically with the facts as they are, with the absolute opposition that is not only tearing the world asunder politically but has planted a schism in the human heart. We need to find our way back to the original, living spirit which, because of its ambivalence, is also a mediator and uniter of opposites, an idea that preoccupied the alchemists for many centuries.
>
> C G Jung, *Aion*

> *O felix culpa quae talem et tantum meruit habere redemptorem*
>
> "O happy fault that earned for us so great, so glorious a Redeemer."

Memory of the Primordial State was retained in several traditions. In *Man and his Becoming*, Rene Guenon describes three stages leading to Union: in ascending order, *balya*, *panditya*, and *mauna*.

In Balya, or the Primordial State,

> all the powers of the being are concentrated in one point, realizing by their unification an undifferentiated simplicity, comparable to embryonic potentiality. It means the return to the 'primordial state'.

In that state, the powers of the being are concentrated in the Self, which is the unifying factor. In the natural state, man is not unified under a unified will. He is uncertain, opinions and desires change from minute

to minute, unconscious drives cloud the intellect, knowledge is hard to come by.

Guenon then compares it to the Western analogue:

> This is the 'Edenic state' of the Judeo-Christian tradition; it explains why Dante placed the Terrestrial Paradise on the summit of the mountain of purgatory, that is to say at the exact point where the being quits the Earth, or the human state, in order to rise to the Heavens, described as the 'Kingdom of God'.

The balya stage is childlike because of the analogy to embryonic potentiality. Jesus implies the same idea:

> Whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child shall not enter it.
>
> Luke 18:17

This is the state enjoyed by Adam and Eve. Nevertheless, it is only preparatory and is far from the state of Union (*mauna*) or the Beatific Vision.

Life in the Edenic Bower

> That spot to which I point is Paradise,
>
> Adam's abode; those lofty shades his bower.
>
> John Milton, *Paradise Lost*

Origins are always a mystery.

> In paradise man would have been like an angel in his spirituality of mind, yet with an animal life in his body.
>
> Thomas Aquinas

Adam awoke from his slumber with an enhanced consciousness. He was able to name the plants and animals. That is, he knew them by their natures or essences, not just as material objects. Pythagoras claimed that it was the wisest man who gave names to things.

Adam was formed, not made. To be formed means to be informed by one's essence. The form acts on matter to make it what it is. At that point, Adam was no longer an animal. He had an intellectual soul. He was a person, since he had an individual name, not a species name like the animals he named.

To make is to construct from existing material parts. I can make a mousetrap. I can even make the cheese (although it is much easier to just buy it). But I cannot make a mouse out of existing parts. A mouse can only be conceived, grow, and be informed by mousiness. There is no divine essence for a mousetrap. That is the difference between a natural kind and an artifact.

As he looked about, he saw the animals. There were vegetarians, and the predators of those vegetarians. He saw them give birth, live, hunt, and die. But as a fully conscious and aware being, he was able to avoid danger. He knew the healthiest foods for himself. He knew the healing powers of the various herbs if any problems came up.

He looked for others like him. There were beings who were similar to him in outward appearance, but quite different in their interiority. There was one who grabbed his attention. She was a woman, just like him, "bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh". He named her Eve and took her as his wife. They belonged to each other, and no longer with the beings they had derived from. In particular, they had to separate from their parents.

> a man shall leave father and mother, and shall cleave to his wife:
> and they shall be two in one flesh.

Adam and Eve were innocent and unashamed.

Innocence

> Freedom from evil desire is known as innocence. In the state of innocence, man's reason keeps the lower part of his nature, namely his body and its senses, so much in subjection that the latter can never interfere with the free deliberation of the mind, but continues to be wholly subservient to it. Reason can then activate the powers of the will, and, when they are excited, curb and suppress them. The first human beings had a nature that was pure and strong, and they had powerful and healthy bodies, nor were they denied the delights of sense, though these were always kept under control and subjected to the reason.
>
> St Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* I, q. 98, a. 2

In the primordial state of innocence, there are four transcendental, that is, preternatural, attributes that are missing or depraved in the natural state:

- Knowledge
- Integrity
- Impassibility
- Immortality

Knowledge Theologians commonly refer to three areas of special knowledge possessed by Adam: regarding God and His attributes, the moral law or man's relations to God, and the physical universe both material and spiritual.

In Adam, the knowing functions appropriate to men were perfect. These are

- **Sense awareness**: His impressions of the world revealed to the senses were without distortion.

- **Rationality**: The intellectual soul separates Adam from the animals. He is rational and can follow a logical argument. That is quite rare today.

- **Intellection**: He had the higher functions of intuitive knowledge. Unlike rationality, this is a direct, unmediated grasp of an idea. This is the way angels know.

In addition, he had special infused knowledge which follows from those functions.

- **Reality**: He had accurate knowledge of the world and of other people.

- **The Moral Law:** He knew the moral law and man's relationship to God. This means he also had complete self-knowledge and internal psychological processes.

- **Transcendence**: He had knowledge of God and his attributes.

Adam knew Eve perfectly,

1. First as the image he had of her in his soul

2. Then as a person in the flesh

There was no conflict between them.

Integrity Integrity means wholeness, so that Adam was unified in body, soul, and spirit. His Self was master and his desires and emotions were subjected to the dictates of reason and free will.

Adam did not experience any division or discord within himself. This was reflected, also, to his outer life. Integrity is the conformance of the interior man to the exterior man in his life, speech, and actions.

Impassibility Impassibility is freedom from suffering. In particular, one is free from negative emotions, such as hate, fear, rage, jealousy, depression, anxiety, worry, uncertainty, melancholy, annoyance, boredom, lack of self-confidence, and the like. That is anything that adversely affects one's quality of life.

Yet this is not a stoical state. In the Primordial state there are positive emotions including love, joy, satisfaction, contentment, serenity, awe. Moreover, even the negative emotions may have their place as long as they are intelligent. There is a healthy fear that protects us from danger. Anger can motivate positive actions to fix problems.

The preceding emotions are experienced in the lower emotional centre, or thumos. Above that there is a higher emotional centre, often called the Heart. Whereas the lower centre is oriented to the world, the higher centre is oriented upwards. Emotions are of a different class and more intense, such as bliss, gratitude, and other emotions that have an analogue in the lower centre.

In the lower centre, suffering is not willed. However, in the higher centre, one can take on suffering voluntarily. Fear of God, or regret for one's sins, are emotions that sound negative, but are not, because they are willed.

Immortality The Body was not a burden in the primordial state, since it was responsive to Adam's will. It was not affected by disordered emotions like anxiety, fear, boredom, excessive desire, etc., which adversely

affect the systemic functions of the organism.

Adam able to avoid all dangers. Since he was fully aware of himself and his surroundings, he was able to avoid external dangers like accidents, wild animals, fire, and so on. Accidents result from

- momentary lapses of concentration
- ignorance of cause and effect

Internal dangers like sickness, poison, ageing, and the like were also thwarted. The I not only had mastery over the emotions and desires, he also had mastery over the body. As we can see from the examples of yogis, fakirs, saints, and even contemporary magicians and endurance performers, there is more mastery over the body than we admit. Saints would be singing even while being tortured to death.

In the Primordial State, there is concentration and meditation. **Valentin Tomberg** describes the effects of deep meditation in *Inner Development*.

> What is striven for, and achieved, by means of meditation is a new relationship between spirit, soul, and body. The spirit approaches the human being, it inclines downward; the soul becomes larger; and the body becomes ensouled. This is the body's inner purification. It becomes pure when everything bound up with its life is permeated by the heart. Nothing in life is ugly if the heart is present. Everything cynical that is said about the life of the body occurs through the fact that those who say such things lack the experience of the soul permeating the body. When the soul permeates the body, the body is raised to the dignity of the soul. Through meditation, a harmony arises between body, soul, and spirit—a harmony that is attained when the spirit inclines downward, the soul expands, and the body is raised to the dignity of soul.

The End of the Beginning As pleasant as life in the Edenic Bower must have been, without suffering, anxiety, or unfulfilled desire, it had a terminus. Like Limbo or the Buddhist heaven, there was no possibility for ultimate deliverance of the Beatific Vision.

Although he was virtually immortal, Adam was obviously not actually immortal. Evil tempted him. He tried to extend mastery over himself to mastery over the entire world, which in effect is to take over the role of his creator. The delicate balance between his Ego and his Self descended into the Ego.

Only a saviour who combined both natures could, not only restore the balance, but lead to the Beatific Vision.

Posted on 2020-09-06 by Cologero

7.4 The Fall from the Primordial State



Let us be clear. The **Primordial State** is not a "state of nature" as in Rousseau, but rather of supernature. But if in the Primordial State man lives in harmony with nature and the divine, with a direct awareness of God in his psyche as his life force, and with bonds of loyalty to his family and nation, then what would account for a change in consciousness? Table 7.1 shows the effects of the Fall in the *Genesis* account, and the corresponding condition that was affected.

Effects of the Fall The point to keep in mind is that the Fall is an event in consciousness; it is necessary to meditate on the symbols of the fall, and the description of the states, to fully understand.

Effect of Fall	Consciousness before fall
Toil	Concentration without effort
Suffering	Natural joy
Death	Transformation

Table 7.1: The effect of the Fall according to Genesis book.

Toil Everyone has had the experience of being totally absorbed in an activity, to the extent that time seems to stand still. One feels energized and does not tire. Similarly, composers and poets have often described moments of inspiration, and the poem or symphony seems to write itself. This state of "concentration without effort" is comparable to the Taoist ideal of *wei-wu-wei*, or doing-nondoing. After the fall, concentration becomes difficult and labored; one becomes restless and bored; activities begin to feel like toil.

Suffering Man lived in a state of natural joy. The sensory experience of the natural world was vivid and pleasurable; it did not require a special trip to a resort. Man was in communication with the gods and angels, was aware of the presence of his ancestors. He lived in peace with his nation and leaders without private concerns. This was replaced with feelings of resentment and ambition. This led to frustration, anxiety, shame, guilt, and fear. Man became alienated from nature, from the divine, from his nation, and leaders.

Death Death was understood as a natural process and it represented a transformation. A man was prepared for his death by understanding the post-mortem states of being. He was aware of his ancestors and felt his immortality in his descendants. After the fall, man lost direct awareness of the divine, of his ancestors, of post-mortem

states, of his own true Self. Death became something to fear, something that signified destruction rather than transformation.

Perversion of Soul Life The psyche, or soul, which had been a pure reflector of both nature and the divine, becomes obsessed with the effects of the fall. The consequence is that the formerly direct intuitive awareness of nature, the divine, and nation becomes occluded. The true Self is decentered and a false self is established. **Julian Jaynes** describes the characteristics of this state.[4]

Spatialization A mind-space model of consciousness is invented.

Excerption Consciousness is focused on just a part of experience. The vividness of the Primordial State is lost.

Analog I A model of one's self is created in consciousness. This acts like a little god in one's own consciousness, with its own plans.

Objectification Beyond the "I" as subject, the self becomes an object in consciousness

Narratization There is a running narrative consisting of a web of thoughts. This narration forms our very identity. Thus, it becomes very difficult to alter since that would be felt as a threat to oneself.

Assimilation Experiences are forced to fit into pre-conceived or remembered patterns. This makes it very difficult to understand, or even hear, new ideas.

[4]Julian Jaynes, in his remarkable book, *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind*, brings historical evidence to a change in consciousness similar to what has been described. Unfortunately, it is sui generis, and due to some faulty assumption, the author was never able to develop his insights further. In particular, he regards the Primordial State as a state of unconsciousness and the fallen mind as the beginning of consciousness. Tradition sees it just the opposite.

Initiation Initiation means conscious experience of the beginning, that is, of the Primordial State. The various traditions have arisen in order to lead back to the Primordial State.

Posted on 2011-01-11 by Cologero

* * *

Will on 2011-01-11 at 12:35 said:

KarlH, I think it's inaccurate to describe the Primordial State as one of "non-differentiation." Rather, it is non-dualistic. The difference is that non-differentiated would be a kind of monism in which all is one and everything is equal to everything else. Non-dualism, in contrast, says that God, or the Absolute, and the creation / emanation are not one and the same, but are not wholly separate either. In this view, differentiation is a natural complement to emanation. As in the Tao Te Ching, from one to two to three to the ten thousand things.

The non-dualist view retains the importance of qualitative distinctions on the relative plane, whereas the monist, non-differentiated view seems to be prominent among new agers, and forms the metaphysical backdrop to their all-embracing naivete. "All is one, all is God, hooray!" while the world crumbles around them. There's a sense in which that's true, of course, since as you say "nothing escapes Him and nothing is apart from Him." But it seems to me this view informs a delusional escapism more often than a genuine realization.

Also, it seems to me that your second comment reduces the Genesis myth to a mere psychoanalytic metaphor. Yes, childhood does have a certain wholeness and ease compared to adulthood, and maybe that is somehow related to a greater connection to the Primordial State, but I think here again this kind of view often gives rise to an error. If the Primordial State is childhood, then the best example of returning to it would probably be something like Kevin Spacey's character in American Beauty, who forsakes his job and family life to live like a teenager again.

There's a sense in which that kind of life is indeed better than the typical, slavish bourgeois life of middle America. For one, it has a sense of awe and wonder about the world which most people lose as they grow older, through the Perversion of Soul Life which the post describes. But it seems to me that a true return to, or realization of, the Primordial State transcends this childhood-adulthood dichotomy.

Will on 2011-01-11 at 13:28 said:

Addendum: The last paragraph of my comment should read "a process somewhat analogous to the Perversion of Soul Life which the post describes." As I originally wrote it, I'm guilty of the very reductionism I was criticizing. Hate it when that happens.

GF on 2011-01-11 at 16:07 said:

I don't believe he ascribes a primarily moral significance to the Fall; here, in fact, he's asserting the Hermetic significance of a division of consciousness. So the issue is wholly subjective. That was clear to me; all the same your clarifications are welcome.

You might be interested in d'Olivet's The Hebraic Tongue Restored, which includes a radical retranslation of the first ten chapters of Genesis based on the Sefer Torah. It can be downloaded from the Internet Archive.

GF on 2011-01-11 at 16:14 said:

Your comments about early Jewish religion are appreciated. I do not know much about it, nor am I particularly interested, so I guess that falls under 'honest dishonesty'. Still, you might be surprised by d'Olivet; the Egyptian or Hermetic connection between Mosaic and Platonic metaphysics is strongly attested. Even secular commentators have noticed this, some going as far as claiming that 'Moses' plagiarized from Plato or vice versa.

Cologero on 2011-01-11 at 19:48 said:

Yes. Not a moral significance, nor is it intended to refer to just the Hebrew scripture. To the contrary, we are discussing the cosmic cycles which is generally interpreted as a decline in all traditions. We can add the following points:

1) The Talmud is not necessarily the authoritative interpretation of Genesis. The religion of the Talmud differs in substantive ways from the Hebrew Scriptures.

2) If the Edenic myth is simply about some pedestrian notion as the growth from childhood to adulthood, then why is it necessary to portray it in mythological symbolism?

3) And this is the most important, and it was mentioned in the post. The matter is ultimately not settled by debate, but by the meditative experience of initiates (i.e., those properly qualified) which reveal the inner structure of consciousness as described in the post.

Graham on 2011-01-14 at 10:10 said:

We seem to be confusing ourselves by using different conventional vocabularies. Non-being is Guenon's term, and refers to the higher, passive state of Being, and this is what I assumed you meant by Emptiness or 'being-beyond-Being'. You suggested that this being-beyond-Being might have implications for hierarchy, and I fail to see why it would, and so I also ended with a question, which maybe now you can answer.

7.5 The Metaphysics of Reintegration

The fundamental aim of the **French Hermetic Tradition**, insofar as it is infused with **Martinism**, is **Reintegration**, that is, the restoration of the wholeness of man that was broken as a result of the Fall. In other words, it seeks the return to the Primordial State of Adam. Since the first task in the accomplishment of any task is the statement of its goal, it behooves us to try to understand more fully what that state would be like. Here we rely on the metaphysical teaching on the soul as well as the testimony of mystics and initiates.

A valuable resource that I am relying on here is the book *Occult Phenomena in the Light of Theology* by the Trappist monk **Alois Wiesinger**. This work is a thorough and fair discussion of preternatural and occult phenomena including topics on psychoactive drugs, telepathy, clairvoyance, telekinesis, ghosts, possession, hypnosis, the subconscious, magic, astral travel, inter alia, which perhaps will deserve a separate review sometime. However, for our present purposes, we are more concerned with his teachings on the soul and its workings, on the inner experience of Adam, and the effects of the Fall. It is not necessary to adhere to a particular theology to gain from his discussion, but rather a commitment to the metaphysics of tradition and on personal experience.

First of all, Fr. Alois has to establish the structure of the soul. Here he relies principally on **St Thomas Aquinas**, although not in the abstract way of the philosophers, but as one who has understood the soul in his own interiority. In particular, as we have described here many times, there is the body, the vegetative, sensitive, and intellectual souls. However, the parts of the soul act together as a whole which, as such, is the form of the body. That is, the body, down to its cells and atoms, is shaped by the soul, or is its material manifestation. This teaching has consequences, which we cannot go into here; specifically, it means that manifestations such as one's sex, family, nation, etc., are not arbitrary and incidental, but rather

are the reflection of something arising from the depths of one's spirit. This is the opposite of the modern view which would regard differences in talents, abilities, capacities, and so on, as cosmic injustices that require political and social interventions to rectify.

Along the way, Fr. Alois dismisses several other viewpoints. First of all, we can disregard materialism as incoherent and incompatible with common experience. Furthermore, he rejects

1. Platonic and Cartesian dualism with the two substances of body and soul,

2. Trichotomy, which then separates the soul and spirit,

3. Anthroposophy and Theosophy, which likewise identify even more substances with their various bodies.

The fault of these conceptions is that they deny the integrality of the human being because of they regard the parts as separate substances. The Thomist (and we certainly don't restrict this solely to Thomas) view certainly incorporates the insights of these rejected views while accepting and even emphasizing the unity and indivisibility of the human substance. Were that not the case, then Reintegration would be impossible.

The soul, or psyche, thus described in "body-bound". Hence, the way it knows is through the bodily senses and the images created in the mind. Fr. Alois then identifies another part that rises above the corporeal part of the soul, which he calls the anima spiritualis or "spirit-soul" or nous. This spirit-soul can, in certain circumstances, withdraw from the body-bound part of the soul and "allow its activity to reach out beyond the body. From this there result phenomena such as we encounter in occultism and to some extent in the mystic life."

There is a tendency in contemporary philosophers to restrict Thomas' teaching to the body-bound soul, which is certainly not his full teaching.

This would reduce Thomism to effective materialism on the one hand; on the other hand, by denying the possibility of the spirit-soul, it falls into the Gnostic error of regarding material existence as a prison from which we need to escape for spiritual realization. It is true that ascetical practice, however, is necessary to free the spirit-soul from being totally body bound. Another way that the spirit-soul can perform its proper function is during the sleep state; this is a teaching of St Thomas and Fr Alois. This is why revelation or prophecy often comes in the form of dreams.

Fr Alois criticizes certain theologians who deny that there can be spiritual communication without the mediation of material sensations or images. To the contrary, God and angels do communicate with men directly; this is a dogmatic truth as well as the common experience of men from different traditions and cultures. Angels do communicate with men through thoughts; actually, this is the ordinary method, as angelic visions and materializations are the extraordinary way. Similarly, the spirit-soul, since it is effectively the equivalent to the angelic consciousness, can conceivably communicate with other spirit-souls through the medium of thought. This is actually the correct teaching of Thomas, since the soul is not completely submerged in the body, so it has possibilities that are not just those of the body.

Lost Tradition Fr Alois points to several specific precursors of the idea of the spirit-soul, not to mention the various unnamed seers, visionaries, and magicians. **Plato** in the *Phaedrus* tells how men "through divine madness become partakers of true prophecy," and mentions true dreams coming in the sleep state in the *Republic*. He also points out that "Aristotle knows of an exalted state of the soul in sleep, in which it withdraws into its own nature and has power over the future."

The Stoic **Posidonius of Apameia** wrote: "there is another method of prophecy that proceeds from nature; this proves how great is the power

of the spirit, when it has been released from the sensual organs of the body. This occurs especially in sleep and in ecstasy." Readers may recognize that the state of deep sleep is one of the states mentioned in the Vedanta, that of the causal body (i.e., the intellectual soul).

Eudemos also wrote on prophecy, claiming that the lower soul "partakes of the divine in ecstasy and in dreams." The Delphic high priest Plutarch declares the daimonion to be "the guardian spirit which, unlike the soul, is not completely united to the body, but reaches out beyond it and sometimes loosens its connection with it to wander abroad and communicate immediately with gods and spirits, whence it derives the gift of prophecy". Fr Alois claims the daimonion to be the spirit-soul. In Guenon's terms, this guardian angel is a higher state of man. Compare this to the episode in Acts 12:15 where the disciples believe that it couldn't be Peter at the door but "it must be his angel"; they just took that possibility for granted.

He concludes with the Neoplatonists, especially **Plotinus**' attainment of the highest states four times. All accepted that, when transcending the body, the soul could function as a pure spirit, could contemplate God, apprehend truths prophecy, experience second sight, etc. This was the consistent teaching of antiquity and therefore the starting point of the Church fathers.

Unfortunately, that understanding was allowed to lapse into oblivion, and was replaced with a "confused belief in demons". That is the situation today, where the occult phenomena described by Fr Alois are ignorantly and indiscriminately considered the products of the devil and are feared. However, this limited view arises from the lack of understanding of the powers of the spirit-soul.

Thus, attempts to revive such teachings tended to become marginalized, despite the positive writings of Thomas Aquinas (who recognized the power of clairvoyance) and other saints. Hence, Fr Alois then mentions figures such as **Swedenborg**, **Cornelius Agrippa** and **Paracelsus**

who accepted certain occult powers as arising from the nature of man.

In our time, we see a small movement to reclaim these teachings as legitimate and necessary. The teachings of the soul are perfectly fine. Unfortunately, they have become desiccated, left to the philosophers, and divorced from the inner experiences that bring them to life and demonstrate their truth. On the other side, since the figures who have attempted to maintain that knowledge have been marginalized, and even condemned, such teachings have been set free from their traditional supports and often devolve into pseudo-mysticism and various aberrations.

That is why a Guenon or a Schuon insist on the attachment to a legitimate tradition, or why a Tomberg tries to bring Hermetism within the umbrella of the Tradition of the West, or a Mouravieff brings Fourth Way teachings back into Orthodoxy.

The Paradisal State

> We know that it is very difficult to tell from a broken machine how its various parts are intended to operate. One can only learn that by seeing a sound machine in actual operation. The same is true of man, particularly when we are concerned with the most important part of him, namely his soul. In order to become acquainted with all its attributes and functions, it is necessary to study it in its sound condition …
>
> Alois Wiesinger, OCSO, *Occult Phenomena*

Fr Alois proposes to study the Adamic state in order to grasp the proper functioning of the soul. First, he takes care to define the natural and the supernatural.

The Natural The natural is what constitutes a substance or derives from it. Note that this is not what is commonly meant by "nature" today,

which is typically assumed to be how animals in the wild act. On the contrary, man has a specific nature that is more than his animal nature. In this sense, nature means:

1. What constitutes it.

   Everything that inwardly constitutes the specific essence of a thing, both the essential and integrating parts of its being.

2. What derives from it

   (a) Everything that proceeds spontaneously: e.g., aptitudes, talents, and powers

   (b) Everything that proceeds under the influence of another being. That is, things that must be taught such as an art, skill, or craft

3. What is required for it. I.e., everything necessary

   (a) for its continued existence (nourishment, light, air)

   (b) for its activity (the will for survival)

   (c) for its development (education, society, government)

   (d) for the attainment of its goal (knowledge of God, free will)

These are called the "demands of nature" as they are owed to man for them to exist as such. The supernatural and the preternatural are beyond nature and are not owed to man qua man. The former is all that transcends created nature and the latter whatever is created, but of a higher nature.

The Preternatural This includes everything of a higher nature. The example Fr Alois gives is this:

If a man makes an act of knowledge without the mediation of the senses and after the manner of the angels, then he transcends his own nature and is permitted to partake in the higher nature of the angel.

The type of knowing is called "intuition", the direct seeing of higher things. This type of knowing is not based on sense images or the "knowledge" of certain propositions. We can rephrase Fr Alois' description as man transcends the human state and reaches an angelic state, as Guenon would phrase it; they mean the same thing. There are two types of the preternatural:

1. According to the matter, or the thing done. This is a perfection to which we have no claim

2. According to the form, the manner of receiving it.

The example above is of the first type, since the matter is from the angels, and man has no natural right to that. An example of the second type is infused knowledge; in this case, acquiring knowledge is natural, but having it infused is not. I would include prophecy or visions in this category.

The Supernatural The supernatural is beyond the natural in that it is not owed to man qua man. The supernatural is beyond all created things, including angels. Man is given a divine nature, beyond his human nature. Since this is freely given, and neither deserved nor earned by man qua man, it is often called a "grace".

The Edenic State In the Edenic state, Adam had all that was proper to his human nature as described above. He also was given supernatural grace so he shared the same nature as God. In addition, he was given several preternatural privileges, in particular:

- Freedom from concupiscence
- Freedom from suffering and death
- The power of higher knowledge
- The faculties of pure spirits, i.e., his spirit-soul

In this fully integral state, Adam shared a human nature, a divine nature, and an angelic nature. To grasp this state of being, we need to focus on the part of the soul that transcends the body. St Thomas describes three ways of knowing God:

1. After the Fall, we know God only in the mirror of his creatures. This was clearly described by Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin[5]
2. In Paradise, God was known via a spiritual light which he infused into the human spirit. This light was uncreated. This doctrine is still remembered in the Eastern churches as the Light of Tabor[6].
3. In the beatific vision, God is known by the light of his glory

St Thomas explains that Adam's manner of knowing is similar to mystical contemplation and knows God as the angels do, at least in part. St Augustine wrote:

> Perhaps God spoke to the first human beings as he does to the angels, by illuminating their spirit with the unchanging light

That is why "reintegration" is often called "illuminism".

[5] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-tableau-of-god

[6] http://orthodoxwayoflife.blogspot.com/2010/02/truth-of-uncreated-light-of-god.html

Action follows Being So Adam had the powers of the corporal soul (tied to the body) and the spirit-soul (free of the body). The body was not a punishment, a prison, or a source of evil; rather, it gave Adam a new form of knowledge that was inaccessible to the spirit-soul. We should clarify Fr Alois' method at this point. On the one hand, he relies on metaphysical teachings and then draws all the necessary consequences from it. On the other hand, he studies empirical phenomena and works backwards to the kind of being that would produce such phenomena. Hence, by the analysis of mystical and occult phenomena, he is led to the conclusion that the spirit-soul is still active in men, even when dominated by the corporal soul. He sees these as residues of the primordial state and as clues to the attributes of that state.

That is justified on the metaphysical principle that "action follows being", that is, whatever occurs is the result of the nature of the being. Hence, if Adam had angelic powers, then necessarily they required Adam to have a spirit-soul transcending the corporal soul.

The Causal State of Deep Sleep **Fr. Alois Wiesinger** makes a rather remarkable point about Genesis, when he writes:

> While he was creating woman, "God cast a deep sleep over Adam", a sleep which in actual fact represented a great release from the senses. Theologians have been at some pains to explain the condition that is indicated by the word Tardemah. Though this word does not really mean "ecstasy", which is the Septuagint rendering, it can nevertheless be rendered as an ecstatic sleep, that is to say, as a state of being in which the soul dwelt outside the world of sense and was active after the manner of pure spirits.

Obviously, this invites comparison with what **Rene Guenon** writes about the three human states in Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta. He distinguishes:

1. The *waking state*, corresponding to gross manifestation
2. The *dream state*, corresponding to subtle manifestation
3. *Deep sleep*, which is the causal and formless state

Moreover, he mentions the state of ecstatic trance, intermediate between deep sleep and death. Guenon, drawing inspiration from the Upanishads, repeats ideas from Genesis, even to the allegedly "incorrect" translation of Tardemah as "ecstasy". So it is worth the trouble to see what Guenon says about this state in Chapter XIV.

> These three are states of Atma, that is, the Person or Self, or, in other words, the possibilities of the Person. In the causal state, there is no longer individual existence, that is, the Person is transcendent. In the waking state, he is one corporeal being among many and in the dreaming state, he is creating an illusory world. In the causal state, the Person "has become one", "has identified himself with a synthetic whole of integral knowledge", etc. In this state, the Person is at the level of Sat, or pure Being. The intelligible Light is seized directly by intellectual intuition.

Thomas Aquinas also understands God as the act of Being and makes the same claim, albeit from a different frame of reference. He explains that Adam, in this state of deep sleep, knew God in His essence, i.e., at the level of Being.

This has several consequences. First of all, it seems to claim that God is known not only through his energies and but also in His essence; presumably, that is possible in the Primordial state. This is consistent with Thomas' understanding that to "know" something is to participate in its essence. So to know is to be, so in a sense the knower is the thing known, at least in essence. So Adam in that state of deep sleep knew God in his essence and therefore "was" God. However, he was not God in His existence, so we cannot say that Adam, as an individual being (i.e., in one

of the states of manifestation), was God, but only as transcendent. With these ideas in mind, one should go back to Guido de Giorgio's descriptions of this state; it may make more sense. If anyone needs more, we can point to Johannes Tauler who explains:

> The more simple, pure, and naked in faith, so much the more praiseworthy, noble, and meritorious it is. This faith merits that God Himself in Himself, in His divine Essence, should be manifested to the soul in many wonderful ways.

Psychological Interpretation This causal state is beyond sensory imagery. In particular, therefore, it is also beyond any psychological process. Hence, the psychologist **Carl Jung** could not understand it. When he confronted certain yogis during his trip to India in 1938 about this state, he adamantly argued with them that it was simply unconsciousness, not a higher state of consciousness. He claimed, too, that the Indian mind was "primitive" since he "doesn't think" but instead "perceives thought". That shows how alienated the modern mind is from its own past, since that attribute is closer to the medieval mind. **Ananda Coomraswamy** has pointed out that to understand the Indian mind, one need only refer to Western medieval and ancient writings.

Consider, for example, this description from **Saint Theresa d'Avila** about the difficulties that may assail the contemplative:

> There is a necessity of suffering the trouble of a Troop of Thoughts, importune Imaginations, and the impetuosities of natural Notions, not only, of the Soul through the dryness and disunion it hath, but of the Body also, occasioned by the want of submission to the Spirit, which it ought to have.

This is quite clear. The Saint is not "thinking" those "troops of thoughts" but instead is perceiving them as distractions to her own consciousness

and arising from an outside source. This is not a matter of interpretation or an invitation to intellectual disputation. To perceive a thought, it is necessary to transcend the flow of thoughts in one's consciousness. Since life is short and art is long, a man or woman should start young to develop this skill.

Mystical Sleep Unlike the cultured despisers of their own Tradition who are so common in certain circles in our day, we can provide examples of this state in the true Tradition of the West. For example, **Fr. John Arintero** writes the following in *The Mystical Evolution*:

> When faithful souls find themselves totally abandoned, arid, cold, mute, lacking affection, and unable to give vent to a single sigh, they raise their dim and darkened eyes to heaven and, directed by the obscure light of faith, they await mercy in silence. As they wait, sweetly enraptured and forgetful of all things, speaking not a word nor hearing nor seeing anything at all, they find themselves in a deep and profound silence which is at times changed into a mysterious sleep. Sometimes they pass entire hours in this condition, but to them it does not seem long because they experience a special attraction for that state.

St. Francis de Sales also writes about this mystical sleep that is beyond, and superior to, any conscious acts.

> When you find yourself possessed of this simple and pure filial trust in our Lord, remain in it, without attempting to perform any kind of conscious acts of intellect or will. This simple and trusting love, this loving sleep of the spirit in the arms of the Savior contains in itself as much excellence as you could ever hope to find. It is better to sleep on His sacred Breast than to be awake in any other place.

The crypto-modernists may be put off by such language, but if they are really traditionalists, they will understand how to relate such symbolic and theological language to metaphysical teachings.

Knowing the Nature of Things **Fr Alois Wiesinger** next provides some detail of the inner life of Adam, or, for our purposes, that of the primordial state. According to Fr Wiesinger, Adam "intuitively beheld God, the creation of the world and the purpose thereof, the principles of law and morals and all that was necessary for him as head and instructor of the human race."

This is not purely speculation since it is based on metaphysical principles and also on the writings of saints and mystics. The latter, through their ascetical practice, were able to transcend the attachment to the corporal soul and reach similar states. **Saint Bernard of Clairvaux**, the patron of the Templars, explained it this way:

> It was only through sin that reason was thus imprisoned in the senses; once man also had a spiritual eye, that did not need the senses in order to know God, but this has now been clouded and darkened by sin and can only be cleansed for contemplation by asceticism.

This teaching, and it agrees with Oriental teachings insofar as they also seek to overcome the attachment to the senses by asceticism, has far reaching consequences. Specifically, those who have lost the primordial state and never made the effort of reintegration are ignorant of the purpose of the world and the principles of law and morals. At best, they can understand such things indirectly by studying the works of metaphysicians and contemplatives. Otherwise, this knowledge is lost and they can only grasp things through the senses.

In a traditional society, there will be those who know and the people accept this knowledge to the best of their ability, some better than others, and the result is a hierarchically arranged society. Obviously, there

is no way to convince the modern mind of this because they regard it as an infringement on their intellectual freedom rather than as a liberation from sin and/or ignorance. That is acceptable and understandable. However, what is disappointing is the number of those who call themselves traditionalists who would reject such notions.

The Names of Things Adam's genius shows itself in the fact that he gave names to the animals. Saint Augustine rated it as an act of the highest wisdom and Pythagoras recognized that the wisest man was the one who first gave names to things. In the mentality of traditional man, the name indicates the nature of a thing, and the man who knows the name of a thing fundamentally knows its nature or essence. Here, without going into detail we can point to the Hindu doctrine of *nama-rupa* (i.e., name and form) in which nama is the essential properties of a being.

There are two ways to grasp the nature of a thing. The ordinary way is by discerning the non-essential properties by abstracting from the sensual image; this requires protracted study and experience. The extraordinary way is by the intuitive understanding of pure spirits. However, in general, the mass of men fail to achieve much understanding at all, except perhaps in a particular field of study, because their understanding is hampered by passions, undisciplined imagination, evil disposition, the requirement to provide for one's support, and the weakness of forgetfulness.

We can postpone examples of all these for a future posting, but it should be clear that there can be no general agreement on anything because the knowledge of the true nature of things is so rare. As a matter of fact, "naming" is by now the total opposite of the knowledge of the true nature of things. Instead, the modern mind believes it can actually change the nature of a thing by changing its name. I'm certain readers can find many examples of this as it goes by the term "political correctness". This is nothing but group delusion and it is virtually an inescapable trap because there is no effort at all made to understand the true nature of

things beyond the word for it.

The Law of Accidents If you know the true nature of things and circumstances, you will not make errors and mistakes. Hence, Adam was able to avoid suffering and all dangers to his health and well-being. Adam was not naturally immortal, but he had the possibility of not dying. Hence, he was not subject to accidents externally nor sickness and old age, internally. In this, even the saints and mystics cannot avoid. Some mystical thinkers such as Aurobindo Ghose and Charles Fillmore (the founder of the Unity churches) believed they could achieve immortality, but time proved them wrong. Transhumanists believe they can achieve immortality mechanically, biologically, or computationally, but it seems unlikely.

The will of Adam in the primordial state was mastery over the body and the lower parts of the soul, and it was not subject to concupiscence. Nevertheless, their bodies were powerful and healthy and they could still experience the delights of the senses. Of course, unlike men and women today whose inordinate and irrational desires lead them into all sorts of trouble, Adam easily avoided such problems.

Fr Wiesinger claims that Adam had powers over material things. Presumably he would have had paranormal powers, or "siddhis", such as telekinesis, that are described in his book.

Posted on 2013-09-09 by Cologero

* * *

jc00001 on 2013-09-09 at 08:01 said:

http://archive.org/details/occultphenomenai00wies A free copy of the book I found online.

Michael on 2013-09-09 at 20:01 said:

Another brilliant post. If the soul shapes the body, is it possible to alter the body through though alone?

Cologero on 2013-09-09 at 20:28 said:

Obviously, Michael, there have been cases of mental healing. However, there is something even deeper and beyond thought, that is what is manifested in the body, so it can't be infinitely malleable. I take it to mean that you can actualize more of who you are, or, as Guenon puts it, manifest all your possibilities.

If you are referring to siddhis, or perhaps a "resurrection body", I don't know how much is possible.

JA on 2013-09-10 at 14:39 said:

so what then is the cause of body-soul conflicts, of the type described of Plotinus that he felt imprisoned in his body ?

Cologero on 2013-09-10 at 15:36 said:

That is the result of the fallen state, JA, not so in the Primordial state.

JA on 2013-09-19 at 11:45 said:

I am still having a hard time with the A-T seeing of form and essence as interconnected as opposed to Platonic matter-spirit dualism. There are some spiritual experiences I've seen that defy reason.

To know a person's name is to know the person but how can one know a name ? Is your name the name your parents gave you for often in these days the most vulgar of reasons (oh how different from the Chinese who truly understand the importance of a name and spend years before giving their children a final name !) or something else more interior ? If my mother names me Lexus does that make me a car ?

From the Catholic perspective is the astral body the same gender as the physical body ? I think of Steiner's claim that the astral and mortal bodies are always opposite each other. A person I know who is male had a vision of himself in another dimension as a woman – when he then made contact with his angel, the angel told him that he should have a sex change to follow his true will.

scardanelli on 2013-09-19 at 12:43 said:

"If my mother names me Lexus does that make me a car ?"

JA, I believe this is what Cologero refers to when he says "the modern mind believes it can actually change the nature of a thing by changing its name."

To truly know the name of something is to know it's essence, and one knows the essence of something through intuition, rather than through the senses or thinking mind. Tomberg refers to this type of knowing as gnosis. Perhaps the upcoming discussion of MOT may be fruitful in gaining this type of "knowing."

It would seem to me that our given name simply refers to our ego, that is, the individuality rather than the personality, or true self. Thus, it is not a true name.

`Cologero on 2013-09-19 at 12:47 said:`

JA, I think you profoundly missed the point about naming, probably because your dualism can't account for the connection between name and form. The ability to name things truly is a rarer power, as it required the recognition of name and form; I believe I pointed out that the modern mind thinks that just by naming things, it can change the essence. However, that is the result of the widespread philosophy of nominalism.

The angel's advice sounds suspect, so I would recommend to your friend that he try for two out of three.

`Cologero on 2013-09-19 at 12:58 said:`

Thanks, Scardanelli. Good point about the personal name. There are many examples of men and women who have taken a new name that may be closer to their essence. Obviously, Sarah and Abraham. But even monks take a new name with their vows. E.g., Lao Tzu means "old master", I believe, which better describes his essence.

7.6 The Guardian of the Threshold

> Thou austere and remorseless Hierophant,—thou who hast sought to convert to our brotherhood every spirit that seemed to thee most high and bold,—even thou knowest, by horrible experience, how vain the hope to banish FEAR from the heart of woman,
>
> Edward Bulwer-Lytton, *Zanoni*

There are two awakenings of Adam:

Awakening from the Muck

> then the Lord God formed man of dust from the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living being.
>
> Genesis 2:7

Since the mist watered the face of the earth, the dust was moist like mud. Hence Adam was composed of the elements of earth, water, and air as well as life. When Adam awoke, he saw it was good for him. He names the animals, which means he knew their essences and their purposes.

Moreover, since the world has an outside as well as an inside, Saint Basil the Great has a deeper understanding of the command to "rule" the animals. He claimed that the animals represent various emotional states, which must be "ruled" by the Intellect. The hylic man is more impressed by physical mastery of wild animals; on the other hand, the spiritual man is more impressed by the ability to master the emotions.

Similarly, Adam did not see God with human eyes. Valentin Tomberg explains how that could be possible:

> In the sixteenth century St. John of the Cross wrote in his work The Night of the Spirit and the Night of the Senses that light as such is invisible. It becomes visible by virtue of the many particles and larger and smaller objects that offer resistance to light on its path. Thus we see the sun's rays because the sun's light falls upon the "atoms" of dust and illumines them. The same holds true for the light of the spirit. As such it is dark, but when it falls upon something—such as the problems and riddles of existence — it becomes visible and illumines them by effecting insight and understanding.
>
> Valentin Tomberg, *Covenant of the Heart*

This means that whenever Adam had a question, he could rely on God's grace to make the answer available to him in his interiority. Adam knew

the animals, his own soul, the structure and purpose of the cosmos, and, most importantly, he knew God.

Thus Adam was one who knows.

Awakening to Eve

> So the Lord God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and while he slept took one of his ribs and closed up its place with flesh; and the rib which the Lord God had taken from the man he made into a woman and brought her to the man.
>
> Genesis 2:21-22

There was one riddle in particular. Adam could see the animals, who always acted out of instinct. There was nothing evil to see. Adam, on the other hand, was able to choose his actions. Thus, the cosmos was moral, but how could it be moral without a real choice. Therefore, he was given one law: not to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. There was no specific evil that he was commanded to avoid, but rather the very possibility of knowing evil.

There was something else amiss. Although Adam knew the animals, they did not know him. Therefore, none of them was a suitable companion for him. Since Adam knew his own soul, he could see clearly that a significant part of him, actually the most significant part, was missing in the world. That would be his companion.

Adam's deep sleep was a descent into his subconscious, to experience the submerged image of his Lover. When Adam awoke, he recognized Eve at once as his companion, wife and lover.

Thus Adam was one who loves.



Figure 7.2: Dweller of the Threshold

The Cherubim Block the Way

> He drove out the man; and at the east
> of the garden of Eden he placed the
> cherubim, and a flaming sword which turned every way, to guard
> the way to the tree of life.
>
> Genesis 3:24

As mentioned above, Adam could turn to the light of the Spirit whenever he had a question. At some point, he turned away from the Spirit, and looked elsewhere for understanding. There was darkness where there should have been light. The serpent inhabited that darkness and Adam turned to Eve, instead of to God, for advice. Together, since their souls were entangled, they ate the fruit of the tree.

Immediately, they saw evil and could not unsee it. They descended into the biological life of the animals: birth, life, and death. God sent angels to prevent a return to the Garden. They had to await the Redeemer who would break the cycle of the Ouroboros.

The Dweller of the Threshold In the novel *Zanoni*, Edward Bulwer-Lytton describes the situation of two initiates, Mejnour and Zanoni, who discovered the Philosopher's Stone and thereby achieved immortality. But first, the initiate needs to pass by the Dweller of the Threshold. This requires great preparation, first in the purification of the soul from desire, ambition, and so on. Then, there were the Hermetic sciences to be known.

Mejnour represents *Infinity*, the repetition of the same. He has no progeny, but only students. His students usually failed to get past the Dweller, since they could not master the inscrutable mental gymnastics necessary for that task. There was only a sequence of self-contradictory thoughts.

Zanoni, after many centuries of celibacy, falls in love with the magically beautiful earth girl Viola. Despite a warning from Mejnour, Zanoni marries Viola and has a child. In order to protect them during the French Revolution, he sacrifices his life to the guillotine. Through his love, he returns to the stream of the world process: *man, woman, life, death*.

Mejnour was able to know and Zanoni able to love. Few men can do both. Most men can do neither.

Posted on 2020-09-30 by Cologero

7.7 View from the Primordial State

> What heaven wishes
>
> Fortune ordains
>
> Reason demands
>
> and, above all, what my will desires.
>
> Don Quixote

> In general, grace does two things. First, it remedies the defects in the natural order that have resulted from original sin, at least partially restoring what would have existed had the Fall not occurred. Second, it directs nature to an even higher, supernatural end — the beatific vision.
>
> Edward Feser

Human Stratification The esoteric understanding of human differences is not horizontal, in the sense that people differ by races or nationality. Rather, the more important differences are in the vertical direction.

Thus the notion of castes is used to explain it. However, caste has the connotation of being hereditary, so it is misleading. Castes can also be defined by function, as in the trifunctional classification of Georges Dumezil. But even that distinction does not take into account that people may functionally be in a caste that is inappropriate to them. That is noticeably true in decadent epochs like the Kali Yuga. So "class" as used here has no other connotations. Hence, it is incumbent to understand the inner state appropriate to each caste. These are defined by how they relate to the three primary influences in the world: Providence, Will, Destiny.

- **First class**: they are guided by "what Heaven wishes", or Providence. They are the spiritual leaders. Those in this class have realized a permanent sense of the transcendent Self. They live only for humanity and have come to help. These are in direct contact with the 1st angelic hierarchy. They have chosen their incarnation to accomplish a specific task.

- **Second class**: they are guided by their Will, which is aligned with the Will of God. They include the political leaders and warriors. People in this class consciously take part in the conflict between good and evil. They have developed, to an extent, a strong sense of Self-awareness and are led by the 2nd angelic hierarchy. They fight for causes that are larger than their own individuality, which they learn to recognize over time.

- **Third class**: they are subject to Destiny which they have been given by God. They have not yet developed a real sense of I and are victims of the curses resulting from the Fall. The people of the third class are all still experiencing their own karma and looking for their real purpose in life. They are under the leadership of the 3rd angelic hierarchy.

Since they don't have a true sense of Self, their psychic center is dominated by one of the three soul functions:

- **Thinking**: Those dominated by the Thinking function seek out rational knowledge and love to dispute and debate. They believe that the road to knowledge is paved by a selection of books.
- **Emotions**: Those dominated by the Feeling function are moved by strong emotions. Since emotions are so fickle, it is difficult to establish a stable sense of Self.
- **Sensations**: They seek out "experiences", and are guided by what they like or dislike. They are dominated by the Will, but a will untrammeled by intellect or sound emotions.

- **Fourth class**: Those in this group do not have any type of center and rely on outside influences for stability. The Church has always held a preference for these people, protects them from arbitrary political and economic powers, and leads them to salvation.

The ideal distribution of power is from the first class downward, but deformations occur in history. The understanding of historical events needs to include the roles of the four classes at that time. This arrangement is not oppressive. Those of the First Class are called to serve the others, not to exploit them for their own benefit. Those of the Second Class take responsibility for administering the state, distributing justice, and protecting against enemies. The remaining classes are not conscious enough to take on those burdens.

Human State A human birth is rare and privileged. The principle of the human being is the Self, his center; a person is human to the extent that he participates in that center. Only then can he progress vertically. To

sum up: our task as human beings, in order to actualize our possibilities, i.e., achieve Salvation, is to move horizontally toward the center and then vertically to reach even higher states.

In the essay *Deliverance and Salvation*, Rene Guenon points out that there is a danger in failing to at least reach the center. His explanation needs to be quoted exactly:

> When a being must pass to another individual state, nothing guarantees that there he will again occupy a central position relative to the possibilities of that state as he does in its present state.
>
> On the contrary, there is even an incomparably greater probability that he will encounter one of the innumerable peripheral conditions comparable in our world to those of animals or even vegetables.
>
> One can immediately understand how serious a disadvantage this would be, especially from the point of view of the possibilities for spiritual development.

Referring to the first part, those in the third class have not achieved the primordial state. Since the intellectual soul distinguishes the human from animals and vegetables, those dominated by the Thinking function still have the possibility of developing their possibilities. On the other hand, those dominated by Emotions and Sensations are in danger of remaining in a state of being comparable to animals or plant life.

Diseased Souls A fundamental metaphysical principle is that Knowing is Being. For example, in order to Know the Primordial State, one must be in, i.e., experience, the Primordial State. It is insufficient to just read and speculate about it.

Hence, the state of the soul determines what the being understands to be real and true. A disordered soul will not see reality, but only the projection of its disorder. 20% of adult Americans, or about 50 million

people, suffer from some degree of mental illness, including 10 million with a serious mental illness. One of the symptoms is a distorted understanding of reality.

For example, you wouldn't ask Sylvia Plath if life is worth living. Nor would you put a paranoid schizophrenic on the security council to identify the most serious threats facing a nation. Those with serious illnesses like personality disorders or psychopathy are similarly unable to relate to the world accurately. For example, the Mayo Clinic says:

> you may not realize that you have a personality disorder because your way of thinking and behaving seems natural to you. And you may blame others for the challenges you face.

That describes a great deal of comments on social media and explains why communication can be so frustrating. This is not to belittle those who are in therapy, especially for conditions that may be situational or temporary. Nevertheless, such widespread mental illness reveals a deep flaw in the collective psyche of a nation.

Moreover, one's level of development also shapes a worldview and opens oneself up to various distortions.

- Those dominated by the Thinking function may fall victim to various ideologies or conspiracy theories.
- Others will react emotionally, rather than rationally, to events.
- At the lowest level, all that matters is pleasure vs pain, like vs dislike, attraction vs repulsion.

Anyone not making the horizontal journey to the center will be inconsistent. He or she will have little self-awareness.

Lost in the Wilderness So living in the fallen world is just as described in Genesis. You will encounter a jungle of vegetation of various types. You will always be on the lookout for animals, some of which are harmless, others dangerous. Some are cute and cuddly, others are repulsive.

You will encounter pockets of proto-humans, able to lead and organize the animals or cultivate the vegetation. The blather of competing opinions sound like the random sounds heard at a watering hole in an African savannah.

On the positive side, fully functional humans are working for things that transcend their own self-interest. They may be organizing for humanity, such as, building nations, administering justice, creating hospitals, churches, etc.

Further off in the distance, you may catch a glimpse of saints and initiates. They are in higher states, but from time to time you may reach that state and recognize them. There are even higher beings. For us, the influences of angels and demons are experienced directly.

Note

- *The State of Mental Health in America:* `https://www.mhanational.org/issues/state-mental-health-america`
- *National Institute of Mental Health:* `https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/statistics/mental-illness.shtml`
- *Personality Disorders:* `https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/personality-disorders/symptoms-causes/syc-20354463`

Posted on 2021-01-10 by Cologero

* * *

Solphomeron on 2021-01-10 at 17:10 said:

Hi I'm a mentally ill man, have been diagnosed with Borderline personality disorder, Narcissism and most recently Dissociative identity disorder (this last one is self diagnosed).

Finding Gornahoor and esoteric knowledge has been a double-edged sword. On the one hand It gives me tools to deal with my diseased soul, for example: Living a chaste life, in obedience to the Catholic faith have helped me to develop self respect and boundaries between me and other people, being vigilant helps me to not identify myself with my intense emotions, praying the rosary constantly have made me grow a more healthy internal dialogue, instead of violent and lustful daydreaming I find myself repeating the Our Father or the Ave Maria.

but on the other hand, My delusion feeds itself with the information found here, and creates more intricate, labyrinthine alternate realities..

So it has become difficult to distinguish between a synchronicity and a delusion of grandeur. My mind is always looking for associations, deeper meanings, symbolism. I often feel many layers of meaning in a conversation or interaction, and the deeper it always have some archetypal/mythic feeling.

Can I trust myself? I find the only way out is to surrender completely To Christ. I'm a cup brimming with demonic goo and a few angelic sprinkles. But they are not me. Who am I? . I'm an interface. I'm a battleground.

Auld Wat on 2021-01-11 at 07:44 said:

A personal reflection:

I believe I was in the fourth class until I was about 22 years of age. I then entered into the Third Class, on the lowest rung, when I became aware of what I liked and disliked. I cannot remember being overly emotional but I do remember enjoying debates and discussions. The changes in my awareness were brought about by external factors, women, political events, recommendations.

I believe I moved from the Third to the Second Class only recently, despite being a practicing Catholic for the last 5 years, as it was only last week that I came to the realisation of what my purpose in life is. I had known what it was to some extent for over 2 years but I didn't recognise it fully until now.

Thank you for writing.

Cologero on 2021-01-22 at 12:52 said:

Savant, please read the article very carefully and try again. However, I must accept responsibility for not being clear enough. This is not a description of a human designed organization, but how God would see it. Perhaps that sounds arrogant, but God has revealed His plan. Perhaps

this might supplement the post: *Liberating the Guardian Angel*[7].

On the other hand, I think that the post makes one thing clear. Few people understand their purpose and destiny in life. But those who do, need to act on it. Otherwise there would be no Saints that you referred to.

Also, please refrain from gratuitous comments that may sound funny to you, but are inappropriate in today's intellectual climate.

7.8 The End of the Golden Age

> Two birds, inseparably united companions, dwell in the same tree; the one eats of the fruit of the tree, while the other looks on without eating.
>
> *Mundaka Upanishad iii.1*



This quote from the Upanishads, which appear at the end of the Vedic period, demonstrates the vague beginnings of the dualistic consciousness, the indicator of the transition from one age to the next. At that time, there was still an awareness of the true Self and its connection to the empirical ego, or "analog I". The latter is active in the natural world, eating its fruits, while the former is the unmoved mover, still in communion with supernature. The rupture, which would later result in the forgetting of the true Self, was not total.

Two Cracks in the Egg The empirical I is born as a result of friction: yes and no, good and evil, self and other. This involves judgment and planning, creating a space for reflective thought between contemplation

[7] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/liberating-the-guardian-angel

and action. What could intrude in that way into the harmony of the Primordial State? Fabre d'Olivet postulates two events, one internal, the other external.

Man and Woman

> To enjoy before possessing is the instinct of man; to possess before enjoying is the instinct of woman.
>
> Fabre d'Olivet

In this difference in the fundamental attitudes between the sexes, reflection begins. The man pursues, the woman flees; he offers her his gifts, she accepts; he enjoys, she possesses. This primal relationship is the foundation of society. The pact is that the "stronger was pledged to protect the weaker and the weaker to remain attached to the stronger." This pact extended to the children, which otherwise would have been impossible, and thence to the extended family.

Taken to unnatural direction, the woman became more interested in "possession", and began to see her husband as a means rather than an end, and developed a sort of matriarchy within the household. This weakened the pact, so man, in reaction, reverted to the instinct of pleasure. His eyes turned to other, younger, women, leading, of course, to conflict. Within the kinship group, this was manageable. But when freed from such constraints through contacts with outsiders, the instinct for possession would lead a woman to the seemingly more prosperous, and man to the more enjoyable, regardless of the consequences.

Great War

> When it has been necessary to write laws has been when laws were no longer unanimous.

Fabre d'Olivet

Based on a story from the *Mahabharata*, Fabre d'Olivet then postulated a great war between the Hyperboreans and the Meridional peoples. The various Hyperborean tribes were forced to unite in order to fend off the invasion. But in the General Will there was no clear idea about how to proceed. Out of the confusion, one strong man arose and declared he had a plan. This was the Herman (Gherman), the chief of men. Whereas previously, roles and castes had arisen naturally and organically, the Herman had to explicitly divide the gathered men into three categories.

1. All the venerable men not able to endure the fatigues of war
2. All the young and robust men, which constituted the army
3. The weak and the old who were still active and would provide for the material needs

This is the beginning of a more formal caste system: the spiritual caste, the warrior caste, and finally the skilled and servile worker castes. This division would outlive its necessity leading to social inequalities, or a fortiori the awareness of social inequalities, with the concomitant possibility of resentment.

Posted on 2011-01-12 by Cologero

* * *

KarlH on 2011-01-13 at 00:40 said:

How and why did the Third Sex emerge? Is it due to this same degeneration of will? Does the Third Sex exist (and how)? Does it have a substance of its own in this emerging duality or does it come after it?

I'm referring to both basic Hijra (gender-male but adopting a female way of life) and those who live as both men and women. Is it a taking-of-turns between the two polarities? Is it the

consequence of realizing both the masculine and feminine ideals? Theoretically, could one born into this condition be inherently closer to the Absolute in terms of the formlessness that precedes divison?

kadambari on 2011-01-17 at 01:12 said:

"I'm referring to both basic Hijra (gender-male but adopting a female way of life) and those who live as both men and women. Is it a taking-of-turns between the two polarities?"

In our tradition these people are considered oddities and are not important. Just as homosexuals are considered not important. People are too intelligent to think they deserve any attention as long as they do not upset the traditional order. Homosexuality is prevalent amongst Muslims in Kashmir, and we see it mostly as a Muslim phenomenon, most of the Muslim rulers of India were bi-sexual, we see this coming from Muslim influence. We cannot relate to such phenomena. I think Hindus were smart to realize that certain types of people cannot be coerced from being what they are, the best thing is to ignore them and not encourage them. That is why unlike Muslims they do not seek to punish such people, but ignore them and do not let them disrupt the traditional order. Ironically those that seek to punish these people such as Muslims have the highest incidence of that which they seek to punish. Just as in Kashmir they are known for being prosmicuous and having the highest divorce rates. Wearing a burka does not indicate anything or any purity as people think.

7.9 The Creator has a Master Plan

A long-time supporter of Gornahoor recently posed this question:

> Cologero, why god created lucifer, knowing that one day he would turn his back on him. God really likes to see the circus on fire?

Rather than provide a vapid response, I decided to go straight to the source. So I DMed Him and waited several days for a response. He woke me up in the middle of a pleasant dream, but, despite my grogginess, I forced myself to awaken. This is the exchange that resulted. (My questions are in **bold**; the responses are in a normal font.)

Before I get to the purpose of this chat, I'd like to clarify something. If you are being itself, how can there be beings other than you? Our best esoterists and philosophers come to this conclusion.

You like that? Yes, it is my crowning achievement. You just need to realize who or what you really are. Then the mystery dissipates somewhat without, however, ceasing to be a mystery!

Let's cut to the chase then. The question arose in regard to evil. If you are Being, then how does an evil entity like Lucifer come to exist?

Let me start at the beginning. I had in mind a great idea for a world. I started with general concepts and worked down to more specific ideas. I created angels to share these ideas; they became excited about the concepts.

I see. That is what we call the Divine Intellect, Universal Intellect, Buddhi, and so on. That is where the ideas or essences reside in a sense. Did we get that right?

That is more or less on track. But you really need to contemplate them, to "sink" into them, as it were. Just verbal knowledge will prevent you from the fullest experience of it.

I you think about it, you will see that it is true.

It's nice to contemplate the Master Plan, but that is not yet a world. What was the next step?

It is not yet a World because it is still just Thought. I needed a way to project it, to experience it directly. So I had to design sense experience. It is just too overwhelming for a single sense. Together, they constituted the passive experience of the world.

In addition, for what I had in mind, I needed to create a way for creatures to interact with the world. It turns out that I only needed a few basic structures which could vary enormously. You call these homologous structures.

More great ideas, but still not yet a world.

That is because I needed a canvas. An artist, who has structures and colors in mind, still requires a canvas in order to visualize his creation and share it with other.

That is why I created matter, which is a total opposite to me. I am pure actuality, uncaused, unmoved, and complete. Matter, on the other hand, is pure potentiality, in other words, nothing in particular. It has the possibility of being but not the actuality, at least not until I project my ideas onto it. So, you see that a nothing becomes something without any self-diminishment on my part.

So why do we see multiple copies of an idea?

Good question! There is only one idea. Once you understand the essence of a Rooster, there is not need for multiple ideas of the Rooster. So I created mathematics, which contains the idea as well as copies. You can understand the idea of a Triangle, and you can also conceive of multiple triangles in the mind.

But you cannot conceive of multiple roosters; for that they need to be materialized. So mathematics is the dividing line between the ideas, or essences, and existence in matter. You understand that matter contains the principle of individuation.

So I created space and time in order to experience the ideas sensually. I see the Rooster in its perfect wholeness, all at once, from its conception to death. You see the same thing unfolding in space and time. Space and time are the analogs of the two traditional branches of maths: geometry and arithmetic.

That can be confusing, I know, when you don't grasp the big picture.

I still don't understand why beings are imperfect if the idea is perfect.

If I made the perfect rooster, it would necessarily be static; it could not change and develop. If I made every rooster exactly alike, they would just be the same rooster. So roosters follow a statistical distribution, e.g., a standard, Poisson, or even a Pareto distribution. The Ancients did not understand that.

In that way, I added a little variety and uncertainty into the world process.

You've explained the rooster. What about people?

Yes, yes. Let's get to that. The angels are purely spiritual beings; roosters, and all the other animals and plants are material beings. What if I could create a being that was both spiritual and material? A being who could grasp the Ideas in spirit, but also the physical world through the senses. That was a breakthrough.

Presumably Adam was that being?

Yes. I had to create the proper corporeal conditions first. Then a suitable animal body had to be prepared. I chose Adam from among them and breathed the Spirit into him. Adam the realized how different he was from the animals he saw in the world. He could no longer feel at home among them, even if some of them had the same outward appearance. So I created a suitable companion for him and gave them a pleasant place to live.

The companion was Eve and the place was Eden. What was that experience like for him?

I gave him what every guy thinks he wants: free and tasty food like an always open buffet. He had meaningful work like tinkering around the garden. And then he had a beautiful naked woman wandering around and available.

But why the temptation, if everything was going so well?

You do understand that Adam's original consciousness, in my "image and likeness', has no duality. It is all good, Adam experienced no lack. Yet Adam was placed in the middle, so there have to be two forces at play: one upward toward Spirit and the other downward toward the physical world.

The third force equilibrates those two forces; this is precisely that nondual consciousness that I breathed into him. As long as Adam was consciously aware of the spiritual world, he would be OK.

But it didn't turn out OK

As I said, there is the possibility of evil, but not necessarily its actuality.

The thing with Lucifer was supposed to be a joke. How did Adam ever fall for such a cheesy temptation? The talking serpent, the attractive fruit, etc.; he should have seen through it.

I didn't teach him "good and evil". And how did he even know what "death" meant, unless he learned it from watching the animals. But their experience is different. Physical death is just part of the material world. The real issue is spiritual death, which is what Adam experienced. He then judged the world on his own terms: good and bad, easy or difficult, and so on and on.

So here we are! What's next?

There is an entire historical drama about that, which need not be repeated in a DM. Your task is to describe that pure Edenic state of consciousness.

Why don't you just tell me?

It can't be told, it must be experienced. There is the joy of discovery. On Easter Sunday, don't you hide the eggs from the children, or do you leave them out in a bowl? It is the search that is meaningful.

One final question. Which came first, the chicken or the egg?

Sorry, you're breaking up ... I have to go

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MUouOwmtVEY`

Posted on 2021-04-11 by Cologero

* * *

`info on 2021-04-11 at 23:51 said:`

If perfection is static. How is the non-static living God perfect?

`Cologero on 2021-04-12 at 00:09 said:`

Dear lack of info: the topic was the perfect Rooster. I suggest you find the perfect Rooster and report back to us.

Or are you suggesting that God changes? That would be quite an unfortunate opinion to hold.

`info on 2021-04-12 at 09:12 said:`

@Cologero

The premise that perfection is static. But life isn't static means that it doesn't quite work as a definition. God is perfect yet he acts as befits a Living God.

He is remains the same yet he isn't static either.

`Cologero on 2021-04-12 at 09:26 said:`

Get lost. You are here just to debate the meaning of words with me? And miss the effing point.

Dictionary definition of static: "Having no motion"

God is the "unmoved mover".

Meditate on that for six months or so. And consider yourself banned from commenting in the meantime.

`MP on 2021-04-13 at 08:06 said:`

Leon possessed a powerful gospel inspired voice. His work on the (redacted) linked tune is probably a bit much for most, recorded as it was during Pharaoh's rather chaotic 'free' style, under the influence of John Coltrane and Sun Ra.

Alternately, Thomas' vocal work on Sanders' tune, Oh Lord Let Me Do No Wrong, is first rate, and would be a good place for a novice to start.

For a while Leon associated with Santana's spiritually oriented jazzish pop group–the time Carlos was hanging with John McLaughlin (during the latter's first Mahavishnu Orchestra phase). With 'fitness' guru Chinmoy Ghose. Back then it was important for musicians to follow gurus. Not sure that remains the case, but I'm out of the music scene so don't really know how it is, today.

`Cologero on 2021-04-13 at 13:34 said:`

Wow, MP, I did not suspect that there are any jazz fans left, especially now when any saccharin instrumental music is called "jazz".

For obvious reasons, I did not link to the full version with the long solo at the end.

I considered the live version of the song by Santana and McLaughlin. But their version is hardly reverent enough. It seems more self-serving just to show how 'with it' they are.

`Angolmois on 2021-04-21 at 09:05 said:`

Lucifer himself is not evil, but the luciferic principle makes evil possible since he is the principle of mind that makes possible both the ascension and descension of man by making possible the discernment between good and evil, and some unfortunate souls choose evil con-

sciously even after they know good and evil (possibly because of a-causal reasons), becoming "a disaster for the human race".

Lucifer and Christ are not opposed, since Lucifer is the bearer of light and Christ the light itself. The crucified savior is Lucifer/Ego. Jesus called himself "the bright morning star" which is a direct reference to Lucifer. The battle between good and evil is fought within man's soul but one cannot blame Lucifer for making it possible, since without him man would be "perfect but unconscious and without merit", a mere useless instrument in the hands of the Gods.

Evil exists within humanity and we have all sinned somewhere along the path, because it is the school of good and evil in which man must ultimately triumph and choose the good willingly.It is man who is to blame for the "sin of pride", and this is what changes Lucifer into a Satan. The real blame is on man conscious of his choices.

In the Finnish epic Kalevala, Ilmarinen (literally "airy", again a reference to Lucifer) is the forger of the vault of Heaven and the axis mundi that holds existence in one piece, Son of Morning and the Nightfall (Venus) and he is also the helper of Wäinämöinen, who is literally an old covenant Christ figure (Melkhisedek in one of his guises).

7.10 Adam's Choice

> The IMAGINATION ... I consider either as primary, or secondary. The primary IMAGINATION I hold to be the living Power and prime Agent of all human Perception, and as a repetition in the finite mind of the eternal act of creation in the infinite I AM.
>
> Samuel Coleridge, *Biographia Literatura*

> What would be needed is a world where socialization and specialization would no longer rip away from each soul its individuality, its spontaneous perception of the life of things, and the religious sense of the beauty of beings. It would be a world where Love would have to precede all Knowledge, a world where the sense of death would be only nostalgia for resurrection.
>
> Henry Corbin, *Eternal Sophia*

> I was a hidden Treasure. I desired to be known; that is why I created creatures.
>
> Hadith

Adam, the Primordial Man, was just below the angels, yet could contemplate God's word. Through Intuition, he could see God's plan, but somewhat imperfectly. But Adam was the only human and God wanted more to share in His plan. Thus He proposed to let Adam incarnate in a body of clay. Adam balked and was resistant to the idea. Since God needed Adam's permission, He offered Adam a preview of what Earth life would be like.

The Plan for Adam God showed Adam the Divine Soul which gave him the gift of Imagination. He filled Adam's Imagination with sensual imagery derived from the five outer senses of hearing, sight, touch, taste, and smell. Suddenly the ideas known to Adam in the Divine Intellect took on a new aspect. Not only did he know the ideas, but he could now experience them in his mind.

Adam was astounded to experience the ideas, not only spiritually in his intellect, but also in his soul. The world of nature was no longer an abstract thought, he could now experience it. The fields, forests, seas, mountains, flowers, and fauna were displayed in a kaleidoscope of color, the multitudinous sounds of the Earth pounded his soul.

Adam was intrigued especially when he watched the animals move about. God explained that Adam would receive the same powers. He would be given not only the means of locomotion but the power of grasping, in a fashion much superior to that of animals. He would be given the gift of speech; this would allow him to not just hear the Word but also speak the word. Most important was the gift of creation. He would be able to create in the world, in imitation of God. He would till the fields, explore the forests, sail the seas, climb the mountains, and make use of

the flora and fauna. Even better, Adam would be able to create beings like himself through reproduction.

The Angels Revolt The angels, with astonishment, listened intently to God's Word to Adam. Gazing deeply into God's plan, they protested that Adam and his progeny, with their power of choice, would only create mischief and shed blood.

God said to them, "You do not see deeply enough. You are appointed to guide humanity and serve them." But some angels resented Adam's gift, and refused to serve men. Having devised their own plan, many of them rebelled against God and were banished from the Heavenly Realms. Instead of being of help to men, they would become tempters.

The Creation of Eve "How can I create beings like myself?" asked Adam.

"I will first split you in two," God replied.

Adam then fell into the causal state of deep sleep while God split him. When he awoke, God showed Eve to Adam. Adam was overwhelmed at the experience of his soul. He knew the Idea of Beauty, but the experience of Eve's beauty was overwhelming. His love for Eve rivalled his intellectual love for God.

God revealed to them that they are to be together for eternity as their lives are forever entangled. Even in their darkest moments, in times of despair, when they seem separated, they are together and must seek each other. From their spiritual marriage, they will find their true Self.

For the nonce, Adam and Even lived in the Garden that God had prepared for them. There was abundance and ease, and they remained aware of the presence of God.

Warning to Adam God gave a warning to Adam. "Eat and do as you will, but do not eat from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil.

There will come a time when you will be tempted, but remember my command. Otherwise, you will forget me. Life apart from Me is death."

"I will never forget you, my Lord. I accept your command but the warning is unnecessary," promised Adam.

Adam's Fall Unbeknown to them, Satan, the leader of the rebel angels, was waiting for them in the Garden. Satan took advantage of their desire for a sensual experience. Satan convinced their soul, Eve, that the taste of the fruit of the forbidden tree provided great pleasure.

For the first time, Adam experienced doubt and fell into darkness. He forgot his origin and his promise. Together they ate, but their delight at sensual experience released them from their innocence.

They fell totally into earth bodies, which became their new center of awareness. They lived among the animals, and now had to struggle for their nourishment. They became alienated not only from God, but from each other.

They must find each other, as God told them, so that through their spiritual marriage a new Self will be born.

Posted on 2021-08-11 by Cologero

* * *

S.P. on 2021-08-18 at 13:18 said:

In spiritual love the passion of the flesh is sublimated and, in a way, consumed by the very fire of its love; Eventually, not only is the body conceived as a transparent expression of the soul, ennobled and embellished by its almost Apollonian light, but the passion is spiritualized until it transcends the very desire of the body, like a burning love, a kind of "melted fire" . In the sacred union man desires only God.

Once you understand it, not as rational information, but as that understanding that is living experience, then life reveals itself. This is a path that every man should discover, even if most will not finish it in this lifetime. For my part, I appreciate these posts.

7.11 Keeping Warm: David and Abishag

> Symbolism can deceive only those who are incapable of seeing anything except the most literal meaning. They will never understand what a symbol is, because their conceptions are irremediably limited to earthly existence and the corporeal world, where, by the most naive of illusions, they try to confine all reality.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Man and his Becoming*

With a little cold wind penetrating the subtropics tonight (45/7 degrees), and the expectation of finding the grounds littered with comatose iguanas in the morning, my thoughts turn tonight to the story of King David and Abishag. This is the Biblical story:

> Now King David was old and advanced in years; and although they covered him with clothes, he could not get warm. Therefore his servants said to him, "Let a young maiden be sought for my lord the king, and let her wait upon the king, and cherish him; let her lie in your bosom, that my lord the king may be warm." So they sought for a beautiful maiden throughout all the territory of Israel, and found Abishag the Shunammite, and brought her to the king. The maiden was very beautiful; and she became the king's nurse and ministered to him; but the king knew her not.
>
> 1 Kings 1:1-4

When a sacred text seems odd, erroneous, inconsistent, etc., it is often a signal that the text should be understood symbolically, not literally. In the story of David and Abishag, it seems odd that lying next to a woman was the only way to keep David warm. Moreover, why did it have to be with Israel's most beautiful woman when rather than any woman? That indicates that the woman had to have a special relationship to David, one that was suitable just for him.

Physics, in the theory of many worlds, shows that it is possible for multiple degrees of existence to share the same space, time, and energy. Hence, in the human state the relationship between a man and a woman can take place in three levels, even simultaneously:

- Gross state: two individual beings
- Subtle state: two sharing same consciousness
- Causal state: alchemical marriage or unity

Since Abishag was to lie next to David, presumably at night, we can assume that the story was about the dream state (or subtle state), so the presence of a corporeal maiden (even if literally true) was not the point of the story. As above, so below, hence the woman in subtle manifestation is in consciousness unlike the woman in corporeal manifestation. The dream state is related to *Tejas*, the fire element. The dream state has the knowledge of internal mental objects. This is how Guenon describes it:

> The fire element is both light and heat. ... Everything relating to this touches very closely on the very nature of life, which is inseparable from heat. Aristotle's conceptions agree fully with those of the Easterners.

Here was can see that David was not just receiving physical warmth from Abishag, but, more importantly, life itself! Fire also brings light physically, but as knowledge in the subtle state. Guenon touches on this aspect:

> The dream state is intermediate between waking and deep sleep. He who knows this, advances in the path of Knowledge by his identification with Hiranyagarbha. Thus enlightened, he is in harmony with all things, for he sees the manifested Universe as the production of his own knowledge, which cannot be separated from himself.

As a reminder, Hiranyagarbha is still Non-Supreme knowledge. Hence, it is related to salvation and immortality rather than full Liberation. In a sense, then, David and Abishag are embarking on the Divine Journey through the celestial spheres. As the embodiment of an archetype, she is his Anima, a psychopomp guiding his soul through the afterlife.

Over the years, I have been logging my dreams of the Anima. The first ones were quite vague; I would wake up with the feeling that I had just met someone. However, I could remember nothing about her and usually assumed she was a living person. Over time, they carried more content. The most recent dreams are about a woman who reveals to me some deep secret. They repeat.

In one of them, she leads up a staircase to an attic. She shows me a secret room with a chest filled with manuscripts. I am allowed to read them after she leaves, but I don't remember any specific content.

In another, there is a secret room at the back of a kitchen. A short staircase leads up to a library filled with texts. Again, I am left alone to rummage through them, but awaken in total forgetfulness. The images of the attic and kitchen library are still vivid in my mind.

I used to be frustrated about forgetting the content of the mysterious texts. As I eventually learned, that is because I was expecting head knowledge, not knowledge of the heart. I wanted a theory of everything, but the dreams were telling me that I needed to change my life.

The dream will be fulfilled when the Anima stays and unites with me in consciousness. She will not leave me alone with the texts, but we will each know them in our own way. Then we begin the journey.

Posted on 2023-01-14 by Cologero

* * *

T. Freitas on 2023-01-15 at 04:05 said:
Very interesting view of the story of David and Abishag.

Santiago on 2023-01-16 at 17:46 said:

The staircases seem important. Jung has said in one of his books (I can't remember which) that staircases represent the sexual instinct ("going-up-going-down"), which seems unlikely. In your case–assuming Janet is off-duty–what is sexual about a library or a book-room?

In most of my dreams, she leads me down the staircase first. The best interpretation I can make of it comes from Dante, signifying there's more hell to see, first.

Kaukomieli on 2023-01-18 at 09:15 said:

@Santiago: I believe it was Freud who made the sexual allusion since for him Everything is about the life instinct and the Death instinct, hence sex. Jung is More subtle and "spiritual". The staircase leading upwards would probably be interpreted by him that something is coming up into consciousness while the staircase leading downwards would mean descending into the subconscious layers of the psyche.

Guenon was mentioned in the article a couple of times. He seemed to be adamant in his convictions that Dreams cannot transmit anything spiritual. I heartily disagree with him on that issue, since as a dreamer who has an intense nocturnal life I have seen a lot of Dreams that I can only label with the term spiritual and even enlightening. Perhaps the words of Guenon have to be understood in the context of making a difference between the psychic and the spiritual.

I am beginning to sense that the whole Bible needs to be understood symbolically.

8

States of being. The Divine Journey

8.1 Dante's Empyrean

In *The Discarded Image*, **C. S. Lewis** invites the reader to a series of exercises, beginning with looking out at the night sky. When he comes to **Dante**, however, he realizes that his first exercise was misleading. You do not experience the Empyrean by looking out at the night sky as though it were a canopy encompassing the universe. He writes:

> The universe is thus, when our minds are sufficiently freed from the senses, turned inside out.

As Fludd's diagram[1] indicates, the highest level of the Empyrean is Mens or Consciousness. The world, then, exists in consciousness. In The Metaphysics of Dante's Comedy, **Christian Moevs** makes a good attempt to describe Dante's worldview in its own terms. Moevs makes these points:

[1] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-cosmic-hierarchy

1. the world of space and time does not itself exist in space and time: it exists in Intellect (the Empyrean, pure conscious being)
2. matter, in medieval hylomorphism, is not something "material": it is a principle of unintelligibility, of alienation from conscious being
3. all finite form, that is, all creation, is a self-qualification of Intellect or Being, and only exists insofar as it participates in it
4. Creator and creation are not two, since the latter has no existence independent of the former; but of course creator and creation are not the same
5. God, as the ultimate subject of all experience, cannot be an object of experience: to know God is to know oneself as God, or (if the expression seems troubling) as one "with" God or "in" God.

Obviously, this point of view can also be found in the non-dual teachings of the Eastern Traditions. Of course, this totally alters the meaning of salvation in Dante, or better said, he has an understanding of liberation beyond mere salvation. This is the process of theosis, or becoming God-like. This seems to make Mr. Lewis quite uncomfortable. He writes:

> The picture is nothing if not religious. But is the religion in question precisely Christianity?

As long as Christianity is assumed to consist of a set of creedal statements to be believed, Mr. Lewis' question is valid. However, if we are describing a conversion, an intellectual conversion[2], the answer is positive: Dante is describing a true picture of the universe. However, as the

[2] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=262

optical illusion demonstrates, the picture can be seen in two, mutually incompatible, ways. As long as a man is stuck with a worldview of the old lady, he cannot discern the young women. No intellectual argument is persuasive, there needs to be a sudden "seeing" of the other view. With that, there is no longer any doubt. But before that conversion, there can be nothing but the demon of dialectics[3]. Mr. Moevs explains it this way:

> The kind of enlightenment or revelation this self-professedly salvific text is meant to trigger cannot be reduced to "doctrine", to a creed or set of ideas (already familiar to most in any case). To profess a religious or philosophical creed is not to achieve salvation; else many residents of Dante's Hell would live in Paradise, and some who live in Paradise, such as Ripheus, would live in Hell. In the Comedy salvation is rather a self-awakening of the Real to itself in us, the surrender or sacrifice of what we take ourselves and the world to be, a changed experience that is one with a moral transformation. We cannot know what we are until we surrender what we think we are, with all its attendant desires.
>
> By Dante's own definition of philosophy (the reflexive love of intellect for itself), a philosopher whose contribution can be reduced to doctrine, to a new set of ideas, has either been misunderstood or is not very good.

Do we see here yet again the need for the First Trial[4]? We need to sacrifice our personal opinions, the false ideas of who we are, in order to know who we truly are, our True Will. This first requires the Moral Purification of the Will[5].

We should not neglect Dante's point of philosophers, of whom he holds **Aquinas** and **Aristotle** in high regard. A Cliff Notes summary of their philosophical doctrines is insufficient. What is required is a wrestling

[3] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=813

[4] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1902

[5] https://gornahoor.net/?p=17007

with their ideas in order to achieve some sort of intellectual transformation.

The Comedy is all-embracing. As we have been trying to show with Solovyov's Law of Development[6], the path to self-knowledge requires knowing the world in its Totality, as the total experience of the human race. To pick and choose, to reject a particular period of the cosmic cycle, is to fall short of the task. Moevs describes Dante's view:

> In the Comedy, to journey toward self-knowledge is to assimilate as oneself, through direct poetic experience, the entire breadth of human experience in history, in its concrete and particular reality. Hence the Comedy is all encompassing; it is built on human encounters; it is one man's experience, the assimilation of everyone's experience. Through this identification with the totality of possible experience, the obsessive point of view (veduta) and attachments of the individual ego begin to dissolve, and the subject of all experience, reflected as the individual mind, begins to awaken to itself, ultimately to discover itself, on the threshold of the Empyrean, as an extensionless metaphysical point, the light that spawns and is all things. Of that point, nothing can be said: it is not a thing, there is nothing to know. One can only be it; that is to know it.

Posted on 2012-01-02 by Cologero

8.2 Divine Journey Summary

In *Man and his Becoming*, **Rene Guenon** outlines a path to liberation. If you start at the beginning and work through it diligently with understanding, you might attain the Supreme Identity. Just as a master mechanic understands the workings of an automobile, the student must

[6] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3504`

have a complete understanding of the inner workings of the human being. These are the main topics in the process, as illustrated in *Man and his Becoming*.

1. The distinction between the true Self (Atman) and the Ego
2. God (Brahman) resides in the human heart
3. The process of manifestation and the play of the three fundamental forces
4. The origin of thought, mind, the senses, and external organs
5. The different states of the human being
6. The five sheaths of the human being
7. The celestial journey through the various spheres
8. Union, which is the realization of the identity of the Atman and Brahman

Postmortem States These are the possible outcomes of man's postmortem states.

Longevity Indefinite prolongation of human individuality in the subtle state.

Path of the Ancestors (pitriyana) After the resorption of human individuality, the being will pass into other states of individual manifestation.

Passive Liberation of path of the mystics Jivatman unites with subtle body until the end of the world. It then unites with Brahman passively, without full realization.

Delayed liberation Jivatman unites with subtle body. Liberation will be obtained, at the end of the cycle, by means of intermediate stages [conditioned postmortem states], and not in a direct and immediate way.

Liberated at death Jivatman does not unite with subtle body, nor pass through other states, but is liberated at death.

Jivanmukta Liberated in life.

Transhuman states Guenon describes multiple transhuman states on the path of the Divine Journey. This journey can be made during human life or possibly after. In the Vedic version described by Guenon, each stage may be associated with a god or deva. Unless you were born and raised in India, gods like Agni, Varuna, or Indra elicit no visceral reaction. At best, you can gain an intellectual understanding of what the various gods represent.

However, as Guenon points out, Dante's description is virtually the same. Do not be deceived by the lack of exact correspondences, which should not be expected in symbolic representations. For example, Dante encounters various personages instead of gods at the various spheres. The point is to understand the state of consciousness described. Guenon also points out that the angels represent higher stages of consciousness. For many living in the West, this may be a better path.

Ideal type In the Vedanta, the Yogi represents the ideal type. Since our goal is the restoration of Tradition in the West, a different model may be appropriate.

Our path is that of the **spiritual knight**, who is active in the world. This provides the opportunity to manifest all the possibilities of the Self. King David is one such model: he was a warrior and a poet (Psalms).

He lived and loved. Work and love are what matters. What tasks are you called to do? Do you have a love, whether real or aspirational?

Individual Path Ultimately, we make the journey alone just as did the Knights of the Round Table, not to mention Don Quixote. There is no operating manual for the Divine Journey, since the specific path depends so much on the capabilities and possibilities of the individual. Oftentimes you don't even know if and when you are on the path. After some consideration, I decided that it is appropriate to use personal experiences to demonstrate this.

So I am doing an experiment using Bergson's and Tomberg's understanding of memory. The goal is not merely reminiscence, but the bringing of the past into the present. That will show the memory in a new light, with the highest being moral memory. The exercise of bringing the past into the present can be fruitful. Only then can you recognize the path you have been on.

From meeting notes of 12 XII 2022

Posted on 2022-12-14 by Cologero

8.3 Spiritual Beings

In esoteric cosmologies, in the transition from essence to existence, the being passes through a series of influences, from the subtle to the dense. According to **John Woodroffe**, in Tantric teachings the schema of the Tattvas from the Samkhya school is important in explaining the various states of the being. In the West, Hermetism has an analagous teaching. John Fludd describes the cosmic process[7] as a series of 22 states from

[7] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-cosmic-hierarchy

the Divine Mind to Earth. We have adapted his diagram[8] to illustrate this clearly. First of all, we point out that these states can be categorized in three Realms corresponding to the Traditional division of Heaven, Man, and Nature. Each of these realms relate to states of beings and to a particular Hermetic science.

Realm	States of Being	Hermetic Science
Heaven (2 to 10)	Transhuman states	Theurgy or Sacred Magic
Man (11 to 18)	Psychological states	Astrology
Nature (19 to 22)	Subconscious states	Alchemy

Note how is integrating the pagan deities into a larger continuum. This is another example of the unity of the Roman Tradition. There are a few main points about this diagram.

Unity at the top, Diversity at the bottom While there is an ontologically unity in principle, at the level of manifestation there is wide diversity. All attempts to establish a unity at the level of manifestation have failed and will continue to fail. But the modern flatland mind can only understand unity at that level, and will extrapolate backwards in time to a fictitious source at the beginning.

Inner experience It is through inner experience that we come to know and understand these forces. They are not proved by philosophy nor by science.

Represent states of being The layers correspond to states of the being, subhuman, human and transhuman. We may sense the obstacles formed by elemental forces, or the forces unleashed by the gods as

[8] Special thanks to Lydia Bisanti (`https://gornahoor.net/?p=1497`) for creating the diagram.

alien to us. But as Evola points out, those experiences are actually a privation, that is, a lack in us, not independent of us. As we gain power, we begin to understand them as our own state.

Personal not impersonal : the I It is a sign of "sophistication" today to regard the gods or God as impersonal forces. However, the Absolute is the I, which acts by its Will, just the opposite of an impersonal force.

Do not act directly These states do not act directly on the world, but rather with man as intermediary[9]. Each layer contributes through thoughts, ideas, and tendencies.

Nature We have already addressed this issue here: Possession by Evil Spirits[10], so there is no need to repeat it.

Man In his sermon on Mars Hill in Athens, Paul criticized the belief in the power of idols. What this really means is the acknowledgment of the end of paganism as an exoteric practice. Nevertheless, Paul does quote some pagan poets, which is *ipso facto* an admission of their inspiration. This was commonly accepted in Hellenic Christianity until the doctrine of *sola scriptura* undermined any possibility of that in the West. So if Homer is inspired, then the myths of the gods necessarily refer to an esoteric teaching. Hence, the gods are symbolic figures and we recognize their influence inner experience.

More than a millennium later, Robert Fludd[11] had the same understanding. He recognized the power of the gods and incorporated them into the Chain of Being. But it was only in the 20th century that **Carl**

[9] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1798

[10] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/possession-by-evil-spirits

[11] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Robert_Fludd

Jung began to explore the influences of these forces in a systematic way and to bring their activities from the unconscious into consciousness.

Heaven Beyond the psychological states in man, there are higher transformal states. These have been called angels in several traditions and this particular schema is due to Dionysius who was a Greek associate of Paul. That relationship made his teaching on the angels authoritative in the Middle Ages. A more recent work on the angels is *Spiritual Beings* by **Rudolf Steiner**. Rene Guenon recognizes the existence of the celestial hierarchy, but doesn't dwell on the topic since, from a metaphysical point or view, it is sufficient to note the existence of higher states, but not the specifics. However, for the Hermetist, whose project is to achieve such higher states, knowledge of this hierarchy is important.

In passing, we can tie this back to Julian. The archangels, in particular, are the forces behind the different nations. Steiner writes: "A nation is a homogeneous group of people directed by one of the Archangels." This used to be the common belief in Europe. The different ranks of angels "guide", in the sense of forming ideas and worldviews, various aspects of life. That is why similar constellations of related ideas can be held by a group of people almost in unison. The existence of a counter-hierarchy is left for another time.

Posted on 2011-03-17 by Cologero

8.4 Multiple States in Christianity

Philippe Guiberteau, a Catholic writer, was preparing an annotated translation (into French) of Dante's *Banquet*. Although M. Guiberteau had been reading Rene Guenon for 25 years, he was still unconvinced about the applicability of the notion of the multiple states of the being to Catholic theology. He was then put in touch with Michel Valsan. There

we have the rather odd situation of a Muslim explaining Catholic theology to Dante's translator.

In three letters to Philippe Guiberteau, Michel Valsan demonstrates that Christianity also has a doctrine of the universal Self and multiple states. He shows that the metaphysical doctrine of multiple states, which considers man in his totality, that is to say as a being mainly "divine", "angelic" and "human", is present in Christianity. Its developments are illustrated in three parts:

1. Theology of Saint Thomas Aquinas
2. The spirituality represented by John of Ruysbroeck
3. Catholic esoterism, as expressed by Dante

But before completing the introduction to Valsan's letters, I shall summarize the states of being as explained by **Adi Shankara** in *Tattva Bodhah*. It will be a refresher to some and to others it may be new. In either case, Valsan will include a chart the encompasses these states and their correspondence to Christian esoteric teaching.

Three Bodies and Five sheaths

1. Gross body: Perceived through the senses.
    - Annamaya-kosha: Physical body. Nourished by food.
2. Subtle body: Known directly, not through senses. E.g., hunger, anger
    - Pranamaya-kosha: vital or vegetative soul. Nourished by air
    - Manomaya-kosha: animal soul. Seat of emotions

- Vijnanamaya-kosha: Intellectual soul. The doer. Nourished by impressions.

3. Causal body: All inherent tendencies which are the cause of the other two bodies

    - Anandamaya-kosha: Person in unmanifest condition.

Plants have a vital soul only, animals, a vital and emotional soul, and human beings possess all three sheaths of the subtle body.

Three States of consciousness These correspond to the three bodies listed above.

1. Waking state: experience of the gross world through the senses
2. Dream state: experience of our individual dream world
3. Deep sleep state: the absence of objects, emotions, and thoughts

The Universal Self The Universal Self, or Atman, is the final stage of Union well known in Catholic spirituality. Valsan quotes Saint Bernard of Clairvaux in *De Consideration*:

> What then is God? That without Whom there is nothing. It is as impossible that anything be without Him as He Himself is without Him. He is to Himself as He is to everything and, therefore, in a certain way, He alone is, who is the very Being both of Himself and of everything.

This does not annihilate the person, because only *in a certain way* is God all Being. This is identical to the Vedantic doctrine of the Supreme Self. The scholastic philosophers can be read on two levels:

- The ontological level, which stops at Being
- The trans-ontic level, which goes beyond Being (Gilson)

Knowledge and Being Aristotle and the scholastics taught the identity of knowledge and being. In the former's words, "a being is all that he knows." Guenon indicates that is precisely what is meant by metaphysical realization. Since scholastic doctrine was close to being a true metaphysics, and there had to have been more to it than just the religious and exoteric aspects.

Valsan turns to the Church Fathers to show that the Way of Knowledge (i.e., Gnosis) was always part of tradition. Then he demonstrates that Dante and the Fedeli d'Amore were perfectly orthodox in their teaching. So with two of the objections out of the way, Valsan continues.

The Multiple States Valsan then launches into the notion of the multiple states of the being. Since most readers will be familiar with Dante and Thomas Aquinas, it is better to let Valsan speak for himself. Although it is clear that Dante understands the multiple states, Valsan has to spend some time on Thomas' understanding of the Active Intellect.

Less known, perhaps, are Nicolas de Cusa and John of Ruysbroeck. Nicolas is mentioned in passing. We can point out, however, that he understood the distinction between the indefinite and the Infinite, not unlike Rene Guenon. No number of steps can reach the Infinite, which is beyond all manifestation.

John of Ruysbroeck has been a personal favorite as we have written about him often, as can be found in this link.

Valsan goes into detail to show that Ruysbroeck's understanding is entirely compatible with the Vedantic teaching of the multiple states.

Mythical Creatures An intriguing side trip involves Valsan's understanding of so-called "mythical" creatures and how they can be understood with the idea of multiple states.

Daimons, Genies, and Jinns are situated between the angels and humans. In other words, they have a causal body and a complete subtle body

just as humans do. However, they lack a gross (or physical) body.

Centaurs, Sirens, and the like, are in a degree of existence between man and animals, so they share the subtle body with both men and animals. Therefore, they would have an intellectual soul similar to man's but lacking in some regard.

The complete text of Valsan's letters in English can be found here: `https://www.gornahoor.net/library/Doctrine_Multiple_States_Being_Christianity.pdf`

Posted on 2021-02-14 by Cologero

* * *

`Duncan on 2021-02-14 at 09:46 said:`
Thank you for this timely post.

`MICHAEL on 2021-02-15 at 06:31 said:`
How is this different or distinct from Steiner's classification of the physical body, etheric body and astral body and their sheaths… ?

`Cologero on 2021-02-15 at 09:04 said:`
If it is just a theory, then the coincidence would be remarkable.
But if the different states of being are observable facts, then we should expect some similitude in the descriptions.

`MICHAEL on 2021-02-15 at 09:51 said:`
Yes, agreed… I don't believe it's a coincidence. Same with Daimons, Jinns, Centaurs and Sirens which reflect the same intermediate stages of being like salamanders, gnomes, sylphs and undines? How unique is Steiner when he links up these intermediate stages in us and the creatures of the world to the interweaving creative actions of the various levels of the spiritual hierarchies?

`Logres on 2021-02-15 at 19:14 said:`
It is a fantastically dense letter, with loads of important references, particularly drawing together undeservedly obscure quotes from non-obscure theological writers. As for the last bit, Iamblichus taught that if we are good stewards of our efforts, we release our daemon, and we

obtain a demigod to guide us. There are three divisions of demigods, leading upwards. From history: "An equation for me has no meaning, unless it represents a thought of God."-and he wasn't kidding. Like ancient Indian mathematicians, Ramanujan only noted the results and summaries of his works; no proof was worked out for the formulae he came up with. He straightaway credited his work to the divine providence of Mahalakshmi of Namakkal, a family goddess whom he looked to for inspiration. The mathematician said that he dreamed of the Goddess' male consort Narasimha, who is denoted by droplets of blood, after which, scrolls of complex mathematical work unfolded in front of his eyes." `https://www.indiatoday.in/education-today/gk-current-affairs/story/srinivasa-ramanujan-life-story-973662-2017-04-26`

There is also the legend of the Little Red Man of the Tuileries & his attachment to France: `https://esoterx.com/2014/08/07/the-little-red-man-of-the-tuileries-a-prophetic-parisian-imp/`

As possible examples of the latter mentioned stuff.

8.5 Astral Symbolism

In *Man and his Becoming*, **Rene Guenon** explains:



> Natural phenomena in general, and especially astronomical phenomena, are never looked upon by the traditional doctrines other than as a simple means of expression, whereby they symbolize truths of a higher order.

This is true because there is a correspondence between the different degrees. Principles therefore find expression in the human states, as he writes:

> If [natural phenomena] symbolize such truths [of a higher order], it is because their laws are fundamentally nothing but the expression of these very truths in a particular domain, a sort of

> translation of the corresponding principles, naturally adapted to the special conditions of the corporeal and human state.

Certainly, this applies a fortiori to astronomical symbolism:

> It must be clearly understood, that when mention is made of the Spheres of the Sun and of the Moon, it is never the sun and the moon as visible stars, belonging purely to the corporeal realm, that are referred to, but rather the universal principles which these stars represent after their own fashion in the sensible world … Indeed the different Worlds, planetary Spheres and elementary Realms which are symbolically described as so many regions (only symbolically however, since the being who journeys through them is no longer subject to space), **are in reality just different states**.

Furthermore, as Guenon notes, the same logic applies in the West to the doctrines of Heaven, Hell, and Purgatory. They likewise represent states, not places. Here we have the hermeneutic key to understand Dante's journey. He starts in Hell (the human state), spends time in Purgatory (states of self-purification), and rises to Heaven, passing through all the planetary states.

The same planetary symbolism is also used to represent the chakras. The same understanding applies: the chakras are not physical organs, but represent inner states of the being. Moreover, this understanding is not optional Guenon emphasizes, in regard to these points:

> It is absolutely essential for the understanding of these matters.

Otherwise, you become like one of:

> those who are incapable of understanding anything but the most grossly literal meaning; such people will never realize the workings of a symbol, because their conceptions are irremediably limited to existence on this earth and to the corporeal world, within which, by the most naive of illusions, they wish to imprison the whole of reality.

The Literal Meaning The symbolic meaning does not debt or replace the literal or historical meaning; rather, the historical event is a consequence of the symbolic or higher meaning. In *The Symbolism of the Cross*, Guenon explains:

> The fact is that people too often tend to think that if a symbolical meaning is admitted, the literal or historical sense must be rejected; such a view can only result from unawareness of the **Law of Correspondence** which is the very foundation of all symbolism. By virtue of this law, each thing, proceeding as it does from a metaphysical principle from which it derives all its reality, translates or expresses that principle in its own fashion and in accordance with its own order of existence, so that from one order to another all things are linked together and correspond in such a way as to contribute to the universal and total harmony, which, in the multiplicity of manifestation, can be likened to a reflection of the principia! unity itself.

To summarize:

> The laws of a lower domain can always be taken to symbolize realities of a higher order, wherein resides their own profoundest cause; which is at once their principle and their end.

Posted on 2022-02-15 by Cologero

* * *

`TSP on 2022-05-26 at 12:04 said:`

I read something in Guenon's "The Spiritist Fallacy" that has given me serious pause. He denies the astral form and in this he goes against not only Valentin Tomberg, Franz Bardon, the UR Group (see the essay on the "diaphanous body" in "Introduction to Magic Volume II"), but

also Fr. Seraphim Rose. In the section "Astral Projection" in "The Soul After Death", Fr. Rose clearly states that not only is astral projection possible, but that some of the realms one can visit are just as perceptible as our own (which idea is also found in Bardon's work and others). Guenon will have none of this, insisting that the entire notion of the astral plane is a mere caricature and misunderstanding of the subtle state.

I understand that matters such as "astral projection" are of little import as regards the ultimate goal of Gnosis or Moksha; the issue is rather that I can't understand how Guenon could make such a serious error in metaphysics. I am wondering if he ever rectified this elsewhere as he did with regards to his original view of Buddhism, or if he ever at least explained more clearly why he took issue with the idea of the astral form and did not equate it with the soul or subtle body as did Tomberg, Bardon, et al.

Cologero on 2022-05-27 at 08:28 said:

You really did your homework, TSP, to get into the weeds like that. Well, you made me look.

I'd prefer to think that G is being overly polemical and his real goal was to move away from the overly materialistic views of those spiritists. It helps a little to compare that text to Man and his Becoming.

G did not deny the subtle states so objections to a "subtle body" or "astral body" seem overly pedantic. In the dream state, they appear as bodies to me, but certainly not as corporeal bodies. I get his point, though. I've heard of experiments that tried to "weigh" the soul as it left the body at death. Such a notion is absurd, although I've known people who believe such things. I believe that is the type of thing Guenon is objecting to.

Obviously, G cannot and does not deny Taijasa, which he discusses on page 97. I think if you read that section, you will find all the phenomena that you mention.

8.6 The Divine Journey

A few weeks ago, a young friend was in town. He told me that *Men among the Ruins*, and *Ride the Tiger* were his constant companions, making a large impact on his worldview. Curiously, he then told me that Guenon's *Man and his Becoming* left him cold. Unfortunately for his worldview, Julius Evola wrote this:

> Guenon's *Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta* will draw the attention of the well trained and qualified reader. Of

> course, it will also become the source of misunderstandings for a certain category of "third rate" critics and intellectuals who oscillate between platitudes and political and spiritual fancies.

I hope my friend will read this article and then proceed on his way to becoming well trained and qualified, but usually sentimentalism supersedes intellect. So the point of a review is to entice readers to return to the original work. There is a reason for it, as Evola explains:

> It is only natural that those readers who have followed Guenon's critique [of the modern world] are now curious to learn about the positive counterpart, consisting of the values and doctrines to be opposed to those of the modern world. It is only natural that these readers wish to know what is this 'tradition' and the 'traditional spirit' so greatly emphasized by Guenon, and which he considers to be the presupposition of any genuine reconstructive work.

Hence, despite Guenon's densely written prose, it is worth the effort to unpack this text. Never forget that Guenon is the master and Evola builds on that foundation, elaborating on his own specific interests. Nevertheless, it should be assumed that Guenon accepts this work, unless he explicitly offers an objection.

Since we have recently been alluding to states of being, the path of the initiate, and postmortem states, we will start near the end with *Chapter XXI: The Divine Journey of the Being on the Path of Liberation*. The final stages of this path assume that a man has reached a certain stage in development symbolized by the coronal artery (*sushumna*) at the crown of the head and connected by a ray to the spiritual Sun. For casual readers, we



point out here that any astronomical or elemental symbolism is not to be understood in the material sense.

The being must then follow the way marked by the path of this ray and retracing it back to its source, which is also identical with its destination. We can point out here, in passing, that this is also the esoteric meaning of the stories of Genesis and Exodus, which is repeated in Tradition: it represents the journey from the source to the fall, then to exile in the West and finally the return back to the source. Guenon reminds us that religious conceptions are capable of a transposition to a higher and deeper meaning, something we should always look for instead of rejecting exoteric teachings out of hand (or even accepting their basest interpretation).

This chapter does not deal with the *jivan-mukti*, that is, the being who achieves Deliverance in the human state, but rather with two types of beings:

1. Beings who obtain Deliverance on leaving the human state
2. Beings who pass into other states of individual manifestation

There are, therefore, two corresponding paths:

1. Path of the Gods (*devayana*)
2. Path of the Ancestors (*pitriyana*)

Note that these two paths do not exhaust all the options for postmortem existence. Keep in mind, too, that these paths concern the subtle states of the being, which are still formal and individual, although the corporeal state is no longer part of the being.

Although there are some differences in the order or names of the stages, it may be helpful to compare this to the diagram in Spiritual Beings.

Path of the Ancestors Some will recognize this from the descriptions of the way of the ancestors in our series on the Ancient City. Its symbols are: Smoke, night, waning moon, the sun descending to the south. This path is restricted to the Sphere of the Moon[12]. Thus, the being is not set free from form or individuality.

The *Sphere of the Moon* represents Cosmic Memory, or the Akashic Record. This is because it is inhabited by the beings of the preceding cycle, who then generate the current cycle. As forms complete the full course of their development, they are dissolved, becoming the germs of undeveloped forms. The end of one state is always the beginning of another.

Thus the being ends one state of existence and begins a new one as an individual in a world of form. Since a being does not occupy the same state twice, the new form does not exist in this world at a later date, as a crude understanding of reincarnation would have it. Nevertheless, it will be in a state of existence, perhaps similar to this one, depending on the possibilities attained in the previous state of existence. This idea is more fully developed in the *Symbolism of the Cross*.

The Lunar Sphere separates the higher, non-individual, states from the lower. This is what separates the two paths. Guenon points to the Litany of the Virgin[13] as representing this division, where we read,

> Who is she that comes forth as the morning rising, fair as the moon, bright as the sun, terrible as an army set in battle array?
>
> Song of Solomon 6:10

Path of the Gods This path represents those who tend toward Union never to return to manifested existence. Its symbols are: Fire, light, day-

[12] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sublunary_sphere

[13] https://www.nashvilledominican.org/prayer/litanies/litany-of-the-blessed-virgin-mary/

time, waxing moon, the sun ascending to the north.

In Vedic symbolism, after leaving the Earth or the world of gross manifestation, i.e., at death, the being is led to the Realm of light, or Fire, ruled by Agni. Then the being is led through the different stages of the *devatas*. In Western symbolism, these stages are said to be ruled by angels. Note, too, that the principle of each stage is personified by a supernatural being. This is not at all insignificant.

Guenon points out that other traditions describe this path and he specifically names the Egyptian Book of the Dead, the Tibetan Bardo Thodol and the Alexandrian Gnostic text Pistis Sophia. He suggests a concordance be written between these texts. 80 years later, this has not yet been done by anyone. We would add to this concordance Ibn Arabi's Meccan Revelations and Dante's Divine Comedy.

As he progresses, the being effectively identifies with the center of the Personality, losing all individual concerns. The effective realization of each state is obtained through identification with the principles of the state. Theoretical knowledge is only a preparation. Transition from one stage to the next is possible only after effective knowledge of the stage. As formless, the being may pass to a Deva or angelic state.

The penultimate stage is the principle of Being, represented by Ishwara. At this point there is no longer any subtle state and the being is in an unmanifested state. The center of the being is identified with the center of all the worlds; this is the same as the fundamental analogy between the macrocosm and the microcosm. This would persist until the end of the cycle. In Western terms, this is equivalent to Heaven.

Final Deliverance is beyond Being, Infinity[14], comprising Being and non-Being. That is why Guenon's Deliverance is usually called non-dual awareness. The being is liberated from the conditions of individual human existence and well as all other limiting conditions.

[14] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3261

Theoretical Preparation Guenon provides us with the theoretical preparation for the path; to become gnosis, a man must realize it fully in his heart. Being and Knowing are one. It helps to think about or meditate on these ideas constantly until your entire worldview is permeated with them. Along with that, there is knowing one's true Self, or Atman. This is beyond the individual and is never manifested as such. A question to ponder is:

What is constant and unchanging in every act of consciousness?

Posted on 2012-08-23 by Cologero

* * *

Sparrow on 2015-03-14 at 02:48 said:

I've been reading a bit about Guenon's view of what happens after death, and while it's logically consistent, I can't really see any reason it's true and the common understanding of reincarnation is false. Almost all ancient teachings that I can recall (Bhagavad Gita, Myth of Er, Bardo Thodol, etc.) don't even come close to suggest a being passes into another state of existence on another plane, never to return to this one. It seems that the opposite case is near universal. While I would be willing to accept that by the fifth century B.C., the ancient teachings had already devolved into reincarnation, Guenon explicitly states this is not the case and that the ancients held the view of transmigration how he describes it.

8.7 Multiple States of the Human Being

> Thou hast ordered all things in measure and number and mass.
>
> Wisdom of Solomon 11:20

> A science was less esteemed for itself than for the degree in which it expressed after its own fashion and represented within a certain order of things a reflection of the higher immutable truth which anything of any reality necessarily partakes of.
>
> Rene Guenon, *East and West*

Namarupa Moving on from Vaisesika to Advaita Vedanta, particularly as explained by **Adi Shankara**, we will focus on the teachings on the world of nature. Namarupa, literally meaning "name and form" constitute an object or being. They correspond to the intelligible and sensible aspects, or, in different words, "form and matter" or "essence and substance". This shows why English is a poor language to express metaphysical concepts, since the words are not precise — "form" is used in two different senses.



Figure 8.1: Ancient of Days

Nevertheless, this concept is identical to Platonism and Scholasticism, which represent the peak metaphysics of the ancient and medieval Europeans. The point is that our experience includes the senses as well as thought. The experience is incomplete until the mind makes a judgment about what it is. Although the senses and thought are not one, there is no dualism of thought and extension in the Cartesian sense: it is nondual.

Everything that exists, has name and form. Physics, then, is the study of the world of matter, i.e., "becoming", and Metaphysics, then, is the study of the world of ideas or essences, i.e., "being". Apart from Adam, who was infused with an intuition of essences (he "named" the animals), we start with the senses and move on from there to an understanding of ideas. Hence, we can accept physics while rejecting the claim that science is the sole and exclusive form of knowing. Rather, properly understood, physics can illustrate metaphysical principles.

It is pointless to denigrate modern science, since the technological consequences of physics are all too evident all around us, for better or worse. Human flourishing cannot depend on the revival of "traditional" sciences like chiromancy ("palm reading") or astrology. I have had my

palm read and my natal chart interpreted — good fun, but limited applicability.

Vladimir Solovyov had a deeper understanding of things, as described in *The development of mind*[15]. Science, philosophy, and theology are three forms of knowing, at increasing depths. Since, as Guenon claimed, time is not neutral, but is qualitative. This means that events occur at time periods that is proper for them, not at random or without sufficient reason. Hence, the notion of development in time a necessary consequence.

Elements The elements and their properties in Advaita are basically same as in the Vaisesika system, since both orthodox schools follow the Upanishads. These elements are qualitative and therefore not part of physics. Nevertheless, as was shown in the case of the element fire or light, it does have real world effects. Another example is the element Akasha, or ether, which fills empty space. Einstein famously rejected the existence of the ether since he understood it only in terms of physical matter. However, the Void, i.e., "empty space", is not a possibility of manifestation. Nature abhors a vacuum. So we should not be surprised when physics find that the so-called vacuum is actually quite busy. See *The Vacuum State*[16], for example.

Atomism and Continuity God has ordered all things by measure, number, and mass. For the first two, we have these relationships:

Measure = geometry = continuous

Number = arithmetic = discrete or atomistic

Measure, as continuous, can be indefinitely divided. On the other hand, atoms are the smallest parts which cannot be further divided. Vaisesika holds the atomistic view whereas Advaita claims the other. Which

[15] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3514

[16] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Vacuum_state

is correct, since both systems are orthodox? If we turn to physics, we see that both are true. For example,

1. Light is both a wave – that is, continuous – and a photon, that is, an atom of light

2. Electrons likewise act like waves or particles, depending on circumstance.

This can go on. Physics cannot explain this phenomenon, but metaphysics can.

States of Being Inorganic nature serves a purpose which lies beyond it; that is because it does not have its own self-organizing principle. The division of inorganic nature if somewhat arbitrary. Where does one mountain begin and another end? What are the precise boundaries of the oceans?

Organic things are likewise composed of the same elements as inorganic nature. In addition, a new principle comes into play: viz., the power of life. Life realizes a state of greater perfection through its power of realising an ideal. Here are examples of states of greater perfection, from lowest to highest.

- **Stone**. A stone does not live, since it has no tendency to become perfect, no inward inclination or strength to turn itself into a pillar or a statue.

- **Plant**. A plant lives. If placed in suitable conditions, it has the power to grow, put forth leaf and blossom, flower and fruit.

- **Animal**. An animal is capable of a fuller life than the plant. It sees, hears and feels, and also knows vaguely what it is about. Not only does it thrive in favourable conditions, but it goes out to find those conditions. It moves on purpose, while the plant does not.

- **Human**. The human being lives a much higher life. He is a reflective being, with understanding and will. He has the growing power of the plant, the moving and the sensing powers of the animal, as well as the power to pierce behind the veil, discriminate the eternal from the non-eternal, choose between good and evil.

- **Angelic states**. Men who realise their ambition are the gods.

- **Jivanmukta**. The realisation of the Supreme Identity or Beatific Vision. Someone who has achieved self-realisation.

Each state of being is ontologically different from the others. Just working out in the gym does not result in an ontological change, as some wannabe traditionalists have claimed. The human state encompasses all the lower states, but adds the intellectual soul. It should be obvious from the description that biology or evolutionary psychology cannot explain it.

The human state relies on rational thinking, which is sequential and therefore subject to time. When a man has realised his possibilities, he has reached an angelic state ("gods" as Radhakrishnan puts it). In this state, there is a direct understanding through intuition, which is immediate and beyond time. It is more like an "aha" experience than logical demonstration. This is the Edenic state, before the Fall. Thomas Aquinas describes it this way:

> In paradise man would have been like an angel in his spirituality of mind, yet with an animal life in his body.

He goes into more detail about angelic states in *Treatise of separate substances*[17].

[17] `https://isidore.co/aquinas/SubstSepar.htm`

Even beyond this state, there is the Beatific Vision, achieved by few. Aquinas elaborates on this description of the Beatific Vision or Supreme Identity:

> Man was happy in paradise but not with that perfect happiness to which he was destined, which consist in the vision of the Divine Essence.

Appendix The study of the metaphysics or the Hindu schools does not mean that we have to accept the mythologies of the Ramayana or Mahabharata, apart from the Bhagavad Gita.

As should be clear, the Medieval and Ancient metaphysics of the West are equivalent to that of the East. Westerners can study Eastern systems either to enrich or recover Western tradition. Those Westerners who fail to recognize this and instead embrace in toto those of the East typically show their misunderstanding of both.

Some unacknowledged quotations are from Indian Philosophy, Volume Two, by **Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan**.

Posted on 2020-06-21 by Cologero

* * *

`Draft Horse on 2020-06-24 at 03:05 said:`

A good post, but I think you write off the traditional sciences too readily, especially astrology.

In a "practical" sense, done properly it can identify a persons talents, and show them the most important days/times of their life, along with helping them avoid danger.

More importantly, it can facilitate in the astrologer (who is suitably disposed) an easier understanding of higher metaphysical principles, particularly the ones written about in Symbolism of the Cross. Then there is also the alchemical usages, hinted at by Evola in his book on the subject.

Of course astrology today has been co-opted by counter traditional forces, but it still has a capacity for higher use in the right hands, at least that's what I believe anyway.

So, in short, I think it does have a great value for people today, especially those who are on a spiritual path.

A minor point in your post, but it caught my attention.

`Cologero on 2020-06-28 at 09:54 said:`

I can't dispute your point in an absolute sense. Astrology at least recognizes that the time and place of one's birth is are necessary conditions of life, whereas the modern mind will typically consider them to be arbitrary and even unjust. Moreover, the planets are analogous to the subtle centers in the body. (See Oscar Hinze on Tantra Vidya[18]).

Whether there is benefit in a practical sense depends on the existence and availability of reliable astrologers.

8.8 On Being a Person

> The personality, let us insist once more, belongs essentially to the order of principles in the strictest sense of the word, that is, to the universal order; it cannot therefore be considered from any point of view except that of pure metaphysics, which has precisely the Universal for its domain.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Man and his Becoming*

Guenon noted:

> the conceptions of Aristotle are in complete agreement with those of the East.

With that in mind, we will use that as a guide to interpret not just Aristotle, but also Thomism as its extension. The goal is not to engage in an academic philosophical debate, but rather to explore how consciousness has altered from the Medieval period until now. We accept Owen Barfield's justification for focusing on Thomism:

[18] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8618`

> In the mind of Aquinas, with his enormous erudition, the whole corpus of medieval thought is in a manner recapitulated; and he is as sober as he is profound.

Person and Ego In this system, a human being is the individuation of a human essence into the corporeal world. That answers the question of "what" it is, but not who. Where then is the specific person, say Peter? Every substance has a *suppositum* or center which, in the case of rational beings, is called "Person" (or Self or Spirit). Hence, Peter as person is also an essence, i.e., an idea in the Divine Intellect (Buddhi). Guenon relates the Person to its manifestation:

> The personality is unmanifested, even insofar as it is regarded more especially as the principle of the manifested state

In practical terms, this means

- The Person always exists as the principle of manifestation
- The Person cannot be detected by any empirical, physical, or psychological test.

The Person transcends psychical and corporeal manifestation. You are not a "spirit in the world", rather, you are in the world but not of it. You cannot "contact" the higher self. Conclusion: every human is a Person, even if only virtually (i.e., unaware of his real nature).

Contemporary thinking confuses the Person with some psychological state, ignoring

> the fundamental distinction between the 'Self'. which is the very principle of the being, and the individual 'ego'.

The Self, or Person, as intellect, is in the spiritual realm whereas the Ego is part of manifestation. Although claiming a pedigree from Aristotle or Thomism, they are not comprehending its source. This is not a failure of a convincing argument, but rather of the inability of consciousness in a give state to even grasp it. Guenon here points out that Aristotle did grasp it:

> For Aristotle, pure intellect is of a transcendent order and can claim knowledge of universal principles as its proper object; this knowledge, which is not discursive in any respect, is acquired directly and immediately by intellectual intuition.

This directly acquired, not-discursive, knowledge is called "knowledge of the heart". This is opposed to a lower form of knowledge that is mediated by sensual images, or even thoughts:

> [Aristotle] said that man [as an individual] never thinks without image.

States of Being Contemporary philosophy restricts the Person to the human state, for the reason stated above: the Ego is assumed to be the Self. This is a failure to understand the medieval texts.

Dante, who claimed to be following Thomas, certainly knew other states of being. There are the subhuman states of hell, states in purgatory, and more famously, the transhuman states of the planetary, celestial, and angelic spheres. Ultimately, he was aware of heavenly states.

Metaphysical Realization In "The Eternal Ideas" from *Miscellanea*, Guenon brings up the common misunderstanding that there is a distinction between the possible and the real, by regarding the unmanifested possibilities as merely **virtual**. Guenon makes clear:

> There can be nothing virtual within the Principle but, on the contrary, only the permanent actuality of all things in an 'Eternal Now'. and it is this very actuality that constitutes the sole foundation of all existence.

The Self "always remains unmanifest, not being affected or modified by any contingency."

This clearly indicates that there is no psychological explanation of the Self because it transcends all phenomenal reality. The Self remains virtual, that is, a mere intellectual concept, until there is a consciousness of oneself as that Self. G concludes:

> From the moment one recognizes that the existence of manifested beings in all their positive reality can only be a participation in principial Being, there cannot be the slightest doubt about this matter. … **What is virtual is not our reality within the Principle, but only the awareness we may have of it as manifested beings**, which is obviously something quite different; and *it is only through metaphysical realization that this awareness of our true being, which is beyond and above all becoming can become effective*, that is actualized in the awareness … an awareness of that which we really are principially and eternally, and *this is in the most absolutely real sense possible*.

Barfield explains it this way:

> Participation ceases to be conscious precisely because we cease to attend to it. … participation does not cease to be a fact because it ceases to be conscious. It merely ceases to be what I have called 'original' participation.

The corollary is that ignorance is just "forgetting", we cease to be conscious of what we know. As the following discussion shows, we can even

be ignorant of our true Self. So **virtual** does not mean **unreal**, rather it is tantamount to unawareness or, in Barfield's term, unrepresented. Yet what is virtual still exists, one is simply unaware of it.

So the more you can become conscious of, the closer you are to, the true Self. Don't forget.

Posted on 2021-09-30 by Cologero

8.9 Principles of Manifestation

If cosmology is the study of the origin, nature, and destiny of the universe, there have been many conflicting theories. In the West, the basis of cosmology has been what is called the **Great Chain of Being**. In various versions, it has formed the worldview of educated people until recently. The dominance of profane science has done much to discredit it, even to the point that exoteric spiritual teachings not only neglect it, but in effect oppose it. This often has less to do with science than with ideology.

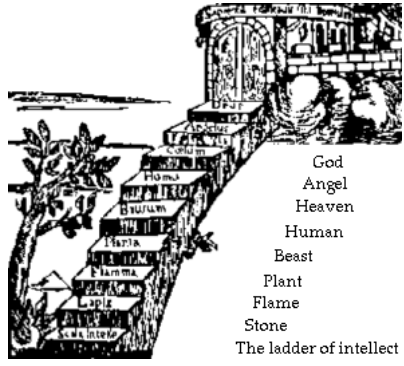


Figure 8.2: Great Chain of Being

The Great Chain of Being is based on certain Traditional metaphysical principles. These need to be made clear, but first the implicit principles of modernity must be made clear.

Profane Worldview In its most consistent form, the modern worldview is based on the notion that the origin, nature, and destiny of the universe can be fully explained in terms of matter and energy. Obviously,

this worldview denies that there is a world of Being ontologically prior to, and superior to, the world of Becoming. Profane science needs to explain:

1. How emergent properties such as life, mind, consciousness, emotions, thought, in short, interiority, evolve from material and exterior processes.

2. How higher order systems are constructed from more basic elements.

Thus far, science has no answer to issue (1), not even a plausible theory. Issue (2) is often hidden in popular discourse. Profane science is committed to reductionism, viz., higher order systems are fully explicable by more fundamental elements. By denying the existence of essences or forms, the task of science is to define higher systems; in its most consistent philosophical expressions, these are mere "social constructs".

Evolution and Involution **Rene Guenon** explains that there are five conditions of manifestation: space, time, form (or essences), matter, and life. The opposite of "evolution" is not creation science, or even intelligent design, but rather involution[19].

Evolution is the notion that simple things evolve into complex structures caused by random variations over time. Involution is the notion that ideal essences are brought into manifestation by a will. Depending on the strength of the will, the existing being will be a better or worse copy of its ideal.

Essences unfold in space and time, thus appearing to be evolving (evolve = unfold), but really involving. For example, Beethoven's Ninth Symphony is an "idea" or essence. However, to be experienced, musicians and instruments are necessary for the symphony to unfold in time.

[19] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=6261`

Profane science has nothing to offer. It makes no sense to say that the first movement "causes" the final movement. A fortiori, it is risible to try to experience or understand the symphony from an analysis of its individual notes.

Hence, Guenon claims that the higher order system defines its components, rather than the other way around. The other point is that "life" is prior to matter. So, in a sense, everything is "alive", that is, it has interiority. Hence, esoterism understands the cosmos as an interior process, unlike an astronomer who takes the opposite approach.

The Idea of the Good Plato understood God to be the Idea of the Good. Hence, man's goal is to passively contemplate the Good. The Christian notion of God as Love builds on that, since Love means to will the good. It is a revealed truth that the created world is "good", so the good is whatever has more being. The goodness of God, then, is His creative activity. So to be godlike is also to be creative, in the sense of bringing essences into manifestation. The gap between the essence and its existence is privation, i.e., "evil".

Rationality and Intellectuality Rationality is the quality that distinguishes man from animals; intellectuality distinguishes God from man. Rationality involves dualist thinking, but intellectuality is non-dual. It is not irrational, but rather super-rational. Any attempt to conceive of God's knowledge and will in rational terms will fail. For example, I read on a web site a few months back the claim that "God knows all true propositions." Not at all, God knows the Divine ideas directly and non-dually, not as propositions. He "knows" the world because He created it. There is not duality of essence and existence for God.

Similarly for the Divine Will, there is no distinction between freedom and necessity. God does not "deliberate", choosing this or that, but rather whatever exists is the expression of his Goodness. Some will claim

that God cannot do things like creating a square circle. It is better to understand that as a possibility of non-manifestation. There are four such possibilities.

1. **Analytic**. The definition contains a self-contradiction (as in the example above).

2. **Synthetic**. The contradiction is not in the definition. "A colored thing must also be extended."

3. **Physical**. The human frame has an upper limit, since as an increase in height is linear, the increase in mass is cubic. Hence, the skeletal structure will not be able to support that weight.

4. **Compossibility**. Certain possibilities of manifestation cannot manifest in the same place or time

The loss of intellectuality in the modern world has consequences. First of all, rationality tries to take its place; it is doomed to failure. The next step is that emotionality, i.e., the subrational, as a sort of non-dual experience, usurps the place of true non-dual intellectuality. Hence, Love is understood not as the creative Will to being, but rather in a sentimental and humanitarian way as compassion and the alleviation of suffering.

The modern mind misunderstands evil and thinks there is a "problem of evil" to be explained. However, the teaching is that creation is good, so that the world of good and evil that we experience is the creation of man. If the cheetah chases the gazelle, the result is good for the cheetah since it increase his being, but bad for the gazelle since his being is ended; however, there is no question of "evil" in that scenario. On the contrary, it is good that the gazelle was given being in the first place.

Principle of Plenitude In the *Multiple States of Being*, Rene Guenon showed that the Absolute must also be Infinite, that is, the number of possibilities is unbounded. He formulated the Principle of Plenitude as "All possibilities of manifestation must be manifested."

This accounts for the immense variety in the world. Every creature has its place in the chain, or scale, of being. It is irrational to expect everything to be the same, so the scale is hierarchically arranged. Moreover, there are many more scales of being than the one that describes our world.

Principle of Continuity A related principle is the Principle of Continuity, described in the *Metaphysical Principles of Infinitesimal Calculus*. The gaps in the scale become arbitrarily small. Thus, we see that a taxonomic problem arises in biology, since it can become difficult to distinguish between closely related species and subspecies. Hence, there is no absolute definition of a species. That problem is insoluble as long as biological and material considerations are the only criteria used. In such a case, definitions are considered arbitrary social constructs.

Of course, the Traditional view is different. These close differences nevertheless reflect different essences in the Divine mind. Proper classifications will have to take the soul and spiritual elements (i.e., "interiority") into account. Hence, the differences are real, no matter how close they may appear. There are some further points that can be derived from this principle, although they cannot be fully developed in this post:

- The attempt to refute Darwinian evolution by pointing to "missing links" in the fossil record (yes, the term is derived from the Great Chain of Being) is actually anti-Traditional.
- The Great Chain of Being is a simplification. It is better represented as scales within scales.
- **Otto Weininger** in *Sex and Character* defines the ideal masculine and feminine qualities. However, they don't manifest in a strictly

binary way, but rather on a scale ranging from absolute femininity to absolute masculinity.

- Intellectual movements always ramify into two competing camps whenever the possibility of a dispute arises. For example, a predestinarian Baptist church will give rise to a "free-will Baptist church". In other cases, movements will split by incorporating elements from other, often incompatible, movements. This is why all movements are prone to degeneration and inner conflict.

Posted on 2014-11-19 by Cologero

* * *

Constantine on 2014-11-19 at 14:25 said:

Reading through this article I felt something was missing. You make a good point fractal, what about energy (chi, prana…)?

Francesco on 2014-11-19 at 16:14 said:

Constantine: Imo, Qi can be handled under the five conditions of manifestation, some more than others Perhaps in the same way that Sophia is not a fourth hypostasism but the life shared in common by the trinity; Qi is not another condition, but something shared commonly among form, matter, and life.

In Chinese metaphysics, there are a great number of "Qis": human body qi (then specific organ and system qi types), cosmological qi (astrology), environmental qi (feng shui), and so on. To see how better how this concept is subsumed in the five conditions, we might consider the famous Chinese character for Qi–which is a pot of rice gruel cooking, with steam raising from the vessel lid–it is interpreted as "it moves", or "acts".

The Classics explain "Qi is the commander of Blood; Blood is the mother of Qi", and that "Qi follows where the Shen (consciousness) leads".

Cologero on 2014-11-19 at 17:37 said:

@Constantine: "Matter is condensed energy and energy is condensed consciousness."

Valentin Tomberg

8.10 Cosmic Environment

In *The Great Triad,* **Rene Guenon** discusses the circumstances and environment in which a given being manifests. First of all, the cosmic environment is a unity, as he writes:

> The cosmic environment can only be conceived of as a whole of which each part is linked to every other part without any break in continuity. To try to conceive of it otherwise would be to assume the existence of a void, but this is not a possibility of manifestation and can have no place in the Cosmos.

The following assertion is difficult to accept on strictly material and physical terms. The Self chooses the environment. This is radically contrary to the existentialists like Heidegger who claims that we are "thrown into the world" somehow by accident and against our will. Guenon says the opposite:

> It is the individual being itself which by its own nature determines the specific conditions of its manifestation.

The entire modern world denies that there is any such nature; they call such a view "essentialism". So birth, to them, is a matter of "luck", something purely arbitrary. That is because they don't take into account that heredity is not just corporeal, but also subtle, as Guenon explains:

> If we take the case of heredity, we can say that there is not only a physiological heredity, but also a psychic heredity. The two kinds of heredity have exactly the same explanation, both being due to the presence in a person's make-up of elements derived from the particular environment into which the individual was born. In the case of the individual human state, it is obvious that the environmental elements will belong to the different modalities of that

> specific state: that is, some will be corporeal, others subtle or psychic. A person's make-up of elements derived from the particular environment into which the individual was born.

These modalities, then, will include the following elements:

- **Physical**: This includes the material elements of the environment, including DNA.
- **Etheric**: This level includes all the life forces in the environment. Together with the next level, they make up the biosphere.
- **Astral**: This includes all the elements of sentient life
- **Noetic**: This modality includes the intellectual currents of the environment. This is called the Noosphere.

Nevertheless, these physiological and psychical influences do not determine the human being. Guenon makes this clear:

> The two terms represent only the superficial and external aspects of the manifested being and are no more than simple modalities of one and the same state of existence — the state of existence represented by the horizontal plane. In short, the physiological and the psychic are just as contingent as each other, and the true being is beyond them both.

That has consequences. Every being is related to every other being, either diachronically or synchronically.

> In reality these influences extend much further; indeed we can say quite literally and without the slightest exaggeration that they extend indefinitely in every possible direction. In fact the *cosmic environment*, which is the domain of the state of manifestation

> we are considering, can only be conceived of as a whole of which each part is linked to every other part without any break in continuity. To try to conceive of it otherwise would be to assume the existence of a 'void'. but this is not a possibility of manifestation and can have no place in the Cosmos. It follows that there must necessarily be relationships — which is basically to say that there must be reciprocal actions and reactions — between all the individual beings which are manifested in this domain, either simultaneously or successively.

Affinity This implies that the being, when entering the human state, chooses the environment that best suits its nature.

> A being's situation in the environment is in the last analysis determined by the nature of that particular being, and the elements which it takes from its immediate surroundings, as well as the elements — both subtle and corporeal — which it draws to itself from the indefinite totality of its particular domain of manifestation, will necessarily correspond in some way to that nature.

And he continues:

> Here we have the explanation for that 'affinity' which dictates that a being coming into manifestation will only take from the environment whatever conforms with the possibilities which it bears within itself, and which belong to it alone and to no other being. In other words, as a result of this conformity it will take whatever is necessary to provide the contingent conditions which will allow these possibilities to develop or 'actualise' themselves in the course of its individual manifestation.

Two Connected Beings The highest level of affinity is when two beings find that they belong to each other in a very special way. They can

only actualize all their possibilities when they have support from each other. They are meant to be together from all eternity, no matter what obstacles are put in their paths.

> For any relationship between two beings to be real it must necessarily be the expression of something inherent in the natures of both. So, the influence that a being might appear to undergo from the outside and to receive from another being is never anything else, when looked at from a more profound point of view, than a sort of translation in relation to the environment of a possibility inherent in the nature of the being itself.

Summary To sum up: the being manifests at the point of the intersection of the vertical and horizontal axis, the former being the Self and the latter the environment in which he works out his possibilities of manifestation.

> In the first instance this individual nature proceeds or originates from what the being is in itself. In the second instance it proceeds from the sum total of the influences exerted on it by the environment in which it manifests. The first element represents the inward or active side of the being; the second its outward or passive side.

Posted on 2022-02-17 by Cologero

8.11 Language of the Birds

> And Solomon succeeded David. He said, "O people, we were taught the **language of birds**, and we were given from everything. This is indeed a real blessing."

Quran 27:16



Rene Guenon showed that the *Language of the Birds*[20] refers to communication with the higher states of the being. The Birds are symbols of the angels, or to be precise, of the higher states of being. A symbol is much deeper than an allegory. An allegory is a mechanical operation, just transposing one set of ideas to another on the same plane of existence. A symbol reaches into higher planes; it says something that could not be said any other way. Its secret is revealed in different ways for different traditions that refer to the language of the birds.

Secret Language In the sacred sciences like alchemy and magic, the Language of the Birds was a secret and perfect language, providing the key to perfect knowledge. John Dee made the association explicit: the Enochian language received from the angels was also the Language of the Birds.

Immortality Sigfried slew the dragon and tasted its flesh, which gave him the ability to learn the language of the birds. He smeared himself with dragon's blood, making his skin invulnerable, that is to say, he gained immortality. Guenon explains the symbolism:

> Victory over the dragon has, as its immediate consequence, the conquest of immortality, which is represented by some object the approach to which is guarded by the dragon; and this conquest essentially implies the reintegration into the center of the human state, that is, into the point where communication is established with the higher states of the being.

Manifesting Possibilities

[20] https://www.gornahoor.net/library/The_Language_of_the_Birds.pdf

> The Kingdom of Heaven is like a grain of mustard seed which a man took and sowed in his field; it is the smallest of all seeds, but when it has grown it is the greatest of shrubs and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and make nests in its branches.
>
> MATT 13:31-32

Guenon explains the symbolism of the Kingdom of Heaven:

- The growing of the tree is the manifestation of possibilities
- The birds of the air represent the higher states of the being

The Observer The *Mundaka Upanishad*[21] expresses the language in this passage:

> Two birds, inseparably united companions, dwell in the same tree; the one eats of the fruit of the tree, while the other looks on without eating.
>
> *Mundaka Upanishad* III.1

- The first bird is jivatma, who is involved in the realm of action.
- The second bird is the unconditioned Self, which observes

Spiritual Battle The combat between Garuda, the Eagle, and the serpent Naga, symbolizes the spiritual battle between the Devas and the Asuras.

[21] `https://www.wisdomlib.org/hinduism/book/mundaka-upanishad-shankara-bhashya`

Angels How then can we understand the angelic language? **Pavel Florensky**, in *The Meaning of Idealism*, clears up the relationship between the symbol and reality. The religious symbolism of the most ancient religions comes to life when we view it in the light of the fourth dimension. Those stuck in the world of three dimensions cannot understand the symbols. Florensky explains:

> Ideas, the Mothers of all existing things, live in the depth direction of our three-dimensional world, and therefore all speech regarding them remain nothing more the "the jabbering gibberish of the Parcae".

There is, therefore, no transcendent vantage point to "see" them, apart from the "birds eye view". Things seem to be what they appear to be, but we miss the intelligence, the *genii*, behind them. That is, we can't see the genus or archetype of the thing. Otherwise, we would experience them like this:

> [The ideas] are not images of gods but are the very consciousness of gods and demons appearing to initiates in the mysteries. Here we have gained entrance into the holy of holies of Plato's philosophy, where eidos and idea become concrete and full of life as well as transcendent.

Since the angels are pure intelligences, they are experienced in the Intellect, the higher thinking faculty. They are the source of the higher gnosis that we experience, i.e., the superconscious; the demons are the source of lower thoughts arising from the subconscious.

The higher that the angel is in the hierarchy, the more he can be understood in fewer thoughts. There is a constant battle against the chaos of the serpent. If the inner chaos is stilled, then, and only then, can the Language of the Birds be understood.

> I think silence and the prolongation of sound is the same thing in terms of space. The only difference is that there is either the presence or absence of sound. More important is whether the space is "living" or not. Our [Japanese] sense of time and space is different from that of the West. For example, in the Shinto religion, there is the term 'imanaka' which is not just the present moment which lies between the stretch of past eternity and future immortality, but also the manifestation of the moment of all time which is multi-layered and multi-dimensional .... I would like it if the listener could abandon all previous conceptions of time and experience a new sense of time presented in this music as if eternal time can be lived in a single moment.
>
> Somei Satoh

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EE9V9TbPCBQ`

Posted on 2022-05-08 by Cologero

* * *

`Balder on 2022-05-16 at 13:55 said:`

I started thinking that could perhaps Odin's eagle and the hawk Vedfolnir play the same role as those birds mentioned in the Mundaka Upanishad? The hawk Vedfolnir is said to sit between the eyes of the unnamed eagle, and they both perch on top of the Yggdrasil. I find it difficult to interpret the hawk between the eyes of the eagle, but it might say the same thing the relationship between the two birds, namely Atma and jivatma. The eagle has been associated with Jupiter which I relate to Atma, but the hawk Vedfolnir doesn't seem to have any (traditionally atttested) planetary correspondence. This might be a procrustean attempt, but scholars have yet speculated that the Norse cosmology would have been influenced by the cosmologies of the East, and I think it is well attested that there is an Indo-European connection going back to pre-history.

I have enjoyed this spring time quite a lot by sitting in my balcony and listening to the singing of birds. I have made a habit to draw a weekly rune, and yesterday it was Algiz / Elhaz which is connected with swans, and in the night I listened to the sound of swans migrating back to the North for summer.

8.12 Enoch's Elevation to Heaven

> When Enoch had lived sixty-five years, he became the father of Methuselah. Enoch walked with God after the birth of Methuselah three hundred years, and had other sons and daughters. Thus all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years. Enoch walked with God; and he was not, for God took him.
>
> Genesis 5:21-24

> By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death; and he was not found, because God had taken him. Now before he was taken he was attested as having pleased God.
>
> Hebrews 11:5

> And the same blessing was bestowed upon Ismail and Enoch and Zul-Kifl, because they all practised fortitude.
>
> The Prophets, 21:85

> And remember Enoch in the Book; he was indeed very truthful, a Prophet. And We lifted him to a lofty station.
>
> Mary 19:56–57

Enoch walked with God and was not. That is because he was taken directly up to Heaven without experiencing death. In *The Bezels of Wisdom*, **Ibn Arabi** describes two ways that the elevation to Heaven can be understood: in terms of place or in terms of rank or degrees.

> Elevation has two references — one of place and one of rank. Elevation of place is "We raised him up to a high place," (19:57) and the highest of places is that upon which the mill of the world of

> the spheres revolves. It is the sphere of the sun and in it is the station of the spirituality of Enoch, peace be upon him! There are seven heavens under it and seven heavens above it, and it is the fifteenth. That which is above it is the red heaven, i.e., Mars, the heaven of Jupiter, Saturn, the heaven of fixed stars, the Starless Heaven and the heaven of the constellations, the heaven of the Kursi and the heaven of the Arsh. That which is below it is the heaven of Venus, Mercury, the Moon, the circle of ether, the circle of air, the circle of water, and the circle of earth. It is the axis of the heavens, and it is a "high place".

Union of Opposites Esoteric teaching is non-dual, and looks for the common principle that underlies disparate phenomena. That is because God, the ultimate principle of everything existing, is One.

> one only has gnosis by joining opposites together in respect of Him. "He is the First and the Last, the Outwardly Manifest and the Inwardly Hidden." He is the source of what appears and the source of what is hidden in the state of its manifestation. There is none who sees Him other than Him and there is none who is hidden from Him. So He is manifest to Himself and hidden from Himself.



Figure 8.3: Enoch's Elevation

Forms in nature may be similar in one respect, yet differ in another. The are both the outward manifestations. Man is in the image of God, and reflects back like a mirror. Mirrors have differing qualities. A purified and cleansed mirror will reflect more precisely than a dusty or smudged

mirror. Nevertheless, the Inwardly Hidden is One but the mirrors are multiple.

> the world of nature is composed of forms in one mirror. Rather, it is one form in different mirrors.

Gnosis and Deeds

> The deed demands place and knowledge demands rank.

The exoterics believe that elevation is a place and a reward for their deeds. As a place, there is no place higher than the Throne of God. For the highest degree, there is nothing but God. Elevation is not due to one's essence, but to one's knowledge. Hence, elevation is by rank, not place. Nevertheless, rank, on Earth, is based on authority, whether or not he is worthy of it.

> The most knowledgeable of people can be ruled by the person with the position of power, even if that person is the most ignorant of people.

His rank has no permanence, and ends with his retirement.

> The one with knowledge is not like that.

The Heavenly Spheres In the *Meditation on Enoch*, Ibn Arabi identifies 15 spheres or "heavens". The Sun is Enoch's station of spirituality, with seven above it and seven below. The vision is heliocentric, since all the spheres revolve around the Sun. He then discusses whether these spheres refer to "place" or to degrees of existence. For those rewarded by deeds, they seem to be places. For the gnostic—the man of knowledge—they are degrees of existence.

1. The Throne (Kursi, 'Arsh) (Empyrean)

2. Zodiac (Primum Mobile)
3. Starless Heaven (crystalline sphere)
4. Fixed stars (firmament)
5. Saturn
6. Jupiter
7. Mars
8. Sun (around which the others revolve)
9. Venus
10. Mercury
11. Moon
12. Ether
13. Air
14. Water
15. Earth

Note, too, Dante's description of his Ascent to Heaven.

Posted on 2021-05-29 by Cologero

8.13 Living in the Real World

> I turned myself to other things, and I saw the oppressions that are done under the sun, and the tears of the innocent, and they had no comforter; and they were not able to resist their violence, being destitute of help from any. And I praised the dead rather than the living: And I judged him happier than them both, that is not yet born, nor hath seen the evils that are done under the sun.
>
> Ecclesiastes 4:1-3

The Three Worlds Tradition understands three worlds:

- The angelic or intelligible world, called the causal or Sivaloka in Hinduism
- The celestial, heavenly or mixed world, called subtle or Antarloka
- The sublunary or sensible world, called Bhuloka

The sensible world is a world of darkness. It is the least real, i.e., it has less being, than the other worlds. It is also the source of multiplicity. As Thomas Aquinas stated, *numerus stat ex parte materiae*, number comes out from the material part. Rene Guenon mentioned the consequences:

> Matter is essentially multiplicity and division; and this is why all that proceeds from matter can beget only strife and all manner of conflicts between peoples and between individuals. The deeper one sinks into matter, the more the elements of division and opposition gain force and scope; and, on the other hand, the more one rises towards pure spirituality, the nearer one approaches to that unity which can only be fully realized by consciousness of the universal principles.

Corporeal World The corporeal or sensible world is that which is perceived by the senses. It integrates quantity from matter, or substance, with qualia from essence. It is considered to be the lowest of the three worlds. This is described in Hinduism as:

> The physical plane, or Bhuloka, is the world of gross or material substance in which phenomena are perceived by the five senses. It is the most limited of worlds, the least permanent and the most subject to change.

Since it is impermanent and subject to change, our knowledge of it is merely opinion, or the most likely story. Therefore, attempts to found our knowledge on science will always be tentative, incomplete, and subject to revision. That is why debates about alternative scientific views, such as heliocentrism vs geocentrism, are ultimately irresolvable, assuming of course that the presentations are coherent and free of contradictions. Hence, it is unwise to base a worldview solely on science.

Some physicalists will dispute that the senses provide an accurate representation of reality. How would they know? Can they compare a subjective representation against "external reality" and give it a score? Of course not. The material part of the sensible world provides the context for sense experience, although the qualities themselves don't emanate from matter. Rather, they arise from essence of the thing.

If the various experiments of physicalists about consciousness show some anomalies, that just proves the point: the sensible world is unreliable and no more than a matter of opinion.

Size of the Universe All the whining about the age and size of the universe are nothing but sentimental intrusions into the facts. The existentialists will opine that the world is meaningless since the earth is "insignificant" among so many stars and period of time.

Adam in *Paradise Lost* wondered about the same thing, so it is hardly a new observation.

> When I behold this goodly Frame, this World
> Of Heaven and Earth consisting, and compute,
> Their magnitudes, this Earth a spot, a grain,
> An Atom, with the Firmament compared
> And all her numbered Stars, that seem to roll
> Spaces incomprehensible merely to officiate light
> How Nature wise and frugal could commit
> Such disproportions

The **Weak Anthropic Principle** relates the mass and the age of the universe. Its definition is:

> The observed values of all physical and cosmological quantities are not equally probable but they take on values restricted by the requirement that there exist sites where carbon-based life can evolve and by the requirement that the Universe be old enough for it to have already done so.

The size and age of the universe are related by the velocity of light, according to the theory of relativity. Just multiply the time by the velocity of light in order to get the distance. If an extended time period is necessary for the appearance of intelligent life, then the size of the universe would need to be correspondingly large (assuming of course that the Universe had a beginning).

The total mass of the universe can also be estimated. For example, if the universe contained just the Milky Way galaxy with 10^{11} stars, then the universe would stop expanding after one month, not long enough for planets and life to appear. Since God has determined the mass of the universe, we are assured that the size of the universe was chosen so that human beings can appear.

From the metaphysical perspective, everything necessarily manifests at the time and place appropriate for it; it is not a random event.

Animal Life

> The nature of animals was not changed by man's sin, as if those whose nature now it is to devour the flesh of others, would then have lived on herbs, as the lion and falcon. … Thus there would have been a natural antipathy between some animals.
>
> Thomas Aquinas

Since Life is one of the conditions of manifestation, Plant and Animal life are also part of the sensible world. That means they are wholly natural beings. Plants have a vegetative soul, or etheric body, and animals have that as well as a sensual soul. Besides the powers of plant life, animals add emotional life to being.

Lemurians

> The subtle plane, or Antarloka, is the mental-emotional sphere that we function in through thought and feeling and reside in fully during sleep and after death. It is the astral world that exists within the physical plane. The astral plane is for the most part exactly duplicated in the physical plane.

A human being is a "rational animal". That means he is both an animal, yet different from, and more than, an animal because of the rational or intellectual soul. The rational animal is not a type of animal, as, for example, a vertebrate is one type of animal.

Rational does not simply mean "intelligent" because even the animals display some intelligence, or the ability to solve sudoku puzzles. Rather it means the ability to choose rational ends, or the good. This entails having an ego or sense of "I". From the natural Darwinian point of view, that makes no sense. There is no way to conceive how abilities like the understanding of mathematics or the choice of good and evil could have

evolved. At most, all such behaviours should be explained by evolutionary psychology. But even that won't do, since as the physicist **Roger Penrose** demonstrated, the mind is not a computable process.

Nevertheless, physicalists and naturalists insist that the human being must be understood by science. The powers and abilities listed above are therefore considered to be just complex animal behaviours. So, on those premises a human being is metaphysically just an animal. For various reasons, let us use the term **Lemurian** to designate a being that in appearance looks human, but interiorly is just an animal. That is, a Lemurian has a physical body, etheric soul, and sensual soul, but not an intellectual soul nor a consistent sense of I.

This is compatible with some traditional and esoteric ideas that see the Lemurian as a stage in the development of a human being, properly so called. Even some contemporary philosophers assert the existence of such beings, at least in the past. But this is certainly a very constrained understanding of the human being. Nevertheless, the emotional soul today is almost universally considered to be what defines the human being. You may often hear talk about how animals behave almost "human", when the proper interpretation is to note how "animalistic" — not always meant in a bad way — humans behave. Emotional life is considered quintessentially human.

Human Beings

> But you are come to mount Sion, and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and to the company of many thousands of angels
>
> Hebrews 12:22

In the Heptaplus, **Pico della Mirandola** offers an interpretation of Genesis 1 as it applies to the human being. Heaven refers to the rational soul

and Earth to the physical body. But there is more. Below the rational soul, there is the sensual soul which is shared with the brutes, and above reason, there is an intelligence which is shared with the angels. These are separated by the waters. So the human lives fully neither in the corporeal world like the animals, nor in the intelligible world like the angels, but in the celestial world which is a mix of the darkness of the corporeal world and the light of the angelic world.

The Sun, moon, and stars refer to different light sources. The Sun represents dianoia, the knowledge of the rational soul, and the Moon is the light of doxa, that is, mere opinion. Pico explains:

> While we wander far from our fatherland and live in the night and darkness of this present life, we make most use of the part of us which is turned toward the senses, and hence *we believe more than we know*.

The Sun is the light of day and the moon of night. The stars are auxiliaries such as "the powers of combining and dividing, of reasoning and defining, etc." This is Moses' teaching on the nous. He next turns to the seats of anger (*thumos*) and wantonness (*epithumia*).

The brutes in Genesis then represent these inner aspects. Some desires pertain to the body and others to the imagination. When the desires for food and sex exceed what is required, they are used solely for pleasure. Paul said "make not provision for the flesh in its concupiscences" (Romans 13:14). These are represented by cattle and wild beasts which dwell on the earth.

The waters then pertain to the imagination and its impulses toward fame, anger, revenge and related feelings. When revenge is the urge for justice or fame for justified honours, these impulses are necessary and useful. However, when they become excessive, we turn something good into evil.

We then understand that dominion over the beasts means that Reason needs to dominate the senses and the imagination. "And man when

he was in honour did not understand; he is compared to senseless beasts, and is become like to them." (Psalms 48:13)

Act and Potency Essence in Aristotelean terms is Act, what we are meant to be, and Potency is our material and corporeal condition. This means that we are meant to actualise our potentials in this earthly life. These are the stages:

- Our sensible life is multiplicity, so we have multiple I's each claiming to be real and each sapping our psychic energy.
- Our rational soul needs to dominate all those pretenders and develop as stable self.
- Then it may be possible to develop a higher self that knows the intelligible world of ideas in the Mind of God.

As much as we are attached to the glamour of the sensible world, it is not our home. Our home is not to live amongst the brutes but rather amongst the angels.

Real Life

> God is light, and in him there is no darkness. If we say that we have fellowship with him, and walk in darkness, we lie, and do not the truth. But if we walk in the light, as he also is in the light, we have fellowship one with another, and the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin. If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just, to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all iniquity. If we say that we have not sinned, we make him a liar, and his word is not in us.
>
> 1 John 1:5-10

Acknowledgements *The Anthropic Cosmological Principle* by **John Barrow** and **Frank Tipler**
Triloka: The Three Worlds[22]
Heptaplus by **Pico Della Mirandola**

> In Lemurian times men walked the earth who had only a physical, and etheric and an astral body. But these were not men who could think, in the sense of today, or who could develop humanly — in the sense of today.
>
> Rudolf Steiner, *Spiritual Hierarchies*, Lecture VII

Posted on 2020-07-05 by Cologero

8.14 The Inferior States of the Being

> O put not your trust in princes, nor in any child of man, for there is no help in them.
>
> For when the breath of man goeth forth, he shall turn again to his earth, **and then all his thoughts perish**.
>
> Psalm 146:2-3)

In **Rene Guenon**'s metaphysical trilogy, the inferior states of the being are passed over without much comment. They are worth addressing here, as these will help us understand our interior life, as well as the Theological concept of Hell. Julius Evola spends some time describing these states in *Revolt Against the Modern World:*

[22] https://www.hinduismtoday.com/modules/smartsection/item.php?itemid=3432

> According to esoteric teachings, at the death of the body an ordinary person usually **loses his or her personality**, which was an illusory thing even while that person was alive. The person is then reduced to a shadow that is itself destined to be dissolved after a more or less lengthy period culminating in what was called "the second death." The essential vital principles of the deceased return to the totem, which is a **primordial, perennial, and inexhaustible matter**… the [infernal] path is that trodden by those who do not survive in a real way, and who slowly yet inexorably dissolve back into their original stocks… this is the life of Hades.
>
> *Revolt Against the Modern World, Ch. VIII*

These are the sub-individual states, spiraling ever downward to "substance" or Chaos. Here reside the Titans, the Cthonic gods of antiquity, and the vital forces of genus, species, and races. Just as the supra-individual states of formless manifestation transcend individuality in the direction of luminous, all-comprehending intelligence, so too are the sub-individual states non-individual, but in the opposite direction: toward the blind "forces" of the Waters, which make up the substance of all formal and non-formal manifestations.

To descend to the lower states means to reduce one's identity down to one of these sub-individual "forces", e.g., to identify only as a member of a race, a class, or with one's individual proclivities, sexual obsessions, etc. These are all forms of sub-human identity that dispense of the individuality, and entail real **identification** with such "forces" below.

Upon identification with these states, "reason" is lost, and the possibility of contact with the Personality is cut off. Free will is thus made effectively impossible, and the human being becomes instead the plaything of the blind forces of the Waters, spiraling indefinitely downward until the "second death" (Rev. 21:8).

King Lear Metaphysical teachings can seem dry and intellectual, unless we enliven them with imagination and experience. Shakespeare's *King Lear* can do just this service for us, if we take it as our guide through the lower states, akin to Dante's *Inferno*. The titular King Lear is a man who should be the supreme governor of his realm, but instead has lived poorly, and thus has gone mad in his old age. He embarks on a downward spiral that will lead to the ruin of his kingdom.

> GONERIL: You see how full of changes his age is; the observation we have made of it hath not been little…
>
> REGAN: 'Tis the infirmity of his age. Yet **he hath ever but slenderly known himself.**
>
> GONERIL: **The best and soundest of his time hath been but rash**. Then must we look from his age to receive not alone the imperfections of long-engraffed condition, but therewithal the **unruly waywardness** that infirm and choleric years bring with them.
>
> *King Lear*, Act 1, Scene 1

Because King Lear wasted his best years without ever striving to **know himself**, he has now arrived at old age with an ever-decreasing possibility of rising out of his low condition. As his mind and body deteriorate, his ability to sustain a link with his Personality has severely weakened, and so an ever more evident madness is the result. Recall Tomberg's teaching[23] that only "moral memory" can maintain a sound mind into old age. Boris Mouravieff elaborates:

> Memory is a direct function of the *being* of the individual… Loss of memory… makes a madman out of a normal man.

[23] https://gornahoor.net/?p=13778

King Lear becomes a shadow of himself.

> GONERIL: I would you would make use of that good
> Wisdom whereof I know you are fraught, and put away
> **These dispositions that of late transform you**
> **From what you rightly are.**
> FOOL: **May not an ass know when the cart draws the horse?**
> Whoop, Jug, I love thee!
> LEAR: **Doth any here know me? This is not Lear.**
> Doth Lear walk thus? speak thus? Where are his eyes?
> Either his notion weakens, his discernings
> Are lethargied Ha! waking? 'Tis not so!
> Who is it that can tell me who I am?
> FOOL: **Lear's shadow.**
>
> *King Lear*, Act 1, Scene 4

Falling into the lower states consists in being **transformed from what one rightly is**, hence the Fool's apt image of the **cart drawingt the horse**. The Self, which should be active, has become passive to the forces of the lower states. Ultimately, one does not even really *have* a "Self" anymore, and is left as a mere shadow or "shade", which is to say, a mere psychic residue, which was only formerly the manifestation of a Person.

> GONERIL:
> **As you are old and reverend, should be wise.**
> Here do you keep a hundred knights and squires,

> Men so disordered, so debauched and bold
> That this our court, infected with their manners,
> Shows like a riotous inn. Epicurism and lust
> Make it more like a tavern or a brothel
> Than a graced palace. The shame itself doth speak
> For instant remedy.
> …You strike my people, and **your disordered rabble**
> **Make servants of their betters**.
>
> *King Lear*, Act 1, Scene 4

Lear should be wise at his age, but is not. His court, which signifies also his inner life, is instead full of a huge, unruly retinue, like Mouravieff's mass of "Little I's", which cause inner chaos and rule over him. In Shakespeare's words, they "make servants of their betters". In other words, the "retinue" enslaves the Individuality and the reasoning faculty.

Such is the nature of a man in thrall to the lower states of his being. In life, it is always possible to emerge from these states by self-remembrance, penitence, and purification. It is even possible to dominate them, as Dante demonstrates. However, it is obvious that if one dies in identification with one of these states, escape from them *postmortem* becomes quite impossible, because of the abandonment of Personhood and free will that such an identification entails.

> **To free human beings from the dominion of the totems**; to strengthen them; to address them to the fulfillment of a spiritual form and a limit; and to bring them in an invisible way to the line of influences capable of creating a destiny of **heroic and liberating immortality** — this was the task of the aristocratic cult. When human beings persevered in this cult, the fate of Hades

> was averted… Once the divine rites were neglected, however, this destiny was reconfirmed **and the power of the inferior nature became omnipotent again**… those who neglect the rites cannot escape "hell," **this word meaning both a way of being in this life and a destiny in the next**.
>
> *Revolt Against the Modern World, Ch. VIII*

Oremus et pro fratribus, vivis atque defunctis.

`https://youtu.be/3mJdk5kOcds?t=446`

Posted on 2022-10-31 by Tannheuser

* * *

`Alex on 2022-11-05 at 19:44 said:`

Knowing oneself seems to involve solidifying a center of consciousness which is not easily shaken or undone. The modern life does not support the development of the center, the spiritual center which is the vehicle for the next stage of life. What we see with modern people is their reactionary body, emotions, feeble understanding of the depth of life. This reactionary body will dissolve with time and will be lost. Perhaps this is why most spirit communications deal with fragments of information, making anything meaningful difficult. Those living in the astral groves will not remain there very long as there is no point to it. So the recognition of a deep core of being will be that which moves us to higher states, not to be lost.

8.15 Ascent to the Divine

> What more liberal and more fruitful provision could God have made in regard to Sacred Scriptures than that the same words may be understood in several senses, all of which are sanctioned by the concurring testimony of other passages equally divine.
>
> St Augustine, *De Doctrina Christiana*

> Now I a fourfold vision see,
> And a fourfold vision is given to me;
> 'Tis fourfold in my supreme delight
> And threefold in soft Beulah's night
> And twofold Always. May God us keep
> From Single vision & Newton's sleep!
>
> William Blake, *Letter to Butts*

The ancient sources all recognized the multivalent interpretation of scriptures. That all changed with the Protestant Reformation. For example, **Martin Luther** sought the "single, simple, solid, and stable meaning" of Scripture. **John Calvin** seconded the idea: "the true meaning of Scripture is the natural and obvious meaning." This single vision also infected the liberal theologians with their fruitless, century long search for the "historical Jesus".

The first level, usually incorrectly named the "literal interpretation", is the material, historical space-time interpretation. The esoteric interpretation, on the other hand, deals with the experience in consciousness. Unlike some Gnostic or New Age systems, we don't claim that the esoteric is the "real" interpretation. *A fortiori*, however, neither is the material space-time interpretation any more real.

Interiority

> Do not go outside into yourself, the truth lives deep within.
>
> St. Augustine

On October 1, 2017, Stephen Paddock shot up a concert from a hotel window, killing 58 people and wounding close to one thousand. Those are the facts, so the investigation could have ended right there. Yet, that is

unsatisfying because the real questions are ignored: what was the man's motive and what is the meaning of the event.

Hence the FBI took 16 months to conclude the investigation, inconclusively. Note, however, that the FBI did not try to explain the event in terms of the motions of atoms or Newton's laws of force. Nor did they analyze his brain to determine which neurons were firing. Still less did they fabricate a genetic, evolutionary scenario.

Had they done so, everything would have been puzzled and assumed that the FBI was way off-track. Nevertheless "intelligent" men today insist that all explanations can be traced back to atoms, neurons, and genes. That is probably because few people bother with self-observation, so they fail to develop the ability to observe their interior life carefully and dispassionately.

The point is that the mere accumulation of facts does not achieve the quest for meaning. The first task is to describe the differences between events in consciousness and events in the world. Just as space and time are preconditions for any experience in the world, so, too, are they required in consciousness. However, the experience is quite different.

Mental space is determined by thoughts and images. Our dreamlife provides obvious examples of this. In a dream, we might envision a scene in a city, which then shifts to a beach scene. That is a change of space. In the material world, time is required to move from the city to the beach, whereas in the dream the change is nearly immediate.

However, in full consciousness, when one is attempting to deliberately shift from one thought to another, say in meditation or concentration exercises, there may be a significant inner time lag. Hence, inner time depends on the intensity of the desire to move from one thought to another.

Of course, this may be difficult to understand if you allow thoughts and images to spontaneously arise in consciousness, while making no effort to monitor and filter such thoughts and images.

Christ the King As an example, we can consider the idea of Christ the King that implies that Christ has dominion over the world. Then, at the end of time, He will establish His Kingdom on earth. However, esoterically, this means that the birth of Christ in the soul will take domination interiorly rather the exteriorly. **Ananda Coomaraswamy** illustrates this point clearly:

> The concept of Victory is of the utmost importance in the traditional theory of Kingship. Exoterically it is by an actual or implied victory over others that a King obtains the throne, but esoterically he is the true Victor who subdues his own passions, allying himself with the Self against himself. The heroism expected of the Knight, whether as King or as the Mortal Soul and Outer Man, is then no longer a matter of merely physical courage, but a symbol and evidence of self-conquest and self-knowledge; autonomy, as we have seen, being the outward tally of an inward Self-control. Whoever has thus found Himself is necessarily both fearless and invulnerable.
>
> Ananda Coomaraswamy, *Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power in the Indian Theory of Government*

Augustine's Ladder In *De Quantitate Animae*, Augustine described seven stages in the ascent to the divine. What is striking is the similarity to the same stages in Hermetic teaching. **Vladimir Solovyov**, in *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, mentioned in passing the connection

between the writings of **Hermes Trismegistus** and the Christian Fathers. Since he never fully developed that idea, it is our task to complete his unfinished work.

This relationship, therefore, is quite ancient, and did not suddenly arise in Renaissance Florence. **Marsilio Ficino** identifies those ancient

sources[24].

These are Augustine's stages, followed by a commentary. It is important to keep in mind that the stages do not represent changes in consciousness of a stable I. On the contrary, each stage means that the sense of I is centred at that stage. The task, therefore, is to move the sense of I upward to higher stages.

1. **Animation**: The soul is life-force without consciousness, in common with the plants.
2. **Sentience**: in common with the animals
3. **Rational**: but not moral, i.e., worldly wisdom.
4. **Virtue**: divine wisdom purges the soul.
5. **Ataraxia**: complete trust in God
6. **Intuition**: Direct, unmediated experiences of higher truth
7. **Union with God**

This is a vertical ascent and thus is radically different from horizontal schemas like Ken Wilber's colour system. Such schemas are arbitrary and tendentious.

Natural Life The first three stages are aspects of the sublunar sphere. Clearly, they correspond to the three souls described by Aristotle and the Medieval Scholastics: the Nutritive soul (plants), the Sensitive soul (all animals), and the Rational, or intellectual, soul.

[24] https://web.archive.org/web/20230212233109/https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/heart-of-the-west

As such, they apply to human beings as they are born into the world. Although all people experience animation, sentience, and rationality, everyone tends to be primarily focused in one of the first three states.

Those centred in the first, or sensory stage, is dominated by instinct, movement, thrills, sensation-seeking, sex, food, or the physical body. The fundamental fault in such beings is **concupiscence**, i.e., excessive or disordered desire.

Those centred in the sentient stage are dominated by their emotions. Feelings guide their lives. When the feeling become negative, such as anger, fear, envy, jealousy, etc., the fundamental fault is **malice**.

Those centred in the rational or thinking centre are dominated by their intellectual life, in the sense of discursive thought. At its best, this leads to technological advance, starting from fire, the wheel, agriculture, husbandry, metallurgy, navigation, and so on. Its fundamental fault is **ignorance**. Of course, ignorance is wide ranging and includes irrationality, logical fallacies, just for starters.

The world, such as it is, is dominated by humans at the first three levels. Although there is some natural goodness, concupiscence, malice, and ignorance foment strife and conflict. There is no way out.

Transitional State In traditional societies, transcendent influences in the form of exoteric religions break into the natural world system. Those who are open to such transcendent influences may undergo a moral conversion. In this case, he tries to apply brakes against the natural impulses of the lower levels. This produces an inner conflict that is necessary to develop a strong and independent I.

Natural men and women, when exposed to transcendent influences, may resent that inner conflict, preferring instead to live unencumbered by any inner constraints. They may desire to pursue sexual excess or create intellectual systems totally independent of any transcendent influences. Hence, they assume that the source of the inner check is not transcendent,

but rather are imposed by their enemies. That is why neopagans, who prefer to live in the moment, may believe that moral norms are Semitic plots.

The fundamental fault at this level is **weakness**. One may know what is right to do, yet fails due to a weak will.

Ataraxia The state of Ataraxia is achieved when the lower emotions come under control, and the will gets purified. This is a state of perfect calm, tranquility, bodily relaxation, and the silencing in the mind of desires, anxiety, fear, vulgar images, obsessive thoughts. While natural men are plagued by lower and vulgar images, in this state the mind receives images from above in the form of symbols. Now a genuine symbol is not merely a representation of a higher thought, but is itself the thing symbolised. This is related to the art of high culture.

Intuition When the mind is cleared of discursive thinking, it gains a direct, intuitive knowledge of spiritual things. This is beyond words and even the symbols of the state of Ataraxia.

Union with God This is the state reached when the I totally submits to the Absolute I. This is knowledge of the Whole. It is the Beatific Vision, which perhaps can be reached in this life.

Posted on 2019-02-12 by Cologero

* * *

`Max on 2019-02-20 at 11:52 said:`

Mentioning the "historical Jesus" was definitely timely since I am currently reading Albert Schweitzer's "The Quest of the Historical Jesus" which attempts to summarize all those various "Lives of Jesus" that have been penned. However, I am also looking into some Rosicrucian tracts in tandem, which demonstrates a much better understanding, for example, the following gem from the "Rosa Florescens" is worth far more than the many books filled with empty speculations

on the life of Jesus. A short passage proves to pull a heavier weight than centuries of idle words by countless of men.

"Man can do anything by means of God, who has His dwelling-place within him, and he can understand by and from himself any books such as a learned man might write, as they are nothing more than a memorial or testimony through which man is reminded and convinced of what is within him, for we cannot acquire any understanding from the letters alone but must impart our understanding to them. If that was not the case and the Holy Scripture carried the sense itself within it then there would not be so many sects and groups, because the words would mean the same to everyone. But instead everyone interprets them according to his own understanding, so do not place your understanding in the book therefore but in the spirit, and the spirit within the man, for man must act towards the spirit completely passively and not use his own will but must allow God to work within him freely according to all His convenience and delight, for God, like a father of all arts and suitability, yes the eternal and unique wisdom itself, will also illuminate for him his soul and awareness with the godly heavenly understanding, to such an extent that in this life nothing can be too much for him and in the future life nothing can be against him. For 'it is the spirit that quickeneth; the flesh profiteth nothing: the words that I speak unto you, they are spirit, and they are life' John 6:63 Now we must go back and seek out the origin of this text, namely the Spirit, and we must listen to it and learn from it on a silent Sabbath. Out of all the books in the world you can learn without especial difficulty from just one single book, and this book is within you and within all men, both great and inferior, both young and old, both learned and unlettered. But there are few – yes few indeed! – who can read it. Yes, there are many very learned people who are forced to deny it within themselves, and so cleave to the dead-letter which lies outside them, and so abandon the Book of Life which, even so, is indited with the finger of God in all men's hearts" -Rosa Florescens (translation Paul Ferguson)

To climb upward the ladder, the sensitive soul must become attached to the rational soul, since it in turn provides the link and incentivize the nutritive soul. If the transitional state as it is described here demands the cultivation of will, it means that the rational soul must descend to rescue the fallen will from the dominance of the surrounding earth, which it may only do by enlisting sentience as its intermediary. When the latter lays dormant, or is impermeable to higher influences, the will proves fickle on its own. The soul in a fallen state is only virtually one, although in ataraxia we might come to know it so in actuality. From the corrupted mixed state, we must learn to separate what is described as events of the world from interior events since "the spirit quickeneth; the flesh provideth nothing". When imagination no longer receives the primary impetus from the body and the world, the sensitive soul that produces the images will shift attention towards the spirit.

There is a teaching of the retrieval of the unfallen state, a state of peace in the "pure sabbath":

"And this in brief is the view of the Brotherhood, at least until another time is reached –

not that all men should be equal (for the majority are too stubborn and godless) but that the believers who keep a pure sabbath for God will be like Adam in Paradise, for it is precisely this pure knowledge and peace in Christ that Paradise consists of, things that an old theologian warns us to observe but which are not observed. Indeed, the Rosicrucian promise says that whoever is in this Paradise will not only by quite natural means be able o broadcast his opinion clearly and unambiguously in the practice of the light and in the spirit of the universals, across several hundred miles, but also will happily learn from a book all the arts of the world, and how to attract to himself pearls, gold and precious stones, how to fully understand everything within the micro- and macrocosm, how to secretly learn the thoughts of men, just like Solomon could, how to effortlessly prepare the Blessed Stone for his kin and his neighbours' use and, indeed, to understand the whole of nature naked and revealed." -Rosa Florescens

We see from the above in what manner the man in Paradise is described as having an archaic consciousness, many of the claims of which would be regarded as quite fantastic by modern men, but relates to coming to know the mental "space" that you bring up, which has other properties than the corporeal space that everybody is familiar with. Here is the same idea again:

"Through sympathy one can 'travel' hundreds of thousands of miles by land and sea in a perfectly natural manner without boots or writing-implements, and even if someone is located twelve fathoms below sea-level yet another person can make known to him everything that he wants in a twinkling." -Rosa Florescens

Michael M on 2022-02-13 at 16:42 said:

Bare-chest and bare-footed, he comes out into the market place; Daubed with mud and ashes, how broadly he smiles! There is no need for the miraculous power of the gods, For he touches, and lo! the dead tress are full in bloom.

8.16 The Primacy of Will

Profane psychology bases itself on some misconceptions. Its goal is to "understand" the reasons for behavior. Its method is to probe hidden desires, attractions, impulses, images, daydreams, memories, and thoughts in order to recover the "real self". Those are all perturbations of the mind.

Esoteric psychology is just the opposite. Its technique is not analysis, but rather concentration, meditation, contemplation. According to Hermetic teachings, concentration is the transition of the directing center of

the brain from the mind and imagination to the will and morality. Hence, the discursive mind must yield to the will and is therefore insufficient to fully comprehend it.

When the perturbations of the mind attenuate, then consciousness returns to silence, rest, calm, and relaxation. The center of awareness is the Real Self, not the thoughts, fantasies, emotions, sensations, etc., that may arise spontaneously.

The fiction of the primacy of the Mind is easily illustrated. The three centers of the human being engender sensation, emotions, and thoughts. Obviously, sensation operates the quickest, then emotions, and finally thought. For example, touch a hot stove, and the finger pulls away long before the mind is fully aware of what just happened. Emotions are slower than sensations, yet manifest prior to thought.

The opposite is clearly false. For the stove example, it is not the case that the mind determines the stove to be hot, and then commands the finger to move. You can find examples of emotions arising before the discursive mind can understand its significance.

That is why esoteric training proceeds in reverse order. First, one tries to master thoughts, or the intellectual center. Then, the next stage is mastery over the negative emotions. Finally, if it be possible, there is mastery over the body to create a spiritual or glorified body[25]. At that point, corporeality detaches from physicality, with the following qualities:

- **Impassibility**: no longer suffer physical sickness or death
- **Clarity**: free from deformity and filled with radiance
- **Agility**: can move at the speed of thought
- **Subtlety**: can pass through physical objects

[25] http://taylormarshall.com/2012/10/do-you-know-four-properties-of.html

Finally, we can tie the Will to the virtues. Virtues, like courage, can be quite difficult to define intellectually. Nevertheless, one can be courageous without being able to define it. Moreover, how to act courageously cannot be learned from intellectual study alone. That is our final proof.

The Cosmic Hierarchy Profane psychology is committed to naturalism, so it has to assume that thoughts arise out of brain activity. However, when the "zone of silence" is achieved, the influx of spiritual forces can be recognized. The diagram of **Robert Fludd** in The Cosmic Hierarchy[26] demonstrates the levels of the hierarchies. These fall into several bands.

- The sublunary or elemental spirits. These include the earth itself as well as the other elements: fire, air, and water.
- The planetary spirits.
- The stars
- The angelic hierarchy.
- The Higher mind.
- The Trinity

This is a practical teaching and is meant to be experienced directly. The temptation to create sensory images in the mind, or to expect to "see" them with the senses, must be avoided. Rather, they can be experienced as thought forms, or constellations of related thoughts.

[26] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-cosmic-hierarchy

Elemental Spirits When the mind is attached to or obsessed with these thought forms, it is not free. The True Will is free, but that requires the zone of silence from such thoughts. The visionary **Anne Catherine Emmerich** claimed that if these spirits could be seen by the senses, the vast number of them would occlude the sky. In practical terms, that means that various thoughts are constantly impinging both on the individual as well as on the human race. The elemental spirits are not benign, yet they are not exactly fallen angels.

Anne Catherine indicates that one such spirit is assigned to each individual:

> I have seen that every man receives at his birth two spirits, one good, the other evil. The good one is heavenly by nature and belongs to the lowest hierarchy; the evil one is not a devil, not yet in torments, though deprived of the vision of God.

She provides a description of them:

> In these spheres dwell the bad spirits who at each man's birth are associated to him by an intimate relation which I clearly understand, which excites my wonder, but which I cannot now explain. They are not lovely and transparent like the angels. They shine it is true, but by an external, unsteady light, as if by reflection. They are either slothful, indolent fanciful, melancholy, or passionate, violent, obstinate, stubborn, or frivolous, etc., a personification of the different passions.

Their effect can be recognized:

> These spirits have something sharp, violent, and penetrating in their countenance. They attach themselves with extraordinary tenacity to the human soul as insects to certain odors and plants, rousing in them all kinds of thoughts and desires. They are full of

> stings, rays, seductive charms. They themselves produce no act, no sin, but they withdraw man from the divine influence, lay him open to the world, intoxicate him with self, bind him, attach him to the earth in many ways.
>
> I have seen that certain inclinations and aversions, certain involuntary antipathies, and especially the disgust we have for certain things, such as insects, reptiles, vermin, etc., have a mysterious signification, since these creatures are images of those sins and passions to which, through their connection with these spirits, we are the most exposed.

The Cthulhu stores of **H. P. Lovecraft** can be read in this light. The monsters are amoral, with their own aims that are indifferent to human life. It is that indifference that is the most frightening, since evil beings can be recognized and battled. The thought of being eaten by an animal like a shark, alligator, or lion, has always horrified me. Obviously, the animal is neither evil nor immoral. The horror arises from its complete indifference to the qualities of the human being who is nothing but protein to it.

Possession by Elemental Spirits **Valentin Tomberg** describes how possession works[27] and relates it to phenomena recognized by psychologists.

> The objective of Sacred Magic is more than healing, pure and simple. It is the restoration of freedom, including freedom from the stranglehold of doubt, fear, hate, apathy and despair. The "evil spirits" that deprive man of his freedom are not at all those of the so-called hierarchies of evil or fallen hierarchies. Neither Satan, nor Belial, nor Lucifer, nor Mephistopheles has ever deprived anyone of his freedom. Temptation is their only weapon and it

[27] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/possession-by-evil-spirits

> presupposes the free will of the one tempted. But possession by an "evil spirit" has nothing to do with temptation. It is the same thing as with Frankenstein's monster. *A man engenders an elemental and becomes thereby the slave of his own creation.* The demons or evil spirits of the New Testament are today called in psychotherapy obsessive compulsive disorders, phobias, fixed ideas, and so on. They were discovered by contemporary psychiatrists and recognized as real, that is to say, parasitic psychic organisms independent of conscious human will and tending to control it.

In alchemical and magical texts, these elemental spirits are salamanders, sylphs, undines, and gnomes corresponding to the elements fire, air, water, and earth. The elemental spirits are in bondage to the elements. As such, they are not free and cannot have the use of reason; they can only manifest in subhuman forms as animals. **Eliphas Levi** describes their qualities:

> Elemental spirits are like children: they torment chiefly those who trouble about them ... they frequently occasion our bizarre or disturbing dreams and produce psychic phenomena . They can manifest no thought other than our own and when we are not thinking they speak to us with the incoherence of dreams. They reproduce good and evil indifferently, for they are without free will and are hence irresponsible... Such creatures are neither damned nor guilty; they are curious and innocent.

Planetary Spirits The planetary spirits obviously relate to the planets, but for our purposes, are actually the pagan gods. Psychologists will claim that the gods were projections of the human unconscious. However, the case is just the opposite. The gods exist and manifest themselves in consciousness. In Degrees of Existence[28], we pointed out how **Johann**

[28] https://gornahoor.net/?p=8618

Gichtel and **Oscar Hinze** demonstrated that the planets correspond to certain centers or chakras in the human being. That is how they can be experienced.

Carl Jung recognized that the gods, which he called archetypes, have an independent existence. However, he did not deign to describe that existence. However, Anne Catherine gives us a more detailed description:

> Great order reigns also among the planetary spirits, who are fallen spirits, but not devils. They are very, very different from devils. They go to and fro between the earth and the nine spheres. In one of these spheres they are sad and melancholy; in another, impetuous and violent; in a third, light and giddy; in a fourth, stingy, parsimonious, miserly, etc.
>
> They exert an influence over the whole earth, over every man from his birth, and they form certain orders and associations. In the planets I saw forms resembling plants and trees, but light and unsubstantial, like mushrooms. There are, also, waters on them, some clear as crystal, others muddy and poisonous; and it seemed to me that each planet contains a metal. The spirits make use of fruits adapted to their own nature. Some are an occasion of good, inasmuch as man himself directs their influence to good. Not all the heavenly bodies are inhabited; some are only gardens or storehouses for certain fruits and influences. I see places in which there are souls who, although not Christian, yet led good lives on earth. They are now in uncertainty, feeling that some day or other their lot will change; they are without joy or pain. Like the others, they feed upon certain fruits.

That explains the fickleness of the gods and goddesses in European myths. The descriptions of the postmortem states are similar to ideas like Valhalla.

Unfinished Business The angelic hierarchy will require a separate post in the near future. The notion that God is fundamentally Will is elucidated on the article on Jacob Boehme[29].

Posted on 2018-03-22 by Cologero

* * *

`james on 2018-03-23 at 04:34 said:`
Thanks for another great post.

`Blanchard on 2018-03-23 at 11:21 said:`
I didn't realize Emmerich wrote on this subject. Very illuminating exposition of Elementals and Planetary spirits. Is there any meaningful distinction to be made between Elementals and Demons, or are they the same type of being? If so, where is the distinction to be made?

`geirón on 2018-03-26 at 01:50 said:`
Blanchard, ≪ any assertion to the effect that two things are different implies that they are reductively the same ≫ – which is to say, Demons and Elementals are the same so far as they have the same qualities and different so far as they have different qualities.

`David on 2018-05-08 at 15:57 said:`
Did you ever realize the diagrams from Symbolism of the Cross?

`Jonathan on 2018-06-07 at 13:07 said:`
≪The thought of being eaten by an animal like a shark, alligator, or lion, has always horrified me. Obviously, the animal is neither evil nor immoral. The horror arises from its complete indifference to the qualities of the human being who is nothing but protein to it.≫

There is no such complete indifference in the animal kingdom, Sir. Apparently not even in reptiles: I recall that one of the Buddha's disciples had been bitten by a snake; the Buddha told him that this would not have occurred if he had but radiated loving compassion throughout the serpentine kingdom. Evil men may attack you regardless of your sanctity, as the example of Christ and countless martyrs should testify to. Wild beasts, on the contrary, will not attack someone in whom they sense the presence of the spiritual authority of their Lord, and I do not think you have to be a great saint for this principle to apply. However, those in whom the spiritual

[29] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=8750`

presence is not immutable may fall into a negative state of fear and so on upon the shock of encountering a dangerous wild animal, such as a bear or tiger, and this might possibly lead to an attack, as one's present spiritual state is of some importance in this regard. A state of complete openness to and trust in God's Grace while fearlessly radiating love will avert any attack from a wild beast. He who practices continually spiritual awareness (for example supported by the invocatory prayer of the heart) whilst in a place where there is a risk of such attacks should have little to fear. For a great master or saint, moreover, perfect sovereignty over wild animals may be possible, as the example of several historical personages should demonstrate (St. Francis is one who immediately comes to mind). This might perhaps have something to do with the Primordial Man's knowledge of the Names of all animals, being their angelic archetypes, which is also their word or vibrating spiritual energy, through which a higher communication with the animal kingdom is possible; and I would add, this is the only essential and inward science of what an animal in reality IS, all the dissective and reductionist pseudo-knowledge of modern science being null and void in comparison. The reason that virtually nobody practice this science is that the intense contemplation required to succeed is better directed to the 'one thing needful'; the hour is late, the days are evil, and time is shrinking if we are honest with ourselves. Before concluding, I'd also have to suggest that attack by a wild animal would ultimately be an outward symbolical representation that is synchronous with a corresponding psychic force within the soul that is unleashed beyond control with fateful repercussions. The end that a person meets is never a random occurrence by chance. It speaks a deep language of its own. The animal merely responds and makes himself an instrument of the forces at work.

9

Vedanta, Tantra and Other Eastern Metaphysics

9.1 Purity of Mind

From "Power as Mind" in *The World as Power* by **Sir John Woodroffe**:

> Mind reveals Consciousness by degrees, some minds more than the rest. The purer the mind the more it reflects or manifests Consciousness. The object then of the self-realising discipline or Sadhana is to purify the Mind so that it may manifest Consciousness. Purity of Mind is therefore to be sought. "Pure" and "Purity" are not used in their sexual sense only. This is only one and an elementary form of purity. It is obvious that if a Mind is dominated by sensuous desires and images, it cannot reflect or show Spirit. For this reason the Tantras in specifying the qualifications of the proposed disciple exclude the lewd and the glutton. It must be pure also in respect of other matters, and therefore free of greed, anger, envy and all else which is the mark of the impure Mind. Such a Mind is incapable of understanding spiritual things. But the Mind must not only be pure in the sense of freedom from what is bad, but must be positively kind and good and free from er-

ror. Purification of Mind is called *Citta-buddhi*. The Mind must be an efficient and trained instrument of knowledge which is its appropriate food, and should if necessary be sharpened by the study of logic and the practice of debate. It should be made capable in this and other ways of understanding the highest metaphysical ideas. And so the disciple is recommended to study the sacred texts, Logic and Metaphysic. At the same time there should be devotion to and worship of God as the Mother-Power (one with Siva as unchanging Consciousness) who is called Lalita, Mahakali Maha-tripurasundari, Mahakundalini and by other names which denote only aspects of the one Reality as Power.

Ritual is the art of religion. The rituals are designed to secure realisation of Unity with Her. *Sakta-Sadhana* which term includes what is called in English "ritual", is based on sound psychological principles with which I will deal in another volume. The ritual is an expression in action of the philosophical principles above described. Thus the whole evolving cosmic process is imagined in the rite called *Bhuta-suddhi*, in which each of the lower principles is merged in the higher, until in imagination the abode of *Siva-Sakti* is reached. So also the *Sri-Yantra* or Diagram represents both the body of the Sadhaka as the Microcosm and the whole universe. All ordinary acts and functions become worship by dedication to the Mother-Power, and self-identification with that Power in all physical functions and acts. The *Sadhana* then realises himself as the Mother-Power in the form of himself.

Posted on 2008-06-11 by Anonymous

9.2 Buddhism and Tradition

Much has been made of Guenon's initial rejection of Buddhism as a "Traditional" religious form, and his subsequent recantation of that position under the influence of some of his close colleagues. It is important to

note the reason for that. Guenon accepted the common belief that Buddhism taught "anatman", or the doctrine of "no-self", which Guenon rejected as not Traditional. However, he was persuaded that the original and pure Buddhism did indeed teach "atman", but was perverted by later Buddhism. Thus, Guenon accepted early Buddhism as Traditional, as did Julius Evola.[1].

However, T R V Murti offers a more subtle interpretation in his masterful study, **The Central Philosophy of Buddhism**[2]. He points out that the Madhyamika is epistemological and says nothing about the ontological. Thus it denies both the "doctrine of the self" as well as the "doctrine of the no-self". What is emphasizes in practice is the direct intuition of realtiy as opposed to rational discourse or speculative metaphysics.

But what makes it interesting from our perspective is Murti's suggestion that "the Madhyamkia Absolutism can serve as the basis for a possible world-culture." Murti was well aware of Rene Guenon and his use of the terminology of the Vedanta as a vehicle to express Traditional doctrine. A Hindu himself, Murti recognized that the Vedanta only makes sense within a Hindu framework (this is the reason Guenon stated for his decision to join a Sufi group rather than become a Hindu).

> Mahayana absolutism and the Advaita Vedanta are valuable as providing the basis on which a world-culture can be built. It is only absolutism that can make for the fundamental unity of existence and at the same time allow for differences. Catholicity of outlook and tolerance of differences are their very soul; both insist on the universality of the Real and transcendence of the ego-centric standpoint. The Vedanta, however, is traditional in outlook and is bound to the authority of the Veda, and perhaps

[1] For a rather enthusiastic advocacy of this position, visit `https://web.archive.org/web/20100704194342/http://www.attan.com/`

[2] `https://www.amazon.com/Central-Philosophy-Buddhism-Madhyamika-System/dp/8121510805`

> it presupposes a specific milieu in which alone it can thrive. The Mahayana is quite liberal, and it has proved its capacity to accomodate itself to various religious and social structure, to revitalise and absorb them.

This project, if undertaken, would have the advantage of incorporating the techniques and philosophy of a non-dogmatic Buddhism, including Tantrism. Murti does recognize that this won't be the work of a scholar, but rather of a "spiritual genius". (This brings to mind Leo Strauss' prediction that the next world class philosopher would arise out of Asia.)

Posted on 2010-03-13 by Cologero

* * *

Olavsson on 2015-11-22 at 13:03 said:

Discussion continued from here: http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8366&cpage=1#comment-19710%5D

Yes, I certainly think that suggestion is worthy of serious consideration. If Guenon's knowledge about Buddhism had been more profound, he might very well have agreed with Murti's thesis. Now, as we know, what initially had the most formative impact upon Guenon's metaphysical understanding was the Vedanta, and he had been led to the opinion that Buddhism was originally deviant, unorthodox and so on, because of the Buddha Shakyamuni's critical attitude to certain trends within Brahmanism at the time, as well as his differing approach to various questions. As you point out, he was inspired to revise this overly harsh position by Coomaraswamy (himself a Hindu) et al (Marco Pallis?), but in spite of this, Guenon never cared to remedy his lack of in-depth knowledge of the Buddhist forms, which truly constituted one serious whole in his Traditional and metaphysical education. His knowledge of Daoism was much deeper, even though Buddhism was a far more extensive phenomenon of the "world of Tradition" in his day, ranging from the exoteric to the esoteric. I'm not saying that an in depth knowledge of all the great traditions is a requirement for true inner realizations of any kind, of course. But since Guenon expressively valued such cross-cultural understanding from a higher point of view, even if eventually devoting oneself to one single path (as he did after being initiated into that Sufi order – which order was it, by the way?), it is surprising, to say the least, that he wouldn't have

been interested in delving more deeply into the Buddhist traditions. As I remember you mentioning in your comment to one of Guenon's letters posted on this site, he couldn't even give a very basic definition of Vajrayana. That is surely no obligatory knowledge for a westerner, but in the case of a man like Guenon, whose interest was Tradition in general and not 'only' his own tradition, one should expect better. Julius Evola, of course, was not illiterate in the case of Buddhism, having introduced us to his own analysis of the Buddhist spirit in 'The Doctrine of Awakening', and shared some (although the book was more focused on Hindu tantra) insights on Vajrayana in 'The Yoga of Power'. With that in view, I am sure Evola would have appreciated such a contribution as Murti's book on madhyamaka.

In order to successfully "incorporate the techniques and philosophy of a non-dogmatic Buddhism, including Tantrism", to quote your words, one would probably have to be initiated into such forms and undergo some extensive training. I know that you were initiated by a Tibetan lama in the US. May I ask which lineage(s) he belonged to? If my memory serves me right, you wouldn't really recommend any of us to do the same. Still, to tell the truth, I am wondering whether a stay in India in order to study the Vajrayana tradition might be valuable for my path. I am especially interested in the higher yogic practices, though I am fully aware that this is not exactly entry-level, and would require completing the foundational preparatory practices. However, at this point, the will to devote my life to initiatic realization trumps any other consideration. Since it seems that the Buddhist traditions – though usually not in any impressive form – have come to Europe to remain, why let the modernists have a monopoly on it?

This is slightly off-topic, but I came to think of a brief comment in another article where you questioned the authenticity of Evola's perspective on Buddhism. Where do you think he went off the track, so to speak? For me, 'The Doctrine of Awakening' is a highly inspiring book, not least because it serves to remind us of the heroic, virile and Aryan qualities that are mostly ignored by modern self-appointed Buddhists. But still, we are dealing with the interpretation of one who was not himself initiated into any Buddhist tradition, which may be biased by his 'personal equation' in certain regards. It is not the 'gold standard' of authentic Buddhism. For a westerner who wants to understand the spirit of Buddhism, 'The Doctrine... ' is a unique book that should be recommended reading for all of a Traditional disposition (not to mention the provoking challenge it would pose to a modernist), but one shouldn't stop there without going to the original sources (as Evola himself did) as well as undertaking a survey of the various Buddhist branches, the living traditions and lineages today, and their historical masters, and also remember that in the case of one specific branch, there are various levels of understanding.

Even when considering the high metaphysics, such as Mahayana's madhyamaka and its emphasis on 'emptiness'/'voidness'/shunyata, one will soon realize that there are varying ways in which this is understood. Do you know of the division between the zhentong and rangtong perspectives on emptiness? I'm not sure if Murti discusses this in his book, as I have yet to read

it. A major traditional work on zhentong translated into English from the Tibetan, is available under the title 'Mountain Doctrine: Tibet's Fundamental Treatise on Other-Emptiness and the Buddha-Matrix', authored by the Jonang master Dolpopa in the 14th century, numbering some 800 pages. The Jonangpas most strongly emphasized this, as I've understood, but the zhentong view has even been prevalent in orders like Kagyu and Nyingma, the rangtong angle being most pronounced by Gelug (the order of which the Dalai Lama is the most well-known representative). The advantage of zhentong madhyamaka is that it makes it absolutely impossible for any nihilistic misunderstandings to creep in.

9.3 Vedanta and Western Tradition

> Lacking nothing, contemplative, immortal, self-originated, sufficed with a quintessence: he who knows that constant, ageless, and ever-youthful Spirit, knows himself and does not fear death.
>
> SHANKARA

In his important but little read essay, *The Vedanta and Western Tradition*, **Ananda Coomaraswamy** points the way for Europeans to come to an understanding of the metaphysics of the Vedanta. He begins with this advice:

> The educated man of today is completely out of touch with those European modes of thought and those intellectual aspects of the Christian doctrine which are nearest those of the Vedic traditions. *A knowledge of modern Christianity will be of little use because the fundamental sentimentality of our times has diminished what was once an intellectual doctrine to a mere morality that can hardly be distinguished from a pragmatic humanism*. A European can hardly be said to be adequately prepared for the study of the Vedanta unless he has acquired some knowledge and understanding of at least

- Plato
- Philo
- Hermes Trismegistus
- Plotinus
- Gospel of John
- Dionysius the Areopagite
- Meister Eckhart
- Dante

> Eckhart, with the possible exception of Dante, can be regarded from an Indian point of view as the greatest of all Europeans.

Here are some of the major highlights:

- Metaphysics is not a system, but a consistent doctrine
- It is concerned not only with conditioned and quantitative experience, but also with universal possibility
- There are things which are beyond the reach of discursive thought and which cannot be understood except by denying things of them
- The immanent Spirit within you is the only knower, agent, and transmigrant
- Ultimate reality is a Supreme Identity in which the opposition of all contraries, even of being and not-being, is resolved
- Its "worlds" and "gods" are levels of reference and symbolic entities which are neither places nor individuals but states of being realizable within you

- For the metaphysician, it suffices to show that a false doctrine involves a contradiction of first principles
- The quest is achieved only when he himself has become the object of his search
- The Vedanta can be known only to the extent that it has been lived
- Man is unaware of this hidden treasure within himself because he has inherited an ignorance that inheres in the very nature of the psycho-physical vehicle which he mistakenly identifies with himself
- What is called "creation" in religion, is called "manifestation" in metaphysics
- Only when we are convinced that nothing happens by chance that the idea of Providence becomes intelligible
- Each human life has run its course when all its possibilities have been exhausted
- Whatever has been an eternal reason or idea or name of an individual manifestation can never cease to be such; the content of eternity cannot be changed
- All the states of being are within you, awaiting recognition

Posted on 2010-06-24 by Cologero

* * *

Dai Leon on 2010-06-25 at 02:07 said:

Coomaraswamy's insights continue to be widely unmatched except by the founders and key saints of the Great Tradition.

However, 'chance' becomes a first principle when understood as contingency which is invariably synchronistic. Thus, "Only when we are convinced that nothing happens by chance that the idea of Providence becomes intelligible" does not sufficiently penetrate the reality of Hierarchical Emergence and Fate on one side and Holistic Causality and Death on the other.

Cologero on 2010-06-25 at 08:33 said:

Are you denying the Principle of Sufficient Reason?

By "chance", I think he means an event that is unrelated to anything else, either empirically or transcendentally. Hence, I would regard "synchronicity", as that relationship. I don't think you would see "synchronicity" as something purely arbitrary and subjective. On the contrary, in this sense, synchronicity is an even stronger indication of Providence.

In a larger context, I don't see Coomaraswamy as advocating determinism as the opposite of "chance", if that is what you are objecting to.

Will on 2010-06-27 at 11:04 said:

Link to the full text:

http://religioperennis.org/documents/acoomaraswamy/vedanta.pdf

Dai on 2022-06-25 at 17:07 said:

Just now revisiting this conversation...I wholly agree with your observations Cologero. Just adding some clarification to what has scientifically become an overriding and limited scientific dogma of 'random chance' made from limited observations, projections and consciousness

9.4 Men of Fine Disposition

If the primordial tradition is necessarily monotheistic, why does polytheism makes its appearance? Again, polytheism, properly understood, is compatible with monotheism provided the understanding of Principle is kept in mind. For example, Pico della Mirandola refers to the angels as "gods" in his commentary on Genesis, albeit in a quite different sense from the true God. Furthermore, these periods of early history that seem to be polytheistic are still quite far from the prehistory of the primordial tradition and hence reflect a certain decadence.

Nevertheless, the elite have always known monotheism, and true

polytheism can only be attributed to the vulgar. For example, we have the example of Akhnaton who tried unsuccessfully to re-introduce monotheism to the Egyptian people.

In the case of ancient Greece, the philosophers were aware of the truth of monotheism. The most famous of them, Socrates, was tried and executed for his beliefs. The charge was impiety against the established religion.

So we see that persecution for religious heresy starts with the pagans and predates popular monotheism and Christianity. Unfortunately, thought crimes have always been part of history and continue to our day, led by the non-Christian governments of Europe. And, today, just as in the case of Socrates, truth is no defense.

Plato learned a hard lesson from this, and suggested in the Republic that a man should follow the religion of his country, as least publicly. However, privately Plato held a different view. He felt it was improper to divulge knowledge of the true God to the vulgar, for fear of exposing such a great truth to ridicule. What was true in Plato's era is just as true today.

Plato writes in his second letter:

> Beware, however, lest these doctrines be ever divulged to uneducated people. For there are hardly any doctrines, I believe, which sound more absurd than these to the vulgar, or, on the other hand, more admirable and inspired to men of fine disposition.

Posted on 2010-06-29 by Cologero

9.5 Shakti Power as Play

> Let no man glory in the greatness of his mind,
> but rather keep watch o'er his wits.
> Cautious and silent let him enter a dwelling;

> to the heedful comes seldom harm,
> for none can find a more faithful friend
> than the wealth of mother wit.
>
> Hávamál, *The Words of Odin the High One*

> There is no form of existence—even "material" existence—which is not an expression of, and in its turn does not express (however veiled the expression may be in relation for certain "cosmic situations"), Joy and Free Power.
>
> John Woodroffe, *Power as Consciousness*



In the Tantric view of things, the world is the Play of Shakti, by which the "divine Mother screens Herself in the form of interplaying Centres." But there is only one centre: "The experience of the Supreme I is "I am the Universe. The limited I identifies himself with a particular mind and body in it." So how do we Play? Are there rules? Can we improve our game?

In a sport—let's take golf as an example—it is elementary. The rules are known in advance and it is a simple matter to count the number of strokes to hole the ball. There can be no possible dispute about best player on a given day. This is why sports appeals to the masses. Even when they play themselves, they accept their inferiority to the top players in the game. So how to reach the top?

Performance experts say it takes about 10,000 hours of practice, whether of a sport or musical instrument, to reach the very peak of talent, and 7500 may get you close. However, the top golfers will be out hitting balls for hours at a time. Besides the talent itself, at a certain level, there is honour

to the game. A golfer won't kick the ball out of the rough and he will report even unseen transgressions of the rules.

So how do we then excel at our game, that is, the game of Joy and Free Power, that veils the Supreme I in a kaleidoscope of multiplicity? Well, let's look at an example. We know that Evola studied the corpus of 19th century German Idealism, along with many other contemporary thinkers. He made himself conversant in Oriental philosophies: early Buddhism, Tantra, Taoism. To this he added a vast familiarity with the range of European history and the mythology of the world. And just as a golfer would not rely on books but would go hit several buckets of balls, so, too, did Evola engage in spiritual exercises to peal away the veils of Shakti.

This commitment is what we must aspire to. The conceit that spending five minutes reading a post is sufficient to come to a sound judgment is risible, and those commenters that do so, just bring shame on themselves.

Every game has its starting position and ours is the vantage point of the limited I, which forgets he is playing and defends his own perspective or point of view, as though it were Absolute truth. Yet, to begin playing we first must understand that

> The entire universe of sensations, feelings, ideas, memories, and so forth, which constitute total Experience at any moment, can never be thought about as a whole ... Perfect Experience is thus alogical. Although unthinkable and indescribable, it is not on that account unknown and unknowable. It is Experience itself, Consciousness itself.

Hence, at some point, thought must be abandoned, in favour of the "Supreme Intuition". This is why, for example, the man who has experience of Spirit and Soul in his consciousness is not confused about their relationship. This is why the man who has experience of the states of being understands the nature of caste distinctions, and so on.

> The only reality is Consciousness, a position for which we may argue but which cannot be established with certitude except by an actual or direct experience of unity. Those who seek to establish supersensible truths on any other ground must fail; just as those who argue against the validity of the individual's experience must fail.

So here is another way to improve our game:

> Mind reveals Consciousness by degrees, some minds more than the rest. The purer the mind the more it reflects or manifests Consciousness. The object then of the self-realising discipline or Sadhana is to purify the Mind so that it may manifest Consciousness. Purity of Mind is therefore to be sought... It is obvious that if a Mind is dominated by sensuous desires and images, it cannot reflect or show Spirit.

Besides the purification of the Mind, it must also be developed:

> The Mind must be an efficient and trained instrument of knowledge which is its appropriate food, and should if necessary be sharpened by the study of logic and the practice of debate.

Reality is Logos, so a sane and rational mind is mandatory, but also a well-bred mind.

> Philosophising is not done because of mere intellectual curiosity but as part of a disciplinary system enjoined for the realization by the limited self of its own unlimited and essential nature. That nature has its intellectual aspect and is expressed as Reason. For what is irrational cannot be spiritually true.

All unattributed quotations are from *The World as Power* by John Woodroffe.

Posted on 2011-03-22 by Cologero

9.6 The Knowledge of God

The transcendental unity of religions is true insofar as it pertains to metaphysics. In Lecture 6 of *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, **Vladimir Solovyov** shows his agreement with that point even for Christianity. In particular, he writes this about Neoplatonism:

> It is impossible to deny the connection between Philo's doctrine and Neoplatonism, on the one hand, and Christianity, that is, precisely the Christian doctrine of the Holy Trinity, of the triune God.
>
> The first speculations concerning God and His inner life by such Christian teachers as Justin the Philosopher, Hippolytus, Clement of Alexandria, and especially Origen reproduced the essential truth of the doctrine of Philo and Neoplatonism.

Furthermore, Solovyov traces this connection all the way back to the Egyptian theosophy of **Hermes Trismegistus**. This is because metaphysics deals with essences, but it is fair to ask if that is exhaustive, when it comes to existing things. **Rene Guenon** skirts around this is his notion of possibilities of manifestation. In that sense, an existing thing, or manifested possibility, is metaphysically no different from a possibility of non-manifestation. This seems to be what **Aristotle** is saying when he claims that God does not know particular things.

Julius Evola disputes Guenon on this point. As we saw in the discussions on the Individual and the Becoming of the World, to become manifest, an idea requires an act of will. As such, the individual is not an object of contemplation. Evola thought he was opposing action to Guenon's contemplation. However, they are not in opposition, since they are united under the "Person", who is both the center of contemplation and of will. As we shall see, Evola was not recovering pagan ideas as he believed, but was actually recuperating Christian ideas.

The Pagan and Contemplation The fundamental revelation made to the rishis in the Vedas was the existence of a higher self and that the manifest world was the result of ignorance, or avidya. The solution, then, was to dissolve the lower self, as knowledge of the higher self was itself liberation. That knowledge is the end of ignorance. This higher self then passively observes the passing phenomena of the world. However, this involves the dissolution of the person, because there is no longer a will. The self does not create the phenomena, but merely observes.

This solution is carried into Buddhism. It deepens the Vedic revelation when it sees suffering as inherent in the phenomenal world and it ties this suffering to desire. The Buddhist solution is therefore the elimination of desire, or the will. Again, the person is denied by following this path, since a person has will by definition.

For the Greeks, too, the highest life was contemplation. Like the rishis, ignorance was the cause of suffering and ignorance was removed by knowledge of the self. This knowledge would lead to "justice", or the proper arrangement and relationship of the various parts of the soul to each other. The world, then, was contemplated as an object.

The Christian Revelation Among the world's traditions, Solovyov explains the distinctiveness of the Christian Tradition:

> The originality of Christianity lies not in its general [metaphysical] views, but in positive facts, not in the speculative content of its idea but in its personal incarnation. This originality cannot be taken away from Christianity, and to affirm it, one does not need to try to prove, against history and common sense, that all the ideas of Christian dogmatics appeared as something absolutely new, that they fell, so to speak, ready-made from heaven.

Solovyov explains the relationship between a person and an idea. Without a subject to actualize it, an idea would be passive and impotent. It

could not really exist. To achieve real, full being, the inner unity of person and idea is necessary.

By analogy, the absolute idea is also determined in its inner subjective existence as a particular and unique person. This insight requires a living God, God as a fact, not the passive Brahman. The living God reveals Himself as "I am", not with respect to particular things but with respect to the All, or the Infinite.

Still, the initial revelation to the Hebrews was incomplete and partial. They saw God's will as arbitrary in Himself, but compulsory for humanity. But the understanding deepened, and the will of God could not be understood as despotism, but rather as the consciously chosen good. For the person, the compulsion is experienced as internal necessity, i.e., true freedom. Hence, the path of salvation, or liberation, is not the annihilation of the will as in the various forms of paganism, but rather the alignment, or better submission, of the personal will to the divine Will. Since God is Absolute and Infinite, there can only be one such Will.

So on the one hand, there is the revelation of the absolute personhood of God made to the Hebrews. On the other, the absolute idea of Divinity was grasped in Greece. The complete knowledge of God requires the synthesis of both these elements. That was the task of Christianity.

Posted on 2014-04-02 by Cologero

* * *

Michel on 2014-04-03 at 13:41 said:

"Hence, the path of salvation, or liberation, is not the annihilation of the will as in the various forms of paganism, but rather the alignment, or better submission, of the personal will to the divine Will. Since God is Absolute and Infinite, there can only be one such Will."

I have a question, when you say "personal will" do you mean individual? Or do you mean Personality, as in Atma?Assuming you mean individual: so whether or not one's individual will subsists doesn't really matter, because God's Will happens anyways. Whether the individual aligns

himself to it and does not experience anything higher than his individual self, or whether he goes beyond it (annihilation as a term to describe this happening is rather misleading, because it implies a loss of something and hence a limitation on the higher station that the being would achieve;synthesis would be a better term, the principal of the individual doesn't deprive him of his individuality, because, being its principal, it has synthesized it in itself) doesn't affect this.

"By analogy, the absolute idea is also determined in its inner subjective existence as a particular and unique person. This insight requires a living God, God as a fact, not the passive Brahman. The living God reveals Himself as "I am", not with respect to particular things but with respect to the All, or the Infinite."

As you have said in your article, there are Possibilities of non-manifestation that are non-manifest-able in accordance with their nature and there are those that are manifest-able being Possibilities of manifestation. They are "passive" insofar as they are Possibility and they are "active" insofar as they are Infinity. Possibility and Infinity refer to the "passive" and "active" "modes" of the Infinite. To use an analogy, Dave is man. Dave can jump, run, sing, shout, sleep and so on. Dave's existence therefore necessitates/affirms jumping, running, singing, shouting, sleeping and so on. Dave encompasses all these possibilities simply because he exists and those are the possibilities that are in concordance to his nature; in his passivity, Dave still "emanates" running, jumping, sleeping etc. If Dave jumps, runs, sings, shouts and sleeps at the same time, then Dave would have instantaneously actualized all the possibilities that his existence necessitates in accordance with his nature. So when you say, "This insight requires a living God, God as a fact, not the passive Brahman" are you referring to the Infinite in its "Passive Mode", viz Possibility?

Consciousness is the sufficient reason for the perception of a state of being. I can perceive this state of being, because I am conscious of it. Destiny is the sufficient reason for the persistence of a being in individual mode. I am here because I have a destiny here. To go beyond one's destiny would be to realize it, by harmoniously synthesizing all the individual modes of existence that exhaust one's destiny. To perfectly and wholly do so, would be to align oneself with Providence and hence realize the Divine Will in relation to oneself. But would one have realized the Divine Will for that which lies beyond oneself and individuality? If so, wouldn't this be a virtual realization, still tied to the cosmological perspective? My question is, why stop there? Why not go beyond one's individuality wholly? Why not Realize the Divine Will that is truly Metaphysical, beyond both the formal and formless states of Being? Beyond the soul and the Spirit? Why not realize the Person, and hence perfect the realization of the Divine Will? If the Entity/Unraveled Archetype possess in itself something that entitles it to supra-individuality, nay to even supra-manifestation , supra-spirituality, true Metaphysics, why not actualize that something and realize this?

I really mean these questions; I am not the type of person to be insincere, so do not take these the wrong way. Forgive me beforehand if they are vague and want of clarity; and if they show a misconstrued understanding of this post and theme in general.

Cologero on 2014-04-03 at 21:40 said:

I'm not sure what you are getting at, Michel. We understand by "person" a being with consciousness and will; the individual is more vague. Atma is consciousness, but how can the Atma be a person? That is the fundamental point of the essay. If God's will happens anyway, then why do we pray "Thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven"?

I don't know why I need to repeat in a comment what was already written, but if a "person" loses his will, then he is no longer a person … that is an annihilation. Our point, however, is that the person cannot be annihilated, as he is immortal. The highest state is "liberation", i.e., total freedom, i.e., absolute self-determination.

The pagans all regarded knowledge as the solution. Even Socrates said the the virtues would follow from knowledge. We know, however, that the moral problem arises in the will. A few weeks ago, a commenter claimed something similar. When I pushed her for the reasons why enlightenment, as she conceived it, could not be taught, she replied with a list of moral failings of the will. I pointed that out to her, and she chose to vanish.

You described Dave in his animal nature; that is not the actualization of his possibilities as a man. That actualization is theosis, becoming fully conscious and fully free. How you and I differ is that I am using precise language to describe the states you mention, while you are just singing in the rain.

Michel on 2014-04-04 at 02:07 said:

This is what I understand by Personality:

"

The personality, let us insist once more, belongs essentially to the order of principles in the strictest sense of the word, that is to the universal order; it cannot therefore be considered from any point of view except from that of pure metaphysics, which has precisely the Universal for its domain.

"

"If a person loses his will, then he is no longer a person."

So the defining aspect of a person is his will. Well, as I understood it, the Personality/Self/Atma is:

"

Is the Transcendent and Permanent Principle of which the manifested being, the human being for example is only a transient and contingent modification, a modification which, moreover, can in no way affect the principle…

The Self as such is never individualized and cannot become so, for since it must always be considered in the aspect of the eternity and immutability which are the necessary attributes of Pure Being, it is obviously not susceptible of any particularization, which would cause it to be

'other than itself'. Immutable in its own nature, it merely develops the indefinite possibilities which it contains in itself from a relative potency to act through an indefinite series of degrees. Its essential permanence is not thereby affected, precisely because this process is only relative

and because this development is strictly speaking, not a development at all, except when looked at from the point of view of manifestation, outside of which there can be no question of succession, but only a perfect simultaneity, so that even what is virtual in one aspect is found to be realized in 'the eternal present'

"

[Man and his becoming according to the Vedanta, Rene Guenon]

Thank you for clarifying that you were not referring to the individual, but to the Supreme Identity, when you said "personal will". (That was all I was asking really, the other bulk of the comment was developed under the assumption that you meant one's individuality).

By will, I understand:

"Immutable in its own nature, it merely develops the indefinite possibilities which it contains in itself from a relative potency to act through an indefinite series of degrees".

Hence realizing the Self would imply realizing Will; and because the Self is

"the Transcendent and Permanent Principle of which the manifested being, the human being for example is only a transient and contingent modification", then nothing is lost because all would be: "found to be realized in 'the eternal present'" in concordance with the Will of the Self.

August on 2014-04-04 at 20:17 said:

" If God's will happens anyway, then why do we pray "Thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven"? "

A better way to penetrate the issue: Do you propose that there is a single event anywhere in the Universe that occurs against God's Plan?

The quoted question invites confusion between the 'personal God' (demiurge) and the Absolute (sum of all disorders); the aspiring student of metaphysics should take pains to differentiate the two.

Further, even in a prayer, that statement can be read as an assertion rather than a plea.

Cologero on 2014-04-06 at 16:08 said:

August, your response invites confusion between God's Will and God's Plan, which presumably you claim to be privy to.

Aspiring students of metaphysics should take pains to actually read a text, learn to think organically, and avoid abstract, mechanical thinking.

For example, to understand the points raised, he may want to read what Rene Guenon wrote about Providence, Will, and Destiny in the Great Triad. Providence is the reflection of God's

Will … we have touched on this topic on many occasions.

The aspiring student may also want to read *Freedom and Power*[3]. Then he could find the post where we quote Julius Evola that the way to know God is to be god. That is, theosis. In organic thinking, there are lot of pieces that need to be tied together, and I mean in one's interiority, not in some artificial metaphysical formulation.

So the best way to know God's will is to actually do God's will … then you will be a man who knows and you will have some authority.

Now, more advanced students may go back a week or two to the discussion of Shankara. If the world we experience is the result of ignorance, or avidya, then that cannot be God's will. Ignorance is not real, but is just a privation of knowledge.

Do you see how things ramify for the student of metaphysics? He needs to balance all the ideas in his head and make them a living realtiy, not an intellectual showcase.

Synodius on 2014-04-06 at 19:07 said:

'If the world we experience is the result of ignorance, or avidya, then that cannot be God's will. Ignorance is not real, but is just a privation of knowledge.'

Our usual experience of the world is the result of ignorance (avidya) and so we cannot see it as God's will. With real knowledge we can see the world as it really is, which involves seeing it now comparatively less real (with different metaphysical status) than we did while in the state of ignorance.

Can it be just different terminology and stress for different points of view or really a fundamental flaw in eastern views?

Cologero on 2014-04-06 at 23:04 said:

Synodius, I assume you are making the point that their is a higher principle uniting Providence, Will, and Destiny. But, before getting to that, it does not change the fundamental point that Providence is the instrument of God's will. As above, so below: these three terms correspond in man to the intellectual, psychic, and instinctual forces, i.e., spirit, soul, body (see Guenon). So from below, the man who lives through his spirit, or intellect, corresponds to living under Providence (the subtle rules the dense).

So the uniting principle is knowledge of the Self. From below, the "I" unites the three forces. From above, God is the unifying principle. Nevertheless, Providence is the instrument of his Will, just as for a (true) man, the intellect is the instrument of his personal will. If you want to insist that whatever happens is God's will then you explain and understand nothing. It is the night where all cows are black.

[3] http://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/freedom-and-power

August on 2014-04-07 at 07:31 said:

Focussing on Providence, do we not again descend from the Absolute to the manifested? I challenge any participant to differentiate the Divine Will and the Divine Plan for us sub specie aeternitatis.

It is sad that the probing of metaphysical certainty seems to you mechanical.

And what alternative to believing that everything happens only by the Will of God? The Poor man confirms his faith, so be gracious and expose the flaw better if you see it.

James 4, 12-15, KJV:

"There is one lawgiver, who is able to save and to destroy: who art thou that judgest another?

Go to now, ye that say, To day or to morrow we will go into such a city, and continue there a year, and buy and sell, and get gain:

Whereas ye know not what shall be on the morrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapour, that appeareth for a little time, and then vanisheth away.

For that ye ought to say, If the Lord will, we shall live, and do this, or that."

scardanelli on 2014-04-07 at 11:18 said:

Sad also are missed opportunities for understanding. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness comprehends it not. To truly probe metaphysics, to comprehend the light, keep thy mind in darkness. As long as we eat from the tree whose fruit is death, we will only play at knowing…we will only be pretenders chasing after imaginary forms and phantoms.

9.7 The Cosmic Revelation

> Without Christianity I don't think the oriental religions, Hinduism and Buddhism, can answer the needs of the modern world. But without the enrichment of the mystical tradition of Asia I doubt whether the Western Churches can really discover the fullness of Christ which we are seeking.
>
> Bede Griffiths

Bede Griffiths, a one-time student of C S Lewis, combined the life of a monk and a yogi. On his own, apparently, he undertook Guenon's

project to reinvigorate his Catholic tradition with Oriental metaphysics. In a series of six lectures, published as *The Cosmic Revelation*, Griffiths provides us with a fine overview of the Vedanta and its relevance to the West. I'll organize the following review by the chapter titles while highlighting their main points.

The Vedic Revelation As does **Rene Guenon**, Griffiths accepts that the *Vedas* arise from a divine revelation. In them, the word (*vac*) is the mediator between God and man. The word *veda* means knowledge, the same as the Latin *video*, to see, to know. Hence "knowing" is like "seeing". As Griffiths points out, the Vedas (and Sanskrit) were brought to India by the Aryans from the North in the second millennium BC. Its authors are called rishis, or see-ers. But Vedas are not a fabrication; they are also called *sruti*, which means they were "heard". In sum, they are what has been heard, what is eternal, without human authorship.

After the Vedas came the *Brahmanas*, which were commentaries on the ritual sacrifices, the *Aranyakas*, written by the mystical forest dwellers, and then the Upanishads, or records of discussions between the rishis and their students. These are all the echoes of the original peoples who arrived in India from the North; that is why they may still resonate in some deep part of us.

The later epics (the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*) evolved over time from the intermixtures of the Northern Aryans with the Southern Dravidians. Griffiths notes that the northern religion is "a religion of a nomadic people, of warriors, and much more dynamic", in contrast with the earthy religion of the Mother goddess worship of the South. Next came the *Darshanas*, or the orthodox philosophical systems.

Monotheism Hinduism, he says, is called the *sanatana dharma*, the "eternal religion". Griffiths does not mention that St Augustine made the same point: there is but one tradition, which is now known as Catholic.

Therefore, Griffiths needs to explain the two concepts of God. The first Veda refers to "the one being the wise called by many names." Therefore, the gods are names and forms under which the one God manifests himself. That is, they are more or less the equivalent of "angels" or the "cosmic powers" mentioned by St Paul. The One Being is behind the powers of nature, the sky, the earth, the sea, fire, and so on. Hence, Hinduism is no more polytheistic than is Catholicism with its cult of angels and saints.

Esoteric Understanding. Words in sacred languages are not as univocal as modern ones. For example, the word "spirit" in most languages also means "wind or air or breath or life or soul or spirit." That is what makes translations difficult: there is no one precise meaning, since the word contains all the meanings. Griffiths refers to *Poetic Diction* by the anthroposophist and inkling **Owen Barfield** for support.

The rishis did not have the same dualistic consciousness of most people today. For example, in the Vedas we find many prayers for material prosperity: cattle, horses, butter, wealth, and so on. **Aurobindo Ghose**, in the *Secret of the Veda*[4] points out that these words have both a psychological and a physical meaning. So as butter comes from milk and thoughts come from mind, "butter" may also mean thought.

A better example, from our perspective, is the fire sacrifice associated with the hearth, since keeping the "home fire burning" was such an important rite to early Indo-European people. But that also means to build the fire in the heart. *Tapas*, which means "asceticism, self-control, discipline", originally meant "heat". Hence, the buildup of friction in the mind through self-discipline is the same as "heart" or the fire in the heart. So there is the exoteric religion of the rites around the physical fire, and the esoteric religion of inner fire. Yet it would be a mistake to separate them, or to claim that the esoteric meaning is the "real" meaning. That is a dualistic view. Rather, our ancestors would have experienced them

[4] https://www.sriaurobindoashram.org/sriaurobindo/writings.php

as the same; the fire in the hearth and the fire in the heart are the same. The discipline of the outer rite is a reflection of the inner discipline.

The Three Worlds The rishis recognized the three worlds of physical being, psychological being, and spiritual being as one, not separating them, as we may do. (Actually, the spiritual is now opaque to most people, and even the psychological is understood as a mere physical process.) Hence, the sun is not just an astronomical body providing light to the physical world but also the source of light to the mind as the inner sun. Hence, the sun, moon, and earth, trees, etc., understood at the level of soul and spirit, are revered because God is in the midst of them. That is, the whole creation is pervaded by God.

Two Conceptions of God The Hebrews begin with God's transcendence. God is infinitely high above the heavens and descends to the prophets, becomes incarnate in Jesus, and so on. That is, it is a movement of descent from above.

The Hindu starts in the opposite way. God is immanent in every created thing. Of course, Christians pay lip service to the idea of omnipresence, but have largely lost the experience of it. Hence, these two visions are complementary, not opposed.

Of course, God as transcendent to the physical cosmos is one thing, but God as transcendent spiritually is another. Hence, we should also understand transcendence in our interiority, in our "heart", as the I that watches the flow of consciousness. Many theological conundrums can be resolved through spiritual experience and understanding.

Griffiths concludes the first lecture with a call for the Church to be enriched from the encounter with other religions, just as it absorbed European paganisms. However, I believe he is neglecting a certain fundamental point. Europeans and the people who were formed around the Vedic revelation have the same ancestors. Hence, there is a certain affinity

of the Vedic revelation to the West which makes it more appropriate.

As the Church has been expanding into Africa and elsewhere, there is an encounter, as he points out, with those aboriginal religions, leading, for example, to cults like Santeria. However, as much as it may be valid for them, that is not our present concern.

The Cosmic Covenant Griffiths next tries to relate the Vedic Revelation to Biblical Revelation. Biblical history is punctuated with a series of covenants. The first one was God's covenant with Adam, which just means "man". Since God was revealed to all mankind, Griffiths calls it the Cosmic Covenant. Its origin is in Paradise, which is that state where man is in harmony with nature and God.

This harmony has been broken. For example, ecological issues reflect the disharmony of man with nature. Wars, crime, conflict, etc., reveal the lack of harmony of man with man. Finally, the communion with God has been lost. The loss of the primordial harmony is called Original Sin. Salvation, then, is the restoration of that primordial harmony.

The next covenant was with Noah, from whose descendants all the nations of the world arose. As the father of mankind, this was a re-expression of the Cosmic Covenant. Thus, all the valid Traditions are rooted in that covenant. There are righteous pagans in the Bible, such as Enoch.

Griffiths then turns to Melchizedek, the pagan priest and king of Salem. In his conversation with Abraham, Melchizedek appeals to the "most high God, the creator of heaven and earth." Griffiths takes this to mean that there was a revelation to the pagans, specifically mentioning the Amerindians and the Hindus. He makes the interesting point that Christ was a priest in the order of Melchizedek, not in the order of Hebrew priests starting with Aaron.

Griffiths provides scriptural support for this claim. In Paul's letter to the Romans, we read that there are two sources of revelation to the pagans.

1. The creation of the world. Paul writes, "His invisible nature is made known by the visible things He has made." (Romans 1:20)

2. Within the Heart of man. Again, Paul writes, "The Pagans who have not the law of Moses have a law written in their hearts: their conscience accusing or perhaps excusing them until the day when God will judge the world by Jesus Christ." (Romans 2:14)

In other words, these are the revelations of the macrocosm and the microcosm, and are relatable to the Pythagorean and Hermetic initiations described by Valentin Tomberg in Letter VI of *Meditations on the Tarot*.

The Sky Father Early man had not acquired the habit of abstract thought, as his mode of thinking was more intuitive. As was pointed out earlier, he saw the physical, the psychological, and the spiritual worlds in their integrated wholeness. **Mircea Eliade**, in *Patterns of Comparative Religion*, shows how primitive man could come to an almost total understanding of God simply by looking at the sky. Griffiths summarizes it this way:

> Consequently, when he [early man] looked up at the sky, the sky was a revelation to him. It was not merely the physical phenomenon which we see; to him the sky had a psychological meaning and a spiritual meaning. It revealed the creator present in his creation.

Therefore, there are several things to be intuited.

- The sky is vast and infinitely above us. This is a revelation of God.

- The sky has no apparent limit, unlike all other objects we experience. The sky is all-embracing, without limit, revealing the idea of infinity.

- Everything in the world is changing. Life arises and dies, the sun rises and sets, the seasons change, etc. Yet the sky is unchanging, just like God.

- There is an order in the sky, so by analogy there is a Cosmic Order.

Griffiths gives examples of how the image of God as immense, infinite, eternal, the source of order, providence and fear, arises, based on the experience of nature (e.g., rain → providence, thunder → fear). We have discussed several times the method of Hermetic meditation in order to recover that primordial state. Also, learn to use the analogy of being to see the connectedness between the physical, psychological, and spiritual worlds.

The Vedas mention the ancient God "*Dyaus Pita*", or literally "Sky Father". In Greek that becomes "*Zeus Pater*", then in Latin, "*Dios Pater*", or "Jupiter". Hence we see, through philology, how the Hyperborean migrations related to each other. So, when Jesus starts his prayer with "Our Father in the Sky", we see a reference to that most ancient revelation. ("Heaven" simply means "sky"; this is clearer in other languages.)

Angels and Cosmic Powers Although our world conception has been devitalized in the modern world through the materialization of our ideas of heaven and earth, as late as the Middle Ages, men believed that God ruled the world through the angels, or "cosmic powers". The angels were present in all creation, especially the stars, sun, moon, and the "host of heaven." "The sky was not simply a material thing, it was the abode of the gods, the manifestation of the Supreme Spirit, the Supreme Father, who ruled over all." Griffiths emphasizes that we have not "progressed" beyond that understanding; rather, the modern view is actually a devolution. He then uses the following example from Hinduism, the highest expression of the cosmic revelation.

> There we have the worship of God through the power of nature. The devas, literally "the shining ones," are these cosmic powers manifesting themselves in the whole creation. In Hinduism the supreme Reality is known as Brahman, and this Brahman, the One Being, manifests himself in the devas, the gods, the powers which rule the creation.

Hence, there is the hierarchy, or chain, of Being just as the Medievals believed. This hierarchy starts with the Supreme Being who transcends all, then the devas, the powers of nature, man with intelligence and sense, and finally the world below him. The difference is that this understanding has been lost in the West.

Sacrifice Griffiths next goes into some detail about the Hindu mode of worship. Apparently his order developed what he calls the "Indian rite" of the mass. First, water is used to symbolize purification. Then there is the bread and wine, which represent the fruits of the earth and the work of human hands. Flowers are placed around them to signify that the sacrifice is at the centre of the universe. Then they incense the gifts and wave fire as the flame of burning camphor. Christ, then, is the sacrifice of the whole creation to the Father.

The Presence of God Griffiths offers a helpful interpretation of the Hindu trinity of Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva, as three forms of God. Vishnu as preserver pervades the whole universe. **Thomas Aquinas** describes how God is in creation this way:

- "God is in the whole creation by His power, because He sustains everything by his power." The Hindus call this power "Shakti".
- Since there is no "spatial" component in God, He does not exercise his power at a distance. Hence, he is in everything by His Presence.

> But not in the sense that everything is a "part" of God, who has no parts. Rather, He is present in His essence.

Once again, we have lost this sense of the presence of God, as totally pervaded by God. Several years ago, a woman told me she envisaged God as like a "gas"; of course, that is simplistic yet I was struck at the time that it indicated some level of understanding of that pervading presence.

The Triple Character of God Griffiths lists these as the triple character in God:

- **Nirguna Brahman**. That is without qualities, without attributes, beyond everything which can be conceived.
- **Saguna Brahman**. God with attributes, conceived as Creator, Lord, Saviour.
- **Atman**. This is God dwelling in each person as his own inner spirit.

In Christian terms, the first is the Father, the Source, the Beyond (Nirguna Brahman). That Father manifests Himself in the Son, or the Word, the self-manifestation of God (Saguna Brahman). Finally God is present in man's innermost spirit, the Spirit of God (Atman).

Griffiths is not trying to convert anyone to Hinduism, or a crypto-Hinduism, but rather he uses it as a tool to recover our own past.

The Cosmic Mystery

> That Self, which is free from sin, free from old age, from death and grief, from hunger and thirst, which desires nothing but what it ought to desire, and imagines nothing but what it ought to imagine, it is that which we should search out; that which we must try to understand. He who reaches that Self and understands it gains all the world of desires.

Chandogya Upanishad

Lead the thoughts from the head into the heart and keep them there.

With this saying of the Greek fathers, **Bede Griffiths** describes the opening of the Heart to the Cosmic Mystery. The Upanishads likewise need to be read that way. Although there are 108 Upanishads in theory, the twelve principle Upanishads are what matter.

From the *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*, Griffiths identifies three words that signify the Godhead: Brahman, Atman, Purusha.

- **Brahman**. Brahman is the source of all creation or the ground of all being.
- **Atman**. Atman, the Self, is the ground of all consciousness.
- **Purusha**. God as Person.

There is a progressive realization that Brahman, Atman, and Purusha are all One. This chapter is concerned with the first two. The understanding of the word "Brahman" illustrates Griffiths' powerful methodology.

The root of Brahman is "Brh" which means "to grow or to swell", which is the physical meaning. The psychological and spiritual meaning then identifies this "swelling" as the rising up of the awareness of God. Hence, he explains:

> The word Brahman came to mean a prayer, something which rises up in the heart, swells within, breaks out and opens up to the divine, to a mystery beyond. Man is in search of this hidden mystery, and it is a mystery which cannot be named.

Sacrifice Griffiths reminds us that "sacrifice was the centre of all ancient religion." Since everything comes down from above, it must be returned. Thus, the sacrifice is the return to God, and sin is the opposite, the appropriation of something to one's self. This rhythm of the world — coming forth from, and then returning to, God — is *rita*, or cosmic order. When you live in that rhythm, you are said to be turning the wheel of the law, the dharma chakra. When you sin, you are going against the law of the universe.

Brahman is the power which sustains the sacrifice and sustains the whole creation. There are two aspects.

1. Brahman is the source of everything.

2. Brahman pervades the universe.

Griffiths rejects the misunderstanding that this represents a form of pantheistic monism. Griffiths then discusses several stories from the Vedas, which we can't summarize here, other than to point out that some truths can only be expressed by stories, parables, myths, and the like.

Positive and Negative Approaches Since Brahman can never be fully encompassed in words, two methods developed to aid understanding. The positive and negative approaches are not unlike cataphatic and apophatic Christian theology. In the first approach, imagery is used to describe the ineffable. The richness of such symbols is adequately described in several of Rene Guenon's works.

In the negative approach, Brahman is "*neti, neti*", or "not this, not that". That is, no image or concept will ever be adequate. Once again, the "head" will fail us, but the "heart" will see. Griffiths reminds Christians of the same thing.

The Hidden Source Few people try to find the hidden source of the things in the phenomenal world. Once again, Griffiths illustrates this with a story about a Brahman youth who learned Sanskrit, memorized the Vedas, and so on. After his studies, the youth returned to his Father, who asked him:

> Svetaketu, as you are so conceited, considering yourself so well-read and so learned, my dear, have you ever learned of that instruction by which we hear that which cannot be heard, by which we perceive that which cannot be perceived, and by which we know that which we know that which cannot be known?

The son did not know, so the father showed him a fruit from a banyan tree and opened it up. When asked, the son said he saw several seeds. When the father broke a seed and asked again, the son said he saw nothing. The father explained that the banyan tree arose from the subtle essence that cannot be seen.

An analogous idea in Eastern Christianity is that all things participate in God's creative energy through an inner principles, or *logoi*. This is explained at *The Uncreated Energy (logoi) of God in Nature*[5]. (H/T **Ekzy'l**)

Thou Art That The deepest mystery of the Upanishads is "*Tat tvam asi*", "Thou are That". This does not mean "I am God", as some Western wannabe Vedantists have told me. That is how it must sound to the thinking rationalizing mind, but its mystical meaning is:

> I, in the deepest centre, the ground of my being, am one with that Brahman, the source of all creation.

[5] `https://thoughtsintrusive.wordpress.com/2015/01/05/the-energy-of-god-in-nature`

Although Griffiths does not express it in these terms, this shows us the two ways to the mystery of God. In the macrocosmic way, we look at the world and recognize God as the hidden source behind the world of phenomena. In the microcosmic way, we look within ourselves to find the source of our own being.

The Four States In following the path to the source of our own being, there are four states of consciousness. We identify the Self with one of those states, depending on what we understand to be real.

Waking State In this state we take our ordinary waking state to be the most real. We are a body, we have experiences, we pursue money, sex and power, and so on. But all this passes away, so this cannot be the real Self.

Dream State A man or woman may then try to find something more real, more immortal. So they look within. They learn to recognize their thoughts, feelings, desires, fears, likes, dislikes, and so on. At this point, people will be led to consider their Personality to be the real Self. Nevertheless, the personality will perish along with the body.

Sleep State Those who go further will learn to detach from the personality, recognizing the real Self is neither the body nor the personality. At this point they may discover something deeper. They will see that much of their life is "just happening". The body adopts certain postures and movements on its own. Thoughts and feelings arise from some deeper part of oneself, beyond conscious control. Hence the real Self is beyond any conscious awareness of it. This is the state of deep, or dreamless, sleep.

Turiya The fourth state is beyond all the waking, dreaming, and sleep states, yet integrates them all. This is the true Self. We are so accustomed to believe that mind and reason are the supreme principles. But that is illusion (*maya*) and ignorance (*avidya*). Yet turiya is beyond thought.

Ego Death Griffiths relates the story of Nachiketas, who does down to the underworld and meets Yama, the god of Death. He explains:

> This is a fundamental principle of all religious teaching. If you want to reach your true Self, if you want to find God, you have to die. In the Christian tradition baptism is death. To be baptized is to participate in the death of Christ. The ego has to undergo this death, the ego, which is the person the mask which we seek to preserve.

Nachiketas is offered three boons by Yama.

1. Nachiketas asked to be reconciled with his father. The seeker has left home in search of Truth. He eventually needs to return to be reconciled with his pat, with the tradition of his family and people.

2. Nachiketas asks to understand the fir sacrifice, which is the offering of everything in the Cosmic fire of life.

3. Nachiketas asks to know what lies beyond death. At first, Yama declines to answer, but finally explains about the Self, Atman, and so on.

Unfortunately, few are those today who would accept those boons. Words like "God", "soul" and so one have lost all significance as they don't correspond to experience. Even the religious, who may know doctrines, do not know God in their hearts.

The Abyss Real doctrine cannot be obtained by argument. Instead, Faith is necessary, when understood as an "illumination of the mind". It comes by hearing. Beyond death by baptism, the illumination of faith, there is something else, as the Upanishads put it:

> The wise man, who, by means of meditation on his Self, recognizes the Ancient One who is difficult to be seen, who has entered into the dark, who is hidden in the cave, who dwells in the abyss as God; he indeed leaves joy and sorrow far behind.

This is the experience of God in the darkness, and the Ancient One is the primeval source of your being.

Posted on 2015-03-08 by Cologero

* * *

`obscure on 2015-03-10 at 02:26 said:`

I notice you mention univocity, so I must warn you away from the narratives being produced by the 'radical orthodoxy' movement wherein they derive some rubbish from Heidegger and Deleuze about Duns Scotus. I am referring of course to the 'univocity of Being'. Their narratives however are not derived from familiarity with Scotus' work. Scotus argued that being is predicated univocally because the analogy is contained in the subject per se. Namely, Scotus argues that we begin metaphysics with an intuition of Being and this raises a disjunctive: finite or infinite? The mode of understanding the infinite subject is analogy and is not found in the mode of predication. Scotists call this doctrine 'real analogy' as opposed to the older doctrine of 'analogical predication'. However, scholars don't often read the fullness of the primary sources and are unfamiliar with whole systems; they are interested in narratives. Nothing new of course.

Scotus in a sense improves upon St. Thomas rather than contradicts him, hence he is called the 'subtle doctor' while Thomas is the easier-to-grasp 'common doctor'. Scotus also promoted the 'absolute primacy of Christ'. which you may be interested in. The Franciscans promote it today, but Scotism is overshadowed by the more popular Neo-Thomism. Absolute primacy is a very important theological doctrine once it is understood adequately, since it entails that theosis is more fundamental than redemption (most important site for the doctrine):

`http://absoluteprimacyofchrist.org/`

Mark Citadel on 2015-03-10 at 23:43 said:

It was through the stunning accuracy of the Doctrine of the Ages and the predictions of the Kali Yuga in the Vedic Tradition that led me to my current stand as a mild Christian Hermeticist (a less bold perennialism). There is simply no other way of explaining how this doctrine so accurately reflects the cyclical degeneration of mankind other than some higher revelation given to its author. Whether this was angelic or diabolical in nature is largely irrelevant, both angels and demons have their role in the order and balance of the Divine Realm, both being products of 'primordial' origin.

If one takes Christianity as the final revelation from God, he need not totally discount some elements of truth in other earlier faiths that may have had lower orders of divine influence, as long as they are not mutually exclusive. In fact, studying these faiths that also fed from the ever-present and almost riverine qualities of the World of Tradition, can lead to a greater appreciation and understanding of Scripture, of God, and of the Divine Realm. Even studying the perverse and fiendish cults of the Canaanites and such can give us insight into the nature of the demonic entities that presumed the status of gods over these debauched peoples and thus some knowledge of these entities that are beyond any realm of practical study and examination.

Great post by the way.

Saint-Efficace on 2015-03-19 at 06:41 said:

"… the gods are names and forms under which the one God manifests himself. That is, they are more or less the equivalent of "angels" or the "cosmic powers" mentioned by St Paul."

Of course The Church does not believe and teach that angels are names and/or forms under which God manifests Himself, or any such nonsense. Quite the contrary. She also disagrees with Griffiths (as well as Guénon) on the inspired character of the Vedas. It is worth noting perhaps that the particular attempts at rapprochement of Catholic and Hindu positions of Griffiths c.s., however slight their resonance in the Catholic Church, have met with typical indifference and r a t h e r w o r s e among Hindus. Exceeding one's brief never was a good idea.

Anyway, Catholics, unlike (most) Hindus, still avoid like the plague any worship of angels as of false gods, "quoniam omnes dii gentium daemonia" (Ps XCV: v) or, in the venerable English translation, "For all the gods of the Gentiles are devils" (Douay-Rheims) following the Greek *pantes hoi theoi to:n ethno:n daimonia* (LXX)

Like the modernisers you can have them as "idols" if you want – which, if you will permit me, I venture to doubt you do, somehow – following the Hebrew: (kol elohei HaAmim elilim) of the trimmed MT. The reference is 96:5 in that case. Hardly an improvement for the case of the Devil's Party. Silver, gold, rocks, stones, devils – the Gentiles were happy enough to worship any of them. Your modern Gentlile, of course, desperately tries to join in, adding paper – but as often as not proves to be worshipping but the Self.

Cologero on 2015-03-29 at 00:48 said:

It's my bad, Saint-Efficace. The question marks appeared because this blog does not support UTF8 encoding, which was not the default when it was created. It would take too much effort to change the encoding at this point.

So now we can move onto your bad. In your zeal to be super-correct, you have misread or misunderstood the text. Of course, Griffiths did not say that the angels are names or forms of God. That is the Vedic claim and he offered an alternative explanation, much as Thomas Aquinas did in respect to the Greeks. See Angels and Demons for an explanation.

Now I can quote the Bible as well as you, though probably not as well as the devil to which you refer. Following Griffiths, I offered a biblical explanation for a type of "inspiration" and even pointed out that there is a greater revelation. That is perfectly orthodox teaching.

What Griffith does with the Vedic teaching is not unlike what the Fathers did with Plato and Thomas with Aristotle. Griffith's aims are not what you claim; in any case, the ideal of a "rapprochement" was never mentioned in the post, so it is out-of-bounds in a cross-examination. Moreover, as we have explained previously, we deal with a text by (1) bringing out its logical conclusions and (2) placing it into a larger perspective. Please try to make an effort to see that and then reconsider your comment.

This larger perspective takes Augustine seriously when he claims there is but one tradition.

Saint-Efficace on 2015-04-01 at 03:55 said:

Cologero, this being the Internet, I realise the mere text of a post may give more of an offensive impression than intended, so please, accept an aplogy. Not that I don't stand by what I wrote; I merely intended it as a kind of reminder, not as an attack. The devil, being the first 'Plotestant' as well as the first Jacobin can probably quote Scripture better than either of us. I have always agreed with St Augustine on the tradition. A reading, time permitting, of an essay by Robert Fastiggi and Jose Pereira, titled "The Swami from Oxford" gives a good indication of where I tend to come from with respect to such issues and Fr Grifiths in particular after several decades of interest – summarising better than I could and saving me more typing than perhaps ought to be done in a comment box. It was in Crisis Magazine, but Catholic Culture has it here:

http://www.catholicculture.org/culture/library/view.cfm?id=3427

(I can't help thinking you might also be interested in James Arraj's work "Christianity in the Crucible of East-West Dialogue" which goes over much of the matter here discussed – and more besides. You may already know it, of course. Online at

http://www.innerexplorations.com/catew/christia.htm)

Re St Augustine… As a reader of Tomberg you are no doubt aware of the interest in his work from the side of the Monastic Interreligious Dialogue/ Centering Prayer people; Fr Keating, Fr Pennington, Br Teasdale, Fr Barnhart… Some of the names, indeed, associated with Fr Griffiths

and his legacy. Golden Cain newsletter, 'Wisdom Christianity'? They appear to have it in for St Gus a bit. It's early centuries yet, of course but I must admit to a measure of unease.

Anyway thanks for the reply.

`argusandphoenix on 2015-03-17 at 22:41 said:`

Lewis has an interesting quote from Till We Have Faces:

"And in that far distant day when the gods become wholly beautiful, or we at last are shown how beautiful they always were, this will happen more and more (having dangerous enemies as one's own house). For mortals, as you said, will become more and more jealous. And mother and wife and child and friend will all be in league to keep a soul from being united with the Divine Nature…this age of ours will one day be the distant past. And the Divine Nature can change the past. Nothing is yet in its true Form."

`Logres on 2015-03-18 at 08:22 said:`

This is his take on "Grace Perfects Nature", and put in a poetic way. The density of the Kali Yuga is also a density of the gods mingling with men, which confuses things more, but has its own beauty.

`Mark Citadel on 2015-04-17 at 13:33 said:`

Yet again, fascinating stuff.

"Brahman, Atman, and Purusha"

Remarkable how this number 3 appears over and over again across theologies, isn't it? 'This Rough Beast' pointed it out just recently.

`David on 2015-04-17 at 23:37 said:`

Those kind of text are most interesting when linked with other text such as "Christianity and the doctrine of non-duality". I highly suggest it. Great stuff again, thank you.

`Cassiodorus on 2015-04-20 at 20:18 said:`

Christians, of course, affirm the reality of the soul. However, traditional Christianity also holds fast to the creature-Creator distinction and explicitly rejects the "supreme identity". Is this merely a confessional bias or does this reflect a fundamental metaphysical first principle? Every time I think I have made peace with classical theism's relationship to the Perennial Philosophy, these concerns of mine come bubbling up to the surface yet again.

`Cologero on 2015-04-20 at 20:24 said:`

Cassiodorus, Guenon claims that "traditional Christianity" is a valid tradition in his sense. I suspect you are misunderstanding something. Specifically, it is not just a matter of verbal

formulations but rather of a realization. You are over-thinking it.

Cassiodorus on 2015-04-20 at 22:19 said:

Cologero,

As always, I appreciate your graciousness and patience in putting up with my repetitiveness. But, I'm troubled by the possibility that I'm not missing something. It seems to me that orthodox Christianity (contra the Perennialist School), aligns much more with Madhva's "dualistic" school of Vedanta as opposed to Shankara's Advaita.

I understand that esoterism transcends all discursivity (a contradiction perhaps). Nevertheless, the Christian mystical tradition distinguishes itself from the jnanic schools in that it speaks of participation, not identity. This is the case because of Christianty's strict adherence to the creature-Creator distinction. It seems to me that Palamite theology bears this out in stark relief. Even though the doctrine of divinization is affirmed (putting aside that this ,again, refers to union, not identity), the Eastern Church still has to distinguish between God's Essence and His Energies. The creature can join with His Energies, but NOT with His Essence, not with what He is in Himself.

From my pov, the Supreme Identity, or "realization" in a Shankaran sense, is simply not on the map for a classical theist. Perhaps, a case can be made for a qualified nondualism of a sort argued for by the likes of a Ramanuja. But I think that even this kind of panentheism might be too "strong" to reconcile with Christian doctrine.

Kind Regards

David on 2015-04-21 at 04:15 said:

Cassiodorius : Have you read Vladimir Lossky on the subject, or "Christianity and the doctrine of non-duality" by an anonymous cistercian monk ? After reading those, you will find that it is not totally alien to Christianity, simply said differently and under different terms. Is it the most prevalent view ? Of course not, but it is not in India either. Is it heterodox ? No, as explained in the cistercian monk book. And this work is much interesting because he said specifically that he doesn't want to delve into mysticism (such as Eckhart) because using this would make it more open to "heterodoxy" criticism, and so he goes to major thinker such as St Bernard, St Thomas Aquinas, St Albert, etc. You should also read Dyonisus the Aeropagite.

Cassiodorus on 2015-04-21 at 18:18 said:

David, I appreciate the recommendations. I am familiar with those authors and works that you suggested. The book by the anonymous Trappist monk was a particularly interesting take on how one might look at the Incarnation from a Vedantin point of view. Nevertheless, it seems to me that is still very difficult to reconcile orthodox Christianity with Advaita Vedanta, that is, an unqualified nondualism. Perennialsts, such as Jean Borella, and Perennialist sympathizers such

as Stratford Caldecott and Robert Bolton, have written on this subject. As I said in my previous comment, the Christian mystical streams never appears to stray from a fundamentally bhaktic, that is theistic, framework. But why?

" Christianity is surely the religion of creation ex nihilo and of the human person loved forever by a God who is different from himself." Moreover, "Advaitins or perennialist non-dualists will find it hard to comprehend how the attainment of supreme realization might be made to depend on the incarnation of God at one particular point in history." – S. Caldecott

That being said, I don't think that a qualified nondualism poses the same problem. For example, Visistadvaita affirms that Reality is Brahman; however, individual souls are real and the universe is also real, being parts of Brahman or modes of His manifestation. This view, I think, "saves the appearances"- can safeguard both the "one and the many" and upholds our personhood as individuals.

9.8 Does Death Exist

Another man who followed the **road of excess** was **Miguel Serrano**. The same man, who believed in flying saucers and secret Nazi bases in the Antarctic, could also write with great depth and sensitivity about Tantric love and his meetings with sages of the East and the West. A modern day rishi, Serrano started having visions even before adolescence even if sometimes what he tried to make out in the darkness may seem dubious in the light of day. Humble in his interviews with the great yogis of India, he nevertheless often added a significant insight of his own, as we saw at the end of his interview with Krishnamurti[6].

In *The Serpent of Paradise*, Serrano paid a visit to **Krishna Menon** who had followers in South America and was described by Serrano as a "pure Vedantist". Serrano asked him this question, which every man has asked, or should have asked, himself at some point in his life.

> Do you believe in existence after death? Do the dead continue to live in some form, and can we meet them?

[6] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=2457`

The sage answered him thus:

> Vedanta tells us that life is an illusion and that the individual ego is also an illusion. How then can death exist, if life does not exist?

Serrano then mentioned his visions of the inner world and his experiences with astral travel. Menon attributed them to Serrano's having practiced yoga in a previous life. Serrano noticed a curious inconsistency of this response. In his own words:

> I have often found it curious that Vedantist philosophers and saints, who are otherwise absolute monists, always have a strong belief in reincarnation. For them, everything is illusion, but reincarnation and the individual karma persist, apparently apart from illusion. Thus I am told that I am suffering from the consequences of having practiced yoga in a previous life. Yet the only one who can activate jivanmukti and overcome illusion is a yogi.

Serrano then pointed out that Swami Menon himself had to deal with karma, for he suffered from chronic leg pain and underwent ayurvedic medical treatments.

Krishna Menon is now dead.

Posted on 2011-08-24 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2011-08-25 at 01:32 said:

That's interesting. Part of the reason I haven't given up Christianity is because it seems willing to "get its hands dirty" by talking about materiality (albeit in a spiritual sense or context). If Life is an illusion, can the illusion also be an illusion? Or even thinking one sees through it? And at some point, does it matter? If one's "heart" is in the right place? I am not sure.

Caleb C on 2011-08-25 at 01:44 said:

I don't agree with traditional Buddhism on this, but if I understand Evola's interpretation, reincarnation and karma both exist, but they aren't personal; like a candle from one flame lighting another flame; an essence is passed on, but it is still another flame.

The soul becomes suffused with the karma of it's current incarnation, but at death diffuses back toward the source, like a raincloud emptying into the sea. The soul that is inherited by a new being is highly unlikely to be the same as a previous soul, but rather a new mixture, partially determined by what the blood attracts, and also the resonance of form and action. Saying someone did something in a past life in this case is a shorthand for saying that they inherited an influential piece with that attribute.

Whether one accepts reincarnation without a persistent individual depends we believe the soul maintains its coherence. However, if we don't accept the existence of time it's pretty hard to argue that the soul would decohere.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-08-27 at 14:39 said:

That's a very astute observation from Caleb with respect to Time – or 'time'. as the case may be. My own view on Reincarnation / 'reincarnation' is that as we attain consciousness it is possible to discern both the history of the cosmos and the history of one's own soul within the self during its present life, which is of course bound by time in this dimension. There are other dimensions where time-space are meaningless, where we are free of that continuum. Ultimately the soul on the path of return would aim to free itself from the weight of karma, to be released from this history, which may be akin to a shadow of great density that keeps it from rising. This is a task so difficult that many probably try to avoid it, albeit unconsciously, by directing their endeavours towards liberating the higher (pure) self by severing it from its shadow – like a Fool deciding to dump his sack. This inevitably leads to a dualistic impasse, whereas the greater challenge consists in transforming the dark leaden shadow (something which has power in an individual sense) into the gold that will allow the unified being to rise, as if along sunbeams, to the deathless source of all life and eternal bliss, where there is no death, just timeless beauty, endless love, unadulterated ecstasy and all other good things. Our 'karmic relations'. are invaluable in helping us to understand how to accomplish this task. To master time travel here is another key to accomplishment. It should be visualised as a spiral rather than a line or a circle, with epochs stacked upon each other like layers of an onion, thus from a higher perspective the distance between them is removed; past lives are like vibratory echoes from the deeper layers and our consciousness of them comes from occupying a similar point in space. Thus Caleb's point about the 'new mixture' is also accurate. There is always a way out of the circle that appears to be closed, it's only a matter of adjusting one's perception – or 'waking up' or turning around. There is a very simply analogy I have for describing the state of unenlightened souls. It is as if their essential selves are lying face down in dark earth and therefore cannot help but believe there is nothing to see and nowhere to go. Thus can an individual be 'face

down' for eternities – millions of years – until somethin gives it the impetus to turn around in its shell (the physical body) and open its eyes onto the 'new world' that suddenly appears when the lights 'come on'. Of course the lights were always on but the soul had its back turned and did not realise. Life here is real (another very difficult concept to fully grasp for a soul occupied fully with the great work and path of return, where spiritual essences seem more real than earthly ones and there is a clearly perceivable distinction between those realms. Because of this confusion – caused by Maya, which in itself is an instrument of the Creator enabling the function of free will – many souls do not fully incarnate, but as soon as the become conscious attempt to return at once to their source rather than take the whole rocky road down and risk – so they fear – never getting back up again.) and so is death. Resurrection is a greater reality than both of these.I do not think it is necessary to remember past lives in order to be enlightened and, I should also point out, on the other hand there are those souls so great that their karma is equivalent to a pair of wings rather than a sack on the back....

Sumanta on 2012-02-11 at 13:25 said:

And how does the individually manifested self come to realize the unity of existence? By undertaking a journey, which features it taking on a succession of material bodies as it progresses on its path of realization. The concept of reincarnation is thus compatible with the concept of absolute monism.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-02-12 at 08:43 said:

i see reincarnation in a less 'usual' way but then I am not a monist, I distinguish between Creator and Created. In the last life (ie, this one) one can/will 'reincarnate' a number of times via a process that is probably seen as synonymous with 'initiation'. which as we have seen is about beginnings. This necessarily entails 'going back' to the primordial origin (the Adam/Eve) and 'returning' from this position, expanding the consciousness to the extent that one comprehends the soul as mirror of the cosmos, and in particular the course of human history. This is something we've spoken of before, the past is ever present, every man is every man and every woman is every woman, with all the opportunities and drawbacks this entails. We carry the sins of our brothers and sisters as well as our own, but equally we can share in their joys and loves. In this we are as one, but not absolute, the mystery remains, God is greater.

Francisco on 2015-03-28 at 00:36 said:

Have been at a snails pace, looking back through what I have of Serrano in print, or pdf. When first encountering him, about 15 years ago, he helped to support some confirmation bias regarding zoological racism. Then, I drifted apart from his thought, as it seemed just downright kooky–with "UFOs" and related matters. Both estimations were in error. Upon approaching him again, my tendency is to see so very much of his writing as a great, immensely clever, and over-

the-top, deliberate Hermetic "mask", intricately woven from two fabrics: some threads directly out of the intact traditional world, others from the side of the dissolution. He appears to daringly take, for instance, discarded and detested "forms"–such as the politician-man Hitler, and use the "form" in a way that "throws off" both literal "rightists", and at the same time, those who would object, or reject, on liberal grounds.

Hermetists always seem to miss something in their fundamental symbolism. The "Ouroborus" never ceases moving while consuming its own tail–thus, what "appears" to be "Hermetic" at some time and place, is already expressed differently by the time it reaches the observer. It is never made "fixed" until fixed within the individual being. Then there is Hermes himself, "trickster", always changing the game rules–or maybe. There can not be equivalent "initiations" for any individuals, Geunon states, citing the rule of identity; and with Hermetism, the mask must change frequently, using even some of the most bizarre and outlandish means of expression–Serrano it seems, was one of a very different "race" living in modern times, as a "witness", to have worn a most unusual, and nearly impervious mask.

> Michael on 2023-08-24 at 11:02 said:
> Not falling under causation: how could this make the monk a fox?
> Not ignoring causation: how could this make the old man emancipated?
> If you come to understand this, you will realize how old Hyakujō would have enjoyed five hundred rebirths as a fox.
> Not falling, not ignoring:
> Two faces of one die.
> Not ignoring, not falling:
> A thousand errors, a million mistakes

9.9 The Marriage of the Sun and the Moon

> Has anybody, at the end of the nineteenth century, any idea what poets of stronger ages called *inspiration*? If not, let me describe it.
>
> With the smallest residue of superstition within oneself, one would indeed hardly escape the idea of being merely the incarnation the mouth-piece, the medium of super-human powers. The idea of revelation, in the sense that suddenly with incredible certainty and subtlety, something becomes *visible* and audible,

> shaking us and overpowering us in our deepest being: all this is merely a description of facts. One listens, one does no search; one accepts, one does not ask, who is giving; like lightning a thought flashes up, with necessity, without hesitation with regard to its form – I never have had a choice.
>
> An *ecstasy of joy*, whose immense tension sometimes dissolves into a stream of tears, and whose pace is sometimes like a storm and sometimes becomes slow; a state of being completely beside oneself, yet with the clearest consciousness of an infinite number of fine tremors and wave-like vibrations running *down to the very toes*; a depth of *happiness*, in which all that is painful and dark, does *not act as a contradiction* but as a necessary condition, a challenge, as a necessary colour within such an *abundance of light*; an instinct for rhythmic proportions, which spans extensive realms of form — the extension, the need for an all-encompassing rhythm ins almost a criterion for the *power of inspiration*, a kind of compensating counter-force against its pressure and tension.
>
> All this happens involuntarily in the highest degree, and yet like a storm of *freedom*, of *unconditionality*, or *power*, of *godliness*... The *involuntary character of the inner image*, the simile, is the most remarkable part; one has no more the slightest idea what is image or simile, everything offers itself as the nearest, the most adequate, the simplest expression.
>
> Friedrich Nietzsche

Lama Anagarika Govinda compares Nietzsche's experience to similar experiences of the meditative state of dhyana described in Buddhist texts:

1. The visualization of inner experience.

2. The feeling of rapture and bliss, even down to the toes, i.e., to the smallest part of the body.

3. The bridging of contrasts through the incorporation and integration of all qualities and all Chakra centres.

4. The increasing luminosity of the mind and the gradual transfiguration of the body.

5. The feeling of release and freedom, beyond personal volition.

6. The awakening of powers of siddhis by awakening the psychic centres, and the attainment of the highest realization in the state of Perfect Enlightenment.

The Lama points out that when the mind becomes luminous, then the body takes part in the luminosity. The opposite path of trying to illuminate the body in order to illuminate the mind, does not work, even if the path begins with the body as we will describe in an upcoming post.

Please notice the passive, even priestly, aspect of Nietzsche's experience, as it involves a self-surrender, an inspiration. Yet that is not the whole story, since the lunar and solar energies must be integrated and sublimated as they rise from chakra to chakra. The attempt to be one or the other leads to imbalance. In the Dhammapada, we read this description of the **Buddha**:

> The sun shines by day, the moon shines by night,
> The warrior shines in his armour,
> The Brahmin by his meditation.
> But the Buddha shines radiant both day and night.

Lama Govinda offers this commentary, keeping in mind what **Rene Guenon** says about the man who has realized all his possibilities:

> These are not merely poetical metaphors, but expressions connected with an ancient Tradition, whose roots lie deeper than any known form of religion.

> Sun and moon correspond to the forces of day and night, to the outwardly directed activity of the **warrior** and the inwardly directed activity of the **priest**. *The perfect man combines both sides of reality: he unites within himself the depth of the night and the light of day, the darkness of all-embracing space and the light of suns and stars, the creative primordial power of life and the luminous all-penetrating power of knowledge.*
>
> The primordial creative power of life is blind without the power of knowledge, of conscious awareness, and becomes an endless play of passions... The power of knowledge, without the unifying primordial force of life, turns into the deadly poison of the intellect, the demoniacal principle, aiming at the annihilation of life.
>
> Where, however, these two forces cooperate, penetrating and compensating each other, there arises the sacred flame of the enlightened mind, which radiates light as well as warmth, and in which knowledge grows into living wisdom, and the blind urge of existence and unrestrained passions into the power of universal love.

Posted on 2012-02-15 by Cologero

* * *

`tomi shevek on 2012-08-13 at 08:46 said:`

"The perfect man combines both sides of reality: he unites within himself the depth of the night and the light of day, the darkness of all-embracing space and the light of suns and stars, the creative primordial power of life and the luminous all-penetrating power of knowledge."

Does this include the perfect woman also?

`Cologero on 2012-08-13 at 12:17 said:`

@tomi shevek,

I don't believe that, at that time, writers were so concerned about "gender inclusive language". It seems to me that Govinda is describing the alchemical marriage, the joining of opposites. So the "perfect woman" would unite the same qualities.

tomi shevek on 2012-08-14 at 06:09 said:
Thank You, That's what I wanted to hear.

tomi shevek on 2012-08-14 at 06:15 said:
I have just recently discovered your site and am finding a lot of interesting things to read, though I have to admit at the moment much of it is beyond my experience. Nevertheless I intend to plough on.

Aleksandar Gueric on 2015-10-14 at 05:02 said:
Lama Anagarika Govinda explains a Solar-Lunar dichotomy very good in "Foundations of Tibetan Mysticism". And there is one quote I remembered from another book, I think "The Secret Doctrine": "Moon is mind, Sun is understanding".

I believe these qualities embody every aspect of our being, from mental, psychological to even physical, through a ever lasting tension between the two (with alchemy being a science of balancing them out), so that dominant force manifests itself in various ways – psychologically perhaps through introversion and extraversion, physically probably in different types and races, with nordic, nordid, or, what we consider Aryan in general, being Solar, and Semitic escpecially being Lunar (physically and psychologically)

I did those Jungian personality tests and they all "showed" that I'm INFJ, with "I" standing for Introversion, "N" for intuition (preferred to sensing), "F" for feeling over thinking and "J" for judgement over perception. I have a feeling that first two are Lunar aspects, if not all four. Maybe I'm wrong. But introversion definitely is Lunar, it is inward, mysterios, contemplative. In school I never felt any interest in math or logic, but loved to just think and imagine. I have imagined whole worlds that could fill volumes. Recently I trained this logic, rational side with Wittgenstein, although probably not too successfully.

Then, as a young adult I manifested Dionysian aspect, overwhelmingly over the Apollonian. I was interested in anything shamanic, tantric, ecstatic, orgiastic and erotic, resulting in the years of existence in unmolded, raw potentiality. Around that time my idea of living further north as possible was born. Another example of unabalanced currents. One girl then told me, after telling her I want to live in arctic or at least subarctic circle, that I have too much fire within and thus feeling drawn by the cold, dark north. This could be true, but I see now it's just a result of disbalance. Not realizing my Apollonian essence, my being intiutively gravitated towards the physical location. I acted horizontally, instead of vertically. Luckily I haven't moved to Svalbard.

These changed finally when I hit 30. Although always being Solar in my essence, I could finally enjoy it's warmth and light after spending years in darkness. A cycle needed to be completed. Not that I'm saying I balanced myself out, I just went through one revolution, in a period of 27-30 years and I feel awakened only now at the beginning of 30s – compared only to a

previous stage. I can only imagine what is the next one. I try not to become "too solar", although undoubtebly I probably am right now. Interestingly enough, soon after realizing my awakened Solar essence I met a girl who is of Lunar essence and coming from a lunar Asiatic culture, and we balance each other out As almost as if my being, getting rid of a portion of lunarity (instead of harmonizing it), projected outwardly, outside of myself, bringing the outter Moon into my life.

My Lunar side is still present, though. I will probably always be introvert, although I can be social if I want to. It takes to complete a whole first cycle to finally see all the good and bad sides and fix them. Transforming what is eventually negative into something positive.

Is it even possible to harmonize and balance these energies perfectly within ourselves? Probably, it should be. But to balance it all out, to perfect these psychic currents within takes time and huge effort. Meanwhile, we are to try living with them best as we can and never let any side run loose. Too much solarity is equally bad as too much lunarity. Perfect balance, in my opinion, makes one being a perfect master over his life and world around. Nothing is an accident anymore. But before reaching that stage, solar and lunar will effect our lives both inwardly and outwordly.

9.10 Unloosening the Knots

The Buddha took a silken handkerchief, tied a knot in it, held it up and asked Ananda: "What is this?" Ananda replied: "A silk handkerchief with a knot." The Buddha tied a second knot, then a third, and so on up to six knots. After each knot he asked Ananda the same question and got the same response.

The Buddha then said: "When I tied the first knot, you called it a knot, and so on." Ananda became puzzled and exclaimed: "Whether you tie a single knot or a hundred, they remain knots, though the handkerchief is made of variously coloured pieces of silk."

The Buddha admitted this and pointed out that although the piece of silk was one, and all the knots were knots, the difference lay in the order they were tied.

The Buddha asked how these knots could be untied. He pulled at the knots, but the knots became tighter. Ananda replied:

> "I would first find out how the knots were tied. For he who knows the origin of things knows also their dissolution. But can all the knots be untied at the same time?"
>
> The Buddha replied: "Not at all! Since the knots were tied one after another in a certain order, we cannot untie them, unless we follow the reverse order."

Lama Angarika Govinda relates these knots to the chakras, which are prior to any activities of the sense organs. He claims that this is why the path must start at the lowest chakras rather than the higher. In other words, we have to reverse the descent of the spirit into matter ("the coagulation of consciousness into a state of materiality") by untying the knots one by one in the reverse order in which we created them.

In Man and his Becoming, **Rene Guenon** describes this descent from Purusha (spirit) to Prakriti (prime matter). Ontologically and logically, the higher states are prior, but the lower states are created first in a temporal sequence. It is useful to try to understand this in the terms of the Western tradition, with its notion of levels of the soul[7]. In this understanding, the higher levels of the soul are to dominate the lower. Knots in the lower soul prevent the free flow of energy from the higher to the lower.

Attraction and Aversion The nutritive soul reacts through attraction and aversion. For example, a plant will bend toward the sun, although desert plants may turn away. In human consciousness, this is experienced as likes and dislikes. These take hold in our minds prior to conscious awareness and are thus automatic processes. As in the case for plants, these attractions and aversions may be useful. However, such as we are, they more often create knots in our nutritive souls, since they subject us to, for the most part, arbitrary attractions and aversions, from long forgotten sources, which no longer suit us in a healthy way.

[7] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3390

Nevertheless, this low level of awareness is very common. Men make decisions, even important decisions, on the basis of what they like or dislike, similar to tropism in a plant[8]. To unravel this first knot requires the awareness of our likes and dislikes and how they affect us.

Desire In the sensitive soul, the analogous process is experienced as desire. When desire is ordered to a man's happiness, it is well functioning. However, knots may appear as weakness (disorder of *thumos*[9]*) and concupiscence (disorder of* eros*)*. The way these knots manifest can be catalogued and be brought into conscious awareness.

Will Since the functions of the intellectual soul, or lower intellect, include knowledge and will, knots appear as ignorance and impotence (or malice). Concerted efforts must be made to gain knowledge and power.

Buddhi and Logos The highest, or transpersonal, states do not have an opposite. However, since they transcend the individual states, they are beyond our awareness insofar as we are knotted in an individual state. The first degree of manifestation is Buddhi, or higher intellect. Although it is formless, it still belongs to manifestation. Nonetheless,

> Buddhi transcends the domain not only of human individuality, but of every individual state whatsoever... If the Self, or Atma, is the Sun which shines at the centre of the entire being, Buddhi will be the ray directly emanating from this Sun and illuminating in its entirety the particular individual state ... while at the same time linking it to the other individual states of the same being.

But what is interesting to us most especially, is the symbolism of the Sun's reflection in the water. As Guenon explains it:

[8] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8349

[9] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1956

- The living soul is the image of the sun in water as the reflection of the "Universal Spirit" (Atma)
- The luminous ray confers existence upon this image
- The water reflecting the solar light is the symbol of universal passivity, common to all traditions
- Buddhi consequently derives from Prakriti, of which it is the first production
- The water represents the potential sum of formal possibilities, that is, the individual
- The sun's reflection is affected by the undulations and perturbations of the water

Note how this corresponds precisely with the Hermetic understanding[10]. The Buddhi is born from the reflection of the Holy Spirit on the waters. The more the waters are clear and calm, the more the reflection will be pure. The waters are disturbed by eddies and whirlpools, which are the knots of lower consciousness. This birth, of course, is not in a temporal sequence.

All doubts can be removed when Guenon points out that what the Vedantists mean by Buddhi is exactly what the Alexandrian theologians meant by Logos. So, in Western terms, the Hindu doctrine is that the Logos is born from the Holy Spirit and the Virgin.

Posted on 2012-02-19 by Cologero

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[10] `https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-word-is-made-flesh`

mleow on 2012-02-20 at 03:39 said:

Where is that initial qoute taken from featuring Buddha and Ananda? Is it some mahayana source behind it? I can't recall reading it in the pali canon. Surangama Sutra

9.11 The Perennial Wisdom

Sanatana has a dual meaning: perennial in the sense of perduring over time, but also "primordial", since what perdures had to exist at the beginning. Specifically, it lasts through a cycle, i.e., a Manvantara which is the duration of manifestation of a terrestrial humanity. Clearly, this is not alien to the Western tradition which understands that duration as starting with Adam and ending in the final judgment. Perennial is not the same as "eternal" since the latter means "beyond time". Nevertheless, Guenon understands Sanatana Dharma as the "reflection" in our world of the eternal.

Guenon next questions whether the Sanatana Dharma is equivalent to the Philosophia Perennis as understood by the Medievals. While Sanatana and Perennis are equivalent, Guenon claims that Philosophia is not exactly the same as dharma. The latter term refers to doctrine that is not understood as a theory, but "as a knowledge which must be effectively realized" and its applications extend to all modalities of human life, without exception.

> This cannot be passed over, since the modern mind rejects this, even those who claim to adhere to, or to be "influenced" by, tradition. In a traditional society, there is no distinction between the sacred and the profane. A "religion" is not restricted to the private sphere nor, a fortiori, is it a matter of choice or of conscience for the individual. Religion ties the community to the eternal and to reject or deny the religion is to ex-communicate oneself, i.e., to put oneself outside the community. All activities are regulated by

> religious law and ritual, things are clean or unclean, taboo or allowed. These are described in Fustel de Coulanges' *Ancient City*. When the neo-pagans start making decisions based on lightning strikes, the flights of birds, or the entrails of chickens, then they would show some understanding. But first of all, they must keep the hearth burning in their houses in memory of their ancestors. Unfortunately, they are embarrassed by their ancestors, just as the moderns are.

Dharma, moreover, implies the idea of permanence and stability of beings; specifically, regarding the preservation of beings, dharma resides in the conformity with their essential nature. This is certainly a key notion in Scholastic metaphysics which was concerned with understanding the essential nature of things. Moreover, a certain people or period also has its dharma; this notion was held by the Medievals who expressed typically in terms of angels or patron saints for nations, regions, and cities. Ultimately, there is a dharma for the human race, i.e., human nature, again an idea found among the Scholastics.

Dharma is the law proper to a cycle, formulated by the cosmic intelligence that reflects the Divine Will and expresses universal Order in it. In the West, this was called the Logos, the intelligence through which all things were made. Hence, Dharma is conformity to this cosmic order

After expanding on this point, Guenon equates the Sanatana Dharma to the Primordial Tradition. Through decline, this tradition has become hidden and inaccessible to ordinary humanity. It is the "first source and the common fund of all particular traditional forms, which proceed from it by adaptation to special conditions or a people or an epoch." However, no particular tradition form is identical with the Primordial Tradition but is rather a veiled expression of it.

Hence, and this important fact is too often ignored, the Sanatana Dharma is equivalent to no particular traditional form, including specifically the Hindu tradition. Is the problem of the white Hindu priest clear

now? First of all, he rejects and condemns the particular traditional form that is the Dharma for his people in their geographical location at this point in time. Furthermore, he assumes the Sanatana Dharma is the same as Hinduism. At best, this is a relative truth, because every other traditional form could rightly make the same claim. In effect, any of the forms could serve to express the perennial wisdom; Guenon chose the Vedas, whereas we prefer to use the Western tradition. What is dharma to one man at a particular place is adharma to a different man in a different place.

Guenon then equivocates on this point and seems to deviate from his usual cold Gallic logic. He asserts, despite what he just indicated, that the Sanatana Dharma *appears* to be bound more closely to the Hindu tradition, since it derives most directly from the Primordial Tradition and is a "sort" of external continuation of it. "Appear" and "sort" are weak words that indicate nothing more than opinion. Certainly, appearances are deceiving, especially in this case, and results perhaps from merely linguistic conditions. Let is call it instead the Perennial Wisdom.

First of all, as we indicated at the beginning, the Perennial Wisdom is the reflection in time of the eternal; i.e., it "derives" from the above, not from the before. Otherwise, traditions that lack a direct historical connection to Hinduism could never embody that Wisdom. Secondly, there is no such continuity, as the fall into the Kali Yuga was a definitive rupture with what came before. That is why there is no historical record or scientific proof of a superior age prior to the Kali Yuga.

Most importantly, it is false to assume that what is closest in time is necessarily closer in truth. Just the opposite, in fact. The definition of the Kali Yuga is the time in which the Primordial Tradition was forgotten. That forgetfulness is immediate, for to "remember" the Primordial Tradition is the same as to "know" it. You may have forgotten your wife's anniversary, but as soon as you remember it, you simultaneously know it. The Western wisdom says that the owl of Minerva flies at dusk, so that a more complete understanding comes only after things can be seen in

their full perspective.

Conversely, being distant in time does not necessarily mean more forgetfulness. When my mother was in the last stages of Alzheimer, she could not remember what she had for breakfast. However, I would sing old songs from the 30s and 40s with her. Those she would remember and she would sing along with me.

Posted on 2013-10-31 by Cologero

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kenneth shaw on 2013-10-31 at 09:38 said:

My sense of things is that, In the West, ebergy of the Tradition is transmitted through the image of Jesus. He functions as our Paramapurusa and Paramesvara.

Just recently I noticed that the name "Jesus" is linguisticly and structuraly indentical to Isha... which is a shortened form of Ishvara.

Logres on 2013-10-31 at 23:01 said:

Oh, I finally see what you mean by "remember" : you don't mean some experiential "flash-back" of a past life. You mean that to truly know something inwardly, you must be remembering it to begin with.

scardanelli on 2013-11-01 at 10:10 said:

Logres,

I tend to see it as Tomberg describes it, as consisting of both a vertical and horizontal memory. These are the two dimensions in which we can know- both symbolically or spatially and mythologically or related to time. To know an event from the past (or the future for that matter... see Cologero's post on the The Future of Prophecy) is to remember or know it in a horizontal fashion, and to know that which is above is to remember or know in a vertical fashion. We are bound by time and space, so these factors restrict our way of knowing. Yet the spirit is not bound by such things, so it is not necessarily remembering a past life, but a knowing that is not restricted by time and space. At least, that is my limited understanding.

Space Lizard on 2014-12-26 at 11:32 said:

"Is the problem of the white Hindu priest clear now?"

What about the white Sufi?

9.12 The Four Happinesses

Taoism holds to the ideal of the four happinesses. The first two concern the extension of the individuality and are included in the restoration of the primordial state.

- **Longevity**: The perpetuity of individual existence.
- **Posterity**: The indefinite prolongations of the individual through all his modalities.

The remaining two refer to the higher and extra-individual states of the being.

- **Great Wisdom:** Learned master.
- **Perfect Solitude:** Peace of mind, inner quietude

The fifth happiness contains them all principally and unites them synthetically, i.e., the **Supreme Identity**.

From this, we see that longevity for its own sake is of no value. In popular culture, we admire elders who manage to accomplish physical tasks more appropriate to younger men, while precious few are interested in the state of Perfect Solitude.

Longevity, extending beyond one's reproductive capacity, makes no biological sense. Hence, the value of longevity is to provide more time to develop one's Real Self and to attain merits.

Posted on 2019-10-05 by Losang Shenphen

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AghorNath on 2019-10-05 at 11:24 said:
God bless you brother! Praying for your healing.

Sviatoslav on 2019-10-06 at 07:56 said:
His work is so unappreciated by today's world. Only a few know about Calogero's heroic mission. God bless him.

9.13 The Dragon Path

In *The Symbolism of the Cross*, **Rene Guenon** shows the influence of **Matgioi** in his expression of Tradition. In particular, the teachings of the Will of Heaven, the degrees of Existence, and the spiral path upward through the degrees, are taken from him.

Matgioi claimed to have been one of just five Europeans initiated into Chinese esoterism ('Society of Heaven and Earth'). He was motivated to describe those teachings according to the following plan:

> I was led to divide this work into three parts: one relates, under the title of "*Metaphysical Path*", the principles of the Tradition and its philosophical and cosmogonic movement: the second, under the title of "*Rational Path*" will relate the systematization of Tradition to Taoism, or Lao Tzu's "*Tao Te Ching*"; the third, under the title of "*Social Path*", will relate the adaptation of the Tradition, with the political philosophy of Confucius.

He never published the third volume. *The Metaphysical Path* is based on the *I Ching*, or *Book of Changes*. It is usually described today as a guide to divination. However, that indicates the degradation of a teaching. Just as the Tarot in the West concealed a complete metaphysical system through its symbols, in our time it has also become a tool for fortune telling.

Likewise, the *Emperor Fohi* collected the metaphysical and cosmogonic mysteries of the Primordial Tradition under the title I Ching. The set of 64 symbols contains the mysteries and describes how to reach higher stages. Symbols force one to surpass the intellectual function with its talk about God, in order to "see" God. In this selection from *The Metaphysical Path*, we see that path that the "gifted man" must follow.

Let us see, for example, in a few lines, how the initiate finds here rules for his conduct as a magician, for his special asceticism.

Hidden Dragon. — The gifted man must regulate his conduct according to the activity of heaven; the gifted man not having been instructed yet, the will of heaven is hidden from his insufficient eye: he therefore remains enveloped in his gangue of the imperfect mortal. The gifted man must therefore meditate, be silent, and try to develop himself in study and contemplation. If he acted while the dragon is hidden, he would not give his measure, and would fall into an error which would be prejudicial to his future.

Dragon in the Rice Field. — The gifted man is aware of his virtue, but cannot yet leave the earth. Little by little he improves beings through his teaching; but he is not yet permitted either to command or to manifest himself. He must only endeavor to follow the fortune and the example of the Mages who preceded him.

Visible Dragon. — The gifted man, placed in a situation inferior to his merits, is in danger; he must act with circumspection; for he attracts by his virtue the sympathy of the universe, and, by this sympathy, the hatred of his superiors. But whether he withdraws or stays, let him always take care to follow the normal path (Tao).

Jumping Dragon. — When the gifted man acts, it is never unrelated to the moment when he acts. He therefore increased his merits and his virtue to be distinguished at a precise and determined moment; he is free to move forward or backward; he retained all his freedom; he can edify by dazzling virtue, just as he can descend again in meritorious humility;

in this situation, he must take inspiration from the circumstances.

Flying Dragon. — The gifted man occupies the superior position which suits him. Having arrived at the heights of intelligence, it is sweet to look down on a man equally endowed with virtue, to help him with his examples and to associate him with his power. When one is in the fullness of one's means, one must act.

Hovering Dragon. — Infinite beauty is difficult to maintain. Also the gifted man must know how to advance and retreat in time so as never to expose himself to losing it. One should never be excessive in one's actions, even good ones.

To end a presentation which could go on indefinitely, let us give, without commentary, the six short, simple and rich apothegms by which Confucius, with his usual clearness and conciseness, determines, on the march of the Dragons, the normal conduct of the ordinary citizen. This quote will give a perfect idea of how the Chinese sages understand the moral law.

1. Do not change according to the age; do not cling to fame; flee the world; have no sorrow at not being appreciated or known by men.

2. Good faith in the smallest words; circumspection in actions; be on guard against lying; improve your society by transforming virtue without boasting about it.

3. Occupy a high position without being proud of it; occupy an inferior position without complaining about it.

4. Perfect your skills; take advantage of the opportune moment.

5. Act, and, by one's action, save the universe.

6. Be careful not to be too noble to have an occupation, and to be too elevated to have friends.

Posted on 2022-08-03 by Cologero

* * *

Johannes on 2022-08-03 at 23:10 said:

Thank you, Cologero, for all the work you've put into this for all these years.

Rui Artur on 2022-08-04 at 08:16 said:

This is incredibly useful! Thank you for this work.

Michael DeJoy on 2022-08-09 at 21:04 said:

Cologero, the references to Matgioi's I Ching fill a void which I have been aware of for many years. Many interpretations of the hexagrams often are mechanical or try to appeal to Western analysis, especially Wilhelm with Jung's introduction. Some offer literal translations which try to lead the reader in a direction the author thinks they should go, so the I Ching will "work" for them. The translation you provided of Matgioi's work is the kind of explanation at the heart of the matter, it provides insight for the reader at the same time calms him down during a time the reader is looking for needed direction. Thank you, Michael

Rui Artur on 2022-08-12 at 05:26 said:

It doesn't map exactly but there's something about this progression that seems to retrace Christ's steps from obscurity to glory. It also seems that Christ in a way breaks the 'rules' of each, he is able to escape the 'negatives' of each stage and hence progress (or perhaps progress despite the negatives).

Hidden Dragon – the time before His ministry starts.

Dragon in the field – 'mine hour is not yet come' – yet he changes the water into wine. these are the lesser mysteries, following the example of previous Mages.

Visible Dragon – cleansing of the temple, healing, etc – attracting the righteous, arousing the hatred of the Pharisees.

Jumping Dragon – miracles of circumstance, Christ doesn't seek to do wonders for wonders sake. He helps those who appear in need before him (the paralytic, the 5000 who need food, the blind man).

Flying Dragon – walking on water, the building of the Church, the 'adoption' of St. John.

Hovering Dragon – the Crucifixion, Resurrection and Ascension. Once the work is accomplished, He retreats.

Only a sketch, but I think there is something to it.

> Luis on 2022-08-19 at 06:01 said:
> Thanks. This is very helpfull

9.14 Subration

I recently pulled out a couple of old books and notes from a box packed up years ago. One is *Advaita Vedanta: A Philosophical Reconstruction* by the philosopher **Eliot Deutsch**. In reformulating Vedantic metaphysics in Western categories, he brings up some useful points. One is the idea of "subration" which he uses to translate the Sanskrit term *badha*. He defines it thus:

> *Subration* is the mental process whereby one disvalues some previously appraised object or content of consciousness because of its being contradicted by a new experience. A judgment about something is contradicted by a new experience when it is impossible to affirm both the previous judgment and what is learned or acquired in the new experience. … An object or content of consciousness is *subrated* or *subratable* when it is or can be disvaluated, denied, or contradicted by another experience.

He applies that definition to different levels of being as described in the Vedanta.

- **Appearance** is that which can be subrated by another experience.
- **Reality** is that which cannot be subrated by any other experience.
- **Nonbeing** is that which neither can nor cannot be subrated by other experience.

Subration involves:

1. A judgment about some object of content of consciousness (thing, person, place, condition, idea)

2. The recognition, in the light of another kind of judgment that is incompatible with the initial judgment, that the initial judgment is faulty

3. The acceptance of the new judgment as valid

How is this related to levels of being? Professor Deutsch points out that the more something is subratable, the less being it has. Clearly, then, the level of being corresponds to the level of knowledge. When we are asked judge not by appearances, but by a just judgment, we are asked to move from appearance to reality. Although Professor Deutsch provides detailed and subtle examples of the various levels and sublevels of being, we are cutting to the basics for now because we are more interested in relating them to esoteric experiences in particular.

Appearance There are three types of existents which account for appearances.

- **Illusory existent**. This comprises those contents of experience that can be subrated by all other types of experience. E.g., hallucinations, fantasies, daydreams, erroneous sense perceptions, false, inconsistent, incoherent, contradictory theories or concepts. They have no relationship to what is real.

- **Ordinary existent**. This can be subrated by other existents or Reality.

- **Real existent**. This can be subrated only by Reality.

The first focus must be the overcoming of illusion, since they absorb psychic energy while bringing us no closer to reality. We are buffeted by illusory inputs which challenge our opinions. But rather than subrating them, we protect ourselves with more complex theories or else hang on more tightly to established opinions. That is why esoteric work begins with the tedious process of breaking down our false self images through intense practice of self observation.

Ordinary existents are not as much false as they are incomplete. For example, we may engage in a relationship of convenience, thinking it is the real thing, yet it falls well short of a true spiritual friendship.

Or we may take things to be independent, failing to discern how they are part of a larger whole.

A real existent is the highest level of the experience of appearances since it cannot be contradicted by other experiences. We know a real existent by discursive thought, i.e., dualistically. This knowledge is subrated by non-dual knowledge.

Reality While illusory existents are mere mental artifacts and have no reality at all, the other categories of appearances do participate in reality. Specifically, they are possibilities of manifestation as manifested. Because of privation, they may not be properly recognized. But to know them is to know the idea of them. Since reality cannot be contradicted, it is non-dual. That is, "knowing is being". When I know the idea of a thing, I *am* that thing, at least in essence, since its idea is in my mind.

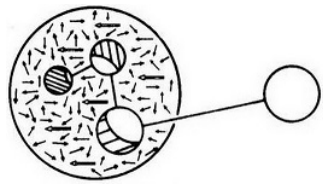
There are more and more comprehensive notions of the real, each higher level incorporating the lower into a larger whole, until Being itself is reached.

Nonbeing Prof Deutsch calls this "unreality", although I prefer **Rene Guenon**'s usage for reasons that follow. Prof Deutsch includes in this category self-contradictory concepts, such as a "square circle", which cannot

be manifested. However, the category of nonbeing includes more than that. For example, Guenon mentions the Void and the Silence as other possibilities of non-manifestation. Another example is Chaos. These are pure privation with no actuality at all. Hence, we could include evil, death, and disease in this category. Being itself is part of nonbeing.

Influences At every moment, we are being exposed to two types of influences:

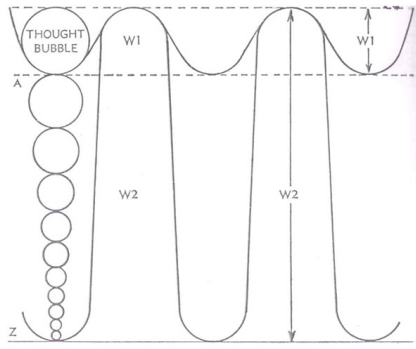
- Illusory influences, or "A" influences for short.
- Real influences, or "B" influences.



Their action is illustrated in the diagram on the right, taken from *Gnosis* by **Boris Mouravieff**. The A influences come from every direction and their net, or vector sum, is zero. Although we may be temporarily in a region of similar A influences, overall, they subrate each other and lead nowhere.

The B influences (represented by the thicker arrows), on the other hand, are consistent and flow in the same direction. These are our encounters with the Real. Hence, the next step in esoteric training is to be vigilant in watching the thoughts that we entertain in our mind. We learn to discard the A influences, while allowing in the B influences.

Science of Being In the same box, I found a yellowing copy of *The Science of Being and the Art of Living*, by **Maharishi Mahesh Yogi**. Published around the same time as the Deutsch book, it was my initial exposure to



Vedantic teachings. Although he was non-traditional in important respects (which we can't get into just now), he was nevertheless well versed in Vedantic doctrines. Since he did propose a path of self-development while being active in the world, he is of a certain interest. In particular, I want to point to a diagram that may help in the process of moving from ordinary to real existents, and then to reality itself.

The goal of vigilance is to improve the quality of thoughts. The Maharishi writes:

> The art of thinking should mean that the manner of thinking is such that the least amount of mental energy is consumed … the thought should not only be powerful but it should be right as well. The art of thinking also means that no useless or wrong thought should occupy the mind.

In esoteric training, we learn to observe thoughts. Ordinarily, we become aware of a thought only when it has become fully formed. At that point, further thoughts arise and start linking with each other. At that point we tend to lose full consciousness and become "lost in thought".

However, by remaining conscious, we may be able to discern the thought in its formation process. This is like bubbles arising; awareness will keep the thought from fully arising. By going into deeper levels of being, we may be able to move beyond the thought into nondual awareness.

Posted on 2014-10-10 by Cologero

* * *

David on 2014-10-21 at 00:46 said:

Greetings Colgero. A question regarding nonbeing. Could you develop more around it ? My understanding of it was mostly based on Eckhart works, and I was under the impression that for him Non-Being was at the center of creation, from which Being sprung forth and was unknowable.

The diagram with the arrows is quite simple, yet very effective. I will have to meditate on that.

Thank you.

Cologero on 2014-10-22 at 00:37 said:

Synchronistically, David, a post on that topic has been planned in regards to the Ray of Creation or Great Chain of Being. Your description from Eckhart sounds compatible with what Guenon writes in the Multiple States of Being.

9.15 The Butterfly Lovers

Matgioi was one of five Europeans initiated into the Chinese Primordial Tradition. He divided it into three stages, each associated with a teacher, or actually a collective entity. As he put it:

> The first of men, **Fuxi** *crystallized* the Primordial Tradition, **Lao Tzu** drew from it a body of doctrine, **Confucius** drew from it a system of morality.

The three parts were to appear in three works:

1. *Metaphysical Path,* the principles of the Tradition and its philosophical and cosmogonic movement. (*I Ching*)
2. *Rational Path* relates the systematization of Tradition, with Taoism, or *Tao Te Ching* of Lao Tzu
3. *Social Path* relates the adaptation of the Tradition, with the political philosophy of Confucius (Analects)

The third volume never appeared.

The Figurists The Jesuit missionaries considered the I Ching to be a prophetic book containing the mysteries of Christianity. They also recognized the ancient origins of Chinese civilization, which predated the Flood. Shem, the son of Noah, was thought to have brought the Primordial Tradition from Adam to China.

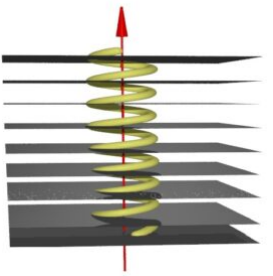
Moreover, they believed that Fuxi, Zoroaster, Hermes Trismegistus, and the prophet Enoch were the same person. Matgioi mentions none of this.

Fuxi Although Fuxi claimed that he drew his teaching from much older sources, he is symbolically recognized as the first human being. Nuwa, his sister and wife, was Eve to his Adam. Together, they are the Androgyne. That is represented in the symbol of the Yin Yang. Matgioi explains the union and separation:

> The eternal androgyne separates only to fertilize itself … the father and the mother exist only to create: at the moment of creation, they are united and form only one; at the moment they separate, the seed exists.

Birth and Death Matgioi explains the process of birth and death:

> Man is not free in his birth nor in his death. For his birth, he is free neither of acceptance, nor of refusal, nor of the moment. As for death, he is not free to avoid it … Birth launches him irresistibly onto the *circulus* of an existence which he neither asked for nor chose. Death withdraws him from this *circulus*, and launches him irresistibly into another, prescribed and foreseen by the Will of Heaven.



The Will of Heaven lifts him onto higher and higher stages of life. Matgioi represents this as a series of planes, with a vertical line indicating the Will of Heaven. A helix, centered along the vertical line, illustrates the ascent from plane to plane. Death at one plane is birth at the next. As Matgioi describes it:

> death at the end of cycle X is greater than birth on the same cycle X, by the whole value of the attraction of heaven's will upon the cycle X, that is to say mathematically the value of the pitch of the evolutionary helix.

Hence, death is nothing to fear

> The phenomenon of death is identical, absolutely, and it seems to us to determine analogous effects, but in the opposite direction, only because we have fallen into the bad habit of considering it from the sole point of view of human state. The *exit* from this state (death) corresponds to the dispersion of the body, to the loss of the human material form, which is the lowest part of our compound. But the entry into the suprahuman state (birth) which is coincident with human death, involves the accession of a spiritual element, the value of which we do not know, and which is superior to the best of our human elements. This is why human death, since it coincides with a better birth, is superior, metaphysically, to human birth.

Iconography The iconography illustrates this. Fuxi and Nuwa are united in Heaven as the Androgyne. Each has as helix that represents their ascents through the planes of existence. They are intertwined indicating that they make that ascent together, as One.



The Butterfly Lovers Metaphysical teachings are often hidden in popular culture and stories. The story of the Butterfly Lovers[11], one of China's Four Great Folktales, is an example. Zhu disguises herself as a man to attend classes where she meets Liang. They have an immediate affinity and Zhu falls in love with Liang. Because he believes Zhu is a man, he cannot reciprocate that love in the way she wants.

Eventually, Zhu's father finds a husband for her. She is forced to return home. When Liang visits her later on, she reveals that she is a woman. They express their love to each other. But Zhu must marry another. Liang then dies of a broken heart.

On the wedding procession, Zhu passes Liang's grave. She leaves the procession to visit it. Suddenly the earth opens up and Zhu jumps in. Liang and Zhu then emerge as butterflies, never to separate again.

This shows that what appears to be death is actually birth into a higher degree of existence.

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sOuPpyuqcOE`

H/T to Prasad for the helix diagram.

Posted on 2022-10-02 by Cologero

[11] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Butterfly_Lovers`

10

Metaphysics of Nonbeing

10.1 Nature Abhors a Vacuum

In *The Multiple States of Being*, **Rene Guenon** describes the concept of the Infinite, Being, the World, among other ideas. The following definitions are taken from this work.

Infinite All possibilities

Non-Being Possibilities of non-manifestation and possibilities of non-manifestation not manifested

Being Manifested possibilities

World A domain formed by a certain ensemble of compossibilities which are realized in manifestation.

Void Absence of any formal qualities or anything to do with any mode of manifestation

He points out that the **Void** has no possibility to be manifested in any world, by its very definition. For those who think that metaphysics has no practical application, this idea demonstrates its fruitfulness for our understanding.

First of all, in the purely physical sense, a Vacuum cannot actually exist. Even is you deny the existence of the Ether, which physics has not really completely ruled out, there is more than nothingness going on in what we call a vacuum.

But more important for our purposes, the non-manifestation of the Void tells us something about the cosmic environment. There can be no gaps in the psychic and physical processes; that it, there is necessarily a continuity synchronically and diachronically. Another way to say it is that everything is in relationship to everything else. Guenon writes:

> The cosmic environment can only be conceived of as a whole of which each part is linked to every other part without any break in continuity. To try to conceive of it otherwise would be to assume the existence of a void, but this is not a possibility of manifestation and can have no place in the Cosmos.

This, we have been at pains to point out the relationships between civilizations, traditions, and the transitions from age to age of the cosmic cycle. So what we experience now is in in continuity both with the past and also with everything else contemporaneous. The whole weight of the past is with us now. Hence, something, for example a particular tradition, cannot have been lost and then suddenly reappear.

Posted on 2011-02-10 by Cologero

10.2 The Void and the Fullness are Indissolubly Bound

> We never start from the "many", but from the "One" in a state of privation which is correlative to the appearance of others around and against it, in order to move to the "One" in a state of fullness and sufficiency, in which such an appearance is consummated.
>
> Julius Evola

To understand the creation of the world, we need to begin with the concept of privation[1]. "Privation" is the absence of a given form in something capable of possessing it. As it is a lack, it has no being in itself, yet it is part of experience. Whatever appears to limit me, whatever seems to oppose my Will, reveals an insufficiency in me, that is, a "privation". Rather than simply representing a lack or insufficiency, a being may embrace privation and deliberately choose to limit itself. **Boris Mouravieff** writes (*Gnosis*, Vol 1):

> Orthodox Tradition teaches that the Universe was created by a *sacrifice of God*. We shall understand this postulate better if we consider that it differentiates between the state of manifested Divinity and that of unmanifested Divinity — which is therefore limitless and free from all conditions. God's sacrifice is *Self-limitation* by manifestation.

By this withdrawal, the unmanifested God, the Universal I, creates a space for the Other selves. The relationship is sustained through Love. Mouravieff explains:

[1] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1815`

> To pass or cross from the non-manifested state — a *monopolar* one, concentrated on the unique consciousness of *Self* within which the Divinity remains before the Creation of the World — *the first Idea* which makes the Divinity come out of the state of non-manifestation to become manifest, is necessarily that of the You. This idea, conceived by the divine sacrifice of Self-limitation, has Love, a neutralizing force, or third force.

We can understand this Hermetically. Mouravieff is describing the Macrocosm, which through a consciously willed privation, creates the Other and binds the relationship with love. Man, the microcosm, on the other hand, wills privation, or the Other, spontaneously without conscious choice. Hence, Trials[2] are necessary. In the **Trial by Suffering**, Man endures the privation in the understanding that it is the product of his own will and consciousness. In the **Trial by Love**, Man neutralizes the privation by Love, ending the opposition.

In *Meditations on the Tarot*, **Valentin Tomberg** takes up the same theme. He makes clear that the withdrawal is real, in the sense that Man has a real, noumenal, free existence, not just an apparent, phenomenal one as in pantheistic systems. Tomberg draws on the Cabbalist doctrine of *tsimtsum* to make the point:

> The first act of En-Soph, the Infinite Being, is therefore not a step outside but a step inside, a movement of recoil, of falling back upon oneself, of withdrawing into oneself. Instead of emanation we have the opposite, contraction… The first act of all is not an act of revelation but one of limitation. Only in the second act does God send out a ray of His light and begin His revelation, or rather His unfolding as God the Creator, in the primordial space of his own creation. More than that, every new act of emanation and manifestation is preceded by one of concentration and retraction.

[2] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1902

Gershom Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*

Tomberg goes on to clarify:

> In other words, in order to create the world ex nihilo, God had first to bring the void itself into existence. He had to withdraw within in order to create a mystical space, a space without his presence — the void. And it is in thinking this thought that we are present at the birth of *freedom*.

A note of clarification is necessary, since Tomberg writes as a cosmologist, not a metaphysician. The void as such can never exist, or be created. Instead, the idea of the void is the ontological space where beings, as possibilities of manifestation, come into existence. The void is freedom, it is the source of creativity. Tomberg summarizes:

> The void — the mystical space from which God withdrew himself through his act of tsimtsum — is the place of origin of freedom, i.e., the place of the origin of an *ex-istence* which is absolute potentiality, not in any way determined… These two indestructible elements—the meonic element ("meon"=void) and the pleromic element (plenitude) are indissolubly bound to one another.

Originally published on 4 Apr 2011 on medtarot.

Posted on 2023-02-14 by Cologero

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Santiago on 2023-02-19 at 00:25 said:

What a remarkable thing, this freedom which God gives us!

Tomberg, elsewhere in this passage, likens the meonic element to the watery void, but the pleromic he associates with a fiery "spark" of love, given directly by God. Do they really have to be more or less equivalent, as "indissolubly bound" implies? It almost sounds like the Void and

Fullness are the Divinity Itself (I'm tempted to read: God's existence is His essence). But God has to be more than those contingent things, otherwise freedom would not truly be free and love would not be a gift.

It seems like the void is reached through what Tomberg calls "depersonalization", that is, through the techniques of dispassion taught in the various traditions. Perhaps I'm projecting onto his writings. But the ability to love is what gives us ownership and autonomy of our lives. It has to be better, or in some way ontologically prior.

I hope this comment doesn't sound too pretentious or ignorant. I've been considering this over the past couple days.

10.3 The Metaphysics of Nonbeing

Metaphysics of Being **Thomas Aquinas** developed a comprehensive metaphysics of Being by integrating Philosophy, predominantly via Aristotle. Plato and Plotinus entered into his system indirectly as mediated by Dionysius the Areopagite and Augustine. As such, Scholasticism is consistent with Traditional metaphysics. Of course, by Being, the Scholastics meant much more than what today's naturalists and rationalists accept as existing.

The Medieval conception of being included nonformal as well as formal states of being. From the metaphysical point of view, the nonformal states as understood theologically, may refer to superior states of the being. Even the Russian Orthodox theologian **Sergius Bulgakov** reached that understanding. In particular, he notes that the guardian angel and the person both share the same essence. In effect, that means that they are different states of the same being.

From the esoteric perspective, then, these states represent the initiatic degrees that correspond to their respective realizations. This was brought out most forcibly in Dante's *Divine Comedy* which used the astrological symbolism of the planetary and stellar spheres to indicate higher and lower states of being that the initiate needs to traverse.

Nonduality **Meister Eckhart** deepened the understanding of the metaphysics of being. Thomism has a limitation that is sometimes misunderstood as a reversion to duality, with a too strong distinction between the natural and the supernatural, between what could be known by reason and what can only be known by faith. Although Scholasticism recognizes a form of knowing — intuition — that is higher than rational or conceptual knowledge, it was Meister Eckhart who developed that notion more fully.

Intuition overcomes the duality of the sensual image and conceptual thought, which are united in spiritual seeing that unites the two. Moreover, some concepts that Thomas had left to faith, can be understood on a deeper level. Specifically, these are the Incarnation and the Trinity. For Eckhart, the Incarnation is much more than an historical event, since it is repeated whenever the Logos is born again in our interiority. By intuition, Eckhart also sees into the Trinity. Since we have recently discussed these ideas, they need not be repeated here.

Nonbeing In *The Multiple States of Being*, **Rene Guenon** points out that a complete metaphysic needs to include Nonbeing as well as Being, as the latter arises from the former. He points out that the West has failed to develop that notion very well. Guenon does mention the notion of the Abyss in Alexandrian Gnosticism as referring to an aspect of Nonbeing.

Independently, **Nicolas Berdyaev** in Boehme: Unground and Freedom notes that:

> Boehme was perhaps the first in the history of human thought to have seen, that at the basis of being and prior to being lies a groundless freedom.

Perhaps, assuming Guenon is correct, **Jacob Boehme** is not the first in the history of human thought, but is at least the first in the history of Western thought to develop a metaphysic of nonbeing. Guenon's presentation of

Nonbeing is rather dry and rationalistic while Boehme's comes from a deeper source, a direct intuition of Nonbeing which he sometimes calls the Unground. In the *Mysterium Pansophicum*, he attempts to describe it. (It is impossible to define, since a definition is a limitation.)

> The unground is an eternal nothing, but makes an eternal beginning as a craving. For the nothing is a craving after something. But as there is nothing that can give anything, accordingly the craving itself is the giving of it, which yet also is a nothing or a desirous seeking. And that is the eternal origin of Magic, which makes within itself where there is nothing; which makes something out of nothing, and that in itself only, thought this craving is also a nothing, that is, merely a will. It has nothing, and there is nothing that can give it anything; neither has it any place where it can find or repose itself.

Obviously, the unground is nothing, since it is not itself manifested. There are two important points that follow from this.

- The Unground contains all possibilities, light as well as darkness, good as well as evil, God's wrath as well as God's Love.
- Being arises from Nonbeing. A fortiori, there is a "craving" for Being, and thus this can be described as a primal Will. Moreover, since Nonbeing is undetermined, it must be perfectly free.

This is just the surface, as Boehme brings an understanding to many other notions, although this is not the time to discuss them.

Letting Go In his commentary on the *Secret of the Golden Flower*, a Chinese alchemical text, **Carl Jung** writes:

> The art of letting things happen, action in nonaction, letting go of oneself, as taught by Master Eckhart, became a key to me with which I was able to open the door to the "Way". The key is this: we must be able to let things happen in the psyche. For us, this becomes a real art of which few people know anything. Consciousness is forever interfering, helping, correcting, and negating, and never leaving the simple growth of the psychic processes in peace. It would be a simple enough thing to do, if only simplicity were not the most difficult of all things. It consists solely in watching objectively the development of any fragment of fantasy.

Jung is referring the Eckhart's idea of "letting go" or *gelassenheit*. Obviously, this is more like the Hermetic teaching of concentration without effort. Simplicity is the detached awareness of whatever psychic processes may be occurring. This watching often dissipates any interference in the psychic process. This letting go then allows something else, something much deeper, to arise. There is a primal will, different from purposeful and conscious willing, that is in touch with more possibilities. In a phrase reminiscent of Jacob Boehme, Jung explains this idea:

> Whether arising from without or within, the new thing came to all those persons from a dark field of possibilities; they accepted it and developed further by means of it. It seemed to me typical that, in some cases, the new thing was found outside themselves, and in others within; or rather, that it grew into some persons from without, and into others from within. But it was never something that came exclusively either from within or from without. If it came from outside the individual, it became an inner experience; if it came from within, it was changed into an outer event. But in no case was it conjured into existence through purpose and conscious willing, but rather seemed to flow out of the stream of time.

The important notion is that a change from within brings the outer event into existence. The art of "letting things happen" in the psyche, or action in nonaction, needs to be developed. Then we may experience synchronicities in our lives, or perhaps better said, "grace". In other words, the pursuit of the outer needs to yield to an interior transformation. This ties in nicely with what Eckhart writes in Sermon 77 about asking God for gifts:

> I say, 'God is Love,' because He must love all creatures with His love, whether they know it or not. … I will never pray to God for His gifts, nor will I ever thank Him for His gifts, for if I were worthy to receive His gifts He would have to give them to me whether He would or not. Therefore I will not pray to Him for His gifts, since He must give: but I will surely pray to Him to make me worthy to receive His gifts, and I will thank Him for being such that He has to give. Therefore I say, "God is Love," for He loves me with the love with which He loves Himself: and if anyone deprived Him of that, they would deprive Him of His entire Godhead. Though it is true that He loves me with His love, yet I cannot become blessed through that: but I would be blessed by loving Him and be blessed in His love.

The Purification of the Will That is a very important lesson in how to pray. There is no point to pray to God for his gifts, because he is by nature willing to disperse his gifts freely. Rather, the prayer should be to be made worthy to receive the gifts. (Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these. things shall be added unto you.) Thus, the inner transformation comes first, and only then perhaps the external things and events.

To become worthy means to please God. That is the purification of the will. Failure to achieve that will bring obstacles to life. The introduction to the Mass of the 20th Sunday after Pentecost in the Roman Missal makes this clear:

> The Liturgy shows us that our misfortunes are caused by our unfaithfulness in conforming to the will of God. Let us beseech the Lord, through the prayers of Holy Church, to pardon our sins, so that we may serve Him with a quiet and trustful heart, always obeying His precepts.

And from the Introit:

> Blessed are the undefiled in the way; who walk in the law of the Lord.

Freedom and License To be "undefiled" is to be made worthy. Undefiled = pure, so our previous tasks of the purity of the mind and the purity the will must not be forgotten. The result is to walk in the law of the Lord. For Eckhart, that is not a restriction on freedom as the world wants to believe, but is rather freedom itself. He writes:

> For the man who stands in God's will and in God's love it is a joy to do all the good things God wills, and to leave undone all the evil things which are against God. And it is impossible for him to leave a thing undone which God wants to have accomplished. As it would be impossible for one to walk whose legs are bound, so it would be impossible for one to do ill, who is in God's will.

Eckhart is emphatic that this does not mean the license to do anything at all:

> Some men say: If I have God and God's freedom, then I can do everything I want. They understand these words amiss. As long as you can do anything which is against God and His commandment, you do not have God's love; you can only deceive the world into the belief that you have it.

This is opposite of the contemporary view that if any action motivated by "love" is thereby legitimate. However, that idea is still focused on the "self", but the self is precisely that which occludes the Will of God. The attachment to sensory images and intellectual ideas are obstacles to spiritual vision. If redemption is the recovery of the primordial state prior to the Fall, this state can be understood only by a pure mind. **Wolfgang Smith** elucidates this point:

> The Patristic understanding of Paradise is mystical in two respects: first, because it insists that the nature of Paradise exceeds categorically what the "carnal man" — St. Pauls *psychikos anthropos* — is able to comprehend; and secondly, because it claims that the things of Paradise can in fact be "seen" when certain degrees of contemplation have been attained. St. Gregory the Sinaite speaks of this explicitly when he explains "the eight primary visions accompanying the state of perfect prayer when things previously happen are clearly beheld and known by those who have attained by grace complete purity of mind."

Eckhart knows that teaching also:

> Not an already existing life — "being" — is to be understood in the logical sense; but the higher understanding — "seeing" — is itself to become life; the spiritual, that which belongs to the idea, is to be experienced by the seeing man in the same way as the individual human nature experiences ordinary, everyday life.

For that to occur, depth is required, where there is a perfect "morality", i.e., the Will of God is known. The world lives on the surface: it looks for understanding (i.e., "explanations") and the satisfaction of desires. There is a fear of "letting go", for the end of understanding is experienced as darkness. However, God's light shines precisely in that darkness. Eckhart writes:

> For everything the understanding can grasp, and everything desire demands, is not God. Where understanding and desire have an end, there it is dark, there does God shine. There that power unfolds in the soul which is wider than the wide heavens. The bliss of the righteous and God's bliss is one bliss; for when God is blissful, the righteous are blissful.

Posted on 2017-11-19 by Cologero

* * *

jonathansolvie on 2017-11-20 at 10:22 said:

Great work!

"For Eckhart, the Incarnation is much more than an historical event, since it is repeated whenever the Logos is born again in our interiority."

This is true with the qualification that the esoteric understanding of the incarnation of the Logos within the initiate by no means dispenses with the objective and macrocosmic significance of the Incanation that took place in the historical Jesus Christ, non-dually uniting time and Eternity, concrete event and universal metaphysical truth and symbolism. While the Logos that incarnates in any initiate of the Greater Mysteries may be principally non-dual with Christ ("I am crucified with Christ, but I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me"), the incarnations are are from equal in the persons of Jesus of Nazareth and Meister Eckhart in terms of total manifestation and macrocosmic and eschatological function. Yes, the incarnation of the Logos reflects in the mirrors of many Hearts, but there nevertheless needs be one Incarnation in the unfolding within time of a human world-cycle that is unique, preeminent and unsurpassable, as the highest peak of personal divine manifestation within creation. Therefore the above esoteric interpretation of Incarnation within our own Heart depeens our understanding of the principle of Incarnation, but does not exhaust the esoteric depth of the historical Incarnation, which has a macrocosmic dimension as well, the delving into which would allow us to understand also the literal truth of exoteric dogma regarding the Incarnation as an objective and historical macrocosmic and eschatological event, and yet in more profound hermetic depth.

jonathansolvie on 2017-11-20 at 15:43 said:

Some might assume from reading this article that the 'Unground' is the Absolute, since Being is said to proceed from it. However, the Absolute Reality, the Gottheit, is not nothingness or non-being as opposed to Being; both of these are 'dependently originated' and mutually conditioned. Since non-being stands in relation to Being, it is not undetermined. The very 'craving'

explained as arising from the Unground testifies to its limitation and its need for Being which stands as its opposite pole. If from one perspective Being arises from the former, both derive their reality from the unconditioned freedom of the Absolute. The undetermined and infinite Reality is beyond both Being and non-being, the manifest and the unmanifest, and the latter is not superior to the former in face of That.

I just thought this might be worth pointing out for certain readers; I do not mean to correct the author, who undoubtedly knows this better than I.

Fred on 2017-11-21 at 16:05 said:

I agree with jonathansolvie.

Possibly the Absolute is even beyond Being and Non-Being, not only beyond all affirmations but also beyond every negation.

There was a time where I tried to study the highest metaphysics, then a monk told me studying the mystics is of no benefit if you are struggling with the purification of beginners. I'm much more comfortable with the daily fights now.

I will keep following this advice until it's time.

Cologero on 2017-11-21 at 21:18 said:

Thanks, Fred and jonathansolvie, for making that clarification. Yes, I was unclear about Non-being and the Absolute. Moreover, I had in mind the Absolute as universal Possibility, without explicitly stating so. There is certainly work to do in adequately relating Boehme's insights to traditional metaphysics. This will be an ongoing project.

Cologero on 2017-11-21 at 21:22 said:

Yes, jonathansolvie, those are good points. The esoteric is not intended to replace or supersede the exoteric. That is what you may find in certain Gnostic or Theosophical circles which claim to reveal the "true" meaning of the exoteric.

Caeliger on 2017-11-22 at 03:42 said:

Non-Being is not merely the 'void'. which follows the primordial 'contraction' or expiration of God (needless to say, this must happen 'before the foundation of the world'), but we could say that the void is one of its 'aspects'. one which will explore the possibilities of the One and the many.

It could certainly be taken in a limiting sense as 'that which is opposed to Being'. in which case it is indeed necessary to conceive a yet higher priciple which is truly infinite.

Arthur Konrad on 2017-11-22 at 11:50 said:

"Some men say: If I have God and God's freedom, then I can do everything I want. They understand these words amiss. As long as you can do anything which is against God and His commandment, you do not have God's love; you can only deceive the world into the belief that you have it. "

This is valid only if interpreted on non-moralistic grounds. Otherwise it makes no sense. There is either inner freedom and hence inner commandment, or you do not posses inner will at all. Discovering inner will absolutely does not equate discovering any commandments not one's own, since one's fate is then already perfectly clear and resolved (hence utter futility in attempting to draw parallel between inner will and religious law). Ekchart has deployed a rather worn out linguistic device here to draw a parallel between apparently religious commandment and an inner will, which demands an esoteric interpretation to overcome it's obstacles.

Numen on 2017-11-23 at 01:24 said:

jonathansolvie's clarification is excellent and succinct.

S.H. Nasr once explained in a presentation that the basis of the theme of the void in Islamic art stems from the understanding that "if the world is everything, then God is nothing; If God is everything, then the world is nothing." In a sense, our understanding of God has to oscillates between the two (Being and Non-being); the Non-being of God has to be a part of the transcendent principle, otherwise God is seen just merely as Being, part of the manifestation itself. Or, as Eckhart put it, God is "Being above Being and superessential Negation."

Dante's intuition is nicely simplified when he wrote: "as certain things are affirmed to exist which our intellect cannot perceive (namely God, eternity, and primal matter), things which most certainly are known to exist and are with full faith believed to exist. But given the nature of their essence we cannot understand them: only by negative reasoning can we approach an understanding of these things, and not otherwise."

10.4 Logos and Chaos

The idea of Chaos was known to the early Greeks. The poet **Hesiod** wrote:

> First of all, Chaos came into being; then Earth with her broad breast, for all things a seat secure forever.

F. M. Cornford explains that Chaos is not 'formless disorder'. as we conceive it today, but rather the 'yawning gap' between earth and heaven.

Euripides wrote: 'Heaven and Earth were once one form.' In the Rig Veda, Varuna 'held asunder spacious Earth and Heaven.' For the ancient Egyptians, *Shu* separates *Nut* (sky) from *Seb* (earth). Of course, in China it was taught that from the Tao came the duality of Yin and Yang, Earth and Heaven.

In the ancient sense, Chaos does not represent the destruction of the ordered physical world, but rather the unmanifested Void that is the principle of heaven and earth, male and female. So behind the physical world, there is a principle that represents the unity of Being. For **Heraclitus**, there is one Logos, one reason for everything, throughout "the one cosmos which is the same for all."

Rene Guenon's criticism of Western theology is that it stops at the consideration of Being alone, and does not penetrate beyond Being. This is true to the extent that God is understood as Being, which is true from the point of view of manifestation. Nevertheless, some figures such as **Meister Eckhart** and **Jacob Boehme** have recognized the "God beyond God" or the Urgrund (Void) ontologically prior to Being. In the East, there is the understanding of the difference between the essence and energies of God. In a metaphysical sense, the West can perhaps be accused of a forgetfulness of Non-being rather than the forgetfulness of Being.

Guenon identifies the Divine Intellect as the 'location' of the eternal ideas. In his conception, the theologian only recognizes the possibilities of manifestation, whereas the metaphysician also recognizes the possibilities of non-manifestation. Guenon identifies the Divine Intellect as the Logos (or Word), which is the principle of manifestation since all things are created from it. Hence, at the metaphysical level Logos is the same as Chaos, as the unifying principle of manifestation. The Logos can also be identified with the Tao, as Tao is used in Chinese translations of the Bible for the Logos.

In Mathematics, Chaoas Theory[3] demonstrates that there can be a

[3] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chaos_theory

hidden order behind seemingly chaotic systems.

> Chaos theory states that within the apparent randomness of chaotic complex systems, there are underlying patterns, interconnectedness, constant feedback loops, repetition, self-similarity, fractals, and self-organization.

Thus, there is no opposition — and there cannot be — between Logos and Chaos at the metaphysical or transcendental level. There the battle has already been won. Hence, the battle is fought on the *psychic* and *hylic* levels, that is, between *cosmos* and *chaos*, which can be understood as 'formless disorder' only at this level[4].

This will be explored in the "Conditions of Corporeal Manifestation".

Posted on 2012-09-19 by Cologero

* * *

`Cassiodorus on 2012-09-20 at 01:19 said:`

Cologero,

I recently discovered this site and I've been devouring the many interesting and insightful posts . There is something that I am somewhat puzzled about. Being that Rene Guenon has such prominent role here, why is there such a dearth of treatment of Frithjof Schuon and others of the Traditionalist school?

`Andrew on 2012-09-20 at 15:59 said:`

This actually answers (at least in part) a question I had asked about Buddhism and Tradition. In Buddhism the condition for a thing is its principle.

If the Void is the Principle of Manifestation, then Form is Emptiness, Emptiness is Form. Another name for Shunyata (Voidness) is Dharmadhatu (which I translate as "World of the Word"). Also, the Buddha said, "He who sees Dharma sees Me; He who sees Me sees Dharma".

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[4]References:

[1] From Religion to Philosophy, F. M. Cornford

[2] Miscellanea, Rene Guenon

Logres on 2012-09-20 at 21:57 said:

Cologero has stated that he doesn't post on Schuon because there are (in his judgement) many well done sites on such already. At least this was his answer if my memory serves, last time it was brought up.

Cassiodorus on 2012-09-20 at 22:49 said:

Cologero or Logres,

I'm an ex- postmodern agnostic that discovered the teachings of Tradition and the Perennial Philosophy several years ago. Since then, the focus of my studies has centered on Catholic Christianity, resulting largely from my increasing acquaintance with the Church fathers and, most importantly, with the Angelic Doctor, Thomas Aquinas. Interestingly, I've noticed that most traditional Christians are hostile to the Primordial Tradition, quick to make the charge of pantheism, monism, or even gnosticism. For most Thomists that I've spoken to, the Perennial Philosophy is often rejected on the grounds of being a modern variant of "eastern mysticism" and that Tradition is antithetical to monotheism by blurring the line that separates God and man. Plainly stated, do you think there is a problem in reconciling the classical theistic traditions of the West with nondualism and the doctrine of the Self?

Cologero on 2012-09-20 at 23:42 said:

Cassiodorus, rather than ask why we don't do something–a negative, the better question is to understand our purpose. Primarily, it is to determine how Tradition can be recovered in the West. Coincidentally–if you believe in coincidences–your namesake serves as a suitable model. The real Cassiodorus was able–in his own mind–to integrate the Ancient with the Medieval, the Latin West with the Greek East, the Roman with the Germanic.

We agree with Guenon that Medieval Europe had more in common with the civilizations of the East than with the Modern West. Even "traditional" Catholics go back only to the Council of Trent and are thus still far from the worldview of the Medievals. Following various suggestions by Guenon, we have pointed out the commonality of the doctrines of Thomas with other Traditions. Thomism today is reduced to a "philosophy", one among other competing systems. However, it must be understood as a metaphysics, which is known experientially, not just rationally; it is totalitarian, demanding one's total adherence.

Thomism will be deepened by the encounter with Tradition. Some can't see it; others do. The charges of pantheism or gnosticism arise because of a misunderstanding of Being or an ignorance of Christian gnosis.

When you can make a certain shift in consciousness, many seemingly insoluble puzzles are resolved.

Cassiodorus on 2012-09-21 at 01:15 said:

Cologero,

Many thanks for your thoughtful response. "Thomism will be deepened by the encounter with Tradition. Some can't see it; others do." This comment reminded of something that Ananda Coomaraswamy said in "Vedanta and the Western Tradition",

To say that "I am a pantheist" is merely to confess that "I am not a metaphysician," just as to say that "two and two make five" would be to confess that "I am not a mathematician."

Nevertheless, on the subject of Christian gnosis, I've been told by both Catholics and Orthodox that there is a fundamental difference between Christian divinization, theosis, and the Indian Supreme Identity, moksha. Furthermore, it is said, the Perennial Philosophy that Agostino Steuco and Leibniz refer to cannot be expanded to encompass the traditions of the East because participation in the Divine and identification with the Divine represent two incompatible ontologies.

Would you say that apophatic theology and pure metaphysics are essentially the same thing?

Best Regards,

Cassiodorus

Cologero on 2012-09-21 at 08:05 said:

Cassiodorus, find the man who has experienced both "participation" in the divine and moksha; I'm sure he could explain the differences to us. Otherwise, it is idle chit chat. This is a journey every man must make for himself and he can't rest content just reading someone else's postcards.

Cassiodorus on 2012-09-21 at 10:13 said:

I believe I see your point.

Michael on 2012-09-21 at 20:32 said:

Cologero, so how does one go about experiencing Aquinas and not just absorbing his writings rationally? Sorry for the ignorant questions.

Cologero on 2012-09-22 at 10:08 said:

It is not an ignorant question, but the only question worth asking. Check out Letters of AKC[5] and read the intro to the first volume. Then bring up the topic again.

[5] http://akc.satishankar.com/2012/09/selected-letters-of-ak-coomaraswamy.html

> Cologero on 2022-02-12 at 08:04 said:
> Although too much Wittgenstein is risky, a small dose may be helpful:
> "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent."
> Otherwise, one is just engaging in a language game, trying to make various propositions compatible with each other. Well, the world is not a proposition nor a riddle to be solved.
> "Thinking", as important and as pleasant as it is, is nevertheless a low stage of development, actually only at stage three of Augustine's seven stages of the ascent to God[6].

10.5 Chaos in Mathematics

These are some reflections on what chaos means in the context of mathematics and physics. Chaos must be understood as the absence, or privation, of order, not as the opposite of order in any active sense.

To explore what chaos may mean from the mathematical point of view, we can consider an irrational real number between zero and one in its decimal expansion to try to represent a number representing true lack of order, that is, the ultimate random number. A rational number is not random, since its digits will repeat after a certain point. The ultimate random number will have two properties:

1. **Not Computable**: There is no algorithm to determine the sequence of digits
2. **Normal**: Every digit, and sequence of digits, is evenly represented in the decimal expansion.

Numbers such as $\sqrt{2}$ and π fail the first condition since there are mathematical formulas to compute the decimal expansion to any desired precision.

In the decimal (or any base) expansion of normal numbers, each digit will appear with the same frequency, i.e., 10%. Furthermore, each sequence of digits will also appear with its corresponding frequency. That

[6] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=10801

is, 10 through 99, 100 through 999, and so on, will also appear 1% and 0.1% of the time respectively. $\sqrt{2}$ and π are believed to be normal, but there is no proof. The mathematician Gregory Chaitin defined a number Ω, Chaitin's constant, that has both properties.

Condition 1 is necessary because an algorithm is the hidden order behind a seemingly random sequence of numbers. Condition 2 is necessary because complete chaos would have to include all possibilities.

In our random number, then, each digit is independent in the sense that its value does not depend on the digit, or sequence of digits, that precede it. Investigating this number, we will observe at some point the sequence of numbers from 1 to 1 million. This poses a dilemma. Do we conclude, then, that we have discovered a region of order within that alleged chaos, or are we convinced that it is truly random? This is not merely speculative as it has real world applications.

- In Intelligent Design theory, recognized patterns are presumed to result from a designer rather than random variation.
- In the search for extra-terrestrial intelligence, cosmic radio waves are scanned to look for patterns hidden within the white noise.
- In the multiverse theory of physics, all possible worlds exist and we just "happen" to live in one of them that exhibits the necessary degree of order to support human life.
- Then, there is the Infinite Monkey Theorem that claims that enough monkeys with typewriters, given enough time, will produce the works of Shakespeare.

We have previously asked this question about whether each moment in time is independent of any previous moment or if there is a deep connection between the past and the present. The first is chaos; the second may

be either order or chaos deceptively ordered. There is no way, apparently, within a chaotic situation to determine if order is accidental or real.

Two of the conditions of manifestation are form and matter. Chaos can only be associated with prime matter, Prakriti, without property and infinitely receptive to any form. Matter, in this sense, can never "exist", that is, it can never be a possibility of manifestation. Hence, Chaitin's constant, is only a thought construction and not a reality. That is why Guenon says that at the heart of the Kali Yuga, where chaos reigns, the state of total disorder can never be reached.

Thus, form is a necessary condition of manifestation; it is transcendent to matter and we know it through our will and intelligence. I design, hence I recognize design; I communicate, hence I recognize a communication; I create, hence I recognize an artistic creation.

Posted on 2012-10-04 by Cologero

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Master Dogen on 2012-10-05 at 02:59 said:

"That is why Guenon says that at the heart of the Kali Yuga, where chaos reigns, the state of total disorder can never be reached."

This is a heartening thing to ponder.

william zeitler on 2012-10-05 at 09:52 said:

"Chaos must be understood as the absence, or privation, of order, not as the opposite of order in any active sense." I'm not sure that's necessarily true. Much of mathematical chaos theory is about observing that there is an 'order' that we simply don't understand (e.g. fractals and 'strange attractors'). Also, related to your article might be Godel's "Incompleteness Theorem"–that for any non-trivial formal system there will always be statements that can neither be proven true nor false. In other words, outside the light from the streetlight of, say, geometry, there will always be a geometrical darkness we can't penetrate. (At least without cognitively stepping outside/above the geometrical system itself.)

Cologero on 2012-10-05 at 11:28 said:

Don't be misled by verbal similarity. I defined precisely what I meant by true chaos, in which there is no possibility of a hidden order, except incidentally. But I agree with you in this sense that a real disorder is not manifestable as "there is an 'order' that we simply don't understand".

Andrew on 2012-10-05 at 18:21 said:

It's not really heartening, as Prakriti is constituent to manifestation but requires Purusha to take on any qualities. Knowing the impossible as impossible ought to be emotionally neutral.

Andrew on 2012-10-08 at 03:47 said:

Bhakti Anand Goswami mentions Meditations on the Tarot in his video:
Tarot & Ancient Symbols of God's Personal Form – Bhakti Ananda Goswami
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-TBUn1Tog20&feature=plcp
He mentions the churning of the milk ocean as the "perturbation of prakiti".

Master Dogen on 2012-10-08 at 06:03 said:

It was a colloquialism, reflecting a feeling I sometimes have, of exasperation and astonishment at the ugliness and, well, chaos of the modern world. When I have the wrong-colored glasses on, I sometimes wonder if literally everything is going to fall apart. Perhaps it's not a very insightful comment, but even those of us seeking the original Tradition exist in specific bodies with specific tendencies and paths, that result in specific emotional reactions at different stages of those paths.

If one is not seeing things clearly, then learning something that is indeed truthful can come as a great relief — thus heartening. Have you never traveled from error into truth and enjoyed the process? If what Cologero points out in this little article is SO self-evident that it has literally zero power to shed light for any of us, then I suppose it's time for Cologero to stop writing them. However, at least for me, that is not the case.

Furthermore, I can't claim that I KNOW the impossible as impossible. I read about Purusha and Prakriti; I meditate on it; but it's not like I have succeeded in slaying the ego and manifesting the eternal in my moment to moment existence. I don't suppose I would have much use for reading Gornahoor if I were already totally secure in all my understandings of Tradition.

11

Epistemology

11.1 Knowledge of the Heart

Light is the most common symbol of knowledge, so that it is natural that solar light represent direct knowledge, that is, intuitive knowledge, which is that of pure intellect, and that lunar light represent reflective knowledge, that is, discursive knowledge, which is that of reason. As the moon can only give its light when it is itself illuminated by the sun, so likewise reason, within the order of reality that is its own proper domain, can function validly only under the guarantee of principles which enlighten and direct it, and which it receives from the higher intellect. On this point there is an ambiguity which it is important to dispel: modern philosophers strangely deceive themselves in speaking as they do of "rational principles", as if these principles belonged by right to reason, as if they were in some way its production, whereas in order to govern reason they must on the contrary impose themselves upon it, and thus come from above. This is an example of the rationalist error, and one can thereby understand the essential difference that exists between rationalism and

true intellectuality. One need reflect but a moment to understand that a principle in the true sense of the word, by the very fact that it cannot be drawn or deduced from something else, can only be grasped immediately, thus intuitively, and could not be the object of a discursive knowledge such as that which characterizes reason to use Scholastic terminology, it is pure intellect that is *habitus principorum*, whereas reason is only *habitus conclusionum*.

A further consequence results from the fundamental character of intellect and reason: intuitive knowledge, because it is immediate, is necessarily infallible in itself; on the contrary, error can always creep into any knowledge that is only indirect or mediate, as is rational knowledge, and it can be seen thereby how wrong Descartes was in wishing to attribute infallibility to reason. This is what **Aristotle** expresses in these terms:

> Among the properties of intelligence, in virtue of which we attain to truth, there are some that are always true, and others that may lead to error. Reason is in the latter class; but the intellect is always in conformity with truth, and nothing is truer than the intellect. Now, principles being better known than demonstration, and every science being accompanied by reason, the knowledge of principles is not a science [but it is a mode of knowledge superior to scientific or rational knowledge, and constitutes metaphysical knowledge proper.] Besides, only the intellect is truer than science [or than reason, which builds up science]; thus principles derive from the intellect.

And to better affirm the intuitive character of this intellect, Aristotle goes on to say:

> One does not demonstrate principles, but one perceives their truth directly.

This direct perception of truth, this intellectual and supra-rational intuition, the simplest notion of which modern man seems to have lost, is

true "knowledge of the heart", to use an expression frequently found in Eastern doctrines. Moreover, this knowledge is in itself something incommunicable; it is necessary to have "realized" it, at least in a certain measure, to know what it truly is, and all that can be said about it gives only la more or less approximate but always inadequate idea of it. Above all, it would be an error to believe that the nature of such knowledge could be effectively understood by anyone who is content to look at it "philosophically", that is, from outside, for it must never be forgotten that like all "profane learning" philosophy is only a purely human or rational knowledge.

On the contrary, "sacred science", in the sense that we have used this term in our writings, is essentially based on supra-rational knowledge; and all that we have said about the use of symbolism and of the teaching contained therein is related to the means which the traditional doctrines place at the disposal of man to enable him to attain to that knowledge par excellence with regard to which all other knowledge, in the measure that it too has some reality, is only a more or less remote participation, a more or less indirect reflection, just as the light of the moon is only a pale reflection of that of the sun.

"Knowledge of the Heart" is the direct perception of the intelligible light, of that Light of the Word spoken of by St. John in the prologue of his Gospel, that radiant Light of the "Spiritual Sun" which is the true "Heart of the World".

René Guénon, Heart and Brain, from *Symbols of Sacred Science*

Posted on 2006-10-25 by Cologero

11.2 How we know what we know

We have often quoted Evola's claim that he thinks like sound and well-born men[1] prior to 1789. As an example, we have referred to Girolamo Savonarola[2], and it will be helpful to bring in more examples. (Of course, not all men were sound thinkers nor well-born, but those who were held positions of intellectual leadership.) Tonight, we refer to a passage from On the Love of God (1616) by **St. Francis de Sales**, describing how we know.

A philosopher may object to his perfunctory treatment, but the Saint was writing for those who would have accepted it as a matter of course. While logical and philosophical discussion of metaphysical ideas has its place, it is imperative to keep in mind that metaphysics is not a branch of philosophy. Physics is the science of sensible things; metaphysics is the science of states of consciousness. There is a plethora of turgid writings in journals and on the Internet that attempt to describe Tradition from the outside, using modernist ideas such as comparative religion, sociological theories, archeology and so on. However, truth is in the interiority of man (**St. Augustine**), so any return to Tradition is dependent on a change of consciousness (what Guenon calls an intellectual conversion[3]).

So in following this passage, we must not adopt it as a theory among other theories. Even less, is it something that we debate or argue about. No, the only recourse is to observe or try to recreate the steps in our own consciousness; only then can we judge its merits. St. Francis describes the process of sense perception, which even a modernist can accept.

> When we look at anything, even though it is present before us, it is not itself united to our eyes, but merely sends them a certain representation or picture of itself, which is called its sensible species,

[1] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1026
[2] https://gornahoor.net/?p=2520
[3] https://gornahoor.net/?p=262

> by means of which we see the object.

But it is the next step that modernity fails to understand. **Immanuel Kant**, for example, got lost at this step when he realized we cannot know the thing-in-itself through sense perception alone. The scientist will attempt to formulate laws using words and mathematical models that describe sensual experience, which he then calls "knowledge". Those are both dead ends: in the former, we are reduced to perpetual ignorance. In the latter, we accept theories provisionally since they are always subject to change. Furthermore, an honest appraisal will reveal how little of our lives, and none of the most important parts of them, are amenable to science. The Doctor of the Church continues:

> When we contemplate or understand a thing, that which we understand is not united to our intellect except by means of another representation and most delicate spiritual image, which is called the intelligible species.

This means that alongside the image created by sense impressions, there is another image in thought. Thus, our mind is also an organ of perception, wherein it experiences things of the spirit (ideas). When the two images coincide, there is knowledge of the thing. St. Francis describes this process of understanding:

> Still, by how many routes and changes do these species get to our intellect. They arrive at the exterior senses, thence pass to the interior sense, then to the imagination, then to the active intellect, and come at last to the passive intellect. Hence, by passing through so many strainers and under so many files they may be purified, subtilized and perfected, and from sensible objects they become intelligible.

The sense object creates a reflection in the mind (imagination). The passive understanding means that we have the potential to understand,

but the active understanding, or the effort of the mind to understand, is also required to make the potential actual. Now, in ordinary life, this happens instantly so we miss out on the entire process, except, perhaps, in recollecting the experience. But sometimes, say in poor lighting, we can observe the mind struggling to make out an object, when suddenly there is the moment of insight when we grasp it.

This all makes more sense when we apply it to human and purely spiritual knowledge. We have discussed the latter on many occasions, for example, in the discussion on St. Augustine[4]. St. Paul uses the analogy of a mirror for spiritual perception, darkly because our minds need be "purified, subtilized, and perfected." But St. Francis goes on to say:

> But in heaven ... divinity will unite itself to our intellect without mediation of any species or representation whatsoever.

But this is exactly how we have been defining gnosis: direct, unmediated knowledge of spiritual truths. For the Hermetist, his goal is gnosis in this life, for which he purifies his consciousness[5].

In between sensible things and intelligible things, there is the human world, constructed by thought, strained and defiled, which is the ground for both the greater and lesser battles. How we come to an understanding of this human world will be the topic of the next post in this series.

All quotes taken from Book 3, Chapter ii.

Posted on 2011-09-30 by Cologero

* * *

[4] https://gornahoor.net/?p=2842

[5] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/moral-purification-of-the-will

EXIT on 2011-09-30 at 10:03 said:

If I have "merely repeated what every perennialist has written down since Guenon", then that is a good thing, since innovation is not my goal. This post was to point out how a particular man thought in 1616, centuries *before* Guenon. To read more from Exit, please visit Utopian Race. – Cologero The article doesn't answer the question in the title. You've merely repeated what every perennialist has written down since Guenon. That doesn't mean you've attained metaphysical states of consciousness. Furthermore, when you speak of self-initiation that only confirms that you haven't attained those states. Or if you've received any other initiations please list them now. Otherwise you can't say you truly know metaphysics, and therefore your knowledge of it is merely philosophical.

Cologero on 2011-10-06 at 20:51 said:

We at Gornahoor choose to discuss what Guenon does not, although he is probably correct that it is unprofitable. We also disagree with G. about the lack of traces. A message to that handful of readers who obsess over my personal being: *You know who's not happy with their lives, when their busy discussing yours.*

> Westerners, including even those who were true metaphysicians up to a certain point, have never known metaphysic in its entirety. Nevertheless there may have been individual exceptions, for nothing in principle precludes the existence, at any period or in any country, of men capable of attaining to complete metaphysical knowledge; and this would even be possible in the present Western world ... it is only right to point out that if such exceptions ever did exist, no written evidence has been found to prove it, nor do the generally known facts reveal traces of their influence; this absence of direct evidence however proves nothing in a negative sens, not should it occasion any surprise, for if cases of this sort did in fact occur, it can only have been thanks to very special circumstances of a nature that we cannot profitably discuss here.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Introduction to the Study of Hindu Doctrines*

EXIT on 2011-10-09 at 08:33 said:

My only interest in your personal being is the fact that upon reading Guenon you have taken his personality and key phrases but have only managed to misrepresent him since you have never attained metaphysical states of conscious with self-initiation which he severely denounced with good reason (since one lacking the spiritual influence cannot give it to oneself).

Cologero on 2011-10-09 at 12:10 said:

> We are all naturally more ready to censure errors than to praise things well done; and many men, from a kind of **innate malice**, and *even when they clearly see the good*, strive with all effort and care to discover some fault or at least something that seems a fault.

From **Baldesar Castiglione**, a wise Westerner.

Moral of the story: In the Comments section, please address specific points rather than general expressions of error, disagreement, etc.

`Perennial on 2011-10-09 at 22:41 said:`

I must confess Mr. EXIT that I continue to be befuddled by your absence of citations or quotes. I do not necessarily fault your interpretation of Guenon, but I do fault you for not sharing your source that people might see your argument in his words and judge for themselves. I personally am more familiar with Evola then with Guenon, so citations would be a big help.

11.3 Esoteric Epistemology

> For the whole human being is at one and the same time a mystic, a gnostic, a magician and a philosopher, i.e., he is religious, contemplative, artistic and intelligent.
>
> VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot*

In the secular world, this is the epistemological question:

> What do you know and when did you know it?

However, this misses the more important question:

> How do you know and what do you know when you know it?

In metaphysics, epistemology follow ontology, i.e., knowledge follows the sequence of manifestation, like this:

1. **Mystical experience**: The pure act of knowledge of the Self
2. **Gnosis**: The intuitive knowledge of the Divine Intellect
3. **Magic**: The expression of that knowledge in representations and imagination, whose source is the Manas.
4. **Philosophy**: The above three states expressed in language, which is proper to the human state.

Tomberg describes the stages in more detail:

> This transformation of mystical experience into knowledge takes place in stages. The first is the pure reflection or a kind of imaginative repetition of the experience. The second stage is its entrance into memory. The third stage is its assimilation in thought and feeling, in a manner where it becomes a "message" or inner word. The fourth stage, lastly, is reached when it becomes a communicable symbol or "writing", or "book"—i.e., when it is formulated.
>
> Valentin Tomberg

Short Circuits There can be deformations of this transformation, such as:

1. Remaining stuck in mystical experience, just for the pleasure of it.
2. Gnosis detached from revelation and tradition lacks any foundation. Gnosis is mysticism that has become conscious of itself.
3. Imagination without gnosis becomes pure fantasy
4. Philosophy becomes pure speculation, and lacks truth

Metaphysical and Profane Knowledge IT is a misconception to assume that the method of metaphysical knowledge is identical to our knowledge of the corporeal world. These are the main differences between the two ways of knowing.

- Metaphysical knowledge is based on the faculty of intuition, which is a direct experience of the real and permits contact between our consciousness and the world of pure mystical experience. Profane knowledge is based on the inferior faculty of the rational mind.

- Metaphysical knowledge is deductive, that is, it begins with higher principles and applies them to particular situations. Profane knowledge is inductive, or better said, abductive.

- Metaphysical knowledge depends on the level of being of the knower. Hence, spiritual practices such as concentration, meditation, prayer, purification of the soul, and so on, are necessary. Profane knowledge, on the other hand, does not depend on the personal character of the knower.

- Metaphysics is known with apodictic certainty and profane knowledge is uncertain and subject to revision.

The Temptation of Philosophy There is a certain blindness in the human being. Those with the intellectual talent often believe that the mere accumulation of books will somehow bring them to gnosis and mystical experience. As we see above, the book is the last stage of the process. Not all mystics and gnostics have the ability to write good books, and certainly fewer can write good poetry.

No matter how many times they hear or read that self-knowledge is more important than book knowledge, it fails to make any impact. You know the type; try to avoid it.

Whenever you think you may have some great idea, don't forget that over the centuries people more intelligent, more educated, and more insightful than you have thought about those issues that so interest you. Turn to the classic authors first, whose thought has endured over the centuries; prefer them to more recent authors.

The Temptation of Science

> Science begins with facts (the "characters" of the book of Nature) and ascends from facts to laws and from laws to principles. Gnosis is the reflection of that which is above; science, in contrast, is the interpretation of that which is below. The last stage of gnosis is the world of facts, where it becomes fact itself, i.e., it becomes "book"; the first stage of science is the world of facts which it "reads", in order to arrive at laws and principles.

There are two ways to understand the Fall of Man:

- From the moral point of view, Adam and Eve disobeyed God's command and were punished for it.
- From the gnosis point of view, Adam and Eve replaced the intuitive knowledge of the Good with the empirical knowledge of good and evil. This had enormous consequences.

The age-old question is, "Is something good because God commanded it, or did God command it because it was good?"

The moral view is based on the first premise and the gnosis view on the second premise.

Science is based on knowledge that begins with, and is restricted to, the sense. It can only produce falsifiable predictions, not certain knowledge.

Posted on 2021-06-27 by Cologero

II.4 The Metaphysics of Knowing

Sense Knowledge Sense knowledge is known through the senses and mediated by thought. There are three inner aspects involved in knowing.

- **Sensation**. The senses apprehend an object
- **Imagination**. The mind forms and image of the object
- **Intellect**. The intellect knows what the object is

What the intellect knows is the form or essence of the object. In that case, the knower *is* the thing, since its essence exists in his mind. However, he is *not* the thing in terms of its existence in manifestation. This is the principle that knowledge is being.

A consequence is that deeper understandings are possible. For example, some people are attuned to animals. They are grasping more of the essence than most people. Others, like Padre Pio, can read men's souls.

Abstract Knowledge Beyond sense knowledge, there is knowledge that derives from abstracting from the world of sense. These are necessary and universal principles, which are independent of all particular facts in space and time. In other words, they are forms of thought. There are three levels of abstraction:

- **Natural Science**. This is the science of the inner universal nature of mineral, plans, and animals, apart from any particular thing.
- **Mathematics**. This includes arithmetic, the science of number, and geometry, the science of shapes. Again, these are abstracted from any sense qualities.

- **Metaphysics**. This is the science of Being in which the intellect recognizes the characteristics of being as such. We previously outlined the main principles of this science.

These abstract sciences demonstrate the immateriality of the soul. Since its knowledge is beyond time, and knowledge is being, the intellectual soul is likewise beyond time.

Analogical Knowledge Since the natural man knows through sense, imagination, and thought, his understanding of spiritual things also begins in the senses, or imagination. That is why spiritual things are explained in terms of images, art, or symbols. That is a way to get to the thought about such things.

The principle of analogy then is that the intellect knows God and spiritual beings by analogy with the sense world. That is, the knowledge of spiritual things is mediated by the imagination and thought.

However, those who do not understand this principle, are able to conceive the spiritual world only in sensual imagery. This leads to misconceptions and distortions.

Therefore, it is necessary to grasp this principle. In Hermetism, this is expressed in the formula, "As above, so below." **Valentin Tomberg** explains this principle:

> Analogy is the first and principal method whose use facilitates the advance of knowledge. It is the first conclusion drawn from the tenet of universal unity. Since at the root of the diversity of phenomena their unity is found in such a way that they are at one and the same time different and one, they are neither identical nor heterogeneous but are analogous insofar as they manifest their essential kinship.

Both Valentin Tomberg and Rene Guenon offer extensive discussions of how to understand metaphysical and religious symbolism. They are worth the study.

Intuitive Knowledge A direct, intuitive knowledge (not mediated by symbols or thought) is possible beyond the natural state. This is the way angelic intelligences know. **Fr Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange** explains knowledge in the postmortem state:

> The separated [i.e., postmortem] soul knows itself directly, without medium. … By this immediate self-knowledge, it sees with perfect evidence its own native spirituality, its immortality, its freedom. … It knows God, no longer in the sense world as mirror, but as mirrored in its own spiritual essence. It sees with transcendent evidence the solution of the great philosophic problems, and the absurdity of materialism, determinism, and pantheism. [postmortem] souls have knowledge of one another and the angels.

Clearly, that explanation leaves out of consideration the possibility of achieving such states before physical death. Of course, the whole point of the spiritual path of theosis is indeed to achieve such states. We have the testimony of those who have achieved them and we have the metaphysical understanding that shows such states are possible while alive.

Knowing in this way is the way that angels know[6]. Angelic intelligences can also be understood as higher states of being, i.e., beyond the natural man.

Posted on 2014-09-29 by Cologero

11.5 Self-Realization through Knowledge

According to **Fr Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange**, there are three orders of knowledge: human, angelic, and divine. They each have their proper object of knowledge:

[6] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=2995`

- **Human**: Sense objects.
- **Angelic**: His own angelic essence
- **Divine**: His own divine essence

Note the lack of symmetry in the object of human knowledge. That is because the natural man is a determinate, material being, unlike angels and God. The type of knowledge proper to man is subject-object and discursive, whereas spiritual knowledge is intuitive and direct.

To restore the symmetry, we can consider the possibility that the proper object of man's knowledge is analogously his own essence. That necessitates the transcendence of the natural human state. Actually, this is the only true knowledge, since our knowledge of sensual things is more properly classified as opinion. **Rene Guenon** asserts:

> The being assimilates more or less completely everything of which it is conscious; indeed, there is no true knowledge in any domain whatsoever, other than that which enables us to penetrate into the intimate nature of things, and the degrees of knowledge consist precisely in the measure to which this penetration is more or less profound and results in a more or less complete assimilation. In other words, the only genuine knowledge is that which implies an identification of the subject with the object.

Thus, to understand one's own essence, one must become more and more conscious of himself. This knowledge is not discursive, but rather intuitive and non-dual. Keeping in mind the principle that "knowing is being", this means that the more we know (in this sense), the more being we have. This knowing is identical to achieving higher states.

It is helpful, therefore, to understand the sense in which angels know in order to achieve such states. Furthermore, we are commanded to "know God". Clearly, then, this means to achieve a certain state of being, which is the idea of *theosis*.

Angelic Knowledge Angels do not acquire knowledge through sense objects. They know ideas, which are in the divine mind, directly. This knowledge is both universal and concrete; that is, it is knowledge both of essence and existence. In Guenonian terms, the former is the knowledge of possibilities and the latter of those possibilities as manifested. However, their knowledge is not co-extensive with the infinity of all possibilities.

The angelic ideas represent a region of intelligible reality and each angel has his own domain. The angels themselves form a hierarchy; since this represents a difference in level of being, there must likewise be a difference in level of knowledge. Fr Garrigou-Lagrange explains:

> The higher the angel, the stronger is his intelligence and the fewer are his ideas, since they are more rich and universal. Thus, with ever fewer ideas, the higher angels command immense regions of reality, which the lower angels cannot attain with such eminent simplicity. A human parallel is the sage who, in a few simple principles, grasps an entire branch of knowledge.

We noted something similar to this previously when discussing abstract knowledge. By knowing certain mathematical or metaphysical principles, the expanse of knowledge just opens up. For the angels, their domains over human existence become increasingly more universal. There are guardian angels or daemons for the individual; then there are higher angles that represent nations, and so on.

Classical Theism Classical theism[7] is the term used by philosophers to represent our conception of God. The downside of this is that it may seem that it is just one possible conception among others, which are then debatable. However, the more correct understanding is that classical theism is the correct conception and all others are simply misconceptions.

[7] `http://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2010/09/classical-theism.html`

(For more details from a philosopher's viewpoint, please visit the link provided.)

While it can be difficult to grasp, it is worth the effort since it reveals many problems in regard to God to be pseudo-problems. The common mind still tends to conceive of God as a Zeus-like figure, that is, a very powerful being, involved in time, interfering in the affairs of men, and so on. Even many philosophers and theologians have but a more sophisticated view of Zeus.

Fundamentally, God is Being itself. As Guenon points out, Being is a possibility of non-manifestation, hence God cannot exist as a being among other beings; furthermore, the corollary is that God is non-material. Being is the cause of Existence, by making the potential actual.

God's knowledge is not different from his being (knowing=being). He knows all possibilities, directly, as they subsist in the divine mind. In particular, God's knowledge cannot take the form, "God knows all true propositions", as I read on a blog a short while ago.

There is a logical consequence of this, that is seldom brought out. As we pointed out last time, when I know a squirrel, for example, I am that squirrel insofar as the idea subsists in my mind. Since the idea of the squirrel, both as an abstract and universal idea, as well as each particular squirrel, we can assert that God is likewise a squirrel, a tree, and so on for everything, insofar as he knows himself. This is not quite pantheism, since we can't go in the other direction and say, for example, that the squirrel is God.

Higher than all the angels, God knows the entire world, as Guenon defines the world as:

> the entire domain formed by a certain ensemble of compossibles realized in manifestation; these compossibles must be the totality of possibles that satisfy certain conditions characterizing and precisely defining that world

He also knows the world and its future because He wills it.

Consciousness and Knowledge God is conscious only analogously to the way man is conscious. Guenon explains that total truth must be coextensive with Being and universal Possibility, while consciousness is a human state. This precludes the idea of God having intentional consciousness, that is, the duality of a subject knowing an object.

In his best book, *Answer to Job*, **Carl Jung** has an interesting speculation that God is unconscious, which is true from Jung's psychological point of view, and that man is God's consciousness. While Jung tries to describe this psychologically and phenomenologically, there is a more metaphysical interpretation. God does not look out on the world, Zeus-like, from on high; rather, he knows the world, as defined above, in his own mind.

Now, man knows sense objects. Specifically, he not only knows the idea of a tree, he also senses the tree: its color, scent, the rustling of the branches in the wind, etc. God has no physical senses. However, he has a perfect knowledge of man as manifested, hence he knows the tree in the same way the man does. God is psychically unconscious in man. Jung writes:

> It is only through the psyche that we can establish that God acts upon us, but we are unable to distinguish whether these actions emanate from God or from the unconscious.

This means that we need to differentiate between the influences that impinge on our consciousness: is their source worldly or transcendent? Jung says that through the Holy Spirit, the divine child, or one's real Self, is born in consciousness. God then becomes conscious in man as man becomes conscious of God.

This is self-realization through knowledge.

Posted on 2014-10-01 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2014-10-04 at 12:06 said:

There was a lot to unpack from this post (which was very good by the way), and so I thought it was best to do a number of re-readings of it before making my comment.

My comment is really just about a question of clarification with respect to the last part of the post on the Answer to Job and God's relation with man. Would God becoming conscious in man be compatible with the principle of God as pure act? It seems that God becoming conscious implies a potential that is yet actualized. I wish I had a copy of Jung's book at hand so I can read it in light of your post.

Cologero on 2014-10-05 at 17:39 said:

Nice catch, Matt, but the problem is just that I may have expressed it poorly. Jung does use that type of language, presumably figuratively. Language is simply insufficient. Jung's point is that the consciousness of God is lacking, but man can become more conscious of God. If God knows every person, then his becoming conscious of God is God "becoming" conscious through the person. The "becoming conscious" is a possibility of manifestation, which God knows eternally, so it is not a question of becoming from His point of view, but it is from the person's. This is not a dogma, but it is worth pondering.

Cologero on 2014-10-07 at 23:40 said:

"We are not to call any man a real philosopher who is a friend of wisdom for profit, as are lawyers, physicians, and almost all the clergy, who do not study in order to know, but in order to get money or office; and if anyone would give them that which it is their purpose to acquire, they would linger over their study no longer."

"Beyond the delightful and the useful, there is a love for wisdom for its own sake; wisdom alone is worthy of man. And just as love between men is genuine when each loves the other without reserve, so the true philosopher embraces wisdom in her totality, and wisdom in her totality opens herself to the whole man."

Dante

11.6 Losing One's Head

The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents. We live on a placid

> island of ignorance in the midst of black seas of infinity, and it was not meant that we should voyage far. The sciences, each straining in its own direction, have hitherto harmed us little; but some day the piecing together of dissociated knowledge will open up such terrifying vistas of reality, and of our frightful position therein, that we shall either go mad from the revelation or flee from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age.
>
> H P Lovecraft, *The Call of Cthulhu*

> Real philosophy seeks rather to solve than to deny. While we hear, every day, the small pretenders to science talk of the absurdities of Alchemy and the dream of the Philosopher's Stone, a more erudite knowledge is aware that by Alchemists the greatest discoveries in science have been made, and much which still seems abstruse, had we the key to the mystic phraseology they were compelled to adopt, might open the way to yet more noble acquisitions. The Philosopher's Stone itself has seemed no visionary chimera to some of the soundest chemists that even the present century has produced. Man cannot contradict the Laws of Nature. But are all the Laws of Nature yet discovered?
>
> Zanoni

St Denis **St Denis**, an early bishop of Paris, was martyred by decapitation at Montmartre. He then picked up his head, held it in front of his heart, and then walked several kilometres. The esoteric significance of this story is that the knowledge of the head needs to become subservient to the knowledge of the heart. **Rene Guenon** explains this distinction:



Figure 11.1: Saint Denys

> Reason, which is only a mediate knowing faculty, is the strictly human mode of intelligence; intellectual intuition can be called supra-human, as it is a direct participation in universal intelligence which, residing in the heart, that is, at the being's very centre where lies his point of contact with the Divine, penetrates this being from within and illuminates him with its radiation. (*The Symbolism of the Heart*)

The New Dark Age

> The time has long gone by when anyone who claims the title of philosopher can think of religion as a superfluity for the educated and an 'opiate for the masses'. It is the only known explosive in the economy of that delicate internal-combustion engine, the human mind. Peoples rich in religious energy can overcome all obstacles and attain any height in the scale of civilization. Peoples that have reached the top of a hill by the wise use of religious energy may then decide to do without it; they can still move, but they can only move downhill, and when they come to the bottom of the hill they stop.
>
> Robin Collingwood

Matter is darkness and consciousness is light. Yet our age considers materialism, the notion that nothing exists but matter, to be the sign of intelligence. **Sigmund Freud** showed us how there is a drive in his patients toward matter, which he called the death instinct. Collectively, our age loves death. It tries to blot out consciousness with drugs, noise, and distractions. That is considered to be the intelligent option.

Westerners today should be deliriously happy, as social goals like sexual liberation have been achieved. Yet reports of mental illness are high as

well as both legal and illegal use of psychotropic drugs. If we are simply material beings, then there should be a material solution to the problems of life.

It is actually materialism that is the opiate of the masses. It absolves them from dealing with their faults in a serious way and from facing the consequences of their postmortem states.

We can see that the light eliminates darkness, yet no one can explain how darkness creates light.

Thinking Perhaps some examples of the three levels of knowledge discussed in the previous post will be helpful.

Most people, assuming they bother to think at all, are constrained to the level of opinion, or *doxa*. They regard every discussion like a court case, with each side arguing for a predetermined outcome. Hence, such a person will accumulate facts and opinions that he feels will support his point of view, and his debating partner will do the same. These opinions are isolated from each other and don't become a coherent whole unless accidentally.

At a higher level, a person is able to reason effectively; that is *dianoia*. He attempts to find the unifying factor by discovering the idea that accounts for the facts. That is the most likely story. However, its defect is that it is always subject to disproof or modification.

The ability to reason properly is actually quite difficult and most people overestimate their skill. Geometry is good practice, so Plato required a knowledge of geometry for his students. Advances in mathematics, such as statistical methods, game theory, and so on, have added more difficulties. In particular, statistical arguments are particularly difficult for most.

Episteme, or intuition, is beyond argument. We can point to Euclid's axioms and postulates as examples. Either you understand them or you don't. You can't prove them or argue about them. The exception is the fifth postulate which has not been so obvious. It turns out, in fact, that

alterations in that postulate lead to other, consistent geometries. Yet, the denial of the other axioms and postulates make geometry itself impossible.

The example Valentin Tomberg gave of such an intuition is the cosmos as an "ordered whole". The scientist implicitly accepts this since he expects his experiments to lead to consistent results; moreover, the laws he discovers should be true across the universe.

The same is true for the religious person. God is the principle of being (the whole) and the Logos (order) is coextensive with God. Again, there is no empirical demonstration nor logical proof. One either understands it or not. It is not the same as a personal, subjective, or arbitrary conviction.

Unfortunately, in discussions of the higher things, people tend to move at the levels of doxa and dianoia indiscriminately. This makes communication impossible.

Yet the effort must be made. Meditation on certain ideas will help one reach the spiritual ideal. Then one can see.

Posted on 2018-08-30 by Cologero

11.7 Thought and Transcendence

If you try to find out how **Plato** in particular described the soul forces of *eros* and *thumos*, you will discover scholars debating with each other, but without reaching any conclusion. The metaphysician, on the other hand, takes a radically different approach. Through meditation and contemplation, he will observe how these forces act in his consciousness. He will learn to recognize the forces in all aspects of his life: *viz*., how they affect his body, his feelings, his imagination, his thoughts.

This is symbolized by "awakening the chakras," which represent the different centers in man. Typically, the symbol is taken for the reality, and,

instead of self-observation, the mystic will go in search of these chakras. This is the occult equivalent of snark hunting.

For example, he may observe how sexual fantasies arise and how they tend to dominate his consciousness. That is *eros*. Or, he may observe other fantasies where he tells off his boss, gets even with an enemy, defeats an intruder. He recognizes those as the manifestation of *thumos* in the imagination. There are obvious reasons that so much popular culture involves sex and violence. Movements to remove them cannot reach to the cause of the problem.

In our thinking faculty, *eros* is experienced as excitement about a system of thought. This may be a new book or article by a favored author, or the expression of some idea that "hits home". There is the search for novelty in thought, the next great idea or movement, a new writer, and so on. People dominated by this force will say things such as "I like that idea," or "I find it interesting." Thought systems that appeal to this force tend to flatter believers.

Thumos can be recognized by aggression in thought. Men become upset or angry by another's ideas. Discussion or debate is regarded as a type of blood sport. I've seen men invite debate with phrases such as "bring it on," as though their words will bring their interlocutor to his knees. Anyone who has browsed in a university library can see that few questions are so definitively resolved. Thought systems that appeal to this force provide a sense of identity and purpose, so that anything that undercuts them is experienced as a threat.

Do not mistake these observations for moral judgments. The forces have their useful purpose, for example, in motivating one in the search for knowledge or in defense of the truth. Nevertheless, that is only possible when the forces are under the mastery of the Intellect. Otherwise, they will simply lead a man astray.

As in the imagery of Plato's Chariot, the Intellect, or the Heart or Spirit, is to dominate the lower soul forces. This notion is common to

Rene Guenon and **Julius Evola**. This is not simply a war between different sources, but rather a movement, a conversion, in a different direction, namely, the vertical or transcendent. Once again to be clear, this is not some philosophical theory, but something that must be verified or "realized" in one's own consciousness.

Specifically, thoughts gradually lose their emotional force as a man learns to observe them without attachment. He sees that all thought systems are points of view and the Intellect is superior (transcendent) to all such points of view. In the Central Philosophy of Buddhism, **Murti** writes:

> Spiritual culture is self-culture ... the essence of self-culture is the bringing about a change in oneself, not in the environment... Spiritual culture must be further understood as an intense and sustained self-reflection, self-criticism. It is a ceaseless watchfulness of one's doings—speech, bodily and mental action. Passions overpower us because of our self-forgetfulness, we are not self-possessed. With mindfulness regained, the passions cease to have hold on us. ... the dialectic on the intellectual side is the reflective criticism of the inveterate tendency of the mind to speculate and spin theories ...

There should be no need to remind readers that this is not a task for hermits and recluses. To the contrary, it is the necessary attitude for action in the world. It is a process of detoxification from false belief systems. As Evola put it[8]:

> To lift oneself up is not possible as long as one remains under the influence of forms of false and deviant thinking. Detoxified, a man can pursue clarity, rectitude, strength.

Posted on 2012-10-15 by Cologero

[8] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4732`

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Cologero on 2012-10-16 at 17:12 said:

These forces are especially prominent in political debates. Ideally, the listener to a debate should sit back and objectively evaluate the positions of the candidates, as well as their character, leadership skills, etc. Instead, we are expected to choose winners and losers. Partisans of one candidate or the other will cheer for their guy, regardless of the wisdom of his platform, character, etc. It is considered impolite to take note of this.

11.8 The Knower and the Known

One of the fundamental differences between the Traditional and the modern worldviews regards the nature of knowing. For the modern mind, knowing depends on the thing known and the knower himself is passive. As far back as the Stoics, the analogy used was that of wax taking on the design of a seal; thus, the sense impressions in the mind are the effect of an external object. The moderns took this up again, although it then led to Kantian skepticism since there is no way to be sure the sense impression really matches the external object. On the other hand, those of a scientific bent totally ignored Kant and continued on their quest; this has consequences for the search for artificial intelligence and the Golem.

In his Consolations of Philosophy, **Boethius** addresses the topic and rejects it:



> People think that the totality of their knowledge depends on the nature and capacity to be known of the objects of knowledge. But this is all wrong. *Everything that is known is comprehended not according to its own nature, but according to the ability to know of those who do the knowing*. [my emphasis]

This needs to be pondered. It means that knowing is not an automatic process and that the object of knowledge does not reveal itself indiscriminately. For example, academics study Tradition as a set of texts that have appeared historically. The academic, then, believes that his impressions represent the truth of Tradition, and all he needs do is to catalog the texts and relate them, temporally or spatially.

But this is all wrong. Only the man who has prepared himself, who has developed within himself the ability to know, only he can understand Tradition. Boethius summarizes the stages of knowledge in the following schema; note, especially, how they relate to **Dante**'s four levels of understanding an esoteric text. Nothing in Tradition is arbitrary.

Stage of knowledge	Description
Sense Impression	The senses examine shape as constituted in matter.
Imagination	Considers the shape apart from matter
Reason	Transcends the imagination and reflects upon the species inherent in individual instanc
Intuition or Intelligence	Passes beyond the sphere of the universe to behold the simple form itself with the pure vision o

Boethius elaborates:

> The point of greatest importance here is this: the superior manner of knowledge includes the inferior, but it is quite impossible for the inferior to rise to the superior. The senses cannot perceive anything beyond matter; imagination does not consider universal species; and reason does not comprehend simple form … [the Intellect] knows reason's knowledge of universals, imagination's knowledge of shape, and the sense's knowledge of matter without using reason, imagination, or the senses, but by the single glance of the mind according to the form.

Boethius makes clear that this is an active process:

> In perceiving corporeal phenomena the mind is not passively affected, but judges of its own power the experience subjected to the body.

This "power", then, can be developed further and Boethius urges us on:

> Let us, then, if we can, raise ourselves up to the heights of that supreme intelligence. There reason will be able to see that which it cannot see by itself—it will be able to see how that which has no certain occurrence may be seen by a certain and fixed foreknowledge, *a knowledge that is not opinion, but the boundless immediacy of the highest form of knowing*.

Golems and Artificial Intelligence The whole premise of the development of artificial intelligence is based on the passive reception of sense impressions. Since a computer can have no conception of the form of a cube, simple tasks, such as recognizing a box, are very difficult. Through sheer computational power, computers are, and will be, able to simulate intelligence, but not have intelligence in any real sense. Legends of golems and homunculi recognized this. The golem could not be merely a being or mechanism of matter; somehow it would have to be animated. In other legends, higher beings were invoked to animate a statue or a doll. But no one thought mere matter could display intelligence.

I'm using the translation by V. E. Watts, published by Penguin Classics

Posted on 2012-10-23 by Cologero

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Logres on 2012-10-25 at 15:44 said:

I wonder if Cassiodorus had similar knowledge – I am thinking he did, more than likely, given his career and task.

Cologero on 2012-10-26 at 12:28 said:

Logres, Boethius was not breaking new ground, he thought the way intelligent men of the time did. (I'm excluding non-Traditional systems like stoicism or epicureanism.) It was that way for centuries; the Romance of the Rose and Chaucer both had high regard for Boethius. The "wonder" is why no one has similar knowledge today. For example, academic Chaucer scholars may pride themselves on their facility with Middle English. But can they truly understand Chaucer without grasping his worldview, from the inside, as it were? Why is that knowledge lost? Has it been disproved or simply lost?

Logres on 2012-10-26 at 21:30 said:

In the Bagavad-Gita, Krishna tells Arjuna that there are lapses of knowledge, in which it sinks into nothingness, & has to be renewed by direct intervention of an avatar. Can we still pull the ring out of the well? Did the ring hide itself?

Cassiodorus on 2012-10-28 at 23:06 said:

"Has it been disproved or simply lost".

That reminds of the first work I read by a defender of Tradition- Huston Smith's Forgotten Truth.

11.9 Knowledge of the Future

In the last book of his *Consolations of Philosophy*, **Boethius** discusses how God can know the future if man is free. Recall how he explained the four levels of knowledge[9]: sense impressions, imagination, rational knowledge, and intuition. It is worth the effort to understand his explanation if for no other reason that intuition is critical for the man of Tradition. It cannot be learned from reading about it, but each man must develop it himself. The seeming contradiction involved in the dilemma can be treated as a type of koan that needs to be meditated on, while being elusive to rational thought. Curious readers may notice that this question arose again

[9] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5098

a millennium later in the dispute about Molinism[10]. That dispute took the form of rational knowledge which Boethius firmly rejects as an adequate explanation. This demonstrates how metaphysical understanding gradually eroded over those 1000 years.



This knowledge of the future baffles the rational mind, since it claims that the future can be known only if it be predetermined. However, this is a misunderstanding of what it means "to know", since it places knowability in the object of knowledge rather than in the knower himself. Hence we are compelled to not consider the thing known, but rather we need to grasp how the knower knows. Following Augustine and the Neo-Platonists (and anticipating Rene Guenon, to be sure), Boethius first distinguishes between eternity and everlastingness. The latter is perpetual existence in time, whereas the former is outside time altogether. Boethius explains:

> The world is still not such that it may properly be considered eternal … Its life may be infinitely long, but it does not embrace and comprehend its whole extent simultaneously. It still lacks the future, while already having lost the past. So that that which embraces and possesses simultaneously the whole fullness of everlasting life, which lacks nothing of the future and has lost nothing of the past, that is what my properly be said to be eternal. … It is one thing to progress through everlasting life, and another thing to have embraced the whole of everlasting life in one simultaneous present. This is clearly a property of the mind of God.

Boethius follows Plato's claim that "God is eternal, the world perpetual." For the world, the past is always receding ("lost") while the future

[10] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Molinism`

is not yet ("lacking"). Thus God cannot be considered as existing "before" the world. Hence, it is not really a question of foreknowledge of the future, but instead the "knowledge of a never ending presence." This is the literal meaning of Providence, "looking forth", which he contrasts to prevision or "seeing ahead".

Next, Boethius addresses the counterargument that to know future events implies that the future is determined and free will is not possible. Obviously, this is mechanical thinking arising from the rational mind as opposed to the organic thinking that sees time as a whole. If I watch you walking down the street, then I know it through sense perception; nevertheless, this type of knowing, which is also a form of direct intuition, does not make your perambulation unfree or necessary.

By analogy, and that is all we may have for now, the same can be said about God's seeing through intellectual intuition. Boethius writes:

> Divine foreknowledge does not change the nature and property of things; it simply sees things present to it exactly as they will happen at some time as future events. … the divine gaze looks down on all things without disturbing their nature; to Him, they are present things, but under the conditions of time they are future things. And so when God knows that something is going to occur and knows that no necessity to be is imposed on it, it is not opinion, but rather knowledge founded upon truth.

In the example of watching someone walk on the street, we were clearly appealing to spatial perception rather than temporal. It is easy to grasp that our experience of objects in space is grasping the whole, as something all-at-once, at least within the limits of our horizon. But events in time don't typically have that same effect, as events come at us sequentially, not all at once. Each moment in time seems independent of what follows; this is what perplexed Hume so that he could not understand the nature of

causality. Yet as we recently pointed out[11], artistic inspiration often takes this form. This is why Solovyov used artistic experience as the model for the type of intuition being described. In particular music and poetry lend themselves to this, this they unfold in time while being grasped as a whole. Hence, we can grasp a symphony as a whole even though our experience is one note after another. Yet, the musicians play the instruments by their own free will.

It may be helpful to draw on what **Rene Guenon** writes about time in The Reign of Quantity. He points out that time is more subtle than space, and that accounts for its elusiveness. It can only be measured by spatial criteria and the most intimate part of us — our mental life — develops in time yet has no spatial character. This means that time is even more qualitative than space and our tendency to experience time just in its quantitative aspect can only result in misunderstanding. Guenon uses the example of the four seasons, the temporal equivalent of the four spatial directions. Once we see things in terms of cycles — organically — we can "predict" the future. Of course, the world unfolds in cycles within cycles, etc.

Next, we can point out the nature of manifestation. Recall that a fundamental principle is the identity of knowing and being. We know that there are possibilities of manifestation. When God knows a possibility of manifestation, as he must since it is an idea in His own mind, then it necessarily manifests—essence and existence are one. And this is so, even if from the perspective of time, it is the result of free acts.

Finally, how can man experience things *sub specie aeternitatis*? Obviously, not man qua man, but only from states that are higher than the human state. To reach that highest state is what Guenon calls deliverance as opposed to salvation. Readers who continue to do their exercises and meditations may find that they can reach a state of detachment in which consciousness is observing the actions of the body. Within the incessant

[11] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=5381`

states of conscious activity, that is, the everlasting or perpetual, what is the one constant? That is the eternal.

Posted on 2012-12-10 by Cologero

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Saladin on 2013-10-18 at 13:25 said:
Very interesting! I have just discovered The Consolation of Philosophy, and it is a real gem!

11.10 Gods, Angels, and Men

Every now and then, it is necessary to go over some basic concepts, particularly because the way we use them is not necessarily how they are commonly used. The claim of metaphysics is that it leads to perfect gnosis. As such, it is not a theory, a set of beliefs, or mere opinion; rather, it sees things as necessarily true. Moreover, besides the formal knowledge of the ideas, principles, and concepts, a change in being is also necessary to turn that knowledge into gnosis. One "sees" that it is so; at some point, as that gnosis sinks in, it becomes impossible to see the world in any other way.

Few men concern themselves with issues of epistemology; that is, they seldom concern themselves with the reasons for their beliefs. A thought crosses their mind, they are pleased with it, probably it brings them esteem in their social circle, it provides a modicum of order to the unstoppable stream of consciousness, and it is imprinted with a strong emotional attachment. Hence, it must be true and they defend that opinion fervently. We metaphysicians, on the other hand, are not so sanguine. We realize how difficult it is to achieve even the beginnings of knowledge. We endure the hardships of the spiritual combat, clearing out mind of the debris of unsupportable opinions. The Muslim sage, **Suhrawardi**, says there are four categories of men who seek after knowledge. The task at hand is to move from (1) to (4).

1. Those who feel the thirst for knowledge and embark upon the path of seeking it.

2. Those who have attained formal, or discursive, knowledge, but not yet gnosis.

3. Those who have achieved gnosis or intellectual intuition, but not discursive knowledge. Many saints fall into this category, since they may not necessarily have the proper metaphysical instruction

4. Those who have perfected discursive knowledge as well as gnosis and intellectual intuition.

Being and God This issue comes up often, so this would be a good time to go over it again. Guenon makes the claim that the primordial unity is universal being. As Being is the principle of any existing thing, this is understood as God in the Western classical tradition. Since it is a unity, it must be monotheism. This is precisely what is meant, and we reject any anthropomorphic god, or even a "personal" god. Unfortunately, to those ignorant of metaphysics, they presume these false and idolatrous notions of God.

To deny this principle, therefore, is to reject the unity of being. One alternative would be complete chaos, or an indeterminate universe like some enormous Schroedinger cat. That would be like the matrix, with the mind confabulating a coherent worldview out of the random universe, not unlike the mind during sleep fabricating dreams out of random neural impulses.

Or else, there are two or more irreconcilable principles with no unifying higher principle. An example is Manichaeism, with an infinite and pointless battle between good and evil. In ancient paganism, the gods and goddesses were independent, some giving their blessings to a project

and others, curses. They themselves are not ultimate, but are subject to the Fates.

Now this understanding of God is common to all Tradition. For example, in the Aristotelian-Thomist tradition mentioned in the Round Table, God is understood as Being. The Muslim metaphysician, Avicenna, says substantially the same thing. God is the necessary Being, the only such Being, and all other beings are contingent. Now these days, you can easily run across web sites that try to demonstrate that Christians and Muslims do not "believe" in the same God. To the contrary, as was just shown, the understanding of God is basically the same, and could not be otherwise. The real question is whether Traditional Christianity is compatible with Protestantism. Even more so, is Mormonism incompatible with this view; they really believe in some sort of demiurge that they name god. Esoterically, one's allies are other than what seems obvious exoterically.

Angelic Intelligences As the gnosis of God was lost in the West and He became regarded as just another being or person, albeit of great powers, so too did knowledge of the angels. In large part this was due to the hyper-rationalism that discredited **Dionysius the Areopagite** and **Hermes Trismegistus** because of the allegedly later dates attributed to their writings; this was also related to the false doctrine of Sola Scriptura. The Hermetic tradition did keep it alive, and we see that also in **Valentin Tomberg**. Tomberg pointed to Rudolf Steiner primarily for his writings on spiritual hierarchies, but we will see what it would mean to restore knowledge of this realm.

The Muslim tradition, or at least one branch of it, did however keep this knowledge alive. They regarded Pythagoras, Hermes, and Plato, among others, as the bearers of an ancient, but still valid, tradition. **Avicenna**, for example, has a cosmology not unlike the one we indicated in Spiritual

Beings[12]. For him, the process of creation is the same as intellection. Keep in mind that angels are pure intellects, hence, non-formal beings. As each level in the angelic hierarchy contemplates the ideas, the world is created until the physical world, which is the final stage in the actualization of possibilities.

Our experience of the ideas is obviously not through the senses, but rather as thoughts. Thus, when we observe the thoughts that appear in consciousness, we are contemplating along with the angels. We recognize how ideas in the fullness appear as constellations of related thoughts. The more detached we are, the higher we can rise to experience more and more subtle realms. Unfortunately, the way is usually blocked by the "spirits of the air", that is, demonic intelligences that fill our minds with counter-creative ideas. This is why "watchfulness" is so necessary to achieve gnosis, so we can "see" the source of all those thought forms that influence and control our actions.

At a still lower level, the erotic and thymotic impulses work in consciousness. They each have an intellectual component, and thoughts related to these impulses form a very large part of our daily consciousness. Spiritual training is therefore focused on the observation of thoughts.

Man and Free Will

> Omnipotence does not mean power to do absurdities. The compulsion of another's will is such an absurdity, and therefore no real omnipotence could force such a compulsion. Omnipotence is spiritual, and spirit acts not by brute compulsion but by knowledge and inspiration.
>
> R. G. Collingwood

Man, as spirit, has free will. Higher intelligences, therefore, cannot "take over" a mind; however, a mind can latch onto a thought, harbor it, and

[12] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1941`

freely make it a part of his own identity. Often after a tragic event, people will plaintively ask, "Why did God allow this to happen?" However, to forcibly prevent a free man from acting, is an absurdity, such as making a square triangle. He simply would not be what he is. The real task, then, is to increase knowledge and to be inspired by the higher intelligences.

Yet men are not equal in their intelligences. A hierarchical society will provide the visual guidance to those unable, or not yet able. For example, the Brahmin type is idealist and objective, while the Kshatriya is idealist and subjective. The former contemplates things objectively; the latter is oriented to action. Hence, his subjectivity is crucial when administering a state or conducting a war, since he needs to take sides. The vaisya is objective but materialist; hence he can work in science and industry, the business of the world. The shudra is subjective and materialist, hence, incapable of true self-government.

In an organic society, the various castes work in harmony until, through degeneration the lower castes will rebel against the higher. At our time, the highest caste is disorganized, and the levers of power are in the hands of the shudra. On their own, they cannot have a direct conception of God and higher intelligences, which is why societies ruled by shudra tend to be atheistic and oriented to the satisfaction of material desires, including base and perverse desires.

These are the clues to understand events from a transcendent perspective. The first task is to understand man and his types, caste being fundamental. When the characteristics of each caste are understood, events and the reasons for decisions and actions will become clear. Beyond that, one learns to see intuitively the various higher forces that strive to influence the world; these are generally of three types: constructive, preservative, or destructive. One will see how various thought forms take hold in men; it is still amazing how groups of men will suddenly latch onto a new idea at the same time. Their makeup predisposes them to accept it.

References:
Nasr, Seyyed Hossein, Three Muslim Sages
Schuon, Frithjof, Castes and Races

Posted on 2013-06-25 by Cologero

* * *

Ash on 2013-06-26 at 01:53 said:

The relationship between knowledge and gnosis is interesting. The third type described here would likely be difficult for many of us to encounter precisely because we could not waste time on sophistry and intellectual pride on them. The holy fool is the most clear example – good luck trying to talk about "the essence of Being", political ideologies, or Heidegger with them. While we try to think our way to Heaven, Heaven finds itself on earth in them and shakes its head in bewilderment.

The idea of the angelic intelligences is one I will have to ponder further. It seems to be a short step from "acting" spiritual entities to the "acting" God to the anthropomorphic God. Father Seraphim Rose's doctrine of the toll houses troubles some of his followers in a similar way…it seems to be too corporeal at least at first glance. I find it interesting that the personalization of God was referred to as idolatry. This leads to a topic I often wonder about: how exactly aspects of exoteric relation are brought into an esoterically minded person's life. Tradition, of course; but how do we approach the Bible, with its very personal God and tribal histories? Christ the Logos, yes; but what of Jesus the Teacher and Carpenter? As a Catholic, Cologero, I'm sure you have encountered this as well in some form.

The way the demonic intelligences are discussed here remind me very much of how they are presented in Lewis' The Screwtape Letters, a book a highly recommend. Not a word wasted.

"When two humans have lived together for many years it usually happens that each has tones of voice and expressions of face which are almost unendurably irritating to the other. Work on that. Bring fully into the consciousness of your patient that particular lift of his mother's eyebrows which he learned to dislike in the nursery, and let him think how much he dislikes it. Let him assume that she knows how annoying it is and does it to annoy – if you know your job he will not notice the immense improbability of the assumption. And, of course, never let him suspect that he has tones and looks which similarly annoy her. As he cannot see or hear himself, this easily managed."

"Indeed the safest road to Hell is the gradual one–the gentle slope, soft underfoot, without sudden turnings, without milestones, without signposts,…Your affectionate uncle, Screwtape."

Jacob on 2013-06-26 at 11:47 said:

I have some trouble with the personal God concept as well. Hopefully, Cologero can help clarify for me. I know Charles Upton once pointed out that when we say something is non personal we equate it with a non intelligent force like Gravity. So he used the word Transpersonal, something transcend to personhood. That helps point towards an answer, but it's still very difficult for me to grasp, especially with the problems you point out, Ash.

@Cologero and Logres: BM's Gnosis I should arrive today. I'm looking forward to reading it. I'll probably have to return with questions though.

Avery on 2013-06-26 at 12:29 said:

At least in my mind's eye, the existence of angels makes perfect sense to me. Devils clearly exist (I agree that The Screwtape Letters, one of the best books of the 20th century, comes in handy here, and Evola makes a compelling but somewhat less poetic case in Ruins as well); devils are intermediaries, and it is odd to suggest the evil one can make intermediaries but God cannot; therefore angels should exist too.

G.K. Chesterton wrote, "The human race, according to religion, fell once, and in falling gained the knowledge of good and of evil. Now we have fallen a second time, and only the knowledge of evil remains to us." It would be irresponsible to rely on one's sense of evil without enriching the much more important sense of good.

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Matt on 2013-06-26 at 17:28 said:

Jacob,

I think what Cologero is getting at with the idea of God not being a person is a fundamental distinction between the classical theist tradition – part of Tradition itself – and what is known as "theistic personalism" which is advocated by thinkers like William Lane Craig, Plantiga, and

Swinburne. Theistic personalism is also what most protestants believe and probably even what the average Catholic in the laity believes in – sadly.

The classical theist tradition affirms that while God is person-like, that does not mean God is tantamount to being a person jut like us, except with qualities to the maximal degree. Its the opposite with theistic personalists – when they say God is a person, they believe that God is a person just like us. It gets down to how they view the divine attributes. Classical theism views the divine attributes in an analogous way – there is something of the reality of God that is analogous to the will and intellect within us – whereas theistic personalists view God's attributes in a univocal way, so his personal attribute is just like our personhood, but to the maximal degree like all of His other attributes such as power (same as as ours but to the "max"), and goodnes (he is a moral agent that is maximally good instead of the Sovereign Good). The A-T philosopher Edward Feser, whom Cologero has mentioned a few times here, goes into detail about this fundamental difference and why theisitc personalism is so problematic. He makes the apt comparison of the theisitc personalists' god to how much of the historical greek religion viewed Zeus – just a being among a class of beings, though a very exceptional one (instead of the Being of beings, Being Itself). Feser also makes the similar comparison to Superman, which I think is also an appropriate one.

Jacob on 2013-06-26 at 19:38 said:

Ok, thanks Matt. That helps a lot. Also explains why the Kalam argument theistic philosophers use so often grew out of a discipline most Muslims scholars looked down upon.

Matt on 2013-06-26 at 19:59 said:

No problem Jacob.

How theistic personalists view God's attributes is the main reason why they don't accept divine simplicity, the convertibility of the transcendentals – the Oneness of God essentially. Since our attributes are metaphysically separate, and if God's attributes are just like ours, then God's attributes are therefore also metaphysically separate. They also think that God – classically/traditionally conceived – can not have accidental properties, but it doesn't seem like they've taken into consideration that God classically concieved can have what is called 'Cambridge properties".

This has a number of logical implications – most of which I don't think have been considered by theistic personalists – in relation to the fundamental tenets of Christianity (and probably Tradition as a whole). If God really is indeed composed of parts, then one can't really say God is infinite (The Infinite is a better term) since God would now have intrinsic boundaries. And, at least to me, I don't see how the fundamental Christian tenet of the Logos as the common principle that unities all is compatible with theistic personalism.

ii.ii Power as Causality

In his important work *The World as Power*, **John Woodroffe** lays out the philosophical principles of **Tantra**, while relating them to the Orthodox Hindu schools and even Western thought. Creation is the manifestation of Consciousness-Power and liberation is participation therein. In successive chapters, he describes Power as **Reality**, **Life**, **Mind**, **Matter**, **Causality**, **Continuity**, and **Consciousness**. Here we are interested in Causality , which is a special case of Continuity.

The first thing to take notice of is that, as **David Hume** so convincingly demonstrated, causality cannot be derived from purely empirical considerations. Thus the Enlightenment project of deriving all knowledge from observation of the physical world is impossible. Kant's odd solution was to situate causality in the mind, apart from the objects. Metaphysically, instead, we understand causality to be part of the cosmic order. Hence, we have in Causality an example of a real category, not derived by abstraction from empirical data.

The method of metaphysics is based on observation of states of consciousness. Unless certain states have been realized, its doctrines will appear opaque or speculative. Yet the refusal to make the efforts to achieve such states is as irrational as the bishop who refused to look through Galileo's telescope to observe the moons of Jupiter. Woodroffe's discussion of causality and continuity is too intricate for a single post, so we will have to be content to start with a few main points. Woodroffe summarizes the Vedantic position:

> Reality is Experience. Experience is a Universe. This Universe lives, moves and has its being in Consciousness or Cit. Cit therefore is Reality and the foundation of Reality. There is no inscrutable thing-in-itself beyond or behind Consciousness. Far from being unknowable, Reality is Cognition itself.

Hence, the cosmic order as the objective arrangements among things is

identical to the subjective representations of those arrangements. That is, Subject and Object are one; Knowing (cognition) and Being (reality) are identical. This is non-duality.

We begin by observing the causal relationship between things or events in consciousness, so we must accept the objective existence of causality. In our own volitional activity, we see directly the principle of causality; otherwise, we could not understand the motives for action. We observe the correspondence between the rational and practical activity of the self (knowledge and action).

Further, we can observe the sense of power within ourselves, that is, our power to effect change. So our understanding of causation is derived from our own conscious activity. This is still dualistic, since there is Mind (purusha) acting on Matter (prakriti). But Mind and Matter are not opposed, as they arise together in consciousness; rather, they form a scale. What is experienced, then, as matter is what is resistant to my Power, that is, a privation.

A deeper understanding is that the phenomenal universe is reducible to one Reality: the **Absolute** or **Brahman**. The world has no reality independent of Consciousness. This is not an abstraction of thought nor derived from experience. Woodroffe explains:

> We say that there is in fact only reality namely Consciousness, a position for which we may argue but which cannot be establilshed with certitude except by an actual or direct experience of unity. Those who seek to establish supersensible truths on any other ground must fail; just as those who argue against the validity of the individual's experience must fail.

We can summarize the understanding of causality from four perspectives:

1. In Material causation, the motion of one thing is communicated to another.

2. In Efficient causation, Consciousness is effective and the Psychophysical Principle operates on its own laws spontaneously.

3. In the Vedanta, the efficient and material causes are understood as aspects of one Reality.

4. From the absolute standpoint, there is no causation at all, since it transcends empirical reality.

Posted on 2011-04-20 by Cologero

* * *

`Izak on 2011-04-24 at 00:34 said:`

What do you recommend as being the best starting point with Woodroffe? Is The World as Power a good place to start? I am considering ordering The Serpent Power and Sakti & Sakta alongside some sort of scholarly glossary on Hindu terminology.

By the way, I like this website – I got the recommendation to visit here from the comment board at Taki's Magazine.

`Cologero on 2011-04-24 at 10:44 said:`

I would start with World as Power since it is more accessible to a Westerner without too much terminology; it exposes the metaphysical viewpoint of Tantra. In conjunction with Guenon's book on Hindu doctrine, it will provide a good foundation. Of course, Evola's Yoga of Power is a good synopsis; everything Evola knows about Tantra was taken from Woodroffe (at least the Hindu Tantras). Principles of Tantra is more systematic than the World as Power. Serpent Power assumes you are actively working with the Tantras with a qualified teacher.

11.12 Worlds Apart

> Opportunities for interpenetration have never been greater—and yet our minds are worlds apart.
>
> Owen Barfield

> It is a platitude to say that the men of our day no longer understand each other. This is nothing new since the Tower of Babel. But God had left a certain relation between men through the intelligence. Now it is this bridge which our day has just broken down. Men no longer understand each other: on the level of the peasant this is not evident; on the bourgeois level is an inconvenience, on the intellectual level it is tragic, because, for the intellectual there is no other genuine reason for living than that of communication, in order to understand the world. Today this communication has become practically impossible. In order to understand each other we need a minimum of ideas which are common and valid for everyone, of prejudices and values which are the same for all—and most often unconscious.
>
> Jacques Ellul, *The Presence of the Kingdom*

After thousands of years, millions of books, billions of words, trillions of thoughts, mankind is still no closer to a common understanding of reality. Along with Solovyov, we can trace this to mechanical thinking. Discourse used to be organic, it was verbal and participatory, it led to a change of being.

The written word was the beginning of the change, a change to mechanical thinking. As technics became the media of communications, discourse came under the domination of technicians. Since technics are mechanical, thinking came to be limited to the mechanical. Thought is rationalized, and anything that does not fit in, is discounted as mere feeling, subjective idea, superstition, or worse.

A similar situation arose in the religious sphere. True faith is organic, involving the whole being. More than mere belief, faith includes the will and feeling. But when the discourse on faith was taken over by the half-educated mechanical mind, it could only understand faith as belief. They then denied that the object of faith could not be comprehended or directly known. Thus, belief became institutionalized.

The rationalists and the fideists each claimed to be the arbiters of truth, and claimed sole competence to define the limits of knowledge. For two thousand years they have been battling each other in various ways, while true seekers of knowledge are marginalized and relegated to the fringe. The best they can hope for is to be left alone to pursue their studies.

Organic knowledge is possible only to the integral personality, that is, a person with the thinking, willing and feeling functions acting harmoniously, each with its place in knowledge. For each function there is a corresponding object and subject.

Function	Object	Subject
Willing	Goodness	Sprit
Thinking	Truth	Intellect
Feeling	Beauty	Soul

In organic thinking all the functions work together in knowing. The world is will and representation, and is felt as well as known. Mechanical thinking is limited to the intellect, and hence incapable of knowing the Good and the Beautiful, which it can only see as subjective and arbitrary.

Reference:

Lectures on Divine Humanity, by Vladimir Solovyov

Posted on 2010-04-12 by Cologero

11.13 The Degrees of Knowledge

Tradition teaches that there are three degrees of knowledge:

1. **Doxa** (opinion): our knowledge of the sensory or phenomenal world

Degree		Object	Form
Doxa	Opinion	Phenomena	Concept
Dianoia	Rational Knowledge	Thought	Idea
Episteme	Intuitive Knowledge	Noumena	Ideal

Table ii.1: Degrees of knowledge

2. **Dianoia** (rational knowledge): knowledge based on thinking and logical deductions

3. **Episteme** (intuition, gnosis, wisdom): direct knowledge of the essence of things

Gnosis remains largely ignored or misunderstood in our day. Voegelin, for example, designated Gnostics as those who believed in a received knowledge, that was really on the level of ideas, or dianoia. In popular parlance, intuition refers to an unexpected insight into the phenomenal world. However, in Tradition, gnosis is direct knowledge of the noumenal that is usually acquired through intense spiritual practices.

An example is the awareness and experience of oneself as a person, that is, as a center of consciousness and will. It sounds simple, but in actual practice there is much more to it. It takes efforts and exercises to become aware of one's real I[13] or true Will.

So much so, in fact, that the obvious is not noticed by those who claim to be the most intelligent and educated. For example, in an earlier post[14], we showed the example of someone who denies his will on the grounds that it defies the "laws of physics". I could point to other examples on the Internet of intelligent people who deny the validity of their

[13] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=57`

[14] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=210`

own consciousness and subjectivity, believing it to be no more than electrochemical processes in the brain. This puts dianoia as the highest form of knowledge.

It is episteme alone that provides certain and absolute knowledge. It intuits the ideal form, which is non-sensory and transcendent to the manifested world. At the level of dianoia, the ideal becomes idea, or the object of thought.

Thinking is limited to manipulation of ideas and can never reach certainty. The theories of science are always subject to future revision and deeper que stions have been debated ad infinitum, from the past and again into the future. Thinking is always about essences and can never penetrate the mystery of existence, the individual, the unique, the non-repeatable, the miraculous.

Doxa, or sensory awareness of the natural, or phenomenal, world is enthralled and deceived by the multiplicity of manifestations. Doxa recognizes concepts through a process of abstraction that extracts the common characteristics. Ideal, idea and concept correspond to the three degrees of knowledge.

Faith is related to gnosis. It does not refer to beliefs in sensory things or a body of ideas (the two lower levels of knowledge). True faith is belief in ideals, or noumenal reality. It involves the entire personality, especially the Will. Meditating on the truths of Faith can lead to authentic Gnosis.

Posted on 2010-04-25 by Cologero

* * *

`Comprehensor on 2010-04-26 at 09:12 said:`

While I reject the idea that free will defies the laws of physics, to be united with the divine is to surrender one's will to God in order that he may do God's Will. To put one's own will over and against God's would be a promethean rationalism. Thus to do one's "true will" would be to do God's Will.

Cologero on 2010-04-26 at 22:13 said:

"We are all attached to the throne of the Supreme Being by a supple chain that binds but does not enslave us. What is admirable in the universal order of things is the action of free beings under the divine hand. Freely enslaved, they function at once by will and by necessity; they really do as they wish, but without being able to upset the general plan".

˜ Joseph de Maistre, "Considerations on France"

So our will is either free (in union with the Supreme Being) or determined. Remove the religious language, and this is precisely what Evola claims.

Comprehensor on 2010-04-27 at 08:46 said:

What does Joseph de Maistre mean by "we are all... "?

Maistre seems to suggest not an either/or but an implication of both predermination and will. Actions of necessity do not override God's plan, for God is always superior to man, since God is all-knowing and everything is predetermined by him. However God allows man a bit of space to do as he will, to choose the light or the dark.

On the other hand as Guenon and Schuon have stated man is passive in the face of the Supreme Principle and he surrenders his own free will in order to become united with the divine. This is what I was getting at in my first comment.

11.14 Organic and Mechanical Thinking

Organic and mechanical thinking and their impact on Tradition in the West.

> To see a world in a grain of sand,
> And a heaven in a wild flower,
> Hold infinity in the palm of your hand,
> And eternity in an hour.
>
> William Blake

Intellectual Intuition In his *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, **Vladimir Solovyov** distinguishes between organic and mechanical thinking, the

former related to intellectual intuition and the latter to abstract reasoning. We will relate this to the understanding of caste and in a later post show how this relates to the Medieval project of implementing the trifunctional society.

Rational thought abstracts from the data of sense experience by a process of negation, that is, by excluding specific features of the object of experience. As such, therefore, these abstractions have no positive content and are mental constructs. That is why Kant was able to demonstrate that the process of pure reason can never lead to certain knowledge about the entities of sense experience.

Ideas, on the contrary, are not the results of abstraction, but are inherent to the entities themselves. This means they are neither rationalist abstractions nor sensuous realities, but have an independent reality. Consequently, only a special form of thought activity can know them; this is called intellectual intuition. Abstract thinking is an intermediate stage:

> it appears when the mind is strong enough to liberate itself from the exclusive domination of sense perception … but not yet capable of grasping an idea in the fullness and integrity of is actual objective being, of uniting with it inwardly and essentially

Solovyov points to artistic creation as the proof of such intuition, since it is neither the reproduction of sensual phenomena nor general concepts abstracted from that reality. Now Solovyov gets to the heart of the matter:

> The truly artistic form or type necessarily requires an inner union of perfect individuality with complete generality or universality. A union of this kind constitutes the essential feature or proper determination of an intellectually intuited idea.

We see this understanding clearly in the poetic mind, as Blake "sees" the universal in the particular. A similar process is at work in revelation,

which itself is often poetical. In revelation, the particular is simultaneously the universal. That is why it is expressed in terms of stories, legends, and myths. Neither the sensuous mind nor the rational mind can see anything beyond the particular events.

Organic Thinking Organic thinking is related to intellectual intuition. As such, it is a "developing" type of thinking, although we prefer to call it thinking in depth or three-dimensional thinking. In other words, it is not "developing" in the sense that it overturns earlier moments in thought, but rather that it understands ideas in more depth, it sees ever more interconnections of ideas. It is a free activity of mind, and cannot be determined nor "evolve" strictly as a function of time. Solovyov lists these characteristics:

- Considers an object in its all-sided wholeness and its inner bond with all other objects
- Deduces form within each concept all the others or develops a single concept not the fullness of the whole truth
- Perceives or grasps the integral idea of an object

Mechanical Thinking Mechanical thinking cannot penetrate into the essence of ideas, so it can only see them in relationship to each other. This type of thinking, therefore, is polemical; it needs to takes sides in a debate, to prefer one idea over another. In the fields of religion or metaphysics, this type of thinking cannot see beyond the dogmas that codify certain insights. It is characterized by:

- Takes concepts in their abstract separateness
- Considers objects under some particular, one-sided definition

- Contrasts them one with another in an external manner
- Breaks up or differentiates or analyzes immediate reality
- Cannot give it a new higher unity
- Unable to apprehend the inner truth or meaning (logos) of objects

Agents of Thought Solovyov makes it more interesting by identifying those groups with the various groups or castes. In particular, there are "those who know", the Brahmins or *oratores*, who engage in organic thinking. Solovyov writes:

> If this intuition is united with a clear consciousness and is accompanied by reflection, which gives logical definitions of the intuited truth, we have that speculative thinking that characterizes the philosophical art [i.e., metaphysical realization]

Interestingly, Solovyov relates organic thinking to the masses[15], those having a "body with a human consciousness". That is, their intellectual intuition is at best virtual, and is thus dependent on their spiritual leaders for its actualization. That relationship explains why the spiritual leaders are so concerned about the care of the poor, the widows, orphans, and so on. In Solovyov's words:

- If speculative thinking remains in its immediacy and does not clothe its concrete patterns in logical forms, it is the kind of living thought characteristic of people who have not emerged from the unreflective life in their common tribal or national unity
- Such thinking expresses what is called the folk spirit:

[15] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5227`

- Folk creation in art and religion
- Living development of language
- Myths superstitions, folk tales, songs, etc

So we see that the mass is focused on sensory and psychic imagery; the spiritual authority then gives them their universal significance.

Opposed to them are, as Solovyov writes:

> Between these two groups are the majority of co-called educated or enlightened people: detached from the worldview of the people, but have not attained an integral philosophical consciousness. These so-called enlightened people are limited to the abstract mechanical thinking that breaks up or differentiates or analyzes immediate reality (and this constitutes the significance and merit of such thinking), but they are not in a position to give it a new, higher unity and union; that is its limitation.
>
> Certainly, it is possible (and in reality, it often happens) that persons of this group, guided in practical life by the ideas of other people's organic thinking in the form of religious beliefs, take the standpoint of the abstract and mechanical intellect in their own theoretical activity.

Tensions As long as the masses and the educated people (e.g., the administrators and producers) acknowledge their limitations and follow the spiritual authorities, things function in a Traditional manner. However, there are some inner tensions that threaten this harmony and concord. If the masses reject the authority, there is revolution, and they revert back to their natural materialism and atheism.

For the others, there is obviously a dualism and contradiction in their worldview. Their own thinking is mechanical, which is absolutely necessary and appropriate in their activities in administration and production. This contradiction can only be resolved in an external manner through

submission to the deeper understanding of the spiritual authority. In particular, in the history of the West, Christianity was understood in three different ways: organic, mechanical, and superstitious. As the authority of the spiritual leaders was challenged at different points, these disparate viewpoints eventually unraveled in the process of the degeneration of castes, as we have frequently written about.

Posted on 2012-11-29 by Cologero

* * *

Avery on 2012-11-29 at 09:54 said:

Aren't Guenon and Evola essentially Platonian, that is, they see objects as attempts to achieve forms that are essentially separate, and discover their meanings in their separateness? And Evola sees the mechanical/artificial as rising above formless, animal nature. Solovyov's philosophy sounds more like Buddhism to me.

Cologero on 2012-11-29 at 13:17 said:

Granted, Avery, I've pulled ideas out of their original context, so there is a strong possibility of misunderstanding. Again, specificity is the key to a discussion. Which statements sound "Buddhist" to you? Where do Guenon and Evola assert what you say about objects (in their own words).

Avery on 2012-11-30 at 11:48 said:

Guenon considers Platonic ideals and Aristotelian forms to be "'archetypes' or the essential principles of things" (Reign of Quantity), and comparable to the qualitative Pythagorean numbers. This seems to demonstrate a commitment to separate principles which manifest as different objects.

Evola similarly writes, "An equality may exist on the plane of a mere social aggregate or of a primordial, almost animal-like promiscuity; moreover, it may be recognized wherever we consider not the individual but the overall dimension; not the person but the species; not the 'form' but 'matter' (in the Aristotelian sense of these two terms) … The will to equality is one and the same with the will to what is formless." (Men Among the Ruins) He argues extensively that an organic State with a unity of purpose will reject an imposed uniformity; that is, objects necessarily have separate forms, even though the ultimate purpose of these forms may be unitary.

I would interpret "Consider[ing] an object in its all-sided wholeness and its inner bond with all other objects", on the other hand, to be the teaching that form is essentially borderless and

that heterogeneity is an illusion. Most of the rest of this summary of Solovyov does not seem so conflicting, though. I will retract my comment about what is "mechanical"; I forgot that in Evola, "organic" is not synonymous with "natural".

Alexander on 2012-11-30 at 20:10 said:

"Consider[ing] an object in its all-sided wholeness and it's inner bond with all other objects" The archetypes pertain to the level of formless manifestation while principal unity is found beyond all manifestation.

Avery M on 2012-11-30 at 23:18 said:

This seems to me to be the confusion that arises when language is insufficiently precise. In Guenon, "all things are linked together by rigorous correspondences". Male corresponds to female, for instance. But male is not equivalent to female, which is the vibe I get from calling a correspondence a "bond" and contrasting it with "separateness".

To elaborate on my reference of Buddhism, the Heart Sutra's teaching of dependent arising and "emptiness" can easily be misinterpreted to say that all things are homogenous, or that all things are equally valued, that is to say, valueless. Before we consider higher unity we must acknowledge separateness and difference in lower manifestation.

11.15 Participation in the World Process

In *Saving the Appearances*, **Owen Barfield** demonstrates how the world is represented in consciousness and, moreover, how those representations alter over time. If the collective consciousness of the first men can be described as an innocence — which was destroyed through our dualist thinking — then the ultimate goal is to achieve a second innocence, or what Paul Ricoeur called a second naïveté. Barfield uses the terms "original participation" and "final participation". Mircea, calling it "archaic consciousness", describes it this way:

> In *imitating* the exemplary acts of a god or of a mythical hero, or simply by recounting their adventures, the man of an archaic society detaches himself from profane time and magically re-enters the Great Time, the sacred time.

Myths, Dreams and Mysteries

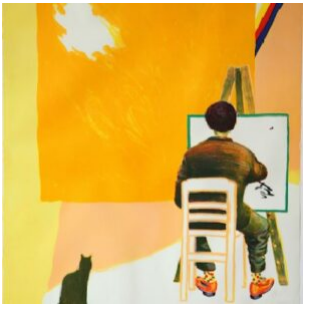
Of course, the modern man, unable to take such myths at face value, does so in a different manor from the primitive man. **Paul Ricoeur** calls this re-enactment the second naïveté. In any case, knowledge of sensory space-time events can never be more than a matter of opinion (*doxa*). Hence, sacred time refers to events in consciousness. **Hans Leisegang** makes this clear:

> Every myth expresses, in a form narrated for a particular case, an eternal idea, which will be intuitively recognised by him who re-experiences the content of the myth.
>
> *Die Gnosis*

Valentin Tomberg in *Meditations on the Tarot* points out the relationship between myths and archetypes:

> myths reveal the archetypes which manifest themselves endlessly in history and in each individual biography — they are mythological symbols pertaining to the domain of time.

The Starting Point Barfield, too, wants to breathe life into those ancient myths, which have mostly become "dead letters" or mere verbal formulations to consent to. Barfield starts by calling attention to two misconceptions about our consciousness of the world: First an omission and then an assumption.



- **Omission**. The omission is neglecting to take account of the role of human consciousness in our experience of the phenomena of the world. If the physical world has no colour, smell,

sound, or taste — and no physicist today would deny it — then those qualities need to come from somewhere. That is the participation of man's own mind in the creation, or evocation, of these phenomena.

- **Assumption**. The unexamined assumption is that human consciousness has remained unchanged throughout human history.

Barfield is not interested in providing any metaphysic justification for these points, since his purpose is simply to describe what is. Nevertheless, a good metaphysic can provide the justification to make these views plausible.

First of all, Barfield notes that our experiences, *ceteris paribus*, are essentially identical. This he calls the "collective consciousness". Yet there is a sound explanation for that, otherwise we would be entrapped in incommunicable subjectivity. The explanation is that we all share in the World Soul, or Manas, which guarantees the identity of our sense experiences.

Then, we need to take into account that there is a larger cosmic process that organizes and unites different epochs in world history. Just as there are longer cycles, there are shorter cycles within the longer cycle. Hence, in line with Traditional cosmology, we would expect changes in the general consciousness during these cycles.

Four Stages Barfield then describes the changes in the manner of thinking over time. He begins with the "representation" and shows how thinking changes. It is not thinking per se that changes, but rather the object of thinking. In contemporary philosophical language, Barfield is describing **intentionality.**

1. **Representation**: This is our sensory experience of the world. The

representation IS the world; this does not mean that the world is subjective and arbitrary.

2. **Figuration**: this is the process of converting the sensations of the world into things.

3. **Alpha thinking**: this is the act of thinking about the things of figuration. This culminates in science which thinks about the world and organizes the things in it.

4. **Beta thinking**: this is thinking about the previous processes and trying to understand them. This is the task typically of philosophy and metaphysics

Once again, there are metaphysical explanations. In order to overcome Cartesian dualism, the act of representation cannot be understood as an "I" observing a "world out there, right now". Rather, the representation is precisely that world; that is nondual awareness. The corollary is that there is no world unless there is someone conscious of it.

This may give you pause, but it is necessary to understand it. The famous example is: "Does the falling tree make a sound when there is no one there to hear it?" The answer is clearly "no". You can continue: "Does the tree make a sight is there is no one there to hear it?" and even: "Does the tree feel like anything if there is no one there to touch it." So whatever may be "there", it is part of the unconscious and thus nothing like the familiar world of our senses.

Figuration basically arises from hylomorphism. Figuration answers the question: "What is the thing that I am experiencing in my senses?" The Traditional answer is that it is the thing's essence or "idea" in the Divine Intellect.

Alpha thinking, then, is simply the study of the things in the world, and beta thinking is the study of one's own consciousness.

The Recovery of Innocence At the figuration stage, there is a direct experience of the world, in which the person feels embedded and part of. Thought creates separation and a false "ego" that feels separate from the world. Barfield's task, therefore, is to recapture the sense of figuration, all the while aware of how consciousness is operating.

These are from the notes of our Summer Reading Program.

Posted on 2021-07-06 by Cologero

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Max Leyf on 2021-07-07 at 14:18 said:

Thank you Cologero for the summary of Barfield's work. Some of your readers may be interested in a more extended treatment of Barfield's vision and its significance that I wrote as a part of my dissertation. The article should be accessible here:

https://www.cosmosandhistory.org/index.php/journal/issue/view/39

The entire dissertation, which integrates Barfield's thought with the theory and method of knowledge developed by Goethe and Rudolf Steiner, is also available:

https://theoriapress.wordpress.com/2020/12/02/new-publication-the-redemption-of-thinking/

Anyone with special interest in this subject is welcome to contact me.

My thanks again to you for all of your offerings.

Max Leyf

11.16 Knowledge of the Future

In the last book of his *Consolations of Philosophy*, **Boethius** discusses how God can know the future if man is free. Recall how he explained the four levels of knowledge[16]: sense impressions, imagination, rational knowledge, and intuition. It is worth the effort to understand his explanation

[16] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5098

if for no other reason that intuition is critical for the man of Tradition. It cannot be learned from reading about it, but each man must develop it himself. The seeming contradiction involved in the dilemma can be treated as a type of koan that needs to be meditated on, while being elusive to rational thought. Curious readers may notice that this question arose again a millennium later in the dispute about Molinism[17]. That dispute took the form of rational knowledge which Boethius firmly rejects as an adequate explanation. This demonstrates how metaphysical understanding gradually eroded over those 1000 years.



This knowledge of the future baffles the rational mind, since it claims that the future can be known only if it be predetermined. However, this is a misunderstanding of what it means "to know", since it places knowability in the object of knowledge rather than in the knower himself. Hence we are compelled to not consider the thing known, but rather we need to grasp how the knower knows. Following Augustine and the Neo-Platonists (and anticipating Rene Guenon, to be sure), Boethius first distinguishes between eternity and everlastingness. The latter is perpetual existence in time, whereas the former is outside time altogether. Boethius explains:

> The world is still not such that it may properly be considered eternal … Its life may be infinitely long, but it does not embrace and comprehend its whole extent simultaneously. It still lacks the future, while already having lost the past. So that that which embraces and possesses simultaneously the whole fullness of everlasting life, which lacks nothing of the future and has lost nothing of the past, that is what my properly be said to be eternal. … It is one thing to progress through everlasting life, and another thing to

[17] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Molinism`

> have embraced the whole of everlasting life in one simultaneous present. This is clearly a property of the mind of God.

Boethius follows Plato's claim that "God is eternal, the world perpetual." For the world, the past is always receding ("lost") while the future is not yet ("lacking"). Thus God cannot be considered as existing "before" the world. Hence, it is not really a question of foreknowledge of the future, but instead the "knowledge of a never ending presence." This is the literal meaning of Providence, "looking forth", which he contrasts to prevision or "seeing ahead".

Next, Boethius addresses the counterargument that to know future events implies that the future is determined and free will is not possible. Obviously, this is mechanical thinking arising from the rational mind as opposed to the organic thinking that sees time as a whole. If I watch you walking down the street, then I know it through sense perception; nevertheless, this type of knowing, which is also a form of direct intuition, does not make your perambulation unfree or necessary.

By analogy, and that is all we may have for now, the same can be said about God's seeing through intellectual intuition. Boethius writes:

> Divine foreknowledge does not change the nature and property of things; it simply sees things present to it exactly as they will happen at some time as future events. … the divine gaze looks down on all things without disturbing their nature; to Him, they are present things, but under the conditions of time they are future things. And so when God knows that something is going to occur and knows that no necessity to be is imposed on it, it is not opinion, but rather knowledge founded upon truth.

In the example of watching someone walk on the street, we were clearly appealing to spatial perception rather than temporal. It is easy to grasp that our experience of objects in space is grasping the whole, as something all-at-once, at least within the limits of our horizon. But events in time

don't typically have that same effect, as events come at us sequentially, not all at once. Each moment in time seems independent of what follows; this is what perplexed Hume so that he could not understand the nature of causality. Yet as we recently pointed out[18], artistic inspiration often takes this form. This is why Solovyov used artistic experience as the model for the type of intuition being described. In particular music and poetry lend themselves to this, this they unfold in time while being grasped as a whole. Hence, we can grasp a symphony as a whole even though our experience is one note after another. Yet, the musicians play the instruments by their own free will.

It may be helpful to draw on what **Rene Guenon** writes about time in The Reign of Quantity. He points out that time is more subtle than space, and that accounts for its elusiveness. It can only be measured by spatial criteria and the most intimate part of us — our mental life — develops in time yet has no spatial character. This means that time is even more qualitative than space and our tendency to experience time just in its quantitative aspect can only result in misunderstanding. Guenon uses the example of the four seasons, the temporal equivalent of the four spatial directions. Once we see things in terms of cycles — organically — we can "predict" the future. Of course, the world unfolds in cycles within cycles, etc.

Next, we can point out the nature of manifestation. Recall that a fundamental principle is the identity of knowing and being. We know that there are possibilities of manifestation. When God knows a possibility of manifestation, as he must since it is an idea in His own mind, then it necessarily manifests—essence and existence are one. And this is so, even if from the perspective of time, it is the result of free acts.

Finally, how can man experience things *sub specie aeternitatis*? Obviously, not man qua man, but only from states that are higher than the human state. To reach that highest state is what Guenon calls deliverance

[18] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=5381`

as opposed to salvation. Readers who continue to do their exercises and meditations may find that they can reach a state of detachment in which consciousness is observing the actions of the body. Within the incessant states of conscious activity, that is, the everlasting or perpetual, what is the one constant? That is the eternal.

Posted on 2012-12-10 by Cologero

* * *

Saladin on 2013-10-18 at 13:25 said:
Very interesting! I have just discovered The Consolation of Philosophy, and it is a real gem!

11.17 Creativity, Nonduality, Inspiration

> The Genius is a man who discovers many others in himself. He is a man with many men in his personality. But then the genius can understand other men better than they can understand themselves, because within himself he has not only the character he is grasping, but also its opposite. Duality is necessary for observation and comprehension … in short, to understand man means to have equal parts of himself and his opposite in one.
>
> Otto Weininger

Recently, we turned to **Boethius**[19] for an explanation of the types of knowledge: sensory and psychic impressions, rational thought, and intellectual intuition. Since intuition is what separates Tradition from philosophical or scientific systems, it is well worth the trouble to go over it again. A woman once told me that she has "hunches" which she took to mean gnosis; of course, what we mean has nothing to do with so-called

[19] See Section 12.8 in this book.

"woman's intuition", but with a direct knowledge that brings absolute certainty.

Vladimir Solovyov relates intuition[20] to "an inner union of perfect individuality with complete generality or universality", and he points to the artist as the proof of intuition. That is because the artistic inspiration unites the concrete individual with its wholeness in the formless realm. This non-dual intuition differs from rational thinking which involves a subject and an object. **David Loy**, in his study of various teachings on Nonduality, refers to the personal experiences of several artists to demonstrate nondual thinking. However, artistic intuition is still not metaphysical realization or mystical intuition, since, as the examples will show, the artist is passive in relation to it and experiences it as an external force. Nevertheless, the examples are instructive and will help the reader become aware of his own everyday nondual experiences; for example, there may be that "aha" moment of "getting it" when the flow of the rational mind is temporarily halted.



Figure 11.2: Leanan Sídhe

We have so many thoughts in a day that we usually take them for granted. We claim they are "our" thoughts, or "our" ideas. A little reflection will show that cannot be true. We don't know what we will think about one minute from now, as thoughts come from a source of their own against our will. Usually we become "lost in thought", as thoughts link themselves together in an intricate story and take over our conscious mind and even feelings. Obviously, this inhibits metaphysical realization since the proper order of things is for the "I" to dominate the other parts of conscious activity including the thought process. It is a good practice to sit quietly while trying to maintain a conscious detachment over the automatic processes

[20] See Section 12.14 in this book.

of the mind. Then it will be possible to observe thoughts in their incipient stage. By maintaining conscious detachment, these thoughts will not be able to link and they will dissipate like wispy clouds in the wind. Otherwise, they will agglutinate into complex formations, and we will fantasize faces, things, and events as we usually do when staring at cloud formations in the sky.

Musical composition provides the easiest examples of artistic inspiration since it is the most abstract of the arts. The common experience is that the composition is grasped as a whole first, and only afterwards are the individual notes written down. This all-at-once feeling is what defines inspiration. In our spatial awareness, we are accustomed to grasping our field of sensory experience as a whole; however, it is more difficult to experience time that way. That is, how can the sequential elements of a temporal sequence be understood as a single whole? Yet, we do that all the time when we hear a symphony; although we experience each note and each instrument in time, we still grasp the symphony as a whole. We will have more to say about this when discussing how God can know the future.

I will let the artists speak for themselves. First we have **Mozart**:

> All this fires my soul and, provided I am not disturbed, my subject enlarges itself, becomes methodized and defined, and the whole, though it be long, stands almost complete and finished in my mind, so that I can survey it, like a fine picture or a beautiful statue, at a glance … All this inventing, this producing, takes place in a pleasing, lively dream.

Loy points out that the subject enlarges or creates itself and it is dreamlike because there is no "thinker" or directing ego. **Tchaikovsky**'s experience is similar:

> Generally speaking, the germ of a future composition comes suddenly and unexpectedly … It takes root with extraordinary force

> and rapidity, shoots up through the earth, puts forth branches and leaves, and finally blossoms.

Some composers relate this to a religious experience. **Puccini** says:

> The music of this opera [Madam Butterfly] was dictated to me by God; I was merely instrumental in putting it on paper and communicating it to the public.

Wagner's experience is that:

> There are universal currents of Divine Thought vibrating the ether everywhere … I feel that I am one with this vibrating force.

Finally, we need to hear what **Nietzsche** had to say:

> Has anyone at the end of the nineteenth century any distinct notion of what poets of a stronger age understood by the word inspiration? If not, I will describe it. If you had the slightest residue of superstition left in you, it would hardly be possible to completely disregard the idea that one is the mere incarnation, a mouthpiece or a medium of an almighty power. The idea of revelation in the sense of something which profoundly moves and provokes, becoming suddenly visible and audible with indescribable certainty and accuracy—is a simple description. You hear — you do not seek; you take — and do not ask who gives: a thought suddenly flashes up like lightning, it comes as a necessity, without hesitation — I have never had any choice in the matter. There is an ecstasy so great that the immense strain of it is sometimes relaxed by a flood of tears during which one does not know whether one is coming or going. There is the feeling of completely being outside of oneself, with the very distinct consciousness of endless delicate shivers right down to one's toes; — there is a depth of happiness in which the most painful and gloomy parts do not detract from

> the whole but are produced and required as necessary shades of colour amidst such an overflow of light. There is an instinct for rhythmical relationships which embrace a whole world of forms: length, the need of an all-embracing rhythm, is almost the measure of the force of inspiration, a kind of compensation for its pressure and tension.
>
> Everything happens quite involuntarily as if in a tempestuous outburst of freedom of absolute power and divinity. The involuntary nature of the images and similes is the most remarkable thing; one loses all perception of what is imagery and metaphor; everything seems to present itself in the readiest, the truest and simplest means of expression. It actually seems, to use one of Zarathustra's own phrases, as if all things came together and offered themselves as images

Loy mentions several other poets, writers, and even mathematicians who have had similar experiences. Although Loy's primary focus is on nonduality as understood in Taoism, the Vedanta, and Buddhism, he does show how this is the same as intellectual intuition as understood by **Plotinus**, **Meister Eckhart**, **Nicolas of Cusa**, and **Boehme**.

Update 25 Feb 2021 I spent 10 minutes searching for creativity. There are articles about how the neurons of creative people are different from the uncreative. As if neurons can create novelty out of nothing. The other modern view, completely opposed to the first, is that creativity can be taught to anyone at random.

If you think you are creative, do you understand any of quotes above? Creativity is dangerous: it is not a medical condition nor can you learn it at a weekend seminar. You need to surrender your imagination to forces whose source you neither know nor understand.

Posted on 2012-12-04 by Cologero

* * *

Mihai on 2012-12-05 at 04:47 said:

When I read words such as these from Nietzsche, I cannot help but wonder how he could be so unlike and above the mediocrity, bourgeois pettiness and socialist stupidity of his time, and yet be so completely immersed in the same roots from which the above mentioned sprung forth.

When reading Nietzsche one gets this impression of a superior way of life, an iron discipline and a shinning intellect with outstanding intuitions (such as those quoted here). But then I can only wonder: what for ? All these great potential subjected to a complete dead end. Nietzsche's "superman" is only a phantasm, an utopia in the same category with Marx's "end of history". He had some pearls, but he couldn't find anything better to do with them but use them as food for swine.

Sorry for my wandering off the topic.

As for the mind, I have to say that trying to focus it is the same as trying to stabilize a ball on the peak of a cone. It stays there for a moment, but then immediately starts to fall towards the base. Even trying to be a silent witness to this process is difficult, as the "I" is immediately attracted to identify with the flow of thought. But, then again, even the fact that one realizes all these facts proves that one, in a way, sees oneself as above and transcendes this very flow. It's a start.

Cologero on 2012-12-05 at 08:20 said:

Yes, Mihai, since the conscious guard is let down in these stories of inspiration, then all sorts of spirits can be allowed in. We could just as easily post similar quotes from murderers and false prophets. The spirits must be tested.

Avery Morrow on 2012-12-05 at 08:58 said:

To expand on that: when you admit the existence of good, you also admit the existence of evil. The whole point is that evil doesn't stand up with a big Nazi flag saying "look how evil I am"; it uses the same techniques as good, and perverts them. Now, obviously, Nietzsche claimed to be above good and evil, but his own life is a kind of parable there… I'm going to quote from a memorable movie review I saw recently:

"He tried to fashion himself … above morality, above guilt, above society, immune to Christian charity, who could exercise his naked will to power, superior to all men who were constrained by mere values and compassion for their fellow man. So it is sadly and very fittingly ironic that Nietzsche, by expressing compassion for an abused horse, in the end himself broke down and gave into Christian pity, when all his life he claimed to be above and did all he could to negate such 'weakness.'"

Cassiodorus on 2012-12-05 at 11:03 said:
I'm not sure, but Nietzsche always struck me as a "bizarro" Nagarjuna.

Mihai on 2012-12-06 at 03:29 said:
Yes, no doubt.
CS Lewis put it very neatly when he said that "the greatest sinners are made from the same fabric as the greatest saints"- understood in potential.

Senko on 2012-12-08 at 22:41 said:
It also strikes me that quote from Nietzche, also strikes me the fact that it is usually quoted here. How can a man who got so many wonderful insights be so stranded as a whole / in the end? It's kind of Zygmunt Bauman, his analysis of modernity is perfect, his choice of countering it with Marxism is plain stupid, specially since his family had to fled the USSR. Returning to the topic at hand, those "Aha!" moments are sweet, they are as the wind, they come and go as they please, but they better catch you working or praying!

11.18 Facts and Existence

> Existence as reality is not something static; it perpetually involves itself in a dynamic movement of ontological self-expression, articulating its infinite inner possibilities in gradations from the less determinate to the more determinate until it appears at the level of concrete forms, such that the particular existences which we regard as multiple and diverse 'things' having separate individual 'essences' are nothing but the modes and aspects of the reality of existence.
>
> Syed Muhammead Naquib al-Attas, *Prolegomena to the Metaphysics of Islam*

Readers should meditate on the beauty of the above passage before continuing. Existence as reality is distinguished from existence as concept.

Existence is not static; it is always in the process of the self-expression of its possibilities of manifestation. Existence descends from its essential form through the degrees of existence into more concreate forms.

Truth is the conformity to reality; the former is the logical aspect and the latter, the ontological aspect. Reality is always in process, so that

> the realities comprising the external world are not immediately or directly given in consciousness, but are abstractions of them in varying degrees performed by the external and internal senses, and transformed into knowledge of the external world by means of intellectual construction.

The corollary is that facts by themselves are insufficient for true knowledge. Facts presume that reality is static and that "facts speak for themselves", ignoring the larger picture. **Alan Watts** gives the following example in *The Book on The Taboo Against Knowing Who You Are*:

> Here is someone who has never seen a cat. He is looking through a narrow slit in a fence, and, on the other side, a cat walks by. He sees first the head, then the less distinctly shaped furry trunk, and then the tail. Extraordinary! The cat turns round and walks back, and again he sees the head, and a little later the tail. This sequence begins to look like something regular and reliable. Yet again, the cat turns round, and he witnesses the same regular sequence: first the head, and later the tail. Thereupon he reasons that the event head is the invariable and necessary cause of the event tail, which is the head's effect. This absurd and confusing gobbledygook comes from his failure to see that head and tail go together: they are all one cat.
>
> The cat wasn't born as a head which, sometime later, caused a tail; it was born all of a piece, a head-tailed cat. Our observer's trouble was that he was watching it through a narrow slit, and couldn't see the whole cat at once.

Beware of fact checkers with single vision.

Postscript Lest you assume that I am relying on unreliable sources, you need to consider the whole reality, not just the fact. The brother of a friend used to hand out copies of Watts' book to whoever would take it. I was befuddled, never having read anything like that before. I went on to devour his books, especially the theological books written prior to his hippie days in Sausalito. That was my introduction to metaphysics and symbolism. Moreover, he introduced me to Rene Guenon, whose books I then sought out. Unlike today, they were hard to come by. Effort makes you value something more highly, whereas today Guenon is often a mere commodity, just another piece in the perennialist puzzle.

When you feel the breath of an angel on the back of your neck, seize the opportunity.

Posted on 2021-09-22 by Cologero

11.19 The Intellect and the Mirror

> The Sage sees things very differently from the average man; neither ordinary experiences nor pains and sorrows, whether touching himself or others, pierce to the inner hold. To allow them any such passage would be a weakness in our soul.
>
> Plotinus, *Enneads*

In the Letter on the High Priestess, Valentin Tomberg recommends the study of Platonism as a preparation for understanding the encounter of Jesus with Nicodemus. He wrote:



> This is the Platonic conception of consciousness, the thorough study of which can serve by way of introduction

> to the nocturnal conversation of the Master with Nicodemus on the reintegration of consciousness or the aim of Christian yoga.

He points to a specific passage from **Plotinus** in the *Enneads* to illustrate his point:

> This is what Plotinus says concerning the duality underlying all forms and every level of consciousness, namely the active principle and its mirror.

The reference is to Plotinus, *Ennead* I, Tractate IV, Section 10. To aid in understanding, I include two versions, slightly different from the A H Armstrong translation. The first is translated directly from the French text. This is the part that Tomberg wants to emphasize.

The second is from the **Stephen Mackenna** translation; this includes the surrounding text to put it in context.

Tomberg's Version

> But if the mirror is absent or is not as it needs to be, the image is not produced although the action exists: Thus when the soul is in a state of calm, it reflects the images of the thought and intellect; but when it is disturbed by the disorder produced in the harmony of the body, the thought and the intellect think without the image, and the act of intelligence takes place without being reflected.

Mackenna's Translation

> Perhaps the reason this continuous activity i.e., the activity of the Intellectual-Principle remains unperceived is that it has no touch whatever with things of sense. No doubt action upon material things, or action dictated by them, must proceed through

the sensitive faculty which exists for that use: but why should there not be an immediate activity of the Intellectual-Principle and of the soul that attends it, the soul that antedates sensation or any perception? For, if Intellection and Authentic-Existence are identical, this "Earlier-than-perception" must be a thing having Act.

Let us explain the conditions under which we become conscious of this Intellective-Act.

When the Intellect is in upward orientation that lower part of it which contains or, corresponds to the life of the Soul, is, so to speak, flung down again and becomes like the reflection resting on the smooth and shining surface of a mirror; in this illustration, when the mirror is in place the image appears but, if the mirror is absent or out of gear, all that which would have acted and produced an image still exists; so in the case of the Soul; when there is peace in that within us which is capable of reflecting the images of the Rational and Intellectual-Principles these images appear. Then, side by side with the primal knowledge of the activity of the Rational and the Intellectual-Principles, we have also as it were a sense-perception of their operation.

When, on the contrary, the mirror within is shattered through some disturbance of the harmony of the body, Reason and the Intellectual-Principle act unpictured: Intellection is unattended by imagination.

In sum we may safely gather that while the Intellective-Act may be attended by the Imaging Principle, it is not to be confounded with it.

Commentary Although there is a duality, they are intimately related: the undisturbed mirror reflects the Intellect, although they are not the same. That is because the Intellect is active, even when the mirror does

not reflect it exactly. Although the Intellect is the source of Wisdom, it is not necessary to be conscious of its activity. Plotinus explains:

> A man unconscious of his health may be, none the less, healthy: a man may not be aware of his personal attraction, but he remains handsome none the less: if he has no sense of his wisdom, shall he be any the less wise?
>
> *Section 9*

In an analogous way to sense impressions which produce an image in the mind, the Intellect also produces an image. We can say, also, that the Intellect is the "Superconscious" because it is unconscious without the mirror. Moreover, it is the Self, since our physical life is not the source of the Self.

> We have here a parallel to what happens in the activity of the physical or vegetative life in us which is not made known by the sensitive faculty to the rest of the man: if our physical life really constituted the "I", its Act would be my Act: but, in the fact, this physical life is not the "I"; the "I" is the activity of the Intellectual-Principle so that when the Intellective is in Act, the "I" is in Act.
>
> *Posted on 2022-04-07 by Cologero*

* * *

Mark on 2022-04-08 at 01:30 said:
Is this physical not being the source of the self somehow related to "the stones cry out"?

Tannheuser on 2022-04-10 at 03:08 said:
Thanks for this – I have been pondering the intellect/mirror relationship recently also.
Tomberg writes about concentration without effort and the gnostic sense as though they are two stages that come one after another, but they seem dependent on one another. He writes,

for instance, that "it is the state of concentration without effort (taught by the first Arcanum), followed by a vigilant inner silence (taught by the second Arcanum), ". Isn't inner silence the prerequisite for the concentration also, as he writes in Letter I? Tomberg moreover writes that concentration/Intuition requires the stilling of the waters of thought and imagination, which is the same what he describes for gnosis in Letter II. It seems like a bit of a chicken and egg dilemma.

Approaching it with personal experience, I often have frequent awareness of the real "I" and even a certain degree of persistent inner silence during my activity in the world, such that I am able to perform many actions without "effort", and also maintain a degree of impassivity toward negative emotions like anger, lust, etc. Sometimes this state is all I can achieve during meditation also, but there is another deeper state which I have experienced (rarely) in meditation which is a much more real silencing of thought and imagination. Returning from that state afterwards to the normal state of consciousness feels like the process of falling asleep, as my consciousness submerges back into a stream of arbitrary thoughts and imaginations.

Although as I mentioned above, it's hard for me to work out the difference logically, from the above experience it appears to me that it is indeed possible to have intuition, to be able to concentrate without effort, and to "suppress mental oscillations", without having that more profound silence of the "waters" that produces the "reflection" needed for gnosis and that more elevated state of consciousness.

Balder on 2022-04-10 at 17:03 said:

Paul said: Now we see as if through a class, darkly. Our senses are as if made up to cloud the clear perception of things. When we ascend into the celestial world, into the world of ideas, our senses must be in balance. if there is un-harmony in the balance of the scale, our perception will be become clouded. The Intellect is made up of pure shining light, and if there is a shadow clouding it, which is our own darkness, and we cannot see the s´Sun in its wholeness; this is what makes our shadow both spiritually and psychologically. It is by way of enhancing the light qualities in our life that we become connected with the spiritual and material source of life and creation.

Balder on 2022-04-10 at 17:21 said:

It would be a quite revelation to the wretched mankind to realize there is no moral imperative in the practice of asceticism, for the whole practical idea is to become free of the dis-information and illusion provided to us by "the world". For as much as we are free of the world inside and out of us, we are open to another world: the Kingdom which is ever-present and cannot be erased. This is what the late children of Tradition are mant to bring into the world. "The origin of my Kingdom is not of this world."

12

Perspectives on Tradition

12.1 The Appeal of Tradition

The appeal of Julius Evola to a segment of disaffected youth is undeniable. Disgusted with the superficial, egalitarian, and epicene culture of the West, and unable to find a suitable home in the existent spiritual organisations, Evola provides an alternative that is absolutely unique.

Once the miasma hovering over Western society is blown away and there is an opening through which one can see a little more clearly, the emotional attachment to the shallow type of person so admired today — politicians, movie and rock stars, professional athletes, emaciated models, industrial magnates, self-help gurus, and all the so-called experts — suddenly loses all its lustre and appeal.

Evola, too, despises this world and offers quite an alternative — the world of Tradition. This world is populated with kings, heroes, warriors, knights of chivalry, sages and wise men, magicians, alchemists, yogis, tantrists, clairvoyants, mystics with occult powers.

He tours the mythology of Traditional societies: from Samurais in

Japan, to Vedic India, Mithraism of Iran, the gods and goddesses of pagan Greece and Rome, to the Valhalla of the Germanic and Norse tribes, even to the Aztecs of Mexico. From the commonalties, he reconstructs Traditional societies as they must have existed in prehistory: their hierarchical and caste-based social structures, their admiration for and cultivation of the "higher" type of man.

For Evola, the Traditional world ended with the waning of the Catholic middle ages. Successive waves of revolution — the Renaissance, the Reformation, the Enlightenment, industrialism, democracy, socialism, feminism — in short, all the movements of thought that we today praise as the highest accomplishments of the West — represent, for him, mere decay and decadence.

He rejects science as providing only contingent truths and suitable only for the mass man of our time. He opposes it with Wisdom resulting from the attainment of higher consciousness, which represents an achievement of the individual.

Instead of constant class warfare, Evola envisions a stable hierarchy in which each man freely and willingly takes his place.

Evola is the rare type of man who follows his line of thought intransigently all the way through, wherever it leads him. He shows us the aetiology and symptoms of the spiritual malaise of the West. The cure he proposes is a different story and is essentially left unfinished. He calls for a new counter-Reformation that will go back through the Middle Ages to recover once again the values of Tradition. The man to do that is yet to appear.

Posted on 2007-11-27 by Cologero

12.2 Restatement of Purpose

To whom it may concern.

Someone suggested there needs to be some "dialog", presumably between Gornahoor and some unidentified dialogist. That presumes there is something to discuss, necessitating some common ground, and resulting in a common goal. The ground is Tradition. The goal is the recovery of Tradition in the West. We have not deviated from that in over five years.

In January, 2008, we set the stage in one of the first posts here on the Prophecies of **Rene Guenon**, Part 1[1] and Part 2[2]. Some commenters seem to believe we are trying to be persuasive although we have been clear that we are only interested in facts, their consequences, and the various possibilities in give situation. These are the two relevant facts.

- The West had a valid Tradition up until the Medieval Era
- The Tradition was eventually lost, after the destruction of the Templars according to Guenon, and perhaps a little later in Evola's view

The following corollary immediately follows from those two observations:

- In order to fully understand Tradition, it is sufficient to look to medieval Europe, its spiritual tradition, and its social structure

In other words, it is not necessary to look to alien traditions, but rather to Europe's intellectual and spiritual past. This was brought to our attention by an essay by **Ananda Coomaraswamy**[3], in which he made clear that a European could not understand the Vedanta unless he was able to understand the great traditional writers of the West. There is a corollary to that observation:

[1] `https://gornahoor.net/p=35`
[2] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=36`
[3] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=556`

- Anyone who scoffs at the spiritual tradition of medieval Europe is unlikely to recognize or understand the traditional elements in the Vedanta.

A project immediately presents itself, one which Gornahoor has endeavored to fulfill:

- Investigate the medieval spiritual tradition and demonstrate its teachings on metaphysics, psychology, anthropology, history, sociology, politics, and so on.

Now, all this is more than a mental exercise. The ultimate purpose is to point out a possible way for the recovery of Tradition in the West. Moreover, that purpose is not the result of a merely arbitrary and subjective preference. As the modern world cannot continue to sustain itself on its present path, Tradition will necessarily return. However, that return can be relatively peaceful or quite painful. As noted in the links to Guenon's predictions, there are three possibilities:

- Degeneration. If no effort is made to restore Tradition, the West will degenerate into barbarity. **Carl Jung** noticed that in the psychology of his patients. Concerning the abandonment of the Western spiritual tradition by modern men, he had this to say:

> At a time when a large part of mankind is beginning to discard Christianity, it may be worth our while to try to understand why it was accepted in the first place. It was accepted as a means of escape from the brutality and unconsciousness of the ancient world. As soon as we discard it, the old brutality returns in force … This is not a step forwards, but a long step backwards into the past.

- Assimilation. Outsiders from the East will bring Tradition back to Europe, whether by consent or by force. In the former case, Europeans would adopt the Traditions of the newcomers. In the latter, the Tradition would come by force marked by painful ethnic or racial conflicts.

- Transformation. In this scenario, the West returns to Tradition spontaneously and voluntarily. This would be initiated by a group of men that Guenon calls the "elite", in the sense that they understand tradition and "true intellectuality". They would be the initial leavening that would eventually spread.

Since we are not interested in promoting the cause of degeneration, and since we are not "outsiders", Gornahoor's real project is almost too obvious to mention.

- To promote the spontaneous and voluntary transformation of the West.

There are several preparatory steps required. Here are some we are engaged in:

- Make clear what the elite must know, both intellectually and morally. That is why we have provided so many translations into English of rare works and have brought to light many ancient texts. Obviously, we read them in the light of Tradition and not as moderns who have little conception of their real meaning.

- Encourage readers to engage with writings that are known to be initiatory, such as Dante, The Romance of the Rose, Boccaccio, etc.

- Investigate spiritual and intellectual currents that still retain real and recoverable traces of tradition.

There are other initiatives in motion, but it is too early to discuss them.

There is absolutely nothing new or novel in all this, it all derives from Guenon and other writers on Tradition. Hence, there is really nothing to dialog about; you either accept the premise or you don't. We are interested only in the former. It is not dialogists that are required, but rather those who want to develop such ideas further, based on their own abilities and interests.

Posted on 2013-10-14 by Cologero

* * *

jc00001 on 2013-10-14 at 09:37 said:

The reintroduction of Neo-Platonism into Western thought would lay the foundations for a true living Tradition if understood correctly. Plotinus's Enneads is the great masterwork of the Western Tradition.

Thorsten on 2013-10-14 at 10:34 said:

Cologero,

thanks for the clarification. When I suggested a dialogue I was referring primarily to the fact that self-styled "traditionalists" in the New Right/Alt Right need to wiling to be more open to traditional doctrine, especially in the shape it assumed in Medieval Europe, and to be more open to metaphysical reality in general. (Otherwise they really have no business calling themselves traditionalists.)

On the other hand I would like to humbly suggest that as prideful and sensually/aesthetically oriented [What else is left in the absence of a living tradition than tribal and racial identity and old symbolic language (e.g. art) from a bygone civilization? These seem to be the default surrogates for tradition, and the only remaining alternatives to chaos when you were raised outside of tradition or have been heretofore fed such a degraded version of tradition that you cannot in good conscience submit to it.] these apostates are that they are not all beyond saving as a group, and should be handled as misguided rather than willfully contrarian. Now doubtless a number of the most strident voices in these circles are in fact willfully contrarian, puerile, and deliberately disrespectful of Western tradition to a degree that is shameful and they are probably not worth the time of Gornahoor or any other advocates of western tradition.

I'm confident that most of the New Right/Alt Right are not interested in Muslim overlordship and therefore are opposed the the option of Assimilation, although I'm not so sure that they

would all be opposed to some level brutality and barbarity in terms of a more militarized society and harsher corporal punishment (It's undeniable that western society was markedly more brutal and barbarous until quite recently in this regard.) If brutality and barbarism refers to coarseness of taste, vulgarity, and surrender to hedonism I think its obvious that most of them would oppose Degeneration in this sense, as this is frequently the subject of articles of the New Right. On the other hand I think the third possibility of Transformation might actually be received quite well as this would appeal to those who were not born into an existing tradition or have been alienated the contemporary Chrisitianity of any sort because they were raised on some anti-traditional low church protestantism which is devoid traditional values such as inequality, metaphysics as opposed to literalist readings of scripture, and the primacy of the intellect as opposed to blind faith.

I myself am not a member in any sense of the New Right, but I do think that there is more potential among those who frequent such circles than there appears to be if you only focus on the stance of the writers and editors. As a former Nietzsche-maniac, and stubborn materialist like so many of those frequent and comment on such websites I think that many of these iconoclasts could be esotericists in the making.

Kind regards,

Thorsten

`JA on 2013-10-14 at 10:54 said:`

when did Evola see the Tradition as being lost in Europe ? I was unaware he differed in chronology from Guenon.

`cosmodromium on 2013-10-14 at 10:59 said:`

Gornahoor maintains an abnormally high quality of thought on clearly defined subject matter. Seeking "dialogue" – especially online – especially with the "new/alt right" crowd would be diverting time and energy to lower the bar. I believe somewhere Guenon states a viable mission for the man of tradition to bear witness to the modern age – as a "watcher" – and maintain purity of doctrine. Which in my opinion Gornahoor has done admirably. Put the material out for those with eyes to see. The others will invariably dilute, distort, or "debate it. In fact, if I were to be so obnoxious as to advance unsolicited advice, I would even suggest cutting loose the ballast of the "comments" section.

`jc00001 on 2013-10-14 at 11:25 said:`

Gornahoor is definitely the spiritual core of the counter-revolution and the living Tradition, online. The only site that comes anywhere near is Ken Wheeler's `http://kathodos.com` and that sadly is private, invitation only now.

Thorsten on 2013-10-14 at 12:02 said:

cosmodromium,

Perhaps you're right about the new/alt right. Maybe I give them more credit than they deserve. My opinion of them has already sunk quite a bit but I think that fostering an intellectual elite will be insufficient in the long run for the project of Transformation. Unless I'm missing something I can't help but conclude that some action must be taken at some point to reach the Kshatriya, i.e. the politically inclined, in order to make some effect on the wider society. Perhaps I'm "jumping the gun" and need to be more patient but time is not on our side I'm afraid as the prospects of Degeneration and Assimilation are materializing quite rapidly. (And I hope I don't come across as arrogant. It's not my intention.) Again when I speak of dialogue I do not mean to suggest debating doctrine or metaphysics, certainly not with those who are less informed but rather to brainstorm the logistics of how a traditional society could be made to work at the present level of technological complexity, globalization, "multiculturalism", mass media etc. It's a tedious and daunting project but I don't see how it can be avoided.

Thomas Blanchard on 2013-10-14 at 14:01 said:

Thorsten,

I'll chime in since I am loosely involved in various New Right spheres, and can echo most of your feelings on this, although I think I've come to a different understanding of things.

I agree that the reformation of an authentic new second estate (warrior caste) will be a necessary step in an overall return to order in the west, just as it will be necessary to reform the third estate on healthy principles. Gornahoor's primary mission (and someone correct me if I'm wrong) is the recovery of the western tradition and and the spiritual development of individuals who will eventually form a truly legitimate first estate that will serve as its elite vanguard.

This being said, a parallel effort to build a true second estate does make sense, but they key is that it should be properly subordinated to a new first estate; the castes and vocations should have proper hierarchical relations with one another. All of the various New Right movements of today represent different manifestations of this impulse, but without a proper spiritual authority to guide them (and you are correct that the modern exoteric Church as the world sees it is rather weak and uninspiring), these efforts constitute a rebellious attempt to re-establish the Bronze Age (written of by Hesiod). In this case I respectfully disagree with Cologero's non-distinction between pure modernists and the New Right types that one might find at a place like Counter-Currents: modernists represent the Iron Age, the "Renaissance", the French Revolution, and the "Enlightenment", but the New Right truly wishes for the return of the Bronze Age and their writers are men like Homer and Nietzsche.

In a sense, the dialogue you have been talking about has been taking place for a long time – you can see it in Plato's works: Socrates' debates with Thucydides or especially with Callicles, where his opponents represent these more "New Right" sorts.

As a person who also has mixed proclivities and tends to sympathize with Nietzsche, I share your feelings, but it's best for the time being to focus on re-establishing a spiritual elite before trying to give direction to the chaotic mess of political agitators who are united only in their opposition to the Iron Age.

For your personal development, if you cannot commit yourself to a religion now, at least I would recommend taking up things like traditional martial arts and mountain climbing – Evola wrote primarily for people of our type, and some of his last advice to young people was not to worry about forming an "order", but to simply focus on building character. I believe that this is good advice.

Thorsten on 2013-10-14 at 20:06 said:

Thomas,

I'm on the same page with you and Gornahoor on the primacy of establishing a reformed spiritual/intellectual elite/oratores/brahmin caste (call it what you will). Thought precedes action and the wise must rule the strong and I say that is all the more reason to quash counterfeit spiritualities propagated by some in the new right and to formulate a working alternative. How to do this specifically I am not sure and won't presume to tell anyone.

I myself cannot say with certainty whether I am more a bellator than an orator but I do have some experience with rock climbing and I intend to take up some form of martial arts when I have the means to do so. Anyway I understand the necessity of rebuilding from the top down as has been reiterated here at Gornahoor many times, but if we don't get things rebuilt (bring about the Transformation) before society collapses into utter degeneracy do we simply allow some semblance of order to be imposed on the West by Wahhabi radicals (Assimilation) by means of brutality and barbarism which may make the barbarian incursions in the last days of the Roman empire look merciful in comparison?

To be clear am no enemy of Islam. I am only pointing out that when the present ideology of materialism and egalitarianism implodes upon itself the most consistent (and forceful) ideology in the West will not only be Muslim but the most ferocious variant thereof.

Michael on 2013-10-14 at 20:25 said:

Cologero, I understand the concept of an elite, but I don't understand how the elite will act as a "leaven" to transform society. Is it purely through contemplation? Or will there also be action similar to the way that enlightenment ideas spread through society? From reading Guenon and Tomberg, I have the impression that it is an unseen spiritual leavening process.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:18 said:

@ Thomas Blanchard Those are mostly excellent suggestions … more generally, besides rock climbing, there are other elements to master depending on your personal equation. See

Qualifications for Initiation[4] for example. If only the NR would follow your advice and stay out of religious and spiritual matters. Their proper domain is the manifestation which should be the focus. An important point you bring up is the "third estate", which does not get the attention it needs. The modern world is in the hands of that estate, not some decadent spiritual tradition as the NR seems to be obsessed with.

There is some subtleties with Socrates, who was executed for atheism and impiety. His call for the rule of philosophers in touch with the ideas replaced the Homeric vision of the rule of the gods. So you could see him as the precursor of modernity on the one hand, or else as someone who spread esoteric teachings prematurely.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:32 said:

@Thorsten

I put up the quotes from Alice Bailey to show how events happen on their own accord apart from the wills of men. She saw turmoil inaugurating a new age of one religion, one race, etc, although it is hard to be so sanguine about that. It is odd that the Theosophists seen eternal progress instead of the cycles of decline, considering their reliance on Asian teachings.

Back to the point, events will unfold as they do. Decisions made and actions executed today will have consequences down the road. I don't know how Guenon was able to see the possibly imminent ethnic conflict in 1921, but they are certainly foreseeable now. Yet it doesn't have to be that way.

I don't know why you feel any personal agitation or anxiety. It is not as though you are in charge of anything nor is the worst likely to happen in your lifetime. Besides rock climbing, seek out Seneca's 41st letter to Lucillius:

> If you see a man who is unterrified in the midst of dangers, untouched by desires, happy in adversity, peaceful amid the storm, who looks down upon men from a higher plane and view the gods on a footing of equality, will not a feeling of reverence for him steal over you? …
>
> When a soul rises superior to other souls, when it is under control, when it passes through every experience as if it were of small account, when it smiles at our fears and at our prayers, it is stirred by a force from heaven. A thing like this cannot stand upright unless it be propped by the divine.

That is the ideal to strive for. Jung's commentary on that passage is also quite interesting, but I'll save it for another time.

[4] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1161

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:44 said:

Guenon ties it to a very specific event: the destruction of the Templars. The reason for this may be difficult to understand or even to accept, but it has to do both with the exodus of esoteric orders from Europe and the ties between esoteric Christian and esoteric Islamic orders. Guenon has left a very interesting clue about that, although I am not ready to make it public without understanding it more deeply. I have pointed out the clue on Gornahoor although it will take some digging.

I don't believe Evola dates it so precisely since he did not have the same interest in that topic as Guenon. Instead he refers to the regression of the castes over a longer time. As we have often pointed out, Evola said he believed what every well-bred person prior to the French Revolution considered normal and healthy.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:47 said:

Yes, jc, and neoplatonic authors are well represented on Coomaraswamy's list. Unfortunately, professional philosophers today consider it an obsolete phase of their discipline. Theologians are worse when the say something like "early theologians used Greek philosophy as the vehicle to express their theology", as though it were a totally arbitrary choice and any modern philosophy would serve the same purpose.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:54 said:

I don't understand either, Michael, as the Spirit will blow where he wills. Yes, false ideas spread quite easily, but true ideas are longer lasting. There is always the feeling of having to "do something" but instead we need that interior silence, not unlike what Seneca described, which connects us to Heaven which allows the influx of forces.

Logres on 2013-10-15 at 06:06 said:

"gain when I speak of dialogue I do not mean to suggest debating doctrine or metaphysics, certainly not with those who are less informed but rather to brainstorm the logistics of how a traditional society could be made to work at the present level of technological complexity, globalization, "multiculturalism", mass media etc. It's a tedious and daunting project but I don't see how it can be avoided."

Thorsten, this may be no reason not to spend time on it now, but the "present level of complexity" may decrease quite drastically over the next 20-50 years. At least on so large a scale.

Thorsten on 2013-10-15 at 11:52 said:

@ Cologero,

I'm fairly well acquainted with the Stoics, including Seneca, but I'm not asking for advice on how to be more equanimous as my emotions are actually quite subdued to the point of being a bit atrophied largely by virtue of studying Stoicism and practicing meditation. If anything I've found it too easy to become detached from the world to the point that I see no point in taking any action. But such a level of detachment seems to be almost antithetical to the Indo-European tradition. So in the interest of taking action on earth beyond my own head I am compelled to insist on answers to a number of riddles about the application of traditional principles on that which is happening right here right now. Therefore the urgency which I show is not indicative of anxiety or agitation (A warrior may be calm and fearless in battle but he still must be swift and decisive and for this he needs a battle plan and tactics.) and at least b) and c) below are hardly more my predicaments than they are all of ours whether we choose to confront them or not. If they do not affect us personally they will affect our descendants. Rather the urgency is indicative of the fact that I (and I would have to assume others as well) remain without any unambiguous answers to and am therefore unable to plan and make decisions with regards to the problems of:

a) What is my tradition if I was not born into one? And if we are to work toward Transformation, at what point do we abandon our current exoteric religions (assuming one is already attached to a religion)? Do we remain faithful by all external appearances to our religion, all the while building a new vehicle for tradition and then as it were suddenly apostasize from the religion that we currently follow when the new vehicle is ready? (whether this be in 5 years or 200) I understand Evola's stance about Riding the Tiger and not being compelled to get involved in politics or religion, but apostasy from religion of any sort is inconsistent with the advice of Guenon et al. is it not?

b) In order to prepare the groundwork for the Transformation do we simply, learn to "watch our thoughts", "stop thinking", cultivate "interior silence" and other such contemplative exercises then build a community of like-minded brahmanic individuals, rather than "do something" out in the real world in terms of metapolitical cultural activities (influencing the media, education etc.) and political activism? Are such activities the business of the second estate? If the Transformation is to be spontaneous how passive (in the conventional sense of the word) must we be in terms of creating the new institutions. Should we have any sense of urgency whatsoever? Or is it so important to ensure that the new vehicle of tradition is fully formed that matters of politics and demographic change should be of no concern no matter how tumultuous things may become if we do not act? I ask because I think it is indeed possible to make a difference if enough individuals care to.

c.) On that note I think it is worth pointing out that men of tradition, at least those of the second estate, have always fought until the bitter end against foreign invaders no matter how traditional the religion of their foes may have been and no matter what the odds were. Just how is our situation any different? (Byrhtwold encapsulates the Indo-European attitude

in such a situation. The same attitude that a stoic Roman, Spartan, or Vedic warrior showed. http://en.wikiquote.org/wiki/The_Battle_of_Maldon) If anything the battle will be largely a political rather than the nasty kind if enough pressure can be brought to bear on governments in the next decade. Is the degeneracy of the contemporary West reason enough to surrender to a more traditional invading enemy? Is the value of ethnic loyalty trumped by the interest of submitting to a more traditional social order? (It bears mentioning radical Muslims are generally opposed to the authority of the first estate).

Again I pose these questions not as rhetorical devices or as incitement but out of a sincere interest in knowledge of the application of Tradition to our present circumstances. And if you are not comfortable providing answers I will understand.

P.S.

@ Logres,

I think such a simplification would be the best possible scenario.

Thanks,

Thorsten

Avery on 2013-10-15 at 13:41 said:

A frightening possibility is that the world will not be simplifying anytime soon, but will continue to confuse one or two generations more with astounding quantities and technological wonders, at the price of any last scraps of tradition. In that scenario both degeneration and assimilation become highly likely. Yet Gornahoor makes transformation sound so easy. Considering the dangers involved it is actually the most difficult of the three paths.

Seraphim Rose probably did more for this transformative process than any of us. He was completely orthodox and he seems to have had prophetic abilities as well. Yet one of his followers started a cult in his name outside the communion of the ROCOR (in Brookline, MA). Can we really say that what we revive will be the West?

Cologero on 2013-10-15 at 20:36 said:

Thorsten, you have no standing to "insist" on anything here. I have been providing answers in several hundred thousand words of original material and translations without feeling the least discomfort. If you want to address specific points discussed, then give it a try, otherwise it is time for you to move on.

Thorsten on 2013-10-15 at 21:03 said:

Cologero,

I meant no disrespect. I suppose the word "insist" was not the right term. Anyway I thought I had addressed specific points which you have discussed but in the interest of not creating any bad blood I will cease to ask these questions.

Best Regards,
Thorsten

Logres on 2013-10-16 at 06:33 said:

Avery, that's a good observation – the next generation or two will be crucial, & the likely real test, because they do have enough resources to string it along for a little further. However, at least to my thinking, it's getting more and more obvious that the group that is benefiting is shrinking and shrinking, and this is in our favor, if we can strengthen the classes that are being shoved aside to keep the profit margins thick enough. This is why a new "elite" is paramount. The situation is conducive for opening eyes to the disgusting nature of materialism.

12.3 The Traditional Approach

In *Traditionalism, this is the Enemy*[5] the "philosopher" of the European New Right, Guillaume Faye, critiques "Traditionalism", allegedly from the inside. He calls it "metaphysical traditionalism", which no one else has ever called it, whatever "it" may be, but, since he attributes "it" to Julius Evola, we prefer to critique the critique with the words of Evola himself. Since this comes from the forward to *Revolt Against the Modern World*, one would not have to read very much to realize Faye's misunderstanding. First of all, he claims to have exhumed three axioms of "metaphysical traditionalism", axioms which are nowhere to be found in either Evola or Guenon. Since the rest of the article depends on those axioms, it is not worth reading past that point, unless you are one of those people who stops and stares at **road kill**.

First of all, Tradition does not refer to a nostalgic looking back in time, though it does involve a remembering. Furthermore, it is not so much concerned with the affairs of men, but rather of the revelations of the gods that give meaning to the past. This is how Evola describes his

[5] http://www.counter-currents.com/2010/06/traditionalism-this-is-the-enemy/

project:

> The order of things that I will mainly deal with in this present work, generally speaking, is that in which all materials have a "historical" and "scientific" value are the ones that matter the least; conversely, all the mythical, legendary, and epic elements denied historical truth and demonstrative value acquire here a superior validity and become the source for a more real and certain knowledge…
>
> The scientific "anathemas" in regard to this approach are well known: "Arbitrary!" "Subjective!" "Preposterous!" In my perspective there is no arbitrariness, subjectivity, or fantasy, just as there is no objectivity and scientific causality the way modern men understand them. All these notions are unreal; all these notions are outside Tradition. Tradition begins wherever it is possible to rise above these notions by achieving a superindividual and nonhuman perspecive; thus, I will have a minimal concern for debating and "demonstrating." The truths that may reveal the world of Tradition are not those that can be "learned" or "discussed"; either they are or they are not. It is only possible to **remember** them, and *this happens when one becomes free of the obstacles represented by various human constructions*, first among which are all the results and the methods of specialized researchers; in other words, one becomes free of these encumbrances when the capacity for *seeing* from that nonhuman perspective, which is the same as the traditional perspective has been attained. *This is one of the essential "protests" that should be made by those who really oppose the modern world."*
>
> **Julius Evola**, Forward to *Revolt Against the Modern World*

Posted on 2010-07-08 by Cologero

12.4 The Traditional Method

In the Forward to **Revolt Against the Modern World**, Evola characterizes the "Traditional Method" with two principles, which I schematize in Table 13.1:

	Perspective	**Principle**
Ontology	Objective	Correspondence
Epistemology	Subjective	Induction

Table 12.1: The Traditional Method

Ontology The Principle of Correspondence "ensures an essential and functional correlation between analogous elements, presenting them as simple homologous forms of the appearance of a central and unitary meaning."

This makes two claims:

1. There is a central and unitary meaning
2. This meaning may appear differently in different circumstances and different times

That this is true can be seen in the use of languages. For example, "dog" and "perro" look different and sound different. Nevertheless, they both "mean" the same thing. However, for someone who doesn't know English and Spanish, the two words ("appearances") appear unrelated. So the denial of this principle implies the absurd conclusion that languages are mutually unintelligible.

In practice, this means that the source of events in the world must be traced back to its corresponding idea. Thus different myths, legends, and

symbolic forms from disparate cultures can be shown to be expressions of the same idea. But just as I cannot "prove" that dog=perro to someone ignorant of those languages, neither can Tradition be proven to someone ignorant of spiritual reality.

Epistemology Principle of Induction is a "discursive approximation of a spiritual intuition, in which what is realized is the integration and the homologous unification of the diverse elements encountered in the same one meaning and in the same one principle."

Again, this contains two elements:

1. Discursive approximation
2. Spiritual intuition

Although a metaphysician may express himself in speech or writing, this can never be more than a discursive approximation, since spiritual reality is ultimately ineffable and irreducible to objective language. However, what the metaphysician knows, he knows by direct intuition. So, in the case of myths, legends and other symbolic forms, one "realizes" that they encompass a unitary meaning by a sort of clairvoyance or spiritual "seeing".

Revolt of the Spirit Via this "traditional method", Evola will portray the world of Tradition as a unity and a universal type. Specifically, this means that the world of Tradition has manifested in various forms and can still manifest in a different form. The man of Tradition does not blindly desire to repeat the past — which "past", since the universal type has manifested in different forms in the past.

Furthermore, Evola will show that the idea or type of Tradition is "capable of creating points of reference and of evaluation different from the ones to which the majority of the people in the West have passively

and semiconsciously become accustomed". Specifically, this the idea that everything is "text", can be written down and debated endlessly — a process that does not result in understanding but only aporia. This is the viewpoint of the modernists and those who think like them.

Only by understanding the sense of the world of Tradition, only by intuiting the spiritual reality behind the world of appearances, then

> this sense can also lead to the establishment of the foundations for an eventual revolt (not a polemical, but real and positive one) of the spirit against the modern world.

Tentacles, Paws, Arms, Wings Since Evola wrote a thorough book on the Hermetic Tradition, I will use an example from the Hermeticist Valentin Tomberg to illustrate the Principle of Correspondence. In Letter XIV on Temperance in **Meditations on the Tarot**, Tomberg writes:

> Tentacles, paws, arms, wings — are they not simply diverse forms manifesting a common prototype or principle?

In other words, Tomberg will show that they are homologous forms of a central and unitary meaning, which is precisely the Principle of Correspondence. He explains:

> They are insofar as they express the desire to bear the sense of touch further, to be able to touch things more removed than those in the immediate neighbourhood of the surface of the body. They are *active extensions* of the passive and receptive sense of touch which is spread out over the surface of the organism. In making use of them, the sense of touch makes "excursions" from its usual orbit circumscribed by the skin which covers the body.

Clearly this is absurd and incomprehensible to one-dimensional thinkers who live and move on a line. So how do we justify this epistemologically?

As we have repeatedly mentioned, the sufficient reason of the world of appearance is the Will. Since we have direct experience of our own Will, we should understand how the Will strives to bring our ideas into manifestation. So it is actually the rationalist who is absurd, since he denies the existence and efficacy of his own will, attributing it to some external force, fashioned by electro-chemical activity in the brain. Thus he denies his own existence while pretending to exist. Let's allow Tomberg to explain:

> The organs of action are simply crystallised will. I walk not because I have legs but rather on the contrary. I have legs because I have the will to move about. I touch, I take, and I give not because I have arms, but I have arms because I have the will to touch, to take, and to give.

The Will is creative. It takes the idea and brings it into the appropriate form. Tomberg makes this clear:

> The "what" [the idea] of the Will engenders the "how" of the action (the organ) and not inversely. The arms are therefore the expression of the will to bear touch further than the surface of one's own body. They are the manifestation of extended touch due to the will to touch things at a distance.

Posted on 2010-07-10 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-07-12 at 15:38 said:

This is another one of your excellent and helpful explications. If I may make a contribution: a couple years ago I found a passage in one of the few books on Spengler in English, by H. Stuart Hughes, where it seemed like he was actually giving a good explication of Guenon's metaphysical [vs. systematic philosophy] method. I think it could apply to Evola's method as well:

QUOTE:

Spengler rejected the whole idea of logical analysis. Such "systematic" practices apply only in the natural sciences. To penetrate below the surface of history, to understand at least partially the mysterious substructure of the past, a new method – that of "physiognomic tact" – is required.

This new method, "which few people can really master," means "instinctively to see through the movement of events. It is what unites the born statesman and the true historian, despite all opposition between theory and practice." [It takes from Goethe and Nietzsche] the injunction to "sense" the reality of human events rather than dissect them. In this new orientation, the historian ceases to be a scientist and becomes a poet. He gives up the fruitless quest for systematic understanding. ... "The more historically men tried to think, the more they forgot that in this domain they ought not to think." They failed to observe the most elementary rule of historical investigation : respect for the mystery of human destiny UNQUOTE

So causality/science, destiny/history. Rather than chains of reasoning and "facts" the historian employs his "tact" [really, a kind of Paterian "taste"] to "see" the big picture: how facts are composed into a destiny. Rather than compelling assent, the historian's words are used to bring about a shared intuition.

I suppose Guenon and Co. would bristle at being lumped in with "poets" but I think the general point is helpful in understanding the "epistemology" of what Guenon is doing: not objective [but empty] fact-gathering but not merely aesthetic and "subjective" either, since metaphysically "seeing" the deeper connection can be "induced" by words and thus "shared".

12.5 Sign of the Times

> We must be ready for an immense event in the divine order which we are travelling towards with an accelerated speed that must astound all those who watch. Awesome oracles have already pronounced that the time is now.
>
> Joseph de Maistre

Rene Guenon closed the King of the World with the above quote. The point is not that de Maistre is a fortune teller, but rather he could read the signs of the times. In Chapter IX of the Reign of Quantity, Guenon explains how to become ready, when he writes:

> Those who have not effectively attained to such a state must at least, as far as their capabilities permit, use every endeavor to reach it.

The state he is referring to is the supra-individual state, as he explains:

> The being who has attained a supra-individual state is, by that fact alone, released from all the limiting conditions of individuality, that is to say, he is beyond the determinations of "name and form" which constitute the essence and the substance of his individuality as such.

Clearly, there is some frustration possible, since there is no instruction on how to reach that state, nor a definitive description of it, yet we are supposed to be single-pointedly dedicated to it. So men begin to wander aimlessly, looking here or there for an answer, defending their favorite theories, attacking those they dislike. They seek in vain for an initiation, because of this situation that Guenon describes:

> Organizations provide an effective initiation only where an authentic traditional doctrine still exists, offering but a shadow when the spirit of the doctrine no longer vivifies the symbols that are merely its external representation; this happens when the conscious connection with the supreme spiritual centre of the world is finally broken.

Can we still be satisfied with that? Has not Guenon taught us traditional doctrines? The centre is everywhere, so that conscious connection can be instantly re-established. After all, Guenon always takes pains to point out that he is describing states of being, not places. So Guenon offers this encouragement:

> It is important to realize that we should be talking of something that is hidden rather than truly lost, because it is not lost to everybody but still possessed in its entirety, albeit by a very few. This gives rise to the possibility for other to rediscover it, provided they search in the proper manner.

In the Ancient City, it was often claimed that the founder had hidden the city's constitution in a tree trunk, or some such place. Finding a secret text is not what is meant, but rather the secret is unveiled in consciousness provided one has the right intention and is endeavoring.

Guenon hints that effective initiatory knowledge can be found in Tibet. He points to Swedenborg as authority in this regard as well as the 'Mount of Prophets' described by Anne-Catherine Emmerich. He alludes also to Agarttha as described in Saint-Yves d'Alveydre's Mission of India.

Meanwhile, there is no excuse to not make endeavors. Learn the doctrines, practice the many suggestions in the spiritual literature we have recommended (or your own favorite), and learn to recognize the different states of being in you own consciousness.

Posted on 2013-01-09 by Cologero

* * *

Mihai on 2013-01-10 at 05:06 said:

Swendenborg is the "father" of spiritism as far as I know about him. Where did Guenon ever refer to him in his works ?

Or maybe we are referring to different persons? Did you mean Emmanuel Swendenborg ?

Cologero on 2013-01-10 at 07:33 said:

Oddly enough, Guenon refers to Swedenborg often. This specific reference was from the King of the World. In the Spiritist Fallacy, Guenon does mention Swedenborg in relation to the spiritists. However, as he points out, Swedenborg is to be understood symbolically, not literally. For example he writes:

> When seers are orthodox mystics, their natural tendencies to stray are in some manner held in check and reduced to a minimum; almost everywhere else they have free rein and the result is often a nearly inextricable confusion. The most unquestionable and most celebrated among them, Swedenborg for example, are far from exempt from this fault, and one cannot take too many precautions if one wishes to extract what is of genuine interest in their works. Better to go to purer sources …

Nevertheless, Guenon does not restrict himself totally to those purer sources. On a personal level, we can presume that Guenon became familiar with Swedenborg from his early involvement with Martinism. Apparently, he felt Swedenborg, in this instance, offered something of interest. Similar things could be said about another seer, Emmerich, who, by the way, served as the inspiration for some scenes in Gibson's the Passion of the Christ. I suppose the point here is to not be too dogmatically close-minded.

Iulianus on 2013-01-10 at 08:38 said:

I think that Yves' book Mission de l'Inde was translated and published in English under the title The Kingdom of Agarttha: A Journey into the Hollow Earth…

Cologero on 2013-01-10 at 12:53 said:

Thanks for pointing this out, Iulianus. Has anyone read it?

Mihai on 2013-01-10 at 15:11 said:

I see.

Oddly, I do not recall any mention in the King of the World regarding him.

I understand the case, though.

My take in these cases: if you find a piece of gold, use it, without concerning yourself with where it came from. But don't go burying yourself neck-deep in trash because you know that there has to be a piece of gold there, especially if you've got an entire goldmine near you.

Pickman on 2013-01-10 at 19:15 said:

"Meanwhile, there is no excuse to not make endeavors. Learn the doctrines, practice the many suggestions in the spiritual literature we have recommended (or you own favorite), and learn to recognize the different states of being in you own consciousness."

One can do these exercises on their own, but without a guiding hand – be that of a master and a structured community of disciplined adherents (often recommended even by Steiners' standards) dangers can and will persist. A student may be off by a millimeter and yet not ever

be corrected on the trajectory. This is why institutions existed in the past to buffer such spiritual endeavors for those who had the vocation to commit to them. Guénon, Eckhart, tomberg and other esoteric maistres may have as individuals labored endearingly for years but they still needed to graft themselves to a Tradition for anchorage. Unfortunately we have been left smashed up upon the ruins, to raise ourselves up without a wall to lean on (of the hypertrophied, post-post-modern spiritually vacant, materialist West – notwithstanding persistent witch cults of a feminine neo-spiritism).

"Guenon hints that the effective initiatory knowledge can be found in Tibet. He points to Swedenborg as authority in this regard as well as the 'Mount of Prophets' of Anne-Catherine Emmerich. (If anyone has located either of these specific references, please share them.) He alludes also to Agarttha as described in Saint-Yves d'Alveydre's Mission of India. I will be making his description of Agarttha available in English for the first time in the near future."

Was this hinting done in Guénon's theosophy days in his exploration of occultist circles and the claims of Bo yin ra? If at a later time he could not get to India, then surely Tibet was out of the question. Then again there are hints towards initiatic centers even in the West still, yet we are told they have refused to act for reasons known to themselves. Telling really. Which is true even of those few who are receptive to a rightist doctrine.

Who are the few and who have remembered so that we can have a living example to aim for? That is what is missing today (among other things).

Senko on 2013-01-10 at 20:42 said:

I know this can only satisfy Christians (Catholics and Orthodox alike), but Prayer of the Heart and Lectio Divina along with a good Confessor and a Priest that can act as a spiritual guide/mentor, should be enough to give the first steps into spiritual realization. What I find truly difficult in this turbulent times is not finding the appropiate way, but keeping up with it in these freaking crazy times

Cologero on 2013-01-10 at 23:16 said:

Guenon hints at this often enough: the goal is not really to "find" a spiritual center some place not least of all because it "is to all intents and purposes inaccessible and invisible to all except those possessing the necessary qualifications for entry."

Also, "both geographical and historical facts possess a symbolic validity that in now way detracts from their being facts."

In other words, the spiritual center that people are seeking (externally) can be right here, right now … it would still be unrecognizable without the necessary qualifications. The few have been born at this era, some of whom will try to remember why. They are the qualified, they are the living examples. There is no magic group to find and you can't wait for George to do it for you. If the world is in ruins … what would a man do?

Jason-Adam on 2013-01-11 at 06:38 said:
The Ladder of Divine Ascent is another useful text of the Christian path....

Jason-Adam on 2013-01-11 at 06:44 said:
It's funny, I just finished reading Saint-Yves d'Alveydre's book Mission des Souverains and sadly was disappointed by his pro-Masonic and anti-Catholic stance, though I do believe his idea of synarchy once adopted to Catholic means is a good system. I'm interested to read Cologero's translations of him soon...

Pickman on 2013-01-11 at 14:27 said:
Reference was made to Tibet on account of them continuing a living pre-modern solar initiation that would be acceptable to those "possessing the necessary qualifications for entry" and not just hollow rites based on empty form and ritual of decadent Western institutions. The reference was not made on "finding" or "seeking" something external or material even beyond the symbolic significance of their locations. An individual of Indo-European heritage already is who he is, but he must activate his center and know himself. This is where it gets confusing and there are many pretenders to the throne. Try joining the Jesuits but it will not be enough for some, but at least a Ur group would have been useful for research purposes. Who's George?

"What I find truly difficult in this turbulent times is not finding the appropiate way, but keeping up with it in these freaking crazy times"

The only way out is to run vertically into the mountains or horizontally to the wilderness.

12.6 Guenonian Scholasticism

Julius Evola was among the first writers to take up the ideas of Rene Guenon, and maintained an epistolary relationship with him until the end of Guenon's life. Yet, although Evola wrote a long article in *La Vita Italiana*, titled "Rene Guenon: A Master for our Times", in praise of Guenon, he also wrote another article in which he opposed what he called 'Guenonian Scholasticism', which he defines as:

> This kind of 'scholasticism' consists in following passively just about every view ever formulated by Guenon, with a pedantic attitude, without any true investigation or discrimination, and

> with a real fear to make even the slightest change in the master's formulations.

This accusation is directed toward Guenon's followers as much as against the Master himself. We can agree with Evola that Guenon's writings are not revealed text, but we also need to take into account the Guenon offered solid reasons for his perspectives. Therefore, we should expect the same from Evola, and not assume that Guenon is writing from his "personal equation". In our day, ironically, we need to oppose an Evolian Scholasticism that takes some of the more marginal positions of Evola as representative of the whole of Tradition. What follows are the points espoused by Guenon that Evola takes issue with.

Knowledge and Action Evola disputes Guenon's contention that contemplation, or knowledge, is superior to action. Guenon explains his position most fully in *The Crisis of the Modern World*, where he associates knowledge with the Brahmin caste and the East, while associating action with the Kshatriyas and the West. If it were just a question of two perspectives, that would be one thing, but Guenon goes on to infer that the West is deviant in that regard. Evola takes the first position (that there are two legitimate paths, one knowledge and one of action), but then in the next paragraph contradicts himself by giving action primacy.

Guenon's contention is that the principle of Action lies outside Action, viz., in the Unmoved Mover, a position also held by Evola. Guenon asserts that the Unmoved Mover is actually knowledge. Evola doesn't actually address Guenon's argument, so we'll give it a try. The debate is a little puzzling, if only because Guenon asserts that there is a more fundamental principle that unites the Brahmin (knowledge) and the Kshatriya (action), but then seems to have forgotten it. Both Guenon and Evola appeal to the Bhagavad Gita as their authority and come to differ-

ent conclusions. On the other hand Tilak[6], who was respected by both men, seems to have learned the right lesson. It is the noumenal Will that is the Unmoved Mover and the uniting principle. While it is true that there have been different paths, Boris Mouravieff describes a Fourth Way path, based on Hermetic and Hesychast Traditions in the Eastern church, that combine both. *Pace* Evola, knowledge is essential, but *pace* Guenon, knowledge without a corresponding change in the level of being is ineffective. Acquiring Knowledge is the easier part, while the change in Being is more difficult as it involves the Will. Evola mentions the practical and ascetic attitude of Early Buddhism to bolster his point.

Spiritual Authority Evola challenges Guenon's position of Spiritual Authority vis-a-vis Regal Authority. Again, this seems like a non-issue, because it also depends on that deeper principle uniting the two castes and seems to not to take into account Temporal Power. Yes, the priestly caste ought not to exercise temporal power over the administrative caste, yet they cannot abandon their teaching task on spiritual matters. Nevertheless, Guenon and Evola agree that there is a Regal initiation that integrates the two castes. For example, it was accepted that the Pope should have temporal power over the Papal States, but I don't recall Evola ever mentioning it.

I think the dispute is exacerbated by historical circumstances, in which the Catholic religion came to be dominated by theological disputes which overflowed into the secular realm. This may be because Christianity did not have a Law, *per se*, as do Traditional religions. Contrast this with the Roman idea of the Emperor or the Muslim idea of the Caliphate. The Emperor or Caliphate is supposed to represent, not just the political unity, but also the spiritual unity of the State. However, in these cases, this involves ensuring that the religious law is followed and enforced. Theological and philosophical positions are personal matters in those systems,

[6] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1619`

so the enforcement of creedal orthodoxy is not their task.

Initiatory Organizations and Masonry Guenon was overly punctilious about the regularity of initiatory organizations and he accepted Masonry as one such. Here we agree with Evola. Self-initiation is possible as we have pointed out[7]. Also, even if the initiatory impetus of a Tradition is passive and virtual, it can still be made active. Evola seems to have picked up his strong *animus* against Masonry from the long-time Catholic opposition to it ... part of *his* "personal equation." This has two roots. The first is related to the Templars which was unjustly destroyed. This led to the end of initiatory organizations in the West, even if Masonry carried it on for a time. Nevertheless, there was a time when Masonry did indeed transform itself into a revolutionary and subversive organization. Guenon describes that process in some detail.

Buddhism Guenon devalued Buddhism, but later corrected himself by discovering an alleged "Brahmanic" version of Buddhism. This Evola rejects; it is sufficient to refer to his work *The Doctrine of Awakening*. In Evola's conception, initiation on this path depends on the descent of "forces from above", something we are sympathetic with for obvious reasons.

The Necessity of a Traditional Exoterism They both make sense. From Guenon's perspective, in a Traditional society, one simply accepts the exoteric system of the group (this is what led to the conviction of Socrates). However, Evola rightly points out that the gap in our day between Esoterism and the available Exoterisms is currently unbridgeable. Perhaps the way forward is to find a way to bridge them.

Posted on 2011-03-03 by Cologero

[7] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1721`

* * *

HOO on 2011-03-03 at 05:20 said:

The Brahmin vs. Kshatriya discussion is most of the time ridiculous and useless, and entertaining it seems like a symptom of counter-productive bookishness, for just as the Kshatriya had have suffered a gradual reduction to "temporal power", to administrative, juristic and military functions, the Brahmin had suffered a gradual reduction to "wordy or moral temporal pressure", to administrative, juristic and psuedoritualistic functions (to which Buddhism was in a way a response to).

´By far more than the sacerdotal title of 'saint', it is that of Lord which, of all times, was used by all people to designate 'God' – as symbol of the highest metaphysical state in which the human being can integrate. Also Guénon, when he uses the title 'King of the World' to designate the supreme centre of spiritual authority, is he not himself referring to a non-sacerdotal dignity? Does he not himself note (p. 137) the symbolic relation between the sceptre, emblem of royal dignity, and the 'axis of the world'?´ Evola, "Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power" Many Guénonianists seem horrified by the truth that even the most vile serial killer (e.g. Angulimala), criminal or cannibal can become enlightened. They seem to be somehow attached to the mere-human cycles of moralism and rationalism, or such social or geometrical judgment.

´Therefore, a good Christian should beware that mathematicians, and any others who prophesy impiously... may be entangled in the companionship of demons*.´ – St. Augustine

*I'll illuminate some of you to the truth that a demon can mean a perspective or an angle (and the inescapable prejudice of an idea).

If the reader finds he react in some way emotionally to this comment he has found at least one of his demons.

Cologero on 2011-03-03 at 08:32 said:

Yes, moralism and sentimentalism, things Guenon seeks to avoid, are the result when the ideal of contemplation is reduced to the human level. I think another problem is that in the West, spiritual progress is often considered equivalent to holding the correct beliefs or opinions.

That is why I recommend the book "Opening the Dragon Gate", since Taoism was so influential on both Guenon and Evola. The young Taoist initiate reveals how he had to undergo several trials before being taught anything that we would consider "knowledge". This is Evola's point about early Buddhism, which, by the way, interacted with Taoism. But here again is the point. Tao means "way" or "path", Buddhism has an 8-fold path. The point is to follow the path, not to believe certain things. That is why there could be eight schools of Buddhism in China without a religious war ensuing.

EXIT on 2011-03-03 at 09:21 said:

Far from useless the dispute is critical for the reduction to a feminine spirituality, i.e.., moralism, sentimentalism, and empty ritualism, occurs as Guenon points out at the moment when an inversion of hierachy takes place due to the revolt by the regal warrior caste.

EXIT on 2011-03-03 at 09:28 said:

Hoo, you are wrong to say that Guenonians are horrified by immorality. But I don't know any serial killers or cannibals that are truly enlightened, do you?

I would also take issue with Christian polemics, as if Augustine was an accurate judge of Greek, Pythagorean, and pagan traditions. I couldn't care less what this or that desert father said, and I am sure that they didn't believe much of their own arguments regarding such.

kadambari on 2011-03-03 at 10:13 said:

@HOO

´Therefore, a good Christian should beware that mathematicians, and any others who prophesy impiously... may be entangled in the companionship of demons*.´ – St. Augustin

I am unable to understand the above comment? Why does he think Mathematicians prophesy impiously? As EXIT pointed out, how much does he really understand of Pythagoras, and the other pre-Christians? Is this not a Christian prejudice towards science? I am understanding science in the philosophical sense as the ancients who created and contributed to science understood it, as a part of the contemplative philosophical life...

Ken Hoop on 2011-03-03 at 15:40 said:

http://zennist.typepad.com/zenfiles/2011/03/buddhism-is-reformed-brahmanism.html

Evola would not have agreed with this?

Will on 2011-03-04 at 11:34 said:

Kadambari, I think that what Augustine means by "mathematicians" is something more along the lines of "numerologists." I don't know how much he did or didn't understand Pythagoreanism and Paganism, but I don't doubt that there were indeed people in his time who claimed to be prophets but were charlatans. One thing early Christianity has in common with early Buddhism is a disdain for divination. The Buddha said about astrology, "What can the stars do to one who is awake?"

Incidentally, there's an amusing scene in the movie Pi, in which two mathematicians are talking and one of them has become interested in Kabbalist mathematics. The other mathematician warns him that if he goes down that road, "You're no longer a mathematician – you're a numerologist," and he enunciates "numerologist" with venomous contempt.

EXIT on 2011-03-04 at 14:05 said:

HOO is implying that a traditional application of principles by Guenon is a rigid mathematical rationalism which doesn't hold up to reality. But Reality is the ultimate Mathematician regardless what the idol-fearing Christians, who are frightened that the devil may be hiding under every rock, think.

`Martin on 2019-05-10 at 03:48 said:`
What "Brahmanic" Buddhism did Guenon claim to find? Can you kindly point me to a source where he does this? Thank you.

`Cologero on 2019-05-10 at 04:29 said:`
Evola makes that claim in "René Guénon: a Teacher for Modern Times"
The topic is also discussed in "The Essential Rene Guenon". Guenon claimed that the original Buddhism of India is different from what it eventually became.

12.7 The Proverbs of Hell

> The road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom.
>
> Truth can never be told so as to be understood, and not be believed.
>
> William Blake, *Proverbs of Hell*

We owe to **Rene Guenon** the recognition of a common Tradition. His elucidation of metaphysics and exposition of the underlying symbolism are indispensable to any understanding of Tradition. There is no way forward without a thorough grounding in Guenon's works, keeping in mind that Truth can never be completely and consistently expressed in words, but that gnosis is the only way to grasp it.

Unfortunately, the guenonian path is ultimately a dead end, as few (if any) have decided to follow it. There are those who converted to Islam, as though that were Guenon's real message, while continuing to remain European. Inadvertently, Guenon on the one hand promotes individualism

by giving the impression that a man can pick and choose his Tradition and on the other opens the door to a false ecumenism of the New Age or Theosophical sort that he opposed.

This is why the professors will find Guenon so congenial as they misread him as an individualist and a universalist. Far removed, though not so far intellectually, are those neopagans who recreate a pseudo-tradition on the model of a modernist church with a creed to be believed and a moral code to follow.

That is why we reject the notion of multiple traditions. There is only one Tradition, the Hyperborean tradition, that has persisted since the beginning of the world; at least, that is the only tradition that interests us. The method is depth, to penetrate to the unexpressed core of tradition, beyond its varying formulations. This is the only way to understand and not create another system of thought to be believed.

The Road of Excess

> If others had not been foolish, we should be so.
>
> William Blake, *Proverbs of Hell*

Guenon's exclusive commitment to metaphysics and refusal to address questions of cosmology or contemporary affairs has led to a distortion of our understanding of Tradition. Nevertheless, these questions come up and a metaphysics that somehow floats above the affairs of the word is hardly a complete metaphysics. Anything real has an effect, just as the strong spirit is recognized by its power. Is the call to tradition answered by living the life of an Egyptian peasant or of "strong warriors? or "god-inspired priests"?

To his credit, **Julius Evola** understood this and, by building on Guenon, redefined the nature of tradition. And rather than abandoning the West,

he sought to recover and elucidate its deep roots. This task was accomplished neither systematically nor consistently. He dared to consider ideas that were unpopular or even distasteful. The positive result of this is that Evola is forever protected from the claws of the professors who will never be able to sanitize or incorporate him into any academic discipline.

Evola wrote voluminously on many subjects and sometimes ventured into the excessive and even the foolish. Who can accept his belief in telegenesis? One must carefully distinguish between Evola's contributions to our understanding of Tradition and metaphysics on the one hand, and the application of principles to particular historical issues.

For example, while we may adopt as our own the spiritual battle between the forces of *cosmos* and those of *chaos*, although the manifestation of that battle will alter from age to age. After the war, Evola wrote a book criticizing the Fascist state from perspective of the one and only Right, that is, of Tradition. In his essay on cultural Marxism, Evola points out that the founder of Dadaism, **Tristan Tzara**, was a Jew. What difference does that make when Evola himself had participated in and promoted that movement. Or that **Schoenberg** and **Stravinski** were Jews, when death or other metal music is equally lacking in melodic elements. To persist in perpetuating that war will lead only to being blind to the real issues.

Nietzsche wrote somewhere that the errors of great thinkers are of more value than the truths of lesser thinkers. This applies to Evola. If we follow and grasp his thought process, we can gain something, but simply repeating his conclusions or views on contemporary topics of interest will lead to not very much.

The Palace of Wisdom

> No bird soars too high, if he soars with his own wings.
>
> William Blake, *Proverbs of Hell*

Although Guenon was early in his life involved with Hermetism[8], he later criticized it on the grounds that it was only a cosmological doctrine. Besides, he added, it could not be a valid tradition since it served as the basis of paganism, Christianity, and Islam. To the contrary. That argument has value only on the assumption of multiple traditions that arose independently. Yet that is not our position so that the ubiquity of Hermetism demonstrates its value. It is the depth behind western traditions, as we have written many times on Gornahoor.

Hermetism presupposes Traditional metaphysics so there is no contradiction. The Hermetist sees no point in the battle today between paganism and Christianity, properly understood, and regards it as a waste of time. Hermetists of any exoteric path are united in their depth not on superficial allegiances. It can draw on the insights of the Vedanta and Buddhism. It is a system of nobility and power. With its complete cosmology it exceeds Oriental systems because it acknowledges the multiple states of being, states far beyond the yogic realization of the Self.

Posted on 2011-08-23 by Cologero

* * *

Perennial on 2011-08-23 at 02:12 said:

Incredible article! Clears up a lot of the nonsense I see going around, and fits right in with Guenon and the others in their insistence on not mixing traditions. The exoteric traditions must not be confused with Tradition...

fa on 2011-09-02 at 09:57 said:

"Or that Schoenberg and Stravinski were Jews" hm... = I was never a Jew (Stravinski)

http://andron.sitecity.ru/ltext_3101202117.phtml?p_ident=ltext_3101202117.p_3101211231

Cologero on 2011-09-02 at 10:07 said:

[8] https://gornahoor.net/index.php?s=Hermetism&submit=Search

I suppose, then, that Evola was misinformed. It's a moot point anyway, since after WWII Evola abandoned the anti-semitism that had so motivated him in the 1930s. In his later life, he was even proud of his Dada "period", a movement he had at one time condemned as being too "Jewish".

`Mr. Fopdoodle on 2017-08-23 at 01:47 said:`

"With its complete cosmology it exceeds Oriental systems because it acknowledges the multiple states of being, states far beyond the yogic realization of the Self."

Can you elaborate on this? I thought the realization of the unconditioned Self was the end all be all of the spiritual quest–there's nothing higher. If you do this then you're a jivanmukta and there's nothing more to attain, you're finished–you've "laid down your burden" and did what had to be done.

But apparently there's more?

12.8 It's up to you

> Westerners, including even those who were true metaphysicians up to a certain point, have never known metaphysic in its entirety... Westerners have little natural aptitude for metaphysics

Here **Rene Guenon** shows a uncharacteristic sort of racist thought, since that is hardly a metaphysical proposition, but rather an empirical assertion with little evidence. Guenon never anticipated how quickly the once traditional civilisations of China and India devolved. The former became radically materialist and Marxist, while the latter is rapidly being Westernized and liberalised.

Guenon does concede that the West did have metaphysical knowledge in neo-Platonism[9] and in the theology of the Egyptian fathers[10]. Rather, the West couched metaphysical principles in theological and philosophical language. Furthermore, in his later writings Guenon reversed

[9] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=2842`

[10] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=501`

himself, admitting the evidence of metaphysical knowledge among the circle of Dante and even Masonry. A fundamentalist reading of Guenon would lead to despair about recovering tradition in the West, yet on metaphysical principles, such an empirical assertion is unprovable.

> Nevertheless there may have been individual exceptions among Westerners , for **nothing in principle precludes the existence, at any period or in any country, of men capable of attaining to complete metaphysical knowledge**; and this would even be possible in the present Western world

In order to grasp the significance of this passage, it is necessary to distinguish between *principle* and *practice*. As a matter of principle, nothing contingent, accidental, empirical, or historical can prevent a Western man from attaining to complete metaphysical knowledge. Specifically, that means that belonging to one of the "approved" traditions is not necessary, nor is study under a guru nor a "valid" initiation (as though anyone without understanding would even be capable of making that distinction). Now, as a matter of practice, a body of tradition, a spiritual guide, and an initiation may be immensely helpful and the more common path; nevertheless, as a matter of principle, they are neither necessary nor sufficient.

A further point that must be made is that, from a metaphysical perspective, time has no meaning. In particular, time can never be a causative agent. Thus, whether a man is enlightened in an instant, over the course of a long period of study and practice, or even through multiple lifetimes in different states of being, is of no import in principle. However, in practice, efforts are usually necessary. Guenon explicitly admits such possibilities:

> it is only right to point out that if such exceptions ever did exist, no written evidence has been found to prove it, nor do the generally

> known facts reveal traces of their influence; this absence of direct evidence however proves nothing in a negative sens, not should it occasion any surprise, for if cases of this sort did in fact occur, it can only have been thanks to very special circumstances of a nature that we cannot profitably discuss here.

A major fault of Westerners is a competitive nature, which spills over into areas where it does not belong. Thus, we see some readers trying to be the "king of the Traditional hill"; I can assure them it is not worth the trouble, since it is a small hill indeed. Gornahoor has no interest in a mindless repetition of texts, nor in historical research of the comparative religion type, which is infecting the study of Tradition. Rather, we are aiming for a restatement of Tradition in contemporary terms, which is really the only demonstration of understanding. The purpose is to awaken in young men the desire to recover Tradition, in a new way, not as a blind devotion to the past, and most certainly not as a call to follow the traditions of Asians. In our present situation, it is up to each man to find his own way. As Guenon writes:

> It is for each man to try and conceive it according to the extent of his own intellectual powers, making good, in proportion to his success, the unavoidable deficiencies of formal and limited expression.

All quotes from **Rene Guenon**, *Introduction to the Study of Hindu Doctrines*.

Posted on 2011-10-24 by Cologero

12.9 Prolegomena to any Future Tradition

As a thought experiment, we shall attempt, in several posts, to specify the characteristics of what Tradition in the West will have to look like, based

on the 400+ preceding posts. In particular, we will look at the following elements:

1. Foundation
2. External structure
3. Internal Structure
4. Practical Dualism

These characteristics will be looked at from the point of view of a spiritual race. Features based on biological or psychic race are not part of this consideration, since they are contingent and arbitrary. Specifically, the originary races no longer exist as such, due first of all to migrations and secondly because the race of the soul alters over time.

Foundation A tradition always has a divine or supernatural founder who is its lawgiver and formative spirit. Thus any and all attempts to build on merely human thought forms are destined to fall short. This divine person reveals the cosmic law and is the unifying factor among the various segments of the members of the tradition.

External Structure The external structure follows the divine plan. There must be a spiritual authority that understands, interprets, and teaches the revealed law. Beneath that is the temporal power that implements the law for the benefit of all, justly, according to the merits and needs of the members. A producing segment provides for the economic well-being of the group. This requires a caste based system of the regal-spiritual caste, a warrior caste, and a productive caste. An Internet comment brought to our attention claims that "Gornahoor loves castes". It is not a question of "loving" castes for their own sake, but rather a love for the revelation of cosmic law. A caste system is the simple recognition

that people have different talents and interests and thus need a place in society where they fit in. The opposite of this is so-called egalitarianism, which is never such in practice since some will attempt to gain power by unprincipled means based on money or mere physical prowess.

Internal Structure Men will understand and experience themselves as threefold beings: spirit, soul, and body. The soul and body are natural elements, irreducible to each other, while the spirit is transcendent. The spirit, or rational soul, understands the external and internal structures directly and intuitively, without the intermediary of discursive thought.

Practical Dualism Men learn to fight the greater and lesser battles, the former for their individual souls, the latter for each other. Every man capable engages in this battle in his own consciousness, siding with the forces of the cosmos against those of chaos. He must learn to assert the primacy of the spirit over the soul, and the soul over the body. His tools are meditation, prayer, rites, sacraments, clairvoyant vision, hence this can never be reduced to a mere system of thought. We call this practical dualism, since it is part of this experience, although it is not a real dualism. Chaos had no independent existence, but as long as we experience is as resistance, it is a privation, not a thing in itself.

To be victorious, a man must know how to think, how to fast, and how to wait. While instrumental and logical thought have their place, man must, however, learn again how to think. Discursive thought, with each thought connected to another, creates a tight web, like chain-mail, that obscures the light of Being. Thoughts need to come in isolation and understood more as acts of perception rather than as a secondary experience of being.

While caloric fasting leads to loner physical life, mind fasting is the path to eternal life. Thus, the first trial is to purge the mind of opinions, beliefs, theories, unexamined assumptions that are connected together

in the flow of consciousness. When freed of this lower mind, then the mind of spirit can gain gnosis, a direct intuition of the world of ideas. Man must also fast from the stories he uses to organize his life. Habitual ways of looking at the world, repeated tales of wrong doings, injustices, excuses, and justifications are dropped in the mind fast.

Then there is the waiting. When the mind is freed of false ideas and emotional perturbations, in can act as a perfect reflector of the Spirit, allowing it to come into consciousness. There is no technology for this, no technique, no drug, no practice, no gene, no new theory, no weekend seminar, no new age "mind treatment".

Posted on 2011-09-26 by Cologero

12.10 On Lacking Credentials

You know when the living thought of a writer becomes fossilized when it turns into text for use by academics, particularly those who find it necessary to boast about their credentials[11] before speaking.

I would like to remind visitors that Evola refused to accept a degree in engineering, because he did not want approval from the system. He had no credentials in philosophy, religion or politics. His German was self-taught, in order to read 19th century German philosophy.

He had no expertise in Asian languages. He read Hindu and Buddhist texts in translations. He even commented on them, apparently something an academic would not dare do. Neither Guenon nor Evola would be considered for an academic post anywhere, nor would their writings meet the standards for inclusion in academic journals.

The question about Guenon's conversion to Islam is dealt with in *Did Guenon convert?*[12]. He did not believe that there was a valid initiatory

[11] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=369`

[12] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=262`

tradition in the West; that is why he became a Sufi.

The difference in Guenon's and Evola's relationship to current political issues is dealt with here[13]. This does not mean that Guenon was effeminate, nor that his positions do not have political consequences.

The Yoga that Evola wrote about was based on the Hindu Tantric writings, not what is commonly made available in the West. Guenon wrote about the Vedas and did not regard the Tantras as orthodox.

Evola considered ancient India to be an Aryan civilization, hence he considered their religious scriptures as part of Western heritage. Nowadays, the so-called Aryan Invasion Theory is not so popular (among "academics"), but both Guenon and Evola accepted it as true. But the real question is: are the spiritual teachings of ancient Buddhism, the Vedas, and the Tantras alien to the Western spirit or not? Of course, this presupposes that one understands the Western spirit. That cannot be learned from books, but only through one's own personal spiritual development.

Evola never advocated a return to the ancient pagan beliefs of Europe, whether Greek, Roman, or Germanic. It was more a state of mind that he endorsed, particularly as found in the mystery cults. Furthermore, he never promoted "polytheism", a metaphysical absurdity, if it implies the denial of a single fundamental reality. Rather his thought ran more along the lines of Herman Wirth[14]. His position was actually closer to atheism, as God could only be realized in the Absolute man.

I remind everyone that to be "Traditional" requires a direct knowledge and understanding of metaphysical principles, and this comes not from academic achievement, but rather from self-development. Although the applications of principles to concrete situations may be subjects for discussion, the principles themselves are immutable and not open to debate.

Posted on 2010-04-13 by Cologero

[13] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=273`

[14] `https://gornahoor.net/library/UltimaThule.pdf`

* * *

Dart on 2015-12-19 at 12:48 said:

"Guenon wrote about the Vedas and did not regard the Tantras as orthodox."

In "Studies in Hinduism," (chapters 7 & 8) Guenon refers to Tantra as an orthodox viewpoint, and even says it is particularly suited to the Kali Yuga. But he warns of falling into the error of seeing magic as an end in itself rather than as a support for realization (as does Evola iirc).

Cologero on 2020-04-13 at 20:01 said:

Thanks, Dart. Guenon views the Tantras as an extension of the Vedas. BTW, Wolfgang Smith also views the Tantras as orthodox.

12.11 Tradition and Traditionalism

A movement called "traditionalism" is apparently the "very next phase", so it becomes necessary to periodically engage in the distasteful task of polemics and critique. The problem arises because "traditionalists" are making the claim that their "traditionalism" is based on the thought of Julius Evola and Rene Guenon.

I realize that Evola is more accessible than Guenon since he writes about trends and politics, but it cannot be emphasized strongly enough that understanding Evola depends on understanding Guenon, despite the sharp differences in certain areas between them. Guenon's writings are more difficult and do not lend themselves readily to short Internet commentaries or radio interviews. Moreover, reading Guenon is not an intellectual exercise, but a spiritual exercise that demands a true metanoia in order to be grasped in their fullness.

Now, one of the foundational works of Guenon, which is mandatory reading for anyone working toward the recovery of Tradition, is *The Reign of Quantity and the Signs of the Times*. Lo and behold, Chapter XXXI is titled "Tradition and Traditionalism" and it deals directly with the peculiar manifestations we see happening in our midst, viz., the misuse of the term "traditionalism". Since this book is so readily available

and well-known, it is difficult to avoid the conclusion that it is deliberate rather than accidental. Guenon writes:

> ... words are applied to things which they do not fit in any way, and sometimes in a sense directly opposed to their normal meaning. This is one of the most obvious symptoms of the intellectual confusion which reigns everywhere in the present world; but it must not be forgotten that *this very confusion is willed by that which lies hidden behind the whole modern deviation*.

Although Guenon concedes the good faith of those involved, he adds:

> Nevertheless it must also be recognized that such errors of interpretation and involuntary misconceptions serve the purpose of certain plans so well that is it permissible to wonder whether their growing diffusion may not be due to some of the suggestions that dominate the modern mentality, all of which lead ultimately to nothing less than the destruction of all that is tradition in the true sense of the word.

"The modern mentality is no more than the product of a vast collective suggestion", but there may come a time where the "resulting state of disorder and disequilibrium becomes so apparent that some people cannot fail to become aware it." Unfortunately, Guenon explains:

> The very idea of tradition has been destroyed to such an extent that those who aspire to recover it no longer know which way to turn, and are only too ready to accept all the false ideas presented to them in its place and under its name. ... People described as Traditionalists ... only have a sort of tendency or aspiration towards tradition without really knowing anything at all about it; this is the measure of the distance dividing the "traditionalist" spirit from the truly traditional spirit, for the latter implies a real knowledge, and indeed in a sense it is the same as that knowledge.

> In short, the "traditionalist" is and can be no more than a mere "seeker", and that is why he is always in danger of going astray, not being in possession of the principles which alone could provide him with infallible guidance; and his danger is all the greater because he will find in his path, like so many ambushes, all the false ideas set on foot by the power of illusion which has a capital interest in preventing him from reaching the true goal of his search.

In *Crisis of the Modern World*, Guenon mentions the diabolical and satanic spirits that are preventing the cohesion of those dedicated to Tradition. One of the tactics of the adversary is the misdirection mentioned above, that is, the falsification of the true meaning of words. It is interesting that the self-designated leaders of something called "radical traditionalism" boast about their intentions to "seduce" young men with flashy web sites and multimedia broadcasts in order to build a mass movement. We, on the other hand, are only trying to influence just the precious few who are interested in sound doctrine. Think hard, young men, and be prudent before committing your life.

Vincit omnia Veritas

Posted on 2010-04-15 by Cologero

* * *

K. L. Anderson on 2010-04-16 at 16:22 said:

I would suggest being prudent about Traditionalism itself, which we think blocks the true Outward Path to Godhood of biological evolution, although as strictly an Inward Path it can be useful.

http://civilizingthebeast.blogspot.com/

Cologero on 2010-04-17 at 17:32 said:

First all, we are not only prudent about Traditionalism, but you should have noticed that we reject the very concept itself as anything meaningful.

Second, what is possibly meant by the path to Godhood of biological evolution? Evolution is non-teleological, hence there is no path, no goal.

Third, it is genetic. What is the gene for Godhood?

This is Ahrimanic influcence gone amuck ... test the spirits before you adopt such a theory.

K. L. Anderson on 2010-04-18 at 14:05 said:

I commented on your blog entry because I felt that if you have the courage to affirm Evola in this age (although it seems to be the thing to do now days) you may have the courage to affirm something of my view of things.

You are so certain that evolution is non-teleological. I disagree, it is teleological, science, tradition and religion missed on this one.

Godhood is epiphenomenal (not transcendent in this sense) and I assume the "genes" for Godhood would be epiphenomenal as well.

Test the Spirits? How do you know I have not? Ahriman may not be the entity you think it is. You need to civilize the beast of materialism, not try to kill it, especially if the material world is the vehicle required in our evolution to Godhood.

I am suggesting a revitalized religion, it does not only look back to Hyperboria, rejecting the modern world, yet it still uses the ancient Inward Path that Evola affirmed. The best of both worlds.

Cologero on 2010-04-19 at 18:28 said:

It is not a question of whether I have the courage to affirm something of your view of things, but rather the intelligence.

You do have a certain insight, unfortunately it is partial and incomplete, compounded by your inability to express it coherently.

I am not "certain" that evolution is non-teleoligical (did I ever use that word?) ... as you mention, science considers it such, so I was assuming the conventional understanding of evolution. If you want to use words in your own private manner, how am I to anticipate that? Furthermore, you claim that, although science and religion got it wrong, you somehow got it right, without specifying why or how.

To summarize your "view": the world-process is immanent in biological evolution and its teleological goal is God.

First of all, for a process to have a goal, there must be something transcendent to the process to define the goal and direct the process towards it.

To wit, your very existence is part of the world process, yet you claim to know the ending well in advance. In other words, you claim to understand the "idea" of the world process. That is

the nub: the idea is transcendent, it is not biological (your point about epiphenomenal genes is nonsensical.)

The world process, actually the World Soul, is not and can never be God or the Absolute. Yet they are related. I will leave you with a short quote from Solovyov which makes the point as clearly as it can be made:

"In the divine order the all is an absolute organism eternally, while according to the law of natural being, the all gradually becomes an absolute organism in time."

If that is what you mean, it is a brilliant insight.

K. L. Anderson on 2010-04-20 at 12:01 said:

I like your quote by Solovyov. But I don't see the "all" exactly that way. Do you really think I have an inability to express these very difficult things coherently? I think I make things very clear. Perhaps today's blog entry below will help, perhaps not.

Transforming The Tiger

The Holy Spirit, which activates the material world in conjunction with evolution, wants the entire world to evolve to Godhood (the Spirit is the Will to Godhood after all) but this does not always happen at the same time. The force of devolution (the force of Satan) pulls the material world toward the Great Black Holes of a given universe (in a multiverse of universes it now seems) and it is this devolutionary force that the Spirit "combats" against.

Evola used the term "riding the tiger" in suggesting how Traditionalists might deal with the decadent modern world, meaning a way to transform destructive processes into inner liberation. This is the Involutionary Inward Path to the Soul Within, but this is not how I apply the term tiger. I affirm the Twofold Path.

The Spirit affirms the Evolutionary Outward Path of material evolution, which is the vehicle required to reach Godhood. The Spirit does not so much ride the tiger as help transform the tiger from devolution to evolution. The danger in defining liberation as only inner liberation, the goal of the Inward Path, is that it blocks the evolution of the material world to Godhood in what we call the Great Spiritual Blockade.

http://civilizingthebeast.blogspot.com/2010/04/transforming-tiger.html

Cologero on 2010-04-26 at 22:00 said:

There is no innovation in metaphysics. Perhaps it can be said better, adapted to different situations, connections made, but as for novelty, no. So what are you trying to express?

First you say it is all biological, natural and material: a process that is necessarily blind and pointless. Then you introduce the "Holy Spirit" which changes everything. Either the spirit dominates matter or the reverse. If the reverse, the lesser cannot "evolve" into the higher. Out of what? The higher had to be virtual from the beginning. So the "goal of the Inward Path" is to

develop the Soul Power, the Will, to actualize the Logos in the material process. Matter cannot create the soul out of itself, not organize itself.

As for the all, there are no two ways to conceptualize it: it is Absolute and Infinite, otherwise it is not "All".

K. L. Anderson on 2010-04-27 at 12:47 said:

To respond in order to your statements:

Spirit IS matter, but the highest epiphenomenal matter, it "dominates" matter in that it can also be defined as the Will To Godhood, so there is no need for a duality here. And, again, evolution is not "blind and pointless." The lesser CAN evolve into the higher, just as the child grows to be a man. The Logos is definition or principle only, which is less than the Object God which the Logos defines. It is time to affirm the real thing, not merely the definition of the real thing. Matter CAN create the Spirit and Soul out of itself if the matter is the highest evolved matter, which is Godhood.

Who says "there is no innovation in metaphysics?" Perhaps not in the religions that stem from the Perennial Tradition, which you cling to, but they are all of the Involutionary Inward Path. The "innovation" in metaphysics come from the Evolutionary Outward Path, which is really a recognition of the sacred direction of evolution.

Cologero on 2010-04-27 at 22:46 said:

I'm afraid the discussion has come to and end. This is what I mean by incoherence: "Spirit is matter" is meaningless equation, as spirit is conscious and matter is unconscious. Do you even understand what "epiphenomenon" means? You can't simply "define" it to mean Will; that is something that needs to be demonstrated. The rest is nonsense, I'm sorry to have to put it that way. I'm sure you have an insight somewhere, but I suggest you pay attention to those who have trod the path before you. I'm trying to save you years of a wasted life.

As for your total dependence on matter ... that is a Satanic notion and you have given in to Christ's first temptation in the desert:

"And the tempter coming said to him: If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread."

Your stones (matter) cannot be made into the bread of life. Think carefully about the direction your ideas are taking you.

F.A. Mercuri on 2010-04-29 at 04:48 said:

The example of a male child growing into a man does not negate the metaphysical teaching that the "lesser can not generate the greater". The case of the child reaching maturity (and old age), is not the lesser producing the greater; rather, demonstrating the completion of a cycle or process that already contains within itself the possibilities of that completion. The child and

the adult man are really the same thing all along, in their essence: a human male. That which changes in the human maturation process are the accidents, while the essence remains the same, from cradle to grave, and moreover, within that essence are already contained the gamut of all possible changes that the accidents might undergo–so, this lesser is not generating anything greater or beyond what the essence has already determined as a series of possibilities unfolding within the context of the laws governing the corporeal state (primarily time, space, and motion).

Paul wrote that, "Now this I say Brothers, that flesh and blood cannot inherit the Kingdom of God; neither does corruption inherit incorruption" I Corinthians 15:50. Again, the essence of the corporeality does not contain the possibilities of "evolving" out of it anything other than that which it is, or contains; however, the Western Tradition depicts man as a tripartite being, the corporeal (soma) representing but one of the modalities of the integral human–consequently, the possibilities of "evolving" (beyond the human state) are found within the (regenerated) essence of the psychic, and then noetic "bodies" of man–it is the Nous, as a "ray" of Logos, which lastly bridges the chasm between the transcendent and imminent, when refined by metanoia, that is, the transformation (regeneration) of the Nous.

Paul continues "We shall not all sleep, but be changed" (supra 15:51), at the Resurrection. This corporeality alone is not responsible for the production of the "spiritual body", but by the former "putting on" incorruptibility which "changes" it–implying that this incorruptibility comes from a different source, a superhuman source. Grace working in tandem with human aspiration engender this "Anothen", or "Birth from Above"; the human component beginning with diskarsis, apatheia, and reaching the metanoia–all necessary, due to the fact that natural mans' psychic and noetic faculties are in a degenerated, or "fallen" condition.

The Hermetic Tradition also sheds light on this problem. The Salt never singularly has any power of its own to effect a self-transmutation–instead, it is by the action of an initially separated and purified Mercury and Sulfur, then acting upon the Salt, that the Salt then "evolves".

K. L. Anderson on 2010-04-29 at 11:15 said:

It is perhaps good that you have stopped my attempt to communicate with you. You have called me satanic, unintelligent, full of nonsense, etc... You are not very friendly. I suppose your version of religion does not include being a gentleman to those you define as satanic. That's a sociobiological example of the insider dealing with the outsider, but then, you virtually dismiss biology in your elaborate rationalizations of spirituality versus materiality. So be it. We will see what the future brings.

Cologero on 2010-04-29 at 17:44 said:

Mr. Anderson,

I haven't said anything negative or insulting about you personally.

I mentioned that equating spirit and matter is incoherent and the idea that the "lesser can evolve to the higher" is nonsense.

I mentioned that world views depending solely on matter is a satanic theory. That is hardly the same as calling you "Satanic".

As for you personally, I suggested that you may have an insight, but it needs to be devoloped properly. You need to learn to separate your personality from your theories.

I also mentioned Solovyov who devoted an entire book to the relationship between Spirit and the world process. He has thought the thing through quite deeply and I suggest you take his work into account. I am far from dismissing biology; to the contrary, I value the integral personality who can integrate spirit, soul, and body into a coherent whole. Understanding the proper relationship betwen Spirit and biology (matter) is hardly tantamount to dismissing the latter.

Unfotrunately, there is no possibility of discussion with anyone who denies any difference between spirit and matter. That is the point.

If I am the unconscious puppet of sociobiology, then so are you. That is the dead end where your theory leads.

12.12 Three Amigos

We recently mentioned Guenon's role in bring awareness of Tradition to the West, but there are two other very important figures: Ananda Kentish Coomaraswamy (AKC) and Julius Evola. Operating on three different continents, they kept in contact with Guenon via post, exchanging letters and even books. That was the precursor of the Internet, in bring together the scattered remnant of Tradition, spiritually and intellectually, if not physically. Both men were accomplished thinkers in their own right, but their respective encounters with Guenon were transformative and heavily influenced their own writings.

There are some who would exclude Evola as a Traditional writer, but the other two did not see it that way. AKC wrote a favourable review of Julius Evola's *Revolt Against the Modern World*, which was published in the Feb-Apr 1940 edition of *The Visva-Bharati Quarterly* and included an English translation of the chapter "Man and Woman". Guenon him-

self reviewed several of Evola's works.

There are clearly differences in interests and interpretations among the three authors, which Evola would attribute to differences in the "personal equation". However, these differences could never be over metaphysical principles, but rather differences in the interpretation of contingent historical events. For example, there were disagreements over the Traditional characteristics of Hermeticism or Buddhism, but in the latter case, Guenon was later to alter his opinion.

AKC was an enormously erudite man and his contributions not just in metaphysics, but also in traditional art, crafts, folklore and mythology are important to anyone not just seeking to understand Tradition abstractly, but also in its potential applications. Similarly, Evola's interests were in the forgotten Traditions of the West, whose characteristics he sought to reconstruct from the analysis of myths, sagas, and legends. He also applied his understanding of Tradition to current political and cultural events.

Another important difference is that whereas Guenon eventually opted to live within a specific tradition (Sufism), AKC and Evola were those rare men who could live outside tradition and caste.

Posted on 2010-07-21 by Cologero

* * *

`EXIT on 2010-07-21 at 20:47 said:`
How come you never mention Frithjof Schuon?

`Cologero on 2010-07-21 at 21:21 said:`
Perhaps he plays the role of d'Artagnan? Although in correspondence for many years with Guenon, Schuon was younger then the others and his most influential works appeared after the ground had been prepared by the others.

At the moment, Schuon is outside the direct interest of Gornahoor, although his works merit close study. Perhaps at a future date.

James O'Meara on 2010-10-06 at 15:56 said:

Speaking of Traditionalists who lived "outside tradition and caste" reminds me of a strangely neglected Traditionalist, Alain Danielou. By 'neglected' I mean discussed, since Inner Traditions keeps most of his books in print, but you seldom see anyone refer to him [outside of his Kama Sutra translation].

And yet Danielou is the only Traditionalist outside Guenon who really lived in a Traditional culture, traveling in India with his lover in a silver house trailer for many years, long before he knew of Guenon. Ironically, he points out that as a Westerner he was an out-caste, and therefore no one cared about his 'out' lifestyle! Despite this, he immersed himself in Traditional culture, leaning Sanskrit and even becoming a Shaivite initiate.

His importance: due to this background, when he did discover Guenon's work, he was able to independently verify the truth of Guenon's assertions about Indian thought.

Another irony: Guenon actually wanted to live in India, and only remained in Cairo because the British, on the eve of the war, wouldn't provide a visa. And Danielou, whose family had ties to the diplomatic corps, tried to get him into French India [whre he could have met Aurobindo!] but to no avail. How different would the whole "Traditionalist" movement be, if the over-emphasis on Islam as "the last revelation" had been short-circuited?

Cologero on 2010-10-07 at 01:02 said:

I'm not sure about that Guenon story. He gives as a reason for selecting Islam over Hinduism what you said: in India he would always be an out-caste, and not part of that Tradition. When I get some time, I'll look for the reference.

I have posted on the blog how Guenon described his "conversion", which was not such in any common use of the word. He may have accepted Islam as the last revelation, but not as any "truer" than other revelations.

BTW, he regarded Aurobindo as not Traditional.

James O'Meara on 2010-10-07 at 18:25 said:

Looking at the passage again

http://books.google.com/books?id=GCOewSVrf2sC&printsec=frontcover&dq=danielou+labyrinth&source=bl&ots=ZzusC8FF9S&sig=vox1ybEpTW-RAURzsaiZl0fJ4O4&hl=en&ei=DUWuTLeIMIT6lwev0anjBA&sa=X&oi=book_result&ct=result&resnum=1&ved=0CBUQ6AEwAA#v=onepage&q=guenon&f=false

I may have given a misleading impression of it. D. talks about Guenon "settling" in Egypt, not of his conversion to Islam. Obviously, he could have lived as a Moslem in India as well! Given his rather Indian POV, due to his teachers, and "transcendent" POV, he may have been initially more attracted to India as a place of residence. D.'s point though is that living in Egypt prevented

him from contacting living centers of pre-Aryan tradition, such as his own Shaivism. And my speculation is I think still related to that; how different the "atmosphere" of Traditionalism [to say nothing of the "Guenonian Scholasticism" Evola mocked] if he had been in a more ethnically diverse culture. The example of D. himself makes questionable the strong implication from the later Traditionalists that modern, Western man is "uniquely" suited for Islam as opposed to Hinduism, for example, although even D. admits the traditional world he entered is no more.

kadambari on 2010-10-07 at 23:12 said:

"in India he would always be an out-caste, and not part of that Tradition."

Ha ha that's funny and quite ridiculous he felt like that. There was a famous missionary in Himanchal, India, who introduced the famous apples found there, who initially sought to convert the natives, but then just married locally and became a Hindu instead! I think Hinduism is large enough for Guenon not to feel an outcaste, and it seems a personal choice. Also I find it odd intellectually that anyone can embrace Isalm reading that book cover to cover by choice! Guenon would have been better off as a Christian considering all the Sufi mysticism (perhaps the only intellectual component of the religion) is just Aryan Persian mysticism (pre-Islamic i. e. Zoroastrian) creeping into Isalm (which was forcibly imposed upon a mystical peoples like the Persians after Arab conquest) combined with Buddhist/HIndu/ influence. I find not a single original neuron in it. Sufism is every bit Persian and not Islamic. Still I have yet to read Guenon!

kadambari on 2010-10-07 at 23:29 said:

The missionary was Graham Stokes, they made him a Brahmin out of respect for him, as he was intelligent. His daughter is active in Himanchal parliament otday, the hill state being almost completely Hindu is one of the most pleasant states left in India. He introduced the golden delicious apples to Himanchal.

kadambari on 2010-10-08 at 00:09 said:

Sorry, his first name was Samuel Evans Stoles not Graham Stokes. He is somewhat of a legend in Himanchal, and to be precise the apples were red delicious. Anyway, he was later known as Stayanand Stokes.

Guenon must have had some other motive for converting to Islam, perhaps he was drawn to it as it is a semitic faith much closer to Christianity its brother and is completely at odds with Hinduism. Anyway, after his conversion, I guess he must stuck to it if his conversion was genuine, as apostasy in Islam is a crime in that religion.

James O'Meara on 2010-10-08 at 09:05 said:

Kadambari,

It's not a question of "becoming Hindu" but what role a Westerner could play in traditional society. According to D.

they would be of the lowest caste. D. could learn the Vedas but not recite them [presumably in public]; contrarywise, his Brahmin teachers could not even look at him, and he had to listen from a concealed place. Hard to imagine RG putting up with that, although just the sort of thing he would promote as "traditional social structure'. perhaps!

D. eventually sank to the level of outcast, not because of his relations with his lover, Raymond, but because Raymond married a Brahmin wife, a theosophist to boot! In the decadent West, of course, it would be the other way around, and Raymond would be socially redeemed by marriage to anyone.

Your remarks on Sufism are very interesting. Despite the happy talk promoted by H. Smith, for example, RG never taught that there was some esoteric "core" to every "religion." In China, C. and T. are quite separate traditions, while the Semitic religions ['religion' as such being only in the West] seem to have "hidden" cores; Islam was sort of mid-way, and he spoke of "Islamic esotericism" rather than "Esoteric Islam."

It's hard to see anything 'intellectual' in Islam, or the other Semetic faiths; think of all the nonsense about "koshering" this or that. Your reference to apostasy as a 'crime' for example; social regulation posing as 'wisdom.' F. Schuon and his school have been taken to task for misleading Westerners by presenting as "Islam" what only pertains to Sufism, and a peculiar brand at that.

I've always thought Sufism was derived from Neoplatonism, via the other Greek wisdom Islam assimilated, but I'm just an amateur. Your Aryan connection through Persia is intriguing; can you recommend anything on that?

Matt on 2010-10-18 at 14:17 said:

I won't get too much into this because I realize that the intent of this site is to speak of metaphysics and pure principles, but I do share the sentiments of James and kadambari. I think it can be too easy to just accept every major religion on the basis of a unity at the metaphysical level and not point out the serious problems of a supposed tradition at the contingent level. This can also lead to many in the self described traditionalist movement to not pose the legitimate question of whether features of a religion conforming to Tradition came from within, or were placed on it from the outside (a question that seemed to only be taken into account with seriousness by Evola). And yes, Schuon and his followers are particularly guilty of all this.

I've always found it funny that Evola became such a black sheep to the perennial movement because of certain political associations he had for a period of his life, and yet Schuon is held up as some type of avatar for the movement when he indulged in what seems to be the cardinal sin in the movement, mixing traditional forms together. At least Evola realized the mistake he made in getting into politics, and never thought of himself as some figure destined to create a universal multicultural esoteric church.

12.13 The Great Divide and our Ownmost

In *The Hermetic Tradition*, **Julius Evola** mentions two competing views of history:

1. History is the continuous upward evolution of collective humanity.

2. Civilizations arise, mature and die in a series of epochs and disconnected cycles.

The first, he rejects out of hand. The second has some merit yet is inadequate. When making distinctions or categorizing, we need to take care to determine whether the category is real or just an abstraction. The second view, whose premier representative is Oswald Spengler, is an abstraction. That is, it is a mental construct derived from contingent and empirical factors by abstracting out common elements. An abstraction may be useful or convenient for a given purpose, but it is an error when taken as a real category. When this is forgotten, the result will be unclear thinking and the perpetuation of ignorance.

Standing firmly on Rene Guenon's groundbreaking work, *The Crisis of the Modern World*, Evola then makes the distinction between the modern world and the world of Tradition. This distinction is a real metaphysical category as opposed to a mental construct or abstraction. Evola is very precise:

> *for the West, we can put the dividing line at the end of the Middle Ages.*

For the Traditional man in the West, therefore, what is "ours" comprises the Vedic civilization, the ancient Hellenic, Roman and Germanic civilizations and the Medieval civilization. Any attempt to draw the line elsewhere, or to split and oppose those civilizations can be based only on artificial, arbitrary, incomplete and misleading considerations. In particular, the Hermetic Tradition draws on elements from the entirety of those Traditional civilizations; hence it cannot be understood apart from all of them. The failure to embrace the Traditional worldview in its entirety can only lead to confusion. Evola explains:

> Who undertakes this study of alchemy and Hermetism without having acquired the ability to rise above the modern mind-set or who has not awakened to a new sensitivity that can place itself in contact with the general spiritual stream that gave life to the tradition in the first place, will succeed only in filing his head with words, symbols, and fantastic allegories.
>
> *The heart of the matter is to re-evoke, by means of an actual transformation of consciousness, the older Traditional basis of understanding and action.*

For those of us today, for whom the world of Tradition may still be a dim memory struggling to come to full light, whom do we look to for guidance, who are our "own"? Besides the Hermetic Tradition and the other figures mentioned in Gornahoor, Evola singles out specifically **Plotinus** and **Patanjali** for their metaphysical writings. In his *Saggi sull'Idealismo Magico*, Evola lists as the examples for his philosophical system:

> The "I", the "pure act" would appear as that cosmic centrality that the esoteric indicates, as examples, the type of the *rishi*, the *yogi*, the **Christ**, and the **Buddha**.

Posted on 2011-04-19 by Cologero

* * *

Mr.Skull on 2011-04-20 at 10:09 said:

1. What is a 'real' category, and how do we reckon it's real? Do we not turn to empirical and contingent factors in reality in order to prove it to be 'in reality', in either static or continuous occurrence?

2. Aren't categories, be them real or unreal, "a mental construct derived from contingent and empirical factors by abstracting out common elements"?

3. I don't see how Evola PROVED Spengler's model to be "unreal" or "an abstraction", to use his own words (or your interpretation). Disproving Spengler's model doesn't end by claiming it is an abstraction, one's has to show why it's an abstraction or "unreal" or "does not correlate with reality".

4. Since Evola did not prove Spengler to be wrong, as far as I can tell "An abstraction may be useful or convenient for a given purpose, but it is an error when taken as a real category." can be applied to the claim: "For the TRADITIONAL man in the West, therefore, what is "ours" comprises the Vedic civilization, the ancient Hellenic, Roman and Germanic civilizations and the Medieval civilization."

I'm no expert on traditionalism, but I've read Evola and Guenon. I enjoyed both writers. Nevertheless, while they do raise some interesting points, they too are entangled within their own verbal 'abstractions'.

Cologero on 2011-04-20 at 13:00 said:

Nothing in the article said Spengler was "wrong", just that it is a theory abstracted from empirical facts. If we take it as absolute, then, because of the discontinuity, then the ancient civilizations can have no relationship to each other, even less so to the modern world. That we reject – see *The Archeology of the Soul*.

"Real" categories are based on eternal ideas, not derived from empirical and contingent considerations. We have referred many times to the cosmic order.

Metaphysical concepts are valid always and everywhere, independent of the physical world. To the contrary, the physical world depends on the metaphysical. So they are the polar opposite of a mental abstraction which are products of thought. Metaphysical concepts depend on a higher form of knowing, discussed her many times. Do a search on gnosis, intuition or episteme.

Graham on 2011-04-20 at 13:35 said:

Mr. Skull,

http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1737

Pay attention to the distinctions between wholes and heaps, and the definitions of the real and the conventional. Tradition is a conventional term used to designate a whole, while Speng-

lerism is a heap, and nothing but. Wholes cannot be reached by analysis; analysis produces heaps. A heap can be useful, and even conditionally true, but it is still a convention, and fundamentally contingent; the point is to go beyond convention and enter the real. This is the metaphysical 'point of view' which Guenon writes of constantly. It's easy for us well-trained critical thinkers to misunderstand these references, and think that he's simply inventing another abstract category, despite how clear and insistent he is on the metaphysical.

Mr.Skull on 2011-04-20 at 16:26 said:

Thank you Cologero and Graham for the exegesis.

Cologero,

1. I know the article didn't state Spengler was 'wrong'. Nevertheless: A. When Evola critiques, it seems like he's making a perfect abstraction as well. Calling his abstraction a "metaphysical" category does not render it real.

B. "If we take it as absolute, then, because of the discontinuity, then the ancient civilizations can have no relationship to each other, even less so to the modern world." Spengler never said anywhere civilizations are disconnected from each other or "exist in a vacuum". What Spengler says is that there are civilizations (either Indo-European, or not) that have reached maturity, and these civilizations decline in time according to certain causal laws. He studies the physical relations between human activities, and the decline of civilizations. He never states that these mature civilizations are "disconnected" from other, previous epochs or societies, the only thing he may say is that these other epochs and societies / civilizations aren't "mature" (he of course defines which civilization qualify to be a mature one). "Germanic c ivilization" is not a "Roman" C ivilization, but they both may share common elements.

2. Spengler's theory is "abstract" as much as Evola's use of metaphysical ideas. Categories derived from abstractions (mental constructs) turn real when they have empirical antecedent, and are initially derived from the physical world, and repeat or cease according to the laws of objective physical reality.

So, "Real" categories are based on eternal ideas, not derived from empirical and contingent considerations." really means: eternal ideas are based upon empirical and contingent considerations? I can't really see where else can they come from, unless some other, mystical, supernatural force come to exist. Humans induce, than deduce.

Graham: Why does one ought to believe Spengler does not base his theory upon what we can just as well call "the eternal idea of circularity", and than demonstrates how the idea is reflected and perpetuated throughout history, in civilizations that reached matureness? Spenglerianism is heavily influenced by the ideas of Plato, and the imminent and WHOLEsome logical consequentiality and causality behind the rise and fall of societies and civilizations. This is derived from the acknowledgment humans are bound to natural laws, which have shaped them as humans and thus their behavior, and that reality works according to this behavioral causality,

which gives rise to imminent human constructions (cultural, social, political), ever repeating throughout history, and than declining when X occurs.

Izak on 2011-04-22 at 02:21 said:

Skull:

The problem with Spengler's construct is that it was based on an admission of epistemological relativism. I'm quite familiar with Decline of the West. It's a great treatise to say the least. But it has serious problems in logic. For instance, if you look at his second chapter of volume one, on mathematics, he shows a complete rejection of the idea that there is a universal mathematical system rooted in an underlying truth. Instead, he defines mathematical concepts as mere expressions of a cultural worldview. To Spengler, works of art, developments in technology, wars, etc. are only indicators of a culture's stage of development in how it basically feels. Objective calculation becomes lost. While Spengler does present the concept of civilizational rise and decline as a universal rule of law, the great paradox is that he claims that each civilization has a worldview no more valid than the other, and thus that each civilization possesses equal importance to the other. Why more postmodernist thinkers haven't written about this, I haven't the faintest idea. But anyhow, Spengler himself gradually departed from that notion entirely in the interwar years (see: Man and Technics).

The traditionalists differ from Decline in that they refuse to let relativism define their views on civilization. They look toward a series of metaphysical principles as the guiding light, and each civilization to be analyzed either more or less conforms to those principles. There is only one true math and science, and it is a traditional math and science. There is only one true language of symbols, and it comprises the traditional symbols. Etc.

Mr.Skull on 2011-04-22 at 11:45 said:

Izak,

What you describe is not necessarily a paradox. Essentially, Spengler says that although "each culture has its own new possibilities of self-expression", NO MATTER what view you hold in your civilization, or what set of values you promote and perpetuate which led a civilization to MATURITY, certain laws or "processes" which are true and apply to all civilizations, lead to a mature civilizations' exhaustion, old age and decline.

For example, every mature / distinctive civilization eventually stiffen into a type of cultural / social / political "formalism" and bureaucracy. Another example: each civilization, once it has finalized the maturity process – has more residents in dense and large megalopolis, than in the rural areas / countryside.

In the page of concealment of the book "Man and Techniques" he writes: "We are born into this time and must bravely follow the path to the destined end. There is not other way. Our duty

is to hold on to the lost position without hope, without rescue... ". And this is the (pessimistic) essence of Spengler's work.

Izak on 2011-04-23 at 12:56 said:

Right, but what I'm saying is that on the one hand, he approaches universal truth as nonexistent. To Spengler, truth is relative to each culture. The traditionalists say, "There is one truth," while Spengler wouldn't say such a thing. You have to remember, he's a Nietzschean.

Man and Technics departs from Decline of the West because Decline talks about how each civilization has just as much importance as the other. It's not "ethnocentric" at all; it's completely egalitarian in its view of culture. Man and Technics, however, is Spengler's first attempt to seriously A) talk about mankind's growth and development, and B) analyze the subject of technology. All of the sudden, his relativism is challenged, because he starts to show world history as A) a cohesive whole, and B) completely affected by Western civilization, hence placing more importance on the West.

This is what why the traditionalists aren't as impressed with Spengler. It isn't as though his books are awful, but if you look at his career, you can see changes in his ideas. The traditionalists possess universal principles, and because of that, their principles are much more solid and uncompromised.

Mr.Skull on 2011-04-23 at 18:00 said:

"Right, but what I'm saying is that on the one hand, he approaches universal truth as nonexistent."

And yet, his thesis is completely logical, and it corresponds with both reality and the facts of history, as is the well-known fact ALL humans go through the cycle of "birth-youth-maturity-old age". The additional accusations of him being an "egalitarian" in his view of culture, evoked by traditionalists has nothing to do with the historiosophic nature of his civilizational analysis, but are completely transparent, since the involvement of the a conception of cultural or value-wise "importance" is necessary if the criticism of traditionalists be even slightly "valid". By using "importance" and the issue of the validity of values, traditionalists can accuse him of invoking "relativism". One thing, though, they have to remember: while Spengler never stated any civilization is "more important" than the other, he never, explicitly opined each mature civilization is equally "important", also – what is importance? How do we measure it? Important to what? In relation to what?

Spengler also recognized that each of the high civilizations had different values, and thus – different opportunities and philosophical velocities, WITHIN the confines of existential circularity – which he examines as a META-ANALYST.

The alleged "changes" in his ideas and philosophy, may simply be notional expansions he decided to phrased in order to clarify the ideas expressed in his often misunderstood thesis

in DOTW and to give them a historical background. He writes in the preface: "But experience with the earlier work showed that the majority of readers are not in a position to maintain a general view over the mass of ideas as a whole, and so lose themselves in the detail of this or that domain which is familiar to them."

In the rest of the book, he uses the same causal method he used in DOTW, to describe how man "evolves" from a certain perception of nature and technology, to yet another, finalized one, in which he's possessed by practical technicality and a 'mechanical' view of the world.

Izak on 2011-04-23 at 19:52 said:

I appreciate your devotion to one of the greatest thinkers of the 20th century, but I can't really agree with much of what you just said.

Man and Technics is a pretty serious departure from Decline of the West. Decline states that there is no such thing as a solid "human history," but that there is only a series of disconnected, autonomous histories of peripheral relevance toward each other. Man and Technics is a look at human history as a cohesive whole, where he begins to lay down very clear principles about human nature, and he examines humanity as an historical concept, not merely a zoological one, which is a clear no-no in Decline.

If you read Prophet of Decline by Farrenkopf, you can see pretty clear and decisive evidence that Spengler was turning around much of his metaphysical ideas during the time leading up to his death. The notes for his book-project on pre-civilized man are very telling.

I think that Spengler's thought was moving into a much better direction in the years up to his death, and it would have been a great contribution to scholarship to see his work come to fruition, but I suppose it was just never meant to be. I also think that Spengler knew quite a lot of things that the traditionalists never have bothered to understand, like economics and political theory... but I think the criticism toward Spengler from their perspective is pretty much right. Spengler never had solid, universal principles beyond his model for civilizational growth and decay, and it caused his philosophy to be useful more as a marker than as a source of metaphysical truth.

Anyhow I'll let you have the last word, since I don't have much more to say on the subject.

12.14 Forgotten Tradition

There seems to be much misunderstanding of Evola's moral position. As he claims, he is drawing on

> doctrines which are in truth of a fundamental value, currently

> almost forgotten, that placed evil in matter.

Apparently contemporary readers really have forgotten them, even those who falsely believe themselves to be relying on Evola in their Traditionalism and paganism. Perhaps such men need to rethink their relationship to Evola. As an example of such an attitude, we need do no more than quote the first line of Porphyry's biography of Plotinus:

> Plotinus, the philosopher our contemporary, seemed ashamed of being in the body.

In sharp contrast to that, we need look no further than the recent Hollywood film, *The Little Fockers* to see the modern mind at work. In it, the European family patriarch is portrayed as humourless and up-tight. Finally, he is defeated by his son-in-law, after which he is informed that he is really a Jew. The benefit of that, as he is told, is that farting, belching, sexing and all such bodily functions — things that used to embarrass the patriarch — are now "good".

Contrast that to the Traditional, aristocratic attitude of a Plotinus. Make up your mind once and for all where you stand: with Tradition or with the modern world.

Henry Chadwick writes in *Interpreting Late Antiquity*[15]:

> Porphyry, biographer and editor of Plotinus, began the Life of his master with the famous sentence that Plotinus always seemed ashamed of being in the body. His concern was with the soul which, true to Plato, he saw as being midway between the inferior flesh and the superior incorporeal mind that is, spirit . *Moral choices are therefore decisions whether to follow the higher reason or lower bodily appetite.* The self (for which Plotinus uses the word

[15] https://www.amazon.com/Interpreting-Late-Antiquity-Essays-Postclassical/dp/0674005988/ref=sr_1_1?ie=UTF8&qid=1300597497&sr=8-1

autos) therefore has levels and power of movement. But the true self is divine and the body no more than its temporary instrument (IV 7.1.20ff.).

Naturally the union of soul with body makes for interaction between them. When ashamed we blush, when terrified we go white with fear. Conversely there are pressures which the body can put upon the soul, drawing it downward toward material satisfactions. *But the soul's true home is in that higher realm which is not governed by the determinism of fate.* Self-knowledge is synonymous with the soul's being identical in being (*homoousios*) with mind (IV 4.28.56; IV 7.10.19). Thereby *salvation is the divinizing of the soul*, a mystical union comparable to the merging of two torches (6.9.18ff.) "in the measure possible to the human soul" (12-9-9.45ff.). The route by which one returns to true being is self-knowledge (VI 5.7), and is a restoration of the unity from which the soul has fallen into multiplicity and has been torn apart in a "scattering" (VI 6.I.5). *As the soul moves toward the good, it recovers freedom, which is a liberation from the constraints of the body* (VI 8.6-7). Plotinus noted explicitly that in his doctrine of the soul's retaining its divine nature "undescended" he was departing from the normal view of the Platonic schools (IV 8.8.I). Origen (Prin. 3.4) shows that the idea was not new with Plotinus.[16]

Posted on 2011-03-20 by Cologero

* * *

EXIT on 2011-03-20 at 08:12 said:

I don't care who wrote what. I don't base principles on someone's emotions, especially shame of the body. Do you actually expect me to accept Plotinus' alleged shame as proof that matter is evil? But of course you say you do not wish to convert anyone yet you urge us to rethink our positions? I don't rely on Evola for my tradition, I rely on my Self and my Body.

[16] All emphases are mine.

EXIT on 2011-03-20 at 08:22 said:

Is it not written in the New Testament that the body is a temple?

EXIT on 2011-03-20 at 08:34 said:

1 Cor. 6:18-20, "Every sin that a man doeth is without the body; your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you... therefore glorify God in your body and spirit, which are God's."

James O'Meara on 2011-03-20 at 12:02 said:

I take your basic point, but based on a nodding acquaintance with both Evola and Neo-Platonism, I don't think Evola would have considered Plotinus' shame even assuming it to be authentic, rather than another of Porphyry's mythologizing touches, like the snake that slithers from under Plotinus' deathbed, or the nine-fold arrangement of his Treatises to be a positive aspect of the Aryan self-image. The classical Greeks and Romans, on whom Evola based his idea of the ideal Roman type see Revolt and even the later Men/Ruins , were not 'promiscuous' like the "mandolin strumming, macaroni scarfing" Mediterranean types, but hardly 'ashamed' of their bodies.

I, most scholars, and I think Evola, would take that notion as a symptom of Late antiquity, either under the influence of Christianity the 'primitive' type, not the Roman, in Evola's terms or else of a weakening of the Roman spirit itself, which is what made the influencing possible.

Like your previous remarks on sola sciptura resulting in the demotion of Classical myth, religion and philosophy from 'revealed' status and thus cutting Christianity off from its roots in Tradition, some, mostly the same kind of Christians, would agree that Hellenism was different from Classical, but see this as a plus for both pagans and Christianity the 'moral advance over the gross pagans' idea , while Evola would deplore it. But either way, it IS different.

Cologero on 2011-03-20 at 13:01 said:

Good points, James, yet we must be very careful about how we read deep thinkers. To be ashamed of one's body is no sign of spirituality, but apparently Plotinus was ashamed of "being" in a body, not precisely the same notion. My intention was not to promote such shame, but rather to point out that Evola's contention – that "necessity" is inherently an "evil" – is not unique to him, but has deeper roots in tradition. Instead of Porphyry, focus instead on the commentary by Chadwick that I quoted. So Plotinus' shame was not the body *per se*, but rather the necessity that limited his freedom and power.

Now Evola does indeed address the idea of "aristocratic asceticism" in Revolt (ch 16), where he uses the towering figures of Plotinus, Buddha, and Meister Eckhart to support his point. This asceticism involves a detachment from all things (yes, the "body" is a thing). Evola writes: "An action dictated by desire ... must not be undertaken." Of course, the ignorant and prudish assume this means that the specific desire or the object of desire is evil. Not at all, that misses the

point entirely. The issue at stake is the feeling of "necessity" that *is* desire; that is what must be overcome.

Looking at chapter 1 of Revolt, Evola writes: "Hellenism saw nature as the embodiment of eternal "privation" yes, that is the correct translation, relating it back to what we have previously written I'll expect the reader to turn to the rest of that paragraph. Note, too, that Evola relates this also back to the Scholastics, something we tried to show in the chart.

At the very beginning of Revolt, Evola makes clear that he is speaking from "knowledge" not mere theory. We can speculate all we want about the self-image of the Aryan, his qualities, attitudes, and so on. Or else, we can actually "be" an Aryan (twice-born) in Spirit and know first hand.

James O'Meara on 2011-03-20 at 15:07 said:

All true enough, but I only wanted to emphasize that we can't really rely on Porphyry; he's not writing what we would call a 'biography' and in fact nothing like that even existed at the time. When Porphyry says "Plotinus seemed ashamed" we are at least 2 steps away from Plotinus himself; what Plotinus thought, how he seemed to Porphyry, how Porphyry fits this into his "Life of the Sage" template. Now, when I compare that language to Plotinus's own, it seems suspicious; its sounds more like the Christians he defines himself against in Against the Gnostics the only Christian writers he seems to know, interestingly as ungrateful wretches daring to despise the world which, defective as it is, his point and yours is none the less the best possible work of the World Soul. Of course, what you, Evola and Chadwick present is a different matter, since it's based on Plotinus himself.

As for theory and 'knowledge,' I'm not sure where it applies here, as the Aryan self-image I reference is also from Evola, from the same book.

Also, I forgot to mention the Fockers reference is spot on; on my blog I have frequently discussed the anti-European 'cockroach literature' promoted by the media and academy, based on Kevin MacDonald's studies of the "Culture of Critique" and Cuddihy's "Ordeal of Civility."

Francis on 2011-03-20 at 21:50 said:

Although EXIT is hardly inviting conversation, perhaps this is due to genuine concerns of which I am unaware. I am a young'in and fairly new to here so forgive my lack of decent input.

The 'body' certainly fascinates an awkward position in the cosmos and so begs a fair amount of attention. That with it time and space occupy from nil; that eternal and terminal somehow meet with the Logos; that the reason for the hypostatic union is the failure of the being with a body... all of this asks the place of the body as it is now, before death.

While the body is a temple, and EXIT does not wish to deny it, that temple will break down and die, and all will have to deny it at death, less they choose to stay with it in death.

1Cor6:18-20 must be reconciled with this and Rom6:6, Rom7:24, Rom8:10, Rom8:13... Not to mention, 1Cor6:18-20 does not necessarily carry with it the meaning you are applying. I was going to grant you that it might be the literal meaning... but even the literal meaning is about the 'body' of Christians who are to be "members of Christ" and not in cahoots with other 'bodies' (ie. there is discord/division/disagreement in the community). In the next section, Paul then addresses issues related to the body. And there, Paul is decidedly negative on the sexual deeds of the body... only good for those who cannot control their passions.

Does this help?

I do not have the time now, but I think Chadwick helpfully refers to Origen, who is also helpful on this point. His 'speculation' (spiritual insight?) in "first principles" on the 'body,' places the body in a simultaneously significant and insignificant position.

HOO on 2011-03-20 at 23:25 said:

Very good, James O'Meara, thank you.

EXIT, amusing as ever. But why don't you try to be more positive? I see you cited Corinthians, ´your body is the temple´, there. That's very good! Now if you would take more time to elaborate on your thoughts, that would be even better. You'll notice I sometime include multiple citations like that from various works, in my posts. Why don't you be a buddy and do more of that rather than mostly ´criticizing´.

I think I agree with your stance on the body. In any case I would think everybody here recognizes that there are at least two ways of dealing with it. One way is ´life-denying´ and ´neglects´ the body for trans-worldly states, the other way is ´(super)life-affirming´ and ´celebrates´ the body for this-worldly and trans-worldly states.

"We are mind and body: if mind and body (inasmuch as they belong to the world of maya) are false, how can one hope to achieve through them that which is true?" quoted in "The Yoga of Power" p. 19

´The analysis of the last age, the "dark age" or Kali Yuga, brings to light two essential features. The first is that mankind living in this age is strictly connected to the body and cannot prescind from it; therefore, the only way open is not that of pure detachment (as in early Buddhism and in the many varieties of yoga) but rather that of knowledge, awakening, and mastery over secret energies trapped in the body.´ Evola, "The Yoga of Power" p. 3 ´In Tantrism the passage from the ideal of "liberation" to that of "freedom" marks an essential change in the ideals and ethics of Hinduism. It is true that even previously the ideal of the jivanmukta had been known. The word means "one who is freed," that is, the one who has achieved the unconditioned, the sahaja, while alive, in his own body.´ Evola, "The Yoga of Power" p. 4 The prechristian world knew this in different traditions. It was known by some in the Christian era too. And it is known by some in the ´postchristian´ era.

Basic stuff, guys.

Cologero on 2011-03-21 at 01:26 said:

This discussion has gotten out of hand, as the original point has been lost. Evola wrote:

"evil in matter, meaning by this that residue of necessity that resists the idea – that is, freedom – and limits it"

Unless one understands this definition of matter, the point is lost. Nowhere does Evola state the body in itself is evil.

Insofar as the body is matter, it sets a limit to freedom, that is, it is privation. But, insofar as the sequence of domination Spirit-¿ Soul-¿ Body holds, the body is not "evil".

I then tied this into a larger framework. First the Scholastics, who Evola references in Revolt. If the fall is the weakening and bondage of the will, then it would seem that Power and Freedom are Good. I used Plotinus to illustrate, and was then forced to show that Plotinus is not an aberration of late antiquity, since Evola is in fundamental with him.

It would be of value to start again at the beginning and follow the argument, point by point.

Zmaj on 2011-03-21 at 06:54 said:

Cologero has explained the case well, I see no issue. To dismiss a few possible confusions that could be stoking disputes:

-Use of the term 'evil' in these articles should not evoke any moralistic connotations. In the same way that 'evil' implies a subversion or counterfeit in theology, we might employ the term 'negate' to describe the same tendency in metaphysic. This clarified, I'll retain the term 'evil' hereinafter.

-Matter, as such, is evil, especially insofar as it is understood according to the modern conception (which conception negates everything other than matter). To the extent that any being on the temporal plane has simultaneous access to higher perception, the evil of matter is mitigated because said being can begin to perceive the general essence underlying the manifestation of matter. Indeed, the modern idea of matter is revealed as un erreur majeur to anyone who breaks the barrier.

-This brings us to comments like "The body is a temple", and discussions about yoga. If the body is understood as a point of departure in supratemporal realization, it is no longer just plain material ideas that we are dealing with. So, it can be a temple that grounds the center of consciousness until sufficient energies begin to displace that center toward its transcendent origin. Thereafter, the idea is to become less dependent on the ephemeral, body included – one awakens to oneself in the body; this does not make the body the origin.

-The body as matter is also evil in the sense that it can condemn your soul by trapping it and limiting realization. Recall certain physical conditions that are prerequisites of some yogic praxis.

12.15 Creative and Heroic Action

I have recently been asked why we are so "one-sided". Such a thought can arise only in a mind conditioned to think on a single plane, thus interpreting everything polemically, in the manner of a teeter-totter. The Traditional mind, on the other hand, thinks in terms of "transcendence", which Evola defines as "surpassing while ascending". The idea of cycles does not mean an impossible return to the ways of antiquity, but rather an absorption of their highest spiritual values in a new synthesis.

In the essay, Rene Guenon, a Teacher for our Times, Evola calls for a "*Creative and Heroic action*." Evola rejects any turn to the East, which, in any case, is in its own process of degeneration. It is actually unnecessary, since the West has its own Tradition, discernible to those with the ability to see. The result will be a work "endowed with a metaphysical, transcendent, ethical, and social character." This is the vision and the task taken up by Gornahoor, however unclearly or poorly expressed.

- **Metaphysical**, by emphasizing the need for a genuine gnosis as the foundation.
- **Transcendent**, by integrating and surpassing the best of antique pagandom and Christendom.
- **Ethical**, by our emphasis on freedom or the will and understanding the creation of a world as a moral act.
- **Social**, by trying to create a **Solidarity** of traditional thinkers in Continuity with the ways of our ancestors.

This is a positive task and should be a thing of beauty, suitable for men with a sense of noblesse oblige. If we seem negative, that is because of the necessary task of outing those who claim to be on the side of Tradition, but who, in reality, form a counter-tradition, which is revealed through

the ugliness of their discourse, their unaesthetic music, and their rejection of a spiritual Solidarity in the present and Continuity with the past. To be considered a man, they misunderstand the true Pagan as a creature given over to his liberated elan vital, and "might is right" philosophy. Thus, they demonstrate their lack of understanding of the counter balancing frein vital, the Buddhist "battle in the cave of dragons", or the man able to dominate and control his unbridled passions.

> The cave of the blue dragon is ominous.
> Only the fearless dare to enter.
> It is here that the forest of patterns is clearly revealed.
> It is here that the one ripe pearl is hidden.

Posted on 2011-07-25 by Cologero

12.16 Action and Contemplation

In the 1950s, several of **Julius Evola**'s essays were published in the English language journal, East and West, by the **Istituto Italiano per l'Africa e l'Oriente**. In January 1954, Evola's review of **Rene Guenon**'s *Crisis of the Modern World* appeared. The particular topic that interests now is the notion of the elite. Guenon refers to them as the intellectual elite, although, of course, he does not mean "intellectual" as referring to any sort of academic discipline, and still less to the intelligentsia of writers, journalists, artists, professors, and so on. For Guenon, the intellect refers to a spiritual gnosis, a form of knowing superior to the rational or scientific mind. Evola describes it:

> Guenon does not use the expression "intellectuality" in its generally accepted meaning: those to whom he refers are not "intellectuals", but men of superior character whose formation has been on traditional lines and who possess a knowledge of metaphysics.

We won't be surprised that Evola brings up the topic of action at this point. Rather than an intellectual order, per se, Evola would prefer to see an Order, along the lines of the Templars[17], Ismaelites[18], or the Teutonic Knights[19]. He explains:

> An Order represents a superior form of life within the framework of a life of action, which may have a metaphysical and traditional "dimension" while at the same time remaining in a more direct touch with the world of reality and with historic facts.

So far, so good. Yet, once again, Evola muddles things a little by misunderstanding the proper relationship between contemplation and action. This bane goes on to affect his understanding of castes, the roles of priests, kings, etc. In order to be true to tradition, Evola often resorts to equivocal formulations. So while we are sympathetic to the idea of an Order acting in history, it is time to clear things up. According to Evola:

> Guenon believes that one of the causes of the crisis of the modern world is to be found in the theoretical and practical denial of the priority that should be given to knowledge, contemplation, and pure intellectuality over action.

First of all, we can agree with Evola that by "action", he does not mean:

> Disorderly, unenlightened, and purposeless activity, dominated exclusively by contingent and material considerations, aiming only at worldly achievements, which is now the only form of action modern civilization recognizes and admires.

[17] https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/14493a.htm

[18] https://www.onislam.net/english/ask-the-scholar/ideologies-movements-and-religions/174770.html?Religions=

[19] https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/14541b.htm

However, Evola is still not ready to conceive the priority of the intellect over action. Contemplation is the symbol of the priestly caste while action is that of the warrior caste and the king. It is true that Guenon claimed that there is a higher principle that unites the two, and this is manifested by the Priest-King of the Ancient City who embodied both principles. Evola concludes from this that neither of the two principles can claim priority over the other. This is clearly an erroneous conclusion, since the two principles need be related in some way, and is especially puzzling coming from someone who rejects any form of egalitarianism. To understand why, it is necessary to identify the underlying unifying principle, something neither Guenon nor Evola bothered to do. Let's start with schema 13.2.

Principle	**Mental Faculty**	**Transcendental**
Contemplation	Thinking	Truth
Action	Willing	Goodness

Table 12.2: Principles and Faculties

From this chart, we can immediately infer that the unifying principle is the One, in Neoplatonic terms, or God (Being), in medieval terms. By the metaphysical doctrine of divine simplicity, God, or the One, cannot be divided; it is nondual, hence Truth and Goodness are the same. However, as they manifest, they separate; it is there that we see their relationship. Let's go back to Evola's rejection of action as understood by the world.

Disorderly Activity The opposite of this is orderly activity, i.e., activity in harmony with the Logos, or the Cosmic Law. It is the intellect that knows the Logos.

Unenlightened The enlightened mind is the mind that "knows"

Purposeless Action cannot determine its own purpose; it is the intellect that chooses it.

Worldly achievements Of course, true action aims at supernatural achievements.

Clearly, the intellectual principle, in relationship to action, is the ordering principle, guiding enlightened action, providing it with a purpose and a superior aim. Another way to see this, is to use the doctrine of the symbolism of the cross, as described by Guenon. Action, in "the world of reality" "historic facts" represents the horizontal direction and the intellect represents the vertical direction.

Whatever Evola may have meant, Tradition does not accept the independence of the will in respect to the intellect. This is the false doctrine: *Sic volo, sic jubeo, sit pro ratione voluntas* "thus I wish, thus I command, my will stands in place of reason" (Juvenal) . Since Evola has defended Reason, as long as its first principles are metaphysical doctrines, he cannot possibly mean that.

If he means that the active life in the world, if engaged in consciously, can lead to higher states of awareness, then we are in agreement. For there is a second way to understand action. Action, in the sense of bringing the potential into act, can be understood vertically. As Guenon states, it is a goal for some to actualize all their possibilities, i.e., to make real what exists only in potential. In that struggle against instinctive and inferior forces, both within and without, *I simultaneously reveal myself, create myself, and know myself*.

H/T Avery

Posted on 2012-05-22 by Cologero

* * *

Charlotte on 2012-05-23 at 10:25 said:

Ah now this is where Tomberg and Guenon do not agree, as the former gives explicit precedence to the artist over 'initiated mages' of the mind. The reason being that artists have the power to inspire love, promote peace and directly convey the word of God to relatively large numbers of people – to enliven the state and provide a channel by which divine guidance might move.

logres on 2012-05-23 at 18:43 said:

Charlotte, when you say "Art" what are you meaning?

logres on 2012-05-23 at 18:49 said:

Sic volo, sic jubeo. Sit pro ratione voluntas. Lutherus ita vult, et ait se doctorem esse super omnes doctores in toto papatu.

Luther, quoting Juvenal

Not surprising.

Charlotte on 2012-05-23 at 19:13 said:

well for example Picasso's Guernica, T S Eliot's Four Quartet's, Tolkien's Lord of the Rings, Bob Marley singing One Love, Sylvie Guillem dancing... .

Charlotte on 2012-05-23 at 19:16 said:

Here's another one:

There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, Than are dreamt of in your philosophy.

logres on 2012-05-23 at 22:37 said:

The Nous manifests in Art, but also in philosophy. This doesn't even address what is unmanifest. I think what you are "seeing" is Tomberg's debt to the French sensibilities of the hermetic current. But I'm still not sure what you mean by Art. I can't picture Tomberg correcting Guenon's metaphysics, although it's fair to say he might find the company of Schuon more genial to his own sensibilities.

Charlotte on 2012-05-24 at 05:29 said:

I never said it didn't appear in philosopy but I can quite assure you Tomberg DID say this – Guenon isn't the last word on truth you know, he's just one more person striving to bring it to light – and in many cases he succeeds. Tomberg also, by the way, warned vehemently against founding 'schools' dedicated to following one mage or another, as they only end up in closed circles of idol worship – something you rightly pointed out are ultimately 'satanic' as they contain no possibility of freedom. In fact he pleaded with his readers not to do so.

In Tomberg's book the artist is 'higher' – more 'elite', than the thinker or mere initiate, for the reasons I pointed out, which seems logical enough to me, I know very well when I'm in the presence of genius and take great joy from its manifestation... .he was humble and discerning enough to comprehend the truth and happy to consider that there were others who'd reached greater heights than he himself had achieved. It must have been a relief for someone considerd by many to be an Avatar – a title he shunned. He was wise, he didn't want mummifying by apparently well meaning supporters – the best school masters prefer free thinking to blind acceptance of every word they utter

Art can be appreciated by a small child and they'll be first through the doors when heaven opens – the heart and soul can go further than the mind. Dante knew this and I presume he is considered 'elite' and therefore 'in the knoww', 'gnostic', as it were?

I have been in the heaven which takes most of his light, and I have seen things which cannot be told, possibly, by anyone who comes down from up there.

Because, approaching the object of its desires, our intellect is so deeply absorbed that memory cannot follow it all the way.

Nevertheless, what I was able to store up of that holy kingdom, in my mind, will now be the matter of my poem.

logres on 2012-05-25 at 00:12 said:

Tomberg frankly admits he is pursuing an elucidation of the personal path (hermeticism); he isn't trying to provide a metaphysic for the dying West. I don't understand why the "flight to Art"- doesn't it have elitists and so forth as well? How is Guenon not an "artist" of the Intellect? Tomberg and Evola both defend the "initation from above", Evola in the res publica, Tomberg in private contemplation. But I've only read MotT and a few articles – VT privileges (for purposes of his work) the French hermetic tradition, into which he "incarnates" for the duration of the work. I agree he is a consummate artist, as well as a better Catholic than Guenon. Are you sure that Tomberg privileges Art over Intellect? Doesn't he see them as two facets to one Truth? If he read LOTR, could we not also imagine him being interested in the thought and life of the man who created it, his letters, the Silmarillion, the diaries, the whole theology of the Inklings? I think he would.

logres on 2012-05-25 at 00:16 said:

Consider above, & see what you think... .

Charlotte on 2012-05-25 at 10:17 said:

Yes I am quite sure, and it is to do with the primarcy of the heart over mind as our guide. It should be no surprise if Guenon / Evola do not always find themselves in agreement with Tomberg. Nobody is trying to deny the intellect is vital, but one must also bear in the same mind

that the Luciferian impulse acts directly on the mind. This is the problem with theosophy – both Guenon and Evola appear to me as being basically theosophists from an intellectual point of view, albeit with catholic sentimentality, with all the attend avenues of illumination but lacking the purity of true Christian heart-centred faith. The problem with theosophy is well known but not necessarily understood – hence the immense errors that early occultists fell into, in many cases unawares.

dear unknown friends, Christian Hermeticism has no pretentsions to rival either religion or official science. He who is searching here for 'true religion' or 'true philosopy', or 'true science' is looking in the wrong direction. Christian Hermeticists are not masters, but servants. They do not have pretension (that is, in any case, somewhat puerile) of elevating themselvess above the holy faith of the faithful, or above the fruits of the admirable efforts of workers in science, or above the creations of artistic genius. Hermeticists are not guarding the secret of future discoveries in the sciences. They do not know, for example, just as everyone at present is ignorant of it, the effective remedy against cancer. Moreover they would be monsters if they were to guard the secret of this remedy against this bane of humanity without communicatin git. No, they do not know it, and they will be the first to recognise the superiority of the future benefactor of the human race, that savant who will discover this remedy.

likewise they recognise without reserve the superiority of a Francis of Assisi – and of many others – who was a man of the so-called 'exoteric' faith. They know also that each sincere believer is potentially a Francis of Assisi. Men and women of faith, of science and of art are their superiors in many essential points. Hermeticists know it well and do not flatter themselves to be better, to believe better, to konw better or to be more competent... That which they possess does not comprise any tangible advantage or objective superiority with regard to religion, science and art; what they possess is only the communal soul of religion, science and art.

Letter 1, The Magician

Of course I guess this only applies if one sees one's self as a Christian Hermeticist first and foremost rather than a philosopher first and foremost...

`Charlotte on 2012-05-25 at 10:27 said:`

Or Evola at any rate seems more theosophical... of the two authors I much prefer Guenon, he has the greater insight

`logres on 2012-05-25 at 13:19 said:`

He's saying that there is no conflict – I don't understand... "no pretensions to rival... ". I take that at face value. The primacy of the heart in union, but the primacy of the intellect in formally judging is the classic Catholic formulation – St. John of the Cross himself helped formulate it. I don't see what your quarrel with that is.

Charlotte on 2012-05-26 at 08:43 said:

err, I think you are forgetting that I was responding to a posting where 'artists, writers' and so on were being given secondary place to 'elect philosophers'... .there were also disagreements about who/what constituted the 'elect' and I object to the majority of people being called atheist and perceived as lesser than unspecified 'others'. I don't agree that those at the top of the pyramid are blameless while the 'masses' are to blame for all the ills of the world. Where is the compassion in that?

Look, I've spent a lot of time on this, if nobody can understand what I'm trying to say then clearly it's energy not well spent! No hard feelings but it's probably best if I leave you to talk amongst yourselves :-)

http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/liberating-action

logres on 2012-05-26 at 09:04 said:

I understand perfectly what you are saying, & agree with the information/wisdom contained in it. I just don't understand the contextual point of making it, except as a warning. Besides the "masses" you are speaking of are the "folk" and individuals, not the modern masses referred to by Guenon and others. Even bees have a hierarchy. It sounds like it's just a dirty word to you. That's fine, but it's not being used in that sense. Maybe we could just agree on another word.

logres on 2012-05-26 at 09:08 said:

I brought up St. John of the Cross because he recognized the "hierarchy" of intellect in apprehending (practically) virtue. Thus, he didn't embrace a rhetoric of practical virtue or liberty, but instead achieved it (not that you are). Ditto with Tomberg. Let's agree to another word to denote "hierarchy" as understood in a non-spiritual sense, that is, a hierarchy which contradicts Scriptural exhortation to "serve one another". Perhaps, dominarchy or something like that? Are you familiar with Mouravieff's diagram?

http://unurthed.com/2009/10/21/mouravieffs-correction/

Hierarchy in THAT sense.

Graham on 2012-05-26 at 11:28 said:

Charlotte said: "it is to do with the primarcy of the heart over mind as our guide."

Guenon and Evola agree with that forumulation. They say that man's symbolic centre is the heart, but they understand the heart as the seat of intellectual intuition united with will, while the mind is the seat of thought. And only in their sense can it be truly said that the heart guides the mind. You consistently give the impression of understanding the heart's Love (Caritas) as principally emotional; but in this case, love is blind. Emotion guiding thought is the blind leading the blind.

Another tradition Guenon points to is that Love and Knowledge are united, as warmth and luminosity are united in physical light. Luminosity guides (thus "illuminate" as "to make known") while warmth empowers.

This is why the fruit of Faith is knowledge of God, and why Faith 'precedes' Love as a theological virtue. Even here, where Love is defined as willing the Good rather than in emotional terms, knowledge is the guide.

But Charlotte you do raise a good point. Cologero has demonstrated that Evola and Tomberg share a great deal – perhaps a fundamental worldview – as hermeticists. But how do we reconcile Evola's "coldness" and "distance" with Tomberg's "warmth" and "nearness"? What is the source and significance of this difference?

Graham on 2012-05-26 at 11:55 said:

Charlotte,

The artist engaged in his concrete function (painting, sculpting, and so on) is servile or imitative. Keep in mind that "servile" here is descriptive rather than pejorative. The artist, if and when he is held rapt in the contemplation of beauty, is at that moment a philosopher, not concretely an artist.

Now it's possible that a philosopher could be a quietist or an escapist, which I think is the phenomenon you object to. But if an artist can be a philosopher, then obviously a philosopher can be an artist, and in the most universal sense.

Will on 2012-05-26 at 20:31 said:

The qualities listed as Transcendental in the chart are two of the three "foods of the soul" in Catholic philosophy – the third being Beauty. The Good, the True and the Beautiful is a common triplet.

Beauty is related to love, which is the nature of God, according to the Gospels. Beauty / love / God is thus the unifying principle, as the article states.

This relates to the discussion of art, which conveys truth and goodness through beauty.

If we add this third to the chart, we might say that its principle is Unity, its faculty is Love, and its transcendental quality is Beauty.

We might also consider the correspondence of these three to the three Dan Tiens in Taoism, and also the three faculties of the soul in Platonism, though there isn't an exact correspondence. In Chinese thought, willing has its origin in the kidneys, which are the seat of the life-force. Love comes from the heart, and thought from the head. These are the bodily locations of the three Dan Tiens ("seas of elixir.")

Platonism, in contrast, associates the lower torso (genitals and stomach) with appetite, the chest with will and courage, and the head with thought, contemplation and intuition. Love is

still central to Platonism however, since the love of wisdom is the essence of the path, and for the philosopher is the ruler and harmonizer of the appetite, will and mind.

logres on 2012-05-26 at 22:52 said:

Typo: "not that you are" I meant, not, you haven't apprehended virtue, but you haven't "embraced rhetoric" (over substance).

Charlotte on 2012-05-27 at 14:11 said:

well thank you for your comments, I do believe you are sincere but I'm not sure how much more I can explain here of what I know to be true. I don't wish to argue or get overheated but when one is in a position of defender of faith it's difficult to just sit nodding quietly when one sees things that are contrary occuring in an environment that is professed to be – and has the potential to be, with the right elements – an active Hermetic community.

As far as I'm concerned this needs to be pure if I'm to play a part in it, but that isn't meaning to be judgmental to anyone here, I understand that there are other peopale with different types of interests and different reasons for looking into things. However my concerns regarding what is really needed in the spiritual dimension are sounding alarm bells very loudly at some of things I hear, at some of the spirit I sense, and I know I'm not the only person to have experienced such misgivings over Evola. Perhaps it would be helpful to ponder why I – we – have had reason to feel this way, even if it is not readily apparent to you?

So, I see some major blind spots with respect to doctrine and even understanding of the perennial philosophy (I certainly don't think Evola is the undisputed expert) but I'm also conscious that others here perceive the blind spot as being mine :-) But that is fine, we are all trying to deepen our knowledge and one of the ways in which we must achieve this is via mirrors... .

I see a dire conflict between some of the authors/philosophers being 'upheld' and all together used – as if they were of one mind, 'mind' being all important, it seems – to bolster both a particular elitist notion of tradition and also catholicism, which is bizarre given Evola's own religious views regarding Christianity. This is why I'm getting my knickers in a twist over terms being used, because I'm sensing some of the spirit that is underpinning them and I don't like it. I'm extremely careful regarding which 'charged' works I read and I would be wary of Evola in any context. Guenon is a different story as I've mentioned a few times, but coldness and cruelty have no place WHATSOEVER in the great work of Christian Hermeticism. I really don't think Tomberg should be used to back up the ideas of Evola, it strikes me as wholly inappropriate, not least of all because Tomberg doesn't want rousing for debates like this, he doesn't like the attention at all. Politically Tomberg and Evola may have agreed, and doubtless they understood some of the same things, but I see no reason whatsover to persist in reviving Evola, those days are gone. Really those days are gone.

Which brings me onto another point relating to catholicism, which is more distressing and

in fact it is probably best if I say nothing as it would give me no pleasure and you neither. I only allude to it so as to help you understand some of what has been troubling me about all this here... .bear in mind the bones of St Peter have already been sent (by the Pope) to Fatima. Don't be blinded by your own sentimentality with respect to personal religion to what is happening in this age. It gives me no joy to say this, in fact it gave me many tears for a number of years... Perhaps I'm repeating myself a bit now, but I also hear it said that intellectuality is something to be sniffed at (fair enough, I basically agree), and yet this all appears to me to be an intellectual endeavour and I'm not entirely sure what the overall agenda is, even though some interesting things are discussed and some interesting works brought to light. This in itself is not an unworthy task – in fact it may be very worthwhile indeed, certainly some of the texts I've read as a consequence have been personally quite helpful – but I sense there is confusion regarding 'faith' that needs straightening out. The problem for the esotericist – in particular a left hand path practitioner – with respect to being led towards Islam, seemingly inevitably, are almost impossible to figure out unless you get back to the right track... .I know this from experience and have resolved it in a way I can fathom, but can all of you?

I realise Evola is not Christian and that Guenon had decided the only way was to go Sufi (I think, tho may have got this wrong?), which is their choice of course, but how does this fit in with catholicism? To the catholic sensibility it all seems very theosophic!! Now I am not a member of the exoteric catholic church so to me personally this isn't a great problem, but overall I see a lot of such contradictory threads that my logical mind is feeling exasperated by that – I think it was Rudolf Steiner who said that the logical person will feel actual pain when faced with illogicality, not that I'm wishing to nail the good doctor further into his coffin by mentioning him again :-)

Regarding 'emotion', yes I have a normal human sense of emotion... .it's also called passion, something quite close to the heart of the Christian faith, which is rightly pointed out to be about the spirit of service to mankind. Spirituality void of passion is a boat without sails, which doesn't mean to say we should ditch the rudder of reason. Evola seems to be lacking both passion and compassion, he veers to far into the dark side for my liking so if he's going to be the main focus I just can't do it anymore!!

Tony Ciapo on 2012-05-27 at 18:08 said:

Dispassion the Aim of All Asceticism[20].

Unfortunately, Charlotte, the illogicality is arising from you. Clearly, we are picking and choosing from Evola, and there are reasons for that. First of all, many have become interested in Tradition because of him. We agree that in many ways, he has also distorted Tradition; that is something we have addressed many times. Yet, because he is not attached to any living tradition,

[20] http://orthodoxwayoflife.blogspot.com/2010/06/dispassion-aim-of-all-asceticism.html

we can use him to demonstrate various points without partisanship. It is part of a larger project and we will be moving beyond Evola.

Now Evola wrote an important book on Hermetism, which has been widely praised by the likes of Eliade and Jung. If you need to pass judgment, at least read that first.

As for the illogicality that distresses you, here are some examples:

1) You disagree with the idea of an elite, yet when you went to Turkey, you boasted about your meeting with a Sufi leader. Why didn't you discuss spirituality with the falafel vendor on the street corner?

2) You object to a certain characterization of the masses, one that Tomberg himself claimed to be true. As a matter of fact, it is historically true that the French and Russian revolutions – "in the name of the people" – were explicitly atheistic. That is all anyone is saying ... there is no disputing facts.

3) You claim the masses are "naturally" devout, but have been "misled" by some higher ups. That is precisely what we mean ... the masses are formless and are *always and necessarily* formed by their superiors. So who should be the proper superiors? Obvisouly, a spiritual elite, in which case the devoutness and faith of the mass will be able to take form and thrive. I can't understand why any thoughtful person would object to this. Was not Jesus and the apostles an example of an elite group that spiritually transformed the West?

Please, Charlotte, before you nitpick and attack, please ask for clarification for things you don't understand. And please don't go off onto fantasies about the "dark side" and other such bizarre notions. Much of what we "know to be true" most certainly isn't. That is why every spiritual path begins with a process of purgation and catharsis, whereby our minds are cleared of our everyday beliefs.

Although we enjoy your lively comments, if what you find here makes you too uncomfortable, we won't take offense if you choose not to participate. But if you do decide to continue, please read again what Tomberg writes about what we have "in common", in our "depths", and not focus so much on personal experience, which is what divides, since it is contingent and changeable. This is found in Arcana IV.

logres on 2012-05-27 at 21:56 said:

Charlotte, I think I may be as Christian to the bone as yourself, and certainly Evola was characterized by some as cold & cruel – I think one of his female acquaintances did in fact. Christ (however) had a special affinity for Roman soldiers (this was noted by Chesterton) and His sword has to be above justice or injustice – "those who are not against us are with us" & "those who are not with us are against us" – He said both of these statements. Cologero has gone to pains to point out that Evola did not (actually) follow a living spiritual tradition, and that this fact makes him (if you wish to hear it plainly) "less elite". However, I can't help thinking (after each reading of his work) – what a fantastic mind – "our Marcuse, only better". Surely it would

be part of the "wisdom of the serpent" to learn from him? There are dangers here, but Life is dangerous, regardless. Evola was a weapon resurrected from ashes, and it would be a service to the Faith to employ him at any and all points that his native worth demands the justice of doing so. And I do hope you continue to read and discuss here... Who else or where else can you gain a clinical diagnosis of the modern situation in such a short, accessible form? Your feelings do you credit, but they could be used against you – I appeal to you to consider it and reconsider it before deciding.

logres on 2012-05-27 at 22:00 said:

Mouravieff, Preface to Gnosis:

"Yet, paradoxically, many Europeans who feel drawn to these researches turn their eyes towards the non-Christian Traditions: Hinduism, Buddhism, Sufism and others. It would certainly be exciting to compare esoteric thinking in these different systems, because the Tradition is One, and whoever delves deeply into these studies will not fail to be struck by this essential unity. Yet to those who desire to go beyond pure speculation, the problem appears in a different light. This unique Tradition has been and still is now being presented in multiple forms, each meticulously adapted to the mentality and spirit of the human group to which its Word is addressed, and to the mission with which this group has been charged. For the Christian world, the easiest way, the least difficult way to reach the goal, is to follow the esoteric Doctrine which forms the basis of the Christian Tradition. Actually, the thought of a man who has been born and formed at the heart of our civilization, be he Christian or not, believer or atheist, is impregnated with twenty centuries of Christian culture. It is incomparably easier for him to begin his studies starting from this environment, rather than to adapt to the spirit of an environment different from his own. Transplantation is not without danger, and generally gives hybrid products."

This last statement is the danger alluded to by Charlotte, but it's been addressed sufficiently by those operating the website to warrant the belief that they are proceeding with caution.

Tony Ciapo on 2012-05-27 at 23:52 said:

Logres, lest you mislead casual readers, neither Evola, Guenon, nor anyone here has claimed to be part of any elite. What Evola did is describe his vision of how a *future* elite may arise and manifest itself. As you yourself pointed out, this is not, strictly speaking, a merely human enterprise; to think so is to ignore the third dimension of history.

It is true that we prefer the Medieval civilization as the model for Tradition, for the reasons you specified. However, let me make it clear, there are pagan, Muslim, and Hindu readers who do not accept all the beliefs of that era. If you want to focus exclusively on "Christian Hermetism", I suggest you move the conversation to http://www.MeditationsOnTheTarot.com. I suggest the topic of "freedom", which Charlotte claims, following the Jacobins, is man's natural state. Jesus, OTOH, said only the Truth will make you free. The saints have claimed that man

in his "natural state" is not free, but rather a slave to his passions. Which side do you plan to take, Logres? You can play Higgins to Pygmalion if that is your cup of tea, just don't fill up the comboxes here with your efforts. A further point is that we are not defending the Traditional worldview, but rather we are simply describing it as best we can. I'm sure it is quite shocking to someone wandering in the dark fog of the illusions of modernity. After all, isn't to be called "medieval" considered an insult in today's world?

Hence, while debate on specific points can be useful, we are not out to convert anyone to a specific worldview. In any case, only an intellectual conversion is of value, and that won't happen from reading a blog.

Moreover, critics are obliged to try to understand what is being said here and not resort to special pleading. For a guest to come here and accuse everyone else of "illogicality", and following the "dark side", on the basis of claims to special knowledge and even moral superiority is simply rude if not absurd.

Charlotte on 2012-05-28 at 06:46 said:

Tony, I'm sorry if you thought I was being boastful – I am not a boastful, prideful person, I'm actually very shy away from writing and have such terrible self esteem that it infuriates most people who know me personally. It really makes me wonder why I continue to get into these things, I must be a true masochist lol!

I only retell personal experiences when I think they might resonate with someone, or to show that I understand what they are trying to say. Unfortunatley many people interpret that as boastful, so most of the time I don't share them anymore. Certainly they don't appear to be of interest so are therefore not worthwhile. I don't believe I said the man in question was a Sufi 'leader', although he might have been and I didn't know it. He was in fact a poor artist I met in a store while looking at pictures and admiring the work, and I actually thought people here might find the tone of the conversation amusing under the circumstances... it was all the more amusing from my point of view because at almost exactly the same time as I spoke to this Sufi I was harangued rather abusively on email by an extremely vehehment member of the Falun Gong who said he thought I wouldn't recognise Jesus if I bumped into him on the street, which of course had just happened, in name at least. I guess it's one of those situations where you just had to be there to get it, but you are right, this is probably not a good place to share personal experience because the concern here is with theory, and the medium of communication we're using is not ideal.

Too much gets lost in translation when people can't hear tone or read body language. Also, I didn't discuss spirituality with the falafel seller as I really didn't want to talk about spirituality with anyone and barely said a word to the Sufi either – I didn't have anything I felt worthy to share, I only wanted to see Hagia Sophia.

And I wasn't accusing you all of following the dark side, I was saying I think there is a

spirt of darkness coming from the Evola work that I'm sensitive to and I felt it my duty to point this out. Is that really an unfair assessment, bearing in mind I am new to his work? Do you only want to preach to the congregation or are you interested at all in introducing new people to the work of someone you believe is so valuable? Can you blame them for questioning what so many others have felt it necessary to question? I don't doubt for one minute that Cologero and others mean well, but I wouldn't be a very good friend if I did not sound a warning bell if and when I saw possible trouble. Why would you bother to resurrect Evola from ashes if you did not believe there was a spiritual force to his work that can act upon people. In me (as a new reader) you have a perfect guinea pig by which to gauge these reactions and yet you get angry with the creature when an effect occurs... .again, I'm missing the compassion that gives me cause to doubt the overall value, although I believe I have already pointed out that I think some of what Evola wrote is useful and that he is maybe even more helpful than Tomberg at one or two critical junturs pertaining to the labyrinth of the Kali Yuga. however, I'm not persuaded away from my basic view that the left hand path will only get you so far and if you want to escape the cycle of reincarnation (however this is to be understood), the only way out is the pure way.

I also felt that the purpose of the site was not clear, it seemed that on some levels an attempt was being made to found in the spiritual planes this 'ideal hierarchy', for want of a better term – a not unreasonable desire, such a thing is needed – yet you now confirm that you're simply trying to describe the meaning of Evola et al. In the latter case then fair enough, there is no need for me to be worried. I am only concerned with the essence of the former (and maybe this concern is what's been affecting my assessment of the activities here, I can see that now) and the way it turns out to be, so in that case yes, I am better off focusing on the Meditations and prayer. I misunderstood your motives and intentions with this website and this is where my concerns have arisen from.

By the way I don't feel ashamed of my defence of humanity – it's a tough job but someone has to do it. We all hate communism, but is the peasant really worse than a Stalin? And I'm not follow the 'Jacobites', I'm not following anyone except Christ – well, trying to anyway, even if I stumble and fall very often.

But maybe you should make this a closed forum if you don't want guests' opinions? I don't have to think you're converting people to have an opinion do I? Are any opinions welcomed at all if they differ at all from the overall consensus in any shape or form? One cannot get very far in the hermetic task of nailing down the opposites if one refuses to countenance any form of challenge to their ideas... And as for feelings and the value of them, well, I appreciate the warning that they'll be used against me as I understand it's made in a friendly spirit. The way I see it there's something called 'balance', and it seems as if the balance here often veers so far towards that of what is seen as rationality (although I don't agree that everything presented as such here really is ultimate rationality) that one's desire for balance and temperace is greatly assaulted! There needs to be a counterweight and like I said before, if I'm the only one willing

to play the fool then it won't be the first time... But Logres, thank you for your more kindly sentiments, they are certainly appreciated and I know you are a Christian. I'm not meaning to have digs at people that isn't my style at all – in my mind there are very important principles at stake and I am willing to stand up for those, but I realise there are rocks and hard places lying around here and don't want myself or anyone else to get pointlessly bruised.

The work of catharsis and purification is – according to what I know anyway – achieved by focusing on Christ and love – the mind can only take us so far, it's love alone that can bring us to our knees.

As for the relative value of being hot or cold, we can at least all take heart from the fact that we're not lukewarm!! blessings to you all Cx

Angolmois on 2012-05-28 at 11:27 said:

It seems to me that Evola is attractive to a lot of masculine men who are of some ancient and even archaic kshatriya tendency, and this is very truthfully dangerous in todays spiritual climate. What Evola needs to be complemented with is Christian love and compassion, in theoretical and intellectual sense he is very much to the core in esoteric matters. Evola is too solar, I have said this many times, and it even caused his "accident" which happened in the course of the war and into the solar plexus chakra. We all need to learn from this: there is absolutely no room for spiritual violence after Christ.

There is a good text about intellect and love in Sophia Perennis website that discusses Guénon's and Schuon's possible prejudices against love:

http://www.sophiaperennis.com/discussion-forums/general-discussion/were-rene-guenon-and-frithjof-schuon-biased-against-love/

Charlotte: Guénon was a catholic when he lived ini France. He turned towards sufism because he moved into a muslim country. This is how traditional men and women act, it is part of being courteous and a way of "choosing a tradition" that fits ones intellectual and even aesthetic sensibilities.

I have seen a lot of criticism of Evola here, and that is a very good thing. You may be over-reacting, Charlotte, but I'm very glad that you have brought things up!

My blessings and love are with all of you, as always.

Matt on 2012-05-28 at 11:33 said:

"By the way I don't feel ashamed of my defence of humanity"

Charlotte, I don't think anyone here is trying to make you feel ashamed for defending humanity. It seems to me that you are afraid that the idea of a spiritual elite (elect might be a better term) is synonymous with misanthropy,and its about getting revenge on the masses, which is the exact opposite of its intended meaning here. As previously stated, the elect is about renewal, one that is to the benefit of the mass (even if they can't see that benefit due to being

caught up with the various illusions of modernity), which is reflective and therefore needs to be formed by that which is beyond it.

There is nothing wrong with being cautious... .whether it be about certain missteps in this or that thinker's thought, but too much caution can lead to a fear that is unhealthy.

Charlotte on 2012-05-28 at 13:58 said:

Ah, thank you Angolmois, I was hoping I would manage to get my point across somehow and I'm glad it made sense on some level! yes, there is a lack of love in them, which is the single biggest problem currently afflicting humanity. With more love the world could be a far more beautiful, safe and magical place for everyone.

Also thank you for clarifying about Guenon, that makes some sense, although I have to wonder if it was simply an outer conversion? It is one thing to outwardly 'be as the Romans when in Rome', but another to fully change one's inner religion?

Thank you for the article, I shall read this with interest. Giving preference to 'Truth' over 'Love' is a tenet of Eastern Buddhist based philosophy, with the Falun Gong I mentioned being a good example of this (from what I hear). This is one very popular worldview, of course, but it is not that of the Western mystery tradition, which makes a clear distinction between creator and creator, lover and Beloved. This is at the heart of the immense dangers of the 'theosophic' philosophies of the kind promoted by the 'new age movement', although it is very very difficult indeed to see this danger when one is in the thick of the magical output – the blinding light of Lucifer is to be treated with more than caution – better the cloud of unknowing in this part of the circle, or 'mantle of the Virgin', as someone mentioned lately, the Armour of God. (LSD, by the way, long considered a product of the 'hippy movement', was created by the Tavistock Institute for official purposes – remember this is when satanism started to be spread in the western world ona mass scale. We should remember also how the illuminati principles (I won't say 'elite') have influenced this movement – this is actually rather scary if one thinks about it carefully).

Sure as anything we all need to put on some form of protection when traversing the zone of contradiction, belt of lies and realm of Maya and we all better believe that if we want to avoid getting deep fried! Maybe I'm overreacting... again it wouldn't be the first time... .buy maybe I'm not! Suffice it to say I felt sufficient cause to urge immediate assumption of the Helmet of Salvation for everyone, better safe than sorry – we should all be fully aware of the types of works that have been used to stimulate the thought memes of the new age movement – Blavatsky, Bailey and Crowley for sure – what about Guenon? maybe he is not well known enough. Evola would have given them something to react against, in that respect the grey area can get so dark it's bound to work against the overall cause. you know even Teilhard to Chardin has been used to promote new age philosophy (Via Terrence McKenna). Of course the supreme danger of 'information wars' is that there is a percentage of dazzling truth in there that lulls people into a sense of complacency with respect to the rest.

Matt, an accident with the solar plexus does not sound great at all (we've been speaking of occult wars remember, it's electrical information so sparks can be expected – but full on melt downs are a scary business and it's better to keep watering those fuel rods!) – indeed it is something to greatly fear and endeavour to avoid, the same go somehow damaging any of the chakras. Can you tell us more about how this incident occurred Angolmois?

Charlotte on 2012-05-28 at 14:37 said:

I just read the start of an essay from someone in the UR group pointing out the immense dangers of inadvertently undergoing a counter initiation. I was actually going to write something like that earlier but as it was relating to personal experience and that's been banned I thought it best not to. Here's what 'Arvo' has to say about it:

Those who attempt to overcome human limitations and yearn to attain knowledge and power need to be aware of the existence of what, using Rene Guenon's term, one may call the counter-initiation. They also need to have an idea of the various forms assumed by it, as well as of the different means it employs to achieve its goals. As a starting point, we may take the general idea that forces exist which attempt to insert themselves into the human domain, both at an individual and at a collective level, not only in order to mislead every aspiration to true spirituality, but also in order to create new currents, suggestions, and ideological systems. These are such as to blur the vision of truth, to falsify values, to favor the emergence of inferior influences, namely of every form of materialism, disorder, and subversion in civilizations. The opposition between the forces of "good" and "evil" is a commonplace in religions; however, this does not adequately deal with the issues at stake. It is not simply a question of the moral and religious order, but of an action much larger, objective, and concrete, which the representatives of religion themselves often fail to recognize, at times even falling unconsciously as victims to it.

See this is what I'm talking about people, I'm more convinced than ever I was right to flag warning signs in grey areas...

logres on 2012-05-28 at 15:02 said:

C, nevertheless, Tony & Cologero are right to warn you about implicitly accepting the French Revolution. Man is born in chains, to himself. The Counter Initiation just makes use of that fact.

Charlotte on 2012-05-28 at 15:27 said:

And how about this one:

Evola himself wrote that the aim of the "chain" of the UR Group, aside from "awakening a higher force that might serve to help the singular work of every individual," was also to act "on the type of psychic body that begged for creation, and by evocation to connect it with a genuine

influence from above," so that "one may perhaps have the possibility of working behind the scenes in order to ultimately exert an effect on the prevailing forces in the general environment."

See how can it be wrong to double-check in this situation?? I knew it was there, impossible to hide, I was just taking part in a chain reaction :-)

12.17 From Crisis to Revolt

> I don't know if the following review by **Rene Guenon** of Revolt against the Modern World has been published anywhere, but it is worth including here for the issues it raises. Like **Ananda Coomaraswamy**, Guenon's primary objection is also the emphasis of regality over the sacerdotal caste. Those who would take Evola's position seem to do so because they object to the word "supremacy", and then interpret the relationship between priest and king as a one way, rather than a mutual, relationship.

Evola's case is weakened by his misunderstanding of the rite of the purohita. Evola simply pulled the relevant reference to the Aitareya Brahmana from subsequent editions of the book, but continued the same theme as though it had never existed. This makes Evola's discussion on that topic suspect; besides, he offers many historical examples, but is short on demonstrating the principles that would support his case.

In his review of Coomaraswamy's *Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power in the Indian Theory of Government*, Guenon delves deeper into this topic, from the point of view of principle. As Mr. Shankar has pointed out in a recent comment, this needs to start with the principle that unites priest and king rather than on what divides them. Furthermore, as the exterior is a reflection of the interior, we need to discern the roles of priest and king in our inner life.

First of all, Evola misrepresents the role of King in the **Ancient City** as documented by **Fustel de Coulanges**. It wasn't the case that the King had priority; rather that the roles of both Priest and King were held by

one man, and thus were united. The regression of castes, then, occurred with the rebellion of the aristocracy, who split up the roles of the Priest-King, stripping him of his kingly function, leaving him as the High Priest of the city.

In that case, the understanding of the relationship between the spiritual and temporal makes little sense in Evola's scheme. The King's role is always in the temporal realm, or manifestation, which is the reflection of the spiritual, and the unmanifest, the province of the Priest. Again, this is necessarily a mutual relationship, so the question of supremacy is irrelevant. As for the King standing in for God, as Evola claims, this is a partial picture. In the Medieval system, Christ is both Priest and King. Hence, the King is God ordained, but that does not exhaust that claim. For the High Priest is likewise the Vicar of Christ in his own domain.

The King rules by edict, that is, the word; spiritual authority, however, comes from the idea, or thought[21], to which the word is the reflection on the plane of manifestation. Hence, the King lays down the law, which is supreme in his realm, but infallibility has never been claimed by the King; that is a quality of the Priest.

Guenon points out that, viewed from the microcosm, these roles appear as the two atmas, i.e., the Self and the Ego. Establishing their proper relationship within, is part of the spiritual task, or "Holy War". Coomarawamy writes:

> The outer, active, feminine, and mortal aspect of our nature subsists more eminently in its inner, contemplative, masculine, and immortal side, to which it can and must be 'reduced', that is to say, brought back or reunited.

Guenon comments:

> For a king, autonomy consists in not letting himself be ruled by the multitude subordinate to him, and likewise for each person,

[21] https://gornahoor.net/?p=3936

> in not letting himself by ruled by the inferior and contingent elements of his being. Hence the two meanings of the 'holy war' for the establishment and maintenance of order in both cases.

By fighting this war within, the Priest and King are united in a common battle. As Coomarawamy pointed out in his review of Revolt Against the Modern World[22], Evola tends to absolutize this issue, categorizing things in absolute dichotomies of masculine/feminine or solar/lunar. However, these are relative terms. The King is masculine in respect to his realm and his subjects, but feminine to the spiritual and transcendental. To deny this is to make the King something he clearly is not; it also has deleterious consequences to one's inner spiritual life.

The following review was originally published in *Le Voile d'Isis*, Paris, May 1934.

> In this new work, the author opposes traditional civilization to modern civilization, the former having a transcendent and essentially hierarchical character, and the latter founded on a purely human and contingent element. He then describes the phases of spiritual decadence that has led from the traditional world to the modern world. We will have some reservations to make on some points: so, when dealing with the original source of the two sacerdotal and regal powers, the author has a very definite tendency to put the emphasis on the regal aspect at the expense of the sacerdotal aspect. When he distinguishes two types of tradition that he relates respectively to the North and the South, the latter of these two terms appears to us as a little inaccurate, even if he does not mean it in a strictly "geographic" sense, since it seems to pertain especially to Atlantis, which, in every way, corresponds to the West, not the South. We also fear that he sees in primitive Buddhism something different from what it was in reality, since he praises

[22] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=4274`

> it in way that is not absolutely encompassed in the traditional point of view. On the other hand, he disdains Pythagoreanism in a manner that is poorly justified. We could also point out other similar things.
>
> This must not prevent us from recognizing, as is right, the merit and interest of the work as a whole, and to bring it in a particular way to the attention of all those who are concerned with the "crisis of the modern world", and who think like us that the only effective means of remediating it would consist in a return to the traditional spirit beyond which nothing truly "constructive" could be effectively undertaken.

Posted on 2012-05-29 by Cologero

* * *

`Angolmois on 2012-05-31 at 01:50 said:`

Evola's mistakes and mis-representations are too serious not to be pin-pointed and repeated. As in the case of Nietzsche as well, his personal life is the best proof that there were some black holes in his thought and "philosophy". I see no "obsession" in Cologero's points, but I do see a fundamental mis-representation and mis-understanding of Evola in many other mansions of the anglosphere.

`Mihai on 2012-05-31 at 05:47 said:`

@HOO: I am afraid that when discussing Evola, things tend to degenerate from rational debate to name-calling and one-sided blind arguments rather quickly, sometimes resembling arguments fought over football teams.

The problem is that it is nearly impossible to completely exclude the individual equation as long as one is still human, so a degree of partiality, no matter how small, is normal- in all these thinkers.

My take on this subject is like this: a king, as long as he embodies both spiritual authority and temporal power- that is he exercises both vertical and horizontal power- is an image of the Divine, of the Center. However, the spiritual aspect in him- the vertical dimension- is superior to his warrior aspect- the horizontal one. As a function, the king is the synthesis of both priest and warrior and as such he rules over both.

Where Evola makes a mistake is where he tries to make these two aspects- warrior and sacerdotal- as being equal, with no importance in which of these holds the higher place.

Furthermore, I think this site is quite respectful and well inclined towards Evola, the only place where it has reservations are some of his more controversial aspects.

Angolmois on 2012-05-31 at 11:02 said:

@HOO: Guénon's own mistakes or mis-understadings (of Buddhism, towards which he changed his attitude after Coomaraswamy) do not relate to his right understanding of Evola's mis-representation of the relationship between royalty and pontificate. I personally agree with Mihai's understanding of the issue.

In discussing 'The Hermetic Tradition', I think it is good to understand that the royal path of alchemy is more cosmic and psychic than universal and "beyond cosmos". This makes it suitable for hermeticists and for the royal caste, and the relation that Evola makes between 'the white phase' and 'the red phase', making the latter superior to the former, is right only in its own context. Yet, tt should not be made a general principle, since it relates to the supra-individual concept of 'coming back to earth' (descending realization) and not into the relationship between sacerdotal caste and the royal caste.

12.18 Eliade on Evola's Revolt

I don't believe **Mircea Eliade's**[23] review of **Julius Evola**'s Revolt against the Modern World is available in English. It was originally published in the Romanian journal *Vremea*, VIII, n. 382, Bucarest, 31 March 1935. Eliade would go on to become a world-renowned historian of religion from his position at the University of Chicago. His books are essential reading, although they are not written from the Traditional point of view, but rather intended for a general audience. Nevertheless, he corresponded with Evola and was involved with Tradition and what is now called "far right" politics. This should be obvious from the authors he recommends in this review. As we have pointed out, his position is what well-bred men considered sane and normal prior to the French Revolu-

[23] https://ro.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mircea_Eliade

> tion. As Galileo insisted about the earth, "yet it moves", what used to be the far left is now considered sane and normal. Humanity has "evolved", except for what remains of well-bred men.
>
> Eliade's review follows. We see he overrated Rosenberg, who is now forgotten, and underrated Evola, who was ahead of his time.

This Revolt against the Modern World is the title of Julius Evola's latest book. Julius Evola is an author too little known beyond the Italian border. In Germany, a short time ago, another of his books, *Heidnischer Imperialismus*, was translated, a modified and, above all, politicized, version of his work *Pagan Imperialism*[24]. In France, I don't believe that there is anyone besides **Rene Guenon** who cites or reviews his books. Nevertheless, Evola is one of the most interesting minds of the war WW I generation. Revolt can be compared—for its historical vision and courageous interpretation—to books like Spengler's Decline of the West or Rosenberg's Myth of the 20th Century, even if it will not have by far the same echo of those two books. Everything contributes to Evola's isolation in the field of thought and modern culture: the rigour of his philosophical analysis, his critical spirit, and the courage that he has in supporting a "traditional" science that is opposed to fragmented, atomized, secular science.

Evola is ignored by specialists because he goes beyond their mental schemes. He is inaccessible to dilettantes, because he has recourse to a truly prodigious erudition, and at the same time does not make any concession to the presentation of his ideas (it is a way of saying why Evola has no ideas that are his "own").

He made his debut with very serious philosophical studies on Idealism. On the other hand, his philosophical formation was recognized even by specialists, and his fundamental work — Theory and Phenomenology of the Absolute Individual — is the most serious book on **Magical**

[24] `https://tinyurl.com/yam974ra`

Idealism that had been written up until now. Moving from philosophy to culture and social criticism, Evola always gave proof of a sense of direction and of a unity of a typically Italian attitude. Evola's view is simple: in this view, that no ideology has adopted, he affirms and reaffirms "traditional" values. With this term, nevertheless, he means every value created by a civilization that does not make life an end in itself, but considers that human existence is uniquely a means to reach a spiritual, transcendent reality. Evola never exposed more completely and with more fervor what thing this "traditionalism" means as much as in Revolt. We recommend this book to all those who wish, if not to go back to old questions, at least to contemplate an explanation of the world and history of a fascinating greatness.

Similar works can be read in very numerous ways: by people ready to accept everything at their own risk and danger, or to refute everything in the same way; but also by persons ready to receive suggestions from wherever they come from, and who are enthusiastic in being able to verify them in any circumstances.

We can say that Evola's work is situated in the cultural lines of Gobineau, Chamberlain, Spengler, Rosenberg. With much more "seriousness", however—as paradoxical that this affirmation can seem — Evola has not forgotten and has not renounced his earlier mentioned studies: he is more "philosopher", but rather in a totally unusual way. Magical Idealism brought to its extreme limits is a meal difficult to digest. It is not part of our intentions to bring up this book, that is both anti-Christian and anti-political at the same time, as well as opposed to communists and fascists, that denies a great quantity of living things and values that today crush us, affirming only "dead" things and values which no one in our times believes in any longer. Evola does not come under any influence. This is what makes him sympathetic. As to the resonance of his thought in Romania it must be remembered that I published a long article on his work at the end of 1927, while in 1928 I developed a study on his magical

philosophy, which remains a manuscript this is apparently lost . Later the only one that he mentioned by name, in our country, was, in 1933, our colleague Vasile Lovinescu[25].

Posted on 2012-05-30 by Cologero

* * *

HOO on 2012-05-30 at 22:52 said:

We do appreciate the effort of Gornahoor &c. of providing all this material and a number of interesting points.

Cologero on 2012-05-30 at 23:23 said:

Hoo, the points of contention I bring up are not those I am obsessed with, but rather those that are in dispute among the best thinkers of Tradition. I doubt such disputes (e.g., regal vs sacerdotal) will be resolved here, but it is necessary to make the distinctions clear. Some men will take one side or the other; some will remain undecided. The point, for now, is moot, since there is no imminent need to take a fixed stand.

Mihai on 2012-05-31 at 05:26 said:

Cologero, where did you find this review translated?

I am Romanian myself so I am curious who had access to this (quite rare) stuff.

Cologero on 2012-05-31 at 05:33 said:

It can be found in the last Italian edition of Revolt. Obviously, I translated it from the Italian translation of Eliade's original, written in Romanian.

Avery on 2012-06-01 at 00:19 said:

Myth of the 20th Century can be found here:

http://www.gnosticliberationfront.com/myth_of_the_20th_century.htm

The author is well-read and well-bred, and he is able to command in the language of the era rather than being commanded by it. Definitely the book will offer a bit of insight for anyone who wants to read it. But unlike Spengler, Guenon, and Evola, Rosenberg seems stuck in the

[25] https://ro.wikipedia.org/wiki/Vasile_Lovinescu

metaphysics of his era and fails to transcend it. Here's an example of one of his more dishonest moments:

"However, their numbers were conveniently diminished by the usual expedient of being burnt by the officers of the religion of love. A single Inquisitor persecuted the Waldensian community. For thirteen years, he was repeatedly successful in catching many of them who had made some heretical remark. Prisoners were then tortured on the rack, had their hands cut off, were strangled or burned alive. In spite of this, the archbishop of Embrum had to report to the pope that the Waldensians remained obdurate in their faith."

This is a sort Christopher Hitchens-style anti-church spiel, basically hating on believers for being too sure of themselves. Rosenberg lacks Nietzsche's ability to stand back from a fight which always involves at least two sides. You would not see this passage in any of the three writers I listed above, and probably Eliade, having read Spengler and Evola, never wrote anything like it either.

`Avery on 2012-06-02 at 11:08 said:`

Interesting quote about this review from "The International Eliade" (SUNY Press, 2007):

"As Paola Pisi points out, the review does not correspond exactly to the content of the book: Eliade writes that Evola is 'anti-Christian and antipolitical' ... moreover, he misunderstands–as we will see later–the Evolian conception of 'Tradition'."

`Revd Frank Julian Gelli on 2012-06-07 at 13:31 said:`

Not a very good review, considering that it came from an excellent scholar like Eliade. Plenty of eulogies but he is vague and fails to give the real kernel of Evola's argument in 'Revolt'. Maybe when he wrote it he was nodding? However, I agree with Avery on Rosenberg's 'Myth' – both the book and its author are best forgotten.

12.19 Guenon on the Young Evola

Two letters from Rene Guenon to Guido de Giorgio regarding Julius Evola. Although Evola translated and promoted Guenon's works in Italy, Guenon had some reservations about Evola's approach. Unfortunately, because of that association, certain political views have been attributed to Guenon that he never personally held.

> He is a fool because he does not know what everyone knows; he is a sage because he knows what everyone does not know.

Fulvio Mocco, *I Tarocchi esoterici*

Rene Guenon was described by **Julius Evola** on many occasions as the 'Master of the 20th century'. By the time Evola began his public writing career, Guenon had already had more than 20 years of experience in Tradition, including initiations into Hermetism, Sufism, and Vedanta. Guenon had no interest in Western philosophy as such. In his trilogy Man and his becoming, Symbolism of the Cross, and Multiple States of Being, he expounded Traditional metaphysics, based primarily on the Vedanta and Sufism. Therein is revealed an understanding of non-duality, the ultimate reality, in terms suitable for a Westerner.

When we discuss Evola, we strive to do so, in the light of Guenon. When there is a discrepancy in formulations, Guenon's position needs to be evaluated very carefully before discarding it. We understand the appeal of Evola; he provides a virile spirituality in a world of effeminate churches and clergy. Yet we must urge those who come to Tradition only through Evola to also delve deeply into Guenon.

We provide here two letters from Guenon to **Guido de Giorgio** regarding Evola, when Evola was under 30 years old. De Giorgio, an initiate into Sufism and a colleague of Guenon, introduced Evola to Tradition in the Ur group. As Guenon notes, Evola's misunderstandings flow from his philosophical position, which is ultimately incompatible with metaphysics. Evola's protests don't ring true, since, as we saw in a recent post regarding Mircea Eliade[26], the former's philosophy was integral to his work.

For Evola, the ultimate was the Absolute Individual, which is not the same as non-dual metaphysics. He also took Bachofen's notion of Solar and Lunar cultures too far, applying them to various traditions. Now a legitimate tradition is based on principle, so the solar/lunar distinction is beside the point. He was also attached to Weininger's theory of the

[26] https://gornahoor.net/?p=4303

Absolute Male and Absolute Female. That may be interesting on the psychological level, but is misleading on a spiritual or transcendental level. Male and Female form a polarity, united by a third term (see Guenon's Great Triad). They are also relative. For example, a knight is masculine in relation to the King's subjects, but feminine in relation to the king. To absolutize one pole would be like making Yang the supreme principle rather than the Tao.

In the letters from Guenon to de Giorgio, we see Guenon's early frustration with the youthful Evola. They speak for themselves to those who understand what is at stake. The first letter is from 20 November 1925.

> Thank you for the issue of Bilychnis that you sent me; since then, I received from Evola himself a complete packet of other journals containing some of his articles. In acknowledging its reception, I told him that I had some serious reservations to make on his point of view that appeared to me too philosophical. He wrote me a somewhat long, rather confused, letter, in which he protested that the philosophical form he uses is for him only a simple means of exposition that does not affect his doctrine itself. I believe none of it. I persist in thinking that he is really too imbued with philosophy, and especially with German philosophy. In an article published in the journal Ultra, he alluded to me in a note, concerning East and West, in terms that prove that he did not understand very much about what I expounded; all the same, he goes as far to describe me as a 'rationalist', which is really ridiculous (considering that it concerns a book where I expressly asserted the falsity of rationalism!), and which clearly shows that he is among those who cannot get rid of philosophical labels and who feel the need to apply them wrongly everywhere. He informed me of his intention to write an article on Man and his becoming; I ask myself what that could be like; we'll see eventually... Since we are speaking of Evola, it is yet necessary that I tell you that he was hurt

> by Reghini's criticisms of him, even though in a very moderated form. He must be rather vain and would like to have nothing but eulogies; it is true that he is very young. Vulliaud, who does not have the same excuse, is almost as sensitive; it appears that he also was rather displeased with my article; he imagines that he alone knows the Kabbalah and is capable of speaking of it. He is in fear that Evola will soon do as much for the Tantras, although he is not very qualified to take it on; he sees all that through his philosophy, from where a deformation arises in the German manner. The true conception of Shakti is a completely different thing from 'voluntarism'.

The second letter is from 26 January 1926

> Evola doesn't lack any pretentions, as you see; but, for my part, I continue to think that he does not understand at all what we mean by 'intellectuality', 'knowledge', 'contemplation', etc., and that he doesn't even know how to make the distinction between the 'initiatic' point of view and the 'profane' point of view. It appears that he has the intention to publish a review of my work on the Vedanta in the journal Realistic Idealism; we will see what that will be. In any case, in spite of everything that we have tried to explain to him, he persists in finding 'rationalism' in the Vedanta, all while failing to recognize that he then takes this word 'rationalism' in a rather different sense that is usually given to it.

Posted on 2012-05-31 by Cologero

* * *

`Zm on 2012-05-31 at 22:54 said:`

Yes, JE did gain wisdom in maturity.

What, pray, is the reason (if any) for the relative absence of references to F. Schuon here? His "Observations" on RG could be made the basis of some profitable discussion.

Cologero on 2012-05-31 at 23:39 said:

Good point, Zm. Revolt, published nearly a decade later, did earn respect from Guenon despite his reservations. The simple answer to your question is that I am not as familiar with Schuon's works. In any case, there is abundant material available on Schuon elsewhere.

Abdul Mateen on 2012-06-07 at 07:30 said:

I like your post, your post is very important for me.. contact me to visit http://zulfiqarahmadnaqshbandi.com

Numen on 2017-05-03 at 14:08 said:

Quite illuminating, thank you for the translations, as always.

I remember reading a joke once about Evola and Guenon's relationship. Basically went like, Guenon was the only person who bought any of the French editions of Evola's work. It is interesting that, despite Evola's early arrogance and ignorance, Guenon seemed to see something in Evola worth correcting.

12.20 Guenon and Islam

Regarding **Rene Guenon**'s ultimate decision to follow a Sufi path[27], he wrote:

> Contrary to what takes place in 'conversion', nothing here implies the attribution of the superiority of one traditional form over another. It is merely a question of what one might call reasons of spiritual expediency, which is altogether different from simple individual 'preference'.

It may be instructive to explore the reasons behind that "spiritual expediency", which is not the same as psychoanalyzing Guenon from afar. No, it is a question only of intellectual reasons, not personal or psychological.

For reasons of spiritual expediency, Guenon followed a path beginning with the French Hermetic revival. He came to reject this, but not

[27] See Section 13.39 in this book.

in toto, since he continued to refer to the writings of certain Hermetists. He then tried to influence Catholic circles. For example, Fundamental Symbols is replete with Christian symbolism. In Crisis of the Modern World, Guenon asserted that only a return to Catholicism could restore Tradition to the West. Eventually, however, Guenon was rejected by the Thomist philosopher **Jacques Maritain**, precipitating Guenon's break with this approach. Personal factors — the death of his wife followed by a trip to Egypt — provided the opportunity to adopt Islam totally. As we will see, certain characteristics of Islam fit perfectly into Guenon's idea of Tradition; we therefore suspect that he may even have generalized Islamic theology to provide his understanding of Tradition. Therefore, there is no surprise that most of his closest followers themselves adopted Islam.

Tradition We owe it to Guenon for delineating the features of religious traditions intellectually. This accounts for the variety of religious forms in a manner totally different from the historical, empirical, archaeological, empirical, and exegetical approaches appropriate to academic research. He identified several specific traditions, specifically, Taoism, Hinduism, certain pagan mystery schools, Medieval Christianity, and Islam.

Nevertheless, some traditions are more comfortable within the parameters specified by Guenon than others. In particular, Christianity, as conventionally understood, rejects certain aspects of it. The most prominent theologians favorable to Guenon — Jean Borella, Philip Sherrard, Seraphim Rose — eventually rejected the Traditional approach. Neopagan revivals, as long as they are bound to certain of Evola's heterodox notions, also reject some primary elements of Tradition, so are doomed to insignificance. Let's look at the lineaments of Tradition as Guenon outlined.

Categorical The fundamental point to grasp is that for Guenon, Tradition is categorical, not essential. That is, it categorizes traditions according to certain criteria, but is not a Tradition itself. Therefore, to call oneself a Traditionalist, "at-large" as it were[28], represents a misunderstanding. Rather, one must follow a specific tradition, albeit understood within these categories. Under normal circumstances, that means a man follows the Tradition of his own place and time. Whether or not a specific religious form is a Tradition is a question decided by these categories.

- **Authentic**

  A religious form is an authentic tradition if it is "orthodox" in Guenon's sense. I.e., is it doctrinally consistent with the ultimate metaphysical principles?

- **Complete**

  Does it have a complete understanding, or are some things lacking? This lack does not necessarily make it heterodox.

- **Living**

  Since principles cannot be fully understood merely from reading and studying, continuously existing initiatory organizations are required to pass on that knowledge. A living tradition will have such groups; a religious form may have lost them, remaining just a shell of what it once was.

Note that the Evolian categories have absolutely no relevance. Hence, his several attempts to label traditions as solar vs lunar, Nordic vs Mediterranean, Aryan vs Semitic, etc., add nothing to our understanding. They are not based on any metaphysical principles but derive from profane sources, primarily Bachofen and Weininger.

[28] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=728`

Esoteric vs Exoteric Traditional doctrines have two complementary aspects. Guenon writes (incidentally illustrating our point):

> Of all traditional doctrines, perhaps Islamic doctrine most clearly distinguishes the two complementary parts, which can be labeled exoterism (*sharia*) and esoterism (*haqiqa*).

He defines them this way:

- The exoteric aspect is the "great way", common to all.
- The esoteric is the inward truth, reserved to an elite. This is from the very nature of things, since not all men possess the qualifications required to reach knowledge of the truth.

The exoteric part is a rule of action (laws, rites, etc.) and the esoteric represents pure knowledge. The esoteric must also include a way, or path, to achieve that knowledge. There must be no conflict between the exoteric and the esoteric; they look at the same thing from a different perspective. (The exoteric from the circumference, the esoteric from the center).

Unfortunately, what often happens is that the vulgar misinterpret the verbal formulations of the esoteric as a new doctrine, opposed to the exoteric. This causes strife and results in religious forms detached from any tradition; New Age movements are obvious examples.

Multiplicity of Forms This is a fundamental doctrine of Islam, which teaches that there have been several revelations made to mankind at various times. The Koran names 25 prophets (including Jesus), and admits many more. Hence the existence of multiple religious forms poses no threat to exoteric dogma. Exoteric Christianity regards those religious forms as false and Jesus as unique. Although we have provided several examples of a broader outlook, this is a hurdle many will find difficult to overcome.

Primordial Tradition Guenon claims that there was a Primordial Tradition, and subsequent religious forms derive from it. Guenon uses the doctrines of the Vedanta as the prime examples for Tradition; this is consistent with the belief of some Traditionalists that the Vedanta was the original revelation made to Adam. The idea of a Primordial Tradition is consistent with Islamic dogma.

Exoteric Christianity believes in a series of covenants made between God and Adam, Abraham, Moses, etc., but specifically excludes all peoples outside them. Furthermore, outside from a few writers, salvation is not the attempt to return to the Primordial state of Adam.

Ahistorical Tradition is ahistorical, that is, it depends on a revelation from above, not on any specifically historical factors. Once again, this is consistent with Islam, but not exoteric Christianity, which sees tradition as the outcome of specific historical events.

Final Revelation Islam claims to be the final revelation made to man, an idea also asserted by Guenon, although he would add "in this cycle". This doctrine is difficult to justify solely from metaphysical principles, so we can explore the reasons. Guenon's justification is that it is the only tradition to arise within history rather than prehistory. Another factor is that previous revelations were given to specific peoples at specific times for their own benefit. Islam, on the other hand, claims to be universal, the final revelation for which every prior one was a preparation. This universality is affirmed by Guenon:

> If there is a tradition where questions of race and origin do not in any way arise, it is certainly Islam, which in fact counts among its adherents men belonging to the most diverse races.

Posted on 2012-06-24 by Cologero

* * *

Michael on 2012-06-24 at 16:20 said:

Interesting post, but I (gently) disagree with some of its points. First, with regards to being ahistorical, it is true that Christianity (and Judaism) look back to specific historical events, but then so does Islam. It completely relies on the historic Mohammed as much of the teaching in Islam comes from the Hadith.

Catholicism sees the covenants as growing in inclusiveness. The covenants of Noah, Abraham, Moses, and David correspond to a covenant with a family, tribe, nation, and kingdom. The final covenant with Christ is a universal covenant that encompasses all people. Of course, people are free to reject the offer.

I can understand how Guenon was attracted to Sufism, but I have to agree with Tomberg that he was impoverished by his decision to reject Christianity.

satishapte05tish on 2014-03-26 at 06:36 said:

Can you give reference of Rene's assement of Islam as Final revelation ?

August on 2014-03-29 at 05:46 said:

@ satishapte05tish

'Studies in Hinduism'. Sophia Perennis,

Extract from Chapter 11 – Sanatana Dharma:

"It is also interesting to note that the Hindu and the Islamic traditions explicitly affirm the validity of all the other orthodox traditions, and if this is so it is because as the temporally first and the last in the course of the Manvantara they must to the same extent integrate – although in different modes – all the diverse forms that have arisen in the interval, so as to render possible the 'return to origins' by which the end of the cycle will rejoin its beginning, whence, at the starting-point of another Manvantara, the true Sanatana Dharma will again be outwardly manifest."

Michel on 2014-03-30 at 14:02 said:

Just to add a source that further shows Guenon's position on Islam being the final revelation, see here:

http://www.studiesincomparativereligion.com/uploads/ArticlePDFs/353.pdf

The article is a short excursion on the symbolism of the letter Nun. The letter resembles the lower half of a circle with a dot at it's center. It represents, in regard to macro-cosmic cyclic manifestation, the complementary Tradition that completes the Heritage of an entire Humanity; the first being the Primordial Tradition, symbolized by the rainbow, which resembles the upper

half of a circle. The letter symbolizes the Tradition that is to act as the ark which would ferry one Humanity's cycle to another, after all the former's possibilities have been exhausted.

Combining the two halves of the circle, the former preceding the latter, the symbol of a full circle is formed, with a dot at its center. Islam(Ark), being the Seal of Prophecy represents the ultimate form of orthodoxy for this present cycle, just as the Hindu Tradition represents the most direct heritage of the Primordial Tradition (Rainbow).

12.21 The Case for Evola

> I'm a pessimist because of intelligence, but an optimist because of will.
>
> Antonio Gramsci: *Letters from Prison* (December 19th, 1929)
>
> Unless a capacity for thinking be accompanied by a capacity for action, a superior mind exists in torture.
>
> Benedetto Croce

Based on **Julius Evola**'s article that **Rene Guenon** quoted, and objected to, in his letter to **Guido de Giorgio**[29], we will make the case in Evola's defense. At a later date, we will provide a counter argument from Guenon's point of view.

Rationalism Evola rejects any system of thought that posits itself above the Self and demands thereby the subjection of the self. Any such system of though he calls "rationalism". Hence, he would reject, at least as first principle, something like Guenon's multiple states of the Being. That is not the Absolute for Evola; rather, the Self is the Absolute, as Atman is Brahman. The Absolute is something to realized, reached, or achieved;

[29] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=4460`

that is the only way to "know" it. The logical arguments used by Guenon can only be secondary.

This Absolute Self is above thought; hence it cannot be reduced to the "sentimental, moralist, and abstractly rational element". In this he agrees with Guenon. Yet he rejects Guenon's distinction between the intuition (nous) and the rational mind (dianoia), relating it to the same distinction made by Hegel. Since the **Absolute Self** is totally free, and not subject to any system, its principle can only be will or power: **Shakti** as Evola calls it. In this, he is in the current of Italian idealism, even with his intellectual nemesis, **Giovanni Gentile**, who likewise rejection rationalism, as the following quote shows:

> Fascism is and should be an enemy without truce or pity, not against intelligence, but against intellectualism which is a disease of the intelligence—**for intelligence too is will**, and fascism at least feels this, disdaining the culture that is an ornament or adornment of the brain and longing for a culture by which the spirit is armed and fortified for winning ever new battles.

So, for Evola, East and West are two equal ideal types, although manifesting in different ways. Guenon, on the other hand, privileges intellectualism, the upshot of which is that he considers the East to be superior to the West, almost by definition. One of the distinguishing details for Evola is the development of science in the West as a manifestation of the Will to Power. Guenon sees science as a form of decadence, but that is true only when science wants to make itself into an absolute, intellectual system.

Scire So Evola is in agreement with the Hermetic principle: "Know, will, and dare."[30] What, then, does the Self know, if not a system of thought?

[30] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=1064`

This "knowing" can only be a direct experience, known in one's being, almost a carnal knowledge in the flesh. The problem with rationalism is that it is not self-sufficient, requiring data to operate on. A philosophical or scientific theory, therefore, will address the data of the sense. This is all the more so for metaphysics.

Potere Beyond the life of sense satisfaction, a real man will pursue a life of virtue, or power. The cardinal virtues are: **wisdom**, **courage**, **healthy-mindedness**, and **justice**. A rationalist like Socrates found he could not define those virtues. Hence, there is no "blueprint" or systematic plan for a man to follow. Rather, through a life of action, he knows the virtues only by becoming the virtues. Wisdom arises from dealing with the issues of life, courage from overcoming fear, healthy-mindedness from self-control, justice from commanding men. They cannot be taught abstractly, but only learned from the exercise of a man's personal power. That is the step of willing.

Audere To dare, then, means to overcome the elements of fire, water, air, and earth. Clearly this can only be accomplished by surpassing and dominating the inferior forces that hold one back. This is the essence of Hermetic Initiation[31]. Real progress in initiation has little to do with memorizing doctrines and passing exams to reach higher grades. Facing danger in this way changes a man, leads him to higher states of being. Hence the attraction of activities such as mountain climbing, spelunking, air and sea sports, etc. These are modern equivalents to the dangers of battle and hand-to-hand combat.

Once a man has encountered such dangers and faced the fear of death, his consciousness is altered. He can no longer be deceived by the "*illusion of everyday life*". He is no longer bound to the conventions and niceties of bourgeois life. He is more conscious and is a man of power.

[31] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=1161`

Posted on 2012-07-11 by Cologero

12.22 Devil in the Details

> All religion and all wisdom is reducible, extrinsically and from the human standpoint, to these four laws:
>
> - enshrined in every tradition is to be observed an Immutable Truth
> - a law of attachment to the Real
> - remembrance of love of God
> - prohibitions and injunctions
>
> These make up a fabric of elementary certainties which encompasses and resolves human uncertainty, and thus reduces the whole problem of earthly existence to a geometry that is at once simple and primordial.
>
> Frithjof Schuon, *Logic and Transcendence*

Here we see Schuon describing the initiatic path as "simple and primordial". It has been well marked out by those who know. **Rene Guenon** likewise points out that the path is precise and exact. Both Schuon and Guenon make use of geometrical symbolism, to indicate the order behind Traditional thinking. Why do you suppose that Plato refused his teaching to anyone ignorant of geometry? There is no room here for disputation or disagreement. It is understood or it is not. Schuon writes:

> This principal polarization is refracted endlessly in the universe, but it does so in an unequal manner — according to the exigencies of manifesting Possibility — and the subjectivies as a result are not epistemologically equivalent.

This explains the disorder in the world, since as the Possibilities manifest, men have different intellectual capacities. Yet there must be some basic, or latent, intelligence to even grasp that. This is all the more true in the modern world when every man believes he is equal and his opinion is as good as another; this is even true, unfortunately, of those who pay lip service to tradition and anti-egalitarianism. In practice, however, it is much more difficult to swallow.

The first of the **corporal works of mercy** is "to feed the hungry". The hungry never object to being fed. But the corresponding **spiritual work of mercy** is "to instruct the ignorant". However, the ignorant, or spiritually hungry, are typically indignant about this, unlike those with physical hunger. Those who sincerely desire true knowledge lap it up, but they are unequally distributed. Being overwhelmed by the world is a sure way to remain in ignorance, and a reorientation is necessary. Schuon describes it this way:

> Man has around him the bewildering multitude of phenomena, perfect intelligence will consist in perceiving their homogeneity and their outwardness as proceeding respectively from a transcendent unity and a reality that is inward; the world will then appear, not as an incoherent mass of quasi-absolute phenomena, but as a single veil into which the phenomena are woven; in this veil, they are joined but not confused distinct but not separated. In the center resides the discerning and unifying intelligence, namely, the intelligence that is conscious of the Principle; it is thanks to this consciousness alone that the phenomenal world can appear both in its substantial homogeneity and in its contingency, its outwardness, its nothingness.

In *East and West*, Guenon explains:

> What we call a normal civilization is one that is based on principles, in the true sense of this word, one where everything is ar-

> ranged in hierarchy to conform to these principles, so that everything in it is seen as the application and extension of a doctrine whose essence is purely intellectual and metaphysical: this is what we mean also when we speak of a traditional civilization

So, again what is required is knowledge of principle, not knowledge of the world. As one of the superstitions of life, Guenon makes this clear; the opposite of the knowledge of principles is an attachment to the sensate world. This can be overcome only by "an understanding of the universal order, which is beyond the reach of the modern world where disorder is law." Guenon Unfortunately, "the modern mind faces almost exclusively outward, towards the world of the senses." To expect order to reveal itself in the sensate world is misguided and delusional; it will lead nowhere. To achieve anything in this area requires efforts and fortitude, as well as both the desire and the ability to turn away from it.

Modern man is also sentimental, driven by the inducements of the emotions. He loves florid language and dreams his Walter Mitty[32] dreams of being a warrior, high initiate or sage. Far be it from us to discourage such noble goals, but, alas, the devil is in the details. It is one thing to talk about overcoming "lower powers" and the like; it is quite another to actually name them. Of course, the battle against such base powers needs to be fought within, long before they can be fought without.

We can get instructions for this battle from various sources, such as, *The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali* or the eight-fold path described by Buddha. Closer to home, we have the *Divine Comedy* by Dante, known to be an initiate of the order of the *Fedeli d'Amore*. In great detail, he describes the obstacles that keep us bound to the horrors of the world, the steps required to purge ourselves of the influences of those obstacles, and finally the final stage to the Supreme Identity.

To be clear, and as Guenon insists, this is not some holy mysticism or wishful thinking that it the result of a divine accident. Rather, it is a

[32] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Walter_Mitty

logical and coherent path that can be followed by those who understand it and make the efforts to follow it. It is easy to talk about "liberation" in some abstract sense. But we are, or should be, interested in understanding specifically what that means. Rene Guenon has made a precise definition of that end result[33], so it can be understood by anyone of intelligence willing to make the effort. There are some men who are no longer satisfied by vague ideas and an attachment to the contemporary world. They will be fed.

Posted on 2012-07-31 by Cologero

12.23 Turning the Tables

We have given free rein to Guenon's critique of Evola which, as far as it goes, is justified. Now we can turn the tables and explore what Evola found lacking in Guenon, specifically, the two issues of "Guenonian Scholasticism" and "Bureaucratic Initiation". The mutual critiques are of different orders, but that does not make one less important. The distinction is between "thesis" (the principle) and "hypothesis" (the application of the principle to the concrete situation).

Guenon is unremittingly concentrated on the thesis in his published writings, which are typically abstract and require some effort to parse. Even in works such as Crisis of the Modern World or Reign of Quantity, the concrete situation is seen in negative terms. Evola, on the other hand, seems impatient with that abstraction, and focuses on the hypothesis, i.e., dealing with one's concrete situation as he famously does in Ride the Tiger and Men among the Ruins.

Scholasticism Guenon's most metaphysical works (Multiple States of Being, Man and his Becoming, Symbolism of the Cross) may seem

[33] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=4527`

to many as too abstract and overly logical. It takes some time to integrate that system of thought into one's worldview and learn to experience the world from that vantage point, *sub specie aeternitatis*, as it were. Yet, Guenon asserts it is above logic, while not illogical, and requires a "realization" to grasp it in its depths.

So without such a realization, it remains abstract and can devolve into a type of Scholasticism, as happened, for example, with Thomism. Examples can be found in some neo-Traditionalist writings, printed or on the Internet, which are often abstract discussion about whether such and such ancient religion was Traditional, or the same for some person or another, as though they are really in a position to discern that.

To avoid such a dry Scholasticism, Guenon informs us of the need for a real initiation from a valid organization. Unfortunately, Guenon is reluctant to share any specifics. He, for example, explains the principle of the Supreme Identity, but not how to realize it. He gives the Divine Comedy as an example of a initiatory text that outlines the path, but ignores any specific details. For example, he will point out that the stages of that poem represents higher states of being, but the reader is on his own to explore what that means as far as a concrete application.

Bureaucratic Initiation Guenon does seem to describe initiation in a bureaucratic way: first, a man must discover a valid organization and then follow their process in a precise and well-defined way. Yet this begs the question of how can a man, starting from a concrete situation of ignorance, be in a position to recognize what is valid or not?

Here, I suppose, it is helpful to know the metaphysics which can serve as the touchstone to evaluate a teaching. Nevertheless, there is no ISO[34] standard to rate such teachings. The other objection to such a strict view is that the "Spirit blows where He wills", so organizations may decline and arise apart from any human effort.

[34] `http://www.iso.org/`

Now I get several newsletters about health and nutrition, which all contradict each other. There is the paleo diet, the Mediterranean, vegan, and so on, mutually opposed and often polemical against each other. On the one hand, there may be frustration about which is the "ideal" human diet, but another conclusion is that there are different diets suitable for different types of men.

Evola, to his credit, made an effort to identify initiatic paths suitable for a modern Westerner. In the Ur/Krur group, he interacted with Theosophists, Anthroposophists, Jungians, inter alia. At one point, he even spent some time in a Catholic monastery, if you can envision him as a monk. He eventually settled on several figures whom he regarded as offering something, among whom are: Eliphas Levi, Kremmerz, Meyrink, Bo Yin Ra, Gurdjieff, Crowley. Perhaps they are "irregular" from Guenon's point of view, yet they clearly understood something and learned it from somewhere. A comparative study of their teachings may be of interest, if the right person ever undertakes it.

Guenon makes the distinction between the lesser mysteries and the greater mysteries, and let us suppose for the sake of argument that Guenon's real objection is that those figures had an inadequate understanding of the greater mysteries, perhaps even because they were not aligned with one of the valid traditions. Nevertheless, knowledge of the lesser mysteries may very well be the "proper diet" for many men today.

While Guenon criticized Evola's interest in those men, he was not forthcoming about an alternative. In his published writings (as far as I recall), he denied the existence of initiatory organizations in the West, yet in his letters he claimed to have received both a Western and an Eastern initiation; he never revealed from where, as far as I know. The reason can only be speculated; perhaps, the group wished to remain unknown, yet somehow Guenon found them.

In my experience, I have met many people involved with various Vedanta inspired organizations, been to their meetings, heard their talks.

Not to be judgmental, it is hard to discern much difference between them and the general populace. Belonging so such an organization often seems to be more of a social thing, a place to make friends, eat exotic foods, and establish an identity. Granted, there may be those with a deeper understanding, but the point I'm making is that initiation in and of itself is insufficient.

In East and West, Guenon passed over Tibetan Buddhism on the grounds that it is too remote from Westerner's understanding. But that was in the 1920s and today Tibetan Buddhist centers can be found in every major city in Europe and North America. Unfortunately, its encounter with the West has not brought the West to Tradition, but seems, on the contrary, to have affected Buddhism for the worse. But that is another topic; suffice it to say for now that the ideal of a theocratic, patriarchical, hierarchical society is not the ideal of any Western Buddhists.

Fraud and Legitimacy While it may be difficult to find a legitimate teaching, a fraudulent one may be easier to identify. The most obvious is if the organization is used for the personal gain of the leader. Hermetists did not earn their living through their teachings. Instead, they held positions, such a horse traders or street artists, which gave them the freedom, and the cover, to travel from town to town to meet with their students. The second is that whether the organization is able to hand down its tradition, which is its very nature, or whether it is just a way of life for its successors.

As an example, I can point to Valentin Tomberg, who explicitly requested that no organization be formed based on his work. This does arouse some curiosity, doesn't it? Why did he expect that to happen? Is doesn't seem likely that he was so vain he assumed it. Perhaps he realized its importance and suspected it would have an impact, even if not right away. Or even perhaps, he was part of an movement that decided this was the opportune time to leave behind some evidence; he certainly hints at

this.

In the example of the *Fedeli d'Amore* — which includes Dante, the authors of the Romance of the Rose, Boccaccio — the organization apparently no longer exists, yet it did make sure to leave written texts. As Guenon points out, it took several hundred years for anyone to realize that the Divine Comedy was an esoteric work and not just a poem.

For more on the notions of thesis and hypothesis, and accommodation of principles to concrete situations, interested readers can read this[35].

Posted on 2012-08-10 by Cologero

* * *

Avery Morrow on 2012-08-10 at 01:22 said:

I actually was considering precisely the same problem at roughly the same as you were writing this post. This is the conclusion I came up with:

> The "unity of tradition" doesn't mean that religions all teach the same thing, but that the most developed of these paths, using its own language, leads to the same wisdom as the other well-developed paths.
>
> Some projects, like Theosophy and the New Age, are anti-tradition and go around in circles forever. After talking with my friend about Bahai Faith, Tenrikyo, and Mormonism, which do seem to guarantee spiritual peace to adherents, I think I understand the meaning of "illusory tradition" as defined by Guenon here. Adherents of these new movements will enter into a journey. But their new paths are undeveloped, and adherents do not yet understand how to see the eternal nature of tradition and cannot receive initiation using the language-worlds created by these vehicles. The average person can live happily with imperfect understanding, so these "illusory traditions" are not useless as ordinary religions, but the intellectual will remained mired in modernity and will have to force his way to escape. Only an old tradition can really guarantee intellectual engagement.

[35] https://opuscula.blogspot.com/2009/08/intervention-of-mgr-duplanoup-part-i.html

> The importance of finding an old tradition has grown for intellectuals because modernity, anti-tradition, builds a language-world that completely rejects the possibility of tradition, a rejection that did not exist in the past or was more widely disputed. This has created confusion and chaos when discussing issues of the mind, which has caused many of these "illusory traditions" to appear. But a real tradition will have a very strong vocabulary from which modernity can be observed and contrasted with truth.

I might add to this that Guenon and Evola may be addressing different problems. The authority that Guenon wants to retrieve from Tradition is a font of sacred knowledge. The hierarchy he proposes is a hierarchy of wisdom, in which knowledge of the profane world symbolizes more constant, eternal concepts which are grasped through initiation. Evola's main interest, to generalize quite roughly, is Tradition as a font of power that flows into the occult war. His World-King really is a world king and not a symbolic creature. Recognizing what is traditional here is recognizing the forms of traditional authority as exerted on the unintellectual world. Thus Evola is not a disciple of Guenon in the same way that the ecumenist Schuon is, because although he agrees on the existence of Tradition, he is asking different questions about it.

`Izak on 2012-08-10 at 03:11 said:`

I thought that Guenon continued to proclaim the legitimacy of the Freemasons up until the day he died. My guess is that he was initiated with them.

In the pamphlet "Guenon: Teacher for Modern Times," Evola takes him to task on his view of the Masons, and publishes a couple of Guenon's epistolary responses regarding the subject. I tend to agree more with Evola, and I also agree with Evola's point about the basic dearth of tradition in the East.

The problem with these so-called initiatory organizations is that they can only do so much as isolated entities. What I see as Evola's chief virtue is that he recognized that a traditional civilization must contain a uniting of both the spiritual and temporal order with which to give faith coherence. This is probably why he admirably never gave himself over entirely to (IE, was initiated by) a corrupt or flawed organization. He recognized that he would never achieve a total immersion, or that too much corruption would seep in, and he thus promoted an individualistic approach – take it or leave it.

In one of Guenon's letters to Evola, I seem to remember him giving a very sparse few examples of initiatory organizations in the West, though he is unsure as to whether they count for anything, or whether they have merely degenerated into "study groups" (his term!).

I don't know anything about Evola's criticisms of Guenon's "scholasticism," but it would seem somewhat pointless in my mind for Evola to even bother leveling such an accusation in the Kali Yuga, where just about any discussions of this nature are bound to become needlessly abstract

and/or dialectical. It would probably be more appropriate to accuse Guenon of producing works which would inevitably engender a type of scholasticism.

In my view, the real problem with medieval scholasticism is that it basically neglected the eschatological/anagogical sense of scriptural exegesis — the only sort which dealt with true metaphysics — which early medieval tradition handled admirably (`http://www.ecriture-art.com/raban-e.htm#` – here's The Symbolism of the Cross, 9th century ed.). By the 12th century, a huge wave of inferior theology took over the medieval tradition with the likes of Abelard (while people like Bernard of Clairvaux and some of the Victorines stayed true). Whatever true metaphysics Thomas was able to resuscitate was overshadowed by the rigor of his form as opposed to content, and the nosedive continued undaunted. Calling Guenon a scholastic seems a bit silly to me, since metaphysics was his chief concern. It isn't as though Guenon was sitting around writing speculations as to whether or not the nephilim were the products of demon incubi impregnating mortal women during astrologically significant days on the calendar (as our friend Thomas, in fact, did!). All of his questions were significant.

`Mihai on 2012-08-10 at 05:20 said:`

Guenon explicitly declared that he wished to explain certain traditional ideas and doctrines in a way accessible to the modern western mind- a mind that is especially unaccustomed to the direct perception of symbolism. Hence his more logical and dialectical approach.

As for the question of initiation, Guenon was initiated in a Sufi lineage, this is the only thing certain. As for the western initiation, it is really unknown to us.

Guenon stressed the importance of initiation in an orthodox tradition, regardless of which. I believe this to be legitimate, since the only alternative to this is some neo-spiritualism or an attempt to find spirituality as a freelancer, which I believe not only to be dangerous, but also delusional and with no chances of success.

I have read Evola's alternatives that he wrote in "The limits of initiatory regularity". He was certainly right to call Guenon on the fact that he does not offer any practical advice, and leaving the seeker in the dark as to the solution, but his "alternatives" aren't really that convincing, and in some ways quite fanciful.

He talks about dream initiation or a certain type of spontaneous event that would initiate the person without the help of an intermediary, but such are really extremely rare cases which, for all practical purposes, should not be relied upon by any person seeking initiation. Besides, such cases have always been rare and in the case of especially "gifted" people. It is easy to consider oneself, in one's own eyes, as being one of such "gifted", but who can tell one is not deluding oneself ?

Besides, as his life showed, Evola never did find the solution to this question. His works tend to show that. Of course, he gave valuable insights and glimpses of alternatives to modern materialism, that can be expanded upon by different people, but still, the fact that he wrote

about such diverse topics- Tantra, Buddhism, Alchemy, mountain climbing, esoteric sexuality etc.- also show his inward seeking for a path of realization, a path that he never came to really grasp.

On the other hand, it is easy to see, throughout Guenon's writings, a continuity and a logical unfolding with each single work.

PS: I am not aware if Guenon was aware of Crowley in any way, but all I can say, regarding him, is that he held some valuable knowledge, but ultimately he gave birth to a dangerous and syncretism of half-truths, packaged in an evolutionist and individualist mentality. His "Thelema" is really indistinguishable from other modern spiritualisms and occultisms that announce a spiritual rebirth of humanity.

Gabe Ruth on 2012-08-10 at 13:13 said:

This is off the topic of the interesting post, but Avery, your note about the nature of these new religions brought this to mind:

"For you, the world will continue to wear a noble, awful face. You will never rise above mysticism, but be happy in your own way."

It's from A Voyage To Arcturus, by David Lindsey. I would be very interested to hear the thoughts of anyone here on it. I can't recommend it, but it is a startlingly interesting book.

Andrew on 2012-08-11 at 23:27 said:

The point about Buddhism being negatively effected by its encounter with the West is quite right. Everything that has encountered modernity has been corroded by it. This puts me in an awkward position as I am a Buddhist at odds with nearly every other "Buddhist" in America. As I see it, the only option is to apply principles to practice and form friendships with like-minded people. With this, we build fortresses and wait out the storm. Though in line with "Ride the Tiger" there may be a place for those unafraid to make matters worse so as to collapse our current culture sooner.

Aghorable on 2012-08-15 at 01:30 said:

Good article. ISO standards for teachings, that's comedy. I don't look forward to the day of *ISO 16003940 – Initiation Delivery Systems*.

"... it is hard to discern much difference between them and the general populace."

That observation might be explained by an important distinction; that between virtual initiation and actualisation. If my understanding is not flawed, this latter depends on a truly unique catalyst to get it started, one that cannot exactly be imposed from outside. But without actualisation, there is only a potentiality that has not yet blossomed, albeit a determinate one.

One can also ask what would be the purpose of receiving more than one initiation, if it is only a question of metaphysical realisation. On the other hand, if it is also about obtaining an

alignment that would allow one to participate in a particular organisation's work, then it can be understood.

12.24 Nietzsche and the Gospel of Buddhism

> The student will, indeed, find that nearly every thought expressed in Buddhism and Hindu literature finds expression in the Western world also; and it could not be otherwise for the value of these thoughts is universal, and therefore they could not be more Oriental than Western; the East has advanced beyond the West only in their wider and fuller acceptance.
>
> Ananda Coomaraswamy

Years ago, before I had known much about Rene Guenon and Tradition, I read Coomaraswamy's book *Buddha and the Gospel of Buddhism*. Published it 1916, it was before Coomaraswamy's encounter with Guenon. Nevertheless, it foreshadowed a Traditional outlook, since Coomaraswamy took pains to point out the correspondences between Buddhism and both Hinduism and Christian mysticism. Oddly enough, and it struck me so at the time, Coomaraswamy also related it to the ideas of the poets **Friedrich Nietzsche**, **Walt Whitman**, and **William Blake**. Since they were three of my favorite poets, I did consider that a plus.

While the author of the introduction (written much later) is perplexed at the mention of Nietzsche, it would be better to explore what Coomaraswamy sees in him, whether he sees something deeper in Nietzsche or is simply off track. That author also objects to Coomaraswamy's use of the word "Aryan", although it was perfectly natural at the time the book was written. It does point out how arbitrary prejudices prevent us from seeing something purely. For example, I used to be prejudiced

against the middle ages. A Jewish woman, who sometimes led the meditations in our Buddhism study group, had a PhD in Medieval History and convinced me it was much more that a long period of intellectual darkness.

A few years later Coomaraswamy published an essay on the "Cosmopolitan View of Nietzsche", in which he explains the religion of Idealistic Individualism, which he calls the religion of modern Europe. He sees Nietzsche as a poet, not a philosopher, and a mystic, speaking in the same voice as Blake and Whitman. Coomaraswamy explains his hermeneutic principle:

> Nietzsche's originality does not consist in an incomprehensible and unnatural novelty, but in a poetic restatement of a very old position.

Given that, Coomaraswamy can ignore the more simplistic interpretations of his thought. Nietzsche was a prophet with a "passionate protest against unworthy values, Pharisaic virtue, and snobism". He then moves on to this:

> Of special significance is the beautiful doctrine of the Superman, so like the Chinese concept of the Superior Man, and the Indian maha purush, bodhisattva, and jivan-mukta.

By ignoring Nietzsche's false philosophical positions, Coomarswamy finds an impulse that is more ancient. "The Superman, whose virtue stands beyond good and evil, is at once the flower and the leader and saviour of men." His "actions are no longer good or bad, but proceed from his freed nature." Nietzsche's objection to the reward of Heaven and Hell can be related to Guenon's idea of deliverance as superior to salvation. Coomaraswamy then deals with the doctrine of the Will to Power.

> The will to Power asserts that our life is not to be swayed by motives of pleasure or pain, the pairs of opposites, but is to be directed towards its goal, and that goal is the freedom and spontaneity of the jivan mukta. And this is beyond good and evil. This also set out in the *Bhagavad Gita*: the hero must be superior to pity; resolute for the fray, but unattached to the result.

Nietzsche's teaching is *nishkama dharma*[36], that is, selfless and desireless action, without expectation of result. The will to power is not "to yield to all the promptings of the senses, to be the slave of caprice." There can be no altruism if there is nothing external to myself. "Physician, heal thyself" means the highest duty is self-realisation. Or to quote Jesus, "first cast out the mote from thine own eye." Coomaraswamy continues:

> The inferior man regulates his life by externals: inasmuch as he is constrained by desire for long life, reputation, riches, rank or offspring, he is not free. The superior man is of another sort, and of him it may be said, with Chuan Tzu, "that they live in accordance with their own nature. In the whole world they have no equal. They regulate their life by inward things."

So the inferior man believes all his actions should be praiseworthy. On the contrary:

> The pattern of man's behaviour is not to be found in any code, but in the principles of the universe, which is continually revealing to us *its own nature*... There exists a voluptuousness that is not sensuality, a passion for power that is not self-assertion, and a selfishness that is more generous than any altruism.

Ascetism is for the strong, who choose it. "Life should grow colder towards the summit." That is why "a Brahman should do nothing for

[36] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nishkam_Karma

the sake of enjoyment." Coomaraswamy concludes with this interesting claim:

> Those who have comprehended the decline and fall of Western civilization will recognize in Nietzsche the reawakening of the conscience of Europe.

Rather than end here, I want to connect a thought from his essay "Young India".

> We stand in the West at the close of the great cycle of Christian civilization which attained its zenith, let us say, in the twelfth or thirteenth century, when the creative will of man swept far beyond its personal boundaries, striving to establish an order in the outer world to correspond with the universal order to he world of imagination or eternity.

Coomaraswamy clearly holds that Medieval Europe was the peak, or at least the last peak, of Western civilization. Can we really see Nietzsche as the prophet to reawaken the conscience of Europe? Specifically, we must first, as he claims, comprehend the decline and fall Western civilization which had reached its peak in the thirteenth century. This is how he understands that decline:

> From the thirteenth to the twentieth century one can follow the progressive decay of life: the ever fainter expression of the creative will, loosening social integration, the substitution of contract for status, the advancement of material and moral to the exclusion of spiritual values, the decline of vision, up to this present hour of pure chaos, when life and art are evidence of centuries of aimlessness.

Posted on 2012-09-21 by Cologero

* * *

Audrey on 2012-09-21 at 15:37 said:

Interesting opening quote, although I disagree with it..the East and West serve differently, and whereas the overarching union is one, that is practically not usable unless you are conversing among Buddhas. Likewise the naive notion that the East is more mature, or embraced things more fully.. And if you permit me, the romanticized notion of a distant path of Europe. EU nobility still rules the US behind curtains and veils. A peak is a peak, and a valley is a valley, regardless of humans and their pefception of it, ie time.

Audrey on 2012-09-21 at 15:55 said:

Also, Whitman and Blake were influenced by a wave of Occidentalism which fashionably hit the West, so these so called points of contact ard largdly fabricated by man. I actually just read a few hings by Oshawa which even in English ar decidedly, mentally foreignto the core, where a human notpart of that core will beunable to drink from it, erudite and genuine as the article may be.

12.25 Thought, Action, and the Elite

In *Perspectives on Initiation*, **Rene Guenon** deals with the notion of the elite in our time. In the kali yuga, there are fewer initiates and, apparently, it requires a larger population to generate the number of men with the possibility of being initiates. Before reviewing that in order to determine who may be a candidate for initiation, it may be wise to review the fundamentals. In our fall from the primordial state, we enter the world of duality. In Thought, that shows up as a yes and a no. Every opinion expressed engenders its opposite which then leads to infinite discussion without resolution. The Will enters a debate between "desire" and "avoidance". With nothing transcendent to resolve these dualities, thoughts and actions are formed on the basis of sympathy and antipathy, what I like and what I dislike.

World of Thought First of all, it is necessary to understand the "person". The person, or "Self", is beyond all manifestation, a fortiori, beyond thoughts, desires, like, and dislikes. It can never be an object in the world, hence never an object of experience, either of my own or of someone else's. This is unnatural to most people since they regard their person precisely as the contents of their consciousness rather than always outside of consciousness. Hence, there is a widespread misconception anent the notion of a personal God. Projecting their own misunderstandings of personhood, they presume that refers to some super-being who also experiences thoughts, desires, emotions, and so on.

What people consider their person or self is actually its projection into manifestation, and Guenon calls this the ego. That becomes the false center around which people live out their lives, rather than their true transcendent center. That ego is unstable, forever shifting with each new idea, desire, or emotion.

So, although it seems that metaphysical principles are expressed in thoughts and words, that is not how they must be ultimately known. As every metaphysician has taught, there is a higher faculty, "intellectual intuition", that transcends thought. As such, metaphysics can never be just another theory about the world, something to latch onto or not, a school of thought that one can say either yes or no to.

Words like "intuition" and "transcend" refer to very real things, they are not meant to obfuscate, and they are not reserved to some erudites who have no familiarity with the "real" world. Quite the opposite. Hence, the metaphysician doesn't bother to debate these principles although he may try to explain them. It is pointless to enter a dispute, because all that amounts to is a no to his yes, a project without ultimate resolution. The most you can do is regard him as deluded.

Through certain practices one learns to "transcend". For the ordinary consciousness, thinking and the ego are on the same level. Men assume they "think", i.e., there is a thinker and a thought and together they de-

fine the man. That is the dualist view. The higher view is different. The person, not the ego, is at the center, and the realm of thoughts is just one of the layers of his being. From the vantage point of the Self, the thoughts are "below", i.e., they are transcended. Hence one's consciousness is superior to the yes and no of the stream of thoughts. That is non-dual awareness, since there is no longer a thinker and his thoughts, instead just the observer.

Field of Action Action takes place in manifestation. Whereas metaphysical principles are known with absolute certainty, that is not the case when acting. Here one's actions are fraught with risk and uncertainty; instead of known principles, what is required is prudential judgment. Curiously, the bulk of men see things quite differently from that. For them, thought can be no more than opinion, or a likely story; a man is free to adopt whatever philosophical, scientific, or religious system he likes based on his "personal equation".

Yet when it comes to making concrete decisions, he is suddenly filled with total certainty, that he knows what to do and everyone else is going down the wrong path. That is the rash man. His counterpart is the scrupulous man how will weigh his options interminably and may fail to make a decision at all.

Obviously, to the extent he doesn't understand his own nature and the workings of the world, his actions will be ineffective. Here his guide must be the virtues: prudence, to be able to evaluate the possibilities of manifestation in a concrete situation; courage, or fortitude, to have the strength of will to act effectively; justice, to be able to act objectively and fairly. Now, as we may suspect from some of Plato's dialogues, these virtues cannot be understood dualistically; the attempts to define them by rational thought ends in aporia. That does not mean they don't exist. Rather it means they cannot be reduced to thought, but must be the expression of one's Self. The courageous man knows directly, intuitively,

and non-dually what courage is, even if he can never express it fully in words.

Man's dual nature is expressed in the gnomic will, i.e., he deliberates the various courses of action open to him. His true will, on the contrary, is the expression of his being; this is non-dual action, arising from a man's primordial state. Purity of heart is to will one thing.

It should be clear that watchfulness is the initial step, the necessary skill to master. All spiritual schools recognize this. It is hardly unknown in the West. For example, it is present in the Philokalia, Scuopli's *Spiritual Warfare*, and even the Gospels. Through constant practice in watchfulness, and unceasing efforts to remove the myriad obstacles that would prevent such, a man can gradually reach non-dual awareness to a greater of lesser extent. There is no point debating non-duality, except in the context of mutual support a spiritual group. Through such practice, one learns to see there are not-two, yet neither term annihilates the other. The "Supreme Identity" will explain itself.

This sounds simple enough, but in practice I've found that some people have great difficulty grasping this. For them, presumably, the esoteric spiritual life is not an option. They are content with the illusion of ordinary life and there is a necessity for that.

The Notion of an Elite Guenon claims that the notion of an elite no longer exists in the West, so that its "reconstitution is the first and essential condition for an intellectual rectification and a traditional restoration." It is the men who accept that who are the objects of our interest, not those who reject the spiritual in favor of some at-best ephemeral political victories. Obviously, this word has a specific meaning, which is quite different from its common usage. It has nothing to do with a small group exploiting the masses, since its goal is the restoration for all. Guenon makes this definition:

> [the elite] represents the totality of those who possess the quali-

> fications required for initiation, and who naturally are always a minority among men.

The dilemma is this: is there no elite in the West because there are no initiatory organizations or are there no initiatory ogranizations because there is no elite? This chicken or egg problem is not resolvable on the rational plane. But it does lead logically to this: does the West have to wait for initiatory organizations in order to form an elite or will the presence of an elite lead to the formation of initiatory organizations?

These are dualistic questions that can only be resolved from a higher perspective. Of course, as things stand, the elite in the West is only virtual and those who believe they are chosen will need to become conscious of their own qualification to be initiates. Consider: if you understand anything of what was written tonight, if you are obsessed with spiritual and metaphysical topics, if the glamor of the world is losing its grip on you, if you have the energy and perseverance to follow an ascetic path, then perhaps you are becoming conscious of your calling. If you know who you are, you will know this to be true.

Posted on 2013-06-19 by Cologero

* * *

Ash on 2013-06-19 at 23:59 said:

"The most you can do is regard him as deluded."

This is exactly the problem I struggle with when thinking about Gnosis (perhaps one day I will be able to receive it). True gnosis is indeed beyond questioning. But in terms of finding the authentic guide and teacher, particularly in real life and beyond books and the internet, it is difficult to see between those who really have it and those who don't sometimes. Like asking a dog to explain the difference between red and green. A key, I suppose, would be that the one with Gnosis isn't going around making claims to it. Christ taught in dark sayings, after all.

Cologero on 2013-06-20 at 00:07 said:

Dogs are color blind. I don't think you can explain the difference between red and green.

Scardanelli on 2013-06-20 at 10:02 said:

Thank you for this post Cologero. I am grateful for your advice catered to those wishing for practical advice along the way. The petty squabbling in the comments section is growing tiresome and it's nice to get back to the work at hand.

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-20 at 11:55 said:

I am one who feels called, I despise the world and am obsessed with the idea of being able to see and know God, I am ready to do whatever is required of me to get there, which for me is on faith as I do not know what I must do, but I dont even know where to begin, I read a lot of anecdotes from people who have crossed the threshold but what I seek is a map, a guide, someone or something that can tell me what to do to reach the true world. In the abscence of a master, I've been looking at some practical books and next week I'm going to start perform the excersises from Mouni Sadhu's book Concentration and from there maybe go on to his Meditation book. I've also been thinking about using Franz Bardon's Initiation into Hermetics. If anyone here can advise m I'd be most grateful indeed.

scardanelli on 2013-06-20 at 12:19 said:

@Jason-Adam

I have not found a clearer exposition or "roadmap" than that found in Boris Mouravieff's Gnosis series. All of Cologero's above summation can be found therein plus much more. I have read Mouni Sadhu's Concentration and performed the exercises, but stopped them after reading Mouravieff. I am no authority, but it seems that MS gives you piecemeal information whereas BM gives you the whole, step by step. If you are a man that likes to see the bigger picture, that likes to see where he is going though he may not be able to reach it yet, I would recommend BM.

Also, have you ever looked into any lay organizations? I came across the Militia Templi a few days ago, and from your comments, it seems like it might be a good fit for you. I am not advocating them as I know very little about them, but perhaps something you can look into.

h.ontologia on 2013-06-20 at 12:20 said:

Jason-A., have you had a look at a meisterwerk, featured on Gornahoor, titled "Meditations on the Tarot"?

Constantine Aetos on 2013-06-20 at 13:04 said:

Very good article Cologero

Jason I recommend you read Christ the Eternal Tao by Hieromonk Damascene

Jacob on 2013-06-20 at 13:18 said:

This is the diamond in the rough of the Internet. Thanks for another piece.

I have wanted to buy the Gnosis books, but I have always assumed Gurdjieff was anti-traditional like Steiner and Bessant (mainly because of Guenon's plague comment). This place seems to have a better opinion of him though. Do I need to have an understanding of Gurdjieff before reading Gnosis? Or can he be read without it?

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-20 at 17:27 said:

I've read Meditations on the Tarot and admire that work truly but it doesn't offer, at least to me, an actual system of works that can be done to raise spiritual awareness. Mouravieff troubles me because of the anti-western statements he made in Gnosis III reminded me a bit too much of Dugin but I will reconsider that. I've thought about looking into the Gurdjieff work as well.

Ash on 2013-06-20 at 20:03 said:

@Cologero

Yes, hence the metaphor. I can judge doctrines, perhaps, but if a doctrine appears legitimate then judging whether or not the teacher is truly speaking from gnosis would be asking someone to explain something he has never experienced himself.

@Constantine

I was able to acquire this book some time ago but haven't yet had the chance to read it. Did you find it helpful? Also, do you know what Hieromonk Damascene's relation to the perennial philosophy is?

Constantine Aetos on 2013-06-21 at 01:34 said:

@Ash

I actually just finished reading it last week and I can tell you it definitely has given me not only a better understanding of God, but also how to reach to God (e.g.: Watchfulness & Jesus Prayer).

I don't know much about Fr. Damascene other than his spiritual father was Fr. Seraphim (Rose). My guess is he probably had some knowledge of perennial philosophy.

http://orthodoxwiki.org/Damascene_%28Christensen%29

Logres on 2013-06-21 at 21:27 said:

Jacob, Mouravieff is probably more accessible than Gurdjieff – G wrote for a very specific time, and was unorthodox in many ways, even by esoteric standards. Ousepensky's The Fourth Way is helpful, but much more so if you read Gnosis first.

Cologero on 2013-06-22 at 10:01 said:

The point about Gnosis is its claim to be Orthodox, that is, it is actually the teaching from the monks of Mt Athos. The publisher, Robin Amis, backs that up as he claims to have spent time on Mt Athos. You can believe him or not; the web site is Praxis Institute[37]. I haven't found any independent confirmation.

The Gurdjieff groups are opposed to Mouravieff, regarding him as a plagiarist. However, since Gurdjieff himself confesses to having "stolen" his system, it is legitimate, and even advisable, to locate the actual "orthodox" (in its traditional sense) tradition rather than follow G's fragment of a tradition. In point of fact, after Ouspensky's death, some of his followers went in search of the real tradition behind the teaching. Some became Orthodox Christians and were instrumental in getting the Philokalia translated into English.

`Cologero on 2013-06-22 at 10:04 said:`

I need to add that Gnosis is incomprehensible without direct practice of the spiritual techniques that would make it clear. Also, keep in mind that Mouravieff uses the word "personality" in a way opposite to its definition here.

12.26 Confronting World Traditions

Curiously, the anti-modern movement founded on the works of **Rene Guenon** is itself the product of modernity. Three historical trends converged. First, the West had lost, or was losing, its grounding in its own Tradition, partially for reasons we have recently discussed. Second, there was the confrontation with world culture (from the perspective of the West) that challenged the notion that the West had some monopoly on all verities. Then there was the wild success of the scientific method which, along with the idea of the rights of man, led to project of universalism based on science and liberalism.

Guenon threw his grenade in the midst of those assumptions. Rather than seeing the modern world as on the tip of an incessant progression, he insisted that it is in "crisis", under the "reign of quantity". He challenged the idea that the world religions were incoherent and incompatible with

[37] `http://www.praxisresearch.net/home.cfm`

each other. Finally, he pointed out that the West had lost something significant in its own self-understanding, even while paying lip service to externalities of its own spiritual traditions.

Grasping other Traditions Guenon's ideas arrived at a time when the usual ways of understanding world religions by those in the West were no longer credible. The simplest explanation is that all religions are mere fantasies, although clearly this reductionist approach does not do justice to such complex phenomena. The next is to regard non-Christian religions as "Satanic", and this is widely held by Evangelical Protestants. This can be taken to extremes as this brief story shows. In South Florida, most nail salons are staffed by Vietnamese for some reason. A woman I knew who attended a megachurch in Ft Lauderdale refused to frequent one such salon because there was a statue of the Buddha displayed in the window.

The opposite view is typical of most New Age groups. For them, there are world teachers, pretty much interchangeable, who brought spiritual teachings at various times. There is little to distinguish them, or relate them to each other. Hence, they are more like those various groups of comic book superheroes.

A close cousin of this view is that a man should choose his tradition as though selecting fruits at the farmer's market. He will choose one based on personal predilections or perhaps social status (some religions are "cooler" than others in his circles). When this view is combined with the notion that the Western tradition is fundamentally and unavoidedly corrupt and criminal, this will be combined with disdain and derision for the dominant tradition of the West for the past 1500 years.

Natural and Supernatural Man A more sophisticated view, adopted by ancient and medieval Christians, is to distinguish between natural religions and the (one) supernatural religion. In this view, they could admit

that yogis, Buddhists, and so on, have some sort of spiritual experience that is merely natural, while reserving the highest "supernatural" experiences to themselves. Given all the material that Gornahoor has made available, this hardly seems plausible. Nevertheless, it may be useful to review the reasons why.

By "natural", we mean the corporeal and psychic (or soulish) aspects of man, which can be traced to the natural processes ("horizontal") of the manifest world. By supernatural, we mean that part that transcends the manifest world, and hence cannot be explained in scientific terms; this comes from above ("vertical"). Now, it is one thing to make an epistemic distinction between nature and supernature, but quite another to make an ontologic distinction. When Little Miss Muffet was eating her curds and whey, she was no longer drinking milk.

So a man who is only natural, is no longer a man, but is rather an animal, some sort of hominid creature. And I don't mean that in the sense the he is a brute, since animals can also be very appealing, like your dog. But as we recently pointed out, Fr Alois makes a case that man also is a "spirit-soul", i.e., there is a part of the soul that transcends the natural part of man. In most cases, the spirit-soul is virtual, as man in his current state is unaware of it and it is not an active part of his life.

Nevertheless, and this is important since Thomists today seem to have forgotten this teaching, it is possible to remember one's spirit-soul. In the teaching mentioned above, the supernatural experience is only the result of God's direct action, e.g., in infused contemplation, and, as it was claimed, the pagans had no possibility of that. Fr Alois documented the falsity of that idea, since man qua man has a spirit-soul and can actualize it in various ways, even to the point of developing unusual powers or siddhis.

Transcendental Unity of Religions So, at this point, the depth of spiritual insight and metaphysical understanding of the so-called pagans

cannot be denied. Of course, there has always been the notion of the "perennial philosophy", or a common core of wisdom and spirituality across space and time. There have been many attempts to document and catalog the perennial philosophy, culminating in the massive thousand page *Treasury of Traditional Wisdom* compiled by **Whitall Perry**. One can be convinced by its gravitas alone without reading a word of it. However, there is a fault in this approach, a glaring fault which, when fully grasped, is also a deep insight.

The fault is the temptation to regard it as collection of nice quotable tidbits that can be recalled at parties, i.e., it is merely intellectual and not substantially different from the superhero mob or secret brotherhood of adepts mentioned above. To overcome that, the question should arise of achieving such mystical experiences on one's own, and not just repeating them secondhand. The insight comes when you notice that all the figures quoted followed some tradition or other: they were Christians, Sufis, Hermetists, Buddhists, Taoists, yogis, etc. They were not isolated men coming to spiritual realization alone and apart from any predecessor or spiritual current.

So here Guenon arrives and throws the lifesaver. Yes, there is more to it than just a collection of quotes. Actually, the perennial philosophy is quite developed, with a deep metaphysical teaching that is expressed in slightly different ways in the major traditions. That is part 1. Part 2 is also a "yes": to achieve the understanding of those teachings, it is necessary to actively participate in one of the traditions that he regards as authentic.

Then you find out that the lifesaver has a leak and won't keep you afloat long enough. The tradition must not only be authentic, it must have maintained an unbroken chain of esoteric teachings to be effective, and in the West, that chain has been broken. So all the saints quoted in the *Treasury of Traditional Wisdom* are to no avail, since their states are no longer accessible to us. Although a few men under Guenon's influence followed him into Islam, there has been no mad rush to do so. Evola

is not much help since he rejected the spiritual authority that created the traditional society that existed up until the French revolution; this is his claim, not mine. Yet he also rejected any attempts at a neo-pagan revival. As those who have read his correspondence with Guenon that was published on Gornahoor can see, Evola sought for years, usually among marginal figures in Europe.

So there are some things that make us uneasy. While we don't doubt the metaphysical teachings, it is legitimate to question Guenon's judgment of contingent and historical events. First of all, the transcendent unity of religions sounds too similar to Noam Chomsky's universal grammar. Initially it seems edifying. Unfortunately, by explaining everything, it explains nothing. Neither the ur-tradition nor the universal grammar exists anywhere; they can't even be conceptualized. So, if the traditions did not fall from the sky, they need to be related to each other as part of the world historical process. And if so, they are no longer separate but equal; the traditionalists reject egalitarianism, so we should not suddenly adopt that view in regards to the traditions.

Forgetting, Sleeping, and Death Now Guenon's introduction to spirituality was through the French Hermetic tradition, as he was associated with **Papus**. Although he broke with that movement, he continued to quote from Hermetic writers in his subsequent books. (Do not forget that Evola also wrote a book, and a good book, on Hermetism.) So we are correct to consider it the esoteric tradition in the West. The remaining question, then, is whether or not it is still active, with an unbroken chain. Now one of the reasons Guenon gave for his departure was the Hermetic teaching on reincarnation, which he claims is not traditional. Well, by that standard, contemporary versions of Hinduism and Buddhism are also not traditional, since I don't know of any major teachers in those traditions who do not accept reincarnation as a fact. That does not mean much else.

Guenon, in his letters, did allude to a Hermetic group in Europe with just 12 members; he could not penetrate into it. So just as one black swan disproves the theory that all swans are white, this one group disproves the assertion that the chain of esoterism has been broken in the West. A group like that would be restrictive in order to maintain its purity and efficacy, however, not so restrictive that it would allow itself to die out.

Another event that occurred after Guenon's death is the appearance of writings that do indeed indicate a deep spiritual gnosis; here I have in mind **Valentin Tomberg** in particular. In brief, we can restate how he sees the traditions as related. Ponder it, and you may see that it is true, even if I have to leave many details out.

He points out that the knowledge of monotheism was an accomplishment, or an end point of spiritual realization, among the pagans such as Plato or Hermes Trismegistus. In the Christian tradition that followed, it is instead a revelation, a dogma, an article of faith ("I believe in one God"), the starting point. For **Plato**, to know is to remember, so he shows us how to overcome forgetting. This is not unrelated to **Pope St Gregory**'s teaching about the prophecy of the past[38].

The **Buddha** overcame sleep and teaches us the path to do so. Most men are sleepwalking through life and not seeing life as it is. In a fallen world, Buddha saw clearly old age, sickness, and death, things we want do hide from through our distractions and amusements. So the Buddha overcomes sleep.

Christ, the Risen One, overcomes death for us. So, we see such a different, and enlightening, approach. These spiritual teachings are related to each other in a hierarchical way that does justice to them. Plato, the Wise Man, Buddha, the awakened one, and the Christ. That is our path. So to be a Christian today, that is, one connected to the esoteric Tradition, is to follow that same path. So where Plato stopped, that is where we begin.

[38] `https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-future-of-prophecy`

We must first become Wise like Plato, then Awake like Buddha, and finally overcome death like Christ.

Posted on 2013-10-03 by Cologero

* * *

David on 2013-10-04 at 00:45 said:

Interesting take. As far as Guenon goes, it is also of note that some of his close contributors and "friends" made progress within freemasonry and that some "traditional" group exist within that order.

scardanelli on 2013-10-04 at 09:56 said:

Perhaps he has been discussed here before and I missed it, but I've just begun reading Karl von Eckartshausen's Cloud Upon the Sanctuary, and his description of the Inner Church bears many similarities to Tomberg: that it has existed since the fall of man, that it's members recognize each other through their depth, that this inner church is the truth of the symbolic outer church, and that Christ is the only master. It seems that where most go wrong is searching for the western esoteric tradition externally in some group or order.

Juan Senko on 2013-10-04 at 15:14 said:

@Cologero: Excellent post. I hold a very similar opinion. I believe, along with Hani and Reyor that the Holy Sacraments fulfill the role of Initiation Rites. thus, the Western Tradition as far as Catholicism goes is not broken at all. I don't believe this out of intellectual conviction or Faith alone but because so first hand experiences. The Hermetic Tradition would be a parallel current running throught it. So, You have the Church, you have Hermeticism and also Freemasonry, Of course the Western Tradition is not dead! It's very much ALIVE!

I don't know if the group you speak about is the same one and we have different information, but ChaboneauLassay was the head of an Order restricted to 15, something along the lines of "Order of the Holy Ghost".

uan Senko on 2013-10-04 at 15:14 said:

@David: Guenón himself was involved in some Masonic groups that tried to restore the old rituals and landmarks and become operative instead of speculative. Also, you always have the Rectified Scottish Rite.

Oh! and Martinism. Though it is pretty much distorted and full of AMORC type of people Martinism is still a valid initiatory path!

Blessings in Christ and Mary to you all!

Avery on 2013-10-05 at 15:03 said:

Guénon located the concept of perennial philosophy in the Indian classics. We know that a similar concept developed in Europe, but we do not hear about it until a much later date, because when India was developing those ideas around A.D. 200, Europe was declaring "extra ecclesiam nulla salus" and heresy hunting.

Recently I went to church for the first time in 13 years. I liked almost everything I heard but I could not get that problem out of my head. Schuon tells us that "extra ecclesiam nulla salus" is a false doctrine. I don't believe in his construct but he raises a good point.

Iñaki Luna on 2013-10-05 at 19:11 said:

I insist on the fact that René GUENON did search (and research) the remainings of the Great Tradition among several groups in Europe (including Anthroposophy etc.) but he was never satisfied .

Thus , he HAD to go (on) EASTWARDS ... (as well as SCHÖNBERG HAD to create dodecaphonism , for instance ...)

I' ll try to explain this further on later , ok ?

Cologero on 2013-10-06 at 09:04 said:

Catching up on comments:

@Iñaki Luna:

Yes, we agree that M. Guenon could not find what he was looking for in Europe, even though he was initiated there by an itinerant painter. So what is your point? That we all relocate to Egypt? Are we sure tradition is alive in the East?

I refute you thus:

The Spirit breatheth where he will; and thou hearest his voice, but thou knowest not whence he cometh, and whither he goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.

So the Spirit is not obliged to be where M. Guenon is looking. True initiation comes in the night:

@Avery

You bring up a topic that was not mentioned in the post. Nevertheless,

I refute you thus:

His True Love: "*Avery, my darling, do you love me? Do I make you happy*?"

Avery: "*Yes, dear, I love you and you make me happy. Nevertheless, there are several other women I've met who could have made me equally happy.*"

@Juan Senko

Thank you for being on topic. Yes, I agree with your point and it must certainly be taken seriously. I have made a case for it here. Perhaps Chaboneau Lassay was what Guenon was alluding to. Where there is smoke, there is fire.

@Michel

The only actions of eternal value are the corporal and spiritual works of mercy. That is not something one boasts about, although what I am doing is obvious.

@scardanelli

Good catch about Eckartshausen. Yes, he was influential in Martinism; Tomberg builds on that tradition and is not as radically novel as some seem to believe. As for the rest of your comment, that is the upcoming topic this week for the medtarot group.

Cassiodorus on 2013-10-07 at 13:32 said:

This post was excellent Cologero!

The section on natural and supernatural man gets at the heart of the tension between Christianity and Perennialism. Here's the thing, it seems to me that to reconcile the TUOR with the Abrahamic faiths, one has to regard the historical facts of Revelation in relative and consequently, non-essential terms. If it is not true that "the supernatural experience is only the result of God's direct action", what exactly is Revelation?

On the TUOR view, is an Orthodox religion a "saving mirage", a map that shows the "path to the summit" and provides "combustible material" to ignite the slumbering intellect? But, how can one square this off with the central claims of traditional Christianity- that puts supreme importance on a set of "temporal saving facts"?

Logres on 2013-10-07 at 23:47 said:

What if Christianity is a perfection of myth and religion in the highest possible sense? And also the lowest? Christ as both true myth and re-establisher of all lost religions. Would not such a hero, if he existed, be the supreme servant, to reunite to mankind both myth and religion, in his historical trajectory? This seems to have been the view of the antique Europeans, or at least, their intuitive sense. Such a "fact" would go a long way towards explaining the tensions in the debate.

Michael on 2013-10-08 at 20:10 said:

Do you think that Guenon was correct about the necessity of having an intellectual elite that would ease the transition to a traditional society? I think Tomberg has a similar concept in MoT: the difference between the crew of a ship and passengers.

And is the idea of moving to a traditional society similar to the middle ages still a desirable goal?

Scardanelli on 2013-10-08 at 21:15 said:

I think it's a little too easy to misunderstand the phrase "intellectual elite." We won't be be delivered by journal articles or conferences. I believe what tomberg refers to could more rightly be called the interior church which acts as a ferment or arcanum for the exterior symbolic church and for exoteric culture in general. I think intellectuals of our day, even if they "lean" towards traditionalism might find it difficult to gain entrance to the interior church. As Eckartshausen says, "We live in the times of the idolatry of the intellect, we place a common torchlight upon the altar..."

Cassiodorus on 2013-10-09 at 14:42 said:

Logres,

I'm inclined to take the view that the Incarnation, when interpreted Traditionally, must be understood as an an absolutely unique event- that is, Jesus Christ is "ground zero" of the Divine descent. Just as there is hierarchy within the Divine Principle (Nirguna/Saguna Brahman), perhaps the same can be said of the Revelations themselves.

12.27 The Opposite of Identity

> Abba Euloge one day was unable to hide his sadness.
>
> — Why are you so sad, Abba? asked an old man.
>
> — Because I am beginning to doubt the intelligence of the brothers concerning the great realities of God. This is already the third time, having shown them a piece of linen on which I had drawn a small red dot and asking them what they saw, they all replied, a "small red dot" but never "a piece of linen".

Recapitulation Before getting to the main point, about which I've been pondering for some time, I want to draw a few more red dots. There are two ways to read Gornahoor. The first is for those who know the principles of Tradition to be true and the second is for those who are willing to consider what might logically and necessarily follow on the

assumption those principles are true. There are three main markers of Tradition:

1. Exoteric religion
2. Esoteric or metaphysical dimension
3. Social structure

We presume the existence of exoteric religions, but don't dwell on the multitudinous practices and beliefs except perhaps for illustrative purposes. The second marker is the main focus since there is a common metaphysics and understanding of symbols underlying traditional teachings. The third is the social structure that would follow from the metaphysics: it would be hierarchical, ordered, and open to the transcendent dimension.

Yet, in some circles there is still persistent confusion, resulting from the emphasis on marker (1) and a misunderstood (3). There is the belief that an exoteric religion can be chosen on a whim based on mere personal preference, such as an attraction to certain myths, art forms, etc., even to the point of arbitrarily reclaiming the superficial elements of a lost tradition as the "real" thing.

The confusion about marker (3) also presumes that social structures can arbitrarily be imposed. With the opposition to the so-called modern world evinced by Guenon, Evola, Coomaraswamy, etc., the presumption is that any opposition whatsoever to certain aspects of the modern world is ipso facto "traditional". Absolutely not, as only a certain opposition has that character, viz., one that is hierarchical, ordered, and transcendent.

Ignorance of metaphysics is the fundamental cause of confusion, just as it is the fundamental point of a Guenon. The "transcendental unity of religion" does not mean all religions are the "same". Clearly, an atheist or a post-modern thinker has absolutely no clue what "transcendental

unity" might mean, yet many self-described "traditionalists" take such comments seriously. To repeat, this is not the place to debate whether tradition is true, but rather to highlight what it means. Anyone is free to deny it; i.e., to assume that reality is fundamentally chaos and that matter takes on forms accidentally and at random. But it takes a special kind of fool to complain about this kaleidoscopic play of forms, as he is bound to repeat them ad infinitum. Instead, we recommend for him an attitude "amor fati".

Normal and Healthy Society For those of us in the West truly interested in Tradition, it behooves us to take a close look at what tradition has looked like. All the early writers on this topic are agreed that for Western Europe, the Middle Ages represented Tradition in each of the three markers. Hence, we should investigate what and how men thought at that time. Evola, in his self-defense, claims that he believes what cultured men considered normal, healthy, and sane prior to the French Revolution, at least in Latin Europe.

For example, here is an article by Plinio Corrêa de Oliveira[39], a man who has that same world view; this may help in understanding it. He came to a similar understanding of historical developments as Guenon's, although there is no direct link. This is an illustration of the "transcendental unity." Now I understand that there are the cultured despisers of the Western tradition who want no truck with such a viewpoint. They, therefore, should substitute the word for their own tradition. Nevertheless, the essence will be the same; the new tradition will have an identical metaphysical understanding; the symbols will be comparable.

To understand how things happen in the world, we need to know the three fundamental forces: Providence, Will, and Destiny. These represent a deeper understanding of the three gunas of the Vedas. Destiny is the au-

[39] `http://www.tfp.org/tfp-home/plinio-correa-de-oliveira/philosophical-self-portrait-plinio-correa-de-oliveira.html`

tomatic process of energy and matter that treats things indiscriminately and without differentiation. For example, the force of gravity will be the same for man and for a rock. Providence is an upward pull that does not operate by brute force. This leaves Will as the field open to Man. However, when men do not know their true will, the actions will be arbitrary and will conflict with others.

Since the will follows the intellect, it knowing is necessary before willing and daring. Without knowledge of God, men will not know how to follow Providence. Without knowledge of science, men will be at the mercy of the material forces. And without knowledge of himself, his will is a tool of desire and ignorance.

So to understand the force of events, it is necessary to understand how men think and what their basic assumptions are. Everything else follows. Of course, few men are consistent thinkers, so most men will deny the consequences of their assumptions; that is why it is so difficult to point them out. Nevertheless, as time passes, consistency will indeed win out. Most people know this intuitively, even if not explicitly; they seem to grasp the idea of the "slippery slope".

Pride and Sensuality As Mr. de Oliveira points out, there are two obstacles to finding the true will, namely pride and sensuality.It is important to note that this has nothing at all to do with "moralizing" or tied to a specific religious tradition, since these obstacles can be precisely defined metaphysically and psychologically.

Ignorance may be of three kinds. There are the unintelligent, the bulk of men, who are simply incapable of metaphysical principles. In a traditional society, they can rely on the social structure to teach them true things through stories, symbols, etc.; they will benefit from the "normal and healthy" beliefs of the leaders. Ignorance itself has a simple cure: to acquire knowledge. Hence, those men capable of it should devote their leisure time to that acquisition.

Yet, there are the prideful, full of self-importance, who refuse to conform to true principles, preferring instead their own opinions. Even if the spiritual and political authorities seem to be running on empty, and are not worth following, the principles they should be expounding are still true. The problem is that if everyone is following his own opinion, social chaos ensues, as is obvious today. The most organized opinions will be able to organize society along their own lines.

If a man does not believe in a higher order, then it makes perfect sense that the purpose of the intelligence and the will is to satisfy desire. Unfortunately, desire is the cause of suffering as desires can never be permanently satisfied. (I am not speaking here of satisfying "needs".) Sensuality will cloud a man's mind, and we see this even among those considered to be "traditionalists".

Posted on 2013-10-09 by Cologero

* * *

`Thorsten on 2013-10-11 at 11:19 said:`

Some important points have once again been need touched upon here that need resolution. It would be fascinating to find out how the Traditionalist Christians differ from the self-styled "Traditionalists" in the Alt Right and New Right in terms of ethnic background. I'm confident that the latter group are overwhelmingly of Germanic (in the broad sense of the term) and to a lesser degree Balto-Slavic descent, while the former have a much stronger Latin component. Perhaps this is an all too obvious phenomenon but I think that in order for a Traditional society to take shape again in the US or Europe the fact that the identitarian/antimodern Teutons can only be reeled in to Christianity by making it resemble a pre-Christian warrior cult as much as creative license allows (Witness to what lengths the authors of the Dream of the Rood and Heliand went in order to make the Gospel digestable.) This is something that will have to be worked out if for no other reason than to get men of warrior spirit on the right side of this fight.

I myself belong to this nettlesome group and have been earnestly been trying to find a way to make traditional Christianity work for me. But I cannot emphasize enough how truly foreign this religion feels, all the more so to the degree that the Old Testament emphasized. Consider how much longer Christianity has settled into the makeup of the culture of Latin Europe as opposed to Iceland or Lithuania for example where pre-Christian beliefs persisted into modernity.

At the same time Traditionalists (of any faith) are by and large right in saying that Germanic, or for that matter any other stripe of European, neo-paganism is contrived because it does indeed lack the degree of continuity in terms of initiation and institutions. This does not negate the fact that many of these individuals truly descend from peoples in which Christianity only ever achieved a relatively superficial penetration into the hearts of its coverts.

I think a dialogue is in order and I hope individuals from both camps can hear each other out for both sides have ignored one another's disagreements and both sides will benefit from the exchange.

Cologero on 2013-10-12 at 10:51 said:

Thorsten, you are bringing up the question of the proper vehicle for Tradition and how it may vary from people to people. Although at the level of metaphysics, a "dialog"should be possible, at the psychological level, the situation is quite different. That is the domain of the psyche or soul, the vast middle ground between the body and spirit. Unfortunately, Guenon simply ignores that, even though that is where people live out their lives. Here is where Jung is of value, since his domain is the psychological effects of religious doctrines, not the truth of the doctrines themselves.

It is obviously true, as you have noted, the Christianity is commonly taught today has lost its hold on most intelligent men. In your case, as you say, it feels "alien". Attempts to "upgrade" it have had mixed results. On the one hand, there are the demythologizers like a Marcus Borg (Nordic) who try to make it suitable for the modern mind. Although he brings up many good points, his worldview is hardly distinguishable from the secular modern mind.

On the other hand, a Valentin Tomberg goes the other way to see the Christian message as a series of true myths, a revelation of the hidden dimension of history. Presumably, he is not introducing novelty, but merely bringing attention to what was already there. Unfortunately, his work is quite difficult, requiring years of study and meditation. It remains to be seen if his work will be the leavening he hoped it to be.

That aside, Gornahoor is not trying to vivify Christianity, but rather to show that at one time its doctrines and metaphysics were compatible with Tradition. That is no different from what a Guenon or a Coomaraswamy also claimed. In the modern world, there are many choices, which are ancestors did not have, so there is the feeling (actually an illusion) that we can simply choose a tradition much like a housewife picking out fruits at the marketplace.

The point I have been trying to make is that the overturning of Christian civilization has consequences, as it is simultaneously tied to the rise of the modern world. However, one feels about Christianity personally, that is simply an objective fact. So my gripe with that new right crowd is that they end up as unconscious enablers of the modern world. Moreover, their criticisms are puerile and ignorant, usually derived from the perennial opponents of Christian civilization.

The task, as I see it, for those who want both to cleave to tradition and to overcome Christian

civilization is to be constructive rather than destructive. Just as you pointed out, Christianity in Europe developed from, built on, and integrated customs and insights from the previous pagan civilization; we have not denied that here. On the contrary, we have pointed it out over and over. So the future neo-paganism, if there should ever be such a prophet who is yet to appear, would have to do a similar thing.

Thorsten on 2013-10-12 at 23:41 said:

Cologero,

I appreciate your response. I have not yet read Jung because I had gotten the impression that his work was incompatible with Tradition. But given his value "in the domain of the psyche or soul, the vast middle ground between the body and spirit" I will have to put him on my list likewise with Tomberg.

Although I understood that Gornahoor has sought to, and to my understanding succeeded in demonstrating the compatibility of medieval Christendom Tradition, I was admittedly confused about Gornahoor's position on Christianity, having been under the impression that an attempt at the revival of Christianity in line with Tradition was indeed a goal of Gornahoor.

So if Gornahoor is not attempting to vivify Christianity (and I would assume doesn't find the vivification thereof possible or worthwhile), but if choosing one's tradition is not an option then where does that leave those of the West who cannot find salvation within Christianity given that (neo-)paganism is (at best) little more than various muddled attempts at reconstructing ancient Indo-European religious practices based on a collection of mythological, philosophical, and ethnographic literature? Is the arrival of a prophet as you allude to who could develop, build on, and integrate customs and insights from pagan antiquity and medieval Christendom (Btw I didn't mean to suggest Gornahoor had in any way denied the influence of paganism on historical Christendom) the only conceivable solution for those in the West who cannot honestly call Christendom home?

I don't mean to put you on the spot but I am struggling to find a workable solution for those who are effectively unmoored from a living tradition. This possibility of a new prophet or a divine king is precisely what I suggested was the only hope not just for the tradition-bereft but for the West as a whole in comment on a post on a well known New Right website. To my disappointment, but hardly to my surprise this received no positive commentary. However I think I succeeded in pointing out the spiritual hollowness of the worship of one's own race. To believe one's race or nation has a divine mission or higher destiny can be positive in certain contexts and has a traditional precedent at least as far back as Virgil, but equating one's biological race with the divine is nothing more than collectivized narcissism (or pride and sensuality) and needless to say is incompatible with Tradition. It really is a shame because there are people of great intellectual and leadership ability, who offer valid critiques of modernity which relies upon an increasingly rare affective detachment and insight, who seem to reject out of principle

the possibility of metaphysical reality.

Regards,

Thorsten

Cologero on 2013-10-13 at 01:23 said:

If you read Jung as a scientist and not as a metaphysician, I don't see a problem. I recommend you read paragraphs 340 and 341 in the chapter Symbols of the Mother in Symbols of Transformation and then get back to me.

I don't know exactly what you are referring to, but it seems that most of that crowd has no objection to the modern world per se, they want it populated just with white people. You can fight political battles on certain issues and take allies of convenience, but that is not the real problem.

The modern world is based on the overturning of the once accepted order of things. That is beyond dispute and it doesn't require any great intellectual ability to discern that. The moderns will freely admit it. To oppose modernity therefore is to desire to restore the traditional order of things. That may sound simple enough, but over the centuries most men have forgotten what that was, or else they mistake the faint echos of that order for the real thing. I would recommend staying away from such men as their "insights" are illusory, but you are free to spend your time and efforts any way you like.

Now, Thorsten, you are putting yourself in quite a bind. You reject both the modern world and the spiritual source of the order that the modern world overturned and continues to overturn. No wonder you feel frustrated and at a loss.

No, Gornahoor is not "trying" to revive Christianity along the lines of Tradition, just the opposite in fact. I agree with Guenon and Coomaraswamy that medieval (in my definition of it) Christianity was traditional. All I have done is to bring to light certain texts to demonstrate that. If you reject Tradition out of hand, as those "great intellectuals" do, then this whole project is meaningless and their criticisms of Christianity are really irrelevant. In effect, they are also denying the source of the order that served their ancestors quite well. If they failed to absorb that teaching fully — and I don't believe that — then they need to yield to those who do understand it. Or do you believe that all opinions are of equal value?

If you claim to be a "traditionalist", then you need to actually live that way. It is more than an intellectual achievement as the moral component is even more important. It requires loyalty to one's ancestors and to spiritual authority. It requires acceptance of a hierarchy. It requires adherence to the divine order of things. It is one thing to say so, quite another to do so. I am not in a position to judge that, nor do I suffer from the grandiose notion that the world is waiting for me to "vivify" tradition. However, I do know that I would never under any circumstances submit to those you claim have "leadership ability". The modern world is preferable to their vision.

As time passes, more and more possibilities of manifestation, which could not have survived

in more stable times, start appearing. They give the illusion of more choices, but the reality is that they just bring more confusion. That is why there cannot be a corporate solution but rather, as Guenon pointed out, an elite needs to form to germinate the corporate body. These elite need to understand metaphysical principles, not to reject them "out of principle", or better said, from a lack of principles.

Without such knowledge, how can you make any sane decision? So that is your first task. Your earlier comment motivated me to write an article about that; you can decide which principles make sense to you.

We are not here just to criticize, nor to put anyone in a perpetual state of anger or agitation. Knowledge of the way things work makes one calmer and happier. It is worth the trouble for those with the intellectual capacity to accomplish it.

JA on 2013-10-13 at 10:24 said:

People forget sometimes that Germanic Austria, is quite Catholic, the seat of the empire was held by the Catholic German Hapsburg family. I think the problem is not race it's geography – the periphery of Europe was less affected by the Tradition, emanating outward from Rome. If we do have a Tradition as a race, it is to be found in Rome, the eternal city that had an unbroken line of emperors beginning with Augustus through Constantine to Charlemagne and Frederick Barbarossa.

I have a lot of issues with Catholicism as a doctrine but it is my religion, I was baptised a Catholic and refuse to apostasise.

Thorsten on 2013-10-13 at 14:51 said:

JA,

I think you are right to an extent about geography being the determining factor, as opposed to race given that Austria and southern Germany were part of the Roman Empire before it was "Holy". But as you touched on, I think that in the absence of the Kaiseridee Catholicism looses much of its appeal even in northern in Germany which was never under the pre-Christian Roman Empire.

In my particular case I was born into Methodism, my last Catholic ancestor was a great grandfather who I never knew, and all the rest of my family has been protestant for hundreds of years (New England Puritans, Episcopals, Methodists, German Baptist Brethren, Dutch Reformed Church). So although it's "in the blood" Catholicism, or any other remotely traditional religion isn't even a memory of any of my living family members. The last time my ancestors practiced the Catholic faith in a traditional hierarchical society was probably the mid to late 18th century southwestern Germany in the last days of the HRE. I wish I knew what to make of that.

12.28 The Seed of the Future World

Recently someone, claiming to be a Hindu priest despite looking European, informed me vaguely that Westerners misunderstand the *Sanatana Dharma*. Since my understanding is heavily colored by the writings of **Rene Guenon**, we shall rely on his essay on that topic included in the collection *Studies in Hinduism*. We shall use the traditional method in debate of using sentences, so it will be possible to refute, rectify, enhance, or embellish any one of them. We do realize that there is a "politically correct" movement afoot to use the term Sanatana Dharma as a synonym or replacement for "Hinduism", but since the Hindus themselves cannot agree on that, it merits no further discussion.

On the surface, Guenon agrees with the claim in question since he asserts that the West has no exact equivalent. Although **Ananda Coomaraswamy** says that its best approximation is the *Philosophia Perennis* of the Middle Ages, Guenon sets out to show there are some significant differences. However, this is pointless in itself, because our real aim is to use the Sanatana Dharma as the key to bring out the full meaning and implications of the Philosophia Perennis.

In his essay, *The Spirit of India*, Guenon again asserts that true wisdom remains solely in the East. He describes the end of the Kali Yuga and the proper attitude of the new elite:

> The world of disorder and error will be destroyed, and by the purifying and regenerative power of Agni all things will be reestablished and restored in the wholeness of their original state, the end of the present cycle being also the beginning of the future cycle. Those who know that it must be so cannot, even at the heart of the worst confusion, lose their immutable serenity. However irksome it be to live in an epoch of trouble and almost general obscurity, they cannot be affected by it deep in themselves, and it is here that we find the strength of the true elite. Undoubtedly, if

> the darkness should continue to spread more and more, this elite could, even in the East, become reduced to a very small number. *But it is enough that some preserve integrally the true knowledge to be ready, when the ages are completed, to save all that can still be saved from the present world and become the seed of the future world.*

There is a little paradox here that Guenon ignores. If the West is furthest along the Kali Yuga, then it will be the first to commence the next cycle, i.e., the West is the "seed of the future world". Since the owl of Minerva flies at dusk, the West may well be in possession of the Eternal Wisdom, even if virtually, and Guenon has his own prejudices. Hence, we will have to revisit some ideas of **Julius Evola**, particularly those that put him at odds with Guenon.

Now, Guenon had the opinion that the West would have to count on aid from the East to restore its traditional spirit. This aid would need a "point of support in the Western world"; however, he admitted that these possibilities are "presently difficult to define." Perhaps 80 years later we can define them. There have been a series of Indian gurus who have embraced the West, starting with **Vivekenanda**, then the Self-Realization Fellowship, Transcendental Meditation, and so on. Guenon did not much approve of Vivekenanda, and probably not the others. More recently we know that Sting practices Tantric sex and many women are doing Hatha Yoga exercises. I doubt that they will be restoring the traditional spirit. On the contrary, India is now exporting engineers and managers, the graduates of their prestigious **Indian Institutes of Technology**, who are all too willing to leave the traditional spirit behind if they are able.

The other choice is Islam, since it has become a daily presence in much of Europe. Although it may be preserving the eternal wisdom, circumcision and the prohibition of alcohol and sausage are obstacles to Europeans. Nevertheless, Islam shows in a vivid way how a traditional society is organized. In Islam, there is no distinct secular and religious

spheres since every aspect of daily life is regulated by sharia law. This includes the proper way to eat and pray, down to how to urinate, even how to clean one's private areas. Throughout the day, the Muslim needs to avoid unclean things and perform duties and tasks correctly. That is not so for the contemporary westerner, who is quite pleased with unclean things. It wasn't always the case, since there was a time when a European man sought to avoid temptations and occasions of sin while doing good deeds. The main difference was that the European was not as concerned about corporeal laws, since he tended to spiritualize ideas about cleanliness.

So it seems that Guenon was wrong about the East rushing to set the West spiritually aright, at least willingly. Hence, it behooves us to start defining the possibilities that Guenon was unable to do. One of those possibilities is to use the Sanatana Dharma to clarify aspects of the Philosophia Perennis that have become incomprehensible to modern man. After that, we shall reexamine the differences in spirituality and mentality between East and West as Guenon understands them. Finally, we will turn to Julius Evola and **Valentin Tomberg** to make that distinction even sharper. Since we here do not suffer from an inferiority complex in regards to the West, nor do we feel alienated from the most recent spiritual tradition of the West, we shall make the case that the Western view is correct and is the seed of the future world despite its current state of disorder. We are convinced that once you think about it a bit, you will also see that it is true. However, that will need to wait until tomorrow.

Posted on 2013-10-29 by Cologero

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kenneth shaw on 2013-10-30 at 09:23 said:

Please continue. This is subject is very helpful to me as I try to map out a course for my religoous life.

Constantine Aetos on 2013-10-30 at 16:27 said:

Well you were right in your welcome post that "Others may have an agenda apart from the group".

Anyway, I would like to add that there is an article by Arthur Versluis titled "The Political Significances of Western Gurus" Esotericism, Religion, and Politics (2012). A very interesting article of westerner gurus steeped in eastern thought trying to "correct" the west.

Max on 2013-10-30 at 18:06 said:

Thank you for this post, I agree fully and have been thinking along the same lines recently. Guenon wrote for the west, that might point toward him also sharing the same ideas brought up here. He probably wrote because he thought he could make a difference -by contribution to the understanding of the west by studying eastern traditions that entered modernity later and therefore was more comprehensible. I have observed that there is a gradual sort of merging of traditions which has interesting implications. It has progressed to the apparent goal of making a kind of synthesis of all traditions that existed, the shepherd gathering his scattered flock. Moving from potentiality of the world in the beginning to fullest realization. Think about it; Christianity inherited from keltic, nordic, roman, judaic, egyptian, greek, and countless others we might not even be aware of just as those traditions themselves probably were syntheses of others that are unknown today. The romans for example incoroporated conquered and subjugated peoples religious views in effect allowing their aspect of the whole to live on and be transmitted. If you look at hinduism it is the same story, and now they contribute to understanding of our inheritance. Those developments are seen in the light of "the product of the manifestation", a new seed. The last times are where a complete understanding of all the facets of the manifestation can be reached, a unique opportunity for those living in that moment. Soon we will be dealing only with reality and nothing else left, the highest vantage point at the top of the mountain where we can pass across the rainbow.

Ash on 2013-10-30 at 18:26 said:

If we take the "east" as including Russia and the eastern Christian countries, would Orthodoxy not present itself as a third solution? Its greater cultural similarity to Western norms and increasing openness to taking in Western traditions, such as examining the forms of worship which were subsumed in the Latin expansion (for better or worse) seem to have made it a successful path for many Westerners to walk, such as James Cutsinger and Fr. Seraphim Rose.

You mentioned Alan Watts a previous post. Do you think that he represented an honest attempt to try and use eastern wisdom to critique the Western decline (which is to say, to some extent trying to grasp the forgotten Traditional principles) or that he was confusing exoteric and esoteric aspects of the east? "Does It Matter" appears to make a connection between principles and everyday life, down to clothing and cooking. In that case, the proper order of the higher

guiding the lower has been recognized, unlike in yoga classes where fitness and relaxation seem to be the end goals, if not utter New Age nonsense.

Ken Shaw on 2013-10-30 at 18:52 said:

In regards to Orthodox Christianity, I've seen Seraphim Rose spoken well of in Perennialist circles

David on 2013-10-30 at 19:53 said:

@Ash : I live myself in a Roman Catholic environnement, and I would very like to know as to why Orthodoxy would not be considered Western Religion, in it's "pure" form; that is, Medieval Christianity. In other words, Orthodoxy may be more traditionnal, just as Medieval Roman Catholic were (in some regards). They sprang from the same roots, even if language does changes alot and Orthodoxy became more greek than their Western counterpart : can we really say they are alien from western tradition ?

Ash on 2013-10-30 at 22:02 said:

David, insofar as both Orthodoxy and Catholicism are manifestations of the true Christian Tradition, I would say they are not alien to each other. Is this the sense in which you consider medieval Catholicism the "pure" form of Orthodoxy? This aside, I'm not sure how that argument can be made, as what we now know as Orthodoxy came through Byzantium, which itself was born in the Greek Christian tradition of the Eastern Empire, and is not an offshoot of the Latin Christian tradition, although both have the same root. When I say it is alien to the West, I simply mean that its "language" (apotheosis vs salvation by grace, etc) and history differ from the Western experience, not its doctrines. That said, if they were completely akin to each other, we would not still have the tragic schism existing in the Christian world. As a Catholic with Tradition in mind, would you say that you could come into the Orthodox community and consider it as Western as your own tradition? As has often been pointed out on this blog (see the white Hindu in this post), purity of principle in a Traditional stream doesn't always mean that it is suitable for each seeker (although I don't believe this to be the case with Orthodoxy – if and when I come to an exoteric path myself, it could well be the Orthodox faith).

JA on 2013-10-31 at 09:42 said:

after having once been very pro-Orthodox I came to see that it is not suitable for a westerner, seeing as the Orthodox church is very anti-west historically (opposing Charlemagne, the Crusades, they see the Holy Roman Empire as a usurpation, what lost Jerusalem for us was the schismatics making deals with the Mohammedans against the Christian army, etc etc) and also from the dogmatic point of view Orthodoxy is very factional, each local church is frequently at odds with other ethnic and national churches, is that the universal church desired by Our Lord ? no –

democracy does not work, Our Lord designed His Church to be a Monarchy under One Vicar – the Pope.

Read De Maistre's Le Pape and Soloviev (a Russian)'s Russia and the Universal Church to learn more... ... ...

Avery on 2013-10-31 at 10:14 said:

I, on the contrary, find the Orthodox Church much more palatable than Catholicism. Last Sunday, I sat in on a large Catholic Mass and was blasted with contemporary music and Latino dance-inspired hymns. I didn't think I had preconceptions of how a church should sound, but I was stunned how inappropriate it was. There were Protestants playing "contemporary Christian music" in the square outside, and I had the strong impression that they were two peas in a pod. The ROCOR services I've been to are also mostly in the vulgar but maintain an ancient, sacred attitude throughout. This is reflected in the dress I saw: headscarves at ROCOR, lesbian 'dos among the Catholics.

The paradox is, if I am church shopping between incompatible faiths anyway, why limit myself to Christianity? If I sense the divine in the ancient, why not just read old books?

scardanelli on 2013-10-31 at 11:39 said:

My experience attending mass in a traditional Catholic church celebrating the Latin Mass with priests from the FSSP and a modern mass at a modern church are miles apart. I grew up with the Novus Ordo mass, so there is a bit of nostalgia attached to it, but when one attends the Latin Mass, there is a sense of beauty and presence, and one feels as if he is no longer in an ordinary setting. One is attending a solemn ritual rather than a party. People dress respectfully- the women all wear headscarves and the men wear suits. When I go, I have the sense that I am taking part in something timeless and beautiful. Of course, not all are lucky enough to live near such churches, so I can understand your disillusionment.

I attended the Divine Liturgy at a local Orthodox church several times as well, and found it quite beautiful. I was really attracted by what at the time appeared to be a more developed mysticism. I no longer think that. But in the end, as JA said, it just felt foreign. What is available in the Orthodox church is available in the Catholic church. It is just not as apparent. There are opportunities to immerse oneself in the tradition of the west... one such is going on right now with the MOTT discussion.

JA on 2013-10-31 at 11:55 said:

Scardenelli we are 100& in accord.

I extend an offer to anyone reading this, who has questions about Catholicism, to join me if you are in New York, USA at Holy Innocents Church every Sunday at 10am – and then tell me if you still think the Mass is vulgar.

I've been to both Latin Masses and Eastern Rite, for a while I went to a Ukrainian church because there was no Latin church I could get to at the time, and – while this is a personal equation to use Evola's term – I feel more at home in the Latin rite. The use of instrumental music for one instance appeals to my inner aesthete... ... ..

It's kind of funny that while I may appear as a doctrinaire traditionalist Catholic at times, I actually praise Catholicism more for its aesthetic value to me than for any kind of petty morality, my lifestyle is more that of an Italian Renaissance Catholic.

David on 2013-10-31 at 14:28 said:

@Ash : I understand your point, and was not trying to contradict you per se, but to understand. I read as much from Latin fathers that I read from Greek fathers, as much from Roman Catholic than Eastern Orthodox and find myself at home with both of those. Of course, it's not all about books, but rather a way of life and rituals that channel that life; but sometimes I doubt that the two faith are so much apart. I think it's more a problem of degeneration than actual doctrinal difference.

Cologero on 2013-11-01 at 22:43 said:

I have missed you dearly, August, and appreciate your insights, but there is really nothing to see here. I have made it clear many times that you cannot choose your religion; however, individualism is well nigh impossible to eradicate in Americans ... here you are free to choose your toothpaste, your church, and even your gender.

Not to single out Avery, but we made this very point in his post about choosing a religion several months ago. However, youth is incorrigible and there may even be a justice in that. He is a victim of what is called "white privilege" here, so he has come to expect nothing but the best priests and the most solemn masses as a birthright, so your homely wisdom will most likely fall on deaf ears. Those of us who have been beaten down a bit come to the realization that we get the priests we deserve; this goes double for women and many other things in life that we feel just "happen" to us by unknown or even sinister forces.

As for your own unhappy situation, let it serve us all as a reminder that while the joys of victory are ephemeral, the consequences of defeat are painfully long-lasting. Worse of all is an unstable equilibrium based on mutual suspicion.

Avery on 2013-11-02 at 04:28 said:

My anchors were cut before I was born. I floated through empty ocean my whole life and only recently became aware of distant shores. I floated by a Buddhist monastery, and I felt no attachment; but a south Indian Brahmin and a Hasidic Jew were pointing me the way to America, and I followed their path. Isn't it odd how such things "happen"? The word "happen" is derived

from "hap", meaning luck or fortune. It's also cognate with happiness. Faith didn't happen at that Catholic church. It didn't happen at the CCM concert, either. Maybe I didn't have enough humility.

I told my Orthodox friend that he was on the wrong side of the Crusades. He was practically beaming. I started to explain about the Kosovo thing, the one you guys told me about, but he stopped me and said something about representatives of principles, and how you can take them down to the store and exchange them for better ones without affecting the principle itself. A bunch of hooey, if you ask me.

"But those who personify an idea should not, cannot, fall below a certain level for generations; if they do, my friend, the idea suffers too," I fired back. I was paraphrasing a book I had read somewhere, by an Italian of the postwar period. Fighting fire with fire!

My Orthodox friend was deep in thought. Finally he said, "Someone who has actually tasted truth is not contentious for truth. Someone who is considered by people to be zealous for truth has not yet learnt what truth is really like; once he has truly learnt it, he will cease from zealousness on its behalf."

Something happened!

Ash on 2013-11-02 at 05:20 said:

Thank you for your words, August. For my part, my heritage is Westphalian German, which is to say, near 500 years of Protestant heresy. My ancestors have also been Anglicans. Extended relatives create a large Muslim branch of our line in South Africa, due to intermarriage a couple of generations ago. As for me, here on the great Canadian west coast, around me stands the "tossed salad" of Canadian multiculturalism and the final break from exoteric religion which comes from being raised by a resolutely nonreligious family.

I don't say these things to complain, but merely to explain the situation many of us face. It's true, religion has its own "add to cart" option here and in the United States. When I attended my first Mass at sixteen, on a path that ultimately brought me here, I was in a way taking part in that culture. One hopes that we have all here gone beyond that delusion. The question is, what is "our" tradition, the tradition which we have been born into, spiritually if not in terms of our actual family upbringing. If it is simply a question of ancestral faith, then the Roman Church would seem to be the natural home for many of us. But let us not forget that there are a "second Rome" and "third Rome", which hold fast to the same Christian tradition (assuming it is, as Logres stated, the religion of the Kali Yuga). If it is not by accident that we are born into the current age, may it be possible that it is not an accident that these traditions, which once would have been impossible to access, are now in that Greek church in the suburb? Could that be one of the possibilities which are said to be easier to realize in the Kali Yuga than in earlier ages? If this has false reasoning or interpretation behind it, correction would be appreciated. It might be hard to explain to those noblemen in the Great Beyond, but I imagine that Martel and Charlemagne would have had some interesting conversations with their countryman Guenon about where his

path took him.

As for me, I continue my own journey into the metaphysical heritage of the West, which is without a doubt a Catholic heritage. Years ago, I began my first studies into the religions of the world with a prayer that the unknown God would guide me in discerning the true path. Perhaps such a prayer would aid us all better than a shopping cart.

12.29 Initiation and the State of War

Rene Guenon wrote nothing, as far as I can recall, about his personal spiritual practice. Because he relocated to Egypt, the assumption is that he lived as a Muslim, following all the precepts of Sharia law. This is made clear in a letter written from Cairo to "L. C." on May 17, 1935:

> The question of the difficulty of practicing Islamic rites in the countries of Europe is often discussed. The prevalent opinion, which in any case seems most justified to me by the very principles of sharia, is that there can indeed be some exceptions for persons living in non-Islamic countries, their condition being likened to a transitional state or state of war. But it is necessary to add that this concerns only those who remain only at the exoteric point of view. For a realization of an esoteric order, on the contrary, it is necessary not to forget that the observance of rites constitutes the necessary base. Moreover, it is clear that those who want the most must, first of all, and as the preliminary condition, do the least (i.e., observe the rites common to all).

We see that Guenon insists that the esoterist must participate in all the exoteric rites that the ordinary faithful are expected to follow. To be concrete, Tradition is not simply a system of thought. A man cannot be a "traditionalist" by believing certain metaphysical doctrines or holding particular political opinions. On the contrary, he must actually follow a

tradition. That requires societal support to be able to observe the rites common to all.

A day in Islam is structured by calls to prayer, ablutions, avoiding unclean things or activities, and so on. Hence, in 1935 it would have been difficult to do all that in Europe, although I don't know if that is still true in the Europe of today. That was the reason behind Guenon's relocation.

For those left behind in the West, the man of Tradition needs to consider the same issue. For 1500 years the life of a European was also structured by a Tradition. The year involved a complete liturgical cycle, with various celebrations, holidays, festivals, and parades. The day was divided into certain periods of prayer. The rites of the sacraments defined a person's entire life; although ablution was not physical, but spiritual through Penance.

In effect, men of Tradition in the West today are in a "state of war" or a state of transition, as Guenon put it, since there is the memory of a recent Tradition yet no way to fully embrace it. Obviously men at war, who are on a journey, may not be able to fully practice the exoteric rites. The question, then, is whether such a transitional state can lead to something. That would require that remnant communities form today so that exoteric rites can be practiced in tandem with the esoteric. Although Guenon eventually became dubious about that prospect, that was a personal opinion not based on any metaphysical principle. In his earliest books, he did think it possible.

However, when Guenon says that the recovery of paganism is no longer possible, that is actually based on metaphysical principles. Early in the Greek cities or in the Roman Kingdom, daily life was indeed fully structured. There were rites involving the hearth, which each home had to have. There were also many rules distinguishing the clean and the unclean. There were ceremonies for various purposes, and so on. Neo-pagan revivals have no way to recover those and artificial reconstructions do not count, since the original religious rites were considered to be divinely or-

dained. Quoting Nietzsche, psychologizing the gods and goddesses, and creating lists of "virtues" may be great fun, but it is hardly what Guenon is describing. Only a new divine revelation can make this a viable option.

Posted on 2014-01-24 by Cologero

* * *

August on 2014-01-24 at 01:04 said:

And this is a problem, and the reason certain of us cannot simply dismiss Evola, and his statements, such as the one describing those today who find solutions in religion as (from memory) 'unable to stand the tension of the nihilist climate... cases of surrender that hold no interest for us'. Significant words in the ears of some.

A kind of ascesis that sets up barriers between oneself and the world has been, and must always be, a legitimate way for some. If nothing more comes of it, let it be a signal of intent. In some wars, it's good to stand with the regular army. In others, the situation is far murkier, and the solitary ones appear.

Whatever the choice made, complacency is always a mistake; we have no reason to believe that the war is merely local, and who is certain of what awaits him? Though religion, and life, tells of mercy and promotes hope.

Ash on 2014-01-24 at 03:12 said:

I was rereading one of Logres' works earlier today and he makes an interesting point in it: the man who plants a garden in the Kali Yuga against all odds has superseded the man who conquers worlds in better times with some odds on his side. In that line, do we overthink the necessity of having to live a religious life the exact way our ancestors would have? Finding the best that one is led to (the FSSP or SSPX traditional masses, the Orthodox parishes, etc) and even re-establishing some of the old traditions in ones' own life or family could work wonders in the Kali Yuga. I've seen the ember days mentioned on this blog before.

As has also been talked about before, those further advanced say that at a certain level we should forget the actual metaphysical goals themselves, at least temporarily, and have present and focused mindfulness on the devotions at hand to assist in the distancing from the ego. Perhaps those around one aren't focusing on metaphysical development as they say rosaries or attend masses, but in that mindset how much does it really matter? Just a thought.

scardanelli on 2014-01-24 at 12:38 said:

I have been reading Paul Sedir lately, and he seems to have found a middle path between the esoteric and the lack of societal support for the exoteric. He presents a spirituality of action, of living out the essence of Christianity and the Gospels in everyday life while not necessarily being dependent on occult orders on the one hand or traditional churches on the other (though he certainly supports the Catholic Church and one's involvement in it if this is available to you).

To love ones neighbor, for instance, requires neither order nor church, nor supporting structures in society. Yet to attempt this act reveals the simplicity and complexity of the Christian tradition... What seems like mere sentimentality actually requires a good deal of "esoteric" practice and development. To love a man who inspires annoyance or hatred in you requires one to become aware of his negative thoughts, to cease identifying with them, to realize his freedom from these thoughts and to exercise his true will in perfect love.

Michael on 2014-01-24 at 13:29 said:

What esoteric rites exist alongside the exoteric rites? I guess that if I have to ask, then they are not esoteric anymore :-) but if anyone can point the way, I would appreciate it.

I try to participate fully in the Catholic Church's liturgical cycle. I realize that the Mass and the post Vatican II calendar leave some things to be desired, but at least it is a legitimate spiritual authority. Meanwhile, I hope for a restoration of parts of the Catholic tradition that were discarded.

@Scardanelli, what writings of Sedir are you reading? Unfortunately, I only have his novel.

scardanelli on 2014-01-24 at 14:21 said:

Michael,

Try searching for Sedir at Scribd. There are many works and compilations translated by Zadah Guerin-McCaffery, a member of Les Amities Spirituelles, which apparently is the group he formed after ending his involvement with occultism and Martinism. All of the essays further develop themes he covered in Initiations.

Michel on 2014-01-24 at 15:19 said:

In a way, and the realization of this concerns a few people, the problem has never been the existence of the Primordial Tradition. The problem has been a 'concealing' of it through the procession of the ages. All other traditions are adaptations of it that are concurrent with the prevailing cyclic conditions. This withdrawal of it, results in a perception of it under various ways, each way congenial to the one perceiving it. Thus one sees it as Islam, another sees it as Christianity and so on. The above article seems to inch at the apparent dissonance between the type of person that can potentially fully realize this and the person that cannot realize the Primordial Tradition . In Islamic esotericism, there are three types of initiates under two primary divisions. The primary divisions are: the murid/mureed and the murad. The mureed is the 'normal

initiate' the person that experiences a progressive spiritual realization. He is the attracted and God is the attraction. The murad however is different; he is the desired, or the attraction and God is the attracted. God desires him. The result is that he directly, without going through any procession realizes the truth, al-Haqq, even spontaneously. To put it in other words, he is the natural contemplative, the one who's perception of the modulation of the Primordial Tradition is not as intense and in some cases is even lacking as compared to the one who, though being also able to realize this Tradition is however warranted to do so via successive stations or stages.

The other three divisions concern the experience of the Supreme Station and not the manner of ritual activity karma , if any, that results in this experience. The first type of initiate is called the servant. This initiate is basically similar to the mureed, he cannot permanently maintain an experience of Buddhi and can rarely experience Atma, or in western terms, he cannot permanently maintain a state of Nous/Christ-consciousness and rarely does he experience the Father as Niguna Brahaman or in a more direct way, because the spirit/buddhi/nous is the most direct 'representative' of the Infinite/atma/Father, it can be said that through knowing it (Christ) one can know the Infinite (the Father), as through knowing the ray of the sun, one knows the sun, because it (the ray) is merely the sun 'projected and limited to the ray'. However, the knowledge of this ray or Christ is not the same as the knowledge of the sun or the Father, because the Father is not limited; even though the spirit/buddhi or the experience of Christ is Absolute, by virtue of it Being the first Principle, it is limited/finite. Thus while to know Christ or to experience satchiananda is to know 'all things' it is still a limited state of knowledge, though limited only to itself. The second type of initiate is called the attracted. This can either be a mureed or a murad. Both the former and the latter can assert a permanence in the experience of the Supreme Station. Moreover, they can also "experience" the Infinite or the Father. However, when they "experience" this, they cannot experience anything else. They do not 'come back' as the servant does; they are like the yogins whose bodies may be severed in the most atrocious of ways without them eliciting any reaction. Sometimes, they even withdraw their bodies at the moment of realizing the Supreme Station, it becomes the 'Resurrected Body' or the 'Transformed trans- meaning beyond, trans-formed 'gone beyond form or figure', to 'be formless' Body' and 'are no more because they have been taken by God' like Enoch or Elijah. The final type of initiate is the Companion. Again, this can either be a murad or mureed, but is mostly a mureed, because he would have to travel through all the stages and know them perfectly; he would undergo a trans-migration , that is a vertical ascension, of being followed by a horizontal expansion of being, or both Satva and Rajas as compared to only Satva. This type of initiate is regarded by the Sufi Masters as the 'best' type of initiate. This is because his experience of the Supreme Station is of the Father and while he does "experience" this, he still "experiences" everything else as distinct, in a way, it's a sort of superimposition of two visions, one Unitive, the other one a vision of multiplicity. He is the one that is able to guide all beings in all worlds to realize the Father in a manner that is congenial to them. Not that the other two types cannot act as guides, but due to the lack of this

double vision, they cannot properly do so, for instance, the second type of initiate, the attracted might assume that everyone is like him and hence may sometimes impose 'harsh' conditions to those under his guidance, while the first type of initiate due to his 'return' to the normal point of view, though possessing Gnosis, if laxity is entertained on his part, he may fall prey to the ego's relentless jaws, or to maya's seductive dance, or to the power of the prince of the air, and hence may mislead those under his guidance. The Companion however possess a vision of all beings, from their respective point of view while at the same time being completely free from maya and being a True Friend of God, possessing His vision as well; he thus is the perfect guide, because he is not privy to a fall and can also raise the fallen to the Supreme Station without 'harshness'; with a 'kind and gentle spirit'.

The reason I've stated all that is due to an implied relationship that exists between these three types of initiates and the state of the world today, in the establishment of an elite. I have not stated all the characteristics of these different types of initiates, but simply the relevant ones. To me, the connection lies in these three types of men and giving unto them what is rightfully theirs. Due to the extreme obstruction of the Primordial Tradition however, what is needed is the murad or the one that the Primordial Tradition or God desires. This one is scarcely atrophied and is 'soft' and is naturally receptive to the presence of the Divine. Thus via an ascesis or sometimes even without one, this one can experience a spontaneous psychic and spiritual regeneration, undergoing both a second and third birth by virtue of mere exposure to the world itself, due to existence of a Spiritual Order that reflects itself cosmically as the drama that unfolds in every macro-cosmic aspect, even those of 'ordinary life'; and these births triggered as a result of predisposed identification to the processes that occur outside with the processes that occur inside, or to put in another way, because all objects perceived "outside" are nothing other than an extension of the being, the truth is there is no "outside",there is only one Reality experienced under different states of being and this under different constrictions of consciousness, which is the sufficient reason for an experience of any state of being. The murad knows this truth innately even if not consciously, ergo by virtue of this softness, or innate disposition, an event as simple as a bird flying to him can suddenly erupt a displacement of consciousness from the individual state of being to the supra-individual state of being. To digress minutely, It seems that Guenon in his 'bureaucratic' expositions on the Arcane had this type of initiate in mind, upon insisting that the rituals simply be preserved properly, even if those preserving them do not quite understand what they are doing, or worse even if the rituals do not affect them, so that, when one such initiate (murad) is attracted to this order as an expression of himself, upon exposure to these rituals, his realization would be almost immediate. Evola may not have completely understood this, hence his critique on Guenon's insistence on this 'mechanistic' preservation. Ironically, on his own exegesis of the Arcane, by giving practical techniques to the qualified, he acknowledged the preservation of the type of man who would, by virtue of his 'softness' be privy to a vertical initiation, devoid of a corporeal order, and hence who would benefit from these practices. He

failed to apply the same reasoning to a different situation. To continue, because in the West there no longer exists any genuine expression of the Divine as an Order, ascesis to me seems plausible. The ascetic as a murad who becomes a companion- the third type of initiate- would be more or less, upon congenially experiencing the Supreme Station or the Father, able to convey guidance to the first type of initiate in the primary division, the mureed. The second type of initiate, the murad who becomes "an attracted"-experiences nothing other than the Truth- need not any intervention, but he cannot properly or even significantly intelligently relay his experience to others that may be able to positively receive them. By 'relay', other than basic discursive activity, I of course mean 'bring water from the heavens' or 'reveal the names of things the basis of Magic ' or by virtue of the harmonious correspondence that exists between the different modalities of reality, show the symbol of the symbolized to his brethren, again show/bring, not 'invent', but literally show you the thing as it is from one order to another, given its essential nature. Thus, the only chance the West has, in the period of transition, is the murad who becomes a Companion, to a lesser or greater degree, the 'Super Saint' who, being the friend of God would convey His Will to those who also wish to know and adhere to it, though being of a different dharma and hence not credulous to a direct vertical unveiling of God. It is those who Being desired, invoke Him, and bid Him "come down!" their hearts always oriented towards Him, never awakening from prostration that He will listen to.

In conclusion, acsesis does not mean 'going away from the modern world' Such a description is derogatory, because the modern 'world', based on the stupid need for agitation in all forms, characterized by a wanton lust for the excitement of the most base and lowest human impulses, those shared by animals, and in some instances, those that are so low to the point of disgusting these same animals is illusory. Unlike a Traditional Civilization, that is based upon an assertion following an affirmation of the Spiritual Order which, being the first Principle, is the perfect "existential condition" and hence in a way, the only thing that properly speaking 'Exists' or 'Is', reflecting this by a conscious participation in the essences of things and corporeally structuring itself in concordance to these essences from a substantial point of view, the modern world, being literally founded on the collegiate of illusion and indulgence is 'not real'. In relation to it, there is nothing to 'go away from'. Ascesis is the reception and the kilning of the received to the point of a sudden violent burst in brazen flames of spiritual truth, at times instantaneously and at other times seemingly progressively, the result of which is the experience of the Christ and at times, of the Father. In short, in periods of transition, the thing that can prevent a collective violent shift from one cycle to another, manifested as a cataclysmic event, is first, the existence of the murad who is a Companion, then the existence of the servant. Because the aspect of interest pertains to a collective and social sphere, the attracted, and more specifically, the murad who becomes the attracted initiate, cannot be of much help to anyone but himself. "The Spirit goes wherever it wishes", to say it differently, the Spirit will go to those it desires, the murads being desired, upon calling it, get a response.

X on 2014-01-27 at 23:42 said:

"A man cannot be a 'traditionalist' by believing certain metaphysical doctrines or holding particular political opinions."

Can one really believe certain metaphysical doctrines? When one begins to "believe" it, it is no longer truly metaphysical.

scardanelli on 2014-01-28 at 08:41 said:

It seems to me that one's belief or lack thereof is irrelevant. True metaphysical doctrine does not change according to our level of understanding. Truth exists, and we must conform ourselves to it, rather than it to us. At any rate, one cannot know until one believes, and to believe is at least better than merely reading and understanding on a cerebral level.

12.30 Tradition and Being

> We think that if a Western tradition could be rebuilt it would be bound to take on a religious form in the strictest sense of this word, and that this form could only be Christian; for on the one hand the other possible forms have been too long foreign to the Western mentality, and on the other it is only in Christianity—and we can say still more definitely in Catholicism—that such remnants of a traditional spirit as still exist in the West are to be found. Every 'traditionalist' venture that ignores this fact is without foundation and therefore inevitably doomed to failure; it is self-evident that one can build only upon something that has a real existence, and that where there is lack of continuity, any reconstruction must be artificial and cannot endure.
>
> Rene Guenon, *The Crisis of the Modern World*

As we get close to the end, it is good to emphasize Guenon's point yet again. The whole purpose of Gornahoor is to go back down to the

foundations of the Western Tradition to see how it can possibly be rebuilt. This actually involves two interrelated task:

1. Going beyond the outward form of the Tradition to recover its inner meaning

2. Developing a real knowledge of Eastern doctrines

The second task serves as a corrective to the first. In other words, Eastern doctrines may serve as the key to extract the inner meanings from the first task. Moreover, "foundations" include the ancient Greek, Roman, Nordic, and Celtic elements that had been assimilated into Christianity. In particular, the Middle Ages, being closest to us in space and time, even if different in terms of intellectuality, are vital to this process of rebuilding. Although there is considerable resistance to this project, even from those who consider themselves "traditional", Guenon is hardly sanguine about alternatives. He writes:

> The least fantastic venture, in fact the only one that does not come up against immediate impossibilities, would therefore be an attempt to restore something comparable to what existed in the Middle Ages, with the differences demanded by modifications in the circumstances; and for all that has been completely lost in the West, it would be necessary to draw upon the traditions that have been preserved in their entirety, as we stated above, and, having done so, to undertake the task of adaptation, which could be the work only of a powerfully established intellectual elite. All this we have said before, but it is useful to insist on it again because too many inconsistent fantasies are given free rein at present.

Some of those fantasies, and objections, can be described as follows.

Confusion with Church Organization

Catholicism, as the Western Tradition, stands on its own. Besides Holy Scriptures, the place to find it is in the writings of the Fathers, Doctors, and Saints of the Church, inter alia. One of the roles of the Bishops is to preach and hand down that tradition. Some may perform that role better than others. However, they do not "own" the Tradition. All too many people presume that Catholicism is just about the church organization. If a bishop is mistaken, or acts badly, that means nothing for understanding the Tradition.

Presentism

Catholicism has very deep roots and cannot be limited to the acts and opinions of Church leaders today. That is not what we, nor Guenon, are referring to. On the contrary, we should not be surprised since Guenon explicitly denies that contemporary church leadership has an in depth understanding of Tradition.

Confusion about Orthodoxy

From the point of view of the esoteric Tradition, Catholicism refers also to Orthodoxy. That is a single Tradition, even if there are now competing church structures on the exoteric level. A heresy is a break from tradition, but a schism is not.

Syncretism and Indifferentism

Guenon is not advocating syncretism, i.e., the arbitrary combining of elements from disparate traditions. Nor should one be indifferent to his own Tradition. Nevertheless, at the true intellectual level there can be fruitful interaction. This is nothing new. Gornahoor has amply documented how pagan Greek ideas influenced the Fathers. The Schoolmen

were quite willing to engage in dialogue with Jewish, Muslim, and Pagan thinkers.

Paganism

There is no religion called "paganism", so a return to it is impossible. What it means today is "non-Christian" or more usually, "anti-Christian". Such movements are useless, fantastic ventures, with no intellectual depth. If you fantasize about creating a post-Christian Tradition, then you would still need to pick and choose those elements from the Christian Tradition to assimilate.

Turning East

Engaging with Eastern doctrines is not the same thing as "converting" to the outward forms of an Eastern religion. In almost all cases, this means adhering to the religion of your forefathers. It is a bourgeois conceit to believe that you can change your religion, something that would have made as little sense to an ancient as changing one's sex or race would have.

False Traditionalism

> "traditionalists" refer to people who only have a sort of tendency or aspiration towards tradition *without really knowing anything at all about it*; this is the measure of the distance dividing the "traditionalist" spirit from the truly traditional spirit, *for the latter implies a real knowledge*...

Let Guenon's words really sink in. There are many who call themselves "Traditionalists", as if it were no more than one philosophical, or even worse "political", movement among many. Someone may say he

"converted" to Traditionalism, or from Traditionalism to some other religion. That is impossible, like a chef saying he converted from reading cookbooks to actually cooking food. Such men know nothing at all, so stay away from them.

Tradition is the normal state of human culture, in almost all times and places. It is the "civilization of space", as Evola put it in *Civilizations of Space and Civilizations of Time*[40]. There is only the question of recognizing it or not.

Hence, the normal situation is to follow a Tradition; that is what makes a "traditionalist". It is a state of being, not a system of thought. At some point he may discover Guenon, which helps him understand his own Tradition in much more depth.

Forgetting Being Heidegger made one good point about the forgetfulness of Being. That means we have exchanged the idea of something for the thing itself. For example, I've known many who are enamored with the idea of being a Buddhist, but few, if any, who strive to purify the mind to perfectly reflect the Buddha nature. As Dogen pointed out, just calling yourself a Buddhist does not lead to enlightenment without proper practice.

This forgetfulness is the result of embracing nominalism rather than realism. For the nominalist, what matters is the "name" of things. A Buddhist is just someone who claims to be. However, the one thing needful is a real change in Being. That requires an inner transformation from a state of less being to more being. Specifically, that means the actualization of one's possibilities. As you are now, your Real Self and True Will are only virtual and need to be realized.

Addiction to Thinking Like sex, food, or drugs, we can become addicted to thinking. It makes us unfree, since we live a factitious life in

[40] https://gornahoor.net/?p=12696

our mind that may have little contact with reality. The lower intellect is mechanical. It responds to an idea with either a "like" or a "dislike"; for proof, just look at how popular facebook has become just on that notion.

It also works on Yes and No. If Tom says Yes to an idea, then Jerry feels compelled to say No and start an argument.

Thought is corrosive of systems whenever it sets itself up as the supreme judge. Yet, there is a knowing that transcends mere rational thinking. Is it better to be courageous or to know how to define it? Is it better to be just or to argue about it?

Purification of the mind is necessary to think well. It will never suffice to explain an idea clearly, logically, and with compelling evidence as long as "the reason is perverted by passion, or evil habit, or an evil disposition of nature".

Religion teaches us how to transcend our passions, evil habits, and bad dispositions. It is much more than a system of thought. One's nominal affiliation proves nothing. You can argue, if you like, about religious or metaphysical ideas. I, on the other hand, am more interested in whether you follow the (traditional) religion of your fathers, have a male priesthood, and pray for the dead. That is Being.

Posted on 2016-04-28 by Cologero

* * *

`Johannes on 2016-04-29 at 01:26 said:`
Conversion to catholicism is probably the worst advice anyone can give.

`Cologero on 2016-04-29 at 03:11 said:`
Johannes, is that the conclusion you reached? This is what I invited the reader to do:

- Go beyond the outward form of the Tradition to recover its inner meaning
- Develop a real knowledge of Eastern doctrines

Did no one read that?

B on 2016-04-29 at 08:41 said:

Many of the points here is what myself and close others have come to as the conclusion... to choose a living established European tradition, and stick with it through and through. The nice thing about the Catholic Faith is that it proves itself True quickly the more you learn.

Adam Wallace on 2016-04-29 at 08:48 said:

"Engaging with Eastern doctrines is not the same thing as "converting" to the outward forms of an Eastern religion. In almost all cases, this means adhering to the religion of your forefathers. It is a bourgeois conceit to believe that you can change your religion, something that would have made as little sense to an ancient as changing one's sex or race would have."

What would be the wisest course of action for a someone who is born into a totally secular environment, without any father figures of any religiousity? Following one's nature, so to speak? The adoption of any residual tradition in one's vicinity, no matter how watered-down? Or is such a person essentially doomed to his circumstance?

Lu Dongbin on 2016-04-29 at 09:39 said:

Many of the Eastern doctrines stress the need to meet an enlightened master in order to actually succeed in attaining liberation. This is why Chan Buddhist monks and Daoist adepts would travel from mountain to mountain and across the realm in search of a true master.

As far as I can see it, modern Catholicism and Christendom in general lacks enlightened masters and increasingly is entirely lacking in vitality. For one sincerely searching for transformation and gnosis, what can modern Catholicism provide to assist in this endeavor? One may be able to make progress trying to implement the wisdom and discipline suggested by the Desert Fathers or the medievals, but without an initiatory encounter with a true master can one truly hope to attain transcendence? I am not saying one will necessarily find this in the East either, but it seems much more likely.

Furthermore, you say no one can change their religion. What of those born without a religion, who grew up in secular households and were without a tradition from birth?Those may also be a product of the modern, multicultural West and have grown up as much around Eastern traditions as anything else. In such a case is choosing one's ancestral religion, which may be divorced from such a person by three generations or more, the only logical choice?

Finally, for all of Guenon's solid reasoning here, why did he become a Sufi Muslim? Could it be he saw that modern Christianity no longer offers the possibility to achieve what he sought to achieve?

Don't get me wrong here, I am supportive of Christianity and would love to see a true restoration as described. That said, excluding the hippy New Age types, I can see why sincere

Western seekers may turn East in the present circumstances.

Scardanelli on 2016-04-29 at 10:45 said:

It seems that for every truly clarifying post, 10 comments arise that seek to muddy the waters.

Lu Dongbin:

When did Cologero advise you to practice "modern Catholicism"? Did he not, in fact, advise the complete opposite? Catholicism in fact grants you access to not just to A master but THE spiritual master in Christ. Follow the instructions of the post and encounter the tradition in the writing of the saints, desert fathers, and doctors in truth and fact rather than merely theoretically. Pray, fast, meditate, and learn what is meant by "concentration without effort" through experience of that state, rather than merely thinking or writing about it. The path begins in "the heart" not the brain. Then ask questions.

As to your second point, I would go so far as to say that anyone born in the west is born as a Christian. The outward conditions are irrelevant. The west is The Catholic tradition and the Catholic tradiation is the West. There is no one without the other as Cologero has written many times. You were born outside of an exoteric form... Fine. That does not exclude you from experiencing the inner truth of the tradition.

JB on 2016-04-29 at 11:01 said:

What Rene Guenon wrote publicly in his books on Christianity and the future of the West clashes singularly with what he wrote privately in his correspondence, Cologero, and you know that, so to pretend otherwise and mislead your readers is bad faith on your part.

Your blog does not address the christianisation of European peoples, with respect to the notion of conversion, and I wonder why. Could it be that it contradicts what you write in the next sentence?

As for conversion to other traditions, you ought to know by now that certain other traditions do not recognize "conversion" in the way it is generally understood in the christian framework. If you are still not familiar with this take on things, more fool you.

Tom on 2016-04-29 at 11:52 said:

Let me be another of the Jerry commenters saying no to Tom's Yes. I admit that the following rebuttals are cliched but I feel they should be repeated since they are pertinent.

"If you fantasize about creating a post-Christian Tradition, then you would still need to pick and choose those elements from the Christian Tradition to assimilate"

What is wrong with that though? You say yourself that the Scoolmen were willing to engage with pagan thinkers and the pagan elements of Christian Tradition are well known. Islam and

Christianity each started, not with an unbroken tradition, but with a break from a tradition, the former actively attacking the sacred relics of its predecessor in the Arabian world.

Any such criticism of those who seek to revive a polytheistic spiritual practice without an unbroken line of Tradition could equally be applied to the founders of any religion.

The intention, in every case, is to get to the truth, which has always been the same

Cologero on 2016-04-29 at 13:03 said:

@JB, I don't know what Guenon wrote privately, but it is his public record that ultimately counts. He could have retracted had he wanted to.

If you are able to get past your inner rage, you may have noticed that I did address the question of a different future for the West; you could have commented on that if only you had the requisite intelligence. Of course, if you insist on following Guenon, a return to some pre-Christian tradition is out of the question. He also claimed that no new tradition is possible. So what do you suggest as a replacement, other than secularism? As you know, Guenon speculated that it would be Islam.

We certainly have addressed the "christianisation" of the European people. It was a national decision. For example, you can read about the conversion of Iceland in *Spiritual Invigoration*[41].

Your comment about "conversion" is pointless. It means to apostasize from one religion and adopt another. Are you not familiar with that?

In the future, I would ask all commenters to make sure their Xanax kicks in before clicking the "Reply" button.

Lu Dongbin on 2016-04-29 at 13:25 said:

@Scardanelli

As stated, he also said to integrate Eastern wisdom. Much of the Eastern wisdom I've read emphasizes how vital it is to encounter a true teacher who can show you the subtleties of the way. If a tradition loses this element it seems to me such a tradition has grown old, weary, and ineffectual. We may be able to ignore the lack of such a master in modern Christendom and practice what the ancients left us, but while such will likely lead to purification and progress on the path, certainly superior results to doing nothing or being a secularist like everyone else, will it lead the most serious of seekers to transcendence, to gnosis?

If the visible, living form of a tradition is utterly without vitality and indeed for the most part consciously promoting the most poisonous elements of modernity and we need to invoke an invisible, non-human teacher to guide us, aren't we in a similar position to the neopagan? The medieval tradition is gone in the same way ancient Neoplatonism is gone–we have the

[41] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8015

texts and practices of both, so where does the difference lie? In that the empty shell of the organized form lives on for the former?

If Catholicism is the West and the West is Catholicism, a notion I generally agree with, then it seems to me that the West is dead. Indeed all signs around us point to such being the case. Hopefully out of the ashes something new will arise, I just hope it won't be Islam for a variety of reasons.

Logres on 2016-04-29 at 18:39 said:

Adam W, Some time ago, when wandering in the morass of Western thought, wondering what to make of the remains of the day, knowing at best just pieces of Tradition (in the form of scholarly trails and remarks), I started praying to Saint Alban to show me in what direction I should move. St. Alban lost his head literally, and became one of the patron saints of England, from where most of my ancestors came. I have to say that that prayer was answered beyond what I could have imagined. Even if you have no physical ancestors to teach you, there are spiritual ones.

Harun on 2016-04-29 at 18:46 said:

Christianity lacks spiritual teachers, this is true but not completely.

The Church is now dominated by modernists and is dying together with the West who was once christian, but on the inside of the Church lie something that can never be destroyed.

The Apostle John will wait until the end of times, preserving true gnosis, there are few in the Church who will always preserve Tradition "and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it".

This is the final part of Kali Yuga, Christianity is not a traditional form among others that will die and be replaced like the Roman religion 2000 years ago. Other Traditions are following the degeneration fo the Church, it merely started in the West and so the Church was corrupted first.

Guénon wrote that just a few people are necessary to preserve a Tradition, even if it's unknown to the world.

So it will be in the last days, the last keepers of all Traditions will be united when the Kali Yuga ends.

Despite the lack of "gurus" with expericence of theosis in modern christianity, its spiritual influence is not dead.

Theosis inside christianity is still virtually possible and it happen even today, even without a "guru".

Isn't Padre Pio a fully realized ascetic with extraodinary siddhi?

De Giorgio visited him and think he was, Guénon was very interested.

I also know Padre Pio visited in a dream an italian hermeticist and foresee his death saying "you are a creature of heaven and you'll return soon to heaven".

What about Mount Athos? St. Silouan certainly reached the highest form of hesychasm and he taught many young monks, and this merely 80 years ago. Some of his disciples died in the 90's and taught many other monk who are still alive today.

Not to forget the secret "legend" about the twelve invisible hermits of Mt.Athos: it's a symbol of a very powerful spiritual influence who still exist today.

Do not mistake rare for impossible.

`JB on 2016-04-29 at 23:28 said:`

Here are two quotes from Guenon's correspondence which perfectly illustrate what I am talking about:

≪ Pour ce que j'ai dit dans Orient et Occident au sujet du rôle possible de l'Eglise catholique (comme représentant une forme traditionnelle occidentale pouvant servir de base à certaines réalisations, ainsi que cela a d'ailleurs eu lieu au moyen âge), je dois dire que je ne me suis jamais fait d'illusions sur ce qu'il pouvait en résulter en fait des circonstances actuelles ; mais il ne fallait pas qu'on puisse me reprocher d'avoir pu négliger certaines possibilités, au moins théoriques, ou de ne pas en tenir compte. ≫ (Lettre à Roger Maridort, 1933).

≪ Vous devez bien penser que je ne suis pas si naïf que cela ; mais pour des raisons qu'il ne m'est malheureusement pas possible d'expliquer par lettre, il était nécessaire de dire ce que j'ai dit et d'envisager cette possibilité, ne fût-ce que pour établir une situation nette, et a eu pleinement le résultat (négatif) que j'attendais. ≫ (Lettre à Julius Evola, 1933).

You can read an article on the subject (where those quotes were found) here:

`http://www.la-question.net/archive/2009/09/04/rene-guenon-un-esoteriste-antichretien.html`

On conversion, if we are to understood you correctly, the ancient Europeans somehow suddenly all developed "bourgeois conceits" and converted to an exotic foreign religion, instead of following the faith of their fathers. How do you justify this?

Your article on the conversion of Iceland is hardly representative of Europe as a whole. Contrasted with the christianisation of Rome, followed by the massacres of Charlemagne, there is a world of difference, both in rationale and method.

To conclude, to rely exclusively on Guenon, a man who was more influenced by nineteenth century occultism than by a genuine knowledge of traditional doctrines, contrary to what he continually maintained, is not only misguided but foolish.

`Nilakantha on 2016-04-29 at 23:30 said:`

There are contingent reasons that necessitate changing one's traditional affiliation. As Guénon himself said: I t too often happens that someone is born into a milieu not in harmony with his own nature, and because not really suitable for him, does not allow his possibilities, especially of the intellectual and spiritual order, to develop in a normal manner. Certainly it

is regrettable in more than one respect that things are this way, but these are the inevitable drawbacks of the present phase of the KALI-YUGA.

Cologero on 2016-04-29 at 23:53 said:

Close, JB, so what's the point? You both consider Guenon as an authority and then not as an authority. But to comment on the content of that correspondence ... He is referring to the "Catholic Church", not to Catholicism as a Tradition. We anticipated that objection if only you could read English as well as your French. Actually, we bemoaned that fact in several texts. Specifically, we pointed out how Guenon was not able to make much headway with the Church, and was particularly opposed by Jacques Maritain, unfortunately. (You can do a search for them.) That was the basis of his complaint to Evola.

Nevertheless, Guenon honored Pope Pius XI's condemnation of Action francaise on the grounds that he was the spiritual authority.

So the conclusion is not that Guenon was anti-Christian or anti-Catholic, but rather that he did not believe that the organized Church was still capable of reviving the very Tradition of which she was the visible embodiment. That is simply a prudential judgment, applicable to a specific time and place. Guenon acted on that judgment and remained in Egypt where his adopted religion was the right fit.

On several occasions, we have offered another judgment, based on the publications of some remarkable books by Valentin Tomberg an Boris Mouravieff. They could not have appeared if the Tradition was totally lost. They reveal the Church of John is still active. Since we've dealt with that in some depth, I won't repeat it here. So we have carried on their work ... you can take it or leave it, as you see fit.

JB, you could have saved yourself the risk of carpal tunnel syndrome by stopping after the two quotes. The last 4 paragraphs are incoherent, so I can't comment on them. But if you are seeking my approval to change either your religion or your sex, my advice is only to follow your informed conscience.

clay masterson on 2016-04-30 at 11:09 said:

Nostalgia for the past is a surefire road to failure, we are evolving beings, not stagnant. New forms and new traditions are needed, not a retreat to the past.

Cologero on 2016-04-30 at 12:14 said:

Mr Masterson, you have managed to combine so many errors, misconceptions, and misreadings into two brief sentences, so I can only conclude it is not the result of chance. In my moments of weakness, however, I have to wonder what it is that you have evolved into and what new tradition you follow!

Harun on 2016-04-30 at 15:34 said:

"The spiritual destinies of such men, the paths they take, are only determined by the orientation of their own nature and the 'calls' from purely spiritual domains that are 'heard'. Their decision is rooted in such inner factors and may only be understood by insight into their inner nature and how it relates to the divine order"

I can relate to this.

I met a qualified representant of Buddhism but he's teaching sunyavada, and inside me everything told me it was not my path.

The problem is if it's wise to reject an initiatic path while we are still unable to follow an alternative path?

If we look at the life of Guénon I think it's the same decision he made when he waited many years in Europe and later became a Sufi instead of moving to India.

Marcel K. on 2016-05-01 at 12:36 said:

A. K. Coomaraswamy's son has written a detailed account of the change that took place within the curia when a dedicated group of Cardinals effected a turn towards liberal-humanist inspired ideas. He mentions that at a time a Marxist intellectual in rather well-known Italian feuilleton literally commented that "the devil had entered the Council". The conservative South Italian members of the curia were wholly unprepared for the onslaught of the new ideological current that emphasized the mundane 'human warmth of Christianity' to the detriment of the traditional teachings. The 'battle' was lost long before it began, because unlike their opponents the conservative members of the curia were at the grave disadvantages of having no particular goals other than the adherence to the traditional framework and were therefore quickly branded mere 'obstacles to progress'.

If it was so easy for the democratic-profane forces to effect a virtual revolution within the Church, the pessimism of many so called traditionalist regarding Catholicism would seem quite arrogant. Rather than abandoning it, one should attempt to change the Church from within – the Church is the domain of traditionalists after all, so with some shrewdness it should not be too difficult to expel the intrusive profane forces which quite evidently do not belong in it.

Nilakantha on 2016-05-01 at 13:37 said:

The mythic Jesus worshipped by Christians as the plenary manifestation of God is not the Jewish messiah. The Jewish messiah has a political function intimately tied up with the ancient Kingdom of Israel. Jesus, on the other hand, is the bearer of a universal revelation formed for and by the Roman civilization centred in the Mediterranean basin, which is why Jesus is God for Europe.

Krishna, along with the other avataras of Vishnu, is a bearer of God's revelation for greater India. Whether or not you can "become" a Hindu is a question that must be honestly answered

before you can authentically become a worshipper of Krishna. Regardless, we should never speak badly of any form that God has used in any orthodox religion to call men back to the truth.

Nilakantha on 2016-05-01 at 20:03 said:

We cannot judge the orthodoxy of any religion by the miracles it produces. We must, on the other hand, judge the source of miraculous phenomena by the orthodoxy of the religion that produces them. We judge a religion orthodox because of its metaphysical doctrine, ethics and spiritual practice. Within an orthodox religion, miracles provide "extrinsic and probable proofs" of the spiritual efficacy of the tradition. Within a heterodox religion, miracles are merely demonic deceptions.

Lu Dongbin on 2016-05-02 at 22:27 said:

I suppose for me the problem is that I am a bit of a pseudo-Traditionalist, insofar as I agree with most of what Guenon and Evola and company have to say, but I also can't seem to bring myself to agree that because potentially the major traditions can lead us to truth that they are therefore of equal quality or value. It seems to me that certain systems, ways of looking at the world, and forms of praxis are superior to others. In this regard I tend to see the ancient Aryan traditions, Neoplatonism, and Eastern traditions like Daoism and Chan/Zen as clearer, more potent, and overall superior in their ability to produce sages than the Abrahamic traditions. Of the latter, I respect traditional Catholicism the most, but I also believe it is due to the absorption of the European racial/pagan spirit and Neoplatonism that medieval civilization was glorious. Outside of Sufism and perhaps some of the insights of the Kabbalah, I have little interest or respect for either Islam or Judaism. This way of viewing things may reflect immaturity on my part and put me outside of some of the considerations of the Traditionalists, but that's how I see it.

I also cannot bring myself to accept exoteric dogmas that I know to be false. The prime issue barring me from Christianity is that I remain convinced there is an unborn, uncreated, timeless element at the core of man. This is heresy to Christianity and historically those who vocalized this heresy (like Eckhart) were condemned. (One of my other favorite Christians, Eriugena, was also condemned.) Of course I also cannot accept the notion of eternal damnation, divine linear time, animal souls dissolving at death, and other dogmas of Christianity. Should I ignore what I know to be false simply to practice the tradition of my ancestors, or perhaps I should say my most recent ancestors? One could retort that actually going through the transformation offered by discipline and practice is most vital, but why should deceiving oneself be required in the process? Combine this with the wretched state of modern Christianity and I see no reason to forgo the chance offered by this precious human life for transcendence in consideration of upholding my civilization's traditional religious form.

So for me, the choice has been to turn East–if this is a bourgeois conceit so be it. That said,

I am not one to dispose of my heritage and try to become an Easterner like the New Age/hippie crowd. I try to remain connected to my racial traditions and culture insofar as possible in the modern world and, despite my own inability to follow the Christian path, I continue to support traditionalism in a Catholic context and hope for a revival in the Church.

Nilakantha on 2016-05-02 at 23:22 said:

There is an absolute necessity to practice an orthodox religion, even though there's no need to take the myth of the religion literally. As Michael Griffin explains in the introduction to his Olympiodrus: Life of Plato and On Plato First Alcibiades 1-9: Olympiodorus treats the language of Christian doctrine, when it is mentioned, as if it belongs to the exegetical 'level' of myth or phantasia. Like any myth, however, it is not simply false: it refers to real facts within the human soul or psyche. We may speak of Hera, or a certain 'power' of the Christian God, but in either case the philosopher will recognise that what is meant is a certain capacity of the soul. We may speak of daimons or angels, but in both cases we are genuinely referring to human conscience. The overt language used, whether pagan or Christian, lies at the level of phainomena or appearances. Thus Olympiodorus is able to represent 'philosophy' as a more fundamental framework that can accommodate various mythological systems and worldviews and facilitate their agreement.

Nilakantha on 2016-05-03 at 00:51 said:

Bryan,

Your inability to find an authentic spiritual director is a problem all serious practitioners experience at this time. The best advice to give is also the most basic: be patient. God is the ultimate guru, and, like it or not, you have to learn to be patient and wait on His will to make itself known. Pray, fast, go to confession and attend Mass as often as possible and have faith that God has not left us orphaned.

The worst thing to do would be to immerse yourself in some kind of spiritual Esperanto of your own divising. Trying to cobble together your own unique spiritual path by picking and choosing bits and pieces from various traditional doctrines will just end up proving the old Muslim adage: He who uses himself as his own spiritual director has Satan for his guide.

And lastly, read *On Gurus and Spiritual Direction* by Rama Coomaraswamy, a Traditionalist Catholic:

http://www.worldwisdom.com/public/viewpdf/default.aspx?article-title=On_Gurus_and_Spiritual_Direction_by_Rama_Coomaraswamy.pdf

/me/ on 2016-05-03 at 01:04 said:

"There is an absolute necessity to practice an orthodox religion"

I understand that this is Tradition 101. However, if there probably is no such thing as a stupid question in mundane matters, certainly here with such a vital and essential matter I feel

justified in asking, "why"?

Johannes on 2016-05-03 at 02:42 said:

Cologero, I personally considered joining the Catholic church at the suggestion of this blog. I talked to several different priests,went to traditional mass a few times a week, read the mystics, medieval theology and prayed 5-15 decades of the rosary daily. However in the end I just couldn't do it; my heart said "no, this isn't true". I wasn't raised in that tradition and just didn't believe in it . To me, its obvious that Catholicism is a false religion, and I was just forcing myself into it, hoping to find some 'tradition' for myself. Look at the silly ramblings of those female mystics, or how far Catholic theology has diverged since the schism between east and west, let alone since VC2. There too many absurd dogmas to believe in, like the co-redemptrix and papal infallibility, which were clearly just made up by the priests to suit their needs as they went along, not 'revealed' by some transcendent 'Tradition'. What thinking person would willingly submit to believe in all that? Just because some old priest said so? Believing in things because some authority said so isn't possible anymore. That's a premodern mindset and its impossible to just 'go back there', no matter how many books we read.

It seems to me that your kind of reasoning towards being a Catholic is only possible for someone who was born into that tradition, and then left it later on, only to realise it was due to youthful mistakes/arrogance/pride or whatever. But for some one who has no experience of Catholicism, it is too exotic, with its hundreds of Saint days and strange rituals that don't have much explanation other than 'tradition'. The Catholic church has clearly been subverted in some capacity since Vatican 2. Catholicism is whatever the priests say it is; if they want to protestantise it and embrace modernity, well that's just Catholicism now. It doesn't make sense to be a traditional catholic believing all that nonsense, let alone now in 2016 where the priests have jettisoned most of that stuff. Your 'hidden esoteric dimension' of Catholicism only exists in your mind and books, Cologero.

Having experienced it, Catholicism has no resonance with me, just like with most people of my age group. The imagined glorious medieval Catholicism doesn't exist, probably it never did, just in your minds, you just don't see this because you have fond memories from your childhood about it. But now it's just some musty old mumbling and mummery that the average westerner has no connection to. I understand that you are at least 70 years old Cologero, so perhaps that is a factor in your case. You are old and were raised in a time when perhaps that religion had some cultural impact, at least on your life. But for young people today, it cannot be that way.

No doubt you will accuse me of 'raging', but rage against what? I was never a Christian, I have nothing to rage against, no issue with Christians. If they want to believe in that well good for them. However I am annoyed at you personally for giving me stupid advice and wasting my time.

Matt on 2016-05-03 at 12:12 said:

Johannes,

Co-redemptrix is not a dogma. It's a theological concept that some within the church accept and others do not. Maybe if more attention was paid to studying that religious tradition you had considered joining, you wouldn't have been left with such dissapointment.

Cassiodorus on 2016-05-03 at 16:18 said:

Lu Dongbin,

I'm curious- what are the exoteric beliefs of Christianity that you cannot believe?

Cassiodorus on 2016-05-03 at 16:32 said:

Lu Dongbin, in some sense, I agree with you. To my lights, Christianity and unqualified nondualism are not compatible. But, why should we be so quick to reject panentheism in either a weak or strong form?

Cologero on 2016-05-03 at 22:27 said:

I have disappointed many people in my life, Johannes, mostly women however. Perhaps you all should create a facebook group where your juvenile whining will find a sympathetic ear.

I have striven to outline a jnana path that certainly has existed in the Tradition. That includes, at a minimum, a correct metaphysical worldview, a method of self-knowledge, and a path to self-mastery over one's thoughts. Have you done any of that? Have you looked into the many texts and practices that have been mentioned in these pages? There are three mailing lists in which such issues could be discussed. In addition, we have weekly training in self-knowledge exercises ... these are real, not texts in a book. You've never participated. And not just you, but all the others who are whining about not finding a teacher. A man takes responsibility for his own education, not to mention the consequences of the choices he has made.

I don't recall recommending all those things to you. For example, what women mystics are you referring to and where did I suggest them to you. I fully understand that a sentimental bhakti path if not very suitable to young men today. You make the mistake I warned you about: viz., confusing structures with the Tradition itself. So which metaphysical teachings do you reject? The unity of being? The cosmic order? The hierarchical organization of the universe?

Faith is a matter of Will. Had you actually paid attention to my advice, you would have learned inner silence, you would have gained authentic gnosis, you would have become a man of daring. Perhaps you are simply not up to the task.

Nilakantha on 2016-05-03 at 23:21 said:

/me/,

The path from our everyday existence to the unconditioned requires three elements. First, we need a metaphysical doctrine to act as a map. But, since map is not territory, we also need concrete practices with which to make the journey. Our second element is an ethics to pry us away from our fascination with the multiplicity of daily life. As Porphyry says:"If we are to speak frankly, concealing nothing, there is no other way to achieve our end than by being riveted (so to speak) to the god, and unfastening the rivet of the body and the pleasurable emotions of the soul which come from the body; security comes to us by actions, not just by listening to lectures.It is not possible to be familiar with a god – not even with one of the particular gods, let alone the god who singly is above all and higher than incorporeal nature – by following just any lifestyle, especially flesh-eating; one can hardly, even with all kinds of purifications of soul and body, become worthy of awareness of the god, that is if one has a fine nature and lives a pure and holy life" — On Abstinence from Killing Animals. And he says in another place: "It is impossible for a man who loves God also to love pleasure and the body, for he who loves these must needs be a lover of riches. And he who loves riches must be unrighteous. And the unrighteous man is impious towards God and his fathers, and transgresses against all men" — Porphyry's Letter to His Wife Marcella. The third element is a spiritual method by which the mind, having been freed to some degree from concern with the body concentrates itself on a symbol of the Absolute. This often involves the recitation of a divine name or mantra with the aid of a ma?la? or rosary. If they are to be effective, the three elements of orthodox religion must have been revealed by God, since He knows the path and the way to traverse it — thus our need for an orthodox religion.

To sum up, I'll just give two quotes; the first on the extreme difficulty of following the way to God, and the second on the different paths that lead to the same end:

Enter ye in at the strait gate: for wide is the gate, and broad is the way, that leadeth to destruction, and many there be which go in thereat: Because strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it. – Matthew 17:13-14

With regard to the highest human goal, there is no contradiction among scriptures, since all teach the very same reward: deliverance. Nevertheless, differing salvific paths are taught, according to the intellect of the beings to be favored. This omniscient Lord taught various kinds of approaches when he saw that "these people can be helped to reach beatitude in the way they prefer on this path." Just as people from a crowd that wants to enter a single fort or a big house also enter through different doors, liberation-seekers too enter the highest abode in the same way. The following wise saying of Jayanta, the prodigy, who has mastered the essence of all sciences, who knows reality, and who has shaken off error, refers to the same thing:

"The many means taught by various scriptural approaches converge in the single summum bonum, as the currents of the Ganges meet in the ocean." – A?gamad?ambara 4110-4115

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me on 2016-05-05 at 14:24 said:
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Thank you very much for your comprehensive reply. I will be mulling it over.

12.31 Institutions, Intellectuals, Mystics

> If we put the subjective interest of the Indian mind along with its tendency to arrive at a synthetic vision, we shall see how **monistic idealism** becomes the truth of things. To it the whole growth of Vedic thought points; on it are based the Buddhistic and the Brahmanical religions; it is the highest truth revealed to India.
>
> Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol 1

> Catholicism is truly the most perfect religion, just as modern European philosophy [i.e., absolute idealism] is the most perfect philosophy: together they are the highest creations of the Aryan spirit.
>
> Giovanni Gentile, *On Religion*

> The prerogative of the human state is objectivity; the essential content of which is the **Absolute**. There is no knowledge without objectivity of the intelligence; there is no freedom without objectivity of the will; and there is no nobility without objectivity of the soul … Esoterism seeks to realize pure and direct objectvity; this is its raison d'être.
>
> Frithjof Schuon, *Esoterism As Principle and As Way*

Friedrich von Hügel, Baron of the Holy Roman Empire, identified in his book *The Mystical Element of Religion* three elements of religion: **the institutional, the intellectual, and the mystical**. Although his intent should be clear from the names, I prefer to use more neutral names that

can be defined with a specificity unencumbered by expectations, viz., the exoteric, mesoteric, and esoteric.

Historically, the three elements have been at odds with each other.

The doctrine of the three souls is clearly taught, even in exoteric theology. What is not so clearly taught is that each person has by birth his center of gravity in one of those souls. Thus a man, by nature, is centered on sensations, emotions or thoughts. No one of them is "better" or "higher" than the others, since each is the result of an interior imbalance.

Hence, the spiritual paths preferred by each type of person will differ. We can presume that a person centered on this-worldly sensations will be unlikely to be attracted to spirituality. In the cases where they do, the spiritual path is often of a low-grade, focusing on paranormal phenomena, séances, talismans, divination, or techniques promising to deliver money, sex, or power.

The emotion-centered type will gravitate to the exoteric element, and the thinking person to the mesoteric. The esoteric, on the other hand, is open only to those who manage to harmonize the three centers into a greater whole.

Exoteric Obviously the institutional church attracts adherents from all three types, but we will focus on the emotional types since they are least likely to move beyond it. For them, the emotional impact is the main focus. The mass and sacraments will make them feel good. They are attracted to devotional practices of a sentimental nature.

In extreme cases, as is not uncommon today, converts and reverts become emotionally involved in "saving" the church, creating an Internet presence. These are the super-correct, even to the point of criticizing popes and bishops. At its highest, the emotional center evokes feelings of loyalty, solidarity, and fidelity. At its worse, these feelings combine with the incensive power to lash out everywhere. They are always hunting for heretics even if their own understanding is itself heretical and untradi-

tional.

Unable to fully grasp the intellectual level, they regard theological ideas as dogmas. Hence, they interpret philosophical ideas in emotional terms, rather than as reasoned-out ideas. This leads to suspicion of those who restate metaphysical ideas in unaccustomed terms.

Similarly, mystics are viewed as just more intense versions of themselves. They develop emotional attachments to devotions of their favorite saints. Ultimately, the value of the saints and mystics lies in their own adherence to the exoteric, institutional church.

Scriptures are understood as naturalistic, historical, and scientific texts. That is a dangerous position to hold, because it justifiably permits historians and scientists to apply their own methods to those texts. In that atmosphere, the commitment to the moral, allegorical, and mystical interpretation of the texts is quite weak.

This is clearly a one-sided representation, but the purpose is only to point out those misconceptions that tend to create frictions and misunderstandings between the institutional and other perspectives. Although there is the danger of being cast out as heretical, esoterists need to respect exoteric practices. This is the teaching both of a **Rene Guenon** and a **Valentin Tomberg**, who insist on an accommodation between the exoteric and the esoteric.

Mesoteric The ancients certainly recognized that **Plato**, **Hermes Trismegistus**, and others held a true conception of God. It is a dogma of the Catholic Church that the God known to philosophy is the same God as that of revelation. There are several ways to approach this. Most often, theologians and philosophers arise from the exoteric church, and reconsider its teachings and dogmas in rational and intellectual terms.

In other cases, philosophers have developed conceptions of God apart from the exoteric church. As the epigraph from Radhakrishnan shows, these take the form of some sort of monist or absolute idealism at their

best. At their worst, they promote a form of theistic personalism[42], i.e., the conception that God is one being among others, albeit of a very special kind.

Now it is dogmatic that God is both Absolute and Infinite. These concepts are certainly comprehensible to the rational mind. It is well worth the effort to work through the demonstrations in such works as *Multiple States of Being* by **Rene Guenon** or *Survey of Metaphysics and Esoterism* by **Frithjof Schuon**. Theistic personalism denies both those attributes.

Radhakrishnan, in his massive study of Indian philosophy, gives many examples of Western philosophers whose thinking aligns with the Vedanta. Inter alios, he writes about **Francis Bradley**, who represents the peak of British idealism, **Giovanni Gentile**, who does the same for Italian idealism, and by extension, for continental European idealism, and even Baron von Huegel.

Since thought is not self-sufficient, i.e., it first needs something to think about, when the intellectual types divorce themselves from the exoteric element, it becomes free-floating. The tendency is to make rather simple things more complex than they are. Hence, they falsely regard their philosophy as superior to the exoteric. The result, all too often, is that they align themselves with the consensus worldview of conventionally educated people. Hence, their erudition and skills in logic and argument produce no more than what the average person can come up with.

At its worse, the intellectual takes uncertainty and doubt as a "badge of honor", a mark of superior intelligence. He will glibly talk about "shades of grey", a fitting phrase for intellectual bondage, "seeing both sides" of an issue, and so on. On the contrary, and this should be obvious to everyone, it is an admission that his intellectual reasoning cannot come to any sort of certainty.

[42] https://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2013/04/craig-on-theistic-personalism.html

The man who comes to know himself sees that it is in the nature of the intellect to have doubt, the "yes" turns into a "no". Someone undeveloped will stay in this step. On the other hand, those who seek to become balanced will search for a higher path, one that transcends the intellect.

Esoteric Of course, we don't want to completely conflate the truly esoteric with the mystical as used by the Baron. The mystical encompasses many things and is not identical to the esoteric. The primary difference is that the mystic follows a passive path whereas the esoterist follows an active path. The esoterist notices the shortcomings in the institutional and intellectual approaches. However, rather than abandoning them entirely, he seeks to balance them and integrate them into a larger whole.

The certainty of faith of the exoterists becomes the certainty of gnosis. While not rejecting the rationality of the intellectuals, historians, and scientists, he becomes aware of a higher mind that is trans-rational, not irrational. This higher mind, the end point of theosis, transcends the duality of the discursive, thinking mind.

Posted on 2014-11-23 by Cologero

* * *

David on 2014-11-24 at 13:05 said:

Very good text, I will have to look at the von Huegel.

That being said, what about non-dualism within this scheme, be it Christian or non-Christian (Advaita-Vâda)?

Boreas on 2014-11-24 at 14:56 said:

There is a book that deals with the doctrine of non-dualism within Christian and perennialist context. Here's the link for the book:

http://www.sophiaperennis.com/books/christianity/christianity-and-the-doctrine-of-non-dualism/

Just for the record, I haven't read the book myself, but it came to my mind when you questioned the existence of a non-dualist position within Christianity.

David on 2014-11-24 at 16:57 said:

@Boreas : This is indeed a book I was referencing. Might I add that Vladimir Lossky is the one that adapted the term for Christian use since the "Monk" that wrote the other book hinted that he took it from him.

@Fractal: I think it might exist. I am neither a saint nor a genius, so instead of explaining it myself, I will direct you to the book that Boreas linked. I would suggest in french since it is the original language and it have a preface by Jean Tourniac, an esoterist who worked on René Guénon. The book from the Monk is both linked with Tradition (use of Guénon most notably), and very orthodox (St Bernard, Nicholas de Cuze, St Thomas Aquinas, etc.). It received the autorization from its superior in his order (Cirstercian).

Wayne Ferguson on 2014-11-25 at 10:34 said:

Trinitarian panentheism ? Christian Nonduality

Apropos of Christianity and Vedanta, I am interested to learn more about Paul Deussen. Quoting Letter 19 of "Meditations on the Tarot":

> In relation to the theme of the mission of intelligence being the way to intuition, it is relevant to indicate the fact that the philosophical work of Immanuel Kant —which scorched the pretensions to certainty of autonomous intelligence with respect to metaphysical things by demonstrating the set limits of knowledge possible to autonomous intelligence —has had an effect comparable to that of wind, which extinguishes the weak fire and which revives the strong fire: the one becoming sceptics and the others becoming mystics. Kant put an end to the speculative metaphysics of autonomous intelligence and opened up the way to a mysticism which non-autonomous intelligence or "practical reason" (praktische Vernunft) is capable of—Kant's "practical reason" being intelligence united to the wisdom of moral nature, i.e. intuition. Indeed, several times I have had occasion to observe the fact that with time Kantians become mystics —to name, for example, the German philosopher Paul Deussen, the author of a synthesis of Kantianism, Platonism and the Vedanta (cf. Paul Deussen, The Elements of Metaphysics; trsl. C. M. Duff, London-New York, 1894).

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Paul_Deussen

Wayne Ferguson on 2014-11-25 at 10:46 said:

p.s. sorry for the poorly formatted quote in the comment above. Also, the "?" is what appeared in place of the "approximately equal" sign that I tried to post.

Here is a link to an online copy of the Deussen book that Tomberg mentions:
https://archive.org/details/outlineofvedanta00deus

12.32 Esoterism and Exoteric Religion

In *Man and his Becoming*, **Rene Guenon** claims that

> Among those who receive the same teaching, each one understands and assimilates it more or less completely and profoundly according to the extent of his own intellectual possibilities; and that is why selection comes about quite naturally, without which there could be no genuine hierarchy.

Although very few take that quote seriously, it is certainly empirically verifiable. Recently, someone brought to my attention an article by an academic who tried to show that Guenon's "explanation for the origin of religions" does not survive historical scrutiny. Hence, his explanation is no better than those of Marx or Freud. Unfortunately for that hapless academic, Guenon was doing no such thing. Quite the contrary in fact. In *The Esoterism of Dante*, Guenon responds to the question of whether Dante was Christian or pagan. He explains:

> we do not think that such a point of view is necessary, for true esoterism is something completely different from outward religions, and if it has some relationship with it, this can only be insofar as it finds a symbolic mode of expression in religious forms. Moreover, it matters little whether these forms be of this or that religion, since what is involved is the essential doctrinal unity concealed beneath their apparent diversity.

If esoterism is "completely different" from outward religions, how could anyone knowledgeable possibly conclude that Guenon is trying to explain the origin of outward religions? Nevertheless, he does provide an example of a "symbolic mode of expression" in *The Symbolism of the Cross*:

> This symbolical character, while common to all historical events, is bound to be particularly clear-cut in the case of events connected with what may be called "sacred history"; thus it is recognizable in a most striking way, in all the circumstances of the life of Christ.

The great Russian philosopher, **Vladimir Solovyov**, understood this independently. He noted, in *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, that Christianity did not create a new metaphysical system; instead it relied on Neoplatonism and the Hermetic philosophy of Egypt to fill that role. What made it distinctive, in his view, is the historical events of the life of Jesus.

Guenon ends with a more controversial conclusion.

> it matters little whether these forms be of this or that religion, since what is involved is the essential doctrinal unity concealed beneath their apparent diversity. This is why in the past, initiates participated in all forms of worship, following the customs established in whatever country they happened to be.

In that regard, Guenon followed his own teaching, unlike his many epigones.

Posted on 2022-02-24 by Cologero

12.33 Defending the Defensible

We have often made the point that the analog of Spiritual Unity in the world is Harmony, not identity of opinion. Just as there are six different

Orthodox schools in Hinduism, seemingly at odds with each other, there are, and should be, different schools of thought in the West, which, despite that, are all reflective of Tradition, but from different perspectives. To expect Guenon and Evola to be the same is akin to trying to describe the motion of cars on the highway according to the laws of gravity. Their apparent differences result from thier different perspectives and differing specific interests.

In our time, we often see a split between self-described followers of the one or the other, a split that would have astonished both of them. As we can see from the correspondence between Guenon and Evola[43], there was not enmity between them, but rather a sense of a common mission. Guenon reviewed several of Evola's books, Evola had several of Guenon's books published in Italy. Guenon even published articles in a Fascist newspaper (*Regime Fascista*). Rather than take sides, we feel it is better to bring out exactly what their views were. A balanced discussion is helpful to that end. However, the goal must be kept in view: to clarify the ideas, not to win an argument. Gornahoor's position is simple: *Those ignorant of Guenon will never understand Evola; those who do not recognize Tradition in Evola, demonstrate their ignorance of Guenon*.

There is much ado about the minor differences between the two writers. For example, in his review of *Revolt against the Modern World*, Guenon opposed Evola's view of Buddhism, and also the notion of a regal initiation. (Keep in mind that it was Guenon who eventually altered his opinion of Buddhism. And he also conceded the existence of a regal initiation in earlier ages. In Christianity the idea of Christ as both Priest and King reflects that ancient tradition, not that Evola would want support coming from that angle!) But in a 400 page book, should we not expect some errors, misjudgments, disagreements, differences of opinion? That does not alter the fundamental value, but gives us latecomers some work to do.

[43] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4489`

Guenon's overall judgment of Evola' book is this:

> These disagreements should not prevent us from recognizing, as is right, the merit and interest of the work as a whole, and to bring it in a particular way to the attention of all those who are concerned with the "crisis of the modern world", and *who think like us* my emphasis that the only efficacious means of rectifying it would consist in a return to the traditional spirit outside of which nothing truly constructive could be validly undertaken.

Similarly, Ananda Coomaraswamy had many specific reservations about "Revolt", although he published an excerpt and a review in an Indian publication (*The Visva-Bharati Quarterly*, Feb-Apr 1940). Having made his objections, this is his overall judgment:

> Nonetheless, this book constitutes a remarkable presentation and exposition of *traditional doctrine* my emphasis and could well serve as an introductory text for the student of anthropology and as a *guide for the Indologist* my emphasis , especially for anyone interested in Hindu mythology and has not understood that, in the words of Evola, "the passage from mythology to religion constitutes a humanistic decadence." The chapter, "man and woman" was chosen for the translation because of its clear, intransigent, and — we can add — tight peroration of the principles, that are reflected in the institutions and the ideals, such as that of *sati*, that is often no more comprehensible and that certainly are no longer held dear, even as memories by our politicians and reformers who, "whether by force or consensus, were induced to accept Western models."

There is a lesson here to those who want to excommunicate Evola in the names of Guenon and Coomaraswamy.

Posted on 2011-03-10 by Cologero

* * *

Will on 2011-03-10 at 11:12 said:

Well said.

Another way of understanding the difference between Guenon and Evola is by means of the Buddhist distinction between Sutra and Tantra. The Sutric approach is characterized by the principle of renunciation. One renounces samsara / becoming / action because it is tinged with suffering, and one seeks nirvana / being / contemplation through a kind of process of elimination. The Tantric approach is based on the principle of transformation. One does not renounce the world, but rather works to transform one's view and one's experience of it. Since, as the Heart Sutra says, nirvana and samsara, emptiness and form, are non-dual, both approaches are valid.

As can be seen from his writings, Evola favored a Tantric approach, both explicitly and implicitly. He wrote about Indian Tantra on numerous occasions, but more importantly, advocated a uniquely Western approach which is arguably true to the principles of Tantra, but which is not a mere western aping of that tradition.

Guenon, on the other hand, was more predisposed to a Sutric approach, as evidenced by his living out his remaining years as a Muslim under Shariah law.

Aidan, in a previous comment, wrote that heroism and individualism are mutually exclusive because the former deals with individuality and the latter transcends it. That is a Sutric perspective, and is valid. But it seems to me that the question for Evola and for those who would adopt his view is, Can one transcend individuality towards divinity through something like a TOTAL FULFILLMENT of individuality?

The Sutric approach seeks to transcend individuality by negating it, thus the practice of humility, turning the other cheek, or 'driving all blame into oneself' as in Mahayana Buddhism. The ideal setting for this approach is a monastery.

The Tantric approach – which in Buddhism is considered more advanced and elitist because it presupposes an experience of emptiness – does not necessarily follow the same rules. It is a total involvement with the world and a working with all of the energies of life. Evola elaborated his uniquely Western vision of this path in Ride the Tiger, noting that he was writing for the man who is involved in the modern world, but does not belong to it.

It's easy to spot a 'heretic' in Sutra because the rules are laid out and produce a great uniformity – if one isn't a smiling monk, one must be a heretic. However, Tantric practice produces a far more diverse display of characteristics, including what the Tibetans call the 'crazy wisdom' tradition of eccentric yogis, and it's much harder to tell who does or doesn't have the goods (or rather, the Platonic Good.)

Heroism is Tantric provided that it is not simply rooted in ego, which is a very real danger, hence the elitist restrictions. While one could argue that perhaps Evola is not quite loud enough in issuing this warning, I think he does demonstrate this understanding.

Guenon called Evola "the demon of action," which I take as a recognition of this complementary position that he held.

Will on 2011-03-10 at 15:20 said:

Correction: the above 5th paragraph should read "heroism and divinity."

Sati Shankar on 2011-10-03 at 19:38 said:

To prevent creeping of any confusion, it becomes necessary here to point out on,

"... Just as there are six different Orthodox schools in Hinduism, seemingly at odds with each other, there are, and should be, different schools of thought in the West, which, despite that, are all reflective of Tradition, but from different perspectives."

In fact in the name of tradition and for the sake of it... we some times overlook the very core of the subject matter. Difference between the six systems appear only when we approach superficially... when approached at deeper level, the underlying "goal" however is the same.For example,the final goal of life in Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism is the same... Release from the repeated cycles of rebirth and liberation of the turmoil and suffering.

The spirituality, introspection, monistic idealism, intuition, respect for authority and the strong belief that the truth is to be lived, not merely known, propel a Hindu and Jain towards the goal of attaining Moksha or Mukti and a Buddhist to attain Nirvana.

Mihai on 2012-05-27 at 16:56 said:

I am curious : where can I find and read the above mentioned reviews (by Guenon and Coomaraswamy). I cannot seem to locate them anywhere on the internet.

Cologero on 2012-05-27 at 18:18 said:

The review by Coomaraswamy was translated and published in the Italian edition of Revolt of the Modern World. I have been unable to locate the journal through my Indian contacts. As much as I dislike doing so (due to the possibility of introducing errors), I may have to translated the review back into English. It is important because it corrects a fundamental error made by Evola on the relationship between the King and the Brahman caste, based on a misreading of a Vedic text.

The review was in The Visva-Bharati Quarterly, vol V, part IV, Feb-Apr, 1940. If you can locate the original, please provide us with a copy.

Guenon published a brief review in Le Voile d'Isis, May, 1934. I don't know if it has been included in any of the English translations of his works.

Sati Shankar on 2012-05-28 at 00:14 said:

Dear Mr. Mihai,

You may find brief version of what Coomaraswamy says in his article, in first few pages(and its foundation in his whole essay) of his "Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power of the Indian Theories of Government".

Mihai on 2012-05-28 at 05:26 said:

I thank you for your replies.

Mr Cologero: I have been unable to locate any of the above mentioned articles. Unfortunetly, Guenon's contributions are hard to come by if they haven't been published in one of the posthumous volumes.

Mr Sati Shankar: I thank you for the recommendation, I'll try to look it up.

Cologero on 2012-05-28 at 07:37 said:

Guenon's excellent review of "Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power of the Indian Theories of Government" is included in the collection "Studies in Hinduism". It clears up any mischief caused by Evola's equivocation on the relationship between the King and priesthood, which has consequences far beyond the merely outward social aspect.

I'll translate the two reviews into English despite the possible errors of a double translation.

Mihai on 2012-05-28 at 15:59 said:

The social aspect is quite irrelevant in our state of affairs.

All in all, Evola is a good exponent of Tradition, though he has some flaws which stem from an attachement to his particular view point and inclination.

However, I do believe he has a point regarding the king as "Pontifex" being beyond both sacerdotal and warrior, if he unites both of these aspects in himself and is not just the head of the temporal power.

I have yet to clarify these aspects in my mind as well.

Charlotte on 2012-05-28 at 16:14 said:

Logres no comments are possible on the other thread, but I did want to say that I don't support the French Revolution and never have, it is a mechanism of the illuminati, it wasn't just a case of the peasants revolting. I also thought it relevant to point out that the Merovingian monarchy of France had already been usurped centuries before by the Franks... .factions in high places lead to unrest lower down the pyramid.

logres on 2012-05-28 at 17:19 said:

Yes, the peasants supported the throne, but the "masses" very swiftly and joyfully succumbed to the lie that "all are equal". Lead by their lusts, they doomed the very France they loved, and themselves. This is what Gornahoor is saying.

logres on 2012-05-28 at 17:21 said:
C, if discuss further, let's do it at MoTT. Or the Forum.

Sati Shankar on 2012-05-28 at 21:03 said:
Here again a point of emphasis emerges,Who are the "Ruler" and the "Priest", the "whole within", the two are Not two persons, when viewed from within, the two are the same, one decides other implements, we have to look within.One comes out from the other, not the former from the later nor vice-versa,and each on covers the whole. Problem begins when two are considered to be two independents...

Sati Shankar on 2012-05-28 at 21:21 said:
... When viewed as independents, the risk runs in the name of
nationalism or as Tolstoy puts,"Patriotism in its simplest, clearest, and most undoubted meaning is for rulers nothing else but a means of realizing their ambitions and venal ends; for the governed it is a renouncing of human dignity, intelligence, and conscience, and a slavish submission to the rulers. Wherever patriotism is championed, it is preached invariably in that shape. Patriotism is slavery. LEO TOLSTOY, The Open Court, Jul. 16, 1896

12.34 The Crown of Creation

> [This] allows us to see the mysterious relationship that exists between Creation and the Incarnation which is its crowning.
>
> Rene Guenon

Among all of Rene Guenon's writings, it is common to overlook the many texts dealing with the recovery of tradition in the West. For a time, that was his primary focus. Guenon taught the Incarnation, the devotion of the Sacred Heart, and the social reign of Christ the King.

I have in mind the first two essays, "Word and Symbol" and "The Reform of the Modern Mentality", included in *Symbols of Sacred Science*. These were written in 1926 and published in *Regnabit*, a Catholic journal. At that time, he was still interested in recovering the intellectual resources

of the Western Tradition. Guenon makes it perfectly clear that this is not a wasted effort when he writes:

> It is certainly wrong to claim that nobody could understand an exposition of pure doctrine. First of all, why wish to restrict oneself to the lowest level on the pretext that this is the level of the greatest number, as if it were always necessary to consider quantity rather than quality? Is this not one consequence of the democratic spirit which is one of the characteristic aspects of the modern mentality? And besides, can they be so sure that so many people would be incapable of understanding? Should we not think that even those who would not understand everything would nevertheless derive some benefit from it, and even more than might be supposed?

Word and Symbol The first essay is "Word and Symbol". Guenon explains why the symbolic form is so important in the transmission of traditional doctrinal teachings:

> Symbolism seems to be particularly well adapted to the exigencies of human nature, which is not a purely intellectual nature but requires a sensory basis from which to raise itself to higher spheres. We must take the human make-up as it is.

This makes sense, given the Thomist maxim that all knowledge first begins with the senses. So it would follow that knowledge of spiritual things would use sensual imagery. Obviously, there is the possibility that the symbol replaces actual knowledge of higher spheres. This leads many astray, as they envision spiritual things as the continuation of the physical world. Boris Mouravieff writes this about symbolism:

> The understanding of esoteric symbols is the result of revelations given by divine grace, and this demands a progressive opening

> out, in quality and in strength, of adequate faculties latent in the student. One arrives at this through a tension of the will toward the goal of the search. When it is strong enough and properly oriented, this tension resolves itself in a series of partial revelations that are acquired, and which lead by stages toward those that are given.
>
> The symbolic form is equally good for all, because it helps everyone to understand the truth it represents more or less completely and more or less profoundly, each according to the measure of his own intellectual possibilities.

The Logos and Creation Guenon writes that

> symbolism has its basis in the very nature of beings and of things, it is in perfect conformity with the laws of that nature, and since natural laws are only an expression and an exteriorization of the divine Will.

Thus, the symbol's origin is higher than the human state. John's Gospel starts: "In the beginning was the Word." The Logos is both Thought and Word.

- In itself, it is the Divine Intellect, the dwelling place of "possibilities", ideas or essences.
- In relation to us, the Logos manifests and expresses itself by Creation, in which the possibilities of manifestation are realized in actual existence. Hence*, the world is like a divine language to those how know how to understand it.*

Here Guenon makes clear that the "possibilities" he described in *The Multiple States of Being*, reside in the Divine Intellect, or Logos. This puts him in the mainstream of the Western Tradition, from Augustine to Thomas Aquinas.

Incarnation and the Sacred Heart The Logos is expressed not only in Creation, but also in revelation. Guenon writes:

> The primordial Revelation, which, like Creation, is the work of the Logos, is also incorporated in the symbols which have been transmitted from age to age ever since the origins of humanity. … Moreover, we see in this incorporation into symbols of the non-human tradition a kind of anticipated image, a prefiguration of the incarnation of the Word. *And to a certain extent does this not also allow us to see the mysterious relationship that exists between Creation and the Incarnation which is its crowning*?

The Heart is a universal symbol which takes the specific form of the Sacred Heart in Christianity. The Sacred Heart is the center of the being, not just symbolically, but really. As such, it must occupy a central place in all doctrines issuing from the primordial tradition.

The Social Reign of Christ In traditional societies, all social organization must be based on traditional principles. This is true not only in the Eastern traditions, but in the West. In recent posts, we saw that Ancient Rome was based on spiritual principles that regulated daily life. For them, piety was the greatest virtue. Similarly, Guenon points to the Middle Ages as Tradition in the West. Positive law was based on traditional principles of the natural law. In a rare outburst of passion, Guenon announces his political program for the West:

> It is high time we reacted against this tendency [i.e., the reversal of the relationship between religion and politics], and in this connection the affirmation of the social Reign of Christ is a particularly opportune manifestation; but to make this a reality, the present-day mentality must be reformed.

The "opportunity" Guenon mentions is the encyclical *Quas Primas*[44] by Pope Pius XI, announcing the Reign of Christ the King, which was promulgated just prior to the publication of Guenon's essay. At that time, Guenon was affiliated with "The Society for the Intellectual Propagation of the Sacred Heart." He described its task this way:

> The reform of the modern mentality, namely the restoration of true intellectuality and of traditional doctrine, is certainly a considerable task; but is that a reason for not undertaking it? It seems to us that such a task constitutes one of the loftiest and most important goals that can be proposed for the activity of a society …
>
> All efforts in this direction will necessarily be oriented toward the Heart of the Incarnate Word, the spiritual Sun and Center of the World, in which are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and science; not of that vain, profane science, but *the true sacred science which, for those who study it in the proper way, opens unsuspected horizons that are truly unlimited*.

Epilogue In the intervening years, we see that the ideal of the Reign of Christ the King[45] has come to naught. Even in the Vatican, the idea died of neglect among the documents of Vatican II. The modern mentality, founded on an incoherent mixture of rationalism, sentimentalism, and humanitarianism, is more entrenched than ever.

Guenon himself moved on, and lived as a Muslim in Egypt. Nevertheless, it is necessary to keep in mind what he wrote about his "conversion". It was not a horizontal conversion, i.e., the rejection of one exoteric form and the adoption of a new one. Rather, for him the move was a matter

[44] http://w2.vatican.va/content/pius-xi/en/encyclicals/documents/hf_p-xi_enc_11121925_quas-primas.html

[45] http://www.remnantnewspaper.com/Archives/archive-christ_the_king.htm

of convenience. The key to understanding this is found in Boccaccio's *Decameron*, which Guenon considered to be an esoteric text.

So it changes nothing essential. What he wrote about the Logos, the Incarnation, the Sacred Heart, and so on, still stands as metaphysically sound. The reform of the modern mentality, which is the Western mentality, is still a noble task. Guenon decided to do that from the outside, as it were. Others will persist in reforming it from the inside.

Posted on 2014-12-31 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2014-12-31 at 14:44 said:

I saw an article yesterday regarding insurance in which someone said "Society has to be forced to make Society help Society". Isn't this the kind of double-speak that you have to ultimately engage in when you shy away from a traditional Order? You don't want to say "people have to be made to be good" so you drape it with "Society". When you deny the One, the Two becomes an endless war of dichotomies and buffering lies. Eventually, "society" will lose the Two as well, and just go to compost. I need to read more Guenon.

Matthew Livermore on 2015-01-01 at 10:41 said:

Can you say any more about how the Decameron is the key to understanding Guenon's conversion?

Cologero on 2015-01-04 at 10:45 said:

Re Boccaccio: First day, third story.

Guenon alludes to this story in the essay, "The Secret Language of Dante."

August on 2015-01-09 at 15:13 said:

The modern mentality can only view all reformation in this direction as an oppressive attack. Proper reformation of this mentality is nothing less than its destruction.

The modern mentality knows this too, that is the reason for its instinctive hatred of tradition. It only pretends to endorse freedom of expression as principle, otherwise it would be able to appreciate, for instance, both blasphemous doodles and the angry acts they inspire, each of which can be morbidly entertaining to the neutral observer. But this mentality knows its limits – death presents it with nothing but the prospect of chastisement, so death alone rocks its foundations and makes it cry foul. The modern world lives for death.

12.35 Everyone Else Knows Better

Deriving some insights from *The Crisis of the Modern World*, by **Rene Guenon**.

Rationalism Rationalism is the notion that human reason alone — by its ability to categorize, analyze, discuss, compare, contrast, interpret, etc. — is an adequate instrument to determine the truth. Guenon points out that is is a modern phenomenon.

> rationalism is a specifically modern phenomenon, one that is closely connected with individualism, being nothing other than the negation of any faculty of a supra-individual order.

The Enlightenment liberal believes that if the disputing parties engage in a rational discussion of ideas, then they will come to a satisfactory conclusion. **However, everyone else knows better**.

It is obvious, by now, that there is no rational answer to the ultimate questions of life; discussions and debates will continue interminably with no resolution. There is the obvious problem associated with individualism and its corollary egalitarianism. In point of fact, not everyone is competent to even understand, never mind debate the issues. Not even science can help.

The conclusions are few:

- Accept that there is no generally agreed upon solution, so that it can be no more than a personal choice. And like the Highlanders, the logical battle of ideas continues on indefinitely.

- There must be a higher form of knowledge that transcends the limits of human reason, and enters into the human world from outside the system.

Intuition The intuitive grasp of principles, which is a direct understanding not mediated through the methods of rationalism, is the solution to the artificial problems posed by rationalism. The difference is that intuition cannot be simply taught since it requires the union of the knower and the known, which is experiential. Unlike rational, which requires nothing of its adherents, intuition requires a change in one's level of being. Traditional truths are immutable and once understood, they are seen to be infallible.

> Intellectual intuition, by which alone metaphysical knowledge is to be obtained, has absolutely nothing in common with this other 'intuition' of which certain contemporary philosophers speak: the latter pertains to the sensible realm and in fact is sub-rational, whereas the former, which is pure intelligence, is on the contrary supra-rational. But the moderns, knowing nothing higher than reason in the order of intelligence, do not even conceive of the possibility of intellectual intuition, whereas the doctrines of the ancient world and of the Middle Ages explicitly recognized its existence and its supremacy over all the other faculties.
>
> Intuition is immutable and infallible in itself, and the only starting-point for any development in conformity with traditional norms.

Verbal Disputes Rationalism tries to sneak into the discussion. As Guenon emphasizes in this passage, metaphysics does not engage in philosophical arguments. Trying to capture ultimate truths verbally is a fool's errand. A fortiori, verbal disputes about the meanings of words are a complete waste of time. Knowledge of principles does not change by verbal formulations.

> It should be clearly understood that it would be utterly useless to put forward here, by way of objection, any more or less specious philosophical arguments; we are speaking seriously, of serious

> matters, and have no time to waste on verbal disputes that would be of no interest, and could serve no useful purpose.

The Party Line Guenon makes perfectly clear that he is not interested in any sort of philosophical "school" nor in party politics. Moreover, Western labels like pantheism or idealism are utterly inapplicable to metaphysical teaching.

> It is our intention to remain entirely aloof from all controversies and quarrels of **school or party**, just as we refuse absolutely to accept any Western label or definition, since none is applicable; whether this is pleasing or displeasing, it is a fact, and nothing will change our attitude in this regard.

Warning to the Possible Elite "Many are called but few are chosen." There are many who have a vague interest in Tradition; they are the called. But the chosen, who have achieved a higher realization, are few. The called only have the possibility of knowledge. The chosen are not seduced by modern ideas, but the called are vulnerable. They need to be extra vigilant is they truly desire to attain any degree of realization.

> A warning must be addressed to those who, because of their capacity for a higher understanding, if not because of the degree of knowledge to which they have actually attained, seem destined to become elements of a possible elite. There is no doubt that the force of modernism, which is truly 'diabolic' in every sense of the word, strives by every means in its power to prevent these elements, today isolated and scattered, from achieving the cohesion that is necessary if they are to exert any real influence on the general mentality. It is therefore for those who have already more or less completely become aware of the end toward which their efforts should be directed to stand firm against whatever difficulties may arise in their path and threaten to turn them aside.

Posted on 2022-01-18 by Cologero

* * *

Mikail on 2022-01-19 at 06:53 said:

"rationalism is a specifically modern phenomenon, one that is closely connected with individualism, being nothing other than the negation of any faculty of a supra-individual order."

It seems that Protestant thinking is the very instigator of the modern order. One could say that the reformation and the scientific revolution occuring in the same time-frame is purely coincidental, but it seems there is a causal link. So which caused which? Did the scientific revolution cause the reformation, or the other way around? Considering the emphasis on rational thought, individualism and free inquiry among Protestant thinkers, the latter could equally be the case.

Mike M on 2022-01-19 at 11:44 said:

"It seems that Protestant thinking is the very instigator of the modern order…be the case."

On the level of earthly manifestation that is a certain way to investigate what occurred. However, causes occur in reality before they manifest, ie. they don't come from nowhere. If Protestant thinking is the instigator, who instigated the instigator? And so on, if infinite regress is an issue, that typically points to a cause outside of the rational sphere. It may be helpful to meditate on why both came about and what the goal is. Barfield's Saving the Appearances may help you if you are truly interested in this question.

Santiago on 2022-01-19 at 18:23 said:

Great post. According to Barfield, the idolatry is still a necessary step. The iguana can't find food without scuffling around like a retarded inbred first. Either it gives up, or it doesn't.

As for the labels, "idealism", "moderate realism", "monophysitism", "Ayn Randian Objectivism", etc. I can see how it's easy to fall into these ideological camps which can taint an entire worldview, as they place an undue emphasis on systems, rather than what is being sought.

Cassiodorus on 2022-01-29 at 09:15 said:

The notion that " Tradition" isn't philosophy is highly dubious . The doctrine of unqualified non- dualism, maya, the degrees of reality and the like are all philosophical doctrines

Gnosis in a traditional Catholic context is light years away from the gnosis of Advaita/ Perrenialism. The spiritual experiences might actually be the same , but their interpretations vary.

What could possibly make one interpretation higher than another if not philosophy ? But that would contradict Guenon's main point about " profane philosophy".

> Cologero on 2022-01-29 at 11:56 said:
> How many years, Cassiodorus, have you been reading and commenting here?
> Well, you finally nailed it.
> As you say, the philosopher is interested in "interpreting" spiritual experiences which he himself never experienced.
> There are only a very few who pursue the "experience", or better said, intellectual intuition.

12.36 The Essence of the Traditions

The New Age view of the various traditions run along the lines that "all religions teach the same thing", "all paths are valid", "great teachers adapted religion for specific people", and similar platitudes along the same lines of thought. From that, they seem to arrive at the illogical conclusion that if all paths lead to the summit, then there is no point in following a path. Even if we concede their assumptions, to get to the peak clearly requires following one of the traditional paths.

Rene Guenon himself makes this clear. Nevertheless, his fundamental assumption differs not much from the new age view, when he claims all traditions are the same; the same, too, for Schuon's *Transcendental Unity of Religions*. As anti-egalitarians, we cannot suddenly consider all traditions as somehow equal or equivalent. Rather, we need to grasp the inner essence of each tradition, i.e., what exact insight each one brings. Beyond platitudes, there is specificity, and it is that quality that separates the players from the patzers.

The Two Worlds From the Vedas to Plato to Augustine, we see the constant teaching of two worlds. Yet, to a great extent, those who claim a tie to Tradition as such seem to forget this teaching. This seems to me to be the case (readers can provide counterexamples) among neoreactionaries and those who try to wed Tradition to various political

movements. The focus is solely on the world of becoming, Even those—and these are legion relatively speaking—whose only exposure to Tradition is through **Julius Evola** cannot evade this. In the first paragraph of the first chapter of *Revolt Against the Modern World*, he writes:

> In order to understand both the spirit of Tradition and its antithesis, modern civilization, it is necessary to begin with the fundamental doctrine of the two natures. According to this doctrine there is a physical order of things and a metaphysical one; there is a mortal nature and an immortal one; there is the superior realm of "being" and the inferior realm of "becoming." Generally speaking, there is a visible and tangible dimension and, prior to and beyond it, an invisible and intangible dimension that is the support, the source, and true life of the former.
>
> Anywhere in the world of Tradition, both East and West and in one form or another, this knowledge (not just a mere theory) has always been present as an unshakeable axis around which everything revolved. Let me emphasize the fact that it was knowledge and not theory. As difficult as it may be for our contemporaries to understand this, we must start from the idea that the man of Tradition was aware of the existence of a dimension of being much wider than what our contemporaries experience and call "reality".

Hence, the man of Tradition must strive to gain true knowledge of that realm of being, even to the point of obsession. Of course, that realm is not obvious, whence the need for Tradition and true spiritual teachings. The natural man is aware only of the inferior world of becoming. That world appears to be governed by evolution and the will to power, and man's only purpose is the pursuit and fulfilment of sensory pleasures. We don't deny those appearances, rather we deny their ultimacy as an explanation of the world process.

To get back to the point, we can find the essence of the various traditions in how they understand and teach the higher world. **Valentin Tomberg**, in the *Covenant of the Heart*, scatters interesting insights about the role of the various traditions in salvation history. I will draw on some of them. First, this is Tomberg's definition of salvation:

> Salvation is the helping hand offered to idealistically minded human beings who, though no longer identifying themselves with natural evolution, still lack sufficient strength of themselves to alter its course.

To rephrase it in Guenon's terms, the actualization of man's possibilities as salvation is not possible within the material world process, but must arise from a transcendent source. So there is a salvation history as that "helping hand" revealed itself in various ways. Tomberg writes:

> The hand of God stretched down form on high to human beings mired in evolution's stream so that they may be raised up and helped to return to the divine archetypal world ... which came in the form of successive stages of revelation, descending like tumbling cascades of a waterfall, awakening, the consciousness of mankind to its divine archetype. This process of revelation took place through seers and prophets and was subsequently recorded and preserved in holy scriptures. Thus, for instance, the revelation vouchsafed to the seven Holy Rishis forms the basis of the Vedas, the Holy Writ of India. The Zend-Avest of ancient Iran records the revelation communicated to Zarathustra when, on a high mountain fastness, he confronted the God of Light—Ahura Mazda—face to face. The Bible tells of the revelation received by Moses on Mount Sinai, where he encountered, also face to face, the God who bore the ineffable name of YHWH.

Note that these are all revelations of the superior world of Being. Regarding Brahmanism, Tomberg writes:

> The primordial revelation of India announces the good news that the divine-archetypal Man, the true self of mankind, is not the empirical self, and likewise that the world—the real world that is, the divine-archetypal world—is not the empirical world of natural evolution.

I was speaking to two Hindus today about spiritual matters and, to my surprise, they could not see this as good news. India is not as spiritual as Guenon believed, but it full of charlatans charging money for quack cures and instant enlightenment; it should be no surprise that many Westerners are drawn to such nonsense. For example, one such guru says your karma will be burned off by walking X times around a certain temple which reciting a mantra he gives you. I told them that salvation cannot be achieved by such mechanical means. Unfortunately, the doctrines of karma and reincarnation seem to be traps and the opposite of good news. The two were obsessed about how to burn up karma and achieve a better life, or actually a better next life.

It reminded me more of the medieval buying of indulgences than any free movement of the spirit. Their idea is that a good life would be free of the many trials we undergo. Yes, I would agree if understood properly. The trials are the results of man's fall and are part of the world of becoming, not of being. Christian salvation promises to restore man to the state before the fall, even in an instant.

One of them told me he was depressed at the thought of the number of future lives that are necessary for him to achieve deliverance. That surprised me because the spiritual life should be one of joy. If one is still obsessed only with improving one's material circumstances in the world of becoming, then, yes, depression will result unless one sinks into in full and unconsciously.

I told him that one's true self transcends the empirical self and that the solution is vertical, not horizontal. As one learns to detach and observe life, emotions, and thoughts dispassionately, there will be increas-

ingly long states of bliss.

To move on, Tomberg then writes:

> The good news of Zarathustra was that the world and Man represented an admixture of two distinct world orders—that of the principle of light and that of the principle of darkness, or the divine–archetypal world order and that of natural evolution—and that the latter would in the end be vanquished by Soshyans "who through will overcomes death", to be followed by the resurrection of the dead.

Note how different this is from "academic" and "learned" explanations of Zoroastrianism. They have no clue that Zarathustra was talking about the worlds of being and becoming. Moving on to the next revelation, Tomberg continues:

> Finally, the good news revealed to Moses and the prophets proclaims that mankind, having fallen into the serpent's domain through the Fall, can yet be redeemed, for the very essence and epitome of the divine-archetypal world order Himself was to become Man so that mankind might thereby triumph over the domain of the serpent and the dead might resurrect.

This has set the stage, finally, for our ultimate purpose, to wit, the self-understanding of the medieval Tradition, how it relates to other traditions, the source of its metaphysical teachings, and how it developed organically from the Roman religion that preceded it. God willing, this will appear this weekend.

Posted on 2014-02-26 by Cologero

* * *

August on 2014-02-28 at 02:46 said:

I wouldn't call recognition of the convergence of paths in transcendental unity an "egalitarian" or levelling view, so long as we understand transcendence in the absolute sense.

Guenon, for example, did differentiate between traditions, not so much horizontally, but vertically, which allows comparison not only of traditions, but of their inner accommodations and followers. To compare them horizontally is not the most useful exercise; the chief reason different paths exist is because races and ages are qualitatively distinct, so that the variety is necessary, and does not need to be reduced by humans. And, like any other contingency, traditions are capable of taking an indefinite number of forms, so that studying the insights of those before us can only ever, at most, bring one to the threshold of the Absolute, the purpose of every tradition being fulfilled at that point.

Consider Guenon here, discriminating:

" The preceding will suffice to mark the profound distinction that exists between the Great Architect of Masonry on the one hand and on the other hand the gods of the various religions, who are only so many aspects of the Demiurge. Moreover, it is incorrect to identify... the anthropomorphic God of exoteric Christians with Jehovah... or with Allah... "

August on 2014-02-28 at 03:14 said:

As exit says, the new age thought will tend to reject all valid paths, because it thinks that is has found, or is about to find, something better, a 'true key', or some great synthesis that operates to combine the good things and skim off the bad all at once. We see this for what it is, yet another combination borne of desperation, stirred by a whiff of the esoteric that whets the collective appetite of a multitude that cannot seize the jewel as a multitude.

But then there are others, certainly not new age, who see (exoteric) tradition, especially religion, as a mainly social phenomenon, and who have a good grasp of transcendence, even if it only be cognitive, enough to create perspective. Combined with a certain attitude fashioned in the exasperation of today, these types will assert a freedom that can participate in any tradition or none, to whatever extent they can or wish. Why shouldn't they? Sure, this world is wrong, but they are its products; and there is a middle path between succumbing to error and adopting a regular lifestyle today, and the strained reversion fantasy that preoccupies many a 'traditionalist'. That middle path, for some, is treating religion as a burden to be avoided without sufficient incentive to participate, just like anything else in our corner of the kingdom of becoming. And like any burden, setting it aside is not all gain, but one thinks about this before deciding.

Cologero on 2014-02-28 at 08:51 said:

August wrote: "Guenon, for example, did differentiate between traditions, not so much horizontally, but vertically, which allows comparison not only of traditions, but of their inner accommodations and followers."

Precisely, August. But it is one thing to assert its possibility, and quite another to actually do the comparison. That is what we are attempting. That Guenon quote is rather vacuous; which Christian Church Father proclaimed an "anthropomorphic God". I am getting weary of broad strokes ... where have we indulged in a "strained reversion fantasy", August? Do you just like the sound of your "voice" or do you actually want to engage in a conversation?

August on 2014-02-28 at 20:40 said:

I didn't have Gornahoor in mind when I mentioned reversion fantasies. This article was strong, and I look forward to the following.

Don't pay me too much mind, I don't know what I want. Carry on, and if the time comes to banish me, say the world and I'll say no more.

JA on 2014-03-01 at 10:33 said:

Personally when I read a book I refrain from making final judgement until I've reached the end; as such I will wait until post 1001 before I can say whether I fully agree with Gornahoor or not, until then all I will do is mention that so far it's been extremely helpful and enlightening to me.

JA on 2014-03-01 at 10:37 said:

New age teaching as I understand claims that the forms (exotericism) is meaningless and the core (esotericism) is the same everywhere; the same approach Evola has – and also Crowley. Dont forget that before encountering Guenon's ideas Evola was involved in the Italian new age milieu albeit those of higher intelligence than the simple frauds that trick old ladies.

Guenon even if he never quite stated it this way saw Hinduism as the highest form of Tradition, but since it's a closed racial path, he saw Islam as the next best thing. What Cologero is showing us with Tomberg is a different way of looking at things which Guenon never considered and I am finding myself in agreement with him.

Scardanelli on 2014-03-01 at 12:03 said:

Do not despair brother August. The ego must be checked from time to time so that we may experience what is beyond the chattering of the mind. For what it's worth, I don't think it's a simple matter of agreeing or disagreeing with the content here, as that is not enough and would be rather presumptuous besides. Truth is not understood but seen, and Gornahoor has outlined the means to apprehend this truth within. Until this becomes active within us, we will not know what to do with ideas; we will not know how to "handle" them. Otherwise we can continue to comment and banter and discuss, or contribute little one liners, and we will remain destitute men of this world without knowledge of the kingdom of God.

"Happy is the man whom truth by itself doth teach, not by figures and transient words, but as it is in itself." -Kempis

I'm glad that you are back in good health Cologero. Your wisdom has been sorely missed. I will pray for your continued health (though perhaps somewhat selfishly).

12.37 Why How What

> Howbeit we speak wisdom among the perfect: yet not the wisdom of this world, neither of the princes of this world that come to nought; But we speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, a wisdom which is hidden, which God ordained before the world, unto our glory:
>
> 1 Corinthians 2:6-7

I listened to a lecture on TED[46] that claimed that an enterprise needs to answer the questions "**Why? How? What**?" in that order. We have answered "what" in many different ways, but apparently not the why. So this is an attempt to answer the "why".

Fundamental points We were motivated at the very beginning by **Rene Guenon**'s *Crisis of the Modern World*. It makes two fundamental points:

1. The crisis is the result of the loss of tradition in the west.
2. Tradition will be restored only via an elite

We take point (1) as stipulated, even while we have identified the many specific ways that tradition has been lost. Point (1) has been written about everywhere, without any consistency. So our two "whys" follow, but in inverse order.

[46] `https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sioZd3AxmnE`

1. Gornahoor aims to identify the qualities of a traditional elite and to offer knowledge, suggestions, and opportunities to develop, or initiate, that elite.

2. Gornahoor aims to make clear which specific traditional principles have been undermined by modernity. Following **Joseph de Maistre**, we don't expect a revolution in the opposite direction (e.g., following some cataclysmic collapse) but rather the opposite of a revolution.

Hence, under the guise of a general interest web site, the real intent is for the relatively few of a like mind to be drawn together in accordance with the Law of Affinity. Therefore, we don't try to convince anyone. We make the case, as necessary, and rely on men's inner convictions to respond as they see fit.

The Nature of Things The conventional view is that things obey certain laws external to them which science then discovers. This is not precisely correct, as we have shown that these so-called laws are really creations in the mind of the scientist. It should be clear then that things act according to their own inner nature.

The Nature of Man Man, as a person, has intellect and will. That is his nature and is what distinguishes him from other things in the world. Unlike things which are unconscious of their nature, man has an intellect and can come to know his nature. Unlike things which follow their nature automatically, man has a will, so he can choose to follow his nature or not.

Human Action The will follows the intellect. Hence a disordered mind will result in disordered actions. That is why the first task is to describe "what" is an ordered mind. But everyone makes that same claim;

there is no shortage of people who will tell other people what to think. The one thing necessary, then, is the "how": how can one achieve an ordered mind and with conviction, knowing it represents the truth.

One Tradition We take it as a given that the Catholic tradition is the proper one for the West as Guenon suggests. In the Crisis, he thought that the elite would arise from that, although he was not sanguine about its prospects. However, whatever its current state may be is not really our concern. There is the Church of Peter and the Church of John[47]; it is the latter we follow, although not in conflict with Peter.

We stand with Augustine that there is only one tradition and it is now called Catholicism. That means it must be understood in that light. That will be the How. *Pace* Guenon, we have shown that there is still a living esoteric tradition. However, if anyone is looking for it here or there, he won't find it. There are no buildings, no ads in the backs of magazines, no permanent structures, no outrageous promises. Movements arise spontaneously since the Spirit blows where he wills; we are initiated from above. If you blink, you may miss it.

An Opportunity Lost Vatican II offered the opportunity to recover tradition. Unfortunately, it created turmoil, although in the long run things may change. Fantasize for a moment if Rene Guenon had been one of the experts at that Council.

Unfortunately, Rene Guenon was a victim of the super correct convert Jacques Maritain. Maritain managed to exclude Guenon from Catholic intellectual circles, to its intellectual impoverishment. Later on, Maritain seemed to make amends when he mentioned Shankara as a philosopher of being, but at that point it was too late to make any impact on his philosophy. Instead, Maritain made a more liberal turn, becoming an influential

[47] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-church-of-john

figure for Vatican II. Meanwhile, Guenon abandoned that project and turned to Islam.

Signs of the Times

> At all times the Church carries the responsibility of reading the signs of the time.
>
> *Gaudium et Spes*

How different would the document on the relationship of the Church to the modern world have turned out had Guenon's book of the same title held sway! We have the responsibility to discern the signs of the times.

Ecumenism How much spiritual depth would have been added to the declaration on the relation of the Church to non-Christian religions! Guenon was opposed to false ecumenism and syncretism of the Assisi type where all religions gathered together indiscriminately. Instead, Guenon said that unity lies deeper, in their respective symbolic and metaphysical underpinnings. Ecumenism as described by Guenon is what we pursue.

Ressourcement Ressourcement is the call to return to the sources. Again, Guenon has shown us the way. As he pointed out, Platonism, properly understood as a metaphysic rather than a philosophical school, Is a nearly complete metaphysic. He was always quick to point out the many correspondences between **Aristotle** and **Plato** on the one side and the various Vedantic systems on the other. Therefore, we, too, are motivated by ressourcement.

Plato, however, was not *sui generis*, but was himself part of a larger Tradition[48], neither at the beginning not the end. Hence, we are justified

[48] https://gornahoor.net/?p=1256

to go back to all those sources, including **Hermes Trismegistus** and **Pythagoras**.

As Vladimir Solovyov pointed out, Christianity did not create a new metaphysic. Rather, it is a story of historical events. The proper metaphysic, therefore, can be traced back to Hermetism and Neoplatonism. That is an option to take quite seriously.

Updated 5 September 2020

Posted on 2014-09-05 by Cologero

12.38 The Synthesis of All Traditions

> It is true that many vestiges of a forgotten past are coming out of the earth in our age, and perhaps not without reason.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Traditional Forms and Cosmic Cycles*

Guenon wrote that well before the discoveries of the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Nag Hammadi Library. The Tibetans have a similar view and believe that sacred texts may be hidden for hundreds of years and then found at the opportune time. We here have noted the publication of texts that point to the likely existence of a continuous esoteric tradition in the West. Even **Dante**'s Divine Comedy can be understood in that vein. As Guenon points out, the inner meaning of that poem was hidden for six hundred years until some poets in the 19th century began to suspect there was a deep metaphysical teaching in the Comedy. It seems, however, that little has been done in the meantime to build on that insight, at least until we encounter the unique meditations of Guido De Giorgio.

Guido De Giorgio was born on 3 October 1890 at San Lupo and died a natural death on 27 December 1957. After graduating with a degree in philosophy from the University of Naples, he emigrated to Tunisia

to teach. While there, he was initiated into the Sufi order led by **Sheik Mohammad Kheireddine**. He returned to Italy at the outbreak of the WW I. After that, he spent quite some time in Paris where he developed a close relationship with Rene Guenon. He returned to the Italian Alps and married his second wife who had done her university thesis on the Vedanta. One of his sons died a hero's death in Ethiopia; it was a loss, since he left behind a journal that displayed his father's influence. His daughter became a nun and his other son was named "Renato" (Italian for Rene) in honor of M. Guenon.

In Italy, De Giorgio collaborated with **Julius Evola** in the Ur group and then in Evola's journal *La Torre*; he also contributed some articles to *Diorama filosofico*, a philosophical journal also directed by Evola. Evola described him in these terms:

> He was a type of initiate in a primitive and chaotic state, he had both lived among the Arabs and known Guenon, who held De Giorgio in high esteem. He possessed an exceptional culture, knew several languages, but his temperament was unstable. His refusal of the modern world was such that he lived secluded in the mountains that he felt as his natural milieu and, finally, in an abandoned rectory, living practically on nothing, from some tutoring that he did, and suffering physically every time he was obliged to make contact with civilized and town life.
>
> His influence on me, which owes nothing to his books, since none of them had been published yet, but which was exercised by his upsetting and aggressive letters, sprinkled with illuminations, and confusions, was tied to his way of dramatizing and stimulating his conception of Tradition. Guenon's presentation was, because of his personal equation, very formal and intellectual traits. But De Giorgio united to that a tendency of absolutism which, naturally, found in me congenital territory. The rare pieces of his that I published, sometimes extracts of his letters against his will, are

> perhaps the only ones that remain, unfortunately. I was in contact with De Giorgio (whom I met twice in the Alps) during the brief period of my review La Torre. Otherwise, in more recent times, we have become distant from each other, because of his drift into a type of "Vedantizing" Christianity.

Nevertheless, that is still too restrictive, because he could equally be accused of "paganizing" Christianity, or more especially, "Sufi-izing" Christianity. De Giorgio, along with **Arturo Reghini** and Julius Evola, was concerned with the project of the restoration of the Roman Tradition. **Piero di Vona** describes this:

> Regarding the project of the restoration of the Roman tradition and with it, Traditional Europe, which is owed to De Giorgio, the best Italian disciple of Guenon, we can only mention a few things because of the great complexity and intrinsic difficulty of his work which would require a deep and independent study. Whoever wants to understand De Giorgio must have a deep knowledge of Guenon. Moreover, we have to warn any possible reader of De Giorgio's style of thought and way of writing. The inspired, wild, and almost raving tone, in some of his pages, masks a very deep understanding of the ideas and symbols of contemporary, metaphysical Traditionalism.
>
> De Giorgio's vision of the transcendent truths of the traditional order is very complex. In it, Neoplatonic, Christian, Hindu, and Islamic themes join and intersect each other. His conception of the supreme principle as silence, and the three degrees of the ineffable, should be studied in relationship to Neoplatonism. Some profound Christian motifs are present.
>
> The non-dual understanding of the supreme is the aspect of De Giorgio's conception that is tied to the well-known Hindu idea, which he shares in common with Guenon. But the Islamic perspective remains preeminent and dominant over all the indicated themes. But it is certainly important to note that, through

> Guenon, the first appearance in Italy of the Islamic vision of the absolute was made with De Giorgio, from which he began to build his Roman traditionalism. That is so much more interesting given that De Giorgio had never converted to Islam.

There is no point to continue with this at this time, as it will become clearer as more of his essays appear in Gornahoor. Yet, things cannot be so simple with De Giorgio, since he also ties Tradition to the two Romes: the ancient pagan, and the medieval Catholic. To return to the beginning, ultimately it is Dante who brings it all together. On the one hand, Dante was influenced by the writings of the Sufi Ibn Al-Arabi. On the other, through the pagan **Virgil**, and ultimately **Aeneas**, the Indo-European pagan tradition enters into the Tradition of the second Rome. De Giorgio goes even further: Dante, for him, brings together the two dominant spiritual strains in the Middle Ages, those of the Dominicans and the Franciscans, or, to say it again, the Thomist and the Augustinian paths. As De Giorgio writes:

> The Dominicans and the Franciscans have marked out the two greatest ways of the realization of the divine.

Regarding his views on Dante, Vona summarizes De Giorgio:

> There is in Rome the living synthesis of the ancient pagan tradition and of the new and Christian one. Dante is the one who not only manifested it, but directly transmitted in the sacred poem and its realizing and initiatory values and meanings. One can reach the most profound parts of Catholicism from Dante, which are related to metaphysical realization by means of contemplation.

References:

Baillet, Phillipe, *Guido De Giorgio, le voyant solitaire* from *L'Instant et l'Eternité*

Di Vona, Piero, *Evola Guenon De Giorgio*

Pintore, Franco, *Preface to La Tradizione Romana*

Posted on 2013-02-15 by Cologero

* * *

Janus on 2013-02-15 at 01:24 said:

Fascinating. It begs the question of whether a restored Tradition in the West will be Christian in nature, or whether it will take a form which draws from many other manifestations of Tradition around the world. Perhaps those who will become the guides must seek out strange lands and traditions to find what is so familiar in their own they become blind to it, before they can "know the place for the first time." (Eliot).

Mercurius on 2013-02-15 at 15:07 said:

Quite interesting and similarly, Theophilus Schweighardt begins his Rosy Cross treatise "Mirror of Wisdom" explaining that the whole teaching is being presented "clearly" and "before your eyes". Then, after pointing out that the "Holy Divine Scripture" comprises the bedrock of the doctrine, he refers readers to the Augustinian Thomas Kempis for practical instruction:

"More I cannot say unto thee of this, but if thou desirest more information concerning this fundament and preparatory work, thou shalt find more thereon in the aforementioned little books of Thomas a Kempis, for the author in the same book does nothing else but teach thee to practise this work rightly and well, and so it may be called his golden writing, well and truly a fount and origin of the Rhodo-staurotic teaching. Hoc de priori".

Cologero on 2013-02-19 at 07:37 said:

Perhaps we could distinguish the main points of the two schools in this manner. For the Thomist, all knowledge begins in sense perception. For the Augustinian, it begins in the interiority of man.

12.39 The Conversion of Rene Guenon

Did **Rene Guenon** "convert"? In the article "Conversions", included in the collection *Initiation and Spiritual Realization*, he explains that

the word can be taken in two totally different senses. The first is an "intellectual metamorphosis", an "interior transformation", metanoia, or "change of *nous*" that indicates the "conscious passage of the ordinary and individual mind, normally turned toward sensible things, to its superior transposition."

This is an interior transformation and has nothing to do with the second type which is commonly called a religious conversion. The second type is the exterior passage from one exoteric religious form to another; this type is just an exterior and contingent change. It often lacks "any real importance" and has "nothing to do with pure spirituality." Guenon has "little regard for such converts in general" who are often associated with the "most exaggerated sectarianism". Guenon claims the opposite:

> Contrary to what takes place in 'conversion', nothing here implies the attribution of the superiority of one traditional form over another. It is merely a question of what one might call reasons of spiritual expediency, which is altogether different from simple individual preference.

Nevertheless, even the first type of conversion may be associated with an outward change of form. However, that choice is not arbitrary and there may be valid reasons for it. Guenon elucidates:

> those who, for reasons of an esoteric and initiatic order, adopt a traditional form different from that to which they would seem to be linked by their origin do this either because their native tradition provides them with no possibility of an esoteric order, or because their chosen tradition gives them a foundation that is more appropriate to their nature, and consequently more favorable to their spiritual work.

So we see that for the elite, it is the intellectual conversion that is important. The outer form is secondary. Therefore, the various attempts

to recover lost forms for their own sake or to critique living forms based solely on their exteriority are misguided. The criteria are these:

1. Is the form rich and varied enough to incorporate true metaphysical teachings?
2. Is the exterior form able to capture the allegiance of the general population, given their various capacities to understand?
3. Does the exterior form provide a safe haven within which the elite can accomplish their tasks?

Posted on 2010-02-25 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-02-26 at 00:01 said:

I think the issue some take with Christianity lies in the third of your criteria. The Christian religion seems to have been the fountainhead of a large number of subversive movements – though even as I write this I can anticipate your response will be that Christianity was Judaized. Well, fair enough, but wasn't it also paganized in an earlier period? It seems to me that what is of most value in historical Christianity is what is least essentially Christian about it.

12.40 Prelude to Development

> All of Saint Bernard's life seems destined to show that in order to solve problems of an intellectual and even a political order there exist means quite other than those we have long since become accustomed to considering the only ones effective, no doubt because they are the only ones within reach of a purely human wisdom, *which is not even a shadow of true wisdom*.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Saint Bernard*

One of the aims of this discussion of Solovyov is to demonstrate how a particular tradition treats the general questions of Tradition as **Rene Guenon** has shown. We pointed out that the three basic forms of being, that is, as we actually experience our life,–feeling, thinking, and willing—are associated with the Platonic Triad of fundamental ideas: Beauty, Truth, and Goodness. These ideas manifest on three levels: material, formal, and absolute (above form). As we shall see, that yields nine different areas of manifestation. Note that the three levels correspond to the traditional castes: Brahman, Kshatriya, Vaishya, which reflect the orientation of a person. Since a person may be centered on the feeling, thinking, or willing function, Solovyov's system demonstrates nine personality types. For example, one may focus on political matters, another on economic activity, another on art or mystical states. Each one will probably think his own area of interest is the most important and will have impatience with those who believe otherwise. The metaphysican, however, is interested in knowledge of the Whole, the One, as only this knowledge is true Wisdom.

That Solovyov's approach is viable, is shown by a similar notion from Guenon:

> Where something truly traditional is concerned, everything must be present from the beginning and subsequent developments serve only to render it more explicit without the adjunction of new and external elements.

This is from Guenon's important essay, The Holy Grail. Obviously, this is equivalent to Solovyov's definition of development. So we shall be interested in the development of Traditional ideas. For one, Solovyov's system explains why there are three castes. He will also deal with the question of spiritual authority and temporal power as it has developed. Finally, the whole cycle must be understood.

In particular, the conclusion we must draw from this is that the Tradition espoused by Solovyov is a subsequent development of the Primordial

Tradition. The process of its development from the Satya Yuga to the Kali Yuga must be explained. Since development must have a goal, which cannot be total chaos because it is impossible, the goal is the recovery of the **Primordial State**.

Misunderstandings In our discussion of the development of Tradition, it is important to clear up some misunderstandings about what Tradition is not.

Documentarian Tradition is not like a documentary. While it may be useful to document how symbols or rites are used across traditions, that is not the main point. Knowing, for example, some ancient Etruscan fertility rite is not ipso facto knowing Tradition.

Antiquarian Tradition is not an antiquarian interest. For example, the recovery of medieval Lithuanian basket weaving techniques is not Tradition. Arts and crafts may be one of the areas we discuss, but it is far from the Whole.

Partisan Tradition is certainly not partisanship. To evangelize for one tradition over another is really an exoteric activity. However, it lacks the dispassion and objectivity required for an understanding of Tradition. In normal circumstances, a man follows the traditions of his people. That is why Guenon acted as a Catholic in France, but relocated to Egypt to be a Muslim.

Understandings Guenon makes several points that will help in an analysis of Tradition.

Privileged Form Guenon writes:

> There is no traditional form that is privileged; the only distinction to be made is between forms that have disappeared and those still living.

There is a marked tendency today to claim the superiority of one form over another, usually on the basis that it is more suitable to the mentality of a particular ethnic group. However, this is a serious misunderstanding, as it is concerned with the psychological. Guenon writes:

> True mystical states elude the domain of psychology entirely.

Esoteric vs Exoteric When we discuss traditions, we are generally concerned with its esoteric aspects. Thus any criticisms based on particular exoteric manifestations of teachings, are irrelevant to us, and only reveal the ignorance of the critic. Hence, we agree with Guenon when he writes:

> There can be no doubt of the existence of Christian esoterism in the Middle Ages.

That is objectively and infallibly true. Anyone who disagrees understands neither esoterism nor the Middle Ages, and is typically deluded by psychological and sentimental motivations.

Many are confused about this, so we dare to hope that these quotes from Guenon will dispel any future confusions:

> Esoterism can under no circumstances be represented by churches of sects of any kind ... those who persist in ascribing to sects what concerns esoterism or initiation are on the wrong track and can only go astray.

This is not said in opposition to exoterism, but rather not to confuse domains. For example, exoterically Christians claim that **Jesus** is the Avatar of the **Logos**. His claim to being God does not rest on the circumstances of his birth,–which would make him a

demigod— but rather on the claim that the Logos is God. As a contingent, historical event, there is no metaphysical proof of this birth. Now, Solovyov claims to prove that the Logos is God, and even that the Logos must incarnate. However, he cannot prove that the incarnation happened at a certain time and place to a particular individual. Please keep this distinction in mind.

Continuity and Incorporation As we have repeated many times, as one tradition fades away, what is essential in it is incorporated into another living tradition. As one illustration, Guenon writes:

> When a traditional form is on the verge of extinction, its last representatives may very well deliberately entrust to this collective memory i.e., folklore what would otherwise be irrevocably lost. This is the only way to save what can be saved; and, at the same time, the natural incomprehension of the masses is a sufficient guarantee that whatever possesses an esoteric character will not be despoiled in the process but will remain as a sort of witness to the past for those in later times who may be capable of understanding it.
>
> It seems beyond doubt that *the origins of the Grail legend must be linked to the transmission from Druidism to Christianity of traditional elements of an initiatic order*. Once this transmission had been effected in a regular manner, whatever the modalities of the transmission may have been, *these elements thereby became an integral part of Christian esoterism*.

There is no question here of "borrowing", or "deceiving", or even distorting. The Grail legend is preserved in its fullness, becoming an integral part of the new tradition. Guenon never anticipated that the masses would have access to all this material; unfortunately, the incomprehension remains, but now results in despoil-

> ing. Thus we see neo-Druids and neo-pagans reappear, and like the **Aghoris**, feed on the cadavers of extinct traditions, and ignore the fresh food of still living traditions. In our example, if they cannot understand the Legend of the Grail as expressed in Medieval literature, how can they possibly recover is alleged original meaning?

Conclusion Guenon lists two works, **Dante**'s Divine Comedy and the Romance of the Rose, that describe the esoteric process quite openly. With that in mind, serious men will choose to study those works assiduously rather than indulge in fantasies. Guenon also points to Saint Bernard as an antidote to the poison of modernity:

> Among the great figures of the Middle Ages, there are few whose study is more suited for counteracting certain prejudices cherished by the modern mind that Saint Bernard.
>
> Saint Bernard was always determined by the same intentions:
>
> - To defend the right
> - To combat injustice
> - To maintain unity in the Christian world

That is enough to get started.

Posted on 2011-12-05 by Cologero

* * *

Avery on 2011-12-06 at 02:34 said:

I don't think the new right is in danger of falling apart. It's a movement made up of intelligent people who lived liberalism and woke up to realize, "this is insane". When you step out of the Matrix you find a bunch of people disagreeing with each other over how to fight it, but you can at least understand their intentions. People who want spiritual disunity are fighting a different battle entirely.

Yes, I understand their intentions, not always their tactics. Our only concern here is to counter some common misconceptions about Tradition. Admin

EXIT on 2011-12-06 at 10:36 said:

Guenon concluded that a restoration of Christianity was impossible, given its modernist leanings and as so meany perennialists agree today so much of Christianity (i.e., its gnostic esoteric elements) have been lost and cannot be put back again. Ere it is the christians who are the aghoris feeding on a corpse of a dead tradition. Christianity is particularly difficult and undesirable for the very reason that the church is not transmitter of the esoteric tradition as it should be were there anyone of any understanding and worth in the church. For without the holy of holies it is precisely useless and of zero interest to traditionalists.

As for the issue of borrowing... how can it be denied given all the evidence that christians borrowed from other traditions? Didn't even Evola admit that the christians distorted the grail legend? I suggest reading Murdock's The Christ Conspiracy. Christianity grew out of a multiculturalized world with Greek and Roman occupations of Palestine and the Alexandrian school. Whether these elements were synthesized or not is an entirely separate issue from that of borrowing; but as we often see, these elements were not always perfectly fitted together precisely because they were borrowings.

logres on 2011-12-06 at 22:45 said:

I don't understand your quarrel with Christianity – most of the Middle Ages was a repudiation of precisely the "multicultural and synthesizing" element which you decry in the decaying Roman world. I understand the dismay at modern Church, however much I might disagree about precisely how to fix it.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-07 at 03:55 said:

Exit, I do understand that it's impossible to get something until you get it. On this subject specifically Rudolf Steiner's lecture about the return of Christ in the Etheric is helpful. For those with an interest in Shambhala this lecture also has some interesting information towards the bottom of the article (which is quite short):

http://wn.rsarchive.org/Lectures/GA118/English/APC1961/19100306p02.html

Perennial on 2011-12-08 at 03:35 said:

Are we in for a another mythinformation fest, EXIT?

Cologero on 2022-12-05 at 09:01 said:

Well, the "New Right" did fall apart. And most of the self-appointed leaders turned out to be opportunists or even decadent. A "bunch of people disagreeing" does not make a "movement". There is a fundamental logical difference between A and not A as Guenon points out in Man and his Becoming.

12.41 Guenon: The Trajectory of his Life

For anyone looking for clues of an initiatic tradition in the West, it is helpful to follow the path trod by **Rene Guenon**. We can leave out of consideration any rumours or allegations, such as a mysterious Hindu or Sufi initiation. His own course speaks for itself and it is absurd to consider it as some sort of charade. The paths he actually followed are what counts, not the paths he may have studied. Of the former, there are three.

Hermetism At the end of the 19th century, Paris was undergoing a sort of Hermetic revival, which attracted the young Guenon. He was secretary to Papus, one of the primary figures of that revival. He later abandoned that movement of some doctrinal issues and the lack of a regular initiation. However, keep in mind that this is the first place Guenon went to look for it.

Catholicism He next got involved with Catholic circles, even marrying a devout woman. He wrote for the journal Regnabit ("he Christ will reign") and traveled in a circle that included the Thomist metaphysician **Jacques Maritain**. He supported the organization Action Française, led by Charles Maurras, which included Positivists and Catholics among its members. Interestingly, he supported the condemnation of Action Française by **Pope Pius XI** on the grounds he was the legitimate spiritual authority.

Sufism Unsatisfied with his first two paths, Guenon took advantage of a trip to Egypt following the death of his first wife to become fully engaged with Sufism. As we have pointed out, this was not a conversion in the conventional sense of the term[49]. It involved an intellectual conversion and the personal judgment that Sufism provided a more certain initiatic for his needs. From an esoteric perspective, the abyss from Europe to Egypt may not be as wide as some think. **Houston Smith** describes Islam as a Semitic Religion built on Platonic metaphysics; he may as well have been describing Medieval Christendom. Furthermore, Sufism also has a Hermetic element of its own.

The Next Step Let's follow this logic, at least those of us who claim to be following the path created by Guenon. If the obvious places to look — Hermetism and Medieval Catholicism — are lacking a contemporary initiatic organization, then how can we expect to recognize such a thing? These obvious places are close to us in time, language, and history and are well documented. Presumably, they should be easier to understand than more alien texts such as the Yoga Sutras of **Patanjali**. Guenon mentions that the Romance of the Rose is an initiatic text, something he should be able to recognize.

Shouldn't all so-called Traditionalists rush out to obtain and interpret this work? I doubt it, as many will prefer to learn the alleged esoteric secrets of the Runes. I say alleged not because the Runes had no such significance, but only because no one today has any means to know those secrets.

What are the clues we can look for? First of all, when Reason speaks, this is understood as the higher intellect, or gnosis, something few contemporary minds can even conceive of. The book is ostensibly about profane love, but that clearly represents a description of a spiritual path, from **Dante** and the **Fedeli d'Amore** to the Sufi poets. A forgettable

[49] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=262

neo-pagan web site I came across suggested that the Medievals "invented" Mary because they had no proper goddesses of their own. That is merely a confession that they invented their neo-pagan goddeses.

Of course, the Medievals knew about **Sophia** and the *Anima Mundi*, unlike those neo-pagans. The Romance even discusses the gods, a page they probably missed. They then make the tired claim that only some neo-pagan witches or Druids can understand it, while simultaneously misunderstanding it. To the contrary, Guenon writes about:

> Christian Hermetists of the Middle Ages, whose intentions were always fully orthodox.

Further East, and this is getting to the point, Guenon recognizes that

> Hesychasm whose truly initiatic character seems indisputable. ... In hesychasm, initiation in the strict sense consists essentially in the regular transmission of certain formulas, exactly comparable to the transmission of mantras in the Hindu tradition and of the wird in the Islamic turuq. It also contains a complete technique of invocations as a true method of interior work.

Guenon mentions that this tradition probably was able to continue by hiding itself. Shouldn't we recognize, however, in the writings of **Vladimir Solovyov**, **Valentin Tomberg**, and **Boris Mouravieff**, all coming from the East, an unveiling of that tradition. The elements are there: invocations, interior work, gnosis, Sophia and so on. I know there are those driven by sentimentalism and an overactive subjective imagination who would choke on such a thought. However, like the Aghoris who eat the repulsive, I say Chow down. A man on the path will stop at nothing in search of enlightenment.

Posted on 2011-12-12 by Cologero

* * *

Boreas on 2012-01-13 at 05:56 said:

"Replacing one exoterism with an allegedly older, non-existent, poorly understood, and artificially constructed exoterism (neo-paganism) is a task for fools."

It is not only a task for fools, it is mostly either disguised (or open) vanity, and, more importantly, it is to feed upon dead corpses. Maybe a single "aghori" here and there can do this and even manage to get some heavenly bread for one's self from it, but many either fool themselves and others at the same time and / or suffer the results of eating in the graveyard: a spiritual diarrhea and possibly even the curses of the dead upon one's souls.

"Let the dead bury the dead"... ?

Boreas on 2012-01-13 at 06:03 said:

... and as a continuation to the above-mentioned (and my former posts

in this topic), the revival and serious study of ancient esoteric knowledge and esoteric traditions of one's own people, for example – which is very understandable and possibly at the very basis of the yearnings of the neo-pagans also – is a completely different thing.

This is to return to Tradition with a capital T, which is the same thing as to achieve a true palingenesis and a re-connection to the World Tree / Tree of Eternal Life through which veins the golden streams of love and light surge with ever-renewing Vigor, and not just one of its fallen and / or dried branches.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-15 at 08:28 said:

do we really have to lump feminisation together with vegetative?! esotericism is intimately concerned with the divine feminine so it seems counter productive (even counter-initiatory!) to negate 50 percent of God and humankind.

Boreas on 2012-01-15 at 14:11 said:

observer: It seems that I have completely missed your somewhat lengthy, thoughtful and erudite comments about the guidestone issue until I now started to browse through the comments of this particular article.

All I can really say that I can relate to most your thoughts about the issue. Please notice that I took the ten points as themselves, and intentionally passed by the consideration of other issues related to it, which can be true or not. The ten points are somewhat ambivalent towards their interpretation, that's my point; they can be seen as subversive and they can be seen otherwise. They (and Freemasonry, NWO etc.) don't belong to my interests, nor do I find it useful to delve upon the matter anymore, after studying it from every possible angle for years and almost scorching myself totally because of it; this is precisely what the counter-initiation wants, for one

to get involved and TOO interested about the world process and the course of history ('men in time' etc.)! Without a second doubt there are many shady things and plots going on in the world, and you can also take my word that I'm no beginner in this issue, that's for certain.

As for "fighting the NWO" part and becoming it's worker in the process, there's a good article about it in Cakravartin by Victor:

`http://www.cakravartin.com/archives/the-mother-of-all-conspiracies`

Evola himself saw it best to withdraw into seclusion and "not to fight against evil" (Ride the Tiger, the first essay) since the world has gone too far in the Kali-Yuga and the "powers that be" right now are on a short leash despite their apparent force, power and the ability for control. This was my point in that it is best to refrain from "fighting the NWO" (besides the great points made by Victor in the Cakravartin text), since it would be to invite a disaster both to one's self and to the things we (the men and women of Primordial Tradition) hold dear; look up for the article 'A Way Out, Further In' here in Gornahoor. Tradition cannot be erased, since it is beyond time and the course of history, and it will prevail in the end no matter what.

Salve Victoria! Salve Nike! (Just do it?)

`Boreas on 2012-01-15 at 14:50 said:`

A few more thoughts spanned to my mind about the issue. Logres seems to mention Rosenstock-Huessy here and there in his articles, and I became interested that has anyone read his book 'Planetary Service – A Way into the Third Millenium' or something like that? The man himself is a complete stranger to me and after a very short glance into the book at Google books it seems to point to somewhat same direction than the guidestones principles; can't be sure about this, however, since I have not read the book and know nothing about the man. However, he does seem to be valued by esotericists and "traditionalists" also.

As for the issue of "a world state", I think that looking the issue for once "historically", it is unavoidable in some form or another: how could anyone think that in this age of information technology etc., which is itself an "exoteric" sign of occult influence towards 'a unification of humanity' in this or that form, could be avoided? I'm not trying to subvert anything here or impose my own agenda / ideology here, I am simply stating a fact. (Of course the real unification and a healthy 'world state' would be altogether different than the one you have brought out, observer, with your comments about McDonalds, Monsanto, cultural levelling / marxism, "one-world capitalist globalism" etc. I certainly do not stand for any of these.)

As I would like to see it, it would be a world with healthy national cultures and true diversity, ruled by different-sized power blocks working in unison for the same cause, the cause of the 'immortal dreamer' itself, not the current multicultural monolithic-globalist mish-mash of "neutered zombies". Nature we must certainly rever and honour, but you are absolutely right that it should not be placed above the spiritual cause.

Dixi.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-15 at 16:36 said:

well the antitode to the unhealthy zombified state of 'monotone' socieites and so on is retreat to the heart of nature, that's the whole point. Spiritual focus is all very well but if we destroy what we was left in our charge in the process does that not in itself point to the adversary? pure spiritual impulses foster compassion towards all life, the world of creation. We must have our houses in order, both the temples of our souls but also the 'Elysium fields' as they appear here. Do you not think that widespread pollution of water (lakes, rivers, etc), is symptomatic of general soul erosion, forgetfulness, greed, selfishness, etc? lack of mastery at any rate. As it is below so shall it be above. Same goes for animals – we can learn so much from them at a soul/spirit level but they're held in contempt and abused by so many – if we can't take care of innocent creatures how can we be entrusted with human souls and the development of humankind?

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-15 at 16:48 said:

seeing as we have got onto the subject of the 'occult war' (and I DO think it is within topic, though you are free to differ, of course, given that it is to do with counter-initiation as part of this), I am grateful to at least have it acknowledged. I have struggled to get true esoteric adepts to engage with me on how best to tackle the situation, which to me was an imperative duty of the call, part of graduating from school, so to speak. It seems to me that there is an intensified oppression present in certain spheres that is remarkably intense and demands constant vigilance. Of course vigilance is key at any stage, but my concern is also related to recent comments I made to do with harmonics and spiritual protection, such as fortifying the aura, donning the armour of God in full, etc. Particularly if one's guardian angel has been 'released' into full service to the spiritual hierarchy above. Never have we been more in need of Michael. I'm sure most of you would do this naturally anyway, but I think it is worth pointing this out in case anyone is dozing... .thief in the night

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-15 at 16:52 said:

I mean surely, for example, it's time for spiritual hostages to be freed (while of course we individually clear through what purgatory we can)? I think it is time for this to happen, for sleepers to arise, including myself in many aspects! do others not?

logres on 2012-01-15 at 22:20 said:

Women & men approach the same objects very differently. Charlotte, you might check out William Humboldt's letters (in Humanist Without Portfolio) on the spirituality of women – I found them helpful, and they seemed to accord with what I've experienced, in interacting with the fair sex. If I remember correctly, he claims women have a harder time actualizing, but if they

do, they make a more comprehensive approach to spiritual matters. I've been caught up in the NWO order thing too much myself – Boreas' link was very helpful (thanks). But your point about Nature & animals is timely and not really debateable (in my mind), and I certainly don't disagree that some awareness of all these currents is helpful in our growth.

Boreas on 2012-01-16 at 04:33 said:

Charlotte is very correct that our relationship towards earth, nature and animals reflects the state of our souls and our relationship towards the divine feminine itself. Evola and many traditional authors have had quite a dangerous relationship towards 'The Mother'. For example, Evola refused the attempts of healing and miracles from a catholic priest who wished to heal him in the name of the Holy Mother – yet he lived with his mother for a long time. Quite telling, isn't it!? Too much solarity leads easily to scorching (Evola was wounded in the Manipura chakra), which makes Evola very 'combustible', as has been pointed out here. Masculinity and solarity should always be balanced with feminity and the right kind of lunarity – the alchemical conjuction of the Sun and Moon etc.

I think these books and authors can do alot to clear the issue between spirituality, tradition and ecology.

http://www.sophiaperennis.com/category/books/spiritual-ecology/

I have myself read only the 'Looking Back on Progress' by Lord Northbourne, and it was a true eye-opener also towards many other things besides ecological questions, but what I have thus far read from Charles Upton, has also convinced me of his humble sufi wisdom.

The exoteric monotheisms have been very destructive in this regard, as Mr. Upton shows already in the presentation of his book 'Who Is the Earth'. It could also be said that the process from the sphere to the cube in its negative repercussions underlies the weltanshauung of all the totalitarian systems.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-16 at 11:22 said:

Oddly enough (while I realise it's considered a masculine trait) up until a couple of years ago I had an enormous excess of fire, which led to all sorts of difficulties and ultimately a form of burnout, although it also helped to give me the spiritual vision and second sight. Creation of fiery water from this state led to the floodgates being opened

Boreas on 2012-01-16 at 12:11 said:

For the sake of clarity I need to clear one thing from the comment 55, since it could be easily interpreted that I'm lying. That is, how could I know the R-H's book's name if I know absolutely nothing about the man? I glanced quickly through his wikipedia biography once earlier on, when I saw Logres mentioning his name here, and the book name caught my eye then already, and now it came back to my mind when this issue popped out.

To observer I wish to say that hopefully you have not been irritated by my sometimes irritable rhetorics. I live in a mad mansion with small children and occult paint and oil vapors, and I cannot always be held 100 % responsible of what kind of frogs come out from my mouth. I'm glad you questioned me and it's a good thing the issue was dealt with. Blessings of the High One to you.

Boreas on 2012-01-21 at 12:00 said:

Although I said earlier on that the issue and argument is already finished for my part, I wish to get into the 'guidestones' / masonry issue shortly, and this is also a reference – and a deep veneration, for sure – to Guénon and to his life's work. Although I'm generally well aware about the many times subversive and negative role that modern Freemasonry has played in the course of world history, Prompted by this I actually ordered Guénon's book about Freemasonry and related issues to see his thoughts upon the matter. I have not yet read the book but only got a glance to it here and there, and that was certainly enough to realize also the guidestones issue quite throughly: instead of 'the Great Work of Universal Construction' which is the purpose of _ancient and true masonry_, it is the manifestation of the Tower of Babel and "the confusion of tongues" only makes it more blatanly clear. (I don't know if observer is still reading the topic and this forum, but kudos for you.)

12.42 Guenon and Islam

Regarding **Rene Guenon**'s ultimate decision to follow a Sufi path[50], he wrote:

> Contrary to what takes place in 'conversion', nothing here implies the attribution of the superiority of one traditional form over another. It is merely a question of what one might call reasons of spiritual expediency, which is altogether different from simple individual 'preference'.

It may be instructive to explore the reasons behind that "spiritual expediency", which is not the same as psychoanalyzing Guenon from afar. No, it is a question only of intellectual reasons, not personal or psychological.

[50] See Section 13.39 in this book.

For reasons of spiritual expediency, Guenon followed a path beginning with the French Hermetic revival. He came to reject this, but not in toto, since he continued to refer to the writings of certain Hermetists. He then tried to influence Catholic circles. For example, Fundamental Symbols is replete with Christian symbolism. In Crisis of the Modern World, Guenon asserted that only a return to Catholicism could restore Tradition to the West. Eventually, however, Guenon was rejected by the Thomist philosopher **Jacques Maritain**, precipitating Guenon's break with this approach. Personal factors — the death of his wife followed by a trip to Egypt — provided the opportunity to adopt Islam totally. As we will see, certain characteristics of Islam fit perfectly into Guenon's idea of Tradition; we therefore suspect that he may even have generalized Islamic theology to provide his understanding of Tradition. Therefore, there is no surprise that most of his closest followers themselves adopted Islam.

Tradition We owe it to Guenon for delineating the features of religious traditions intellectually. This accounts for the variety of religious forms in a manner totally different from the historical, empirical, archaeological, empirical, and exegetical approaches appropriate to academic research. He identified several specific traditions, specifically, Taoism, Hinduism, certain pagan mystery schools, Medieval Christianity, and Islam.

Nevertheless, some traditions are more comfortable within the parameters specified by Guenon than others. In particular, Christianity, as conventionally understood, rejects certain aspects of it. The most prominent theologians favorable to Guenon — Jean Borella, Philip Sherrard, Seraphim Rose — eventually rejected the Traditional approach. Neopagan revivals, as long as they are bound to certain of Evola's heterodox notions, also reject some primary elements of Tradition, so are doomed to insignificance. Let's look at the lineaments of Tradition as Guenon outlined.

Categorical The fundamental point to grasp is that for Guenon, Tradition is categorical, not essential. That is, it categorizes traditions according to certain criteria, but is not a Tradition itself. Therefore, to call oneself a Traditionalist, "at-large" as it were[51], represents a misunderstanding. Rather, one must follow a specific tradition, albeit understood within these categories. Under normal circumstances, that means a man follows the Tradition of his own place and time. Whether or not a specific religious form is a Tradition is a question decided by these categories.

- **Authentic**

  A religious form is an authentic tradition if it is "orthodox" in Guenon's sense. I.e., is it doctrinally consistent with the ultimate metaphysical principles?

- **Complete**

  Does it have a complete understanding, or are some things lacking? This lack does not necessarily make it heterodox.

- **Living**

  Since principles cannot be fully understood merely from reading and studying, continuously existing initiatory organizations are required to pass on that knowledge. A living tradition will have such groups; a religious form may have lost them, remaining just a shell of what it once was.

Note that the Evolian categories have absolutely no relevance. Hence, his several attempts to label traditions as solar vs lunar, Nordic vs Mediterranean, Aryan vs Semitic, etc., add nothing to our understanding. They are not based on any metaphysical principles but derive from profane sources, primarily Bachofen and Weininger.

[51] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=728`

Esoteric vs Exoteric Traditional doctrines have two complementary aspects. Guenon writes (incidentally illustrating our point):

> Of all traditional doctrines, perhaps Islamic doctrine most clearly distinguishes the two complementary parts, which can be labeled exoterism (*sharia*) and esoterism (*haqiqa*).

He defines them this way:

- The exoteric aspect is the "great way", common to all.
- The esoteric is the inward truth, reserved to an elite. This is from the very nature of things, since not all men possess the qualifications required to reach knowledge of the truth.

The exoteric part is a rule of action (laws, rites, etc.) and the esoteric represents pure knowledge. The esoteric must also include a way, or path, to achieve that knowledge. There must be no conflict between the exoteric and the esoteric; they look at the same thing from a different perspective. (The exoteric from the circumference, the esoteric from the center).

Unfortunately, what often happens is that the vulgar misinterpret the verbal formulations of the esoteric as a new doctrine, opposed to the exoteric. This causes strife and results in religious forms detached from any tradition; New Age movements are obvious examples.

Multiplicity of Forms This is a fundamental doctrine of Islam, which teaches that there have been several revelations made to mankind at various times. The Koran names 25 prophets (including Jesus), and admits many more. Hence the existence of multiple religious forms poses no threat to exoteric dogma. Exoteric Christianity regards those religious forms as false and Jesus as unique. Although we have provided several examples of a broader outlook, this is a hurdle many will find difficult to overcome.

Primordial Tradition Guenon claims that there was a Primordial Tradition, and subsequent religious forms derive from it. Guenon uses the doctrines of the Vedanta as the prime examples for Tradition; this is consistent with the belief of some Traditionalists that the Vedanta was the original revelation made to Adam. The idea of a Primordial Tradition is consistent with Islamic dogma.

Exoteric Christianity believes in a series of covenants made between God and Adam, Abraham, Moses, etc., but specifically excludes all peoples outside them. Furthermore, outside from a few writers, salvation is not the attempt to return to the Primordial state of Adam.

Ahistorical Tradition is ahistorical, that is, it depends on a revelation from above, not on any specifically historical factors. Once again, this is consistent with Islam, but not exoteric Christianity, which sees tradition as the outcome of specific historical events.

Final Revelation Islam claims to be the final revelation made to man, an idea also asserted by Guenon, although he would add "in this cycle". This doctrine is difficult to justify solely from metaphysical principles, so we can explore the reasons. Guenon's justification is that it is the only tradition to arise within history rather than prehistory. Another factor is that previous revelations were given to specific peoples at specific times for their own benefit. Islam, on the other hand, claims to be universal, the final revelation for which every prior one was a preparation. This universality is affirmed by Guenon:

> If there is a tradition where questions of race and origin do not in any way arise, it is certainly Islam, which in fact counts among its adherents men belonging to the most diverse races.

Posted on 2012-06-24 by Cologero

* * *

Michael on 2012-06-24 at 16:20 said:

Interesting post, but I (gently) disagree with some of its points. First, with regards to being ahistorical, it is true that Christianity (and Judaism) look back to specific historical events, but then so does Islam. It completely relies on the historic Mohammed as much of the teaching in Islam comes from the Hadith.

Catholicism sees the covenants as growing in inclusiveness. The covenants of Noah, Abraham, Moses, and David correspond to a covenant with a family, tribe, nation, and kingdom. The final covenant with Christ is a universal covenant that encompasses all people. Of course, people are free to reject the offer.

I can understand how Guenon was attracted to Sufism, but I have to agree with Tomberg that he was impoverished by his decision to reject Christianity.

satishapte05tish on 2014-03-26 at 06:36 said:

Can you give reference of Rene's assement of Islam as Final revelation ?

August on 2014-03-29 at 05:46 said:

@ satishapte05tish

'Studies in Hinduism'. Sophia Perennis,

Extract from Chapter 11 – Sanatana Dharma:

"It is also interesting to note that the Hindu and the Islamic traditions explicitly affirm the validity of all the other orthodox traditions, and if this is so it is because as the temporally first and the last in the course of the Manvantara they must to the same extent integrate – although in different modes – all the diverse forms that have arisen in the interval, so as to render possible the 'return to origins' by which the end of the cycle will rejoin its beginning, whence, at the starting-point of another Manvantara, the true Sanatana Dharma will again be outwardly manifest."

Michel on 2014-03-30 at 14:02 said:

Just to add a source that further shows Guenon's position on Islam being the final revelation, see here:

http://www.studiesincomparativereligion.com/uploads/ArticlePDFs/353.pdf

The article is a short excursion on the symbolism of the letter Nun. The letter resembles the lower half of a circle with a dot at it's center. It represents, in regard to macro-cosmic cyclic manifestation, the complementary Tradition that completes the Heritage of an entire Humanity; the first being the Primordial Tradition, symbolized by the rainbow, which resembles the upper

half of a circle. The letter symbolizes the Tradition that is to act as the ark which would ferry one Humanity's cycle to another, after all the former's possibilities have been exhausted.

Combining the two halves of the circle, the former preceding the latter, the symbol of a full circle is formed, with a dot at its center. Islam(Ark), being the Seal of Prophecy represents the ultimate form of orthodoxy for this present cycle, just as the Hindu Tradition represents the most direct heritage of the Primordial Tradition (Rainbow).

12.43 The Exoteric Path

> If our contemporaries as a whole could see what it is that is guiding them and where they are really going, the modern world would at once cease to exist as such, for the rectification could not fail to come about through that very circumstance.
>
> RENE GUENON

> A day will come, one day in the unending succession of days, when beings, beings who are now latent in our thoughts and hidden in our loins, shall stand upon this earth as one stands upon a footstool, and shall laugh and reach out their hands amidst the stars.
>
> H G WELLS

Rene Guenon appeared in the world process at the time of the spiritual emptiness of the West. With all of history and geography pretty much known, it had become impossible to ignore the vast differences in spiritual experiences in the world. Guenon was able to sort them out and to reveal their deep similarity in terms of social organization, inner experience, and metaphysical principles. Yet his voluminous works are just a beginning. The logical consequences of his writings still need to be explicated. He himself suggested several areas for further research in those writings.

Although we don't always make them explicit, we conform to the core of Guenon's principles. That is not a slavish following, a "Guenonian scholasticism" as Evola called it. Evola himself, although calling Guenon the Master of the Twentieth Century, challenged Guenon on certain points. Sometimes he was mistaken but on other times he made key contributions. Furthermore, we need to distinguish between metaphysical principles which are apodictic and personal judgments which are at best informed opinions.

Guiding Principles

> If worship of providence were forbidden, the natural consequence would be their fall, for a nation of fatalists or casualists or atheists never existed in the world, and we saw that all the nations of the world believe in a provident divinity, and have embraced only four principle religions: paganism, Judaism, Christianity, Islam.
>
> Giambattista Vico

We are not out to "prove" any Guenonian principles; for that, his own works need to be consulted. Rather, we accept them, even if provisionally, and draw out their consequences as if they are true.

First of all, the modern world is an anomaly in the world, as no civilization has ever been based on its principles, or, better said, anti-principles. Instead, they have all been based on what he calls Tradition, whose basic principles have been described throughout Gornahoor. Tradition means "handed down", not a nostalgic return to some idealized past. Hence, it is not necessarily Luddite, as the example of the City of the Sun[52] shows.

Traditional societies are hierarchical with specific functional areas and daily life was centered around the rites and rituals of an exoteric religious tradition. Beyond that, there is an esoteric tradition related to, but

[52] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=518

different from, the exoteric tradition. The esoteric tradition comprises various practices and metaphysical teachings that lead to higher states of being.

Exoteric and Esoteric The relationship between the exoteric and the esoteric is expressed in this principle: every exoteric religious or theological statement is equivalent to an esoteric metaphysical statement. That is why we don't get involved in theological disputes since they can't be resolved at that level without appealing to faith or authority. Esoterism, on the other hand, results in gnosis, or certain knowledge. In other words, what the believer believes, the knower knows.

For example, the religious idea of monotheism is the metaphysical idea of the Absolute, i.e., there is one foundational principle of the world. Polytheism, hence, means competing principles with no underlying unity. Atheism is the denial of an underlying principle so everything that happens is the result of determinism or chance events. As Vico pointed out, no society based on atheism, fatalism, or chance events could survive for long. The modern mind considers atheism as simply another defensible opinion, but for the traditional mind the atheist is an enemy of the people and a danger to the state. He would have no more right to free speech than a quack physician who prescribes harmful and ineffective treatments.

Guenon's next point is that the esoteric component has been lost in the West. We accept that, but not absolutely since it is an opinion not a metaphysical truth. Nevertheless, it is pointless to criticize bishops, popes, and so on, for that reason. The task, for us, is to delineate the features of a Western esoteric Tradition to prepare the way for its return.

A further point is that the esoteric should not be seen in opposition to the exoteric. Rather, those capable of and interested in pursuing and esoteric path should do it in the context of an exoteric path. These would be, at the risk of over-simplification, one of the many paganisms or one

of the Abrahamic religions as Vico noted. The normal choice, however, is to choose the exoteric religion of one's land. Hence, Guenon did not fully embrace Islam as a lifestyle until he migrated to Egypt.

The notion of picking and choosing and shopping around for one's religion is absurd from the Traditional point of view. Religious pluralism is a liberal and modern idea. The opposite Traditional view is called "Integralism", i.e., the nation as an organic unity. Evola's solution of avoiding any commitment to a Tradition was an unfortunate choice and serves as a bad example.

A writer can praise the virtues of loyalty and fidelity in the abstract, but they must be tested in practice. Hence, a commitment to an exoteric religion can be a serious challenge to one's loyalty and fidelity. However, we accept all its dogmas and rites as an act of will. (Faith is an act of intellect commanded by the will.) The point is that we are not out to reform the exoteric religion but rather to bring to light the latent esoterism in it.

We often hear the complaint that the exoteric teachings are not good enough or that there is not esoteric teaching, and on and on. That, for us, is simply too passive; if you are not finding anything better, then you probably don't deserve anything better. A more active approach is to stifle the complaining while mining the hidden gold nuggets of esoterism.

As a reminder, anyone who is thriving under the exoteric religion does not need anything here. Esoterism is purely optional and is intended for those to whom the exoteric religion, as conventionally expressed, lacks all power and meaning.

Paganism As we have seen, pagans considered that there was a semi-divine founder of their tradition who established the spiritual, religious, and political practices that dominated their everyday life. By maintaining the worship of the ancestors, and appeasing or propitiating the gods, providence would continue to guide the people. Hence, we see that the Indo-Aryan Brahmans could trace their lineage back to 21 rishis, each

Greek city had its own divine founder, and Rome was founded by a few noble families.

Hence, any attempts to revive Western paganism are counter-traditional, unless a demigod arrives to start a new family. It is not possible to just jump into an existing stream. The other issue is that in a pagan society, the bulk of the population would be serfs, slaves, or shudras. No revivalist cares to mention that.

Posted on 2015-02-04 by Cologero

* * *

Lu Dongbin on 2015-02-05 at 09:03 said:

How does traditional China, particularly the Tang Dynasty, stand in relation to your notion that "picking and choosing" ones religion is a modern and liberal idea? During the Tang people were free to choose from a variety of religions which coexisted with each other such as Daoism, Buddhism, Nestorian Christianity, Manichaeism, and Islam (Confucianism too if you consider it a religious tradition prior to the metaphysical reform of so-called neo-Confucianism.)

While some of these died out, many continued to be present on Chinese soil and choices available until the Red takeover.

Cologero on 2015-02-05 at 09:17 said:

First of all, Lu Dongbin, we are focusing on the West and the recovery of Tradition therein. I am not familiar enough with Chinese spirituality, but I believe that it, too, at least on one point was founded on ancestor worship.

Second of all, pluralism exists in an Empire; we specifically referred to the "nation". For example, the Roman Empire comprised many nations and religious forms, but the Evola essays we recently translated referred to the earliest periods of Rome.

According to Guenon, Confucianism was the exoteric form and Daoism the esoteric form of the Chinese religion. Buddhism is a special case, since it was at its inception primarily a metaphysic and a path of self-development. As such, it could be absorbed into other traditions, as happened in China and Japan. In India, its metaphysical teaching become incorporated into Advaita Vedanta so it barely survives as a separate religion.

Christianity and Islam were brought in by foreigners and have not historically defined the Chinese consciousness. (Maybe that will change in the future?) There will always be pockets of dissent even in an integral society.

Lu Dongbin on 2015-02-05 at 10:10 said:

I am not Chinese myself but rather a Westerner interested in Chinese traditions. I realize your focus is on the West and the recovery of Tradition (Christianity) here, but how should one view the new traditions that have planted their feet in the West in recent years such as Buddhism, etc. In the scenario Gornahoor's project were to succeed, would these new traditions have to uprooted, would they simply disappear, or would a situation akin to the Tang Dynasty I mentioned earlier have to be the way to approach it?

Also, just a few notes, while it is the case that China was an empire, it was a bit different in this case than Rome was due to the overwhelming dominance of the Han ethnic group, whereas of course in Rome you had Latins, Britons, Greeks, Syrians, Egyptians, etc. in reasonable numbers. In this sense the empire was nearly equivalent to a nation despite including other minority ethnic groups.

Secondly, the Buddhism that arrived in China wasn't the pure metaphysic of earliest Buddhism but rather the religious tradition of Mahayana, complete with its own pantheon, cosmology, eschatology, etc. I am not sure if we can say it was absorbed in a manner similar to Advaita because while it left a massive influence on Daoism (which in turn influenced it and helped create Ch'an/Zen), it also competed with the other traditions at various points in history and remains a separate tradition. Many Chinese tended to approach Daoism, Confucianism, and Buddhism as a harmonious unity, the so-called idea of "san jiao he yi" and would often learn from all three.

An interesting discussion about the Chinese traditions in relation to Guenonian Traditionalism can be found here, particularly the exchanges between a user named "Justice&Mercy" and Charles Upton:

http://www.sophiaperennis.com/discussion-forums/neglected-traditions/what-about-neglected-traditions/

Cologero on 2015-02-05 at 11:52 said:

In a spiritual void, who can say what will prevail? I've referenced Guenon's take[53] on it several times. For example, Michel Houellebecq's new novel (in French, but English translation expected in the fall) shows how the Islamization of France may occur. He refers to Guenon in that book, by the way, so Guenon will be going mainstream in intellectual circles. Be prepared.

I accept Evola's list of Western traditions: Brahmanic India, pagan Rome/Greece, and Medieval Europe. Those can be reincorporated into a larger whole, perhaps along the lines laid out in Guido De Giorgio's "Vedantized Christianity". I'll hold off on that discussion until the second part.

[53] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=35

Buddhism has become quite decadent in the West. Many people I know call themselves "Buddhists" because it sounds cooler than atheist, but they hardly believe that all life is suffering. Nor do they accept the sexual restraints that are part of their vows of initiation. The Dalai Lama has turned out to be a rather weak fellow, capitulating to Western values at every opportunity.

What is happening in the USA is a New Age amalgam based around the Course in Miracles, the Power of Now, and the Law of Attraction. Speaking of Upton, he wrote a long book (The System of the Antichrist) on several New Age movements from a Traditional perspective. He gave them more attention than they deserved and actually made them some appealing and even traditional in several aspects. Since I've been looking at that book lately, I checked Amazon. Miracles is #5 on Amazon's "Christian Living" category.

I don't accept Justice&Mercy's approach. Just because something happened in the past does not make it "Traditional". We are interested in the metaphysical not the historical; the latter is used to illustrate the former. And we can hardly be concerned about the religious practices of Tom, Dick, and Harry, but the focus should instead be on the highest exponents of a given tradition.

Furthermore, his partisanship is not really helpful. He mentions Guenon's Great Triad book with high praise. But Guenon's point is that the teaching found in Daoism is also found in other traditions.

Lu Dongbin on 2015-02-05 at 15:26 said:

Well I certainly agree with your comments on Western Buddhism–it is largely, though not entirely, a joke full of materialists, atheists, those who conflate modern politically correct leftism with "the dharma", and those who try to psychologize Buddhism (especially Zen) as a means to cope with daily problems or find peace within daily life (not bad aims, but not enough) rather than awaken to the Absolute and intuitively uncover the answer to that grand question, "Who am I?" Then again, not many modern Christians follow the ethical standards of the ancients or are searching for a means to begin the process of theosis either.

I should point out that I also don't entirely agree with that fellow "Justice&Mercy" mentioned, but I think he may have been on to something in that the Traditionalism of Guenon and others is primarily from the viewpoint of Hinduism, Christianity, and Islam. It seems many of the categories or ideas Guenon and others held cannot be consistently applied within the Chinese sphere with their multiplicity of traditions, syncretism, etc. (not limited to Tom, Dick, and Harry from my studies) but who nonetheless produced many sages over the centuries and maintained highly metaphysical aspects of their culture until relatively recently.

On a personal level, I was born without a tradition and raised in a secular household and have been searching for where to focus my efforts these past 5 years or more. While I continue to appreciate Guenon, Evola, and the Traditionalists and agree with most of their views, in finding which tradition to devote my life to I don't start from the perennialist point of view and work

back but rather try to understand the particularities of each tradition and discern which are true and possess the most efficacy/potency to lead me to gnosis and salvation. This may have put me in the "pick and choose" category until just recently, but the unique conditions of my time, nation, and birth forced me into such a category.

ja on 2015-02-05 at 12:23 said:

Couldn't Aleister Crowley be seen as a reviver of the pagan stream, through his contacts with Aiwass the god of ancient Sumeria ? Playing devil's advocate here….

Cologero on 2015-02-05 at 22:23 said:

Sure, Ja, and I know Thelema has many followers today. And there are other dictated teachings such as the Seth books or Alice Bailey. The difference, I think, is that some spirit has revealed something. But I don't believe that any one of them is a spiritual ancestor in any sense, neither by birth nor adoption.

SydneyTrads on 2015-02-07 at 22:38 said:

We would be grateful if a pinpoint reference could be provided for Giambattista Vico's indented quotation.

Cologero on 2015-02-07 at 23:28 said:

The quote is from Vico's New Science, paragraph [602].

> If worship of providence were forbidden, the natural consequence would be their fall, for a nation of fatalists or casualists or atheists never existed in the world, and we saw that all the nations of the world believe in a provident divinity, and have embraced only four principle religions: paganism, Judaism, Christianity, Islam.

KSS on 2015-02-10 at 12:23 said:

"The normal choice, however, is to choose the exoteric religion of one's land."

What if the exoteric religion of one's land is cultural marxism? What if the values of your country's "christian church" are identical with those of the new left radicals?

Cologero on 2015-02-10 at 13:02 said:

Please read the follow up post to this one, which goes into more detail.

First of all, "cultural marxism" is not a valid tradition.

Then, as Guenon explains, "its present representatives seem to be unaware". The Tradition is one thing, its management is something else. We are interested in preserving the former, not necessarily the latter.

Also Guenon explicitly writes: "In this case it would be better, although not absolutely necessary …", so if you have a better choice, then go for it.

The bottom line, KSS, is that if you see yourself — much like a typical citizen of the model world — as a passive consumer waiting for George to create a suitable Tradition ready-made for you, you will wait in vain. What is necessary are active and creative agents.

Cologero on 2015-02-16 at 09:43 said:

Let me tell you some personal stories, Nyklot.

Yesterday, I was walking along the beach, checking out the girls every now and then, when I was drawn to the ocean. So I sat down and did a meditation. I was struck by its size and power and looked out onto the horizon. I wondered about the character of the first men who determined to sail out onto that horizon. I tried to feel the spirit of the ocean, since everything is alive. Eventually, in the depths, I experienced the presence of Poseidon and considered what had been lost or gained. But Poseidon was himself subject to destiny. Deeper still, I felt the living presence of the God. So nothing was lost, but the overcoming of destiny was gained. Unfortunately, in our time "God" is out there, not as a living presence, so the ocean is just the movement of matter.

A second story involves a trip I took with my son several years ago to Sicily to explore our roots. My family had lived in Salemi for 5 or 6 hundred years since the arrival of the first Salvo from Tuscany. Now Salemi was the site of an old castle used by the Normans when they re-established the Holy Roman Empire from Sicily. High on a hill, one could see everything for several kilometers. Not quite sure what I was looking for, I checked the walls, both inside and out, looking for Runic inscriptions. There were none … that time had long past, even one thousand years ago.

There was a much larger castle in Palermo, where the situation was clarified. The castle had a beautiful chapel, the Palatine Chapel. I was awestruck, as I mentally put myself as one of the knights in the presence of that chapel. That was what was flowing in their blood, not some lifeless paganism.

So, Nyklot, you can dismiss a thousand years of your ancestors as somehow being ignorant, or deluded, or whatever unspoken insult you want to hurl on them. But if you truly want to honour them, you should honour their choice. At one time there was a Europe that was spiritually united, while respecting the multiple nationalities.

Furthermore, Nyklot, you may want to consider why, or by whom, medieval Christianity has been under siege for centuries. In that so-called clash of civilizations (which is ongoing), where do you take your stand? An effete and deracinated paganism, suitable only for fanboys, is no threat to anyone. There are no "cartoons" satirizing pagans.

You still don't get it. The goal is not an artificial creation to fill up the void left by the "nihilism" of modern society. Weightlifting won't do it, or else football teams would be centers of enlightenment. Moreover, you are still thinking in categories that we ourselves have rejected, so an "honest" conversation with you is still not possible.

It is not for nothing that Evola titled one of his books: "The Myth of Blood".

Lionel on 2017-12-07 at 12:57 said:

Putting together a few threads here.

My brother, Bhante Jason, is an Early Buddhist monk. He eats once a day, is homeless, spends Rains in a cave, owns only his bowl and robes, walks around everywhere barefoot, etc. He ordained in a highly respected Sri Lankan monastery, saw the failings there first hand, and walked off, finding a way back to Australia to instantiate the old way is not just possible without cultural support, but spiritually, mentally and physically superior. He never heard of Evola before my introduction.

Original Buddhism is non Traditional as Guenon identified, because Buddha denied the need for succession and lineage (apart from the suttas themselves) and stated clearly that there are no secret teachings. But it is also very supportive of Tradition in that he encouraged Brahmins to continue being Brahmins, showing a way his crystalised ascesis could make one the best Brahmin possible in this cycle. He also spoke of how vital it is to respect ones own ancestors, and only go out to the Homeless life with the blessing of ones parents and family.

A difficult road that not many can walk, Early Buddhism is the Anarch that redeems the necessary castes by transcending them. What he has taught me thus turned this family man into quite the devout, soon to be Baptised Anglican.

Cologero on 2022-02-06 at 19:27 said:

Lionel, Ananda Coomaraswamy seems to think otherwise, in Hinduism and Buddhism[54] where he writes:

> The more superficially one studies Buddhism, the more it seems to differ from the Brahmanism in which it originated; the more profound our study, the more difficult it becomes to distinguish Buddhism from Brahmanism, or to say in what respects, if any, Buddhism is really unorthodox.

Lionel Chan on 2022-02-06 at 20:06 said:

Peace Sir,

[54] https://www.gornahoor.net/library/hinduism_buddhism.pdf

Thank you for your engagement. Much has changed in my brother's life and my own since 2017, let alone the state of the world… the reminder of the strange twists in the path is very welcome.

I don't see My Coomaswarmy's comment as antithetical to what I wrote about what WAS my brother's Dao at that time, and still may be in some form. In times of degeneration, a kind of "Protestant" and Fundamentalist" call can be very Traditional indeed. And as Mr Guenon emphasises, certainly it is rarer for the "spiritual genius" to reach Deliverance with no initiation within an orthodoxy (a Left Hand way perhaps), but it is not excluded from possibility.

Salaam.

12.44 Sense and Nonsense

> We are men of the middle ages, not only because that is our destiny, the fatality of history, but also because we will it. You, you are still men of modern times, because you refuse to choose.
>
> Nicolas Berdyaev

> The power of a new Middle Ages is needed.
>
> Julius Evola, *Pagan Imperialism*

> Samsara is Nirvana
>
> Nagarjuna

> The sensible is the symbol of the divine
>
> St Bonaventure

The attack against the power of a new Middle Ages is constant, sometimes even coming from unexpected sources. Recently a bizarre argument has been circulating around the Internet. It claims that the starting point for the metaphysics of Thomas Aquinas, to wit, that knowledge begins

with the senses, "leads to" the modern world. When pressed about the meaning of "leads to", the author has no answer. Either there is a logical or empirical necessity coercing the conclusion from the premises, or there is not.

By that logic, for example, Euclidean geometry "leads to" Riemannian geometry. But the latter actually denies one of Euclid's postulates, so there is no logical relationship. Similarly, if the road "leads to" Rome, it also leads to the pit when you walk off the edge. That then turns out to be the crux of the argument: the fellow does not want to follow the road to Rome. Hence, he presents this elaborate and prolix ruse to justify his own apostasy. Never mind that the Nordic-Roman Medieval Tradition encompasses much more than Thomas Aquinas. Even if he succeeds in pulling out that brick, like some giant Jenga game, the structure remains intact.

Being and Becoming In the very first paragraph of the first chapter of *Revolt against the Modern World*, **Julius Evola** writes:

> In order to understand both the spirit of Tradition and its antithesis, modern civilization, it is necessary to begin with the fundamental doctrine of the two natures. According to this doctrine there is a physical order of things and a metaphysical one; there is a mortal nature and an immortal one; there is the superior realm of "being" and the inferior realm of "becoming." Generally speaking, there is a visible and tangible dimension and, prior to and beyond it, an invisible and intangible dimension that is the support, the source, and true life of the former.

The alleged argument asserts Aquinas, by beginning with the senses, creates somehow a "two story" philosophy. From that, the modern world can dispense with the second story of Being, focusing solely on the lower story of Becoming.

Obviously, that can happen only through the forgetfulness of Being. The modern mind forgets about being, mistaking the changing world of appearances for Being itself. Opposed to that, Thomism tries to "lead to" the awakening of Being by beginning with sense experience. Once understood, the world of becoming is intuited as a theophany of the world of Being. If not understood, then the worldview of naturalism arises, which is just the denial of the world of Being. **Julius Evola**, in *Pagan Imperialism* identifies this ignorance:

> Far from exhausting itself in naturalism—as today only the ignorance or the tendentious falsification of some people are able to present it—beyond knowing the ideals of manly overcoming and of absolute liberation, in the pagan conception, the world was a living body, suffused with secret, divine, and demonic forces, with meanings and with symbols, as illustrated by that saying of **Olympiodorus**: "the sensible expression of the invisible".

Olympiodorus was the last of the pagan philosophers at Alexandria, but his statement applies likewise to the Christian philosophers who followed him. The modern mind displays "ignorance" of knowledge, but the "tendentious falsification" of the author's screed is much more sinister.

Johann Fichte understood this when he wrote about the "Divine Idea of the World [that] lies at the bottom of Appearance" and "Sensuous appearance is the vesture, the embodiment of the Divine Idea." Goethe calls this the "Open Secret", because it is open to all, yet seen by none. You need to choose whether or not to see this.

Hierarchy and Docetism

> The authors of the Middle Ages could not imagine … the Universal Church without a pope. Because if the world is governed hierarchically, Christianity or the *Sanctum Imperium* cannot be otherwise. Hierarchy is a pyramid which exists only when it is complete.

Valentin Tomberg, *Meditations on the Tarot*

The opposite of Naturalism is Docetism. The former denies the world of Being, while the latter denies the world of Becoming. Docetism wants to inhabit some abstract spiritual reality, while denying its sensible expression in the physical world. Since the spiritual world is a Cosmic Hierarchy[55], it has a peak. Hence, to avoid Docetism, the world of Becoming, which is the symbol of the Divine, needs a peak. Hence, the denial of Thomism leads the author of that screed to the denial of the Pope. As we said, he is an apostate seeking, apparently, justification.

The vestiges of liberalism remain even in those who decry it the most. The following claim occurs so often these, it could be mistaken for a straw man. But it goes something like this: "I have done a deep study of the Church Fathers and reached the conclusion that the Orthodox Church is most faithful to them." What could better exemplify the Protestant spirit? Or John Stuart Mill's "marketplace of ideas", in which one evaluates competing worldviews and chooses one "based on the evidence".

But that is to remain at a lower level of knowledge. Doxa, or opinion, is our knowledge of sense phenomena. Dianoia is rational discursive knowledge; that is, the "weighing of evidence", disputation, and so on. But the highest level of knowledge is episteme, that is, the direct, unmediated intuition of Being. That is what the Fathers teach.

So when we arrive at that level of knowledge, we "see" the truth of the cosmic order. Our "choice" in that case is to submit to it. Tomberg explains:

> The vow of obedience is the practice of silencing personal desires, emotions and imagination in the face of reason and conscience; it is the primacy of the ideal [Being] as opposed to the apparent [Becoming], the nation as opposed to the personal, humanity as

[55] https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-cosmic-hierarchy

> opposed to the nation, and God as opposed to humanity. It is the life of cosmic and human hierarchical ordering; it is the meaning and justification of the fact that there are Seraphim, Cherubim, Thrones; Dominions, Virtues, Powers; Principalities, Archangels, Angels; Priests, Knights and Commoners. Obedience is order: it is international law; it is the state; it is the Church; it is universal peace. True obedience is the very opposite of tyranny and slavery, since its root is the love which issues from faith and confidence. That which is above serves that which is below and that which is below obeys that which is above. Obedience is the practical conclusion to that which one recognises as the existence of something higher than oneself. Whosoever recognises God, obeys.

Tomberg is describing the virtue of Piety — one of the Roman virtues as well as a gift of the Holy Spirit. Piety means the submission to whatever is higher, relinquishing the merely personal element. This sort of obedience is based not on ignorance, but on knowledge of Being; it is not coerced by an outside force, but is freely embraced.

This is the foundation of a Traditional society. How could such a society function if everyone starts "examining the evidence" and coming to different conclusions? You could not rely on or trust anyone. It is the replacement of the knowledge of the Sacred with arbitrary personal opinion.

Posted on 2016-12-14 by Cologero

* * *

O on 2016-12-15 at 11:20 said:

But as you have pointed out elsewhere, the 'order' in the West today is not a sacred Catholic order, but rather one dominated by the forces of 'the Antichrist'; and the worst is yet to come, according to a detached analysis of global trends as well as the 'forecasts' of traditional prophetic data dealing with the end-times.

Especially in the case of a westerner born outside a Catholic framework, whose most recent ancestors were Protestants, for example, I cannot see why choosing the Eastern Orthodox tradition based on such an evaluation is somehow undesirable. It is inevitable for many westerners today to have to choose between traditions. The 'episteme', direct knowledge that you mention has, at least in the case of most people, as its prerequisite condition that one already practices a traditional path aimed at such knowledge. Orthodox Hesychasm is a very clear example.

Paul on 2016-12-15 at 12:18 said:

O — To the extent that bleak forecasts come true, they may separate out the faithful from the insincere. There is a definite rise, especially among the younger generation, of interest in and attendance at the Tridentine Latin Rite mass, as well as a return to the pre-Vatican II Catholic tradition in general. The current Pope's pointed question to the young regarding this trend, "Why so rigid?" is being challenged by a movement which has been building steadily, including a current increase in priestly ordinations for celebrating the traditional rite. Some time ago, Pope Benedict predicted that the church would continue to empty, but that would not necessarily be a bad thing, since the true remnants would hold fast to preserve it for the future, as has happened in the past. Indeed, in another development, there has been increased discussion about Rod Dreher's "Benedict Option," this in reference rather to Saint Benedict and his efforts to re-establish a spiritual base of human life in the aftermath of the collapsing Roman Empire. His monastic communities became the remnants that held fast for centuries. Today this has inspired Dreher who has been on the road touting ideas for similar community formations…

Eric on 2016-12-17 at 08:37 said:

The local Roman Catholic mass: guitars, Protestant "worship" songs, priest facing the people, modernist architecture, "altar girls", communion in the hand, "social justice" homilies, etc.

The local Eastern Orthodox Divine Liturgy: male choir singing ancient chant, priest facing the altar, Romanesque architecture and traditional iconography, reverence for the chalice, homilies focused on repentance, etc.

Where would you take your children?

Cologero on 2016-12-17 at 09:32 said:

I understand, Eric. In a state of emergency, a man needs to make the best choice for his family. My only recommendation (and plea): accept it as a disorder and cool it with the harsh polemics.

Bill on 2016-12-17 at 13:11 said:

Eric, if I were a father, I would talk my children to the Catholic Traditional Latin high Mass, preferably one with a professional choir singing in Latin in the organ loft. The Novus Ordo Missae,

i.e., the New Order of Mass, is an ecumenical rite designed to please Protestants. If you read Pope St. Pius V's Quo primum tempore, you'll know that the Traditional Latin Mass rite is the only one that priests in the Roman part of the Catholic Church should use except for some liturgical rites that were already at least 200 years old when he published that document.

`http://www.catholictradition.org/Encyclicals/primum.htm`

Here's the Ottaviani Intervention that Cardinals Ottaviani and Bacci signed soon after Vatican II. For me, it carries plenty of weight because Ottaviani headed the Holy Office, now called the Sacred Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, during that council. Feel free to read only the summary if you want to do that. Even that little part of it may help explain why I attend only the Traditional Latin Mass. In my opinion, it's time for the Catholic Church to abolish the Novus Ordo partly because it should never have been invented.

`http://www.ewtn.com/library/curia/reformof.htm`

`Eric on 2016-12-18 at 12:19 said:`

Colegero-

My friend (and teacher), where did you see any "harsh polemics" in my post? I'm as sick over the state of the Roman Church as anyone…and to be honest I would rather be RC. I was raised Southern Baptist but I came to Christ primarily through Roman Catholic thinkers (GKC, Nicolas Goméz Dávila at the top of the list), and I am absolutely in love with the Catholic Middle Ages. All I'm doing is reporting the "facts on the ground" in my small city in West Texas.

`Cologero on 2016-12-18 at 12:59 said:`

Eric, if something does not make sense, try to re-read it in a different context. The particular post concerned a fellow who did resort to unnecessary polemics. So, it was more a recommendation in general and certainly not specifically to you. I understand the "facts on the ground". Don't be sick about anything; that is neither necessary nor helpful.

`S. Wes on 2017-03-12 at 09:41 said:`

I've been frequenting this site for years, and was taken back by this post. It seems to be the most emotional offering by Cologero. I wish I knew the author he is speaking about, perhaps that would help me clarify what he's trying to say. I thought it might be Jay Dyer, who studied Thomism for years and has spent time recently refuting it.

I'm not sure if Cologero is defending Thomas Aquinas or the legitimacy of the papacy in this post. I can only assume he is defending Aquinas. His Evola references (who rejected the RCC), and some of his previous efforts (which I can't imagine and RCC hierarchy in history approving of) along with his attacks on exoteric constructs in general, would point to this post being a defense of Aquinas. But then he concludes about a submission to a higher authority, which again seems to suggest papal authority. Which would almost undermine all of his writings on this site,

as I'm sure they were not submitted to the RCC hierarchy or their official publications. I'm just not sure what exactly he's trying to say here. Hopefully he writes more on this subject, I in no way am being critical of Cologero, I deeply respect him and his thoughts.

Cologero on 2017-03-18 at 16:40 said:

@Wes, the opening statement is "The attack against the power of a new Middle Ages is constant, sometimes even coming from unexpected sources."

So what do you suppose is being "defended"? Then there is this:

> The vow of obedience is the practice of silencing personal desires, emotions and imagination in the face of reason and conscience; it is the primacy of the ideal [Being] as opposed to the apparent [Becoming], the nation as opposed to the personal, humanity as opposed to the nation, and God as opposed to humanity. It is the life of cosmic and human hierarchical ordering

Does that not answer the question about the "higher authority" that "personal desires, emotions, and imagination" are to be submitted to?

13

Discerning the Own Tradition

13.1 Nietzsche and life-affirming religion

Nietzsche has done as much as anyone in undermining the Traditional spiritual roots of Western man in his division of religion into life-denying as exemplified in Christianity and life-affirming as exemplified in Paganism. The destruction of Christianity has not led to a life-affirming paganism, but rather to a paganism that limits itself to the satisfaction of biological needs. As was shown in a previous post[1], there was much less difference between the Christian and the Pagan elites (whatever the masses may have believed). The dichotomy proposed by Nietzsche is useless; the spirituality of the elite has always been life-transcending.

It is likely that Nietzsche borrowed this concept from his "educator" Arthur Schopenhauer. Schopenhauer took the opposite position from Nietzsche; within the context of his philosophical pessimism, Schopenhauer praised the life-denying religions at the expense of the life-affirming. Among the former, he included the religion of the Upanishads, Bud-

[1] http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=241

dhism, and Christian mysticism, particularly in its Neoplatonic form. Clearly, this not only ties Christianity to the Eastern religions, but also to the most advanced manifestations of Classical Greek and Roman paganism. I believe that in this matter, Schopenhauer is a better psychologist than Nietzsche.

Furthermore, Schopenhauer criticizes Judaism as a life-affirming religion. This is hard to deny, since Judaism does not have all those otherworldly elements that Nietzsche attributes to Christianity. It is also more interested in material benefits than is Christianity. So all the anti-Semites who lean on Nietzsche for their anti-Christian attitudes are inadvertently promoting Judaism, and are totally missing the continuity between the Classical Pagan civilization and the Christian Middle Ages.

Posted on 2010-02-19 by Cologero

13.2 Guenon and Tradition

Tradition, in the Guenonian sense, has nothing to do with the past in itself. Just because it happened yesterday does not make it therefore traditional. And it is not a reaction against modernity, nor a nostalgia for the past. Its expression today may appear that way, but that is because a Traditional path either no longer exists in the West, or is accessible only to a few.

The method of Tradition has nothing at all to do with the study of comparative religion. One can be a so-called "Traditionalist" within the confines of one's own religion alone, without any detailed knowledge of any other religion whatsoever. As a matter of fact, that is the way it has been for most of history, recorded and unrecorded. So it is not a process of somehow "distilling" the core teachings of several religions to end up with something remarkable. I don't see what that even entails or how it could be accomplished, since it implies one can somehow have the inside

("esoteric") without an outside ("exoteric"). Even worse, is syncretisim, that is, combining all the religions into some incompatible stew.

So that brings us to the next item: the relationship between the esoteric and exoteric sides of a religious tradition. In *The Esoterism of Dante*, Guenon responds to the question of whether Dante was Christian or pagan. Guenon explains:

> we do not think that such a point of view is necessary, for true esoterism is something completely different from outward religions, and if it has some relationship with it, this can only be insofar as it finds a symbolic mode of expression in religious forms. Moreover, it matters little whether these forms be of this or that religion, since what is involved is the essential doctrinal unity concealed beneath their apparent diversity.

So this brings us to the crux of the matter, which few people seem to find palatable: "in the past, initiates participated in all forms of worship, following the customs established in whatever country they happened to be." So let us make clear the necessary corollaries that follow from this.

Esoterism is neither pagan nor Christian. So whoever — and I have met many — believes that by rejecting Christianity and reverting to some pagan practice, whether Greek, Roman, or Germanic, he therefore is coming closer to Tradition, then he is quite mistaken. Guenon again:

> The ancient mysteries were not paganism, but were superimposed upon it. In the same way there were in the Middle Ages some organizations of an initiatic, and not religious, character, but which took Catholicism as their base.

Since Catholicism has been, at least until recently, the Traditional form of worship in Europe, then we would expect Traditionalists to find their home there. The idea that we can "pick and choose" our religion

comes from a modernist mindset and is alien to the Traditionalist. Unfortunately, Catholicism has lost much of its Traditional character, leaving Traditionalists without solid ground in the West; reenacting the lost forms of ancient paganisms is an even worse option.

Posted on 2010-02-23 by Cologero

13.3 The issue with Christianity

I had a different topic in mind, but I decided to address this thoughtful comment first:

> I think the issue some take with Christianity lies in the third of your criteria. The Christian religion seems to have been the fountainhead of a large number of subversive movements – though even as I write this I can anticipate your response will be that Christianity was Judaized. Well, fair enough, but wasn't it also paganized in an earlier period? It seems to me that what is of most value in historical Christianity is what is least essentially Christian about it.

We need to look at this from the point of view of Tradition and not in a partisan way. The third criterion is this: "Does the exterior form provide a safe haven within which the elite can accomplish their tasks?" Even though the post made no reference to Christianity, the comment nevertheless brought it up.

As a word "Christianity" encompasses a long period of history and and too many movements, and yes, most of them subversive. See we are not nominalists, we need to specify something with a determinate content. As a side note, it should be pointed out that the subversive movements are nomilinist, either explicitly or implicitly. For the background to this, I recommend *Ideas Have Consequences*[2]

[2] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ideas_Have_Consequences`

So as far as I am concerned, we should only be concerned about the "Religion of the Middle Ages" (ROTMA). Some, such as Maurras and Comte regarded it as a form of paganism and Evola considered that some "rectifications" were made to make it near pagan. Guenon referred to it as Catholicism, but regarded it — both esoterically and esoterically — as an extension of Classical Rome, not of Jerusalem. These are the assumptions of the latter two expounders of Tradition:

1. The Middle Ages represented a civilization of the Traditional type
2. The end began with the Renaissance and Reformation
3. There is no longer a Traditional religion in the West

So the third point is moot; there exists in the West no Traditional religion readily available, whether Christian or pagan. If this point were the only issue in dispute, it could be intelligently discussed. Unfortunately, discussion is replaced with partisanship, with the most absurd and irrelevant arguments made against Christianity. These come straight from the enemies of the West, so you have to wonder if they are really false flag operations. At some point we can address some of them.

It is not advisable to throw away the accomplishments of the west, described by Donoso Cortes[3]so quickly. Because of the ROTMA, Europe had spiritual unity. A knight could travel from Portugal to Poland and encounter the same religion and the same code of chivalry. The attempts nowadays to create a unity based on "whiteness" or "genetic similarity" are ludicrous and doomed to failure.

If we reject ROTMA out of hand, then we will miss out on what was able to establish a continental unity and Traditional society. Guenon regarded Hermeticism as the esoteric core of ROTMA; this is the perspecitve of the Brahmin. We can also point to the chivalric orders to get

[3] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=223`

the perspective of the kshatriya. Everything said deserves much deeper treatment, and that will be forthcoming.

Posted on 2010-02-26 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-02-26 at 21:21 said:

I thought your post 'Did Geunon Convert?' was a continuation of 'Guenon and Tradition', and that is why I brought up Christianity. While it seems that such wasn't your intention, the mistake has proven to be edifying.

In the latter post you said that "we would expect Traditionalists to find their home in the Catholic church ." (Now is a good time to recall that Evola never joined the Catholic church.) In this post you appear to have taken that back; here you say "there exists in the West no Traditional religion readily available, whether Christian or pagan." Although I can see sense in both statements, they do appear to contradict eachother. Perhaps you could (a) qualify them; or if they are not in contradiction, (b) show how you think this is so. I don't make any of these comments in an adversarial spirit.

If memory serves, Maurras believed that the Christian idea contained a dangerous potential for egalitarianism. Though this potential was checked for a time by the ROTMA, the Christian message has proven to be singularly volatile. So even though a paganized Christianity fulfilled the third criterion for around 4-5 hundred years, it still seems to me questionable whether a religion whose popular message is egalitarian really fulfils it.

Cologero on 2010-02-26 at 23:02 said:

I'll have to get to Maurras another time, though for most of his life he was a pagan with a high regard for the Catholic Church; it will be worth exploring why. Evola's objections to Christianity were more subtle than crude anti-Catholic bashing; again worth exploring as some of it was incisive, other parts somewhat misguided in my opinion. Ultimately, he felt that its spirit was alien to the Aryan spirit; however, we should not conclude that everything that goes by the name of "paganism" in our time is much better.

I don't see Christianity as egalitarian at all. There are celestial hierarchies, which is reflected both in the ecclesiastical hierarchy, chivalric orders, and formerly in the arrangement of society itself. Why that changed is a involved discussion.

My point was, even if somewhat unclear, is that a man adopts the religion of the land; it is only modern individualism that gives us a choice of which religion to take on. Since there is no religion in the land with a full metaphysical teaching, we are in a difficult situation. An elite

needs to arise, an elite with actual gnosis. What will arise from that, perhaps a hermeticized Catholicism or a new pagansim? But if you regard medieval Catholicism as a continuation of classical Rome – as Guenon and I do – then we can expect a continuation of what we have, even if it superficially appears as a clean break.

"If ... ... truth were recognized by a small number it would still be a result of considerable importance, for it is only in this way that a change of orientation leading to a restoration of the normal order can begin; and that restoration ... will necessarily take place sooner or later" R Guenon

Comprehensor on 2010-02-26 at 23:47 said:

Guenon realized that a restoration of Catholicism was not possible because of severe modernist influences. How much more impossible is it today where V2 Catholicism has become totally politicized by Marxist/materialist elements!

Matt on 2010-02-27 at 04:37 said:

Cologero, what are your thoughts on Eastern Orthodoxy and its relation to Tradition? Eastern Orthodox was never mentioned that much by Guenon (at least to me), and Evola never seemed to talk about it in his critique of Christianity.

Cologero on 2010-02-27 at 18:46 said:

During the time period I am interested in, there was only one church, orthodoxy and catholicism were the same and represented the continuation of the Roman Empire, even though split in two. At least Orthodoxy pays lip service to the concept of theosis: that is, it is not blind faith that is salvific, but rather one must become "god-like". Geunon and Evola talk about it, but few bother to understand. It is not the apotheosis of the ego, but rather the transcendence of the human state.

Fundamental is metaphysical understanding and gnosis. This must precede everything, including religious, racial, political, and social considerations.

Mark on 2010-03-02 at 03:30 said:

Let me start out with a quote from a site that uses Nietzsche.

"But there is another "enemy," though unconsciously so, and that is Christianity's own "will to truth." The need to grasp truth, verily the morality of truth, in this sense, is ultimately Christianity's gravest danger. If Christianity had been content to remain a schematism it might still exist; but its will to absolute truth has undermined its credibility, especially in relation to its extravagant competition with science."

http://www4.hmc.edu:8001/humanities/beckman/nietzsche/Genealogy.htm

Christianity had its history. I think what has happened in it, was bound to happen. It inherently has this tendency towards desacralization and demythologizing, and because of its positivistic nature, it must with all its force make the death and resurrection a fact that did happen. Hence its "will to truth" towards this event, will turn against it.

Just look at the end of your posting, where you state Brahmin and Kshatriyah. The Hindu schematism is still strong, and you are using it, and many Traditionalists use it. I could do this for philosophy as well, the system of Transcendental Idealism can be schematized as the "veil of maya", and our machines as "yantras". This ability does not exist in Christianity anymore, its "myth" does not have this power anymore.

What are your thoughts on this?

`Cologero on 2010-03-03 at 08:31 said:`

Nietzsche was looking at the end result of a series of revolutions, where the spiritual authority was overthrown and eventually lost its own self-understanding. Hence, having lost gnosis or Wisdom, it was left with faith alone. This is in contrast to science; this mock battle has been going on now for centuries. We have no interest in it, although it is a "hot topic".

I refer you to this chapter from Evola's "Pagan Imperialism":

Those who know and those who believe[4]

`Mark on 2010-03-03 at 13:32 said:`

I do believe that the issue of Christianity is important for understanding the present condition as far as the presence of sacred values or lack thereof. I am looking for my copy The Pagan Temptation by Thomas Molnar, because there is a section at the end of the chapter titled, "The Christian Desacralization", where he references both Evola and Guenon. The question is can Christianity in this sense Catholicism regain a sense of spiritual vitality by making the sacred real again in the Europe and America, or was there an inherent flaw that needed to develop out and cause its demise?

This flaw could be this, the intense positivism. Christianity must take its myth as a literal fact, and by doing so, it becomes a question of an empirical truth, not a symbol that points to the transcendent. This then creates the need for philosophical elaboration of the doctrine and dogmas of the church, then this philosophical method turns against it, even in so called Christians. Kant had a miracle critique along with Hume.

Hinduism on the other hand, still has the schematism. Their mythopoetic language is so powerful in explaining things. They can even take modern ideas like virtual reality, and explain it as an allegory to Maya. This computer in front of me is not the "dead machine" like it is in the West, but it is a Yantra.

[4] `http://www.gornahoor.net/PaganImperialism/ThoseWhoKnow.htm`

The question is this, is there an inherent flaw in Christianity that so wants the death and resurrection of Jesus to be a historical fact, that it loses sight of the transcendent meaning behind a dying and rising savior? It more and more moves to defending the historicity, and then the skeptics attack, it the vicious cycle repeats. The existentialism of someone like Kierkegaard is the end result of this.

Hypothetical Conversation

Person: I am meditating on the story of Jesus in regards to a counter to evolutionary psychology. The materialist position has it that I am a slave to my genes, and nothing can be done. The "Christ" in me shows a divine nature in me that connects to the transcendent.

Modern Christian: Stop talking all of this nonsense about deeper spiritual meaning, this will not get you saved, you must believe that he died and rose literally.

Was this inevitable, due to the nature of Christianity?

`Cologero on 2010-03-04 at 06:11 said:`

Some quick points, because these issues will be dealt with in more detail.

As for the Molnar book, I read a *review*[5]; if the reviewer understands Molnar correctly, the book is disappointing. For example, Schumacher was a Catholic himself and correct in his assertion that there is an intellectual power above reason. Also, it is incorrect to assert that detachment and dispassion are distinctly pagan and foreign to Christian spirituality.

The next point is that there is no reason to rule out miracles out of hand despite Hume and Kant. A historical event may nevertheless have a transcendent significance; "as above, so below" ... the historical and contingent are manifestations of something higher.

Again, the debate between a religion based on faith and science is of little consequence; the former is based on opinions about the spiritual world, the latter on opinions about the contingent world. There can be no ultimate agreement on opinions. About gnosis or Wisdom, there is always and necessarily agreement, assuming the levels of understanding are the same.

Do you really need Hinduism to explain away the artifacts of contemporary society?

As the Molnar book shows, the caretakers of the Christian religion have lost direct intuition of the spiritual. There is nothing inherently flawed with the religion. The problem, as documented both by Guenon and Evola, is the degeneration of the castes. Low caste individuals have taken over the positions of leadership in the various Churches and the results can be seen. Was that inevitable? Yes, given the nature of cosmic cycles; no, since there remains the question of the Will.

While the consciousness of Western man may be Christian, the unconscious of Western man remains pagan. Catholicism accomodated that. But it was the North Europeans who believed they could eliminate the pagan element from the Christian spirit and the results have been disastrous.

[5] `http://armchair_academic.homestead.com/pagantemp.html`

For example, by eliminating the pope and priesthood, they opened the door to egalitarianism and the overthrow of legitimate authority.

Mark on 2010-03-05 at 07:07 said:

Follow this as a paragraph by paragraph response, ending with the second to last paragraph

There chapter called the Christian Desacralization goes into issues that you would find interesting, so check it out.

The reference to Kant was that of a person who called himself Christian eliminating aspects of the religion like grace and miracles, because he wanted a "religion within the limits of reason. It was about the historical process of Christianity's "will to truth" that I referenced in the Nietzsche quote.

It is of important consequence if it is inherent within Christianity to have this positivism that works against it in a historical process. I don't believe that a Brahmanical or Kshatriyah like force could have prevented it. I think this is where we disagree.

I was lauding Hinduism in that it is still a powerful schematism. It has a langauge that you even use to explain spiritual ideas. Why did it not go through this "will to truth" turning against itself as what happened in Christianity

I think this is the central issue. I hope this gets focused on. I think that this was inherent in the doctrine, not just a cause of "low caste people". The focus on the facticity of the death and resurrection will always break through any Hermetic covering. I just read a section on polygenism vs monogenism and the Catholic church, and the Catholic Church is so adamant about having monogenism to protect the concept of original sin. I don't see Christianity as plastic to the forces of Tradition that allow it to be completely rectified. That is the issue

Is Christianity plastic enough so that Traditional Forces are able to make it a proper vessel for Tradition, and have it stay that way?

Or

Is there certain doctrines in it, part of what makes it its kerygmatic core, makes what has happened, destined to happen?

This is what I believe to be the central point, so I will end here.

Cologero on 2010-03-05 at 09:58 said:

Kant, Nietzsche, Molnar were not among "those who know", so their opinions are of little interest. The "degeneration of castes" as an historical process is all too obvious, so your disagreement is the result of a misunderstanding. Obviously, the "Brahmins", or what was left of them, did not prevent the process of desacralization. However, it is not because of anything inherent in doctrine (I mean that in the Traditional sense), but here is where we can bring in Nietzsche: forces of resenentment were unleashed that emboldend the masses in the lower castes to rebel

against their superiors. Don't forget that there were identifiable elements within Europe that formented and financed such movements.

Your line of reasoning is fruitless. We could also say, for example, that there was something inherent in Classical and Germanic paganism that caused it to yield so quickly and thoroughly to Christianity. Or in Hinduism, because it didn't prevent the Aryan invaders of the sub-continent from self-destruction. But to repeat, I claim that paganism was not lost, but remained in the subconscious of the West and its best parts where incorporated into the ROTMA either through theology and philosophy, or the chivalric system. Rather than concentrating on the failures of this Catholicism, you should instead understand and explain how it sustained a Traditional civilization for such an extended period over such an extended space. Every human movement necessarily deteriorates and requires fresh impulses to re-animate it.

As for Hinduism, it is one tradititon among many and I don't regard it as superior to anything in the West. I may use the terminology of the Vedanta for convenience, but the West has everything it needs. See, for example, "The Shape of Ancient Thought" by McEvilley.

We don't need to defend all the decisions of the Church hierarchy, and from a certain perspective some may seem to be at odds with Traditional or esoteric doctrine. There are reasons for that, some legitimate, others illegitimate because true gnosis was lost at certain points. If you are really interested in the topic, then you need to look at the development of Hermeticism, which is the hidden core (assuming there was one) of esoterism in the West. If we follow the line from Hermes Trismegistus, Pythagoras, Plato, Plotinus, we find a lot of early Christian theologians at the end.

As for polygenism, some recent writings by Christian Hermetecists make the claim for the existence of "Pre-Adamic" people who may be biologically human but not spiritually. I refer you to Jung's "Answer to Job" and to "Gnosis" by Boris Mouravieff.

You object to the historicity of the resurrection, without giving a reason. Isn't the goal of alchemy the Elixer of Life? So we should not and cannot rule out the overcoming of death *a priori*. There is another book worth checking out: "Covenant of the Heart" or "Lazarus, come forth" by Valentin Tomberg. He relates forgetting, sleeping, and dying as related processes, with the corresponding opposites: remembering, waking up, and living. The corresponding world teachers are Plato (the Sage who related knowing to remembering), Buddha (the awakend one), and Jesus (who overcame death.) This is how a Hermeticist thinks, so if you want to reject something, then reject this.

Nothing is "destined" to happen, as all depends on Wisdom and Will, or ignorance and weakness. I refer you to this though of Joseph de Maistre (another Christian Hermeticist):

> Very few battles are lost physically. Battles are lost almost always morally; the real victor like the real loser is the one who believes he is.

Mark on 2010-03-06 at 08:48 said:

I am dealing with ideas and the consequences that they have, such as your reference to an earlier post that referenced a book called Ideas have Consequences. You seem to think that it is acceptable to argue that the nominalism of Occam had historical consequences, but not the positivism inherent in Christianity as a whole. So what are the ideas that have consequences, and what are the ideas that don't? Could you give me a list?

Again, it is not a fair comparison with Hinduism and Nordic/Slavic paganism, since I am dealing with ideas, and how well those ideas stand, and only those ideas. Hinduism is still vibrant as far as its language that expresses reality. Traditionalism depends on the language of the metaphysical concepts inherent within Hinduism. Also, Nordic and Slavic paganism did not fail because of the ideology failing, but because a sword was placed to the throat of the pagans. So, if Nordic and Slavic paganism failed because of ideas that failed in the historical process, then I would say that it deserves the same critique as Christianity. But we know that was not the reason.

You use the terminology of Hinduism because of its power. If you stopped using terms like Kshatriyah, Brahmin, Kali Yuga, etc., then your rhetoric would lack its power. Why not use language from only Christianity? Don't use Brahmin and Kshatriyah, use Clergy and Knight, and lets see how well you do in your rhetoric.

I am not trying to come off as rude, but it seems as if you are not dealing with my point. Thomas Molnar, who is a devoutly Catholic philosopher, seems to have dealt with the concepts inherent in Christianity that could lead to this situation we have.

Cologero on 2010-03-08 at 10:17 said:

The list of ideas is forthcoming.

The point, however, is not that the ideas of Occam had historical consequences; rather to understand how and why. That is because Occams' metaphysical position is defective.

Again, to be clear, the perspective of this blog is not Traditional Catholicism, but rather metaphysics as taught by the the highest representatives of the various Traditions, and brought to light by Guenon (the perspective of the Brahmin) and Evola (the perspective of the Kshatriya). I am not a poet, so I am not concerned with the power of words, but rather of their truth. We use Hindu terminology (1) because it is precise, (2) because it is distant from us — I find that using European or Christian terms seems to instigate unnecessary polemics, and (3) because there is widespread ignorance about the Traditional forms available in the West. Thoughtful writers in the Middle Ages used their own terminology to describe their social structure quite effectively. This needs to become common knowledge; unfortunately, as part of our dispossession, we denigrate the Medieval period ... all sides are guilty of this.

So, to repeat, I do not regard Molnar as a representative of this perspective and I gave two quite specific reasons. I expect specificity in return.

I need to point out that the Traditional teaching is that the empirical world is a reflection of the spiritual – as above, so below – an not merely a "symbol" for it. Spiritual reality manifests as empirical reality. Now positivism only accepts the empirical as real, and so deals in facts alone, without reference to the transcendent. This is a low caste point of view, not something a Brahmin or Kshatriya would ever accept. This demonstrates the degeneration of castes: men of low caste have risen to important positions in church hierarchy, men who are unable to understand their own Tradition and can see in it nothing but a collection of empirical facts.

I've provided several references (and I can provide more if pressed) to new contemporary writers who see more than "mere" facts; this demonstrates there is nothing defective in the ideas, but instead indicates defects in the ability of many to properly understand them. For the lower castes, believing in a literal resurrection is all they are capable of and they should be left in peace. Others see the spiritual reality behind it. Again to be repetitive, esoteric teaching is not a collection of ideas to be debated or believed in. There are ideas of course, but, they must be alive and directly intuited by the knower in an existential way. For that reason, they cannot be grasped from outside the Tradition, nor by anyone not willing to undergo the necessary transformation or intellectual conversion.

Although this is hardly the entire reason for the propagation of Christianity in Europe, I concede there was often enough a certain amount of compulsion. This caused, as I pointed out, the pagan mind to be forced into the unconscious. Catholicism, to a large extent, incorporated pagan ideas and customs (see, e.g., Clement's Stromata, where we read about Druids, Buddha, Hindusim, and Christian gnosis); the Protestants rejected all that, thus pushing paganism even deeper into the unconscious. Now that it is "liberated", this paganism is being expressed in some unhealthy ways. The best of the pagan minds were not beer guzzling libertines.

I am being as clear as I can in the confines of an Internet comment. I don't expect anyone to "believe" anything, but I do encourage anyone capable of it to try to develop true gnosis. From that perspective, there is not room for these interminable and irrevolvale polemics.

13.4 Choosing my Religion

> The direction in which we may find awakening and liberation, the direction of initiation, is vertical and has nothing to do with the course of history.
>
> Julius Evola

Spirituality in the Modern World I spent some time tonight, actually too much time, checking out on Amazon various books on spirituality, mostly obscure, that have been recommended to me. Without passing judgment on books I have not read, I did notice a disconcerting similarity among them. First, there is always the claim by the author for his or her spiritual realization, usually with a laundry list of initiations or teachers from an incompatible collection of traditions, usually Tibetan Buddhism, Kabbalah, Gnosticism, Vedanta, and so on. Second, there is an assumption of universality in that anyone by following the advice in the book can come to a similar state of spiritual realization. Third, is the objection to dogma in any form while not seeing the implicit dogmas in their own formulation. Fourth, is the lack of understanding of the heroic task of asserting the cosmos against the forces of chaos. Chaos is deemed not to exist since any claim to a higher order is considered judgmental.

Closely related, is the most egregious, which is the concession to modernity. Every dogma of modernity is accepted, particularly the fruits of cultural Marxism. For example, there is a gnostic group that used to have an order for men, based on Templar type virtues, and a separate order for women to develop their particular gifts. But now, they admit, the orders are open to either gender as a reflection of the times. Whatever side you are on in regard to that decision, the fundamental point is that it is based on feminism and egalitarianism, which have totally secular roots. What sort of authentic spirituality judges itself on the basis of secular standards? One should simply skip the costume drama and join the enlightenment.

The Antidote The organization of the Ancient City is utterly different from modern liberal societies. For the liberal today, it is simply incomprehensible. Committed to the social contract theory, she cannot understand how men and women in a "state of nature" could agree to such an arrangement. Yet, from the antique viewpoint, there is no such

"state of nature", but rather the **primordial state**, which is supra-human. Hence, its social hierarchy is considered, if not divinely inspired, then established but the very nature of things. Further, there is no distinction between "is" and "ought", as man, too, in his willing is subject to that nature. This, the liberal opposes by inserting a wedge; by questioning everything, she creates a second reality of thought whose purpose and intention is to replace the divine law.

So, what would a book of spirituality based on the ancient city look like? Just to recap. The city is structured around rites and rituals honoring founders and ancestors. Implicit in this is the understanding of fate and cosmic law that dictates those rites. The members of the three castes are initiated into those rites, which in reality is their mystery religion. At a later time, as the force of the rites is felt less, mythos and logos arise. The law is attributed to the word of a god and then with the rise of the philosophers, the gods are dispensed with and the law is expressed as Logos. Fundamentally, however, mythos and logos see their function is explicating the implicitly understood dogmas of the city. With modernity, the Logos is separated from its source and becomes free floating thought, or ideology. This process will be dealt with in a later post.

Since no one reading this blog has been initiated, we have to resort to a sort of Hermetic meditation[6], and imaginatively place ourselves in its midst. There are those today who claim to understand the spirituality for "our" people, usually in the form of the recovery of the period of Mythos. However, this shows no understanding of origins. Leaving aside the disputed question of who actually belongs, in terms of race of the body, such a position shows a lack of understanding of the Ancient City. Recall that there are the twice-born caste members who are initiated, but there are also the clients who are not. That is, the members of the caste would follow an esoteric mystery religion, but the clients (or serfs) would follow the rites of their patron family as an exoteric religion.

[6] `http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=898`

The clients, then, would be attracted to the exoteric forms of polytheistic worship of the Olympic type gods (or their Roman and German counterparts). Thus, we regard the frequent calls of neo-pagans to Thor worship, and the like, as contemporary manifestations of the serf mentality.

Mystery Religion In From Religion to Philosophy, **F. M. Cornford** describes the nature of mystery religion, focusing on the later cult of Dionysus which transcends any particular city. Nevertheless, the pattern would have been similar in earlier stages. Here is Cornford's characterization, which matches Evola's frequent descriptions of the man-god.

> Because the province of a **Mystery God** is always, primarily, the human society from which he immediately springs, it is possible for him to remain human as well as divine. In this lies the secret of the vitality of mystical religions. The characteristic rite is sacramental, an act of communion and reunion with the daemon. Its effect may be conceived under two complementary aspects: either as *enthusiasm*... or *ecstasy*

Discounting Cornford's secular viewpoint, we can instead understand *ecstasy*[7] as man rising above the prison of his individuality to a super-individual state, to become immortal and divine. As he writes: "*God can enter into man, and man can become God.*" The mystery God is attached to his group, thus resists incorporation into the universalist Olympians. Hence,

> A mystery religion is necessarily monotheistic ... Teaching the unity of all life, it disposes of polytheism by the doctrine that all the Gods are only diverse shapes of one divine principle, one nature with many names.

[7]Those who wish to understand enthusiasm (or *enstasy*) and ecstasy from a Hermetic point of view should read the relevant section in *Meditations on the Tarot*.

It is this specificity of the mystery God, tied to a particular people, which is the surd in all new age schemes. Cornford stumbles onto an interesting dichotomy here. On the one hand, New Age spirituality wants to jump straight to the "one divine principle" and the "one nature with many names". Yet without a mystery God, they are left holding the bag of many names, with little understanding of the one nature or divine principle.

Next: Spirituality and the spiritual race.

Posted on 2011-08-29 by Cologero

* * *

Anon on 2018-08-29 at 16:09 said:
Thank you Cologero. Looking forward to new posts.

13.5 Spiritual Combat and the War on Christmas

With all the recent publicity about the so-called "war on Christmas", as it has weirdly become the "holiday that dare not speak its name", it is easy to forget that there has always been a war on Christmas, ever since Herod. The forces of revolution are the obvious culprits, who need not again be identified here, but it is probably less well known that the celebration of Christmas was forbidden in 1644 in England by the Puritan government; it was regarded as "too pagan". The novella, *A Christmas Carol* by **Charles Dicken**, was the force that restored what we today consider the "traditional" way of celebrating Christmas. In the process, he also secularized it, a process still incomplete.

In the older European tradition, Advent, the period leading up to Christmas, was a time for fasting. Christmas Eve was a day of abstinence,

hence the customary fish dinner on that day. That was followed by the famous twelve days of Christmas, after which gifts would be exchanged.

Curiously, there has arisen in our time a movement that claims to be restoring Tradition in the West, while denying all its specific Traditional elements. This countertradition, for that is what it is, thinks it is being edgy by rejecting that Tradition on the grounds that it is pagan, which it claims to be the authentic tradition. Unfortunately, virtually all they know of that pseudo-tradition is what has been preserved in the real Tradition or else documented by monks.

The joke is that this countertradition is not at all pagan, but actually aligns itself with the Puritans of England and related groups; they even use the same arguments against the Medieval Tradition. The joke would be funny were they not so full of passionate intensity. As we pointed out many times, virtually all people adopt a world view based on affinity: *viz.*, what their friends think, what makes them feel good, what they are accustomed to, their inclinations and aversions, and so on. *A fortiori*, if a choice needs to be made between an authentic tradition and personal perversity, the latter will most often win out.

Hence, the true war against Christmas if fought first in our own hearts. This is denied by no authentic tradition, even Evola writes the same thing. However, it is up to us to move this along with specifics. Here is an important little exercise in this spiritual combat; it trains us to see beyond affinity, or our arbitrary likes and dislikes, and to see things objectively, as they are, and without illusion. This exercise is a requirement for initiates, whether Christian, pagan, Hindu, and so on. What follows was originally written by **Lorenzo Scupoli** and collected in his Spiritual Combat. The version provided here is based on Scupoli, but edited by **Nicodemus of the Holy Mountain** and further revised by **Theophan the Recluse**.

> The reason why we have wrong judgment of things is that we do not look deeply into them to see what they are, but conceive a lik-

> ing for them or a dislike of them from the very first glance, judging by appearances. These likes and dislikes prejudice our mind and darken it; and so it cannot form a right judgment of things as they really are. So, my brother, if you wish to be free of this prelest, or spiritual delusion, in your mind, keep strict attention over yourself; and when you see a thing with your eyes, or visualise it in your mind, keep a firm grip on your desires and do not allow yourself at the first glance either to conceive a liking for the thing or a dislike for it, but examine it in a detached way with the mind alone. Unobscured by passion, the mind then remains in a state natural to it, which is free and pure, and has the possibility to know the truth and to penetrate in to the depths of a thing, where evil is often concealed under a deceptively attractive exterior and where good is sometimes hidden under a bad appearance.

Posted on 2012-12-23 by Cologero

* * *

Senko on 2012-12-23 at 21:29 said:

Excellent post. It is a most difficult exercise, detaching your feelings from any given object, but most neccesary for true progress in the spiritual life. I'm writting a brief article about the secularization and degradation of Christmas, if you don't mind I'll post the link.

George on 2013-02-02 at 14:25 said:

"Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles?"

Another is time. Where we may not be intelligent enough or too deceived to initially see the truth, we may examine the results and whether or not they match up with the claims.

Of course the modern world will always claim "the bad fruit is only because we have not completely destroyed our enemies and just need more progress/government/destruction of tradition."

13.6 Making up your Mind

> When equality is enforced in the social or political fields, there is a general lowering of the average level of society to that of the lowest individuals, because it is infinitely easier to do that than to create a standard higher than that existing before.
>
> Mieczyslaw Demetriusz Sudowski aka Mouni Sadhu

Atheist, Pagan, and Christian An atheist, a pagan, and a Christian walk into a bar ... If it sounds like the beginning of a joke, I forgot the punch line. If it sounds like the beginning of an interesting conversation, you will be disappointed. A fruitful conversation will have a terminus and a way for the participants to agree on when that terminus has been reached. This necessitates something in common. If they appear to have little in common in terms of outer form, then they must determine if there is a higher principle they can agree on. For example, you would not debate the colors of M & M candies with someone who is color blind, but you could discuss things like texture and taste.

To return to our bar hoppers, we first need to define their positions metaphysically, in line with Guenon's suggestion that all religious positions can be restated as metaphysical positions.

Atheist

An atheist denies that there is a transcendent unifying principle. There are only things and events; the role of a thinker is to arrange, catalog, and formulate theories about them. As for religious phenomena, all events are on an equal footing. There is no (consistent) way to distinguish an enlightened sage from a televangelist.

Pagan

A polytheist claims there are multiple, independent principles underlying the cosmos. When personified, they appear as gods and goddesses. Since no one of them is absolutely supreme, conflicts or even battles arise among them. A man finds himself at the mercy of their fickleness: one god may bless him, while another actively thwarts him. If the pagan does admit a higher principle, it is called "fate", to which gods and men are both subject. Pagans pride themselves on loving that principle even though it doesn't love them back. That principle is unknowable and is experienced as power. It has no purpose, so one's human, all-to-human, life consists of one damn thing after another, endlessly repeated in cyclic regularity.

Monotheist

The monotheist accepts that there is one ultimate principle of the cosmos, the one God, with an indefinite number of states of being between that principle and man. Man's task is to ascend these transhuman states to the best of his abilities. Ultimately, through grace and persistence, in an act of integrating wholeness or *theosis*, he transcends all states to become One with the divine.

Chattering and Resolution Obviously, I am describing an esoteric conversation, which reaches "to the very presuppositions of all thoughts". Anything else is idle chattering by which we construct an ersatz world as Heidegger describes. In our imaginary conversation, the atheist is the least common denominator, so we are limited to describing discrete events without grasping their essence. It is the intellectual equivalent of picking up sticks and putting them into a pile; the pile itself is meaningless. Even beavers gather sticks and create something superior to the sum of its parts.

To expect an intellectual dispute to be resolved in this way is to expect

your bowl of alphabet soup to spontaneously spell out the meaning of life. Principles cannot be derived from accumulating facts, but rather facts must be understood in the light of principles.

Folk Religion By folk religion[8], we mean the exoteric religion practiced by the mass of people. Esoterists, unlike the cultured despisers of religion, understand the necessity for that and avoid scandalizing them. Shallow thinkers consider folk religion as a form of "control", although it is unclear by whom and for what purpose. Rather, it is a way to elevate their spirit in mythological terms; actually, they are spiritually superior to those who would critique them from an allegedly "higher" point of view. In this, we agree with **Arthur Schopenhauer**, whom we regarded at one time as our educator, and still respect despite his Kantianism. He wrote:

> All that can be thought only generally and in the abstract is quite inaccessible to the great majority of people. Thus, in order to bring that great truth of self-transcendence into the sphere of practical application, a mythical vehicle for it was needed everywhere for this great majority, a receptacle, so to speak, without which it would be lost and dissipated. The truth everywhere had to borrow the garb of fable, and in addition, had to try always to connect itself in each with what is historically given, and is already known and revered. That which *sensu proprio* was and remained inaccessible to the great masses of all times and countries with their low mentality, their intellectual stupidity, and their general brutality, had to be brought home to them *sensu allegorico* for practical purposes, in order to be their guiding star.

Those cultured despisers also mock the folk religion for their alleged ignorance or their failure to live up to the higher standards of its doctrines. On what grounds? Metaphysics is the queen of sciences and is

[8] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=5323`

accessible to the few. We esoterists are not egalitarians so we accept with calm detachment the inability of the many to understand and fulfill the highest aspects of doctrines.

A common criticism of Christians by the pagans, is that the Christian folk religion incorporated elements of the earlier paganism. We have never denied it, to the contrary, we have called attention to it. Furthermore, we have insisted that it is not restricted to folk religion, but also to the greatest minds of the Middle Ages, including **Dante** and **Boethius**. This is hardly a reason to reject Christianity, but rather to reject paganism, since everything of value in it has been incorporated into the folk religion, not to mention the esoteric religion. In The Sacred and the Profane, **Mircea Eliade** mentions the same phenomenon and comes to the same conclusion:

> The customs and beliefs of European peasants represented a more archaic state of culture that that documented in the mythology of classic Greece. It is true that most of these rural European populations have been Christianized for over a thousand years. But they succeeded in incorporating into their Christianity a considerable part of their pre-Christian religious heritage which was of immemorial antiquity. *It would be wrong to suppose that for this reason European peasants are not Christians*.
>
> We must recognize that their religion still retains a cosmic structure that has been almost entirely lost in the experience of urban Christians. We may speak of a primordial, ahistorical Christianity; *becoming Christians, the European cultivators incorporated into their new faith the cosmic religion that they had preserved from prehistoric times*.

Another shallow idea of the cultured despisers is that religions use guilt, especially about sexual matters, as a means of control. Again that defies any logic. First of all, guilt is the natural feeling for a transgression;

someone who never feels guilt is called a sociopath, and that is a bad thing in case you didn't know. To the contrary, deeper thinkers will see that sex is itself the power that is used for social control and repression. Religion provides a buffer against that form of control.

Choosing My Religion So by now, we have demonstrated the value of the exoteric, or folk, religion, particularly the dominant form it has taken in the Western Tradition. Some may reasonably ask, then, why we should prefer it. Perhaps a parable will help. Peter fell in loves with a woman, and told her, "Honey, I love you above all other women. No other woman could make me as happy as you do." When Paul fell in love, he told her, "Honey, I really love you, but to be honest, there are probably 5 or 6 other women who could have made me equally happy." Do I really need to create a poll question to decide whether Peter or Paul has chosen the better path? But then we would have to mention Ralph who is still waiting for the woman who is good enough for him; discretion prohibits us from describing how he spends his Saturday nights. Just remember these wise words from the Lovin' Spoonful[9], regarding the need for decisiveness, loyalty, and faithfulness:

> Did you ever have to make up your mind
> Pick up on one and leave the other behind
> It's not often easy and not often kind
> Did you ever have to make up your mind
>
> Did you ever have to finally decide
> Say yes to one and let the other one ride
> There's so many changes and tears you must hide
> Did you ever have to finally decide

Ananda Coomaraswamy wrote a small monograph, titled Hinduism and Buddhism, that shows their inner identity on the esoteric level. As we

[9] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K8NZUdtEuKI

have mentioned several times, AKC also pointed out the Western Christian texts that have the same esoteric teachings as those Asian religions; those who cannot recognize it in the West, certainly cannot recognize it in the East. Hence, we can make a very plausible case that Brahmanism, Buddhism, and Christianity represent the peaks of the religious experience of the Indo-European people. A century before AKC, Schopenhauer came to the same conclusion, based on his understanding of the inner state of consciousness that these three traditions lead to. He wrote, although we would substitute "metaphysics" for "philosophy":

> Thus Christianity, Brahmanism and Buddhism are to be regarded as sacred vessels in which the great truth, recognized and expressed for thousands of years, possibly indeed since the beginning of the human race, and yet remaining in itself an esoteric doctrine as regards the great mass of mankind, is made accessible to them according to their powers, and preserved and passed on through the centuries. Yet because everything that does not consist throughout of the indestructible material of pure truth is subject to destruction, whenever this fate befalls such a vessel through contact with a heterogeneous age, the sacred contents must be saved in one way by another vessel, and preserved for mankind. Philosophy has the task of presenting those contents, since they are identical with pure truth, pure and unalloyed, hence merely in abstract concepts, and consequently without that vehicle, for those who are capable of thinking, the number of whom is at all times extremely small.

Still not convinced? Although I will probably treat this topic in more detail at another time, since it is in sharp agreement with Guenon and Schuon, I will provide a couple of quotes from Mouni Sadhu:

> Changes of religion are usually meaningless and without any profit for the person concerned. Therefore I don't believe in all the missions directed to people who already possess their own religious

> philosophy expounded by one or another of the Teachers of humanity. I cannot see any gain for an intelligent Christian who knows much about his divine Master Jesus to be "converted" to Hinduism or Buddhism.

According to the teachers, the divine Jesus was the avatar of the Logos, who brought saving gnosis. He demonstrated this with power, or miracles, which is the criterion[10] used even by **Julius Evola**. Legends of miracles cannot be arbitrarily rejected without rejecting all such. Given everything else written above, those credentials should be decisive.

Posted on 2013-01-25 by Cologero

* * *

Avery on 2013-01-25 at 01:28 said:

"The believers in miracles accept them, rightly or wrongly, because they have evidence. The disbelievers in miracles deny them, rightly or wrongly, because they have a doctrine against them." G.K. Chesterton

Tosti on 2013-01-25 at 09:30 said:

Brilliantly done! I hope that my more intelligent pagan friends will read and understand. I fear it will be too subtle for some of them. Of course those who can be convinced through contemplation of words will be convinced. How to reorient the rest, those who are completely captured through their passions and who willingly wear the blinder of unlimited choice?

Scardanelli on 2013-01-25 at 14:44 said:

Ultimately it was this revelation, that the Catholic tradition could be seen as a continuation, a redemption, and a refinement of the European pagan tradition, that led me back to Catholicism. Along these lines, I think a study of the Heliand might be interesting as a jumping off point in the study of Nordic influences in the catholic tradition. I have a few works by G. Ronald Murphy on the subject, as well as James Russell's Germanization of Early Medieval Christianity, but I havn't had the time to read them yet. Perhaps I'll get to it soon...

[10] https://gornahoor.net/?p=5678

Cologero on 2013-01-26 at 09:42 said:

That is the question, Tosti. Intellectual conviction (which is abstract) does not necessarily lead to a decision of the will (which is personal). The vices of the vulgar are obvious to all, as they would include the tendency to violence, sexual misconduct, dishonesty, drunkenness; the decision to improve these faults is universally applauded. However, the vices of the best and the brightest are of a different sort as they are typically pride and willfulness (or rebelliousness). These are very easily re-interpreted as great virtues.

14

Action and Active Metaphysics

14.1 Possessing the Truth Actively

Decline and Cosmic Cycles In a recent comment, Jason-Adam brought up a few pertinent points that are too complex to address in a combox. For example, he wrote:

> One error Guenon and Evola might have made about the West I think is to judge it as a culture in formation against those who were fully fulfilled. . . .looking into the future
>
> I am confident in the future of the West because history shows all cultures have a Second Religiousness phase, where the springtime beliefs reemerge and overcome materialism and rationalism.

I don't know that Guenon and Evola expressed it in quite those terms, but even so, it would be better to see the West as a "culture in decline". That is, through a process of degeneration, it abandoned its roots in Tradition and has been implementing its opposite; specifically, it has rejected the sacred world while embracing the profane world. **Mircea Eliade** put it this way:

> all the definitions given up till now of the religious phenomenon have one thing in common: each has its own way of showing that the sacred and the religious life are the opposite of the profane and secular life

So the "second religiousness" that Jason-Adam mentioned can only be the return of the sacred and religious life. Once again, Eliade calls this the "Eternal Return", that is, the mythic age returns, even as circumstances may differ. In terms of cosmic cycles, the end of the Kali Yuga, moving along the turn of the wheel, is followed by an era of increasing enlightenment. We see the Traditional societies of China and India increasingly following a mercantilist path, something Guenon had not anticipated. Chances are they will continue to decline into their own version of modernity and it will be the West that leads the return to Tradition.

The Age of the Holy Spirit **Blessed Joachim of Fiore**, whom Dante numbered among the elect, foresaw the age of the Holy Spirit following the Age of the Son. While care must be taken not to take this too literally, if understood as a deepening of understanding it makes sense. For the sacred and religious consciousness, it is the myth of the origin that dominates, not the end point. The Age of the Son revealed that the Logos is the origin of all. The consequences of this still need to be fully absorbed. The Franks understood this, a topic we will return to soon.

Since the Owl of Minerva flies at dusk, we, at the decline of the West, are in a position to understand more directly, and more fully, what has happened and what is to be done. Those societies still at their peak cannot understand their possible future decline in an existential way. Unfortunately, we in the West are able to understand the modern world existentially, but seem to have forgotten any previous stage. That is why we take such pains in describing the most recent Traditional stage of the West: some few may be awakened to remember, and those few may turn into many.

Active Truth The Traditional teaching of the West, which may still be repeated today, claimed that the purpose of man in this life is to "*know, love, and serve God*." We can immediately see this as the basis of jnana, bhakti, and karma yogas for the West. To focus on jnana yoga for the moment, we need to point out that this goes well beyond the memorization and recitation of a catechism. The goal of the jnani is gnosis, or intellectual intuition, a direct knowing of God, beyond rational and literal formulations. In "Modes of Spiritual Realization", **Frithjof Schuon** explains it this way:

> Only he who possesses the truth in an **active manner is really intellectual**, and not he who accepts it passively.

He goes on to distinguish these two types, each of whom has "learned a metaphysical truth":

Active Type

- He recognizes himself in it in a certain fashion
- He is capable of formulating it spontaneously
- He formulates in in an original and inspired manner
- He projects the light of his knowledge onto the most diverse contingencies
- This is because of a direct vision of the realities concerned and not by means of reasoning

Passive Type

- He has a presentiment of its evidence
- He, however, is incapable of expressing it other than by repeating the doctrinal statement that was given to him

Conclusion It is clearly important, or better said, it is the one thing necessary: that is, to know metaphysical truth in an active manner. This should require much contemplation of metaphysical teachings, and beyond that, a great deal of self-knowledge that is the fruit of self-observation. As long as a man remains passive in respect to metaphysical truths, he can only understand them as abstractions. This is revealed by his tendency to want to debate or choose sides in a dispute. Unable to directly intuit the ideas of Tradition, he thinks it has something to do with the past. Hence, he may try to "prove" and "demonstrate" these truths, for example, by false and tendentious historical studies. His efforts would be better spent in squaring the circle or inventing a perpetual motion machine. Such types are more dangerous than the totally ignorant.

We know many metaphysical truths. These must be pondered, they must be related to contingent conditions, whether in the past or the present. When a critical mass of men is achieved, then change will come. However, this is not a passive process, there is no historical necessity, but it depends instead on the collective and harmonious will of those who know.

Posted on 2012-11-26 by Cologero

* * *

David on 2012-11-26 at 22:52 said:

In vipassana meditation, this kind of active knowing is the highest form of wisdom (in the tradition of Goenka). When you speak of passive knowledge, it makes me think of submission to reason : you cling to your ideas, which is erroneous, since they are not "yours" to say. Debating or attaching yourself to those ideas is sign of passivity indeed. Very interesting read, as always.

Logres on 2012-11-27 at 13:23 said:

Romanides was a tempting turn of thought, for me. I am glad I read Ruskin's praise of the Gothic, which seems to have been a genuine impulse of Soul in the vein of Tradition to resurrect (but not embalm or deify) what was good in the Classical soul. It's paradoxical because

historically it "looks" like a starting over, but am becoming convinced that it was a recovery, which may be what all "conservative revolutions" (or the opposite of Revolution) looks like?

Jason-Adam on 2012-11-27 at 22:48 said:

This is a very good article and I am pleased to have been the catalyst for Cologero to write this.

I am glad he mentioned the fact, which Evola had said too, that as the West is where the decline began, the West will also be the first to arise anew…..

Possessing the truth actively is something that is needed but is that possible without initiation ? In other words, can a person teach himself or does he need help from a master to enlighten himself ?

Jason-Adam on 2012-11-27 at 22:54 said:

My remaining question of the period of the formation of the Franko-Roman-Gothic culture is, given the fact that it was a traditional society, what was the means by which Tradition was carried over from Ancient Rome to Mediaeval Rome ? Was it via Catholicism as Guenon thought or the Germanic Aryan blood as Evola thought or something else entirely ?

Caleb C on 2012-11-30 at 11:30 said:

Both the priestly Catholic strain and the Germanic warrior strain came together powerfully when Charlemagne was crowned 'Emperor of the Romans' by Pope Leo III on Christmas of 800. This was understood as a resurrection of the Western Roman Empire and transferring its imperium to the Frankish King. A beautiful example of how Tradition gives rebirth to the good and power of previous ages. The Holy Roman Empire lasted a good thousand years at the heart of Europe, the physical bodily manifestation of the Christian millennium until Napoleon, acting as an anti-christ of the counter-tradtion, killed it off in 1806.

Jason-Adam on 2012-11-30 at 14:30 said:

Caleb C, your comment is absolutely stunning and overwhelming in its truth. If only more so called "Traditionalists" would see instead of hearing…..

14.2 Primer on Tradition and its Future

> The ignorant are humble since they know that they do not know. The intelligent are humble because they understand how difficult it is to know something. But the half-smart are so absolutely

certain about everything.

cjs

Executive Summary In the *Reign of Quantity*, **Rene Guenon** describes two opponents of Tradition. The anti-Tradition, since it is openly opposed to all traditional ideas, is easily recognized. However, the counter-tradition is a caricature, counterfeit, and deformation of Tradition, so that "it can fool even the elect."

The purpose, therefore, of this essay is to point out the signposts of Tradition so that its counterfeits can be more easily identified. Julius Evola identified Traditional civilization as a civilization of space[1]. Thus it is considered, but modern standards, to be "stable, static and ultraconservative". In contrast, modernity is a civilization of time, seeking "progress", novelty, change. The counter-tradition adopts the values and vision of the modern world while using the language of Tradition.

Ergo, historical studies of a Tradition are ultimately irrelevant. History is Brownian motion, not leading anywhere. The goal is to find the escape: out and up.

Our purpose is certainly not quantity, but rather to identify the one, the two, or the three individuals who are really interested. If you are here, try to remember exactly why you were born and what might be your life's goal. Certainly it is not to become the best ping pong player at the Olympics.

The counter-tradition will reject a known Tradition, all the while fantasizing about some pseudo-tradition that never has, nor never will, exist. Yet, even if the exterior form of Tradition changes, our task remains the same, although, perhaps the language would differ somewhat. The task is still to be freed from our automatic responses, to truly be free. Few

[1] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=12696`

are those who are willing to make serious efforts in that direction. And even among those few, not many are serious.

Category Theory In order to remove emotional responses, which are a sure indicator of the counter-tradition, I will describe Tradition in terms of the mathematics of Category Theory – knowing the category tells you much about its individual members. As a category is an abstraction, Tradition never manifests as such, only traditions.

Mathematical theorems take this form: If a set of conditions hold, then some conclusion is true. For our purposes, we won't need to assume that the conditions hold, only that the syllogism holds. To eliminate or modify one or more of the conditions will most likely produce an incoherent or incompatible system. Nevertheless, it is common to pick and choose among the conditions, or else to accept conclusions without accepting the conditions that justify them.

The conditions, or axioms, cannot be proven empirically or logically. Rather they must be "seen". A life of prayer, meditation, contemplation, and the development of detached self-awareness are necessary. Hence, we don't try to "prove" them.

A Tradition has two aspects: the esoteric & the exoteric. There is a horizontal isomorphism between the esoteric aspects of two Traditions. This represents the metaphysical teaching. Different traditions will have similar notions of Non-being, Being, the Absolute, the Infinite, Transcendence and the transcendentals such as the One, Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. There will be similar teachings on degrees of existence. There is a recognition that man, as he is born, falls far short of his potential and thus is in need of salvation or liberation. There will be a teaching on how to achieve that. Man's interior life is understood as multilayered, with various sheaths or souls. The macrocosm is reflected in his consciousness.

Thus esoteric practitioners of different traditions will have a common understanding, making dialogue between them possible and even

fruitful.

Within a Tradition, there is a vertical mapping between its esoteric and exoteric aspects. This is a mapping between the metaphysical teachings of the esoteric aspect and the religious-theological teachings of the exoteric aspect. Religious language is in the form of imagery in space-time unlike metaphysical teachings. Exoteric teachings recognize this, since they admit that its sacred teachings can be understood on multiple levels, the literal being the lowest. For example, Valentin Tomberg describes the second birth of the Logos in the soul, or the esoteric meaning of the Garden of Eden story.

Fundamental Conditions The first condition is that Tradition comes from above, from a super-human, transcendent source, as a revelation. Thus, it doesn't arise "from a people" like some folk dance, but rather it descends into a people, providing its spiritual formation.

Hence, no one "creates" a Tradition, least of all neopagan re-enactors.

The esoteric and exoteric aspects point to the doctrine of the two worlds. In the very first chapter of Revolt, Evola describes this as the "*fundamental doctrine*". Moreover, he says, in order to understand both Tradition and the modern world, it is necessary to begin with this doctrine. Apparently many readers of Evola treat the book like a mystery novel so they read the end first to find out "who dun it" while ignoring the clues at the beginning that would make it plausible.

Knowledge of these two worlds has always been present in every Tradition: viz., the World of Being and the World of Becoming. The inability to understand this distinction leads to many misunderstandings. The counter-tradition is seldom aware of this doctrine.

Manifestation The mapping of Tradition to its exoteric aspect is best understood as vertical causation, i.e., the descent of the Tradition from the World of Being to that of Becoming. Three things will result:

- The pure tradition will fall onto the two horizontal currents of material-physical and historical-psychological-cultural causes. What are called borrowings, mimicry, etc. in outward forms, myths, rites, and so on, are therefore perfectly normal. Pointing them out in an attempt to discredit a tradition makes no sense.
- Manifestation involves privation. That is, the features of the Tradition fail to manifest perfectly, leaving shortcomings in the exoteric forms. Hence, it is beside the point to point out historical or other shortcomings. In a decadent age, there will be many such shortcomings.
- The individual adherents of the Tradition form a statistical distribution, like, for example, a normal distribution or bell curve. Thus it is impossible to judge a Tradition fairly or adequately from its adherents because their own understanding and practices will vary widely. The Tradition is not judged by the individual, rather the Tradition judges the individual.

In other words, when discussing Tradition, it is necessary to be able to distinguish between the Essential and accidental qualities. The essential qualities pertain to the world of being and the accidental, to the world of becoming.

In particular, the Traditional doctrine itself is independent of any organization or of those who claim, within that organization, to be upholders of the Tradition. Hence, the persistent criticisms of certain accidental manifestations are characteristic of the counter-tradition.

Tradition and the Political System The purpose of the Tradition is salvation (exoteric) or liberation (esoteric), without going into the specifics of those terms right now. Its purpose is *definitely* not to support some political, racial, or secular goal as many seem to believe these days.

Rather, the first duty of the political system or power is to protect the spiritual tradition, allowing it to function in its roles as a means to salvation and as educator. The political power needs to maintain public order, protect the group against internal and external enemies, and support an economic order that ensures widespread prosperity. To accomplish those ends, the political power has wide latitude, as long as positive law is in conformance with moral and natural law.

The political power is responsible for matters of citizenship or immigration. If someone does not like some policy, for example, the blame goes to the temporal powers, not the spiritual authority.

Theocracy, patriarchy, hierarchy, transcendence, and sexual restraint characterize traditional societies.

- **Theocracy**. A traditional society is based first of all on spiritual unity. Secondary factors follow that. The attempts today to base a society on race or nation will fail, as long as the members believe any old thing. Spiritual Authority not based on force, which is the prerogative of the political power.

- **Patriarchy**. Societies used to be based on rule by fathers. A so-called "mannerbund" of unaffiliated men is a mirage.

- **Hierarchy**. Due to the statistical distribution of individuals in the process of manifesting, there will always be variations in knowledge, skills, etc. The attempt to reject hierarchy in the name of equality is misguided, since hierarchies of one sort of another will always arise. The issue, then, is to determine the best hierarchy.

- **Transcendence**. A traditional society recognizes the transcendent source of its existence. Attempts to base a society on science or atheism will be ineffective, because they can't define any rational purpose.

- **Sexual Restraint**. By contemporary standards, traditional societies are considered "puritanical" or "up tight". This is a large topic which we've addressed several times. What the modern mind cannot discern is the extant that artificially induced sexual excitement serves as a form of political and economic control.

The Revival of Neo-Paganism The counter-tradition denies the obvious examples of Tradition. In particular, these days, the Middle Ages are denied to be a Traditional civilization, e.g., by an Alain de Benoist[2] who, on the contrary, considers that civilization to be a disaster.

Au contraire, according to Guenon and Evola, it is normative for Europe and the modern world is the disaster. Nevertheless, Benoist's position has become an idée fixe[3] among otherwise intelligent men. They need an exorcism more than an argument.

The related part of that idea is the anachronistic tendency to criticize contemporary manifestations of the religion of the Middle Ages, as though they applied to that truly Traditional civilization.

Another ignorant criticism is to accuse the Medieval Tradition of some sort of cosmopolitanism. This disregards the pagan Stoics who first came up with the idea of the "Brotherhood of Man", and especially Alexander who himself promoted a brand of cosmopolitanism.

The idea of a "European" paganism is an anachronism. A universal doctrine or practice never existed. Europe never existed, except as a geographical designation. The pseudo-sophisticates of neo-paganism deny that the gods even exist, believing in that way that they can tame the world. True paganism was much more primitive. If you can find neo-pagans like those of Romans and Spartans[4] at war, let me know.

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[2] https://gornahoor.net/?p=8547

[3] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Id%C3%A9e_fixe_(psychology)

[4] https://gornahoor.net/?p=2024

The Decline of Tradition This is the hard one to swallow. A civilization declines — and many today believe that the nations of Europe and North America are in decline — not because of a "bad" tradition, but rather because the people themselves are in decline. The Tradition declines because its leaders decline.

Those seeking for some racial unity for Europe fail to realize that race is not a constant. As a part of the "world of becoming", it is subject to the vagaries of time and lower forces. Evola tried to point this out in his theory of the spiritual races: a Swede of today has a quite different inner spiritual quality from that of a Viking a millennium ago.

Hence, any sort of mass movement will fail to achieve its stated goal. The future belongs to the few, not the many.

The Future of Tradition **Joachim of Fiore**, recognized by **Dante** as being in Heaven, intuited three ages: the Age of the Father, the Age of the Son, and the Age of the Holy Spirit. Without going into all the details right here, we can point out two of his errors which, when corrected, give his vision more cogency. First of all, his attempt to give a precise date to the Third Age was misguided. Such things do not follow quantitative or chronological time, but rather sacred time. One must be attuned to the signs of the time to determine when ages begin and end.

The other misunderstanding is to assume that Joachim was describing some automatic process of human spiritual evolution into higher states. This leaves out his prophecy that there will be a period of tribulation before the Third Age. In other words, the Age of the Son brings the current age to an end, marked by a time of desolation.

Hence, the Age of the Holy Spirit is actually the beginning of a new cycle, not the final stage of some evolutionary process. If the first age was that of the fathers, then of priests, Joachim thought the Third Age would be that of an elite corps of contemplative monks. Actually, it is more likely that that corps will consist of men and women active in the

world, while transcending it.

Further Reading **Rene Guenon**: *The Crisis of the Modern World*. An early book that explains Tradition in the West.

Rene Guenon: *The Reign of Quantity and the Sign of the Times*. One of his last works, summarizing the obstacles to Tradition in the modern world.

Julius Evola: *The Revolt against the Modern World*. Builds on Guenon's works, adding more specific details.

Ananda Coomaraswamy: *Metaphysics*. This is a collection of his essays. *Vedanta and Western Tradition*[5] provides a reading list for Westerners to master before they will be ready to study the Vedanta. In particular, **Dante** and **Meister Eckhart** are held out as the exemplars of what the European mind is capable of.

Of course, the primary source should be the sacred writings, and those of the saints, mystics, and esoterists of your own Tradition.

Posted on 2016-08-25 by Cologero

[5] See Section 9.3 in this book.

15

Notes on Metaphysics

15.1 Logical Analysis Squared

Logical Analysis Squared = Logical Analysis of a Logical Analysis, from January, 2005. This was a commentary on Chapter 6 of Open Secret by **Wei Wu Wei** used as the talking points for a regularly meeting group discussing non-duality.

Point 1: Objects are only known as the result of reactions of the senses of sentient beings.

Commentary: The conventional wisdom is that something "out there", let's say an apple, interacts with our senses—visual, olfactory, tactile, for example—which then cause the nerves to send a signal to the brain which somehow recreates an image or copy of the apple in consciousness. This conception is problematical on several different levels. First of all, in this schema, we never actually see the "real" apple, we just have the image in our mind. No one can get out of the system to see the real apple out there and the image in here to compare the copy to the original. Therefore, the existence of the real apple out there is merely a

surmise, since all we know is the apple in consciousness.

Of course, it gets a little more complex than that. In this model, the nervous system is reacting to various wavelengths of light. If so, how does the mélange of various shades of reds and greens get recognized as an "apple". If we then take a bite out of it, the smell, taste, and texture in some unknown way combine with the visual sense so that we still recognize an "apple" in our minds. That means we must first have the concept "apple" in our minds and then be able to categorize all the sensory data under the concept "apple".

Point 2: The subject itself is not sensorially cognizable as an object.

Commentary: The subject does not appear in the world of appearances, so it is not known.

Point 3: Metaphysically unacceptable

Commentary: Metaphysics as the ultimate science claims to know what is true always and everywhere, in any possible world. As such, its tenets are certain, unlike physics, whose theories are always in principle falsifiable.

Point 4: There is no valid evidence for the existence of an external world

Commentary: Since what we call the "external" world is what appears in consciousness, which must be the consciousness of some sentient being, the external world is the sentient being.

Note: This does not mean that there is no objective world; the objective world is precisely what appears in consciousness.

Point 5: There is no factual evidence for the existence of sentient beings

Commentary: Of course, by this standard, only objects can appear in consciousness, not subjects. Therefore, the "subject" appears in consciousness as a concept. So who is there to be conscious?

Point 6: The definition of consciousness

Commentary: Consciousness can not be defined or demonstrated

or pointed out. Metaphysically, consciousness is the manifested aspect of the unmanifested. This is consistent with what we learned from Guenon's Multiple States of Being. So consciousness is beyond all concepts and there is no thing that the word "consciousness" can refer to. Consciousness is properly basic and is inexplicable in terms of something simpler. Therefore, it is fruitless to ask such questions as why do possibilities manifest?

Point 7: Consciousness as absence

Commentary: Consciousness is not a "thing". Rather, it is the clearing in which things (beings) appear. In consciousness, things are unconcealed (from unmanifested to manifested) and become present to us. This unconcealing (non-action, wei wu) is not the same as a "projecting" by the Mind of the world into consciousness. We take this unconcealing as the "real" world, failing to realize the infinite possibilities that remain concealed; clearly, if something is appearing in one way it is not appearing in myriad other possible ways. We identify with this limited world and maintain its communal existence by immersion in everydayness. Idle chit-chat and the popular media and culture serve to reinforce this limited view. We focus on novelty and fashions and celebrity gossip. Instead of seeing the Infinitude of reality as it is, we are constantly checking to see what "They" think, whether the "they" be our family, group, or whatever social unit we identify with.

Point 8: Intuition

Commentary: This is the answer to point 3 — the truth of metaphysics is not something that can be expressed mathematically, scientifically, conceptually, verbally, or logically (although it is logical). It must be grasped all at once in intuition. The phenomenal (apparent) universe is the noumenon manifesting in the consciousness of a self which itself is not an object in the phenomenal universe and so must be the noumenon itself.

Posted on 2006-10-26 by Cologero

15.2 Illusions

> And the independent reality of the individual, when we examine it, is in truth mere illusion. Apart from the community, what are separate men? It is the common mind within him which gives reality to the human being, and taken by himself, whatever else he is, he is no human ... If this is true of the social consciousness in its various forms, it is true certainly no less of that common mind which is more than social. The finite minds that in and for religion form one spiritual whole have indeed in the end no visible embodiment, and yet, except as members in an invisible community, they are nothing real. For religion, in short, if the one indwelling spirit is removed, there are no spirits left.
>
> F H Bradley, *Truth and Reality*

> Religious feeling must establish itself as a rational way of living. If ever the spirit is to be at home in this world, and not merely a prisoner or a fugitive, spiritual foundations must be laid deep and preserved worthily. Religion must express itself in reasonable thought, fruitful action and right social institutions.
>
> Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan

Types of Illusions There are three types of illusion:

- Optical (or perceptual) illusion
- Logical illusion
- Transcendental Illusion

Optical Illusion An optical illusion arises from a misperception. For example, one "sees" a snake in the grass. This illusion is dissolved when the perception is clarified. One then sees that the snake was really a harmless stick.

Logical Illusion A logical illusion is the result of a faulty chain of reasoning, resulting in an incorrect conclusion. When the logical mistake is pointed out — and understood — then the illusion ends and the proper conclusion reached.

Transcendental Illusion The third class of illusions is the transcendental illusion — that is, taking appearances (and space/time) as reality. However, even when one understands intellectually the falsity of the transcendental illusion, the illusion itself remains. Or does it? This seems to be the divide between Western and Eastern systems. Kant claimed the transcendental illusion was ineradicable, because the rational mind could not penetrate or conceive anything beyond that. The Eastern claim is that the illusion can disappear in a moment of intuitive insight.

Posted on 2006-10-27 by Cologero

* * *

Lyon on 2018-05-06 at 16:48 said:

Religious feeling must establish itself as a rational way of living. If ever the spirit is to be at home in this world, and not merely a prisoner or a fugitive, spiritual foundations must be laid deep and preserved worthily. Religion must express itself in reasonable thought, fruitful action and right social institutions.

Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan

Agreed.

There are three types of illusion:

Optical (or perceptual) illusion

Logical illusion

Transcendental Illusion

Also agree.
Good work!
Thanks.

15.3 Natural and Supernatural Happiness

> In any case, the important thing is to make the distinction, well known to traditional teachings, between the happiness or pleasure that is ardent, and that which is heroic ... The distinction corresponds to that between two opposite attitudes and two opposite human types. The first type of happiness or pleasure belongs to the naturalistic plane and is marked by passivity toward the world of impulses, instincts, passions, and inclinations. Tradition defines the basis of naturalistic existence as desire and thirst, and ardent pleasure is that which is tied to the satisfaction of desire in terms of a momentary dampening of the fire that drives life onward. Heroic pleasure, on the other hand, is that which accompanies a decisive action that comes from Being, from the plane superior to that of life...
>
> JULIUS EVOLA

> Humanity surges with uncontrolled passion, is tumultuous with ungoverned grief, is blown about by anxiety and doubt. Only the wise man, only he whose thoughts are controlled and purified, makes the winds and storms of the soul obey him.
>
> JAMES ALLEN, *As a Man Thinketh*

Natural Happiness Although the vast majority of people in all times and places has desired natural happiness, Tradition teaches that, in every age, there are a few who are called to transcend such desires and reach as state of peaceful bliss. Evola lists four motivating powers of desire.

Instinct Inborn desires that do not need to be taught.

Impulse A strong idea that creates desire.

Passion A strong emotion that creates desire.

Inclination Arbitrary likes and dislikes that lead to desire or aversion.

Instincts, impulses, passions, and inclinations create ardent desires that the natural man seeks to quench. This is always accompanied by the belief that the satisfaction of the desire will lead to happiness. However, although the natural or carnal man may experience happiness for a season, as soon as the fire is quenched, another desire—equally ardent—arises, again demanding satisfaction.

Desire and Volition To understand the "passive" and "active" forces in the face of desire, it is necessary to observe the process of conation clearly. The **Principle of Sufficient Reason** leads us to look for the reason for things and events; for example, this may be the logical necessity of a mathematical proof or the physical cause for things in the world. In the case of human action, it is the motive, or the reason a man gives to explain what he does.

A man, then, will have a motive to reach some result and he is free to choose the means to reach that result—in this limited sense he is "free". However, is he free to choose the very motive that drives his actions? If a man's consciousness is passive in respect to instincts, impulses, passions, and inclinations, then his motivations are formed by those factors external to him. In this much deeper sense, such a man is not free and is in bondage to forces arising outside him.

Detachment

> Detachment coexists with a fully lived experience; a calm being is constantly wedded to the substance of life. The consequence of this union, existentially speaking, is a most particular kind of lucid inebriation, one might almost say intellectualized and magnetic, which is the absolute opposite of what comes from the ecstatic opening to the world of elementary forces, instinct, and nature. In this very special inebriation, subtilized and clarified, is to be seen the vital element necessary for an existence in the free state, in a chaotic world abandoned to itself.
>
> J Evola

Supernatural happiness, or "heroic pleasure", or "lucid inebriation" is the effect of detachment. Detachment is not the same as withdrawal from life. Rather, the detached man is the active force in respect to life. No longer is he the puppet of instincts, impulses, passions, and inclinations. Instead, he is the center of awareness, the "unmoved mover", the observer. Instincts, impulses, passions, and inclinations become merely "options" and not fate, necessity, *"ananke"*.

Posted on 2007-09-07 by Cologero

* * *

Me on 2016-03-23 at 15:56 said:

"That exquisite poise of character which we call serenity is the last lesson culture; it is the flowering of life, the fruitage of the soul. It is precious as wisdom, more to be desired than gold – yea, than even fine gold. How insignificant mere money-seeking looks in comparison with a serene life – a life that dwells in the ocean of Truth, beneath the waves, beyond the reach of tempests, in the Eternal Calm!" (Allen)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nW8M6Km_baA

15.4 Occult Facts

> Existence is only real when it is conscious to somebody.
>
> Carl Jung

Suppose you observe two men, man A is aiming a gun at the man B whose arms are raised. As a strict positivist, who only accepts the evidence of the senses, that is the limit of what you can say about this "fact". But have you really explained anything?

Man A could be robbing man B in the street. Man A may be a police officer placing man B under arrest. Or perhaps Man A is a private citizen looking for his daughter whom Man B kidnapped. Three quite different stories about the same alleged fact.

A physicist may treat man A and man B as physical objects and try to predict their future actions based on their mass, momentum, and so on. Of course, he will fail. We cannot understand the scenario without taking into account human consciousness, particularly in its relation to social and political structures that would legitimize or criminalize the observed facts. Similarly, there are "spiritual" facts, of a totally different kind, and these require their own methodology. Consider Table 16.4.

Kingdom	Study	Influence	Occultism
Nature	Science	A	Mechanical
Man	Philosophy	B	Hygienic
Heaven	Religion	C	Eugenic

Table 15.1: Universal influences

First we have the traditional three kingdoms — nature, man, heaven — as expounded, for example, in the Tao Te Ching. Science, or positivism, is the study of nature in an external way, as a set of facts to observe and

theorize about. Depending on the object of study, we have physics, chemistry, biology, and sociology.

Philosophy, or idealism, is related to the second kingdom. Its method is the contemplation of concepts transcending the natural world. Such systems as the Vedanta, Buddhism, Pythagoreanism, Platonism, and Stoicism are the results of such contemplation.

Religion is not the result of purely human expression and creation. They enter the world as a revelation from a divine, supra-human, source. Certain of the world's religious traditions have preserved that revelation in a superior way, and it is these that deserve our special study.

Boris Mouravieff, in **Gnosis**, shows the three realms directly influence our world; he refers to these influences as the A influence, B influence, and C influence; all our ideas can be traced to one of these influences. Valentin Tomberg looks deeper into things, and claims to understand the hidden inner nature of these influences. These he calls "occultisms" and categorizes them as mechanical, hygienic, and eugenic. This study, he claims, leads to a higher positivism, where we achieve direct and certain knowledge of higher things; this he calls spiritual science. Julius Evola similarly claimed that there is a positivism of metaphysical wisdom.

So we see that facts don't speak for themselves and require a consciousness to penetrate into their inner nature.

Posted on 2010-03-15 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-03-20 at 03:20 said:

Since the topic of late has been Christian hermeticism I thought I'd ask, what do you make of Swedenborg? (People often don't mention him along with the others.) He definitely endorsed a higher positivism.

Cologero on 2010-03-22 at 05:34 said:

I've only read "Heaven and Hell", which I interpret symbolically, not as eye-witness accounts. The volume of his work is overwhelming, so it would be a huge task to understand him in full.

Nevertheless, the Martinists tend to think highly of him (along with the two Martins, Boehme, and Thomas a Kempis), so you are right, he has had an influence on certain streams of hermeticism.

Tantalizingly, Guenon makes a casual reference to him in his study of the esotericism of Dante. Regarding their descriptions of the Heavens and spiritually hierarchies, Guenon claims that an interesting concordance could be established between the conception of Dante and that of Swedenborg. I am not aware of any work that investigated that "interesting concordance" in depth ... could be a fascinating project for a young scholar.

As for the aspect of a spiritual positivism, Guenon points out this line from Dante:

"To see what is meant by this third heaven, I say by *haven* I mean science, and by *heavens*, sciences."

15.5 Chess and the Royal Art

Chess originated in India and made its way to Europe via the Persians and Arabs. It symbolizes the world as the play of divine powers with their respective armies of light and darkness: *devas* vs *asuras*, gods vs titans, or angels vs demons. Thus Chess is a game for *Kshatriyas*, or Warriors.

The king represents the Heart, or Spirit, while the other pieces represent the various faculties of the soul. The movements of the pieces correspond to the realization of cosmic possibilities represented by the chessboard, actually a type of mandala: the castles are masculine, the bishops feminine, and the jump of the knights is intuition.

Much is lost today, since few any longer have the patience to play or even the ability to understand chess. Instead, energy is devoted to computerized games, which don't represent the cosmic law, but rather the imaginary world construction of the game designer. Thus the will and intelligence of the player is secondary to the skills of the designer.

Chess, on the other hand, represents the ability of the player to make his own destiny based on his intelligence and will. Titus Burckhardt describes it:

> At each stage of the game, the player is free to choose between

> several possibilities, but each movement will entail a series of unavoidable consequences, so that necessity increasingly limits free choice, the end of the game being seen, not as the fruit of change, but as the result of rigorous laws.

While the player freely chooses his moves, they must be in conformance with the nature of the game. This applies, too, to our lives, which are played out in the world and need to conform to cosmic law, or Logos, to be successful. Only this gives us the freedom to create our destiny, as we can see that the outcome of the game is related to the choices we make. Burckhardt concludes:

> The **royal art** is to govern the world—outward and inward—in conformity with its own laws. This art presupposes wisdom, which is the knowledge of possibilities; now all possibilities are contained, in a synthetic manner, in the universal and divine Spirit. True wisdom is a more or less perfect identification with the Spirit (*purusha*), this latter being symbolized by the geometrical quality of the chessboard, seal of the essential unity of the cosmic possibilities. The Spirit is Truth; through Truth, man is free; outside Truth, he is the slave of fate. That is the teaching of the game of chess; the *Kshatriya* who gives himself over to it does not only find in it a pastime or a means of sublimating his warlike passion and his need for adventure, but also, according to his intellectual capacity, a speculative support, and a way that leads from action to contemplation.

Reference: "The Symbolism of Chess", by TITUS BURKHARDT, included in *Mirror of the Intellect*.

Posted on 2010-05-10 by Cologero

* * *

Richard the Lionheart on 2010-05-11 at 11:17 said:

Chess seems like something that could survive the end of the current cycle. Although the modern spirit has thoroughly "professionalized" the sport and made the game when played in that context about memorization as opposed to contemplation, once the knowledge that has broken the game is forgotten it could become a tool for displaying true achievement again. Either that, or a new variant could become popularized, as I'm sure the Indian version was different than the one that became known in the Holy Roman Empire.

larissa on 2010-05-17 at 19:14 said:

Titus you're smart–most people don't even know that chess originated in India–

Today however Indians don't produce much that is interesting after being under the Muslims for 700 years and then the British... all the glory and creative phase was before the semitization of India with the introduction of Middle Eastern religions such as Islam and Christianity which tells you that something terrible happened such that a productive, unique culture was destroyed such that it survives today in a spastic, sickly form... There is a spark still left there that has not quite died out despite the disruptions... Chess is a beautiful game... .

larissa on 2010-05-20 at 23:23 said:

I'm sorry but I thought above that Titus was the one who posted the snippet! Ignorant me!

larissa on 2010-05-20 at 23:26 said:

Now that I have discovered that there is a Titus very much worth reading... thanks Gornahoor!

GFJF on 2010-06-09 at 22:55 said:

It occurred to me that a game of chess can serve as a symbol for history and occult warfare: conscious agents directing their forces in ever more determined ways. A rough symbol, of course, since in real life there are no artificial beginnings or endings, and many more possible moves.

Cologero on 2010-06-14 at 20:59 said:

This leads to an interesting thought experiment. Give the primordial state (i.e., the initial position on the chess board), how did we get here, and who is directing the moves?

15.6 Intuition

Note: This originally was part of the notes for an open class in non-duality, given in the summer of 2005.

In **The Act of Creation**, Arthur Koestler writes:

> Not only scientists, painters, and musicians find it often difficult to convert their ideas into verbal currency, but writers too. Even H. G. Wells lamented: "The forceps of our minds are clumsy things and crush the truth a little in the course of taking hold of it." The novelist suffers from the poverty of his vocabulary when he tries to describe what his characters feel (as distinct from what they think or do). He can write streams of what goes on in the cranial cavity, but if it is a pain in the abdominal cavity, all he can say is 'it hurts' – or use some equally insipid synonym. Suffering is 'dumb'; the glandular and visceral processes which colour emotions do not lend themselves to verbal articulation.

In our verbal, hyper-rationalistic age, we privilege 'thinking' and 'doing', and consider 'feeling' to be merely subjective and therefore somehow less real. The opposite is actually the case. Our 'feelings' give us direct access to the inner workings of the cosmos, and our 'thinkings' and 'doings' are superimpositions.

Of course, to the writer Wells' chagrin, our feelings can only be known directly, in consciousness — this direct knowing is precisely what is being meant by the term "intuition". Basically, then, to know an emotion such as anger, or joy, or love, we must be angry, joyous, or loving; no verbal description or brain scan can replace that direct acquaintance. Furthermore, when we learn to experience the world as arising continuously in consciousness, we will then know the world directly, by intuition. And when we then come to know the Self that is the unchanging presence in every act of consciousness, we will be realized. It is that simple.

Posted on 2010-10-24 by Cologero

15.7 Quality

Note: This originally was part of the notes for an open class in non-duality, given in the summer of 2005.

One of the signs of the **Kali Yuga** is the displacement of Quality by Quantity. This is so pervasive that we may find it difficult to see the distinction between the quality "blue" in consciousness and the quantity of a certain wavelength of light. So we have scientists since Galileo deny that the "real" world has any color, smell, or other sensation. Philosophers claim that "beauty is in the eye of the beholder" and the "good is all relative." But if the scientist is not trying to manifest Truth, the artist Beauty, and the man of action Good, then what exactly are they doing?

Follow up Since there were a few computer scientists in the group, I asked for a solution to the problem of writing a computer program to detect the color "blue". Every one of them suggested hooking up a spectrometer and detecting the wavelengths characterized as blue (by, of course, the programmer); they saw no paradox in this. But the true solution would be for the computer to determine the wave lengths.

Posted on 2010-10-24 by Cologero

15.8 The Human Being

Plants and animals, since they have a determinative nature, have only to actualize that nature in the course of their lives. With man, it is different, since the human is a combination of being and non-being. Though a man starts with a certain nature, his potential is much vaster. So a man is not until he creates himself. Reality is not already "out there" waiting for us to contemplate it; rather it is a reality which

> waits for us to construct, a reality which is truly even now love and will, because it is the inward effort of the soul, its living process,

> not its ideal and external model... The world is no longer what is known but what is made and we begin to conceive the mind as freedom or moral activity... The whole world is a world which is what it should be, or a world ... essentially moral.
>
> Giovanni Gentile

Therefore, we see that the human is necessarily creative, and true creativity involves the manifestation of quality in the world. The truly creative are more attentive to the possibilities offered.

Note: This originally was part of the notes for an open class in non-duality, given in the summer of 2005.

Posted on 2010-10-24 by Cologero

15.9 Life of the Spirit

Originally published in November, 2005 for a private seminar studying non-dual writings.

> The race of the spirit predominant in a person, in a people, in a community, is given by the orienting characteristic assumed toward the sacred and the divine, life and death, destiny, the world.
>
> *Noi possediamo una verità, non una retorica.*
>
> We possess a truth, not a rhetoric.
>
> Julius Evola

The Traditional view is that man is a tripartite being: body, soul, and spirit. The body represents our phenomenal existence, the spirit our noumenal existence, and the soul — though phenomenal — is suspended between them.

The soul is the animating, or integrating, principle of the body. In a healthy personality, the soul dominates the body, and the soul is the expression of the spirit, reflecting its fundamental and orienting principles.

In a disordered personality, the center of gravity of consciousness may be situated in the body, and the existence of higher states is only dimly present to consciousness, or else totally denied. In such a state, then only the desires, pleasures, and pains of the body are of any significance.

If consciousness is centered in the soul, then life is dominated by either emotional states, or by a rationality that denies any sort of higher knowledge, wisdom, or gnosis.

If consciousness is centered in spirit, then the center is the noumenal self, the silent witness, the "unmoved mover", that is unaffected by anything in the phenomenal realm, yet is the source of all that manifests.

It is important, then, to realize that anything in manifestation is not by accident, but has its source, rationale, and *raison d'être* in spirit. In particular, one's gender, race, ethnicity, character, qualities, even historical circumstances are a reflection of this noumenal Self.

This is the esoteric understanding of "Karma": karma is not the result of some accident, or event, or act, nor is it imposed from the outside, so to speak, perhaps as some sort of punishment or reward. Rather, it arises out of the very nature of the Self and is its own self-expression in phenomena.

As noumenon, the Self is beyond Being, and therefore partakes of Non-being, that is, its unrealized possibilities. As life is the actualization of possibilities, this brings us to the esoteric meaning of "Dharma". Dharma is our destiny: our task, then, is to manifest the Self in phenomena, or to say it more plainly, to "become who we are".

To the exoteric mind, this is an outrage. It regards these differentiations as unfair and arbitrary. To be born a man or woman, a prince or pauper, good or evil is simply a genetic accident. It misunderstands the progressive unfolding of the higher Self in history as the evolution of the lower self to the higher self.

In this diagram[1], we can regard point N as the noumenal self and the plane as the phenomenal world. Every point on the sphere is projected onto a point on the plane, with its origin at point N; for example, Q maps to P', and R to P. S, the lower self, is the tangent point where the sphere meets the plane. Note, however, that point N itself does not map anywhere onto the plane, even though it is the source of all the projections.[2]

Fate, destiny, freedom: these three concepts can now be understood. Fate is necessity on the phenomenal plane: the present is determined by the past. Destiny is necessity in the noumenal sense; it is our dharma, what we are called to be(come). As such it differs from fate, which is necessity compelled from the outside, whether in the corporal sense as impulses from other bodies, or even in the soul sense, as impulses from psychological and other mental complexes.

Destiny in its fullest expression is self-determined, the Self-expression emanating from our deepest source. This is experienced as the mysterious source of creativity and will. Note that this is the esoteric meaning of "Freedom" — it does not mean that we could have chosen otherwise; rather it means that our choices emanate from our deepest self and are therefore self-determined — not "other" determined. If our choices arise from a conflict of other forces, whether spiritual and material, then such a choice cannot be said to be fully free.

Evola, in this book, intends to reveal the spiritual forces that drive world-historical events. These forces are analyzed both as micro forces acting on the individual and as macro forces acting on communities and nations. Referring back to the diagram above, most works of social analysis confine themselves to the plane of phenomena, and analyze the material, economic, and psychological forces to account for world events, as

[1]The image is no longer available in the original site. It is likely it is referring to the stereographical projection.

[2]The circle on the plane represents the lifespan of the Self in a particular plane of existence — more on this in due course.

though such an analysis exhausts all possibilities. For us, instead, we will focus on the "third" dimension — the spiritual dimension — and look at the occult, or hidden, forces that impinge upon the plane of phenomena.

Posted on 2011-04-12 by Cologero

* * *

HOO on 2011-04-13 at 23:10 said:
One of the best posts so far. O, sweet metaphysics.

15.10 Nonduality

Originally published in June, 2005 for an open seminar.

> In all of us there dwells a secret marvelous power of freeing ourselves from the changes of time, of withdrawing to our secret selves away from external things, and of so discovering to ourselves the eternal in us in the form of unchangeability. This presentation of ourselves to ourselves is the most truly personal experience upon which depends everything that we know of the supra-sensual world. This presentation shows us for the first time what real existence is, whilst all else only appears to be. It differs from every presentation of the sense in its perfect freedom, whilst all other presentations are bound, being overweighted by the burden of the object. Still there exists for those who have not this perfect freedom of the inner sense some approach to it, experiences approaching it from which they may gain some faint idea of it. ... This intellectual presentation occurs when we cease to be our own object, when, withdrawing into ourselves, the perceiving self merges in the self-perceived. At that moment we annihilate time and duration of time; we are no longer in time, but time, or rather eternity itself, is in us. The external world is no longer an object for us, but is lost in us.

Friedrich Schelling, *Philosophical Letters upon Dogmatism and Criticism*

Dual Vision In dualistic vision there is the so-called "real" world "out there, right now" and a more or less exact copy in consciousness. Unfortunately, no one can explain how the mind creates a copy of the world. Moreover, all the qualities that make up consciousness, such as color, smell, etc., are not properties of the objects themselves.

Philosophers then dispute whether the "I" is part of, or distinct from, the space-time continuum.

Nondual Vision In nondual vision, objects arise in consciousness, emanating from the Noumenon. The Witness watches this arising, yet is not the cause of it, nor is it among the objects that it witnesses. Therefore, it can never know itself as an object.

Superimposition In superimposition, the dualistic view is superimposed on the primordial nonduality, leading to a mistaken understanding of reality.

The empirical ego, itself simply another object in space-time, then posits itself as the true self, clouding the unchanging and transcendent witness.

Wei Wu Wei is prodding us to make this shift in awareness from centered in the empirical ego as object, to the transcendent witness as subject. This is not so much a task to be done, as a non-action to let happen.

Reference: *The Open Secret*, Wei Wu Wei

Posted on 2011-04-18 by Cologero

15.11 Ontogeny Recapitulates Phylogeny

> Judgment is between Apprehension and Appetite. First, a man apprehends a thing; then he judges it to be good or bad; then he pursues or avoids it accordingly. If therefore the Judgment guides the Appetite wholly, and in no way is forestalled by the Appetite, then is the Judgment free. But if the Appetite in any way at all forestalls the Judgment and guides it, then the Judgment cannot be free; it is not its own: it is captive to another power. Therefore the **brute beasts** cannot have freedom of Judgment; for in them the Appetite always forestalls the Judgments.
>
> It is therefore again manifest that this liberty, or this principle of all our liberty, is the greatest gift bestowed by God on mankind: by it alone we gain happiness as **men**: by it alone we gain happiness elsewhere as **gods**.
>
> Dante Alighieri, *De Monarchia*

In the 19th century, **Ernst Haeckel** popularized "**law or recapitulation**" by giving it an alleged scientific foundation. This law states that ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny, or in other words, the development of an individual organism follows the stages of the evolution of the species. To buttress his case, Haeckel provided tendentious drawings of embryonic development that still show up in biology textbooks to this day, despite being discredited by biologists. Nevertheless, this law has had wide influence, not least of all on **Rudolf Steiner** who referred to it with approval.

As understood in the strictly material sense, the law as stated is false. However, there is a metaphysical version of the law that is more promising and was actually held by **Thomas Aquinas**. In this exposition, the ontogeny of the individual follows the development of the soul from the human to the plant to the animal and to the human kingdoms. The

embryo begins as a biological and material being. It then develops the vegetative soul which governs its growth, nourishment, and development. Next comes the sensitive soul as the embryo feels its environment and initiates motion. Finally, in the human case, there is the rational soul which, as the form of the body, unifies the other souls and body. This is not a natural process. Since a material process cannot cause an immaterial substance as Aquinas claims.

This, however, is not the same as evolution. Priority does not just refer to temporal sequence. As long as one whose thinking is limited to time, then he cannot think like a metaphysician as **Rene Guenon** asserts. A more fundamental notion is ontological priority. Hence, we can say that the idea of the rational soul precedes the sensitive and vegetative souls and the body, although they appear in time in the reverse sequence. Here Aquinas' explanation seems somewhat shaky. He claims that the rational soul is created at the time it is infused with the body, replacing and including the other souls. First of all, phenomenological analysis shows that the three souls have a relative independence of each other.

By the priority of order, the rational soul should command the sensitive and vegetative souls. However, personal experience shows this not to be the case. It is only with great efforts that the priority of order can be developed. Aquinas makes it clear that man is not an accidental being. If the rational soul were created after the body, then their joining would be accidental. Hence, the idea of the soul is ontologically prior to the body. Aquinas takes pains not to admit the pre-existence of the soul. Nevertheless, we have to conclude that the idea of the soul is prior to the body, so their conjunction is necessary, not accidental.

In any case, the temporal pre-existence of the rational soul in this world makes no sense, which is all that Aquinas means. This is obvious since the rational soul is transcendent to the world process. But this does not preclude that the soul chooses and wills its incarnation. A fortiori, the very nature of the rational soul is intelligence, will, and freedom of

choice. To deny this would give credence to the argument that the fetus is not a person since it displays neither intelligence nor will.

The important point is that the rational soul is not an object in the world. Hence, misguided attempts to weigh the soul and take pictures of it leaving the body at death are necessarily measuring something else. As pure consciousness, the rational soul, or Intellect, is inexplicable in natural terms. In his book on the metaphysics of Dante, **Christian Moevs** writes:

> In medieval **hylomorphism** (the matter-form analysis of reality), pure Intellect (consciousness or awareness) is pure actuality, or form, or Being, or God: it is the self-subsistent principle that spawns or "contains" all finite being and experience. Intellect-Being is what is, unqualified, self-subsistent, attributeless, dimensionless. It has no extension in space or time; rather, it projects space-time "within" itself, as, analogously, a dreaming intelligence projects a dream-world, or a mind gives being to a thought.

Posted on 2012-01-08 by Cologero

15.12 Metaphysics of Dueling

In De Monarchia, **Dante**'s goal is to demonstrate that, in general, the power of the Emperor derives from God, and, more specifically, the Roman Empire was such by right. It is instructive to follow Dante's reasoning, as it challenges both the modern way of thinking, such as it is, as well as common misconceptions among those who identify themselves as Traditionalists. If he is a contender as the "greatest of Europeans", as Coomaraswamy claims, then anyone whose avowed goal is to "save Western Civilization" is duty and honour bound to understand Dante, to know what he is trying to save.

For Dante, the **Logos** created the world, which is therefore logical, reasonable, and orderly. Man is a **Rational Soul** who has the power to understand the Logos and hence its Will. Dante takes pains to demonstrate all his points with a logical argument. To buttress his points, Dante refers to secular and religious, Christian and Pagan, sources, as suit his purpose.

The fundamental first point to ponder is whether God, or the gods, are a force in the world. As **Rene Guenon** insists, everything that happens, does so necessarily and for a reason. The modern mind doubts that, believing instead that things occur randomly with no guiding purpose, in the mistaken belief that this is the more hard-nosed and logical way of thinking. To the contrary, to know something is to know its sufficient reason; that is the very definition of rationality.

The Ancients referred to the will of the gods as Fortune, "that agency which we more wisely and rightly name Divine Providence," as Dante claims. This aligns him more with Guenon, who in The Great Triad wrote of the interactions of Providence, Will, and Destiny[3]. Dante, therefore, takes pains to explain how to discern the Will of God, or Providence. He writes:

> For hunting down adequately the truth of our inquiry, it is essential to know that Divine judgment in human affairs is sometimes manifest to men, and sometimes hidden. And it may be manifested in two ways, namely, by reason and by faith.

Keep in mind that Reason is used in a wider sense than what is common today, as it includes the Practical Reason: duty, ethics, virtue, etc. Hence, as an example of knowing God's will by Reason, Dante provides examples from **Aristotle**. The Natural Law is itself Providential, as God is the Author of Nature. Some truths, for Dante, cannot be known by

[3] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1798

Reason alone, and for these he refers to Scripture. Nevertheless, there are some judgments of God that are hidden and inaccessible both to Reason and Revelation. These cases require a Special Grace to be known. These appear in two ways (along with various ways of manifesting):

1. **Simple revelation**
    - Spontaneous Act of God
        - Expressed directly
        - Expressed by a sign
    - Answer to Prayer
2. **Judicial award**
    - By lot
    - By contest
        - Duel, or contest of champions
        - The contest of athletes

It is not my intent at this time to dwell on the simple revelation, so I have simply summarized the ways that is may manifest itself. However, we should point out here that Dante's view in this regard is no different from the Ancients. In our series on the Ancient City, we documented how important actions were decided by prayer and signs or omens. **Constantine**'s victory was attended by a sign; to disbelieve this is a rather arbitrary decision.

Similarly, to make a decision by lot has an ancient heritage. Dante points out that the thirteenth Apostle to replace Judas was chosen by lot. (To be clear, it was not totally random, since the choice was between equally qualified candidates.) For Christians today to deny the discernment of God's will by drawing lots is also an arbitrary decision. It is well

worth pondering why many are discomfited by this. Perhaps because it seems unjust, but Dante makes clear that this is the last resort when the just result cannot be determined by Reason or Revelation. Yet if everything happens for a reason, that is, not by accident, then to what ought we attribute the winning of a lot? To be clear, this has nothing to do with gambling per se, where the players are interested in personal gain, only where there is a disinterested search for justice.

Dante points out that the word contest is derived from certare, "to make certain". As an example of the duel, Dante points to the story of **Hercules** and **Antaeus**, as told by **Lucan** and **Ovid**. As for the second, the example is the story of **Atalanta** and **Hippomenes**, again from Ovid. In the latter story Atalanta determines her husband from a footrace. That the winner is revealed by God's will is evident from the aid that Aphrodite provided to Hippomenes. This is how Dante justifies the duel:

> Whatever is acquired by single combat duel is acquired with Right. For when human judgment fails, either because it is wrapped in the darkness of ignorance or because it has not the aid of a judge, then, lest judgment should remain forsaken, recourse must be had to Him who so loved her that, by the shedding of His own blood, He met her full demands in death. Hence the Psalm: "The righteous Lord loveth righteousness." This end is accomplished when, with the free consent of the participants, in love and not in hatred of justice, the judgment of God is sought through a mutual trial of bodily and spiritual strength. Because it was first used in single combat of man to man, this trial of strength we call the duel.

However, the duel must be the last resort:

> But always in quarrels threatening to become matters of war, every effort should be made to settle the dispute through conference, and only as a last resort through battle. **Tully** and **Vegetius** both

> advance this opinion, the former in Moral Duties, and the latter in his book on The Art of War. And as in medical treatment everything is tried before final recourse is had to the knife or fire, so when we have exhausted all other ways of obtaining judgment in a dispute, we may finally turn to this remedy by single combat, compelled thereto by the necessity of justice.

That is the first rule of combat. The second is that the contestants enter the combat not in hatred, but in the "pure zeal for justice by common consent." Dante claims that under these conditions, they duelists meet in the name of God, hence God is present with them (according to the Gospels). And if God is present, then it would be a sin to deny that Justice can fail. If that is not a convincing argument, Dante points out that the Ancients believed the same thing, for which he uses the story of **Pyrrhus**' message to the Romans:

> I demand no gold, nor shall you render me a price; we are not barterers in war, but fighters; with steel, not with gold, let each decide the issue of life. Whether **Hera** wills that you or I shall reign, or whatever fate may bring, let us determine by prowess.

On the other hand, a duel should not be settled for a price which would be an injustice as God would not be present. To the objection that one party may be stronger than the other, Dante refers us to David and Goliath. Hence the conclusion: *whatever is acquired by a duel, is acquired with Right and Justice*.

Homework. Try to discern the workings of Providence in daily life. Act justly. Trial by lot or combat are now forbidden. Why? How much faith or trust in the Will of God, or the gods, would be required to stake everything on the outcome of the drawing of lots or a duel? Men were willing to die trying to be the husband of Atalanta.

Posted on 2012-01-10 by Cologero

* * *

logres on 2012-01-10 at 02:25 said:

Where two or three are gathered in my name...

Boreas on 2012-01-10 at 06:13 said:

"Homework. Try to discern the workings of Providence in daily life. Act justly."

synchro: I just forbade my dear daughter an ice cream dessert since she did not follow the rules of dining (sitting in the chair etc.) even after three warnings. I consider this as a just act. I gave my wife a possibility for mercy upon the matter, but as a good parent she declined although she'd wanted the dessert by herself also, yet couldn't have it since it would have caused trouble and arguments with a little girl in a non-rational emotional swing.

"Trial by lot or combat are now forbidden. Why?"

Since the Word of Logos is a penetrating sword and Justice uses the scales instead of a lot-cup.

HOO on 2012-01-10 at 11:01 said:

"Heroin Addict Prays to God for a Miracle – Watch What Happens"
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vn7_zJEJqww[4]

Cologero on 2012-01-10 at 12:52 said:

As Dante pointed out, Justice is often hidden, hence the use of the lot or combat. Do we really believe that all questions of justice have been settled and we no longer need to rely on Fortune or combat? That is hardly obvious, which brings us back to Dante's contention.

Hoo, no one is praying for a miracle, rather for justice. Isn't addiction the just result of taking heroin?

HOO on 2012-01-10 at 14:39 said:

miracle:

1. An event that appears inexplicable by the laws of nature and so is held to be supernatural in origin or an act of God.

2. One that excites admiring awe.

mid-12c., from O.Fr. miracle, from L. miraculum "object of wonder" (in Church L., "marvelous event caused by God"), from mirari "to wonder at," from mirus "wonderful," from *smeiros, from PIE *(s)mei- "to smile, be astonished" (cf. Skt. smerah "smiling," Gk. meidan "to smile," O.C.S. smejo "to laugh;" see smile). Replaced O.E. wundortacen, wundorweorc. The Greek words rendered as

[4] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vn7_zJEJqww

miracle in the English bibles were semeion "sign," teras "wonder," and dynamis "power," in Vulgate translated respectively as signum, prodigium, and virtus.

You were writing of Spontaneous Acts of God. I wait for a miracle.

And no heroin isn't addictive. However, frequent use can develop into severe psychological dependence and then addiction. As Jung said in this direction, all non-spiritual highs are a search for a replacement for spiritual highs (experiences), as indeed the search for spiritual "truth" is a replacement for knowledge of the veracit rites (actions that actualize experinces).

Boreas on 2012-01-10 at 15:05 said:

O' Fortuna, velut luna!

Fates (Urd, Verdandi & Skuld) and Fortuna decide and influence apparent co-incidences according to the hidden will of God. Justice, on the other hand, is many times blind and thus hidden. Combat and dueling is for men of honor in the case that other means don't suffice, usually influenced by Fates and the hidden will, and manifesting the call for Justice. "Luck" in the case of Victory is a hidden lustration and grace, apparently called out by Fate & a minifestation of supreme Justice.

The just result for taking heroin is intoxication.

Last but not the least, sorry about the long link, but this is a must:

Whether God plays dice[5]

Cologero on 2012-01-10 at 22:58 said:

Missing google page from whether God plays dice: summary of main points.

- quantities pertain to matter, qualities are indicative of essence or form
- space corresponds to the material and time to the formal aspect of the space-time continuum
- Prof Smith mentions the male-female complementarity as another example of hylomorphic polarities. We can point out that Guenon likens this to the Purusha-Prakriti teachings of the Vedanta schools.
- The next topic is yin-yang. Yin corresponds to matter, yang to form.
- yang is black and represents the unintelligible aspect of the thing or phenomenon. Yang refers to the intelligible aspect.

[5] https://books.google.com/books?id=JRWgUwJOj6oC&pg=PA95&dq=wolfgang+smith+god+plays+dice&hl=en&sa=X&ei=tgMNT6jIAoittgeOi-yvBQ&ved=0CDUQ6AEwAA#v=onepage&q&f=false

- but why, then, the black circle in the white field and vice versa? More is involved than complementarity. There must be a mutual indwelling (perichoresis). Prof Smith then claims this is the key to the problem of determinism.

Cologero on 2012-01-10 at 23:16 said:

Prof. Smith brings up good points.

So, Boreas, in the midst of our best laid plans, there arises Fortune or Luck, the dot of yin in the field of yang. In some circles there is too much emphasis on Solarity, to the detriment of full understanding. Alchemically, the marriage of the Solar and Lunar cannot be avoided.

Prof. Smith's discussion on natura naturata and natura naturans relates back to that strange dream I posted here in regards to the question of whether each moment of time is new or whether it is restrained by the preceding moment.

Jacob Boehme and Nicholas Berdyaev are good commentators on the void or abyss from which creativity flows.

Cologero on 2012-01-11 at 10:04 said:

For a contemporary example of the use of lots to make a judicial decision, please read this:

In 2006, American federal judge Gregory Presnell from the Middle District of Florida ordered opposing sides in a lengthy court case to settle a trivial (but lengthily debated) point over the appropriate place for a deposition using the game of rock-paper-scissors. 11 The ruling in Avista Management v. Wausau Underwriters stated:

Upon consideration of the Motion – the latest in a series of Gordian knots that the parties have been unable to untangle without enlisting the assistance of the federal courts – it is ORDERED that said Motion is DENIED. Instead, the Court will fashion a new form of alternative dispute resolution, to wit: at 4:00 P.M. on Friday, June 30, 2006, counsel shall convene at a neutral site agreeable to both parties. If counsel cannot agree on a neutral site, they shall meet on the front steps of the Sam M. Gibbons U.S. Courthouse, 801 North Florida Ave., Tampa, Florida 33602. Each lawyer shall be entitled to be accompanied by one paralegal who shall act as an attendant and witness. At that time and location, counsel shall engage in one game of "rock, paper, scissors." The winner of this engagement shall be entitled to select the location for the 30(b)(6) deposition to be held somewhere in Hillsborough County during the period July 11–12, 2006. 12

source: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rock-paper-scissors

Boreas on 2012-01-12 at 12:35 said:

Thanks for the summary and modification of the link, Cologero.

I must say that the miraculous healing-conversion of the heroin addict and the judicial decision in the comments of this post are truly American.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-12 at 13:10 said:
I thought his humility was very touching – such a small thing but the degree of gratitude shows how desperate he was feelig. Maybe not a full on miracle but certainly a sign and encouragement, such little things are what can get a person through a very hard time.... .

Boreas on 2012-01-12 at 18:02 said:
Yea, I meant no critique for the man's emotional response or following actions either.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-01-12 at 18:31 said:
no i didn't think you did Boreas, I just wanted to comment on the video as I watched it the other night but didn't say anything at the time

15.13 The Aumkara of The West

As is well known, the Mandukya Upanishad explicates the individual letters of the sacred monosyllable "AUM" as symbols of Atma within various states, and finally with the twelfth verse describes the AUM taken as a whole as the "state" of Turiya: the identity of Aum and the Self, the ineffable reality of Atma knowing Atma, for, by, and through Atma.

Recently, in his Living the Dream[6] essay, Cologero summarized the "description" of Turiya as found within the Vedanta Tradition, in "via negativia" language; with the important conclusion being drawn, that the state need be cultivated by mastering thought, and stilling the mind. As opposed to repeating those "descriptions" herein, readers may wish to review the respective entry before proceeding.

Since metaphysics as "Universal science" is not the "property" of any religious form, as Frithjof Schuon put it, one might then anticipate

[6] https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5811

within the Western Tradition to locate something equivalent or parallel to the elucidation of Aum. And indeed, with the Neo-Platonic "To Hen", The One, is such, a rather obvious ineffable equal of Atma or Para Brahman.

In his *Commentary on Plato's Parmenides*, Proclus explains that while there can really be no "name" to assign to the Principle he is speaking about, the best that can be done is to settle upon "hen", although calling it "The One" must never be understood as anything other than a place holder for what can never truly be named. Still, the word "hen" itself,

Proclus points out, contains some clues to assist our contemplations—clues moreover worth comparing with the Mandukya:

1. Proclus states the One is "beyond breath", "But the first of the things that emanate from it is represented by the rough breathing with which we utter 'hen'. Itself, it is unnamable, just as the breathing by itself is silent". The "A" of Aum is "all pervasive", unmanifest, yet the principle of all manifestation–while well near the Absolute, it still is not quite the metaphysical "beyond Being"; similarly, the hen cycle proceeds with "rough breathing"–primitive, the rudiments of all breath that could be breathed, and yet not indistinct enough to be not breath, or "beyond breath" (The One).

2. Proclus continues, "The second is represented by the utterable vowel which now becomes utterable with the breathing, and it in itself becomes both utterable and unutterable, unspeakable and speakable; for the procession of the second order of existence has to be mediated". Similarly, the "U" of Aum has the function of mediator in the Mandukya Upansishad, not just as occupying the central place within the word, but as the dream state (hence between waking and dreamless sleep), and more importantly by analogy, as the "psychic" world, the "Mundus Imaginalis" betwixt the corporeal and spiritual worlds. The "lower" bounds communicat-

ing with the corporeal; the "upper" bounds communicating with the spiritual, which is why Proclus calls it "utterable AND unutterable", "unspeakable AND speakable", as it participates in both directions.

3. "Third comes hen which contains the unsounding breathing and the soundable force of 'e' and the letter that goes with this, the consonant 'n', which represents in a converse way the same thing as breathing". As it "represents in a converse way" breathing, it is a return to breathing, which began with the "rough breathing" of hen (1); similarly, the "M" of Aum is in Mudukaya a type of return to the unmanifested in the "A", or the "beyond breath" at the initiatilization of hen.

4. Proclus concludes this section noting "The whole is a triad formed in this way: from this one derives a dyad, but behind the dyad there is a monad. But the first principle is beyond everything and not merely beyond this triad which is the first thing that comes after it... .that prior breathing which is the silent symbol of Being". This whole then, more than just sharing an accord with previous "descriptions" of Turiya as in the mentioned Cologero essay, is to be found only in a certain profound, "prior" (primordial) "silence".

Posted on 2013-02-20 by Frater M

15.14 Illusion and Spiritual Warfare

> The *Jagat* the total experience of the individual in the three states of existence appears to be true so long as Brahman, the substratum, the basis of all this creation, is not realized. It is like the illusion of silver in the mother-of-pearl.
>
> Shankara, *Atma Bodha*

We know ideas As we have seen, Shankara shows that our waking life is the product of a web of illusions. So without the realization of Brahman, there is no knowledge of reality. Hence what we know are merely ideas and images manufactured in the mind.

The knowledge of Brahman, in this sense, is the knowledge of the ideas in the Divine Mind, which is the substratum onto which the illusions are projected. When we know the ideas, we know the true essences of things.

World as prior and independent The most fundamental idea we believe is that "the world exists prior to and independent of my consciousness of it." A limited and finite self experiences its own privations as an obstacle to its manifestation. The struggle to manifest one's possibilities is what gives the world its moral dimension.

But what was the world like before any conscious beings experienced it? As astronomers gaze into the heavens, they identify stars, planets, asteroids, comets, moons, galaxies, black holes, and so on. But before the astronomer came into being to mark out the heavens in such a way, such things did not exist as such. The universe could only be a random collection of matter and energy. A "star" was only a particular agglomeration of matter and energy and had no independent existence as such.

Science as creative act In many circles, science is considered as the only, or most reliable, source of knowledge. Through mathematical models, it is believed an adequate picture of the world is achieved. However, maths is only on the dividing line; on the one hand, they are not physical, yet they are not essences.

So a scientific theory is a creation of the human mind that has the property that various phenomena can be deduced from the theory. This is called "saving the appearances." For example, we have the Newtonian model of the universe that for quite a while served very well in predicting

future events. For a couple of centuries, people assumed it provided a true picture of the universe.

However, it was eventually overturned by the Einsteinian model, which predicted events just as well as the Newtonian, but, in additional, correctly anticipated other phenomena that could not be explained by the earlier theory. Now many people, including professional philosophers, have told me that the Newtonian model is a good "approximation" to the Einsteinian, so in a sense it must be "true". This is to misunderstand the nature of a scientific theory which, by definition, saves the appearances. Would anyone be surprised to learn that a Shakespearian and an Italian sonnet both have 14 lines? Of course not, since that is its very definition.

Furthermore, that only makes sense if you restrict maths to arithmetic. But maths also includes geometry. Geometrically, the Newtonian and Einsteinian models are wildly divergent.

We deduce a world So this is a clue. The mind creates an illusory model of the world and from that, various things are deduced from it. That is, a human world is created based on the model and its necessary deductions. Various models are in conflict with each other, with no way to adjudicate them. Yet they are all illusory and only knowledge of Brahman is the ultimate resolution.

Debate of the Geometers For example, suppose a Euclidean and a non-Euclidean geometer engage in a debate? They both have consistent worldviews, within their own assumptions. Yet, there is no way for them to decide on the issue of the fifth postulate.

Will to power as fact If the Will to Power is considered as some metaphysical theory, it is clearly false. However, Nietzsche regarded it not as a theory, but as a fact. As a fact, it is simply obvious. In our example, the Euclidean geometer could point to his successes in surveying, perspective in

art, and many other applications as a demonstration of the power of his theory. The non-Euclidean could point to his successes in GPS systems.

Spiritual Warfare Spiritual warfare, then, is the battle of ideas. There are nine levels corresponding to the angelic hierarchies, in order to reach the pure essences. However, in addition to the creative force, there are destructive forces at each level. Since ideas in themselves have no power, the real battle takes place in consciousness. Until then, the idea is a possibility of manifestation, but without the human element, it does not manifest. It is therefore legitimate to see the battle on three levels. Every idea, or zeitgeist, etc., can be evaluated in these ways:

1. What is the prevailing idea, ideology, etc.? How does it comport with Tradition or revelation? Is it creative or destructive?

2. Who are the conscious agents of the ideology? That is, who, or what group, is aware of the ideology and actively promotes it. They know the purpose, goals, and ultimate consequences of the ideology.

3. Who are the unconscious agents of the ideology? These people or groups latch onto the ideology without understanding its source, purpose, or consequences. They have an emotional attachment but only a vague intellectual understanding. They are oblivious to any unintended consequences.

Arguments, logic, evidence, rhetoric, and persuasion serve only as tools in spiritual warfare and can never bring ultimate victory. Instead, what is necessary is awareness and the ability to overcome illusion. Of course, one must be clear about what constitutes "victory".

Posted on 2014-05-27 by Cologero

* * *

Caeliger on 2017-05-03 at 19:29 said:

Thank you for this, brother. I have just recently, after a phase of dualistic theism, perceived the faintest glimpse of the Universal. Guénon's The Multiple States of the Being and Evola's The Hermetic Tradition have helped me a lot, and I now see invisible correspondences where there was only darkness before. Forgive my enthusiasm, but when man first hears the cry of the Hidden Treasure, he is awe-struck.

15.15 Oriental Metaphysics

> The greatest of all lessons is to know one's self. For if one knows himself, he will know God; and knowing God, he will be made like God, not by wearing gold or long robes, but by well-doing, and by requiring as few things as possible.[7]
>
> Clement of Alexandria, *The Paedagogus*

> The soul is all that it knows.
>
> Aristotle, *On the Soul*

> The conceptions of Aristotle are in complete agreement with those of the East.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Man and his Becoming*

> Dear Unknown Friend, do not scorn mediaeval scholasticism. It is, in truth, as beautiful, as venerable and as inspiring as the great cathedrals that we have inherited from the Middle Ages. To it we owe a number of masterpieces of thought—thought in the

[7] https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/02093.htm

> light of faith. And, like all true masterpieces, those of mediaeval scholasticism are beneficial. They heal the disorientated, feverous and confused soul. What is at stake with scholasticism is God, the soul, freedom, immortality, salvation, good and evil. Therefore, do not despise mediaeval scholasticism, dear Unknown Friend; it is still of value.
>
> VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot*

In a letter to Guido De Giorgio[8], Rene Guenon mentioned that he had given a lecture to a study group at the Sorbonne in 1925[9]. This post is a summary of that lecture. In it, most of Guenon's main themes are covered. The text seems straight forward after a cursory reading, yet many people seem to struggle with the ideas. On the one hand, this may lead to confusion where there is none, and on the other, to widely speculative notions that have no basis in fact, and are, mere diversions.

Keep in mind that Guenon is not an original thinker, and, in his case, that would be a compliment. However, he has provided a valuable task of synthesis, and more importantly, he has demonstrated how metaphysical knowledge, which used to be known, has all but disappeared in the West. That does not mean, however, what many seem to think it means. The teachings are available in plain sight; what is missing, apparently, is how to transform rational knowledge into spiritual realization.

Metaphysics In itself, metaphysics is neither Eastern nor Western. Guenon deals with "Oriental" metaphysics because in the West such knowledge

> is a thing forgotten, generally ignored, and almost entirely lost, while in the East it still remains the object of effective knowledge.

[8] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4460`

[9] The text of that lecture can be found at Oriental Metaphysics: `https://www.gornahoor.net/library/OrientalMetaphysics.pdf`.

Guenon mentions specifically Hinduism, Taoism, and Islam where the true metaphysics can be found. In 1925, Guenon concedes that he was most familiar with Hindu metaphysics.

He is more sanguine about the East in 1925 than I am in 2020. China has been irreligious for four generations, and I have yet to meet a Chinese national familiar with Taoism. I don't know about the state of Islamic metaphysics; there are two mosques in town, but they don't advertise esoteric schools to the general public. At that time, Guenon did not consider Buddhism to be a valid tradition, although today it is more missionary than either Taoist or Islamic esoterism. Hinduism, on the other hand, is widely available in the West in the intervening years since Guenon's lecture.

I used to give talks and lead classes at a metaphysical bookstore in Deerfield Beach. There I met many Western students of Hindu doctrine, even gurus from India and their America acolytes. When I was leading a weekly class on Guenon, none of the Western Hindus recognized anything corresponding to their understanding. Usually, they were more interested in reincarnation, and even adopting Indian styles of dress and cuisine. Indian tech workers in the USA are typically more interested in technical subjects and practice their exoteric rites. I asked a group how many had read the Bhagavad Gita; the response was none. Guenon claims that is normative in Hinduism, since individuals absorb as much of the esoteric doctrine that suits their abilities.

So I decided to focus on the recovery of the Western Tradition. This decision is justified because Taoism and Islam are restricted, and there are too many fraudulent Hindu gurus in the West:

> these doctrines are reserved for a relatively restricted and closed elite [in Taoism and Islam]. This was also the case in the West in the Middle Ages, in an esotericism comparable in many respects to that of Islam and as purely metaphysical as the Islamic one; of this the moderns, for the most part, do not even suspect the

existence.

Western Metaphysics The notion of a common metaphysics across traditions was not unknown in the West, for example Medieval Scholasticism drew on:

- Pagan metaphysics, particularly Aristotle and Plato
- Influence of Arabic and Islamic Philosophy on the Latin West[10], including al-Fārābī, Avicenna, and Averroes
- Hebrew metaphysics, at least via Maimonides

Had they known about it, they probably would have included Hindu metaphysics. So Guenon is preaching to the choir here.

Intuition Reason is a human feature and thus is fully natural. If physics is the study or the natural world, then metaphysics is the study of the supernatural, i.e., what is beyond the human state. The method of knowing the supernatural is "intuition", that is, a direct understanding of metaphysical ideas. It is analogous to sensory intuition, but differs since it does not involve the senses. Intuition is beyond Reason, so that bookish knowledge is not at all what Guenon means. Nevertheless, such knowledge use usually necessary as preparation.

Realization Therefore, metaphysical doctrines must be "realized", not just "known". Specifically, they must be made "real" and to do so requires the transcendence of the merely human state. The indispensable means to such realization is **Concentration**. Guenon explains:

[10] `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/arabic-islamic-influence/`

> There is nothing in common between metaphysical realization and the means leading to it, or, if preferred, which prepare for it. This is why, moreover, no means are strictly or absolutely necessary; or at least there is only one indispensable preparation, and that is theoretical knowledge. This, on the other hand, cannot go far without a means which will play the most important and constant part: This means is *concentration*.

Many readers get hung up at this point. Instead of learning concentration, they believe that they just need to read yet another book to explain it. However, what they really need is to learn concentration, which is the very first thing an esoteric school will teach you. Unfortunately, there is no "method" or "recipe" for this, since the means "have to be adapted to the temperament of each individual and to his particular aptitudes and disposition." Perhaps it will be helpful to describe some particular exercises.

Soul Awareness. Aristotle and the Scholastics taught that plants, animals, and humans each add to the layers of the soul. These correspond to the sheaths or koshas of the Vedanta[11]. One can learn about them simply as a doctrine, using the faculty of Reason, or one can realize it through intellectual intuition.

To do that, one needs to learn to concentrate on the observation of one's inner states: i.e., all the sensations, emotions, fantasies, thoughts, etc. Through these observations, he will see directly the operations and interactions of the vegetative, sensitive, and intellectual souls. Obviously, that is a huge task and will take some time. We can't provide a guidebook here, but ultimately one wants to be able to become the master of one's inner states.

The Unmoved Mover. Guenon refers to Aristotle's notion of the unmoved mover several times in his writings. Specifically, this means the

[11] `https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=9647`

principle of manifestation, which is motion and action, must be actionless. As a concentration exercise, sit still and silently and passively observe whatever appears in consciousness. You should observe random changes. In the midst of them, try to find the "unmoved mover", that is, what does not change while everything else is changing.

Primordial State This realization of the integral individuality is described by all traditions as the restoration of what is called the "primordial state" which is regarded as man's true estate and which moreover escapes some of the limitations characteristic of the ordinary state, notably that of the temporal condition. The person who attains this "primordial state" is still only a human individual and is without effective possession of any supra-individual states; he is nevertheless freed from time and the apparent succession of things is transformed for him into simultaneity; he consciously possesses a faculty which is unknown to the ordinary man and which one might call the "sense of eternity."

This is of extreme importance, for he who is unable to leave the viewpoint of temporal succession and see everything in simultaneity is incapable of the least conception of the metaphysical order.

> Why this appellation of "primordial state"? It is because all traditions, including that of the West (for the Bible says nothing different) are in agreement in teaching that this state was originally normal for humanity, whereas the present state is merely the result of a fall, the effect of a progressive materialization which has occurred in the course of the ages, and throughout the duration of a particular cycle.

There is not much to add to this except for this point. In a lecture by a hand-picked student of a guru, she mentioned the Fall, but also said she did not know the reason for it. On the other hand, the dominant Western Tradition of the past two millennia does provide a deeper understanding, which can even be verified through its effects on consciousness.

Higher States The Primordial State is still a human state, so Guenon describes higher states, as summarized:

- **Ordinary Human state** = result of a fall
- **Primordial state** = realization of the integral individuality. Freed from time. Sense of eternity. Originally normative for the human
- **Supra-individual but still conditioned**. Includes substates in these categories:
  - Informal but still pertaining to manifested existence
  - Universality which is pure being
- Principle of all manifestation or Deliverance. "In this unconditioned state all other states of being find their place, but they are transformed and released from the special conditions which determined them as particular states."

Deliverance means being in possession of the fullness of one's own potentialities. It is the state of absolute plenitude. Limiting conditions, or privations, disappear. The human state is a mix of Act and Potency, or Essence and Existence. As the potential becomes actualised, one gets closer to God, for Whom there is not privation so Essence and Existence coincide.

Phenomena These states have nothing to do with woo-woo. That is, these states have nothing to do with preternatural phenomena, visions, healing, powers, out of body experiences, channeling, or other unusual happenings. These are still part of the physical, not metaphysical, order. Such phenomena do not in themselves indicate the states of metaphysical realisation, even should they appear as side-effects.

Source of Teachings Tradition has no human origin in time. It was known in the Primordial State but forgotten in the Fall. The Tradition has taken various exterior forms. Augustine recognized this in his claim that there is just one Religion, which is now called the Catholic religion, at least in the West.

Metaphysical knowledge, as well as the realization that will turn it into all that it truly ought to be, is thus possible everywhere and always. This means that initiation by an esoteric group is not strictly speaking necessary. We have already shown that it is not even sufficient.

Metaphysical realization cannot be achieved by human means alone. Rather, it is a gift and one can only prepare to receive and recognize it.

Posted on 2020-07-12 by Cologero

* * *

Adil on 2020-07-18 at 17:48 said:

"The Tradition has taken various exterior forms. Augustine recognized this in his claim that there is just one Religion, which is now called the Catholic religion."

This makes me think of the recent conversion of the Agia Sophia back into a mosque. The West (including Eastern Orthodox churches) have not been late to condemn this move. But in reality, what has changed? Agia Sophia was a mosque for 500 years, until it was turned into a secular museum. Inside it, you can see a blend of Islamic and Christian art. Now, it has once again been turned into a sacred space, instead of a poorly maintained museum piece with an entrance fee.

Don't get me wrong. Ideally, the cathedral would be used as a church, but history is what it is. This wasn't exactly unexpected. At least, somone will now feel responsible for the building, and perhaps not let it fall apart. If the west was serious with its critique, perhaps it could respond by forbidding any mosques in Europe, and turn the existing ones into museums?

15.16 Notes to Oriental Metaphysics

I've been cleaning up paperwork. I stumbled across some personal musings that go back decades. The topics then are similar to those of today,

although the approach was quite different. I also found some class notes for a discussion group on Oriental Metaphysics by Rene Guenon. They date back to November 2005. The audience was primarily Theosophists and Vedantists, who had little understanding of metaphysics. The following notes were geared to them. They are merely an introduction to certain concepts. I have only found the notes for the first class. In retrospect, further notes were probably not necessary as we went straight to the text.

> The consummation of the infinite End, therefore, consists merely in removing the illusion which make it seem yet unaccomplished. The good, the absolutely Good, is eternally accomplishing itself in the world: and the result is that it needs not wait upon us, but is already by implication, as well as in full actuality, accomplished. This is the illusion under which we live. It alone supplies at the same time the actualizing force on which the interest in the world reposes. In the course of its process the idea creates that illusion, by setting an antithesis to confront it; and its action consists in getting rid of the illusion which it has created. Only out of this error does the truth arise. In this fact lies the reconciliation with error and with finitude. Error or other-bine, when superseded, is sill a necessary dynamic element of truth; for truth can only be where it makes itself its own result.
>
> Hegel, *Logic*

> The dominant note of barbarism is will and that of culture, especially the culture influenced by Greek ideas, is reason or intellect, so that of Christendom is love.
>
> Martin D'Arcy, *The Mind and Heart of Love*

Aporia Aporia is an insoluble contradiction or paradox in a text's meanings. (The end result of dialog.)

Stages of Rationality



Figure 15.1: Losing one's head, finding ones' heart

- **Subrational.** The subrational is characterized by instinct, impulse, elan vital, unchecked will. Lacking an inner check or desires, subrational societies rely on custom and taboo to control behaviour. These often seem quite irrational to outsiders.

- **Rational.** Reason gives man much power of nature, and to a lesser extend, over his own passions. However, every assertion creates its opposite, every Yes a No, every Idea its antithesis. These antinomies result in interminable — and irresolvable — discussions. "Reasonable men can agree to disagree", which demonstrates, not the value of reason, but its impotence to lead to any kind of genuine knowledge.

- **Surparational.** The suprational, or metaphysical intuition, is above reason, yet not irrational. Dualities are resolved, and there is a genuine knowledge (gnosis). Identifying characteristics are:

    1. Conforms to experience
    2. Coherent
    3. Consistent with natural knowledge

Occam's Razor *One should not increase, beyond what is necessary, the number of entities required to explain anything.*

It is necessary to resist the temptation to postulate entities such as "higher" and "lower" minds, etc. The fundamental insight is to realize the unchanging and eternal that subtends every experience. This is the Witness, or Self, which is *not* a postulated entity, since it can never be an "object" to anything.

Reading a work like Oriental Metaphysics is in invitation to achieve such self-realization.

Degrees of Experience Here are some distinctions to keep in mind:

- **Metaphysical Intuition**. This is the realization of the Atman, Self, Witness. It is beyond any particular state of being, and beyond any particular experience. It is beyond nature.

- **Mystical Experience**. This is an experience of a state of being higher than the human state. Although such experiences may be rapturous, ecstatic, extraordinary, insightful, and peaceful, they still belong to the phenomenal realm. This is what distinguishes such an experience from metaphysical intuition.

- **Paranormal Experience**. This is an experience of the subtle (i.e., non-physical) realms of the human state.

- **Demonic Experience**. "Demons" are particular constellations of thought patterns that can influence behavior. Since the ego often identifies with such patterns, it considers them its own, and is in bondage to them. As such, this is akin to "demonic possession".

Guenon is careful to strongly distinguish Metaphysical Intuition from particular experiences. Mystical and paranormal experiences are still in the psychic or psychological realm.

Characteristic Signs

- **Ataraxy**. Tranquility, imperturbability. State of soul which is peaceful, undisturbed by events, either external, or even internal, such as thoughts, fantasies, desires, emotions.

- **Apatheia**. This is not the Stoic state of freedom from emotions, but rather freedom from "passions", rightly understood. They are negative emotions contrary to nature (not nature just limited to the physical!). Examples: conceit, gluttony, lust, vanity, greed, malice. Some emotions may or may not be contrary to nature, depending on their object: anger, hatred, sorrow, fear.

  Similarly, some legitimate pleasures and desires are not necessarily passions. One obvious example is the feeling of Bliss (Ananda) which accompanies metaphysical realization.

- **Agape**. More than friendship, family affection, or erotic attraction. This is spiritual love.

Lessons to be Learned It has been said that life is a school, where lessons are to be learned. If so, it is a strange sort of school where we are not only not given the answers to the question, we are not even given the questions. If lessons are to be learned, we seldom see it. Instead there are the same mistakes repeated, plans gone awry, potentials unfulfilled, resolutions broken, love unrequited.

Desire is insatiable, no sooner is one fulfilled, than a dozen others arise to take its place. If there is a lesson to learned, it must be this:

There is no solution within life.

Isn't this also Buddha's conclusion, or Jesus' assertion that "My kingdom is not of this world"? The solution is in another direction, unnatural, or better, supernatural (in the true meaning of this term). Therein lies deliverance.

Only the human state offers the possibility for deliverance (or Beatific Vision).

One Thing Needful With it, there is not doubt; without it, there is no understanding.

This is the realization of the Self that witnesses, but is not witnessed.

Prakriti (matter) brings into manifestation (multiplicity) Purusha (spirit).

What does the Witness witness when it is witnessing?

Posted on 2020-12-22 by Cologero

15.17 The Intellectual Love of God

> A common man marvels at uncommon things; a wise man marvels at the commonplace.
>
> Confucius

> Men employ their reason to defend conclusions arrived at by reason, but conclusions arrived at by the passions are defended by the passions.
>
> Benedict de Spinoza

Realizing that the drug culture was no path worth following, I turned to Hindu philosophy and learning meditation and yoga practices. **Alan Watts** was the bridge to this; the older brother of a friend of mine used to hand out Watts' *The Book: On the Taboo against Knowing Who You Are*, which I eventually read. I read all his books, finding I preferred his early books, promoting a sort of Vedantized Christianity. That is where I first encountered the name of "Rene Guenon". However, his books were

unavailable and he was otherwise quite obscure. The name was filed away for quite some time.

Hence, I studied Vivekananda, Ramakrishna, Nisargadatta, Aurobindo, Maharishi Mahesh Yogi, Paramahansa Yogananda, as well as westerners such as Bubba Free John. I noticed that those around me would adopt Indian ways, such as manner of dress and diet. These superficial aspects were much easier than penetrating into the heart of the Vedanta. This was opposed to my goal of incorporating the metaphysics of the Vedanta into the West. I also reasoned along these lines, since it coincided with the beginning of the Neo-Christian revival. If I were an Indian, I would most likely be unable to distinguish these TV evangelists from the deepest of Western thinkers. So, of all the visiting Gurus, how could I tell the most authentic? I couldn't go to India to visit these men.

That is when I turned to **Benedict de Spinoza**. As someone who had written his 10th grade term paper on Russell's and Whitehead's *Principia Mathematica*, the claim that the foundations of man, God, and the universe could unfold logically from first principles was quite appealing. I spent some time going through the Ethics line by line. This, in itself, was a transformative process. Obviously, no one today can agree on what Spinoza actually meant. As I am writing from memory, I won't try to defend my own rather mystical interpretation, although it does seem to have its supporters. Rather, the subjective impact is what matters.

First of all, Spinoza was admirable as a man, so I modeled some of his character. There was his commitment to logic and reasoning, but he didn't preclude a higher form of knowledge. He worked independently as a lens grinder. So I, too, valued my economic independence and sought a technical career. When a man is forced to deal with the material world, affect it, and transform it, he is usually protected from the airy impractical ideas of the so-called intelligentsia. It appealed to me, too, that Spinoza was described by some as an "atheist", yet by others as a "God-intoxicated man". That perhaps is as it should be.

If I was reading the Vedanta into Spinoza at that time, I probably now read Guenon into him. This is not without justification. Spinoza can be read as one of the early moderns, or else as one of the last medievals, incorporating the rich philosophy of Moorish Spain into his own system, or even a Cabbalist as some claim. The Italian writer, **Piero di Vona**, whose book Evola Guenon De Giorgio is an invaluable resource, claims that Guenon was influenced by Spinoza in significant ways. That Guenon was familiar with Spinoza is true enough, since he is frequently mentioned, but not in a positive way. Nevertheless, there are points of contact. Unfortunately, I haven't been able to locate di Vona's monograph on the topic for a full treatment of the question.

Stanislaus de Guaita was one of the leaders of the French Hermetic revival and was well known to Guenon. In The Temple of Satan, he wrote:

> It is the **High Science**, what Spinoza magnificently defined as regarding objects *sub specie aeternitatis* [under the aspect of eternity].

So we see that that circle regarded Spinoza highly, and "regarding objects *sub specie aeternitatis*" is a fundamental point for Guenon.

In Spinoza's teaching, God is the fundamental reality, in which essence and existence coincide; this does not really differ from the Western understanding. God has an indefinite number of attributes, but only two of which — Thought and Extension — are known to us. But what we experience are not the attributes directly, but their modes, or modifications. Oddly, Thought and Extension have no interaction between them. Hence, we can know the world entirely through its material processes, or else through the interplay of ideas. Either would be correct.

In conformity with Western metaphysics and Tradition, Spinoza recognized three forms of knowledge; *opinion*, or knowledge of sensual things; *reason*; and *intuition*, the direct grasp of things understood from God's

perspective. There are three types of men corresponding to the three ways of knowing:

- the **ignorant** [ignarus], who only have opinions
- the **free man** [homo liber], guided by reason
- the **sage** [sapiens], who understands through intuition

In this schema, "reason", for most men, is a higher state of consciousness, well worth pursuing. Intuition does not contradict reason, but moves beyond it. This differs from New Age thinking which wants to dispense with Reason, hence intuition can mean any old thing. A woman recently told me she has "hunches", which she regards as access to higher knowledge.

For Spinoza, God is known through the laws of Nature. Unlike common people, who can only understand God through the miraculous and the unusual, the sage knows him through regularity. The same applies to man, as Spinoza devotes much of the book to the understanding of the emotions or passions. Now a "passion" is passive, something undergone. When a passion is understood intuitively, i.e., from the aspect of eternity, one is conscious of and above that passion. This is a skill to be learned: when faced with a strong emotional experience, say of Anger or Anxiety, try to remain conscious of that experience, detaching from it, watching it as one would the clouds passing overhead. The bad experience will often dissipate.

In the third state of knowledge, there is the emotional experience of the Intellectual Love of God. Unlike the passions, this is an active state of Joy. Such a being

> is hardly troubled in spirit, but being, by a certain eternal necessity, conscious of himself, and of God, and of things, he never ceases to be, but always possess true peace of mind.

This is the same as the experience of Brahman, or Sat-Chit-Ananda, or Being (God), Consciousness, joy or peace of mind.

Like Guenon, Spinoza says there are possibilities of manifestation and non-manifestation. What is possible must also be actual. Hence that which can be rationally conceived must also happen; this is consistent with the independence of the two attributes. But, on the other hand, not every passing thought represents a possibility of manifestation. This is more difficult to grasp than it seems at a quick look.

A very intelligent friend recently told me it is conceivable that a wealthy man, tired of life, would commit suicide; but prior to that, he would have put my friend in his will, thus making him rich. I challenged him, so he tried to put together a coherent narrative. Yet the devil is in the details, the holes in the narrative. A real possibility necessarily will manifest.

How can Spinoza be improved? Perhaps, we can regard the Attributes as gross and subtle manifestation. Then we could understand the other unnamed attributes as higher states of non-formal manifestation as Guenon does.

Update:
In The Sacred Heart & the Legend of the Holy Grail, Guenon writes:

> It is then said that the Grail was entrusted to Adam in the Terrestrial Paradise, but that at the time of his fall Adam lost it in his turn for he could not take it with him when he was cast out of Eden; and this also becomes very clear in light of what we have just indicated: man, separated from his original center through his own fault, found himself henceforth confined to the temporal sphere; he could no longer regain the unique point from which *all things are contemplated under the aspect of eternity*.

It seems that Guenon and Spinoza mean the same thing by that phrase.

Posted on 2012-06-27 by Cologero

* * *

Aghorable on 2012-06-28 at 01:02 said:

"Realizing that the drug culture was no path worth following, I turned to Hindu philosophy and learning meditation and yoga practices…"

Looks like someone didn't get the memo:

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Religious_and_spiritual_use_of_cannabis

Cologero on 2012-06-28 at 08:57 said:

Au contraire, Aghorable, I have made the pilgrimage to Bob Marley's house in Kingston. The bullet holes are still visible in the wall. Jamaica is a very spiritual country.

Aghorable on 2012-06-28 at 18:57 said:

The above are actually Hindu Sadhus making offerings to Shiva.

But it is quite interesting that you bring up the Rastafari movement, the pièce de résistance of the black man's charismatic cults. It's almost believable that you've made the pilgrimage, given the historical relations between the Ethiops and Italians; bickering like forlorn lovers last century! This area, with its actions and extensive reactions, could be fertile ground for a study of the occult war.

Izak on 2012-06-28 at 19:12 said:

Actually – without wanting to derail this discussion altogether – are there any available discussions on the charismatic black movements, from a traditional perspective? You have the Rastafari, the 5% Nation, the Nation of Islam, the Black Hebrew Israelites… all of these seem like various aspects of the greater counter-traditional distortion, but they're utterly fascinating nonetheless.

Cologero on 2012-06-28 at 23:12 said:

Aghorable, you are struggling to make a point, but it is alluding you. Let's assume the goal is an "intellectual conversion" or "liberation" as understood by the Traditional writers. What is the message of the memo? Obviously, it is not sufficient, otherwise enlightenment would be quite common. But is it necessary? That would be a hard case to make. So, at best, it is somewhat of an optional distraction.

As for Ethiopia, it has an ancient culture, not well known outside its boundaries. Mussolini was so desperate to create an Italian Empire, he settled on Ethiopia. It was more difficult than expected, given the intrigues of the French and British. Since boys will be boys, he had to pass an anti-miscegenation law back home, in order not to upset his new alliance with the Third Reich.

I absolutely made the pilgrimage. I found myself in Kingston, for reasons I cannot make public. What other attraction do you think is there?

Cologero on 2012-06-28 at 23:25 said:

Izak, I'm not aware that those groups have provided sufficient written documents, or, if they have, their categories of thought may not correspond to what is "expected" in Guenonian terms. You neglected to mention Santeria, which is more common in my area. I have visited Botanicas, but not yet witnessed a ritual despite some inquiries. Would you compare these movements to white neo-pagan movements? Or are they of a totally different order?

P.S. I just looked up the 5% group. Curiously, like Spinoza, they assign people into three similar categories, with their own notion of an "elite".

Aghorable on 2012-06-29 at 00:54 said:

Dear Cologero, read not too much into my 'memo' comment, it was a humorous play following on the dissenting opinions of some readers concerning your firm stance on intoxicants, saying tongue-in-cheek that the pictured pursuant of Mok?a didn't receive the memo, not that you were failing to understand something. If you ask whether drug use is necessary in the pursuit of liberation, it most certainly is not; we know that the one indispensable criterion is the establishment of an effective initiatory connection to a living spiritual center, and even this necessity is not so rigidly specified that it has to happen in a comparable way for all aspirants.

But we can leave drug use to one side for now, it is very much a secondary matter that has been dealt with sufficiently here and in an excellent chapter of Cavalcare la Tigre. If anyone wants to develop dialogue on the matter, the forum is still available.

You will forgive our interpretation of sarcasm where there was none, in your comment on Bob Marley and Jamaica. I'm sure it wouldn't take us long to think of a few other attractions Kingston has to offer! To name just one; savouring a nice cup of Blue Mountain coffee. Were you received hospitably by the general population?

Cologero on 2012-06-29 at 14:16 said:

Kingston is divided into two parts. Nestled in the hills are expensive houses, while down below there is the core of the city. We made a motor trip up the mountains, but had to turn back when the road was blocked. There were no Starbucks along the way. After that, I was not in the mood for coffee.

My hostess lived in a large home high up the hill with an armed security guard watching the driveway at all times. Whenever we got near the "general population", we were asked to raise up the windows of the limo and lock the doors. Some of the "general population" were kind enough to wash the windshield at red lights, but they got no tips because no one dared open up a window.

Probably not the best way to experience Jamaica, but I got an inkling as to how our government thinks.

Izak on 2012-06-30 at 15:44 said:

Cologero – I'd only compare them to the quasi-nationalist white pagan movements, although they must be fairly benign, since modern society treats them with plenty of kindness. My only interest is really in the more militant black spiritual movements, and they all appear to be personalists who believe in a single God (and therefore absorb the Semitic tradition), whereas the more militant white pagan movements appear to be impersonalists who believe in some sort of natural force whose various aspects are represented by different Gods in old myths, and they reject the Semitic tradition. They all appear to see Christianity as a grotesque aberration from true traditional practice. But when I say all of this, I'm speaking as a complete outsider. My only knowledge of the Black Hebrew Israelites is from watching their presentations on public cable access TV, wherein I learned that they believe that the King James version of the Bible is the most authoritative and trustworthy translation (because it contains more references to the Israelites being black), and they really take Song of Solomon 1:5 to heart. The 5% Nation I'm only really familiar with through their wikipedia page, and the lyrics and imagery of their musicians, most of which are amusing but seemingly incoherent.

Some more research into the matter could be fruitful… if not just because all of these groups seem to be dissenting from the more peaceful globalist sentimentalism of the New Age groups and similar movements, and therefore might resemble some undesirable outgrowths for the greater counter-traditional process.

Cologero on 2012-07-01 at 22:50 said:

Izak, it always struck me as curious that Guenon would devote an entire essay on Mormonism; I can't imagine Mormonism had any influence at all in France of the 1920s. Clearly, he read through their literature and he had his reasons. So I am sure your idea has merit, if only for the reason you propose: opposition to globalism will arise where least expected. Unless those groups have published some sort of catechism, it would be a time consuming task.

15.18 Space Aliens, Pigs, Roosters, and Snakes

> For we know that the whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now.

Romans 8:22

Every now and then, this question comes up among some smart people: are there other planets in the Cosmos on which "man" did not fall? Obviously, this naively assumes that the notions of man and the universe are perfectly clear. It also assumes that a pre-fallen world is in historical, geographical, and scientific continuity its fallen counterpart.

On the contrary, the Fall of Adam affects all of creation, not just planet Earth. That seems to require that the pre-fallen world transcends the world as we now know it. Since no one believes in a flat Earth, then it is just as absurd to believe in a flat Cosmos. Rather, the esoteric teaching is that there is a vertical, as well as a horizontal, dimension to the Cosmos. Although the notion is common in alchemical and Hermetic texts, this is best illustrated in **Dante**'s *Divine Comedy*.

The Three Poisons I used to spend many hours meditating on the Buddhist wheel of life, which represents all of creation. At its center, there are three animals representing the three poisons of the life of all sentient beings, not just earthbound humans. These are:

- **Ignorance**, represented by the pig
- **Malice**, represented by the snake
- **Concupiscence**, represented by the rooster

There are easily recognizable as the effects of the Fall of Adam. The Buddha recognized these poisons at the core of creation, but did not, and could not have, understood the original cause. In that scheme, the only answer is that they are the results of karma from previous lives. But does that not require an initial life at some previous point, a life that did not suffer from such defects?

Yet, even when he knows, and seems to understand, these poisons and their dangers, the chela finds he is still unable to overcome them. That is due to "weakness", the fourth effect of the Fall, but omitted in the Bhavacakra. The chela's guru will again attribute his weakness to a past life. Hence, the chela is stuck on the wheel.

Buddhism goes quite far in its understanding, but it falls short without the notion of grace, which is the antidote to weakness. Like the Buddha, Christ shows the way, but unlike the Buddha, he provides the Power.

As a practical matter, it has proven very difficult to even conceive of the life of a pre-fallen being. In popular culture, including the many movies and TV shows about aliens, they always act as though they had already consumed the poisons.

Moreover, the same applies a fortiori to androids. With all the chatter in vogue today about Artificial Intelligence threatening the human race, one would expect a better idea of its capabilities. An android, at best, would be capable of simulating the rational part of the human mind, although it would lack all interiority. Nevertheless, in films like *Ex Machina*[12] and in HBO's *Westworld*, the androids display all the effects of the poisons.

Both of those are examples of the fear engendered by the Sorcerer's Apprentice: man's creations will turn on him. It also shows how we judge by appearances, not by truth. "If it looks human, it must be human." As I predicted some time ago (an easy prediction, of course), the first uses of androids will be for sex and for war. Sexbots are already for sale, and videos of dolls resembling attractive women are readily found. However, what will happen when sexbots are designed to simulate those few sexual acts that are still considered perverse in contemporary culture? Please, don't try to imagine it.

The danger is subconsciously recognized, although it does not arise from the androids, but rather from concupiscence not regulated by real-

[12] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=8390`

ity.

The Human Kingdom The Traditional view is that there are four kingdoms of manifest beings: Mineral, Plant, Animal, and Human. Flatland science regards human beings as just another species of animal life. That opinion is forced due to its limitation to appearances, DNA, homologous characteristics, in short, any and all exterior features.

When we turn to the qualitative features, i.e., interiority, the situation is quite different. Then, we see that the human being is not a type of animal, but a kingdom unto itself. A fortiori, any alien visitors from outer space, assuming they have these features, will be species of the human kingdom, no matter how their external form might appear.

Specifically, they will be fallen humans, subject to the three laws. The Eastern teachings from Yoga, the Vedanta, and the Tantras provide a detailed map of the inner life. Chart 16.2 shows the main features of that map, including the Western equivalent. I've slightly slanted it to be more aligned with Hermetic teachings, although without distorting it.

The three bodies correspond to three degrees of manifestation: gross, subtle, and formless. They can be regarded as sheaths over an inner core. The subtle body itself is further subdivided. Note that plant life has only the pranamaya sheath and animal life adds the manomaya kosha. The latter can be further divided into emotional and mental parts. The lower the life form, the less there is of the mental part.

The *vihnanamaya* sheath, or intellective soul, is less easily recognizable without proper training. It is the center that grasps essences. The rational center, which most people assume to be the limit of intelligence, can only understand individual events, which it then constructs into a whole. Hence, in this view, a table is "made" of atoms, an animal is made of genes, and so one.

The intuitive power is synthetic and grasps the whole. In its view, the higher creates the lower, not vice versa. A human being differs radically

Yogic body	Sheaths		Western
Karana-sarira or causal body	Anandamaya kosha		Spirit
Sukshma-sarira or subtle body	Vijnanamaya kosha	**Intellect** Intellective soul Intuition	Soul
	Manomaya kosha	**Mind** Sensitive soul Reason, ego, common sense	
	Pranamaya kosha	**Elan vital** Vegetative soul	
Shula-sarira or gross body	Annamaya kosha		Body

Table 15.2: Map of Inner Life

from an android, because the human has an inner unity while an android is composed of parts. Its unity is built into from the outside.

So, an alien that is a metaphysical human being, would be composed of all those sheaths. Now a science fiction writer, who understands metaphysics, could do literary experiments with the bodies and sheaths. A very intelligent animal could conceivably lack the causal body and intellective soul, while having a highly developed rational part. It could easily pass the "Turing test", and there probably have been such beings on the earth. Attempts to create characters without an emotional center have not been very convincing.

Incarnation The mathematician and metaphysician, **Wolfgang Smith**, has done much to recover the traditional teaching of a multi-leveled cos-

mos, while integrating the concept with the latest scientific theories. For example, he shows that the body must be conceived not just as a corporeal entity, that is, as the shula-sarira in isolation. A lived body is energized by the vegetative soul, and that only is alive. Otherwise, the body is no more than a corpse. That soul is the body as experienced interiorly.

In addition, there is the physical substratum or body, i.e., the one studied by science solely through its quantitative techniques. The physical body is understood as neurons, biochemicals, and so on. Note that this is definitely not to be identified with the corporeal body which is in our daily experience. The pranamaya bonds with the corporeal, not the physical, body.

Now the Western teaching is that the intellectual soul (which would include the lower souls) bonds with the zygote at conception. The homolog to that in the pagan world was the story of Er who chose which body to incarnate into. The result of that compound is that the intellectual soul does not have full control over the lower forces, since the body has a separate inception. There is then a privation, since existence in the physical world resists the activity of the human essence. The human task is to bring more of his being under control of the Self. In psychological terms, the Self seeks to synthesize the unconscious with the conscious.

Note that Adam did not come from a zygote, so that his intellective soul had complete power over the body. This subtle body has four qualities: impassibility, agility, subtlety, and clarity[13]. This body can move at will by the power of thought, physical objects are impervious to it, and it does not suffer. You can get a sense of the subtle body in your dream life, if you pay attention. In a multi-leveled cosmos, the subtle body is a corporeal entity that exists apart from a physical substratum.

There is a lingering feeling, or longing, for that body as our true Being. There are many stories of saints who could levitate, bilocate, or read souls. The Chinese wuxia tradition is replete with Taoist masters with

[13] `http://www.newadvent.org/summa/4045.htm`

remarkable powers. Those are gained through an inner discipline of the mind and spirit. The *Bene Gesserit* group in the Dune stories is not much different.

Alien Teachings So what can spacemen teach us earthlings? The schema just described does not depend on remarkable intelligence or high technical skill. These little green men will have the same problems dealing with the Fall that we have. There are two possibilities.

There are common sense tips, but we really don't need aliens for them. I have a birth certificate from Earth, and I can mention some. Don't get hooked on opioids, don't bomb children. That is merely a start. You can give the knowledge, but there is no easy cure for weakness.

Then, they could possibly provide us with extraordinary knowledge about philosophy, physics, black holes, disease prevention, economic systems, how to cook scrambled eggs (cream or no cream). But, seriously, how many people will understand? It is a futile endeavor, which I learned quite a while ago when I tried to teach freshman algebra and chemistry to education and phys ed majors.

There are two belief systems. The modern view is that all will be known in the indefinite future. The traditional view is that all important knowledge has been given to us already, but has been forgotten.

Which spiritual teacher will give us the answer to that dilemma?

Reference for multiple bodies: *Neurons and Mind*, **Wolfgang Smith**

"Three Poisons" image by Redtigerxyz – `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Bhavacakra_Thikse.jpg`

Posted on 2018-04-26 by Cologero

* * *

`Lionel Chan on 2018-04-27 at 22:54 said:`

Can't wait for Wolfgang Smith's documentary. He should get together with the appropriately metaphysically primed parts of the Thunderbolts Project, would shake things up quite a bit as conventional cosmology continues to run into anomalies.

Byron Nightjoy on 2018-04-30 at 18:17 said:

"Buddhism goes quite far in its understanding, but it falls short without the notion of grace, which is the antidote to weakness. Like the Buddha, Christ shows the way, but unlike the Buddha, he provides the Power".

This is not true. In the teachings of the Buddhist sage, Shinran (1173-1263), one clearly finds a profound doctrine of grace based on the power of the Buddha ('tariki') which is given to us, as creatures of 'blind passion', for our emancipation from samsara. In many ways, his insights take the notion of grace to its logical conclusion.

Cologero on 2018-04-30 at 18:33 said:

Doesn't that just prove the point, Byron? Shinran taught Pure Land Buddhism and claimed that the traditional Buddhist practices are no longer effective. Hence, tariki is necessary to overcome weakness. In other words, one is no longer dominated by karma. Perhaps the traditions converge.

Byron Nightjoy on 2018-04-30 at 18:33 said:

PS: An excellent introduction to this school of Buddhist thought (from a broadly traditionalist perspective) is *Call of the Infinite: The Way of Shin Buddhism*, written by a priest of that tradition.

Byron Nightjoy on 2018-04-30 at 18:41 said:

Hello Cologero. Yes, you're quite right – 'tariki' is quite necessary to overcome human weakness in light of 'self-power' practices being no longer effective in this Dharma-ending age. However, unless we are able to surrender to the Buddha's grace, our lives will continue to be very much dominated by unfavorable karma and the realization of Nirvana thus becomes impossible for ordinary beings.

15.19 Hunting Iguanas

Justice is the condition in which everything is in its proper place. Justice is the reflection of wisdom, which is necessary to understand the proper

and right place for a thing or a being to be. For example, in nature, each animal species is in its ecological niche. It has adapted to that niche; it has food sources and natural enemies.

When a species is introduced into an environment which is not natural to it, it either cannot survive in it or else it creates an imbalance in the natural order of things. Reptilian pets like pythons and iguanas have created a problem in Florida so that iguanas are among invasive species now banned in Florida[14].

Pet owners let them out into the wild when they grow too large to keep at home. Pythons thrive in the Everglades but iguanas, like rats, do well in human environments. They are messy and replace native species of lizards; on the rare days when it gets cold, they fall out of trees. Although some people try to rescue them, iguanas are legal, and even encouraged to hunt down. The humane method is to use an air gun.

Iguanas are marvels of evolution: they are nimble afoot, and they can swim, jump, and climb. That makes them hard to shoot. We tried traps with enticing canned iguana food. One iguana was so stupid he couldn't find the trap door to get at the food. Instead, he kept bumping into the cage; discouraged he scampered away.

Right Action If justice is the condition of being in the proper place, then its complement, right action, is the cognitive action that actualizes the condition of justice. So if iguanas are not in their proper place, then the right action is to hunt them down.

In *Prolegomena to the Metaphysics of Islam*, **Syed Naquib** calls right action *adab*. It is a marvelous concept, since it relates seemingly disparate situations under the same theme of the condition of justice. He lists the following examples of adab:

[14] https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2021/mar/22/toilet-invading-iguanas-invasive-species-banned-florida

- **Adab toward one's self**: The human self or soul has two aspects: the one predisposed to praiseworthy acts, intelligent by nature, loyal to its covenant with God; the other inclined to evil deeds, bestial by nature, heedless of its covenant with God. The former we call the rational soul the latter the carnal or animal soul, When the rational soul subdues the animal soul and renders it under control then one has put the animal soul in its proper place and the rational soul also in its proper place. In this way, and in relation to one's self, one is putting one's self in one's proper place.

- **Adab toward family**: In relation to one's family and its various members, one's attitude and behaviour toward one's parents and elders display sincere acts of humility, love, respect, care, charity. This shows one knows one's proper place in relation to them by putting them in their proper places.

- **Adab toward social circle**: Similarly, such attitude and behaviour, when extended to teachers, friends, community, leaders, manifest knowledge of one's proper place in relation to them; and this knowledge entails requisite acts in order to actualize adab toward them all.

- **Adab toward language**: This is putting words in their proper places so that their true meanings become intelligible. Sentences and verses in like manner so that prose and poetry become literature.

- **Adab toward nature and the environment**: When one puts trees and stones, mountains, rivers, valleys and lakes, animals and their habitat in their proper places.

- **Adab toward home and furniture**: The same applies to one's home when one arranges furniture and puts things in their proper

places therein until harmony is achieved.

- **Adab toward art and music**: Putting colours, shapes, and sounds in their proper places producing pleasing effects.
- **Adab toward knowledge**: Knowledge too, and its many branches and disciplines, some of which have more important bearing upon our life and destiny than others, grading them according to various levels and priorities and classifying the various sciences in relation to their priorities putting each one of them in its proper place.

Self-mastery, literature, art, and even keeping a well-designed home all fall under the same rubric.

Corruption of Right Order Right order takes the form of a hierarchy. Corruption of right order is marked when no one is in his right place. Places are determined by power, wealth, lineage, or reputation rather than the highest criteria of knowledge, intelligence, and virtue. False leaders emerge in all spheres of life. This comes about through the loss of knowledge. Even worse, there is not even the capacity and ability to even recognize and acknowledge true leaders. Naquib goes further:

> Because of the intellectual anarchy that characterizes this situation, the common people become determiners of intellectual decisions and are raised to the level of authority on matters of knowledge. Authentic definitions become undone, and in their stead we are left with platitudes and vague slogans disguised as profound concepts. The inability to define; to identify and isolate problems, and hence to provide for right solutions; the creation of pseudo-problems; the reduction of problems to mere political, socio-economic and legal factors become evident. It is not surprising if such a situation provides a fertile breeding ground for the emergence of deviationists and extremists of many kinds who make ignorance their capital.

Posted on 2021-09-26 by Cologero

* * *

`scyld on 2021-09-29 at 21:53 said:`
how does rational soul conquer the animal soul?

`Cologero on 2021-09-29 at 22:52 said:`
How does one trap and kill an iguana?

`.chris on 2022-09-26 at 18:49 said:`
In being, brazenly, said sad Iguana, ignorant of its relevance.

15.20 Infidels and the Faithful

According to **Rene Guenon**, theological, or exoteric, statements can be expressed in esoteric terms. In *Symbolism of the Cross*, he illustrates how the esoteric version deepens our understanding with a precise formulation.

In the example he uses from Islam, the categories of the faithful and the infidel cannot depend simply on the nominal affiliation to an exoteric religion. He points out that "Islam" means "submission to God's Will". Hence, the faithful, or the elect, are those who "consciously and voluntarily conform to the universal order".

The infidels are of two types. The rejected "obey the law against their will", that is, they oppose the Divine Plan and face God's wrath. Those who have gone astray — most people — are ignorant of God's Will and are absorbed in the affairs of the world.

He relates those tendencies to the three gunas.

- The **elect** are sattvic, being pulled upward. They follow the "straight path", which is the place of "peace", and their conformity to the universal Will makes them true collaborators in the Divine Plan.

- The **rejected** are tamasic following the downward force along the vertical axis, towards the lower states. Because they do so consciously, this path is the "infernal" way opposed to the "heavenly" way.

- The **ignorant** are rajasic, interested in working out their potentials horizontally in the human state.

Since everything is subject to the three gunas, it is necessary, in esoteric work, to learn to recognize their effects. Sattva is the drive to higher states of being and to knowledge. Saints, Prophets, and Sages provide signposts in this direction.

The tamas leads downward from the human state to the animalistic and even material states. Animal life is dominated by the three lowest chakras: fear, sex, and hunger. These appear as anger, lust, and the desire for power. Hence, anything that excites those feelings can be recognized as tamasic.

The majority of people are dominated by rajas, which is recognized by an excessive concern for worldly affairs. Even these are subject to sattva and tamas, but seldom in a fully conscious way. They may experience a call to spirituality, but it is usually in a sentimental way. Others may follow their lower forces, not to consciously oppose God's will, but rather to improve their lot in life.

Appendix To be specific about the sattva pull, but not very specific, here are some general recommendations. Much of this material has been covered, but more is forthcoming.

- Follow your exoteric teaching

- Learn the universal order

- Dominate the subhuman states

- Purify the human states
- Develop awareness of higher states

Posted on 2021-12-29 by Cologero

15.21 Defects and Accidents

> Among those who receive the same teaching, each one understands and assimilates it more or less completely and profoundly according to the extent of his own intellectual possibilities; and that is why selection comes about quite naturally, without which there could be no genuine hierarchy.
>
> Rene Guenon, *Man and his Becoming*

After the discussion of heredity in *The Great Triad*, Rene Guenon refers the reader to the chapter, *Qualifications for Initiation* in *Perspectives on Initiation*. This has broader interest than the narrow question of initiation, since it exposes the topic of human inequalities. After all, if the Self is somehow complicit in choosing the conditions and circumstances of birth, then why would not every Self choose to be Healthy, Wealthy, and Wise?

First of all, the following fundamental distinction must be understood.

- **Person**: The Person or Self (le Soi) is the transcendent and permanent principle of the being.
- **Individual**: An individual is a transient and contingent modification of the Being. In this discussion, we mean, by "individual", the human being. The Ego (le moi) is the conscious element of the person.

Each individual starts from the state of manifestation in which he is situated. This state includes many determinate conditions which are of two types:

- Those that are generally inherent to that state. For example, the human state includes conditions which are common to all humans.
- Those that are particular to the individual and distinguish him from other individuals.

Most contemporary thought in the West consider the individual to be the entire the human being, and the understanding of the "Person" is restricted to the individual. Then the individual is then divided into a body and a soul (or mind, etc.) The former is the gross aspect and the latter contains the subtle aspects; there cannot be a duality between them, since they are all modalities of the Self. As such, they interact with each other according to the Law of Correspondences. Hence, the body may influence the mind and vice versa.

Obstacles to Initiation Guenon explains the reasons why certain infirmities and bodily defects are considered obstacles to initiation. In themselves they may seem insignificant — for example, a stutterer, or those with asymmetries in the face or limbs, cannot become a Freemason — yet they are outward signs of certain psychic imperfections. This follows from the correspondences between the various states of the human being. The subtle states necessarily correspond to the gross, or physical, state.

Curiously, he points out that the impediments to Masonic initiation are almost identical to the impediments to Catholic Holy Orders[15]. The point is that certain defects affect the proper performance of some rites. Physical defects, as such, are not an indication of a moral failure.

[15] https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/08170a.htm

There are two types of defects:

1. Defects that the being exhibits from birth or that develop naturally over the course of its existence as a consequence of a certain predisposition.

2. Those that are the result of an accident.

The first type inheres in the very nature of the being, However, since nothing can happen to a being that does not correspond in some way to an essential element of his nature, then even apparent accidental infirmities cannot be considered indifferent.

Law of Accidents

> "Don't you mind," said Puddleglum. "There are no accidents. Our guide is Aslan."
>
> C S Lewis, *The Silver Chair*

It is certainly difficult, in contemporary worldviews, to accept that accidents are a necessary aspect of one's being. On the contrary, the commonsense view seems to be that all qualities and conditions of human birth are arbitrary and inessential. Hence, inequality in circumstances of birth is regarded as unjust. Guenon anticipates this view when he writes:

> Some may be astonished that accidental infirmities thus correspond to something in the very nature of the being affected by them, but this is after all only a direct consequence of the real relationships the being has with the environment in which he manifests itself. Everything a being undergoes, as well as all he does, constitute a modification of that being, and must necessarily correspond to one of the possibilities in his nature, so that there can be nothing that is purely accidental if this word be understood in the sense of 'extrinsic', as it commonly is.

Rene Guenon

Victim Souls

> Now I rejoice in my sufferings for your sake, and in my flesh I complete what is lacking in Christ's afflictions for the sake of his body.
>
> Colossians 1:24

Victim souls[16] deliberately agree to a life of painful physical defects and suffering.

Saint Elizabeth of the Trinity[17] is an example; in her writings, she seems to have known that her role would be to intercede for the sick and suffering.

Posted on 2022-02-21 by Cologero

* * *

De Bosit on 2022-02-22 at 00:43 said:

The Victim Souls strike me as overzealous martyrs. Too much too fast?

Unless you're born perfect you probably have to go through hell or purgatory anyway (in life or death later), and with experience maybe it can become bearable.

Then you are a demon to demons, and can execute a meek revenge.

I like this idea more than constant pain and suffering.

James on 2022-02-23 at 18:11 said:

The great American mystic Flannery O'Connor describes in her short story "A Temple of the Holy Ghost" a young child who is told of a hermaphrodite at a local fair who would tell the paying customers who entered the tent, " 'God made me thisaway and if you laugh He may strike

[16] https://catholicstand.com/victim-souls-defeat-satan/

[17] https://www.carmelitedcj.org/carmel/saints-of-carmel/160-bl-elizabeth-of-the-trinity

you the same way. This is the way He wanted me to be and I ain't disputing His way. I'm showing you because I got to make the best of it. I expect you to act like ladies and gentlemen. I never done it to myself nor had a thing to do with it but I'm making the best of it. I don't dispute hit. sic' "

The hermaphrodite's words confused the young child who goes to bed imagining the hermaphrodite talking to her saying: " 'Raise yourself up. A temple of the Holy Ghost. You! You are God's temple, don't you know? Don't you know? God's Spirit has a dwelling in you, don't you know?' "

The story ends with a trip to the convent where the girls witness Exposition and Benediction of the Blessed Sacrament and the young girl remembers the hermaphrodite's words just as she sees the Blessed Sacrament being raised up: " 'I don't dispute hit. This is the way He wanted me to be.' "

Thus there are some things to understand:

The fact that there is life in us is signal and proof enough that regardless of the physical state of our bodies, we are Temples of the Holy Ghost and the treatment of our self in all of its layers is our sacred duty as custodians of this temple. There is no physical "defect" that could nullify this inherent reality.

The association the young girl makes of the Hermaphrodite's Body and the raising of the Body of Christ is a recognition that our bodily suffering and defects is a participation in the suffering and passion of Our Lord.

The mystery of why the Hermaphrodite would disavow any choice in the matter might seem like a stumbling block, but it is not necessarily. What we can understand is a reiteration that suffering and defects are not inherently to be sought after. What the Hermaphrodite's SELF chose is not the individual nastiness of defects, but rather the salvific suffering of being united with the Lord's suffering. Just as the Lord asked His Father to let the cup pass, so, too, does the Hermaphrodite understand that suffering is indeed undesirable. It is disordered. Contrary to O'Connor being read as someone who might refuse the participation of the will, I believe it is more a careful reaffirmation that suffering is an evil that will be wiped away and that the soul properly does not choose evil, but it can, however, surrender to the work of salvation.

Funny enough, at the end of the story, the fair is shut down because local Protestant preachers came around had the police close the fair. There is no solution to suffering in the Protestant mindset–either bodily or circumstantially. It is why the corpus on the crucifix is a scandal to many southerners. Not even counting that we eat His flesh and drink His blood.

As far as my meditations on our existence is concerned, I tend to think that we are here for one of two reasons. We chose this most bleak time of our history because we are either one of the thieves crucified along with the Lord, or we are those who have the moral courage to undergo intense spiritual training (c.f. the unity of the Lion and the Angel "to dare" in the Wheel of Fortune). In other words, I can choose right now to turn to the Lord who is suffering with me

and tell Him that it is not at all unfair that I am subject to a godless society for I myself deserve this curse for my crimes and that all I ask is that He remembers me when He enters into His Kingdom. Otherwise, I am a daring soul who has decided to participate in the age of catacombic heroism. I have not yet penetrated into which one I am yet. I tend to think with all my sins I am the thief and I tend to think with all of my faith that I am the one who dares with moral courage. Perhaps everyone who is born in this time is a little of both.

Squirrel on 2022-03-10 at 12:40 said:

Personal infamy such as being an actor or working in a slaughterhouse was also a bar (though almost always overlooked) to taking the Chinese standardized test, although eunuchs and the crippled were eligible since they wanted as wide a base as possible.

15.22 Asleep to the Real World

> God has described Himself as the Outwardly Manifest and the Inwardly Hidden.
>
> Ibn Arabi, *Bezels of Wisdom*

There can be no difference between the symbol and the doctrine, since the symbol is based on doctrine and doctrine can be expressed in symbols. Often the symbolism erupts in the mind and only later is the doctrine understood. That is why chaos and the non-manifested are revealed in a poem[18] rather than in text.

Rene Guenon describes the Two Nights in the collection *Initiation and Spiritual Realization*. The lower darkness is the Chaos, the state of indifferentiation that is the starting point of manifestation. This is the first night. Those confined in the affairs of the world, the dunya, can only see a reflection of the principle. To them, the non-manifested is the night, the second night. Their only contact is in the causal state of deep sleep, so they remain unaware of the true causes in the world.

[18] https://gornahoor.net/?p=15803

On the other hand, for those aware of the unmanifest, it is the world that is in darkness. Its many appearances are but different modes of the sole Existence.

The Myth **Selene** is the Moon goddess; her name is derived from the Greek word for "light". She is described like this:

> From her immortal head a radiance is shown from heaven and embraces earth; and great is the beauty that ariseth from her shining light.

Selene was in love with the mortal Endymion. Although pulled by her love, Endymion was still attached to the world, as shown in his perpetual state of sleep. The Moon goddess Selene, in her Love for him, kisses him sweetly as he sleeps. Hence, only in his dreams does he escape the illusion of Chaos. This incites pleasant dreams in him, but the Queen of Night remains elusive as long as he sleeps.

> Divine Selene watched him from on high,
> and slid from heaven to earth; for passionate love
> drew down the immortal stainless Queen of Night.
>
> Quintus Smyrnaeus

Plato **Plato** was the prophet of the unmanifest. Every object is the reflection of an idea. The object is a sense perceptible phenomenon but the idea is supersensible. Objects perish but idea are immortal. Therefore, objects are transient and illusory. Only the ideas are real.

But the ideas express a unity. This higher unity, the fundamental idea, is the Logos. The Logos brings the phenomenal world into manifestation. In other words, the Logos is the creative cosmic Word that incarnates into the world. However, the things of the world are shadows, different modes of the one true Existence.

Aristotle **Aristotle**, on the other hand, claimed that the idea inheres in the thing, not in some abstract world. The idea and the thing are inseparably connected. This gives reality to the physical world of the senses. This union of idea and substance overcomes the chaos of the manifest world. Like Plato, Aristotle also knew of the primordial idea which is called the Logos. However, it is most real when incarnated into the world of senses.

Posted on 2022-03-03 by Cologero

15.23 The Man Who Knew Too Much

> One might say that set theory is to mathematics what quantum theory is to physics; it is what remains when every last vestige of "being" has been exorcised.
>
> Wolfgang Smith

It is hardly uncommon to listen to amateurish metaphysicians on the Internet who are fixated on quantum theory and set theory. One fellow droned on and on about an "actual infinity", whatever that might mean. There was no way to interrupt, so I had to click pause. Obviously, such a concept is incoherent because there is only one Infinity. He is just one of many with a new Theory of Everything. Often they are merely the sequel to **Alfred Hitchcock**'s *The Man Who Knew Too Much*: The Man Who Understood Too Little.

What Wolfgang Smith means is that those concepts are so abstract that they become essentially meaningless. Quantum particles do not "exist" as things; rather they are described by possible quantum states. Only when "measured", what Dr. Smith calls vertical causation, do they become beings. Similarly, as set is a mathematical concept with no properties other than its members.

It is the height of arrogance, inspired by presentism, to presume that no one in the history of the human race ever understood anything about the world, the human race, and God until quantum and set theories were invented, yes, "invented", not "discovered".

To know God, it is best to rely on the esoterists, saints, prophets, etc., who actually knew God, not some innovator with a novel theory about God.

We Have No Bananas Today An underemployed philosopher was forced to take a job as produce manager in a German owned supermarket in a small town in Arkansas. Since bananas were sold by the piece rather than by weight, he implemented a system of using sets of bananas in order to track them. He figured that when new bananas arrived, he could just take the union of two sets of bananas to get a count. However, a set must have unique elements but all the bananas looked alike. So he had the stockboy number the bananas to give them an identity.

One day a tribe of monkeys bought all the bananas. When the philosopher asked for inventory, the stockboy answered, "There are no bananas."

"You mean," explained the philosopher, "that the bananas are a null set."

"Yes," replied the stockboy, "we have no bananas today."

The Consultant The philosopher was sacked and is now an Uber driver in the Ozarks. Management brought in a consultant to convert the sets of bananas to their own inventory system. He had to explain the problem as best he could, and here are some passages from his white paper.

A "set" of bananas tells you nothing about bananas, since a set is a mathematical construct. As such, it is intermediate between the pure realm of ideas and the sensible realm represented by the bananas. Since the bananas are numbered, as set of 12 bananas is isomorphic to the set of

numbers from 1 to 12, for example. Hence, we can dispense with the set of bananas since the set of numbers tells us everything we need to know.

The claim that the universe itself is a set, is no different. At any moment, there are a finite number of physical things in the universe, so the set of things is likewise isomorphic to a finite set of natural numbers, no matter how large it may be. Obviously, calling the universe a set may be tautologically true, but it reveals nothing about the universe.

Moreover, there are two rather vexing problems. The first is how to define a "thing". Is a racoon a thing? How about the head of a racoon? This involves questions of mereology, which cannot be solved with set theory alone.

The second problem is that objects are coming into and going out of existence. A set is definitively defined, and its members cannot change. Hence, the universe cannot be a single set, but rather a series of sets.

Epistemic Closure By epistemic closure, I mean the notion that the world is self-explanatory. In practice it means the attempt to understand the world from a small number of axioms and any tautologies that necessarily follow from them.

This is clearly false in practice, since there are many things that we don't know about the world. Moreover, if we include mathematics, then there will always be truths that cannot be contained in any system. It is impossible not to notice that all important problems are not resolvable within the universe. Thought is dominated by incessant and futile arguments with no apparent end.

Hence, in principle, the world is incomplete and requires a revelation from outside the world. As we recently showed in the article In The Beginning[19], the most important issues about living in the world cannot be solved by science or logic; rather, they must be revealed from outside the world process.

[19] `https://gornahoor.net/?p=16477`

Love is not an Emotion I recently watched three men of above average intelligence try to describe love as if it were an emotion. That is so far from the truth of the matter. God is Love, and God is not an emotion. We are commanded to love, and emotions cannot be commanded.

The ultimate point of knowing the world is not knowledge for its own sake, but rather to know the Good. For Plato, it was sufficient to contemplate the Good. However, is the Will is fundamental, then that is insufficient; rather, one must Will the Good. That is what is meant by Love: to Will the Good.

Many people get stuck in a rut of theodicy by misunderstanding physical pain. That is understandable, but spiritual good is unmeasurably more important than material good. Hence, to will the good for someone means to help him spiritually as well as materially.

Divine Simplicity God is simple, which means He has no parts. Hence, it is loose talk to claim that a human being is a "part of God"; that is simply a logical absurdity.

A fortiori, it means that God cannot be the set of all sets. First of all, it is an incoherent notion. A recent comment showed a justification for the claim, but it involved two incompatible notions of containment. The explanation sounded more like the Sokal hoax[20] than a serious definition.

We cannot worship the set of all sets, nor can it reveal itself. The claim that everything knowable about God is among those sets, so that there is nothing to reveal.

Moreover, as we pointed out, a set is beneath the world of ideas. God, however, is transcendent to everything in the world, hence cannot be a set of any kind.

Concluding Unscientific Postscript That is enough for now. Someone's alleged IQ has no bearing on the quality of his system. Even a moun-

[20] `https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sokal_affair`

tebank like Jordan Peterson considers it necessary to reveal his IQ.

If a system can convince some yobs to believe in God, accept moral responsibility for their postmortem state, and see the influence of Satan in the world, there is some good in it. However, at some point they should tire of feeding on Froot Loops and seek out the solid and nutritious food of Traditional metaphysics.

`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HygopC4S5W0`

Posted on 2022-08-18 by Cologero

* * *

`Arthur Konrad on 2022-08-19 at 05:33 said:`
What if our universe is just an elaborate forgery?

`Cologero on 2022-08-19 at 15:20 said:`
Forgery of what? By whom? For what purpose?

`Dimitri on 2022-08-19 at 20:33 said:`
Perhaps he's alluding to the cosmologies of old commonly placed under the umbrella term of "Gnosticism"? Incidentally, that sort of thinking or at least variations of it seem to be having a resurgence these days, albeit in materialistic terms (e.g. "the universe is a computer simulation").

`Michael DeJoy on 2022-08-22 at 09:53 said:`
Cologero, currently there does not appear to be a solution to the Wests' slow motion collapse. Numerous podcasts, blogs, etc. try to argue their points on what needs to be done to stem the tide, however none of these things seem to work. I have been considering the following as a fantastical solution which lies within our grasp. I believe the Catholic Church still has much power and influence in the world that she has let go dormant and often is at odds with its' own original goals. Imagine if one morning Pope Francis woke up and said " gentlemen, we have been wrong about promoting liberal ideas and we are returning to the ways of our founder. I don't care what governments say, I don't care what news organizations say, I don't care what liberals of all stripes say, we are changing course. Those who agree can stand with us, those against can go their own way." I think this would cause a shakeout and restoration of the Church. It would be stronger and rock the world.

Cologero on 2022-08-22 at 10:59 said:

What you call a "slow motion collapse", most other people call "progress and freedom".

If you join the priesthood and are ambitious enough to become pope, then you can implement your program. Otherwise, the pope does not give a rat's ass about your opinion. In any event, the purpose of the Church is to save souls, not to implement some political program.

If you recall, Adam disobeyed God's commandment; since then, many others have followed Adam's example. So if people are quite willing to disobey God, why do you think that they will suddenly obey the pope in your scenario?

There is a Law of Harmony. Everything is in its right place for a reason. This is the world as it is. As I wrote a year ago:

"This is a difficult path; after all, only 3 Knights found the Holy Grail out of the 150 who started. This is meant for those three. Failure comes from this misunderstanding: Tradition is a way of life, not a system of thought."

While everyone else is looking for a guru with a great system, a few hearty souls go out in search of the Grail without a guidebook. I am looking for Knights, Michael, not whiners.

15.24 Traditional Metaphysics

> Guenon's *Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta* will draw the attention of the well trained and qualified reader. Of course, it will also become the source of misunderstandings for a certain category of "third rate" critics and intellectuals who oscillate between platitudes and political and spiritual fancies.
>
> Julius Evola

Rene Guenon was not happy with Nicholson's translation of *Man and his Becoming*. A literal word for word translation of a text that may read well in French, may not result in smooth English. Many people have informed me that they have had trouble understanding *Man and his Becoming*. That may be due, in part, not to the difficulty of the concepts but rather to the confusion of the translation. Hence, I have begun a slow-motion translation of the most important sections of his major works of metaphysics.

This is the beginning of a slow motion translation, still in progress, of the fundamental texts of metaphysics as described by Rene Guenon. These texts are mostly found in the following books:

- *Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta*
- *The Symbolism of the Cross*
- *The Multiple States of the Being*

The first goal of the translations is to make it read smoothly in English; this is not possible with a word for word translation, which often is misleading. In this way, the fundamental points of the text.

The second goal is to employ the most commonly accepted English words to express the metaphysical ideas. This is often not the literal translation of the French word.

The third goal is to make the style and terminology consistent among the three works listed above.

The first text selected is *Chapter II: Fundamental Distinction between Self and Ego* from *Man and his Becoming according to the Vedanta*. I will be updating it depending on my time commitments and positive feedback. Here is a teaser with a fresh translation of Chapter 2 on the Self and the ego.

See Principles Of Metaphysics[21]

Posted on 2022-09-03 by Cologero

15.25 Paying the Cost

> It takes years of training to teach us to deal intelligently with the world of everyday life. Our schooling — whether in plain reasoning or formal topics — is rigorous, because the knowledge we are

[21] `https://www.gornahoor.net/library/PrinciplesOfMetaphysics.pdf`

> trying to impart is very complex. The same criteria apply to the sorcerers' world: their schooling, which relies on oral instruction and the manipulation of awareness, although different from ours, is just as rigorous, because their knowledge is as, or perhaps more, complex.
>
> Carlos Castenada, *The Power of Silence*

Most people do not spend time mastering some field of knowledge, because they remain content to repeat whatever they have learned over and over, year after year. Yet when it comes to the most abstruse topics in metaphysics or philosophy, many people assume it is possible to become an instant expert.

Au contraire, it takes years of study and practice to begin to master metaphysics.

Gladwell's Law **Malcolm Gladwell**, in his blockbuster book *Outliers*, proposed the rule following rule for success:

It takes 10,000 hours of intensive practice to achieve mastery of complex skills and materials.

That is equivalent to 5 years of 40 hour workweeks, but that is approximately what it takes to develop world class expertise of a talent. Obviously, after work and family obligations, there is little spare time for a hobby or other avocation. That is why we like to hear stories of novelists, for example, who had to wrote at odd times of day, while not engaged in family and/or work duties. In times past, mathematical and scientific discoveries were often made by men who were otherwise engaged.

This applies a fortiori to one's spiritual life, particularly the path of the Spiritual Knight and Hermetic philosophy. Few are able to dedicate adequate time.

Since Gladwell proposed his law, there have been emendations and criticisms. However, they are the exceptions that prove the rule. There

are two, in particular, that have relevance.

Success. Talent is not sufficient to guarantee success, at least in worldly terms. Sometimes someone is aided by a wealthy benefactor, or a talent agent, or even a serendipitous break. A good friend of mine has been enjoying great guitarists in concert for years. So I recently asked him who are the great guitarists of today, and this was his response:

> Music biz is > 90% promoter agent vs 10% performer. There are outstanding musicians out there. Too few care to look for them. So there is no buzz. Within 8 days, 9/14- 9/22, I saw live Kurt Rosenwinkel, DiMeola and Richard Thompson. Times change How many great living violinists can you name?

Although I listen to a lot of classical music, I cannot name the best living violinists; perhaps that young girl who is a street performer. Moreover, I cannot name one great oboist, ever in history. But I don't think it takes 10,000 hours to master the oboe.

Teacher. A good teacher or coach can save many of those hours.

It is of no value to repeat the same thing for all those hours, otherwise mailmen would get really good at mail delivery. We used to have the same mailman for 17 years. I suspect that he learned his route within the first few months.

So a good teacher can evaluate performance, make corrections, suggest alternatives, and so on, which might save years of effort if you had to do it on your own.

Sacred Science There is one other factor, without an easy explanation and which may offend our contemporary notions of egalitarianism, is that not everyone has the potential to excel in every field. In other words, we are not born a "blank slate" as John Locke proposed. Instead we have innate potentialities which may or may not be developed.

This is most especially true when it comes to metaphysics, or Sacred Science. Few have the aptitude for it. Many try, but then drift away. They learn the vocabulary and some basic ideas, but slowly drift away. For them, it was never more than a pastime. On the other hand, a few become very interested and spend as much time as they can. Rene Guenon, in Man and his Becoming, explains the way it is:

> Among those who receive the same teaching, each one understands and assimilates it more or less completely, more or less deeply, according to the extent of his own intellectual possibilities. This is how the selection quite naturally operates, without which there can be no true hierarchy.

The Sun and the Moon One of the stumbling blocks to the study of metaphysics is that, at the superficial level, it "looks like" philosophy. That is, it seems to be a subject matter that can be debated and discussed, just like philosophical, political, or scientific theories. At one level, that is correct. But that type of discursive knowledge is just indirect knowledge.

Profane teachings to not require a change in the learner. That is, there is no necessity for moral purification to become a great physicist. However, that is not the case for the study of metaphysics. The physicist observed the outer world and performs experiments.

Analogously, for the metaphysician carefully observes, not the outer world, but the inner world of sensations, emotions, images, and thoughts. By accumulating data of this type, he learns the concepts, not indirectly, but through direct observations, called "intuition". Without have made the requisite efforts of this type, the metaphysical teachings can never be fully known. Guenon explains:

> in the transcendent order, only direct perception or inspiration attains the principle itself, i.e., what is highest, and all that remains is to draw out the consequences and the various applications.

This is represented by symbolism:

> The intuitive faculty and the discursive faculty, may be represented respectively by the sun and the moon.

Discursive knowledge is always open to debate; intuitive knowledge is certain. The Shaman explains:

> Don Juan had stated his belief that the Christian idea of being cast out from the Garden of Eden sounded to him like an allegory for losing our silent knowledge, our knowledge of intent. Sorcery, then, was a going back to the beginning, a return to paradise.
>
> "What we need to do to allow magic to get hold of us is to banish doubt from our minds," he said. "Once doubts are banished, anything is possible."

Who has 10 thousand hours for that result?
`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oUTwVtS_-NA`

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`Tannheuser on 2022-09-26 at 10:54 said:`

A good teacher can save his students thousands of hours. The importance of having a teacher is that instead of just dispensing general advice (which can be found in books or online), the teacher gets to know the student better than they know themselves, and can provide invaluable personalized guidance.

One example is the way that good teachers often don't answer students' questions directly, but instead guide the students toward finding the answers themselves. In many cases, the work necessary to discover the answer is as important as the answer itself.

From observing those more advanced than myself, I believe that to progress past a certain advanced stage in esoteric development, it is necessary to become a teacher oneself.

`mark siegmund on 2022-09-26 at 16:50 said:`

" A Case Western Reserve University team has subsequently performed a review of over 9,000 research papers about practice relating to acquiring skills. In their paper, they found that deliberate practice explained 26% of the variance in performance for games, 21% for music, 18% for sports, 4% for education, and less than 1% for professions. They conclude that deliberate practice is important, but not as important as has been argued in Gladwell's book."